



神魔天記

신마정전기

신마정전기 (1권) 신마정전기 시리즈

JAPANESE ORIENTAL FANTASY

RP
FRUS
로맨스 판타지

Information

Table of Contents URL: <https://www.lightnovelworld.co/novel/chronicles-of-the-heavenly-demon>

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Divine Astonishment

Author: [Il-Hwang](#)

RANK 709

4.2

208

Chapters

203K

Views

1.92K

Bookmarked

Completed

Status

Categories

- [Action](#)
- [Adventure](#)
- [Seinen](#)
- [Wuxia](#)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon novel is a popular light novel covering Action, Adventure, and Seinen genres. Written by the Author Il-Hwang. 208 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

You emphasized harmony your whole life and this is how you go...!’ The successor of the Spear Master Sect and his apprentice Hyuk Woon Seong were framed of learning a forbidden Demonic art and slayed.

A helpless and pitiful death by the hypocrites of the Orthodox sect.

The moment Woon Seong faced his death, the artifact of the Spear Master Sect emitted light and gave him a new life.

The life as Number 900, a trainee of the Demonic Cult!

The two identities, the Orthodox Sect and the Demonic Cult.

But his objective is one. Vengeance! Accepting his destiny and remembering his grudge, Woon Seong trains in martial arts and his time of revenge slowly comes closer....

Take over the Demonic Cult and punish the hypocrites of the Orthodox Sect! The revenge story of Number 900, Woon Seong growing in tasks of life and death.

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- 1
Horri
Reader
26d

Compared to other Murim, Reincarnation and Revenge series, it is definitely underrated and a pioneer of its kind. MC is a very high-quality work, its world is very high-quality and its philosophy is very good.

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 6
OnionBhaji
Reader

1mo

This is s tier, I would advise everyone to give it a read for sure

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 12

Louisery

Reader

2mo

I read manwha of this novel and it was great idk how goood the novel is but it should be good

Edited: 2mo

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 1

Icepanda

Reader

4mo

pov you came to the comments to see what other ppl thought abt the novel but all you see is comments about people complaining that people are comparing it to RI so you just keep searching cuz it prob not worth it

[Reply](#)

6 0

- 1

RexDaGod

[Icepanda](#)

Reader

3mo

I was so confused at first like why the f*ck are people comparing this to Renegade Immortal they are nothing alike. Then reading more realized it was Reverend Insanity lol.

[Reply](#)

0 0

◦ 1

TheLaughingMan

[Icepanda](#)

Reader

3mo

the manwha was good. Idk about the novel yet havent read it but the chapters seem to be less than i would have expected.

[Reply](#)

2 0

◦ [View More Replies](#)

• 4

Saiff

Reader

5mo

I came here wanting to know what's this novel's about just to find the comments filled with; RI this RI that, fang yuan blah blah. Stop dude this is really annoying

[Reply](#)

2 0

• 6

BlueHeimOcean

Reader

8mo

Its not called Demonic Cult because they are evil, its called that because its a religion of the Heavenly Demon. Main wish of the cult was to be recognized as a religion. So dont compare RI to this directly. Both are good novels.

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 1
Suthard3
Reader
8mo

Has a great story and the side-cast is developed enough where it doesn't seem they just in the background. The story contains very profound messages which aren't regularly seen in Murim novels.

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 20
Daoist_Carefree
Reader
9mo

I liked the beginning, after 100 it becomes boring when Soon Seong becomes the heavenly demon. Plus the old heavenly demon doesn't feel like heavenly demon. I have seen it happening, when demonic are with MC, there demonic nature never shows. Only when they are opposed by the MC do their nature shows.

[Reply](#)

6 0

- 26
Veldora_Tempest
Reader

9mo

People should know that any novel when compared to RI will look bad

[Reply](#)

[Redacted]

13 [Redacted] 10

- o 7

Blind_Eyes

[Veldora_Tempest](#)

Reader

8mo

RI- renegade immortal? Or revred insane?????

[Reply](#)

[Redacted]

2 [Redacted] 0

- o 21

SoleKefe

[Veldora_Tempest](#)

Reader

9mo

Grab a tissue and wipe all that white stuff off your mouth 🤢
Y'all RI fans can never just enjoy something. Bet y'all wake up and be like "Oh sh*t, it's already 6 pm, gotta make sure to get my daily RI glaze in before it's too late. Oh can't forget to showe- aaah who am I kidding? Haven't touched that bih in a couple years" 🤢

[Reply](#)

[Redacted]

52 [Redacted] 5

- 6

CereMians

[SoleKefe](#)

Reader

7mo

Absolutely agree bro. I have a theory that most of those RI and LoTM brainrot fans are 14 - 16 years old kids that have just started reading web novels. Because at that age they are starting to enter their edgy, "it's dark like my soul", phase, hence they are squirting everyday to Fang Yuan quotes or Amon's f*ck*ng monocle.

[Reply](#)

4 0

■ 13

yangkaier

[SoleKefe](#)

Reader

8mo

thank you for speaking up bro 🥺🥺🙏

[Reply](#)

5 0

■ 20

Daoist_Carefree

[SoleKefe](#)

Reader

9mo

Yeah I agree, Though Ri is my second favorite novel, I don't like when everyone just compares and compares. And no, my favorite novel is not Lotm, Lotm is 4th favorite.

[Reply](#)

3 0

- 8
Mr_Failure
[Daoist_Carefree](#)
Reader
8mo

Constantly comparing something just make everything bad
Look what that sh*t do to my young self esteem bro

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 5
Auvem
[SoleKefe](#)
Reader
9mo

real, its crazy how much LOTM and RI fans glaze their
respective novels and hate on every other novel in
existence. Its not gonna make me want to read the novel,
its just gonna make me hate it.

[Reply](#)

22 0

- 10
Lolimancer
[Auvem](#)
Reader
9mo

I tried RI and couldn't stomach it. It's the kind of novel
where the MC is a complete loner, a lunatic, and refuses to
properly communicate with anyone. Not to mention, it
feels like every single other character is out there to plot

against him and kill him. There isn't a single reasonable person in MC's path, and he makes no friends. It got boring real quick and I had to drop it.

[Reply](#)

[Redacted]

9 [Redacted] 9

■ 5

Auvem

[Lolimancer](#)

Reader

9mo

same i really dislike how evil and ruthless he is, generally i dont like mc's like that very much its fine if they are a little ruthless and a little evil but fang yuan is a complete d*ck and from what I heard from other people he is a complete maniac and slaughters his family to enhance his talent.

[Reply](#)

[Redacted]

4 [Redacted] 9

■ 20

Daoist_Carefree

[Auvem](#)

Reader

9mo

Different eyes, different sights. RI is not for the weak stomach plus Ri is from a villain's POV so it is like that. Plotting for something is ingrained in Gu world. Not only against MC, everybody plots against everybody. There are no reasonable persons in Gu world because in that world, to reach true heights, you have to have "undesirable" traits. I put on quotes because we should not judge a fantasy world with vastly different values. Maybe Grimdark is not for you, how about you try a western novel called Broken empire trilogy, a real fantasy hard copy novel to see if you

like Grimdark. If you still don't like the one I am recommending, Grimdark is not for you. Though I would say Ri is not without flaws. It's good but not without flaws.

[Reply](#)

8 3

■ 5

HeavenlyOverlord

[Daoist_Carefree](#)

Reader

8mo

I tried RI I got pretty form it was really good but I literally could not take it EVERYTHING ALWAYS WENT WRONG the most bazaar changes out of nowhere and in the end he lives not unscathed at all almost dead but alive but you know what wasn't alive my nerves I was sometimes scared to read the next chapter cause it was nervewracing so bad.And for the first time I met my match I got to the part were he was at the tower and he was forced to ascend

[Reply](#)

1 0

■ 20

Daoist_Carefree

[HeavenlyOverlord](#)

Reader

8mo

You mean 88 imperial court true yang building and when he became a zombie? Well it is a part a lot of people don't like because Fang Yuan loses a lot in that part. But it's finale is also super amazing. Also, everything going wrong is explained and then detailed even further in the story revealing truths we didn't know existed. I mean I like

Reverend Insanity because of that nerve wracking feel. I can't predict Ri as I could most stories.

Edited: 8mo

[Reply](#)

3 0

■ 5

Yellowflaash

[Auvem](#)

Reader

9mo

Its not every person cup of tea but once in a while we need evil MC not all need to be goody shoes or ruthlees like most MC only killing enemies and etc My Man Feng Yuan is a tramigrator and a reincarnator... Mean he died on earth went to that world then lived a naive and good life got fuked by the world and became evil over course of 500 years then died and started again and now he is ruthless For him the most beautiful women are nothing bcz when they die they will be bones like everyone so he sees the most beautiful women as bag of bones that will left after their death His goal is ETERNAL LIFE and for that he will sacrifice everything even himself He will destroy Fate with his own hands if he has to but he will achieve Eternal Life and if he does in the process then he will die with a smile

[Reply](#)

4 0

■ 6

Terrorist

[Yellowflaash](#)

Reader

9mo

But that's b*llsh*t tho

Reply

2 2

▪ 20

Daoist_Carefree

Terrorist

Reader

9mo

That's not though. If you can't read until 650 chaps then you can't say that. You don't have enough information to form opinion about Fang Yuan. And 650 chaps is a minimum.

Reply

2 1

○ 20

Qoye

Veldora_Tempest

Reader

9mo

Any WN or LN specifically*

Reply

0 0

▪ 26

Veldora_Tempest

Qoye

Reader

9mo

Yep only web/light novels, wut did you guys think 🤖

Reply

[Redacted]

3 [Redacted] 2

◦ 4

tls123__

Veldora_Tempest

Reader

9mo

RI?? Nani

Edited: 9mo

[Reply](#)

[Redacted]

2 [Redacted] 0

▪ 26

Veldora_Tempest

tls123__

Reader

9mo

Reverend insanity

[Reply](#)

[Redacted]

2 [Redacted] 0

◦ [View More Replies](#)

• 2

__L__

Reader

9mo

The novel stands out positively when not compared to "RI" because the main character isn't inherently evil; rather, his malevolence stems from a desire for revenge. What captivates me is his quest for vengeance, which I find intriguing.

[Reply](#)

6 0

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Chapter 1: Woon Seong

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon1 – Woon Seong

His legs trembled.

Woon Seong's entire body was shaking roughly from overexertion of his internal qi and apparent injuries.

The barren dirt on the ground stung as it stuck to the bloody wounds on his body and his head was ringing with a massive headache.

All of this was nothing compared to what Woon Seong truly cared about. His teacher and master died. The man who took care of him and raised him like a child was murdered and dead laying in front of him. What was even more aggravating was the scene in front of him however.....

‘The one who taught me the essence of martial arts and becoming a man. Is this how you go?’

Woon Seong's anger was directed at the people in front of him who murdered his teacher and were responsible for his current state. It was a group of people who were once respected as his teacher's peers and their disciples.

The fact they had turned on the Spearmaster, his teacher, and his sect was a sad sight to see.

“Hahaha...”

Woon Seong laughed like a madman.

“Hahahahahhhhhhhhhhhhhh!!!”

As he slowly turned my head, He could see the body of his deceased teacher who had fallen first.

His Master, the current master of the Spearmaster sect in the Orthodox society of Murim, who was betrayed by those who falsely accused him and schemed against him, claiming he had been learning in secret the demonic path, killed him in cold blood.

When Woon Seong turned my gaze again, all he saw was the bastards who were responsible for everything.

The Sage of Bright Rock, from Mount Hua Sect.

The Three Swords of Qingcheng, and the First Apprentice.

The Legendary Mountain Cleaver and the Peng Clan.

In addition to these people, were the 5 generations hailing from their respective factions that held together the Orthodox Alliance within all of Murim.

But lastly... was *that* bastard.

The Lord of the Martial Alliance, Jwa Do-Gyeul.

He was a fool and a bastard man who had always felt inferior to Woon Seong's master, who also was the person who most openly accused his master as "The vilest practitioner and master in all of Murim". It was likely he was the one behind all of this Woon Seong thought.

Woon Seong looked at Do-Gyeul's hypocritical facial expression and gritted his teeth.

Then he slowly opened his mouth, erasing his wrathful countenance as if it was a lie.

"Let me ask you one thing."

"Tell me."

The person who answered was the Sage of Bright Rock, hailing from the Mount Hua Sect.

He was the only one who could not erase his expression of unease and guilt, even when he killed his teacher.

However, in Woon Seong's eyes, he looked the same as any of the other hypocrites gathered here.

Although the Sage may feel guilty or remorseful about his actions, he did absolutely nothing to save his Master's life.

Looking back at the group before him, Woon Seong slowly opened his dry, chapped lips to speak.

"I know that some of the people here are not fools. You know better than anyone that my Master nor I, practiced any demonic art."

"....."

At the words of Woon Seong, the people around him closed their mouths and remained speechless like puppets.

The only remaining shred of sanity within Woon Seong snapped at this disgusting sight before him.

He laughed inwardly to himself, and Woon Seong continued to talk.

"Then let's talk candidly. Why did you do this? My Master was virtuous and honest as any man to ever walk the path of Martial Arts. And yet.. You openly frame him and conspire to taint his image and then trample our sect?! WHY?!!"

The cry from Woon Seong was filled with both desperation and sadness, as if he were a wounded beast crying out in anger at his attacker before it's last moments.

Those who stood before him and saw this were taken aback by the ferocious display of spirit and power in front of them.

One of the corners of Woon Seong's mouth curled up as he saw them cower and step back.

‘Yeah, Of course none of you have any idea who did this to us. It's because all of you fuckers are responsible for this!’

In fact, Woon Seong knew their personalities and tendencies

Why they would do this, and what false merit it would bring to their own image.

The Spearmaster Sect was the smallest sect in number, as it was a one master and one disciple type of sect. It was obvious what would happen if several other Orthodox sects attacked them.

But his Master was already something else compared to these so-called masters before him.

His Master's ascension in his martial path and cultivation had long reached above and beyond his peer's levels.

Even the Lord of the entire Martial Alliance was compared to evenly matched to his master..

Despite all the false glory they would attain from purging an evil villain in name who was as strong as his master, there was definitely something else hidden in this accusation!

However, nobody defended them whatso-ever when the accusations surfaced.

It started half a year ago. A strange rumor had started to spread all over the country that an ancient demonic text that was unparalleled in power was revived and found.

All those who learned this art, were different from normal Unorthodox practitioners as they were purely demonic. Demonic Arts were powerful indeed, but their power depended on the amount of bloodshed of others,

hence why those who learned it turned into disastrous murderers within all of Murim and were put down as soon as they came to power.

As soon as one learnt it, they would also lose all remaining sanity and completely turn into a different person.

But... the rumors turned towards his Master for some reason and he was accused of holding onto the book.

The Spearmaster sect had one of the largest libraries in all of Murim despite being the smallest when it came to texts and cultivation methods. But the rumors went as far to accuse his master that he had already started practicing the demonic arts!

Nobody listened to the cries of Woon Seong and his master, as two people cannot stand up to the entire world or Murim.

After a while, an investigative group was sent from the Alliance to check if the rumors were true or not.

Both Woon Seong and his master were certain the rumors were complete falsehoods. But... something changed.

‘I should’ve realized it sooner.’, he thought.

For some reason during the rigorous investigation, the text of the demonic art was found in the investigators hands.

In no other place than the Spearmaster Sect’s library!

The appearance of the demonic text, when first pulled out of the shelf, embarrassed even his Master since Woon Seong knew that neither his Master had any inclination to study or even look for that blasphemous text. Naturally, anxiety and worry appeared on both his master and his own face.

At that point Woon Seong realized.

It was a scheme to frame them. For some reason, somebody in Murim conspired against their sect and his Master.

And it just so happens that those bastards who framed him, were standing right in front of the bloodied and fierce-eyed Woon Seong at this very moment.

“If you have a mouth, TELL ME!”, Woon Seong roared pointing his spear at the two-faced martial artists.

When the people of the group before him did not answer, Woon Seong shouted even louder.

It was then that the Lord of the Martial Alliance, Jwa Do-Gyeul emerged from the group and responded.

“How long are we going to let that demonic child spout his dirty lies?!”

As Jwa Do-Geul stepped forwards, Woon Seong grasped the blood-stained spear of his deceased teacher tightly in his grasp.

Woon Seong glared intensely at Jwa Do-Gyeul. If looks could kill, Woon Seong would have slaughtered the entirety of Murim with just that gaze alone.

“Of course, you always hated my Master. Not only were his merits higher than yours, but his skill was also leagues above yours!”, Woon Seong shouted in contempt.

The Do-Gyeul’s eyebrows wriggled and contorted in anger at the words spoken.

“I guess your teacher didn’t teach you any manners with that spiteful tongue of yours. Heh, I will purge all the laymen who practiced the devil’s art starting with your master and you!”

“Bullshit!”

Woon Seong shot forwards with vigor, as his spear wound itself tightly in qi and moved with him towards his target.

It was a strike with such ferocity and stability that it was nearly impossible to imagine that Woon Seong had only been practicing for a short ten years.

And in fact, his skills were the most highly rated amongst the younger generation as well!

The smooth and refined movement of his spear proved it beyond a doubt.

As he moved towards the group, Woon Seong's movement resembled a thunderbolt.

Originally, it was Woon Seong's intention to catch Jwa Do-Gyeul and kill him right then and there.

But, he wasn't the Lord of the Martial Alliance for no reason!

'I need to, if anybody is to die here. It must be that man!'

Woon Seong though moving incredibly fast-paced, almost like a mirage to the untrained eye, slowly glanced over at his Master's face who lied there on the ground to the left of him in sorrow and anger.

Woon Seong was bitter about it to the very end, since it wasn't like his master couldn't defend himself from all these masters. He was visibly poisoned, and Woon Seong had noticed the physical symptoms long ago.

In addition to poisoning and framing his master for practicing Demonic Arts, Woon Seong absolutely would not let Jwa Do-Gyeul live for what he had done!

'I'll kill him.. for as long as my body still breathes life, I will definitely kill him.'

It was a gathering of the most powerful masters within the entire Orthodox Alliance that were in front of him, Woon Seong knew there was no way he could escape them and that he would surely die here.

Since that was the case, he had to at least avenge his master in some way.

As soon as Woon Seong shifted his gaze back towards his target, his eyes shone brilliantly with determination, the spear in his hand flashed with a bright orange aura and set fire.

“Y-You!”, Jwa Do-Gyeul shouted in surprise and a little bit of fear.

Even a cornered rat would bite a cat.

Jwa Do-Gyeul brought his sword in hand in front of him quickly and was forced to parry the fierce strike he tried to redirect as much as the pressure and force behind the spear, away from him.

Bang!

Zing-singgg-zingggg

A flurry of strikes unfolded at an unseeable pace before the group as the spear and sword clashed.

It wasn't a completely futile effort either.

Two fingers!

Woon Seong could see that Jwa Do-gyeul's middle and ring finger of his left hand were cut off by the speartip and flew in the air.

“How dare you!”

Jwa Do-Gyeul clenched his teeth and shouted with pain and anger evident in his voice.

He wouldn't just let some fool's disciple from the lower generation get away from him after humiliating him this far.

Woon Seong didn't back down either in spirit as he bared his teeth and vented his anger.

“Ahh!”

Woon Seong was angry beyond words that he was not able to pierce Jwa Do-Gyeul's heart at the very last moment, he couldn't and wouldn't be satisfied with just two fingers.

But as cruel as reality was, that was all he could do with his skill as a younger generation disciple facing a master.

“Lord!”

The Mountain Cleaver and First Apprentice of the Sword Sect shouted out and approached Jwa Do-Gyeul.

Of course it was them. The two that hung around most with Jwa Do-Gyeul and were basically his loyal dogs.

They were the epitome of hypocrisy.

“You're too young to even try and escape from us you little bastard!”

“His skills are as good as they say! Be careful!”

Pheng-teng-teng-

The cold, bloodied spear and the sword of the First Apprentice collided, causing a series of dangerous exchanges to be heard throughout the field.

Behind the First Apprentice who kept Woon Seong occupied, was the Mountain Cleaver gathering up his internal energy for a huge over-handed strike.

And as if that was not enough, even Jwa Do-Gyeul, which had stopped the bleeding from his wounded fingers, rushed toward the Woon Seong in anger with his sword.

The remaining members of the group, including the Sage of Bright Rock, the renowned scholar of the Mount Hua Sect, just watched the fight in front of their eyes with bitter expressions.

The fierce battle continued for more than a few minutes.

And at the end of the battle, the sword of Jwa Do-Gyeul pierced the heart of the brutally beaten and wounded Woon Seong.

“Oh, my God! Is he still alive after even that?!”

Woon Seong staggered, gripping the hole in the left side of his chest. A chunk of blackened blood and unrecognizable organ tissue sputtered out from Woon Seong’s mouth.

It was the result of several inflicted strikes that harmed him internally in a cruel manner... This tortuous method of death was due to Jwa Do-Gyeul alone.

Even from an outsider’s perspective, it was impossible for Woon Seong to survive here. Even if he was left alone here, he would bleed out in a sad state since he wouldn’t be able to move a limb in his body.

However, the Orthodox martial artists that attacked Woon Seong had different ideas.

‘This guy.. He’s a monster. He is still standing still, even after this much of a beating!’, was the common thought between the assailants.

Woon Seong was outstanding as a martial artist to them, though they were even more frightened and wary at the fact a mere apprentice held out this long against 3 masters and was even able to injure one of them.

The next attack was one of zero practicality, and had more of a disgusting and vengeful feel to it, completely contradictory to any Orthodox belief or moral practice. It wasn’t even a stance or move from any specific practice. Jwa Do-Gyeul grinned with a disgusting smile at the limp and completely broken Woon Seong who was supporting his weight against his tattered spear.

He leapt up in the air and came down with his weight and holding his sword in a executioner type of manner.

Boom!

It was impossible for an already near-death practitioner to avoid such an obvious attack.

blaat-

Blood spattered like paint being thrown on a canvas as Woon Seong's body was struck once more directly to the ground by Jwa Do-Gyeu and his sword that penetrated through Woon Seong's flesh.

Gasp!

Woon Seong couldn't even make out any sounds from the pain he was going through. He just gasped desperately for air as his lungs had been pierced in that final blow.

'I wanted to at least take one down with me...'

He truly wanted to kill at least one of the hypocritical bastards that caused this terrible event.

'Master, I'm sorry.'

In the midst of Woon Seong's collapsing consciousness, his gaze landed on his teacher's resting face.

'I told you it was Jwa Do-Gyeul. I told you not to be too nice to him.'

Woon Seong felt bitter as he cursed the man Jwa Do-Gyeul even in his last moments, while looking with endearment towards his master.

If he and his master were to die like this here, there would be no one to recover their bodies.

No, even if they did, will these blasted and corrupt liars allow a tombstone to be built?

It was likely their bodies would be thrown into the woods and eaten by the wild animals residing there.

‘Master... if I can live another life, I will avenge you. I swear to you and myself that I will kill at least that man if I had the chance.’

There was no such thing called living a second life, or re-incarnation. It was simply a fact accepted by every sane man and woman in the world.

Woon Seong’s sight blurred as he sorrowfully wept for his caring Master.

His five senses were slowly getting more and more dulled, but to Woon Seong it seemed as if he could see his Master’s very soul departing in front of him.

‘So don’t be too much of a pushover in the afterlife. Take care of your own interests, okay?’

Woon Seong felt his life slowly coming to an end.

In the meantime, he could vaguely hear Jwa Do-Gyeul shouting something,

“I’ve knocked down these evil bastards HAHAAH!”

Woon Seong gathered all his strength to spit out the last curse while his consciousness was blurring.

“You fucking dog.”

The last word of a warrior and martial artist devoted to the spear that couldn’t defend his master due to his lack of strength.

But even as he said this, Woon Seong couldn’t hear anything or see anything else. He had lost consciousness.

But... no one knew nor did they notice it.

On the neck of the deceased Woon Seong, hidden beneath his robes.

There was an emerald green necklace with a crystal embedded in the center of it, shining ever so faintly.

Chapter 2: Second Chance (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon2 – Second Chance (1)

“Hmm.”

Sang In-Hyo, the General Director for the Cave of Latent Demons, a training facility for youth within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, handed over the pile of documents piled up in front of him.

All the documents he received were sent from the upper echelons of the Cult.

Sang In-Hyo looked carefully through the papers.

Skimming his eyes over the documents he rubbed his forehead out of habit from stress.

The Cave of Latent Demons was a similar training facility used to nurture youth and find talents, it was similarly designed to several programs within the Murim Alliance.

However, they did not educate the youth in a similar and ‘polite’ manner as the Orthodox Factions within the Alliance. This was due to the Cult being part of the Unorthodox Faction.

It was unlike the selective processes that the Orthodox went through as their code was similar to survival of the fittest. Only the most talented youth that showed promise would survive by the end of the training. The unfortunate ones however, were not so lucky.

While handing over the documents, Sang In-hyo recalled the three main teachings in the facility. More specifically, they were referred to as the 3

‘nots’

Keep up **not**, you die.

Strengthen **not**, you die.

Endure **not**, you die.

That very code they lived by, was what made the Cave of Latent Demons one of the most well-known programs for it's harshness.

It was inevitable to be brutal since the remaining talents would surely strengthen the power of the cult, and was only held every 20 years.

The reason for the 20 year periods in between, was to bring fresh talent of the younger generation to stimulate and compete with the older ones.

This training was surprisingly, just that effective.

It was inevitable that those who survived would become masters in their own right, and be able to hold themselves accountable and at least have means to protect themselves within all of Murim.

Though rigorous and harsh, one would wonder why even try to attempt the arduous training that walked the tightrope of life and death? It was simple. If one was a master, they could overcome any kind of pre-existing status and make a name for themselves and their loved ones.

However, there are no shortcuts to power.

This remained true for even the brightest of talents among the many youth gathered.

If a thousand children entered the Cave of Latent Demons, not more than 100 would make it out alive. One-tenth. That was just the survival rate. Finding the most supreme talents among them to become masters was even lower.

But, as difficult as the training was, there had to be some youth that continuously overcame setbacks and proved themselves to stand out.

“Who among the batch of youth has been standing out?”

Sang In-hyo would not be the only person to want to know either. The upper echelons wanted the director and his subordinates to keep their eyes peeled too.

When Sang In-Hyo was briefed half a year ago, his assistant mentioned three particular children to him.

Even if they stood out though, they would not get any kind of special treatment. One could die at any time here.

That was just the cruel reality of it all.

‘I wonder if anybody new has entered the lead.’

Sang In-hyo smacked his lips in curiosity to see if any new talents had shown up other than the three.

The assistant answered in earnest.

“As I mentioned before, Numbers 1, 17, and 109 continue to stand out amongst their peers.”

“So none of them have died yet.”

When Sang In-hyo heard his assistant’s report, he nodded.

The number of students that are taken in the Cave of Latent Demons consists of a thousand children each time.

And as soon as they enter the Cave of Latent Demons, they must abandon their names and receive numbers to identify themselves according to their talent level amongst their peers.

The one with the greatest talent was number 1, and the one with the worst talent was labeled as 1000.

‘Hm.. number Seventeen.....’

Sang In-hyo knocked on the table with his fingers, recalling No. 17.

She received a number of seventeen for certain reasons, even though she had talent rivaling the No. 1.

Considering her background, she would not be allowed to die, even if she failed here.

One of the most surprising things is that no. 109, who numbered in the hundreds, was being noticed among the children who stood out.

‘His resolve must be impressive.’

Sang In-hyo finished his thoughts about no. 109 and covered up the report.

Then, he asked in a passive tone,

“Anyone else except those three?”

At Sang In-hyo’s words, the assistant hesitated and opened his mouth.

“.....we have no. 900.”

Sang In-hyo’s eyebrows wriggled in skepticism at his assistant’s words.

“No. 900?”

A number like 900 was a talent almost on the verge of garbage.

In fact, those in the last 100 were intended to be used to alert the more talented children by dying early rather than using them as members of the Cult.

But, the 900th child was standing out.

It might have been understandable at the start when everybody had a fresh start... But, now of all times?

Wouldn't this be considered a record in all the history for the Cave of Latent Demons, that someone numbering in the 900's was even alive this long?

There were only 600 children alive!

Sang In-hyo's countenance demanded an explanation for what was going on with no. 900.

The assistant noticed this and continued to explain his findings.

"It was about half a year ago when no. 900 first started to change...."

* * *

"Whooh...."

Inside the dark stone room, was a young boy who looked to be about eleven years old.

The boy fell down with a look of exhaustion plastered all over his face.

"Ughhh."

The floor was hard and his muscles were sore.

He was incredibly tired at this point and wanted to fall asleep right away.

His eyelids felt as heavy as iron ingots as they wavered in the darkness of the room.

The boy could feel clearly all the kinds of bones and muscle fibers screaming at him to rest his adolescent body at once.

Any other ordinary boy would have fallen asleep as soon as they lay down.

But he wasn't some ordinary boy.

'I can't fall asleep right now.'

The boy got up from his seat and went to a corner of the stone room. Then soon he lit a small candle wick with a match.

whoohaa-

The small flame flickered to life in the darkness of the small cave that was the size of about 1 pyeong. Illuminating the corners of the room, the boy felt a warm and cozy air embrace his body.

It was obvious, this little stone chamber wasn't his real home.

It was just another small room that each child received when they entered the Cave of Latent Demons.

It was becoming a familiar place to him now.

The boy, who lit the candle, returned to his original seated position and sat with his back leaning slightly against the wall.

The unique cold touch of the cave transmitted its temperature to his back, awakening his mind and body from its exhausted state.

"Whoo-huuu."

Tapping into his 5 senses, no. 900 slowly closed his eyes and sank deep into his thoughts.

'It's been about half a year.'

The identity of No. 900 was actually Hyuk Woon Seong, the deceased apprentice of the Spearmaster Sect.

The very one who had been falsely accused with his master, and killed brutally by the hypocrites within the Orthodox Faction.

In fact, even he didn't fully understand the situation when he first woke up.

It was a matter of something fundamentally impossible.

'I definitely died.'

He knew better than anybody what his own ending was like.

The situation at hand, was not something he could dare to even try comprehending.

He first awoke in this body half a year ago.

It was incredibly embarrassing at first.

Why would a person who died in his mid-twenties be in the body of a child?

And he had these new memories that were not his, meddling and mixing with his previous life's memories. Who could possibly give him a reasonable explanation for what happened?

As half a year was not a short time, it was natural that there were many theories he tried to conjecture in that time.

And after contemplating his thoughts for that half-year, Woon Seong came to a conclusion.

'I don't know why I'm here... but if there was anything at all that could point to this happening, then it would be.....'

The gaze of Woon Seong subconsciously fell to an area around his chest.

It was a small, old necklace hanging around his neck.

Surprisingly, it was the same exact necklace that Woon Seong was wearing just before he died.

The artifact of the Spearmaster Sect.

It wasn't just some imitation of the artifact, but the real deal.

At first, Woon Seong thought he was coincidentally wearing a similar necklace.

However, there was no way that he, the former apprentice of the Spearmaster Sect, could not recognize the treasured artifact of his Sect.

It was a necklace that he had worn around his neck for over five years in his previous life.

Woon-seong knew by touching the emerald prism that was laced around the string with his fingertips.

He knew that he would always be loyal to the Spearmaster Sect and his deceased master, even in this life.

However, it didn't explain why he had been shoved into the body of some child that was in the Cave of Latent Demons. It was one the most powerful Sect of all the Unorthodox Factions.

But, Woon Seong had a slight hunch as to why he had been reincarnated into this body which was trying to get into the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

What power could have possibly interfered with his destiny to place him here of all places?

Even as he went through the grueling training of the Cult with this child's body, he still practiced the qi cultivation art that he learned in his previous life.

‘It's still not nearly enough.’

Woon Seong eventually just gave up trying to think about what impossible forces were moving him around and just went with what was in front of him.

He couldn't find any true purpose to this life for over half a year.

Even if he thought about it for a while now, nothing would really change in his path as a martial artist if he did nothing to improve.

If anything, it would be better to adapt to his current situation and decide later on what he needed to do in the future.

‘No, it’s actually clear what I need to do.’

The faces of the bastards who framed and brutally murdered his master and him.

By comparing and contrasting the memories between 900 and his old memories, it had been about 1 year since ‘he’ had died.

Of course those hypocrites would still be alive.

‘Then this time, surely Jwa Do-Gyeul... I will kill you for what you did.’

Hyuk Woon Seong gritted his teeth and recalled the face of the parties involved with his master’s death.

The faces of the sect leaders of several orthodox factions like the Mountain Cleaver, the First Apprentice and the Sage of Bright Rock came to mind.

They would surely die by his hands as well.

‘With another chance at vengeance, I can’t screw this up!’

Woon Seong, determined to get revenge for his master, checked his situation.

His body was untrained and didn’t have a speck of talent to be seen, when he first came to.

The place where he woke up was in the Cave of Latent Demons within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The body of an untalented child wasn’t really a problem. He had changed at least that much through his own training and hard work.

There were many and countless Qi cultivation techniques in the entirety of Murim, and there were also specific types of techniques that could even help cultivate talent.

And the previous Woon Seong happened to know one of those techniques.

第二章 건혼곤신(乾魂坤身) : The Heavenward Soul Earthen Body.

He paved the road to heaven by igniting his soul and he molded his body to become as firm as the earth itself in all its entirety.

So you had the soul of the heavens and the body of the earth.

That was the essence of this Qi Cultivation Art he was using.

This incredible Cultivation Art, fell into the hands of his Master when the Quanzhen Sect fell.

It belonged to the library hidden deep within the Spearmaster Sect, unreachable to anybody besides Woon Seong and his Master.

The effects of the Earthen Body were showing effect quickly, but the Soul that would change his talent was very slow since it was like pouring water into a dried up pond.

‘It’s not an easy process by any means. It should take at least 10 years to accumulate the amount of talent and internal qi needed to reach my old level.’

Although slow, the body of No. 900, now Woon Seong, has steadily grown in earnest. And there were some tangible results starting to finally show.

“We can solve the physical problem with this, but I just had to revive here didn’t I?”

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Actually, it was a little ironic and comical.

If there was someone writing the script of fate in the heavens above, then they surely liked to pull pranks.

The Unorthodox Factions.

In other words, in the Orthodox Factions, they would openly despise and condemn practitioners of the unorthodox path calling them, calling them ‘demons’.

Woon Seong felt the image of his master smiling at him, stimulate emotions within himself. He had lived an earnest and loving life, taking a child like Woon Seong in, who had nothing to live for. And what he did was nothing short of a miracle; giving Woon Seong a purpose in his life.

But that life had been reaped by the very hypocritical bastards of the other Orthodox Sects.

‘But, I really can’t believe I’m here, of all places.’

Woon Seong smiled faintly without realizing it.

However, there were always sides to both stories as his master had told him.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon and even the Unorthodox as a whole, were a little different than how the Orthodox portrayed them.

Yes, they might be condemned as evil, but even they had all been wronged by someone in the past that led them to create their purpose and group.

Woon Seong focused back on observing his internal circuitry and total internal qi he possessed. Even though Woon Seong had just come into this new body half a year ago, he had accumulated about 3 years worth of qi.

As his hidden identity being the deceased apprentice of the Spearmaster Sect, he needed to stay pursue his lonely road of vengeance alone.

He was making some progress steadily and shouldn’t complain too much really. If anyone else had his knowledge at 11 years old, they would be an unheard-of prodigy.

Even though at first Woon Seong felt disgusted about reviving in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, his master told him dearly in the past that not all Unorthodox Practitioners were ‘demonic’.

‘Maybe this is a good thing.’

Since he had to walk his path of vengeance alone, it might not be such a bad idea to take all that he could from here before his leave.

On top of all the teachings his master left him. He always emphasized harmony.

If he was to use a so-called ‘righteous’ attitude with a mid-level cultivation technique and stubbornly challenge his enemies like he did in the past, then it would all be in vain. Woon Seong decided that to keep the teachings of his teacher that emphasized harmony as well as taking a new path would be necessary.

He had to get stronger than anybody else.

Strong enough to decide other’s fate. Like the fate of the bastards who caused him ruin.

* * *

“Looks like 900 changed after consuming the poison 6 months ago....”

Sang In-hyo once again, contemplated his assistant’s earlier words.

Sometimes that happened.

After experiencing a life and death crisis, some people take the opportunity to change and challenge their so-called limitations.

But Sang In-hyo knew that pulling that off was not something easy by any means.

Most take that opportunity and their resolve that drove them to grow, but all of them inevitably fizzled out.

‘But, this means that no. 900 is still growing at an impossible rate for over 6 months now.’

Sang In-hyo lightly smacked his lips.

Of course, number 900 was not comparable to the top three that were mentioned earlier.

In the case of ‘the three’, they were still leaps and bounds ahead of everybody else at the Cave of Latent Demons.

However, the fact remained that no. 900 was growing at a rapid pace beyond belief, and was closing the distance.

‘There’s nothing wrong with watching him a bit more closely.’

Taking that into consideration, Sang In-hyo ordered his subordinates to observe 900 a bit more closely.

It wouldn’t be a bad choice to surprise the ‘brain of the cult’ with this chance of no. 900’s future.

Chapter 3: Second Chance (2)

3 – Second Chance (2)

Crick-Creeaackk-Criiik

From the depths of Woon Seong's new body, there was a fundamental change occurring internally.

His muscles stretched and contracted. His bones started to become reforged and remolded themselves to become more durable. His veins and capillaries pumped and pumped; speeding up his blood circulation. His very body was changing slowly and his mind was clearing up.

Woon Seong practiced the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body Technique diligently and circulated his internal qi throughout every nook and cranny of his body.

It was a different source of energy that affected his soul and was increasing his talent levels. Since the technique was working with the soul, it didn't interfere with his circulation of internal qi. This was because they were fundamentally two different types of energy.

Slowly but gradually, and meticulously, he was sculpting his body to become an unparalleled retainer for holding internal qi.

How long had it been?

Ba-dump!

Finally the sounds of his bones creaking and blood circulating, finally stopped.

The very quality of his own soul had slightly increased again.

‘It’s changed again this time.’

Woon Seong opened his eyes, feeling refreshed.

It wasn’t very noticeable, but the eyes on the body of No. 900, Woon Seong, were slightly different compared to last night.

Since the change was so miniscule, nobody would be able to notice it unless they tried to dissect him.

However, Woon Seong himself was clearly aware of his own change.

He clenched and unclenched his fist while trying to get adjusted to his new changes.

Hisss-

The candle’s flame last night had burned out already and it was early in the morning.

It was a new day of training today.

And it was also the perfect chance for Woon Seong to test his new strength through this training.

Woon Seong nodded to himself with a satisfactory smile.

Looking at the burnt out wick, Woon Seong guessed roughly what time it was.

“Is it almost three o’clock?”

It was probably around the end of night and about to break into the early morning dawn.

It was time for the children who were sleeping in their rooms to start waking up.

Some of the children could not wake up yet due to the injuries they were sustaining.

If the children broke one of the '3 nots' they would get a slap with a stick by one of the instructors.

Of course this wasn't just some light, little slap. It was bone crushing and bruising. Hence why some of them were not waking up.

Of course Woon Seong never got beaten, since he did his best to not only survive but grow here.

BONG- BONG- BONG-

"Everyone, gather around a few minutes!"

Sure enough.

There was a loud shout that could be heard from one of the instructors outside the children's rooms.

At the sound, Woon Seong opened the door of the stone chamber assigned to him, and went outside.

Thanks to practicing the Heavenward Soul and Earthen Body technique at night, Woon Seong did not need to rest and all of his bodily fatigue had gone away.

For the past year, all the children in the Cave of Latent Demons had been learning how to defend themselves and develop their bodies through endurance and strength training.

However, they had many more ordeals and different kinds of training to undertake.

The Cave of Latent Demons was a 10 year-long training program.

Therefore, it was paramount for the children to develop their bodies before undergoing any of the later tests.

‘Hm?’

There were always very small numbers of children who had developed early on and had a better start than others by learning some qi cultivation techniques or body cultivation techniques through their family backgrounds.

They might not have been the types to practice during their sleeping hours, but they must have practiced and developed themselves prior to coming here.

Of course, the original owner of No. 900 was an orphan, so he never had any opportunities to learn any of them.

In other words, his internal qi and body was incredibly weak when he first inherited the body.

Of course, the amount of energy Woon Seong could collect was minimal since his body wasn’t that talented yet. But he was able to hide his internal qi due to a special technique.

If an orphan without any kind of history or prior teaching had somehow cultivated internal qi in the Cave of Latent Demons, anyone would be suspicious of him.

For that reason, it was almost a miracle that Woon Seong had been able to secretly cultivate about 3 years worth of internal qi in only half a year.

It was all due to the knowledge and experience of his previous life.

Although Jwa Do-Gyeul was the bastard who had murdered him and his master, he had developed a technique known as intimidation qi. It was a technique that allowed the user to mask his true levels and hide the amount of internal qi he had cultivated.

Thanks to this, none of the instructors in the Cave of Latent Demons were able to notice any internal qi from Woon Seong.

Of course, he also had to cultivate his body slowly as well.

Many children were eliminated in the early trials of the Cave of Latent Demons due to not having the physical limits to cultivate, but there were still children who were enduring it.

In addition, most of them, like the previous owner of No. 900, had any knowledge of what internal qi even was.

All of these brutal training were being endured with the small body of a child.

As long as Woon Seong knew that, he couldn't use any of his previous techniques to physically develop his body at an accelerated rate even if he got bruised or broke any bones.

Of course, it was hard enough to not to die but he couldn't die here early.

On the other hand, he felt quite proud when he thought about it.

While practicing this grueling training as a child, it was hard to enjoy life in a cave. But, when Woon Seong thought of the long road ahead of him and how well he was progressing towards it, he felt empowered.

As Woon Seong was lost in thought, the children gathered one by one at the gathering place.

Woon Seong was located in Shiwan Hall.

The Cave of Latent Demons consisted of four halls. Two hundred and fifty children were placed in each hall.

The number of children who had survived until now, were about 130.

It was cruel but it was a fact that nearly half of the children died after a year of training.

More would die though.

They were still only in the first year of the 10 year training.

On the other hand, he felt compassion for them.

However, Woon Seong had to keep his mind steeled towards his goal.

He didn't have time or feelings to spare for the other children who would die, since he needed to survive as well and get his revenge at all costs.

'If it were my previous life, I would not have hesitated to help these children survive. But I can't. Not in this life.'

He had no intention of walking the path of a demon, but he had to walk the bloody and long road of vengeance.

For that purpose, he had to take advantage of every opportunity he could get.

Woon Seong closed his eyes for a moment, thinking about it.

His brief look of pity of compassion was erased and only determination could be seen in his eyes.

Then the instructors who ordered the assembly appeared.

'Looks like the morning training is about to begin.'

Morning training in the Cave of Latent Demons was hiking.

It seemed very simple, but that didn't mean it was by any means easy.

No wonder since they were located in the Daecheon Mountains, otherwise famed as 'the ends of the world'.

The reason for such a heavy name, was because the peaks of these mountains were incredibly steep. This made the climb incredibly difficult to grasp your footing, and was by no means easy to traverse 3 miles up a mountain and downwards for any 10 year-old child.

But, the children from the Cave of Latent Demons climbed these peaks every single day when they woke up.

That wasn't all however.

Originally, no matter how hard it was to climb a mountain as difficult as these, if you kept climbing the same mountain, one was bound to find little areas to rest and certain places that were easier on the body to climb.

In order to prevent that, the instructors changed the order of the mountain peaks the children had to climb every 10 days.

Thanks to this, even simple climbing became very difficult training.

On top of that, today was the designated day that the peak they had to climb would change again.

The children slowly all gathered into the hall, and stood there shaking off their early morning fatigue.

Just then, the last five instructors came into sight.

They were carrying a large sack on their backs, and when they put it down on the floor, a loud thud rang out inside the cave.

At a glance, it was clear that whatever was in the bag weighed a lot.

Though they were young, the children were no fools and also noticed it.

Due to the harsh training up till now, if the children didn't adapt a fast sense of wits, they would die inevitably.

"What is that?"

At the moment when all the children's attention was focused on the bag, including Woon Seong's, the senior instructor, who was at the forefront, smiled grimly and put his hand in the bag.

He pulled out several iron weight bracers.

"From today onwards, the level of difficulty in your training will increase! All of you will step forward and take these!"

As soon as the senior instructor finished speaking, other instructors turned the sacks over their shoulders and poured the iron bracers on the ground that were inside their respective bags.

‘Hm, arm and leg bracers.’

As soon as Woon Seong had seen the weights get pulled out, he immediately realized what they were for, and how he could benefit from this.

It was one of the most primitive ways to strengthen a martial artist’s body and muscles. Yet, surprisingly as countless years and different methods of training were found. This simple weight training was still incredibly effective. He remembered a time when he had tried something similar in his previous life.

‘It felt like each of my limbs would fall off.’

Thanks to trying this method in his past life, Woon Seong knew the benefits of this training. He would have incredibly well built muscles in his legs and arms that could be as strong as brick; and his stomach and abdomen area would flow and bend freely like an elastic band.

If the children wore these bracers and climbed up the mountain peaks for their morning training every day, it was inevitable that those who endured would attain incredible benefits for their own bodies.

Although some of them might die at a faster rate, it was also a high risk high reward type of training.

‘As simple as it is, this is actually something amazing for me.’

Thinking so, Woon Seong received his bracers from one of the instructors handing them out and attached one to each of his limbs.

The weight of each iron bracer that he received was about 7.5 kg.

Wearing one on each forearm and ankle, Woon Seong placed them in the places that would help distribute the amount of strain evenly throughout his

body and keep his strength balanced.

Among the children, there were some children who could not stand from the sudden increase of weight applied to them.

In order to adapt properly and climb the mountain, the children would need some time to adapt to the sudden increase of weight applied to them

But the instructors were harsh.

There was no time to adapt, since in reality this was not just a simple training session. They needed to nurture the strong ones that would bring a bright future to the Cult.

“I’ll give you 4 hours. Climb the mountain, take a flag and bring it back here. There are only 100 flags. Those who do not bring one down, will not receive breakfast.”

The meals that were served to the children in the Cave of Latent Demons, were incredibly nourishing and well balanced. However, they were small in portion and that meant every meal of the day was crucial.

Missing a meal, would mean even more pain and possibly death by starvation.

When the words hit the children’s ears, their eyes turned fierce and determined.

Since there were only 100 flags, around 30 of them would not have breakfast.

Some of the children had already bolted out of the hall and started climbing the mountain.

On the other hand, the children, who were a bit more calculative with their actions, did not immediately climb the mountain but rather, seemed lost in thought.

Seeing the scene unfold in front of him, Woon Seong clicked his tongue.

‘The ones waiting, will strike the weakened ones and take their flags.’

He knew what they were thinking.

As it was such a steep and arduous mountain to climb, adding weights on top of the already exhausted kids was bound to make them incredibly tired and exhausted.

These calculating kids who were lost in thought, were most definitely going to attack these weakened kids.

‘He must be thinking the same thing.’

Woon Seong glanced at a boy across from him on the other side of the hall.

He was one of the larger boys who had pretty good talent, he was known as No. 185. Though not exactly on the same level as No. 17, 1 and 109, he was definitely one of the strongest kids in the hall.

Most of the children, if attacked by him as they descended down the hill would lose their flag.

‘What’s disappointing is that he doesn’t even know the value of hard work, and wants to take the shortcuts to power.’

Woon Seong clicked his tongue in disgust and turned away.

Of course, it wasn’t like Woon Seong was an upright and moral person either, he even thought about it for a brief moment as well.

He would be able to definitely eat his breakfast easily without much trouble.

But eventually, the star began to move.

This was an opportunity to train and get stronger. With his goal in mind, he would do anything to achieve it. That being said, to achieve his goal, he needed to climb this mountain without complaints.

‘No. 17 just started to move.’

Woon Seong saw that No. 17 had started to move. He wasn’t sure why she was ranked 17th, because as far as he could tell with the experience of two lives, she was definitely the most monstrous talent in this entire Cave of Latent Demons.

Woon Seong closed his eyes and took a deep breath in.

“Whooh.”

Chapter 4: The Cave (1)

4 – The Cave (1)

Of all the types of training that had happened so far, none were quite as cruel as this one.

It was precisely because of the mental and physical fatigue piled on with wariness amongst the other children. It was the first time they had been pitted against each other in anything like a competition.

Among all the peaks in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the mountain that was selected this time, was one of the steepest in the entire domain.

It was so high up, that it seemed like the very peak of the mountain was about to pierce the heavens themselves.

Not only that, but the road was one of the most dangerous ones for the children to climb. The rocks were hard to grip and had no real solid footholds.

“Hoot. hoot.”

For any 10-11 year old climbing this mountain with lumps of metal on their limbs and not using any internal qi, this was a nigh impossible task.

But, not everybody here was average.

“Ahhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh!”

A boy next to Woon Seong had just lost his hold and rolled off the slope and landed on a patch of ground a few feet below.

“Uhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh!”

Although he was not seriously injured, his wound looked serious.

Woon Seong looked back and silently started to climb the mountain again.

In fact, he felt like he was about to die, too.

He refused to use his internal qi as a shortcut, and the body of No.900 was still incredibly lacking despite the small changes he had undergone through the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique.

“Hoo- hah, hoo- hah.”

His hands and fingers were bleeding a bit, as the blisters on them popped. His lungs felt like they were burning.

The hem of Woon Seong’s clothes was drenched with sweat, which only restricted his movement even more.

He really wanted to take a break right now.

‘No, I can’t rest right now.’

Woon Seong knew that if he rested here, his mind and body would get so relaxed, that he wouldn’t even continue to climb after he stopped.

Therefore, he steeled his mind and decided he would allow himself some rest once he reached the top and got a flag first.

Woon Seong just kept the image of his master in his head fresh every time he took a step up the mountain, and gritted his teeth with determination.

However, being strong-willed and suffering from physical exhaustion were slightly different issues.

Woon Seong climbed the mountain, biting his lips to the point of bleeding. As he was getting close to the top of the mountain he was almost crawling on all fours.

It wasn't just him though.

Almost all the children who were near the summit were at the point of climbing on all fours.

It was that difficult to endure.

The one silver lining in all of this, was that Woon Seong had fulfilled his promise to himself and not stopped once for rest until he would reach the top.

“Huhu, Hahaha.”

Woon Seong finally had reached the top, pulled out a flag and laid sprawled out on the floor to rest his body for a bit.

Fortunately, it was a large space at the summit to rest and about 50 other children were sitting or lying down resting their exhausted bodies next to their flags.

‘I definitely feel like I’m dying again ahah.’

Woon Seong started to regulate his breathing and regain his stamina as fast as he could.

As he finally was at the summit, he could feel the cool breeze hit his skin and start to cool down his clothes.

It was good to rest, but if he stayed too long his clothes drenched in sweat would get cold.

‘I have to go down quickly.’

There was even a time limit for this test, so he couldn't afford to rest more than a few minutes.

During the time he gave himself to rest, Woon Seong stretched his limbs that were sore and tried to regain as much stamina as possible before heading back down.

As Woon Seong was examining his body's condition, he darted his eyes to see how many flags were left.

There were about 30 flags left, excluding the one already in his hands.

'If the amount of flags gets thin, the last ones to reach the mountaintop will fight for the flags.'

It was just another reason for Woon Seong to leave and go down the mountain quickly.

If he stayed here, he would get caught up in a fight.

Sure enough.

The flags quickly ran out, and the children who came up late started to fight the ones with flags in their hands, trying to steal them.

Of course, Woon Seong had just slipped out before that started.

'Hm....'

Perhaps because Woon Seong took a short break, it felt like his muscles were a little rejuvenated and the way down was much easier.

What was even more interesting to him was the way he was descending down the mountain.

'Long flags are a problem for other kids to carry, but not for me.'

If the mountain is steep, it was harder to go down than to go up since you could slip and seriously injure yourself with your exhausted muscles.

On top of that, if you had to take a long flag in addition to the iron bracers, it became increasingly difficult to maintain one's sense of gravity.

However, this common sense was being broken by Woon Seong. It was quite comical if one looked at him going down the mountain.

He sprinted down the mountain using the flag like a spear, flipping, turning and gliding through the air multiple times as he speedily moved down the mountain with ease.

Tadak-Tadak-Tadak-

Woon Seong maneuvered the flagpole brilliantly and used the swiftness to cut some of the branches and twigs that hindered his view.

Woon Seong cut in from one of the side routes he was taking and went down the open road inbetween.

In a situation where one could have slipped, the only thing that could be seen was circular imprints from Woon Seong's flagpole as he flew down.

Toong-

He used the rebound of the force in the flagpole to propel him even faster.

It was absolutely incredible just how nimble he was. Anybody watching could tell Woon Seong in the body of No. 900 was incredible with a spear in his hand, just based on how he maneuvered with the long flagpole.

'It shouldn't be that hard to get down.'

It was natural for a smile to hang around the mouth of Woon Seong as he felt free like a bird with something resembling a spear in his hand.

However, the smile soon disappeared from Woon Seong's lips.

It was around the time he was about to arrive at the bottom of the mountain where the instructor was.

"Hey, leave your flag behind and get lost!"

A sudden voice shouted out at him in Woon Seong's direction.

Woon Seong slowed his movements and gradually came to a stop.

Comparing No.900's body to the body of the boy who had just shouted at Woon Seong was hilarious to most if they saw this. The boy was a head taller, wider and had a much deeper voice than Woon Seong in No. 900's body.

As Woon Seong stopped in place and glanced at him with indifference, No. 185's face contorted in anger and pointed with his two fingers at Woon Seong.

“Didn’t you hear me? The flag in your hand, leave it and buzz off you mongrel!”

Woon Seong's look of indifference disappeared and he looked at him, like he was looking at a fool and laughed.

The children gathered in the Cave of Latent Demons were in the ages between 10-15 years old

To Woon Seong, a mere height difference and deeper voice was a complete joke to him.

With a flagpole in his hand that could be used like a spear, it was borderline insanity for No. 185 to try and pick a fight with him.

But, it wasn't like No. 185 could possibly think that the boy in front of him could be the worst choice to try and rob. He, No. 185, who was used to intimidating others with his size and weight thought this would be easy even if things had to get physical.

In the Cave of Latent Demons, the children brought there didn't have such easy lives before they came there, so it wasn't as if No. 185 didn't know how to fight.

‘I bet you’ve probably grown up thinking size and intimidation is the easiest way to get the things in life that you want.’, Woon Seong thought.

He wasn't wrong, seeing how No. 185 was acting right now.

“Oh, this is funny to you?”

It seemed No. 185 had his pride hurt, as Woon Seong blatantly laughed at him.

Woon Seong boldly walked right up to No. 185 and sized him up.

looking at No. 185, Woon Seong spoke with a cold smile.

“What a fucking idiot. You ever heard of picking on somebody your own size?”

It was such a cold laugh that Woon Seong’s canine teeth were revealed.

Woon Seong glared at No. 185.

He already knew why No. 185 chose to try and rob him.

The ones who came down earlier than him were the ones who had continuously proved themselves to be elites among the elites here, and he didn’t want to fight them.

After those elites had passed, No. 185 was just waiting for the next person with a flag to show up since he was confident in beating them as long as they weren’t at the level who had shown up earlier.

No. 185 didn’t want to try his luck fighting against the other elite talents, even though he was technically an elite himself. He was just looking for an easy person to beat up, rob and get his breakfast.

And it just so happened the next one to come down the mountain was No.900.

To No. 185, No. 900 seemed to have non-existent talent, physique and strength. He assumed Woon Seong probably got the flag through sheer dumb luck.

‘That’s why he made a move on me.’

Because Woon Seong knew exactly what this bastard’s thought process was, he couldn’t just sit still and rather decided to beat him down here and now.

No. 185's morality and behavior was incredibly hypocritical. Bowing down to the strong and beating up on the weak, just because he could.

For some reason a bitter memory surfaced as Woon Seong thought of this.

“What did you say to me?”

No. 185 approached Woon Seong with an incredibly irritated expression.

From his point of view, meeting No. 900 was an absolute fortune.

Sure, No. 900 was doing alright these past few days, but he used to always beg and grovel like a bug half a year ago.

He was small and rarely talked to other children, so he was clearly an easy prey.

No. 185 didn't know how he came down quickly, but he pretty much knew that he must be exhausted.

So he had thought that if he threatened that bug a little bit, he would put the flag down quietly and obediently.

But what the hell was this?

Some half-wit who was ranked in the 900's was talking back to him? Him, who was ranked in the 100's?

Thinking about that fact, No. 185 couldn't hold back his anger and shouted loudly.

“What did you say? AAH!”

Cuckoo-

But he didn't know.

Even before No. 185 could process what was happening, the flagpole in the hands of Woon Seong was swung around.

It was a blow with the might of 7.5 kgs in both of his hands.

The wooden flagpole smacked the temple of No. 185.

“Ahhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh!”

No. 185 was holding his bleeding temple, jumped to his feet.

“You bastard!”

Then he swung his big fist right in front of Woon Seong.

But there was something that No. 185 couldn't possibly know. Sure the body was that of No. 900. But the soul was from a person that had reached the Transcendence Realm in his past life, using the spear.

Boo-woong-

Woon Seong casually avoided the blows from No. 185 very easily by taking a step back and shifting his center of gravity just a bit.

Boomp!

The flagpole had moved so fast No. 185 couldn't even see the movement, and struck No. 185's ribs incredibly hard.

“Uh-Urk!”

No. 185 was beaten down and his ribs were definitely broken as he was forced to kneel on the spot and gasp for air.

But that wasn't even the end of it from Woon Seong.

Puck-

Taking advantage of the fact No. 185 was forced to kneel, Woon Seong mercilessly and brutally crushed No. 185's ankles.

“Ack!”

No. 185 fell on the spot as he stretched out his legs one after another and rolled his feet.

It was fortunate that he didn't hit his head against the big tree behind him, but.....

Thud!

Before No. 185 knew it, the flagpole in the hands of Woon Seong was pressing down on the chest of No. 185 coldly.

“I bet you felt good being beating up the weaker kids than you, didn't you?”

At the question of Woon Seong, No. 185 lips trembled and dared not open his mouth.

He was so afraid of No. 900 right now that he felt as if he were the one that was a head shorter in height.

“Uhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh.”

Looking at his trembling expression, Woon Seong lifted up the flagpole in his hand.

Then, he grabbed the flagpole firmly as if he was about to drop it.

“No!! Please!!!”

No. 185 couldn't even move from his position and prayed to Woon Seong to spare him with a trembling voice.

No. 185 was only eleven years old.

It wasn't too young, but it was also not that old.

He wasn't at the age where he could clearly distinguish what it meant to be good or evil. He was old enough to pick on others and feel good about it, but he still had the chance to change his ways.

And trying to take Woon Seong's flag was not a sin worthy of death.

Of course, it was a sin big enough to warrant death if this was in another place and he was of a different age.

"I'll let you live. But.."

That didn't mean Woon Seong would just let him go though.

Furthermore, Woon Seong was not a just man either. At least not in this life, he couldn't be. Not only that, but if it were the other way around, he might have been killed without being able to fulfill his revenge for his master.

"You have to be punished."

Woon Seong lifted the flagpole in his hand high.

"So far, You've done nothing but pretend to be strong and do what you want to do to those who are weaker than you. You were probably sure that you would steal a flag off somebody weaker than you today as well. But now, maybe you'll be able to know what it's like to be the one on the receiving end of being weak."

"Come on, come on!"

No. 185 cried and pleaded with Woon Seong, but there was no mercy in the hands of Woon Seong whatsoever.

Qua-ric!

With the powerful impact of hitting his forearm, No. 185 lost consciousness.

But before No. 185 had lost consciousness, Woon Seong leaned in close and whispered to him some parting words.

"There won't be a second time."

At that voice, No. 185 trembled in utmost fear before losing consciousness.

Chapter 5: The Cave (1)

5 – The Cave (2)

‘He won’t die.’

Woon Seong glanced back towards the path near the mountain.

In the direction of his gaze, No. 185 laid sprawled out, unconscious.

It looked like No. 185 passed out from the pain that Woon Seong inflicted upon him. Woon Seong scoffed and turned around.

He proceeded to leave and grabbed the flagpole.

Thanks to the annoying presence of No. 185, he was a little tighter on time. Nonetheless, Woon Seong was confident to get to the bottom in time.

There wasn’t much time till the instructors ended the time for the training.

As if to prove it, Woon Seong began to see children resting one by one.

Some of them had bruises on their eyes or a lump on their head.

These children were injured in a large scuffle that had erupted at the top of the mountain when all of the flags had been taken.

‘I’m glad I came down early.’

Otherwise, Woon Seong would have likely been caught up in a large brawl like the kids resting before him.

Woon Seong smiled faintly and hastened his steps.

Of course, the process of going down the mountain was not so smooth.

As he descended down the path, there were children who rushed to take the flagpole from the hands of Woon Seong, much like what No. 185 tried to do earlier to him.

All of them were children who attacked because they thought with the impression that being No. 900 he would be weak.

Each time, of course, they were severely beaten and left bruised on the side of the path by Woon Seong.

‘Whoa, that’s a funny sight.’

When he knocked down the fourth child who attacked him, Woon Seong found out that there were hidden instructors watching him with nervous expressions for some reason.

What were they expecting? Woon Seong had been biding his time and hiding his talent as best he could, but now he could care less for such trivial things. If the instructors wanted to watch, he’d go ahead and give them a show.

Woon Seong eventually made it all the way down the mountain and arrived at the gathering place where the instructors were handing out breakfast to those who brought down a flagpole. There were a little more than 40 children who had brought down a flag before Woon Seong.

Among them, No. 17 was in the crowd too.

“I brought a flag.”

“It’s within the time limit. Take your meal.”

When Woon Seong handed over the flag, the instructor accepted it and handed over a fist-sized dumpling.

Dumplings were a nutritious and tasty prize with a balanced use of meat and vegetables for the children that they rarely got to eat in their time spent

at the Cave of Latent Demons.

‘It’s a little small, but there’s no nutritional problems at least.’

This was just a typical meal in the Cave of Latent Demons. The sense of satiety applied the logic of making a warrior lazy and never gave the children enough food to be full.

Woon Seong accepted the dumplings and joined the other children that were sitting down and found a spot. Getting comfortable on a patch of dirt he slowly began to eat his dumpling.

To increase the amount of nutritional value he could get from the dumpling, it was important to chew it little by little, slowly, and for a long time.

That way, even a small amount of it could actually fill your stomach appropriately, instead of just wolfing it down in one bite and staying hungry.

When Woon Seong almost finished eating his dumpling, most of the other children returned.

Like Woon Seong, the children who brought a flag received dumplings, and those who did not were forced to look at the other children with envious or resentful eyes.

No. 185 was the latter.

Woon Seong turned his head and looked at him.

No. 185 was escorted to the infirmary and had gotten his broken arm bandaged up. The interesting thing was that he was grinding his teeth with a resentful look at Woon Seong.

Nevertheless, he did not dare to make eye contact with Woon Seong.

It was because he knew well that he could do nothing about it.

Woon Seong stared at him for a while and eventually turned his head.

Now that he had breakfast, it was time to start a new type of training.

“You will learn martial arts in earnest from now on.”

After breakfast, the children of Shiwan Hall were greatly shaken by the words of the senior instructor.

Some children were learning martial arts because they had some background up till now, and the unfortunate ones with poor backgrounds did not have anything.

However, just because they weren't learning any martial arts, didn't mean they didn't know what it meant.

They could grow stronger and hold enough power to break free of the shackles known as poverty.

According to the stories told to most children when they were young, the best martial artists in legends could fly in the sky and split rocks with just one finger.

That was what learning martial arts meant to these kids.

It was natural for children to be shocked when they learnt that they would start learning what they wanted for so long.

The entire hall was chattering and got noisy quickly.

Boom!

“Be quiet!”

The senior instructor stomped his foot loudly.

Shockwaves emitted from the instructor's foot spread throughout the cave, leaving a clear footprint on the floor.

The ground around the footprint was left with cracks of earthen rock all around it.

Woon Seong's eyebrows trembled slightly when he saw it.

‘First-rate?’

Those who were considered first-rate martial artists were able to exert quite a bit of force from their bodies since to get to that level, one had to be able to accumulate quite a few years worth of qi. Not many people in the world of Murim could honestly call themselves first-rate martial artists. But with one glance, Woon Seong knew that he had clearly underestimated these instructors.

Once somebody was skilled enough to be called a first-rate, they were strong enough to level their surroundings when fighting. It was the very definition of breaking through human limits.

The senior instructor in front of him was a powerful man who could easily join small and medium sized clans as a major fighting force.

As Woon Seong was evaluating the senior instructor, the senior instructor looked at the quiet children and smiled with satisfaction.

“Just because you’ll be learning martial arts, does not mean you will be stronger right away. You can’t build a castle out of sand and expect it to be majestic. Just like you’ve been training yourself for the past year with preparation, you first will learn how to cultivate.”

He took a little booklet out of his robes.

“This is the Dark Flower and Red Spirit Method.”

Woon Seong nodded lightly as he heard the name.

The Dark Flower

Called the Dark Flower technique, it was one of the best foundational unorthodox techniques for building an incredibly solid foundation of pure demonic qi.

Orthodox cultivation techniques had the emphasis of stability but traded that off for slower growth compared to most unorthodox methods.

Unorthodox techniques typically had the polar opposite trade-offs. They emphasized fast growth with the risk of instability in the qi. This could lead to problems in later growth as a martial artist.

However, The Dark Flower Red Spirit method was a high level technique among the Unorthodox Methods. It was a rare method that Woon Seong had heard of. It had incredibly explosive growth compared to most Unorthodox Methods, but what was incredible about it, was the fact that it collected incredibly pure demonic qi with even better stability.

“Ones who already know how to read move to the right, and those who don’t, move to the left!”

At the senior instructor’s yell, the children first hesitated and then began to move to the groups they belonged in.

Of course, the group on the right was where Woon Seong was.

The senior instructor first approached the group of children who had learned to write.

“Before lunch, all of you will memorize the first thirty lines of text from the scripture.”

In other words, it seemed like the children who didn’t get meals earlier might not get lunch either based on the manner of speech the senior instructor used.

“Those who don’t know how to read will memorize one thousand characters and two hundred words a day. If you can’t memorize it, there will be no meal.”

The children’s eyes glistened with devotion at the words of the senior instructor.

It was not easy to memorize 30 phrases or two hundred words out of one thousand characters for either group.

Simply looking at the speed they were requiring the kids to learn at, it meant the children would be learning all the characters of the alphabet within 5 days. (T/N: in Korean, the dialect is known as Hangul. There are around 11 thousand possible character variations with it.)

It was important for kids to eat in the prime of their development so this was just another cruel punishment if they didn't meet expectations.

Starvation naturally made one physically weaker over time and the mind fatigued.

‘And this is a place where you die if you get weaker.’

It was cruel for sure, but the Cult of the Heavenly Demon only needed strong warriors to lead their cult. Not weaklings.

Woon Seong went up and received a booklet along with the other kids that was being handed out by the instructor.

‘The Dark Flower is supposed to be within one's body and is not yet in bloom, so it represents one's potential.’

—

The Red Spirit is one that rages and surges with one's passion.

The Dark Flower as the medium, will neutralize the ferocity of the Red Spirit but still allow it to show its passion.

When the Dark Flower and the Red Spirit meet within one's self, they will come together and fuse with each other.

The act of combining the Dark Flower with the Red Spirit allows one to temper their passion and potential with each other while creating a balance.

This balance represents a heavenly entity in it's perfection.

This Heavenly entity that would reach perfection would become the great Heavenly Demon himself!

—

Any warrior seeing this scripture could not help but be tempted with greed looking at such a high-level technique.

However, Woon Seong boldly curbed aside the greed within himself.

‘I am the apprentice of the Spearmaster Sect, and I will not abandon my roots.’

The Spearmaster Sect's technique that Woon Seong practiced to gather internal qi was called ‘The Completed Method of the Tempered Orthodox Qi’. The Heavenward Soul and Earthen Body was a technique he used to increase the level of his soul; which in result increased his body's talent and tempered his body to become a retainer. It was fundamentally a different technique that did not gather any internal qi within the body.

Because of his roots and devotion to his goal and master, it was easy for Woon Seong to abandon his greed for this technique.

But.. that didn't mean he had to completely give up on the technique. With sudden inspiration, Woon Seong suddenly thought of something incredible!

‘The Dark Flower accumulates the purest demonic qi possible with incredibly fast growth, but the Tempered method of Orthodox Qi boasts the greatest stability. Is there a way to possibly combine the two and create a wholly new method?’

The Dark Flower Red Spirit method had stability, but compared to the Tempered Orthodox Qi method it was lacking.

Combining the two that had naturally opposing natures, would be incredibly difficult. However, if he somehow succeeded with that slim chance, the new

method that resulted from it would be incredibly powerful and stable. If it did fuse correctly as well, then it would also have unparalleled synergy.

Plus, having demonic qi was a must when inside the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. If one didn't have a hint of demonic qi, it would raise suspicion.

Combining the two, would allow Woon Seong to not abandon his roots as an apprentice to the Spearmaster Sect, and also take as much strength that he needed to fulfill his goal of revenge from the Cult.

If he used the same method as before, he would have a very difficult time reaching new heights that were necessary in order to fulfill his goal of revenge.

Either technique here on their own would not be sufficient for him. But combining the two, could give birth to something incredibly powerful!

Furthermore, his life as the apprentice of the Spearmaster was not his current identity. He right now needed to assume the identity of a member of the Cult.

The Spearmaster Sect was devoted only to developing the pinnacle of Spearmanship.

However, the Spearmaster Sect was known for one other thing. Their library was full of techniques. Unlike other Sects, the Spearmaster Sect did not discriminate in gathering knowledge from all sorts of techniques as their goal was to reach the pinnacle of spearmanship. Cultivation techniques were just a means to growth.

'Let's take a chance and try it.'

Both cultivation methods were highly stable, so the possibility of suffering any kind of qi deviation or backlash was negligible.

If it didn't work, he could just give up on learning the Unorthodox Methods inside the Cult.

‘But in order to do this, I’ll have to memorize the passages of the Dark Flower Red Spirit first.’

After closing and opening his eyes, Woon Seong calmly began to memorize the lines within the scripture of the Dark Flower.

It was not too difficult to memorize the lines in the passage.

A total of 30 lines.

To Woon Seong who had loved literature when he was in the Spearmaster Sect, this was a cakewalk.

Plus there were over 100 lines of scripture in the entire Method. Just learning 30 per day was easy enough.

Of course not all the other children would be like that.

More than half of the children did not know how to read, and even if they did, it was not easy for children who knew to memorize all 30 lines of scripture.

What was interesting to Woon Seong is that he could see just how much time and effort the Cult put into developing these talents. Although harsh, they did not hesitate in using as many resources as possible. This was why Woon Seong was surprised that the instructors had actually been already teaching some of the kids in their free time over the past year, how to read earlier on.

However, learning and memorizing the techniques was not easy even for these kids, and as a result, only about 20 kids had been able to leave the hall for lunch.

All of these 20 children went and started a new training after lunch.

Woon Seong was just busy experimenting. He could already feel the movement of qi within his body.

‘I can already sense how this technique moves.’

To actually cultivate qi, it meant one had to find the pathways of the method, open them up with internal qi and then make the qi flow smoothly and cycle it throughout the body.

In general, it would take about two days for a talented child to truly feel the qi from the method coursing throughout their body.

In the case of those who severely lacked talent, it would take probably around 10 days.

Of course, there were only a small number of kids who were just starting to get the basics down and feel their own internal qi. This didn't mean they could move it around or find their pathways. But it was incredible to even be able to do that with only a few hours of practice.

In the case of Woon Seong, it was not long after waking up in the body of No. 900 that he had already begun to start cultivating internal qi within the body.

The stages of feeling energy had already passed for him.

“Those who feel something cold, hot, or itchy within their body, raise your hand.”

According to the instructor's instructions, Woon Seong should have raised his hand.

But he didn't.

It had only been two hours since he had learned the first 30 lines of the scripture.

However if he said he already felt the energy within his body, it would be absolutely ridiculous and preposterous.

What was interesting was that the other kids who had started to develop and feel the energy within themselves also did not raise their hands.

‘No. 17 is also playing coy like myself.’

Woon Seong had already mastered feeling his and others qi in his previous life. Thanks to the technique he was calling ‘intimidation qi’ which hid his internal qi completely, nobody would be able to notice that he was proficient with qi already.

Woon Seong decided that he would raise his hand in about 3 days.

‘I can’t raise it too soon nor do I want to raise it too late. I need to pick somewhere in between.’

Thinking so, Woon Seong again focused on his body.

The energy in his body moved according to the direction and in the specific pathways within his body.

At the same time, he began to slowly wash away the fatigue accumulated while climbing the mountain that morning.

By evening, almost all the fatigue accumulated in his body had disappeared.

After about five days, children who did not know how to read began to learn how to cultivate.

In fact, there were few children who made rapid progression due to their talent, despite not being able to know how to read at first.

In the meantime, time passed slowly.

* * *

Unlike breakfast and lunch, dinner was given fairly without any kinds of condition attached. It was because of the policy that starving from evening to morning could disrupt the next day’s training.

Woon Seong ate his dinner that was given to him and went back to his room.

In the evening, time was given for free training or relaxation, but Woon Seong obviously didn’t want to socialize with kids.

‘What am I supposed to talk about with kids ten years younger than I am?’
(T/N : LMAO)

During the time given, it was much more profitable for Woon Seong to go and practice the Heavenward Soul Earthen body technique to cultivate his talent in secret, and if he had time left, he decided to start experimenting with the combination of the two qi cultivation methods he was referring to earlier.

‘Before completing all the training within the Cave of Latent Demons, I need to be at least first-rate.’

Being able to call one’s self first-rate, they had to be able to channel qi into their weapons and limbs. Although they couldn’t materialize it outside their body, since that was what those at the Peak Realm and above could only do, they could utilize incredible might behind their attacks.

Woon Seong set his goal to become first-rate by the end of the 10 years here. If he couldn’t achieve at least that much, he would never be able to get his revenge.

If he had the power right now, he would go right up to Jwa Do-Gyeul and rip him to pieces after torturing him alive.

As soon as Woon Seong had entered his room and was about to shut his door, someone placed their foot in between the door and the hallway, stopping him from closing the door completely.

With an irritated and uncomfortable look on his face, Woon Seong opened the door and identified the guest who came to his room.

Long, light brown hair that came down to shoulder-length. Neat and tidy clothes despite being in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Woon Seong was irritated at the fact he let somebody sneak up on him without noticing their presence beforehand, but it was the limitations of his current body and he could do nothing about it yet.

“Hi?”

Chapter 6: Change (1)

6 – Change (1)

No. 17 was the best in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Woon Seong didn't think she was just the best in terms of talent, he also thought she was the best in how she carried herself among the other children.

On top of that, every one of her behaviors had purpose and meaning behind them.

‘Considering the actions and behaviors of the instructors, it's safe to say she has quite a background.’

Woon Seong also didn't exclude the possibility that she might have a relative that was a high-ranking member of the Cult.

He was sure it was one of the two.

Either she came to the Cave of Latent Demons to get stronger by her own choice, or she was forced by her family to come.

However, none of this had anything to do with Woon Seong.

‘How would she react if I showed my true talent?’

That was Woon Seong's only concern.

However, it was a little surprising that No. 17 actually came and visited him, who was ranked No. 900, out of her own volition.

“What do you want?”

Woon Seong stared at No. 17 beyond the wooden door with a slightly cold look.

At the words, No. 17 gazed slowly at Woon Seong and opened her mouth.

“You did it, didn’t you?”

‘What?’

At the mysterious words from No.17, Woon Seong stared at No. 17 silently.

Of course, the matter of No. 185 passed through Woon Seong’s mind briefly.

“No. 185.”

‘Ugh.’

At the words of No. 17, the Woon Seong clicked his tongue.

‘Was she watching?’

His weak body and talent that was still making improvements, wasn’t helping him right now, seeing that she must have been able to sneak by his senses.

It wasn’t just the realm of Woon Seong that had lowered, but his senses were still slightly dull because of his body that still lacked a lot of things.

“Yeah, but it’s not like I broke any of the rules here.”

“So you’ve been hiding your power all along haven’t you?”

Woon Seong glared coldly at No. 17.

“Why should I tell you even if I was, it’s not like you’re any different.”

No. 17 despite being ranked so high, was actually also hiding a vast amount of her talent and power. Of course even though Woon Seong's senses might have dulled a little bit, it wasn't like he could blatantly miss that kind of thing, especially if the person in question was right in front of him.

When Woon Seong pointed out that fact, No. 17's eyes widened with surprise.

“You knew?”

“.....”

When Woon Seong did not answer, No. 17 smiled faintly.

“You're interesting.. hehe!”

As Woon Seong predicted, No. 17 was one of the descendants of the high-ranking members of the Cult.

Thanks to this, her skills were already incredibly strong that it was hard to find an opponent among her peers.

Even the instructors couldn't underestimate her ability.

Ordinary children would not notice that No. 17 was hiding her power, which was normal.

However, Woon Seong spoke of it as if it were an obvious fact right in front of her.

“It's because I have some pretty good eyes for that type of thing.”

At the words of No. 17, Woon Seong replied brusquely.

She had already seen himself knock down No. 185 with incredible ease.

It didn't matter to Woon Seong that she was hiding her power; what concerned him, was her cleverness.

Furthermore, stating the fact that she was hiding her power, it was an indirect threat.

However, it seemed that the indirect threat from Woon Seong had gotten through to her.

She pressed her lips lightly with her fingertips.

“Well, then I guess I’ll keep your secret for a while. By the way…….”

It was a bit of a surprise that she did not just turn around and leave but rather, wanted to leave some words for Woon Seong.

Woon Seong glared daggers at No. 17 preparing for any kind of counter-threats she might give.

“No. 185 was gnashing his teeth at you.”

Woon Seong sighed at her words.

It seemed she was still a child by heart and in her sincerity.

Perhaps she had gained some confidence in thinking that No. 900, Woon Seong, had only just learned the basics of Qi cultivation that day.

She probably thought that he didn’t really have that much power, but she still thought he was interesting.

Her line of thinking was a common mistake for those who had high praise from a young age and had little experience in the *true* world of Murim.

However, he already knew what he would do with No. 185 if he dared go again after he spared him and clearly told him that there would be no second chances with mercy…….

‘If he does I’ll kill him.’

By the time Woon Seong calmly wrapped up his thoughts, No. 17 spoke again with a cheery and innocent voice.

“Wow, you’re so calm. You must be able to knock down No. 185 any time you want.”

“I’ve told you this before, but don’t talk about it as if you’re any different. You should know well that this Cave of Latent Demons is not a place you can slack around in”

“What? Hahaha....HAHAHAHAH!”

Woon Seong’s words made No. 17 laugh loudly into laughter.

The eyes of the children who were outside still in the hall turned and all focused in the direction of where No. 17 and Woon Seong were talking.

“My name is Ah-Young. My last name is a secret. So it’s just Ah-Young. What about you?”

Woon Seong, clearing his throat hinting to No. 17 to get lost.

“No. 900. That’s all you need to know.”

Boom-

At the end of the sentence, Woon Seong shut the door coldly on Ah-Young.

Ah-Young kept her smile though even after getting the door shut on her, her eyes twinkling in half-crescents as if she had just found something incredibly interesting.

“He’s so interesting..hehe.. I’ll guess I’ll have to wait and see.”

—

Three days passed by.

During that time, Woon Seong tried to fuse the Dark Flower Red Spirit and the Orthodox Tempered Qi

Of course, it was incredibly difficult to try and fuse two completely different cultivation methods into one.

However, it wasn't impossible. Also, Woon Seong was incredibly well versed in the countless types of qi cultivation methods that were located within the Spearmaster Sect's library.

Despite the Spearmaster Sect only being a Sect that had a single successor, it had accumulated countless amounts of literature and qi cultivation methods.

'There's nothing impossible in the world of martial arts. I just need to be meticulous and take it slowly.'

In fact, there had already been some tangible results.

To some extent, the two methods began to fuse already.

Of course, there were still certain pathways and flows that had not been fused yet.

But Woon Seong could go over each and every one of those and fuse them one by one.

At night, he practiced the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body.

Woon Seong also faithfully participated in daytime training.

First, on the third day, he raised his hand that signaled that he felt energy within him.

The instructors, who did not expect much from a talentless No. 900, were a little surprised.

It was much faster than expected for them.

However, they did not believe that No. 900 at first, but when they confirmed it by feeling the pathways and flow of qi that Woon Seong had allowed them to see, they could not deny reality.

Shortly after revealing the fact he could feel energy within his body, the way he trained was slightly changed by the instructors.

On the fifth day-

There were two incredibly noticeable changes for him.

First of all, the weight of the iron ring on the arms and legs increased by half.

The total number of pathways he had opened with his new cultivation method was 10, and he had succeeded in successfully fusing 4 of them completely.

Another change was the fact that small balls were given to the children during their morning mountain climbing.

‘Don’t let go of the ball and also don’t let it get taken away by others.’

If the ball was taken away, there was no breakfast even if the children were successful in bringing a flag down.

On the other hand, even if you couldn’t bring a flag down, you would be given breakfast if you somehow collected three balls.

There was a constant scramble among the children to take the flags and balls from each other.

As this change started to get fully implemented, the children naturally learned how to use their bodies properly through several scuffles and fights from the cutthroat addition to the morning training.

Of course, Woon Seong clicked his tongue when he saw the other kids starting fighting with each other.

‘I can’t believe you’re using a simple capture the flag type of training like this.’

It was an indirect way of training the children to know what desperation was, and what fighting for your life on the line meant.

‘It doesn’t matter to me though, because I will not bow to anyone if it comes to meeting my goals.’

Of course, Woon Seong never lost his flag or ball. He clearly distinguished himself among the other kids by knocking them down mercilessly.

‘It wouldn’t be bad to show some of my skills if it means shaking off these annoying bastards.’

Woon Seong had started to become aware that the instructors had started to observe him more in secret, but they did that for all promising individuals so he knew it wasn’t a bad thing.

Especially since he had openly shown incredible speed in regards to qi cultivation, their gazes had become more keen.

As Woon Seong steadily strengthened his position, No. 185, who had been stubborn and starting to plot revenge, did not dare to attack Woon Seong.

When Woon Seong had first felt the energy, he knew he had to start distinguishing himself from that point on. It was not a question anymore since the fork in the road was coming near.

The fork in the road had two options. Become strong, or be the weak ones who were trampled on.

And so... another year in the Cave of Latent Demons had passed.

* * *

A year was by no means a long time, nor was it a short time.

However, considering the children’s ages, it was clear that a year was by no means .

No wonder, over the past year, the appearance of the children in the Cave of Latent Demons had changed remarkably.

It was only a year, but the boys began to develop their muscles, jaw lines and their respective masculine traits.

On the other hand, even the girls began to show a very small, but feminine appearance.

It wasn't just changes related to gender physiques however.

The children's gazes were sharpened and their mentalities had started to show qualitative changes.

The daily competition over meals was getting fiercer day by day.

Of course, what was distinctively different in this past year, was that not a single child dared to provoke Woon Seong, otherwise known as No. 900 to them.

For the past year, the children were well aware of the fact that Woon Seong had been undefeated in combat, just like No. 17.

Sometimes, after several consecutive victories, there were some people who rushed to their confidence thinking that he might be exhausted, but they were ruthlessly crushed by Woon Seongs hands before they had even taken 5 steps near him..

What happened a month ago was also crucial in their decision to consciously avoid any kind of contact with Woon Seong.

When Woon Seong received his meal in the morning once again, without missing a single meal for over a year, some of the children who saw this with bitterness joined together into a large group and tried to attack Woon Seong.

For once, the other children observing this take place, thought that No. 900 had finally met his match.

However, the result was one that not even the instructors observing Woon Seong from the shadows expected.

Woon Seong completely demolished and ruthlessly beat all 5 of them with complete and utter ease.

Since then, the other children had to make a conscious effort to even avoid eye contact with Woon Seong.

Even No. 185, which was looking for a chance to exploit and exact his revenge, completely avoided Woon Seong's gaze.

‘Pft. Even I can’t adjust to this change in treatment.’

Woon Seong smiled and laughed internally at the children who were clearly trying to avoid his eyes.

Over the past year, there had been many changes that Woon Seong had undergone..

First of all, the effect of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body began to develop his body in earnest and was clearly making visible changes.

His bone and muscle density and even cognitive abilities had increased several fold. Even No. 185 who had been almost 2 heads taller than him just a year ago, was barely a few centimeters taller than Woon Seong recently.

On top of that, my shoulders began to broaden quite a bit.

Now it was hard for anyone to imagine that Woon Seong's current body belonged to the old No. 900.

‘It’s not fully completed, but if I can break through a few more meridians, I can exert more force than I currently can by several fold.’

At least that’s what the Woon Seong thought.

Both his internal and external frame had been tempered by both the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body and his newly completed cultivation

technique that he had been working on developing the past year. He had named this technique after much deliberation.

Tempered True Blossom (磨砂真花) : *The firm and unshaking roots will bloom a true flower.*

Chapter 7: Change (2)

7 – Change (2)

“Starting today, you are all going to begin training with weapons!”

It was exactly a year ago when Woon Seong first showed any proficiency with pole-type weapons. A direct result of this, was beating on the other children with a flag-pole on the first day of the mountain climbing with them.

Over the past year, the surviving children had become stronger and the number of children dying had decreased significantly.

Therefore, the children that had made it this far, were somewhat confident in their abilities.

In addition, the weight of the iron bracers the children were given had increased to 45 kgs.

Of course, it was no longer a weight that was possible to climb the mountain without using internal qi.

Woon Seong was also no exception to this even with his newly strengthened body from the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, was no exception to this. However, this also gave him the opportunity to practice circulating his new cultivation technique.

Of course, Woon Seong did not stop at just circulating his new technique and internal qi. He began to penetrate the clogged veins and muscles that were strained or tightened within his body and cleansed his body of any impurities on a microscopic level.

‘It’s going to be a lot to learn for the other children, since learning about the basics of whatever weapon they choose on top of their already incredibly tight training schedule will be difficult.’

In any case, it wasn’t much of a problem for Woon Seong since he knew exactly what weapon he would choose and already was incredibly well versed in the mastery of it.

But for the other children, they were incredibly excited about finally learning about the types of weapons they wanted to choose, because it was a tell-tale sign of finally becoming a recognized martial artist.

In front of these excited children, the senior instructor and other instructors at the Shiwan Hall took out three carts.

“As you know, these are the weapons that are the staples of the martial arts societies today.”

The instructors each took out a single-edged and heavy sword, a light double-edged sword, and the spear.

They were called the Dao, the Jian and the Spear

But what they put down was the most basic appearance of the three weapons.

“You will choose one of these weapons and learn it’s corresponding martial arts. If each of you has a weapon you want, go and stand in front of it.”

The children began to hesitate at the words of the senior instructor.

It was evident that each of them were agonizing over which weapon would be the best for them.

But there were also children who were moving fast among them.

One was the No. 17 and the other was Woon Seong.

Ah-young walked without hesitation and stood before the Jian.

It was pretty much an absolute given fact that Woon Seong darted right over to the spear.

The next one to move was No. 185. No. 185 looked at Woon Seong and Ah-young, and stood before the Dao with an uncomfortable expression.

No. 17, No. 185 and No.900. The three strongest children in this hall had picked their weapons.

Only after this, did the other children begin to move hesitantly.

“Decide carefully! This weapon will be with you for the rest of your life!”

The instructor’s warnings and instructions continued, as the children stopped and moved again as if to think again.

Most children chose the Jian, of course. It was the most classic and commonly used weapon in Murim. It offered balance, strength and mobility in a proportionate manner.

Next, the number of children who chose Daos was the second highest, and the number of children who chose the spear was... the lowest.

It was a natural result because there was a certain amount of reverence for the spear due to its complex mastery compared to the other weapons.

Even the children that had not heard much about the spear or the respect masters of the spear received, they knew from a glance that using a spear was no easy feat.

‘That has nothing to do with me.’

The instructors also looked over what each child chose and advised them if one weapon would be more suited to them or not.

The children were then given three books each on their individual weapon, leaving them with quite a bit to look at when learning the basics of their respective weapon.

‘Is it the Seven Stars of the spear?’

Two of the books were the basis of movement techniques involved and a manual for the weapon titled ‘The Seven Stars of the Spear’.

Woon Seong recalled old memories when he saw the cover of it.

‘I felt really excited when I first learned it.’

The other two books that were added to that were the Six Combinations of the Fist and the Cloud and Wind Movement technique.

The knowledge of all basic, intermediate and some advanced techniques were ingrained into Woon Seong’s very soul.

After setting up the foundation of his body and mind with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, he had developed an incredibly high-level qi cultivation technique and now... he finally had the spear.

“From now on, you will have time to study and learn about the martial arts of your weapons on your own! The instructors will be waiting here, so if you have any questions or things you don’t know, we will do our best to teach you!”

The senior instructor spoke to the children in a more lenient manner compared to the first time he started here.

He wasn’t acting generous without reason though.

‘I’ll help you learn, and in return learn about how many of you will survive in half a year. Hehe, if you don’t learn how to do it properly, you’ll probably have a hard time surviving. Even if you survive, you’ll be half-dead.’

He was just having the same mentality as always since it provided him the opportunity to report more in detail to his superiors.

The instructors’ eyes that were set on the children were shining with a rather frightening look.

Woon Seong took his booklets and went to the corner of the cave.

He looked through the booklet first.

He knew everything, but he read it one more time just in case there was anything new since he had died.

There was nothing new it seemed.

He already knew every single thing in the book, so he only looked at the book as a cover to his skills from the instructors.

‘The basics of spearmanship, the thrust, the strike and the cut.’

Picking up the spear, Woon Seong smiled faintly and started to move.

The Cut, picking up the spear and letting it bounce and whip with sharp movements like a hummingbird.

Striking, winding the spear like the spiral of a conch shell and exploding it forward with force.

The Thrust, stab forwards with unwavering confidence and precision .

Those were just the three most basic movements of spearmanship. Combine those with parrying, blocking, twirls and many other fundamentals, it created an infinite series of possibilities.

There were 36 moves within the spearmanship manual. Putting those numbers and multiplying them by each other was just another reason why spearmanship was regarded as the most complex and yet the most revered weapon of choice.

Wrrring-Siik!

The spear in the hands of Woon Seong moved with utmost elegance, precision and rampaging ferocity. He did this in a quiet corner of the cave to avoid others eyes. Yet... there were three sets of eyes that were secretly

watching his every move with all 3 having different expressions on their faces.

The senior instructor, Ah-Young, and lastly No. 185.

* * *

No. 185 had been constantly looking for a chance at revenge on Woon Seong ever since his humiliating and embarrassing defeat to him.

Having lived in the world of Murim and seeing his Master get killed in front of his very eyes by people that plotted against him in the dark, Woon Seong knew very well what those people looked like.

Those with violent tendencies and not much brain to their brawn tend to die early on in life. Those who plot in the darkness and take their chances carefully and only act when absolutely needed to. No. 185 however, was not the smartest child in the Cave of Latent Demons.

In fact, he didn't hesitate to fight with other children or start unnecessary arguments.

In addition, he rarely lost to the other children.

It was because he was quite big compared to others his age, and he had been trying his hardest to get back at Woon Seong.

However, he couldn't even think about challenging Woon Seong yet.

'How the hell am I supposed to defeat that monster?'

He couldn't think of any method or scenario in his head where he could possibly win against No. 900.

In addition, the group attack by some of the other children not too long ago had failed miserably. Even trying to use numbers against No. 900 was useless.

Woon Seong had clearly set himself apart from the other children when he smashed apart the group attack the others had tried.

But what frightened him even more, was seeing Woon Seong wielding the spear in the corner of the hall.

It had only been one hour since Woon Seong had received the book on basic spearmanship and there was no way for anybody to read all of the contents within the book in under an hour. Yet, Woon Seong was shattering all sorts of common sense within No. 185's head right now.

The way he was wielding the spear was skilled. Too skilled.

No. 185 sighed deeply and grinded his teeth in anger.

‘Fuck you, you bastard.’

No. 185 did not forget the humiliation of being thrashed and made a fool by Woon Seong.

Whenever he saw him, his broken arm from that time felt like it was still throbbing. His body trembled with anger when he remembered the day he was still in pain for weeks after, even though the instructors said there was nothing wrong with his body.

He was going to get revenge no matter what. He just had to play it safe and hide his ambition and anger until it was ripe.

Only stupid people would show their anger and pick a fight when they were clearly outmatched.

And the eyes of No. 185, which gritted its teeth, was the eerie and frighteningly talented No. 900.

* * *

“I guess No. 900 really has changed.”

Sang In-hyo nodded as he listened to the report from the senior instructor in charge of Shiwan Hall.

Surely as the report says, it was clear No. 900 had changed. It was so baffling and almost unexplainable how this child was deemed so low in terms of talent.

Now even Sang In-hyo was visibly interested in the changes from No. 900.

“It wouldn’t be too difficult for him to pass the Gates of Life and Death in half a year.”

Sang In-hyo nodded at the words of the senior instructor.

The Gates of Life and Death was the first gate of trials symbolizing the Cave of Latent Demons.

This event was an event so dangerous since almost half of the children would die from this trial alone, which was incomparable to the past trials they had been facing up till now.

If they could cross this Gate, you could be officially recognized as a Demonic Soldier within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

A Demonic Soldier was the lowest of ranks within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, as there were the Demonic Captains, then the Demonic Generals and even after that, the Great Demons which were ranked just below the 10 Demonic Masters and the Heavenly Demon himself .

In particular, the 10 Demonic Masters were almost never seen in public and directly served under the Great Heavenly Demon directly.

However, a Demonic Soldier was by no means an easy rank to achieve.

Fewer than 10,000 of the 100,000 members who made up the entire population of the Cult, were able to become recognized as Demonic Soldiers..

What made the Cave of Latent Demons so special as a training program, was the fact that kids under the age of 15 were able to become ranked as such.

Reaching that level of martial arts in Murim was very difficult.

‘But it’s the Cave of Latent Demons. We don’t hold this program just to produce mere Demonic Soldiers. Reaching that rank should be the bare minimum of talent required.’

The Cave of Latent Demons was made as a special program to produce Demonic Captains.

Only 2,000 members of the Cult could be strong enough to be called Demonic Captains.

In addition, this Cave of Latent Demons was a little more special than the previous generations that came from the Cave.

‘We have to produce a few Demonic Generals. It would be even better if we could somehow produce a Great Demon....’

In fact, Sang In-hyo knew expecting to raise a Great Demon was too much. He himself was barely ranked within the ranks of the 200 Great Demons in the Cult.

In any case, even if only one or two were able to reach the levels of Demonic Generals, it would be already considered an incredible success.

“How’s the preparation going for the Gates of Life and Death?”

“We sent out some of our own to buy and even train some of the beasts within the trial. By the time the Gates of Life and Death open, they will definitely not be normal beasts.”

At the words of the senior instructor, Sang In-hyo nodded satisfactorily.

“Okay, let’s reward those who pass the Gates of Life and Death with 3 Demonic Medicinal Pills of the Ayu Kalpa and also open the Divine

Treasury of the Demonic Sea. After all, it was the rewards the Heavenly Demon himself personally ordered to give them.”

At Sang In-hyo’s words, the chief instructor shouted with his head down.

“Yes Sir!”

* * *

Half a year had passed within the Cave of Latent Demons.

In the meantime, the children had become accustomed to their respective weapons.

Of course, each of them had mastered the basics of those weapons.

In addition, after learning martial arts, the weight of the iron bracers on their arms and legs no longer increased.

As a result, the children were moving much more freely than before, even though they wore 45 kg bracers on all 4 limbs at all times.

They were moving as if they weren’t even wearing the iron bracers at all anymore.

The same was true for Woon Seong.

In addition, Woon Seong gained one more achievement unlike the other children.

‘I have finally completed the True Tempered Blossom to it’s finest form.’

He had successfully fused them before completely. But only now, did the two methods resonate in harmony!

Creating one’s own qi cultivation technique was by no means an easy task. Completing in successfully creating a high-level technique? It was something only the greatest of legends within all of Murim could have been said to accomplish.

It was proof. Proof that Woon Seong was making the strides and preparations necessary to exact his revenge!

What was very interesting about this cultivation technique was that it had a special form of energy that Woon Seong could now utilize in earnest.

Intimidation Qi was what he had used to mask his levels of cultivation before. Now he could finally materialize that specific energy outside of his body.

It was incredible.

Then one day, there was an unusual announcement made.

The senior instructor standing in front of the confident children, slowly opened his mouth.

Chapter 8: The Gates Of Life And Death (1)

8 – The Gates of Life and Death (1)

There was a lot of dense and saturated demonic qi. The demonic qi that unique to the lower depths in the Cave of Latent Demons, oozed out in the area around them.

There were only two torches that were glowing in a tight space that could be used for visibility.

Even with the two sources of light, it was difficult to illuminate the entire cave.

Two gates stood at the very ends of the dark cave.

The entrance to the gates had long been blocked by a large rock in the past.

Woon Seong swallowed his saliva and repeated the name of the place.

“The Gates of Life and Death.’

If you somehow managed to cross the gate, you’ll be able to live. If you don’t, you’ll die then and there.

What the senior instructor said earlier was echoing again in Woon Seong’s head, as he recalled the name of the gate.

“When you enter the gate of life and death, you will surely face a certain crisis that will put you in a life or death situation. It is not simply a crisis that can survive even though you have been training hard so far. Struggle

with all your might! If you fail, you will die knowing the pain of being eaten alive.”

“If you can solidify your mentality as a warrior and the body of an adult, you will be stronger. Through this opportunity, you will have the opportunity to achieve even greater heights!”

“Keep in mind, The Cult of the Heavenly Demon is strong. There is no need for those who are weak. Be strong for the Cult, not only in your body but also in your heart. If you do, this Cult of the Heavenly Demon will give you a place to live!”

That’s what the senior instructor said.

There was not a single word in his speech that was useless, or hinting at something further.

‘The pain of being eaten alive, limb by limb.’

Woon Seong noticed from the words, what the hidden hints were in this Gate of Life and Death.

It sounded like there was a good chance it was something to do with an animal of sorts.

In addition, the mentality desired from members of the Cult, was a mentality that did not take joy in killing, but rather was confident with it, if required.

They needed members that would not hesitate.

‘It’s not a problem for me.’

Woon Seong grabbed the spear in his hands.

This time, it wasn’t the same wooden spear he received from the instructors before. It was an iron spear. It was much more durable and could be called a ‘real weapon’.

Woon Seong smiled pleasantly at the sensation of the cold and sharp iron on the tip of the spear. It felt nostalgic to hold a real spear for once, since after his death.

Woon Seong slowly started to arouse his internal qi.

His senses expanded and stretched throughout the cave. At the same time, he could sense the movement of a four-legged animal moving throughout the tunnel.

Crrrrr-

Out of the darkness of the cave, the beast started to emerge into the full range of Woon Seong's senses and was visible in plain sight.

Watching it closely, Woon Seong stared at the predatory amber eyes of the beast.

Woon Seong's eyes flashed. He had already noticed what it was.

It was a Grey Wolf from Mt. Tian Shan!

It was a little smaller in size than a normal wolf, but its movement could not be compared to the average wolf.

On top of that, a tough hide and it's incredibly powerful legs that could destroy entire tree trunks on their own.

‘At least I have a bit of luck here.’

What was rather lucky for Woon Seong was that it was only a single Grey Wolf. Grey wolves and even normal wolves for that matter, were ten times more dangerous when they were in packs.

However, just because it was by itself did not mean that the Grey Wolf was not dangerous.

‘No wonder they gave me an iron spear.’

If it was a wooden spear, he wouldn't have been able to pierce his tough skin.

Woon Seong grabbed the spear and coated it roughly with a thin layer of qi.

The Grey Wolf started to circle around Woon Seong looking for an opening.

It observed Woon Seong's movement around his hips, arms and thighs keenly with its glowing amber eyes.

The kinds of actions the wolf was displaying was odd. It wasn't completely odd to most people, but to Woon Seong who had more than enough combat experience in Murim, he could see something off.

'It's been trained to deal with humans.'

To be exact, the wolf had been trained with martial artists, seeing how it reacted to Woon Seong's movement of internal qi.

Wasn't the survival rate of this Gate 50 percent like the instructor said earlier?

'Umm.'

As Woon Seong observed the wolf closely, he became more certain that the wolf had been trained to fight with martial artists to a proficient degree.

The members of the Cult had been training it behind closed doors for over half a year, just for this trial.

It was only natural that after several beatings and fights, the grey wolf had learned to adapt to the movements of martial arts practitioners.

'It's not exactly an easy trial.'

But there was nothing Woon Seong couldn't do if he truly put his mind to it.

In addition, Woon Seong was now able to use all of his abilities in earnest, since nobody was spectating the trials individually. They were only told to

meet at the end of the tunnel past the gate. If they didn't, then they were assumed dead.

Wuuuonngg

Suddenly a fearsome aura started to emit from Woon Seong's body.

It was something that frightened any being regardless of their origin if they were weak.

The dark currents of aura started to coat around Woon Seong's body.

Whoosh-

It was the first time he was going to use it in battle since developing the new technique.

Intimidation Qi

Whoo-whoo-whoo-whoo-

The spear in Woon Seong's hands, started to be coated once more in another layer of the fearsome Intimidation Qi, started to resonate fiercely as if in synchronization with Woon Seong's very soul.

'I'll kill you, beast.'

.....and as he leapt forwards, Woon Seong's eyes started to glow with a golden hue.

* * *

"By now, all the children must have been killed or arrived at the Saengsa Temple."

It was the space provided for those who passed their trials of life and death to rest and eat.

Thus, the trials of Saengsa Temple were divided into two groups.

“Yes, I am. I’m sure they’ve met their opponents by now.”

Sang In-hyo nodded at the words.

The senior instructor took it as a sign of permission to speak further and continued to report.

“As you said, the top 30 children who have been showing better results than the rest have been paired with the alpha wolves instead of the regular grey wolves.”

They were quick to react to human movements, react to qi and were much stronger than other wolves.

In order to kill the grey wolves, it was necessary to press them with a formidable force from the very start, because they had the tendency of learning how to adapt to their opponents incredibly quickly and getting stronger due to their endless stamina.

“Will the other children survive?”

“For children who are descendants of direct cult members, or children who have known some degree of martial arts prior to coming here; they are probably quite likely to survive.”

“Otherwise, more than half will die.”

In fact, Sang In-hyo was expecting about half of the children to die through the Trials of Life and Death.

It was no exception even for the children who stood out, since they had been paired with the alpha wolves of the grey wolves.

“But if they survive, they’ll be more than just a regular old member of the Cult!”

It was a strong gamble. High risk for high rewards

Only the strong would survive and enjoy the benefits of passing.

For those who didn't?

‘It was just the necessary sacrifice, since they can't be a help to the Cult.’

In the process, this Trial created a new kind of mentality within those that might be still soft-hearted. Kill or be killed.

The children who survived, were likely to become strong figures for the cult.

‘The future of the Cult is looking better and better.’

Sang In-Hyo smiled at the thought of it.

The most important results were for the thirty people who would face the alphas of the grey wolves.

No. 1, No. 17 and No. 109 would pass easily.

Among the others, the ones who were originally learning martial arts prior to coming here would pass somehow.

But, there would be some children who didn't.

Most of them were children who stood out due to their initial talent, but got lazy and complacent with their training.

Then suddenly, one particular child came to Sang In-hyo's mind.

No. 900 who was at the bottom of all standards, and most outsiders would think it was a miracle that such a low numbered child had survived this long in the Cave of Latent Demons.

In addition, he was showing incredible achievements that even No. 1 wasn't able to pull off.

Last time, a senior instructor he had managed had said, “If it were him, it would be easy to pass the trial.”

But, that would have been the situation if he were in a regular trial.

No. 900 was placed in the same temple as the strongest 30 individuals.

The lowest number to survive till now, even when compared to past generations, was placing in the top 30 of children.

“I’m looking forward to it, No. 900.”

Would he be able to pass it easily? Or would he pass with difficulty?

Sang In-Hyo for some reason just felt that there was no way No 900 would not pass. This thought even intrigued him since he wasn’t sure why he was so confident in such an abnormal child.

But regardless, he just needed to see the results soon.

* * *

Krrrr-

The grey wolf in front of Woon Seong was bleeding just a little bit.

The distance between the two was about 5 meters.

The two didn’t dare take their eyes off each other, just staring at the other with wary eyes from that distance.

The Intimidation Qi that Woon Seong had planned to use for the first strike, was nowhere to be seen.

‘I was thinking of killing it in one attack using the intimidation qi, but it would be a waste to not use this opportunity to practice my martial arts away from prying eyes.’

He changed his mind.

He really had been feeling restrained having to hide his true talent, even while standing out.

Therefore, he really wanted to try and see what he was currently capable of without any special techniques.

He didn't even circulate his internal qi.

If he did that, he would have slaughtered the alpha wolf a long time ago.

He wanted to find out how much stronger he had become in this body with just his 5 senses and nothing else but his spear.

The body of the Woon Seong, who finished his thoughts, moved like lightning.

By kicking the floor with a sharp movement, he moved the spear with intensity and unfolded his advanced techniques he had learned within the Spearmaster Sect. Not the basic moves they were taught with the manuals within the Cult.

Whirl-

Woon Seong twirled the spear as it got close, using the centripetal force to slash at the wolf with greater strength.

Kkkkkkkkkkkkkkkkkkkkk!

The alpha wolf felt that something was different and retreated from Woon Seong immediately.

Leaping on all fours it jumped back and started to run around Woon Seong at high speeds in a circular motion in an attempt to confuse his senses.

Yet Woon Seong knew where it was.

‘Left!’

As soon as Woon Seong felt the direction of the air change, he tilted his waist and body backwards but felt a slight sting on his left cheek.

The air was pushed out and a terrible tension was imminent.

Woon Seong felt angered that it had managed to wound him since it had become desperate and made moves that weren't easy for him to practice with.

Coming back at Woon Seong for another attack, Woon Seong lowered the tip of the spear and stabbed upwards.

Puck-

“Kang-!”

He stabbed the eye of the wolf that dared to injure him.

Using his internal qi at this point, since he was pissed that it was time to finish this, he rushed forwards and followed the wolf trying to retreat.

He could see the movements of the wolf in the complete pitch black ends of the passage. No to be fair, it would be that he could ‘feel’ where it was intuitively.

Chapter 9: The Gates Of Life And Death (2)

9 – The Gates of Life and Death (2)

The sound of the spear slashing through the air sounded like an onslaught of arrows being shot out from a legion of archers.

How many times did he stab in that one moment?

Woon Seong, who had been emitting his intimidation qi relentlessly, quickly stepped back.

Then he slowly moved around and observed the trapped wolf that was still on its feet.

The alpha wolf did not move properly as it was thoroughly made a fool by Woon Seong and carefully observed back at Woon Seong.

‘The wounds are shallow.’

Woon Seong looked over at the small wounds inflicted on the hide of the grey wolf.

The attack was a dangerous one, yes. But, was rather shallow compared to the intended result that Woon Seong had hoped for.

There was no fatal wound.

The evidence was displayed through the wolf’s fierce gaze despite gasping for breath.

‘It’s gonna take a while to get past it with a battle of endurance.’

His other option was to risk it with his life as collateral.

However, Woon Seong did not intend to risk his life on some mere animal.

Besides, this wouldn’t even take that long if Woon Seong took it seriously.

Grrrrr-

Did the wolf notice that Woon Seong was observing it, or did it think that Woon Seong was looking down on itself?

It cried as if it were offended and bared its teeth while showing its hostility.

However, Woon Seong responded to the gesture with a snort as if the wolf were being cute.

“Haht. pft-“

‘What a joke, let’s just finish this.’

Whoooooooooooooh-

There was an aura of qi that started to permeate itself around Woon Seong’s body.

Soon, a dark fog began to flow out, and the eyes on Woon Seong slowly turned gold.

His internal qi started to circulate and churn within his dantian.

Criiing- Criiing-

Maybe it was because of the new and unfamiliar aura around Woon Seong that scared the wolf.

The wolf let out a wary cry as for the first time in the battle, it intuitively sensed its own death.

Then the attitude and cry changed once again into a low growl.

grrrrrrrr-

It was similar to before as it sounded threatening but, fundamentally different as it sounded a bit desperate.

However, that kind of measly threat would not work on Woon Seong.

Woon Seong saw the change of mentality in the wolf as he gripped his spear.

‘That works. At least now, this seems worthy enough of a fight.’

The wolf was standing tall even in its final moments, as if to prove that it was worth fighting for even if the chance of survival was minimal.

Woon Seong slowly approached it, circulating his internal qi.

As Woon Seong approached he could examine the wolf’s features.

In fact, it was very surprising to Woon Seong that it seemed somewhat similar to himself in his own final moments of his last life, although Woon Seong did not die with fear in mind.

This wolf had never known fear throughout its entire life, but was definitely starting to feel it as Woon Seong circled around it.

In fact, it was not intimidated even when the instructors trained it to fight against other martial artists.

But right now, that very wolf was tucking its tail in front of Woon Seong.

It was a scene that clearly showed the effectiveness of the derivative technique Woon Seong was developing with the Intimidation Qi.

An ordinary person would most likely faint on the spot if they were exposed to this technique.

‘If there was a standout problem, it would probably be the fact that it takes up way too much internal qi to maintain.’

The form of the intimidation qi was wrapped around Woon Seong like a blanket.

It spread out in all directions, like a fog, with the thickest source of it being Woon Seong.

Therefore, the internal qi consumption was huge.

If he could gather his internal qi and channel it into his weapons he could get rid of this wolf with ease.

However, Woon Seong had yet to get to that level yet with the body of No. 900.

‘With time, we can get there within a year.’

Right now, he needed to focus his thoughts on the wolf as his internal qi was being consumed at a rapid pace.

If he dropped his focus on the beast in front of him, it was certain that the beast was no fool and would try to attack him in that moment he would show a gap.

‘I have to end it now.’

Crack-

The moment the fog lifted from the beast's eyes, was the moment it saw its death.

Crrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrr!

The wolf saw Woon Seong approaching it midair with his spear raised in hand.

It was a blow utilizing all of Woon Seong's energy at one point.

Puck-!

The speartip of Woon Seong's spear pierced through the skull of the Grey Wolf and its head burst like a watermelon.

* * *

Grrroooo-

When the wolf had finally died, the huge rock that was tightly holding off Woon Seong and the wolf from the exit, began to move slowly.

It was the door exactly opposite to the direction of the entrance Woon Seong had gone through.

'If I were dead, that door would have never opened.'

That's just how the trial itself was set up.

In any case Woon Seong had survived. He also had measured out everything he wanted to test.

He was able to truly check the progress of his internal qi levels, high-level spear techniques he learned when he was in the spearmaster sect as well as check the overall progress of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique and his derivative version of Intimidation Qi.

Woon Seong smeared the blood of the dead wolf on his clothes and spear.

He applied the blood around the areas his shirt had ripped.

He thought it would be a good idea if he made it seem like he had a tougher time than he really did, just in case the results were too out of the ordinary.

It wasn't long before the door finally fully opened.

As Woon Seong stepped outside, he noticed those who had exited before him in their own trials.

‘Twenty or so.’

Some of them were quite severely injured and others were fine.

Ah-Young was the latter.

She was dressed as if she hadn’t gone through a fight at all.

But the iron sword in her hand was dripping with blood.

The blood of the Grey Wolf was evident.

‘Did she kill it in one blow?’

If she did, that would mean she was truly hiding more power than he initially thought.

Or course, Woon Seong could have killed the wolf in the very beginning with one blow as well if he did not want to hide his true strength and test out his body’s full and current capabilities.

However as great as that would be, it would only be possible since Woon Seong had the iron spear in hand and his previous life’s memories.

Withthat much taken into account, it was clear Ah-Young had already surpassed any child their age’s talent. Her strength had probably already reached the second-rate level.

‘No, maybe they’re already first-rate.’

While Woon Seong was evaluating her from a distance, Ah-Young also found Woon Seong and waved her hand with a silly-looking smile.

“It must have been a pretty fierce battle.”

It was a judgment based on the amount of blood from the Grey Wolf that was smeared purposefully around Woon Seong’s clothes.

“It’s not as easy for everyone else as it is for you.”

Ah-Young nodded with a smile at Woon Seong's words.

“That's right. I almost died, too.”

‘What a lie.’

Woon Seong knew she was lying, but paid no more attention to her and sat down against the stone wall in the cave around him..

Then he adjusted his breath to make it fit his appearance that it was a tough battle.

“Whoo... whoo....”

Then he looked around.

Among the children who came out before him, there were quite a few who he thought to be weaker than himself.

‘But they somehow came out before me?’

In fact, it was quite fast of a time to slay a Grey Wolf in the amount of time Woon Seong had done it in, but for children weaker than him to finish faster, it made no sense at all.

However, Woon Seong had predicted there might be a case like this, and the reasoning for it seemed plausible in his head.

‘Maybe not all the trials were done fairly.’

He thought it might be the case, but he couldn't be absolutely sure before the actual trial happened earlier.

But as Woon Seong had entered the finishing area for the children who passed and examined the results, his earlier conjecture turned into that of one with conviction.

Grrroooo-

“Wow, I did it!”

It was the noise of No. 185 cheering like an idiot as he exited his trial.

His clothes were relatively normal with slight injuries, Woon Seong thought.

His skills weren't bad, but he was still lacking in skill when compared to the Grey Wolf that Woon Seong faced.

‘Then there's only one conclusion to be made. Either he somehow learned some new skills, or he didn't face the same kind of wolf that I did.’

Woon Seong, who finished collecting his thoughts, closed his eyes.

There was no reason for him to ponder on it any longer. In any case, he had passed the trial of Life and Death and that was all that mattered.

As Woon Seong closed his eyes, No. 185 picked up on Woon Seong's presence as he shut his mouth and glared fiercely at Woon Seong from a distance.

Woon Seong felt a gaze rest on him, and he opened his eyes suddenly to see No. 185 glaring at him as he glared back right back at No. 185 with a smirk.

Then, Woon Seong paid no more attention once No. 185 averted his eyes quickly.

Woon Seong knew that No.185 still felt hostile towards him.

Nevertheless, the reason why Woon Seong had yet to kill him No. 185 was because No. 185 had still not openly shown his hostility yet.

“Well, it doesn't matter even if he openly bared his hostility at me.’

Woon Seong could toy with No. 185 at any time.

Woon Seong thought to himself and gave up any lingering thoughts on the case with No. 185 as he closed his eyes once more.

He had something more important to do right now.

When Woon Seong closed his eyes, he recalled the fight he had with the Grey Wolf and the full extent of the derivative technique of Intimidation Qi he had created.

The effects of the technique were excellent, but there were still many shortcomings in retrospect.

It was simply because of just how fast it depleted his internal qi reserves inside his dantian.

‘Is it because this body is still too weak, or is it just a matter of efficiency?’

Whether it was the former or the latter, it seemed that Woon Seong would have to train further to obtain favorable results.

Numerous martial arts came to mind when he thought of how to improve the technique itself.

There were a number of different processes within the different martial arts that came to mind and Woon Seong collected and took tiny bits of information from them of how to implement their processes into improving his intimidation qi.

However, no matter how many calculations in his head that he made, he still was stumped..

The blanket of intimidation qi would still be troublesome for him to deal with expenditure-wise.

At least that’s what Woon Seong thought.

“If I continue to improve this body’s very talent with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique, I can guarantee it will have a positive effect above all other options.’

With all the achievements he had made in his previous life and knowledge he collected in his time living as the disciple of the spearmaster sect, he

would most definitely improve and break through all of his past limits.

Woon Seong did not have a doubt in his conviction. He couldn't afford to when it came to his revenge.

* * *

Goooooglllleee-

The remaining doors from the other children's trials had finally opened or closed.

Woon Seong counted the amount of children who had survived in total.

'It's about... seventy or so.'

Woon Seong recalled the belief of the cult that the senior instructor had mentioned several times during their training at that moment.

The weak had no place in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, however if one persevered and blossomed their strength, they would become pillars that would never be broken down.

Chapter 10: The Divine Demonic Vault (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 10 – The Divine Demonic Vault (1)

As the 3 pills of the Demonic Medicine Ayu Kalpa were passed out and Woon Seong sat down in meditation from his rewards of clearing his First Trial, he felt a surge of qi that was compressed within the pills.

Woon Seong roused his internal qi and opened up his pathways in vigor, in order to accept the mass of internal qi being supplemented into his body.

The Demonic Qi supplemented by the 3 Pills of the Ayu Kalpa surged violently and aggressively in nature, through Woon Seong's dantian and pathways.

However!

Whoooooooooooooooooh!

A golden and blue qi that was originating from his Tempered True Blossom Technique offset the violent energy of the Demonic Qi and brought it under control.

His completely new technique that he had made by himself, was something so high-level, that even Woon Seong could not fathom just how incredible it's true worth was. But it was definitely something that would not struggle to rein in the demonic qi from the 3 pills of Ayu Kalpa.

The Tempered Qi surged and mixed in with the demonic qi, melting the unrefined parts of the qi down, to become stable and suitable for Woon Seong's body.

Swirling together with Woon Seong's collected internal qi he had been cultivating ever since he gained the body of No.900, the Ayu Kalpa medicine's qi was mixed into it and added efficiently to his already existing internal qi.

Woon Seong couldn't help but struggle though.

Once again, he led the newfound internal qi throughout his body, restricting the rampant and undiluted demonic qi with the rest of his tempered qi.

Inside his body, Woon Seong's internal circuitry was being forcibly expanded, along with the number of pathways being forced open, in order to adjust to the newly consumed qi.

As Woon Seong thought, this large surplus of Qi right now, would serve as the best foundation for his power to build in the future.

The meridians within Woon Seong's body were pushed and stretched apart as they expanded to support his joints and flow of energy.

Once, twice and then a third time around.

Woon Seong started to memorize the new pathways and circulated the finished expansion of his internal circuit with his accumulated qi.

How long had it been?

“Huuu...”

Woon Seon opened his eyes, as he slowly took a breath in.

A slight amber gold sheen of color remained in Woon Seong's eyes and then disappeared.

It was the last bit of unrefined qi within his body that had surfaced to his irises and then returned back down to his dantian.

Soon the eyes of Woon Seong regained their original color. It was too short of a time, that no one had seen the amber glow within his eyes.

It was about 20 years worth of qi.

It was safe to say that Woon Seong had been incredibly efficient with absorbing the maximum amount of qi possible within the Ayu Kalpa pills.

It was a waste that was about a year's worth or so had been lost, but it was an inevitable loss for anybody who was intaking medicine to forcibly increase their qi reserves. Most children had probably lost about 5-6 years worth through this process.

So if anything, it could still be considered a large boon for Woon Seong that he had been so successful.

However, if his talent had been much higher in his current body through the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique, he wouldn't have even lost that 1 year's worth.

'It's a shame, but I can't help it.'

Woon Seong let go of his lingering attachment and looked around his surroundings. When he looked around to see the other kids, Woon Seong's gaze lingered on Ah-Young.

Just as she had passed the Trial before him, she proved her talent once more, she had finished absorbing the full effect of the Ayu Kalpa Pills before Woon Seong.

This just proved even further to Woon Seong, that a genius was indeed a genius.

Ah-Young mouthed her words with her lips to avoid the eyes of the instructors when she made eye contact with Woon Seong.

'Did you do a good job?', she mouthed to him.

Feeling no need to answer the question, Woon Seong snorted and turned his head away.

(T/N : what a tsundere Woon Seong hehe)

It was needless to say that Ah-Young made an ambiguous expression.

How long had it been?

As time went by, the children began to wake up one by one.

There may have been individual differences between them, but everyone seemed to have achieved some results with the pills.

The senior instructor noticed that all the children were awake and stomped his foot to gather their attention once more.

Boom-

Each of the children focused their attention on the instructor as they heard the sound of foot stomping, echo throughout the chamber.

The same went for Woon Seong.

“Everyone seems to have absorbed the energy of the Demonic Medicine. Congratulations on becoming stronger.”

The senior instructor said so and gave a fishy smile. The smile felt as if he were really saying, that this was only the beginning.

Obviously, there were still several years in the 10 years required for the Cave of Latent Demons to graduate.

“Lucky thing is, this is not the only gift that the Lord has decided to gift you.”

The words shook the eyes of Woon Seong.

It was already a huge gift to receive those 3 medicinal pills. Most kids on average had absorbed 6 years worth of internal qi through those pills alone. For Woon Seong, he had gained about 20, which was a gift he already hadn't expected.

‘But this isn't everything...?!’

Woon Seong could not hide his surprise.

There were a number of children who were also surprised by this, but there was one who looked as if they had already expected the next gift.

That one, was the calm facial expression of No. 17, Ah-Young.

‘You know something.’

Woon Seong soon stopped his useless thoughts and focused on the instructor's next words.

“You can start learning proper martial arts finally... And these martial arts are the best martial arts known even across the entire world.”

‘In the world?’

Just what kind of martial arts were the instructors planning on giving them, Woon Seong wondered.

However, before Woon Seong could even formulate an idea about it, the instructor turned around and spoke.

“Follow me.”

It was a narrow road that the instructor led the children down within a large canyon. A canyon between the peaks of the mountain ranges within the territory of the Cult.

The children from the Cave of Latent Demons, walked along the narrow road through the canyon, following the instructor.

It was such a narrow path that it could only fit 3 people in width as a time.

As they walked along the road, Woon Seong examined the scenery with indifferent eyes.

The end of the canyon began to be seen.

The one at the end was a huge cliff. It was a high cliff along one of the peaks of the Cheonsan Mountains.

Underneath this cliff were two large iron doors.

And right above the iron gate, there were a series of characters engraved with brush strokes.

‘The Divine Demonic Vault!’

The eyes of Woon Seong who read the letters, trembled.

It was a library that was famously known all throughout Murim, that contained the martial arts of the Heavenly Demons and several Demonic practitioners of incredible legends.

It was one of the 3 largest libraries, within the cult, but this one was the most secretive of the three

The name of this vault was frequently mentioned amongst the several political factions beyond the regions of the Cult. It was that secretive and highly valued.

“Some of you might have heard of it. This is the Divine Demonic Vault.”

The senior instructor’s shout rang around.

These three demonic vaults could not be entered by anyone unless they had permission from the Lord of the Cult, himself.

Perhaps even at that moment, there were masters ready to ambush any unauthorized intruders.

“Give thanks to the Lord for his kind grace. Because of the Lord’s grace, who watched your achievements, has granted you the right to enter the Divine Demonic Vault!”

And right now, this very secretive vault, that several masters across Murim had heard of, and had envied the knowledge within it, was being opened to mere demonic soldiers from the Cave of Latent Demons.

‘What the hell is the Cult of the Heavenly Demon truly up to?’

This was definitely not like any past records Woon Seong had heard of, when it came to Cave of Latent Demons.

Woon Seong closed his eyes and thought.

Young children that were supplemented and given massive rewards for massive growth. They were not simply just training the next generation.

This was the very basic of standards when trying to develop a Peak Realm martial artist.

Though Peak Realm Martial Artists were very few in number across the whole landscape of Murim, the Cult of Heavenly Demon was giving the basic support to produce several of these, and probably were aiming to cultivate Transcendent Realm Martial Artists, or even martial artists stronger than that!

Woon Seong’s eyebrows trembled slightly.

‘Is the Cult of the Heavenly Demon preparing for a war?’

It was a low probability, but incredibly dangerous possibility that could not be ruled out.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon had always hoped to return their Cult’s practices to become the State Religion.

‘If so, it wouldn’t hurt to use them for my growth like they are trying to use me.’

The goals of the Cult, if they were truly for war, would be incredibly beneficial for Woon Seong to grow from and establish his strength to an unbelievable degree to achieve his revenge.

There was no need to think about loyalty to the Cult.

They were the ones who were trying to use him first. So it was only natural Woon Seong would use them as well for his own benefit.

Besides, The Cult's practices were strictly a religious group.

In the history of Murim, it was incredibly rare for the Cult of the Heavenly Demon to ever start or initiate large-scale violence, let alone a war.

There were cases of them even doing their best to support the public welfare to expand their influence through non-violent means, which was rare for any unorthodox organization.

But if it was through war, Woon Seong would have great opportunities to prove himself to the cult and rise in political power. His goal was to become much much stronger than a simple Peak Realm Martial Artist or even Transcendent Realm Martial Artist, so it aligned with his goals if he could move his own power within the cult for his own goals.

'It's the last resort of options to gain power through the cult, but war won't hurt me in terms of growing in strength.'

As Woon Seong thought so, the senior instructor continued to talk.

"But keep this in mind. You can enter this place only once in your time here, and only for one day! In addition, we limit the number of books that can be brought out of here to one book."

Only one day.

It was impossible to go back inside once he came out.

And all he could bring back, was one book.

Woon Seong engraved the message from the senior instructor, in his mind.

One day may be considered a long time to some people, but for the children in the Cave of Latent Demons, it was not long at all.

‘I need to exploit as much knowledge as I can out of this opportunity.’

Woon Seong’s eyes glistened as he looked at the Divine Demonic Vault.

For the spearmaster sect’s disciple, Woon Seong, who had copious amounts of literary knowledge, this was a one-of-a-kind chance of a lifetime.

“So choose carefully. I hope you can choose the right martial arts for you.”

The senior instructor smiled politely.

And finally, the opening of the Divine Demonic Vault began to take place.

Grindddd- Grindddd-

* * *

“Did the children in the Cave of Latent Demons enter the vault?”

Sang In-hyo asked the senior instructor about the details of the event.

The senior instructor had just returned to report the amount of children who had survived the Trial of Life and Death.

“Yes, 72 surviving children, all entered the Divine Demonic Vault”

Sang In-hyo nodded at the words.

“Some average martial artists find opportune luck, and some talents become prodigies, but it all depends on their luck when picking the best martial art for themselves.”

Chapter 11: The Divine Demonic Vault (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 11 – The Divine Demonic Vault (2)

The time spent inside the vault for the day, flowed effortlessly like water in a stream.

Woon Seong tried to read as many volumes of martial arts that were applicable to him within that small time frame of 24 hours.

And as a result, he was able to memorize a little more than thirty volumes of martial arts.

To even read 30 books, and somehow generalize their information was quite a feat, but Woon Seong took it a step further and ingrained the knowledge into his head.

It was something he could barely do even with his iron will.

Ordinary people could never memorize such vast amounts of intricate knowledge in their heads with only 24 hours.

Woon Seong was more or less the same.

It wasn't normal to be able to completely memorize all those volumes of texts, but he couldn't exactly not remember the most important volumes of texts.

‘But this is enough.’

Nevertheless, there was a smile hanging around the mouth of Woon Seong, who was stepping outside the Divine Demonic Vault.

This is because he had achieved all his goals he set on himself, when he first entered the Divine Demonic Vault.

‘It’s already enough if I can get the core information from each manual, not just focus on one manual the entire time there .’

He was the heir to the Spearmaster Sect, which originally had a wide knowledge of martial arts inside their library.

To be able to summarize the core points of each martial art manual of the thirty books he was able to read through in one of the biggest libraries across all of Murim was incredible for Woon Seong and his goals moving forwards.

‘It’s not bad.’

No, that was an understatement.

‘No, it’s amazing.’

There was a slight smile on the mouth of Woon Seong.

There were two more things he earned, aside from the summaries of the 30 Martial Art texts he found.

The first was an in-depth understanding of a spear martial art he thought to have been lost a long time ago.

‘In the end, it all came down to harmony like Master said.’

Woon Seong was able to find harmony within this special spear martial art he had found. As his master had once said, it was true that harmony was the most important thing for him to remember.

‘The degree of how well I can utilize this martial art, depends on how well I can harmonize the internal qi flow required for it, with my own body’s

compatibility with it.'

On the contrary, most martial arts were known to trade such explosive power with incompatibility with the user's body. Especially so when they were demonic arts.

But it was actually a misconception that almost every martial artist fell for.

The more outstanding the martial art, the more it actually requires that balance of harmony with the mind and body. And if found, the more powerful it actually becomes.

As a result of this, a lot of martial artists used martial arts they were incompatible with. This was best described as pearls on a swine's neck.

Although they were made to balance through their initial imbalance, not everyone could transcend their human limits to achieve such harmony with the martial art.

If one picked a martial art they did not have the knowledge to master it with, the body or the internal qi to match it, it was obvious they would struggle to bring the full ability of the martial art out.

'In the end, the goal to become stronger is almost a must if I want to bring the glory of this martial art out. And...'

Woon Seong raised his hand and slipped the book into his robe's sleeves, recalling his goal of vengeance and the strength required to achieve it.

'I never thought I'd find this here.'

Not only did Woon Seong realize he would have to train harder to complete Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique to achieve harmony and talent required for his goals, but he also realized the true glory of the new spear martial art he had once thought was lost.

It was the martial art he just slipped into his robe's sleeves.

Heavenly Spear Martial Arts : *The Six Seals of Destruction* (六結破天例)

Upon returning to his room within the Cave of Latent Demons after leaving the Divine Demonic Vault, Woon Seong put his hand back in his robes and went up to the dim candlelight within his small room.

The small booklet he had taken out of the Divine Demonic Vault came into view.

The dust from the cover of the book was wiped off by Woon Seong's delicate hands as he handled the booklet with care.

Woon Seong carefully read over the title of the martial art once more.

‘The Six Seals of Destruction’

Woon Seong had heard of it and its origins.

The creator of the martial art was someone that had once been a part of his very own Spearmaster Sect! However, that person had also joined the Demonic Cult, which led to a very unusual history regarding the Spearmaster Sect in Murim.

The story had been told to Woon Seong back when he was a child in his previous life, when he first became the disciple of the Spearmaster sect.

The history was indeed unusual, but what was for certain, was that this was indeed the lost and great martial art of that unique individual, who seemed to have walked a path with the same setting as Woon Seong currently.

‘In the end, The Six Seals of Destruction was being kept hidden within the Divine Demonic Vault. I got lucky.’

Woon Seong smiled faintly, slightly shaking the dust off the back of his hand.

As he recalled this mysterious master's history, this martial art was known to be incredible. It was unbelievably strong, yet also was just as mysterious

as its owner. That was the case for it being known as a lost martial art, all throughout Murim.

Woon Seong knew that in Murim, the knowledge about this legacy was rather misled. The Spearmaster sect was known as a sole apprenticeship sect. Meaning there was only one heir to the sect at a time.

But, if this legacy had somehow gotten to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, then how was the apprenticeship still strong until Woon Seong's generation?

'That's because some of the stories about the spearmaster sect that are known to the public are not true.'

For generations, the Spearmaster Sect produced only one disciple at a time. Therefore, it was treated as the common knowledge in Murim...

However, this was not technically true.

The Spearmaster Sect, if one looked hard enough, had no such law or rule to their apprenticeship stating it was only for one heir.

The reason for this was because mastery with the spear was known as one of the most respectful, and most difficult to learn, in terms of the martial arts associated with the weapon.

If one also looked closely enough to the history of the Spearmaster Sect, one would realize there was indeed a generation where there was more than one apprentice to the sect.

This happened to be the case in the 5th generation of lineage for the Spearmaster Sect. The Master of the Spearmaster Sect at the time, accepted two different apprentices and taught them both equally.

However, the Title of the Spearmaster, could only be passed down to one of them, and the apprentice who was not able to inherit the title, traveled far and wide to pursue his martial arts further.

The apprentice who had decided to travel, traveled as far as the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, and had created his own martial art in this process. That martial art he created, was titled the Six Seals of Destruction (六結破天例).

‘But I’d never heard that the martial art for the Six Seals of Destruction was actually formally recorded anywhere. There were only partial records of this martial art left behind in the Spearmaster Sect.’

However, it was the apprentice of the Spearmaster Sect who had created the art. If that was the case, then why was the full art left behind here, in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Although he had left and traveled all the way to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, he did not forget his roots as a martial artist of the Spearmaster Sect.

‘But if that was really the case, then why is the record left here?’

There was something that seemed to be hidden from the public eye and the records of the Spearmaster Sect, seeing how the record was left here in full. If so, something must have happened between the unknown apprentice, the Spearmaster Sect, and the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Besides, that was not what mattered now to Woon Seong.

‘What matters, is that it’s now in my hands.’

Woon Seong clenched his grip tightly with his free hand that was not handling the book.

The Six Seals of Destruction was made with both the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’s practices, and the Spearmaster Sect’s practices as well.

It was quite literally perfect for Woon Seong, who although might have different goals from that apprentice, also was treading the same path currently.

It was as if the Six Seals of Destruction dropped into his hands like it was fate.

For Woon Seong, this martial art would definitely play a pivotal role for him in his revenge against Jwa Do-Gyeul.

‘That fucker, I’ll kill him.’

As Woon Seong recalled the face of Jwa Do-Gyeul, a surging and violent anger popped up inside of his head. In all the times in the Cave of Latent Demons, the only time Woon Seong ever truly felt this rage was when he recalled that bastard’s face.

Perhaps Woon Seong’s emotions had been fluctuating since he was excited about the discovery of the Six Seals of Destruction.

‘Let’s not get too excited.’

Bit by bit, Woon Seong recollected his breath.

A scarlet aura of killing intent swirled around in Woon Seong’s eyes before disappearing altogether.

He didn’t forget.

He was just waiting to build his strength and bide his time accordingly.

His revenge would happen. He would make sure of it no matter what, even if it took him countless years to achieve it.

‘Master...’

As an orphan, Woon Seong’s master was not just a man who taught him martial arts, but a father who had helped him rediscover what it meant to be human. He had brought Woon Seong up, who was nothing but a measly orphan, practically on death’s door, to someone who could appreciate his own life.

‘To do so, I will use what I can, and I will take what I can.’

Even if that means using the power from the Cult of the Heavenly Demon!

Woon Seong clenched his fist.

Woodduck-

The sound of Woon Seong's teeth grinding rang out in the room along with his knuckles popping in frustration.

He would wait patiently.

Until he could build enough strength to pursue his revenge whole-heartedly.

He was incredibly likely to die if he went out as he was now, trying to recklessly pursue his revenge on Jwa Do-Gyeul.

He had to focus on what he could do right now.

Woon Seong thought as such, and then admired the Six Seals of Destruction with a murderous glint in his eye.

However, there was also a look of utmost concentration as well.

Inside the stone chamber, only ragged and fierce breaths from Woon Seong could be heard.

* * *

After the trip to the Divine Demonic Vault, the schedule of the Cave of Latent Demons continued without much change.

The only difference was that one's personal time to practice had increased.

The instructors would have normally made the children move according to the tight training schedule before dinner.

However, after leaving the Divine Demonic Vault, Woon Seong and the other children were given free time after finishing training before lunchtime.

Of course, it was a given time to learn the martial arts that they each took out of the Divine Demonic Vault.

Woon Seong made the best use of his time to learn the art of the Six Seals of the Destruction.

The qi flow required for the martial art was needed to be trained, along with the technique itself for his body.

‘The martial art is so strange in nature, it’s not easy to grasp at all.’

It was incredibly difficult to master the Six Seals of Destruction. Even for Woon Seong, who had knowledge of the Spearmaster Sect’s original values and martial arts, this new technique was incredibly difficult, odd... and extremely dangerous.

The martial art could not even be pulled off in earnest if one did not have the correct body frame and firmness in their bone structure. Otherwise the user’s body would be torn to shreds if they tried to complete their mastery of the martial art impatiently.

“Even so, the Six Seals of Destruction is a well-made martial art.’

As many generations of martial arts had been passed down since the creation of the martial art, Woon Seong could tell just how amazing it was to create such a dangerous and powerful martial art back then.

However, the analysis for finding the roots between the Spearmaster Sect and the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, was incredibly hard to divide.

‘It’s like trying to split a tree down the middle and expecting to find two main roots.’

This was the case for the martial art Woon Seong was learning that was passed down through texts from opposing cultures and practices.

‘However, that’s exactly why I can master the art itself.’

Line by line, Woon Seong analyzed the text and scripture from the booklet.

Of course, it was also important to learn the art with his body as well.

The difference between learning by simply reading and learning with the body was huge.

Whirl-

The spear in the hands of the Woon Seong moved.

The movement was unbelievably impressive, with the iron speartip twirling in a half crescent, hanging from his hands and feet.

‘This is the origin.’

The Spearmaster Sect’s main martial art unfolded in the hands of Woon Seong with his spear.

The Divine Spear of the Ending Night (霸道 流水)

The name of the spear art handed down in reverence to the spear of god, which erases all things, even the night, was the martial art his teacher had passed down to Woon Seong.

It was stable and soft compared to the flow from the Six Seals of Destruction and was the martial art his master had developed by himself.

...

The spear flows like water.

The stream and current of the stable water flow, traps the opponent in a sea of endless spear strikes.

The opponent who gets trapped by such spear arts, will be lost and drowning in the endless barrage of spears, unable to do anything.

...

The reason it was such a strong martial art, was because of the breath by breath nature of the art, and the stability within the structure of movements.

‘Next is Six Seals of Destruction.’

The iron spear, which was swirling all over the place performing the Divine Spear of Endless Night, disappeared.

Soon after, a series of heavy blows were swung. The spear parted heavily in the air.

Boom-

It contained the power to smash even rocks in one go.

The air shook and cracked every time the spear in the hands of Woon Seong moved.

In other words, if the Divine Spear of Endless Night was water, the Six Seals of Destruction was fire. The Six Seals of destruction flowed out like a lava that cracked through the molten earth and ravaged all living things to oblivion.

The movement of the spear was so destructive and powerful that Woon Seong’s body that he had been training rigorously, still couldn’t come out unscathed after practicing it.

‘This is a dilemma.’

The softness and consistent flow of the Divine Spear of Endless Night, and the extreme firepower from the Six Seals of Destruction.

In other words, if Woon Seong was able to somehow combine these two, he would be able to complete a new martial art that had never been seen before.

But to do this, it would be much harder than creating the cultivation method he created already in the Tempered True Blossom technique.

This was like directly mixing oil and water together.

Therefore, if he could combine the two somehow, he would create a dastardly new technique that would be unparalleled to any spear martial art in existence.

It's not like it hadn't been attempted before. But none were able or capable to even try finding an ounce of success in combining two polar opposite techniques like this before.

‘But it's still worth trying.’

The pursuit of extreme stability, and extreme destruction.

The two spear martial arts depicting these two natures that Woon Seong had, were already enough to be called treasures in all of Murim in terms of their profoundness.

However, if he could mix these two martial arts, which were already so high-level, that were able to be treasured as a Clan's secret martial art, he would create a martial art only to be known in legends.

In addition, the generational difference between the two martial arts to master them on their own, was not much of a problem for Woon Seong as it would be for others.

‘What I have to pay attention to, is the mastery of both martial arts first, and creating a foundation to build upon. If I can create this martial art successfully, those orthodox hypocrites will truly die by my hand!’

In terms of mastery between the two martial arts, Woon Seong could most likely master them both with his old body at that very moment. However, the current body of No. 900 was not used to such movements quite yet.

If it doesn't work, I can always use other martial art techniques to cover up the flaws if I can't mix the two of them perfectly.

‘Let's do it.’

Woon Seong was not only excited for his revenge, but to learn and create new martial arts was any true martial artist's greed. Especially when Woon Seong held all the keys to power within his own knowledge, he was bound to be ready.

'First we master these two separately, then... we create an entirely new martial art!'

Chapter 12: Discord (1)

Water naturally flowed in rivers or streams, there was always a current and a direction in which it flowed.

The flow of time was no different.

It had been three years for Woon Seong and the other children within the Cave of Latent Demons.

The once-children, were now reaching the adolescent years of their lives. The boys had started to grow more masculine and their muscles started to become more defined.

The same could be said for the girls for their muscles, and natural body curves were becoming more accentuated.

But the children within the Cave of Latent Demons, were unlike any other children their age within all of Murim.

Although hidden from the surface, they all were emitting fierce and predatory auras underneath their appearances.

They had miniscule amounts of it growing when they all passed the first Trial of Life and Death, but not only did it grow to a substantial amount unlike before, the children were also able to completely contain these fierce auras and hide them.

Almost all of the children were able to hide their fearsome auras and would be considered premium talents within all of Murim when compared to other kids their age.

It wasn't just the children's bodies and mastery over their internal circuitry that had changed.

Over the past three years, the children had started to align with other children that shared similar goals to their own and created several groups.

It was like watching the very basis of Murim unfold as these children created their own tiny factions within this Cave of Latent Demons based on each other's interests and goals.

It was natural that wherever these groups and factions within Murim were formed, there were certain gains and losses to working as a group.

Such a nature was not an exception to the groups of children within the Cave of Latent Demons.

Despite the children pursuing their own goals and interests along with others, they did not slack off in their training at all. However, they did spend their free time together chatting and what not amongst themselves.

Their training time was dedicated mostly in the time they had with the instructors, and didn't extend much outside of that time-wise for their training.

However, there were also individual children and groups that showed superb work ethic when it came to practicing their martial arts.

As a result, their proficiency and mastery over their respective martial arts became more and more refined.

In addition to growing older, these children were also given more autonomy within their free time within the Cave of Latent Demons

The instructors before this period, had only been there to set up the foundation of which these children would survive and grow upon. After which, they let the children have more freedom to do what they wanted and grow stronger on their own.

‘It might not have been just that though. Maybe the instructors wanted to create a divide amongst ourselves and the groups were exactly for that.’

Woon Seong had other thoughts about the intention of letting the children have more free time, as he thought the creation of the groups was to let the children find allies for their own ideals when they joined the Cult formally.

And unlike those children, Woon Seong rather, did not join any group and remained diligent in every second of each passing day, with his training.

The individuals who were not in groups, were either children who were too weak to join any, or who had no interest in relying upon others and pursued their own individual strength.

Woon Seong’s case was the latter.

He was so powerful that he didn’t feel the need to mix and mingle with the other children.

Not only that, it just felt a little peculiar and odd for himself to interact with kids who were 15 years younger than himself when it came to his total years of life in both bodies.

Naturally most children knew that Woon Seong was incredibly powerful and no longer looked down upon him for his number as No. 900. They knew he was a monster, but also naturally took offense to his ignorance to their groups as brooding arrogance.

“Is that No. 900?Tsk- What a jerk.” (T/N : the following are all different children talking amongst themselves in a group.)

“Well, there’s a time I need to pay back for him humiliating me.”

“Pft, training by himself. Who does he think he is pretending to be all noble?.”

“Yeah, plus my skills aren’t what they used to be.”

“Even so, just in case, if I had one or two people to move with me, I’d turn him into a mess.”

Furthermore, Woon Seong obviously had been attacked out of purposes of revenge by groups of these children. But, Woon Seong crushed them all without an ounce of mercy.

Amongst the other children who lived alone without being a part of a group, Woon Seong had a particularly notorious reputation because of that.

Eventually after this time of three years... an incident had broken out.

* * *

It was around evening that the incident broke out.

It also happened to be on the day when the instructors called all of the children in the cave to gather, unlike the usual.

‘What’s going on?’

Woon Seong wondered, and moved to the place where the instructors ordered the call.

Over the most recent year of the past 3 years that had gone by, there had been little to no contact with the instructors, let alone an order to gather.

Only during the morning training and handing out for meals throughout the day, could the instructors be seen or talked to by the children.

In the process, any changes to the schedule or routines were normally discussed then one-on-one with the instructors, and then later passed on between the children’s groups.

That was the children’s normal routine.

But this time, the instructors ordered a meeting. It meant they were going to be delivering some important news.

Woon Seong thought about what it could be, several times as he headed towards the hall, but he couldn't figure out exactly what was going on.

There were some guesses, but this was the Cave of Latent Demons.

This was not a place that could be predicted so easily,

Plus, there was no point in thinking too much about it, since he would find out everything he needed to know once he got there.

‘There’s no point in thinking about it.’

As Woon Seong went to the hall, the children who came first gathered and were chattering and talking amongst themselves.

But when Woon Seong arrived, the groups of children parted to let a path through for him to walk.

They were children who knew their own limits and didn't want to start a meaningless fight right then and there to piss off Woon Seong somehow.

Of course, there were some kids who stared at him from afar with eyes full of malicious intent.

‘Hah, seems you haven't given up on your revenge yet.’

The one Woon Seong was thinking of, was No. 185 who was glaring at him from afar.

‘What a whiny little bitch.’

If anything Woon Seong was irritated No. 185 didn't just come and attack him already. However, he knew that No. 185 stood no chance and that No. 185 knew that as well.

‘Sure, you're being cautious. But that doesn't make you smart.’

Come to think of it, No. 185 had displayed the same type of behavior in the past as he was now, clearly overestimating his own power and

underestimating his opponents.

If No. 185 hadn't tried to attack Woon Seong just because he was numbered No. 900 in the past, none of this would have happened.

'He's as fat and big as a bear, yet he's got the traits of a fox. At this rate, he's got the traits to be leading of these stupid groups by now.'

It's not like Woon Seong actually cared for No. 185, but No. 185 continuously annoyed Woon Seong with his glares and cunning nature.

Woon Seong then did recall that No. 185 actually did happen to be a leader of one of the groups of children within the Cave of Latent Demons.

In their own way, these groups did have some leaders of sorts, being the ringleaders of their respective group of children.

It would make sense to Woon Seong since typically leaders of factions, clans and sects needed not only martial prowess, but cunning and wit.

'But compared to those, No. 185 is like a complete child.'

Real and proper leaders knew when revealing their anger would only result in terrible results. Thus they would hide their anger until it was the right moment to strike. However, No. 185 was an idiot in that sense, as he openly displayed his bitterness to Woon Seong.

Not only that, but Woon Seong could tell that No. 185's martial arts were far from being even subpar in his eyes.

Since that was his evaluation of No. 185, it only made sense that Woon Seong did not like to spend his time and energy even being in the same space as No. 185.

It was so natural that Woon Seong didn't even spare him a glance, despite No. 185's open resentment.

Of course, the face of No. 185, when he saw this, was distorted. Woon Seong went his own way without paying attention to his face, which was

visible without seeing it.

However, Woon Seong's look of indifference soon disappeared.

“Hello?”

Like Woon Seong, who was not a part of any group, Ah-Young, No. 17 did not join any group and was standing in front of him.

“What do you want?”

Ever since that first visit to Woon Seong's living quarters three years back, Ah-Young would periodically come and annoy him and see what he was doing.

Therefore, Woon Seong had no choice but to feel uncomfortable around Ah-Young.

“I just said hello to you because I saw you. Don't look at me like that.”

Woon Seong snorted and turned his head away at Ah-Young's words.

Ah-Young was about to tease Woon Seong for his tsundere attitude but didn't have the chance.

This was because the Instructors came into view first and let out a shout throughout the hall.

“Quiet!”

Boom-

The senior instructor's stomp shook the floor heavily.

The internal qi of the instructor, was channeled from his dantian and into his foot, resonating and shaking the floor violently, as Woon Seong's eyes widened.

In fact, over the past three years, Woon Seong naturally had the chance to check and evaluate the skills of the instructors in more detail.

There was even an incident where some of the children felt fed up with the instructors' domineering tone and tried to raise a fuss out of them, and attacked them.

However, the moment that incident happened, the insolent and rebellious children had their necks cut off without a moment's delay in front of the instructors' frightening skill.

There was also the accompaniment of the qi around the instructors' feet to vibrate and be felt through each and every child's body.

'If they can channel their internal qi briefly into their actions, then that means at the very least, they're first-rate martial artists.'

It was ridiculous and showed just how much power the cult had, to have first-rate martial artists as mere instructors for children.

It just went to say how rigorous and extreme the talent of the children were, if they were to be supervised by such high-level martial artists.

Through these small experiences over the years, it made Woon Seong realize just how frightening and powerful the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was.

'The Cult of the Heavenly Demon truly does not lack in comparison to the entirety of the Murim Alliance in terms of manpower and strength... If I can somehow utilize the power of this Cult, it will be incredibly useful in my revenge!'

It wasn't just the leaders of the factions who had murdered and conspired against his Master and himself. It was also their direct disciples of the multiple factions.

Those factions were the core strength of the Murim Alliance, and almost no known power could directly oppose them.

Dealing with them would be no different than declaring war on the entirety of Murim itself, all by himself.

Therefore, it was only natural Woon Seong felt that if he had the power of the Cult, which was the only known individual power to rival such a large and frightening force of power, he could achieve his goals.

As Woon Seong had these thoughts at the display of power from the instructors, he clenched his fists tightly.

At that moment, the lead instructor opened his mouth carefully.

“Good job, everyone.”

The surprised expressions and wariness of the children became present from those words onwards.

* * *

“.....”

After the senior instructor’s words, there was silence in the hall. The senior instructor’s words complicated the children’s minds.

Woon Seong also slowly mumbled at the senior instructor’s words.

‘He said the Trials of Life and Death were only beginning? That we will be doing closed door training and that the past 3 years was only the beginning’

The words ‘Trial of Life and Death only beginning in earnest as of right now’ were enough to make all the children in the hall become incredibly vigilant.

They remembered the first time they had ever faced death with their own two eyes against the Grey Wolves in the first Trial of Life and Death, 3 years ago.

At that time, over half of the children in the Cave of Latent Demons had died back then. The notion that they were going to start closed door

training, wasn't exactly something they were sure they should be thrilled about.

As long as the name remained as 'the Trials of Life and Death', there was no way they would remain calm in their minds.

'I don't know what it is, but there's no way what comes in the future will be easy.'

Woon Seong was no exception when it came to being wary at the words like the other children.

However, for every trial and tribulation, Woon Seong knew there would be equal opportunity to grow a step stronger with equal risk.

The other children could be seen with the same stiff expressions as Woon Seong and Ah-Young, as they started to prepare themselves mentally for the oncoming strife.

Once again, as the children recollected their thoughts, the lead instructor spoke up.

"If you need anything, just let myself or the other instructors know before you go into your personal closed-door training sessions. If it's a simple request, We will prepare it for you. You don't have to worry about food or water since you will be prepared and fed well with grains and water daily.... And starting from today onwards, you may take off your iron bracers that you have been required to wear the past 3 years."

At the words of being able to take off their bracers, the children buzzed with excitement.

The weight of the iron bracers was no longer heavy for Woon Seong, but it was thrilling for the other children to hear.

Woon Seong had trained harder than anyone else in the Cave of Latent Demons, so the iron bracers just felt as if they were just another extension of his own body.

This did not mean that there is no difference between wearing them and taking them off.

‘You’ll be much stronger as you lighten up the weights on your body.’

Some of the other children were already showing signs of excitement.

The senior instructor smiled genuinely at the sight of some of the other children showing their visible excitement about taking their bracers off.

“Five days from now, we will enter the first series of this Trial of Life and Death for closed-door training. Remember that if you need anything, make sure to ask us before you leave. Now, you can have dinner and talk amongst yourselves. Dismissed!”

“Yes Sir!”

The children shouted loudly, repeating the words of the senior instructor, and Woon Seong stood in front of the senior instructor, not going back with the other children to dinner.

“Hm, what’s going on No. 900?”

As soon as the order to dismiss the children was ordered, only a few children had stayed but none had come to request anything, and the instructor’s eyebrows wriggled at the sight of No. 900, Woon Seong, who was in front of him.

“I have something to request.”

The senior instructor looked a little surprised at the words.

He had given the children five days to decide if they needed anything before they underwent their closed door training, but Woon Seong, No. 900 had already decided on what to request.

Depending on what each child requested, if they did at all, their path of training would be influenced for the next few years based on this request.

“It’s a matter of careful consideration, isn’t it?”

“I’ve thought it through enough.”

Nevertheless, there was only one such case for Woon Seong who already knew what he had been wanting.

‘You’ve only been thinking about training for this entire time, haven’t you?’

The senior instructor smiled faintly as he thought about Woon Seong who was standing in front of him.

‘He’s been a completely different person ever since he consumed that poison a few years back.’

The instructor continued his thoughts, as he could see that the achievements were increasing day by day for No. 900.

If anything, it would be nigh impossible for the instructors to not notice the incredible growth displayed by Woon Seong.

‘I’m sure he’s not even first-rate yet... is he?’

The instructor swept his eyes over Woon Seong, as he tried to inspect the level of strength within Woon Seong’s internal qi.

However, the instructor couldn’t get a proper gauge on Woon Seong’s true strength and it was a great surprise for the instructor to notice this, as Woon Seong rarely interacted with the other children and even less with the instructors.

“Are you ready for my request?”

The words caught the senior instructor’s eye.

“What can I get you?”

“I need four different iron braces, and I need each of them to weigh 20 kilograms. I would like to have them measured if possible, as accurately as

you can get them, as well as an iron spear.”

The senior instructor felt perplexed at the unusual request.

He had just offered the children to take off their bracers, and yet here was No. 900 asking for more, and at almost 3 times the weight than the weight he was currently wearing!

“It must be heavy.”

The total weight on Woon Seong’s body would be around 90 kilograms if he added the spear on top of the bracers’ weight.

It was about the weight of adding a healthy adult male onto his body.

It was definitely not something any other children had requested in years prior in the history of the Cave of latent Demons.

“That’s all I need.”

“Okay, that’s definitely possible. Wait until the end of 5 days before you start your training and I will have them prepared for you.”

Woon Seong lowered his head and bowed to the instructor to give his thanks as he turned around and headed back towards his room.

Chapter 13: Discord (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 13 – Discord (2)

“Chet- don’t you think 900’s such a douchebag?”

“Yeah, don’t you think so too Captain?”

No. 185 nodded modestly at the words of the children who were a part of his group that he was the ringleader of.

Strictly speaking, No. 185 was still amongst the top children in the 3rd hall in the Cave of Latent Demons, where he, Woon Seong, and Ah-Young were part of.

In addition, there were only five children who followed him, but they were quite talented as well within the 3rd hall.

However, the thing that brought these children together in the most part, was the fact they were absolutely manhandled and punished by Woon Seong in the beginning of the Cave for their impertinence against him.

They were those who had believed in their skills and thought that he was weak. However, reality was cruel and they were crushed by Woon Seong in the past. This resulted in their pride being wounded, and the topic of No. 900, Woon Seong, a sore spot for them.

“Captain, why don’t we attack him at least once?”

“Us?”

One of the children continued to ask No. 185 his thoughts, and nodded excitedly when the others displayed interest in his idea.

“I’ve been feeling much stronger ever since we took off the iron bracers. I’m sure it’s the same for you all too. Of course, I think with even just the five of us we could take him on. What do you think, Captain?”

The teen flirted the idea to No. 185.

No. 185 looked at each of the children one by one, examining their gazes as they nodded fervently.

No. 185 also felt like he was much stronger ever since he had taken off the iron bracers.

As they had taken off their iron bracers, their confidences also seemed to have increased excessively.

“But won’t No. 900 also take his iron bracers off too?”

One of the children shook his head and pointed at No. 900 who was walking back to his room, with his chin.

“No, look, he’s still wearing his bracers.”

When No. 185 turned his head, He saw Woon Seong walking away from Koo Baek-Ho, the senior instructor, with his bracers still on.

He didn’t know the reason, but Woon Seong still had his bracers on.

“I think even with just the five of us, even if the captain doesn’t want to join on in and dirty his hands personally, if we jump him, we can beat him up thoroughly without him even having the chance to take his bracers off.”

The mere thought of Woon Seong sprawled out on the floor made him feel excited.

However, No. 185 couldn't get rid of the lingering anxiety he felt from the words Woon Seong had left him with last time.

'There won't be a next time.'

So he took a peek at his minions expressions one more time.

All five of his minions had great skills. Would it be enough to take out No. 900 with his bracers still on?

No. 185 shook his head and smiled insidiously.

'Let's test it with them as the bait.'

The bait was enough.

These five in front of him, were eager and practically drooling to go out and try their chances at revenge.

"Okay, I'm out of this. But, you guys have your own way with him."

At the words of No. 185, the other five stood up immediately, all with eager looks on their faces.

They all looked at No. 185 and shared the same insidious smile with him.

Whisper- Whisper-

"Hey!"

Woon Seong raised his head instead of eating the rice in his bowl, at the voice calling out at him.

At the entrance to the stone chamber assigned to him, five shadows were cast at the entrance.

Five children... no, teenagers at this point, stood there emitting a murderous blood lust, holding their weapons tightly and emitting their qi wholeheartedly.

Woon Seong knew their faces. They were among the lackeys of No. 185 whom Woon Seong knew had a bitter resentment towards him.

Their hairs on the back of their arms were standing up. The murderous air was clearly eminent, even if they didn't say anything.

'They must have seen the chance ever since the iron bracers were taken off for everybody else. But where's No. 185?'

It seemed not taking off his bracers was beneficial for him other than for training. Now, it seemed like No. 185's goons and him were going to take their chances and give Woon Seong a justification to get rid of them finally.

Woon Seong slowly raised himself in a creepy manner and grabbed his spear that was alongside him.

"What's going on here?", he asked.

"What do you think?"

He already knew, but Woon Seong was asking them to confirm if they really wanted to rush to their deaths so early.

Their appearances were ones of starved animals, craving for meat.

"I'm pretty sure I made it clear last time. That would be your last time to try something against me. There won't be a second chance this time to beg for mercy."

The teens took a step back reactively away from Woon Seong as they flinched from the dark aura covered in Woon Seong's murderous intent.

This was not because of his power. They already knew he was powerful, but they couldn't gauge his power accurately. It was mainly because they remembered the bitter experiences each of them individually had experienced from Woon Seong.

However, they soon regained their wits as they felt confident in their newfound power! Not only that, but there were 5 of them here!

“Damn it, what the hell? Let’s get him!”

They had resolved themselves earlier to not give Woon Seong a chance to take off his bracers, and here they were spacing out. Woon Seong still didn’t take off his bracers, so now was their chance!

In accordance with their overall physiques increasing in mobility from the absence of the bracers, their movements were unlike anything from before.

However... they were not the only ones who improved.

Whoosh-

Suddenly a blur past them.

At the same time of them turning their heads wondering what it was, they saw Woon Seong behind them with his spear lodged through the chest of the teen that attacked from the middle.

Blood burst out from the wound and spurted out everywhere, dripping on Woon Seong’s face.

“Uk- uck!”

The teen with the spear lodged in his chest, collapsed coughing out blood, desperately trying to cling onto his life that was already forfeit.

He started to crawl on the floor to escape frantically.

But...

“I said... there would never be a second chance.”

The teen paled and frantically tried to speed up, but Woon Seong’s spear didn’t give him a chance to see another second of life.

Woon Seong didn’t give them even a second to collect their thoughts to realize what was happening to them.

The other four quickly realized what was happening, and bared their teeth, but to no avail.

‘You don’t deserve to be forgiven any further.’

They deserved death in fact, with their past transgressions against him. But, Woon Seong felt that they were still young and could turn over a new leaf.

Yet, they didn’t heed his warnings and were foolish enough to come once more.

Only to have their lives reaped by him.

* * *

“Oh, my God.”

Listening to the screams of his minions, No. 185 didn’t feel any sadness or worry, but rather a nauseating feeling came up.

He instinctively knew that the screams he heard were only his minions, and not a single sound that resembled No. 900’s voice.

It was hard for him to tell. Was Woon Seong wearing his bracers or not? If he was not, then hopefully it made sense.

But if it wasn’t...

‘If I take off my bracers, would I be able to take on the 5 of them?’

He didn’t know.

He couldn’t guarantee a victory.

At the end of his thoughts, No. 185 pulled out his jian from its sheath and held it behind his back.

‘I can’t go for it yet.’

The difference between them had hardly narrowed, if at all. Woon Seong was leagues above him right now, and it was futile to try and strike.

The eyes of No. 185 sank naturally as Woon Seong emerged from his resting chamber and walked down the steps of the corridor. No. 185 panicked inwardly and tried not to show it.

He wondered if his expression of anxiety had been revealed to Woon Seong as Woon Seong approached No. 185 slowly.

No, No. 900 was not an idiot.

He probably knew that the people who had just attacked him, were No. 185's lackeys.

‘But I thought he’d at least be a little injured.’

But it didn't matter. The bait was set and No. 900 should be only at half-strength with his internal qi. Right?

‘Yeah, I just have to wrap it all up neatly.’

Yet in front of him, No. 185 thought he was staring at a monster.

‘Why are you staring at me, motherfucker.’

Anxious, No. 185 slowly took off his iron bracers stealthily.

click- ka-click-

The iron bracers came off as No. 185 undid their bindings. Removing them, he felt much lighter than before. He was already looking forward to how he would fare.

He didn't know just when he had gotten accustomed to the bracers, but right now it felt as if he had feathers for arms and legs.

He felt confident that if things went awry, he could at least escape safely.

At that moment however, Woon Seong stepped within range of No. 185.

“What’s going on No. 900?”

No. 185 feigned ignorance to see if he could catch Woon Seong off guard.

But Woon Seong, who stepped in front of No. 185 just smirked devilishly and then laughed.

“I’m sure I warned you very well last time. There won’t be any second chances.”

At Woon Seong’s words, No. 185 bitterly shook his shoulders in memory of the words Woon Seong had left behind before.

‘Ugh.’

But No. 185 forced himself to hide his anxiety.

Then he shouted.

“What did I do?”

“Do you think I came here without knowing what you did?”

Woon Seong grinned as his canines revealed a sharp glare.

Was it an illusion?

No. 185’s eyes widened a bit in shock and worry. No. 900’s eyes seemed to be gleaming with a gold ferocity!

It was the worst outcome possible.

No. 900 knew who was behind the attack and even knew he was directly plotting it.

As he moved his eyes shakily, No. 185 looked at the iron spear in Woon Seong’s hand.

‘Can I do it?’

Would he be able to overcome his fears and worries embedded in his head of Woon Seong’s martial prowess?

There was blood dripping from the edge of the speartip. It was the blood of his 5 minions that had gone in earlier...

No. 185 who didn’t feel his will shake just yet, had it broken and shattered to pieces as he saw the blood on the spear. He felt the looming presence of death emanating from Woon Seong.

‘I can’t die like this yet! Let’s focus on warding off his attacks first!’

“ARGH!”

No. 185 jumped back and brought the Jian forward as he swept up the sand from the floor into the air.

The sand that he had swept up with his momentum of swinging his powerful jian forwards, was flung at Woon Seong’s eyes.

But...

woosh-

Woon Seong’s body fluidly bent and avoided the sand with ease, as his center of gravity wasn’t shaken in the slightest. Then, the speartip from Woon Seong curved and bent as it exploded forth with a surge of might.

Bang-

No. 185 immediately leapt up and saw the damage left in the spear’s wake. The rocky floor was crushed and No. 185 cursed as he saw that Woon Seong’s strength was too much for him, even with his bracers still on!

“Damn it!”

As soon as No. 185 landed, he shot forwards at Woon Seong swinging his fist!

Kagang-

The wrist of Woon Seong shook, and the spear bent like a snake as it dodged the trajectory of No. 185's fist cleanly.

Pupuk-

Woon Seong's spearhead penetrated his chest cleanly.

“Huh...Huh?”

No. 185's body stopped and he tilted his head down to look at the unbelievable result.

The speed. It was too much for him, and Woon Seong was still wearing his bracers...

Woon Seong gripped the outstretched spear and pulled back with ease.

Blood poured out of No. 185's chest like a waterfall, yet made no sound.

Then his body started to tilt backwards and fall, as his vision blurred.

The ceiling of the cave was the thing No. 185 had seen in his short-lived life.

“Tch, shouldn't have kept his resentment attached to him....”

Woon Seong turned his head as he bitterly cursed the fact that No. 185, who was talented, refused to let go of his terrible nature and schemes.

The dark aura from Woon Seong's intimidation qi, withdrew itself from the surroundings and disappeared altogether.

Woon Seong glared at the body of No. 185 one last time, before turning back around once more and leaving.

* * *

A little while later.

Srrrrrrrrr-

A dark figure crept up onto the scene of the dead No. 185 where Woon Seong had just been.

The dark figure revealed itself. It was No. 17, Ah-Young

She alternated her gaze between the dark corridor where Woon Seong had just left from, and the dead body of No. 185.

Then she murmured without realizing it.

“What exactly is he doing?”

Chapter 14: Closed Door Training

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 14 – Closed Door Training (1)

* * *

Five days went by quickly.

Before entering the training, each of the children asked the instructors for what they needed, and the instructors provided them with the supplies they had requested as long as they were within reason.

Woon Seong was also given the items he had requested from the senior instructor.

Four iron bracers and a new iron spear weighing a total of around 90 kilos.

Just thinking about the odd request Woon Seong had given the instructor, it seemed the instructor had given Woon Seong an additional set of bracers a bit heavier in case he got used to the ones he requested as well.

And the spear.

‘It’s definitely heavy.’

Woon Seong frowned as he moved his body that was heavier than before.

If he circulated his internal qi at all times of the day, he would be able to move freely like before.

But otherwise, the movement was a little bit unnatural and difficult. Not only that, but it was ridiculous to be able to circulate his internal qi at all times of the day, so it would be a good challenge to overcome.

‘When I get used to it, I can be much stronger.’

He was already amongst the top talents within the cave and his body’s talent had started to change in accordance with his body, due to the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique.

Even if he was already looking at the results the training would bring about after the next few years of training, he would already be amongst the top of the children right now as they finished in four years. He was that far ahead.

‘First, I need to build up my mastery with the Six Seals of Destruction and my other techniques.’

He was ready to combine the techniques or at least start on combining the Divine Spear of the Ending Night and the Six Seals of Destruction.

By the end of the closed door training at the very least, if not completely, he would hopefully be almost finished with combining the two, he thought.

Then, he might be able to even finish his body’s talent cultivation with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, which was almost finished with cultivating the talent of his soul.

‘And on the day I’m done with all my training, I’ll try and go for Body Modification!’

Woon Seong clenched his fist tightly.

This was a fact that Woon Seong had learned in his previous life, but every time a martial artist moved up within the Major Realms, they would undergo a certain process if they had an unparalleled cultivation technique.

And the techniques that Woon Seong were cultivating, in particular the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, was not just a technique that changed his body a bit and developed his muscles.

It was a miraculous technique that was built to enhance everything about the practitioner cultivating the technique. However, in order to achieve such a perfect state of a body and achieve harmony properly, they had to shed the shell of their previous body through Body Modification!

The Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique, instead of becoming more familiar to Woon Seong, became more and more mysterious as he practiced it.

It was clear that it was no ordinary high-tier technique... No, it was far beyond the scope of humans.

He only read it through the several books within the library in the Spearmaster Sect, and did not imagine a Buddhist Scripture like this, would be so mysterious in origin and extent of abilities.

‘There’s a clear multitude of changes happening inside my body even at this very moment. It’s not something that’s so simple like I had thought....’

Reflecting on the fact that this was something gained from his previous life, and the slightly bitter emotions that were aroused uncontrollably when thinking about the past, Woon Seong forced himself to stop thinking about it and move forward with his steps.

The closed door training area was in an area that was separated by two cliffs. There were small caves that were called rooms that were about 5 pyeong wide that went up the sides of these cliffs.

It was an area that was usually guarded by instructors and could not even be seen up until now.

‘It’s a much steeper slope than I thought.’

In addition, the caved rooms were not naturally shaped.

The rooms where the children had been living in were made of the basic framework of natural erosion, but this was purely an artificial cave made by human hands.

‘They dug deeper inside the natural cave to enlarge the training space.’

Woon Seong looked inside one of the caves, moving his head around.

The current area he was in was assigned to the children of the 3rd Hall, purely for the closed door training within the Cave of Latent Demons.

(T/N : There are 4 groups/ halls of children and they’re each separated from each other, so Woon Seong hasn’t met children from the other halls. Just clarifying this.)

That meant there were a few more steep cliffs and training areas like this, throughout the Cave of Latent Demons.

‘I can’t believe they’ve artificially made such a training area of such size.’

Indeed, there was a bit of exclamation that it was only a part of the several training areas within the Cave of Latent Demons.

In the meantime, the senior instructor who was walking earlier suddenly stopped walking.

It was after the long walk that was accompanied by silence, into the cave.

“From now on, you’re going to have your closed door training session here for the next 4 years.”

As soon as the senior instructor stomped his foot, the flames on the torches in the hands of the other instructors lit up.

The torches were lined up from all sides, and the interior of the cave became clearly visible.

“Wow!”

There was a burst of admiration and wonder from the children.

It was a huge space, much larger than even Woon Seong had thought. It was extremely deep and large... almost frightening if one thought of it as a jail.

That combined with the darkness.

Dark areas, where one could not see past one's fingers and were combined with silence in a confined space, were enough to make the most courageous of humans break their wills.

It was highly likely that even some of the children might go crazy within this time away from everybody else.

That was why this trial was part of the titled trials of 'life and death'.

Could one survive in such conditions of utter silence, unfavorable living conditions, and complete darkness? That was their challenge.

Inside his room, Woon Seong slowly closed its eyes.

He started to circulate his internal qi, and focus it around his eyes. By doing this, he would be able to see just fine.

But, he knew he would not be able to do that all day long.

If he did, he would be exhausted without any chance to properly train his body.

'I'm getting used to the darkness.'

It was in the dark with nothing in sight anyway, but the senses of Woon Seong picked up on a bowl of rice grains in the corner and a bamboo shoot for water.

The senses of Woon Seong stretched out and expanded within the darkness, as he got a grasp of his surroundings.

He could hear the wind blowing in and out of a tiny crack between the rocks.

He then slowly opened his eyes.

The extended sensations and comprehension of his surroundings passed to his brain, as he started to memorize the dimensions of his room, to minimize his effort needed to circulate his internal qi in his eyes.

On top of that, he wasn't sure, but he was starting to make out his surroundings naturally with his eyes.

Intimidation Qi (暗順應).

It wasn't clear, but his intimidation qi, helped him gather the grasp on his surroundings easier.

(T/N : Another difference from the webtoon, as the translators in the webtoon thought he was using his heavenward soul, earthbound technique to sense his surroundings, but the hanja here says otherwise.)

Woon Seong opened his eyes and looked at the water flowing through the bamboo chute.

Next to it was a small wooden handle, which was the size of an arm.

It is a structure that could not be opened from inside the room, the wooden handle for one to crank the machinery behind the wall, to gather water to drink.

‘How interesting, they used machinery to draw the water in.’

There was a wooden gate on the other side of the cave that Woon Seong suddenly picked up with his senses.

It was locked from the outside, and he was unsure of what its purpose was for. But, like all things in the Cave of Latent Demons, they would be revealed at a later date.

‘I shouldn't try to mess around with that.’

Woon Seong took a sip of water and put it in his mouth.

He had to spend four years here. Woon Seong clenched his fist tightly and grabbed the spear.

‘I can do it.’

Woon Seong immediately began his training.

The training regimen for Woon Seong was simple. At night, he spent less time sleeping and cultivated his Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique, and at dawn, he focused on improving his internal qi reserves with the Tempered True Blossom cultivation technique.

During the day, he used the time to learn the martial arts that he had deemed useful from his past life and then afterwards at noon, practiced the Six Seals of Destruction and Divine Spear of the Ending Night.

It was a great boon for him to be able to reduce his sleep while being able to practice and rest at the same time with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body technique.

Day by day, progress started to accumulate...

And four years passed.

* * *

Sisst-

The dark space was filled with an even darker and compressed energy.

The dark energy was fluctuating as if it were smooth as water, winding around the entire room like a snake.

Gsh- Gsh- Gsh-

In the meantime, Woon-Seong was breathing slowly. Breathing in and out very slowly.....

The dark energy contracted and expanded in accordance to match the breath of Woon Seong.

The intimidation qi, had been assimilated thoroughly into Woon Seong's very body and breathing habits. His proficiency with the technique was incomparable to before.

How long had it been?

For the first time, the breathing of the seated Woon Seong, which was breathing and exhaling in a rhythmic flow regularly, changed.

Sigh, Sigh-

Breathing in slowly, very slowly and with depth.

He was changing the breathing technique to the pattern required for a different martial art.

His breath went deep into his lungs. And the internal qi responded to him.

The wide-spread internal qi gathered around Woon Seong.

The gathering qi gathered atop the head of Woon Seong and started to knead itself into a sphere.

A small sphere rose above Woon Seong's head.

And finally!

When Woon Seong stopped breathing, the qi scattered with a sizzling sound.

Soon after that, Woon Seong opened his eyes.

Paat-

At the moment, a bright gold light flashed in the eyes of Woon Seong. His eyes had turned fierce. The figure was like the eyes of a cold hearted

assassin in front of his target.

However, after a while, the eyes of Woon Seong soon returned to their original form, and the gold sheen in his irises, dissipated.

Woon Seong slowly rose from his seat, circulating the deep reserves of internal qi that had expanded leaps and bounds, within his dantian.

“Is it today?”

As the cultivation of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body had grown, Woon Seong had been able to naturally expand his senses without the use of internal qi.

It felt strange as he looked back on the time he had spent in this room the past 4 years.

Yet everything was so clear when he closed his eyes.

Through his senses, he saw the numerous markings he had made, scratching the wall the number of days that had passed.

As if it were corresponding to Woon Seong’s finalizing thoughts, the mysterious wooden gate that had not moved since he had entered the cave, moved subtly.

‘Is this the end of the life and death trials, or will there be more?’

Perhaps there was more since it hadn’t quite been a full 10 years.

Woon Seong gripped the spear in his hand tightly.

The four iron bracers and iron spear in his hands, could be felt throughout his body with much ease.

Despite the weight becoming more than adding another body in terms of weight onto his body, Woon Seong’s movements were completely smooth.

The senses of Woon Seong that had expanded past the darkness of the cave and towards the wooden gate.

Chapter 15: Closed Door Training (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 15 – Closed Door Training (2)

* * *

Over the course of four years, Woon Seong had completely changed into a young man.

Everything was developed except for his pale skin from the absence of sunlight for over 4 years.

His jawline was firm cut, and the bridge of his nose was rather high.

His long blue hair swayed easefully through the light breeze in the cave.

His body and muscles looked as if he had been sculpted out of clay.

Even though his muscles and body were well-defined, he did look swelled up or even remotely close to it. He was sleek, compact, and fit to even the finest fiber of muscle.

It was the most suitable body possible, adjusted to the nature of spear martial arts, which emphasized flow, harmony and flexibility.

On top of that, his body was now strong enough to not be injured internally or externally, when it came to unfolding the Six Seals of Destruction or Divine Spear of the Ending Night.

Thanks to the body modification that Woon Seong had achieved, it was a body that was in a pristine state.

‘But the only thing that’s disappointing is that I failed to combine the two martial arts into one.’

After four years of effort, Woon Seong realized just how short-sighted he was in thinking that combining two incredible martial art techniques would be as easy as combining the two cultivation methods he had combined before.

Considering that the one who developed the Six Seals of Destruction, the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon, had taken his entire lifetime to perfect just that martial art alone. And the fact it had taken his master his entire life to perfect the Divine Spear of the Ending Night... it might as well just take as long for Woon Seong to combine the two into one.

“But the good thing is that it wasn’t completely uneventful.”

He had caught the thread.

It was truly smaller than a needle, and was incredibly difficult to grasp, but Woon Seong had found the thread that would tie the two together.

‘And if I can find the end of that thread completely.....’

With a faint smile hanging around the corners of his mouth, Woon Seong cut his hair with the speartip in his hands.

The hair that he hadn’t cared about for four years, had grown down to his waist.

Woon Seong cut it to his shoulders.

Sagak-Sagak-Sagak-

After Woon Seong cut his hair, he scratched his unkempt beard and shaved it off roughly with the blade.

Shik-shik-

When Woon Seong finished cutting his beard, he felt the vibrations in the cave slightly as he looked at the wooden gate open in his room.

‘Perfect.’

The door to meet with the other teens was opening now.

Ggg

“Hmm?”

Woon Seong looked beyond the exit and noticed something interesting.

The open exit was connected to another tunnel shrouded in darkness.

It seemed the trial wasn't over with just the closed door training.

“You want me to come in?”

As to be expected it seemed.

What would be after this would be unknown. Would it be the outside world? Or would there be yet another trial?

Whatever it may be, Woon Seong he would be able to confidently pass whatever was thrown at him due to his incredibly fruitful 4 years of secluded training.

Therefore, Woon Seong moved without hesitation toward the darkness waiting for him.

A dark passage ran all the way through the exit. The passageways narrowed and widened, went down and continued steep slopes at seemingly random.

Through the passage, Woon Seong was walking through them without batting an eyelid at what might be a difficult path to traverse for others.

Nevertheless, his speed was very fast running through the several obstacles in complete darkness. It was hard to say that it was a speed that could be produced simply because his eyes had become adapted to the darkness.

‘I think I know now.’

Even without having to expand his reach of eyesight with his internal qi like before, Woon Seong’s body was utterly perfected and optimized due to the effects of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, that whenever he concentrated his mind and heightened his senses, they were much vaster than before.

How much time had passed as he wandered through the passage?

Woon Seong was traveling through the passage relatively with ease when suddenly, a chink in his senses was briefly revealed and he reacted swiftly.

Woon Seong quickly pivoted his foot into the ground, revolving the spear over and across his back in a full swing.

Whik-!

The speartip collided and deflected a small dagger that had been flung out of the darkness.

Woon Seong could feel a warmth being emitted from the blade that had been heated and shot out at him.

Then he realized what it was when a terrible smell was picked up from the blade as well. It was poison.

Woon Seong shifted his gaze back to where the dagger had originally come from and narrowed his eyes.

‘It wasn’t an ordinary passage either.’

It seemed that there was hidden machinery and traps strewn about.

He could lose his life at any moment that he let his guard down.

This was just the passage and rite of way for the cult to measure if the teens had properly trained in the 4 years.

Woon Seong understood then. That even these exit was not meant to be taken lightly.

Sure enough, as Woon Seong moved along, more traps and machinery shot out hidden weapons and often revealed hidden pitfalls.

The range of traps varied from poisoned hidden weapons, trap doors, pitfalls, a hail of arrows, spinning blades and much more.

Of course, it was not a problem for Woon Seong.

Woon Seong's speed was faster than the trap's activation speed, most of the time. And if it wasn't something he could outspeed, he could block or parry with his spear with ease.

There eventually came a trap that Woon Seong had not encountered yet.

‘Swamp of the Poisonous Demon.’

Woon Seong looked calmly at the black swamp in front of him. It was a heavy water filled to the brim with countless poisons that even leaves could not float without being melted on the touch.

It was made to look like a dark area of water, but it was the complete opposite.

As soon as one's skin touched it, they would start to sink while having their body corrode down from the skin, all the way to the bone.

The depth of the swamp was unknown, but Woon Seong had no intention of finding out.

It was natural that one had to either cross the swamp by either emitting enormous amounts of qi around their body, which needed one to at least be a Peak Realm martial artist to accomplish. Or, they had to be able to traverse it another way.

Woon Seong looked around the swamp.

The distance to the opposite side of the swamp was just over ten paces or so.

Considering the training that the Cave of Latent Demons had been arduous thus far, it seemed they obviously needed the children to be able to jump that far in order to cross.

‘They would have to be able to at least become First-Rate in order to strengthen their limbs individually with qi.’

Woon Seong looked at the iron bracers on his arms and legs.

A weight of 90 kilograms in total.

A ten pace distance, and he wouldn’t strengthen himself with qi either. He needed to be at least this much, he thought.

‘Can I do it?’

He could easily cross with using his qi. But, he also wanted to not only wear bracers while doing it, but not even circulate his internal qi to his limbs.

‘But.. what if I can’t?’

The hesitation was short.

There was one reason. If he hesitated and ended up falling short, then he would never be able to get revenge. He had to be this strong at this age in order to slay the Murim Alliance hypocrites.

Not only that, but he needed to believe in his strength. It was the one of the core traits to becoming a martial artist.

‘Let’s do it.’

Woon Seong stepped back and blinked slowly.

Then, he gripped his right hand on the shaft of the spear and shot forward.

He decided to use a basic footwork that required no qi. It was the Gale walk!

Woon Seong's figure became a gale of wind that was light but firm.

Whoosh-

The gale flew through the air and stopped on the other side of the swamp. Woon Seong slowly stopped rotating his body and his hair swayed.

He took a leap of ten paces successfully without using his internal qi, or taking off his bracers.

'I succeeded.'

If it was only half a step shorter, he would have utterly failed and met his end.

But he had succeeded. Woon Seong felt the sensation of accomplishment as he calmed his shaking hands.

However, he soon dulled his sense of pride and content down as he knew there was still a long way to go in terms of fully exiting the passage.

'I can feel better only once I fully complete the Trial.'

Woon Seong continued to move.

As Woon Seong was passing by, closer to the exit, he came down a narrow pathway once more and noticed the cracks in the wall which normally meant a trap was located there.

But....

'Hmm?'

Picking up his senses, Woon Seong felt something amiss as he expanded his range with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body.

It was not a machine or trap like he had been encountering up until now.

There was breathing. And the breathing of a human being at that.

Woon Seong slowly gripped his spear tightly and raised his guard, albeit giving off the appearance that he was defenseless.

Then he was sure once he felt the killing intent.

In that crack between the walls.

‘I see, there’s someone I need to kill in order to pass further.’

Sisst-

Sure enough, as soon as Woon Seong entered the range of the other person, he heard movement.

It was a movement with little-to-no sound

‘The Cult truly is heartless.’

Woon Seong pretended he didn’t notice the movement to draw out the attacker.

He could hear, feel and smell the opponent that was trying to stay hidden.

However, Woon Seong feigned ignorance and kept moving as he came to a small room. There were three other entrances leading to the room and one exit. However, the exit was blocked off with a giant stone.

Woon Seong slowly approached the stone door.

Even then, the unidentified person was looking for an opening to attack Woon Seong.

He didn't seem to notice that Woon Seong had picked up on his presence long ago.

Woon Seong ignored him and walked up to the stone gate and read the writing engraved on the stone.

Woon Seong raised an eyebrow as he read what the writing said.

‘Only one may leave.’

3 entrances, and only 1 person to leave.

Woon Seong then understood that the assailant was probably another child who had killed the other one who came through.

Technically speaking this kind of mentality training was the harsh and extreme opposite to the Orthodox methods, but the Demonic Cult was a pseudo religion and not one to pursue anything other than strength.

It was at that moment that the other teen attempted to attack.

Whoosh-

The assailant thought that Woon Seong was utterly defenseless, leaving his back completely exposed.

The sword in his hand danced and drew a line towards the back of Woon Seong.

Shhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh!

Suddenly the spear blurred in Woon Seong's hand, and Woon Seong could be heard clicking his tongue.

That was all it took.

“I could already sense you long before I entered this space, did you really think you were fooling anyone.”

Kkagang-

The sword in the assailant's hands flew backwards as the strength from the iron spear in Woon Seong's hands was heavy.

The sparks of the collision slightly revealed the other teenager's facial expression.

It revealed utter shock and embarrassment.

Quickly trying to reel his sword back in, the teen tried to gain distance.

Whik-

However, Woon Seong was a step faster.

Woon Seong's arms moved smoothly like a dancer's, and a torrent of internal qi sprung forth from his dantian as he swung the spear in the shape of a cyclone, creating a suction force.

The sword in the hands of the other teen started to get pulled forward and the teen's eyes started to shake.

Woon Seong brought the cyclone to a halt and the sword was flung back as it collided with the centripetal force of the spear.

The expression of the other boy wasn't good.

But, Woon Seong showed no gaps of mercy.

Boo-Woong-

The spear cut through the darkness and drew several lines in the air, marking all over the body of the boy.

Boom-

The sword was flung back and stuck into the ground with a loud boom, as the other boy quickly pulled out a blade and backed off, eyeing Woon

Seong carefully.

“Are you not going to come?”

Woon Seong took a step forward.

The boy reflexively flinched back and made the mistake of showing an opening to Woon Seong.

“Then I’ll go ahead.”

Woon Seong started to circulate his internal qi rapidly and the tempered true blossom’s stored qi started to show it’s brilliance within his body.

It gushed into the internal pathways of Woon Seong’s body covering every millimeter of depth as Woon Seong’s muscle fibers stretched and contracted.

Woon Seong swiftly moved and outstretched his arm with the spear in tow.

Six Seals of Destruction : *First Seal (星雨) Raining Stars of Extinction*

The First Seal of Destruction unfolded as several images of bright lights enveloped Woon Seong’s speartip.

The spear started to move faster and faster as several stabs flew towards the other boy. The light enveloping the speartip exploded and the boy tried to hurriedly defend.

Caang-

The boy felt a slight sense of relief that he was able to make contact with one of the spears for a brief second, but then realized how foolish he was.

Several spears appeared next to him, as his feet started to lift from the ground from the full exploding force of the stab he thought he blocked.

bubbubbubbubbubbubbub!

Blood shot up like a fountain and sprayed out all over the stony room.

The boy couldn't even scream properly and collapsed on the spot.

There was no one who could survive with ten fist-sized holes on their body that were marked all from one spear.

Flop-

The sound of the boy's body falling off the blade of the spear and hitting the ground, rang out. The blood on the spear dripped down coldly.

Soon after, a heavy vibration could be felt from the stone door.

Ggg

Woon Seong could start to see the light coming through the gaps of the opening door.

It had been years since he last saw proper light. Woon Seong frowned and squinted his eyes.

His eyes slowly started to adjust as he gave himself a bit of time.

And finally, when his eye fully adapted to the light, Woon Seong was able to see the imagery of what layed beyond the door.

Woon Seong smiled faintly at the sight.

‘I passed.’

Chapter 16: Ranking Dispute (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 16 – Ranking Dispute (1)

* * *

When Woon Seong stepped out from the exit of the passageway, a bright and dazzling light poured into his vision.

Woon Seong frowned slightly at the sudden flash of light that invaded the corners of his cornea.

He slowly opened his squinted eyes over time and adjusted to the lighting of the room he had entered.

What he saw was that the senior instructor from his Third Hall with some individuals standing side by side of equal strength.

However, the number of senior instructors was four times higher than usual.

‘Not only has my senior instructor arrived, but I think the other instructors are the senior instructors from the first, second and fourth halls.’

Woon Seong moved his gaze slowly.

There was only one child who left the Trial of Life and Death closed door training before him.

The face attached to the boy who had completed the trial earlier than him was a new face he had not seen in the Third Hall he was a part of.

If he was a member of the same Hall as Woon Seong, he would have seen his face even if he was just a passerby, but that wasn't the case..

It's not that he didn't pay attention to his surroundings or the other children. Sure, Woon Seong was rather isolative, but he just didn't see the boy before.

'I see. This is what must have happened.'

Woon Seong, who understood what was going on, knew why the other senior instructors were gathered.

The number of children who would pass through this trial of life and death, would probably number to only about 100 children if they were being generous with the numbers.

Since the trial itself was meant to cull the ones that would not be of use to the cult, it was only natural the numbers of the survivors would be low.

Hence, why there was no need to separate the children by different numbered halls anymore.

'The entire population making up the Cave of Latent Demons has gathered here.'

As Woon Seong looked around, one of the instructors stepped forward and looked at him.

"Hmm.... What number is that one?"

He was Sang In-Hyo, the general manager of the Cave of Latent Demons.

With the appearance of Sang-hyo, Woon Seong turned his head and looked at him. Then he reflexively gulped and swallowed his saliva as he stared at Sang In-Hyo.

'He... He's a Peak Realm Martial Artist'

Woon Seong's was barely above him in terms of strength when comparing his previous life's strength to the current Sang In-Hyo. The amount of strength Woon Seong currently had was maybe enough to fend off his attacks at best.

However, considering the circumstances, it was not worth finding out whether he could or not.

In any case, Sang In-Hyo was a Peak Realm martial artist who was on the verge of being a Transcendent Realm martial artist.

Of course there would be no need to worry about his strength with his previous life's body. Woon Seong might be wary of Sang In-Hyo at most back then.

According to the Realms of strength sorted out by the whole of Murim, Sang In-Hyo was at the threshold between Peak Realm and Transcendence, but Woon Seong was a full fledged Transcendent back then.

Right now however, Woon Seong felt he could exert the physical strength of a Peak Realm martial artist if he took off all his bracers.

But, there was no need to do that right now.

Did he notice that Woon Seong was measuring his strength? Sang In-Hyo grinned at Woon Seong.

His grin was devilish and would make anybody and their mother, faint on the spot.

“He is No. 900.”

It was the senior instructor of the third hall that Woon Seong was a part of, that replied to Sang In-Hyo's question.

Sang In-Hyo nodded at the words and slowly scratched his chin.

“Oh, how interesting. This is the one is he? The one that has piqued the interest of the other senior instructors and has been achieving great things,

no?.”

Woon Seong felt a curious gaze toward him.

As Woon Seong had just done earlier, Sang In-Hyo was now measuring the strength of Woon Seong.

Then he turned his head and compared the strength of Woon Seong to the child who had finished first.

Woon Seong was the second to arrive. However, the first child had his clothes in rags, whereas Woon Seong had not even a scratch on him.

Blood was even trickling out from wounds here and there.

Sang In-Hyo, who confirmed the strength of Woon Seong, smiled and murmured once more.

“He must be a blessing for the Cult.”

It was then that another entrance to the cave they were in, began to vibrate and open.

The next person to walk out was Ah-Young, who also knew Woon Seong from the Third Hall.

She grew up to be an unrecognizable beauty, and her hair was a little messy, perhaps after a fierce battle or it was just her natural tomboyish nature.

“Oh, my?”

She recognized Woon Seong and waved her hand at him. Woon Seong saw this, snorted and looked away feigning ignorance.

She was curious about Woon Seong before, but her interest had become even more riled up ever since Woon Seong had killed No. 185 and his 5 other lackeys with utter ease.

He, in her eyes, was a sleek and fit boy with long wavy blue hair and eyes that were cold like a serpent's.

She knew Woon Seong, but the first child she did not recognize, and one other child was just entering as well.

They didn't know it other than Sang In-Hyo, but these were the three children that had entered aside from Woon Seong, and had established themselves very early on in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Of course, there was one more person... Woon Seong, the dark horse of sorts.

No. 900 wasn't worth much in the beginning in the eyes of the instructors, but he started growing at a frightening pace with a higher learning curve than all the other 3 children, combined.

In any case, all 4 of them at the same time flinched as they examined each other's strengths. They knew these other 3 people aside themselves, were the other elites from the Cave of Latent Demons.

Starting with them, more children passed through their own trials of life and death hall one-by-one. When the door finally closed, there were a total of 89 people.

"Hmmm, I think there's quite a lot. It seems you all were able to pass."

Sang In-Hyo quickly summed up the deaths of the children who had died.

He was addressing the children who went crazy and couldn't stand the solitude of the training and went crazy.

"Well, you did a good job anyway. You've now gained the titles of Demonic Captains by passing through this trial of life and death. Congratulations."

A Demonic Captain.

Woon Seong recalled just how many Demonic Captains there were in relationship to the entire Cult of the Heavenly Demon. If one looked

throughout the entire Cult of the Heavenly Demon, there were only about 2,000 of them.

The young men and women from the Cave of Latent Demons, who now had just finished their closed door training, were officially part of those 2,000 Demonic Captains within the Cult.

It seemed this was just one of the reasons for the Cave of Latent Demons, Woon Seong thought.

Considering the Senior Instructors of the Cave of Latent Demons were Demonic Generals and Sang In-Hyo was a Great Demon, it was a great boon for the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“.....there seem to be a few who are good enough to even be called Demonic Generals, but you must all be tired from exiting your closed door training.”

Sang In-Hyo smiled widely as he looked at 4 children among the 89 there. They were the first four children to arrive from their closed door training. No. 17, No. 01, No. 109 and lastly.... No. 900.

This was the Cave of Latent Demons, and it would be an amazing blessing if Sang In-Hyo was able to produce even a single Demonic General.

However, forget one. He had four of those individuals!

“For you, the teachers have personally given you a prize. So just for today, you can eat proper meals and enjoy yourself as much as you’d like.”

When he stomped his foot lightly, a sweet, greasy and aromatic smell began to start emanating in the air.

The trainees turned their heads toward the source of the smell in unison, and servants carrying multiple bright and beautiful dishes that were enough to even make the Emperor drool in satisfaction, were being brought out.

“Come on and enjoy yourselves, you will need the food and rest in order to be prepared for your last trial of life and death inside the cave tomorrow.”

Sang In-Hyo turned his head and smiled as the food was finally placed in front of the children. He made a special emphasis on the fact that it was the final trial of life and death for them. But, Woon Seong picked up on the clause at the end that left more thoughts to be desired.

‘Inside the cave that is... Hm.’

“We’ll get out of the way, so enjoy yourself.”

At the end of the speech, all the instructors, including Senior Instructors, left their seats, and the children looked at the food in front of them with puzzled eyes.

There were mountains of food

There weren’t any dishes that were not fancy enough to not be called an absolute delicacy.

It was a beautiful scene of wonderful dishes and meats that the children had never known in their lives.

Especially so when they started their lives in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Aside from the basic nutritional supplements, they were trainees who had never eaten any dishes that could seriously fill their stomachs.

As a result, natural hesitation arose within the children. But, there were four individuals who moved in between the hesitating 89 children,

The first one was No. 01.

He moved slowly, packed a huge amount of food onto a plate, and headed to a corner to eat by himself.

Next was No 109.

He approached quietly and went to the corner with some food while snarkily moving his eyes like a rabid animal, wary of anyone who tried to touch him or his food.

Next up was No. 17, Ah-Young.

She settled down on the table, kept her dignified appearance, and started to taste the various kinds of food.

And the last one among the four to move was, No. 900, Woon Seong.

After packing only a few different foods on the table, seemingly the same kind of small amount that the children had been receiving prior to this, Woon Seong took his small plate of food and returned to where he had been leaning against the wall and started to eat very slowly, savoring the small bits of food he received.

Soon, the puzzled and hesitant trainees noticed the situation and moved with excitement on their faces.

“Wow!”

“Let’s eat!”

* * *

Sang In-Hyo, who was walking outside, called in a senior instructor to his side. It was the senior instructor in charge of the Third Hall of Latent Demons.

“I’m sure now that I’ve seen it with my own eyes. No. 900 has changed. How can one possibly look at him and think he was the 900th in terms of talent?”

“I was surprised to see it, too.... I was even more shocked to see that he had grown so much in the last 4 years, I didn’t expect him to grow all the way to the level of a Demonic General.”

Sang In-Hyo smiled at the words.

“No, he’s not just a Demonic General like the other three. That boy... he’s already above the level of No. 01, 17 and 109.”

At the words, the faces of the instructors who were listening to Sang In-Hyo, including the senior instructor in charge of the Third Hall, hardened.

Maybe that was why Sang In-Hyo asked the senior instructor in charge of No. 900's growth for his thoughts.

"What? Are you saying he's really stronger than *'her'*? No. 900 is stronger than No. 17?"

Sang In-Hyo replied with a shrug.

"Well yes, but one thing is for sure."

Sang In-Hyo stopped walking and glanced back, saying so.

Among the children who were scooping the food with delight earlier, Sang In-Hyo quietly observed Woon Seong's strength in more detail.

"That boy is a tiger among tigers."

No. 900.

He was someone Sang In-Hyo was sure would bring a great wave of change within the Cult.

* * *

The day of rest went by quickly.

The trainees enjoyed themselves when they were first given a break, but as the break ended, they couldn't erase their nervous expressions of what was next to come. This was because of the parting words that Sang In-Hyo had given them all.

'After a day's rest, there will still be the third and last trial of life and death within the Cave of Latent Demons.'

It was hard to imagine what it would be like, since the trials of life and death up till now, were all different.

Besides, they didn't get a proper rest, but only one day's worth.

However, there were some people who had little change in their facial expressions. Among those groups of children were Woon Seong, No. 17, No. 01 and No. 109.

It was those who were confident in their abilities to make it through whatever was thrown their way.

They were also ones who ate moderately, checking their condition safely in preparation for the next trial ahead of time by not stuffing themselves.

Wooddeuk- Wooddeuk-

Woon Seong among them, even started to meditate and check his internal qi's condition.

Inside his dantian, he could feel the forces of qi from the Tempered True Blossom surging and writhing with unparalleled strength when compared to before the closed door training.

'I don't know what kind of Trial it will be, but I hope I can get through it with the iron bracers on, if possible.'

His strength was something he didn't want to show off to the limits if possible. It was always beneficial to hide one's true strength until it truly mattered.

If there was an unavoidable situation, Woon Seong would only display his full strength if his life was in actual danger or there would be no other witnesses.

'Once I know what the trial is, I can decide then.'

Woon Seong circulated the internal qi within his dantian calmly as he cracked his eyes open to a slit.

Then, he examined the strength of the other 2 individuals who had arrived first with him that he wasn't familiar with.

‘No. 01 and No. 109.’

They were said to be the top trainees within their respective halls of Latent Demons.

As he had heard the children talking amongst each other about the strongest individuals in their respective halls, Woon Seong could certainly confirm the rumors of them being strong were not exaggerated at all.

However, that was not to say that the three of them had similar levels of strength.

“No. 01 is just a half-step above No. 109 in terms of strength.”

Woon Seong determined he could defeat No. 109 with all of his bracers on.

He would likely be able to win confidently with his bracers on, as long as his strength was well balanced and his techniques were utilized properly

But the other two were a bit different. No. 01 and No. 17.

Woon Seong wasn’t sure if he could defeat No. 01 or No. 17 without taking his bracers off.

He would definitely be able to deal with them if he took off his bracers, but he was unsure of the results if he kept them on.

Woon Seong thought so and clicked his tongue.

‘I’m not strong enough yet.’

It was just an excuse to not be able to defeat them with his bracers on. If he couldn’t do that much, then he wasn’t strong enough to get his revenge now or in the near future.

However, it wasn;t that he lacked effort. He just lacked time right now to train properly and surpass them.

Chapter 17: Ranking Dispute (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 17 – Ranking Dispute (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

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* * *

In the morning, the senior instructors came to lead the trainees somewhere. It was unknown how far and for how long they walked. Finally, they stopped in an area with quite a lot of space.

In the middle of the area, Sang In-hyo stood with a smile of unknown meaning.

“This is where the third Trial of Life and Death will be held.”

It seemed that the third Trial would be held in a vacant lot, void of any life-threatening things. The trainees, who were expecting more dangerous terrain, murmured at this realization.

“Only the strong stand at the end. The strong stand alone and the weak perish. This is true in any part of Murim, but especially so in our Cult.”

His voice was small, but it reached the ears of all the children. Woon Seong once again shook his head due to the skill of this General Director.

“The strong are treated appropriately. If so, aren’t you all curious? Who is the strongest of you?”

The children looked at each other. Their skills had been accumulated through the closed door training. Now, they had become quite proud of their abilities. Each of them came and went with eyes that showed they thought they were the best.

Sang In-hyo nodded at their behavior, as if he were satisfied. "That is what we find out in this third Trial. We call it the 'Strife of Life and Death'."

A fight between life and death.

"Life and death. Make the opponent surrender through your strength, dead or alive! If they don't surrender, you can kill! But keep one thing in mind. There is only a living person and a dead man walking, a winner and a loser on this stage!"

Sang In-hyo's words made their hearts beat. Some of them could not contain themselves and shouted.

"Oh, I have not told you." Sang In-hyo added, slowly descending the platform. "To the one who survives until the end, we will make you a weapon of Flame Patterned Black Iron. If you desire it, do not lose." He smiled.

Soon after, the Trial began.

The process was very simple. The instructor would call two children forward to fight. The winners and losers would then be split and fight again in their respective groups. It would repeat until there was the final winner left.

The martial arts of the trainees who climbed upon the state continued to burst forth. All were trainees who had survived the Cave of Latent Demons. There wasn't a single one who had half-baked skills. The trainees were all no nonsense, because the winner among them would have honor.

Even in such an atmosphere, Woon-seong thought differently. Who cared about this shallow honor? The last person standing could receive the prize.

He moistened his lips with a swipe of his tongue. He would be lying if he said he had no ambition.

Black iron had a value similar to a lump of gold. It was natural that greed would arise. In addition, this was no ordinary black iron but the flame-patterned sort. This type had flame patterns and when melted, made a beautiful weapon that was stronger than ordinary ones.

Even if it wasn't for the weapon, Woon-seong planned to defeat them all. Pride from his previous life would not allow him to lose.

“Number 63 and Number 900!”

Woon-seong's name was soon called and he went up to the stage.

The moment you stepped onto the stage, the duel began. Strictly speaking, this duel had already begun.

Woon-seong slowly moved forward, looking at the face of Number 63. He did not recognize the other, so perhaps the other was not from the 3rd Hall.

Number 63 smiled after hearing the ranking of Woon-seong and believed that his opponent was akin to a free win. This was because their number represented their ranking in talent and strength — 900 was essentially dead last. Of course, this ranking was not absolute: people could go beyond their supposed level, but who was monstrous enough to overcome natural talent?

Number 63 had not met someone that could show skills far beyond their rank. Currently, there were 800 ranks between himself and his opponent. He believed it would be an easy victory.

“Why don't you surrender now and I'll let you live!”

Maybe it was supposed to be a provocation, but it showed that he had not judged Woon-seong's level very well.

The trainees of the 3rd Hall, who remembered Woon-seong's face, swallowed their saliva. This was a guy who started as Number 900 and

showed overwhelming accomplishment by beating almost the entirety of the 3rd Hall. Number 63 was looking for death.

“Did you hear me? I said you could live if you surrender now.”

“You seem to overestimate yourself.”

The moment the other was shaking his head at his words, Woon-seong darted out. Frenzied movements spilled out from his body.

Number 63 was startled and lifted his sword. Sparks formed as their weapons met!

Number 63 was immediately pushed backwards and Woon-seong chased him again, wielding his spear. The other was hit on his thighs and shoulders in a row. At this point, his body had twisted.

With a spear to the other’s neck, Woon-seong asked, “I ask the opposite. Will you let me win or will you choose the punishment?”

At the mention of punishment, Woon-seong wrapped himself in ‘intimidation qi’. Number 63 murmured his answer with his limbs trembling like the branches of an aspen tree.

“Hah, I surrender.”

Woon-seong had his first victory just like that.

These duels continued. Some won, some lost. Even in such circumstances, there were a few who continued with overwhelming, continuous victories.

Number 1 used twin blades and defeated the others with pure strength. Number 109 used a quicksword, moving faster than anyone else, causing his opponents to fall down before they could even surrender. Next was Woon-seong. He knocked down his opponents without using an qi. His ability was so great that he did not even need to reveal his martial arts properly in order to defeat the others.

Woon Seong also noticed A-Young’s strength.

Previously, Woon-seong had only been using basic martial arts. With how neat his movements were, even if his opponent did not surrender and were killed, he did not have a drop of blood on his sword or staining his clothes.

After watching the matches, he was now confident in winning Number 1 and 109 without removing the bracers. However, unless he took them off, he could not guarantee winning against A-young. The eyes staring at her gradually hardened.

The duels continued. In the process, more than ten children died. The Cave of Latent Demons, which had begun with 1,000 people, now had fewer than 80 left.

Finally, there were only four trainees qualified to remain on the platform.

Woon-seong identified the faces of the other survivors and confirmed his previous predictions as correct. Number 1, Number 109, A-young, and himself.

Only two more fights would determine the final winner.

“Number 1, Number 900. Come forward!”

Woon-seong went up the state with a cool face when he heard this call. His opponent could not hide his hostility. Number 1 pointed one of his blades at his opponent, feeling humiliated to see a Woon Seong who was still nonchalant.

Woon-seong laughed in response. His opponent’s answer to that was even worse than before. Number 1 released a totally different energy that he had when he dealt with his other opponents.

“There was no one in 1st Hall who looked down on me. That remains the same here!”

Again, Woon-seong laughed. He twirled his spear, round and round. In his body, a turbulent stream of qi began to circulate.

“You have no idea how vast Murim is.”

In response to the provocation, Woon-seong moved casually. As he approached, his opponent was also preparing to move, but Woon-seong's movements were getting faster as his body became a storm.

Gwan Tae-ryang blocked his first strike and swung back. As their weapons collided, sparks emanated from all sides and the clashing of metal could be heard.

Ta-ta-ta.

As they exchanged blows, balance seemed to be maintained. Spear, blade, spear, blade. They rotated their bodies and manipulated their qi.

“Someone like you is nothing special in the martial society. If you don't want to be looked down on, go train yourself more.”

Woon-seong suddenly started to move faster. His eyes were dark and as his spear moved faster, the body of Gwan Tae-ryung flew out.

‘The Art of Six Seals and Destruction’

‘The Moon of Death and the Dark Night’

Chapter 18

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 18

Translated by : FluffyKHZ

* * *

Boom!

“Cough!”

The spectators impatiently waited as Woon-seong’s opponent flew to the other side of the platform, smashing into the floor. But they waited in vain. Previously ranked Number 1 for talent, Gwan Tae-ryang, had fainted and could not stand up.

Woon-seong looked at the instructor who was in charge of the duel.

Sang In-hyo, who had been watching from a distance muttered, “‘The Art of Six Seals and Destruction’...” Even though it was not originally a demonic art, it became one and even surpassed many others of its kind. He had never imagined its successor would come from the Cave of Latent Demons.

Maybe he will become the rear wave of the Yangtze River and sweep through the Cult. [1] Somehow, Sang In-hyo felt his heart beating in his chest.

It wasn’t difficult. Either way, Woon-seong had made sure that he would be in the finals. *Well, I think he would barely make it as a Demon General.*

Honestly, Woon-seong felt that he was lucky to have met Number 1 at this time. He was quite glad that he wouldn't have to fight seriously twice in a row.

“Next, Number 17, Number 109. Come up!”

Meanwhile, the second match had started.

Among them, the winner would fight against Woon-seong in the finals. Woon-seong returned to his seat and watched the two carefully. If either side was hiding their real strengths, it would not be easy to beat them. Despite the current exchange of twenty seconds, no one had gained the advantage. Sword met sword and created little sparks. Countless skills were shown as each tried to drag the other down, causing tatters to appear on their clothes.

Both the other trainees and the instructors held their breaths. It was clear that Demonic General-level fights proved that they were skilled.

Ah-young was going to win. It was only Sang In-hyo, the instructors, and Woon-seong who believed this for sure.

Number 109 had conviction that he would be the winner and eventually became impatient, leaving openings. On the other hand, Ah-young remained steady and did not reveal her high-level martial arts. In addition, there was a crucial difference in their breathing. While Number 109's was rough, Ah-young's was steady.

It will probably take another dozen seconds.

Woon-seong calmly assessed the situation, and his judgement proved to be correct. After three more seconds, Ah-young finally showed her strength.

Hut! That's 'The Dark Flower Red Heart'!

Ah-young had shown it for just a moment, but Woon-seong had clearly seen it. The unique energy of the 'Dark Flower Red Heart' was revealed in that short moment!

As soon as he saw it, Woon-seong was able to know Ah-young's full name.

That's why you didn't tell me your last name! Chun Ah-young.

Why hadn't she said her last name before? 'Chun' was the most noble surname, only one person in the Demonic Sect had it!

'The First Connection of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon', the direct descendent of the Cult Leader, Chun Hwi!

Woon-seong looked surprised and looked around at the instructors. They nodded, as if it was natural. It seemed that they already knew that Cheon Ah-young had the bloodline of the Heavenly Demon.

The divine art of the Heavenly Demon was inside the Cave of Latent Demons.

Woon-seong's eyes were deeper than ever as his fighting spirit surged.

Meanwhile, Ah-young had overwhelmed Number 109. It had taken about ten seconds, like Woon-seong had guessed.

How awesome.

Woon-seong put a hand to his chest, his heart was pounding hard for a win. He felt the desire to compete instead of fear.

The duel between him and Ah-young was passionate. They struck like lightning over and over, sparks flying everywhere.

This was not a confrontation between those who were Demonic General-level in name, but one between those who had truly entered that stage.

Woon-seong gripped his spear tight and wielded it. Ah-young's sword seemed to melt into the air, blocking his spear.

Boom!

With this collision, they were simultaneously pushed back.

They crossed weapons again quickly. Woon-seong could feel his spear trembling.

So this is the heritage of the Heavenly Demon.

She was strong enough without using divine arts, but if possible, he wanted to see the strength of the ‘Dark Flower Red Heart’. There was the question of whether she could still use it though.

‘The Dark Flower Red Heart’ is the ‘First Connection of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’. But Chun A-young’s body does not have enough qi to use it.

It seemed that Ah-young could only use it for a short period of time. Woon-seong stepped back against the storm of attacks, before advancing with increased vigor. A few sword winds blocked in front of him like a folding screen, which Woon-seong countered with his qi. The waves of energy caused by their fight shook the platform.

However, Chun Ah-young still had not used the ‘Dark Flower Red Heart’ yet.

I guess you want me to show my sincerity...?

Woon-seong rolled his feet and pushed Ah-young before slowly gathering his energy. Though it was not enough of a crisis to use his ‘intimidation qi’, he was willing to show some of his tricks.

‘Erase from the stars to the sun!’

Woon-seong drew his energy into his arms and prepared to strike.

“Oh, I can’t beat him. I surrender!” Chun Ah-young actually shook her hands and stepped back.

Woon-seong faltered at her words, his eyebrows twitching with annoyance. This was a good chance for him to compete with her and he did not want to miss it.

Ah-young shrugged her shoulders when asked by Woon-seong. “My physical condition is not very good, I have internal injuries.”

“Internal injuries?”

She shook her head and closed her eyes, as if she refused to speak anymore.

Woon-seong smelled the faint smell of blood as she spoke. Blood was flowing from the corner of her mouth. It was likely caused by a backfire in her earlier fight, when she had forcefully used the ‘Dark Flower Red Heart’. It was possible that her qi had been sealed to conceal her true strength, either by herself or by someone else.

Anyways, fighting against Ah-young would not have let him confirm the true strength of the divine martial art. Winning as it was and taking the black iron weapon was enough for the current Woon-seong.

“I see.”

He dissolved the energy that he had raised to the maximum and pulled back his spear.

As Woon-seong accepted her surrender, Ah-young laughed. “You owe me one.”

Woon-seong scoffed at her reply, “That’s ridiculous.” He wiped his mouth with his sleeve, warning her to do the same and to watch her injuries.

Ah-young, listening to him, descended from the platform and continued to laugh. “You’re something special Number 900.”

He did not dignify that with a reply.

At the end, the Senior Instructor shouted loudly. “The winner of the ‘Strife of Life and Death’, champion of the Latent Cave of Demons is Number 900!”

“Congratulations.”

“I was lucky.”

Sang In-hyo’s mouth twitched as he watched Woon-seong answer his congratulatory remarks. His eyes turned to the latter’s wrists and ankles, where his bracers remained intact.

“Luck huh...It could be.”

Woon-seong felt the eyes of the General Director, but did not make any comments.

“Number 900. When the Cave started, you were one of the weakest. So be proud of yourself. In the history of the Cave of Latent Demons, no champion started from the 900s. The highest was maybe the 200s.”

Woon-seong accepted these words of Sang In-hyo, who continued to talk as if he did not care about the other’s response.

“But despite that fact, you setting a new record can only mean two things.” Sang In-hyo paused to watch Woon-seong, whose eyes were clear. “You either have something that we don’t know, or your wisdom surpasses your potential. Which one do you think it is?”

Woon-seong shook his head. “I am not sure.”

Did he like Woon-seong’s answer? Sang In-hyo did not show it on his face. Instead, he put his hand inside his sleeves and removed a lump of black iron.

“If you have the image of the weapon you desire, tell it to the senior instructor. Since you use the spear, we will forge the shape you want with this iron.”

When he finished talking, he put the black iron back into his sleeves. It would only come into the hands of Woon-seong once it was a complete weapon.

“You may go back.”

Sang In-hyo sent Woon-seong back and slowly looked around. Each survivor made eye contact.

“Everyone has worked hard. Only a fraction of you survived, but I’m glad that only the real ones had survived.” But what came out of his mouth next shocked the children. “But did you know? The Cave of Latent Demons still has six months left.”

The Cave of Latent Demons had a total of ten years. It had only been a little over nine at this point.

At this, the trainees groaned but were silenced just as quick.

“For the rest of this time, you will face the last trial of the Cave of Latent Demons. And this final trial ...” Sang In-hyo laughed viciously.

Just like he said, the training was not over yet.

Chapter 19: Sandstorm Of Death (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 19 – Sandstorm of Death (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

* * *

The wind that came from somewhere swept the boy roughly. The sand fluttered through this wind, stinging his eyes.

Hmph.

The boy used his qi to shake off the sand, causing his clothes to flutter gently. He then started moving again. Every time he walked, he could feel the hot energy from beneath his feet. In this heat, Woon-seong lifted his head up and looked at the Heavens.

The rising sun looked strangely large and bright.

The endlessly wide Great Desert, as it was called, stretched out before the boy.

Looking at the desert, the boy brought out the water bottle and lightly drained the water. Not much was needed. As long as a small amount of moisture was sent throughout the body his thirst could be gone with just a sip of water.

The boy's thoughts floated to just a month ago.

The Third Trial had been the final test to the Cave of Latent Demons, but not the training of the Cave of Latent Demons.

In keeping with ‘real world training’, the trainees were released out into the world to perform some missions. This allowed them to gain hands-on experience and at the same time make contributions to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. The contributions made at this time were also considered as important achievements and would help determine the final ranking and status of the trainees after returning to the Cult half a year later.

One of the places where Woon-seong was sent was the Great Desert. It would have been nicer if he had been dispatched somewhere else, but unfortunately the only options were the North Sea or the Great Desert.

Not like he had a choice to begin with.

Along with Woon-seong, about forty other trainees were sent to the Great Desert. About half of the trainees were sent to barracks or command posts with missions on them. The trainees had to resolve the missions listed for them in order and report their achievements at these posts.

There were two types of missions to be completed. There were individual and group missions, among which the individual missions were given with varying difficulty according to the achievements within the Cave of Latent Demons.

Of course, Woon-seong’s arms carried a command that he had received before leaving the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

You really are preparing for war.

Like his own, the missions of many other trainees were also to subjugate nearby factions. This was literally the Cult cleaning up the region. Arranging to settle the elements that threatened the back of the line before charging forward was the basis of great military strategy. Of course, this was not set in stone, but the probability was high.

Woon-seong continued to move and forgot about the idea of war, that was beyond the current him. Instead, he thought about the mission stated in the order. Personal and group missions, he had to first finish his personal one. A full month was given for the trainees to gather and then resolve the group mission, so all individual missions had to be finished within a month.

My mission is to subjugate the Sandstorm of Death.

Called the Sandstorm of Death, they were a band of thieves that had grown rapidly in power recently. Due to their agile movements through the use of horses, a number of branches of the Cult settled in the Great Desert were having annoying experiences.

Of course, this was not an easy mission. An average trainee of the Cave of Latent Demons could never do this alone. However, Woon-seong was a Demonic General-class trainee as well as the first rank in the entire Cave. If not him, then who? The higher ups, as well as himself, had determined the he alone was enough.

If I use Intimidation Qi it will not be difficult.

Woon-seong walked through the sand, then put his hand into his sleeve and grabbed a slate. This was a symbol from the Cult of the Heavenly Demon that guaranteed his status as a Demonic General. It had been handed to him as he left the Cave.

I must first find a branch of the Demonic Cult.

In order to identify the location of the Sandstorm of Death, he first had to find a branch to provide him information.

“If you want to get help from the branch, remember these places now: Urumqi, Turpan, Korla, Lop Nor, Kashgur...” That was what the Senior Instructor had said before the trainees left the Cult.

Among these places, Lop Nor was not far away.

Lop Nor it is then.

Lop Nor had one of the largest lakes in the Xinjiang area, which was mostly composed of desert. Because of this, there were big and small cities formed around the lake. Among them, Qi Ke Xuan was the largest city formed. It had all kinds of things, although it may not be comparable to other larger cities.

Of course, the reason why Woon-seong was going was a place called Han's Bookstore. This store was a traditional place in Qi Ke Xuan and had run for five generations. At present, a man who had reached his sixties named Han No was operating as the master. After living here for a long time, Han No had become acquainted with the neighbors. Thanks to that, he had easy access to rumors and information nearby. As a result, there were more visitors in this bookstore who asked for directions or for simple information than those who wanted to buy a book.

Woon-seong, who had entered Qi Ke Xuan, was headed to this place. Of course, he was not going there to obtain information concerning the branch of the Cult in the area. Even if he wanted that information, it would have been impossible. No, he was visiting because the bookstore was the branch of the Demonic Cult itself.

The location of this branch was simply for gathering information and as a deterrent; it had no real combat effectiveness. It was also for this reason that the Demonic Cult had not properly solved the problem of the Sandstorm of Death, a group of mere bandits.

Of course, there is another reason why it hasn't been done until now.

The Sandstorm of Death wasn't a size that needed to be paid attention to. It was only in these few years that it had increased in size. In less than five years, the group had grown to a scale large enough to call it a medium-sized organized group and not a horde. If the Cult was preparing for a war, it would make sense for the Sandstorm of Death to be removed, though it was not a great threat.

Even though...the branch of the Demonic Cult is disguised as a bookstore.

Woon-seong went inside with a light smile on his face as he saw the sign saying 'Han's Bookstore'. The smell peculiar to old books was strong and there were a few other guests.

Things are visible. All of them have not learned martial arts and are ordinary guests who have nothing to do with the Demonic Cult.

Beyond that, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was seen in the presence of the manager, who did not even reach the Demonic Captain level. However, it was better to be safe, so Han No was sent to be the branch manager of this place.

Woon-seong passed by the long shelves of books and approached the manager.

"I'm here to pick up a book I ordered."

At the words of the boy, the man, whose eyes did not see well, looked him up and down.

"Do you know the title of the book?"

"'The Dirty and Treacherous Stories'."

On the surface, this was a book of ghost stories. The eyes of the man trembled at the title though.

"Interesting. I don't think that's something that came in recently. Can you tell me when you ordered it?"

Woon-seong tapped his chin lightly at the question, his actions telling the man what he needed to know. If they did not speak or act properly, it was impossible for him to get inside the branch and receive information.

Haha, it's a good thing I listened to the Senior Instructor well.

"I cannot remember exactly when I ordered it, but it seems to be about a year ago."

“One year. Then the book will be in the back warehouse...” The man glanced back. The warehouse could be seen through a half-open door, it was filled with books. “Will you come in with me and look for it?”

The boy nodded his head and the manager rose from his seat and entered the warehouse. Woon-seong followed him in.

“May I see your slate?”

Once he entered the warehouse and closed the door, Han No’s behavior changed. He was a branch manager of the Demonic Cult, but he did not have that high of a status. He could not treat a man on a mission outside like a mere guest, death would come if he made a mistake.

“Here.”

Woon-seong showed his slate and as soon as Han No confirmed his identity at the Demonic General level, he shuddered.

“I have confirmed it.” Immediately afterwards, Han No became even more polite. “What information would you like?”

“The Sandstorm of Death.”

“You’re talking about those devils.” He took out a small booklet from the corner and handed it over. “Here it is.”

“Song Mong Zone?” Woon-seong accepted the book and checked the cover. The information did not seem to be about the Sandstorm of Death. “The story is an ordinary Murim hero’s journey. Can you not write down confidential information...?”

Woon-seong nodded to himself before the other could answer, realizing the answer to his question was obvious; it made sense to hide it.

“Then, how can I check the contents?”

“You can get the information you want if you take out the last chapter and burn it.”

Woon-seong soon left the bookstore and went to the outskirts of the town, then burned a bunch of leaves and firewood together. The shadow of fire was reflected in his eyes. The flames swayed back and forth and the sparks sprang up towards the sky. He was reminded of complex thoughts.

If I leave Xinjiang and go to Zhongyuan, I can meet them.

He could see the face of the enemy. Since his body had changed, his enemies would not recognize him and he could deal with them.

Aren't I wasting time here?

Wasn't it better to go right now and aim his spear at the necks of his enemies? Woon-seong sure felt that way. But he shook his head.

Chapter 20: Sandstorm Of Death (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 20 – Sandstorm of Death (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

On that last day, dozens of the Murim had come to seize the lives of Woon-seong and his master. If you added up the number of men who were part of the siege, it would actually exceed 500. Revenge against all of them was unreasonable by the power that Woon-seong currently held. Even if he regained his former power, even if he reached the same level as his master, he would fail.

That's why I will use the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The Cult would be better than an individual. In fact, half of Murim was already the Cult's enemy, so there was nothing wrong with using them.

Let's not be in a hurry. Don't rush this.

It was enough even if he had to take a long time. As long as he could spear through their hearts in the end, it was enough.

The first step is to strengthen my power in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong opened his eyes and brought out the book. He opened it to the last chapter and brought it near the burning fire before his eyes. As the heat

of the flame reached the last sheet of paper, translucent letters began to appear on the page. The information which had been written with a special dye appeared.

How the Sandstorm of Death had grown in the last five years. Who the officials and important people were. Their movements and strongholds. The Cult had a very detailed record of their observations.

His eyes shrank as they scanned the paper. An unbelievable name was discovered. The current leader of the Sandstorm of Death, who joined five years ago, was believed to be the ‘Sword of Men’, Mae Hong-sung, one of the Three Swords of Qingcheng.

Three Swords of Qingcheng!

Woon-seong smiled brightly at the name of an enemy he had found in an unexpected place, revealing his fangs. His face was darker than ever before.

The ‘Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset’. This swordsmanship, named for the style like the sun and clouds, is considered to be one of the most difficult styles to learn alongside the Shaolin’s ‘Three Swords of Dharma’, the Wu Tang Clan’s ‘Wise Sword of Taiji’, the Nangong’s ‘Sword Form of the Emperor’, and Mount Hua’s ‘Divine Sword of Purple Sunset’. If it could be passed on to one person in each generation, it was considered a good result.

The current successor of the Qingcheng’s Martial Division was Qingcheng’s Great Elder, the First Apprentice, Song Chi-hak. Ever since he was a child, he was chosen as the ‘Sword of Heaven’ of the Three Swords of Qingcheng and learned everything they had. When he became a Great Elder, he raised a new line of the Three Swords of Qingcheng. His disciples were the current ‘Sword of Heaven’, ‘Sword of Earth’, and ‘Sword of Men’.

Woon-seong climbed up a rocky hill. The Murim knew the Qingcheng as people who would lead the new generation, but he also knew their dirty truth. Their duality had been shown to him very clearly in his past life. With one of them here to meet his spear, Woon-seong was naturally joyful.

But why is there one of the Three Swords of Qingcheng here?

Woon-seong stopped at the top of the hill. Strictly speaking, this area was out of the Qingcheng Sect's reach. To be more precise, the area was so remote that it was unnecessary to send one of the Three Swords of Qingcheng.

The boy tapped his chin. It was five years ago that the 'Sword of Men' Mae Hong-sung had joined the Sandstorm of Death, and five years ago, the Sandstorm of Death suddenly grew in strength.

Woon-seong shook his head quietly. There were no coincidences in Murim. You had to think like that in order to live. If something seemed like a coincidence, it was better to think and move carefully. Only that way could you survive longer in the world of Murim.

Woon-seong bit his lip. There was definitely something going on under the surface, he just wasn't sure what.

Then I can just catch him and ask him.

A run-down temple was located on the rocky hill he had been climbing. This is where the bandits were staying. Woon-seong grabbed his spear from where it was strapped loosely to his back. Within a few steps, he could see the entrance. A decaying wooden door barely blocked the wind at the entrance. Beyond that, the boy could feel the presence of some members of the Sandstorm of Death. However, he could not feel that of the Sword of Men.

Woon-seong moved smoothly. He killed the lookout, flew inside like the wind, and slid up to the pillar that supported the roof.

"Hahahahaha. Bring more alcohol!"

"Are there no women? Do we have any women?"

The men were drinking alcohol, with their plundered belongings piled up inside. Woon-seong's eyes glanced over them. Perhaps the Sword of Men

was away, but that wouldn't give him the chance to escape his fate at the hands of the boy. Either way, they would all be killed.

Save one for interrogation, kill everyone else.

Woon-seong closed his eyes for a moment. Once he opened them, they were gold, like that of a tiger's at night. He then dropped his body to the floor below, with no consideration of his surroundings. The bastards of the Sandstorm of Death faced a disaster they had never seen before, the disaster called Hyuk Woon-seong.

It was a complete one-sided slaughter. The boy moved like a ghost and avoided their swords. His body was like a shadow that faded away and their swords would pass through his body. Shortly afterwards, he would melt back into existence and sweep them away with his spear. He had activated his murky 'intimidation qi', stimulating and grabbing at the bodies of the bandits, who shook and dropped like flies. Waist, chest, thighs, shoulders — these bandits were sliced all over the body and fell. There was not a single one of them that could avoid Woon-seong's attacks.

But some of them had not yet fallen completely and continued to scream, "What a monster!"

They're pretty strong for ordinary bandits.

In addition, Woon-seong believed some of them could use inner strength and practiced Taoist qi. Take, for example, the guy charging at him now. However, the guy flew backwards faster than he had run over, and was smashed into the wall of the temple. The walls of the ruined building collapsed into rubble from the impact.

Woon-seong stared at the fallen men before him with a weird gaze.

"Who did you learn martial arts from?" He already had a good guess, but asking was for the sake of certainty.

When asked, the man on the ground shook his head, groaning. Woon-seong spared him no mercy and slashed his chest apart. He then moved towards

another one.

“I ask again, who taught you?”

At this moment, Woon-seong was a king of terror even though he was not using his ‘intimidation qi’. The bandit in question trembled with a white face.

“Well, it was Master Chuk.”

The name of the one he was looking for was Mae Hong-sung, not a Master Chuk. However, it was not possible to rule out the possibility of an alias.

“Does this Master Chuk have a thin chin, bushy beard, and thick eyebrows?”

Would this description be correct?

The man was trembling. “How the hell do you...? Who are you? Are you from the government?!”

Woon-seong grinned. “Then let me continue to ask you. Mae Hong-sung, no your Master Chuk, where is ...?”

Originally he was trying to find out more, but he stopped talking. There was no need to continue asking. With his spear pointed to the closed the door, Woon-seong watched as it opened and a man entered.

“What the hell is going on?!”

Woon-seong turned his head to see the man’s face and welcomed him with a greeting, “It’s been a long time, Master Chuk.”

The man was a bit older than he remembered, but it was obvious. He glanced at the enemy that he had been reunited with after ten years.

The Sword of Men, Mae Hong-sung.

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Chapter 21: Sword Of Men (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 21 – Sword of Men (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Oh no! Please help me!”

Mae Hong-sung looked at the woman with derision, loosening his pants as he did so. “Two years! Who would even care if I killed you right now?”

There was a strong lust that could not be hidden in the voice of the man. Could the woman foresee her fate from his voice? She only had one wish at this moment, as only death would free her from the phantom before her.

“Huh. You have a nice look there.”

A woman’s voice could be heard, crying for mercy. However, the man attacked her, and she could not bear the strength of a man who had learned to use inner strength. At this time, you could hear the screams of the woman and the lustful noises of the man. After he finished, he struck the woman and left the alley alone. Inside the alley, there was only the dead body of the woman, which had cooled with her eyes still open.

“How long do I have to live like this?” Mae Hong-sung, clicking his tongue, looked around. A small lake in a deserted desert. There was quite a large village nearby. Of course, that was in comparison to its surroundings — it was it was more dead as a city prefecture less its size. This was a remote place, and nothing could deny that fact.

It had been five years since he had come here under the direction of his master. Three Swords of Qingcheng, this name was well known in Murim. But for five years, he had played and ate as a bandit in this peripheral corner of the world. He felt insulted, humiliated by his master. When he had left, he received only two orders from his master: (1) stay in the area until we call for you and (2) find the Sandstorm of Death, teach them martial arts, and train them to be great guerilla fighters.

He had wanted to protest. However, his master promised to teach him the final lines of the 'Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset' if he quietly completed what he was tasked with. Within a few years, Mae Hong-sung believed that his master would call on him and he would be able to receive the last verse.

Mae Hong-sung started straight for Xinjiang, following his master's command. He met the Sandstorm of Death and raised them. He stalwartly believed that someday his master would call, but it had now been five years. His patience was running out. In addition, almost a year ago, he began to believe that his master had abandoned him.

It was then that Mae Hong-sung started wandering. His hidden, dirty desires began to sprout now that there were no eyes that judged him. It had led to his acts of raping and killing women in the nearby villages, ruining any servants around the area.

How much longer do I have to stay with these dirty thieves?

Mae Hong-sung's head was full of complex thoughts as he walked. Suddenly he stopped. Although he had rolled for a few years among the low-lives, his instincts had not died yet. A slight smell of blood was mixed with the sandy breeze. However, he shook his head and kept walking. Soon, his face hardened. The direction which this bloody breeze was coming from was the place where he was headed. At first, he had thought it was the smell of a pig, but it was definitely human blood.

What happened?

He had raised those guys for the past five years. It was annoying and dirty, but when his master called, they were what he could show as his results. What happened to those guys? Mae Hong-sung was a bit anxious.

“It’s been a long time, Master Chuk.”

A young man was smiling brightly among his underlings, who had turned into a pile of corpses.

This young man was Woon-seong, who flashed his pearly whites and straightened his body. He seemed to be liberated from something and was simmering with life, staring intently at the other.

Mixed with hot desert winds, the boy’s qi had spread everywhere. He had become a Demonic General and was again cherished, how unusual. This was the first meeting after ten years. This was not how Woon-seong had ever imagined it, so he did not jump out at once and run over to slice the other’s neck. Despite the fact that one of his enemies stood in front of him, the boy’s head was clear.

This was the effect of the marriage of his techniques. His soul and body were strengthened, helping maintain a calm judgement even before his sworn enemy.

His lips still curled up though.

Mae Hong-sung stared at himself, reflected in the young man’s dark eyes. He was actually embarrassed and found the situation ridiculous. After five years of training, the Sandstorm of Death had fallen to just one guy. Absolute trash.

The person had also greeted him as if they were familiar, but Mae Hong-sung had never met this person before.

The young man before him was about twenty, his body felt sharp like a blade. His skin tingled even when he stood still. By contrast, the man’s eyes were clear and calm.

“Who are you?”

At that question, Woon-seong grabbed his spear instead of answering. He had no intention of telling Mae Hong-sung who he was. It's not like the other would have believed him, so it was better not to say it at all.

I only need information from him.

Of course, the story related to his identity may come out in the interrogation process.

‘Intimidation qi’ rose from the body of the boy. This dark qi spread around, like a fog, surrounding Mae Hong-sung. This outstretched energy stimulated the human instinct of fear, causing the whole body to shudder, violently and fearfully.

Subconsciously, Mae Hong-sung had drawn his sword. He was confused at first, but it was soon clear that he had to first fight against this dark stream of qi. He relaxed and the profound energy of the Qingcheng Sect spread across his body.

Looking at that, Woon-seong ridiculed him inwardly. “Taoist qi, being a monk doesn’t suit you.”

It seemed that Mae Hong-sung’s skills had also not taken a major step forward. Of course, decades could pass without much development.

It won’t be such a difficult fight.

Woon-seong was quite confident, he didn’t even need to take off any of his metal bracers. The ability of himself with the bracers on and the Sword of Men didn’t differ much.

“What are you muttering?”

At that time, Mae Hong-sung jumped out and wielded his sword. This sword containing history fell down in an arc, scattering light and energy. Its appearance was like a blue cloud! This was the swordsmanship of Qingcheng.

This move corresponded with Woon-seong's own. With six revolutions of his spear, he used the 'Art of Six Seals and Destruction'. At the same time, he pushed more 'intimidation qi' out. Even if you were an apex predator, you could only instinctively crouch!

With the energy wrapped around his body, Mae Hong-sung flinched for a second. But it was only a momentary pause. The Taoist qi interrupted the 'intimidation qi'. Woon-seong smiled bitterly when he saw this and promised to review this problem after the fight was settled.

In the meantime, the clash continued. Sparks glittered through the fog and mist. The walls continued to collapse. Any bandits who were still alive but unable to move due to serious injuries were buried there as they screamed.

Mae Hong-sung could no longer suppress his anger, his energy bursting out. Woon-seong stepped on the falling debris and snorted coldly.

At this time, Woon-seong changed his spear arts. 'Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset' was hard to fight against with his unfinished combinatory martial arts.

'Divine Spear of the Ending Night'!

Woon-seong grabbed his spear. His opponent would probably recognize this move, so the moment it was unleashed, the fight had to be finished at once.

"Where are you running?" Mae Hong-sung chased Woon-seong into the air, sword sprinkling more than a dozen cuts.

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Chapter 22: Sword Of Men (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 22 – Sword of Men (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Blood burst into the air. Mae Hong-sung quickly bowed over. As he looked down, he saw a spear in between his legs. He had been attacked, his legs cut right off under his knees. His upper body, having lost its momentum, was slowly leaning forward. It was a situation where it would have been acceptable to curse the Heavens, but he didn't. Even before he could overcome his shock, his suffered from pain so great it left him speechless.

“Oahhhhh!”

Searing pain ran through his body, as if it were a fire ant gnawing at his bones. It was a rough and crude pain that could not be expressed as anything but blistering. Mae Hong-sung wanted to get up and protest. But his two legs were cut off, so he could only scream and roll around.

Looking at him, Woon-seong laughed, revealing his white teeth. Of course, he had a cold smile.

“God, you brat! How dare you!” Mae Hong-sung screamed like the devil.

Woon-seong was indifferent. “What do you mean?” The boy slowly approached him, spear grasped in one hand.

Mae Hong-sung's heart pounded with each step Woon-seong took towards him, each thump louder and louder. In near disbelief, he realized he was trembling. He was afraid of this body, a fear that ran down to the bone. At this moment, he was a lamb at the mercy of a tiger.

“Damn you!”

Mae Hong-sung tried to crawl away with his arms, but the boy was faster. Woon-seong lifted his feet and stepped on the shoulders of the Sword of Men, squishing him in place without a fuss.

“We fought and I won. Isn't one arm and one leg usually cut off in fights like these in the martial world? Did you think we were going to just laugh and shrug it off after a fight to the death?” From the body of the boy, a dark qi was flowing out. Thanks to it, Mae Hong-sung's anger melted back into dread. “I am the winner, you are the loser. And from now on, I will exercise my rights as the winner.” Woon-seong flipped the man over, feet now planted on Mae Hong-sung's chest. “Between you and me, there's no way we could ever just laugh it off.”

Mae Hong-sung once again questioned how he knew this boy. From the first moment, the boy had talked as if they had known each other. Weirdly, he could not erase the feeling of déjà vu either.

Woon-seong patiently waited for the other to recognize him, he had already thrown the bait.

“You, are you...Are you the successor of the Spear Master Sect?!”

“Yes, I am the successor of the Spear Master Sect!” Woon-seong chuckled darkly.

“That's impossible! The Spear Master Sect is a sole apprentice sect!”

Woon-seong laughed at his cry. “If that's what you think, that's good. As I said before, I intend to exercise my rights as the victor.”

Mae Hong-sung trembled at the coldness of the iron felt under his chin. He could not think properly because of induced fear from the ‘intimidation qi’ and the presence of death. In his mind, there was only fear. Thanks to that, the pain was reduced — funny how true fear dulls all the senses.

“Let me ask, why did you attack the Spear Master Sect at that time?”

“What are you talking about?” Now Mae Hong-sung was confused. Everyone knew the answer to that question. “They practiced a vile demonic art that even the lowest and filthiest of the demonic people refuse to touch!”

Obviously, that was not the answer Woon-seong wanted to hear. For such a dumb answer, Woon-seong cut Mae Hong-sung’s left arm off. The severed limb was thrown into the air, tumbling several times before it fell to the floor.

The boy stood above with a sinister smile. “Do not lie. I know we were framed. Tell me what you know.”

The ‘intimidation qi’ stimulated fear. And fear stimulated the brain. Even if you didn’t think, you could throw out the facts just by being horrified.

With his eyes flashing like a gold mine, the boy faced him once again. “If you tell the truth, I will at least kill you without pain,” Woon-seong promised.

With his legs cut off and arms cut off, Mae Hong-sung feared this pain more than his inevitable death. In the end, he had no choice but to spit out all that he knew. “I don’t know, I don’t know anything! That’s all I heard!” He shouted as if he was warding off evil spirits. “I just followed my master’s orders! Our only order that day was to surround the mountain so the master and apprentice of the Spear Master Sect, who learned the ‘Silent Ten Skills of the Demon’, could not run away!”

Woon-seong stared at his eyes and judged. There were no lies in his eyes. This was a man who knew he was already dead, but was afraid of suffering. These eyes could not lie.

Thus, the boy judged his words as the truth and continued to the next question.

“Then let me ask something else, why are you here?” Woon-seong increased the pressure of his foot on Mae Hong-sung’s chest, who choked for air. “Why are you fucking around and teaching petty thieves martial arts?”

“Fuck if I know!” Mae Hong-sung shook his limbs, as if in exasperation. Except for one arm, the only things left were up to his elbows and knees, it was a ridiculous sight. Except, Woon-seong was not amused. “I just did as my master told me. I was only told to go and raise them as guerilla forces.”

At that, Woon-seong gave an even colder look.

What are you thinking about? What kind of work was the Sword of Heaven planning in such a remote place? The boy really could not understand.

In the end, he had obtained no useful information. He had only got revenge on one of his enemies. *Am I allowed to be satisfied with this?*

Woon-seong stared up at the Heavens, hoping that counting the stars in the sky would help answer his questions.

As he did so, Mae Hong-sung desperately grabbed at his leg. “Oh please, if the questions are over, kill me as promised!”

“Why should I?”

“What? You promised! You promised a merciful death!”

Woon-seong nodded in agreement, he certainly had. However, “You aren’t a man worthy of a death like that.”

The boy extended his hand in place of a spear and pierced the man’s body.

“Ohhhh!” The man screamed, freakishly twisting his whole body.

Woon-seong then pressed some other points, forcefully shutting the man up.

Left to convulse on the floor, silent screams continued to pour from the mouth of Mae Hong-sung.

What Woon-seong used was a technique known as ‘Crushed Bones and Squeezed Muscles’. It was a bizarre and quite awful sort of torture that had been collected by the Spear Master Sect. Once used, the victim would feel extreme pain up until their death, wishing that they would die already. The one that Woon-seong used at this point was a bit more special. The victim would continuously feel pain and be unable to faint for at least two hours before dying.

Suitable for the death of an enemy.

Woon-seong watched the scene of Mae Hong-sung pitifully twitching, then turned his back and descended down the hill.

Sitting before a fire, he brought out a blank book and a brush with ink.

Although his revenge had just begun, everything was already so frustrating.

Of course, it could have been worse. With a little less determination, Woon-seong could have died in the Cave of Latent Demons. Even worse, the grudge could have melted away over the years.

Woon-seong closed his eyes and blew out a breath.

He had failed to get any information about the others from Mae Hong-sung.
What a useless guy.

Woon-seong wrote the names of all his enemies one by one on this empty book. No, it was not just a book anymore — this was a promise. He vowed to never forget these names and not miss a single one. He would move forward with firm steps. If anything stood between him and his revenge, it would be obliterated.

With such a pledge written into the book, Woon-seong lifted the brush and drew a line across a name.

~~Mac Hong-sung (Sword of Men).~~

That one was dead already. The boy was now — officially — a murderer.

At some point in time, he would draw a line over every single name in his book. His revenge was just beginning.

In the future, this book would be called “Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon”.

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Chapter 23: The Five Evils (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 23 – The Five Evils (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

After spending a day there, the boy moved on towards the next place. His destination was the group mission meeting spot: Kashgar. [1]

Whee! Whee!

The wind that came from nowhere swept past the boy roughly, swirling up sand and stinging his eyes. The boy used his qi to shake off the sand, causing his clothes to flutter gently in the wind. Sighing to himself, he started moving again.

Dejectedly, Woon-seong trudged through the desert.

I wish I had some more time to visit the safehouse. It's a real pity.

The time given for personal missions was one full month. Now, there was only about one day left in that time. As he had originally planned, the mission should have taken less than a month.

The problem was that he had failed to consider the climate in his plans. With the harsh desert environment, Woon-seong had to spend more time traveling than he had expected.

Oops.

Forced to huddle around a fire to stay warm at night, Woon-seong was only able to travel during the day. However, he couldn't move at top speed in the scorching sun since he had to conserve water. Unless he was someone who had reached the level of 'impenetrable to cold and heat', limitations to his traveling were inevitable.

I'll have another chance to visit the Spear Master Sect's safehouse, Woon-seong comforted himself.

In addition to being located deep in the mountains, the safehouse was protected by spiritual powers. Those who did not know the way would never find it. Of those currently alive, Woon-seong was positive no one else could touch the stuff in there but him.

The wind howled and the sound whistled past his ear.

First, I should go to the promised location.

Although it was a pity, he should focus on what was at hand. Either way, completing the missions assigned by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was beneficial towards his path for revenge.

Kashgar was in the southernmost region of the Cult of Heavenly Demon, adjacent to the realm of the Martial Alliance and Empire. In addition to the Cult being located in this area, there were a large number of smaller forces that were not tied with the Martial Alliance. Since most of them had signed numerous nonviolence treaties with the Cult, they were left as is.

Sometimes, however, people out of their right minds would pop up.

There was only one group mission and the details given to the trainees by the Cult were sparse. It was said they were criminals who committed crimes at the Potala Palace and fled, they were the blood lamas called the 'Five Evils'.

These bastards were vandalizing the territory of the Cult, not caring about where they were. In his heart, Woon-seong truly considered them idiots who thought too highly of themselves.

Even the demonic cultivators who swore obeisance to the Cult were angered. The Cult could not ignore their duties to their followers. After all, *it is our duty to protect the commoners*.

Woon-seong walked as he recalled more details about the mission. The mission was a kill order: Get rid of all five of them.

By this time, Woon-seong had long left the desert behind him and reached the branch of the Cult in Kashgar. Unlike Lop Nor, Kashgar did not try to hide its true nature — it was definitely a branch of the Demonic Cult.

The two guards by the gate noticed Woon-seong as he walked closer. Maybe it was the weather, or maybe it was their occupation, but they were aggressive.

As soon as the guards had seen him, their hands were on the hilts of their swords.

“Who goes there?”

Woon-seong chuckled at them, not taking any offense. Understanding the instinctive reasoning, he felt amused more than disrespected. After all, anyone who randomly approached would be suspicious, especially one as young as himself.

Even if they *had* acted, the guards wouldn’t have stood a chance against Woon-seong anyway.

Woon-seong threw a slate at the one that identified him as a Demonic General.

One of the guards caught the slate using both his hands. Looking at it, he began to tremble, possibly in fear or in shock. Despite his age, the young man before them was a Demonic General! Acting up against a higher-ranked official was a crime, one that could cost you your life. Would he be so unlucky today?

The other guard was put off by the seemingly arrogant boy in front of him and hadn't noticed his partner's change in demeanor. "Hey! You can't just throw your slate like that!"

When the first guard cried out with an "Ah!", the second asked, "What's wrong?", confused by the panicked expression of his companion.

The one holding the slate only awkwardly tossed it back towards Woon-seong, still a bit shaken.

Woon-seong only smiled as he caught the slate. Though it was not unkind, the guard found it mocking. "I heard the 1st Latent Demon Squad is supposed to gather here."

Attitude having done a 180° turn, the guard welcomed Woon-seong into the branch with a deep bow. "Everyone's here. Follow me."

His companion mirrored his actions, partly out of habit and partly due to the look on the other's face. Still, he could no longer hold his curiosity after Woon-seong had left hearing range. "Hey. who is that guy?"

"Shhhh!" His companion nervously put a finger to his mouth, glancing at Woon-seong's retreating figure. "Pipe down, you idiot! He's just like Mok Dae-young, the Branch Manager of Kashgar, who we serve. That was a Demonic General!"

Leaving his friend in shock, the guard hurried to follow Woon-seong and guided him towards the inner branch area.

Woon-seong walked along the streets, admiring his surroundings. While the streets weren't unclean, it was bustling with activity. As he observed the people, he realized that many of them were martial artists, though their levels were too low to be of much use to the Cult.

With everyone around tied to the Cult by membership or treatise, there was no need for Woon-seong to hide his identity as a Demonic General or put up pretenses. In fact, if he were less loyal to the Cult, Woon-seong could stage a rebellion and take over the branch.

At the same time, Kashgar was a much more militarized branch than Lop Nor. Since Lop Nor was so remote, the branch there was almost solely used for scouting and intel purposes. This could be seen in the way the branch doubled as a bookstore, where the branch manager couldn't even be considered Demonic General level. On the other hand, Kashgar contained a relatively famed Demonic General leading a whole division of officers. The branch was also organized like a fortress, with roofed walls and a few guarded gates.

The two guards who had been at the entrance brought him to the inner branch area, where they opened a second gate for him.

“This way, sir.”

When Woon-seong walked in, he saw a young man waiting for him by a tall tree. The man had his hair cut short and multiple scars across his face, the most noticeable one a large scar running across his right eye.

“You’ve arrived.” The man lifted his hand in an awkward half-wave, but otherwise appeared happy to see Woon-seong.

“It’s been a while, Gwan Tae-ryang.”

In all honesty, Woon-seong had been feeling somewhat awkward too. With a weird mixture of emotions, he greeted this other trainee who had been Number 1 in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Back then, Woon-seong had beaten Gwan Tae-ryang until he passed out in the ‘Strife of Life and Death’ and lectured him. While everyone had naturally understood the concept of ‘survival of the fittest’ and ‘winner takes all’, there were still people like Number 109 who could hold a serious grudge...

Since Gwan Tae-ryang was to be his Lieutenant, he hoped everything was just water under the bridge.

Thankfully, Gwan Tae-ryang was actually beaming as he welcomed Woon-seong, “It’s good to see you safe, Squad Master!”

Naturally, as the strongest in the Cave of Latent Demons, Woon-seong had been tasked with the leadership position during the group mission, becoming the Squad Master for the 1st Latent Demon Squad. Since Gwan Tae-ryang technically had the power to lead his own group, it seemed that their group mission would be a difficult challenge.

They smiled at each other as Woon-seong observed the other.

It seems like he's been through a lot ever since then. He's a much more humble man than back at the 'Strife of Life and Death'.

Woon-seong knew that Gwan Tae-ryang's appearance meant the successful completion of his individual mission. As he knew the difficulty of the missions assigned and his own strength, he was sure that everyone else would have been given a relatively difficult mission as well. Even for him, subjugating a faction by himself hadn't been a walk in the park.

As they could be considered friends now, partners at worst, Woon-seong was glad to see that Gwan Tae-ryang had learned a lot through his journey to the real world.

Waking up from his musings, Woon-seong turned his head to the other side of the courtyard. There, numerous other trainees were sitting at tables, all gathered together, as if waiting for him.

"Oh...It looks like I was the last to arrive."

Once these other trainees saw that Woon-seong had acknowledged their presence, they simultaneously stood up and walked in front of the tables. They lined up in front of him as a group, with Gwan Tae-ryang at the front, leading them. They bowed and greeted him in an orderly fashion.

"1st Latent Demon Squad, reporting for duty, Squad Master!"

Woon-seong chuckled at their actions, understanding that this was a required formality. He let himself feel a little proud, as this was a step towards gathering power and authority in the Cult, a step towards revenge.

For their journey outside, the trainees of the Cave had been divided into three different groups: the 1st, 2nd, and 3rd Latent Demon Squads. These were said to be temporary but received missions much like actual forces of the Cult.

As Woon-seong was the strongest of the Cave, he was commissioned to command the 1st Latent Demon Squad.

“I’m glad to see that all of you are well.” He waved his hand, motioning for them to stop. “But why are you all here and not waiting inside?”

There were only twenty or so of them; no way the branch was unable to give them a place to stay. If they had been random members of the Cult, it might have been understandable. But the squad were here with a mission from the Demonic Cult Headquarters.

“I requested everyone to do so,” Gwan Tae-ryang answered. “We’re about to carry out an important mission and we shouldn’t relax too much.”

Woon-seong was surprised at first, but soon let out an amused huff. “That’s not a bad idea.”

“Right?” Gwan Tae-ryang grinned, obviously quite proud.

Woon-seong only smirked and turned to the rest of his group members. “However!”

He immediately poured cold water over Gwan Tae-ryang’s happy mood.

“Resting and getting rid of fatigue is also important. Being in poor conditions and losing to people weaker than you is a common thing in the martial society.”

The other trainees didn’t look scared or worried, but they had awkward looks on their faces as they imagined losing to someone weaker than them.

“You must maintain the best condition to perform at your best. I know you lived most of your lives disciplining yourselves, so resting might feel awkward, but it’s about time you learn how to take care of your own

bodies.” Woon-seong massaged his palms, still slightly swollen and bruised from overexertion during his fight with the Sword of Men. “If you don’t, you might just run into big trouble sometime. For today, let’s rest well.”

The trainees seemed startled at these words, as if remembering for the first time that they had left the world inside the Cave of Latent Demons. They had spent almost half of their lives sleeping in a rundown cave and learning to torture themselves. They tried too hard to survive, too hard to keep going. Right, it was time to learn how to take care of their bodies. Who knew when or where they were going to get attacked next?

They contemplated his words, schooling their previously excited auras.

“You all must be tired because of your personal missions.”

Woon-seong turned his head to the side, where a building with multiple floors stood. Although no person could be seen in the corridor, which was open to the air, he felt a powerful presence.

“Can we get assigned to some resting rooms?”

The person there was startled that Woon-seong had noticed, as they had obviously been trying to hide. They appeared in a flash since they had already been caught, melting from the walls like shadow.

Gwan Tae-ryang and another trainee who was close by were startled by the sudden movement and unfamiliar presence. With years of battle instincts kicking in, they immediately approached the wall with their weapons drawn.

Woon-seong quickly restrained the actions of his men. They were in a branch of the Cult, whoever was inside and could mask their presence was likely not an enemy but someone relatively high-ranked in the Cult!

“Stop!”

“Hahaha. Rumors say that the current Cave of Latent Demons produced the best members in the history of Caves...”

The shadow that had flashed into their view stepped into the sunlight.

“And it seems true.”

It was a middle-aged man, obviously also from the Cult. There were numerous long, red scars covering both of his arms as well as his neck, which the man didn't try to hide.

Woon-seong's thoughts flashed through his mind as he rapidly tried to place the man's identity based upon his appearance. This man was at least Demonic General level! There was only one person skilled enough in this branch who could hide from the senses of the Cave of Latent Demon trainees.

When he appeared, the trainees bowed their heads. “Good to see you!”

Woon-seong did not bow, but he quickly greeted the other. “It's an honor to meet you, ‘Fire Demon of Scars’, Mok Dae-young. I am Hyuk Woon-seong, Leader of the 1st Latent Demon Squad.”

“Kashgar's Branch Manager, Mok Dae-young. The Cult has contacted me in advance about you. I heard you're the strongest amongst the Cave's trainees.”

“I'm flattered by the overstatement.”

It was true, but Woon-seong hoped to stay in the good graces of this branch manager. While he was self-assured, he wasn't the type to brag either. He was a bit interested in the way that the Cult spoke of him, but that wasn't something he could ask about.

“Overstatement?” Mok Dae-young leaped from the second floor, where he had been standing, to the floor in front of Woon-seong. “You all are our fellow comrades who will lead the next generation of the Cult. I am excited to work with you.”

The man had decided that he approved of the young man before him, and stuck out his hand to shake.

“Me too.”

“Hahahah! Although it’s not like some branch manager in the middle of nowhere can do much!”

“You don’t need to be so modest, ‘Spider of Thousand Ears’.”

Mok Dae-young was startled at being addressed by his lesser-known nickname, especially by someone so young. “So you even know about that?”

“Senior Sang told me that you used to work at the ‘Thousand Miles Communication Department’.”

The ‘Senior Sang’ that Woon-seong mentioned was obviously Sang In-hyo, who worked as the General Director of the Cave of Latent Demons. Before Woon-seong had left the Cult, Sang In-hyo had described all the people they should seek if they needed information along the way.

Mok Dae-young smiled slightly, he remembered the guy. “I see...”

The Thousand Miles Communication Department was an information organization run by the Demonic Cult; it had been the eyes and ears of the headquarters. General Director Sang had been up there in the past, with a position as a middle-level executive.

The star at that time was a certain ‘Spider of Thousand Ears’. That was a man whose information channels wouldn’t miss facts as fine as spider silk and could spread it delicately like a web.

Now, because of infighting, few still remembered this man.

However, General Director Sang obviously still remembered him, placing high importance on this man.

“You are the ‘Spider of Thousand Ears’ who worked as the eyes and ears of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.” Woon-seong clasped his fist in front of him, in a martial bow. “That’s why I need help from you for this mission.”

“My help, huh...Since you mentioned ‘Spider of Thousand Ears’, I assume you want the information that only I could have.” Mok Dae-young was silent for a moment, as the trainees waited apprehensively. “Alright! Let’s talk over a cup of tea. I’ll tell my men to assign new accommodations for your squad.”

“You heard him.” Woon-seong turned to the others as he followed Mok Dae-young into the building. “Rest well until we start the mission. Of course, don’t be lazy either. Maintain your condition and keep yourself prepared so you can fight at your best at any time.”

“Yes, sir!”

[1] Kashgar, sometimes spelled Kashgur, is a real city in the Xinjiang Uyghur autonomous region. It’s an oasis most famous for being a stop-off point on the Silk Road.

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Chapter 24: The Five Evils (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 24 – The Five Evils (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

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The gentle scent of tigerwood spread out into the office room like a whisper. Mok Dae-young moved the pot of tea onto the table and stared at the young man before him. *Indeed, Demonic General.* He could see the iron bracers that Woon-seong wore on his arms and legs, covered by baggy clothing. *Definitely stronger than me.* Mok Dae-young was convinced of his defeat. Although he was considered a Demonic General, his abilities were only enough for him to be the Kashgur branch manager.

However, the young man named Hyuk Woon-seong seemed like he could do great things. Not only did he rank first in the Cave of Latent Demons, but his attitude was excellent.

For sure, he isn't just some ordinary kid.

From there, Mok Dae-young stopped thinking. A man with that ability would someday become a central figure of the Cult, but that would be distant from him, who was out in the middle of nowhere. How long had it been since he left that all behind?

Mok Dae-young took two cups of moderately warmed tea and placed a cup in front of Woon-seong. The boy glanced at the cup in front of him.

Baihao Yinzen ('White Hair Silver Needle')

He hadn't noticed it because of the smell of incense, but this was his master's favorite tea too. Of course, the taste was slightly different from which his master boiled it. The master's tea had a deeper bitterness and would often leave a bitter taste in his mouth. But the fragrance of the tea was enough to remind him of his master.

“So, what information do you need?”

Mok Dae-young's question woke the boy up from his memories. “Oh...it's about the ‘Five Evils’.”

“Ouch...That is a difficult task.”

Mok Dae-young's expression became a bit awkward at these words. If he were in charge of this mission, he would have suffered a bit. In addition, from the standpoint of the branch office, these targets were difficult to deal with.

Despite being only five, the members of the ‘Five Evils’ were all top class martial artists. In addition, the leader, the ‘Black Evil’ was a peak level martial artist who was able to use sword aura. Many people could use sword aura in practice, but few could put it to use in a practical situation. In that sense, only those who belonged to the upper echelon of the Demonic General class could fight him. Compared to Mok Dae-young, it was definitely one step above.

Mok Dae-young looked at the young man before him with a cautious expression. Could this young man deal with ‘Black Evil’? No, if it was just ‘Black Evil’ alone, the branch itself could deal with it. However, the opponent was not a single member, but all of the ‘Evils’: Black, Blue, Red, White, and Yellow. Honestly, it would be difficult for the 1st Latent Group to deal with them. Perhaps it was possible, but about ten people would have to die in the best case scenario. Nevertheless, this was a mission from the Cult.

Mok Dae-young smiled bitterly. *Is there any chance that the Cult is trying to weed out even more trainees?*

“I need information because the mission is difficult.” Woon-seong’s eyes were deep, incomparably so.

Mok Dae-young felt cold flames from within his gaze. Thoughtful, but determined to act, eyes that only those who had ambition and drive could have. The eyes of those who have faith to walk their own path, those who didn’t hesitate to devote themselves for what they decided to do.

And Mok Dae-young had met people with those same eyes when he had been at the headquarters of the Cult, ten years ago. At that time, most of them had died due to their ambition. But some survived the difficulties, and became stronger than everyone else. The ‘Ten Demonic Masters’, they were ‘under one person, above all others’, the strongest in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

And now the eyes of this boy were enough to remind Mok Dae-young of those days.

So you’re a man of that caliber.

Whatever Woon-seong hid behind that gaze, if the boy succeeded in his mission, it would be good to keep an eye on such a young man. It would surely be a big windfall for the Cult. So Mok Dae-young made a decision. “Okay. I will give you the information.”

The order from the Cult was to destroy the ‘Five Evils’. The information collected about them could not be given away so easily, but Woon-seong had passed the unspoken test.

Woon-seong, who had received the information, headed for the branch’s resting areas.

The branch had given generous lodging and care for the members of the 1st Latent Demon Squad. Thanks to this, the trainees were taking a rest they had never enjoyed before. The food brought by the maids was also organized. They had a chance to taste the Holy Communion before they headed out for a fight, but the atmosphere was different. Comfortable and

cozy. Not only that, they could wash off the dirt and fatigue with warm water.

Except, the situation was a bit uncomfortable.

“Hmm.”

Looking at the feast on the table in front of them, all the members of the squad had awkward looks plastered upon their faces.

At that time, Woon-seong arrived. “You’re all making some interesting faces there.”

Gwan Tae-ryang stared at him, as if scared. “This is...I think it’s too much.”

At his words, Woon-seong looked around. Not only were they in a state of distress, but everyone was looking uncomfortable. No matter how you give a meal, it’s useless if you cannot eat properly. He made a decision. “I’ll ask the servants to leave.”

“But...” The maid opened her mouth to speak, but shut her mouth just as fast.

“Just put down the food and get out. I will speak with the branch manager about it later.”

With that said, the maids bowed and left the room. After they went out, the members of the squad looked more relaxed.

Woon-seong smiled and sat down next to Gwan Tae-ryang. “I’ve gathered information about the ‘Five Evils’.”

Was it because of the mention of their mission? The momentum of the squad seemed to have changed from when they looked relaxed. Now, their auras were sharp as a knife and their eyes were crackling with gunpowder.

“I’ll talk after we eat.”

However, Woon-seong raised his hand, restrained them, and lifted his spoon first. Looking at that, the squad members looked awkward again and lifted their own spoons. Soon, only the sound of cutlery could be heard.

After the meal, the members gathered in one place. The purpose was to hear the intel brought by Woon-seong. He was sitting in front of them, with Gwan Tae-ryang sitting next to him.

“As you all are aware, the group mission is about the ‘Five Evils’.”

Strictly speaking, they were a group of blood lamas. A group of five Tibetan blood lamas who were practicing asceticism in the Tibetan Potala Palace before fleeing after committing crimes.

“All of them are known to be top notched martial artists. For a better understanding, the youngest ‘Yellow Evil’ is said to be around the level of our Senior Instructor.”

The Senior Instructor and ‘Yellow Evil’ were both considered to be first class martial artists. But if they had to fight, the one who won in the end would be their Senior Instructor. As there is a big difference between those at the top, there is also a difference among the first class.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong’s comparison meant that he was nervous. The skills of the trainees were first class. But except for him, there was no one who could win a one-on-one melee against a top class master.

“Of course, Blue Evil, Red Evil, and White Evil aren’t much stronger than Yellow Evil.”

With that, the faces of the trainees relaxed once more. Four of them were on the same level, to be precise.

Of the four Evils, they would have to fight against them using a wheel formation and clinging to the advantage of the majority. That was the initial plan, but Woon-seong also had another thought.

“You deal with Blue Evil alone, Gwan Tae-ryang.”

Among them, only Gwan Tae-ryang could compete against the Senior Instructor. Seven times out of ten, the Senior Instructor would win. But according to his condition that day, the Senior Instructor could not guarantee victory either. Gwan Tae-ryang was a talented person and at least this would be a good fight for him, even if it only ended up as him stalling for time. In addition, like this, more trainees could face Yellow, White, and Red Evils.

Gwan Tae-ryang bowed his head. That solved four of the Evils.

But there was a bigger problem.

“The problem is Black Evil.”

Woon-seong had explained it to them, he was the strongest of the five and could use sword aura. Except for himself, it would be impossible for the others to hold on for more than a few moves. Even if they tried to push with numbers, they would only get beaten back.

Only one man was able to deal with Black Evil in the 1st Latent Demon Squad. And that one man said, “Let me deal with Black Evil.”

Woon-seong played with the bracers on his arm.

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Chapter 25: The Five Evils (3)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 25 – The Five Evils (3)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

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In his body, the inner qi fluttered unexpectedly. Woon-seong felt it and smiled, comfortable. Through his steady practice, the spirit of this ‘intimidation qi’ was much more advanced. In both quantity and quality, it was incomparable to how it was back in the Cave of Latent Demons.

However, Woon-seong had discovered a disadvantage of the ‘intimidation qi’ when he fought with the Sword of Men. In addition to the rapid consumption of energy required, the qi did not seem to be as reliable as predicted against Orthodox cultivators. This had to be supplemented as soon as possible. In order to do so, he could either increase the fearful strength or fix the weaknesses.

Woon-seong chose to do the latter.

Although increasing the power of ‘intimidation qi’ could compensate for its shortcomings, the fundamental problem would still remain. In order to cripple opponents with mind-clearing martial arts, he had to find a way so that the qi was universally effective.

Woon-seong randomly recalled all the Dao and Orthodox methods he knew. Dozens of different verses repeated and then scattered in his mindspace. It had been a few days already that Woon-seong had been trying to find a solution.

That wasn't his only problem, of course. He had gone over his battle with the Sword of Men numerous times. Considering that he had not released the iron bracers on his limbs, Woon-seong lagged behind his opponent by about 30 seconds. He hoped to narrow this number down to around 10 seconds.

If Woon-seong wanted each to be perfect, it was impossible for his mind to focus on multiple things at once. Then, it would be better to focus on what he had to do right away.

The thoughts in his head disappeared like mist underneath the morning sun, until only one remained: How could he prepare to fight the Five Evils?

Step by step, slowly. It would be hard to become a true expert if you expected rapid progress or sudden enlightenments. It was important to prepare one by one, as if you were building a solid tower brick by brick. Although it may take time, this tower would be fundamentally strong. A tower that could withstand storm and fire, Woon-seong wanted such a tower.

I'm not in a hurry.

Thinking like this, Woon-seong's consciousness slowly subsided to the inner depths of his mind. Needless to say, his 'intimidation qi' fluttered in response.

From some meters away, Gwan Tae-ryang clicked his tongue while watching the rhythm of practice. At first he had believed that Woon-seong was a monster, but now he realized the squad master was a *hard-working* monster. With his talent and effort, it was only natural to defeat others. Woon-seong had started as Number 900, meaning that he worked *that* much harder to reach the top.

Compared to Woon-seong, Gwan Tae-ryang suddenly felt like he had made very little effort. This was the real world, he realized. Unsure of what kind of threats were waiting for him, Gwan Tae-ryang was not confident enough to go around boldly like Number 1. Increasingly, he realized Woon-seong's words back then had been correct — he was frog in a well.

It was known to the people of the Cave that Woon-seong's boldness originated from the character of his inner qi. The instructors had all been quite surprised by the nature of his qi and many wondered what the hell this boy had gotten from the Divine Vault of Demonic Sea.

Of course, it was natural that even the instructors were intrigued. Woon-seong's qi was produced through evolutionary fortifications from the two cultivation methods he merged. Despite living two lifetimes, even Woon-seong was amazed.

Gwan Tae-ryang knew that soon he would have to fight against the 'Five Evils', where he could only rely on his own strength. He gripped the blade in his hands. *He's really an incredible person, I must work harder too.*

Scree—!

A bird's cry suddenly through the morning calm.

Gwan Tae-ryang lifted his head and shouted to alert Woon-seong. Eyes flashing open, Woon-seong reached his arm out to the side. With a flutter, an eagle landed lightly on his arm, presenting the bamboo scroll tied to its leg by a black string. This was one of the Cult's liaisons, likely carrying information about the Five Evils.

As the rest of the squad members were quickly notified to gather in a conference room, Woon-seong read the message.

"Tsk." There went all his hopes of a best-case-scenario.

"What is it?"

After finishing the entire letter, Woon-seong handed it over to Gwan Tae-ryang. Speaking to the others, he answered, "There is good news and bad news. I assume you would like to hear the bad news first."

The others nodded.

"The bad news is that they have noticed our existence. A surprise ambush is no longer an option."

The Five Evils had been alerted that the trainees were tracking them. From the standpoint of the trainees, this was indeed bothersome.

A member raised their hand and asked, “What happened?”

How did this occur?

The one who’d asked was Baek Woon-ji, a female member of the 1st Latent Demon Squad that was talented in covert operations. She wore a black cotton bandana to enhance the effect of stealth, covering her pretty face. Beyond the covering, her skin was beautiful like white snow. [1]

Woon-seong glanced at her, but the one to answer was Gwan Tae-ryang.

“One of the intel agents who was after them got caught. The autopsy reports signs of torture.”

After reading the message, Gwan Tae-ryang’s face had hardened. Signs of torture on the spy meant that not only were the Five Evils aware they were going to be attacked, they had likely also found some other information about those who were after them. It was safe to assume that the agent had spilled valuable information .

“By the way, Squad Master, where’s the good news in this letter? The only other thing mentioned is that the Evils are openly exposing themselves at some inn in Sici.”

Gwan Tae-ryang didn’t think that this could be considered good news, as Sici was a village about three days away from Kashgur. This was an act of clear provocation — the Five Evils were practically begging the 1st Latent Demon Squad to go there and attack. Openly waiting for the Cult to appear was a show of self-confidence.

“That is the good news,” Woon-seong smiled and said. “Waiting they’ve underestimated us. Hearing about the havoc they wrecked in the Cult’s territory, I thought they were some confident martial artists. But this only proves that they are just some reckless idiots.”

Vigilance in Murim meant life, carelessness equalled death. In addition, it was stupid for the Five Evils to evaluate themselves so highly that they proudly loitered in the Demonic's domain. If the Cult so wished, a single high-ranked Demonic cultivator could handle the Five Evils in a clean sweep.

Woon-seong concluded with a snort, "Surely the training of the Cave should be enough to deal with such morons."

Even in the future, the training of the Cave of Latent Demons would probably remain as some of the hardest days in their lives. Those were days where they made friends with Death. Day after day, a struggle against death.

Death was part of daily life, but they'd still come out alive.

A sharp energy rose from the squad, carrying the aura of a knife. Just remembering the Cave of Latent Demons had caused hostility and fighting spirit to pour out.

Woon-seong confirmed the change in atmosphere and laughed, rising from his seat. "We will return the Cult with the five heads of the Evils!"

The others also jumped up from their seats, following him out. "Yes, sir!"

"Hmm, the dogs of the Cult might show up today. What do you think, Venerable of Great Virtue?" Blue Evil asked Black Evil, who was eating the leg of a beast leg.

Mouth still full of meat, Black Evil responded, "Well. It's all about the Will of Buddha. They will come when the time is right."

The Five Evils giggled and burst into laughter.

The youngest, Yellow Evil, tapped the table with the cup in his palm. "Haha. There should be women even amongst the dogs of the Cult, right? I wish to build virtue through interaction with the fairer sex."

It was White Evil who answered his words. “Of course. The intentions of the Venerable of Virtuous Acts are praiseworthy. I’m sure the Buddha will answer your wishes.”

As these men called each themselves the ‘Venerables’ of this or that and praised their supposedly virtuous acts, it was clear they were unrepentant. It was quite ironic, as they were roguishly talking about sexual interactions with women, drinking alcohol, and eating meat, yet dared to call each other as followers of Buddha.

Yellow Evil laughed violently, nodding at the words of White Evil. “I hope so. Is there more alcohol?”

Next to him, there were five already empty jars of liquor, but he was not drunk. This showed how strong his evil, impure qi was.

The other guests in the vicinity had scampered off, as none of them were brave enough to stand up to these five. Only the owner of the inn was left.

“Here you go, sir.”

This was the fifth day they had been waiting, Yellow Evil’s mind and body were in need of some excitement. “Is this the only drink?”

“Yes, all of the drinks we had were already consumed...”

“The Buddha shows such praiseworthy intentions, and yet this is the only virtue you can practice. You must be a pawn of the devil.”

Yellow Evil clapped his hands together, his next words terrifying the owner.

“I must ignore the rules against killing to send you, devil’s pawn, to meet the benevolent Buddha.”

Yet, Black Evil restrained such behavior. “That’s enough from the virtuous. We have some guests.”

As he said this, Blue Evil waved his sleeve. A powerful force sprouted from his hand, forcing the door of the courtyard open. Beyond the dust, the men

could see the figures of twenty-two people surrounding the area. At the forefront stood a young man with a spear.

“The dogs of the Cult have arrived.”

The young man at the front replied as he stepped out from the dust.

“No. We’re here to send you bastards to meet the great and benevolent Buddha.”

The members of the 1st Latent Demon group poured into the area.

☆*:..o.o(≥▽≤)o.o.:*☆

Chapter 26: The Five Evils (4)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 26 – The Five Evils (4)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

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Like gusts of wind, the members of the 1st Latent Demon Squad rushed in through the windows, jumped down from the roof, or entered through the open doors.

The owner of the inn and remaining guests left for the kitchen, crawling on the floor in fear.

In the meantime, each Latent Demon took something out of their pockets and threw it .

Palm-sized piercing needles!

A total of forty-four iron needles, two from each person, soared through the air. The air exploded with the whistling wind as the needles rained down upon the heads of the Five Evils.

“Hoh, what is this?!”

Blue Evil shook both hands. A strong wind struck the air in front of him, and the needles that were pouring down rebounded, flying in all directions. They embedded themselves into the walls, floor, tables, and chairs. In the end, none of the needles had hit a target.

Watching this, Gwan Tae-ryang smirked. They hadn't thought that the needles were going to do anything to the Five Needles in the first place. This was all part of the plan!

The needles were just enough of a distraction to divide the Five Evils and surround them.

Gwan Tae-ryang ran to Blue Evil and swung his blade down.

"You fucking rascals!" Blue Evil's fist collided with the blade, causing shockwave of flame and energy to blast out. Retreating from the danger zone, further separated from the other Evils. .

The other members had also done their jobs, surrounding the White, Red, and Yellow Evils.

The only one left was the strongest of the Evils.

Woon-seong began to move towards that one.

Just as Woon-seong moved, so did Black Evil. Realizing the situation, Black Evil had figured out who his opponent was through almost animalistic intuition.

The other's sword met Woon-seong's spear with a smack, making a harsh sound. They were soon face to face.

"Did you say you will send me to Buddha?"

"Why? Would you prefer meeting the Asura in hell?" Woon-seong taunted.

"I'm fine. Why don't you go yourself? I'll personally lend you a hand by breaking your skull."

A few other choice words were exchanged as their weapons collided.

Woon-seong gripped his wrist, which was trembling slightly. *He's strong indeed.*

Black Evil was surprised too. *So young yet so much inner strength! He's definitely a dog of the Demonic Cult and a pawn of the Devil.* His arm was shaking from the strength of Woon-seong's attack. *I must not hold back. If I don't cut him down here, I will surely regret it later.*

Black Evil attracted energy towards himself, now set on killing Woon-seong at once. A dark energy flowed out of the sword, stretching out into several branches at once. These branches eventually gathered in one place, overlapping with each other. Sword aura.

Looking at its appearance, Woon-seong also activated his own energy. A dark energy soared out from the spear and wrapped around it. In response to the sword aura, he had activated his own spear aura.

"Hahaha. So a spear qi is the best you can do? You're pretty good for your age, but you're still no match for me! But don't worry. I don't enjoy torturing men, so I'll end this quickly."

At his words, Woon-seong bounded forward instead of proving an answer.

"You seem to lack patience." Black Evil also wielded his sword. As Woon-seong ducked, the fearsome pressure of the sword aura passed over his shoulder, cutting him. Woon-seong grit his teeth and swung his spear, but Black Evil had already stepped back and escaped.

There were several other exchanges, but the result was no different. Despite no huge injuries, Woon-seong consistently moved half a beat slower than Black Evil. With the aggressive nature of sword aura, Woon-seong was soon covered in small cuts.

Woon-seong spun his spear and backed off, barely breaking off from Black Evil's offensive. *It's a bit difficult.* It wasn't easy, but it wasn't terribly hard either. The good news was that the sword aura coming from the sword was weaker than in the beginning. *It seems like he's burning up his qi.*

Woon-seong wasn't so sure what to do. If he dragged this out, his opponent would definitely become too exhausted. As the fight progressed though, his chances of becoming critically injured also increased.

I'll have to do it.

Woon-seong released the iron rings that bound his arms.

Boom, boom!

Black Evil's eyes trembled finely at the heavy sound of them hitting the wooden floor. Before he could react, the boy had charged over. Spear met sword with sparks of fire. Within this chaos, Woon-seong attacked and parried Black Evil more easily than before. Debris spilled all over the place, tables and chairs smashed into piles of driftwood.

A flash of light. With the sound of thunder, Black Evil was pushed back. Black Evil stared alternately at the sword in his hand and Woon-seong. He ground his teeth. "You hid your strength!"

"You're spouting nonsense." Woon-seong grinned and received his words. It was natural for the energy consumption of Black Evil to be greater than his own. "Do you stupid, fake monks not even know how to pace yourselves?"

Indeed, it was almost like his opponent was a guy who didn't know his own limitations, believed too much in his martial arts, and ran around.

Breathing was not merely breathing. Knowing one's own limits, adjusting the force and power used as necessary was also a part of breathing. Black Evil had neglected this.

Woon-seong activated his 'intimidation qi', one of his best weapons. Everyone else was busy dealing with their own problems and no one was concerned about this dark energy. It flowed out like a cloud from the boy's body, spreading out towards Black Evil. In addition to understanding the Five Evils and improving his understanding of the 'intimidation qi', Woon-seong also had practiced energy management to surprising levels. It crawled along the floor and wrapped Black Evil.

You may be an apostate monk...but if you've ever learned Buddhist qi at all, you can't ignore this.

It had a surprisingly good effect on the mind of Black Evil, whose movements became slower and more robotic. Woon-seong grinned and gripped his spear. “I’ll gift you two things at once! Spear aura!”

Kuakuakuakuakua-!

While Black Evil tried to escape the offensive, he also tried to shake off the intimidation qi. He screamed, a mixture of pain and frustration. At this time, a powerful sword aura flowed out of his sword once again with a brilliant light!

Boom!

However, the moment this aura collided with his opponent’s, Woon-seong’s energy changed. Dozens of branches of qi soared into existence, visible to the eye.

Knng!

They cut straight through the sword! The upper torso of Black Evil was sliced just like his sword and fell.

Looking at such a person, Woon-seong left a last message. “Go to hell, you fake monk.”

After saying this, Woon-seong no longer cared for Black Evil and moved again. This time, his goal was another Evil.

Some distance away, Baek Woon-ji took a hit and staggered back. Her hand was torn and blood flowed out.

Alternate! Another member jumped out from behind her, switching positions.

What they were doing now was their wheel formation battle against the Evil. Following the plan, their fight would continue until Woon-seong came after his fight with Black Evil. Even though the Evils were stronger than the squad members, the difference was not enough to kill them with a single blow. Thus, as long as they shifted positions, they could persevere.

Or at least, that's how it should have been.

Baek Woon-ji was panting heavily.

"Hey you! Why are you leaving in such a hurry?" Yellow Evil could not hide his lustful eyes and chased after Baek Woon-ji, completely ignoring the others.

She barely blocked his blade. Luckily, he was always aiming in the same positions: her chest, hips, and thighs. As a woman, this was extremely unpleasant. Still, it allowed her to barely block and stay alive.

When the Evil ignored him, the squad member, who had shifted with Baek Woon-ji, wielded his blade from behind.

"Son of a bitch! This Venerable here is trying to reach Buddha by achieving harmony between yin and yang!" Yellow Evil swung his arm backwards, punching the guy away.

Yellow Evil spared no energy when dealing with males. This young man, who had been beaten up, flew into the air and was thrown far away in an arc of blood. One of the seven people fell and the balance of power had been broken.

"Haha, don't be in a hurry. Come here, back to me!"

Although the situation was creepy, Baek Woon-ji knew his target and barely blocked his attack.

"That's in the way!" Yellow Evil twisted his body. He flew to the side and smacked at the sword in Baek Woon-ji's hands. Slicked with blood, the sword easily slipped from her hands.

Now empty-handed, Baek Woon-ji turned white as a sheet. *Fucking-!*

Yellow Evil extended a wicked hand towards her. With this hand coming towards her, Baek Woon-ji shut her eyes. She wanted to die! The other possibility was worse than death!

A rattling boom sounded, like a thunderbolt was sent down from the Heavens. Baek Woon-ji, amazed by the sound, opened her eyes. There was only one thing to see. Yellow Evil had been split into two.

Beyond that was the figure of a spearmen who was walking towards White Evil.

After Black Evil and Red Evil, Woon-seong had finished off Yellow Evil and now moved to beat White Evil. With his bracers off, he was trying to end the battle as soon as possible. *If I waste any more time, the squad members would sustain too much damage.* One of them had already suffered a serious injury.

As he moved towards White Evil, Woon-seong noticed that Gwan Tae-ryang was still fighting with Blue Evil. Though his Lieutenant seemed to be passively taking hits, he wasn't being pushed back in the least. Rather, it was embarrassing to watch Blue Evil attack with such carnal desperation. Woon-seong could already see the result. *Gwan Tae-ryang will win.* It wouldn't be easy, but there wouldn't be any major problems either.

Gwan Tae-ryang would not need any help. *I'll finish off White Evil.*

Given the power disparity, it wasn't much of a fight. Within a few moments, White Evil's arms were cut off as his decapitated head rolled across the floor.

Around that time, the other fight was also ending. With great triumph, Gwan Tae-ryang stabbed through the chest of Blue Evil point-blank, piercing his heart.

Only Gwan Tae-ryang cheered, the other Latent Demons too exhausted. Ever the calm one, Woon-seong looked on as he put his iron rings back on.

The battle against the Five Evils was over.

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Chapter 27: Dark Currents (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 27 – Dark Currents (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Mount Shiwan, also known as the Mountain of One Hundred Thousand [1].

There were two known origins for this name. One was from the fact that there were almost 100,000 members in the Demonic Cult. The other reason was that the mountain range was said to have almost 100,000 peaks, cut through by a winding river.

However, not all of them rose equally tall.

Out of all those peaks, the tallest was known as the Jenkish Chokusu, the Peak Reaching Up to the Heavens [2].

It was a peak that lived up to its name as even the clouds were under its summit, with rough slopes that deigned to permit human travel.

On the Jenkish Chokusu, fierce, cold, biting winds raged throughout the seasons. Even through the depth of summer, it was covered in deep snow. A normal martial artist couldn't even possibly come close to this place of extreme cold. Only those who reached the level of 'impenetrable to cold and heat' could climb to the top. In a show of power and selectivity, there were less than 500 martial artists who met that mark in the whole Demonic Cult.

Except, the people of the Demonic Cult also did not dare climb the Jenkish Chokusu for another reason.

To them, this peak had another name: the Peak of the Heavenly Demon's Majesty.

At the top was where their god resided, the Heavenly Palace.

That was the place where the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the 'Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon', Cheon Hwi, dwelled.

Some of the high-ranked Great Demons, the thirty Demonic Kings, and the Ten Demonic Masters were allowed to go in and out. However, it was not often that everyone gathered in the Heavenly Palace. Entry was only permitted when there was official business or if there was a summon from the Cult.

Only one of the Ten Demonic Masters, the Senior Strategist, visited frequently due to the nature of his position.

It was the same on this particular day.

A lone figure was climbing up the steps carved into the snow. As he opened the doors into the palace, his figure could be clearly seen. That old man was the Senior Strategist of the Cult, one of the Ten Demonic Masters. Known as the 'Brain of the Heavenly Absolute Demon', he was Sang Gwan-chuk.

Walking down the entry corridor, he stopped outside another set of doors which led farther inside. He stood there and adjusted his clothes, which had become disheveled during his climb. Once satisfied, he coughed, announcing his presence to those on the other side of the door.

A "come in" could be heard, emanating from somewhere beyond the set of doors.

The doors opened, revealing the figure of a woman. Like most members of the Cult, she dressed relatively plainly, but her clothes were neat and clean. Her face was hidden completely by a piece of white cloth.

“He orders to come in.”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded to her as he passed through the doors and into another hallway.

“It’s been a while, ‘Flower of the Dark Night’.

The Flowers of the Dark Night were the Heavenly Demon’s escorts and security squad. They hid in the shadows, protecting him, but also assisting him with everything he needed to do. It was a secret group, as each of the members had the skills of a Greater Demon, but were not officially titled. No one knew their names or faces; they were simply the ‘Flowers of the Dark Night’.

The hallway was dimly lit and continued on into another space. This area was much larger, both in width and in height. Numerous reddish-brown pillars held up the ceiling. As Sang Gwan-chuk continued down the path that lay in the middle of the room, he stopped at the bottom of a large tower-like structure at the end.

At the top, a figure could be seen sitting behind a curtain. The room trembled with the pressure that this person emitted.

“So...Senior Strategist. What brings you here?”

Sang Gwan-chuk spoke gravely as he bowed. “I have urgent news.”

Behind the curtain, the figure was a bit startled. *Urgent news?* “You do know that I highly appreciate your capability and loyalty. As a result, over the past several years, I have allowed you to take care of important matters. And yet you have come with news that requires my presence...So what urgent news is it?”

Sang Gwan-chuk hesitated only for a moment, still bowing deeply. “It is related to the Young Lady.”

At his words, it was clear the figure was startled. The person behind the screen was Cheon Hwi, the leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon...

Cheon Ah-young's father.

Sang Gwan-chuk took the silence as a sign to continue.

“As you know, the Young Lady is currently a trainee of the Cave of Latent Demons and is out for real world training as Squad Master of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad. That was a decision made because you explained that the rank of ‘Vice Leader’ is not obtained by heritage but through skill and ability.”

“That is correct.”

The figure behind the screen nodded, agreeing with his words. That was the reason that Ah-young worked hard in the Cave of Latent Demons: to gain his recognition.

Then he seemed to come to a conclusion, causing him to stand up from his throne. “...Wait, are you saying...?”

“The Young Lady is in danger.” Sang Gwan-chuk stopped bowing and looked up.

“Danger, you say...To be frank, even putting aside the fact that she is my daughter, she is still pretty skilled. Furthermore, I heard she is ranked second in the Cave of Latent Demons. Second is a bit of a shame... Is it a mission that would put her in danger?”

The figure's face was still hidden, but his voice was sinister and mocking.

“As you are already aware, the missions given to the Latent Demon Squads are no easy ones. Of course, they still are missions that even in the worst cases, the members would have no problem in retreating. The mission for the Young Lady and the 2nd Latent Demon Squad is to eliminate the ‘Nine Vices of Death’.”

“I think I have heard of them, but I cannot quite remember.”

“Yes. They are not worthy of someone like you to remember. They are the nine apprentices raised by one of the elders of the Vile Demons of Heaven.

Their master, the elder, was a threat but has already been dead for eight years. They are no match for the 2nd Latent Demon Squad.”

“So what is the problem?”

“Looks like they have a new leader.”

“A new leader?”

The Senior Strategist hesitated again. “Do you know about the ‘Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain’?”

“I think I have heard of him. No, I am sure that I have.”

“The Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain is a powerful martial artist, well on the level of a Great Demon. Even the Cult does not have many members that would be on par against him.”

“But is he not a mountain bandit in Qinghai? Qinghai should be hundreds of miles from where she is doing her mission. Are you saying he lost a power struggle against his men, came to Xinjiang and made the Nine Vices of Death his henchmen?” Cheon Hwi stared down at Sang Gwan-chuk, voice powerful.

“That is correct...”

The Cult Leader was silent for a while. His daughter, Ah-young, was still lacking if she wished to be the Young Leader. However, it wasn’t like he did not regard her as a daughter. Even though it was clumsy, he wished to show his love as a father. It was just a bit hard because he was the Cult Leader and he needed to raise a leader, not a daughter.

“Where is she now?”

“We believe she is currently near Korla.”

Both of the men were now aware of the problem with this situation. The Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain was a powerful martial artist. If they

didn't send the right people, they would only be sending people to their deaths.

“But we cannot simply send one of the Ten Demonic Masters or a Demonic King to do the job.”

Especially since Cheon Ah-young had not been recognized in the Cult yet.

Sang Gwan-chuk was also aware of this. “There is a lot of suspicious movement internally. Sending them to help the Young Lady, who has yet to become the Young Leader, will only give them an opening to attack you.”

Cheon Hwi hummed his agreement.

“So I came with an idea.” Sang Gwan-chuk opened a paper that he had been holding. “The 1st Latent Demon Squad is returning earlier than expected after successfully finishing their mission. They should be passing by Akesu by now. So if they depart now, I believe they can arrive in Korla in four days.”

“Do you think she can survive until then?”

“Half of the Nine Vices of Death have been slayed and the Blade Ogre is tracking down the Young Lady, but she is with the 2nd Latent Demon Squad. Luckily enough, they were able to keep distance from the Blade Ogre, so four days should be enough.”

“Approved. Command the 1st Latent Demon Squad to move to Korla.”

After he finished speaking, Cheon Hwi closed his eyes. He had given his orders, but the worries didn't go away.

The Senior Strategist bowed his head and shook it slightly as he retreated.

An internal struggle.

The Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and the father of a young woman.

It was difficult to be both.

Somewhere in the forest, a hooded figure spoke.

“Is the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain good enough?”

The man sitting in front of him was not hooded, but was old with a grey beard.

“Actually, it doesn’t matter if the Blade Ogre succeeds or not. He’s only doing it because you wanted him to do so.”

“But...!” The hooded figure jumped up.

“Shh.”

“Ugh.” The hooded figure was unable to move, as a strong force pressed down upon his body.

“Worry not. I haven’t forgotten the deal I made with you. Besides, what’s the big deal with killing a girl. What’s important is neither the ‘rook’ nor the ‘knight’. It is the ‘king’. Am I wrong?”

The hooded figure stared across the table at the man in front of him. The identity of that man was one of the Ten Demonic Masters of the Demonic Cult, an absolute master that was even one of the top three even amongst them!

“So, show me the item you have brought for the deal.”

The hooded figure sat down reluctantly and reached into his sleeves, bringing out a small vial filled with dark liquid. “It’s this.”

“Is it? That’s the item you were so confident in? Although, are you sure it’s as effective as you say?”

The hooded man chuckled. “This poison is the poison that slayed the ‘World’s Best Spearman’, the Spear Master, ten years ago.”

“The Spear Master, huh...He indeed was a powerful fellow. But is he comparable to the Cult Leader?”

The other nodded confidently. “Listen to me. This is not the same poison. After the Spear Master died, I took a whole decade to improve it.”

The other man took the vial, observing the liquid. “Very well.”

“I kept my side of the deal, so don’t forget your side of it.”

“Don’t worry. You make me the Cult Leader and fulfill the promise for our Cult and I will keep my promise.”

The two men laughed into the darkness, as if close friends.

“Heh heh heh.”

“Ha ha ha.”

[1] “shi-wan” is 100,000 in Chinese

[2] The Jenkish Chokusu is a real mountain, being the highest peak in the Tian Shan Mountain Range, also known as ‘Victory Peak’. It can be assumed that the real mountain range is being mixed with a fictional one here.

TN: Thanks for reading, guys! PR is a bit behind at the moment, but I hope the chapters have still been readable!

☆*:.o.o(≧▽≡)o.o.:*☆

Chapter 28: Dark Currents (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 28 – Dark Currents (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

An eagle flew through the wood-filled forest, making a large turn with its large wings. It circled a few times in the air then zipped towards the middle of the forest as if it had found something.

It was a boy who accepted the bird.

Handing over a piece of dried jerky to the now familiar eagle, Woon-seong unwrapped the message tied to its leg.

Gather around him, the other members of the 1st Latent Demon Squad looked on with excited expressions. They had finished their mission one month ahead of schedule. No matter how they thought about it, it was unlikely that the other groups could finish so quickly. So, the trainees had been awaiting the letter from the Cult. How would they be evaluated, what praises would they hear?

All eyes of the squad were focused on the boy, but he only lightly shook his head and sighed.

“Hmm.”

It seemed that the letter was different from what they were expecting.

It was Gwan Tae-ryang who opened his mouth, unable to stand not knowing. He had also noticed Woon-seong's change in expression. "What does it say?"

Staring at the campfire, Woon-seong responded, "Go to support, send reinforcements."

The mood instantly plummeted.

Woon-seong rose from his seat, looking to the sky. There was still some time left before the sun rose. In order to meet the deadline mentioned in the letter, they would have to get up and run without a break.

He looked around at the others, taking note of the injuries from the fight against the Five Evils. Most were just minor injuries, but one of the trainees had serious trauma. If he was to fight, it would be his inevitable death. Woon-seong wasn't willing to have such a liability on his hands.

"You two return to the Cult with the heads of the Evils," Woon-seong ordered another man to take the injured with him. "Everybody else, get up. It's time to move now."

Less than half an hour after the bird arrived, a group of people began to move through the darkness. They were naturally the members of the 1st Latent Demon Squad.

Just like in the report, Cheon Ah-young's situation was quite dire.

It had been raining since dawn, so the air was misty and unclear. It would have been a good day to rest.

Worse still, the 2nd Latent Demon Squad truly had the means to properly solve their mission. They had easily cleared half of their mission, but unexpectedly, had then become enemies with the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain. She had never imagined that they would meet him here.

She bit her lips as she ran.

Missions created by the Cult were designed to be clearable, though not without loss. The Blade Ogre was an unconsidered variable, a terribly concerning one at that. He was comparable to the top of the Cult — at least a Great Demon. Even if Cheon Ah-young revealed her trump card, she would still not be his match.

As a trainee of the Cave, all she could do was lead her people to escape with all their strength.

Five had died already. Now the number of people remaining in the squad was about sixteen, half of whom were injured.

“Ugh.”

Cheon Ah-young approached a member who had fallen with a groan and supported her arm. Dang Boo-ah, supported by A-young, was another one of the few female members of the Cave who had survived.

“Let’s go a little longer. There must be support coming.” Ah-young spoke to the entire surviving group, speaking calmly but firmly. They had to run. The Blade Ogre was tracking them and would catch up if they delayed.

Ah-young ran ahead. Those who survived chased after her. Their escape didn’t last very long.

“I was wondering where you were headed...and this is it?”

The Blade Ogre’s voice rang in the canyon.

Ah-young raised her head with a startled face. It was amazing that the Blade Ogre had already caught up to them. Even more surprising, his voice had come from in front of them, not behind them.

The wind blew and the fog that covered the path ahead slowly lifted. Beyond that, five men emerged. One was old, but the other four were younger. She recognized them immediately and screamed internally: the Blade Ogre and the remaining Nine Vices.

The members of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad raised their weapons and watched the front. In fact, they knew the situation was already hopeless. They had already fought him once and lost, fully aware of his strength now. In addition, compared to their opponents, their conditions were less than perfect. Not only did they lack people, they had also lost health during their escape.

“It was worth riding through the shortcuts,” snickered the Blade Ogre.

In the meantime, Ah-young judged the situation. Would support come, how long would it take? They were probably near, trying to find them. The question was whether the squad could make it until then.

Ah-young glanced back. Each trainee held their weapon, but looked exhausted. With them like that, a battle against the Blade Ogre was impossible. *Stall for time*. She restrained the members of the squad and slowly walked forward.

The Blade Ogre and the Nine Vices frowned, not knowing what she was doing. However, her subsequent words made them laugh.

“Can you hear me? Let’s do this one on one!”

“Puhahaha, this little bitch is looking to die!”

The Blade Ogre was about to move forward, but was stopped by one of the Nine Vices. “Will you allow me to take care of that bitch? She’s part of the Demonic Cult and has slain five of my brothers. I wish to kill her myself.”

The Blade Ogre nodded seeing the hatred within his eyes. Then he looked at Ah-young’s body, eyes gleaming. “Good. But do not kill her.”

A-young trembled. If she lost in this fight, she wouldn’t die immediately, but would probably wish that she had.

“I have no intention of killing her immediately. I will show her what pain is, then tear her apart and feed her to the wolves.”

The Blade Ogre smiled and slowly moved back. Needless to say, the other stepped forward. Ah-young went to the front, sword in hand.

In the meantime, Ah-young's head was spinning with thoughts. She was not confident enough to handle the Blade Ogre, even if she was prepared to bear internal wounds to push her limits. Six out of ten times, she would probably die. Compared to that, fighting one of the Nine Vices was the best option.

You must stall for time. Endure without falling.

She could do this.

The Vice rushed forward. "What are you thinking about?"

His sword struck like a thunderbolt. Ah-young stopped the offensive and drove forward, splitting his attacks and moving without mercy. However, she only hit air.

Defeating First Death isn't a problem, but I must not attack first. If I finish him, the Blade Ogre will be next. If that happens, I won't be able to last a minute, let alone an hour.

A-young avoided the other's attacks and retreated. Of course, the actions were deliberately directed to make it look like a close encounter.

"You sly little bitch!" The First Death of the Nine Vices was blinded by hatred and did not notice.

But it wasn't possible to fool everyone who was watching.

The Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain, who was watching the two fight, wielded his nine-ringed turtle head blade (九環龜頭刀).

Deep furrows were suddenly slashed into the ground and the two fighting separated immediately.

"Go away. You can't beat that bitch."

“What do you mean?!” First Death shouted at the Blade Ogre, his breathing rough.

The Blade Ogre’s eyebrows raised. “You still can’t tell? Fool! That bitch is stalling for time by fighting you!”

At that point, First Death looked alternately at the Blade Ogre and Cheon Ah-young. He noticed then. While his breathing was rough and his shoulders were shaking, she was breathing evenly. He burst with anger and spat, “Damn it!” However, he was also certain that he was not her match and stepped back.

The Blade Ogre stepped forward. “Oh you little demonic bitch. That’s a real cute idea you have there, hahaha.”

Ah-young bit her lips. She hadn’t stalled for enough time. It was a mistake that she hadn’t thought the Blade Ogre’s eyes to be that sensitive. Should she tell him her identity? Even he wouldn’t dare touch the daughter of the ‘Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon’, Leader of the Cult. But she wished to be acknowledged through her own efforts and not her father’s influence.

“I can hear your brain rushing to think of petty tricks to live!”

Ah-young wielded her sword to block the blades. But the strength of his blows caused her wrists to shake, pain like her hands were bursting coursing through her arms. She retreated back in succession.

If only I learned the Middle Connection of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon...

The Dark Flower Red Heart was the Divine Art of the Cult. Strictly speaking though, it was an introductory martial art. Of course, the latter parts of the martial art was a far cry for the current Ah-young, who was barely able to even cultivate the first part. In addition, the true Divine Art could only be learned by those who were to be the Leader.

In the meantime, the blade of the Blade Ogre was pressing her back! She flipped herself in the air, avoiding the offensive. However, strands of her

hair were cut off. If she had been less quick, it would have been her neck! Ah-young's face darkened.

Meanwhile, the Blade Ogre stood back. "Hey, this is the end." He was confident in his victory.

You have to use Dark Flower Red Heart, A-young told herself.

Even if she would suffer internal injuries due to her current strength, if she didn't use it she would definitely die! From the depths of her body, qi soared like lava.

Shh.

Yet before Ah-young could do anything, there was a swooshing sound from above.

From the top of the gorge, several iron needles thundered down towards the ground, followed by a figure flying over.

A bird? Falling debris?

"A person?"

Ah-young looked at the figure and realized it was a person.

It was a man with a spear in hand, striking towards the Blade Ogre.

TN: It's a bird! It's a plane! No, it's Superman!

☆*:..o(≥▽≤)o..*:☆

Chapter 29: Rescuing

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 29 – Rescuing

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“What the hell?!”

The spear thrown by the boy created a crevice at the bottom of the canyon, separating Cheon Ah-young and the Blade Ogre.

Obviously, it had been thrown by a certain Hyuk Woon-seong.

Said boy was observing his opponent as he fell from the sky.

The shape of a turtle head...Is it a nine-ringed turtle head blade? It's an irregular one with rings.

However, martial artists that used this kind of weapon usually had a weakness. They either lacked inner strength, or their qi was impure. It was hard to say which in this case, but there had to be something; there was no reason to use an unusual weapon for anything other than hiding a weakness.

Now, why was the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain using one?

Landing casually by Ah-young, Woon-seong tried to answer the question based on its appearance alone.

The Blade Ogre was also staring at the boy. His mind wasn't quite so analytical though. "If you swing it one more time, know that you're in the way and will be seeking death!"

Rather than responding, Woon-seong ordered the 1st Latent Demon Squad. "Come down and protect the members of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad!"

As soon as they heard the command, the members of the 1st Squad, who had a momentous fighting spirit, charged down.

Although it was a canyon, the walls were not straight. Despite this, the rough slopes were no problem for the trainees, who had been running up and down mountains since childhood. Gwan Tae-ryang jumped down first, standing as if to protect everyone by himself.

In the meantime, Woon-seong grabbed his spear and used it to block the Blade Ogre. To be more accurate, he was shielding Ah-young, who was now behind him.

Ah-young, who recognized him, shouted to stop him.

"Number 900!"

Woon-seong, his spear still outstretched, spoke to her without looking back.

"Stay back. I'm here to help."

Ah-young huffed, still gripping her sword. "The Blade Ogre is a Great Demon-level martial artist. Can you deal with him alone?"

"Don't make me repeat myself. Stay back. Fighting with the wounded will only drag me down." As he said this, Woon-seong swiped with his spear, the movement lighter than ever.

Ah-young, as well as the Blade Ogre, almost missed the movement.

Since when has Number 900's movements been so fast? Ah-young was speechless for a moment, gaping at him. *Oh*, then she noticed something. *You've taken off the iron rings.*

To be precise, Woon-seong had taken them off just before jumping down the canyon. The situation seemed urgent and he had made a quick judgement: He wasn't good enough to face this opponent with them all on.

Woon-seong stared at the Blade Ogre, admiring how light his body felt. Even when he had dealt with Black Evil, the moment he had taken off the iron rings, the feeling of his whole body becoming light was hard to express in words. Whenever he dealt with the strong, it seemed that he was becoming addicted to the sense of freedom from taking off the bracers.

So you should never take off the other two.

If he got addicted to this sensation, he would be unable to practice properly.

Indeed, unless the situation was a matter of life or death, Woon-seong had firmly decided not to take off the rings on his legs.

Moreover, how will you get your revenge on opponents stronger than this if you take off all your rings today?

The Blade Ogre stared at him. "Are you also a dog of the Demonic Cult?"

At that, Woon-seong mocked, "Calling me a dog of the Cult will only make you more miserable."

"What?"

Seeing that the Blade Ogre didn't understand, Woon-seong immediately rushed forward. "What do you call someone hunted down by a dog? Are you implying that you're lower than a dog?"

Boom!

The energy of the boy collided with that of the Blade Ogre. Two weapons intertwined with sparks in between.

Clang—! Ka-kang!

A dark cloud seemed to float around the body of the boy. His eyes were flashing gold, so it was clear this was some sort of intimidation qi. It flowed from his body and through the spear, soon passing through to the body of the Blade Ogre.

“Hmm?” The Blade Ogre unconsciously flinched...

Woon-seong smiled at this reaction. *It works.*

This was his trump card, so the fewer people who knew of the existence of intimidation qi, the better. However, there was no way he would use it in dangerous situations like this, so he had to hide it. What the boy was using now was an application of intimidation qi, the one he learned during the fight against Black Evil.

‘Intimidation dress’.

It was a skill of suppressing the intimidation qi into a thin layer that wrapped around his body, like a cloak, instead of radiating outwards.

“How dare you!” The Blade Ogre swung his blade wildly, not liking Woon-seong’s laughter.

As soon as the blade flew out, Woon-seong flipped. At the same time, the spear swung to prevent the attack, creating a lattice cage of energy with the Spear Master Sect’s technique.

Woon-seong’s upper body shook violently. As the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain was strong, it would be dangerous.

He corrected his posture once again.

“So you blocked that! You really do know a thing or two!”

“Didn’t you hear me? You asked to be someone lower than a dog. You must not be so bright.”

“You fucking brat!”

Based on his reactions and the previous collisions, Woon-seong had deduced why the Blade Ogre used an unusual weapon.

His qi is impure.

Woon-seong guessed that this was probably due to his cultivation arts. While it looked like the Blade Ogre's insights into the blade dao was deep, it was likely very shallow. Incorrect practice would cause an accumulation of impurities in the body and qi.

Though the opponent was a more complete martial artist than Black Evil, Woon-seong had the upper hand in short-term explosive power.

Thanks to his opponent being easily provoked, it was also easy for him to use the intimidation qi.

Of course, beating the Blade Ogre was still easier said than done.

Whoa, whoa, whoa.

The Blade Ogre swiped at the air, causing undulations of energy to travel through the air. From his movements, it was clear that he hoped to kill Woon-seong in a heartbeat.

Woon-seong, in the meantime, was trying to come up with a solution. *His qi is more impure than Black Evil's, but more complete...* He wasn't confident that the impure qi would make much of a difference.

"Son of a bitch! You're pretty good for your age, but blame yourself for being so arrogant!"

Hualalala-

A violent storm occurred when the two collided. Beneath the feet of the boy, the earth cracked. At the same time, Woon-seong felt like his bones were being snapped.

It was impure, but the amount of qi was suppressing him. The Blade Ogre attacked with an onslaught as if he was fully aware of this fact. With his

attack, the ground shattered and dust flew.

Kua-kua-kua! Boom!

Woon-seong eventually broke through, though he was covered with large and small wounds. None were deep, thanks to him avoiding most attacks, but blood flowed down his body. He was in pain and his legs were heavy. He wanted to take off the iron rings, but he didn't.

Two moves came to Woon-seong's mind: 'Art of Six Seals and Destruction' and the 'Divine Spear of the Ending Night'.

Wanting to be a bit more conservative, Woon-seong chose the latter.

'Divine Spear of the Ending Night'! His spear swam like a golden carp, running through the attacks of the Blade Ogre. At that moment, the spear headed right for the Blade Ogre's head!

Khut-!

The offensive of the other changed: what had been an attack turned into defense. A solid wall of blades!

Woon-seong's offensive was blocked by this defense with a sound like the thunderbolt. Coping with this, he unleashed another attack. 'Rain of Star Destruction!'

"It's an impressive form, but you have yet to complete the art. You bastard of the Demonic Cult!" The Blade Ogre seemed to have transformed again. He unleashed a rain of blades, each carrying blade aura.

A bizarre sound rang and the end of his spear began to distort. Even if the spear was made of black iron, it wouldn't have mattered — there was no end to the sword!

What should I do?

The 'Divine Spear of the Ending Night' would penetrate the rain of blades, but would be blocked by the blade wall. On the other hand, the 'Art of Six

Seals and Destruction' could break through the blade wall, but would not get past the rain of blades.

What a dilemma.

"Hey, let me end this." The Blade Ogre was walking forward, his voice sounding closer and closer.

Boom!

The attacks continued without stopping.

I have to make a decision! The Ending Night or the Six Seals...Or should I take off my leg bracers?

In a crisis, Woon-seong's concentration was compressed to the limit. Even the passage of time seemed to slow momentarily. With this, he was reminded of an entirely different option.

Why not both?

It was an instinctive question that flashed unconsciously. In addition, it seemed to hit the nail on the head. The Dark Flower Method and the Completed Method of the Tempered Orthodox Qi...Fill in the flaws with all the manuals that he had seen in the Divine Vault of Demonic Qi, that was how he had made the Tempered True Blossom.

Then what about the Ending Night and the Art of Six Seals? Wasn't this his goal, to combine the two? He was only putting it aside since he hadn't mastered either of them.

Should I stop?

Combining two incompletes was likely to produce adverse effects.

That was a rational judgement, but the spear in his hands was already moving! It traced a trajectory that he had never seen before!

Kuang—!

With a bang and flash of light, a dragon with wretched claws and smooth movement began to dance.

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Chapter 30: Some Advice

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 30 – Some Advice

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Needless to say, it was Cheon Ah-young who most closely watched the fight between Woon-seong and the Blade Ogre. In her eyes, Woon-seong had become a completely different person.

How can taking off two bracers make him that powerful...?

To be honest, Woon-seong was being pushed back a bit, but he was still managing to fight back.

Ah-young chewed on her lip. *How much has he grown since we left the Cult?* The difference over the last half year seemed to be clearly visible before her, making her feel worse. At the same time, she could not help but admire his character.

He was Number 900 at the beginning of the Cave of Latent Demons. But by the last Trial, the Strife of Life and Death, he had risen to the top. At that time, she thought they were similar.

If I fight him now... Ah-young could only shake her head.

At that moment, the battle between the two came to a peak and a bright flash burst out.

Kua-kuang!

It was never easy to fuse two martial arts into one. Even more, the two spear arts he was mixing were absolutely top of the top. If Murim were to know that he had successfully combined two martial arts that he had not perfected, even if just for a moment, many would be vomiting blood [1]. This meant that Woon-seong was more than just top class.

There were three reasons why Woon-seong was able to succeed in this heaven-defying task.

First, he was lucky. There is always some luck needed in creating things, especially in creating something from nothing.

Second, his concentration had been compressed to the extreme. His concentration, which was already superior to that of others, was compressed to the limit, opening a new world for the boy. It was as if a wall in his mind had broken down, allowing him to awaken parts that had been hard to reach.

The third and final reason was the most important in explaining how he was able to complete the fusion.

The third reason was none other than essence and identity — the uniqueness of Hyuk Woon-seong.

The Spear Master Sect was a top sect in both scholarly learning and martial arts. The boy had accumulated the essences of numerous martial arts after many years. In addition, he also had the knowledge of demonic arts. As the situation became more serious, this gathered knowledge was like a heated bulb. The extreme concentration made it possible to find exactly what was needed from the emerging knowledge and miraculously use it to complete the martial art.

Kuakuakuakua—!

A giant dragon wiped out the entire body of the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountains, its teeth tearing and claws ripping.

Moreover, the dragon's movements were soft and ecstatic. It could not be stopped by a shower of rain or blocked by a wall — everything collapsed when it touched the dragon's might.

“Augh!”

The Blade Ogre screamed as his body was torn apart, but that was it. Soon, his head soared and fell off the spear of the boy.

Scht—!

The newly created martial art was not only enough to kill the Blade Ogre, it pushed forward and left a large trace on the floor. There were even traces of its claws passing by.

The other members who were hunting the remaining Nine Vices, were amazed.

However, the facial expression of Woon-seong, who had created such a phenomenon, was very calm. Well, not exactly calm. In reality, he had no idea what to do because he was embarrassed by the attention.

“Amazing...”

It was a word from Ah-young, who murmured subconsciously, that caused Woon-seong to awaken from his stupor. His senses came back to the vivid reality. In a daze, the sight of his own destruction was shown before him.

Did I do that?

Woon-seong almost laughed at himself. The old him had also been able to create traces of destruction when fighting. But looking at the current destruction, this had already surpassed the power he had in his past life.

How did I do that?

It seemed as if he had exceeded his own limits. So how did he do it? He squeezed his spear with his fingers. It had been so sudden and instinctual that he could not fully remember it himself, but only remembered how it

felt. If someone had asked him to do it again, he would have had no confidence in replicating it.

Nevertheless, he couldn't help but be pleased. *I think I have found the way to go.*

Despite his happiness, Woon-seong suddenly became aware of the state of his body as a terrible fatigue hit him.

“Hnng.”

There were wounds all over his body. He had been injured like this quite often in the past, but it was the first time this had happened since he had become Number 900. Since reincarnation, he had not met someone who could threaten him to this extent.

Of course, if it was my past life, I wouldn't have struggled against the Blade Ogre.

He was still lacking a lot.

Woon-seong recognized this fact and spread medicinal ointment on his wounds.

Ah-young approached him. Her hands held some ointment which seemed to be her own. “Is there any place you can't reach? I'll help you.”

Then, she didn't wait for his answer and spread the ointment on his back. His back was also full of scars, just like everywhere else. Ah-young's eyes widened, her fingertips ghosting over the edges, confirming them up close. Woon-seong hadn't shown it earlier, but each movement had been painful and bitter.

You didn't let go of your spear even with wounds like these?

Ah-young realized why he could win against the Blade Ogre. It wasn't simply because he was powerful. What was more amazing was his willpower. Indeed, he had never given up until the end. Since he could beat the Blade Ogre with two iron rings, what if he took them all off? Ah-young,

imagining that far, shook her head. She was disgusted by the difference between herself and Woon-seong.

Woon-seong wrapped clean cloth over the places where he had applied the medicine.

“There is no debt between us anymore.”

It took a moment, but Woon-seong realized that Ah-young was talking about their confrontation during the Strife of Life and Death. At the same time, he got up from where he had been sitting and wore the new cape that Gwan Tae-ryang handed to him. “You say some funny things.”

Hearing the cold and cynical words, Ah-young looked at him as if she were surprised.

Woon-seong’s eyes were sharp. “What do you mean ‘no debt’? I’m pretty sure you owe me now.” He grabbed his spear as he said so, strapping it back on. “Let me make myself clear. You didn’t let me win back then. You just didn’t have the confidence to win, so you stepped back. If you don’t like it, you can try me right now.”

A frosty aura flowed out of the boy’s body. He had just finished a battle. His condition was not great, as wounds covered his body. Blood still flowed from these places, dyeing the cloth red.

Nevertheless...Ah-young dared not open her mouth at the moment. It felt like an illusion of a huge beast was in front of her. She swallowed.

Towards Ah-young, Woon-seong spoke with little emotion. “Don’t be such a baby. If you decided to live in Murim, behave like an adult. If you’re looking for someone to coddle you, don’t even pretend to be a martial artist.”

“What are you talking about?”

He turned his head back, “I’m saying you’re acting like a little bitch right now.”

At the end of his mini lecture, Woon-seong escaped from her side and moved towards the 1st Latent Demon Squad. Ah-young could only stare unhappily at the distant boy.

Hmph. Woon-seong made a face with his tongue sticking out at Ah-young's dazed expression. *I gave you some good advice.*

Like he said, it really was just some advice. He clearly recognized Ah-young's talent and the threat she posed. If she had similarly ambitious thoughts, it was likely that she would become his opponent in the bid for Young Leader. On the other hand, if she supported him later on as the daughter of the Cult Leader, he would become a serious threat to other competitors.

If he thought the latter, it was some correct advice. However, Ah-young's actions were so different from what he expected that he just couldn't not speak.

Pretending to be an adult and acting like a child when necessary...

"Tsk." Woon-seong shook his head once more and clicked his tongue. But no matter how he thought...

It was really unnecessary.

But he just had to make some things clear. There was no debt to be cancelled, but rather she now owed him.

The Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon is indebted to me...

Okay, maybe that was overstating it.

Once his thoughts came to this, he banished them altogether and shouted at the members of the 1st Latent Demon Squad. "Retrieve the heads of the Nine Vices and the Blade Ogre. We're returning to Mt. Heaven!"

Even with the Blade Ogre, the Nine Vices were originally the mission of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad. But in this case, half of the trainees who cut their

heads off were members of the 1st. Woon-seong had every intention of taking all the credit.

Oh well, the credit shall be the price for the advice.

[1] vomiting blood: completely shaken up; thrown into a state of utter disbelief or shock

☆*:.o.o(≧▽≦)o.o.:*☆

Chapter 31: Return To The Cult

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 31 – Return to the Cult

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Thunk! Thunk!

When Woon-seong wore the iron rings, heavy weight crushed his body once more. It was like the iron rings imprisoned his body and senses, slowing him down.

Of course, this did not mean that Woon-seong complained about the feeling. He had chosen this path himself, he would not complain now that he walked it.

But not everyone felt the same.

“I know you love to train, but why not take care of yourself for now?”
Gwan Tae-ryang had come back from ordering the members to procure the heads, politely advising.

At that, Woon-seong shook his head lightly. “Unless your life is on the edge, it’s better to temper yourself even in extreme situations. So that way even in the worst cases, you won’t make an excuse that you lost because your body wasn’t in good condition.”

Those who made such excuses were useless, regardless of their actual strength or talent. Thus, Woon-seong was trying to prevent himself, and

others, from that path.

Was there any reason in those words? Gwan Tae-ryang muttered a “true” and nodded.

Seeing his eyes, as soon as they returned to the Cult, it seemed that Gwan Tae-ryang might also get some iron bracers. Either way, they were both likely to enter a state of practice.

His talent is not bad, so if he tried, he could get quite a bit of achievement.

As the former Number 1, Gwan Tae-ryang’s talent had been ranked as the first. That was basically 900x better than the original Number 900. Even now, he boasted a more muscular physique and was even a couple of inches taller than Woon-seong.

Still, fortunately, Woon-seong was not much smaller in stature compared to his peers. Because of the constant use of ‘Heavenward Soul Earthen Body’, his body was improving day by day.

I’m not far from achieving perfection.

In the beginning, he had looked forward to the completion of the martial body (天武之體) in ten years. According to that estimation, less than a year was left. The only problem was that the change would happen little by little. There was also no record of a person who had learned it to the end, so the limits of this martial art could not be known strictly.

As a human being, there should be no limits to their road. It was slow, but endless.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong’s goal was at least “completion”.

Woon-seong operated his energy with a faint smile on his mouth. The energy he used was that of the ‘Heavenward Soul Earthen Body’, which sped up his recovery process because an injured body was not considered a perfectly complete one.

At this time Baek Woon-ji ran forward, in front of Woon-seong and his second-in-command. “All preparations are complete.”

Gwan Tae-ryang stared at Woon-seong, who nodded.

“We’re returning to the Cult!”

The return of the 1st Latent Demon Squad was accompanied by the 2nd. With the Blade Ogre and Nine Vices dead, their return was because their mission was technically completed.

Both returned at the same time, but their atmospheres were completely different. Not only had the 1st Squad fulfilled their own mission, they had even helped another. On the other hand, the 2nd Squad not only struggled with their own, but required assistance.

It was hard to use an unexpected variable as an excuse, since the variable in question, the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain, was now a trophy under the hands of the 1st Latent Demon Squad’s leader.

Practice missions were important in determining where they stood upon their return to the Cult. Purely based on results, the 2nd Squad could be said to be behind the 1st Squad at the starting line.

In such an atmosphere, the 1st Squad led at the front.

We’re about a day away.

Staring at Mt. Heaven in the distance, Woon-seong slowly closed his eyes. During this real-world training, he had accomplished a lot. Looking at it, he was likely to earn a good rank in the Cult.

If so, I should set a clear goal.

Practically the Orthodox society as a whole was his target for revenge. The noble families, houses, and elite sects. Maybe not every single one, but it didn’t really matter much. Woon-seong couldn’t do it himself; he needed the power of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

In order to properly use the power of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, just some rank won't cut it.

If he was smarter, the position of the Senior Strategist was not bad. However, Woon-seong was well aware that he was not that type of person.

If so, what about a Demonic King?

No, that wasn't enough.

The Cult only had thirty Demonic Kings, but this rank was still not enough to use the full power of the Cult. It was the same for the Ten Demonic Masters.

Then I only have one choice.

Cult Leader.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon's apex, the Heavenly Demon. At the same time, he would become the god of a religious cult. Only like this could he command all the people. And in order to be the Cult Leader, Woon-seong must first become the Young Leader.

What a coincidence that Cheon Ah-young's father, the current Cult Leader, had publicly stated he would prioritize strength and talent in his search for Young Leader, not bloodline.

Woon-seong slowly opened his eyes. Suddenly under his scrutiny, Ah-young was a little uneasy.

Having made a decision, Woon-seong's narrowed.

If you interfere, I can only get rid of you.

It was not so difficult to return to the Cult. As soon as they entered, familiar faces welcomed them.

Woon-seong recognized them at once despite the distance.

Instructors, the Senior Instructor...and is that Senior Sang In-hyo?

The instructors ran to stand in front of the returned trainees.

“Good work. Although I see some damage...”

Sang In-hyo, who was at the forefront, opened the speech and looked at the 2nd Squad, whose numbers were significantly reduced.

Needless to say, Ah-young’s expression crumpled.

The 1st Squad did not really change their expressions. This was not because they received no damage — many of them were injured and one was seriously injured — but because the 2nd Squad had exceeded the level of simply calling it ‘damage’.

Of course, Sang In-hyo did not hesitate even after seeing Cheon Ah-young like that. She may have been the daughter of the Leader, but she was still lower in rank. Wasn’t she currently just a trainee of the Cave, the program he directly managed?

“Either way, it seems like you all have completed your missions.”

Once he finished, Sang In-hyo’s eyes travelled to Woon-seong.

He wasn’t the only one. Among the instructors, all the top instructors also turned towards Woon-seong, slowly observing the boy. As the winner, he had already attracted attention after the Strife of Life and Death. It was natural that they wanted to gauge how much more he had improved since then.

“Hoh.”

The instructors let out a little sound. They couldn’t read Number 900’s qi at all! There wasn’t a way to win. It was reminiscent of an unbending iron wall. No, not just an iron wall. His qi was like an iron fortress, thoroughly prepared to counterattack — something you could not, dared not, cross.

Half a year has passed, you’ve become a lot stronger.

It was a little different for Sang In-hyo, who was someone on the level of Great Demon, but he had also noticed that Woon-seong was now stronger.

I heard he beat the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain.

What happened was not yet properly reported, but no matter how it was written, the fact that Woon-seong had beaten the Blade Ogre did not change. The Blade Ogre was definitely a martial artist on the level of a Great Demon.

Sang In-hyo smiled. *We produced an incredible monster in this time's Cave of Latent Demons. I look forward to the future.*

“Anyways, congratulations on your return. When you get back to the Cult, we will assign you a new place to live. Rest there. You longer need to return to the Cave of Latent Demons.”

General Director Sang's voice rang out, piercing the now ex-trainees' ears and hearts. These words were enough for their hearts to pound.

The change in lodging could only mean one thing...

“From this moment onwards, you are no longer trainees of the Cave of Latent Demons. You are now demonic people who will lead the next generation of the Cult. Be proud of yourselves!”

Their faces were filled with joy that could not be hidden. Even the 2nd Squad, who had been gloomy because of their poor results, were now excited. Despite the results of the mission, General Director Sang's words meant that they were still the 1 in 100. As survivors, they'd finally graduated!

“The 3rd Squad has not yet returned. When they do, I will call you, so rest well in your new quarters.”

Luxuriously, the members were all given accommodation in single rooms. Still, the members of the 1st Squad had enjoyed similarly at the branch office in Kashgar, so they were somewhat accustomed.

However, some did not rest comfortably.

One such person was Woon-seong.

He looked at the crushed spear in his hands, holding it up under the shattered moonlight. *It's too bad about this.* He thought that it would be powerful because of the black iron, but the tip was broken because it couldn't stand the sword of the Blade Ogre.

Of course, he was not upset about the spear tip, per se. It was still usable, he just had to ask the Cult to help him reforge it.

It was his own ability that he was sorry about. His lack of ability had caused it to be crushed. *I should reflect on that.*

Woon-seong recounted the fight, looking at his spear. He imagined fighting the Blade Ogre several times, but was unable to defeat him.

Seven times out of ten I lose.

The three victories were after Woon-seong's body saw terrible losses. It was difficult unless he gave up an arm or a leg. This way, he realized that he had been extremely lucky in reality.

He did have some gains though. Slowly, he was starting to remember some of the forms he had used that day.

But he wasn't satisfied. He closed his eyes and continued.

Three days later, the 3rd Squad returned.

☆*:..o(≧▽≦)o..*:☆

Chapter 32: Great Demon (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 32 – Great Demon (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“The peak you are climbing right now is the Peak of the Heavenly Demon’s Majesty... And as you are all aware, at the top is the Heavenly Palace. Be proud of yourselves. Not many have been given the chance to enter at your age.”

Sang In-hyo was leading the Latent Demons up the mountain. The three squad leaders, including Woon-seong and Ah-young, walked behind him. Subsequently, their squad members lined up behind them.

Sabak-Sabak-

As they approached the top, the snow piled up under their feet only increased, and Sang In-hyo continued to murmur as they walked. Most of what he said were the rules and courtesies of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon to be observed in the palace.

But Dal Mu-ji, formerly Number 109, was not properly listening to these words. As the snow drifted, his head turned to Woon-seong. Unlike Ah-young, who was simply conscious of Woon-seong’s existence, Dal Mu-ji did not bother to hide his jealousy and envy.

He arrived before me?

Dal Mu-ji could not believe that Woon-seong would be so strong.

He had been born as a Miao warrior and was confident in his own strength. Even inside the Cave, he was victorious. Of course, he was defeated by Ah-young once, but that was just because he let his guard down. Now that he knew about the Dark Flower Red Heart, if they fought again, he would win.

This was the same with Number 900, he was confident in victory as long as he was alert.

Thus, whenever he had the chance, Dal Mu-ji wanted to prove that he was the strongest of the trainees in the Cave of Latent Demons. For that, the mission was good as proof. With his position as the 3rd Latent Demon Squad Master, he could gain accomplishments by completing missions faster and more accurately than anyone else. But his plan had failed. Not only had the 1st Squad, led by Woon-seong, completed their mission, they had even helped the 2nd Squad. *You cocky bastard, you're only Number 900!!*

Woon-seong felt this uncomfortable gaze towards himself and chuckled. Except for Ah-young, he had never thought anyone else in the Cave would show hostility towards him. Especially Dal Mu-ji, who had lost against Cheon Ah-young and was less talented than Gwan Tae-ryang.

But I can expose my fangs, if that's what you want. A cold smile spread across Woon-seong's face, mirroring the look in his eyes. He murmured to himself, conscious of Dal Mu-ji, who was still glaring at him. "It might be better for me to find a chance to take care of him."

Meanwhile, their steps had brought them to the front of the palace.

The Peak of the Heavenly Demon's Majesty towered high to Heaven. A huge palace with four floors was built upon it. It was thought that the pavilion held by the dragon encircling pillars was the place where Cheon Hwi, Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, dwelled.

Sang In-hyo saw the palace and reminded them in a low but stern voice once more, "Everyone, show your manners. This is the Heavenly Palace."

Inside, the usually empty palace was packed with people.

As he entered, Woon-seong confirmed the strengths of those who filled the place. Their strengths were similar to that of Sang In-hyo, some better and some worse. As there were no glaring differences, all those gathered in the seats had to be Great Demons.

Woon-seong continued to look around as he thought to himself, *Why are all the Great Demons gathered here?*

Sang In-hyo led them to the center of the palace and shouted loudly, bowing low to the floor.

“Long live the Cult! Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon! I bow upon all Demons!”

Then, having shown a great example of courtesy towards the Leader, he stepped off to the side and joined the other Great Demons.

And so the only ones left in the center were those of the Cave.

Thrown into such a situation, the Latent Demons expressed anxiety. They stood there shuffling their feet, staring blankly at each other and looking much like some lost ducklings.

Suddenly a huge presence engulfed the entire palace.

“Nice to meet you.”

The words were spoken in a commanding tone, appearing together with the presence as if they had been there all along.

Woon-seong was startled. *Why didn't I notice them before?*

No, it was natural for Woon-seong not to notice. This person had been there the whole time, but they had failed to notice him. The boy realized what this meant and was astonished. There was such a difference in level that they couldn't even notice the Heavenly Demon's existence unless he allowed it!

It makes sense that he claims to be the world's best!

This was the 'One Demon' of the 'Twin Stars and One Demon' (雙星一魔), the 'Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon' (斬月天魔) Cheon Hwi!

Even Woon-seong's former master, the 'Spear Master' Nok Yu-on, had only reached the level of the world's best spearman. This was a level that you couldn't even aim for unless you had the talent of a heavenly divine.

While Woon-seong was amazed by Cheon Hwi's presence, the Leader continued to speak. "I heard it was not perfect, but you have all finished your missions well."

Hearing praises from the Leader, the faces of the 1st and 3rd Squads were bright. On the contrary, the expressions of Ah-young and the 2nd Squad were gloomy.

"This is a gathering to discuss the rewards for all of your achievements so far. So those who are proud may stand with their heads held high."

His words again caused the 2nd Squad members to become even more embarrassed. Again, the 1st and 3rd Squad were opposite.

Only Woon-seong still had his head cocked to the side, trying to figure out even more of Cheon Hwi's strength.

"I think that is enough for the openings. Let us move on to the actual discussions...I believe we should start with the punishments. 2nd Latent Demon Squad, listen!"

The Cult Leader's voice was strong, causing the whole room to shake.

Ah-young and the other members immediately got on one knee. "I listen upon our Leader!"

"Not only have you failed your mission, but you also received help from another squad. This proves your lack of abilities and strength. Do you concur?"

Cheon Ah-young was obviously the daughter of Cheon Hwi, this Woon-seong knew for a fact. Nevertheless, his voice towards his daughter was inexorable. Lessons were lessons. The Cult Leader seemed to draw a clear line between work and life.

“Do you concur?”

Ah-young bit her lips as the Great Demons repeated the question in unison. She could only shake from the pressure and lower her head. “I concur.”

The Heavenly Demon nodded. “Good. Then I shall give you punishment. I order the 2nd Latent Demon Squad, including its Squad Master, to conduct closed training at the Valley of Thousand Spirits for half a year.”

“Yes, sir.”

They had no right to refuse, even though that sounded less like a punishment and more like a death sentence...

A thousand ghosts and spirits gathered in that valley. Unless they endured, they would not survive; the weak would be tormented to insanity, eventually turning into a vengeful spirit themselves.

Despite this, Cheon Hwi was calm as he looked at the 1st and 3rd Squads. “That was all for the punishment. Next, the rewards.”

As he spoke, his sight seemed to fall upon the spear, the one of black iron that Woon-seong was trying to cover.

“1st Latent Demon Squad and 3rd Latent Demon Squad, listen!”

Both Woon-seong and Dal Mu-ji shouted like Ah-young had.

“I listen upon our Leader!”

“You have done a wonderful job. You have proved yourselves as worthy strike forces within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. Therefore I order...”

Hundreds of eyes slowly widened as realization dawned.

“The 1st Latent Demon Squad shall be promoted into the Charred Dragon Unit (墨龙隊)! The 3rd Latent Demon Squad shall be promoted into the White Ape Unit (白猿隊)! The Charred Dragon Unit and the White Ape Unit are two of the Twelve Supporting Units (護教十二隊) that guard our Cult. Take your responsibilities seriously and I hope you all do your best for the Cult.”

At the end of his words, the eyes of the Great Demons shook.

The Twelve Supporting Units each had between twenty and fifty members, with more than one Demonic General. These were some of the Cult’s elite forces, numbering less than 5,000. In addition, if the former troop disappeared for some reason, the next troop inherited the zodiac-derived name. Thus, the names of the Charred Dragon Unit and the White Ape Unit had existed since the founding.

“If you have an objection, speak up!”

A few of the Great Demons flinched, then one bravely stood up. “We acknowledge the skills of the two Latent Demon Squads, but I believe that promoting them to the Twelve Supporting Units is excessive!”

After one man spoke, the others opened their mouths more easily.

“The Twelve Supporting Units are the elite forces of our Cult, in which every member is at least a Demonic Captain. That is an excessive position for those who have just finished their Cave of Latent Demons training!”

“We are worried that an important position of the Cult might be misrepresented by the senselessness of the young.”

“The Captains of the Twelve Supporting Units all possess the rank of Great Demon. The Squad Leaders of the 1st and 3rd Squads do not possess the necessary rank, my Lord!”

Woon-seong snorted. Dal Mu-ji’s and Ah-young’s levels were unknown to him, but Woon-seong clearly had the same ability level as the Great

Demons. This had been proven when he killed the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountains by himself.

Sure, this feat did not mean that Woon-seong could immediately join the rankings.

Unlike the Demonic Generals, who were fluid in number, the Great Demons had a limited number: the number of Great Demons in the Cult was exactly 300. If someone wanted to become a new Great Demon, they had to first defeat an existing one.

Since Woon-seong had yet to issue a challenge, it was true that he technically did not possess the rank of a Great Demon.

“It is so.” Neither Woon-seong or Dal Mu-ji had done so, Cheon Hwi agreed with this. “Therefore, right now I shall allow the Squad Masters of the 1st and 3rd Latent Demon Squads to challenge for the rank of Great Demon.”

As his words fell, the faces of the Great Demons paled.

This was an exhibition that the Cult Leader was officially presiding over. When defeated, it was obvious that they would be demoted to Demonic Generals.

In addition, the traditional confrontation was one of life or death (生死不問).

If you made a mistake, not only could you lose your rank, you could lose your life.

Cheon Hwi continued, ignoring what anyone else thought about his decision.

“The time and location of the challenge shall be here and now. Squad Masters, each of you shall choose the Great Demon you want to challenge!” He then added some sarcastic words, almost to himself. “Conveniently, we happen to have all the Great Demons gathered here.”

How convenient indeed.

It was now obvious why Cheon Hwi had called them all here: he had anticipated the present situation.

The original purpose of the Cave of Latent Demons is to replace the generations within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. Even so, I never imagined the Heavenly Demon to have such surprising decisiveness...

Woon-seong suddenly felt that his heroic spirit and determination were less than the Cult Leader's. Even so, he found this to be a good chance to prove his worth.

He slowly looked up and began to assess the Great Demons, as he was commanded. "Hmm."

When the eyes of the boy turned to them, the Great Demons looked uncomfortable.

"Hmph." Some were blindsided and felt threatened, glaring down at him. Somehow, a child was looking to join their ranks.

Others, though, were just laughing to themselves. These were the ones confident in their abilities. Just as Woon-seong could read their qi presence, they could also read his. Considering their power, it was unlikely for Woon-seong to challenge them. If he was stupid enough to do so, they would just smack him around a little — it wouldn't do to humiliate a weaker, younger opponent too much in front of the Leader.

Sang In-hyo was one of those unbothered. He smiled softly when his eyes met with Woon-seong's, sending the boy an encouraging glance.

The boy appeared even calmer after that, relaxing his shoulders. He finally spoke. "I will point to my opponent." His eyes penetrated to the center of the group, where someone stood.

"My opponent is..."

Chapter 33: Great Demon (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 33 – Great Demon (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

One of the Great Demons, the one who had received the challenge of the boy, trembled with rage and contempt.

“This fucking brat!”

The man who could not wait to kill Woon-seong was named named Ah Neung-so, better known as the ‘Shadow Ghost of Flying Blades’. He was currently trying to glare Woon-seong to death. There were 300 Great Demons gathered here today. Since he had been challenged, he felt that Woon-seong found him to be the weakest among them.

Ah Neung-so’s conclusion was not exactly wrong.

I would have preferred to fight someone stronger, but not in this situation.

That would be inconsistent with Murim’s dictum of keeping one’s skills hidden.

There’s no need to show my true capability in front of all these master martial artists.

Rather than go all out, it would be better for Woon-seong to obtain the rank of Great Demon by defeating someone who he could comfortably deal with.

After all, what he wanted was not glory but status.

Whether he knew the idea of the boy or not, Ah Neung-so stepped forward slowly from the ranks. The two swords in his hands were already buzzing with energy. “I’ll show you how wide the world outside is today.”

That was a familiar phrase. Woon-seong had said the same to Gwan Tae-ryang back during the Strife of Life and Death.

Hearing them, Woon-seong could not help but laugh. He wasn’t like the Gwan Tae-ryang of back then.

“Pfft, haha.”

“You dare laugh?” The laughter made Ah Neung-so more irritated. The moment he stepped up he tried to attack the boy.

But...

“Wait a moment.”

It was the Heavenly Demon who stopped him. He raised his hand, restraining Ah Neung-so, and stared at the spear on Woon-seong’s back.

“That spear is broken.”

As he reached out, the spear floated into the air and was sucked into his hands.

Woon-seong inhaled sharply.

Telekinesis (以氣御劍)!

Cheon Hwi’s expression was still very placid, as he stared at the spear with an unchanging dry gaze. “I remember. You had an extra achievement for assisting the 2nd Squad. I shall reward you by giving you a weapon afterwards.”

He touched the spear’s crushed tip with his finger.

Shing—!

With a flick of his hand, a new spear point was revealed, smooth like it had been originally.

Molding the flame patterned black iron with his bare hands!

“This will do for now.”

Nodding, as if satisfied, he threw the spear back to Woon-seong. It landed with such momentum that it had dug into the ground deeply.

Shhh!

Despite Woon-seong's strength, he struggled slightly pulling the spear out of the ground. Hiding how surprised he was inside, the boy observed the new speartip. Some of the weight had been removed, so it was lighter in his hands, but the center of gravity was still well established.

It's sharp enough...He did that in a heartbeat!

Cheon Hwi ordered them again, “Resume the fight.”

Woon-seong removed one of the iron rings.

Bang!

Strictly speaking, Ah Neung-so was a half-step weaker than the Blade Ogre. In addition, Woon-seong had raised his odds against the Blade Ogre through image training.

One bracer should be enough, he decided.

The spear of the boy and the Great Demon's blade collided with sparks of fire. At that moment, the boy rotated and penetrated into the other's defensive area.

Huh-

With the same speed, Ah Neung-so swung his other blade. His two blades orbited in the air in front of him, covering both offense and defense.

Woon-seong swiftly stepped backwards, nimbly avoiding this attack.

In the meantime, however, Ah Neung-so had also distanced himself from the boy. Looking at that, Woon-seong coolly gauged his opponent's skills.

Quick and irregular attacks using the characteristics of flying blades and maintaining a distance. It's not as easy as I thought. However...

There was no need to use 'intimidation qi'. He had reached a new level thanks to reviewing his fight with the Blade Ogre. In addition, his wounds were almost all healed. As proof, his inner qi space was almost full!

Woon-seong shifted back once more. With that, he rushed back towards his opponent like an arrow.

Boom!

Ah Neung-so's blades were comparatively weak in offensive strength and had points where the defense was shaky. Woon-seong aimed at those areas without hesitation. Ah Neung-so continued to move backwards, as if to escape, as the boy chased after him with his spear.

"Hmm."

The other Great Demons were already aware of who was better, as anyone watching could. And it was needless to say that it was actually Woon-seong who was superior.

In fact, many in the audience looked uncomfortable. It could be said that Woon-seong had chosen to fight against a seemingly weak Great Demon, but there were quite a few weaker than him. In terms of ranking, Ah Neung-so was around 230. The number of Great Demons similar or weaker than Ah Neung-so was about 80. All of them were nervous about the emergence of a new powerhouse called Hyuk Woon-seong.

In the meantime, the boy in question was slowly driving his opponent into a corner. The most terrifying thing was the spearmanship he showed. He used only simple moves with nothing special, but each one fell with pinpoint accuracy. This was the result of his study after the fight with the Blade Ogre.

Shifting his hands and feet little by little, Woon-seong did not rush. It seemed careless, but he was slowly laying down the paving stones for victory. Each attack was increasingly difficult to avoid, so his opponent would be tangled. His appearance was reminiscent of a seasoned martial artist.

His indifferent gaze was still there, but the Heavenly Demon continued to observe the movements of the boy.

The same was true for Ah-young. As far as she knew, she and the other members of the Cave of Latent Demons were not at the level of Great Demons.

The gap between me and Number 900 has become wider again. And it only took ten days this time. The gap keeps widening...!

She shifted her eyes to her father, the Cult Leader. He looked uninterested, but his eyes were still chasing the movements of the boy. She needed the ability to be recognized by him. Ah-young bit her lips. *Half a year in the Valley of Thousand Spirits, I cannot lose anymore after that!*

The fight between Woon-seong and Ah Neung-so was slowly running towards the conclusion.

It's not as easy as it looks, Woon-seong sighed to himself.

Woon-seong slowly regulated his breathing while driving his opponent into the corner. No 'intimidation qi' was used and he was still wearing three iron rings. It really was not easy for Woon-seong to push a Great Demon in that state. Behind his vicious offensive was hidden careful calculation. His spear rained down, becoming like a tsunami that would strike down the incompetent.

Huahuahua-

“You brat!”

This wave swept over Ah Neung-so, who swung his swords to slash away at the spear.

But even if you tried to cut a tsunami, how much water would disappear?

Woon-seong had completely trapped Ah Neung-so, who continuously tried to escape. *Fuck, fuck, fuck!*

With another step, Woon-seong reduced the radius that Ah Neung-so could move and in a violent sweep, smacked one of the blades away. His spear was now aimed at the neck of his opponent. If it pushed forward, Woon-seong would win, and he would not hesitate.

“I lost.”

The Great Demon was the first to admit defeat.

Ah Neung-so looked at his blade on the floor and admitted defeat with a bitter expression. Like this, he would fall to the rank of Demonic General. If he thought about the position and reputation he had built up so far, it was all a waste. But was it worth losing his life over?

Ah Neung-so surrendered, but soon turned his head and stared at the other Great Demons. This was a warning that he would return to the rank of Great Demon by taking one of them down. *I'll be back.*

Some of the Great Demons weaker than Ah Neung-so flinched.

Looking at him, Woon-seong slowly moved his spear away. It didn't matter what the Great Demons weaker than Ah Neung-so thought, he had already gotten what he wanted.

“Huff, huff.” Little by little, his breathing evened and he smiled, satisfied.

Great Demon.

This rank was neither too low nor too high, he had even shown his skill in front of the Heavenly Demon.

In order to become the Young Leader, I need skill as well as contribution.

And he had shown his skills. This was basically hitting two birds with one stone.

Cheon Hwi spoke, looking at Woon-seong, “You’ve become a Great Demon at a young age. Congratulations.”

In the midst of regulating his body, Woon-seong bowed his head and thanked the Cult Leader, “I thank the Leader.”

The Heavenly Demon spoke to another, “You also deserve to challenge the Great Demons. Who will you challenge?”

Dal Mu-ji’s abilities were technically inferior to a Great Demon’s. Thus, he was unable to know who was stronger or weaker among the ranks and was unwilling to gamble.

However, there was one Great Demon who was currently weakened and had consumed qi.

Dal Mu-ji smiled and asked, “Am I allowed to challenge *any* Great Demon in this place?”

“Of course. No one here is an exception.”

Hearing this question, Cheon Hwi nodded and smiled for the first time. He was aware of Dal Mu-ji’s idea.

“Then my opponent shall be this man.”

Dal Mu-ji was pointing at Woon-seong.

At such an occurrence, Woon-seong picked up the iron ring he had removed earlier.

The chance came earlier than I thought, he thought, chuckling to himself.

Life or death. The fight to become a Great Demon was technically one of life or death. Woon-seong had been looking for the chance to get rid of Dal Mu-ji since climbing up the Peak of the Heavenly Demon's Majesty. Now, Dal Mu-ji was offering his head on a silver platter.

Killing intent radiated from his smile.

Snap-

The sound of an iron ring snapping back into place echoed through the room.

Chapter 34: Great Demon (3)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 34 – Great Demon (3)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“What are you doing?” Dal Mu-ji frowned once he saw Woon-seong putting the iron ring back on. Woon-seong had clearly been chosen because he was the weakest. “Do you think you can beat me with those on?”

You thought I would be tired after a single fight? Woon-seong laughed at those words. “This should be enough.”

No matter what Dal Mu-ji was thinking, Woon-seong was free to do whatever he wanted. Helping the Cult get rid of someone stupid like Dal Mu-ji... He didn't even feel bad.

It's not like it even mattered if Woon-seong was tired or not — that's how large the gap between them was.

In fact, everyone else could also feel the difference between Woon-seong and Dal Mu-ji.

Only Dal Mu-ji was not aware of it.

“This bastard... You do realize this fight is allowed to conclude with death?”

Woon-seong responded briefly. “Of course.” And then with his spear aimed at his opponent, he added on a few words, “And that’s why this is good enough.”

“Son of a bitch!”

“How long will you bark? Unless you practiced martial arts with your mouth, draw your sword. If not...”

Shh.

Woon-seong rushed in front of his opponent. Dal Mu-ji quickled pulled the sword from his waist and blocked the spear.

Ka-cha—!

The sword soaring from below and the spear crashing from above! In just one collision, the body of Dal Mu-ji was pushed back.

But the offensive of the boy had only just begun.

You should’ve known your place. You dare show hostility towards me? Do not cross me!

This was a warning not only to Dal Mu-ji, but to all the Latent Demons who were watching the battle.

Dal Mu-ji was just an example.

Thud-

Dal Mu-ji slowly retreated backwards, avoiding the onslaught. Then he lept towards one of the pillars and went in a circle around it, adding rotation to his next move, before swinging towards Woon-seong.

“Did you think I was just going to sit down and lose?!”

Shh.

Dal Mu-ji's sword was coming in a straight stab. At first glance, the movement looked basic: it was a thrust with rotation. However, Woon-seong knew better; the waist was overly twisted. This was a fake move, hiding a cut! It was a peculiar technique rarely used by practitioners in Xinjiang, but it would not work on Woon-seong. [1]

Shnng-

Woon-seong casually avoided the cut, ducking down. He then leaped into the air, shoving his shoulder into Dal Mu-ji's chest.

"This is it!"

Kuang!

"Agh!"

Woon-seong's hit had forced Dal Mu-ji's body to bend at a weird angle, causing pain to lance up his opponent's spine. Trauma from the blunt force and pain devastated his mental capacities. Not only was Dal Mu-ji blown backwards, he was basically unconscious!

Dal Mu-ji crashed through a pillar and was buried into the wall of the palace, cracking it.

"Ku-ugh."

The only good news for Dal Mu-ji was that he was still conscious.

Not that it would help him much.

As Woon-seong approached, Dal Mu-ji slowly raised his sword. This was the movement of a man who had four iron bracers on. There was a great battle before, how could he not be tired? Dal Mu-ji could only stare. Unlike when he had been against Ah Neung-so, Woon-seong's breathing was stable.

The man standing before me is a monster.

Dal Mu-ji felt tremendous fear, his legs trembling. He had to give up right now, or he would die. He tried to surrender, hiding his trembling voice.

“Hah, I...”

But...

Woon-seong was faster.

Whee-

Suddenly, Woon-seong reached out and grabbed Dal Mu-ji’s neck. Five fingers only touched his neck for a moment!

Crack!

Dal Mu-ji’s head was turned around such that the Heavens and the Earth in his eyes were reversed.

“Huh?”

And his body fell forward.

Until then, Dal Mu-ji wasn’t even aware of his own death.

“It’s over.”

Soon, the Heavenly Demon announced the winner and the loser.

Dal Mu-ji came out of the Cave of Latent Demons believing in his own superiority and died for it. The overwhelming disparity in power caused some members of the Latent Demon Squads, such as those under Woon-seong, to look at the boy in awe. Others showed fear.

Either way, Woon-seong smiled with satisfaction. *That should make everything clear.*

The voice of the Heavenly Demon rang again. “The 1st Latent Demon Squad shall be promoted into the Charred Dragon Unit. Also the Squad

Master...”

The Heavenly Demon glanced at Woon-seong.

The boy bowed and stated his name once more, “It is Hyuk Woon-seong, sir.”

“Is there any objection to the promotion of the Squad Master, Hyuk Woon-seong, into the ranks of Great Demon?” The Heavenly Demon’s voice echoed through the interior of the palace.

No one objected. Everyone saw clearly the ability of the boy. Rather, they were thinking how fortunate it was that he had not challenged them.

“There seems to be no objections. If so, from this moment onwards, the 1st Latent Demon Squad shall become the Charred Dragon Unit. The Unit Master Hyuk Woon-seong shall be given the rank of Great Demon.” [2]

“Thank you, sir.”

Woon-seong and the new Charred Dragon Unit bowed and loudly thanked the Heavenly Demon.

But Cheon Hwi was not yet finished.

“Also the 1st Latent Demon Squad aided the 2nd in their mission. Hyuk Woon-seong, who has defeated the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain, shall be given the right to enter the Cult’s Demonic Armory. Continue to show your devotion to the Cult in the future!”

At the end of those words, Woon-seong bowed deeply.

“Yes, my Lord!”

The atmosphere of the 1st Latent Demon Squad, which was now the Charred Dragon Unit, was like that of a festival ground. Most of them had a face full of smiles. In addition, Gwan Tae-ryang, who could have led his own squad, was now the second-in-command of an elite troop and laughing brighter than anyone else.

On the other hand, the people of the 2nd Squad, who needed to go to the Valley of Thousand Spirits, were crying together. They were upset, but there was nothing they could do. It felt unfair because there had been unforeseen variables, but the fact that they had been unable to complete their mission remained — exceptions would not be made just because they felt life to be unfair.

Even if they complained, they had no choice — since the Heavenly Demon said to enter the Valley, they would enter the Valley no matter what.

Knowing this, Ah-young glanced over at Woon-seong. *After the Valley of Thousand Spirits, there won't be such a difference between us.*

The Valley of Thousand Spirits was a place where you would go crazy if you couldn't become strong. Like the Cave of Latent Demons, growth was the only option there. Ah-young clenched her fist with determination.

For the 3rd Squad, the atmosphere was the most ambiguous. They were not punished, but neither were they rewarded. In fact, their leader Dal Mu-ji should have qualified as a Great Demon and helped them become promoted like the 1st Squad. However, he challenged the wrong person and was killed by Woon-seong. Thanks to that, the promotion of the 3rd Squad was cancelled. It was a situation in which they could neither cry nor laugh.

Nevertheless, they could not be angry with the lunatic who knocked down Dal Mu-ji. Woon-seong was, without a doubt, the strongest of those from the Cave of Latent Demons. After seeing his strength, they did not dare protest.

Woon-seong, who had achieved his wish, was thinking slightly differently from the others.

The Cult's Demonic Armory...

That was the only first class armory within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. The building, composed of five levels, was filled with weapons collected from all around the world. According to some rumors, the Cult's

Demonic Armory contained weapons that could be considered as either demonic weapons or heavenly weapons.

Woon-seong's eyes were bright with excitement. *I never imagined that I would enter the Cult's Demonic Armory...*

Although a martial artist should not rely heavily on their weapon, it was only natural for them to covet a superior weapon.

The flame patterned black iron spear was a nice weapon, but it could not be considered as a masterpiece.

No, a true masterpiece was forged with the soul of a blacksmith from excellent materials. More importantly, it also needed to perfectly match its owner.

People say that a weapon with a soul will sometimes accept its master's will.

Unfortunately, Woon-seong had never owned such a weapon before and did not really understand the concept all that well.

But that wasn't the only problem.

He looked over his shoulder at the spear resting against the wall. If he got a new weapon, what should he do with his current spear? It was made from flame patterned black iron, afterall. It would be a shame to waste the precious metal.

Should I melt it and make a new weapon?

Of course, the spear was not made from pure black iron, but it was good enough. Depending on what he wanted, he could make at least two weapons.

Thinking about it, Woon-seong decided that he wanted something that was good for long range and another for close range. Since a spear was great for mid-range combat, he needed other weapons to complement it.

It would be good to look for a blacksmith within the Cult.

After I get a new spear from the armory that is.

Woon-seong didn't know if he would find a good spear, but it felt a little like Fate. If he went there, he would find the one he wanted. This wasn't based on information nor facts, but a feeling deep within him.

Either way, he would find out tomorrow.

[1] Dal Mu-ji is from a family of Miao warriors. Most Miao people live in the Southern part of China (in Guizhou), while the Cult is in the North-West (in Xinjiang).

[2] Unit Master and Captain will be interchangeably used.

Chapter 35: White Night Spear (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 35 – White Night Spear (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The newly formed Charred Dragon Unit celebrated amongst themselves until the early hours of the night, but the rest of the Cult operated as usual.

At the dawn of the new day, a guide visited Woon-seong's quarters to lead him to the Cult's Demonic Armory, just as Chun Hwi had said.

It was someone he recognized.

“Are you guiding me, sir?”

“They asked me to do the job since we are already acquainted.”

“The Leader asked you?”

“No, the Senior Strategist did.”

At that point, the youth nodded.

The one who had come was the ‘Demonic Sword of Layered Blood’ (疊血魔劍), Sang In-hyo.

“I ask that we start moving unless you have something else to do,” Sang In-hyo said, and Woon-seong could tell that the General Director's attitude

towards himself was subtly different.

That's only natural.

Before yesterday, Woon-seong had barely been a Demonic General, unqualified for the Great Demon Sang In-hyo to show much respect towards. On top of that, as the General Director of the Cave of Latent Demons, Sang In-hyo controlled Number 900's life and death.

After graduating with flying colors, Woon-seong could not be treated the same.

"I understand." Woon-seong nodded and they began to move.

Leading the way, Sang In-hyo left the village surrounding the Charred Dragon House and started towards the inner mountains.

Wherever they went, peaks and valleys spread out before them. It seemed like a normal walk, but each step covered great distances.

Woon-seong chased after Sang In-hyo. How far had they gone?

After some silence, the first person to speak was Sang In-hyo.

"You have improved a lot."

"Isn't the nature of demonic arts like that?"

Sang In-hyo laughed bitterly at that. It wasn't Woon-seong's intention, but his words had hit a sore spot.

Demonic arts pursued great power by breaking down harmony and did, in fact, tend to be cultivated faster than Orthodox arts. But the growth rate was not consistent from beginning to end: achievements got slower as you became stronger.

Not only that, due to the rapid growth rate, it was easy for people to experience qi deviation [1]. Because people were scared of this, they could only remain stagnant.

Sang In-hyo was one of those people.

About a decade ago, at the start of the Cave of Latent Demons, he was already a Great Demon. Now, he was still a Great Demon. Of course, there were improvements, but the degree was small.

His face showed a lonely smile.

Soon though, he schooled his expression.

“Just because the demonic arts possess that nature does not mean that everyone can achieve the degree of growth that you have. With your skills, you will continue to grow and climb ranks without a problem. Let us continue to grow without rest.”

These words were spoken to Woon-seong, but also to himself.

Sang In-hyo felt partially responsible for Woon-seong’s explosive growth. Was it because he had watched the boy from the beginning?

That was a question that would remain unanswered.

Woon-seong did not respond to these words and Sang In-hyo could only speed up. “Let’s move a little faster.”

Shh, shh, shh.

The speed of the two men travelling over the peaks and canyons of the Heavenly Mountains increased and their surroundings blurred around them.

The location of the Cult’s Demonic Armory was unfamiliar to the people of Zhongyuan [2], but was well known to the people of the Cult. All Great Demons and higher were aware; there were even some Demonic Generals who knew.

But that did not mean everyone could enter.

The path to the armory was constantly guarded by mysterious high level martial artists, who denied entry to anyone who approached without

permission.

Their identities were shrouded in many secrets.

Some said that they were a group of Great Demon level martial artists, others said a single Demonic King was guarding the place.

Of course, like all rumors, they weren't very accurate.

Strictly speaking, the guards of the vault belonged to the 'Unrecorded Demonic Group', which meant they would not be found in the records of the Cult.

The group itself was recorded as an existence, but everything else about the group remained a secret. Since no members were listed there was no way to know just how many belonged to the Unrecorded Demonic Group. Even if someone *was* found in the records of the Cult, there was no guarantee that they *weren't* a member of the Unrecorded Demonic Group.

The only thing known for sure was that the Unrecorded Demonic Group had agreed to obey the Heavenly Demon for generations.

However, they did not restrain Woon-seong and Sang In-hyo. After all, these two were approaching with permission from the reigning Heavenly Demon.

And finally, the armory could be seen.

Sang In-hyo stopped once the building could be seen about fifty meters away. "I can't go forward anymore. Only you are allowed to enter. Go on."

Woon-seong nodded and headed onwards. The building was taller up close. What was unusual was that the door was made of heavy iron, compared to the building looking like it was made of wood. The iron on the hinges had rusted, as if the door had not been opened for a long time.

That wasn't a problem though, it still worked just fine.

With a shove, the iron door opened with a *thud* and the interior of the armory was revealed.

“Hmm.”

Looking inside, Woon-seong made a small sound of appreciation.

The inside wasn't as large as Woon-seong had thought based on the exterior. However, it was full of weapons with barely any room outside of the passage. There were a number of *jians* (double-edged swords), a large collection of *daos* (sabres), and a good number of spears.

This is only the first level.

The Cult's Demonic Armory consisted of five floors. Moreover, not everything from the ground floor was visible right now either.

Amazing.

Woon-seong swallowed his saliva and slowly walked inside.

At that moment, someone's voice flowed into the room. “You have only one hour.”

Woon-seong nodded instead of answering aloud. It did not matter if the member of the Unrecorded Demonic Group saw his signal or not, he was already looking through the weapons.

No martial artist could see this scene and not be tempted into admiring the place.

The moment he moved forward a little, his face changed.

“Ugh.”

Since the weapons were everywhere, the temple suddenly exerted a pressure that made his bones tremble and his skin sizzle. It felt like many powerful people surrounded him.

Cold sweat dripped down his neck. *What a strong illusion.*

However, Woon-seong quickly calmed his mind using the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body.

I finally feel a bit better.

The feeling of his body being stabbed had disappeared.

In fact, Woon-seong did not completely understand, but what he had just faced was the qi of the armory itself.

As you stepped into the armory, your anticipation would be maximized. Furthermore, fear clouded judgement. A blunted judgement was a hindrance that would cause a person to miss out on good opportunities. If you did not overcome this test, you would not choose the proper weapons.

And Woon-seong had passed the test nicely.

As his mind eased, the inside of the armory was more clear to him.

There's nothing that impressive...

Most of them were ordinary weapons. Maybe they were a bit sharper than what was available on the market, but they weren't anything special. Anyone with a little bit of money could obtain them.

This is a trap.

Woon-seong realized the truth. The pressure was a test of unwavering composure, a test of worth.

I should be careful.

His eyes deepened. He picked up some of the spears and swung them. They performed well, but that was it.

Soon, he moved on to the second floor. It was the same as the first. The floor seemed irrelevant to the quality of the weapons, as these were not so

different from the others.

There were some nice spears, which could be considered at the level of a namesake weapon. Not only that, many of them seemed to have hidden functions or abilities.

They were all good weapons, but not perfectly satisfactory.

Perhaps I was too excited.

Woon-seong was a bit disappointed as he stood on the stairs leading to the third floor. He decided that if he didn't find something he really liked, he would choose the spear he had just put down.

An anomaly occurred the moment his foot hit the third floor.

Weng—!

The necklace on his chest, the one of the Spear Master Sect, showed a small response. At the same time, Woon-seong was trembling, naturally turning towards a corner of the armory.

There, in the corner, was a spear Woon-seong had overlooked.

In a daze, he moved to the area and picked up the spear. As he did so, the spear trembled and the rust covering the speartip fell off.

Weng—!

It revealed its true appearance!

[1] 走火入魔 (zǒu huǒ rù mó), roughly translates to 'walk the path of fire and become possessed by the devil'. During qi deviation, the flow of qi becomes impossible to control and the practitioner is severely hurt or dies in the process. Those who succumb to their inner demons, those who practice incorrectly, or those who use forbidden arts are the most at risk. The demonic and unorthodox are infamous for having explosive growth, but carry huge risk for qi deviation as a result.

[2] Zhongyuan, or the Central Plains, is referring to the Orthodox martial society.

Chapter 36: White Night Spear (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 36 – White Night Spear (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

There was something familiar about the spear as Woon-seong held it in his hands, the Spear Master Sect's artifact resonating with it.

The speartip was about eight inches of shining white metal; the length and width of the shaft were a little longer and thicker than the general spear.

There was a red cloth tied directly under the tip.

He touched the fabric lightly with his fingertips. Despite being here for so long, the cloth was undamaged.

Enchanted tussar silk.

He suddenly noticed that there were markings made on the cloth.

There's something written.

And the letters were embroidered onto the fabric.

'From Star Absence to Unrecorded'.

This spear had clearly been gifted and passed from one hand to another, so why was it here?

Woon-seong swung the spear in his hand. It truly resonated with him! At the same time, his heart began to beat wildly.

This is it.

The materials were unknown, as the tip was a majestic, silvery white. Despite the rusted layer, the actual spear looked just fine.

Still, he knew that this was the spear that he had been searching for. The thump of Destiny he had felt the other day had been to find this spear.

But it didn't all make sense.

Woon-seong thumbed the necklace hanging on his neck. *Why did the artifact of the Spear Master Sect react to it?*

The moment he had grabbed the spear, the artifact had stopped humming.

No matter how he searched though, there were no traces of the Spear Master Sect on this spear.

However, at the bottom, characters had been engraved: Dragon Fang of the White Night (龍牙白夜).

A spear made from the fang of a dragon, shining like the full moon on a clear night.

The White Night Spear...

Having taken a liking to this spear, he decided to shorten its name to the 'White Night Spear', since the 'Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night' was a mouthful.

Woon-seong swung this White Night Spear.

Once again, the feeling of using it was different. It truly was something like Fate.

Whoa, whoa.

The White Night Spear resonated with something within the boy, not just the Spear Master Sect's artifact.

In the end, Woon-seong chose this White Night Spear as his weapon. Just in case, he had checked the last two floors, but there had been nothing that would suit him more.

When the boy came out of the armory, Sang In-hyo, who had been waiting, asked, "That spear...is that your choice?"

In response to the question, Woon-seong adjusted the spear strapped to his back, looking pleased with himself. *Wasn't it a good choice?*

However, Sang In-hyo wasn't taking in the striking figure of the boy.

His eyes weren't even on the boy — he was staring intently at the spear itself.

Some time passed in silence.

"Phew." Sang In-hyo exhaled deeply, then turned around. "Let's return if you are finished with your business."

Woon-seong couldn't read Sang In-hyo's expression, but the other's eyes were deep.

The 'Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night' and the 'Art of Six Seals and Destruction'..., Sang In-hyo murmured within his heart. *So in the end, the two come together...! What fate...*

It was a fateful encounter between two objects, indeed. One that had taken hundreds of years to occur.

But Sang In-hyo only closed his eyes and continued on in silence, only speaking until they had reached a nearby village. "Being part of the Twelve Supporting Units...you must be burdened."

"Yes, I do feel the weight of my responsibility."

The Twelve Supporting Units were the elite troops that guarded the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, facing the enemy head on and performing missions. Excluding Woon-seong, the members of the Charred Dragon Unit desperately lacked the experience equivalent to their skill level. Without the memory of his past lives, Woon-seong's situation would not have been any different.

Still, they had no choice but to bear their responsibilities.

“It won't be easy, but I believe you will handle it well,” Sang In-hyo said and laughed.

If it was another Great Demon speaking, they probably could not have been so genuinely supportive. Naturally, most of them were wary of Woon-seong, who had risen to power so young.

No, what they were wary of was not just Woon-seong, but the entire Charred Dragon Unit.

The origin of the new Charred Dragon Unit was the Cave of Latent Demons, and the Cave had always been used to create extensive change within the hierarchy of the Demonic Cult.

From the perspective of the other Great Demons, the Charred Dragon Unit was a sword pointed at their necks .

Sang In-hyo was the exception. As the General Director of the Cave of Latent Demons, he had practically raised these trainees up and out of the Cave. He was quite happy to see the children he had watched for the past decade become strong. Aside from sentiment, *the stronger you all are, the greater my contributions to the Cult.*

In fact, Woon-seong could tell that Sang In-hyo was watching him carefully too. Unlike the others though, it was a favorable gaze.

And since Sang In-hyo expressed goodwill, Woon-seong showed no hostility to his senior — he was a man who did not burn bridges so easily.

“You will likely be receiving a mission soon. It’s not a laid back job, so I wish you luck.”

“I also feel prepared for it.”

Sang In-hyo chuckled at these words filled with confidence.

“By the way, I have a question I want to ask.”

Sang In-hyo stopped a bit suddenly. All this time he had been speaking and Woon-seong had been responding. This was the first question.

“What is it?”

“I would like to know the smith who made my spear with the flame patterned black iron last year.”

Sang In-hyo looked the boy up and down. The most prominent thing about him was the newly acquired weapon. “I see. You’ve got a new spear, so you don’t need the old one. Will you melt it and use it elsewhere?”

Woon-seong nodded. “That’s right.”

There were not many blacksmiths who could handle black iron. Forget about forging anything, there were few who could even melt it. So rather than running around to find one, asking Sang In-hyo, who had helped make his old spear, would be less troublesome.

Fortunately, Sang In-hyo found it to be a reasonable request.

“I believe it was around the Cave of Latent Demons...”

“Right...”

“Go to one of the villages of the demonic people, Village Fifteen. Go to the forge in that village and find the smith Gong Ya-ja.”

There were a total of thirty villages inhabited by the demonic people in the Cult’s homeland, numbered by their proximity to the center.

Village Fifteen was not very far away from the Charred Dragon House. If he rushed, Woon-seong could get there within two hours.

Woon-seong remembered the names of the villages and simply bowed his head in thanks.

Sang In-hyo nodded silently. “Then, I will take my leave. You’ve got a good spear in your hands, I hope you’ll take care of it.” With that, he disappeared without a trace.

Woon-seong took a step in the direction Sang In-hyo had disappeared in, continuing towards the Charred Dragon House.

This building had been used by the Charred Dragon Unit for generations and would now be the home of the ex-Latent Demon Squad. It was a luxurious accommodation with a dining area on the ground floor and individual housing — there was even a separate room for banquets!

As he entered, several people were sitting and eating.

“Welcome!”

They jumped up from their seats and greeted Woon-seong, who entered and nodded at them.

“Will you eat, Captain?” Baek Woon-ji rose from her seat to ask.

“No, not very hungry.”

At such words, Baek Woon-ji had a dull look for a while before returning to her seat. “I’ve decided to have a small banquet with the unit tonight. Can you come then?”

“Banquet?”

“We’ve never eaten together since being promoted. Why don’t we all celebrate together?”

Woon-seong's idea of bureaucracy changed slightly as he realized that when he was away, the Lieutenant and Baek Woon-ji took care of the responsibilities. In fact, Woon-seong had the Charred Dragon Unit under his control, but he was not the kind of person who cared for his subordinates like a mother hen.

But, Baek Woon-ji was playing that supporting role.

Seeing that Woon-seong was lost in thought, Baek Woon-ji asked once again, "Can you come?"

"I will."

There were still a few hours left in the evening, enough for him to finish what he wanted to do.

Woon-seong took a step upstairs, into his personal quarters. His room was on the fourth floor, the highest level of the building. As he entered his room, his eyes immediately gravitated towards the spear he'd left by the window.

A spear of flame patterned black iron.

Now that he had a better spear, he wouldn't be keeping this one anymore.
I'm going to melt it down and make a new weapon.

Woon-seong quickly grabbed the spear and went back out.

Was it because they had already said 'hello' and confirmed he would attend the banquet? Despite descending the stairs, no one greeted him. Only Baek Woon-ji quietly left some words as he left.

Woon-seong immediately left the Charred Dragon House and headed towards Village Fifteen.

The villages of the demonic people were formed around the Peak of the Heavenly Demon's Majesty, meaning that they were organized in a systematic manner.

Woon-seong lightly jumped over a peak as he watched the moon rise above the ridge.

It did not take long for him to reach Village Fifteen. Just as he had predicted, two hours was enough.

It took even less time to find the forge, as the village was not very large and only had one forge.

Dang, dang, dang.

As he entered, the sound of iron being hit rang out and a fierce heat emanated from within. Even though the days had become quite chilly, the inside of the forge was hotter than summer.

Woon-seong decided that although the forge was small, it looked promising.

“Is there a smith named Gong Ya-ja?”

When Woon-seong asked, the hammering stopped and a person appeared. “Who is it that is looking for me?” This man was huge, almost seven feet of pure muscle. The giant hammer in his hand seemed small, and Woon-seong’s eyes widened at the size of the man.

“Are you Gong Ya-ja?”

The man nodded. “I am Gong Ya-ja. Why are you looking for me?”

“The Demonic Sword sent me here.”

At the mention of this recommendation, the man scratched the back of his head with the hand not holding the hammer. But he only shook his head. “There’s a number of Demonic Swords that I’m aware of...so I’m not sure which one you’re talking about.”

“The Demonic Sword of Layered Blood.”

At these words, the blacksmith’s body stiffened.

Inside the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, there were indeed many given the name 'Demonic Sword', but only one of them was special. That was because only a single one, the 'Demonic Sword of Layered Blood', was a Great Demon!

"Who...are you?" His attitude towards Woon-seong had changed simply because of who was introducing him.

"I am Hyuk Woon-seong, who just recently became a Great Demon."

Gong Ya-ja could not help but cry out in shock. "Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit!"

Unbeknownst to him, Woon-seong was now a famous figure among the demonic people. Despite his age, he was already a Great Demon. He was also the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, one of the Twelve Supporting Units.

"Yes, I am the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit." Woon-seong nodded and bowed shallowly.

"I apologize for my manners!" The smith hastily bowed.

With this bow, Woon-seong was able to vividly realize the power of the name of the Charred Dragon Unit and the status of a Great Demon. Woon-seong was not necessarily satisfied just yet, but this was already high above the commoners. *But it doesn't change the fact that I must become stronger, faster...*

Gong Ya-ja was still bowing low to the floor and Woon-seong waved at him.

"Get up. I visited here today because I have something to ask."

Gong Ya-ja hurriedly looked up, "What are you asking for?"

Woon-seong handed the black iron spear over. "I heard that you are a blacksmith who can handle black iron, right? I think that this spear was also made by you?"

“Yes, yes. It’s subtly different, but it is definitely my work.”

A blacksmith who could handle black iron. It was just what he needed.

“I would like to melt it and make something new. Can you do it?”

Woon-seong asked this carefully. Martial artists had their pride, but blacksmiths were also proud of their work and ability. But now, Woon-seong was asking a blacksmith to melt his own work and create something new, it was a delicate situation.

“This spear...” The voice of the smith was trembling. He moved his eyes around as if he was uncomfortable and soon his eyes landed on another spear, which was strapped to Woon-seong’s back.

Chapter 37: White Night Spear (3)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 37 – White Night Spear (3)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night.

As long as you had eyes, you could see how great of a spear it was at once.

In addition, this smith was a skilled blacksmith who could handle black iron. How could he not recognize the value of this spear? His eyes shook harder than ever before.

“That’s right. You’ve got a better spear.” His voice trembled, as did his shoulders. He understood why Woon-seong didn’t need his spear.

“Right. So I’m trying to make something new.”

At the words of the youth, the smith wryly shook his head. But he immediately perked up. The youth had said he would melt the spear, the black iron. As a blacksmith, he still had a chance to show off his skills!

“What are you planning to make?”

“Throwing knives and pauldrons,” Woon-seong replied briefly. [1]

If you have the soul of a blacksmith, you’ll want to make a weapon that can prove your worth no matter what.

Woon-seong smiled faintly as he saw the smith thinking of working with the black iron, then looked at his new spear. He didn't know where this spear originated, but it was definitely a top tier weapon. Unfortunately, Gong Ya-ja was not skilled enough to make such weapons. That was why he had first bowed his head upon seeing the White Night Spear; the value of the two could not be compared. Of course, this did not mean the black iron spear was of poor quality. The White Night Spear was just far superior.

This wasn't so bad either. Although it was just throwing knives and pauldrons, it fueled Gong Ya-ja's will as a blacksmith seeing that he had another chance.

You can make something quite useful.

Just as a swordsman did not learn swordsmanship alone, a spearman did not only learn spearmanship. Those of Murim needed a variety of skills to cope with various situations. Spear users needed to figure out how to deal with enemies that penetrated through their range, either too far or too close.

However, apart from the need for throwing knives, it was a little surprising that the youth had chosen pauldrons, which did not seem to help in combat.

Except, one of Woon-seong's recent experiences had become a great inspiration.

Woon-seong huffed lightly to himself, *Rushing forward and hitting the enemy with your shoulders can cause more damage than you think.*

The battle with Dal Mu-ji had come to mind.

In a fight, the smallest gap in movement could become the turning point. What would a spearman do if the opponent narrowed the distance? Wait until they were one foot into their grave? In such a situation, he could only stab or be stabbed.

Woon-seong smiled, thinking of how convenient the pauldrons would be for attack and defense.

At that time, the Gong Ya-ja had gone inside and walked back out. He held a small wooden box in his hand. “Oh, you haven’t told me when you expect these to be finished, right?”

Woon-seong shook his head and answered, “I will come find you during the next full moon.”

The smith nodded and held out the wooden box. Woon-seong opened it and found a few throwing knives, a belt, and some shoulder plates.

“If you need them, you can use these as substitutes before I have completed the throwing knives and pauldrons,” explained the smith.

“Thank you.”

Woon-seong put the leather belt around his waist. There were a total of ten holes, just enough space to fit the knives he had just been given. He adjusted the fit and soon smiled with satisfaction. *That should do it.* Even while wielding a spear, the belt could be easily adjusted for optimal use with his left hand.

Next were the shoulder plates. They were designed to be worn on the left shoulder and sort of looked like a stack of metal, but they weren’t so bad either.

After putting them all on, Woon-seong grabbed his spear again.

“Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night.”

Weng!

The spear began to tremble.

At the same time, energy flowed out of his body. Black-colored ‘intimidation qi’ spread out and scattered. Woon-seong’s eyes were now glowing gold. He looked like a predator looking at prey.

“Hehe.”

The moment that the spear began to tremble, Woon-seong had already started to swing his spear.

Shh. Shh.

He had decided to try the Art of Six Seals and Destruction.

The spear of the demonic god who erased the night in six steps. When you learned the sixth verse, you could even destroy the Heavens.

Bzz-

Eh?

As Woon-seong began the movements though, the spear shook as if it had reacted to something. It started to control its own vibrations, completely in line with the motions of the youth.

‘Rain of Star Destruction’.

‘Black Night of the Death Moon’ (死月黑夜).

‘Divine Wind of the Past’ (神風過日).

There was more to go, but he had to end it there.

Those were three of the movements from the Art of Six Seals and Destruction. Woon-seong was powerful, but he would not be able to use the latter three moves until he increased his qi. Since he couldn’t finish the art, he could only practice other things.

A torrent of energy began to flock around, creating a huge vortex that shrouded the area. The youth’s arm was pulled taut like a bowstring before being released in one fluid movement. The strike was like a dragon, plowing the land until the earthworms came out. This was the move that had beat the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain!

Khh-Kuang!

The spear blasted forward as power erupted from Woon-seong's hands, groaning. The spear slammed into the ground as sand and dust billowed into the air.

“Huff, huff.”

Woon-seong was panting and trembling, hands sore. He had not been able to properly control his energy, so that one move had used up almost everything. It had been a few days where he was stuck like this.

Just as expected, it's difficult to make a tiered martial art into one... [2]

My breathing and invoking of my qi when I use the skill. Those two should be the problem...or are there three? The excessive amount of qi also seems wrong...

Improvements would require a lot of trial and error. But since he knew where the problems lay, he only needed to work hard.

But if I can use it properly, it will become a hidden trump card.

Woon-seong had not yet named this skill, as that could wait until after it was complete.

He felt that the pain in his arm had eased a little so he pulled the spear from the ground. Strapping it to his back, he pulled out three throwing knives.

Shh.

These knives, which left the hands of the youth, flew in a straight line and hit a tree.

Pak-pak-pak.

This was not a skill, but no craftsmanship was without art. This could be seen in the way the knives were all evenly spaced apart.

Woon-seong recovered the three knives he had just thrown and pulled out four this time.

Since he had to hold his spear with his right hand, the number of knives he could use at one time was limited to four.

The knives flew like a thunderbolt and lodged into the ground some distance away, forming the shape of a cross in the four cardinal directions.

'Lightning stitching throwing knives' (雷停飛刀).

Looks like I can still use them.

This skill allowed him to throw knives like a lightning god of the Heavens punishing the sinners, each knife faster than a lightning strike. This was actually something he was formerly known for, second only to his spear arts. However, it was not as powerful as it used to be, as he had not practiced in a long time.

Plus, he would not be satisfied with just reaching his old level. Not only spearmanship, but his other skills, had to surpass that of his former self in order to infiltrate the heart of his enemies.

No, I have to even surpass the level of my master.

Woon-seong aimed at two things and once again scattered the knives.

Fababababat-

He gradually got back into his old rhythm. The knives that had been sprayed in all directions were recovered as he tidied up.

Shh-

Woon-seong grabbed his spear and once again, collected the knives.

I'm quite satisfied today.

Several clues about the skill that killed the Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain had been grasped. He had re-familiarized himself with using the knives and spear at the same time. His only complaint was...

I wish my skill with throwing knives was a little bit better...

The sun was setting over the mountains as he looked up. The red glow was bleeding into the sky.

I may be a bit late, but I can still arrive before sunset.

Woon-seong flew into the air and became like a bird, disappearing into the forest. In his place, he left only the violent traces of intense training.

[1] pauldrons are shoulder armor

[2] he's trying to make the Art of Six Seals and Destruction, which has 6 tiers/movements, combine with the Divine Spear of the Ending Night

Chapter 38: Heavenly Brain Tower (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 38 – Heavenly Brain Tower (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

As Woon-seong had expected, he arrived at the Charred Dragon House when the glow of the sky had dimmed.

Did the banquet already begin?

Inside the Charred Dragon House, a number of voices could be heard. Wondering why it didn't sound like a banquet inside, he pushed the door open. Despite the hinges being greased, they still squeaked, causing all heads to turn towards the entrance as the bright light of the interior illuminated Woon-seong.

“You’ve arrived, Captain!”

It was Gwan Tae-ryang who saw him first and shouted excitedly.

Looking around, the Charred Dragon Unit members were all present. It seemed that everyone who had been injured by Yellow Evil were now all healed. Each table was covered in plates of food and jars of alcohol, but none of them showed signs of being touched.

“Didn’t you say it was a banquet?”

“Of course.”

Gwan Tae-ryang nodded his head and dragged the youth over.

“Captain did not arrive yet, how could we start? All of us were able to be part of the Charred Dragon Unit thanks to our strong Captain.”

At that, Woon-seong laughed. He had thought Gwan Tae-ryang was just a muscle-headed bear, but it seemed like he was cunning like a fox too.

Even if I'm not there, I know the unit is in good hands.

As directed by Gwan Tae-ryang, Woon-seong sat in the seat of honor. Settling down, he looked around at the faces of his unit members one by one. He didn't recognize all of them, but some familiar faces from the Cave stared back at him.

When Woon-seong realized that he didn't even know most of their names, he felt like he had really neglected his leadership duties.

With that thought, he wore a bitter smile but quickly hid it.

At that time, Gwan Tae-ryang filled Woon-seong's glass. “Why don't you say a few words.”

Woon-seong hesitated, lifting his glass slowly.

“The Charred Dragon Unit is one of the Twelve Supporting Units. It is not an easy role and we should not be idle. As we have done so far, we have to keep our bodies in the best condition so we are ready to fight at all times.”

The atmosphere that had been excited sank as if it had been doused with a bucket of cold water.

Oops. Seeing their faces, Woon-seong only smiled and lifted his glass. “But today, let's drink!”

At the moment these words fell, Gwan Tae-ryang lifted his glass. “For the Charred Dragon Unit!”

With that cry, the dying atmosphere was revived.

“Let’s drink!”

The banquet started with all their cheers.

In fact, the food that had been prepared for the banquet was not special at all. Most of the dishes were made by the everyday Charred Dragon House chefs.

The only thing different was the atmosphere.

They were able to enjoy their food with a smile.

Congratulations on surviving the Cave of Latent Demons! Congratulations on completing your missions! Congratulations on being promoted to the Charred Dragon Unit!

During their time in the Cave, the members had not enjoyed the luxuries of human life. So this celebration felt more important than ever.

Over time, the atmosphere only ripened. The banquet, which began late in the evening, seemed like it would continue until the morning.

But unfortunately, the banquet had to end around midnight.

That was because a visitor opened the door to the Charred Dragon House and entered.

Thud-

The movement was stealthy, but it was not possible to deceive Woon-seong’s senses.

Actually, it was not only impossible to hide from Woon-seong but also the rest of the unit.

Gwan Tae-ryang immediately reached for his blade, but Woon-seong stopped him.

“Who is it?”

Looking at the man, Woon-seong was sure that he had some status. He was standing in front of the new Charred Dragon Unit, but his positioning and aura were quite extraordinary. The man stood just outside the distance a knife could be thrown — given it wasn’t Woon-seong who threw it, of course.

“Greetings. The ‘Brain of the Heavenly Absolute Demon’ (脑天極魔) has a message for the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit and I, Ha Mo, am tasked to relay it.”

His words immediately caused the alertness of the unit to disperse. This man was a messenger of the Cult. However, there were still some suspicions.

“By ‘Brain of the Heavenly Absolute Demon’, you mean the Senior Strategist, Sir Sang Gwan-chuk. A message from him?”

“Yes. He asks, if the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit is present at his quarters, enter the Heavenly Brain Tower.”

The Heavenly Brain Tower was one of the Demonic Master Towers, obviously belonging to the ‘Brain of the Heavenly Absolute Demon’. Since it was run by the Senior Strategist, it could also be considered as the Cult’s military strategy center.

“The Heavenly Brain Tower? At this time?”

“He says that there’s a new mission. I wasn’t briefed about the details, but I was told that it was an urgent matter.”

It wouldn’t make sense for one of the Ten Demonic Masters to set a trap to eliminate a mere Great Demon like me. Especially for the Senior Strategist.

Although Woon-seong had been growing rapidly, he was not on the level of being a threat to the Ten Demonic Masters. Each one could crush him easily under their feet and would not lower themselves by tricking him.

A mission.

Tak-

Woon-seong put his cup down. The faces of the other members all turned to him as he got up.

“I’ll be off.”

The man, who had introduced himself as Ha Mo, led the youth to the Heavenly Brain Tower.

Just like the demonic villages, the towers of the Ten Demonic Masters were similarly arranged in a circle with the Peak of the Heavenly Demon’s Majesty at the center. However, the towers were all located closer to the edges of the Cult’s territory. This was because of the idea that the Ten Demonic Masters should be at the forefront of battle, defending the people of the Cult. [1]

That was why Ha Mo guided the youth outwards.

About half an hour after leaving the Charred Dragon House, Woon-seong could start to see the Heavenly Brain Tower. It was a seven-story structure that looked very much like a watchtower. Wherever the enemy was coming from, such a watchtower could look far beyond the surrounding mountains.

As he hurried towards the Heavenly Brain Tower, Woon-seong glanced towards Ha Mo.

“Huuk, huuk, huuk.” Contrary to the beginning, Ha Mo was breathing very heavily. “C-can we take a break.”

“Don’t make me laugh.” Woon-seong’s words were cold.

“...”

Woon-seong turned his head to look at the tower, which was still far in the distance. “It was your idea to increase the pace to test me.”

“You found out?”

Ha Mo trembled. He was not a Great Demon, but he was one of the top amongst the Demonic Generals. Even though it was just a single step, he did not have the skills to reach the next rank. Seeing Woon-seong who was so much younger than him, he could not help himself from testing the other.

Except...

“How dare a mere Demonic General try and test a Great Demon? You’ve got some nerve.”

The Demonic General-class Ha Mo testing the Great Demon-level Woon-seong was a sin equivalent to a knight rebelling against their king. Right now, no matter what Woon-seong did, it was his right.

You can’t be serious. Ha Mo swallowed his saliva seeing that he had angered the youth.

Although he was a Demonic General, Ha Mo believed the Heavenly Brain Tower stood behind him. With this background, he had taken the chance to test Woon-seong.

However, the subsequent words of the youth were completely beyond his expectations.

“Let’s do it this way. Run to the Heavenly Brain Tower like you have been so far. If you stop to rest or slow down even a little bit, you shall take responsibility for insulting a Great Demon with your life.”

Ha Mo tried to protest. “Do you really have to—”

But Woon-seong cut off his words. “Silence! I’m not done yet.”

An icy chill wrapped around the area. Fear seemed to solidify into a figure, and Ha Mo trembled as if he were facing Death.

“If you arrive later than me, it won’t be as bad as resting on the way, but you shall still take responsibility!”

This voice was like a roar and Ha Mo didn't dare open his mouth, even as Woon-seong was running past him.

“Heavens, I was wrong. I was wrong!”

The messenger fully recognized the disparity. No matter how much he tried to chase, it was impossible for him to catch up to the youth.

“Huff, huff, huff.”

As evidence, Woon-seong's breathing was even when Ha Mo finally arrived. Woon-seong sneered at the man, whose breathing was rough.

“You're late.”

The man could only look up and say, crying, “What will happen to me now?”

“Oh, you can still talk? Must not have tried hard enough then. I told you: I'll bury you.”

Ha Mo protested, “Are you not going to show generosity as a strong man? Behind me —”

Even before his words were finished, the youth had grabbed him by the neck, cutting off his words with a hand around his windpipe. Woon-seong slowly raised his arms. Surprisingly, the man's body was lifted up.

“Gurck, guhgs.”

The man was choking, but Woon-seong paid no mind. Instead of releasing him, the youth pulled the face closer to his own. The other's terrified eyes were clearly visible.

“Did you think the Brain of the Heavenly Absolute Demon would look after your ass? You think too highly of yourself!”

“Ugh.”

In the meantime, Ha Mo continued to gasp for breath, and the other hand of the youth, which was not grasping the neck, moved.

Wooduk-

With one powerful punch, Ha Mo's stomach was smashed inwards. Ignoring the sound of innards shattering, Woon-seong threw the man to the floor.

"Chooo, huh. Agh. Oh my god." A few of Ha Mo's ribs had been broken and he was still gasping for breath! The man trembled and did not even think about getting up from the ground.

"Hmph."

Seeing him play dead, Woon-seong only snorted before entering the tower.

[1] The Heavenly Towers are at the edges of Cult headquarters territory, then the Twelve Unit houses, other living accommodations, the ordinary villages, and finally the Heavenly Palace. The strongest are situated farther away from the center.

Chapter 39: Heavenly Brain Tower (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 39 – Heavenly Brain Tower (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Senior Strategist's office took up the entire seventh floor, the highest point of the tower. To get there, Woon-seong had to walk through six floors. Despite this, no one stopped him.

It seemed that his arrival had already been announced. So, the youth climbed seven stories of stairs. Upon entering the seventh floor, the first thing he saw was a wooden door leading to a seemingly empty office. Despite no presence being sensed, voices could still be heard from beyond the door, terrifying him.

At this point, the door opened before Woon-seong could announce his arrival.. Seeing this, the youth could only swallow. Although it seemed inferior to the skills of the Heavenly Demon, that was still telekinesis!

While he hesitated, a voice floated over. "What's the matter? Come in."

Crossing the threshold, a peculiar smell originating from old paper permeated the air.

It's as if I entered the safehouse of the Spear Master Sect.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly at the familiar smell as the Senior Strategist got up from his seat and slowly walked over.

“Have a seat.”

Three pens could be seen on the Senior Strategist’s belt: The black pen, the blood pen, and the pen of life and death. Woon-seong was well acquainted with the story surrounding these three iron pens.

When the Demonic Cult’s Brain of the Heavenly Demon draws his black pen, an arm or leg is severed. When he draws the blood pen, all limbs are lost. When he draws the pen of life and death, you will surely meet your end!

While Woon-seong was thinking about the famous saying, he sat down at the urging of the Senior Strategist. Once they both settled down, the other held up two cups of water. Unlike how most people made their tea, the tea leaves were not yet in the cups and the water was cold.

“Let’s start with a cup of tea.”

As Woon-seong sat in his seat, he saw the strategist calmly pull out tea leaves and put them into the teacups. He then patted the cups with his fingertips. In an instant, the tea had finished boiling and the fragrance of tea rose into the air.

That was Samādhi ignition (三昧眞火)!

Being capable of Samādhi ignition means he’s at the same level as my master...and there’s supposed to be nine more like him?

Woon-seong trembled slightly.

Although it was easy to classify someone as first class or top class, it was hard to say who was better or worse until two people actually fought. In addition, if two martial artists had similar strengths, victory or defeat depended on health, mood, and the surrounding environment.

Again, Woon-seong was surprised by the power of the Cult after seeing the strength of one of the Ten Demonic Masters firsthand.

“Here.”

At that time, one of the teacups, which had been heated, was handed to the youth. Despite the fact that Samādhi ignition was used, the water vapor was almost undisturbed.

Woon-seong leaned over and drank some of the tea.

Confirming that the youth had swallowed some tea, the strategist spoke, “I’ve sent someone to guide you here. It seems like he committed a mistake against you.”

Woon-seong noticed that the Senior Strategist knew he had punished the messenger, meaning that the other’s qi senses reached all the way to the bottom of the tower.

“Ah...he tried to test me. So I gave him a light punishment.”

“Oh dear...” The strategist nodded and laughed. “He’s a capable fellow, but sometimes he has the tendency to overestimate himself. That should teach him a valuable lesson.”

Woon-seong put down the cup in his hand. “I heard that you needed me.”

“To be precise, I’m in need of the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit.”

Woon-seong stiffened at these words.

Asking for the Great Demon Hyuk Woon-seong and asking for the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit were two different matters. If you asked for Hyuk Woon-seong it meant you had something to say or do personally, asking for the Captain...

“You have a job that needs to be done.”

The strategist tapped a scroll on the side with his hand, causing it to unfurl. As the scroll opened, a map appeared. "I need you to lead the Charred Dragon Unit to Sichuan."

Sichuan could be considered both the outskirts and the center of the world. It was clearly a place of great importance to the Orthodox Sect. The Qingcheng, Mount Hua Sect, and the Sichuan Tang family were all there. This was not an area easy for the demonic to casually stroll through.

"Sichuan?"

The strategist nodded heavily, then pointed to the region on the map. "Branches of the Cult reside everywhere, Sichuan is no exception."

Woon-seong silently listened.

"The Sichuan branch leader has been kidnapped by the Orthodox Sects." The strategist clicked his tongue.

In the meantime, Woon-seong weighed the importance of the Sichuan branch and the Charred Dragon Unit. It was not difficult to infer this was a rescue mission. But no matter how he looked at it, calling for an elite unit was going overboard.

"Is it necessary to move the Charred Dragon Unit?"

This was a branch leader, but the Charred Dragon Unit was still one of the Twelve Supporting Units.

However, the strategist explained some more. "It wouldn't have, if it were some other branch leader in Sichuan. But the one kidnapped is a man named Un Un. He is the general manager of all branches in Sichuan."

Even so, it was still overboard.

Unless he had something special.

Senior Strategist Sang Gwan-chuk continued after drinking some tea, guessing Woon-seong's thoughts. "Unlike ordinary branch managers,

general managers know the location of the Secret Demon Vault.”

Woon-seong immediately stiffened. The Secret Demon Vault was the vault of the Cult and an important part of the communication network. It’s location could not be exposed!

“Word says that he’s currently imprisoned in the Sichuan branch of the Martial Alliance. It’s also safe to assume that the Alliance won’t send someone ordinary for the interrogation.”

Woon-seong understood why it was an urgent matter, one worthy of mobilizing the Charred Dragon Unit. The youth rose from his seat while inelegantly pouring the remaining tea into his mouth. “I’ll leave right now.”

On that day, a little over twenty people hurried from Mt. Heaven into the villages surrounding the Cult. Their leader was, of course, a young man with a spear.

The Charred Dragon Unit had set off.

The slow moving sword gradually increased in speed. A light blue qi spread and bloomed like clouds. Another sword glare flowed near the ground, bright red like an ember. It was a subtle difference, but another integral part of the swordsmanship.

Blue clouds and a sword of red glow.

In Qingcheng, there was only one person who was able to unleash this sword perfectly.

The First Apprentice of Qingcheng, the Elder of the Swords of Qingcheng, Song Chi-hak. .

‘Sword of Earth’ (地劍) Jang Seo-ah, a disciple of this swordsman, was unable to take her eyes off the sword. The aura had become thicker than what she had seen three years ago.

“Did you see it?”

“Yes, Master.”

“With enough effort, you will be able to achieve it too.”

The teacher’s eyes moved. He pretended to be stern, but his eyes were licentiously roaming the disciple’s body. The talented child he had brought back as an apprentice was now a fully developed woman. His eyes flitted to her slender waist. Then, he shook his head lightly. It was not the time yet. It would not be too late to take her after making Qincheng his own, even after taking over Murim would still be fine. Thus, he forced his gaze away.

“We have lost contact from the youngest.”

The youngest he was speaking of was the Sword of Men, Mae Hong-sung.

“Go and find out what’s going on. I sent him to Lop Nur for a task, but something seems to have happened.”

The disciple bowed her head.

“Originally, I should be doing it myself, but the Martial Alliance has sent a request to me. It looks like the Sichuan branch of the Alliance, where our eldest is, caught an officer of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. My job is probably to interrogate him.”

“I’ll take responsibility for finding my junior brother. I’ll make sure you don’t have to worry about a thing, Master...”

The First Apprentice smiled brightly and reached out to grab her hands. He caressed her hand a few times, indulging in the softer skin of a young woman. Jang Seo-ah was feeling uncomfortable from the unwanted touch, but did not dare say anything to her master.

“But seriously, I wonder what the youngest is doing...”

At that time, the First Apprentice did not know that the Sword of Men was dead, and that the person who killed Mae Hong-sung was also aiming a knife at his own heart.

Likewise, Woon-seong did not know that one of his enemies, this swordsman, was headed to the same regional branch of the Martial Alliance as he was.

Chapter 40: Exploiting The Enemy (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 40 – Exploiting the Enemy (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Clop, clop, clop.

A group of horses galloped across the plains, kicking up a cloud of sand and dust.

Today marked seven days since the Charred Dragon Unit had left the Cult. Thanks to the constant change of horses, the time required to reach the edge of Xinjiang had been greatly reduced.

Nevertheless, they could not move on horseback forever.

“Whoa!”

When Woon-seong sent a signal, the following Charred Dragon Unit stopped all at once. The horses whined.

In front of them was a huge mountain range, extending through and outside of Xinjiang.

The Kunlun Mountains. [1]

“From here, we’ll abandon our horses and move on foot.”

The Kunlun Mountains marked the start and end of Zhongyuan (Central Plains). Twenty people travelling on horseback would attract the attention of others no matter where they were.

Woon-seong and his men got off their horses and tied them to some nearby trees. One of the men shot an arrow into the air. It soared vertically and exploded in the sky, releasing a burst of blue flame. After seeing this signal, people from a nearby Cult branch would come and collect the horses.

“Continue to move.”

It was time to enter the Kunlun Mountains.

Their target was Sichuan, which lay beyond Qinghai [2]. Thus it was important for them to lay low in the Qinghai province, which was the territory of the Kunlun Sect.

The Kunlun Sect was one of the Ten Great Sects, but it was actually quite rare for fellow cultivators to encounter them even if they passed the Kunlun Mountain. They were a group with an intense Taoist culture, more so than any other group. For them, it was important to build up inner strength. They felt different from the similar, yet more secular, Mount Hua and Qingcheng.

I don’t have a deep grudge against them, since they weren’t there.

Woon-seong crossed the ridge of a mountain and slowly recalled that day. The day his master died, his own death — he forgot nothing. But that day, apparently none of the Kunlun showed up.

That’s strange.

They weren’t the only ones that didn’t show. Neither the Shaolin, the other Ten Great Sects, nor the Five Noble Clans had been seen that day either.

Although it ended up being a false charge, it was still the execution of a demonic being that practiced a forbidden demonic art.

And yet the Lord of the Martial Alliance had not moved the Shaolin or the Kunlun?

No matter how Woon-seong thought, something did not add up. It seemed like he was still missing something before he could guess the answer.

Jwa Do-gyul, what on earth were you thinking?

Woon-seong's eyes, slowly chewing on those memories, sank deeper and deeper.

The Charred Dragon Unit reached the end of the Kunlun Mountain after half a month.

"I can see the end."

It was not too difficult to reach their destination as long as they left the Kunlun Mountains. However, they had to be careful. They could not move carelessly. Now was the time to set up their operation and judge the situation. What they needed most was information.

The youth glanced back and called someone. "Baek Woon-ji!"

In response, Baek Woon-ji ran forward. "Yes, Captain!"

Despite the uneven ground, her footsteps were light and silent — a characteristic of someone who had mastered the art of stealth.

Woon-seong nodded to himself, "How many of our members have proficiently learned the art of stealth?"

"How proficient do you mean?"

Woon-seong closed his eyes for a moment. "Enough to hide themselves in less than a foot of darkness. Enough to walk on rooftops and not make the roof tiles rattle at all."

Baek Woon-ji thought for some time, as she was the best at stealth in the unit. Naturally, she met the mentioned conditions. So which of the

remaining members also met those conditions? Most of the unit could to some degree. However, few had reached a satisfactory level.

“Three. If you stretch a bit more, there are five.”

Three or five.

“We’ll go with three. I’ll group them up temporarily as Team One. You take the role of leader.”

Baek Woon-ji nodded and waited calmly, listening.

“The moment you enter Sichuan, start gathering intel. Their numbers, shift times, size and structure of the Martial Alliance Branch and the location of the imprisoned branch leader. You need to gather as much information as possible.”

The objective was to get a clear picture of the situation so that he would be sure of what to do.

“Yes, sir!”

As he turned away, he added one last thing, “Do not let any information slip, no matter how trivial it is!”

“I heard that the Charred Dragon Unit has headed out.”

A man in black shrugged. “The Charred Dragon Unit? They may be part of the Twelve Supporting Units, but they’re still a bunch of newbies. Is there anything to worry about?”

The other man laughed. “You underestimate the strength of our Cult. They may be new, but they are the Charred Dragon Unit.” The man corrected the words of the other, tapping the table lightly with his finger.

Tuk—tuk—

Every time, a hole was dug into the surface of the table. It was a heavy wooden table, not tofu!

“Even though I have joined with you, underestimating the Cult will cost you greatly.”

At that point, the man in black was attentive and nodded.

The man in front of him was the Vice Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and one of the Ten Demonic Masters.

‘Soul Splitting Flame King’ (斷魂炎王), Joo Moon-baek.

No matter who you were, this was not a person easily ignored. Furthermore, when the Heavenly Demon died, this man would become the new Cult Leader. There was a need for good relations in the future.

“Pardon my manners.”

“Setting that aside, are you prepared to stop the Charred Dragon Unit? Rumor says that their captain is very capable.”

The man in black laughed. “We’ve thoroughly prepared for decades. We have also prepared some decent martial artists. The ‘Sword of Heaven’ of Qingcheng is there.”

Joo Moon-baek had obviously heard of this man. “Isn’t he still a brat?”

The Sword of Heaven was in his late thirties, making him about twice as old as those in the Charred Dragon Unit. Still, he was considerably young. Wasn’t he only the successor of the ‘Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset’?

“Have you forgotten that the captain of the Charred Dragon Unit is abnormally skilled for his age?” Joo Moon-baek seemed to think it would be difficult to block the Charred Dragon Unit with just the Sword of Heaven. Unless the captain was an idiot, he would not have a head-to-head match with the Sichuan branch. “If this plan fails, it will be difficult to blame the Cult Leader for being incompetent.”

The man in black nodded. A few conditions were required for Joo Moon-baek to become the head of the Cult. The absence of the Heavenly Demon

or the incompetence of said leader was one of them.

“That’s why I sent one more person.”

“Who?”

He laughed. “The First Apprentice.”

When this name was mentioned, Joo Moon-baek nodded. As a master, the First Apprentice was on a completely different level. The First Apprentice shouldn’t have much of a problem dealing with the Charred Dragon Unit.

“But before that, what about the ‘Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon’ (天魔神功)?”

Even if all preparations were complete, it was useless without the Divine Art. This was the surest symbol of legitimacy of leadership.

Joo Moon-baek laughed at this question. At the same time, a grey haze rose up from his body. The energy was transformed into a flame, covering the fingertips of the man. The color was a little different, but that was definitely the flame that symbolized the Heavenly Demon. Seeing it, the man in black swallowed saliva.

“This is the Divine Flame of the Heavenly Demon.”

The Charred Dragon Unit was settled about three villages away from the Martial Alliance’s branch. They were neither too far nor too close. No matter what happened, they had room to respond.

As mentioned earlier, members of Team One, including Baek Woon-ji, were collecting information at the Sichuan branch.

The rest were sharply tuning their condition.

Woon-seong was no different.

He had sought out a small vacant piece of land away from the others. There was a sense of calm in the dark atmosphere of this secluded area, away

from the reach of people. Here, he began to practice his spear arts.

There was the sound of the air being perforated, as the White Night Spear was swung. Long grass was cut off with no resistance. The trees hindered the course of the spear, but were cut through.

Shhh-

Woon-seong unveiled powerful strikes in succession. Following these moves, the spear began to tremble slightly. His fingertips also trembled finely. There was a clear difference between this spear and the old one.

Did my basic skills become better?

That was likely a reason, but it wasn't enough. There was a fundamental difference. Woon-seong looked down at his spear.

The fundamental reason for this change in strength was the spear in his hand.

[1] The Kunlun Mountains constitute one of the longest mountain chains in Asia, extending more than 3,000 km (1,900 mi; about the entire US east coast). Kunlun is originally the name of a mythical mountain believed to be a Taoist paradise.

[2] Just as a reminder, the Cult is located in Xinjiang. By moving southeast, they will pass through Qinghai and then Sichuan.

Chapter 41: Exploiting The Enemy (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 41 – Exploiting the Enemy (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

This spear, in the hands of the boy, made a difference. It was a very slight difference, but he had felt it clearly just now. The moment Woon-seong had begun to lose control, the spear had sent a signal to the boy as if saying that this was not the way.

Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night.

Woon-seong looked at the spear. The main question was why, in response to him, this phenomenon was produced. He observed the spear to find what was unusual, but it was just a normal spear. Nothing was out of the ordinary, except for the writing on the tussar silk wrapped around it.

‘From Star Absence to Unrecorded’.

There were many nicknames in Murim, but only one person used ‘Star Absence’.

A former Cult Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the ‘Star Absence Heavenly Demon’.

Then perhaps this spear had been a gift which the Star Absence Heavenly Demon presented to someone.

The problem was who?

Woon-seong did not know who or what ‘Unrecorded’ referred to and wondered if it had something to do with the ‘Unrecorded Demonic Group’.

Soon he determined that this was probably not the case.

The Unrecorded Demonic Group was a *group*, not an individual. They would not be presented with a single spear, and even if they were, the spear would be a symbolic wall-hanger rather than a practical weapon.

The White Night Spear was definitely a practical weapon. Not only was it sturdy and well-balanced, there were no ornamental embellishments.

The greatest mystery was that the spear felt familiar in Woon-seong’s hands, as if he had tamed it in the forges himself.

None of this makes sense to me...

For a while, Woon-seong stared at the spear before finally giving up and shaking his head.

At that time, someone came near with a rustling sound.

“Lieutenant, is that you?”

A voice came out of the bush. “Yes, Captain. Team One is back from their recon mission.”

Woon-seong sighed to himself, then walked with Gwan Tae-ryang back to the house everyone was staying at.

Baek Woon-ji, who had returned, reported. “There’s around 300 men in the Martial Alliance’s Sichuan branch. Around 200 of them are combatants.”

200 warriors. This was not a small number, but not all of them would be strong.

“And out of them, about 150 are third-rate martial artists.”

These people were better than the general public, but considered weak according to Murim levels.

“The rest are either second-rate or first-rate. Out of them, there are three to be especially careful of.”

“I assume one of them is the branch leader.”

This was the Martial Alliance’s branch leader of the Sichuan area. Given the importance of this area, it was safe to assume they were at least first-rate.

However, Woon-seong believed the Charred Dragon Unit could handle them.

“Yes. He’s known as the ‘Blood Seeker’, Tang Pae-jong.”

“Is he from the Tang Clan?”

“Yes, but he’s from a collateral line. He’s somewhat skilled in the art of poison and is more capable in the art of assassination.” [1]

Poison and assassination...? He might be a pain but shouldn't pose a problem for Baek Woon-ji. Even putting the art of stealth aside, she's one of the best.

Baek Woon-ji nodded, seeing Woon-seong silently signal to her. “I’ll handle him.”

“Who are the other two?”

“It’s the Sword of Heaven and the First Apprentice.”

At her words, Woon-seong’s face immediately hardened. “You mean the successors of the Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset?”

Baek Woon-ji nodded.

The First Apprentice is here?

Woon-seong felt his heart pounding within his chest. It hadn't been long since he took care of the Sword of Men and yet he was now about to meet the Sword of Heaven and the First Apprentice.

How fun.

It felt like the Heavens were helping him.

“I'll deal with the First Apprentice. You take care of the Sword of Heaven, Lieutenant.”

“Yes, sir.”

This was natural as the First Apprentice was stronger than the Sword of Heaven, and Woon-seong was stronger than Gwan Tae-ryang. In addition, Woon-seong hated the First Apprentice much more.

“But this is the worst case scenario. If possible, we must rescue the branch manager undetected.”

It was not good to work too hard.

This was Sichuan. Although not in the middle of Murim, it was territory occupied by three factions from the Ten Great Sects and the Five Noble Clans. For the Demonic, it was not an ideal place for bloodshed.

“Fighting should be avoided as much as possible. However, if it happens, the situation should be handled as quietly as possible.”

“Understood,” replied the Charred Dragon Unit.

This was a warning to Woon-seong himself too.

The First Apprentice was his enemy, but only one of them. As the current captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, he must not put himself and the whole

unit at risk to kill a mere swordsman.

Perhaps he would not be able to kill the First Apprentice today, but he would only have more opportunities in the future. As a youth of barely twenty and still gathering his power, he did not need to hurry. Delaying a fight in order to have a surer chance of total annihilation was also a good plan.

“Baek Woon-ji, continue your report.”

The detailed plan for the operation was based on the information that Baek Woon-ji had gathered.

Supposedly, Branch Manager Un Un was being held in an underground prison. Since they did not know his exact location, they would have to reach the underground cells and identify him with the picture the Cult gave.

This would take time.

Woon-seong slowly calculated the time required for the operation. It was important that they had to go in and out quickly and quietly. If possible, they should take less than 30 minutes.

“I assume there’s a good number of guards.”

Baek Woon-ji nodded solemnly.

“Considering they’re holding a branch manager of the Cult, they’re making sure the place is secure.”

That was a given — the Martial Alliance was just waiting for the Cult to show up.

“They change shifts every four hours. There’s a good number of guards. Going in and out with a large number will be a problem if we want to maintain a low profile.”

Woon-seong nodded thoughtfully.

“The mission requires us to be swift and silent. I’ll only enter with Team One and the Lieutenant.”

“Understood.”

“The rest of the unit will be on standby around the perimeter. Also, in case things go south, let’s decide on a signal before going in. This time, the signal will be red fireworks. Shoot it with an arrow in case of an emergency. Those who are going in will prepare smoke bombs for escaping. Prepare yourselves...”

Woon-seong looked up at the sky. They needed darkness, and it would be darkest just before sunrise.

“We’ll move at 0500.”

The darkness was thick. The moon was slowly losing its power, but it was still too early for the sun to rise.

The Charred Dragon Unit moved silently.

As discussed earlier, only five people would be heading inside: three people with excellent stealth, Gwan Tae-ryang, and Woon-seong. The rest of the unit was stationed at regular intervals, surrounding the perimeter.

Woon-seong warned everyone one last time before heading in. “Once again. Our priority is to rescue the branch manager, not fight the enemy. Combat is the last option, only for when things go wrong.”

Four shadows moved with the boy.

Shh. Shh.

The shadows zipped along the walls like gusts of wind, merging with the night to hide their forms.

They hid in the darkness and quickly escaped the guards.

The footsteps of the quintet, including Gwan Tae-ryang's, made no sound as they entered.

In that situation, Woon-seong signalled to Baek Woon-ji.

‘Where’s the entrance to the underground prison?’

Baek Woon-ji pointed with her finger. ‘Right from the wall beyond.’

Woon-seong moved along the wall, following her directions. How many times did they turn? There were numerous guards, but it was not difficult to deceive their eyes.

Soon a prison appeared before them. There were only six men guarding the entrance. It seemed that these guards could be stunned quickly and the quintet would be able to enter the prison to easily rescue the manager.

Woon-seong, however, raised his hand quietly.

It seems too easy. Their guard seems too loose considering they should be expecting us. The overall surveillance so far also seemed somewhat odd. It's almost like they intentionally left holes in their security. I have a bad feeling about this.

‘Captain, is something wrong...?’

Woon-seong shook his head and looked inside slowly, calming himself.

What's my top priority? The cells are right in front of us. Retreating is not an option at this point. If we're past the point of no return, moving swiftly is an option. The First Apprentice...the Sichuan branch manager should also be here. But considering things, the First Apprentice should be the one in charge. ...! That's right!

Woon-seong suddenly remembered the personality of the First Apprentice. When that thought came to mind, his lips curled into a sinister smile.

‘Let's go.’

Dozens of soldiers were following behind two men.

“Maybe they’re in by now, Master.”

“A chance to catch some more dogs of the Cult in addition to their branch manager. It seems like luck is on our side.”

“It’s all thanks to your hard work, Branch Manager.”

The one who responded with a laugh was the First Apprentice. Just that morning, he had arrived at the Alliance’s Sichuan branch to interrogate the prisoner. He remembered what had happened earlier that evening.

“Branch Manager, I think a rat has come in.”

As he was touring the branch, the swordsman had sensed the signs of the three Charred Dragon Unit members who had hid in the branch to collect information.

“The dogs of the Cult are on the move.”

“Then shouldn’t we find them?”

“Normally, you would. But I have a better idea than wasting this chance to swap a mere three rats. If we’re going to catch them, we should catch them all! Don’t worry, they’re leaving. Seems like they only came for recon. We’ll use this chance to take them down altogether.”

As the First Apprentice had guessed, they had really come back.

Huh, dogs of the cult. I wonder what breed they are...

Seeing the underground prison, the First Apprentice smiled. Why not take the fish that had leapt into the net themselves for interrogation too?

At that time, the Sword of Heaven shouted. “All the guards have fallen. It looks like they were attacked at the pressure points.”

The First Apprentice slowly looked around, carefully observing the footprints and scuffle marks.

“There are traces of them going in, but none of them coming out. They should still be inside.”

After all, there was only one entrance to the prison.

“Now lets go catch some rats.”

It wasn't like the Demonic were *actually* rats who burrowed into the ground.

The First Apprentice smiled viciously and entered the prison.

[1] In martial arts novels, the Sichuan Tang Clan is renowned for their knowledge in poison arts and hidden weapons. As a result, they are usually also capable assassins.

Chapter 42: Followed (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 42 – Followed (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The First Apprentice entered the underground prison with a small number of people, including the Sword of Heaven and the branch manager. The remaining personnel were set up outside in case of any unexpected circumstances. It was unlikely for anything, but the people inside could try to escape by risking their lives.

The chances are quite low though.

Walking down the stairs that led to the cells, the First Apprentice confidently smiled. “Let’s see what kind of dogs they sent from the Cult.”

As he stepped inside, the damp smell unique to the underground wafted over. Due to poor ventilation, it was extremely unpleasant. Despite the odor, the First Apprentice continued inside after simply putting a sensory seal on his nose.

Behind the bars were prisoners. Whether they were asleep or not, all of them kept their heads down and did not move.

Hmm.

The First Apprentice touched the iron bars.

The prisoners were too quiet.

Even if they were sleeping, the atmosphere would be disturbed if people came inside, so it didn't make sense that no one had woken up in such a loud situation.

There are no coincidences in Murim.

He headed at a fast pace towards the deepest part of the basement. The one who had been imprisoned here was the head of the Sichuan branch of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Or, at least, he should have been.

The cell was empty.

“What is the meaning of this?!”

Staring at the now empty prison cell, the First Apprentice shouted in fury. Then something seemed to come to mind and he pulled his sword out.

“No way!”

The sword easily sliced the prison bars. He had not cut the empty cell, but the one next to it. The grate fell to the floor with a loud clatter.

The Sword of Heaven was surprised, “Master!”

The branch manager was no exception either. “What are you doing now?!”

The First Apprentice was the head of the Qingcheng Sect, but there were things that even the Master of the Alliance should not do. His current actions were improper. These prison cells held dangerous criminals!

However, the First Apprentice had no interest in these cries.

Even now, the prisoners were asleep without knowledge of the commotion.

He grabbed one by the shoulders and sent his qi through. The energy sent passed through the skin but was blocked by something in the meridians.

He shouted in anger, “His pressure points have been compromised! It should be the same for the other prisoners who seem to be asleep!”

“Key, I need to get the keys!” The branch manager fumbled about in confusion and embarrassment, but soon took out the keys and opened all the other cells.

The First Apprentice, the Sword of Heaven, the branch manager, and the others moved about the prison cells to confirm.

“Compromised pressure points!”

“Here too...”

Their conclusions were all the same: the man from the Cult of the Heavenly Demon they had imprisoned had disappeared while the other prisoners were knocked unconscious.

“Well, we seem to be one step late.”

“But how could they have compromised the pressure points of the prisoners still in their cells?”

In general, pressure points became compromised when external qi was forcefully transferred into the meridian pathway. Due to the precision needed, most people had to physically press the victim’s acupoints with their fingertips.

However, some could do it without touching the other person.

“It seems that there’s someone who can use ‘sword aura point pressing’ (劍氣點穴) or ‘finger wind point pressing’ (指風點穴).”

As the First Apprentice spoke, his anger boiled. If this hadn’t been a branch of the Martial Alliance, he would have let out a string of expletives. *But I can’t fucking do that here.*

Instead, he spoke with forced calm, “It looks like we need to assemble a pursuit team...”

The branch manager immediately perked up. “I thought ahead and applied some ‘thousand mile tracking scent’ on him.”

As soon as he finished speaking, the branch manager took out a small bottle and uncorked it. A faint scent that could only be sensed by him began to flow, continuing into the distance like a road.

The appearance of the bottle caused the First Apprentice’s eyes to glow brightly and he gripped his sword.

“Let’s follow it then.”

The crowd that went into the prison came out in a rush.

The situation was urgent.

But the scene when they reached the top was just as surprising...

The bodies of the martial artists they had been stationed outside littered the entrance.

“Hut, what the hell?!” Seeing the scene, the First Apprentice could not stand the rising anger and almost vomited blood. “The Demonic Cult released some pretty capable pups.”

Then the branch manager exclaimed, “The warriors that were guarding the entrance are not there!”

The First Apprentice rounded on him in annoyance. “What?”

In a panic, the branch manager double-checked the numbers. Again, he came to the same conclusion.

“The ones who were guarding the entrance, I mean, the ones who were knocked out cold, are not here.”

“How dare those fucking bastards use a trap against me!” The First Apprentice ground his teeth. He understood the situation at once.

At first, the “guards” outside had been the dogs of the Demonic Cult, who had stolen the clothes of the real guards. It was a grave mistake that the First Apprentice had not confirmed their identities before entering. While this had been a risky move, the rats had prevented a large number of people from tracking them.

The Sword of Heaven also quietly assessed the situation. He concluded that this was not a maneuver you could do just by being bold. No matter how powerful a person was, he would not take such a risk for no reason.

No, the opponent had been convinced. They had been confident that the First Apprentice, intoxicated with a false sense of victory, would enter the prison without properly checking the faces of the prison guards on the floor.

Who was it? This was a plan by someone who knows him well.

Which person from the Demonic Cult understood the character of the First Apprentice so accurately?

As the Sword of Heaven was still racking his brain for an answer, the First Apprentice had moved on.

“They couldn’t have run far. Take us to them, Branch Manager!”

“But we don’t have enough warriors. It might be a trap. We should be cautious and —”

The First Apprentice exploded with anger. “Do you dare think I will just let those Cult scums go after insulting me?”

Faced with the wrath of the First Apprentice, the branch manager could only agree.

“Okay...”

Shh, shh, shh.

A group of shadows was moving through the night. Their numbers were a little over twenty, and the general manager was on the back of Gwan Tae-ryang.

Woon-seong had discovered that the man's pressure points had been compromised in order to incapacitate him, but he couldn't do anything about it for now.

It can be solved but it will take time.

If the problem could have been easily solved, the general manager would have been on his own feet and not carried on someone's back.

What they lacked most was time.

Woon-seong moved to his lieutenant's side, "General Manager, is your body okay?"

At that, the man smiled faintly and nodded. "Thank you. It seems I've caused you trouble. Can you tell me which unit of the Cult you are?"

Woon-seong replied briefly. "The Charred Dragon Unit."

The words of the youth shook the man. The Twelve Supporting Units were elite units composed mostly of Demonic Generals. That meant the young man who was carrying him was as powerful as he was! More importantly, the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit was a Great Demon! [1]

"W-where is the Captain?" the man asked in a panic. If his pressure points weren't compromised, he would have been looking around in a frenzy.

It was Gwan Tae-ryang who answered, "He is talking to you now."

At that, the man was frightened and tried to raise his upper body to bow.

"Stay still, your pressure points are still compromised."

"I, Un-Un, present myself in front of the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit."

Woon-seong nodded his head.

Un-Un examined the youth in detail. As a Great Demon, the force held within his body would be unimaginably powerful. He did not dare judge the youth by age alone.

Ah, the Cave of Latent Demons was held some time ago.

Un-Un suddenly recalled some rumors about the most recent Cave of Latent Demons. And now looking at how young the members of the Charred Dragon Unit seemed, he speculated that they must be the rumored trainees.

At this moment, the youth called out to the lieutenant.

“Give the branch manager to another member.”

Gwan Tae-ryang did not question the orders and called over another person. Another member approached them and carried the man away.

“What is it?”

Instead of answering, Woon-seong turned towards the rest of the unit, “The Charred Dragon Unit will continue to move in this direction. Baek Woon-ji, from now on you are in charge. After two hours, if I do not join up with you at the rendezvous point, go straight back to the Cult. “

Baek Woon-ji’s eyes shook for a moment, but she could only agree.
“Understood.”

“Gwan Tae-ryang, you follow me.” Upon hearing Baek Woon-ji’s answer, Woon-seong turned and talked to his lieutenant. “We have pursuers.”

Woon-seong had sensed them around fifteen minutes ago. Thanks to his strength, his senses were sharp.

The problem is that it looks like they know our route.

He would have understood if the guards had been chasing them from the get go. But to prevent that, Woon-seong had schemed the set-up of disguising

themselves as guards.

After all, the Orthodox branch had already noticed their scouts. Especially when dealing with people like the First Apprentice, it was easiest to use their own plans against them.

Woon-seong had also made the judgement that in case they got caught, it would be better to fight inside the branch than out in the open.

The First Apprentice had obviously also come to this conclusion, since he had gathered the troops to trap the Charred Dragon Unit inside the branch.

As far as Woon-seong had noticed, no one had followed them out.

In addition, the Charred Dragon Unit had changed their path several times in order to shake off potential pursuers.

Yet, they're still tracking us accurately. Since we never made direct contact with them, they must have done something to the branch manager.

Woon-seong could guess what the tail was.

Scent tracking.

[1] As a reminder, the Demonic General class is not fixed, so the number and abilities vary. At this point, Gwan Tae-ryang is confirmed as Demonic General class, but we don't know where in the rankings he stands. Based on the fact that barely any time has passed since they graduated the Cave, everyone else is still only a Demonic Captain.

Chapter 43: Followed (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 43 – Followed (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Even though the Charred Dragon Unit kept changing paths, their pursuers were still right on their heels. This meant that the pursuers were likely following some sort of odor, which you would be unable to wash off.

Woon-seong sighed to himself. *In the end, conflict cannot be avoided.*

The youth gripped the spear in his hand as he stood in the clearing with Gwan Tae-ryang. The pursuers seemed to be getting closer. There was an expression of impatience colored by tension on his face, muscles tensing in anticipation.

Woon-seong was ready to fight.

The first thing that he did was to take off the iron rings on his arms. Heavy iron rings fell to the floor with a ‘thud’. Along with a sense of liberation, his power dramatically increased.

The pursuers were even closer now, visible a few meters from the entrance of the clearing.

Woon-seong had a wide smile on his face as he welcomed them, revealing his fangs to the fullest. His eyes, staring at the enemy, burned with hatred and fighting spirit.

Woon-seong mentally patted himself on the back. *It was a good thing you decided to deal with them here.*

The pursuers had been right behind them.

Fighting them off while protecting General Manager Un-Un would have resulted in significant casualties for the Charred Dragon Unit.

The First Apprentice stops here.

As soon as Woon-seong brandished his spear, the First Apprentice and the Sword of Heaven stepped out into the clearing.

“Branch Manager Tang, you’ll continue to pursue the rest of the dogs,” the First Apprentice ordered.

“I understand.”

The First Apprentice flicked his hand and the group began to move, now led by Branch Manager Tang.

Gwan Tae-ryang tried to stop them from leaving.

“Enough.”

Woon-seong stopped this movement though.

That was only a group of six average warriors and one little branch manager.

Even considering Un-Un’s condition, Baek Woon-ji and the rest of the squad could take care of them without a problem.

But not these two.

“The First Apprentice and the Sword of Heaven must stop here.”

Gwan Tae-ryang nodded in understanding.

Meanwhile, several warriors, including the branch manager, passed by the two. Soon, the only ones left in the clearing were the First Apprentice, the Sword of Heaven, Woon-seong, and Gwan Tae-ryang.

The First Apprentice glanced at the remaining two and opened his mouth with a sneer. “Hmmm. You have some sharp fangs for a dog of the Cult.”

At that, Woon-seong reached out with his spear, wearing a shit-eating grin.

“A dog of the Cult? If so, I feel bad that you’re going to have ‘bitten by a dog’ written as your cause of death. Also, you must have terrible insight to call a tiger a dog. I’m surprised they gave you such a high position, old fart.”

The eyes of the First Apprentice trembled. He couldn’t help the anger that rose from the blatant provocation. “How dare you say that, you little demonic brat.” He barely managed to suppress his anger and swung his sword, causing energy to arc towards Woon-seong.

Well, it has been ten years, Woon-seong sighed to himself. At least he learned not to fall for such provocation. I remember him as an idiot being fooled every time I provoked him...

But you have no idea. At this point, it’s not you who is suppressing the most anger. It’s me.

Woon-seong’s anger made him cold. He kept talking to the First Apprentice, “But what on earth were you doing in Xinjiang?”

Energy from Woon-seong hit the sword of the First Apprentice, smacking it off course.

Looking to the side, the clash between the Lieutenant and the Sword of Heaven had already begun. According to Woon-seong’s calculations, Gwan Tae-ryang and the Sword of Heaven were evenly matched in both strength and skill. It was obvious that it would not be an easy fight.

He might not win, but at least that will keep them busy.

In the meantime, the First Apprentice was deeply shaken by Woon-seong's question. Speaking of Xinjiang, the only thing that came to his mind was the Sandstorm of Death and the Sword of Men. But how did the Demonic Cult know of this?

“What...?”

That question was soon resolved by the next words of the youth.

“The Sandstorm of Death. You sent your apprentice to raise them.”

“Did you meet our youngest?”

Woon-seong nodded noncommittally. “I asked a question first. What were you trying to do with them?”

“You really met the youngest!” It was as if the First Apprentice had been hit by a bolt of lightning as his mind suddenly jolted. He remembered that news from the Sword of Men had been cut off recently!

The strength flowing through the First Apprentice's body increased, his aura growing sharper than the sword in his hand.

Heavenly Sword Unification! So he wasn't wasting all those years, Woon-seong mused.

With the appearance of high-level sword comprehension, Woon-seong worried that one more iron ring had to be taken off, but soon shook his head. Just as his enemy had grown, so had he.

The First Apprentice charged with all the momentum of a raging bull. “What did you do with the youngest?”

In response, the youth bolted forward like lightning and swung his spear. “It seems you don't intend to talk. Since that's not the only thing I'm going to ask you, I'll start by cutting all your limbs off. ”

Boom!

The spear and sword clashed and fierce waves of energy swept the area.

It was good that Woon-seong had chosen a clearing, otherwise they might have leveled half the forest!

‘High qi’ was a symbol of reaching the level of Transcendence, but how many martial artists in the world could actually use high qi? There were less than fifty in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, so there should be less than fifty in the Martial Society.

What about the First Apprentice?

The First Apprentice is Transcendence-level, but cannot fully use high qi, Woon-seong concluded after a few exchanges.

The First Apprentice had more inner qi within his dantian than Woon-seong did. Being a man from Qingcheng, the quality of the qi was also naturally very pure.

Luckily, in his past life, Woon-seong had also reached Transcendence-level. Therefore his insight into this realm was no less than that of the First Apprentice. Actually, it was probably more mature!

Still...

It's definitely strong.

The Sword of the Blue Clouds and Red Sunset.

Named after the sights seen on Mount Qingcheng, it was the unique ‘Sword of the Blue Clouds and Sunset’ that allowed the Qingcheng Sect to stand at the top of Murim.

The skills of someone who had practiced this powerful sword art for decades could not be underestimated.

The sword of the First Apprentice moved quickly, flashing towards Woon-seong's neck. A blue cloud rose in its wake, forming clumps of qi that battered the youth from all sides.

Fluffy clouds on a beautiful spring day? More like roof tiles flung off during a windstorm!

Woon-seong hastily retreated, stretching his spear out to scatter the clouds.

Without giving the youth any time to rest, the First Apprentice's sword zipped back around, executing the next sword movement, sword aura now emanating a red glow.

As the sun fell and the sunset spread across the skies, the sword seemed to embody suppression by the Heavens and fell down heavily, causing waves of qi burst forth everywhere.

Kua-kua-kua-kau!

The clearing was turned upside down as the soil, sand, and tree roots were flung into the air.

Woon-seong nimbly avoided the attack.

He may have insufficient strength, but he had already experienced this sword style before!

Let's think about it a little bit more.

Woon-seong swung his spear, judging the situation even more seriously.

Should he use the 'Divine Spear of the Ending Night' or the 'Art of Six Seals and Destruction'?

The former was more suitable for fighting against the sword arts of Qingcheng. But the situation was not truly advantageous for the First Apprentice yet. Given the rough stalemate, Woon-seong was not willing to risk an identity leak.

I've experienced the Sword of the Blue Clouds and Red Sunset before, but it's the other way around for him. Also, I have more than one weapon.

At the same time, the eyes of the youth were stained with gold, as a muddy energy spread out through his body. Woon-seong was unleashing his ‘intimidation qi’!

Hiss—

The First Apprentice recoiled as the silent energy surrounded him. *What the hell is this?* The moment he touched the energy, just for a brief moment, his heart had fluttered with fear. Goosebumps rose on his skin.

Looking at this, Woon-seong grumbled in frustration. *It’s still not good enough.*

The mind breaking capabilities of the ‘intimidation qi’ was still not as effective as he thought they would be against Orthodox martial artists. Currently, it was barely able to make them flinch. In order to deal with his enemies, there would be many things he needed to fix.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly. He had thought he was very strong, but it was now apparent that he still had a long way to go.

“You damn demonic brat! How dare you use some vile spell!”

The First Apprentice pushed through the barrier of spear aura and ‘intimidation qi’, striking at the youth’s shoulder.

The strike did not completely land, but Woon-seong’s shoulder began to bleed. The cheap, borrowed pauldrons could not stand the blow and became shredded scraps of metal.

However, Woon-seong did not moan once. Instead, he just clicked his tongue.

Tsk. I knew they would be worse than ones made from black iron, but they’re shit. Fucking useless.

Woon-seong’s eyes deepened. He remembered what the First Apprentice had just called him and spoke with a chilling voice, “I’m no brat. I’m a

Great Demon. I'm a demonic practitioner who is one of the few who has achieved the rank of a Great Demon."

"Don't spew bullshit! I don't care what rank you are! Nothing changes the fact that you're a vile demonic practitioner!"

A violent offensive came over.

Woon-seong defended himself under this pressure, avoiding the wisps of sword aura sharply piercing towards his body. There were no fatal wounds, but small scrapes appeared here and there.

"Khh!"

Woon-seong dodged to the side, but the First Apprentice was one step faster.

"Hmph."

As soon as Woon-seong side-stepped, the First Apprentice was already waiting for him. Sword already outstretched, the First Apprentice easily delivered a strong strike straight to the chest.

Puchi—

Woon-seong spat out a mouthful of blood on the spot.

"Hurgh."

He staggered back, barely escaping the offensive, but was inevitably injured. Woon-seong raised his hand and wiped the blood from his mouth, glaring at the other.

Meanwhile, the First Apprentice slowly approached the youth.

With a graceful movement, a few throwing knives and some needles were thrown towards the First Apprentice.

Woon-seong's lightning stitching throwing knives!

But it was no use.

Ding, ding, ding—

The First Apprentice smacked them right back towards Woon-seong and sarcastically complimented, “Oh, you’re so skillful!”

This is definitely hard.

Should he take off another bracer? Or even two? Temptation rose in Woon-seong’s heart, but he shook his head. He had suffered a lot of injuries, but not yet. He wouldn’t die yet, so he could still win. Overcoming this battle meant he would be one step further.

For his revenge!

The youth raised his energy. With conviction, his strength flowed out to his limbs. Although his spear trembled as if it recognized and welcomed the energy, Woon-seong did not notice at all.

“Die!”

The sword of the First Apprentice ripped through the place where Woon-seong had stood a moment ago.

Kuah!

The sword carved deep furrows into the ground, one after another, as it chased after the youth.

Woon-seong avoided them all, but suffered several injuries. The most serious was one on his thigh.

This is not good, Woon-seong thought as he quickly staunched the deep gash.

As if the First Apprentice knew Woon-seong was in pain, he shouted excitedly, “Let’s see how far you can escape, you rat!”

At that point, Woon-seong breathed out a deep breath, as if he had finally made up his mind about something.

After hearing those words, Woon-seong suddenly realized he'd made a mistake.

Storm-like strikes once again engulfed his body.

But this time, Woon-seong reacted differently.

He did not back down.

He really had been scurrying around like a rat.

I can't get revenge by running away.

The path towards the summit required a different mindset.

He needed to take a risk to achieve his goal. The First Apprentice could hurt him, scathe his flesh. But in exchange, the man would die today!

Woon-seong's energy increased once more, spurred by his determination. It flowed into the spear as he prepared for a big move. At that moment, the Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night glowed with a bright light. Hundreds of letters flowed into his mind, but didn't form coherent sentences.

Then someone's voice soaked into Woon-seong's ears.

'That's not how you do it.'

Spear in his hands, that shining light transformed into a dragon.

Chapter 44: Flow Of The Divine Dragon (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 44 – Flow of the Divine Dragon (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The resulting flash of light was dizzying.

A spear swelled from within.

The First Apprentice mumbled without realizing, “The Divine Dragon Flows In?”

Fwoo—

With that, the spear cut off one arm of the First Apprentice. The detached left arm of the man soared into the air. At the same time, the blood spouted out like a fountain and the First Apprentice screamed.

“Ahhhhh!”

That was him being dragged through the fiery depths of hell, turning into a dreg of human life. Screams of unbearable pain ripped through the air!

The ‘Sword of Heaven’ Lee Gum-han shouted in surprise at the sound, still some distance away.

“Master!”

He wielded his sword to scatter the offensive he was facing, trying to run towards the First Apprentice. However, Gwan Tae-ryang did not give him the chance to do so.

“No way!”

Lee Gum-han lifted his sword and stopped the attack of the Lieutenant. He grit his teeth to fend off the attack and the incoming energy. The sound of metal hitting metal rang. He was clearly very strong, but his opponent was also formidable.

In addition, the situation had changed due to an injury.

This was a chance for Gwan Tae-ryang to seize victory!

The Lieutenant continued to attack without missing a beat.

‘Echoing Blades of the Lost Soul’

A startling offensive like the hands of Yama [1] aimed at the Sword of Heaven, irrational and unstoppable. Blitz after blitz fell one after another.

Boom, boom!

“Grrrgh!”

The attack tore through his defenses.

Lee Gum-han faltered and stepped back.

“What the hell?!”

Lee Gum-han could only curse within his heart seeing the appearance of the Lieutenant who followed him. It was alright for his opponent to be unafraid of death, but to charge forward with minimal defense?

Terrifying. Are all the demonic people like this?

Lee Gum-han, who had never fought with someone of the Demonic Cult, had thoughts like this.

In reality, his thoughts were half right and half wrong. Most of the demonic people were like that. The doctrine of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, which was based on Xinjiang's barren environment and 'survival of the fittest', made them so.

Of course, not all of them were so unafraid of death.

There were only certain people who were committed to this path. And the people of the Cave of Latent Demons were just some of them.

To practitioners like Gwan Tae-ryang, death was familiar. The Cave of Latent Demons, after all, was a place where a thousand people went in and fewer than a hundred people walked out.

"For the past decade I've learned. How to kill someone, how weak you need to be to die, and how much you have to break someone to kill them! Someone like *you* cannot kill me!"

The dark sword that was swung towards Gwan Tae-ryang was clearly deadly, to the extent it caused him to feel his skin prickling.

But it was not enough to feel death.

Hell is spread out in front of you. If you don't go in, you're still alive. Death was more sour than flesh falling alone in the cold — life was little more than dancing on the knife's edge.

Fight, kill, survive.

There was no 'what doesn't kill you makes you stronger' compassionate lesson to be learned, only a harsh rule of survival.

Only the strong survive.

The Cave of Latent Demons and the demonic practitioners it produced, including Gwan Tae-ryang, were produced from such a truth.

My first time against the Captain was more terrifying than this!

Reminiscing of the days of life and death, Gwan Tae-ryang once again confronted Lee Gum-han.

Boom!

While Gwan Tae-ryang was dealing with his opponent, an unknown voice continued to infiltrate the ears of Woon-seong.

Through the spear in his hand, words flowed into his head.

“Heir of the path of the Spear Master. I shan’t ask why you are part of the Cult. However, take in what I have left behind.”

Words from the Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night came to mind in glowing letters.

“I had also once devoted my life to the path of the Spear Master. This is my legacy to an apprentice of the future. Take the spear as a whole and stand strong on top of the world!”

Some words were added to the head of the youth. As if it was a thunderbolt, it crushed him in a moment. In the midst of the flow though, the voice was not yet finished.

“I am the Unrecorded. This is a present from I, the forgotten, to the heir of our Sect!”

At the same time, an unfamiliar energy settled into the youth’s body.

Weng!

Soon, Woon-seong returned to reality.

What just happened?

After such an unfamiliar and mysterious experience, Woon-seong unknowingly covered his face with his hands.

He groaned.

There were still a lot of passages in his head. It was straining his consciousness to assimilate all the new knowledge.

In addition to the unfamiliar energy, what happened just now was clearly not a dream.

It was too vivid to be a dream, but too unreal to say it was not.

Woon-seong was quite confused.

“Agh!”

The First Apprentice screamed in pain, freeing the youth from the chaos.

Woon-seong slowly raised his head.

Oh yeah, there's still him.

The First Apprentice had lost an arm, but he was still an enemy.

I need to break the enemy thoroughly.

Any worries about this surreal hallucination were to be postponed.

He grabbed his spear.

The First Apprentice, who had just lost an arm, was no longer the opponent of the youth. He had stopped the bleeding, but it was no good. Not only had he lost a lot of blood, the balance of his body had collapsed. In such a situation, it was impossible for him to even block successfully.

As if to prove this, the right leg of the First Apprentice was cut off less than ten seconds later.

“Augh!”

Five seconds later, the left ankle was severed. Blood spewed out like a fountain, and the man writhed on the ground in pain.

Woon-seong walked slowly towards the man. The First Apprentice tried to stop the youth, but could only swing the sword with his left arm. The moment it collided with Woon-seong's spear, it was over.

Crack!

Half of the sword was shattered into pieces, the other half was sent flying into the air.

A late pain came from the limb that was cut off, causing the First Apprentice to moan. "Ugh."

"Master!" Lee Gum-han shouted for his master once more.

But if things could be changed only by moaning and shouting, the past Woon-seong and Master Nok Yu would not have died.

So Woon-seong approached the one-armed man, aiming the spear at his neck. With it hovering under his chin, the First Apprentice could only tremble.

The youth glanced backwards. Gwan Tae-ryang looked like he was going insane against the Sword of Heaven.

They won't be able to hear us. Woon-seong confirmed this and wet his lips.

"Now tell me. Why was your disciple wandering around with the bandits in Xinjiang?"

The First Apprentice responded with a growl, "Do you really think I would tell you?"

'I will not talk even if all my limbs have been cut'.

Woon-seong laughed at that resolution. "Let's see how long you last."

In Woon-seong's eyes, the First Apprentice was a dragon without its limbs — in other words, a worm.

“What?”

Woon-seong used his fingers to tap on some acupuncture points, causing extreme pain to flood the First Apprentice's body. His bones twisted, muscles shredded, and fire ants seemed to gnaw at his blood vessels.

The man rolled on the floor, screaming.

“Arrrgh!”

But the pain only got worse.

The Sword of Heaven once again screamed for his master, but he could do nothing.

After some time, Woon-seong tapped some more acupuncture points and the pain disappeared.

“Huff, huff, huff.”

Nevertheless, the First Apprentice's breathing was rough and painful.

Looking down at him coldly, Woon-seong opened his mouth.

“Tell me now. What was your disciple doing there?”

“....”

Woon-seong shook his head once when he was met with silence. He moved his hand and harshly slapped the First Apprentice. “Let me change my question.”

He lowered his head and whispered something into the other's ear.

The First Apprentice's eyes bulged in shock, “How do you know that?!”

At this exclamation, the eyes of the youth deepened by themselves. If looks could kill, the First Apprentice would have died on the spot.

“So it was a false accusation. Why did you falsely accuse the Spear Master Sect of Learning Demonic Arts?”

I knew Master wasn't learning some forbidden demonic art.

Obviously, Woon-seong had asked about the fall of the Spear Master Sect and the First Apprentice's lack of composure was a dead giveaway.

“How did you...No, how are you related to the Spear Master Sect?”

“...”

“Could you be a disciple of the sect? No way. Obviously he died that day...”

Woon-seong did not answer the question. There was no need or reason to explain his rebirth by fate to a dead man. In addition, his appearance was very different now compared to what it used to be. The soul was the same but the body was different.

Woon-seong wasn't about to tell the First Apprentice something so useless — the man obviously wasn't going to find out by himself either.

During the silence, the First Apprentice blabbered like a lunatic as he flailed about with his sword. “Why? Who are you? What happened...”

Looking at him, Woon-seong could see that the end was not far. Blood flowed from the broken limbs and was driving the other to his death. He was losing time and he needed answers.

“Who was it? Who framed the two people of the Spear Master Sect?”

At this question, the First Apprentice laughed instead of answering. Feeling uncomfortable, Woon-seong made a scratch on the other's cheek.

“If you do not speak, I will kill you horribly. Giving you all the pain possible before your death!”

Woon-seong did not say that he would spare the other; the First Apprentice had to die today.

Normally, unwillingness to die gruesomely would be enough to for a person to admit all of their sins.

However, the First Apprentice’s response was unexpected.

“No matter what you ask, there’s nothing you can find out from me.” As Woon-seong’s expression twitched, the man continued with an increasingly faint voice, “Whatever happens here, the fact that I will die does not change.”

At that, Woon-seong felt cold sweat dripping down his neck. He had understood the implication of those words. “If you don’t tell me here, would you die painfully?”

“...”

I’m here trying to intimidate you with a painful death, but you refuse to open your mouth! That only meant one thing: death today was better than staying alive to die later.

He’d rather die by my hands than be killed by his supposed allies... For him to be so afraid... Who the hell is behind this?

Woon-seong stared at the crumpled form of the man, but the First Apprentice refused to speak.

Master, what on earth did you do for you to be framed by these people?

Woon-seong had seen the First Apprentice several times and understood how the man worked. If he was behind this scheme, he would have opened his mouth.

But right now, the man was silent.

Is it the Imperial Palace?

Woon-seong did not even want to think of that.

Then, he asked one final question, almost as a plea, “I’ll ask for the last time. Answer at least one of the questions I have asked!”

The only response to this was more silence — the First Apprentice even closed his eyes.

It was a clear statement: I will not answer whatever you have asked.

In aggravation, Woon-seong swung his spear.

Fwoo—

Blood sprayed from the man’s neck like a fountain.

Without a sound, the First Apprentice had died.

“Master!” The Sword of Heaven cried out in anguish.

Everything was getting more complicated, problems were multiplying.

But one of the enemies Woon-seong needed to kill was dead.

Good, that was another one down.

[1] Yama is the Buddhist deity of death and the Underworld. It is said that once you have received an invitation from Yama, you are destined to die within ten breaths of time.

Chapter 45: Flow Of The Divine Dragon (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 45 – Flow of the Divine Dragon (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

I didn't find anything out. Damn it.

Woon-seong sighed, feeling uneasy.

But hey, it wasn't like there was nothing at all.

He pulled his little booklet out and crossed out the name of the First Apprentice with blood.

~~First Apprentice, Song Chi-hak.~~

That was another one down.

“Cou-aghh!”

No, that would be two.

~~Sword of Heaven, Lee Gum-han.~~

Along with a single scream, the Sword of Heaven fell too. After a desperate struggle, his lieutenant had won.

“Huff, huff.”

Gwan Tae-ryang breathed heavily and was still unable to recover after some time. His clothes were covered in blood. How much of it was his own?

“You must be tired,” Woon-seong said as he put the booklet back into his pockets.

The Lieutenant wiped his sweat off with a sleeve and asked, “He was strong. Is this the level of the elder apprentices in the Orthodox sects?”

Woon-seong shook his head. “Lee Gum-han was a little old for an elder apprentice. The Qingcheng have a slower pace in their change of generations. He’s practically equivalent to the elders of the Ten Great Sects.”

An elder of the Ten Great Sects! Every one of those people had great status in the Martial Alliance — the Sword of Heaven did too, though he was still technically considered part of the younger generation.

Barely over the age of twenty, Gwan Tae-ryang had now defeated one of those elders. His countenance brightened considerably.

Though he could only be considered one of the youngest of the elders, of course.

Woon-seong kept that thought to himself; there was no need to ruin a good mood.

The Lieutenant spoke again, “What do we do with these bodies?”

The body and combat trails were an important clue when tracking. The Charred Dragon Unit, including Woon-seong, were still in Sichuan. This place was deep into Martial territory, so it was best not to leave clues.

The Lieutenant had some ideas of his own. “Should we use the Bone Burning Acid?”

Just like its name suggested, the Bone Burning Acid melted people without leaving a single bone behind. It could not be used in combat because it took more than a day to do its job, but it was the best at getting rid of bodies.

Ordinarily, Woon-seong would have suggested this as well.

But not now.

“Have you forgotten where we are?”

At these words, there was a slight murmur of realization. They were located in Zhongyuan, in the middle of the Martial Alliance’s territory!

Most importantly, it was Sichuan.

“In Sichuan is the Sichuan Tang Clan.”

If this family sent out their forces in pursuit, especially the Servants of Poison, the Bone Burning Acid would only be a clue to their location and identity.

“Then what should we do?”

Woon-seong swung the spear in his hand.

Kuakuakua-

He may have had some internal injuries, but his strength was still enough to carve out a large circle of fallen trees.

“With this, it will be hard to know if one or two people fought.”

In order to figure out the mess, the Martial Alliance would need to send someone skilled in tracing and trained martial arts, not a poison master. By the time someone like that arrived, the Charred Dragon Unit would be long gone.

Woon-seong then turned back towards the bodies, nudging them with the tip of his spear.

“Compared to the decapitated First Apprentice, it will be easier to move the Sword of Heaven.”

Gwan Tae-ryang listened and carried the corpse of the man on his back. It was sometimes hard to guess what was on the mind of his captain, but he didn't ask.

“Let's meet up with the rest of the unit.”

Every time Woon-seong's foot hit the ground, the wind caught in his ears. The sky was brightening after the raid, which had taken place just before sunrise.

We need to get out of Sichuan.

Suddenly, the steps of the boy sped up. He had internal injuries, but he was still extremely swift.

“Huh?”

As the boy had darted forward in an instant, Gwan Tae-ryang had momentarily fallen behind. But soon he increased his speed and caught up.

“Tell me if you want to speed up next time,” muttered the Lieutenant.

Woon-seong didn't pay him any attention, closing his eyes as he thought.

What was that before? I still feel the trembling from the White Night Spear. The force and sound that flew in through the spear.

The Unrecorded. He was a part of the Spear Master Sect. The one who made the marvelous 'Six Seals and Destruction'...Literally unrecorded in any texts. I don't know why he was called that in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong slowly opened his eyes.

But one thing I know for sure is that he did leave a record behind. In the White Night Spear!

The Unrecorded most likely could not have anticipated that an apprentice of the Spear Master Sect would follow his footsteps and join the Demonic Cult. Perhaps he thought the bearer of the spear would leave the Cult instead, tracing his path back to the Spear Master Sect.

Who knows.

What was certain was that Hyuk Woon-seong had inherited what was left behind.

A great cultivation skill and the seed sprouting inside me.

The Unrecorded, who had studied martial arts for many years, had handed down all he knew. It was a seed, a seed that would transform into a great tree once the knowledge was truly understood.

That's not all.

In addition to that, the energy that led his hands when he was considering taking off another iron ring.

Thanks to it, I completed a skill.

Woon-seong had been able to completely combine the Six Seals and the Ending Night for the first time. His efforts had finally borne fruit.

At the same time, he was full of admiration. Respect for the senior who walked this path of martial arts first and reached such a high point.

Even though the Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night was a divine weapon, it was still just a weapon in the end.

The Unrecorded had been able to leave his will in a mere object. This was something that was only possible after achieving the level beyond that of a semi-divine being, a true deity!

Such a person never achieved the title of Spearmaster.

I don't know what happened at the time. But one thing for sure is that to leave his own will in an item, he has to have transcended beyond the abilities of a mere human.

Once you were a semi-divine being, you stood at the boundary between human and god. [1]

But a divine being? You were basically a god!

A legendary status that only a few throughout the entire history of martial arts had achieved.

It was speculated that not more than three Heavenly Demons had entered the Divine realm since the creation of the Cult.

Someone like that was from my sect!

This proved that the spear arts he practiced could reach the Divine stage.

Woon-seong might have fist-pumped if he wasn't still running through Sichuan.

What was more fortunate was not just this hope. He also learned the name of the skill.

Though it could be ascribed to the Unrecorded's will, Woon-seong had indeed finished the fusion. With that, it was time for him to choose a proper name.

Busy completing the mission and without a completed skill to see, Woon-seong hadn't thought hard about a name.

Things were different now.

Actually, it apparently already had a name.

When the First Apprentice had seen the move, he had said, "*Divine Dragon Flows In.*" Seeing that it really did look like a dragon, Woon-seong took some inspiration from the Orthodox.

'Flow of the Divine Dragon' (神龙流水).

The Lieutenant opened his mouth at this time, "There's the crew."

Like he said, the Charred Dragon Unit were gazing at the landscape as the pair arrived. The previous pursuers were already bloody piles upon the ground.

They did it, of course.

The Charred Dragon Unit members may all be weaker than Woon-seong, but everyone was famous for having excellent skills in the Divine Cult. The unit would not fall into the hands of a few blind defenders and a mere branch manager.

Woon-seong smiled satisfactorily.

The White Night Spear, the connection with the Unrecorded, the completion of the skill, naming said skill. Confidence in the abilities of the Charred Dragon Unit!

...And my contribution within the Cult.

I've gained a lot in this mission.

Now they just needed to leave Sichuan and report back to the Cult.

I see the end, though it's only the end of this mission.

My revenge has only just begun.

The young man still had many names to erase.

He charged forward, heading towards the bright light of the rising sun just beyond the mountains.

"What are we going to do with these guys?"

As their captain and lieutenant arrived, the Charred Dragon Unit laid the bodies in one place. The corpse of the Sword of Heaven was soon added.

They all understood the need to get rid of the clues.

“Should we use the Bone Melting Acid?”

One of the unit members asked the same question as the Lieutenant, and funnily enough, Gwan Tae-ryang took the initiative to answer.

Shaking his head, Gwan Tae-ryang lectured, “This is the realm of the Sichuan Tang. If you use poison, you would still somehow be tracked down.”

Woon-seong snickered as he watched Gwan Tae-ryang speak, imitating himself from a while before.

“His words are correct. Gather the fast ones in the unit. They will carry the bodies of the dead.”

“What are you planning to do?”

“We’ll use some people and have them drop the bodies a few distances apart.”

“Ah!”

Gwan Tae-ryang and Baek Woon-ji simultaneously cried out in understanding.

The corpses were traces of battle. But if they were spread out, it would be hard to trace anything if all the clues were all over the place.

“It would also help if we left signs of combat around those places.”

Woon-seong nodded at Baek Woon-ji’s words. “Inform the members where to meet and let the rest of the Charred Dragons head back.”

With those orders, the group got to work. “Yes, sir!”

[1] Previously, the ‘Enter God Realm’ (入神境) was the Divine Realm, but will now be the Semi-Divine Realm. Above that is the ‘God Fusion Realm’ (神和境), which was previously the Mythical/Mystical Realm, and will be corrected to the Divine Realm.

Chapter 46: Back To The Cult (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 46 – Back to the Cult (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Tak-

“So that is what happened.”

Cheon Hwi put down the report in his hand. It was related to the Orthodox factions.

“The secret vault of the ‘Sword Emperor of Ice and Light’...”

According to the report he had just read, rumors about the secret vault were causing chaos within Zhongyuan. The Sword Emperor of Ice and Light was an invincible martial artist from 500 years ago. Unparalleled at the time, his sword skills were still considered legendary to this day.

Knowledge about his vault was enough to cause commotion in Murim, including within the Cult. It was to the extent that there was talk about moving the Cult to investigate in secret.

“What do you think, Senior Strategist?”

“It is a fake.”

The Senior Strategist’s words were decisive.

In response, Cheon Hwi motioned for him to explain.

“If the secret vault of the ‘Sword Emperor of Ice and Light’ was really discovered, the word should have spread silently. But this one is spreading very quickly. Too quickly.”

“Someone is spreading the word on purpose.”

The Senior Strategist nodded. “Someone is trying to make the factions fight each other. ‘If you really want the vault, fight for it.’ I say it is best not to get involved.”

There was no need to get tangled in unnecessary battles.

The Heavenly Demon was thinking the same thing.

“An objective perspective, I see... It looks like residing in the barren lands outside of Zhongyuan helps in times like this.”

The Senior Strategist only bowed in response.

The Heavenly Demon took his gaze off the Senior Strategist and picked up a new report, reading over it silently. As he finished the report, he started to lightly chuckle.

“Huh, I have not heard such pleasant news in a while...”

The Strategist was surprised by the Leader’s happiness, as it was not often for him to show such surprise. That was the Heavenly Demon! He had seen many geniuses and walked the path of success.

In this situation, the delighted surprise was marginal, but still very rare.

“The Charred Dragon Unit has fulfilled its mission.”

Cheon Hwi chewed over the contents of the mission again, slowly.

It was not the most difficult task to give to one of the Twelve Supporting Units, but it was also no easy feat.

According to the report, there were some unexpected variables, namely those from the Qingcheng Sect.

However, the Charred Dragon Unit had accomplished its mission brilliantly. Not only had they successfully saved Branch Manager Un-un, they had also destroyed more than half the personnel of the Martial Branch. All those that had come running after them were finished off too — even the Swords of Qingcheng and Orthodox branch manager.

This was an unexpected result, especially for a mission at the heart of the Martial Alliance.

Even more surprising was the planning of the entry and escape.

So brilliant that it makes me doubt if this is an individual who spent half of his life in the Cave of Latent Demons.

The Senior Strategist thought about the report too, remembering its contents. It had been quite surprising. The new captain, Hyuk Woon-seong seemed like someone with experience in the world of Murim.

“There was not a single death on our side in the process...”

Even with the secret vault, this was still a dazzling accomplishment.

Cheon Hwi asked his supervisor quietly, “How many children have shown such achievements?”

Instead of answering the question, the Strategist lowered his head.

That was a rhetorical question — the answer was absolutely none.

A young man who had achieved something like this would not appear for decades.

No, it would be hard to find someone similar if you turned both the Cult and the Alliance upside down.

“Not bad.”

The Strategist's eyes deepened. *Does the Leader like this child named Hyuk Woon-seong?*

"I wonder how much this child will surprise me."

That answered it.

Obviously, the Heavenly Demon was fond of this young man named Hyuk Woon-seong.

Twenty years old. Strong enough to become a Great Demon, leading the Charred Dragon Unit.

Soon, Hyuk Woon-seong would catch the attention of the entire Cult.

By then, if the successor had not been appointed... Now that this young man had caught the Heavenly Demon's eye, it was very likely he would become the Young Leader.

"Let us set up a stage. It was about time to do some replacement anyway."

The Senior Strategist did not speak of his thoughts. It was the Heavenly Demon who would appoint his successor. There was no need for him to choose between this young man or the Young Lady.

I will continue to help my master accomplish what he wants.

"Prepare the 'Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame'."

The Cult Leader's voice echoed across the palace.

Krak-

A sword and a spear collided, sparks flying. The surroundings were burnt to a crisp or thrown upside down, flung into the air.

An impregnable sword wall. A spear that could pierce through everything under the Heavens.

A fierce battle took place outside of reality, in the mind of Woon-seong.

“Hmm.”

He was still processing the battle with the First Apprentice. He had gained an epiphany about the Flow of the Divine Dragon, but his opponent had still been strong.

Woon-seong's unexpected power-up had startled the First Apprentice, giving Woon-seong the chance to cut an arm off. If the First Apprentice had been more prepared, the fight would have been even harder.

Thankfully, the gap between the two was gradually decreasing.

The first simulation took about 300 seconds. Now, Woon-seong had shaved off a good 100 seconds.

I will need some proper training to further decrease the time.

Woon-seong already knew where he wanted to go, since the harder the training area, the better. After all, martial artists became stronger through adversity.

I just hope I'll be allowed to.

It was likely that he would be rewarded for completing this mission safely. If it was possible for him to choose his reward, he would ask.

I really hope so.

But, he couldn't help it if it didn't work. Even if he was given a reward, the final say was not his.

You're not in bad shape, so if you keep trying, you'll get results no matter what.

He opened his eyes and checked his condition, the gold light in his eyes fading.

It seemed that the internal injuries inflicted during the battle had healed.

Glancing to the side, Woon-seong saw the Charred Dragon Unit. Despite spending the night in the mountains, the unit had only just started the fire.

He then turned to look at his lieutenant. Gwan Tae-ryang had also suffered some minor injuries. Fortunately, most wounds seemed to have healed. Internal injuries... Well, those would heal with time too.

Next to the Lieutenant, Branch Manager Un-un sat with his back against a tree stump. He hadn't bled much, but the fatigue of prison could not be underestimated. This man would be returning with them, as he could no longer serve in Sichuan now that his face was known.

Woon-seong looked at the fire. He was ordered to return to the headquarters of the Demonic Cult in Xinjiang, which was now about five days away.

Even if there had been no trackers so far, they should still move more carefully. Nothing was irreversible and mistakes happened when you were careless.

Still, it is a bit suspicious that there's been nothing so far.

He had used many tricks to slow down any pursuers, including scattering the bodies and constantly changing course.

Why is there no one after us?

He had guessed a few reasons.

One of them was that the troops had been gathering for an all out attack, which was the worst possible outcome.

But it doesn't seem like that.

Several members had been sent to a nearby village to procure supplies. They had returned with nothing to say about pursuers altogether. Rather, they spoke of rumors that something big had happened in Murim.

It was likely the discovery of a divine treasure; even if a gold mine was found, it wouldn't cause so much commotion.

Either way, it didn't matter to Woon-seong. He just got lucky.

When I hear such news, it feels like the Heavens are helping me.

The more the Alliance was focused on that side, the easier it would be for him to leave.

If the rumors keep spreading, we might be able to get out of Sichuan safely.

Just before the sun came up, it was time to move again.

Maybe it really was because of the rumors, but the Charred Dragon Unit was able to leave Sichuan without encountering another problem.

Just as quickly, they also passed through Qinghai, reaching Xinjiang.

Xinjiang was the realm of the demonic. Here, they could travel at full speed without care.

The Charred Dragon Unit sped up as soon as they stepped upon Cult soil.

It was an unconscious decision. It was only natural to speed up once there were no dangers and your heart yearned for home.

Nevertheless, they weren't tired at all. Unlike in the mountains, when resting, they could eat and sleep properly too.

By the tenth day, they had arrived at the headquarters.

The first thing they did was to head to the Charred Dragon House.

Technically, they should have reported their mission's success as soon as possible, but they wished to tidy themselves up before visiting the Divine Palace.

The Heavenly Demon obviously thought otherwise.

The moment that the Charred Dragon Unit arrived, someone was already waiting for Woon-seong.

“As soon as the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit arrives, he is to stop by the Palace.”

Woon-seong had been summoned.

Chapter 47: Back To The Cult (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 47 – Back to the Cult (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Inside the Divine Cult, the command of the Heavenly Demon was absolute.

After the mission, no matter how tattered or miserable you were, you had to go when the Leader called upon you.

Fortunately, Woon-seong was not in a bad state. No, not terrible at all. He had been hurt everywhere, but he was basically healed. Except for the fact that his clothes were a bit shabby, no one could tell that he had just come from a mission.

Pavat-

At last, Woon-seong began to see the Divine Palace, where the Heavenly Demon dwelled.

The young man stopped walking at the entrance of the palace. Inside, he could feel the presence of many others. The energy these people had was not significantly different from his own. With that conclusion, he quickly realized who was inside.

The Great Demons.

The door opened for him as he approached.

Beyond that, the interior was revealed.

I see.

The first thing that caught his eye were the people standing on both sides. As he had predicted, the Great Demons were all gathered inside the palace.

Beyond them was also a familiar face.

The Senior Strategist motioned for him to come inside as their eyes met.

As he entered, he finally saw someone beyond the Strategist.

Cheon Hwi, the supreme ruler of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

From the highest position, he was looking down at the young man.

As soon as Woon-seong recognized him, a terrifying pressure crushed the palace.

An existence that stood as high as the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong had experienced it once, but it was still amazing. His instincts warned him of danger and he felt as insignificant as an ant before an elephant.

Woon-seong bowed his head. "Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit Hyuk Woon-seong, I have just come back from a mission."

The Heavenly Demon nodded. "Lift your head."

As Woon-seong raised his head, the other spoke to him again.

"You have done a wonderful job."

"I just got lucky."

"You may have benefited from other incidents when you were escaping, but decimating the Martial Alliance's branch is your achievement. And I heard

you defeated the First Apprentice.”

“Again, I was simply lucky.”

I really was lucky. I only defeated him with my bracers thanks to the help from the Unrecorded.

Of course, he didn’t explain that out loud.

Whether he knew the mind of this young man or not, Cheon Hwi was still smiling an unreadable smile.

“Luck you say... Even so, this is quite delightful. It has been a while since we had such young blood. I hope our Cult continues to have more young blood like you.”

The words coming from the Heavenly Demon’s mouth made the surrounding Great Demons uncomfortable. They couldn’t believe he was blatantly talking about the change in generations in front of them. They were expecting for it to happen, but they could not hide their bitterness.

At the same time, Woon-seong also realized the gravity of these words. *Are you using me to keep the Great Demons in check?*

The trainees of the Cave of Latent Demons had already come out into the world. There was only one that stood out right now. However, after some time, others would rise up too. It was obvious that the Great Demons would be the first to lose their place.

Just Woon-seong and his achievements alone were enough to make the Great Demons nervous.

‘If you do not want to be eliminated, make some effort.’

That was the message silently echoed.

The Heavenly Demon continued, “That is enough about the mission. I heard the rest from the reports.” He gazed at the young man. “As for a reward, let me know if there’s anything you want.”

Woon-seong closed his eyes. He had to be careful now. If he wanted something that was too much, he could upset the Heavenly Demon — he didn't want to waste his reward or be blacklisted by the Leader in front of the upper echelon.

Taking time to think, Woon-seong was silent for a moment.

“I would like to enter the Valley of Thousand Spirits for half a year.”

A thousand vengeful demons dwelled in the Valley of Thousand Spirits. It was the place the members of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad, including Cheon Ah-young, had entered as punishment. And now, Woon-seong chose it as a training ground.

Those who were punished entered the place like they were walking the road to Hell; Woon-seong saw it as a reward.

The Great Demons gathered roared to life.

However, when the Heavenly Demon raised his hand, the commotion quickly subsided.

The Heavenly Demon seemed slightly amused. “The Valley of Thousand Spirits... And why do you want that?”

“I heard that the Valley is now being used as a place to punish sinners, but it was originally one of the Cult's designated training grounds.”

At this point, Cheon Hwi and the Senior Strategist seemed to imperceptibly nod their heads. Although filled with malicious spirits, the Valley of Thousand Spirits had indeed been a training ground.

Woon-seong continued, “A martial artist becomes stronger by overcoming hardship. Since I decided to train, I thought it would be best to do it in the toughest place I could find.”

“I see.”

The Heavenly Demon was thoughtful. This was the reason why he pushed all the members of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad, including Ah-young, into the Valley of Thousand Spirits. Of course, it would only be beneficial if they could successfully withstand the spirits.

Whether he knew this reasoning or not, Woon-seong wished to enter the valley himself.

Does he understand?

If so, then Cheon Hwi thought that was truly astonishing.

Maybe the young man had even noticed the relationship between himself and Cheon Ah-young.

If so, Woon-seong likely knew that Cheon Hwi would not have sent Ah-young somewhere to deliberately harm her.

No, it didn't matter whether Woon-seong knew or not.

Either way, he was willing to throw himself into such a situation. This added to the favorable impression that Cheon Hwi already held.

“What a prime decision.”

Woon-seong heard the approval in the voice of the Heavenly Demon and relaxed slightly. He thought it just might be possible to enter the Valley and train for half a year.

However, the words that came out next were completely different from what Woon-seong had predicted.

“I shall not approve.”

Woon-seong's eyes shook as his whole body tensed. *Was I mistaken just now?*

As if answering the questions inside his mind, the Heavenly Demon continued on. “You may enter the Valley of Thousand Spirits for four

months. Instead, I will reward two pills of ‘Demonic Medicine of Blood Kalpa’ to all members of the Charred Dragon Unit”

By the end, the young man had already guessed the meaning of everything.

It's just like before.

A short moment ago, the Heavenly Demon had kept the Great Demons in check using Woon-seong. It was hard to deny that the glaring difference between Demonic Generals and Great Demons was time and experience.

If there were suddenly two Great Demons in the Charred Dragon Unit, this new blood would only continue to grow in strength and influence.

The shoulders of the Great Demons sagged even more.

The Heavenly Demon then added the last nail in the coffin.

“A month after the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit returns from his closed training, we will open the ‘Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame’.”

The Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame.

The Heavenly Mountain was the peak where the Cult of the Heavenly Demon resided, the great Mount Heaven reaching to touch the skies.

What about the Divine Flame?

The Divine Flame carried the will of the First Heavenly Demon, so manifestation of the Divine Shaped Flame was seen as proof of being the Heavenly Demon.

In other words, this ‘Banquet of the Heavenly Demon and Divine Flame’ was a celebration that took place in front of the foundations for all demonic practitioners.

And a banquet for demonic people meant only one thing.

Combat.

Separating the weak from the strong.

The strong climb to their rightful positions and the weak are left behind.

That was the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame.

There were many who complained about holding the Banquet.

“The Cult Leader shouldn’t be doing this to us!”

Bam!

Numerous Great Demons had gathered at a table, in a little coalition.

The one who spoke was the Great Demon ranked at 100th, ‘Six Bladed Blood Monster’ Doe Pae-geuk. He had slammed his hand into the tabletop, leaving behind a clear palm print.

“Yes!”

“I agree!”

“It seems like our Leader is forgetting who has sustained the great Mount Heaven!”

Several other Great Demons shouted loudly, agreeing with each other.

Of course, these were all things they could not do before the Heavenly Demon.

In all the commotion, the highest ranked Great Demon calmed down the crowd. “Come, everybody, calm down. All the opinions made here can’t change the Leader’s mind.”

“Hmm.”

“Ugh.”

Those who were excited by their own words stopped what was pouring out while biting their lips.

However, Doe Pae-geuk turned to look at this eminent Great Demon.

“You seem to have an idea if you speak so calmly.”

The one who nodded at these words was the Great Demon ranked 10th, ‘Palm of Blood and Jade’ Kwak Soo-mil. As the 10th, he was a practical leader among these people.

“You should all be aware that there are some people within the Cult who are making some rebellious decisions.”

At that, some of the Demons coughed uncomfortably. There had been a movement like that for years, it just hadn’t surfaced yet. However, no one could *not* notice it.

“If we oppose the opinions of the Cult Leader here, we might be targeted as rebellious forces. Not to mention that the Leader is probably already thinking about us that way. What other reason would there be for him to stimulate us like this?”

Everyone nodded. Although it was time to speak of a generation replacement, the Cult Leader had provoked too many of them this time.

“Are you saying he’s trying to weed out the rebellious within the Cult?”

Replacing generations, stimulating and keeping the Great Demons in check, and also weeding out the deviants.

A truly terrifying heart.

The best option in this situation would be to lay low. There was nothing good about standing out and being viewed as rebellious.

“But we can’t afford this. Those bloody Charred Dragon bastards, they’ll be too strong if we move late.”

Doe Pae-geuk nodded. “With their reward, the Charred Dragon Unit will significantly improve their cultivation.”

“It seems like you’re missing something, ‘Six Bladed Blood Monster’.” Kwak Soo-mil chuckled. “We may not have ‘Demonic Medicine of Blood Kalpa’, but our experience far surpasses theirs!”

“Ah!”

Some of the surrounding Great Demons realized this and could not help but call out in their excitement.

“Besides, even if it’s not ‘Demonic Medicine of Blood Kalpa’, you all have some qi medicines you gathered personally, don’t you?”

Kwak Soo-mil turned his head to examine the others, many of whom turned to look away.

“Give me five pills and I’ll take responsibility and defeat that Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit.”

“I thought we needed to break the whole unit, not just their captain?”

“That isn’t necessary. I heard that the captain brat is the strongest out of the whole Cave. The rest of them are heaps behind him.”

“Oh.”

The listeners nodded, “If we break him, I’m sure the rest will start laying low.”

At this point, many of them were tempted. But it still seemed a bit suspicious.

“What if there are those who still dare challenge us after we defeat the captain?”

Kwak Soo-mil laughed. “Have you forgotten the rules of the Banquet?”

During the ‘Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame’, the winner could continuously choose their next opponent. Most of the time, of course, the winner would choose someone stronger than the last. Sometimes though, the winner would point at someone weaker. That sort of person was not confident in defeating the strong, so chose to exaggerate their skills by beating down the weak.

Proving yourself strong by defeating the underdog... What an embarrassment.

This was especially disgraceful for anyone part of the Divine Cult, who prided themselves for ruthless advancement.

“Are you saying that you will defeat not only the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, but several people in the unit?”

“That’s exactly what I’m saying.”

Kwak Soo-mil said that he would do the dirty work for them.

“I’ll break the few at the top of the Charred Dragon Unit, and then no one will dare challenge for the rank of a Great Demon.”

Seeing the others stay silent, he opened his mouth again. “Now, who is willing to give me their medicine? If you do, I’ll make sure to pay you back plenty.”

His eyes glinted darkly, but no one noticed his treacherous air.

Chapter 48: Valley Of Thousand Spirits (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 48 – Valley of Thousand Spirits (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Soon the Great Demons left the meeting room one by one. In the end, only Kwak Soo-mil was left, smiling to himself.

“Heh, heh.”

Tak, tak, tak, tak!

He tapped the table with his fingertips, as was a habit of his.

“Five pills...It was a promise made in public. They will have to keep their promises.”

What made Kwak Soo-mil so happy was that these pills would soon be in his hands. In order to save face, all the other Great Demons would undoubtedly fulfill their end of the deal.

Next, it would be time for his side of the deal. Absorbing all the medicinal qi, he would trample upon the Charred Dragon Unit and their captain.

He smiled just thinking about it, his teeth like fangs. It was a wicked smile.

In conclusion, Kwak Soo-mil did not intend to keep his promise.

To be precise, he would probably fulfill half of it.

I will trample upon the captain, that brat. But not the Charred Dragon Unit.

In exchange for the five pills, Hyuk Woon-seong would be defeated.

That was the least he could do.

He did not intend to face the whole Charred Dragon Unit — it was beneath him.

The reason he asked for five pills was not to deal with them. *No, I am going to challenge for a higher rank.*

In a society where the strong prevailed, Kwak Soo-mil had successfully maintained his rank in the Cult for over a decade.

In other words, his cultivation had stagnated for more than a decade. Even while others moved up and down the ranks, he remained as Rank 10.

Others laughed at him, saying that he had reached his limit and had seen the end of his potential.

Now was the chance to change their thoughts! He would rise and prove them all wrong.

Using these five pills as a foundation, he would beat the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit without a problem.

The kid hadn't been bad last time, but even with the two pills of 'Demonic Medicine of Blood Kalpa', they wouldn't be equals. Especially now that he would take five similar pills.

Defeating him will be easier than breaking a baby's neck. I'll challenge for a higher position.

Greed for status and power burned from the corners of his mind. The position he wanted was not just this pile of crap.

He didn't even want to be the strongest Great Demon.

Deceiving people of the same rank as himself...

He didn't want to hear complaints from them, so he just needed the strength to shut them up.

A Demonic King.

If he became one, no one would dare to complain even if he didn't keep his promise.

It was not an easy position to achieve, which was why it was so appealing.

An attractive position, attained by betraying the aspirations of the other Great Demons.

Was that any better than bullying the Charred Dragon Unit?

It would be better to die if he didn't successfully become a Demonic King.

Kwak Soo-mil closed his eyes for a moment. When he opened them again, his eyes blazed with fighting spirit.

For that, I need you to die as the scapegoat, Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit.

Afterall, that was the bare minimum required of him by the promise.

His laughter was eerie as it echoed in the now empty meeting room.

Hehehehehehe-

Ahahahaha...

"It's a treacherous result for what you promised. Don't you think?"

The man in black, sitting across from Joo Moon-baek, twitched in his seat.

He wanted to say something. But in the end, he couldn't bring himself to. The man in front of him was the Vice Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon...

This was supposed to be a negotiation by people of similar status, but the man in black clearly had lower strength and status.

There would be nothing gained from aggravating Joo Moon-baek.

Thus, the man in black held back from speaking his mind.

"I never knew that brat, the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit would be so powerful."

"My dear, according to the reports, he's even stronger than you. Calling him a brat is a bit harsh."

"Hmm."

Joo Moon-baek continued on, "Thanks to you, the plot to expose the Leader's incompetence has failed."

"But, we have a number of other plans in progress too."

The other ones were not as straightforward, but no one went in with only one plan.

However, Joo Moon-baek shook his head. "It looks like the Heavenly Brain Tower has found out. We called back all of our men yesterday."

The man in black had no choice but to question again. "Then what should we do?"

"Hmm, you're the one who failed, and I'm the one who's going to clean up after you," Joo Moon-baek scoffed. "I won't be showing any movement for a while."

“For a while?”

“The Leader has stimulated the Great Demons in a recent assembly. I assume the Leader is trying to seek out some rebels because he’s aware of something. You should be well aware it’s best not to act during a time like this.”

“Hmm.” The man in black agreed reluctantly.

Apparently, the image of the Heavenly Demon yesterday was different from the usual ‘Benevolent Tyrant’ (霸君賢王).

A benevolent tyrant, they said.

An outstanding ruler who showed both benevolence and tyranny. To those within his fence, he showed his benevolence. To those outside of it, he would become an unforgiving tyrant.

For the Heavenly Demon to speak such insidious words at the assembly, it only meant that there were those among the Great Demons that he recognized as outside his fence.

“I’ll start moving after seeing how the Heavenly Brain Tower reacts. We’ll pause everything we’ve been conspiring for a while.”

“I understand.” The man in black got up to leave.

“Oh, and I’ll punish the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, who got in our way, through my own means.” While speaking, Joo Moon-baek smiled at the man in black. “I’m cleaning up your mess. You owe me this time.”

To the man dressed in black, it was a cruel, mocking smile.

“It really is ‘Demonic Medicine of Blood Kalpa’ (血劫魔團)!”

Gwan Tae-ryang shouted without concealing his excitement, basically salivating. In his hand were two red, gleaming pills.

It was not just him. In the hands of all Charred Dragon Unit members were the same. No one could hide their expectations and stared at the pills in amazement.

‘Demonic Medicine of Blood Kalpa’, this was stronger than the ‘Ayu Kalpa’ pills they had consumed in the Cave some years ago. There were two of them too, adding up to be a total of 20 years’ worth of qi.

This was a joy that they could not contain. No one here relied on medicine, but neither would they be offended if they found a way to increase their qi safely and quickly.

“But where did Captain go?” Baek Woon-ji asked Gwan Tae-ryang, putting the pills away.

Gwan Tae-ryang thought about it, but he was still distracted. “I heard he went to train...”

“Training?”

Baek Woon-ji was shocked. Not even a day had passed since the Charred Dragon Unit returned from the mission, but Woon-seong was running to train. This captain of hers was really flexing his toughness.

As if he had the same thoughts, Gwan Tae-ryang stuck his tongue out in concentration. “He’s definitely tough. To the degree that it only makes sense how strong he is.”

Looking at the current Woon-seong, no one could imagine that the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit had been Number 900 back in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Baek Woon-ji clenched her fists. “We have to work hard too. To not be a burden to Captain.”

Gwan Tae-ryang nodded. “Of course.”

“By the way, where is Captain going for training?”

Gwan Tae-ryang scratched his cheek with a finger. He had definitely heard Woon-seong mention it while dropping off the pills, but he couldn't remember it well. "Where was it? The Alley... Wait, no the Valley..." He paused, thinking long and hard. "Ah wait, I got it. I think he said it was the Valley of Thousand Spirits."

Baek Woon-ji was glad she had put her pills away or she would have dropped them on the floor in shock.

Hui-ying-

Winds that whipped at his clothes, sharp as a blade.

As he walked, Woon-seong could see the cliffs carved into the sides of the valley.

There was only one way down the Valley of Thousand Spirits: use whatever was left of the ladders.

Of course, you could also try your luck by jumping down. Perhaps you wouldn't careen down and impale yourself on a stalagmite.

The Valley of Thousand Spirits, the valley where a thousand spirits dwell.

Woon-seong wasn't even in the Valley yet, but he could already feel the dense forces from below. *Hmph. How vile, the energy is stinging my skin...* The pressure was crushing, making it hard to breathe. However, Woon-seong sighed lightly and the pressure around him disappeared.

It would be hard for an ordinary human being to survive here, but Woon-seong had been trained to do more than just survive.

Sure, there might be some mental pressure, but it was the best place for a martial artist. *Excellent place to train.*

Inside the Valley, he sensed some strong fluctuations of energy. Those must be the members of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad, who had been sent here for punishment about three months ago.

They've definitely gotten stronger than before.

Among them, he felt an especially strong presence. Naturally, it was the energy of Cheon Ah-young. The blood of the Heavenly Demon.

Couldn't she just ignore the talent that came from her bloodline?

Ah-young was much stronger than before.

“Not bad.”

But soon, Woon-seong lost interest. He couldn't afford to waste his time being interested in other people's growth.

Hui-ying-

The corners of his clothes fluttered in the wind once more.

He had four months here and two qi condensing pills. These were some excellent conditions. The only thing left to do was to become strong, strong enough that no one could ignore him!

If that's going to happen, I better start as soon as possible.

With that thought, he threw himself down the cliff.

In one hand, he gripped the White Night Spear. It shone brightly as his body was sucked down into the darkness.

Chapter 49: Valley Of Thousand Spirits (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 49 – Valley of Thousand Spirits (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

In the depths of the valley, energy carried within the Heavenly Demon's bloodline rose and wrapped around the body of a young woman. Fragments of energy stretched around, drawn to the Dark Flower Red Heart, which shone through the gloomy atmosphere, in hopes of awakening the senses of the body one by one. The muscles were refreshed and the blood in the body boiled with vigor.

That was the qi from the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon flowing through Cheon Ah-young.

The world of martial arts is so vast...

So cultivation is like planting and growing a tree on such a vast world. A great tree, one that can cover a vast plain.

That is the path I must take.

I still have a long way to go.

The pressure of cultivating in the Valley of Thousand Spirits had enlightened her, allowing her to tap into the true power of the Dark Flower

Red Heart.

Evidence of Ah-young's improvement flickered in the form of a flame nestled in her hands.

Burning hot and bright, this was the purest demonic flame.

This force was the sprout of the Divine Shaped Flame, a manifestation of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon! All members of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon were to kneel before it.

Ah-young still couldn't fully bring it out yet, but there was no doubt what the energy in her palms was. Knowing that, she smiled happily. How many buckets of sweat and tears had it taken for her to cultivate this mysterious force? Only she herself knew.

She continued to meditate for several days, maintaining her energy to fight back against the chaotic spirits of the Valley. It was not just meditation, but also continuous physical training.

Some of the crew members were tired and had rested, but she had not stopped once.

Her satisfaction was earned through effort.

With this, I won't lose to Number 900...No, I won't lose to Hyuk Woon-seong.

Cheon Ah-young tightly clenched her fists and stood up, walking out.

The valley had numerous caves built into the sides, as numerous as the graves that littered the bottom. Looking down from her own cave, she could see several other caves where the other members of the unit were living.

It was then she heard a strange sound.

Kachi-kachi-kachi-

It was the sound of something scratching against the sides of the valley.

Since there were no dummies to practice with, all the members had gotten used to the sound of something hitting the wall through strength practice.

But there seemed to be a slight difference...

Is that sound coming from above?

It was indeed coming from above. The members of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad all looked up, as if they could not believe their ears.

Even then, the sound came once again.

Kachi-kachi-kachi—

Nope, that was definitely the sound of something repeatedly hitting the wall.

As Ah-young looked up, she could see the blue sky that peaked out between the cliff walls.

There was something that was falling.

“Is that a bird?”

Ah-young wasn't sure what it was. The Valley of Thousand Spirits was filled with different creatures, but most of all, dangerous spirits. Most animals instinctively gave it a wide berth. A flying beast would also turn away or fly higher to avoid passing through.

If it was a bird, it sure was a weird one to seek its own death.

While she was thinking, the thing fell at an ever-increasing rate. She could hear the sounds from the wall, like the suicidal bird had stretched its wings to slow down its descent.

As the thing got closer, the appearance was clearer and clearer, enough to be recognized by the members, including Ah-young.

No, it wasn't a suicidal bird. It was a man with a spear in his hand!

As the man fell, he would use the spear to slow down his fall, causing it to bend and draw along the cliff wall. That was how they had heard those scratching sounds.

Boom!

As the spear bounced off the wall, the man went up a little bit, forcefully decreasing his speed significantly.

“Oh my god!”

Some of the members were impressed.

That was the Art of Lightness, an art that controlled the weight of the user’s body. This man was using his spear in accordance with the elasticity so that his speed would decrease.

Who could this be?

Based on the sound of the spear against the wall, the person was preparing to land. With one final *scritch*, the man fell towards the floor.

Boom! Kuung-!

Did only one person fall? The amount of dust and the shaking of the floor made it seem like two or three people had simultaneously landed.

Sand and dust billowed into the air.

Cheon Ah-young did not take her eyes off the swirl of sand. The person had fallen too fast for her to identify. The rest of the team also showed their vigilance, grabbing their weapons.

Whoo-hoo!

In the meantime, a spear rose out of the cloud and cleared the air.

And finally, a person slowly walked out.

“Looks I got down okay.”

It was dangerous, but the owner of the voice made it sound like falling off of the cliff was an unimpressive feat.

Cheon Ah-young, without even seeing the owner of the voice, muttered, “Number 900?”

Of course, it was Hyuk Woon-seong. He slowly walked forward, towards her.

“It’s been a while.”

What a relaxed greeting.

Cheon Ah-young bit her lip. After her breakthrough with the Dark Flower Red Heart, she thought their skill gap had been narrowed.

But...

He’s become more of a monster again.

The Woon-seong that had just fallen into the Valley of Thousand Spirits was truly astonishing.

Besides, she’d noticed that he still had all his bracers on. If someone asked her to do the same...

Cheon Ah-young berated herself for even thinking about it. Anyone else would have smashed themselves to smithereens.

Meanwhile, some of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad members were shouting at Woon-seong.

“What are you doing here?”

“Are you here because you were punished, too? Serves you right!”

“You’re just a mere Number 900!”

“Well don’t you look healthy, Number 900?! Don’t be arrogant!”

“We’re stuck here because of you!”

Many of them had always disliked Woon-seong, especially now that they wished to blame others for their suffering. There always had to be a scapegoat — Woon-seong was the obvious choice. It wasn’t because their squad had failed their mission, but because the others had accomplished their mission too well.

Of course, it was a bad idea.

Ah-young naturally did not agree with the people who had spoken out.

What a terrible mindset to have. To lay blame on others, even if it was obvious that you were in the wrong?

Some people had become poisoned by the energy of the vicious spirits in the Valley, adding to their existing complaints

Unfortunately, they were the most vocal now.

“Stop-!”

Ah-young tried to stop them. However, a cool voice interrupted her.

“Believe whatever you want.”

Some eyebrows twitched when they realized they could be mistaken. Woon-seong stared at them with soulless eyes, looking at them like they were dead men walking.

“I didn’t come here to be punished, I came here on my own.”

“The fuck?”

“Don’t joke with us.”

“This crazy bastard, coming down to this dreary place—”

The man couldn't finish his thoughts, as Woon-seong had grabbed him by the collar.

“Huff!”

With his hands around the man's throat, Woon-seong lifted the man straight off the ground. Tendons flexed on Woon-seong's forearms as the man's feet dangled helplessly. Truly tremendous power!

“Don't think of me like any of you,” Woon-seong snarled ferociously, pulling his face close to the other. He continued in a commanding tone, “I am a well-qualified Great Demon. This is no place for you idiotic Demonic Captains to open your mouths.”

The shoulders of the man trembled. He felt like a mouse standing in front of a viper. Fear from the overwhelming difference in power shook him.

Woon-seong dropped the man unceremoniously — the man crumpled to the floor, coughing and hacking — before glaring at the others. “If you have nothing else to say, move aside.”

Some of the unit members shook their heads, but no one said anything.

The people hastily parted for him, giving him a clear path to Cheon Ah-young.

He walked uncaringly and passed by her.

It was Ah-young's voice that could be heard next. “Did you really come here for training?”

Woon-seong stopped walking. Without even looking back he asked, “Do you think I came in because I was punished?”

Although he couldn't see, Ah-young shook her head. If he had been punished, the whole Charred Dragon Unit would have entered. But here Woon-seong was, alone. That meant he really had volunteered, unless there was a deeper reason.

“It couldn’t have been an easy decision...”

Woon-seong laughed. For the first time, his gaze was on her face. Of course, he still looked quite emotionless.

“You know how meaningless it is to look for the easy way, don’t you?”

‘Look for the easy way out and you might just find the easy road to death’. That was common sense for any martial artist who lived with a weapon in their hand.

“That’s somehow more convincing coming from a person who started from the bottom and ended at the top...”

“There’s no such thing as easy training.”

That was all Woon-seong had to say to her. When he finished, he turned around and walked ahead.

Where he was headed was the most dangerous part of the valley, the deepest place.

Woon-seong eventually stopped walking, feeling the sinister energy rising around his feet.

Here we are.

The energy here was more toxic than any other place. If an ordinary person were here, they would have gone insane within record time.

Woon-seong only smiled.

It’s a good place to train.

There was no easy training.

Moreover, the path he walked was one of bloodshed, a path of revenge.

Woon-seong couldn't go easy on himself. What he had told Ah-young was like a commitment to his own beliefs.

Focus on where to go, what to train, and what to do.

Woon-seong reached out to feel the walls, checking what there was around him.

The walls were damp and soaked with evil energy. Moss grew on the walls, which he could eat.

They have a toxin that causes abdominal pain, but they can be consumed as long as you have the strength.

Woon-seong had heard this somewhere, before he had entered. Moss inside the Valley of Thousand Spirits could be eaten as a food substitute while inside the valley, as long as you picked it from somewhere you could endure.

Around him, enough moss grew to feed a hundred people.

So he had everything he needed. He sat down.

Time to start.

And then three months passed.

Chapter 50: Metamorphosis (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 50 – Metamorphosis (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Whew.”

Cheon Ah-young huffed as she lowered her sword, wiping away sweat with the back of her hand. Her clothes were soaked with sweat and dirt.

Three months had passed in the Valley of Thousand Spirits.

It was a period of much growth, growth faster than it had ever been.

Perhaps the reason for all the improvement wasn't even the Valley of Thousand Spirits.

Yeah, maybe...

She turned her head toward the deepest part of the Valley.

There, beyond the darkness, was a young man.

Woon-seong, who had entered three months ago, was still there.

Of course, Woon-seong did not continue to appear here and there in the valley. He was occasionally seen, but spent most of his time holed up in the deepest region.

However, his absence did not mean that the others forgot about his presence.

It was especially so for Ah-young. A wall that needed to be overcome someday; she was conscious of it. She had to defeat him. She couldn't help but feel that way.

Look, how could she not feel that huge presence blocking the inside of the valley? Moreover, its existence grew stronger every day.

Cheon Ah-young swallowed. *I won't lose.*

But soon she shook away those thoughts. She had been training hard for the last three months. For the first time in ages, she felt the agony of torn skin, blisters and cuts littering her hands and arms. With all the new calluses, the hands of a young noble lady had transformed. But that was alright, since these hands held traces of her identity as a martial artist, one who had practiced the way of the sword with all her might.

Thanks to her struggles, the energy harnessed by the Dark Flower Red Heart was greater than ever before. It wouldn't be long before Ah-young could summon the Divine Shaped Flame.

Thinking of the future, she grinned.

It was not only Ah-young who had benefited during these three months.

Influenced by Woon-seong's growing presence, the rest of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad had also focused wholeheartedly on training. Perhaps it was because of his extravagant entrance into the Valley.

Anyways...

Whatever the reason, the overall strength of the squad had risen to an unparalleled degree.

Ah-young examined the members of the 2nd Latent Demon Squad.

They'll become a foundation for me to climb higher.

As she was the captain, it would only be better if the group she was in charge of became stronger. She smiled faintly.

A good harvest.

Ah-young turned, again, staring into the darkness.

I guess I have to thank you now.

Thank you for being such a good stimulant.

She bowed her head slightly, barely discernible.

Still, this was a bow from someone with the bloodline of the Heavenly Demon.

Someone approached Ah-young from the side, "It's done."

"Excuse me?" Ah-young was afraid someone had seen her.

The member spoke again, slightly embarrassed, repeating what he had just said. "It's time to leave."

At that point, Ah-young suddenly realized that a total of six months had passed. Her punishment in the Valley of Thousand Spirits was over.

Time to return to the Cult.

They're gone.

Woon-seong slowly opened his eyes.

Nothing that a large number of presences had begun to leave, he realized that it was about time for him to leave as well.

The 2nd Latent Demon Squad was to stay for half a year; Woon-seong's stay overlapped with three of those months. And now that three months had passed, it was time for Ah-young and them to leave.

Feeling the presences receding, Woon-seong slowly rose to his feet.

Of course, he was not getting up to send them out.

The spear lying next to him trembled.

Woo-woo!

As if responding to its cries, he picked it up.

The energy of the Unrecorded...

He smiled faintly, feeling the power coursing through his body.

Cheon Ah-young had cultivated like crazy for the past three months, as if in competition with himself. As a result, she had indeed grown remarkably strong.

However, Woon-seong did not feel the same pressure.

He had achieved no less.

He was toeing the line of Transcendence.

I've already been through this before and I'm in much better conditions this time.

Pills and remarkable martial arts he didn't have access to last time, combined with experience and new abilities.

They had brought Woon-seong onto a new path.

'Intimidation Qi'.

It felt a little different compared to before. If the previous one was like a cloud, this time it was spreading like a dense fog.

Within this fog, Woon-seong began to move.

Movement delay.

Even an ant would be unable to escape. However, each movement contained the strength to crush layers of rock.

Huuung-

The air moved in slow motion, scattering and crackling with qi. A wind blew in circles, following the movement of the White Night Spear.

The trajectory of the spear in his hands suddenly changed. His movements sped up, adapting to the differing speed and strength.

Haste.

A linear movement that connected you to your enemies. The air distorted as space melted, qi sweeping over the area.

Boom, boom!

A new cave was made, pounded into the wall. This was evidence that Woon-seong had entered a new state.

Another dreadful wave was brewing.

Rain of Star Destruction.

Hualalalala-

The ground shook like it had been hit by an earthquake.

Black Night of the Death Moon.

Guaguaguagauagua!

Pieces of stone smashed into the ground, creating craters and plumes of sand dust.

Standing within the cloud, Woon-seong slowly lowered his spear.

“Whew.”

No, not yet. There was still one more move!

The spear in his hand was pulled back as his muscles tensed. As soon as he bent down, the energy contained within his spear rushed out like rolling thunder, striking the area around him.

Flow of the Divine Dragon!

Kuku-

A golden dragon flew through the Valley of Thousand Spirits, its roar echoing through the empty cliff. A chunk of the wall fell from the sky, creating a heavy sound. Again, dust covered his vision.

After the billow of sand and dust subsided, the traces of destruction would be seen.

There were multiple cuts on the cliff, followed by a large cut from the ‘Black Night of the Fourth Moon’. The deepest cut was from the ‘Flow of the Divine Dragon’, which had torn into the walls as it passed by.

Would people who saw its traces think that a true dragon had descended?

It was obvious that Woon-seong was at least twice as strong as before.

Woon-seong couldn’t help but smile. *What the Unrecorded left behind suits me perfectly.*

Maybe it was because of the Spear Master Sect’s arts at the foundation of it all.

The Spear Master Sect was Woon-seong’s root.

Even during this second life, his foundation had never changed.

Instead, his natural athleticism had overlapped with new martial arts to create an even stronger base.

The roots wove together to form the Tempered True Blossom.

No, they did not just weave together, they harmonized.

Woon-seong savored this feeling and slowly closed his eyes. He had achieved what he wanted when he entered the Valley of Thousand Spirits, so it was time to move on.

‘Demonic Medicine of Blood Kalpa’.

He looked at the two marble-like pills that he had pulled out, then shoved them into his mouth without hesitation.

Gulp.

The pills melted away in no time and Woon-seong swallowed carefully.

Hot energy flowed down his throat, flashing past his stomach. Inside, the medicine met with the force of the Intimidation Qi, scattering around the body.

He gathered his energy slowly, carefully.

I’m ready.

He had gathered enough energy in one place.

Let them open: the ‘Twin Veins of Control’! Opening them up is the way to becoming a true master of martial arts!

Energy that he could barely contain rampaged through his veins, crashing into the walls that blocked his channels of control. His body shook violently as a dreadful pain spread throughout his body. The impact was transported to the brain, causing more mind-boggling, spine-breaking pain.

Ugh...I need to concentrate or I’ll end up passing out.

But Woon-seong was upset.

The veins were still blocked.

One more time!

He tried again.

Boom!

The rushing energy hitting a roadblock caused extreme pain.

However, the walls are thinner!

Go! Do it! Again!

Woon-seong continued to direct his energy without missing a beat. Once again, the energy crashed into the blockage and rebounded. As the internal injuries increased, blood to gush out of his mouth.

I've done this before! There's no reason I can't succeed this time!

Indeed, Woon-seong had opened his Twin Veins of Control in his first life, allowing him to enter the Transcendence realm. There was no reason he could not do it again.

Once more!

Kuaaaaaaang!

Along with a thundering sound in his mind, the wall blocking the veins finally collapsed.

A cool sensation flooded his body, numbing the pain.

But such a sensation was too short.

The pain inflicted by breaking through was too much. After enduring for so long, Woon-seong finally found the pain unbearable and collapsed into unconsciousness.

As he lost consciousness, the excess energy within his body began to circulate once more. Like a wild horse, it stampeded through Woon-seong's body.

No, that was actually incorrect.

The energy was carefully controlled, scattering into different limbs.

If someone was present to follow the qi flow, they would discover that Woon-seong's qi was being directed by a mysterious force from within the White Night Spear...

Undoubtedly, a surprising result awaited Woon-seong.

And soon...

Thump, thump, thump....

Small sounds echoed through Woon-seong's changing body.

Chapter 51: Metamorphosis (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 51 – Metamorphosis (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

A partial success.

How unexpected.

Woon-seong had used all of his strength to smash the walls, but that had only been enough to free one of the veins!

The small walls that blocked the rest of said half collapsed one by one.

The resulting impurities oozed out of his pores, leaving Woon-seong with drops of black sweat on his skin.

Suddenly, his body turned hot. The black drops of sweat changed color as they hardened, baking against his body like clay. Like a snake shedding its skin, this layer cracked and peeled away from Woon-seong's body, revealing clear skin and shining hair underneath.

Woon-seong's body twitched intermittently as the change continued, his body temperature rising and cooling.

For how long did that continue?

There was no one to keep track of time.

Drip.

Drip, drop.

A few drops of water dripped off the wall and onto the face of the young man, who lay there like a corpse.

Color returned to his whole body in the instant of a heartbeat.

Woon-seong began to twitch.

“Mmmmm...”

A groan came out. Woon-seong, who had been unconscious for a long time began to wake slowly.

As if trying to wake him up faster, the White Night Spear trembled and hummed.

At the sound, Woon-seong sat upright.

“What...did something happen?”

The awakened youth slowly leaned forward and instinctively grabbed for the White Night Spear. With that, the trembling of the spear subsided.

Despite being unconscious for an unknown period of time, his last memory was quite vivid.

I was definitely trying to open the ‘Twin Veins of Control’.

Woon-seong shifted his energy, feeling the different sources and following the course they took.

Hmm.

However, there was still a wall blocking one of the veins.

Half success.

Smiling bitterly, Woon-seong confirmed once more. It did not go as planned, since he wanted to open both at once.

But he hadn't been able to, so there was nothing he could do. *What a shame.*

He shook his head and stored that thought in the back of his mind. Surely, there would be other opportunities. Even at the current rate of growth, his progress was incomparably fast.

This is already much better than my past life.

Furthermore, his goal was to control the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

There was still a long way to go.

Still, Woon-seong was confident he was steadily getting closer to it.

Woon-seong's eyes suddenly burned with hatred as the faces of his enemies flashed through his mind.

Jwa Do-gyul...

That was the name of an enemy that must be torn to pieces.

“Phew.”

He calmed his boiling fury and slowly exhaled.

At the same time, Woon-seong looked around slowly. How long had he been unconscious? For one day, a week, or a month? The weather was clearly cooler than before, so it was definitely not a day or two.

Has the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame finished?!

That thought startled him so much he sprang from the ground and broke into a sprint, dashing towards the exit like a mad man.

Then he stopped moving just as fast, skidding to a stop in shock.

His body was light, too light.

Woon-seong looked down at his arms and legs, only to see that the bracers were still there. However, his movements were very natural, as if there were no extra weights attached at all. Not only that, even though he hadn't eaten for days, his muscles were filled with vigor.

Then his eye twitched.

He finally noticed his clothes, which were now black.

He hadn't changed for a long time. Also, they smelled like old clothes, a bit rotten. There was the smell from dirt, but also sweat and contamination.

Wait a minute... No way...

In a hurry, Woon-seong sent another surge of energy through his limbs. Just a moment ago, he had only focused on the opening of the Twin Veins.

He had indeed missed something.

He could feel the qi flow all the way down to his fingertips.

All of his body's meridians had opened up!

There could only be one explanation.

Body modification!

Every martial artist's dream, body modification was like a rebirth. A martial artist who climbed to the top could gain a whole new core, propelling them even higher. There was also another part: the renewal of the skeleton and cleansing of the bones. Like a newborn baby, the new body would be energy-pure and free from mortal impurities.

Woon-seong hadn't even imagined this would happen, but it had.

Still, his happiness was bittersweet.

Like how I only opened up half of the veins, it looks like I only achieved body modification halfway too.

Body modification was achieved, but unfortunately, it was not complete either.

Except, it wasn't even part of the original plan, more like an extra surprise.

Since Woon-seong had failed to open both veins of control, but had cleansed his body of impurities, he could consider this a mis-matched success.

He once again assessed his body. Not only had he gotten a little taller, but his muscles had become denser. Thanks to that, he could lift heavier things faster and easier. The reason his body felt so light was that the iron bracers on his arms weren't heavy enough anymore.

Soon we'll have to increase the weight.

Progress, no matter how small, was always something to be happy about.

Woon-seong's mind soon got recalibrated and he headed towards the top of the Valley of Thousand Spirits. Every time he tapped his foot, he would fly forward hundreds of meters. With a small smile on his lips, he leapt up the walls, movement as light as the wind.

Body modification was really an unexpected outcome. Paired with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, his heightened senses made up for the unopened vein.

He could feel the wind, the movement of an insect climbing the cliff, the shaking of a blade of grass growing between the crevices. Everything around him was captured clearly, almost as if he were seeing them with his own eyes.

What was that?

Woon-seong also felt a group of shadows as well. He tilted his head and spread his senses out even farther. There were people at the top of the cliff,

around the entrance into the Valley of Thousand Spirits.

Pinpointing their location, Woon-seong focused his senses on that area. Soon, their movement was clearer to him and he confirmed their number and placement.

At least one behind the shadows of the trees, one under the rocks, and another one underground.

Woon-seong still had his eyes closed, but he was sure that this was definitely an ambush. He had no idea who they were, but they were obviously waiting for someone to come out of the Valley of the Thousand Spirits.

Are they here after me?

The more he thought about it, the more likely this was. He was the only one left in the Valley of Thousand Spirits. Who else, if not him?

Why?

Why were they targeting him though? There were some Demonic Generals and Great Demons who held grudges against him. Especially among the Great Demons, there were those who did not want him in their ranks. Could one of them have sent assassins?

He didn't dwell on his questions for very long. Suddenly, like the new sun rising, his feet landed on the top of the cliff. From his vantage point, he could see the area that stretched around the cliff.

He could also sense the assassins hiding even clearer.

“Hey, you all, who sent you?”

Woon-seong's qi exploded outwards, bursting towards those hidden. A rain of five throwing knives flew like lightning, straight through the heads of some of the assassins.

Fubuck-

Like the sound of a watermelon erupting, the knives split and burst their heads. The one underground, protected by dirt, was no exception.

But Woon-seong did not relax. Instead, he wielded his spear.

Did I miss two?

The number of knives thrown was five, three of them hit their targets. That meant there were two left.

Whee-

Woon-seong disappeared from where he was originally standing. Moments later, he reappeared in front of one assassin.

“Shit!”

Intimidation Qi covered the other’s mind and body for a single second, which was enough for the White Night Spear to crush his chest. With a crack, his ribs were broken and his heart pierced.

Phew!

Blood spewed out like a fountain, but Woon-seong paid no mind. He focused on the last survivor, who had managed to run quite far already. It was clear that this last one had sensed that the mission would end in a failure and bolted.

Woon-seong raised his spear. Would it work? His body moved before he could finish his thoughts. His ankles, waist, and shoulders twisted in sequence. As the force was drawn from his waist and into his wrist, the White Night Spear left his hand.

‘Lightning Stitching Art’, White Night Spear style!

Whoo-hoo!

The air screeched as the spear tore through the air, slamming into and through the body of the last assassin. The man’s legs were torn off and his

upper body smashed into the trunk of a tree, skewered by the spear.

“Cough!”

Woon-seong could have caused an instantaneous death, but he wanted to keep at least one of them alive long enough to answer his questions. No matter how talented you were, you wouldn’t live very long without legs.

He sighed a little as he looked at the human-tree kebab. *Well then, let’s find out who ordered it.*

Woon-seong didn’t intend to forgive whoever it was. It wasn’t like him to spare those who bared their fangs at him. His eyes gleamed, horrifying like that of a demon.

But he would not find out who was behind it.

By the time he approached, the assassin had already killed himself. The other’s face was pale and bleeding from his eyes and ears, his brain had likely melted too.

Nasty bastards.

The assassin had ingested poison. Even an excellent assassin should have needed some decision-making time, which would have given Woon-seong a few moments. But there was no hesitation.

“Tch.”

At that moment, the sound of shouting drifted from the peaks farther away.

“Wahhhhhhhh!”

It announced the beginning of the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame.

TN: It will be clarified in the coming chapters, but the assassins are known as the ‘Blood Slaying Five Shadows’. Woon-seong, of course, does not know this.

Chapter 52: Banquet (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 52 – Banquet (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Hua-

The fire on the altar burned high and bright. Even though the festival had not started yet, the people were already passionately cheering.

It was because of what this fire meant to those of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The Divine Flame of the Heavenly Demon.

The flame used by the Heavenly Demon was commonly considered to be the Divine Flame.

But it was more correct to call it the Divine *Shaped* Flame, a manifestation of the true flame.

There was only one flame in the Cult that embodied the true meaning: the translucent flame burning upon the sacred altar. Also known as the Remains of the Divine Flame, it was one of the many things the First Heavenly Demon had left in this world.

The Divine Flame was the root of all demonic arts. Thus, it had a mysterious power that stimulated the souls of all demonic practitioners.

Cheon Ah-young, who was looking at the Divine Flame, also felt that she was not different from the others. It seemed like the flickering resonated with her heartbeat.

So that's the real Divine Flame.

Suddenly filled with inexplicable emotion, Ah-young almost shed a tear. The flame felt warm, radiant, and frenzied at the same time. Even just looking at it from afar, she could feel the sacred energy.

Wondering what it would be like closer to the flame, Ah-young turned her gaze to the Divine Maiden, who stood closest to the altar. The near seventy-year-old woman was holding her hands together in prayer.

The Divine Flame was not open to the public except during events like the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame. It simply stayed inside the Divine Maiden's palace.

But there were two people within the Cult who could face the Divine Flame at all times.

The first, of course, was the top of the Demonic Cult, the Heavenly Demon. The Heavenly Demon was always allowed to face the flame, but that didn't mean he had any special communication with it.

Unlike the Heavenly Demon, the Divine Maiden was able to communicate with the spirit of the Divine Flame.

A Divine Maiden was chosen by the spirit of Divine Flame, destined to serve the Divine Flame and the Heavenly Demon her whole life.

There was no option to refuse.

'Serving her whole life' could mean marrying the Cult Leader. However, if the Heavenly Demon refused to recognize her as his spouse, that would mean a life of solitude.

I wonder what kind of thoughts she's had her whole life.

The current Divine Maiden was of the latter group.

It was not uncommon for the people to mourn the fate of such a lady. However, the current Divine Maiden was not at all dissatisfied with the life she led. Just by communicating with the spirit, she felt happy.

Ah-young's gaze began to move slowly, now directed towards the throne placed at the highest point of the stands. It was still empty, but anyone could easily guess that it belonged to the Heavenly Demon.

Only one person in the Demonic Cult could sit above everyone else.

Her gaze was shaking. How much effort had she put into catching her father's eye and becoming the next Heavenly Demon?

In that sense, this banquet was definitely a place of opportunity.

I need to show you my skills this time.

Cheon Ah-young clenched her fist tightly.

At the same time, another person's description flitted through her mind. Not her father, Cheon Hwi, but a completely different face. As she remembered him, Ah-young could not help but scold herself.

Hyuk Woon-seong.

Her interest in him had been out of pure curiosity at first. Still a naive child then, she had been curious about how Number 900 suddenly became so strong. The next emotion was competitive spirit, as she felt like she had found a strong opponent. Such rivalry turned into jealousy after Woon-seong revealed his skills.

She admitted it.

Woon-seong is strong enough to impress my father.

That was why she wanted to beat him even more, hoping to use his reputation to boost hers. Ah-young wanted to be recognized by her father

too.

Thinking about it, Ah-young looked around. She could not find Woon-seong in the crowd. However, her eyes burned brighter and brighter.

Finally, someone appeared on the throne.

The Heavenly Demon had arrived.

Baek Woon-ji looked around nervously.

Soon, the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame would begin. However, there was still no sign of Woon-seong anywhere.

Out of habit, Baek Woon-ji chewed on her fingernails. *Maybe something happened to Captain.*

Of course, there were many people gathered here. Not only martial artists, but also ordinary believers of the religion. There were probably a few thousand people gathered for this day. It would be hard to find anyone in this situation.

Nevertheless, she eagerly perused the crowd for her captain.

I don't see him.

She eventually lowered her head in disappointment.

It was when the Heavenly Demon ascended to the throne that a voice came from behind her.

“You’ve gotten stronger.”

A low, yet heavy, familiar voice. Baek Woon-ji turned her head to glare.
“Captain!”

And there was a familiar face.

She noticed slightly longer, messier hair, and an old, dark, discolored outfit.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly as he felt Baek Woon-ji's lingering gaze on his clothes. Having heard the cheers, he hadn't been able to change his clothes in time.

"Shall I bring you some new clothes?" Baek Woon-ji had a pensive look on her face.

Woon-seong shook his head, "I thought we were here to attend the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame."

Woon-ji nodded quietly, they were both martial artists and Woon-seong was a Great Demon.

"Then I don't want you to get my clothes, but for you to bring me good results today."

Baek Woon-ji nodded once more at these words. Clothing didn't matter. It wasn't about how you looked, but about how much you had grown.

Woon-seong looked towards the Heavenly Demon, who was standing in front of his throne. He was opening a celebration that would showcase the progress and glory of the Cult.

There was a strange aspiration in Woon-seong's eyes as he watched the Heavenly Demon.

I wonder how close you and I are.

Of course, Woon-seong understood he had a long way to go. It would be hard to get revenge for his master without the appropriate level of skill. A high seat within the Cult, or maybe unparalleled skills. You must have both or you must have either, but revenge was certain.

Woon-seong stared at the Heavenly Demon with blazing eyes and tightly grasped the White Night Spear.

As if in tune with his mind, the spear trembled.

As Woon-seong stared at the Heavenly Demon, Baek Woon-ji continued to stare at the young man before her.

He told me that I've become stronger.

His words echoed in her mind, her body trembling just thinking of his voice and from the excitement of recognition. Her eyes roamed Woon-seong's body.

You look a little taller and your skin looks a little better....

Baek Woon-ji may have grown up in the Cave of Latent Demons and practiced demonic arts, but she was still a young woman. Suddenly, she noticed all these changes in Woon-seong. She wanted to ask him about it. "Captain, your appearance..."

But she got interrupted.

"Then, we shall begin the Banquet of the heavenly Mountain and the Divine Flame!"

Baek Woon-ji's words were buried in the cheering that erupted after the Heavenly Demon's speech.

"Woahhhhhh!"

The festival had begun!

The Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame took place on four large stages, conducted over the course of a single day. During this single day though, numerous demonic practitioners experienced drastic changes in rank.

Of course, these changes were strictly based on one-on-one challenges. Since performance was not judged by the accumulation of wins, each challenge was almost always a fight to the death.

Stand on the stage while risking your life to go higher, or maintain your current status and preserve your life.

Today was a day where hundreds of demonic practitioners would die and their ranks would get filled with others.

That was the true nature of the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame.

There were those who did not want to die and sat outside the stage, merely watching the matches.

Many people were injured as their rankings rose and fell. Amongst them, there were those who would rather die valiantly, stupidly, than have their ranking stolen.

As time went on, blood slicked the stages. A small break had to be called every now and then to drain the blood and clear the corpses.

Woon-seong was slowly examining the people. His gaze was on the Demonic Kings though, not on the Great Demons.

Higher than the Great Demons... I'll use this Banquet to become a Demonic King.

Woon-seong was currently trying to figure out which Demonic King to challenge. He was sure that he was still no match against a higher ranked one, but he felt ready to fight a lower ranked Demonic King.

Although I'll probably have to take three bracers off.

He was sure that he was stronger than all of the Great Demons, so he could probably fight a low-ranking Demonic King and have some strength to spare.

If Woon-seong succeeded in his challenge, he would probably become the youngest Demonic King in the history of the Cult.

Meanwhile, the matches continued. The person who was on the stage got a satisfactory ranking and stepped down without proceeding any further.

At that moment, the crowd became rowdy again. Based on who was coming onstage, a great show was about to begin.

“That man is going up!”

“Oooh!”

Kwak Soo-mil, Great Demon Rank 10...

Woon-seong stood to the side, observing the man and reciting his name in his mind.

Kwak Soo-mil was the first high-ranking Great Demon to go onstage since the start of the Banquet.

Then Kwak Soo-mil opened his mouth, “I challenge the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit!”

“Ugh!” Cheon Ah-young, who had just defeated her opponent on another stage, groaned in frustration. “Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit?”

Damn it, someone got to him first...

A-young anxiously turned to look at Woon-seong, waiting to hear his answer. Accepting the challenge or not was completely up to him.

But nothing was more shameful than running from a fight.

That was why most demons of the Cult accepted, even if they were bound to die.

However, this was different.

Conventionally, if a higher demon challenged you, you would not accept. The Banquet was designed for a lower ranked practitioner to advance in status, not for those at the top to bully the weaker. In this case, even if Woon-seong avoided the challenge, he wouldn’t be ridiculed.

But there was a problem: the nature of Hyuk Woon-seong.

Although Ah-young wasn't intimate with Woon-seong, she knew that he was not one to back down.

And just as she predicted, she heard him agree.

"I accept your challenge."

Chuck-

Woon-seong leapt from the seats and dropped down towards the stage.

Chapter 53: Banquet (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 53 – Banquet (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Woon-seong stood onstage and stared at his opponent with a blank expression.

Why was he being challenged?

Kwak Soo-mil was the Rank 10 Great Demon and Woon-seong was just a low-ranking Great Demon. [1]

Well, whatever. Woon-seong shook his head. Rankings didn't really matter — all he had to do was fight to the best of his abilities.

Woon-seong's eyes glowed fiercely.

At the same time, the voice of Kwak Soo-mil flowed into Woon-seong's ears.

“Aren't you going to take off those bracers on your arms and legs? I saw you fighting in the palace last time. I'm stronger than that man. Shouldn't you at least take one off?”

Kwak Soo-mil remembered the day Woon-seong had been promoted. On the spot, Woon-seong had undone at least one of the bracers. However, today, he did not remove any. *How strong does he think he is?* Kwak Soo-

mil was angered by Woon-seong's actions, which he thought was a disregard for his status and strength.

In response to the question, Woon-seong responded lightly, "I'll take them off when I feel the need."

A cold, curt answer. At that point, Woon-seong's gaze had narrowed into a look of obvious disregard.

With that, red-colored energy poured from the palms of Kwak Soo-mil like fire. "Haha, good. I'm sure you're well aware that it would be too late to regret it after your death."

Whoa, whoa, whoa.

The moment Kwak Soo-mil prepared to fight, it became obvious why his nickname was the 'Palm of Blood and Jade'. His energy coalesced into blood-red orbs, constantly growing in size as they floated above his head. It was as if a dozen red moons were rising behind the man.

"Then come. Face my blood spheres!"

Kwak Soo-mil waved his hand. A sharp wind rose from his fingertips and flew towards Woon-seong.

Wind?

Skee-!

It wasn't wind of course, but the energy of the blood spheres from the hand of Kwak Soo-mil. The man was expanding and contacting his spheres into whips, swinging and cutting with them.

With these couple of movements, the stage the two were standing on split like butter under a hot knife.

It was a failed attack since Woon-seong had side-stepped, but the destruction demonstrated Kwak Soo-mil's attacking power.

That's some remarkable power, Woon-seong commented to himself. He wasn't surprised though. Considering that Kwak Soo-mil wasn't some ordinary Great Demon, this level of power was to be expected.

Those who were watching swallowed their saliva. This was a battle between Great Demons. Based purely on ranking, it was a battle that should result in an overwhelming victory for Kwak Soo-mil.

Someone in the crowd commented, "So that's the power of the high-ranking Great Demon, Kwak Soo-mil! That's some incredible power!"

Others, those watching from high above, had different thoughts though. *Idiot. So there's a reason he's only a Great Demon. The important part is that the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit casually evaded that.*

The Great Demons watched the movement of Kwak Soo-mil, while the Demonic Kings noticed the movements of Woon-seong.

Such was the difference in strength and insight.

Unlike the general predictions, there was no quick, overwhelming victory.

Instead, Woon-seong was still boldly on the stage. Although Kwak Soo-mil hadn't shown his true power, Woon-seong's movements were still too casual.

In the meantime, the tensions on the stage continued to rise.

In fact, Kwak Soo-mil seemed angry at the fact that Woon-seong had easily evaded his attack.

"Evade? You dare evade my attack?" *No. Evading it is still possible. But he shouldn't be doing it that easily! I've become stronger with the pills! Enough to become a Demonic King!* "Let's see how much longer you can do that!"

Sching-!

Kwak Soo-mil moved his hand and red whips streaked out from the blood sphere and swept across the stage. His attack blew through the area like a red-colored storm!

Despite all this blood-haze obstructing his vision, Woon-seong moved forward slowly.

One step, and a streak passed over his right shoulder.

Two steps, and another brushed past his thighs.

Three steps, and Woon-seong bowed his head lightly. Several strands of his hair were cut off as another whip rushed overhead.

Another step, and a blade passed by his sleeve.

Woon-seong stepped forward and dodged the attacks, getting more precise as time went on. As it continued, none of the whips even touched his clothing.

Kwak Soo-mil felt like he was attacking thin air.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong continued to walk forward.

With each step, Kwak Soo-mil's eyes widened further and further. Fear of the young man walking towards him began to settle in.

Before his fear could reach a tipping point, Kwak Soo-mil shook his head, shaking off Woon-seong's imposing presence.

"Grrrgh!" The blood sphere above Kwak Soo-mil's head grew larger and larger as Woon-seong moved forward. Then, picking it up, Kwak Soo-mil raised his hands high, "Then try avoiding this with a straight face!" Cackling to himself, he threw the huge blood sphere at Woon-seong.

"Heh-heh-heh!"

Contrary to expectations, Woon-seong only stood there and smirked. As the sphere seemed to swallow him, Woon-seong moved the White Night Spear

for the first time during this battle.

Shiriririt-

The White Night Spear spun at a fierce speed, sending white-colored whirls of energy shooting from his hands like a rainstorm.

Like a bubble bursting, the huge blood sphere burst under the intense pressure that was building from within. Instead of fierce red energy gathering in that spot, it was now a bright, painful white.

As Woon-seong once again entered the audience's field of view, he prepared to execute the 'Lightning Stitch Flying Blade' Spear Style!

"Grrrrgh!" Kwak Soo-mil could not believe what was happening. *He broke my blood sphere...? It was made with a lifetime's worth of qi...This can't be happening. I've become stronger than before...!* Kwak Soo-mil crossed his arms in front of him and prepared to block the spear, "Come at me with your puny attack!"

It was obvious that Kwak Soo-mil was prepared to even lose his arms in order to block this attack.

Alas, that desire wasn't enough.

The spear tore through Kwak Soo-mil's body, even hitting his heart, and blood spurted out as he crumpled to the floor.

Just like that, with one move from Woon-seong, the previously ranked tenth Great Demon Kwak Soo-mil fell without achieving his goal of becoming a Demonic King.

As if controlled by a higher power, the White Night Spear drew an arc and fell to the ground with a light '*thud*' just a few feet away.

Using the hole now present in his opponent's torso, Woon-seong was able to see where his spear had landed. Like nothing major had happened, he walked over and casually retrieved his spear.

Indeed, to him, maybe nothing had.

From start to finish, the young man hadn't even broken a sweat.

It was Woon-seong's overwhelming victory.

For one large section of the audience, there was complete silence.

The results of the match seemed to make all the spectators lose their breath. It didn't matter what happened on the other three stages, who was dying or who was surviving. The only thing that had their attention was that lone figure holding a spear.

After a moment, the audience exhaled.

The reactions of the Great Demons who provided pills for Kwak Soo-mil were even greater.

Disbelief. Complete and utter disbelief.

This wasn't the result that Kwak Soo-mil had promised them! In exchange for the humiliation of the young rising stars, they had sacrificed their own wealth and improvement.

Shock and regret, even fear!

Of course, for the other top 10 Great Demons and practitioners above, this was a largely anticipated result. The difference in strength was already known. In fact, victory and defeat had been predicted the moment Woon-seong avoided Kwak Soo-mil's first blood whip with a casual sidestep.

The level of the general public was just too low compared to Kwak Soo-mil and Woon-seong, so they had not been able to discern it.

Nevertheless, it was a surprising enough result.

The fact that a high-ranking Great Demon was so easily dealt with meant that Woon-seong had likely reached Demonic King level. Such status and strength at such a young age! Was there anyone who was like him?

Those who thought this way were startled again and couldn't help turning their heads to look in a certain direction.

There were indeed people who showed such strength.

The most powerful practitioners of their time.

Impossible skills and devilish talent at the age of twenty or so.

It was only natural for their eyes to turn towards the zenith.

Cheon Hwi, the Heavenly Demon. The Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, who could split the moon in a teacup as entertainment.

The Woon-seong of now was actually like the Heavenly Demon during his youth!

Whether he knew what the demons were thinking or not, Cheon Hwi was smiling lightly as he looked down at the stage.

There was one more person staring intensely at Woon-seong.

“Amazing!”

Cheon Ah-young, who had been looking over, urgently covered her mouth. Did anyone hear her say that? She realized her mistake and bowed her head in haste, but still snuck another glance at Woon-seong.

Seriously, though. He really is amazing. That much skill at such an age. All things considered, I'm in no position to feel like his rival. How much of a gap is there between us?

A sense of competition could only be shared when opponents were at a somewhat similar level.

It was now obvious that Woon-seong and Cheon Ah-young were nowhere near similar.

Back in the Cave of Latent Demons, I thought we were similar...

No record, no show of strength was comparable to his.

She should have known that he wouldn't stay quiet after exiting the Valley of Thousand Spirits.

Cheon Ah-young sighed. She had to admit it now.

Woon-seong is stronger than me. No, he's stronger than any demonic practitioner of his age...maybe even stronger than any preceding demonic practitioners! At this pace, he'll become the next Young Leader.

It was pretty clear that Woon-seong would be the top candidate, given his age and newfound status. From her position, A-young could only watch him.

The Young Leader will grow to become the Cult Leader. And the bloodline of the Cheon Family, as the bloodline of the Heavenly Demon, must live on. If so...

It seemed, then, that Hyuk Woon-seong's future and Cheon Ah-young's future were already set.

...That's what happens. I think I finally know why I felt curious about you.

Since the first time they'd met, Ah-young had been curious about the boy numbered 900. This curiosity seemed to lead to some kind of fate. Of course, Ah-young barely acknowledged this thought and continued to bury it deep within her heart.

The Divine Fire seemed to burn a little brighter.

At that moment, the crown burst into noise.

“Whoa!”

Originally standing in the silence on the stage, Woon-seong now took a step forward. To the side, the body of Kwak Soo-mil was being removed by some organizers.

He had won the challenge and got the ranking he deserved. Even if it was still within the Great Demons, it was now in the top 10. Most people would be satisfied and get off the stage.

Except, Hyuk Woon-seong still had not left.

Instead, his gaze was on the Demonic Kings.

The people watching gulped. What was this young man about to do?

Woon-seong bowed towards Cheon Hwi and said: “I ask the Heavenly Demon. In accordance with the provisions of the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame, may I continue fighting ?”

At his question, the crowd began murmuring.

“What is he doing, staying on the stage?”

“Is he thinking of doing more after that tough battle?”

Cheon Hwi raised his hand and once more, silence reigned. Everyone, including Woon-seong, tensed.

“I approve.”

The Heavenly Demon had just given Woon-seong permission to challenge a Demonic King.

Unseen, Woon-seong smiled at these words. Now he had control of the situation. He raised his head and his gaze returned to the horde of Demonic Kings.

Of course, their gazes were also on Woon-seong.

Who would he point at? Who would battle this young man?

The power was in his hands!

The moment everyone's gaze became focused on him, Woon-seong opened his mouth.

“Which one of you will accept my challenge?”

Surprisingly, Woon-seong handed the knife over to them.

This was an open provocation!

[1] Woon-seong became a Great Demon by beating Ah Neung-so, who was ranked around 230.

Chapter 54: Demonic King (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 54 – Demonic King (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Hmm.”

The Demonic Kings who had just been provoked all twitched and glared down at Woon-seong in silence. Some sneered in derision, others snorted in amusement.

Woon-seong wanted *them* to challenge *him*? What a joke.

This was an act showing that the position of the Demonic King was clearly at the top of the Cult.

Combining all the recorded and unrecorded members of the Cult, there were less than 50 Demonic Kings.

Born and raised under the banner of ‘survival of the fittest’, they stood proud.

Gwan Tae-ryang noticed, however, that some of these Demonic Kings looked a little cautious. It was clear that they weren’t exactly afraid, merely cautious.

The Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, a young man less than half their age, was trying to challenge them.

Was Woon-seong's confidence mere youthful arrogance? Given his achievements so far, it was hard to say.

If Woon-seong had pointed one of them out, it would have been easy for that Demonic King to step forward. However, as Demonic Kings, the current situation was a bit uncomfortable .

After a few beats of chaos, there was one person who slowly walked up.

“I accept your challenge.”

A uniform that was almost entirely black with dozens of throwing knives strapped to his body, also a katana to the side.

With his appearance, several Demonic Kings flinched.

Cult of the Heavenly Demon, Demonic King Rank 26.

It was the ‘Demonic King of Dark Pursuit’ (暗順魔君), Yeo Moon-rang.

The man's feet seemed to stay on the ground when he moved. This was a showcase of his self-made footwork, called ‘Ghost Steps’.

Several Demonic Kings tilted their heads as they watched Yeo Moon-rang walk up to the stage. It was a bit weird for him to be making a move. The man was an assassin, most skilled for stealth during the darkest of nights. Even if he wasn't weak, direct confrontation out in the open like this was not his strong suit. Also, there should have been no conflict between the two.

Woon-seong was interested in testing himself against this opponent of his, but was also confused as to why Yeo Moon-rang had accepted his challenge. *Does he have a reason?*

Yeo Moon-rang was also staring at Woon-seong, but he was thinking of other things.

It looks like the ‘Blood Slaying Five Shadows’ have failed. I taught them myself; they were my disciples. Each one of them was equivalent to a low

ranking Great Demon. They were supposed to become the next 'Demon King of Dark Pursuit' after me...yet none of them returned after trying to assassinate the young man in front of me.

Yeo Moon-rang observed the young man standing in front of him. The mission he had received a few days ago rang in his ears.

"Is this the organization known as 'Death Curtain' run by Yeo Moon-rang? I have a job request for you."

Not all Demonic Kings did, but many high-ranking Demons ran private groups. It was like the Heavenly Brain Tower under the Senior Strategist, a small group loyal to itself. Many Great Demons also imitated such groups, though those held much less influence.

Some organizations were not official, or were at least not advertised by their leaders.

Death Curtain was one such hidden group, as it was an assassination organization created to effectively silence people in and out of the Cult. All involved identities were hidden when missions were made and received.

It was a request like always, but the target this time was a big shot. That was the reason why I sent the 'Blood Slaying Five Shadows'... But none of them came back...and their target, the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, returned alive and even attended the Banquet.

The death of the Five Shadows was a problem too, but Yeo Moon-rang was more worried about the consequences of failing the request. Any request made to the Death Curtain had to be accomplished. That was why he stepped out. He needed to finish the request with his own hands.

Yeo Moon-rang picked up some knives with his left hand. Four in total, placed between each finger. With his right hand, he grasped his katana and slowly walked forward.

There wasn't much Yeo Moon-ryang could do other than fight Woon-seong now that he had stepped onto the stage.

Woon-seong felt the pressure of the Demonic King and wondered to himself: *How much can I do without taking any bracers off?*

He would think about the assassination attempt later, the current situation had not been resolved yet.

Between opponents, there was nothing to talk about.

Peng-!

Woon-seong swung the White Night Spear and the air in front of him exploded.

No! What exploded was the inky black robe that Yeo Moon-rang had been wearing!

He disappeared! He's at the level of being able to hide himself even without the assistance of darkness!

Woon-seong immediately activated the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, which would heighten his sensory abilities. With its qi released, the air seemed to be distorted around him.

Above me!

Woon-seong immediately looked up and hurled a throwing knife into the air.

Grrrr!

The energy shredded the air horribly, but the throwing knife did nothing to the katana falling down. It looked like a black line — a line that connected the living to the dead.

Ding!

Woon-seong's knife hit the oncoming katana and bounced off, falling to the ground. However, he had gathered some information from that attack.

It's not a simple attack with his katana...Just as I expect from a Demonic King.

‘Spear Curtain’!

Woon-seong moved to create a solid wall in front of him, instinctively blocking the oncoming attack.

Of course, his choice was not wrong.

The katana aimed at his heart crashed against this curtain of light and the surrounding air exploded.

Yeo Moon-rang thought, *It makes sense that the Five Shadows lost. He realized the hidden throwing knife behind my katana.*

“What’s happening?”

“It’s too fast, I can’t see anything!”

Given the speed and destructive quality of Demonic Kings, the audience was having a hard time enjoying the show.

“What’s happening?”

“It’s too fast, I can’t see anything!”

Even so, the battle continued.

Despite the shield he had formed, the hidden knife still grazed Woon-seong’s shoulders.

I’m lucky it wasn’t poisoned. Maybe he isn’t using it because we’re on stage?

But at the same time, Woon-seong had also been holding back! He shook his arms roughly, rolling his shoulders. He removed the weights and a sense of freedom wrapped around his whole body.

As he did so, something came flying out of the dust, flung towards Yeo Moon-rang. It was obviously something heavy based on the whistling sound of the air.

Yeo Moon-rang realized he did not have time to dodge and instead put his arms up to shield himself. Like a true assassin, his judgement was swift and his actions were even faster. Knowing he could not dodge, he crossed his arms immediately!

Boom! Boom!

Yeo Moon-rang felt fractures in his arms as something heavy thudded into his body. He was lucky nothing had been broken, but the pain was still there. His arms trembled and he raised his head, enduring the agony.

But...

Boom!

“Ugh!”

Yeo Moon-rang looked at what had been thrown at him, suppressing his excruciating pain.

“Iron bracers?”

At first glance, it was just an iron bracer and didn’t look very heavy. As Yeo Moon-rang raised his head, he noticed Woon-seong, whose steps looked lighter than before. There seemed to be a single iron ring still bound to his body.

Seeing that, Yeo Moon-rang felt two emotions at the same time: shock and anger. As he was still absorbing how absurd the situation was, red hot anger hit him. Of course, anger was more intense than any other emotion and stirred up his energy, causing it to surge outwards.

“I am dumbfounded. You dare think of fighting me while wearing chunks of metal? And furthermore you didn’t take any of them off until now!?”

Woon-seong felt the power rushing into this body, but had to control himself from becoming intoxicated by this liberation. He picked up his spear, his own energy soaring. “Taking them off feels so much better. By the way, why the fuck do you care if I wear bracers or not?”

As Woon-seong twisted in midair to avoid the oncoming attacks, he threw some knives.

Ta-da-da-da!

There were sounds and sparks as iron clashed with iron, the energy released distorting the air.

“Hmph!”

“Is that the ‘Great Eight Moves of the Cloud Dragon’ of the Kunlun?!”

Yeo Moon-rang seemed to recognize some of the Orthodox skills that Woon-seong’s spear style contained. *No...it’s similar but different.* But because of the skills of the Unrecorded within the White Night Spear and his new experiences, Woon-seong’s moves were still different.

“Let me see how you can stop this, too!”

Yeo Moon-rang gathered his energy together, causing the strands to overlap one by one and increasing the overall strength of the attack.

The complete synchronization of his sword and qi. Sword aura!

Usually, when you saw at such a show of strength, the overwhelming presence alone would cause you to lose your will to fight.

That wasn’t the case for Woon-seong.

“Hehe, bring it on!”

Woon-seong’s eyes flashed with strength, glowing with determination. His energy flowed through his forearms like a haze and gathered at the tip of his spear.

'Spear aura!'

Since Yeo Moon-rang wanted to use sword aura, then Woon-seong would use spear aura.

Furthermore, a dark, hazy energy wrapped around Woon-seong like a garment.

'Intimidation Dress!'

What's more, the White Night Spear trembled as it reacted to Woon-seong's energy. The will of the spear resonated with him, pouring out its energy and accepting his will. At that moment, it was as if he had truly become one with his spear.

The light from his spear was like a constellation that glowed brightly within the night that was the Intimidation Dress.

It was a complete form of spear aura!

Chapter 55: Demonic King (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 55 – Demonic King (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Boom!

The energy from Woon-seong collided with that of Yeo Moon-rang. As the spear and katana met, sparks flew into the air.

With this move, it was clear that Woon-seong had become much faster than before. Now, he could move faster than the wind, traveling meters within an instant. The spear in his hand was natural and he looked as if he were dancing.

Yeo Moon-rang saw the inky black energy that was the Intimidation Dress around Woon-seong. *What's this cold feeling?! Is it this black aura around me...*

He woke himself up from the momentary stupor and blocked out this foreign energy from invading his senses.

Once again, he attacked and energy waves spread out with a bang.

He's pretty good! As this exchange continued, it became clearer that the Woon-seong currently in front of him was much stronger than Yeo Moon-rang originally thought. *Such a complete spear aura at such an age! That is*

some horrifying talent right there. If I don't break him now, I'll regret it later.

With this in mind, Yeo Moon-rang's attacks become sharper and even more silent than they were before. He threw some knives with his left hand, then brandished the scabbard of the katana.

Woon-seong swung his spear.

Whee!

A knife prevented Woon-seong from forming a shield of energy. Even so, it seemed like Woon-seong had deflected it easily. However,

He's dangerous.

Woon-seong watched a knife clatter to the ground.

None of the moves are flashy at all, but each one of his moves are heaps more lethal than whatever Kwak Soo-mil threw at me. If I let him land a hit on me even one, it will definitely block a pressure point, leading to sure death.

He sure is a master killer.

Woon-seong spat some blood out from his mouth.

But, there's something odd about his killing intent. I myself am dueling him with the intention to kill...But those eyes! It's as though he's simply gazing at prey, not an opponent! And these moves of his remind me of the five assassins that came after me at the Valley. What is the relationship between them...

Energy continued to flow from Woon-seong's arms into the spear, attempting to maintain a certain level of spear aura.

But that doesn't matter. I simply have to win over Yeo Moon-rang here. He's not an opponent I can afford to fight while thinking about other things. I'll just ask about it afterwards.

There was evidence on Woon-seong's body and clothes of his fight, as blood trickled from the numerous injuries found all over his body. Maybe it was the pain in his body, but Woon-seong's eyes glowed amber for a moment. At the same time, he erased all useless thoughts from his mind.

It was as if the dragon that was slumbering within him had finally awakened.

A strong vortex of white and golden energy swirled in front of the young man. It looked unusual at first, but it was soon clear that Woon-seong was preparing for some final attack.

He seems to be up to something. Normally, for big moves like that, it's not necessary to face it upfront and I would rather parry or dodge it... But looking at the scale of it, those don't seem to be viable options. I would get myself killed trying to dodge it.

Not only is there overwhelming 'flow' and 'vigor' in a single skill, but there's also 'bewilderment' in it! It's simply impressive.

And against such a powerful force, I should also focus my attack and pierce through it!

Yeo Moon-rang thought quickly and acted just as fast. Instead of moving his feet, he wrapped his energy around his twelve throwing knives and katana. Although it looked less flashy than what Woon-seong was doing, he was also focusing his ferocious energy in order to pierce through anything and everything.

“Demon Art of Dark Pursuit Special Move ‘Pinpoint Death’!”

Kuaaa!

At that moment, the roaring of a dragon could be heard from Woon-seong's direction.

Flow of the Divine Dragon! 'Two huge forces of energy collided with each other with a loud boom. An intense, bright light wrapped around the entire

stage. Unable to stand the power, the stage collapsed and slowly fell to the floor, causing dust and debris to fly into the air.

“Who won?”

“What happened?”

The dust rose so high and was so thick that the crowd couldn't see the results of the match.

One of the Demonic Kings who had been watching intently swept his hand in an arc, blowing away the sand and dust in the area.

Down below, on the destroyed stage, there was only one person still standing. The other had fallen to the ground, half of his body mangled and torn.

“Look! The Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit is still standing! But his wounds seem deep...And the Demon King of Dark Pursuit...”

It was Woon-seong who had won.

Despite this, Woon-seong did not look good at all. There was a huge gash across his chest, which was bleeding, and many other smaller cuts.

“Heh heh heh, what a shame. Both of us would have been lying down like this if my attack went a bit deeper...”

“That would've been the case if my ‘Flow of the Divine Dragon’ was weaker,” agreed Woon-seong. Yeo Moon-rang was a Demonic King after all.

Woon-seong pressed his palms onto his chest, attempting to stop the bleeding. The flow seemed to weaken, but it was hard to tell.

One person falls down, another remains standing. That was the distinct difference between who won and who lost.

Woon-seong's position meant that he was now a Demonic King.

“I see. It’s no coincidence that you defeated the ‘Blood Slaying Five Shadows’ and come back in one piece.”

“Blood Slaying Five Shadows?”

Woon-seong tilted his head, but couldn’t concentrate. The bleeding from the wound on his chest wasn’t stopping and his energy was draining at a rapid pace.

“However, don’t...think this is...the end of it...”

“What do you...” Woon-seong, who had been trying to speak, stumbled on the spot. “Uagh!” Blood spilled out of his mouth like a waterfall as he coughed.

Baek Woon-ji came running over. “Captain! You need medical attention, now!”

However, instead of looking at her, Woon-seong stared at the dying Yeo Moon-rang.

What the hell did he mean? Who is he talking about? Is someone in the Cult targeting me? Who and why?

Woon-seong had so many questions he wanted to ask, but they would remain unanswered.

The only one who could answer was unable to speak and he himself was losing consciousness.

“Captain!” It was possible that Baek Woon-ji could read the expression on Woon-seong’s face, or was just concerned with how pale it had suddenly become.

“Kuarg!” Woon-seong fell forward, once again coughing up blood.

Master, am I going down the right path? Someone, please tell me...

After Woon-seong fainted and was taken to receive medical attention, the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame continued on as scheduled. However, there were no longer any intense fights like that of the previous two.

There were a number of Demonic Generals challenging to become Great Demons, but a collision between Demonic Kings was never a common occurrence.

By the end of the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame, the ranks within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had changed.

A whopping ten members had promoted themselves from Demonic Generals to Great Demons.

Among them, of course, was Gwan Tae-ryang.

When Woon-seong woke up, five days had passed since the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame.

He woke up with a gasp and almost immediately started coughing.

What happened? My whole body is aching and throbbing with pain....Oh, that's right. I fought with Yeo Moon-rang...

As he coughed out some blood, he felt a towel pressed to his cheek. Wiping away the blood, he turned to the side only to find Baek Woon-ji. As their eyes met, Baek Woon-ji lowered her head and unknowingly blushed.

To her, Woon-seong spoke in a small voice, "Thank you."

There was a small glass of water, which Baek Woon-ji offered to him. "Would you like a glass of water?"

"No, I'm fine."

She hurriedly lowered the glass.

At that moment, the door opened and someone barged in.

“You’re awake!”

It was Gwan Tae-ryang of course, a man who had become as loud as he was burly.

“It seems like quite some time has passed,” Woon-seong commented.

“It’s been five days since you lost consciousness.”

“The Banquet must be over by now. How are the results?”

“Results? Which ones are you talking about...?”

Woon-seong replied briefly, “The ones of the Charred Dragon Unit.” He wasn’t curious about the results of his own match; Yeo Moon-rang had obviously died. “Because I doubt even a Demonic King would survive after losing half of his body.”

Even if Woon-seong had passed out not long after, it was doubtful that anyone would try to stop his ascension as a Demonic King. If people wanted to argue, Yeo Moon-rang had passed away and ghosts were not allowed to testify. Since his spot would be vacant, Woon-seong would naturally end up filling it. So the important point now was the results of the Charred Dragon Unit.

The Charred Dragon Unit was a force that only listened to Woon-seong. It was a precious supporting base for Woon-seong, who was now a Demonic King and lacked any real connections in the Cult.

If the Charred Dragon Unit has shown excellent results in the Banquet, I will also have gained status.

With this question, Gwan Tae-ryang and Baek Woon-ji looked at each other. However, the one who spoke first was Baek Woon-ji.

Chapter 56: Results Of The Banquet

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 56 – Results of the Banquet

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Let me answer,” Baek Woon-ji said. “Most of the members of the unit have promoted themselves into the rank of Demonic General.”

“Demonic Generals...”

Back when the Cave of Latent Demons ended, there had only been three Demonic Generals: Cheon Ah-young, Gwan Tae-ryang, and Woon-seong himself.

Technically, it had been four, but Dal Mu-ji had almost immediately met his demise under Woon-seong’s hand so he didn’t count.

Now, a little more than a year later, most of those from the Cave had become Demonic Generals.

“Not bad. Has anyone become a Great Demon?”

Woon-seong turned towards Gwan Tae-ryang as he asked, looking forward to the answer. Since the first time he came out of the Cave, his lieutenant was already a Demonic General. Given his abnormal growth rate, there was nothing unusual about becoming a Great Demon.

Gwan Tae-ryang nodded, smiling brightly, simultaneously happy and embarrassed. “That would be me. Even though I’m only part of the lower ranks...”

Woon-seong nodded. “Good job. It couldn’t have been easy.”

It was clear that the Great Demons would have desperately defended their positions, so Gwan Tae-ryang’s rise in status reflected his own efforts.

As Woon-seong praised him, Gwan Tae-ryang beamed.

However, his laughter disappeared as soon as it came due to his captain’s next words.

“But don’t feel satisfied. Remember my words when we first dueled and keep trying.”

Thinking back to how he was called a ‘frog in a well’, Gwan Tae-ryang smiled wryly and nodded. “I’ll keep that in mind.”

“Anyways, we’ll leave you alone, Captain. The doctor said that you need absolute rest for at least three months! We’ll leave some spare clothes for you.”

After the two had left and he had changed his clothes, Woon-seong sat in a lotus position.

I can’t just stay in bed for three months. Heavenward Soul Earthen Body... There’s one thing I learned through all these battles. This Buddhist art doesn’t simply complete the body, but also heals it. My body is slowly, but surely rejuvenating. I guess it makes sense that an injured body isn’t considered a complete one...

As he sat there, Woon-seong felt the energy cycling throughout his body.

What’s this force?

There was something new.

It was like his original energy, but purer and clearer. As this new energy touched his wounds, it resolved his internal injuries and got rid of any trauma.

Innate essence qi?

Innate essence qi, like its name, was the energy of life that all creatures were born with. It revived all things and benefitted all nature.

However, it seemed to be moving according to his control right now.

So Heavenward Soul Earthen Body is an art that controls innate essence qi.

This has never happened before... Maybe it touched the roots of my life force because I've been practicing it for so long? It's such an incredible art!

Woon-seong's eyebrows could not help but twitch. There were very few martial arts that dealt with innate essence qi. A martial artist could even go his whole life without having the ability to control, or even feel, his innate essence qi.

Woon-seong remembered what his master had told him all those years ago about innate essence qi.

"Do you understand what innate essence qi is? A martial art that can control innate essence qi is thought to break through the limits of a human and allow enlightenment into the realm of gods."

Woon-seong hadn't believed that it was possible for a martial art to enlighten a human into a god then; he still wasn't sure about it now.

Who would've thought that some lost Buddhist Art had such powers!

No... It's too early to judge if it actually does that or if my innate essence has simply been stimulated by my injuries.

Woon-seong shook his head. As long as he continued doing what he was doing, everything would eventually be understood.

Let's not be too hasty.

Sitting on his bed, Woon-seong slowly sank into a trance. Unknown to him, his spirit seemed to be showing a change. Very small sounds echoed through his body and this new energy flowed through his system.

With clean clothes and a wash bowl in hand, Baek Woon-ji tilted her head questioningly in the hallway. *What is this smell?*

A sweet smell that I can't exactly describe...I think it's coming from Captain's room.

To her, it was refreshing. She was attracted by the smell and unwittingly visited him.

It was still dark outside and Woon-seong had not opened his eyes yet. However, the view inside was certainly a sight Baek Woon-ji had never seen before.

A shimmering light flowed out from his body and formed a shape.

Moreover, the shape was...

A dragon?

It was the appearance of a single dragon. The shape was not yet complete, but it was writhing in the air.

Baek Woon-ji gazed at the dragon for a long time, as if in a trance herself.

It was only a matter of time before Woon-seong woke up.

“Phew.”

He stretched his limbs and did a thorough check of his body. As he found out, there were some successes.

I fixed my inside and outside, then combined them into one! [1] I finally formed a martial body. Maybe my body modification from earlier helped the

completion of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body too? My original plan was to form a martial body with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body and then achieve body modification... There was a change in order, but things turned out pretty well.

As he slowly opened his eyes, rolling his shoulders, he saw Baek Woon-ji standing in a haze by his bedside.

The young woman was still immersed in her thoughts, unaware of the passage of time. *It doesn't look like he was experiencing deviation, or had a sudden understanding...*

“What are you doing?”

Baek Woon-ji woke up from her stupor with his words. “Oh,” she frowned a little, then brought forth the clothes and water. “I thought you might need these...”

Woon-seong looked down at his body and nodded, “Thank you.”

During the process of forming his martial body, it seemed that he had sweat quite a bit. His garments were essentially soaked through.

As he peeled his clothes off, Baek Woon-ji asked, “Are there any problems?”

“I don't like how I can't move around. But besides that, I'm fine.”

“But the doctor said you should rest for around three months.”

“That's his opinion.”

Woon-seong swept his chest area lightly, where the wound was healing. So far, there was only a small difference, but it was a noticeable difference. That was some incredible healing power given that it had only been three days since the match.

My body is slowly healing. At this rate, I should be able to get up within two weeks.

Now that the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame was over, there was silence inside the palace once again.

There were currently only two people in the palace: Heavenly Demon Cheon Hwi and Senior Strategist Sang Gwan-chuk.

The one who spoke first was the Senior Strategist.

“It seems like they did not show themselves.”

“It only means that they are careful enough to not show themselves because of such taunts,” Cheon Hwi replied coldly.

The Cult Leader was right, of course. Sang Gwan-chuk had recommended provoking the Great Demons in order to catch some tails about the resistance but had gotten nothing. It was natural that he was a bit dejected.

“I was hoping for us to catch something this time. It is quite a shame.”

The Heavenly Demon nodded slowly.

This year, the Banquet had three distinct purposes.

The first objective was to stimulate the Great Demons and find the traitors.

It seemed that the first objective had failed, but that didn’t mean the rest of their goals had too.

“But the attempt was not in vain. We failed to provoke the Great Demons into doing questionable things, but we had about ten young ones become Demonic General-class martial artists.”

Of course, ten more Demonic Generals was not a big deal for the Cult. What was important was their age, as these were all youths who had come straight out of the Cave of Latent Demons — youth meant talent and time. A thirty-year-old Demonic General would probably stay a Demonic General for the rest of his life; a twenty-year-old one had the chance to reach higher.

“And even though it is just three, there are also people who have become Great Demons and a Demonic King. Gwan Tae-ryang, the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, and the Young Lady...”

The Charred Dragon Unit has a lot of talented individuals, Sang Gwan-chuk noted as he reported.

“They will bring caution within the Cult while working as the new, young blood of the Cult.”

The Great Demons, who had settled for their positions, should be aware. No, not only the Great Demons, but also the Demonic Kings. The Senior Strategist smiled faintly as he thought about Woon-seong. *I thought he was going to aim for a high-ranked Great Demon at best, but he's beyond my expectations. He's even brought awareness to the Demonic Kings.*

And the final objective of the Banquet this time...

The Heavenly Demon spoke just as the Senior Strategist stopped smiling.

“It seems like that child is the only choice.”

The Senior Strategist nodded at these words, “The matter has been decided then.”

The final goal of this year's Banquet was the decision of the Young Leader.

The answer was now obvious.

“Summon the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit into the Inner Garden of the Divine Palace as soon as he recovers completely.”

[1] He's healed his external and internal injuries, thus also fixing his soul (spirit) allowing him to form his martial body and complete the 'Heavenward Soul Earthen Body'.

Chapter 57: A Summons

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 57 – A Summons

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“I thought you were going to punish him.”

The man, who was dressed in black robes and had just spoken, trembled, as the man sitting across from him remained silent. As the silence stretched, he began to suffocate.

“Cough. I made a mistake being so upset. Please forgive me,” the shadowy man spoke. His tremulous voice clearly held the meaning of forgiveness. *He’s at the level of choking me just because he’s upset. And yet...he’s still not sure he can defeat the Cult Leader...? ‘Soul Splitting Flame King’, Joo Moon-baek.*

That was when Joo Moon-baek said, “It looks like I’ve underestimated him.”

“Are you talking about that brat?”

“Brat? I really think you should reevaluate those words...” Joo Moon-baek tilted his head and squeezed the teacup in his hands. The water boiled and white steam spilled out. “Within two years of leaving the Cave of Latent Demons, he started from a Demonic General and ended up a Demonic King. Yet you still insist on calling him a brat?”

The man in shadow unknowingly nodded at these words.

“Admittedly, even I thought of him as a mere lynx, but he turned out to be a tiger. This is clearly my fault.”

Joo Moon-baek admitted that it was his mistake, but the other man could not respond. It wasn't because he disagreed, but because he had seen Joo Moon-baek's power with his own eyes. It was surprising, and doubtful, that Joo Moon-baek would have made such a mistake.

“However, just because I made a small mistake does not mean that the big plan is ruined.”

The man in shadow twitched. “Did you succeed?”

“Of course,” Joo Moon-baek grinned.

The shadowy man really disliked that smile, but he did not forget to pay attention to the words being said.

“The Cult Leader consumed the poison yesterday.”

“Oh!”

“Considering how deep and powerful his inner strength is, we still need to wait for any symptoms to show up. But I can guarantee with my life that he has consumed the poison.”

“Is that so?” *The Soul Splitting Flame King... I doubt the Vice Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would make up a lie like that.*

“The process would be faster if we gave him some more poison, but unfortunately, I don't think that will be possible.”

The man in shadow closed his eyes, thinking. His organization's alliance with Joo Moon-baek was built on mutual understanding. But it would take a long time to get confirmation?

That was a shame.

“Hmm. How long do you think it will take?”

“Six months, at maximum. And within a whole year, he will barely be able to move his body.”

Hmm, the shadowy man took a moment to think. If it wasn't for the Spearmaster 10 years ago, the big plan would've been achieved then. But it was a plan prepared for decades, so a single year shouldn't be a big deal...

“Do you have a problem?”

“No,” the man in black quickly shook his head at the question. “I just remembered an unpleasant memory.”

Anyways, the shadowy man shook his head, as if erasing that memory. The two people of the Spear Master Sect were killed that day, and as long as the Cult of the Heavenly Demon moves as planned, our big plan will be completed.

Joo Moon-baek laughed, “How about forgetting the unpleasant past and moving on to the future?”

“I should do that,” the man also smiled.

Both of them grinned, hiding their poisonous intentions.

“‘The ‘Spear of Gale’ or the ‘Spear of the Black Dragon’.”

Woon-seong, who had been following after the Senior Strategist, suddenly stopped and looked over in confusion.

Sang Gwan-chuk was still facing forward and walking, “Some even say it's the ‘Spear of the Black Gale’.”

“I don't follow,” Woon-seong said, chasing after the other again.

The Senior Strategist glanced at Woon-seong for the first time, “Is it the first time you're out of the ward?”

“It took me some time to recover.”

I see. “Then that makes sense,” Sang Gwan-chuk nodded. “It’s what the demonic people are starting to call you.”

Now that Woon-seong understood they were nicknames, he slowed down once more. “Oh.”

“It’s a nickname they made because your movements on the stage looked like that of a black dragon or a gust of wind. The ‘Black Gale’, I say it’s quite the nickname.”

That said, Woon-seong smiled unconsciously. *‘Black Gale’. I see. So it’s ‘black’ because of the color of the Intimidation Dress and ‘gale’ because of my vigorous moves.*

Without having looked back, the Senior Strategist commented, “You seem pleased.”

“It’s not bad.”

After that, there was a period of comfortable silence. Woon-seong took the time to look around him.

It’s a path with complete darkness, but the glowing marbles in the walls lead the way. Glowing marbles are supposed to be more expensive than gold, yet there are so many of them.

Where the hell are we going?

Woon-seong smiled bitterly to himself, remembering how they got here.

A steel door behind a monument in the Divine Palace. And a tunnel connected to it. Has it been about 15 minutes since we entered? I think I hear water flowing somewhere...

Right then, the Senior Strategist broke the silence, as if reading his mind, “Did you know that there’s a lake above this tunnel?”

The word ‘lake’ made the Woon-seong’s shoulders twitch and tremble. Just now, he had indeed heard the sound of water. “I was wondering what that sound of water was. So it was a lake.”

There’s a lake at a place of such high altitude? Woon-seong silently marveled to himself.

“Yes. This path was made under the lake. No need to worry that the lake might collapse on top of us.”

Sang Gwan-chuk smiled at his little joke. Woon-seong also smiled despite not finding it very funny, thinking it would be better to match the atmosphere.

“Do you know where this path leads to?” the Strategist asked him.

“Since we’re in the Divine Palace, I simply assume it’s somewhere inside the Palace.”

Somewhere in the Palace, the Strategist snorted to himself.

“Somewhere in the Palace, that’s not wrong.”

After speaking, he accelerated. Following him, Woon-seong also sped up.

“The Divine Palace is divided into the Inner Garden and the Outer Grounds.”

After saying that, the Senior Strategist glanced at Woon-seong. He was speaking lightly, but he could clearly feel the boy’s gaze sharpen.

“The Great Demons do not know about this. They simply presume that there’s a place somewhere that the Cult Leader dwells.”

They stopped walking for the first time.

“And we are heading to the Inner Garden,” continued the Senior Strategist.

“This tunnel, which is the path to where the Cult Leader dwells, is only

known to the Demonic Kings. Since you are now a Demonic King, there's nothing wrong for you to know about it."

There was an iron gate where they had stopped, just like how there had been one at the entrance of this tunnel. Woon-seong looked at it curiously.

"Do you know what this means?"

"It means that this place is about as important as it gets. I assume only Demonic Kings or above are allowed, with the exception of maybe the Cult Leader's family members."

As Woon-seong talked, the Senior Strategist slowly brought them closer to the iron gate with a laugh.

"Exactly. What you said is all correct except one thing. The *right* to enter the inner garden without being a Demonic King or the Cult Leader's family member. Do you know what that is?"

"I cannot say I do."

The moment Woon-seong shook his head, the Senior Strategist knocked on the gate and then pushed it open with his hands.

Cold wind blew through the gap and some wisps of grass rushed past the two.

The smell of vegetation between the gates...The outside?

Woon-seong became sure that the iron gate led outside and turned toward the Strategist. Unlike before, the Senior Strategist was smiling earnestly and gesturing forwards.

"The answer lies here."

The world beyond the iron gate.

A wide open field with a perfect view of the vast night sky.

Chapter 58: Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 58 – Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Crackle.

A large flame burned brightly upon its altar.

After the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame, the Divine Flame was transferred back into the Divine Maiden's palace and kept away from the public eye.

In front of this altar, an old woman was currently kneeling. Naturally, this old woman was the Divine Maiden of the Cult.

Within the Cult, she was the person most intimate with the Divine Flame.

Towards this flame, the Divine Maiden neatly bowed and began to pray.

How much longer can I protect the Divine Flame? I was chosen as the Maiden when I was twenty.

That was before Cheon Hwi, the current Heavenly Demon, ascended the throne.

And it has been over forty years since then...

She smiled with reminiscence, wrinkles gathering around her eyes.

I remember those times. My five little brothers and I couldn't eat properly or wear nice clothes. If I didn't become the Maiden, we probably would've ended up dead in one of the freezing winter nights.

Thankfully, the Divine Flame chose me and my brothers were saved.

All five of them have grown to become warriors of the Cult.

There is no doubt that I owe my life to the Divine Flame.

Thank you very much.

O'great Divine Flame, Will of the First Heavenly Demon...and that is why I am worried. Because I know that I don't have much longer to serve you...

She was the Divine Maiden, carrying part of the Will. It was said that all Divine Maidens thus had a sense of foresight, but it didn't matter. Many people could feel themselves weakening as they died — even animals could sense death.

She lifted her head and watched the flame. That vibrant flame that had never been extinguished since the beginning of the Cult. Just looking at it made her feel better.

She had never learned martial arts, studying only religious mantras and doctrines.

She closed her eyes slowly and knelt in a kowtow once more.

“O'great Divine Flame, I do not have much time to live. So I desire to choose a Divine Maiden that suits you.”

It was a sincere prayer, *Please select a good successor.*

As if in response, the Divine Flame crackled with vigor.

Whoa, whoa, whoa!

“So this is Lop Nor,” a young woman wearing a large hat sighed.

This is going to be like finding a needle in a haystack. Master isn't helping much either. How am I supposed to find Younger Brother in Lop Nor without any clues? Maybe even Master doesn't know where he is exactly.

She shook her head, sighing again. She stuck her hand into a pocket and took out a folded piece of paper, which opened to reveal a drawing of the Sword of Man.

Hmm... I don't want to self-praise too much, but I did draw his face pretty accurately. But can I really find him with this facial composite? I should ask around after getting something to eat...

She shook her head once more before stepping confidently into a restaurant on the street. Due to the constant stream of merchants passing by, restaurants in Lop Nor were always bustling with activity. As it was about lunchtime, she decided it was an excellent time to ask around.

Just as she walked inside, a young boy greeted her. “Welcome!”

“Can you get me something I can eat that is light, like fried rice and vegetables?”

“Yes, ma'am. Fried rice and veggies coming right up.”

The boy was very cheerful and the woman nodded satisfactorily, then handed him the drawing.

“Also, would you mind taking a look at this if you're not too busy?”

“Oh, is this a facial comp...Ah!”

The young woman had been watching the boy and was surprised at how he sharply inhaled. That wasn't shock, it was terror. How unexpected.

“What's wrong? Do you recognize this person?”

“Where did you get this sketch? Are you from the authorities?”

She shook her head, “I’m an apprentice of Qingcheng and this is my martial brother.”

“You’re saying that... this man is a warrior of Qingcheng? But he’s the leader of the Sandstorm of Death.”

The boy’s reactions and words were making her surprised and confused. She tilted her head at the unfamiliar name. “The Sandstorm of Death?”

“It’s a famous group of bandits in this area! Although they haven’t been active for a while... but they were very active around a year ago.”

... One of the Three Swords of Qingcheng being a leader of bandits? The young woman was appalled. “That can’t be! There must be a mistake!”

Like she asked, the boy looked at the drawing again. Soon though, he looked up, eyes filled with certainty and he spoke with conviction. “I remember this man raiding our village. The man in this sketch is definitely the leader of the Sandstorm of Death.”

The young woman was furious. If it weren’t for the fact that the boy looked like he was just beginning puberty, she would have drawn her sword for insulting the integrity of Qingcheng.

“Are you sure?” she grit out.

Now the boy was indignant and yelled, “I am sure! *And* I’m sure everyone here knows that this man is the leader of the Sandstorm of Death!”

Surprised at this confirmation, the young woman stood up. She approached people who were eating and showed them the same drawing. Very soon, she felt her insides twisting. No matter who she asked, everyone answered the same way.

“Ugh!”

The young woman groaned in frustration and rested her head in her hands.

“Are... you okay?”

“This... leader of the Sandstorm of Death... where can I find him?”

The young woman did not know for sure that her martial brother was actually a bandit, but was determined to find him.

Her question was one that no woman would dare to ask, but she wasn't just some woman. She was a disciple of the First Apprentice and one of the Three Swords of Qingcheng.

Finding some bandits shouldn't be a problem.

“I don't know... They haven't been active for a year now...”

“But there should be a place they used as a base, right?”

“Uhm...” The boy hummed and hawed, not sure what to do. *Should I tell her? There's no way that they would leave a girl like her untouched...*

“So you do know! Please tell me!” She shook his shoulders in agitation.

“But, they'll do terrible things to you...”

“You don't have to worry about that. I'm stronger than you think.”

She drew her blade from its sheath and swung it down, slicing the table in one move. The boy, and many of the other guests, were all surprised.

“See? I'm an apprentice of Qingcheng. A mere group of bandits is no match for me.”

Seeing him still hesitate, the young woman took out a lump of silver and placed it in the boy's hands. “This is for the food and the table I just destroyed. You can keep the change.”

“Ugh...,” the boy wavered some more. *This thing alone is worth several months of my salary... and I can use the money to feed everyone at home something better...*

In the end, the boy could not overcome the temptation of money.

“Go to the old temple, their base is there.”

“Thank you.”

After months of travel, the young woman had finally gotten a clue about the Sword of Man’s whereabouts.

However, she did not know that she would be sorely disappointed.

The man she was looking for was already dead, as was her master, both done in by the hands of one Hyuk Woon-seong.

Walking through the field of grass, the night sky stretched high above Woon-seong. There was a small pond not far from him, where a fountain of some sort caused the water to flow and bubble.

He couldn’t help but be surprised by what he saw.

So this is the Inner Garden of the Divine Palace?

Following after the Senior Strategist, he had been sure that he was heading *inside*, yet now he ended up *outside*.

Apparently his sense of direction needed to be checked.

And all of this is man-made... The power of the Demonic Cult continues to surprise me.

Woon-seong stuck his tongue out in contemplation.

The Senior Strategist, who led him here, had already closed the iron gate and left.

In other words, the only one standing there was Woon-seong himself.

By the way... I did come in, but where the hell am I supposed to go now?

The only thing the Senior Strategist had told him was to go inside for all the answers.

The exception to the ‘only family or Demonic Kings and higher’ rule...

It was at this moment that some force was transmitted over, causing the wind to blow, whipping at his clothes.

“Hup!”

Cold sweat dripped down Woon-seong’s neck as he watched the energy flow around him.

It’s a force, calling me.

This was the Inner Garden.

There was only one person who could be summoning him here.

Woon-seong shot towards the origin like an arrow, hurtling through the grass. The wind broke around him as he ran, whistling in his ears.

Eventually, he reached a bridge, which led to a pavilion in the middle of the lake.

It didn’t take long for Woon-seong to cross the bridge and he stopped at the entrance of the pavilion.

A man spoke as if he had been waiting for Woon-seong to arrive.

“You’re here.”

Chapter 59: Mind Sword

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 59 – Mind Sword

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Woon-seong gave a formal greeting, lowering his head.

“I, Hyuk Woon-seong, present myself to the Leader.”

The owner of the calling force and the only other person present in the Inner Garden.

The other man was the Heavenly Demon, the Cult Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, just as Woon-seong had guessed.

Woon-seong had never seen Cheon Hwi anywhere other than his throne before, which made this meeting a little different.

If the Heavenly Demon sitting on the throne looked like an asura, the man standing before him was a magnanimous sage.

That's weird. He feels smaller than when I saw him on the throne... It's almost like he's a foot smaller than back then.

Woon-seong had thought that the Leader was 7ft tall, but it looked like he was actually around 6ft.

Moreover, the atmosphere was unexpectedly welcoming.

Suddenly, Woon-seong's eyes met the Heavenly Demon's.

"It's nice to meet you," greeted Cheon Hwi.

Woon-seong bowed in haste. It could be considered a crime for him to study the Heavenly Demon, if Cheon Hwi deemed it so.

But Woon-seong had clearly looked into the other's eyes.

They say that the eye is the window to the soul, allowing you to read another's mind. If so, what does the gaze inside the Heavenly Demon's eyes mean? Does it imply confidence that he can unleash a furious storm whenever he wishes?

Even though it was just the eyes, part of Woon-seong was trembling.

Hmm...

I can feel it. A gap between the two of us that I cannot possibly fathom...

Woon-seong wasn't sure whether or not Cheon Hwi had purposefully shown him the gap.

Cheon Hwi spoke once more, "Come up here."

"How can I dare...", Woon-seong said, as any demonic cultivator would.

Cheon Hwi smiled. "No need to be polite. Your eyes tell me that's not your true nature. Come, I need a drinking companion."

These words caused Woon-seong to raise his head.

So the Leader was also looking into my eyes. If so, what did he see inside me?

Woon-seong was curious, but he didn't ask. Instead, he stepped onto the stairs and into the pavilion. Inside, there was a table with some cups and a bamboo container.

Two cups that are barely touched... It looks like he was preparing for me to come.

As Woon-seong ascended the stairs, Cheon Hwi sat down. "Have a seat."

That said, Woon-seong quickly sat down across the table. Although it was a simple phrase, the words carried an aura of sovereignty. He had no idea what the other was thinking, but he was just another demonic cultivator in the presence of the Cult Leader. He had no real choice.

Once Woon-seong had taken a seat, the Heavenly Demon glanced at him and smiled. "Have a drink." He raised his hand, grabbed the bamboo container, and poured some liquor into Woon-seong's cup. "Bamboo Green Tea is best served cold."

As he said this, the tea in Woon-seong's cup was frozen.

Woon-seong's eyes widened as he watched. *There's thin layer of ice on the drink... and he did it with just his aura.*

The Heavenly Demon acted like nothing out of the ordinary had happened. He filled his own cup and raised his glass, downing it first.

Following Cheon Hwi's example, Woon-seong also finished his glass, politely holding it with both hands.

Tak-

The Heavenly Demon spoke after putting down his cup. "Good...So I've heard that you've become a Demonic King."

"Thank you. I was simply lucky."

"A Demonic King isn't a rank that one can achieve simply through luck."

Woon-seong could only stay silent.

What did the Heavenly Demon want to say?

He didn't have to wait long to find out.

“There are many in the martial world known as ‘elite apprentices’. Not only in our Cult but even in the outside world, the martial society has always been full of competent martial artists. The elite apprentices are no different.” The Heavenly Demon’s eyes did not stray from Woon-seong’s, eyes a swirling gray. “However, the world may be vast, but I doubt anyone has achieved your level at your age.”

An unknown energy gushed from Cheon Hwi’s body, enveloping Woon-seong. It was not an intangible force. Upon facing it, Woon-seong felt like he was facing the Heavenly Demon that sat upon his throne.

The Leader’s presence feels colossal, like a mountain. This must be how it feels to see a mountain emerge before yours eyes. And this is him not even showing his aura, but just his presence.

Even my master wasn’t at this level...

It only makes sense that he claims to be the absolute top of the world. How much power does it take for a person to possess such an overwhelming presence? No, it isn’t about his power. It simply means that Cheon Hwi is a man of such caliber.

Feeling this force, Woon-seong was certain.

He feels different from the Heavenly Demon that I have known. I never remembered him being such a humane person...

Which side was the real one?

Or maybe both sides are his true faces.

While Woon-seong was lost in thought, the Heavenly Demon opened his mouth once again.

“Let me propose an offer.”

Cheon Hwi paused for a moment. At that time, his eyes seemed to be filled with intense longing.

Woon-seong's gaze sharpened. An offer from the Cult Leader was something anyone would be greedy for.

“Become the Young Leader of the Cult.”

“...” Embarrassingly, Woon-seong was shocked into a stuttering silence.
“W-What... do you mean?”

At those words, Cheon Hwi drank a cup in silence. He did not take Woon-seong arguably rude words to heart.

The Heavenly Demon drank three cups of tea in succession. Each time, he would also fill Woon-seong's cup. Every time the Heavenly Demon emptied his cup, Woon-seong would do the same.

“I have always said that the Young Leader shall be appointed from those who are capable.”

Woon-seong nodded.

The Leader's selection criteria was well known throughout the Demonic Cult.

Of course, Woon-seong had been aiming to become the Young Leader from the beginning. That was why he had put effort into becoming somewhat famous, standing out and showing his skills.

But he never thought that this day would come so soon. Sure, it was his goal, but it was a bit embarrassing because it was too sudden.

I have been aiming to become the Young Leader, but I've never imagined that I would achieve it this easily...

“And out of those who are considered to be the next generation, there is no doubt that you are the best within the Cult.”

In Woon-seong's stunned silence, Cheon Hwi got up from his seat.

"It's quite awkward for me to talk in this way."

The Heavenly Demon slowly descended the stairs and walked across the bridge, staring down at the lake.

Woon-seong quickly followed behind him.

Upon the surface, a full moon was illuminated. Moonlight spilled across the pond. Cheon Hwi smiled.

Suddenly, an overwhelming sense of power rushed from the Heavenly Demon's body.

"Do you know why people call me the 'Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon'?"

Woon-seong swallowed.

He changed again. A tyrannical tone that can't possibly be from the same nice man, who was smiling up until a moment ago.

Woon-seong was easily influenced by the changes in the atmosphere and understood.

I see. They're both the same man. Neither is a facade. The Leader is a man with two faces.

Woon-seong's voice trembled slightly as he spoke, "It's because of the story that you have split the moon that was reflected in a glass of wine."

He did not say that it was just for entertainment too, but it was implied.

Cheon Hwi nodded slightly at these words. His gaze was still directed towards the lake. To be precise, it was directed at the reflection of the full moon.

“It should be an unbelievable story. It may be a reflection, but how can a mere man possibly split the moon?”

Woon-seong felt like parts of him were being sucked towards the Heavenly Demon. Something other than energy and air were being drawn in and clumped together. He had no idea what it was or what it looked like, but his back was covered in cold sweat.

“However, there is no end to the potential of martial arts and ‘impossibility’ becomes a mere word the closer you reach and the further you go upon this road.”

Roar!

The voice of the Heavenly Demon resounded through the area as he pointed at the reflection, making a single vertical stroke.

Before Woon-seong’s eyes, something amazing happened.

Following Cheon Hwi’s finger, the moon upon the lake slowly split in two.

There were no ripples from the wind, only the half moons.

A martial god!

Woon-seong jaw had fallen at this breathtaking show of power.

The Heavenly Demon made a grasping motion and the moon reflected in Woon-seong’s eyes returned to its original state.

“The reflection of the moon on a lake is no different from that in a glass of wine.”

Cheon Hwi was still standing by the water, looking at the moon he had just split.

“However! What I truly want to cleave is not a mere reflection of the moon!”

Cheon Hwi raised his head.

Woon-seong looked up too, feeling compelled to under the atmosphere created by the Heavenly Demon. In the sky, he saw the full moon floating high as if it were the Heavens. The highest peak in the sky! For some reason, the moon looked larger than ever.

As soon as he saw the moon, Woon-seong turned back to look at the Heavenly Demon.

No way...

He suddenly remembered what the man had just said. *“What I truly want to cleave is not a mere reflection of the moon!”*

Does he mean... that what he truly wants to cleave is... !

Before he could finish that thought, Cheon Hwi spoke again.

“Become the Young Leader of the Cult and become my apprentice.”

Something gathered again in front of Cheon Hwi.

“Then I shall give everything to you. The 100,000 followers of the Cult, the martial artists within them.”

It's like my consciousness is being sucked in.

I get it... The Leader isn't presenting aura or qi. It's a manifestation of a human's consciousness. An absolute force that cleaves even the image in the mind!

“Even this power!”

With the sound of something shattering, the very image of the moon reflected within Woon-seong's mind split in two.

The 'Mind Sword'! [1]

The Heavenly Demon's voice echoed into Woon-seong's ears once more.

“Let me say it again. Become my apprentice. Become the Young Leader of the Cult.”

It was an offer he couldn't refuse.

[1] Also translated as the 'Heart Sword', meaning that it cuts the image reflected in one's heart. Basically, Cheon Hwi can change the perception of those around him.

Chapter 60: Young Leader (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 60 – Young Leader (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Huff...huff...”

After following the young boy’s directions, the young woman from Qingcheng arrived at what remained of the Sandstorm of Death’s headquarters.

The only thing that she found, other than the worn down buildings, were the dozens of skeletons left to rot in the desert.

No, wait... none of these are his body...

Where is he... ?

Ah...

She saw a familiar sword in the distance. Rushing over, she reached out and picked up the sword, which was now dull and rusted. However, the words engraved onto the edge of the sword could be no mistake: “Heaven, Earth, Men”.

The young woman trembled as she ran her fingers over these words, collapsing onto the floor.

This was the sword of her martial brother.

Her eyes teared up.

The skeleton by the sword was confirmation of the Sword of Men's death.

At the same time that this young woman learned of her martial brother's death, there was a great commotion in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

"Hey, did you hear about that?"

"About the Young Leader? Of course I did!"

"The position of Young Leader has been vacant for a long time..."

"Do you think he's good enough to be the Vice Leader?"

"Of course he is! His martial arts and contribution to the Cult are both exceptional."

"Haha. I heard he destroyed a whole Orthodox branch at the age of twenty."

"I've also heard that he's already achieved the rank of Demonic King."

"That's no rumor! I saw it with my own eyes at the Banquet."

All the noise was about the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, Hyuk Woon-seong, being appointed as the Young Leader.

Baek Woon-ji and Gwan Tae-ryang were walking down the street in the village looking awkward. It felt strange to hear people talking about their captain. The awkwardness was from how instead of their whole unit being complimented, their captain was singled out.

"Haha!"

Gwan Tae-ryang suddenly laughed out loud, the sound booming through the street. The people turned to stare at him in annoyance. The young man only shrugged off the stares.

How embarrassing... Baek Woon-ji ducked her head in shame. “Why did you do that? You didn’t have to add your qi to the laugh...”

It was obvious that Gwan Tae-ryang had done this to get attention.

The man in question was only slightly embarrassed and scratched the back of his neck. “I was just curious how many people would recognize me...”

Baek Woon-ji burst into laughter, “You’re such a kid sometimes... But don’t worry about that. People of the Cult are already praising you by calling you the ‘Great Demon of the Champion Blade’ (敗刀大魔).”

Gwan Tae-ryang had performed well in the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame, rising to the rank of Great Demon. Although it was only a Great Demon, there were only 300 of them in the Cult. It was a formidable rank for such a young age. After all, the rank of Great Demon meant that Gwan Tae-ryang now also had the authority to lead one of the Twelve Supporting Units.

“Really?” Gwan Tae-ryang was quite pleased with himself. He continued on with a smile, “But still, I’m nowhere close to our captain.”

“Of course not,” Baek Woon-ji nodded with a proud smile on her face. “Our captain is constantly breaking records within the Cult. Not only did he graduate the Cave of Latent Demons as the top when he started as Number 900, but he also became a Demonic King. To be honest, as a person who joined the Cave of Latent Demons as Number 700, I know how incredible that is. Our captain is a role model for people like me.”

Woon-seong’s achievements could not technically be considered unparalleled. Throughout the history of the Demonic Cult, there were other geniuses who had reached similar levels.

However, they were all of the Heavenly Demon’s bloodline, set to become the next Cult Leader.

Woon-seong wasn’t of the Cheon Family, but the result was similar. His talent had actually beaten out the Heavenly Demon’s bloodline!

Well, it was now public knowledge that Woon-seong was to be the Young Leader. If there were no mishaps, he would no doubt become the next Cult Leader.

A new conversation soon made Baek Woon-ji's smile drop, however.

“By the way, if he becomes the Young Leader, what happens to the bloodline of the Leader?”

“The position has been exclusive to the Cheon Family throughout the whole history of our Cult, right?”

Hyuk Woon-seong was definitely not of the Cheon Family, that was something to note.

Baek Woon-ji scowled, glaring at the road ahead. Gwan Tae-ryang had also heard this strand of conversation, but could only follow her in confusion.

“Oh come on. There's obviously a way to get around that. I thought you already knew about it.”

Just because the position of Cult Leader stayed within the Cheon Family didn't mean that all of the Cult Leaders were actually descendants of the Cheon Family. Throughout the thousands years of Cult history, it was impossible for no one like Woon-seong to pop up.

“Remember how the Leader has a daughter? Just make the two get married and you retain both the martial art skills and the lineage!”

That was not a new idea.

Marrying into the family had indeed occurred several times in the past.

“That makes sense! They could keep the bloodline going on with the Young Lady!”

Publicly thought, very little was known about this rumored Young Lady. People speculated that she should be around the age of twenty and should be an excellent martial artist, thanks to the lineage of the Heavenly Demon,

but were unsure. This was because the Young Lady had never appeared in public after she turned 10 years old. Her past and current whereabouts were a strict secret, unknown to even the Ten Demonic Masters.

There were thus numerous rumors about her.

Perhaps she was being homeschooled. How strong must she be if her father had taught her himself? But wait, if she was so powerful, why was Woon-seong the Young Leader...?

Maybe her bloodline was defective and the Heavenly Demon was embarrassed of her. She wouldn't have been killed, right...?

If the Young Lady wasn't weak, had she gotten into an accident and become horribly disfigured? Or maybe her beauty was too enchanting for the public...

Many people within the Cult talked about her, but no one truly spoke the truth.

In another area of the Cult, a young woman was hurriedly making her way into the White Ape Unit's building.

Having survived life and death together, this young woman was one of the few Demons who knew the truth behind the hidden Young Lady.

"Hmm? Dang Boo-ah! Why are you in such a hurry?"

"How about having a drink with us?"

Some of her friends called out to her.

"Not now! I'm busy!"

She ignored them. There was something that she had just heard and had to tell her captain immediately. Everything else could wait.

She ran up the stairs, heading into the highest room in the building. In her haste, she mastered the art of stepping five stairs at a time.

She slammed the door open and shouted, “Captain! Did you hear the news!?”

“You’re here, Bu-Ah,” Cheon Ah-young, Captain of the White Ape Unit, turned towards her. She nodded without any emotion, “... It’s nothing unexpected.”

“But how can they appoint the new Young Leader when there’s you...?”

“A stronger person is becoming the Young Leader. That should be good news for our Cult, don’t you think?” Ah-young smiled. “And I couldn’t help but admit it after I saw Woon-seong fight the Demon King of Dark Pursuit. It actually felt relieving to just let go and admit it. And then I looked back at myself. I’m the Captain of the White Ape Unit, one of the Twelve Supporting Units. And it made me think that I wasn’t doing too bad either. Woon-seong’s life is his; mine is mine. Each of us just needs to do the best that we can with what we have.”

Father also acknowledged me...

Ah-young closed her eyes.

She remembered Cheon Hwi’s eyes on the day she was promoted as Captain of the White Ape Unit.

While his gaze had not been one of a proud father, his eyes had also never once left her.

He was the Heavenly Demon, but definitely also her father. He distinguished between family and work; he worried for her, but could not favor her too much.

My father was still the same.

Cheon Ah-young slowly opened her eyes.

Dang Boo-ah stared at Ah-young, unconvinced. *She says that, but Captain hasn’t realized something... About the fact that she’s started calling the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit by his name...!*

“...Then did you also hear about the marriage?”

“Marriage?” Ah-young tilted her head.

Dang Boo-ah immediately started to explain the accompanying gossip, which was arguably more important.

“You didn’t know? About how they are saying that you need to sleep with the Young Leader to continue the bloodline of your family...”

Ah-young’s expression became stiff.

After Dang Boo-ah left, Ah-young was left alone in the room. She lowered her head, hugging her knees to her chest and burying her face in her knees. This was her habit when she was troubled or embarrassed.

This is nice and cozy... it helps me calm down.

Marry...?! I can admit that Woon-seong is stronger than me. But a marriage... I never thought about that.

Ah-young shook her head. That wasn’t correct.

No... deep inside, I probably saw this coming.

The ways to fulfill what my father said while continuing the lineage of the Cheon Family. It was either I became the next Cult Leader or I married the Leader-to-be.

It wasn’t that Ah-young hadn’t thought about the second option, just that she wanted her father’s acknowledgement and only cared about the first.

Maybe I didn’t have time to search my feelings because I was too busy seeing Woon-seong as a rival...?

Getting married... I don’t know about any of that stuff...

Under the moonlight coming from the window, the tips Ah-young’s of ears and her cheeks were tinted pink.

“Hah...” The person sitting down laughed drily. “It seems like things have resulted in a strange way! I was only planning to punish him a little, but destiny is quite unpredictable.”

Oh, destiny and fate were unpredictable indeed.

I thought he was a pesky flea, yet he grew rapidly and became part of the Leader's side. This is annoying... he will get in my way.

He became the Young Leader. Which means, even if the Leader dies like how I planned, there's another person who can legitimately inherit the position...

The Leader is poisoned and he will die one day. It doesn't matter how powerful he is. He can't survive that poison. That poison is something you would only find in legends.

The important part is, after the Leader collapses, the Cult will be divided into factions of the Vice Leader and the Young Leader.

The Leader has one year max until the poison consumes him. Objectively, that isn't enough time for the new Young Leader to build up a large faction of his own.

Nevertheless, let it be small or large, they will be an obstacle to the plan of I, Joo Moon-baek.

The man, who had been sitting, crushed the table in front of him with his hands. Clenching his fists, a huge plume of flame shot out from his palms, incinerating the wood. Black ashes fell onto the floor.

However, I shall not let that happen. I shall burn every last one of them!

If I can't make the Young Leader one of mine...

It would be impossible to take the throne while the Cult was divided. The problem had to be resolved somehow. Obviously, some weird sort of equal-standing partnership was not possible. [1]

... I'll just have to kill him.

I'll have to hire someone powerful, like how I hired the Death Curtain. Or in the worst case, I'll have to step in myself.

In the darkness, Joo Moon-baek began to move.

[1] The Vice Leader and Young Leader are technically of equal rank. The technicality comes from the fact that the Vice Leader is usually stronger, but the Young Leader is the legitimate next-in-line.

Chapter 61: Young Leader (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 61 – Young Leader (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Early in the morning of the next day, the Divine Palace was full of people.

Unlike the usual meetings, most of the Great Demons, all thirty Demonic Kings, and the Ten Demonic Masters were in attendance today.

Meetings like this were not very frequent — the presence of the top brass meant that today's meeting was about the future of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Everyone who was present had a good idea about what the meeting was about.

“I heard that the future of the Cult will be decided in today's meeting.”

“I thought that was fairly obvious.”

“You know, about the famous Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit...”

The Great Demons and Demonic Kings chatted amongst themselves.

Then, a new voice could be heard.

“Hmm, a Young Leader, or so they say... too bad I didn’t get to see him at the Banquet myself. I just had to be away at the time... I wonder what kind of man he is.”

The man who spoke looked to be seven feet tall. It was one of the Ten Demonic Masters, the ‘Fist Master of Demonic Wind’, ‘Wind Demon Fist King’ Koo Jong-byuk. He had left the Cult during the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame for some reason, so he had never actually seen Woon-seong. With his simple character of worshipping the strong, he naturally felt curious about this new Demonic King.

Once one of the Demonic Masters opened their mouth, the Great Demons and Demonic Kings could only awkwardly mutter.

In the end, it was the Senior Strategist who walked over and spoke.

“He is an exceptional martial artist for his age. He is one of the children the Leader has given special attention to. I expect he will only improve from this point forward.”

“Oh, Senior Strategist! Haha! It’s been a while! Would you mind telling me a bit more about the new Young Leader?”

“That shouldn’t be a problem.”

Unlike the previous day, the Senior Strategist used more respectful words in regards to Woon-seong. When they had first met, Woon-seong was just another demonic cultivator. However, now that the other was the Young Leader, there was no doubt that Woon-seong would become the Cult Leader in the future. Even if Sang Gwan-chuk was older and more powerful, Woon-seong’s rank was now objectively higher.

“Is there anything else you would like to know?”

“Thank you, Senior Strategist! It looks like the Leader has selected a brilliant heir!”

“I’m glad you think so.”

After he finished speaking, the Senior Strategist looked in another direction. His gaze fell upon a small group of people.

‘Soul Splitting Flame King’, Joo Moon-baek.

“Don’t you think so too, Vice Leader?”

“Hmm... Are you talking about the Young Leader?” Joo Moon-baek tapped his chin, eyes carefully blank. “I’ve heard the rumors, but the more I think about it... it just looks like I’ve grown too old to judge such things. I assume the Leader has made a sound decision anyways.”

Hmph... that cunning geezer... !

Not only does he spare his words, but it’s also hard to grasp what he’s thinking. On top of that, he never leaves traces of himself whenever he plans something.

I need to be careful of people like him. They are the type that can backstab you with a smiling face... exposing a weakness means an opportunity for them to take over. I’m sure that he is related to the wicked atmosphere within the Cult... I am confident of it. My instincts are telling me so, but I can’t act without any solid evidence. He’s one of the Ten Demonic Masters like me and is also the Vice Leader of the Cult, acting without evidence would only backfire.

The Senior Strategist lowered his gaze, keeping his thoughts to himself.

At that moment, someone entered the Divine Palace, making their presence known.

“We present ourselves to the Leader!”

Cult Leader.

The Heavenly Demon had appeared.

Silence swept the palace as the Cult Leader walked up to his throne and sat down, looking at the people gathered.

“Everyone’s here.”

The Heavenly Demon’s low, but heavy voice seemed to crush the air in the room. Those who gathered instinctively lowered their heads.

Joo Moon-baek was no exception.

Hmm. It looks like he can still withstand the poison. Or maybe the poison isn’t affecting him yet. With his head still lowered, Joo Moon-baek glanced quickly at the Heavenly Demon. At this distance, his face still looks unaffected. It makes me want to jump up there right now and thoroughly inspect his face. No... it must be because he only just consumed the poison. No need to rush right now. Because of his power, we need to wait for at least six months for the poison to show effects. I must be patient.

“Raise your heads. The reason I summoned all of you today... I believe all of you are already aware of it.”

The people nodded to themselves. It was about the new Young Leader, of course.

There were some murmurs of dissent among the Great Demons. They had seen Woon-seong the other day. Of course, when they saw him he had only just become a Demonic King from a Great Demon.

Hmm. The Heavenly Demon watched the commotion in silence for a few moments.

“Enough.” The Heavenly Demon waved his hand, causing a crushing pressure to silence those talking. “There’s no need to start a fuss about it.”

When he finished speaking, he tapped the arm of his chair with his finger.

Tuk-tuk-

As the small sound echoed and spread, shadows could be seen falling from the ceiling and opening the palace doors.

“‘Flower of the Dark Night’...!”

The snow-covered outside was revealed. Bright sunlight shone in through the open door, illuminating a single figure.

It was a man, about six feet in height. There was no spear upon his back today, but he was dressed in his finest robes.

The moment he showed up, all eyes were upon Woon-seong.

The young man in question walked into the palace, escorted by the Flowers of the Dark Night, past the cultivators.

Woon-seong had been to the Divine Palace several times now. But today, it was different. He did not enter the palace for the same reasons as the last few times.

Woon-seong stopped in front of the stairs that lead up to the throne. On his left stood Joo Moon-baek, the Vice Leader, and on the right was Sang Gwan-chuk, the Senior Strategist.

He greeted with a formal bow, “Apprentice Hyuk Woon-seong, I present myself to the Leader.”

His voice echoed throughout the Palace.

In the end, the suggestion to become the Young Leader was very attractive to Woon-seong.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon had long wanted to start war and invade Zhongyuan.

This feels terrible... but it's also what I've been aiming for. Young Leader of the Cult! I need the power of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon for revenge. I just need to inherit the position of the Leader and the Cult will become mine! Then everything shall be ready...

At the same time, it was also true that Woon-seong had hesitated when he received such an offer.

I am an apprentice of the Spear Master Sect. But what if I become an apprentice of the Heavenly Demon? What happens if I learn the 'Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon'?

No. That's not a problem, just like all the other arts I learned until now. I just need to combine the Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon with the arts of the Spear Master Sect. It won't be easy, but I can eventually do it...

The problem... is my master.

It's not about the martial arts.

Master, will you understand me if I served under a different master?

Woon-seong slowly closed his eyes. Could he convince himself of this part? After all, the dead could not answer these questions of his.

*"Woon-seong." The words of his master echoed in his mind as he thought.
"Woon-seong... I'm sorry..."*

Although he was troubled, Woon-seong soon came to a conclusion as he remembered his master's final moments.

Master. I will become the Young Leader of the Divine Cult. I don't care what you think...! I will avenge you, no matter what.

Master would never want me to take the bloody path of revenge. Because he was a chivalrous man...

But even without the demonic training, Woon-seong's temperament differed from the righteous Nok Yu-on's.

However! I have no intention of becoming chivalrous!

I can never forgive the hypocrites of the Orthodox Sects.

I don't care if I have to drench my hands in blood forever. I will achieve my revenge.

That is my choice.

Therefore, I will become the apprentice of the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong shook himself from his thoughts and stood up from his bow. He could feel the gaze of the Heavenly Demon on him.

The voice of Cheon Hwi boomed throughout the room.

“I have already decided who shall become the Young Leader. If anyone disagrees, speak now.”

No one complained.

No, no one *could* complain.

As the youngest Demonic King and Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, Woon-seong was the star of the younger generation.

Even those who did not look kindly upon Woon-seong could not object in this situation. Complaining when there was nothing to complain about? They weren't so suicidal.

The Heavenly Demon slowly nodded, then turned his attention back towards Woon-seong.

“If there is none, I shall appoint Hyuk Woon-seong as the Young Leader. Conduct the Nine Bows.”

He signalled to Woon-seong.

This was part of the formal ceremony, honoring the founder, seniors, and new master.

“First, bow thrice to the First Heavenly Demon, who protects us all from above.”

Woon-seong bowed towards the First Heavenly Demon, whose image was hanging behind the throne.

“Next, bow thrice to the Heavenly Demons of past generations.”

Woon-seong bowed to the images hung upon the columns lining the palace.

That was six; only three left.

“And finally, now thrice to your new master.”

Once again, Woon-seong went down to his knees and bowed three times.

At the end of the bows, the Heavenly Demon stood up from his throne and turned his head towards the image of the First Heavenly Demon.

“I pledge to the First Heavenly Demon that I shall take Hyuk Woon-seong as the Young Leader and my apprentice, raising him to be a leading figure of our Cult.”

The First Heavenly Demon was the founder of the Cult, the Heavenly Demon worshipped by all. As a demonic cultivator, it would not be wise to break an oath under his name.

Woon-seong followed the other’s example, “I pledge to the First Heavenly Demon that I shall become the Young Leader of the Cult and an apprentice of the Leader to become a leading figure of the Cult.”

The oath was fulfilled under the First Heavenly Demon’s name, watched by the Great Demons, Demonic Kings, and Ten Demonic Masters.

Hyuk Woon-seong had just officially become the Young Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

TN: I used ‘bow’ instead of ‘kowtow’, but Woon-seong performed what is known as the “full kowtow” that consists of three kneelings and nine knockings of his head against the ground.

Chapter 62: Training (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 62 – Training (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Since you’re from the Cave of Latent Demons, I assume you know about the ‘Dark Flower’.”

The Dark Flower is not only the basics in the Cave of Latent Demons, but also a basic cultivation method for all demonic practitioners...why is he bringing up such a basic cultivation method?

Woon-seong kept his confusion to himself. There was definitely a reason why the Heavenly Demon had asked about the Dark Flower — it couldn’t be to check if he knew the basics, after all.

“I do, sir.”

As Woon-seong responded, Cheon Hwi nodded lightly. Immediately, words began to flow from his mouth.

“The Dark Flower sets fire to the mind. The burning mind becomes red, referring to the Red Heart, and the Red Heart shall be planted with the true demonic spirit...”

Like a thunderbolt in his head, Woon-seong felt a strange rhythm from these words that affected the qi inside of his body. Like a cotton ball soaking up water, he quickly accepted the words into his mind.

“...With that, the Red Heart shall bloom an everlasting flame.”

At the end, just as Woon-seong had begun to suspect, Cheon Hwi said, “It’s a line from the ‘Red Heart’. Remember it.”

“Yes, sir.”

Woon-seong still sounded calm, but he was feeling a bit of shock and excitement. *The ‘Red Heart’ ... It’s a part of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon!*

“The Dark Flower is a basic cultivation method of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. But when it’s combined with the ‘Red Heart’, it becomes the ‘Advanced Art of the Dark Flower’, or the First Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon. Remember and review the ‘Advanced Art of the Dark Flower’.”

Woon-seong thought to himself, *It looks like I’ll have to accumulate the ‘Red Heart’ into my ‘Tempered True Blossom’.*

“I am grateful for your teaching. I will keep it in mind.”

The Heavenly Demon walked over to where Woon-seong had been sitting attentively. “Let me show you how the qi should flow.” He pressed a palm onto Woon-seong’s back. “I’ll inject some of my qi. Don’t resist it. Relax and let it flow.”

The Heavenly Demon told Woon-seong to relax, but how could the youth do so when it felt like being smacked by a tidal wave?

Guaguaguagua!

Not just physically but also mentally, Cheon Hwi had begun to teach Woon-seong the day after he was appointed to the position.

He taught me the First Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon on the first day. And he just taught me the Middle Connection on the second day... It looks like he wants to teach me everything in a short period of time.

Even if so... it seems like he's rushing it a bit too much. He's barely past his forties... why would he need to hurry?

Soon Woon-seong had to stop asking himself these questions.

“Focus your mind. Feel and remember the directions of the qi flowing.”

As the Heavenly Demon's voice echoed in Woon-seong's ears, he controlled the qi.

Woon-seong focused his consciousness on the process and memorized the flow.

The Leader's qi flows through my 12 main meridians, then the tangled meridians and exits back out. It's a powerful presence that flows through in a short amount of time. But... why is it familiar?

It's not completely identical, but the qi that the Leader is controlling inside me is following the path of the Tempered True Blossom.

The Tempered True Blossom' was based on the Spear Master Sect's 'Completed Method of the Tempered Orthodox Qi' and the Cult's 'Dark Flower'... I've also improved using the cultivation methods I learned from the Unrecorded. Since both the Tempered True Blossom and the Divine Arts make use of the Dark Flower qi-refining method, it's understandable if they are similar.

However, this is too similar.

A lot of it is especially similar to the cultivation methods I learned from the Unrecorded.

How in the world...?

Even when considering that the Dark Flower is the basis of all demonic arts, how can it be so similar in where it flows — where it flows fast, where it flows slow, and even where it flows backwards?

The Red Heart is a cultivation method only taught to the bloodline of the Heavenly Demon or the Young Leader. How can the two be so similar?

Given that the Unrecorded had originally been a part of the Spear Master Sect, Woon-seong was sure that the mysterious Unrecorded was not of the Heavenly Demon's bloodline. Obviously, there had been no Heavenly Demon with that name either.

So, why?

As Woon-seong was questioning it, Cheon Hwi was actually asking himself the same questions.

Hmm. There was a trace of worry in Cheon Hwi's heart at first, since this was the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon they were talking about. It wasn't a problem about bloodline inheritance, but an issue of Cult secrets!

Does he already know a cultivation method that has a similar breathing method? Even if the Red Heart is the First Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, it won't be completely different from the other cultivation methods. It can be somewhat similar to certain methods, but this is almost identical.

The Heavenly Demon's qi made a round through Woon-seong's body once more.

Cheon Hwi shook his head.

I even diagnosed all of his meridians, considering the chance that he may have somehow obtained the Red Heart... but it's not the Red Heart... I can only conclude that he learned a different cultivation method.

Just then, the Heavenly Demon's gaze shifted towards the spear lying next to Woon-seong.

It's a different spear than what I saw back when he was a Demonic General...

Oh, that's right. I let him choose a weapon from the Demonic Armory.

Suddenly, all of Cheon Hwi's worries and confusion melted away like snow. He smiled and glanced back at Woon-seong, who was still concentrating in silence.

He had figured out why Woon-seong's cultivation would have traces of the Red Heart.

I see... So it's the spear of the Unrecorded, the one he used when he was still alive...

Cheon Hwi focused back on Woon-seong, observing the energy flowing through his meridians. The other's blood vessels were also clearly visible, as if a ray of light was shining on him.

However, it's still not completely identical. His meridians are developed in a different way than that of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon. It looks like he added the Unrecorded's cultivation method on top of what he previously practiced.

Impressive.

But he still lacks understanding of the Unrecorded's method.

The accomplishments were not small, especially for Woon-seong's age. But it wasn't enough.

He hasn't reached the 'Divine Shaped Flame' yet... but the fact that he inherited the will of the Unrecorded... that in itself is a curious coincidence! Some would call that a strange fate.

However, this child has much more to learn before he truly understands the Unrecorded.

But when he does create the Essence of the Divine Flame in the future...if he can achieve the Divine Shaped Flame with the 'Unrecorded's Mind Connection', he shall be able to reach the truth between the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon and the Unrecorded. And if so, he may achieve a whole new power.

Cheon Hwi smiled to himself at these thoughts.

The energy that had been flowing in Woon-seong's body was disconnected, rushing back to the Heavenly Demon. "I retrieved my qi. Now try it on your..."

Although Cheon Hwi had retrieved his energy, he realized that Woon-seong had not woken up.

He's already started to review. That is some talent. The things we call a 'strange fate' or an 'enlightenment' are not something easily achieved...and this child is already well aware of that. Enlightenment only occurs after continuously reviewing the knowledge and experience one has newly achieved.

Practice, review, improve.

That was exactly what Woon-seong was currently doing, in a trance like state.

I need to remember and repeat the usage of the 'Red Heart', Woon-seong was telling himself. One at a time, with detail. The fact that it's similar to the Unrecorded's cultivation method bothers me, but I need to focus on the task at hand.

No matter how hard Woon-seong thought about it either way, he had no answer. At this point, the information wasn't necessary either.

Undoubtedly, the Heavenly Demon had also noticed the similarities.

Since the Cult Leader had chosen not to say anything, only time would tell.

Remember the paths the Leader opened up. Since he retrieved all of his qi, everything flowing inside of me right now is mine.

Within a short amount of time, Woon-seong was growing more and more familiar with this new energy.

It's flowing faster and stronger. So this is the Red Heart!

Woon-seong smiled to himself. *The Young Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. And it's symbol, the 'Dark Flower Red Heart'! It's just my first step, but I am closer to my revenge.*

As Woon-seong continued with his cultivation, Cheon Hwi was watching him from the side. No, it was better to say that he was making a judgement.

He's skillful! It's only his first time. How can he be reviewing for more than 30 minutes? On top of that, he has already fully understood parts of the Red Heart.

Cheon Hwi's eyes deepened, a small satisfied smile on his face.

Hmm, simply knowing and understanding are two very different things. That's just how talented he is...

What an amazing amount of talent.

Cheon Hwi had no knowledge of Woon-seong's past life. Thus, he had no choice but to conclude that everything was purely because of innate talent.

This much talent has never been heard of.

Even those of the Heavenly Demon's bloodline would not show such quick understanding.

Of course, Cheon Hwi's base assumption was incorrect.

Still, it wasn't like Woon-seong was going to correct him.

At the same time though, Woon-seong's real talent was not negligible. The Hyuk Woon-seong of the past life had been a genius apprentice.

Every time Woon-seong breathed in, he understood a little more. Slowly, he was approaching the source of his confusion. It would take him a while to get there, but he was making great progress.

After some time, Woon-seong slowly opened his eyes.

Though he had not found any answers, but had reached some sort of understanding.

The teachings of the Heavenly Demon did not end there.

The Heavenly Demon was not just some title — the previous cult leaders went through some hellish training.

“Huff...huff...”

I'm sweating like it's raining. I don't remember the last time I sweat this much.

There were now thin needles embedded into Woon-seong's wrists and ankles, perfectly sealing his energy. Not only that, the weights on his arms and legs had also increased.

“You were training with some quite interesting methods. Metal bracers... so sealing your inner strength and increasing the weight should vastly improve your fundamentals, correct?”

That's what the Heavenly Demon had said, so the weights were increased.

Curse it all. Woon-seong almost wished he hadn't even started weight training.

On top of that, I'm forced to continuously make dynamic movements, Woon-seong complained in his heart.

Woon-seong darted through the dark like a mouse, running here and there.

Trrng!

Cheon Hwi touched something with his fingertips.

It was a wire, thin like a strand of silk. The moment it was touched, an arrow was randomly released.

Swoosh—!

Woon-seong twisted to avoid it.

Damn it! It grazed my thigh! It did not tear his clothing, but the spot still stung with pain. *Thank Heavens it doesn't have a tip. If it was an arrow with a proper tip, it would've ripped my thigh.*

Woon-seong did not have time to dwell on that as Cheon Hwi touched the wire once again.

This time however, it wasn't just one wire.

Swoosh—! Swoosh—! Swoosh—!

Shit! They're coming!

Dodging arrows left and right, Woon-seong soon lost track of time. How long had he been running around in the dark?

Eventually, thousands of lights lit up the room with a soft hum.

The brightness revealed Woon-seong, who stood there looking like a blood-soaked murder victim.

Chapter 63: Training (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 63 – Training (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

It's finally over...

Woon-seong looked down at his body, gritting his teeth through the pain.

My clothing was pure white at the start. Now it's more red than white...

It wasn't blood. After all, the arrows were too blunt to tear skin. The red marks left on his body were from dye, which had been applied to the tips of the arrows.

A cloth drenched with red dye instead of an arrow head... this is a real clever method of training.

Woon-seong slowly tilted his head up, breathing in rough breaths. "Huff, huff."

"Your body must feel heavy. However, you must endure."

Woon-seong could hear the Heavenly Demon's voice emanating through the training room. It was possible that this room had been reserved, or maybe it had been set up specially for Woon-seong.

"This is the 'First Gate', the 'Gate of the Darkroom'."

It was literally a dark room.

When Woon-seong moved, he could not see even a single point of light. Thus, when the machine-controlled arrows flew, he had to dodge by instinct.

“It’s a training program in which you avoid numerous arrows launched by machine devices. Based on the color of your clothing, you can easily review and reflect on your performance. Remember, when your inner strength reaches its limit, the only thing you can trust is your will to not let go of your weapon and the training you have gone through!”

Cheon Hwi talked to Woon-seong from somewhere above. Woon-seong nodded and went to the corner of the room. In this corner, there was a pile of white clothes, which had not yet been worn.

Woon-seong picked up one of them and changed out of his current outfit.

“I’m ready.”

Woon-seong had returned to the center of the area with his fresh clothes.

The Heavenly Demon smiled slightly, then nodded, gesturing with his hands.

Whee!

A wind blew and all the lights went out, welcoming back the darkness.

It was time to go back to training.

It was only the First Gate, but it wasn’t easy at all.

If those arrows all had proper tips... Woon-seong felt a chill up his spine. I would be a hedgehog.

He shook his head as he gasped for breath, sweat pouring down his face.

I thought I trained intensively everyday, but this denies my confidence in that statement...

Woon-seong slowly closed his eyes.

An experience that pushes me beyond my limit. I would love to collapse right about now, but I need to review even if I'm exhausted. Because if I don't do it today, I'll make the same mistakes again tomorrow

So this is it...! If those who were titled the 'Heavenly Demon' were born only after going through dreadful training like this... then I shall face it too! I'll push through this if it's what it takes to achieve my master's revenge!

Woon-seong grit his teeth in determination.

The young man heard a small sound and when he opened his eyes, he found Cheon Hwi standing before him.

“It looks like you have surely improved.”

“Thank you, sir.”

Cheon Hwi's gaze was on Woon-seong's clothing, which was mostly white. *It's been exactly 15 days since he started his training at the First Gate. His dress, which was completely soaked in red on the first day, has only been grazed in a few places. The number of hits has drastically decreased.*

I am constantly surprised by his attitude and spirit, how he approaches the training. I can feel the value of teaching him.

Of course, Cheon Hwi also fleetingly wondered if Woon-seong was satisfied with his own improvement.

Cheon Hwi sat down next to the collapsed Woon-seong. “You're moving dynamically without the help of your qi. It's only obvious that your muscles are strained.” He placed a palm on the other's back. “Let me help you with that.”

Oooo-

A turbulent force rushed from the Heavenly Demon's body into Woon-seong's. It flowed through Woon-seong's muscles, relaxing and repairing them as it went.

Cheon Hwi let his energy circulate a few times before retrieving it. He threw a small pellet at Woon-seong, like usual. "Eat this."

He said that this stabilizes my body and rejuvenates my energy, Woon-seong thought, eating it. I would've collapsed by now if it wasn't for this.

"It's time to take out the needles too."

Cheon Hwi waved his hand and the silver needles drifted out of Woon-seong's body, carried by the wind.

Once the needles were removed, Woon-seong's body immediately felt lighter than before. *The qi restriction is gone! I feel much stronger than before.*

Cheon Hwi's voice broke through Woon-seong's momentary ecstasy.

"It's about time to move on to the next step."

It had been about two weeks since the start of the training at the First Gate, which focused on honing the senses. It seemed Woon-seong was ready to move on to the second.

"This doesn't mean your training in the First Gate is over. As before, we'll continue the training of the First Gate every day. Your skill level is only just good enough to enter the Second Gate. You haven't even mastered the First Gate yet."

"Yes, sir."

"Also! Considering your rapid pace of improvement, we will increase the difficulty of training."

It was only natural that the intensity of the training matched with the speed of improvement. Not only did the number of arrows flying at Woon-seong

increase, their speed also increased.

“Ugh!” Woon-seong groaned as he stumbled, an arrow hitting him on the thigh.

“The moment you sit down, you’ll only become a target of more arrows! Get up!”

Seriously. He doesn’t give me a chance to get used to the training at all.

Of course, Woon-seong could only endure.

Besides, training in the Second Gate was much more painful.

Ugh.

Woon-seong gripped his spear, searching his surroundings.

The Leader should be hiding somewhere in this maze. Did he hide his presence?

No. He’s not hiding. He’s simply existing. It’s just that I can’t sense him.

Just then, Woon-seong felt a tingling sensation and unconsciously twisted away from the source.

Shhhhh!

Something sharp sliced through the air, tearing the fabric at his waist.

I would’ve had a hole in my waist if I reacted any slower. Though there was no blood, Woon-seong’s hair stood on end. That was dangerous.

Woon-seong turned to look at the man who had attacked him, cold sweat still dripping down his neck.

It was the Cult Leader, of course, who was playing with something flashing silver some distance away.

It was a knife. It's a knife the size of a finger, but I was barely able to react.

As soon as Cheon Hwi realized that Woon-seong was looking at the knife in his hand, he acted once more.

Woon-seong instinctively raised his spear in front of him.

Ding-!

A small spark rose from where the knife had hit the shaft of the spear.

Woon-seong had no time to react before the knife was once more directed towards his neck. He acted on pure reflex.

“Ack!”

This time, several strands of Woon-seong's hair were cut off as he ducked.

Everything seemed to move slowly, time oozing like thick honey.

Another close call.

Cheon Hwi gave him a split-second to rest before moving once again. A hellish attack followed. Woon-seong reacted with the White Night Spear in his hand, but was unable to touch Cheon Hwi at all.

Just as Woon-seong was beginning to seriously struggle... *He disappeared!*

“I'm here.”

Woon-seong looked up to see Cheon Hwi, who was standing some distance away on the wall.

I didn't know there was this big of a gap between us. I'm sure he's not giving his best, but I can't even catch his shadow.

Woon-seong was angry, though he wasn't sure at who or what.

Cheon Hwi's voice lightly floated into the boy's ears, "If you're angry, be angry. Try harder to catch up to me."

The Leader's voice sounded mocking and the smile on his face was goading.

With a small sound, Cheon Hwi vanished from his spot on the wall once more.

The labyrinth walls were part of the Second Gate. When Cheon Hwi attacked Woon-seong, he freely went back and forth around the maze.

Woon-seong, who was in such a hurry to dodge and parry the oncoming attacks, had yet to make a single proper counterattack.

I would've destroyed the walls of the maze if I had enough qi. But I was restricted to 10 years worth of qi before the start of this training, so that's not an option...

"Huff, huff."

Woon-seong searched the area, breathing heavily. *Where did he go?*

Let's think about it. There must be a reason this training takes place after the First Gate. Focus. Use the sense you trained during the First Gate!

From his position above Woon-seong, Cheon Hwi let himself smile. *He's already starting to realize his sixth sense and use qi detection!*

It was then that the Heavenly Demon's voice echoed through the maze, coming from all directions at once.

"Don't let your guard down just because you can't see the enemy! They are always aiming for you!"

Something whistled through the air towards Woon-seong but was met by the White Night Spear. Without pause, numerous knives came raining down. Woon-seong twisted his body, barely avoiding them. He had no choice but to be continuously pushed back.

“You’ve gotten pretty good,” praised Cheon Hwi.

A compliment... Woon-seong chuckled self-deprecatingly. I’m only barely keeping up here.

But I’m starting to see his movement little by little, he comforted himself. I know he’s not giving me his best... but this is still exciting!

My senses are reacting before my eyes can catch up. There are always signs before a human’s movement. I just need to read them!

Within Woon-seong’s eyes, the figure of the Cult Leader could be seen clearly. He stared intently at the other’s movements.

I can see the Leader’s muscles twitching. A sign of attack.

Woon-seong lifted his spear and the knife was blocked with a sharp sound.

Clang!

The Heavenly Demon seemed a little surprised. *He’s predicting my movements through my muscles?*

“Oh-ho,” Cheon Hwi almost laughed to himself, then sped up his movements.

Shit! He’s speeding up! He’s only engaging with 10 years worth of qi too, but he’s faster than a peak level martial artist! Extremely swift movements like there is no limit.

Woon-seong’s head was spinning fiercely.

I need to think! How do I react to attacks that come from all directions? Do I retreat? Woon-seong thought about it, but shook his head. No... my path of retreat is also within his attack range. In cases like this, I must advance. Building the habit of retreating will only result in my death!

“Uahh!”

Woon-seong pressed forward, attacking wildly with his spear. His muscles twitched and energy gathered in the spear, which Woon-seong released in an all out offensive.

And then Cheon Hwi used the knife to swipe at the boy.

Just one, smooth movement.

Guagua-!

There was a flash of bright light and Woon-seong was swept into the air, slamming into the opposite wall.

“Cough!”

Fortunately, there were no heavy injuries on Woon-seong’s body.

Just before he had hit Woon-seong, Cheon Hwi had flicked his wrist to the side, changing the knife’s trajectory.

Still, Woon-seong could not help but be shocked. He and his all-out offensive, albeit an exhausted one, had just been swatted out of the air like a fly.

“That will be all.”

Woon-seong, who had been clutching at his chest, took this as permission to collapse. He stretched out on the floor, unable to get up. Fatigue had piled up in his body and finally spilled over his limit, so he let himself pass out.

That was the first day of training in the Second Gate.

It was one hell of a day.

I think I’m going to die...

Chapter 64: Ambush (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 64 – Ambush (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Woon-seong was returning to the Charred Dragon House in the middle of the night one day after training. His clothes were ragged and he had slight eye-bags.

He scowled. *I am exhausted.*

It had only been about two months, but Woon-seong felt like the Leader was rushing things. Why was the man trying to cram everything about the Cult into his mind?

Is he just excited that he has a young leader?

“Get up!”

The Heavenly Demon gave him very little time to rest, always telling him to stand up and begin again.

Even considering that, the training schedules are pushed too hard... and every time I get pushed to my limits, they heal me back with all the medicine they have in the Cult. I would probably be dead by now if the Cult didn't force-feed me pills.

Once again, Woon-seong had been surprised at the affluence of the Demonic Cult. They were very generous with the medicine that they offered him.

Thanks to that though, my body is stronger than ever.

Yet, even after two months, I have no idea why the Leader is in such a hurry.

There must be a reason.

Suddenly, Woon-seong felt his skin tingle.

A killing intent?!

Woon-seong turned on pure instinct.

A knife passed right by his ears.

If it were anyone else, it could have been considered luck. Woon-seong though, had predicted the knife's aerial course and dodged it by a sliver.

I didn't notice that knife until it was right next to me. If not for the training of the First Gate, that would have killed me!

Woon-seong sprang into the air, twisting and swinging with his spear. He deflected another round of small knives.

Hmm.

That was not the end, of course.

The darkness shifted, waiting for Woon-seong to make his move.

Some thin streaks shot out from the reed fields, coming at Woon-seong from all sides.

Glug-ug!

They were chains with knives on the ends!

Woon-seong used his spear to vault into the air and pulled his own knives out, causing the chains to miss and become tangled.

He lightly landed on the twisted chains.

Five chains... and the wielders must be at the ends.

'Lightning Stitching Throwing Knives'!

His throwing knives whistled through the air, each headed straight for the end of a given chain.

Kacha—

One of the chains was broken with a loud 'snap'.

He stopped the knives with his chain! They're pretty good... however...

Just this was not enough to catch Woon-seong. He grabbed the White Night Spear and swung it in an arc, aimed at the ground towards which he was falling.

Two more of them have secretly laid caltrops...

There had been a trap of iron spikes sprayed with poison just waiting for Woon-seong to fall on them. His spear strike swept them into the air, allowing him to land safely on his feet.

Woon-seong carefully surveyed the reed field he was standing in.

He counted the number of chains in order to determine the number of people he was dealing with.

There's at least 7 of them... and each one of them is heaps better than the ones that attacked me at the Valley of Thousand Spirits. An attack by assassins...

Woon-seong eyes turned dark, the words from the Banquet of the Heavenly Mountain and Divine Flame echoing in his mind, *“Don’t think this is the end of it.”*

This ambush was a continuation of the one before it.

Woon-seong’s mind whirled.

Who is targeting me? Why do they want me dead?

I can probably find out after suppressing these guys.

Woon-seong’s mentality suddenly sharpened, becoming like that of a beast. Like this, he did not hesitate to hunt and kill. He was able to rush in, grab a neck, and immediately sever the major artery.

That’s what he was doing now.

Starting with this one!

As Woon-seong’s spear moved, the reed field was split open. A man in black had caught his eye beyond the grass, holding a chain in his hands. It was clear that this man was one of the assassins targeting him.

Woon-seong rushed over mercilessly, spear pointed straight at the other’s throat. The man would have been instantly killed, if not for a sudden sound.

Fwoo~

The sound of a tungso (bamboo flute)?

The previously silent night air revealed a simple, yet extraordinary melody. As soon as it was heard, something jumped into the air.

Ssssss-Sssss-Sssss!

And a group of snakes reacting to it. They’re obviously no ordinary vipers...

The moment he saw the snakes, Woon-seong leapt backwards and swung his spear. It was thanks to this instinctive movement that the snakes fell to the ground in pieces.

How can he control this many snakes? It's probably more than some unorthodox vile art.

Woon-seong looked around himself, at the numerous snakes that had gathered due to the flute song. It was quite disgusting to see the snakes advancing over the blood and guts of their dead brethren.

That's why Woon-seong was swinging his spear so rapidly.

However, they'll have to try better than that to kill me.

Woon-seong activated his Intimidation Qi, allowing him to kill more snakes in a shorter amount of time.

Flesh and blood splattered in all directions.

Of course, none of it hit Woon-seong at all.

The training of the First Gate was far more dangerous than this!!

Thinking about his training with Cheon Hwi, this assassination attempt seemed like a child's prank.

There were chains, knives, and snakes flying at him, but the situation was still the same.

Woon-seong flipped in the air and avoided everything, striking and slicing with his spear. With terrifying accuracy, the nearest metal chain was cut into ribbons.

The person holding the chain was sent flying into the air, pierced by the throwing knives. A fountain of blood rose up in the field of reeds.

Phew!

However, the man with the flute was not yet finished.

Fwoooooo~!

Woon-seong turned his head towards the source of the sound.

'Lightning Stitching Throwing Knives'!

The man with the flute had to pause and use the flute to block the knives, his playing momentarily stopped.

Woon-seong did not miss this gap. He vaulted into the air and slashed towards the other man, cutting the flute cleanly in two.

“Wha-?”

The man dodged the first strike, but Woon-seong's White Night Spear was still faster.

Sching!

As the man was split in half, hot blood pooled on the grass. Since the one controlling them died, the nearby snakes scattered.

The remaining people...

Woon-seong spread out his senses once more. A circular wave of energy emanated from his body, brought out and extended along the arc of his spear.

He could see the shadows moving through the field. Even though two of their companions were now dead, the other assassins were circling around Woon-seong like sharks.

Two chains rushed towards Woon-seong, one from above and one from below.

Woon-seong leapt up and away from the chain coming from the bottom.

However, the other one was still flying towards his head!

He moved the White Night Spear, blocking it from above.

Heave-ho!

To the others, it looked like the second chain had wrapped around the White Night Spear, incapacitating it.

However, reality was different.

Woon-seong unclasped one of the iron rings. The iron rings he currently used were custom-made by Cheon Hwi; they were twice as heavy as before. With one taken off, his strength rose dramatically.

Woon-seong spun the White Night Spear, letting the oncoming chain collide with it.

“Ugh!” The person who wielded the chain was surprised at Woon-seong’s sudden power-up and was dragged out of hiding.

The person’s four other colleagues ran over, unable to see the true situation.

Boom!

However, the whole reed field trembled. Once the ones who had been hiding revealed themselves, Woon-seong took the iron bracer off his left arm too.

Boom!

The iron ring smacked into the face of an approaching assailant, causing the man to go off flying.

Stitching knives were thrown at the other three.

This was a bluff — Woon-seong knew that just the knives would be unable to stop his attackers. They would, however, buy him some time.

The slight moment they use to parry the knives, that's all I need.

Poof!

The skull of one man was crushed by Woon-seong's fist.

After punching him, Woon-seong disappeared just as quickly, rushing in another direction.

He reappeared right next to another assassin.

Assassins were only scary when they hid. The moment they revealed themselves, their defeat was as good as confirmed.

Woon-seong plummeted down and cut the person clean through, snapping the the man's spine.

As the assassin fell, he flailed about and haphazardly swung his chain, accidentally slicing his own comrade's throat in the process.

There's only one left... I only need one to interrogate. And I'm not going to let them kill themselves like last time.

The last assassin was fleeing, realizing that this attempt failed miserably.

However, Woon-seong was much faster. Having taken off two iron bracers, he was stronger than ever before.

“What's with the hurry?”

Woon-seong had caught up to the assassin in an instant, grabbing the other by the collar.

First, I'll take out the poison pill from his mouth.

Woon-seong slapped the assassin across the cheek. With a cracking sound, the assassin's jaw broke and a pill fell out of his mouth.

And before he attempts any other suicide method...!

Woon-seong threw the other man to the ground, resulting in another crack as the man's head smacked into the dirt.

A strange scream came from the other's mouth, "Uaagh!"

"Who ordered you to kill me and why?!" Woon-seong asked ferociously, with his foot now pressed to the other man's chest.

The assassin groaned, mumbling out a string of indecipherable words.

Woon-seong frowned.

This man... he has no tongue!

What about his fingers?

He doesn't have fingers either.

An assassin trained and prepared to not give out information no matter what... so they used their chains by winding them around their arms.

"Damn it!" Woon-seong trembled with anger.

It looks like I'm not getting any information out of them...

In one smooth motion, Woon-seong swung his spear and slit the throat of the last assassin. He had killed them all, but felt wholly unsatisfied.

"They all failed?"

A man dressed in black received a report and got up, gnashing his teeth. His voice was venomous as he spat.

"Damn it. They weren't even able to take care of a new Demonic King. Why were they so confident...?"

This assassination attempt was my idea. Old man Joo Moon-baek doesn't even know about it... I attempted it without any support yet it failed like this. This failure will backfire and negatively affect my influence within the

group. In order to keep what little influence I have left, I have to succeed. However, the Senior Strategist of the Cult! Right now, it's impossible to bring in more forces while not being detected by him...

The man wiggled his fingers and grabbed the sword strapped to his waist.

If so, I'll have to do it myself.

The man's eyes glowed sharply in the moonlight.

However, the man didn't know that someone had been watching and listening to him...

"So an idiot made a premature move. I only tolerate him because of the deal and he decides to act out of place."

Joo Moon-baek stared into space after hearing the report.

He called for someone, huffing, "Shadow."

A man covered by shadows appeared suddenly.

However, Joo Moon-baek continued on casually, as if he had known the other had been there. "Go. You can take care of this yourself in case it goes south."

"Yes, sir." At the words of the Vice Leader, the other man bowed his head. However, his eyes soon glinted and he lifted his head up. "Also, what do I do with the Young Leader?"

"What do you do with the Young Leader? Hmm." Joo Moon-baek tapped his chin slowly. "If the Young Leader ends up getting killed, let it happen. If not, let him live for now. There's no reason for me to do it myself and provoke the Leader. Getting rid of the Young Leader can wait until after the Leader becomes disabled."

At these words, the other man bowed.

"Acknowledged."

Chapter 65: Ambush (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 65 – Ambush (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Where is this?

The surrounding space was entirely gray. Despite walking forward, there was nothing else visible.

What... Am I doing...?

No, it wasn't correct to call it 'walking'.

There were no floors to walk on, nor walls and ceilings for reference, just a vast gray expanse.

Cheon Ah-young was floating in the middle.

Who is it? Who's pushing me? Where are they taking me?

Ah-young was moving because she was being pushed by something, but she had no idea who or what it was. Thus, she wandered around the unknown space for a long time, being driven forward by this unknown force.

How long has it been? I don't know...

“Ugh.” Ah-young groaned without her realizing.

It's hot...! She suddenly felt a wave of heat from within the gray space. Turning her head, Ah-young saw a flame blazing vigorously some distance away. *Wait, fire?!*

The blazing flame flashed towards Ah-young in an instant, burning the space around her as it approached. The searing heat become more intense, burning her skin.

“N-No!”

Ah-young swung her arms forward, attempting to protect herself. She tried to keep the fire at bay using a wall of qi, but nothing happened.

I can't draw qi from my core?!

As she was panicking, the intense flame consumed her.

And then...

It's not hot? I'm sure I was feeling the flames just a moment ago. But now it feels warm and comfy, like I'm in my mother's arms.

Ah-young wondered a bit about how much she really enjoyed this feeling.

Then, the fire made one final change.

What's it doing...?

The flame gradually decreased in size, reducing to the size of a palm and digging into Ah-young's chest.

“Ugh...”

Ah-young's whole body was suddenly engulfed by burning pain. Screaming, the heat coursed through her body.

“Aaaaaaah!”

She woke up from a dream.

When she woke, Ah-young was soaked in sweat. She muttered, puzzled, “That was a dream...?”

Apparently it had only been a dream, indicated by the fact that she was still in bed and the moon hung high in the sky.

The feeling of a burning flame and the warmth inside me... was all of that just a dream too?

“Whew... huh...”

When she realized it was only a dream, Ah-young breathed a huge sigh of relief.

However, she didn’t know what that dream represented...

An assassin, huh...

Woon-seong had returned to his room. Unable to sleep however, he thought about what had happened earlier.

Based on what the Demon King of Dark Pursuit had told him, Woon-seong was sure that the assassins from the Valley of Thousand Spirits were somehow related to the assassins from tonight.

There can’t be many within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon that would dare target me...

Woon-seong boiled some water for tea, but got up and walked towards the terrace without drinking anything.

The problem is... who? And why? I don’t have a single clue. It’s clear they were targeting me. They attacked me knowing who I am... yet I don’t have even the slightest idea of who my enemy is.

I don’t like this. Woon-seong growled with irritation, gripping the banister so hard that the wood splintered. *It’s getting on my nerves.*

It was natural for Woon-seong to be angry, but he shook his head.

My rage doesn't give me access to the information about the enemy. This is going to be tough...

The men at the Valley swallowed poison without a moment's hesitation. The men I encountered today came with bodies that were physically impossible to interrogate. I don't know who's behind them, but they were thoroughly prepared.

Woon-seong sighed. He took a deep breath before turning around and heading back inside. Sitting down, he poured himself some tea.

Without the Leader's qi sensitivity training, I wouldn't have survived. A sickle might have broken my bones or a viper might have killed me.

And looking at how my senses were improved in such a short time, I can't help but admire the Leader's skills as a teacher.

So he's the Heavenly Demon for a reason.

Woon-seong's gaze deepened as his mind moved past the ambush earlier. But after a while, there was a commotion that woke him up from his thoughts.

“May I enter?”

It was the voice of Gwan Tae-ryang.

Although this voice had woken him up, Woon-seong wasn't particularly angry. It wasn't like he had been meditating or sleeping anyways. Plus, he'd gotten distracted from his earlier distraction.

“Come in.”

With his captain's permission, the other man entered the room. Given that Woon-seong had been training with Cheon Hwi from dawn until dusk, the two hadn't seen much of each other recently.

“Excuse me. It’s been a while, Captain!”

As Gwan Tae-ryang entered, Woon-seong brightened a bit and swept his gaze over the other. *Are those metal bracers...?*

Maybe it was because Gwan Tae-ryang realized that Woon-seong was staring at his arms. He raised one arm, looking down at the bracer and shrugged. “I tried copying your methods since I couldn’t keep up with you. This is the least I can do to try and get to your level.”

“Not bad.” Woon-seong smiled and nodded, praising the other.

Gwan Tae-ryang grinned at the praise.

That wasn’t the only change.

“And I assume you’ve also improved your martial arts?”

“Yes. I think I got better than before.”

Though Gwan Tae-ryang had smiled, Woon-seong felt like something was not right. It was probably what had brought the lieutenant here so late.

“You ‘*think*’ so...? Then how good are you now?”

At his questioning tone, Gwan Tae-ryang smiled awkwardly. He seemed surprised that Woon-seong had read his thoughts.

“Your words seem to lack confidence for a reason.”

Gwan Tae-ryang smiled stiffly. “The thing is... After I’ve seen some improvement, it looks like I’m not seeing any more improvement at all.”

“If so...,” Woon-seong laughed lightly. Then he looked out the window, looking at the garden surrounding the Charred Dragon House. “The moon is bright tonight. I’ll take a look myself.”

“Right now?”

Woon-seong shrugged, clipping his metal bracers back into place. “Is that a problem for you?”

“Of course not.”

Ta-da.

As soon as he heard that, Woon-seong leapt through his window and landed in the garden. He had jumped from the third floor, but there was no problem.

Ta-da.

Like Woon-seong had jumped, so had Gwan Tae-ryang.

Woon-seong pulled his White Night Spear out, pointing it towards the other.

“Let’s see how much better you’ve become since you left the Cave of Latent Demons.”

Woon-seong snapped his fingers and Gwan Tae-ryang threw his metal bracers off, rolling his shoulders.

This is giving me shivers down my spine... “Heh heh...” Gwan Tae-ryang chuckled to himself. *It reminds me of the moment when I lost back then.* With those memories clear in his head, he couldn’t help but be afraid. He gulped.

“It won’t be easy like last time.”

“How about actually proving that, Lieutenant.”

Woon-seong smiled faintly, egging the other on.

It was at that moment that Gwan Tae-ryang leapt forward, swinging sharply with his blade.

It sank into the ground, leaving a gash in front of Woon-seong.

The blade had missed by a fraction of an inch.

I thought that was a sure hit! Gwan Tae-ryang was momentarily startled. *He dodged slightly backwards, the moment right before my attack landed. So this is how good Captain is...* Though he was still afraid, he was now more motivated in this fight. *Good! Just what I would expect from the captain I follow!*

Thanks to his training with Cheon Hwi, it hadn't been hard for Woon-seong to dodge that blow.

To understand why Gwan Tae-ryang is having a problem, he was thinking to himself, *I first need to understand his movements.*

Woon-seong examined the other's movements like a hawk, observing the other's coordination and movement flow. Just like during his training, he was getting better at reading muscle movement and qi flow.

I see.

He'd found a discrepancy and his eyes glowed as focused.

There are moments of hesitation between his attacks. That must be why he felt like he had halts in improving his skills.

Woon-seong soon became lost in thought. Threatening attacks whistled by his ears, but none of them came close to touching him.

Thus, Gwan Tae-ryang swung his blade wildly until he exhausted himself.

"Huff, huff, huff."

Was there this much of a gap between us? Gwan Tae-ryang was sitting collapsed on the ground, breathing heavily. *Captain didn't even break a sweat...*

Just as Woon-seong had known there was a clear gap in their skills, Gwan Tae-ryang was also aware of it now.

“Captain, huff... What do you, puff... Think?”

Woon-seong laughed, looking at the exhausted lieutenant.

“I understand why you weren’t improving.”

At these words, Gwan Tae-ryang swallowed his words and held his breath.

Woon-seong’s next words were still casual though.

“You said you had a major breakthrough recently, correct?”

“That’s right.”

Woon-seong swung his spear, scratching a straight line into the dirt.

“That’s the wall that you recently overcame.”

Gwan Tae-ryang looked at the line, then muttered, “Wall...”

“But overcoming the wall doesn’t mean the end of it.” Woon-seong swung his spear again, erasing his previously drawn line. “Walls are simply measures made within the martial society for an easier understanding. Just because different people overcame the same wall doesn’t make them martial artists of the same level.”

Gwan Tae-ryang nodded his understanding. There would always be some stronger and some weaker.

“You just overcame a wall. That means you need to put more effort into getting used to the new area you’ve found beyond the wall. And it only makes sense that you’re having a hard time understanding it — it’s uncharted territory, after all. But one thing for sure is that there is no easy way to adapt to this new strength.”

“So what should I do?”

Woon-seong shrugged, setting his spear down. There wasn’t any way for someone to quickly adapt to these changes.

“All you can do is take your time and get used to it. Don’t be impatient. The devil visits your heart when your mind goes astray... Focus on your path and you’ll eventually get there. That’s how martial arts works.”

Woon-seong spoke as if he had deep confidence, but Gwan Tae-ryang wasn’t entirely convinced.

A wall...

Still, Woon-seong was someone that Gwan Tae-ryang had known for a long time. The other was also the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, the youngest Demonic King. There was nothing wrong with listening to him, so Gwan Tae-ryang let his mind relax.

“Your words make me feel better. Thank you, Captain...”

As the two youths turned their heads, they could see a dim glow emerging from behind the mountains.

“The sun’s rising. It looks like I’ve been taking too much of your time.”

“Don’t worry about it.” Woon-seong smiled, looking over at the other.
“Teaching his men is also part of a captain’s duty.”

Gwan Tae-ryang had gotten up, but still looked exhausted. “Is that so... Thank you, sir.”

Woon-seong sighed softly.

It’s already morning. I was just planning to take a look at Gwan Tae-ryang’s skills for a moment. And it ended with him showing me everything he’s got...

But thanks to him, I was also able to go back to the basics. It wasn’t a waste of time at all.

I should be patient too.

Woon-seong adjusted his sleeves, thinking about his plans for revenge.

Though, it looks like I'm not getting any sleep today.

Chapter 66: Ambush (3)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 66 – Ambush (3)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

After some time staring into the horizon, Gwan Tae-ryang decided to head back and catch some rest.

“Captain! I’ll be going back now.”

“Alright. Keep improving yourself.”

Once Gwan Tae-ryang left, Woon-seong sighed to himself. *It’s dawn... too late to go to sleep now.*

That was fine with him, though. At dawn, the cool air felt lively. The world had just woken up from its sleep — new energy was everywhere. This was the reason that many people chose to meditate or practice in the early morning.

Woon-seong was one of those people.

I’ll just cultivate the ‘Heavenward Soul Earthen Body’ instead.

Woon-seong found a place to sit nearby and slowly began to meditate.

Ignite the soul to reforge the Heavens, govern the body to dictate the Earth (燃魂改乾, 鍊身訂坤). By setting your soul aflame, you can change the

Heavens, and by refining your body, you can control the Earth.

I've set up most of the basics of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body. Now I just need to unify Heaven and Earth. If I achieve unification, my body and my soul will achieve harmonization and become one, allowing me to complete the body reformation.

Except... I thought Heavenward Soul Earthen Body was a Buddhist art that changes one's body with time and effort, but the more I practice it, the more complicated it becomes... At this point, it's way beyond some ordinary Buddhist art. I'm not even sure if it's some simple Buddhist art or some foreign art at this point. It's so complicated.

Woon-seong slowly opened his eyes, shaking his head and clicking his tongue.

Despite his lack of sleep and his practice with Gwan Tae-ryang, Woon-seong felt surprisingly energetic.

Thanks to the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, my body is good to go and not fatigued anymore.

Now that that's handled...

Woon-seong picked up his spear and stood up.

“Come out.”

Like a beam of light hitting his eyes, Woon-seong's senses had alerted him of someone else nearby. At first, he believed that it was a passing mountain beast. However, the presence had been slowly approaching him.

Woon-seong stared at the forest, thinking about his training with the Heavenly Demon. *My senses have become sharper than they used to be because I've been practicing them lately.*

When nothing happened, he spoke once more.

“Didn't you hear me? I said, come out.”

A man in black appeared, stepping out from behind a tree. He was an adult, with a beard that was about a finger's width thick. He gripped a blade in his left hand, heavy like the ones Gwan Tae-ryang used.

"I see. So a Demonic King is still a Demonic King."

"How can't I notice when you're radiating such obvious hostility?"

The man only stared at Woon-seong, making the young man uncomfortable.

Woon-seong did not relax in the slightest. *So this is the guy who got caught in my qi detection during Heavenward Soul Earthen Body.*

"Let me ask first... Do you know who I am?"

"How can I not, Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit? The talented one who became a Demonic King at the age of twenty. And also the Young Leader who will lead the future of the Demonic Cult."

That sure sounded like a compliment. However, Woon-seong would be stupid if he couldn't hear the heavy sarcasm dripping from those words.

He's showing obvious hostility! A man I'm completely unaware of is trying so hard to kill me... Woon-seong's eyes were deep and as he stood there silently, there was a sudden thought in head.

"Were the assassins from before sent by you?"

At the mention, the man's face contorted.

"So you're an excellent martial artist who's also smart and clever. I knew it. I need to kill you right now."

"Kill me? So that means you're admitting that you're behind the assassins, right? Let's see..." Woon-seong took the time to examine the other man.

"You can talk, so your tongue must be intact. And seeing how you're fine holding your swords, your fingers are fine too." He smirked arrogantly.

"Excellent, I'll need you to answer some questions of mine."

At the same time, the two rushed at each other. Their gazes, like their weapons, clashed violently in the air.

Guaguagua-

Streams of energy carved into the earth, flowing through the air.

Woon-seong's arm trembled slightly from the force. *This won't be easy.*

Standing apart from each other, the man released more of his energy, covering his blade with light. It flowed like waves and was gray as steel. However, the feeling of the qi was hard to ignore.

“That qi... is not demonic. You! You're not from our Cult!”

Woon-seong quickly recognized a problem. *How can someone not part of the Cult infiltrate so deeply inside? Is that even possible?*

As Woon-seong stared at the other, the man answered him.

“Now that's another reason why you need to die!”

A vortex formed on the sword, blossoming like a flower and dangerous like a cannonball.

“Vortex Blast!”

Woon-seong ducked his head, avoiding it.

That's some horrific power. The ground is damaged as though it was hit by a tornado. Truly no ordinary attack. It's a high speed whirlwind that sucks the opponent in and shreds them into pieces the moment they touch it. Then, even a graze could be critical. But it's not a problem as long as I don't touch it.

Woon-seong's back was slightly damp.

Most of all, he's not the only one who has skills like that.

He grabbed his spear, thinking about his next move. *Art of Six Seals?*
Woon-seong cleared his mind. *No... I'll go with the Divine Spear of the Ending Night.*

Woon-seong's aura changed. His eyes became molten gold.

At the new energy, the other man withdrew unconsciously. *Fear? I'm facing a brat like this... and I'm feeling fear?*

The man had not been mistaken. The fear was a natural response, as Woon-seong's aura provoked the fundamental terrors in a human. He had combined the Divine Spear of the Ending Night and Intimidation Qi!

You can use blade aura... If so, I'll just use my Intimidation Qi on top of my spear aura and combine the two. I should call it the 'intimidation spear aura'. And my metal bracers... Two thuds were heard as Woon-seong discarded two metal bracers, the ones on his arms. *I'll start with two first.*

The enemy is powerful. Not to the level of the Leader, but he's stronger than the Demonic King of Dark Pursuit and similar to mid-level Demonic Kings.

Woon-seong grit his teeth. He was also a Demonic King, though where he stood was unknown. It was clear that Cheon Hwi's training had helped him improve, but would it be enough?

'Divine Spear of the Ending Night'!

'Vortex Blast'!

Woon-seong swung his spear just as the other man swung his blade down, the attacks rushing towards each other.

A powerful wave blasted through the clearing, pushing the two farther apart.

Of course, the two did not stop to rest.

Attacks were hurled at each other, creating a storm of dust and qi. The earth crumbled as gashes were gouged into the dirt and plumes of dust billowed

into the air.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong had quickly taken the remaining two bracers off. *Ugh, forget bracers. This is no situation for that. I'll have to give him my everything.*

Ugh.

The blasts swirled through the air, tearing Woon-seong's clothes. The youth was covered in small and large wounds. But there was not much he could do but continue fighting.

'Divine Spear of the Ending Night'!

One of the paulders on his shoulder cracked apart, leaving a bloody scratch.

It must be weakened after getting through the Divine Spear, yet it's still this powerful.

Woon-seong stared at his opponent, annoyed.

However, the Divine Spear of the Ending Night is slowly surrounding him. It's about binding the opponent with large spear movements, drowning them in a sea of spears. It's a staple art of the Spear Master Sect.

Now, what will you do?

It could be seen that the other man was also having a difficult time. "You little bastard!"

His spear is slowly binding me while shooting down the vortex blasts. A single wrong move would result in me being shredded by the hail of attacks! Continuing to shoot vortices won't solve the situation. I have no choice. I didn't expect doing this much against this brat...!

The man stopped firing his vortices. He had realized that while powerful, these attacks weren't doing any real damage to Woon-seong. Instead, in a flare of anger, he concentrated all of his strength. It was gathered onto the

blade, creating a terrifying turbulence of power. This was completely different from the small tornados that he had been firing.

“The ‘Plough Vortex Blast of Black Victory’! Try taking this!”

Woon-seong recognized the difference. *It's his final move of desperation.* Any momentum that he had built was swept away with this change. *Alright. I'll face it straight on!* As if he was pulling back a bow, Woon-seong's arms tensed.

At this point, Woon-seong unleashed his fastest and strongest move.

‘Flow of the Divine Dragon!’

“It's too late, bastard! Die!” cackled the man in black.

The two monstrous energies collided with each other, shaking the clearing. A plume of dirt could be seen and the forest shook. The bright light soon dissipated, revealing the conclusion.

That... was close.

Woon-seong's spear had pierced through the other's abdomen. His spear had broken through the other man's attack.

My previous experience against the ‘Palm of Blood and Jade’ was really helpful. But still... I only won because my Flow of the Divine Dragon was a more powerful attack than his. A second later and I would've been the one who lost...

Anyways, as the winner of the situation, I just need to do what I should do. The right of the victor...

Coldly, Woon-seong wiped his sweat off and pulled the spear out. Blood splattered the floor as the other man collapsed. He swung his spear once more.

The man screamed in pain, barely conscious. “Kugh!”

“I just cut all major tendons in your four limbs.” Blood was pooling around his feet, but Woon-seong just swung his spear once more. “Don’t worry about bleeding to death, I sealed your pressure points. Now tell me, why am I your target?”

“You idiot,” the other man laughed. “Do you think I will tell you that?”

“If you don’t want to... I just have to make you want to do so. I’m a patient man with lots of time.”

Woon-seong had a way of course, he had used it before. He used his finger to tap some points. *‘Crushed Bones and Squeezed Muscles’*.

“Ugh!”

As the dreadful screams began to erupt, Woon-seong quickly silenced the other.

“I sealed your throat. You won’t be screaming any time soon. Let me know whenever you change your mind.”

Woon-seong just stood there, waiting for the other to crumble. He tidied his appearance in the meantime, wiping away blood and dusting off his clothes. How long had passed?

Finally, the other man gasped and pleaded. “I-I’ll speak. So please.”

He withstood it longer than I expected... But it looks like there’s no need to wait anymore. Woon-seong nodded down at him, eyes gleaming.

“I-I am... a person of the... sky.”

There was a flash as something flew through the air and thudded into the chest of the dying man.

“Kugh!”

Woon-seong raised his head in a hurry, turning towards the source. He raised his palm and blasted energy, trying to get a good look at his

surroundings. In the distance, subtle movement caught his eye. It was too far for him to chase, especially within a forest.

An instant death... I didn't realize it at all! And what's more surprising is that I didn't detect his existence near me at all.

Realizing he had been discovered, the mysterious attacker melted into the shadows.

Woon-seong grit his teeth. "Damn it."

Chapter 67: Divine Maiden (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 67 – Divine Maiden (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“So that’s how things turned out... tsk.”

Joo Moon-baek, who had received the report, shook his head and closed his eyes. The assassin had been overconfident in his skills.

Although, it’s still better than him staying alive and giving the Young Leader information. If we left him alive and the information was leaked, it would definitely have worked against us.

“What should I do?” The reporter, who stood in the shadows, asked.

The Vice Leader of the Cult opened his eyes and clasped his fingers. “That should be obvious. We’ll have to ask them to send another partner. Hwa Chung-mong was pretty clumsy, but allying with them was still very helpful.”

The other man nodded at these words. “Then I shall send them a message.”

“No. That’s too dangerous. We have to send someone.”

“You want to send a person instead?”

Joo Moon-baek nodded, looking the other man in the eyes as he spoke. “Is there someone from the Unrecorded Demonic Group that we can trust?”

At the mention of the Unrecorded, the man twitched. However, he soon shook his head. “There are still those who don’t completely believe that you are the Second Advent of the Unrecorded. Commanding them right now might cause them to antagonize us.”

“Hmm.” The Vice Leader grits his teeth. *If Shadow, one of the Unrecorded Demonic Group, says so himself, I can’t just ignore his words.* “I see. Then I’ll send one of my men. You continue to persuade the Unrecorded Demonic Group.”

The other man, Shadow, bowed his head.

“Glory to the Unrecorded.”

The Heavenly Demon’s training for Woon-seong only became harsher over time.

Shh, shh, shh.

A massive volley of arrows and shadow arrows that are launched between them. Training is becoming more and more difficult.

Shh, shh.

But the biggest pain in the ass... It’s the one that’s less than half the size, yet faster and more powerful. The pyeon-jeon (short arrow).

Woon-seong quickly twisted to the side. An arrow narrowly grazed his thighs and another his shoulder, though neither drew blood.

He let out a sigh of relief.

However,

Pfft.

And this. The knife that's launched every time I seem to let my guard down even a little bit.

The knife cut his shoulder, even though Woon-seong had dodged. It left a little trail of blood.

“Ugh.”

Oops, right after the knife was an arrow.

I can't dodge this one...

It was lodged at an angle difficult to avoid, so Woon-seong swung his spear.

“Hup!”

The arrows were cut mid-flight, thrown to the side broken and splintered.

Just as the arrows were taken care of, a large fishing net fell down from the ceiling, aimed at Woon-seong. That wasn't all, three chains flew towards his ankles.

Woon-seong took a deep breath and leaped upward, narrowly avoiding the chains. As soon as he was sure that he had avoided them, he swung his White Night Spear upwards forcefully. With this, the falling net was torn apart.

He landed safely on the ground as the entire room lit up with bright lights.

“Excellent.” Cheon Hwi appeared above him and smiled slightly. “Change your clothes. We shall start the Second Gate.”

Throughout the training, Cheon Hwi advised Woon-seong without rest.

“While the First Gate is a training to build your senses, the Second Gate goes beyond simply sensing the movements of your enemy. It is about training you to read their muscles and predict their movement.”

Like before, Cheon Hwi restricted both Woon-seong and himself to a decade of qi and attacked him with a knife.

“If you are against a martial artist of the same level, having better senses and being able to predict movement will put you on the advantageous side. Do not be obsessed with simply wielding your spear with all your might.”

“You need to catch the image of the enemy and strike swiftly and deadly at the correct position. As you know, the basis of any weapon based martial art is to find the enemy’s weak spot and exploit it.”

“If you can stand above the opponent skill-wise, it is not impossible to best a higher level martial artist.”

“Your breathing is important. Similarly, you must also read the opponent’s breath and make them lose focus.”

By the end, Woon-seong was lying down, collapsed in a heap. Cheon Hwi, of course, had barely broken a sweat.

It’s oddly amazing. None of this stuff is new to me..., Woon-seong noted. By simply telling me at the exact moment I need it, not only do I understand it better, but it also makes my body learn it faster. My every muscle is learning as though it understands the meaning of each movement.

As Woon-seong had noticed before, the Cult Leader was a kind man towards those within his circle. Woon-seong, as the only apprentice and next-in-line, was given extra special care and attention.

On top of that, he teaches me facts that only a martial artist at his level can know. It’s a level far beyond that of me in my past life or my former master.

Cheon Hwi was currently near the exit of the Second Gate. Maybe it was the lighting, but Woon-seong was unable to see what stood beyond. Under the bright backdrop, Cheon Hwi stood, wreathed in a warm glow, smiling back at him.

The Leader's advice... is very constructive and useful. To the point that I can feel that I'm becoming stronger! I can become even stronger. With the Leader's teachings, I feel like I have no limit to how much stronger I can become.

Woon-seong stared ahead, then grinned.

Under the guidance of the Heavenly Demon, Woon-seong became stronger and stronger over time.

Soon, five months had passed.

“Huff. Huff. Huff.”

Woon-seong panted harshly. He had exhausted himself just to land one blow. *Like always, I couldn't touch him at all...*

Cheon Hwi glanced at the barely standing Woon-seong. “That is enough for today.”

The young man collapsed to the floor. He did not fall unconscious this time, but it was too hard to stand.

Seeing that, Cheon Hwi shuffled closer and tossed him a single pill. “What is making you so impatient?”

“...” Woon-seong stared at the medicinal pill in his hand.

“That's right. Your breathing is not stable yet.” The Heavenly Demon took his silence as an inability to answer. He waved his hand slightly. Warm energy flowed through Woon-seong's body, stabilizing his breathing.

Seeing that, Cheon Hwi repeated his question.

“Whenever I see you training, you look like you are being chased by something. Why are you being pushed so hard, to the point where you are trying to calm yourself down?”

Woon-seong's face solidified into a mixture of shock and horror. He slumped his shoulders in resignation, hiding his face. Cheon Hwi's words seemed to stab him.

He knows exactly what I'm thinking... What's making me so impatient...? I tried so hard to not become anxious, but what can I do when I remember the face of my master whenever I close my eyes? What can I do when I keep remembering the faces of my enemies?

What conclusions had the Heavenly Demon drawn from his apprentice's expression?

Looking at Woon-seong, Cheon Hwi seemed to think that the other was filled with complaints against the world.

"You do not have to tell me if you do not wish to."

At his words, Woon-seong jolted out of his thoughts and looked up at the other.

"Leader..."

"Call me 'master'."

Woon-seong continued on, though hesitantly, "Master. Then, why are *you* being so impatient?"

This time it was Cheon Hwi's face that became stiff. A crushing pressure squeezed Woon-seong and he momentarily panicked, thinking he had gravely overstepped.

Soon however, the pressure receded.

"I said it is not necessary to answer it if you do not wish to, right? Because it is the same for me."

With this, Cheon Hwi smiled.

It was the most unpretentious smile that Woon-seong had ever seen.

A bronze furnace burned roughly in the night.

These were the only traces left of the First Heavenly Demon, the Founder of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

In front of his will, a maiden with an aging body had her hands clasped before her.

She was earnestly praying.

“O’Heavenly Being.”

Her voice trembled.

The First Heavenly Demon gave me a revelation last night... that my life has less than a year left. We need a new Divine Maiden... and I need to teach her everything that a Divine Maiden must know. But one year is too short for that.

Please... I wish you to select the next maiden as soon as possible.

Did the remnant understand the prayers?

Either way, the fire seemed to burn even brighter. It rose to a height that reached the ceiling, resembling a pillar. Soon, it passed the ceiling, flooding out of the building. The wind and rain outside did not douse the flame; the flame did not burn people or buildings.

Oh...!

The Divine Maiden was amazed to see the column of flame. She smiled softly.

Throughout my whole life as a Divine Maiden, I have never seen the Divine Flame burn so vigorously. But I think I know why. It’s about to select the new Divine Maiden.

The flame, taking the appearance of a dragon, rushed into the sky. Its presence turned the sky red and orange.

Soon, it could be seen by all the nearby cultivators and believers.

“Oh!”

“It’s the Divine Flame!”

The Demonic cultivators who saw this scene knelt to the ground, facing the Palace.

Even then, the flame only momentarily paused in its journey across the sky. The flame seemed to split, burning even more vigorously as it did so. It was as if all the energy in nature was raging inside a ball of fire! The entire will of the Heavenly Demon was contained in a little fireball.

The piece of fire continued on for a long time, soon falling down somewhere on the Cult’s lands.

A huge glow rose from the landing place as every Demonic cultivator turned towards the direction, gazing at the light.

The current Divine Maiden was staring too. *Wherever that flame lands will be the location of the next Divine Maiden, the next one to serve the Divine Flame and the Heavenly Demon.*

This news was soon reported to the Heavenly Demon.

At the time, Cheon Hwi and Woon-seong had just finished their usual training and exited the Inner Garden

As Woon-seong exited the gates, he took a breath in. *The air feels especially fresh today.*

“You have done well in today’s training.” Cheon Hwi patted Woon-seong lightly on the back. “I will see you again tomorrow at the same time as always.”

Woon-seong nodded lightly.

The two slowly walked outside. There, someone was waiting for them.

It was the Brain of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, Senior Strategist Sang Gwan-chuk.

However, the man looked embarrassed to be there.

The Heavenly Demon's eyebrows twitched.

“My Leader.”

Seeing Cheon Hwi approaching, the Senior Strategist hurried forward. He immediately began speaking, seeming very flustered.

It did not seem to matter that Woon-seong was standing right next to them. Apparently, the information was *that* urgent.

“The next Divine Maiden has been decided.”

The Heavenly Demon narrowed his eyes. The next Divine Maiden was indeed a matter of concern for the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“Good. I was getting worried about the current Maiden getting too old.” Cheon Hwi nodded, not seeing the problem.

“But the woman who was selected...”

As the Senior Strategist whispered the name, Cheon Hwi's expression crumpled.

Chapter 68: Divine Maiden (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 68 – Divine Maiden (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

That evening, Cheon Ah-young had been sitting on her window frame and staring blankly at the sunset. The sky was colored a glittering red.

It was then that she saw the rising column of flame.

It was far away, for sure, but clearly visible. Ah-young stood up reflexively once she saw where it was coming from.

Hmm? Was there a fire at the Divine Maiden's Palace?

As she watched, the column continued to fly upwards.

It's like a fire dragon is ascending to the Heavens. How pretty.

Part of the fire disappeared into the sky. Another part shot in another direction, like a meteor towards the earth.

Ah-young stared at the sky and tilted her head in confusion. *Wait... Is that thing coming towards me...?*

“Kyah!”

Such thoughts were not just a delusion. *It is! It looks like it's growing larger...!*

By the time she had realized this, the ball of fire was already right in front of her.

Ah-young flew off the window frame and quickly retreated back into her own room. Turning sharply, she dashed past her bed and out the door. She continued running, breaking into a cold sweat as she rushed down the corridor and towards the staircase.

It's hot!!

Despite the heat crawling up her back, she thought that she'd dodged the fireball. However, the ball of fire swiftly turned and continued flying towards Ah-young.

Did it just change its trajectory to chase after me...?

That was unexpected. No one would have thought a flying ball of flame could change direction and pursue its target.

Ah-young twisted to the side again in an attempt to avoid the fire. But the ball of flames moved even faster. The chunk of fire quickly approached her, trapping her in on all sides.

No...!

“Aahhh!”

It then exploded right in front of her chest and she screamed.

Fwoom—

Meanwhile, the flames had taken over the surroundings in an instant.

Crackle—

When the Heavenly Demon heard the Senior Strategist's words, his face stiffened. Cheon Hwi then immediately rushed ahead, leaving Woon-seong and the Senior Strategist to chase after him.

That's some incredible movement.

Woon-seong shook his head, looking at the man who was leaving them further and further behind.

That speed only suits his title as the Heavenly Demon. If I want to catch up to that speed and inherit the name of the Heavenly Demon, I will have to work hard in the future.

But putting that aside for now...

Woon-seong's eyes deepened.

After the Senior Strategist had spoken to the Cult Leader, he had not had time to relay the message to Woon-seong before they were chasing after Cheon Hwi.

Of course, Woon-seong made an educated guess based on the Cult Leader's reaction.

I never thought she'd be chosen as the Divine Maiden.

Cheon Ah-young!

The image of a young woman flashed through Woon-seong's mind, memories of her as a young child and also recently.

We weren't exactly friends, but we have known each other since childhood. Her attitude seems to have changed recently, but we've been in some sort of rivalry until not long ago. Now that I think of it... it looks like I actually had a sense of competition when I was young.

That was back in the early days of the Cave of Latent Demons though. Now, no matter how hard she tried, there was a gap between her and Woon-seong.

Anyways, the Divine Maiden...

The Divine Maiden was the one who communicated with the Divine Flame and received the Will of the First Heavenly Demon, but she also served the presiding Heavenly Demon.

As long as Woon-seong was the Young Leader, he was destined to become the Heavenly Demon.

Then, the one the Divine Maiden would be serving was...

Hmm.

Thinking up to that point, Woon-seong's face went rigid.

He stopped thinking.

Oh, the Leader has already arrived.

By then, the Heavenly Demon had reached the White Ape House. Woon-seong and the Senior Strategist could see him standing there.

Snap, crackle—

The entire building was burning, causing the face of the Heavenly Demon to harden.

The fire seemed to originate from the third floor, the highest room in the House.

If the White Ape House had the same structure as the Charred Dragon House, that room would be where Cheon Ah-young, the captain of the unit, lived.

It was natural for the Heavenly Demon's expression to harden.

Woon-seong frowned at the building, furrowing his eyebrows, as he ran closer.

Something was wrong.

The place is on fire, yet the actual building and its surroundings don't seem to be damaged at all.

At first, Woon-seong thought he had seen wrong.

Fire.

Or, in other words, flames that could burn the everything else to ashes.

By that definition, the fire in the White Ape House was definitely strange.

It looks like this isn't some ordinary [Fire]. Really, the fire is surrounding the wooden house, but nothing is damaged. It's like the fire is just burning by itself.

But they couldn't just sit back and watch the mirage-like fire forever.

The Heavenly Demon moved first.

With a 'whoosh', he was flying up to the top floor in an instant. With two steps, he landed on the balcony. The Senior Strategist and Woon-seong followed after him, entering the building through the window in that order.

Like the outside, the fire burned the inside of the House too.

Crackle—

Cheon Hwi's gaze was directed towards the center of the fire, where Cheon Ah-young sat, the flames encircling her.

Is the fire protecting her or imprisoning her? Woon-seong wondered. I mean, it doesn't seem to be harming her.

Either way, the appearance of the fire around the young woman could not be easily explained with words.

Woon-seong was slightly trembling. *So this is the power of the Divine Flame...?*

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon continued to surprise him.

At that time, Ah-young opened her mouth. “Fath-” She stopped herself, looking up as she tried to think of what to say. She only continued a little while later. “Leader.”

Is it just me... or did I see the Leader shiver a little...? Maybe Woon-seong had seen wrong, but it seemed that when Ah-young changed the way she addressed Cheon Hwi, the Leader’s shoulders had trembled very subtly.

Woon-seong soon erased that thought.

It was because of the response.

“Come out from there.”

The voice of the Heavenly Demon was no different than usual. It was a voice filled with confidence. But just like with the trembling shoulders, Woon-seong seemed to hear bitterness in that voice.

Woon-seong didn’t bother to question why. Like he had noticed often before, the Leader was a man with two faces. He was a tyrant to those beyond his fence, but was a benevolent king to those beside him.

It was not strange that Cheon Hwi had the face of a Heavenly Demon and a father.

As Woon-seong thought, Cheon Hwi once again spoke. “Come out from that fire.”

“But...”

Cheon Ah-young glanced at the wall of fire surrounding her. Though it seemed like it protected her, it was also trapping her inside.

It was not Cheon Hwi who answered her doubts.

“That flame will not harm you, milady.”

As the new arrival walked forward, the flames split apart, revealing a gray-haired lady.

The Divine Maiden.

The fire opened the way for her, as if dancing in welcome.

The current Divine Maiden walked towards Ah-young through an open road.

“Because this flame is not here to harm you, but to greet you.”

“Greet me? What do you mean?” Ah-young tilted her head in confusion.

“Literally.” The Divine Maiden reached towards Cheon Ah-young with gentle hands. “You have been chosen as the next Divine Maiden of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

Was it so hard to believe? There must have been a reason that this fire had not hurt her.

Cheon Ah-young hesitated for a moment, looking back towards her father. It seemed that Cheon Hwi agreed with the Divine Maiden, so Ah-young could only nod her head and slowly stand up.

Just as the Divine Maiden had said, the flames that wrapped around her did not have any effect on her. Like earlier, the flames parted for her. When she finally reached her father, she was silent.

He, however, spoke.

“It looks like... I need to have a talk with you.”

Some time later, there were two people standing side by side under the moon. They were by the lake in the Inner Garden, where Woon-seong had first spoken to the Heavenly Demon many months before.

They were Cheon Hwi and Cheon Ah-young, father and daughter, watching the water in silence.

It was only natural that Cheon Hwi spoke first.

“Ever since your mother passed away after giving birth to you... you have been my only family in this world.”

“...”

At these words, Cheon Ah-young remained silent. She scuffed her feet against the dirt.

In fact, Ah-young was upset exactly because of that fact: even though she was his only family left, he refused to give up his position as the Heavenly Demon.

Although she had acknowledged Woon-seong’s strength and abandoned that competitiveness, she was still envious. Her father had not shown her the same attention or affection. *If I’m his only family member, why is he like that to the Young Leader...*

Had the other read her thoughts? Cheon Hwi reached out towards his daughter.

Ah-young was startled out of her thoughts when Cheon Hwi patted her on the head, softly brushing his fingers through her hair. This was the hand of a father comforting his daughter.

“You know, I wanted you to grow up into a normal woman.”

Ah-young’s eyes widened, surprised at these words.

“The Heavenly Demon is a position of solitude. I have the whole world in my hand... Yet there is barely anything I can truly grasp. I did not want you to live a life like that. I wouldn’t have been so concerned if you were a man. I simply wanted you to live as a woman, to fall in love with a man and have a family. You may have never known, but that was all I hoped for.”

Cheon Hwi was telling the truth, a truth that he had not told anyone else.

Ah-young wanted to speak, but she silenced herself as the other continued on, speaking with sincerity.

“I have heard about the rumors, and I was even prepared for you to refuse to inherit the bloodline of the Heavenly Demon.”

So father also heard about the rumor that I have to marry Woon-seong... Ah-young was honestly surprised that her father had even heard of them, since rumors were rumors. The things that the ordinary people spread on the street were not the sort of things the Heavenly Demon would like to have knowledge of. I never imagined that. I never thought that he cared about me so much.

Ah-young bit her lips.

“But since you became the Divine Maiden... it looks like all of those thoughts were meaningless. As you already know, the Divine Maiden must only serve the Divine Flame and the Heavenly Demon.”

Although they could choose not to, no Divine Maiden in recent history had actually refused to serve the Heavenly Demon. This was because even if they did so, they were not allowed to start a family with a different man.

Being chosen as the Divine Maiden meant that the option of having a normal life was eliminated.

The selection could not be revoked either.

The Divine Maiden was chosen by the Divine Flame, the will of the First Heavenly Demon. Refusing not only went against the very foundations of the Cult, but it could end gruesomely. There was a record of a woman who had gone mad and died in a fit of insanity just two weeks after attempting to refuse.

Although Cheon Hwi wished for Ah-young’s freedom of choice, he did not want to see her become a lunatic.

“If I stopped you from entering the Cave of Latent Demons at all cost, I would at least have had the chance to spend some more time with you...,” his hand paused in her hair. “I regret not stopping you that day.”

Ah-young opened her mouth for the first time that night.

“Not at all.”

“...?”

Ah-young had been avoiding her father’s gaze all night. Now, she raised her head and met his eyes. Her voice was filled with power and conviction.

“No, Father. I have never regretted the choice I made that day. I entered the Cave of Latent Demons because *I* chose to do so.”

“Is that so...”

“I will do well even after becoming the Divine Maiden. I’ve also known the Young Leader since back at the Cave of Latent Demons. So I’m sure he won’t treat me carelessly.”

‘He won’t treat me carelessly’... Those words sounded strange to Cheon Hwi. He asked her, “Are you willing to accept him as your husband?”

He continued to ask.

“Are you willing to love him?”

His words did not stop there.

“He may be my apprentice, but there are times when even I do not know what he is thinking. It makes me scared because even when you look at him... It makes me worried that he may not look back at you, my daughter.”

Even though he was the Heavenly Demon, even though he could control the mind and heart with his power, love was something that he could not change. Human emotions were not his to control.

Cheon Hwi could do nothing but ask his daughter once more.

“Can you fall in love with a man like that?”

Cheon Ah-young was silent.

Chapter 69: A Conversation

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 69 – A Conversation

Translated by : moonchildkhz

After the current Divine Maiden showed up and the Leader took Ah-young with him, the fire at the White Ape House disappeared like it never existed.

Not to mention, there was not a single trace of fire on the White Ape building.

This was possible because it was the Divine Flame, but it was still hard to believe.

When he got back to the Charred Dragon House, Woon-seong was still thinking about it.

The Divine Flame is known to be left behind by the First Heavenly Demon...

Woon-seong sat on the edge of his bed, mindlessly getting ready to turn in for the night.

According to the legends and texts within the Cult, the First Heavenly Demon reached a realm beyond that of a semi-divine being.

A true divine being!

He shook his head at this thought though.

He did not believe it.

The realm of a divine being?

Even the Leader, who practiced the Mind Sword, had barely set foot into the realm of a semi-divine being.

A human entering the realm of myths...

He closed his eyes, gripping his hands.

Is this how martial artists look from the perspective of normal people?

But no matter how much I think, I can't possibly fathom it. Splitting the moon with the Mind Sword is already something I can barely understand. But a being who has achieved beyond that... Does that mean he was an actual god?

Woon-seong shook his head again, banishing that thought.

No... It can't be. It's just a being I can't begin to comprehend. I should probably be cultivating rather than waste time thinking about the realm of divine beings.

Whether it was semi-divine or divine, both were way above his current level. There would still be time to revisit these things after he gained the necessary strength.

As he thought about gaining strength, he naturally thought about his current cultivation.

Use the Dark Flower Red Heart to split the mind into two and set up two wills. Mind Split, Double Will. Use one will to remember the Dark Flower Red Heart and the other to remember the Tempered True Blossom... Now that I think of it, the Dark Flower Red Heart had another name. It is also the First Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon...

Woon-seong sat down in a lotus position on his bed and tried to reach the headspace necessary for cultivation.

Then...

“Captain.”

There was a voice outside his room, calling for Woon-seong.

Ugh... It erased the previous thoughts in his mind and caused his consciousness to jolt.

“Come in.”

The door was pushed open and a young woman appeared. Her white skin was glowing and her hair was tied up.

It was a visit from Baek Woon-ji, one of the few female members of his unit.

Woon-seong tilted his head. “What is it?”

“Captain, you have a visitor.”

“A visitor?”

Woon-seong turned his head and stared out the window. There, he saw the moon floating high in the sky.

It was a late hour to be having visitors.

That was why he was confused when he had seen Baek Woon-ji at his door — it was already weird for Gwan Tae-ryang to visit him at this hour.

It's too late for anyone to visit me. And yet I have a visitor...

“Who...” Woon-seong tapped his chin lightly. “No, wait. I think I already know.”

Woon-seong rose from his bed, walking towards the direction of the door. His senses had now become so sharp that he could identify the people of the Charred Dragon Unit by their presence alone. He only needed to focus a little bit more to identify other people, but *I can't possibly forget this unique presence.*

“Ah-young. No, I guess I should call you the Young Divine Maiden now.”

At the words of Woon-seong, Baek Woon-ji wore a confused expression. *The Young Divine Maiden...?*

Ah-young had only been chosen by the Divine Flame earlier that evening so the news had obviously not been announced to the public yet. Of course, even if it was not officially broadcasted, her position was set in stone. Thus, Woon-seong called her the Young Divine Maiden.

A young woman appeared behind Baek Woon-ji. “Can we talk for a moment?”

“It’s getting late, but I guess we can do that.”

Cheon Ah-young, who stepped out from behind Baek Woon-ji, casually asked to talk so late into the night. Woon-seong, despite being interrupted from his practice, accepted without being difficult. This was all done with an air of normality, as if nothing out of the ordinary was happening.

“I was wondering if we could talk while having a walk in the garden...” Ah-young spoke hesitantly, trailing off as she walked down the corridor, heading outside. She looked back, as if afraid he would refuse. “Please.”

It wasn’t a difficult request, so Woon-seong nodded without saying anything.

Ah-young smiled gratefully.

Baek Woon-ji, still confused, looked anxiously at the exchange between Woon-seong and Ah-young.

Ah-young and Woon-seong walked silently in the garden outside the Charred Dragon Unit for a long time.

Baek Woon-ji, unsettled by the rapidly unfolding events, chased after the two some distance away in the name of escorting her captain.

Eventually, the silence became too uncomfortable and Woon-seong spoke first.

“I prefer we get to the point already if you have something to say...”

Ah-young stopped walking. As she had paused, Woon-seong had to stop walking too.

She looked over at him. Maybe it was because of her father’s words, but her face burned. Her eyes shook as she looked at him. Soon, however, she calmed down.

“They say that I’ll become the Young Divine Maiden.”

“Which is obvious, considering you’ve been selected by the Divine Flame.”

Ah-young nodded at his words. Somehow, his calm voice made her feel a bit foolish. *This is all because father said things like that.* Ah-young could only shake her head and the feeling disappeared.

“Do you know who and what the Divine Maiden serves?”

This time, it was Woon-seong who was embarrassed.

“Hmm.” Although he had seemed calm, Woon-seong was panicking internally.

He had finally realized what Ah-young was trying to say and her purpose here tonight.

It was Cheon Ah-young who saved him from his lack of words.

“The Divine Flame and the Heavenly Demon,” she stated.

She said it so nonchalantly that he was surprised. *That can't be something for her to talk about so lightly.* No matter how skilled she was, it seemed that even the daughter of the Heavenly Demon had a maiden's heart.

“That's why father asked me, about how I think of you...”

This girl... Without him realizing it, Woon-seong's eyes widened. It seemed that Ah-young had viewed him as more than just a rival, even if she hadn't always known about it herself.

“So, it made me curious about how you thought of me.”

At Ah-young's words, Woon-seong's expression softened just a bit. He closed his eyes in thought.

My life is already occupied with getting revenge... Emotions like love might just be too much of a luxury for me. Moreover, there's no guarantee that I can actually achieve my revenge. My enemy isn't an individual but the whole Orthodox society.

But I can't possibly explain all of this to Ah-young.

“You may not know, but there are a lot of things I have to do.”

“...”

“I've become the Young Leader like I've always wanted, but I am still not confident that I can achieve my goal. It probably won't make a difference even if I become the Heavenly Demon.”

Ah-young was still listening to his words.

She seemed to be waiting for his next words.

“So... I can't give you the emotions you are wanting from me. Because there's something else I have to focus on right now. Anything else will only come after I achieve my goal. If that actually happens, that is.”

Ah-young remained silent, processing her thoughts.

Woon-seong, too, was silent. He had said everything he wanted to say. Although he not spoken directly, he considered it enough to convey his thoughts.

Cheon Ah-young was clever; she must have fully understood what he said.

The silence continued.

Baek Woon-ji watched all this from a distance, looking nervous. It was no problem for her to eavesdrop on the conversation. *Captain...* She shifted uncomfortably.

Ah-young eventually broke the silence. “I see. I understand what you’re saying.”

“That’s good to hear.”

Woon-seong slowly closed his eyes. *I feel like I’ve just done something terrible to the woman named Cheon Ah-young, considering she has to live the rest of her life as the Divine Maiden...*

However, Cheon Ah-young’s answer was not what he had expected.

She laughed lightly before saying, “Then let’s put aside this conversation until you’re done with your goals.”

Woon-seong nodded and turned away from her. “That’s right. I’m glad you... Wait, what?”

Woon-seong snapped his head towards her in surprise, but she had already disappeared. Some distance away, Ah-young was exiting the garden of the Charred Dragon House, heading towards her own building.

Ah-young became a dot in the horizon, leaving behind only the scent of her perfume and a blankly staring Woon-seong.

“That... wasn’t what I was expecting.”

Woon-seong shook his head. As he walked back inside the building, he thought to himself.

What the hell is she thinking? I gave her a clear sign that it isn't going to happen, yet she just puts this aside 'for now'?

His mind was spinning with all sorts of complex ideas, but he put them all on hold.

I guess she is right though, there's no end in just thinking about something. I just need to worry about it when the time comes.

Woon-seong distracted himself by going back to cultivating. He resumed his earlier position.

Mind Split, Double Will. The Tempered True Blossom and the Dark Flower Red Heart.

The circulating energy swept away any complex thoughts about the future he may have had.

Soon however, he noticed a change. Something was blooming within his blood, spreading like a wildfire. It didn't burn him at all, though it seemed to sear. Rather, the heat seemed vaguely familiar.

What's happening? The power inside the Tempered True Blossom that I received from the Unrecorded is twitching. It's like it's welcoming the changes within the Dark Flower Red Heart.

Should I control it to flow normally again? Woon-seong momentarily tried to control the qi, but gave up just as quickly. *No... power is best left alone to flow the way it wants to.*

Looking at the situation, it's unlikely that some evil thing is trying to engulf me from the inside. The cultivation art must be moving towards its destined direction. Okay then, flow the way you want.

Once Woon-seong freed his control, the energy from the two sides mixed into one. It mixed in his dantian, swirling through his mind and body.

Tendrils of light and energy extended and collapsed, weaving together.

Unknown to Woon-seong, a sort of pressure built up in his surroundings. As he sat there, he caused the entire Charred Dragon House to tremble. Mysterious energy covered the building and surrounding training grounds, causing the unit members to pause their actions and look around.

Woon-seong though, had identified the cause.

I get it now.

He opened his eyes, staring at his palm. A ball of fire, the size of a small bead, flickered in his palms. He smiled brightly.

It's the essence of the flame.

It was the moment that the Dark Flower Red Heart reached a higher realm, forming the Divine Shaped Flame.

Chapter 70: Poison

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 70 – Poison

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Even if the same thing happens to two different people, the reactions from the populous could be very different. In a certain sense, this was only natural. Emotions, after all, were greatly influenced by a person's disposition, situation, and desirability.

The same could be said for the choice of the Young Divine Maiden of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“Is the news true? The Leader's daughter became the Young Divine Maiden?”

“It is! I'm sure the Leader must feel relieved about it.”

“What do you mean?”

“Don't you get it? I'm talking about maintaining the bloodline of the Cheon Family! The Young Leader and the Leader's daughter get married and everything becomes fine.”

“Ah! I see! The bloodline of the Heavenly Demon continues and the two become a happily married couple!”

The roads were buzzing with the news and rumors, as people had seen the fire from the White Ape House the night before.

“Oh? So Cheon Ah-young, the daughter of the Leader, is the one chosen as the next Divine Maiden.”

Joo Moon-baek, who had just heard the story, smiled to himself.

This is odd... This was a different reaction than what Young [1], his subordinate, had expected. Considering his nature, I would've expected the Vice Leader to react more negatively. Although they say that the Divine Maiden has become more of a symbolic position, it still shows massive influence amongst the ordinary believers. Cheon Ah-young, the daughter of the current leader, becoming the Divine Maiden would only work against the Vice Leader. It's obvious that she will side with her father... yet he's showing a smile.

However, Young did not dare to ask Joo Moon-baek about his thoughts. Instead, he finished reporting and stepped to the side.

Meanwhile, Joo Moon-baek's eyes had taken on a weird light.

“Hmm.” The Vice Leader tapped on his chin, thinking to himself.

I've kept an eye on her since her childhood. I've always thought she would become quite a beauty when she grows old enough. I always wondered why she disappeared about a decade ago... Being in the White Ape Unit must mean she has been in the Cave of Latent Demons. She has always done her best to impress her father since she was young, so it's not too surprising of a choice. But now that she's chosen as the Divine Maiden, her dreams must have met their end.

Joo Moon-baek smiled, thinking back to Cheon Ah-young's appearance. If she was the Captain of the White Ape Unit, he had seen her once.

I've been thinking that she was a beauty good enough to quench my surging thirst caused by the 'Art of the Soul Splitting Flame King'. And that's why I've been anticipating for the day that I would drag the Captain of the

White Ape Unit into my bedroom... So she was the daughter of the Leader all along? It looks like 10 years is enough to transform a child into a full grown lady. I want to seize her immediately.

No matter how strong Joo Moon-baek's personal beliefs were, he was still the Vice Leader of the Cult. Actually, his position was stressful. While he needed to keep up appearances, it made his lust boil that much stronger in search of release. He cultivated an art that strongly divided Yin and Yang, but focused on the Yang aspect. Thus, he felt intolerable thirst towards sources of Yin.

No, now's not the time. A premature move always spoils the plan.

However, just because he was patient didn't mean he could tolerate it. Joo Moon-baek reached over for his glass of water. He would quench his burning desire by holding another woman today.

It won't be bad to seize her at that very moment, when the time comes and I bring down the Heavenly Demon. A woman taken by the very man who had dragged down her father.

Joo Moon-baek was almost drooling, but he smiled.

Not bad. And in case things go south, I can always use that method!

Joo Moon-baek smiled, showing his white fangs.

That smile, what could be said?

“Hahahaha! A misfortune can also become a blessing, they say! It seems like those words are correct. Haha!”

It was only a matter of time before the man stopped laughing though.

As if he had become a different person, he asked his subordinate with piercing eyes.

“Hmm. By the way, what is he doing now?”

“He’s a much higher level martial artist compared to our last partner... So we’re having trouble keeping an eye on him. But one thing for sure is...”

“One thing for sure?”

“He’s confining himself in his place.”

Joo Moon-baek muttered the name as if he didn’t like the other very much. “The ‘Demonic Emperor of Oblivion’, huh...”

A man crouched over the figure of a woman, both panting heavily.

“Uagh!”

The woman moaned, as if in pain. It was unknown whether it was from the sexual intercourse or something else.

However, the appearance of the woman gradually changed, proving that the current exchange had nothing to do with passion.

Dark spots slowly bloomed all over her skin. Subsequently, wrinkles began to appear and the woman’s body began to wither.

The woman reached out and tried to push away the man laying on her.

However, it was impossible. Her body had aged and the degraded strength was not enough to push away a strong man.

“Uagh...”

As her body grew older, even the woman’s moans became weaker. As her voice faded, the eyes of the man became brighter and brighter. Life was spilling out! He licked his lips, excited by the act of taking someone else’s life.

And finally, when the woman breathed her last, the man slowly got up. The woman fell to the ground, becoming a shriveled corpse.

“Hmm.” The man stared at the body in disgust. “I know it’s my own work of art, but it’s still hideous to see.”

He kicked at the body with his foot, pushing it off of his bed and into the middle of the room. Remnants of blood and bodily fluid soiled the carpet. With a wave of his hand, the man burned the corpse into ashes with a fire. Then, a gust of wind blew the ashes apart.

“Be thankful, woman. I’m even cleaning up for you, heh-heh. Call in the Imperial Unit.”

The guard standing on duty immediately called out, “The Emperor is calling the Imperial Unit. Go report immediately!”

“Yes, sir.”

Soon, at the Emperor’s command, a man stood with his head bowed before him.

The Emperor smiled satisfactorily.

“Report.”

The other man didn’t even have to think.

“The secret vault of the ‘Sword Emperor of Ice and Light’ has recently collapsed and 1,248 Orthodox Sect individuals have lost their lives. The victims include elders from the Ten Major Sects and people from many other smaller ones. If we include the victims from any and all related events, the total casualties are around 2,000. About 30 have retired from the martial society after being severely injured. And of course, those who have retired are all at least first-class level martial artists.”

The so-called secret vault of the ‘Sword Emperor of Ice and Light’ had been big news ever since it was first discovered. When the Vault had been discovered, the Orthodox Sects had called it a ‘major blessing’...

Not only did martial artists start a mudslinging battle over the rights of the Vault, it was all in vain. In the end, the Vault collapsed and killed everyone

inside it. On top of that, the contents that were salvaged were identified to be fakes.

It was far from a blessing, becoming more of a calamity.

“The results were far more than what we had planned. It is safe to say you can be satisfied.”

“Hmm. Good... I mean, not bad. Since the Imperial Court has set foot in this matter, it only makes sense that we achieve this much.”

The government and the martial society leave each other alone. That was a very basic rule which even the youngest members of the smallest sects were aware of.

But just like how the martial society kept an eye on the government, the government did the same. Because martial artists were capable of destroying the elegant ruling system with overwhelming force, the government and the Imperial Court had actually interfered in a number of events.

However, this was the largest involvement ever since the ‘Martial Society Annihilation Plan’, a plan that was conducted over several centuries but only ended up in a failure.

If Murim became aware of this current involvement, there would be an uproar about how the Imperial Court was planning another annihilation.

However, the Emperor and his Imperial Court’s target wasn’t limited to Zhongyuan...

“What happened to the Demonic Cult?”

The cult he was referring to was obviously the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The subordinate shook his head. “It looks like that side of things will take some more time.”

“Hmm?” The Emperor glanced down and frowned slightly, obviously annoyed. *It’s already been several years since we conducted our plan against the Demonic Cult. And yet...*

“The Demonic Cult is virtually a religious group, which makes it an open and a closed group at the same time.”

The subordinate gave a plausible reason. It seemed that the Emperor agreed, as he nodded his head, indicating for the other to continue.

“This special nature of theirs is hindering our plans. However, we have reports that the ‘Moon Splitting Heavenly Demon’ has been successfully poisoned. It will not take long for us to see the results.”

“‘Not take long’, you say. And how long do you think this is going to be?”

The subordinate was silent for a few moments, reflecting.

“We received the reports of the poisoning 6 months ago. It’s about time that the Heavenly Demon himself has realized that he has been poisoned. Actually, it’s more likely that he realized long ago. Now, it should be near the point where resisting becomes impossible.”

“Which means...?”

“A major event will occur in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon within a month.”

The Emperor relaxed and smiled down at his subordinate. After a moment, he glanced to the side and tapped his chin.

“By the way, who was the man we sent to the Cult this time?”

“Do you mean the ‘Demonic Emperor of Oblivion’?”

“Oh, that’s right.” The Emperor thought of the man in question and laughed. “‘Oblivion’ in the sense that he deceives and tricks his enemies into oblivion. It’s quite the perfect nickname for him.”

[1] Young has the codename ‘Shadow’, which he is usually called.

Chapter 71: Collapse

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 71 – Collapse

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Wind sliced through the air like a sharp blade. High above was a jagged stone ceiling, beneath was a powerful river. If one mistake was made, it would be hard to even salvage an intact corpse.

There were two men standing on a narrow stone bridge above the river.

Whee-!

A whirlwind blew the corners of his clothing. However, it was smacked to the side with a flick of a spear.

One of the people standing upon the bridge was Woon-seong, of course.

Both men were exhausted though, at this point.

Despite that, one of them would have to die today.

Either someone was given a quick death by the blade, or they accidentally committed suicide by falling.

The one with the spear knew this well; his opponent was no different.

Woon-seong grabbed his spear.

At the same time, the blades of wind ceased.

However, Woon-seong was forced back.

This was because an even sharper wind started to gush forth from the other man's sword. It seemed the other had decided to stake everything on this one move.

Obviously, a dreadful move was coming. In order to not see his own blood, Woon-seong had to prepare the same.

‘Flow of the Divine Dragon’!

That was the strongest move the current Woon-seong had in his arsenal!

Whoo-hoo!

From his spear, a blue light seemed to form the image of a dragon. At the same time, there was an entire storm coming from the other man's body.

The dragon met the cloud of blades in the middle of the bridge, causing the cliffs to quake like they were about to collapse.

The wind poured around the dragon, piercing the area around Woon-seong's White Night Spear. Woon-seong did not hesitate anymore!

Roar!

Another dragon left Woon-seong's spear, harshly twisting through the windstorm.

Every time the new dragon twitched, the blades of wind shook.

As soon as the first dragon heard its new companion, it crashed through the wall of blades with renewed vigor, swallowing Woon-seong's opponent alive.

Fwoom!

The surroundings changed.

With a crackle, a round flame burned and lit the surroundings. Oil lamps could be seen as the smell of incense wafted over.

A man walked out.

It was the Heavenly Demon.

Unlike Woon-seong, who was now soaked in sweat, Cheon Hwi looked very leisurely.

“And that was the ‘Polymorphic Combat Illusion’ made by our Cult’s illusionists. What do you think?” he asked, using his qi to help Woon-seong stabilize.

“It was incredible. Seriously...”

The Polymorphic Combat Illusion.

It was an illusion designed by the Cult’s Senior Strategist, Sang Gwan-chuk, and completed by the illusionists. This illusion formation’s only purpose was to produce incredibly real illusions. But it had two quirks. One was that the illusions produced were terrifyingly realistic, and the other was that the illusions were all recreations of the Leader’s memories.

It was like facing an actual martial artist... I still remember the sensation of the ‘Dragon Fist Wind’ and the ‘Blade Winds’ from a moment ago.

Woon-seong sat there and could only shake his head.

Meanwhile, Cheon Hwi was lecturing him.

“A skilled martial artist must be aware of a hundred solutions for the hundreds of problems he will potentially face.” Cheon Hwi turned to look at the Third Gate, where the illusion had been installed.

“Even more so if you’re the head of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.” Turning back towards Woon-seong, his lips quirked upwards in a small

smile.

“That is why I made my past experiences into illusions and made you fight against them. In that sense, the Polymorphic Combat Illusion is excellent. Because I can make you experience a hundred problems, just like how I experienced them...don't you agree?”

Woon-seong nodded at these words.

Just like the Leader said, the Polymorphic Combat Illusion is tough... but it gives me a lot of experience.

I was also a martial artist in my past life, but I hadn't even reached the age of 30. Just based on years survived, my level of experience is nowhere close to that of the Heavenly Demon's. But by using the Polymorphic Combat Illusion, I can experience the Heavenly Demon's experiences as they were and become stronger.

Still, none of this is easy at all. I've already faced 3 martial artists from his past.

Oh... 3 a day... I filled my quota for today...

I should rest a little.

Woon-seong relaxed his body, letting himself lie down and stare at the ceiling.

Knowing that the other was tired, Cheon Hwi did not stop him from doing so. Instead of being upset, he was actually amazed.

He's already at this level while wearing metal bracers, which are even heavier now that I injected them with my qi... He continues to impress me. Cheon Hwi could barely keep a smile off his face. But I can't let him have it easy just yet. I still need to speed things up.

“How far are you with the Middle Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon?”

At these words, Woon-seong opened his eyes and sat up.

“I’ve achieved around Level 2.”

The First Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, the Dark Flower Red Heart, was considered to be mastered once the user could form the Essence of the Flame. The next step to achieve was the Middle Connection, the Flame-Soul Passage.

Level 2 means that he is closer to learning the Flame-Soul Passage. Not bad, Cheon Hwi nodded to himself. His pace of learning is fast because he has a high understanding of the art itself.

However... Maybe it was because he knew something Woon-seong did not, but Cheon Hwi’s heart was impatient.

“You’re still not there yet. You have to achieve at least Level 5 to completely integrate the Flame-Soul Passage with the Dark Flower Red Heart.”

Woon-seong could only agree. “Yes, sir.”

The Flame-Soul Passage, like the name suggested, was about achieving a complete connection between the soul and the Essence of the Flame. After integrating it with the Dark Flower Red Heart, it would become known as the ‘Flame Passage of the Dark Flower Red Heart’. The user bloomed a dark flower in their core, brooded a red heart, and connected with the Divine Flame.

“Only after this process will you achieve the Divine Shaped Flame. Continue with your effort.”

At this pace, it will take about 6 months for him to achieve Level 5, Cheon Hwi concluded. Such exceptional talent, it’s a terrific pace of learning. I can’t help but feel very proud of his growth...

A student’s growth should naturally please the teacher.

However, Cheon Hwi’s expression held more worry than joy.

Turning away from Woon-seong he wiped the blood dripping from his mouth and clutched his chest.

The problem is whether my body can last until the child can achieve that level.

While Woon-seong was training to become the Heavenly Demon, something else was happening on the other side of the Cult.

It was the succession ceremony of the Young Divine Maiden, Cheon Ah-young, who was chosen not long ago.

Even though it was ceremonial, the Divine Maiden was known as the mother of all 100,000 demonic believers.

It was not a ceremony that could be performed sloppily.

The ceremony took place a month after Cheon Ah-young was chosen as the Young Divine Maiden.

While the Divine Maiden's Palace was normally off limits for normal believers, the day of the succession ceremony was an exception.

Woon-seong stood with Cheon Hwi on a cliff, staring down at the people gathered below.

It's such a grand crowd of people who came to see the succession ceremony. Even with so many demonic practitioners, there is one road that isn't stepped on by any of them.

The Road of the Divine Maiden, the road connecting the Palace's front gate to the inside. Only the Divine Maiden is allowed to tread that path

No one else was allowed to step foot there.

Even the Heavenly Demon, the head of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, must enter the Divine Maiden's Palace through a different entrance.

Soon, Cheon Ah-young was going to walk down that path.

Hmm.

Speaking of Ah-young, Woon-seong had some strange thoughts.

I shouldn't have talked with her that day.

I wouldn't feel this way if I hadn't talked with you...

Focus, Hyuk Woon-seong... You will be alone, walking a path painted with blood. Since you have chosen the life of an avenger, that is an inevitable destiny.

Thinking about a woman when you have such burdens on your shoulders is nonsense.

Just like we talked about, it is best to think about everything else afterwards.

Woon-seong closed his eyes. It was only for a moment, but it was enough for all these thoughts to fly through his mind. When he opened them again, there was a great commotion.

“The Divine Maiden has entered!”

At the end of the road, Cheon Ah-young appeared.

She wore a splendid outfit, one that made her stand out to all those who gathered there. Unlike the usual, she wore makeup on her face. Along with her intricate outfit, her hair was styled, framing her features.

The cultivators gathered were dazzled by her presence. Silence settled as they stared in awe. It was an honor to have such a stunning Divine Maiden.

However, there was an exception.

Joo Moon-baek was basically drooling. He quickly schooled his expression though, but couldn't hide his slightly flushed cheeks. *Look at me... I accidentally leaked my vulgar inner thoughts.*

But not one person was paying much attention to him.

Lucky for him, everyone's attention was captured by another person's appearance.

Whoa!

One more time, a commotion started.

Opposite to Ah-young, the current Divine Maiden walked slowly out of the Palace. She held a bronze brazier in her hands, where flames burned brightly.

That flame was a symbol of the Cult.

The old woman smiled at Ah-young and approached her.

The moment she took the brazier, she would begin her new life as the Divine Maiden.

Of course, she still lacked a lot, so she would continue to learn from the previous Divine Maiden.

But the fact remained that her position as the Divine Maiden would bring major changes in her life.

The Heavenly Demon looked down at his daughter with a complicated gaze.

It was then that he felt a spark of pain in his chest.

At the same time, there was warm liquid rising out of his throat.

No, not now.

Cheon Hwi barely suppressed the urge to cough. His daughter was about to receive the brazier.

The brazier was slowly being lifted into the air, a new set of hands reaching for it.

In fact, Cheon Hwi already knew that he had been poisoned.

When I achieved the realm of a semi-deity, I was confident that I also became 'immune to a million poisons'. Yet it's a poison that affects me... it must've been an abnormal poison. Understandably, I couldn't find a cure. Sang Gwan-chuk did his best to find a solution, but it was impossible. As I thought, it was no ordinary poison.

So I bore with it. Even though I knew I couldn't last long, I endured. That's why, even when my apprentice... even when Woon-seong showed such an exceptional pace of learning, I wasn't able to hide my impatience.

It's my fault. I already knew I wasn't capable of holding on for long.

The brazier was slowly passed into the hands of Cheon Ah-young. All she had to do now was place the brazier at the altar in front of the Divine Maiden's Palace entrance.

Just then, once again, liquid rose in his throat. The pain in his chest became impossible to ignore

But not now.

Ah-young was climbing the steps to the altar.

Cheon Hwi pressed his lips tightly together, clenching his fists tightly.

No, not yet.

He willed his body to hold it together for just a few more moments.

Just a bit more...

“Uagh-!”

Cheon Hwi's body betrayed his will.

“Uack—!”

Coughing, black blood spilled out of his mouth and he collapsed onto his knees.

From the Heavenly Demon’s mouth, not anyone else’s...

Everyone’s gaze snapped towards the Heavenly Demon, confused and horrified.

Only Joo Moon-baek smiled.

Finally! Soon, the Cult will be mine!

Chapter 72: Aftermath

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 72 – Aftermath

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“What a terrible poison. Looking at the progress, I assume he was poisoned a long time ago...I’ve helped him regain consciousness, but I don’t think it will hold out much longer.”

The one speaking was the Head of the Medical Department, the ‘Demonic Doctor of Life and Death’. He was speaking to three others: the Senior Strategist, Woon-seong, and Cheon Ah-young.

Sang Gwan-chuk’s expression had horribly crumpled at the doctor’s words, as had Woon-seong’s.

Among them though, Ah-young looked the most distressed. She was unable to hide the trembling of her fingers. She clutched the fabric of her dress in an effort to hide it, but her entire body trembled.

“He should still be awake for a while longer. Would you like to see him?”

“Alright.”

At the doctor’s words, the Strategist nodded and opened the door to the room where the Leader was lying down.

With a soft swoosh, the door opened.

Inside, it was obvious that the man lying down was a hospital patient: strong wafts of medicinal fragrance flowed through the room.

The Heavenly Demon lay upon the bed, a far cry from his usual appearance.

It was a difficult scene to take in, as the Leader lay there like a tiger that had gotten its teeth knocked out.

“My Lord...”

The Strategist took a step inside, but Ah-young was faster.

“Father!”

She didn’t care that the doctor probably wouldn’t approve of her rushing in like that, kneeling by the bed and grabbing his hands. A strong wave of heat spread through the palms of her hands — how was a human’s body running so hot?

“What is this...?”

The heat almost rivaled that of a fire.

Cheon Hwi smiled bitterly at his daughter. “You’re here.”

His gaze then moved to the Strategist, who was standing a few feet away. “I’m sorry Strategist. I couldn’t withstand the poison.”

At Cheon Hwi’s words, both Woon-seong and Ah-young turned to look at the Strategist. *So Sang Gwan-chuk already knew about the poison.*

“Uncle Sang. Why... why didn’t you tell me?” Ah-young cried.

“...”

“If Uncle had told me, I could have looked for a cure earlier! Why didn’t you?!”

I was finally getting a chance to get closer with my father... Ever since I became the Divine Maiden, the best thing that happened was having a real talk with him...! But why does this have to happen now?

Cheon Ah-young's tone was desperate and emotional.

Sang Gwan-chuk didn't say anything. Given the situation, it was natural for him to be unable to easily explain.

"Don't fault him. I told him to do so."

Cheon Hwi's voice sounded much more powerful than before, but his breathing was still rough. "Of course, the Strategist looked for a cure himself. However, this poison doesn't exist anywhere in this world."

Now, Woon-seong became more concerned. *A poison that doesn't exist in this world? A completely new type of poison... So it's a poison that even the Leader, who achieved the realm of a semi-divine being, can't withstand?*

At that, Cheon Ah-young lowered her head. "But—!"

"It's okay."

Cheon Hwi cut off her words once more. "I won't die that easily. It's tough, but I can still withstand it. If I choose to, I'm sure I can live a few more years like this. And I'm sure the Senior Strategist will do something during that time."

"..."

Cheon Ah-young could only stay silent. She felt like she needed to say something, but there was nothing for her to say.

As soon as Cheon Ah-young shut up, Cheon Hwi's gaze turned towards Woon-seong, who was standing to the side. "There you are."

"Yes, Leader..."

"I told you to call me 'master'."

“Master.”

At the words of Woon-seong, Cheon Hwi nodded with difficulty. “That’s right. Call me ‘master’.”

“...”

“I’m sorry. It’s no good for a master to show such weakness in front of his apprentice... I shouldn’t be lying down like this.”

Cheon Hwi said all of this with a bitter smile. But Woon-seong did not see the expression on the Heavenly Demon’s face.

His gaze was directed elsewhere — he had begun to examine the Leader’s body.

I can see the signs of poison here and there. There’s dark circles under his eyes and red eruptions here and there. His eyes are also red, as though some capillaries have burst. Those red eruptions don’t seem normal either. They’re shaped like tiny handprints and there are purple dots in the middle of them.

Wait, is this....?!

Woon-seong’s eyes trembled.

I’ve seen signs like these on my former master’s body. It’s the same poison that took away his health little by little and ended up with him getting killed by the hypocrites of the Orthodox sects.

Why is that poison here...?

Woon-seong’s whole body trembled slightly, but he wasn’t given time to think because the Heavenly Demon had moved to grab his hand. Feverish heat spread from his palms.

“My apprentice.”

Woon-seong knelt at Cheon Hwi's side, turning his head towards the voice.
“Yes, Master. I'm here.”

Cheon Hwi had closed his eyes because he was losing consciousness. The tremor in his voice was worse than before.

Woon-seong remembered what the Divine Doctor had told them: *I barely made him conscious right now, but I don't think it will hold out much longer.*

“While I'm on the bed, take care of the Cult and...”

Cheon Hwi's grip slowly slackened and his hand fell onto the bed. The sound of his breathing became rougher and rougher and the room became silent.

The Leader had lost consciousness.

Woon-seong panicked and grabbed the Leader's wrist, feeling for a pulse.
His pulse is still there! Thankfully, he's just unconscious.

In Woon-seong's ears, which had been by the Heavenly Demon's mouth, rang Cheon Hwi's last words before unconsciousness.

“Please take care of Ah-young. I'm sorry to leave such a burden on you.”

That's not like you, Master...

It wasn't a very optimistic thing to say.

“It's been three months already.”

“That long already?”

The men speaking were from a delegation led by one of the Ten Demonic Masters, ‘Blade Demon of Hell’ Mo In-ryang.

At his signal, the group stopped to take a break. Subsequently, Mo In-ryang took a moment to look up at the clear sky.

“Three months. A lot has happened since then.”

There were murmurs of agreement.

The incident regarding the Heavenly Demon collapsing after coughing up blood during the succession ceremony of the Divine Maiden had been three months ago.

After it had happened, it was predicted that there would be a huge uproar inside the Cult.

Contrary to expectations, nothing much happened.

The only difference was that the Vice Leader, Joo Moon-baek, and the Young Leader, Hyuk Woon-seong, started leading the Cult.

Of course, that’s what it looked like on the surface.

What the general public saw was just the tip of the iceberg.

The very day Cheon Hwi collapsed, Vice Leader Joo Moon-baek showed his hidden ambitions — his ambition of wanting to kill the Leader and rule the Cult of the Heavenly Demon himself.

However, the Young Leader and Sang Gwan-chuk weren’t just going to let him have that position.

Thus, it was inevitable for a split to happen.

Anyone who had any idea of the internal politics within the Cult would know of this fact.

As time stretched on, the confrontation between the Vice Leader and the Young Leader would steadily meet its peak.

Tsk.

Within three months, the upper echelon had split between the factions of the Vice Leader and the Young Leader. There was no place for neutrality, since

two people could not become the Heavenly Demon.

Most of the Ten Demonic Masters had already chosen a faction, ending with an almost equal split.

I myself have chosen the Vice Leader, Mo In-ryang thought. Considering our old relations and the fact that he has always been friendly enough to me...

Of course, there were also those who had not set their minds upon one faction just yet, dragging out the conflict.

Which is also why I'm moving right now.

Mo In-ryang could only click his tongue lightly.

So he wants me to appease the 'Wind Demon Fist King' Koo Jong-byuk.

Under the orders of Joo Moon-baek, Mo In-ryang was moving to attract the Fist King to their side. Of course, he was only moving because it was the Vice Leader who had requested this, otherwise a Demonic Master like himself wouldn't have moved.

That guy, huh... I don't know him much besides that he's known to be a broad minded man.

Mo In-ryang had brought his usual escort, but there was no relationship between them and the Fist King. Of course, it wouldn't be bad to get to know him now.

I just hope he doesn't ask me to spar him out of nowhere. But considering his tendencies, I'm afraid it's likely to happen. If it does, depending on the situation, I guess I'll have to play along with him. If I want to satisfy him while not making myself look bad... I don't know how much I could do, but it seems best for me to stay on level with him.

Mo In-ryang turned his head to the side, where someone was carrying a huge bundle. Inside was a crate filled with goods sent on behalf of Joo

Moon-baek. Under normal circumstances, anyone who cared about wealth or collecting goods would be swayed.

I don't know about other people, but I doubt he will be interested in any of these goods. Still, I presume it's better than nothing.

Mo In-ryang could do nothing but think as he walked towards the Wind Demon's tower. Shortly after, one of his subordinates spoke, "I can see the Wind Demon's tower."

"Hmm."

Distantly, a couple people could be seen exiting the tower.

Mo In-ryang sighed to himself. *It looks like I'm late...*

As the people got closer, his subordinates also recognized the two and began to get restless. "Is that... the Young Leader and his people?"

The two who had come were indeed Hyuk Woon-seong and Great Demon Sang In-hyo, greeting the group with smug smiles.

"You're a step behind, 'Blade Demon'."

Woon-seong was the one who spoke first.

Mo In-ryang's brows furrowed slightly, but his voice gave nothing away. "What do you mean that I'm late?"

"Do you really need me to spell it out for you? Or are you just pretending that you don't understand?"

The atmosphere surrounding Woon-seong was casual before this Demonic Master.

Mo In-ryang's thoughts were racing, as this was a complicated situation.

The Young Leader has changed. Both in competence and skill level. If he's this much... hmm... I can hardly say he's different from my level. He was

barely a Demonic King when he first became the Young Leader, yet he has become on par with the Ten Demonic Masters... I have no idea what the Leader has done to him.

How much of Woon-seong's current level was due to training by the Heavenly Demon and how much of it was due to the young man's own talent? It was hard to say, but the latter was more important.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong's words had not stopped. "I'll explain it for you then. The Fist King has decided to join forces with us."

"Hmm."

At Woon-seong's words, the group behind Mo In-ryang grew uncomfortable. The Young Leader's gaze turned to the procession, staring at the crowd. The young man was no fool, he knew what the group was trying to do.

"You're making a useless attempt. I assumed you already knew that the Wind Demon Fist King is not the type of person who would be moved by commodities..."

"Who knows. They say that seeing is wanting and that gold can even buy a ghost."

Woon-seong snorted. "Then give it a try. We'll see if you're right or wrong."

As he finished, Woon-seong began to walk away. His actions did not seem to prevent the group from actually going inside, which made the crowd frown.

Woon-seong left one last message as he left, "I'll see you later then."

Since the Young Leader radiated his qi just now, Koo Jong-byuk in the Wind Demon Tower should also have an idea about what just happened. But he hasn't shown himself at all. Which means he has already made up his mind... Damn it. I don't know how the Young Leader convinced Koo Jong-

byuk, but it's clear that he's not on our side. Meeting the Fist King now would just be a waste of both of our times.

“What should we do...?” One of Mo In-ryang’s subordinates asked hesitantly.

“Let’s head to the Flame King Tower.”

Chapter 73: The Demonic Teacher (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 73 – The Demonic Teacher (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Hmm. Four against four.”

Joo Moon-baek was talking with his subordinates and tapping his chin in thought.

The group knew exactly what he meant.

The Cult was divided into two factions, the Vice Leader’s and the Young Leader’s.

The number of Ten Demonic Masters in the Vice Leader’s faction, excluding Joo Moon-baek himself, was four.

The number of Ten Demonic Masters in the Young Leader’s faction, including the Senior Strategist, was also four.

Given that Woon-seong was not inferior to a Demonic Master, the numbers were virtually equal.

Comparing the forces under the Ten Demonic Masters was also useless too, since those forces were also pretty much equal.

“Most of the Twelve Supporting Units decided to be neutral. However, the White Ape Unit and the Charred Dragon Unit are naturally supporting the Young Leader, so it looks like we’re losing on that side...”

Joo Moon-baek laughed to himself since there was nothing that he could do. “Heh heh heh.”

How long had he prepared for this?

How many years had he waited patiently to become the leader?

How much effort had he put in to hide his ambition from the tyrant known as the Heavenly Demon?

Yet, nothing had changed after the Heavenly Demon collapsed.

No. The Strategist has been openly condemning me because I showed my ambition.

What led to the current situation was indeed the influence of the Senior Strategist.

I should have made him part of my plan long ago...

Knowing that would have been impossible, Joo Moon-baek shook his head.

Sang Gwan-chuk is deeply loyal to the Leader. He’s not a man I can simply convince onto my side.

Mo In-ryang suddenly spoke up. “Since we’re too late with the Wind Demon Fist King, how about we try to convince the ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’?”

Joo Moon-baek tapped his finger, taking this suggestion into consideration.

The ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’ (日月魔師).

As the eldest of the Ten Demonic Masters, he was still known to be healthy and strong despite being over 100 in age. Even though his age should have

been a drawback, none of the Ten Demonic Masters could guarantee a sure victory against him.

Even Joo Moon-baek, who was supposedly the most powerful out of the Ten Demonic Masters, was expected to barely achieve victory six out of ten times.

Also, now that the Wind Demon Fist King had officially taken a side, the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon was the only member of the Ten Demonic Masters who still maintained a neutral stance.

“Hmm... the ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’...”

Importantly, he was also nicknamed the ‘Teacher of the Demonic Way’ and a popular figure amongst the believers of the Cult. Not only would the number of officials be tipped, the public would also back them up.

If that was possible we would be able to topple this tight balance in an instant... The ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’...

Joo Moon-baek looked at the corner of the room as he thought about this.

There stood an underling of his, ‘Shadow’.

The man, seeing that Joo Moon-baek was asking a silent question, shook his head.

The Vice Leader sighed. “The ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’ will not move easily.”

“Not move easily? How can you be so sure?”

When asked the question by the crowd, Joo Moon-baek sat down and reclined in a chair. “I have a reliable source that can communicate with him. I have no way to convince him right now.”

The Vice Leader’s voice held great certainty, so the group could only quietly agree.

But once again, Mo In-ryang asked the Vice Leader if he had abandoned his stubbornness.

“Ugh. Is there really no way?”

In another place, Woon-seong and his supporters were having a similar conversation.

The Senior Strategist said a decisive, “No.”

Woon-seong could only nod, “I see.”

It may seem that the two factions were equal in strength, but that also meant it would only take a slight shift in the balance to make a huge difference.

It was quite the dangerous situation.

And the best way to get out of this state was to bring in the only remaining neutral Demonic Master...

It may seem like we're equal in strength, but it also means that it only takes a slight shift in the balance to make a huge difference in the current situation. And the best way to shift it to our favor...

“It seems I have no choice but to make the Demonic Teacher one of ours.”

At the words of the Young Leader, it was Great Demon Sang In-hyo who nodded slowly. “He will not be easily convinced. That’s why you will have to go talk to him yourself.”

Woon-seong agreed. “Just like the Wind Demon Fist King.”

With that said, the Senior Strategist excused himself from the conversation. “I’ll be off for now then. Someone else will come to help you.”

To be honest, I was incredibly lucky to bring the Wind Demon Fist King to our side. Woon-seong realized that this whole “balanced” situation was only possible thanks to Sang Gwan-chuk. Not only did he immediately bring two of the Ten Demonic Masters to our side, as though he predicted

the whole situation, but he also brought the Fist King's gauntlets within a mere three months. This is only possible if he thought about bringing the Wind Demon Fist King to our side before this all began.

“I assume that the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon will only be more difficult...”

When Woon-seong spoke his thoughts out, someone entered the room and spoke.

“But in the end, we have to do it.”

The gazes of Woon-seong and Sang In-hyo were on the newcomer at the same time.

“Fire Demon.”

It was Sang In-hyo who spoke, as the man at the door was known to him.

The newcomer was the ‘Fire Demon of Scars’, Mok Dae-young.

He was formerly the Cult's Kashgar Branch Manager, but after the Heavenly Demon collapsed, Strategist Sang had brought him in for Woon-seong, who was in dire need of an information gathering expert.

And just as Sang Gwan-chul had hoped, Mok Dae-young had been working well as Woon-seong's source of information. [2]

“Greetings, Young Leader.”

Woon-seong acknowledged the newcomer, who was late, with a nod. “Is there a way?”

Seeing as the man was late, the Senior Strategist must have given him some advice.

As Mok Dae-young walked inside, he shrugged his shoulders and shook his head. “Even the Senior Strategist said it's difficult to predict what he's thinking.”

“It looks like I’ll have to meet him in person. Since Sang Gwan-chuk doesn’t have an answer, I’ll just have to face this matter straight on...”

Mok Dae-young and Sang In-hyo nodded. Even the Senior Strategist believed there was nothing else they could do.

In thought, Woon-seong played with the fabric of the White Night Spear, which was strapped to his back.

It was then that Sang In-hyo said something with conviction:

“The only person who can convince the ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’ is the Young Leader.”

Woon-seong nodded lightly.

This was because the Young Leader had taken those as words said solely to cheer him up.

But, he didn’t know...

When Sang In-hyo had said these seemingly optimistic words though, his gaze had been on Woon-seong’s spear...

Eventually, Woon-seong, who was now in front of the Sun and Moon Tower closed his eyes. He knew that if he walked inside he would find the ‘Demonic Teacher’.

By the way, I have no idea why the Vice Leader is being so open with his ambition.

Standing there, Woon-seong’s thoughts were moving quickly.

The position of ‘Heavenly Demon’.

It’s obviously a position that every member of the Cult has dreamed of at least once in their life. If I was born a demonic practitioner, I probably would’ve aimed for it myself, even if it wasn’t for my revenge.

At the same time, a position that everyone dreams about isn't a position that anyone can achieve. Out of the numerous demonic practitioners, only a few with the right conditions can achieve it.

The first condition was simply sufficient strength. With 'survival of the strongest' being the top virtue of the Cult, the weak obviously could never become the Heavenly Demon.

Of course, the 'Soul Splitting Flame King' satisfies this condition. He may be younger than the 'Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon', but his martial arts are known to be a level higher.

The second condition was lineage. However, this problem could also be solved relatively easily. Simply being connected with the Cheon Family through marriage was enough to maintain the legitimacy of bloodline.

Ah-young will resist, but if you think about it, Joo Moon-baek is a man who can and will do anything he needs to. He wouldn't hesitate to use some vile art to make Ah-young obey him if necessary.

The real problem is the last condition...

The third and final condition was the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

Unlike the other two, this was the most surefire way to gain legitimacy.

However, the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon wasn't something one learned *after* becoming the Heavenly Demon.

It was learned by those who were *destined* to become the Heavenly Demon.

Therefore anyone who wished to become the Heavenly Demon had to also be familiar with the Divine Art.

But the fact that the Vice Leader showed his ambition... Does that mean he learned the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon? This question only creates more questions. If he did learn, how?

The Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon had no written form and was passed down person by person, from the Cult Leader to his apprentice.

That was a fact Cheon Hwi had personally confirmed.

So how could Joo Moon-baek have possibly learnt it?

Woon-seong wrinkled his eyebrows in confusion as this question weighed on him.

A cold breeze blew across the hill. As it passed through his sleeves, Woon-seong was woken up from his musings.

I'll worry about this later.

As usual, it was best to focus on what was before him.

With his mind made up, Woon-seong observed the Sun and Moon Tower. Unlike the others, the Sun and Moon Tower had a quiet and calm atmosphere. *It looks more like a storage tower than one owned by a Demonic Master.* There were fields of grass and even some farming tools lying around. The equipment was still covered in soil, as if it had just been used yesterday. *So it's true that the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon enjoys farming...*

At that time, one of the people working there came out of the tower. The man hurried over to Woon-seong. "I've been expecting you."

Woon-seong nodded towards this man.

"But I'm sorry. There's a guest who came before you, so you will have to wait for a while."

A guest?

Woon-seong's eyebrows twitched.

I'm sure I sent a message that I'll come visit him. Yet he still accepted a guest before me? According to what people say, the Demonic Teacher of

Sun and Moon is not a man of disrespect or rudeness.

The more the thought about the other's temperament, the more ridiculous it was.

If so...

Woon-seong quickly came to a conclusion, which didn't help his irritation.

It's either that the guest is such a big figure that even the 'Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon' couldn't refuse, or the guest has visited him forcefully. Or maybe both. And there is only one person who would be either case.

"Hmm."

Woon-seong's expression almost instantly crumpled.

The subordinate waiting for him, who saw it, swallowed in fear. *Did I upset him?!* The young man standing in front of him was the Young Leader, with strength and status on par with the Ten Demonic Masters. If the Young Leader decided to pull out a knife and kill him anger, he would be able to do nothing at all. *I'm so dead...*

Woon-seong, who had been scowling, finally spoke. "Still, lead me to him."

"Y-yes sir! This way, please!" At that, the servant lowered his head while sighing in relief. *I live to see another day...*

As they walked, Woon-seong observed the inside of the tower.

Just like the exterior, the interior of the tower is also different. There are no luxurious items at all. Most of them are made and repaired with planks and wooden nails. That actually gives me the shivers. Because in the worst case scenario, the blade used to carve those wooden pieces would be pointing at me.

Suddenly, cold sweat built up on Woon-seong's neck. He hadn't been this nervous in a long time.

If the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon became my enemy and I had to fight him to the death, my chances would be at best six to four.

Me being four and the 'Demonic Teacher' being six.

Although I won't know for sure until it happens.

One thing for sure is that his martial arts skills are enough to make me shiver.

Woon-seong ignored the uncomfortable sensation and continued to walk into the tower.

The servant continued to politely show Woon-seong the way, afraid to make the other angry. "This way, please."

This is a familiar presence. Familiar, yet unpleasant.

It was a presence he'd become familiar with after the Heavenly Demon had collapsed.

I made the right decision. I knew it. The man inside there is...

Before Woon-seong could do anything, people appeared in the corners of the corridor. They were all wearing uniforms of red and black.

Woon-seong remembered what the Senior Strategist had told him: "*Since you'll constantly be clashing with the Vice Leader, I'll take this time to tell you in advance about the most important core forces of the 'Soul Splitting Flame King'. The 'Flame King' commands Seven Reapers, which are the seven men known as the 'Soul Splitting Reapers'.*"

Just as Woon-seong had recognized them, they also recognized him and blocked him from moving past the corridor.

"You people seem to know who I am. And you still decide to get in my way?" Sounding enraged, Woon-seong unstrapped his spear and let out his qi presence. "You lowly servants dare to do that?! Come! I will make you pay for your sins on this very spot!!"

[1] As a reminder, Mok Dae-young and Sang In-hyo know each other because they both worked at the ‘Thousand Miles Communication Department’.

Chapter 74: The Demonic Teacher (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 74 – The Demonic Teacher (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The atmosphere immediately became incredibly tense.

It was the seven Soul Splitting Reapers who spoke first.

The one who looked like their leader blocked Woon-seong slightly. “We were ordered to let no one inside.”

Woon-seong laughed dryly, “An order to let no one in...”

Woon-seong stirred up his aura as he talked, causing it to spread like fog and wind throughout the entire passageway. So as to avoid any meaningless casualties, he signaled for the servant to leave first. At the same time, he reached out and pulled down his White Night Spear.

“Then I ask you in the name of the Young Leader. Is that order above the law of the Cult?”

The others in the corridor trembled at his voice. Along with the crushing qi imbued into Woon-seong’s words, his aura was suffocating. Their limbs trembling, the air around the Soul Splitting Reapers felt heavy like wet wool.

Even more frightening was the culprit, with his shining golden eyes standing amongst a dark cloud. *Look at him... it's like facing a tiger disguised as a man.*

Moreover, what Woon-seong had said kept ringing in their ears.

Was this order more important than the law of the Cult?

According to the laws of the Cult, the Vice Leader and the Young Leader were equally ranked.

Equal positions.

That was why an order from the Vice Leader could not be used to stop the Young Leader.

Moreover, the ones to carry out the order were the Reapers themselves. As subordinates of the Vice Leader, it was reasonable for them to open the way.

However, the members of the Soul Splitting Reapers acted differently.

These seven men had pledged absolute loyalty to Joo Moon-baek and only Joo Moon-baek.

Woon-seong made a slight movement with his spear, merely adjusting his grip, and seven swords immediately pointed in his direction.

Seeing that, Woon-seong gripped his spear tightly.

“So that’s the choice you have made.”

He was here today to persuade the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon. These people could be considered the enemy, but he hadn’t been planning to spill blood today.

“It looks like I’ll have to give the Demonic Teacher my apologies for dirtying his hallway first.”

As a result, even if this corridor turned into a pool of blood, a decision made was not easily taken back.

The moment when the Soul Splitting Reapers were ready to die and leap towards Woon-seong, someone's voice stopped them.

“Enough.”

The gazes of Woon-seong and the Soul Splitting Reapers naturally focused in the direction of the voice, where a door had opened and a man was slowly walking out.

Red and black clothing, just like the seven Reapers, only more stylish and luxurious.

Woon-seong recognized the man and said calmly, “Soul Splitting Flame King.”

“It's been a while, Young Leader.” The man also pretended that nothing was out of the ordinary.

If it wasn't obvious, Joo Moon-baek had just met with the Demonic Teacher. He may have been old, but he couldn't hide the slight spring in his step. Or maybe he purposefully didn't bother to hide it.

Woon-seong's eyes and thoughts moved rapidly.

The Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon isn't with him. It looks like they haven't allied yet.

Internally, he heaved a sigh of relief.

If Joo Moon-baek had managed to convince the Demonic Teacher, it would have been a huge problem.

Regardless, the relieved Woon-seong still growled. “I don't know how you raise your dogs, but they were uselessly violent for being out of their bounds.”

The expression of the seven Reapers, who had just been called dogs, crumpled.

“You may be the Young Leader, but you cannot insult us like that!”

“We’d rather die in a fight than listen to an insult like that!”

Joo Moon-baek shouted and stopped them. “Enough!” His heavy voice echoed through the hall. “There’s no need to react against a taunt like that. Facing your blades against him will only make things complicated. Don’t you think so too, Young Leader?”

As he listened, Woon-seong’s eyes deepened. *He’s no easy man.* It seemed that Joo Moon-baek had the patience and caution to think things through, though he might be running out of it.

As if supporting Woon-seong’s thoughts, Joo Moon-baek continued to taunt, “I’m sorry. Dogs are just dogs after all... It looks like they misunderstood my words when I said to not let in *anyone normal*.”

“‘Anyone normal’, huh...” Woon-seong knew it was no coincidence that the word ‘anyone’ had been emphasized, but he also knew not to lose his temper. Thus, he skillfully responded, “Don’t worry. How would any of this be the dogs’ fault? It’s just their master’s for not training them properly.”

This time, Joo Moon-baek’s eyebrow twitched and the atmosphere became glacial.

I wasn’t planning to actually fight... But looking at the flow of things...

There was a voice that broke the mood. “How long are you going to block my guest like that, you brat.”

At that, Joo Moon-baek recollected all of his aura. “Hah hah. My apologies, Senior.”

Even though he had been called a brat, the Vice Leader didn’t look angry. In any case, the Demonic Teacher was older than almost anyone in the Cult —

had probably been a Demonic King before Joo Moon-baek was out of diapers — he was qualified to call Joo Moon-baek a brat.

Moreover, like Woon-seong had concluded, the Demonic Teacher was still neutral. Joo Moon-baek needed to give him some face.

“Enough with the stupid chit-chat and let him in!”

Joo Moon-baek could only shrug. “Go in, Young Leader.”

The look on Woon-seong’s face was absolutely cold. He stared at the Vice Leader, then turned and walked towards the room.

As Joo Moon-baek made way, so did his underlings. However, the seven Reapers glared at the young man with anger.

As they passed by each other, Joo Moon-baek added, “I wish to meet you in a more proper setting next time.”

What the Vice Leader meant was a place where the two could fight each other to the death.

This fit in well with Woon-seong’s desire to rip Joo Moon-baek a new one.

Woon-seong faced him, smiling to show his fangs.

“I agree.”

“Hmph!”

At the sound of Woon-seong’s words, there was a brief snort that left the room across the hall.

With that said, Woon-seong immediately entered the Demonic Teacher’s office of sorts.

“So, what brings the Young Leader to the dwelling of this old man?”

The one speaking was obviously the ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’, Lee Shin-jung.

Woon-seong observed him, taking in the plain clothing and the long white beard. “It’s an honor to meet you, Demonic Teacher. But I just realized... you seem to look like more of a divine spirit than a demonic master.”

“Hah hah hah. It’s odd to see the Young Leader flatter an old man like me. Oh, pardon me. I should’ve started with offering you a seat. Please, sit down. I’ll bring some tea.”

So this man is the ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’, Lee Shin-jung. He looks like an ordinary old man. But that’s why I should be more cautious. He’s one of the Ten Demonic Masters — I must not let my guard down just because of his looks.

Woon-seong noticed something black and white on the other’s arm. The coloring was unique, but it looked ordinary otherwise.

Must be the ‘Black and White Heavenly Rings’ (黑白神環輪). A bracer which grows into the shape of rings through injecting qi. I was told that it’s the Demonic Teacher’s unique weapon. Apparently it’s a heavenly item that is designed to match the yin-yang qi he has cultivated.

A little self-consciously, Woon-seong responded with, “Thank you.”

After Woon-seong had sat down, the Demonic Teacher did too. With a smile, he pushed a teacup towards the young man. “Have a drink. I harvested the tea leaves myself.”

Woon-seong picked up the cup of tea and drank it, letting the aroma spread through his mouth. *A simple but sincere taste...*

“How do you like it?”

“It’s not bad.”

“So if it’s not bad, do you mean it’s not good either?” For some reason, the Demonic Teacher found this terribly funny and burst into laughter.

“Hahahahaha!” After laughing until he teared up, Lee Shin-jung suddenly stopped smiling. His piercing gaze landed on the body of the Young Leader. “You’re quite an honest man, Young Leader.”

“I just said my thoughts as is.”

“Hmm. Frankness is a good trait. I like people who are honest.”

“...”

“Now, tell me. What brings you here to meet an old man like me?”

All the talk about honesty was to bring up this question.

The Demonic Teacher wanted to know why Woon-seong was here, without the other trying to hide his intentions or omit details.

Very well. Woon-seong smiled. *I wasn’t intending to hide it anyways.*

As long as the Demonic Teacher wasn’t an idiot, it was obvious why Woon-seong was here. Plus, Joo Moon-baek had just been here for the same purpose.

Woon-seong looked up and replied, “I’m here for the same reason as the Vice Leader.”

“For the same reason as the Joo kid, huh...”

The Demonic Teacher’s gaze turned away from Woon-seong, as if the other man was in thought. Instead, his gaze settled on the White Night Spear that Woon-seong had set to the side.

His eyes curled up like crescent moons.

“You have quite an interesting spear with you.”

Woon-seong felt like the conversation was going in the wrong direction, but accepted the topic change for now.

“I found it in the Cult’s weapon vault.”

“Ho ho. I’m sure you found it because you had a connection with it. The question is just how deep that connection is...”

Woon-seong seemed to notice a peculiar light in the Demonic Teacher’s eyes. *Does he know something about this spear? If that’s the reason he changed the subject...*

“Do you know about this spear?”

At that, Lee Shin-jung smiled innocently. “It’s your spear. I’m sure you know much more about it than I possibly do.”

Woon-seong felt like that was a smile that held many hidden meanings. *I’m sure that the Demonic Teacher knows something about the Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night. Then does he also know anything about the Unrecorded? What about the force that the Unrecorded left behind in the spear?*

But Woon-seong was hesitant to bring up any of his secrets, so he eventually cleared his mind. “You’re right. This is my spear.”

“Ho ho ho.”

To this response, the Demonic Teacher only chuckled.

What kind of laugh that was, Woon-seong had no idea. *I have no idea what this man is thinking...*

“Then I’ll get straight to the point. I wish you to help me instead of the Vice Leader.”

“You want me to help you?”

“I know you haven’t left your tower for a while, but I assume you are aware of the situation within the Cult. Am I wrong?”

The Demonic Teacher continued to smile as he chuckled at Woon-seong's serious tone. "Ho ho ho."

Actually, Woon-seong wasn't wrong. Although he bustled about as if he lived in a farm village, the Demonic Teacher had eyes everywhere in the Cult. While not everyone knew about it, Lee Shin-jung controlled the largest organization in the Cult.

Of course, Woon-seong had no idea. He'd just assumed that this was something important enough to travel into the ears of the Demonic Teacher.

"I only know that the conflict between the Joo kid and the Young Leader is at its peak... and you want me to help you with it?"

Woon-seong nodded.

Lee Shin-jung drained the cup of tea in front of him.

"Help, you say... That isn't too difficult. To be honest, that Joo kid came and asked for the same thing."

Woon-seong's eyes seemed to sparkle.

That's obvious enough. Considering that Joo Moon-baek is, strictly speaking, slightly losing against me, it is easy to predict that he was going to make a move.

"He asked me to help him, and if not, to be on nobody's side. Do you wish for the same, Young Leader?"

Helping me would be the best case, but it would still be the next best thing if he at least decides to not help the Vice Leader. And Joo Moon-baek would have thought the same.

Woon-seong nodded once more as he adjusted his grip on the White Night Spear.

"If so, I have no choice but to ask you the same question I asked the Joo kid."

The same question that he had asked Joo Moon-baek.

Perhaps the Vice Leader had been unable to answer the question. Or, at least, he hadn't given the answer Lee Shin-jung wanted.

Considering the Demonic Teacher hasn't made a move yet...

With Woon-seong still in thought about the current situation, a question came from Lee Shin-jung.

“Young Leader. Is what you seek simply my help or my sincere help?”

Technically, Woon-seong only needed the Demonic Teacher's help. But it would be even better if someone like Lee Shin-jung was sincere, so the answer was already established.

“It is your sincere help.”

Woon-seong believed that Joo Moon-baek would have given the same answer, so the important thing was the Demonic Teacher's response.

“Hmm. So it's my sincere help. That makes sense.”

“...”

“But do you know? In order to earn my sincere help, you need to fulfill one condition.”

Woon-seong leaned forward as he listened.

“If you cannot fulfill it... even the Leader himself cannot earn my sincerity.”

“And what is that condition?”

The question made the Demonic Teacher smile. He didn't tell Woon-seong the answer to that. However...

“You may already have the answer to that, Young Leader. You just might not know it.”

In other words, everything was up to Woon-seong.

Chapter 75: The Divine Shaped Flame (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 75 – The Divine Shaped Flame (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Three shadows were cast upon the floor by the glow of an oil lamp. Two shadows were bowing towards the one in front of them.

“...”

The one who spoke first was the owner of the shadow standing on the right, “How was your meeting with the two?”

Surprisingly, this man was Sang In-hyo.

The man who stood beside Sang In-hyo also raised his head, allowing the lamp to reveal his face. Unexpectedly, it was the man known as ‘Shadow’, who worked under the Vice Leader.

This was a meeting of the closest subordinates of the Vice Leader and the Young Leader.

Even more surprising was the identity of the third shadow standing before them: an old man.

With both Sang In-hyo and Shadow staring at him in earnest, the old man turned his head back with a soft murmur.

The light revealed that his old man was actually Lee Shin-jung, the ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’!

“Hmm...,” the Demonic Teacher raised a wrinkled finger and scratched his face lightly. “First, the Joo Kid has something very similar, but I cannot say for sure that it’s the real thing. It’s similar, but incomplete and different.”

The expression of Shadow darkened as Sang In-hyo’s expression brightened.

But that was not the end of the old man’s words.

“However, the Young Leader isn’t much different either. Compared to the Joo Kid, there’s a higher chance that the Young Leader is closer to the real one. However, he doesn’t know what he has yet.”

This time, Sang In-hyo had also stiffened.

According to the Demonic Teacher, neither candidate fit the bill.

“What do you plan to do?” Shadow asked.

Lee Shin-jung raised his hand to stroke his beard. “I should keep an eye on them for a bit longer. After all, we are the Unrecorded Demonic Group.”

Both Shadow and Sang In-hyo bowed their heads in acceptance.

The Unrecorded Demonic Group.

A group that remained outside of official Cult records, yet continued to help the Cult.

Except, that wasn’t the only reason they were called the ‘Unrecorded Demonic Group’.

“Our true master is the heir of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon, who will descend upon us one day,” Lee Shin-jung slowly muttered.

When that time came, Lee Shin-jung would choose. Should he help the Young Leader or the Vice Leader...

Or maybe it will be a completely different person...

Even as Lee Shin-jung recited this truth to himself, the night was getting deeper and deeper as other things happened in the Cult.

“Ugh.”

A stab of pain rushed through Joo Moon-baek’s chest and he patted his pockets, looking for a small piece of medicine. Finding it, he shoved it into his mouth without any hesitation. Once it was swallowed, the pain subsided. At the same time, his fingers, which had been trembling, also stilled.

“Phew.”

Maybe it was because the pain was gone, but he let his hand fall from his chest with a relaxed expression.

In his other hand, a grey flame rose from his fingertips. This was a Divine Shaped Flame, a result of cultivating the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

But it was a little different from the flame created by the Heavenly Demon. The genuine flame had a red color, similar to real fire. Although, of course, it was more of a blood red color.

Compared to that, the flame in Joo Moon-baek’s hand was grey.

“The Divine Flame of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon...”

He looked at the flame burning across his fingertips. Not just its color, but the power intrinsically contained in the Divine Flame was reproduced.

Naturally, as the Divine Flame of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon, the art and look was different.

But it's incomplete. A grey Divine Flame isn't enough to prove that it's the art of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon. The Unrecorded Heavenly Demon's Divine Flame possesses two characteristics... One is its grey color, which is different from the conventional Divine Flame. And the other one, which is also its flaw... is that possessing this Divine Flame disrupts the balance of the body.

“Hmm.”

Without medicine, I'm barely able to even walk around with this inside me... So... this is the price I have to pay for forcefully using the power of the Heavenly Demon. If I simply abandon this Divine Shaped Flame, my body will go back to being normal.

But I cannot do that.

The Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon is the symbol of legitimacy for becoming the ruler of the Cult. Without this power, I can never become the leader. I'll have to bear with it using medicine.

Joo Moon-baek sighed as he recalled the amount of medicine that he had left — a mere ten pills.

But even with the medicine, I can only present the Divine Flame for fifteen minutes. And that's why it's considered incomplete... If it wasn't for this problem, I would've proceeded with my plans more vigorously.

Joo Moon-baek grit his teeth in frustration, but was interrupted by sounds from outside his door. “What is it?” he shouted, as he was accustomed to having visitors.

“You have a guest, sir.”

As expected, he had a visitor.

“A guest?” Joo Moon-baek tilted his head and looked out the window, where the moon was rising above the mountains. *At this late in the night?* Unknowingly, he clicked his tongue. “Who is it?”

The response was succinct, “The ‘Demonic Emperor of Oblivion’ is here.”

That response surprised Joo Moon-baek. *He has never visited me since the first time he came here and formally met me. And he decides to visit me now?* He had no idea why this man would come looking for him at this time. *I can't say I like this.* Still, he only shook his head and said, “Let him in.”

As soon as he spoke, the door opened and someone walked in.

It was a figure that appeared like a ghost.

Of course, it was the ‘Demonic Emperor of Oblivion’, Hwan Dok. On his back was this sack of some sort, tied in a piece of black cloth.

“It’s been a while. We didn’t have much of a chance to communicate, did we?”

The words of Joo Moon-baek were spoken like a taunt, but the other man spoke without a change in facial expression. “I just needed time to get used to the Cult.”

“So I assume you’re done adapting now.”

“Of course.” For the first time, a smile appeared on the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion’s face. “I wouldn’t have been making something interesting like this before I made myself comfortable.”

As he spoke, Hwan Dok set down whatever he was carrying on his back. With a thump, he also removed the cloth that covered it.

“What...?!”

It was a man with a medium-pale complexion. Immediately, Joo Moon-baek’s attention was drawn in by the red pupils.

Joo Moon-baek quickly reached out and grabbed the wrist of this man.

He doesn't have a pulse, but I can feel a faint sense of liveliness in his body... On top of that, there's a strong sense of vile qi.

Joo Moon-baek, coming to this conclusion, took a step back.

“That thing is neither dead nor alive. It exists somewhere in between.”
Hwan Dok casually explained, “A blood jiangshi [1].”

“So you’ve been spending your time making this?”

“Yes, but this was a test case, so I only used a second-rate demonic practitioner.”

“Hmm. A blood jiangshi made from a second-rate demonic practitioner...”

“But now that he’s a blood jiangshi, he can compete with a martial artist who’s about to ascend to first-rate.”

Joo Moon-baek tapped his chin with his finger. “And why, pray tell, are you showing me this?”

With a smile on his face, Hwan Dok responded, “I know that you’re not exactly in the best situation right now.”

“Hmm.”

Joo Moon-baek agreed to this in his heart. What if the Demonic Teacher stopped being neutral and took the Young Leader’s side? If that happened, it was clear that the demonic practitioners who took his side would immediately step down. No, not only would his subordinates abandon him, he would probably be removed from his position as Vice Leader by Woon-seong.

Hwan Dok continued, “Which is why I would like to make a deal. Give me ten peak-level martial artists. I’ll make them into blood jiangshi and give them to you.”

“Ten peak-level martial artists?!” Joo Moon-baek exclaimed. “You’re talking about Great Demons and barely 300 of them exist within the Cult! And you want ten of them? You must be joking.”

“I’m not,” the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion said, shaking his head. “Give me ten people, no, ten bodies of peak-level martial artists... and I’ll present you ten blood jiangshi, each as strong as a transcendence-level martial artist.”

“The Cult also possesses ways to create blood jiangshi. I know because I’ve seen them before. However... The methods are too cruel, making them forbidden by the rules of the Cult. Doing such things will only scar my reputation within the Cult...”

Joo Moon-baek was honestly feeling reluctant. Even the Cult of the Heavenly Demon felt that the creation of blood jiangshi was not acceptable and he was unwilling to harm his reputation.

Hwan Dok smiled sympathetically, his eyes seeming like he wanted to entice his potential customer. “I also wish you never have to use them, but we’re talking about it just in case things go in an unfavorable direction.”

“Just in case...”

“You never know what might happen.”

Transcendence-level. Ten blood jiangshi each as strong as a Demonic King should come in handy sometime. Hmm.

The more Joo Moon-baek thought about it, the more Hwan Dok’s words were like sweet poison. He knew that this could be a horrible idea, but he couldn’t help but reach out.

“You can just get rid of them after everything is over. Fabricating events as though they never happened. I believe you have the ability to make that happen, Vice Leader.”

Joo Moon-baek was thinking about it again, and the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion didn't intend to rush him.

After much thought, Joo Moon-baek said, "I'll think about it."

At that, Hwan Dok turned around with a nod. "You're free to take your time. It's just a deal, after all. I'll leave this blood jiangshi here, so feel free to take a look at it."

As he left Joo Moon-baek's room, he coincidentally met the eyes of Shadow, who had been standing to the side.

At that moment, all Shadow saw was a stream of bright light.

It was only for a short moment, one that Joo Moon-baek didn't seem to catch, but Hwan Dok's eyes flashed with red light. This light soaked into the eyes of Shadow and soon disappeared.

After finishing what he wanted to do, Hwan Dok left with a smile on his face. He already knew what was going to happen.

It's over.

The Vice Leader is as much a worried man as he is a greedy one. Which makes him the easiest type to predict.

Ten days later, the 'Demonic Emperor of Oblivion' received something that was sent by Joo Moon-baek, just as he had expected.

"A gift from the Vice Leader?"

Opening the 'gift', he saw the body of one of the Soul Splitting Reapers, a peak-level demonic practitioner.

Hwan Dok smirked.

I knew it.

.

Schsst—!

An arrow flew past Woon-seong's head. At the same time, three more arrows flew towards his waist and shoulders.

He casually ducked his head.

Ding—! The arrow aimed for his shoulders, it hit the poulders and bounced off.

At the same time, he moved his legs and twisted his lower back and the arrow aimed at his waist missed him by the width of a piece of paper.

As time had passed, Woon-seong was able to skillfully avoid the arrows flying at him from the First Gate.

Ting—!

Woon-seong must have deliberately touched some of the wires installed as arrows once more flew towards him. There were fifteen more than before now, so he would become a hedgehog if he did not avoid them.

These arrows rapidly smashed into him.

Shh.

The 'Woon-seong' that seemed to have been hit vanished as the real Woon-seong appeared about five paces away. The arrows that would have hit him crashed into the wall on the other side.

That concluded the training for the First Gate.

As the lights turned on, Woon-seong took a deep breath in.

“Phew.”

It's been a month since I met the Demonic Teacher. Neither side was able to tip the balance and we are simply making small moves in the dark. There have been no major clashes.

What the hell is Joo Moon-baek thinking?

Woon-seong shook his head as he exited the First Gate and walked ahead. Even then, he was still pondering the current situation.

Did he really obtain the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, the very symbol of the legitimacy of the Heavenly Demon?

Woon-seong huffed out a breath.

They say you should always prepare for the worst case scenario, but this is sounding like the worst of the worst...

Woon-seong remembered the message that the Senior Strategist had conveyed to him a few days ago.

The information that I'm getting through Sang Gwan-chuk is somewhat odd. If Joo Moon-baek's so active about trying to become the leader, we must assume that he obtained something that proves his legitimacy. Whether it's the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, or something else...

Besides, if Sang Gwan-chuk's theory is correct, it's a huge problem.

If my opponent is trying to prove his legitimacy with something, I also need to show my own legitimacy by presenting the Divine Shaped Flame!

Woon-seong sighed. Presenting the Divine Shaped Flame would be a step forward, but all it could do was prevent either side from gaining the advantage.

Still... In the end, if I want to prepare myself for the future scenarios, my only option at this point is to bring in the Divine Shaped Flame.

The steps of the young man continued past the Second Gate. Unlike the First and the Third, the Second gateway was used for training the senses in the maze. Now that Cheon Hwi had been poisoned, Woon-seong was unable to train there alone.

Thus, Woon-seong headed straight for the Third Gate, the Polymorphic Combat Illusion.

Whoo—!

As Woon-seong stepped inside, the illusion was triggered. Reading into his mind and Cheon Hwi's memories, enemies were created and the landscape changed dramatically.

Suddenly, Woon-seong was standing amongst a field of grass as an elderly man stood in front of him, brandishing a sword.

The plum blossom pattern embroidered on the man's sleeve caught Woon-seong's attention.

The 'Plum Blossom Sword Saint'.

This was a man that Woon-seong remembered vividly!

You filthy hypocrite!

In response to the young man's wrath, the White Night Spear shown with dazzling light.

[1] A jiangshi is a type of reanimated corpse. Unlike a 'zombie', a jiangshi is created from a person's corpse and must be controlled.

Chapter 76: The Divine Shaped Flame (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 76 – The Divine Shaped Flame (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Huff. Huff.”

Woon-seong gasped for air as he leaned on his spear for support. His clothing was torn to rags and his shoulders sagged with exhaustion. The throwing knives previously strapped to his belt were also scattered everywhere.

The deepest wounds were on his thighs and chest.

My thigh was stabbed three times and my chest has a wound so deep that my bones are showing.

If everything hadn't been an illusion, it would definitely have been fatal.

Of course, even within the illusion, Woon-seong was the one standing and the Plum Blossom Sword Saint was lying on the ground before him.

The Sage of the Bright Rock is definitely a level higher than Jwa Do-gyul.

Woon-seong shook his head, straightening his back to examine the corpse. It was an illusion made from the Leader's memories, but everything was

very realistic..

It took me five hundred seconds to defeat this man. I even had to sacrifice a number of hits to win... I can safely say that this fight was similar to that of fighting one of the weaker Ten Demonic Masters.

It looks like I caught up to my former master.

Woon-seong thought for a moment, then shook his head looking weary.

No... not quite yet. Considering I only barely defeated the Plum Blossom Sword Saint, I'm still a quarter of a step behind my former master.

Woon-seong looked back down at the corpse at his feet.

Compared to Jwa Do-gyul, who was a straight out hypocrite... The Plum Blossom Sword Saint, who showed a sad face without a sense of tolerance from his sword, pisses me off more.

Woon-seong grit his teeth and waved his hand, erasing the corpse from existence. *Disengaging Polymorphic Combat Illusion.*

Immediately, the scene changed as the illusion collapsed. The wounds on his body disappeared, though the weariness remained.

“Phew.”

Woon-seong sighed as the pain from the illusionary wounds also disappeared. Thanks to that, he took a deep breath and exhaled, feeling very much alive. With some time, his breathing also stabilized.

Now, it's time to review.

Woon-seong sat down in the middle of the Third Gate and began to circulate his qi.

On top of the qi and lessons the Unrecorded left, I now have the First and Second Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon down. And with those connections, I can generate qi from my core, distribute it to my

limbs, and circulate it through my body. My qi starts circulating, from small to large, one at a time, and then...

Woon-seong circulated his qi, repeating the same movements over and over. Once, twice, three times... Soon, his consciousness sank into the depths.

'Mind Split Double Will'.

Just like the name suggested, the mind was split into two. The divided mind could not proceed to do two different things simultaneously, saving time.

One mind will cultivate, while the other one will continue to review and thoroughly analyze my last fight. And after I recreate the fight again and again...

Slowly, what Woon-seong had been lacking became apparent..

I should've done it a bit more gently at this point... So this is the 'Plum Blossom Sword' style. It strikes like fierce waves— silently yet ferociously... Simply being smooth and gentle is not enough. I need to have strength within it that can win the fierce waves...

Each of these is too trivial to be considered insight, but these small pieces of enlightenment pile up to become something larger.

As he learned these small things, the changes in his experience affected the other side of his mind too.

Like a swarm of bees, there was movement from the qi in Woon-seong's core. Slowly and surely, his energy was beginning to move into the small flame essence that sat within his core, feeding and strengthening it.

Hmm?

Woon-seong's eyebrows furrowed and his consciousness sank further, gathering at his core to sense what was happening.

The 'Heavenward Soul Earthen Body' is reacting to the qi from my core...! Wait, the flame essence is also reacting?!

It seemed that in response to the enlightenment from the fight just now, the flame essence planted within him had reacted and like a flower emerging from its seed, energy was flowing out.

With that energy came pain, coursing through his body.

“Urgh.”

Woon-seong’s chest tightened with pain and he quickly endured the pain, trying to control the energy. Yet, the more he tried to control it, the more the energy acted up. Instead of retreating back into the flame essence, it mixed and melted with his original qi.

With a puff, a huge flame rose from Woon-seong’s back.

The Divine Shaped Flame!

Woon-seong realized what it was almost immediately as he stared in shock at his back, where the fire curled around him like large wings.

Normally, I would’ve been happy about this, but there’s an unexpected problem.

The reason why Woon-seong wanted to manifest the Divine Shaped Flame so much was in order to prevent the worst case scenario: Joo Moon-baek obtaining the Divine Shaped Flame and becoming the Heavenly Demon.

I finally obtained the Divine Shaped Flame that I wanted so much, but I didn’t expect it to be this uncontrollable. Simply manifesting it has only put me in danger... The fire is spreading without control!

There was a fact that Woon-seong did not know. In order to control the Divine Flame, one must learn the third and final connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon!

But Chun Hwi had collapsed before he could pass on the final verse to his apprentice. Thanks to that, Woon-seong had no way to control the flame at the moment.

As if the Divine Flame knew that, it rampaged like a horse gone wild. Starting from his back, the fire wrapped around Woon-seong's body.

“Urgh.”

An out-of-control flame rushed around, spreading as if it wanted to burn and consume Woon-seong.

This could no longer be considered as the Divine Shaped Flame — it was akin to a rabid dog that was crazy enough to bite its owner.

If Chun Hwi had been present and seen this situation, he would have quickly controlled the situation. But the only one who could help Woon-seong, the Heavenly Demon, was not there.

“Shhh.”

Woon-seong bit his lips so hard that his eyes turned white. *I need to focus!* Blood gushed from his lips. Thanks to the pain, his mind cleared, but his situation had yet to improve.

Now, instead of only raging on the outside of his body, the flame was actually traveling through the inside too!

The pain seemed to burn from within his blood.

The ‘Heavenward Soul Earthen Body’ is helping to block some of the fire, but it’s nowhere near enough to suppress it... the Divine Shaped Flame is becoming more and more violent.

Had it not been for his completed martial body, Woon-seong would have been burnt to a crisp.

I have to control the Divine Shaped Flame somehow!

Woon-seong tried to control the turbulent energy with all of his might.

Instead of calming down, the fire actually raged further!

Hua—!

As it grew in size, the flames from Woon-seong's body spread until the entire Third Gate was engulfed in flames.

Through the reflection of the room in Woon-seong's eyes, the only thing that could be seen was a sea of flames. Staring into those eyes, it would seem like the fire emanated from his pupils.

Soon the flames billowed and reached the ceiling.

The White Dragon Spear, sitting in the corner, suddenly shone with a terrifying light.

As if drawn by something, it flew into the air.

Weng—!

"The White Night Spear..." Woon-seong unconsciously murmured as his spear appeared before him.

A mysterious wind pressure spread out from it and pushed the flame away from Woon-seong's body.

Whoo—!

The spear trembled and there was a burst of light, once again pushing the flames away from Woon-seong.

The youth blinked blankly at the spear before him.

Suddenly, a bright light flashed once more.

The light seems to be gathering around the spear and is etching some text...!

Woon-seong slowly read the phrase that had appeared in a trance.

“Fire is the cleanser of the demonic. Control it with your deepest desire and rule over it. And then you shall achieve divine harmony.”

The tremble of the Divine Shaped Flame has reduced. The pain has also disappeared significantly. Does it want me to read the text continuously?

Woon-seong didn't have much time to think it over as it was never easy to tame a wild horse. Almost as soon as he had finished the phrase, the flame once again started to run free.

Fire is the cleanser of the demonic. Control it with your deepest desire and rule over it. And then you shall achieve divine harmony. Fire is the cleanser of the demonic. Control it with your deepest desire and rule over it. And then you shall achieve divine harmony...

However, the more he repeated the phrase, the more that the flame seemed to listen to him.

And finally...

I succeeded in controlling the Divine Shaped Flame...!

With a calm murmur, the flame now danced across Woon-seong's palm according to his will. Having succeeded, he quickly realized that almost all of his energy had been used up due to the turbulent flame. Quickly, he tried to reign in the fire.

Once again, it didn't exactly move as he wished.

This time, however, there was no malicious intent.

With a small whoosh, the flame rose into the air. Once a safe distance away from his palm, the flame split into dozens of smaller flames, illuminating the room in a beautiful glow.

Like before, the fire was still grey. If you looked closely though, it now seemed to have a faint tongue of purple flame flickering through it.

Floating in the air, the new flame emanated an aura that was both eerie and majestic.

What Woon-seong now had was a complete Divine Shaped Flame under his control.

Having exhausted himself, Woon-seong collapsed onto the floor. As he lost consciousness, the voice of the Unrecorded resounded through his brain.

“Successor of our Sect. If you want support from the Cult, find the Unrecorded Demonic Group. They shall serve you like your own limbs... Find them and show them my Divine Flame as proof.”

Woon-seong woke up about half an hour after that.

“Knng.”

He blinked the weariness out of his eyes and struggled to sit up, examining his body. His clothing had mostly been burnt away, but he was physically fine.

I was knocked out...?

After the extreme pain of being burnt both inside and out, Woon-seong had lost consciousness the moment he was given relief.

Oh. That’s right. I lost consciousness while trying to control the Divine Shaped Flame through reading the text. But, I succeeded in controlling it!

The moment that it came to mind, Woon-seong called the Divine Flame to his palm, forming a small ball of fire.

Flickering, the grey flame covered his hand. Nevertheless, it was not hot to him at all.

At the same time, Woon-seong remembered how the flame had floated in the air. Following his instructions, the flame rose into the air, illuminating the Third Gate. Separating into smaller sparks, twenty smaller flames roamed the air according to his will.

Playing with it, Woon-seong found that he could also easily change the flame's size and appearance.

An irresistible demonic force that oozes out of the flame. So I finally achieved the Divine Shaped Flame!

Woon-seong couldn't help beaming. *I haven't felt this happy about achieving something for quite a while now!*

Actually, in an uncharacteristic show of excitement, Woon-seong practically wanted to jump for joy.

But before that, he thought of something. Just before he passed out, a voice had spoken to him from the White Night Spear.

'Find the Unrecorded Demonic Group'?

Woon-seong believed that it was the will of the Unrecorded.

The fact that he left his will in an inanimate object... That means that the Unrecorded achieved the realm of a divine being.

Instead of being terrified by this fact, Woon-seong couldn't be any happier. Not only did this prove that humans could indeed reach that level of power, the man in question had been one of his predecessors.

So there was a person of the Spear Master Sect who achieved the realm of a divine being! I couldn't be any prouder.

However, that wasn't all he had learned.

And he wants me to find the Unrecorded Demonic Group. I was suspecting it myself, but it looks like the Unrecorded really is related to the Unrecorded Demonic Group.

Originally, Woon-seong had guessed that it might have just been a coincidence that the two shared a name. But, of course, he should have known that nothing was ever as simple as mere coincidence.

The Unrecorded Demonic Group. The ones who did not reveal themselves to others nor stay recorded in any official records of the Cult.

The Unrecorded.

Un-recorded.

Finding them without a clue won't be easy. However, it won't be that difficult either. Because they must be there...

Woon-seong's lips curled into a smile as he thought of a place to go.

It really wouldn't be too hard.

Chapter 77: The Unrecorded Demonic Group

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 77 – The Unrecorded Demonic Group

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Elsewhere, such as the Qingcheng Sect, many things were happening too.

Jang Seo-ah, the ‘Sword of Earth’, had left Sichuan months earlier under the orders of her master to investigate her junior brother’s whereabouts. After confirming Mae Hong-sung’s death, she came back to Zhongyuan after suffering through a number of hardships on the road. Without a chance to pull herself together, she returned to Mount Qingcheng with his sword in hand. All she wanted was to deliver this grim news to her master and her senior brother as soon as possible.

But when she finally arrived back at Mount Qingcheng...

What greeted her arrival was neither her master nor her senior brother, but their spirit tablets upon the shrine [1].

“Master! Senior Brother!”

She could not contain her tears and fell to the ground in mourning.

Jang Seo-ah had entered the Qingcheng Sect only after having lived a lonely and painful life as an orphan. At Mount Qingcheng, she met a

family: she had her master and her martial brothers.

Being slow in cultivation, the Sword of Earth never earned the most attention. Of course, she also knew that her master had often swept over her body with a licentious eye.

But even so, he was my master... He has taken care of me since I was young. Instead of letting me die in the cold of winter, he took me in and gave me a new life.

But that person — no, her whole family — had died.

The loss that Jang Seo-ah felt was hard to put into words. Suddenly, she was alone in a world full of red roses. It was as if everything in the world was harmoniously intertwined, but she just couldn't immerse herself within it.

She felt numb to the core and spent the next few days crying.

No, it wasn't just a few days. Her grief lasted months.

She didn't eat or drink properly. Thus, as time went by, she withered until her bones showed.

Some of the elders tried to comfort her. "Seo-ah... Please eat something. You've barely eaten or slept for the past months..."

"Elder..."

"Don't worry. I'm fine..."

Of course, what they really meant was: "I'm just afraid that we might lose the last successor of the 'Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset'."

Interestingly, Sang Seo-ah finally regained her senses half a year later thinking this very thought: *Last successor... That's right! I'm the last successor!*

She grabbed her sword and went to find the elders, asking, “Who was the one who killed Master and Senior Brother?”

The elders shook their heads, “We don’t know for sure, but we simply suspect that it has to do with the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

“The Cult of the Heavenly Demon!” *I’m Jang Seo-ah, the apprentice of the First Apprentice and the Sword of Earth of the Three Swords of Qingcheng.*

It seemed that in this small province of Murim, an instance of revenge had birthed another journey for vengeance.

Back in the Cult, Woon-seong immediately left the Third Gate once he woke up.

With a thundering sound, a huge stone gate opened, allowing light to pour into the room.

Walking out, Woon-seong quickly passed through the mountains of the Inner Garden inside the Palace. He briefly stopped by the lake and glanced towards the pavilion where he and Chun Hwi had spent time when the Heavenly Demon had still been healthy.

...Master.

But now there was nothing to say and no one to talk to.

Turning away, Woon-seong focused on his current job. *The place where I can meet the Unrecorded Demonic Group...*

As he walked out of the Inner Garden, someone was waiting for him.

Sang In-hyo, who had been watching over Woon-seong since the Cave of Latent Demons, was now one of his trusted subordinates. He came to Woon-seong with new clothing, as if he had known that Woon-seong was training.

“We’ve been waiting for you, sir.”

Next to Sang In-hyo was Mok Dae-young, who was standing in for the Senior Strategist.

Woon-seong received the fresh clothes from Sang In-hyo with a nod. The clothes he currently wore had been soaked through with sweat and then charred by the Divine Flame.

Returning the destroyed set to Sang In-hyo he said, “There’s a place I need to go.”

“A place to go?” Sang In-hyo asked as Mok Dae-young also looked at him in question.

It seemed odd that Woon-seong had left the Inner Garden and sounded so urgent.

Woon-seong briefly said, “We may just be able to tip the power balance to our favor.”

Sang In-hyo and Mok Dae-young both swallowed some saliva. *The Young Leader is not a man that tells lies... Then there must be a reason he believes that.*

As they were thinking, Woon-seong had already started moving in a rush.

Sang In-hyo and Mok Dae-young asked, “Where are you heading?”

“The Cult’s Demonic Armory.”

“The armory? Now...?” Sang In-hyo still remembered going to the armory as a guide for Woon-seong, back when the Young Leader had just become a Great Demon and needed a new weapon. “But nobody is allowed inside the armory without the Leader’s permission.”

The ‘although he is poisoned, but Chun Hwi is still the Cult Leader’ was left unsaid.

Sang In-hyo quietly noted the speed at which Woon-seong was traveling, which was now well beyond the speed of a Great Demon.

“I know.”

“And you still insist on going?”

Woon-seong responded matter of factly, “There’s someone I need to meet there.”

“Someone you need to meet...?”

Mok Dae-young and Sang In-hyo followed after the Young Leader and tilted their heads at the same time, but Woon-seong did not answer the question. Instead, he just quietly sped up, eventually leaving the two behind.

Of course, Woon-seong was not randomly deciding to pay the Demonic Armory a visit.

“The day I entered the armory, there was someone guarding the place.”

Woon-seong had chosen the armory as the place to contact the Unrecorded Demonic Group because he knew that while he had not seen the man, a member had been there: Woon-seong had heard his voice.

That person must be it...

Woon-seong soon reached the place where the armory was visible. *I’m here.*

Shh!

Woon-seong suddenly stopped and dropped to the ground. He had stopped on the outskirts, such that he could enter the armory if he wanted. Instead of continuing forward, he broadened his senses.

Engaging qi sense!

His qi spread in a circle, allowing him to feel even the flapping of wings by the spirit beasts in the trees. In between this aura he felt a strange sensation, a blurry but unbroken presence.

Woon-seong smiled. *Just as I expected.*

It was then that Sang In-hyo arrived by his side.

Mok Dae-young, who was weaker in strength, arrived a little later. His presence was made known by some ‘huff huff’s and a billow of dust. The man was breathing hard after being forced to chase after the Demonic King-level Young Leader and a higher ranked Great Demon.

Woon-seong looked at the gorge below and shouted loudly at the surrounding area.

“I know there’s someone here. I’ve heard that a person of the Unrecorded Demonic Group is in constant standby near the Cult’s Demonic Armory.”

The wind blew as soon as he finished speaking.

Whaaaaah—!

Woon-seong’s clothing fluttered in the wind, but there was no response.

So they’re the Unrecorded Group for a reason. He was talking to martial artists that secretly supported the Cult from the shadows — the ones that even the Heavenly Demon, the top of the Cult, could not control. *It only makes sense that they won’t respond to the Young Leader.*

“So you’re not going to show yourself?” Woon-seong smiled and asked again.

Once more, there was still only the sound of the wind.

Mok Dae-young stared at him in confusion, not knowing what the Young Leader was going to do at all. *What is he thinking?*

On the other hand, Sang In-hyo was watching Woon-seong’s behavior carefully.

What neither the Young Leader nor Mok Dae-young knew was that Sang In-hyo was a member of the Unrecorded Demonic Group. Moreover, he

was no ordinary member but an executive.

Cave of Latent Demons or not, Sang In-hyo had been closely monitoring Woon-seong the moment the youth had chosen the White Night Spear.

Woon-seong, the inheritor of the ‘Art of Six Seals and Destruction’ as well as the ‘Dragon Fang Spear of the White Night’, was finally going to do something.

Sang In-hyo’s eyes deepened as he observed.

As he watched, something amazing happened.

Woon-seong made a light huff, then said, “If you won’t show yourself, I’ll just have to make you!”

Suddenly, there was a fire that burned across Woon-seong’s body.

Whaaaah—!

The Divine Flame! An overwhelming presence and pressure that no demonic practitioner could dare stand up against.

Sang In-hyo bowed towards the flame, as was the instinctive reaction of every demonic practitioner. The same was true for Mok Dae-young.

As he bowed though, Sang In-hyo was still observing Woon-seong. *So the Young Leader has already achieved the Divine Shaped Flame! As far as I know, he has yet to learn the Last Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon...*

Sang In-hyo was filled with surprise as he looked up and saw Woon-seong’s back. The fire wrapped around Woon-seong’s body like a cape. *Ah... look at him... It’s as though Zhurong, the god of fire [2], has descended upon this world... But the truly impressive part isn’t his figure. It’s the grey fire!*

Sang In-hyo trembled slightly as he remembered a figure so many years ago: “So, Sang In-hyo. Is this enough for the Unrecorded Demonic Group

to approve me?” That was a memory of Chun Hwi from his youth. Sang In-hyo smiled softly. My Leader, the Young Leader is just like you.

The grey flame manifested by Woon-seong was one of the two symbols of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon.

He must have found the teachings of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon somehow. However, it's still only half complete. I understand why the Young Leader came here. Although I have no idea how he knew that this Divine Flame was connected to the Unrecorded Demonic Group... One thing for sure is that the Young Leader is here to contact the Unrecorded Demonic Group.

Sang In-hyo shook his head. *But that's not enough.*

Even the Vice Leader has obtained a half-complete Divine Flame. That is not enough to move the Unrecorded Demonic Group. If he truly wants to meet the Unrecorded Demonic Group... If he truly wants to obtain them... He must present a complete Divine Flame.

The moment Sang In-hyo thought about this fact, the flames dancing around Woon-seong changed.

Whoosh!

The flames expanded and drifted away from Woon-seong's body. As it did so, the flames separated and floated into the air as a dozen balls of fire.

Sang In-hyo made a startled sound, “Huup!”

A confident statement came from Woon-seong, “Is this still not enough?”

Subsequently, through his senses, Woon-seong felt a presence moving closer to him. He smirked. *Show yourselves, Unrecorded Demonic Group!*

The presence he had been following suddenly disappeared, but then quickly returned, now joined by a few others.

Shhh! Tak!

With a whistle, a group of people appeared in front of Woon-seong out of a cloud of wind and dust.

The man in front observed Woon-seong just as Woon-seong observed him.

The man had a stuttering beard on his chin, with a scar across his lip and a wide forehead. *An unfamiliar face*, realized Woon-seong.

Then what about the clothes? Woon-seong noticed that the man's black robe was made of quality silk. The word 'Unrecorded' was engraved clearly on the cuff.

His power is no less than that of mine... He must be at least as strong as the Ten Demonic Masters...!

Woon-seong's eyebrows twitched.

However, the one who first spoke was the other. "So, you're the one who presented the Divine Flame of the Unrecorded?"

Hearing these words, Woon-seong had the vague feelings that the other man had modulated his voice. It was possible that his voice sounded different over qi transmission, but he wasn't sure. It was just a hunch that the man had changed his voice on purpose.

But that's not important right now. What matters is that this man must be ranked high within the Unrecorded Demonic Group...

Once again, the trembling voice of the other man could be heard, "If so, show me proof."

Instead of speaking, Woon-seong raised his hands.

Fwoom—!

The silent grey flame burned upon his arm once more. The flame lingered there for a moment before rising straight into the air in little balls of fire.

A flame. Not red, but grey... [3]

As soon as the fire appeared, Sang In-hyo, who had been standing behind Woon-seong, knelt to the ground.

It was not just Sang In-hyo.

In fact, the man dressed in black standing before Woon-seong had actually gotten to his knees faster than Sang In-hyo.

“I, the Tenth Group Leader of the Unrecorded Demonic Group, present myself to the Advent of the Unrecorded.”

Looking around, the man added, “This... is not a proper place to have a lengthy conversation.”

Raising his head, the man guided Woon-seong into a safe house. Once he entered the safe house, Woon-seong was brought through another passage.

The man in black walked at the front, leading Woon-seong. After that was the group from the Unrecorded Demonic Group and Sang In-hyo. Mok Dae-young also tagged along.

Woon-seong’s gaze turned to Sang In-hyo. *So Sang In-hyo was also part of the Unrecorded Demonic Group. The moment I presented the Divine Flame, I sensed a change in his breathing. Mok Dae-young was frozen in awe, but Sang In-hyo didn’t do so.*

Woon-seong turned around and looked at the man who was leading them forward.

The passageway forward was not long. At the end was a stairway.

The man opened another door, “This way.”

Once inside, a familiar space unfolded.

Woon-seong had only been here once before, but it was definitely a memorable space. Looking around, he noticed the unusual traces from his altercation a few months prior.

Woon-seong tilted his head. *This place is...?*

The man in black scratched at his face with his fingertips as he took his outer layer off.

Beneath the black robe was a set of white clothing.

In addition, his face peeled off.

[1] A spirit tablet is made during the funeral period and enshrined after the burial, with the name of the deceased person inscribed upon it.

[2] Zhurong (祝融) is the god of fire in traditional Chinese mythology, said to rule over the southern hemisphere.

[3] As a reminder, the color is being emphasized because the conventional Divine Flame is blood-red. The Divine Flames manifested by Joo Moon-baek and Woon-seong have both been grey colored. For clarity, the Divine Shaped Flame is just the usable form of the Divine Flame.

Chapter 78: The Unrecorded Heavenly Demon

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 78 – The Unrecorded Heavenly Demon

Translated by : moonchildkhz

There were many peculiar items in Murim.

Amongst such strange items were things like heavenly weapons, which even martial artists rarely saw, or the Great Medicine, which was considered to give users an extra life.

Each and every one of them was hard to assign a value to.

However, not all of these peculiar items could be considered incredibly precious either.

Some of these items were accessible to anyone who had the proper payment.

The ‘human skin mask’, an item that allowed the wearer to effortlessly change their appearance, was one of them.

With another scratch, one such ‘human skin mask’ was peeled off and thrown onto the floor like trash.

What appeared under was a wrinkled face.

Woon-seong narrowed his eyes when he saw the man's true face, for it was one he recognized.

"It's been a while, Young Leader."

The old man chuckled and smiled as if he were a little embarrassed.

"So you were the leader of the Unrecorded Demonic Group, Demonic Teacher?"

The old man, who Woon-seong had now identified, nodded. "That's correct."

Woon-seong noticed the man was not the same as the last time they had met. Obviously, last time they had talked, Lee Shin-jung had treated him as a junior. Now, he was speaking and acting with respect.

It was a small and subtle change, but still noticeable.

"You seem to have changed. I don't remember you being this polite with me."

At these words, the Demonic Teacher smiled. "That is only obvious."

"Obvious, you say..."

The Demonic Teacher bowed his head once more in a polite gesture. Lee Shin-jung was not the only one this time; Sang In-hyo also bowed his head.

"Let me introduce myself again. I, Lee Shin-jung, Tenth Group Leader of the Unrecorded Demonic Group, present myself to the one who has inherited the will of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon."

The Unrecorded Heavenly Demon...? Woon-seong's eyes widened for the first time today. "The Unrecorded Heavenly Demon. So does that mean the Unrecorded achieved the position of Heavenly Demon?"

The title of 'Heavenly Demon' was only given to the very top of the Cult, those who sat on the throne as the Cult Leader. As the Young Leader, Woon-

seong learned about each and every one of his predecessors. Yet, this was the first time he'd heard of a 'Unrecorded Heavenly Demon'.

Lee Shin-jung lifted his head and answered, "If you mean the position as the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the answer is no."

"Then, why...?"

"But it is true that he has practiced the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon and was acknowledged as the Heavenly Demon."

He was acknowledged as the Heavenly Demon, yet did not rise to the throne as the Cult Leader... Is that even possible? It didn't make any sense however Woon-seong looked at it. Thus, he turned to stare at Lee Shin-jung with a frown, as if trying to determine the truth of what he was saying.

As the Demonic Teacher, Lee Shin-jung had a lot of experience in dealing with people and noticed Woon-seong's scrutinizing look.

"Haha. I know it's hard to understand. The Unrecorded Heavenly Demon was a unique being. One of a kind in the whole history of the Divine Cult."

That didn't make Woon-seong feel any better.

"And how exactly was he unique?"

"Hmm. Before that, would you excuse this old man and allow him to ask you a few questions?"

Woon-seong nodded instead of answering.

"How much do you know about the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon?"

Hearing this question, Woon-seong subconsciously turned to look at the White Night Spear.

I can't say I know everything. But I'm sure the few things I know are important. Then, how much should I say?

The fact that the Unrecorded was a person of the Spear Master Sect, and the fact that I'm also related to the Spear Master Sect? But then I'll also have to talk about my past life...

Remembering his secrets, Woon-seong's eyes deepened and he came to a conclusion.

I can tell the truth, but I don't have to tell him everything.

Woon-seong chose one fact that could be used to explain things in the future: "I know that the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon was a person of the Spear Master Sect."

This time, it was Lee Shin-jung's eyes that deepened. *How does he know that...*

Woon-seong was silent and did not say any more.

Immediately, Lee Shin-jung nodded his head, "Is that all you know about him?"

"Yes."

"If so... Looks like we'll need to have a long conversation."

Lee Shin-jung sighed to himself and buried himself into a chair.

Woon-seong sat in the chair across from him, while Sang In-hyo and Mok Dae-young stood a step behind.

There was a moment of silence that followed.

"Young Leader."

It was still Lee Shin-jung who broke the silence in the end.

"I don't know how you know that the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon was a person of the Spear Master Sect, but do you know what kind of sect it is?"

“Of course.”

Woon-seong spoke with deep confidence this time, feeling a bit smug in his heart. *You’re looking at the only inheritor of the Spear Master Sect this generation, old man...*

“That should make things easier.”

Lee Shin-jung was quiet for a moment as collected his thoughts.

“Just as you said, the Unrecorded was an apprentice of the Spear Master Sect. In that generation, the sect was unusual and had two apprentices. One of them was the Unrecorded, who later entered the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

This Woon-seong already knew.

His questions were: How did the Unrecorded master the Divine Art and why did he leave it in the White Night Spear? Also, why was he called a Heavenly Demon?

Woon-seong looked at Lee Shin-jung, not intending to rush the old man. He was sure the story would come naturally.

“After he joined the Cult, he became a demonic practitioner and eventually rose to become one of the Ten Demonic Masters.”

It was very rare for someone who originated from outside the Cult to reach that level. Aside from the necessary level of power, it was a burden for the Cult to entrust such a high position to an outsider.

Surprisingly, the Unrecorded was able to claim a spot relying solely on his accomplishments.

“At the time, he successfully restored a number of demonic arts of the Divine Cult. Many demonic practitioners did not hesitate to praise those achievements. And those were all achieved thanks to his knowledge in the Spear Master Sect’s martial arts.”

It's just as I predicted. It looks like the Unrecorded was more talented in Demonic arts than Orthodox Arts. Woon-seong nodded to himself as he listened. Those of the Spear Master Sect were focused on reaching the top with the spear and delighted in collecting knowledge from many places. *But he didn't forget his roots from the Spear Master Sect even after he joined the Divine Cult.*

As Woon-seong had been thinking, Lee Shin-jung continued his story.

“But it looked like the Unrecorded’s ambition didn’t end there. Although he wasn’t interested in the position of Heavenly Demon, he was interested in the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.”

For the first time since Lee Shin-jung started his story, the Divine Art was mentioned. Immediately, Woon-seong listened more attentively.

“Of course, it was no easy matter. He may have been one of the Ten Demonic Masters, but gaining access to the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon was impossible for those besides the Leader and the Young Leader. He only had partial information. Traits shown outside and the manifestation of the Divine Shaped Flame. There were also some records shown from time to time in the old texts. But the Unrecorded persistently dug into even the most trivial record. In the end, he was able to manifest the Divine Flame without learning the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon. To quote the Leader at the time: ‘there were differences, but it was without a doubt the Divine Flame.’”

Woon-seong hummed in amazement. *Not only did he manifest the Divine Shaped Flame, but even the Heavenly Demon gave approval...*

“On top of that, because the Unrecorded’s new art was surely similar to the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, the Leader acknowledged it as a different form of the Divine Art. However... at the time, no, even for today’s standards, it was an incredible matter. To no one’s surprise, those who weren’t friends with the Unrecorded responded with an uproar.”

That was to be expected, since two Heavenly Demons could not exist under the same sky. On top of that, if the Unrecorded’s art became acknowledged

as another Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, it was bound to become a problem for legitimacy in the future.

“The Unrecorded’s art was only acknowledged as a Divine Art because he was very close with the Leader,” explained Lee Shin-jung.

Woon-seong closed his eyes instead of answering. *Lee Shin-jung’s words are correct. Normally, a person would have been executed the moment they revealed such a controversial thing.*

“Fortunately, the Leader highly favored the Unrecorded. Not only were they sparring friends and frequently practiced together, they were close enough to drink together in private.”

However, a Cult Leader had to distinguish between private and public life, between work and friendship — he could not simply ignore the uproar from the Cult unless he wanted rebellion on his hands.

“According to the records at the time, the Leader said: ‘*Enough! Unrecorded, your art rightfully deserves to be acknowledged as another Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon. However! I forbid for your existence and art to be recorded and inherited down within our Cult. Also, your followers shall not be left in any official records of the Divine Cult of the Heavenly Demon.*’”

Just like that, the man was erased from the records of the Cult so thoroughly that not even his true name was known. That was why he was known as the Unrecorded — he was literally *unrecorded*. That was the origin of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon and the Unrecorded Demonic Group that followed him.

“Then why is his Divine Art left in the White Night Spear?”

Lee Shin-jung showed a sly smile. “As far as I know, a will left in a spear is not considered as a ‘record’.”

I guess... Woon-seong let out a small chuckle. Passing it down by cleverly circumventing the prohibition...

“The Unrecorded Heavenly Demon was a martial artist,” added Lee Shin-jung. “No martial artist would ever want his arts to end in his generation. So after pondering for some time, he finally entered the Divine Realm and found a way for his successor to inherit his arts. And it looks like his method was proven correct, considering I’m speaking to the inheritor right now...”

Woon-seong nodded slowly at these words.

Hmm... If I wasn't an apprentice of the Spear Master Sect... If I didn't practice the cultivation of the Spear Master Sect... Then the Unrecorded's art wouldn't have been passed on to me. Nor would I have recreated his Divine Flame.

In his heart, Woon-seong bowed his head towards the figure of the Unrecorded for the existence of the White Night Spear resting on his back.

Thank you, Senior.

There were many ways in which the Unrecorded had helped Woon-seong, whether it was by making him stronger or by confirming his beliefs.

The White Night Spear trembled, as if it understood that it had been appreciated.

Lee Shin-jung spoke up once more, “Do you remember my words from earlier, Young Leader?”

“You mean how nobody can truly command you without the right conditions?”

Lee Shin-jung smiled brightly and nodded, then bowed his head.

“I, Lee Shin-jung, the Tenth Group Master of the Unrecorded Demonic Group, shall do everything necessary to serve the heir of the Unrecorded.”

From that moment on, the Unrecorded Demonic Group — including the ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’ — was brought under the rule of Hyuk Woon-seong.

Chapter 79: Allegiance (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 79 – Allegiance (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

From that day on, Demonic Teacher Lee Shin-jung abandoned his position of neutrality.

It didn't take long for this piece of news to reach the ears of the high-ranking officials of the Cult because Lee Shin-jung now accompanied Woon-seong wherever he went.

At first, some people thought that it was Woon-seong who chased after the Demonic Teacher in the hopes of convincing him.

But it didn't take long for them to realize the truth.

Lee Shin-jung was very careful of his behavior in front of Woon-seong.

The Demonic Teacher was a man who had never shown such polite actions, even towards the 'Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon' Cheon Hwi.

Yet, there he was, constantly bowing before Woon-seong.

Seeing that, numerous rumors were created. Some even suspected that Woon-seong was actually an old martial artist who had become enlightened and rejuvenated to a younger form.

Of course, most of them were baseless rumors, but they were all pointing towards one fact: the Young Leader had successfully made Lee Shin-jung his ally and was now ahead of Joo Moon-baek's faction.

It only took two weeks for the news to spread throughout the entire Cult.

"It looks like the Young Leader is doing well, my lord."

The Senior Strategist was standing before Cheon Hwi's bed, dutifully reporting.

He can barely remain conscious for twenty minutes a day now, Sang Gwan-chuk noticed.

Nevertheless, the Senior Strategist reported to Cheon Hwi every morning and evening. Whether the Cult Leader could hear or not did not matter.

Of course, it was just reporting. However, it was never easy to maintain such a consistent attitude for so long. Sang Gwan-chuk's loyalty towards Cheon Hwi was clearly deep-rooted.

"Since the Vice Leader is falling behind, I expect that he will make a move soon."

"..."

Was Cheon Hwi conscious? Sang Gwan-chuk could not tell, but the other's eyebrows trembled. Thus, the Senior Strategist did a sweep of the Leader's body.

Traces of the poison now covered the entire body. The fever and rashes were getting worse while a variety of other symptoms were developing, like weird bruises and strange marks.

Instead of getting better over time, Cheon Hwi was deteriorating.

A venom that can poison a martial artist of his caliber... how is it even possible? Other martial artists would've been dead long ago.

The Senior Strategist shook his head lightly.

After the Cult Leader had fallen, he had been searching for a method of detoxification everyday.

However, no poison in the world was known to have such symptoms. And without a sample of the poison, there was simply no way for Sang Gwan-chuk to identify its components and create his own antidote.

Hmm.

As the ‘Brain of the Heavenly Demon’, Sang Gwan-chuk also needed to help manage the 100,000 members of the Cult.

While he thought, his forehead wrinkled.

There was something just as pressing as the problem of poison.

Joo Moon-baek.

“Hmm.”

There were about ten possible moves that Sang Gwan-chuk could predict the Vice Leader might make. Joo Moon-baek was indeed a meticulous man, but he had not stepped outside predictions yet.

I’m sure he’ll make a move soon... He’ll probably move within a month. Maybe tomorrow, if he’s in a hurry.

It was unknown to Sang Gwan-chuk how the Young Leader had brought the Demonic Teacher to their side, but Joo Moon-baek’s plans couldn’t be more obvious.

Maybe the man would choose the worst of the predicted possibilities...

If so, how many will show themselves, and how many will hide themselves once again?

The Senior Strategist tapped the table with his fingertips.

Whose 'worst' will that 'worst choice' become?

“The situation has progressed into a rather ridiculous situation. Two of the Ten Demonic Masters who supported me have gone back to being neutral. You’re the only one left on my side, Mo In-ryang.”

“What are you planning to do?”

This was Mo In-ryang’s most important question and his face was full of anxiety.

I would’ve abandoned him myself if I had the chance. However...the unavoidable fight against the Young Leader that happened during a conflict between the factions... If only I didn’t join that... Fortunately, no one was killed then. But if the Young Leader is keeping that incident in mind, going back to being neutral won’t be enough to spare my life...

Like it or not, I’m stuck in the same boat as Joo Moon-baek.

Across from Mo In-ryang, Joo Moon-baek was reclined in his chair with his eyes closed.

Hmm.

The two sat in silence, deep in their own thoughts for a long time. The hot tea before them had long gone cold.

It looks like I’m out of options. There’s no choice but to go with that move.

A part of Joo Moon-baek’s heart sank. This option was his last resort, meaning that his situation was as bad as it could get.

He opened his eyes with a sigh.

“Did you make a decision?” Mo In-ryang asked, rushing the man.

“I did.”

“And what is it?”

“Before that, there are some people I would like to introduce to you, Blade Demon.”

Joo Moon-baek led Mo In-ryang out of the room and towards a secret place within the Cult, one that was not commonly passed by.

“Be right behind me. There are illusions here and there. You might lose your way.”

Finally, Joo Moon-baek stopped once they had arrived at a safehouse.

There's a safehouse at a place like this? Mo In-ryang asked himself. Looking at its condition, it's fairly new. About three years old, at maximum.

Hmm. Why did the Vice Leader bring me here? Is he planning something else? Mo In-ryang was starting to feel anxious now. Well, since he brought me this far, I should at least start with seeing what he's trying to show me...

The duo slowly walked along the corridor of the house, then down another passageway. At the end of that was another door which led underground.

Joo Moon-baek led the way forward without any hesitation and eventually brought them to a large space.

What is this place?

There was the peculiar smell of medicinal herbs.

If someone had the time and knowledge, they could figure out what these herbs were used for.

However, Mo In-ryang did not have such profound knowledge.

And who are those?

Instead, what caught his eyes was the group of men standing in front of Joo Moon-baek. They were all wearing the same uniform of a white mask and a brown fur coat with a sharp sword hanging at the waist.

Other than their coordination, what was more frightening was the power.

Transcendence level?!

Mo In-ryang twitched.

As cultivation increased, the difference between two ranks became greater and greater. As such, there was also great variety among those of the same level.

Some of the Ten Demonic Masters, such as Mo In-ryang, were not in the Absolute Realm, but the pinnacle Transcendence Realm.

For Mo In-ryang, such a crown was anxiety-inducing.

I was too naive... If things went south between us, I assumed I could at least escape safely... Two of those are enough to keep me at bay. Three will surely defeat me.

With cold sweat dripping down his back, Mo In-ryang asked, “Vice Leader, who are those?”

The answer came from somewhere behind him.

“They are martial artists especially trained for the Vice Leader.”

Mo In-ryang turned in surprise. *He came so close to me! Where did a man of this caliber appear from?*

It was a middle-aged man with sharp features, but gave an overall awkward atmosphere, like he was uncomfortable about something.

Mo In-ryang reached for his sword, ready to strike.

Joo Moon-baek stopped him. “Blade Demon, he’s one of us.”

“You know this man?”

The Vice Leader nodded. “He’s the one who instructed these men.”

Now Mo In-ryang found the situation even more bizarre than before. *A man of this level is an instructor?! I can't guarantee victory against him, unless I'm willing to become crippled. This man is surely at the level of a Demonic Master.*

A total of eleven transcendence level martial artists. What is he planning to do with this much force?

More importantly, if the Vice Leader had this much power, why had he been hiding it?

“Vice Leader, what exactly are you planning?”

“Blade Demon. What is it that one needs to become the Leader?”

“I don't know how that's supposed to answer my question, but I suppose it's the legitimacy and the symbol to prove said legitimacy.”

One was the manifestation of the Divine Flame through the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, the other was the inheritance of the bloodline.

“I've been keeping it a secret so far, but the truth is that I already possess one of them.”

Mo In-ryang was surprised. The Vice Leader either had the Divine Flame or the bloodline? “What do you...”

Suddenly, heavy pressure crushed down on him.

Before him, Joo Moon-baek's palm was on fire.

It was a ball of flame that made Mo In-ryang want to worship it, even if the color was a little weird.

“The Divine Flame! How did you...?”

When Joo Moon-baek first announced that he would seize the throne of the Leader, I did expect him to have something up his sleeve. But I never imagined him to have learned the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

At this time, the ten masters standing at the front drew their swords and pointed them at Mo In-ryang.

“Moving on. Like I just showed you, I already possess the Divine Shaped Flame... And I play to sieve the remaining other one. Now, I want you to answer me, Blade Demon. Are you in this with us?”

“...”

With ten blades pointed at his throat, this was an offer that Mo In-ryang could never refuse, unless he was seeking an immediate death.

The Blade Demon closed his eyes.

It looks like I'm caught in a fix... So in the end, we're choosing the worst move possible...

There was only one answer anyway.

“With that, it looks like most of those who were on the Vice Leader's side are now pledging loyalty to you. They're all just like dogs without tails.”

Lee Shin-jung was assessing those who had come to visit Woon-seong.

Of course, Woon-seong did not let them take advantage of him and did not accept them easily. For their loyalty to the Vice Leader, they had to pay a price.

The price now surrounded Woon-seong.

There was a pill given by the ‘Corpse Master Poison Star’ sitting in the pocket near his chest. It contained poison that could kill a man, but could also be used to strengthen one's qi and poison resistance.

There were crystal throwing knives — a demonic weapon that was difficult to see once thrown due to being made of crystal cold steel, a transparent metal harder than regular steel — hanging on his waist.

And finally, the flying explosive rings — an assassination weapon that flies at the target and explodes when injected with qi — which Woon-seong wore on his left index finger like regular jewelry.

Every one of those were precious items.

On top of that, he promised to stay low for six months and answer one request from me...

Over to the side, Lee Shin-jung was asking some servants to carry the rest of the items away. “Take them all to the Vault.”

Bringing Lee Shin-jung to my side brought this much influence... it's all thanks to the Unrecorded.

Woon-seong looked over his shoulder and patted his spear once again. *It looks like I owe you a lot, White Night Spear.*

At that moment, someone appeared by Lee Shin-jung's side.

Shadow.

Chapter 80: Allegiance (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 80 – Allegiance (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

After pledging allegiance to Woon-seong, Lee Shin-jung had taught him many things.

One of those things was related to the man nicknamed ‘Shadow’.

Just like how Sang In-hyo had been assigned to observe Woon-seong, the Unrecorded Demonic Group had assigned Shadow to observe Joo Moon-baek.

The reason that Joo Moon-baek needed to be observed was because apparently he had been able to create an incomplete Divine Flame of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly.

The situation was just like Sang Gwan-chuk had predicted: Joo Moon-baek had somehow been learning the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon. Even more surprising, it was the one made by the Unrecorded.

If it had taken any longer for me to manifest the Divine Flame, I would've been the one in trouble.

Woon-seong's expression soured just thinking about it.

Meanwhile, Shadow was telling Lee Shin-jung urgent news. Seeing that his expression was stiff, something unusual must have happened.

Listening to the story, Lee Shin-jung's face also quickly hardened. Standing up, he shouted, "Young Leader! It looks like Joo Moon-baek has made a move."

Just because a man had sheathed his sword didn't mean he had forfeited the fight. Joo Moon-baek was still the Vice Leader, he was still a major opponent. With the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon joining Woon-seong, Joo Moon-baek was not left with many choices.

He means that Joo Moon-baek has finally made a decision and started to execute it. It's faster than I expected.

Woon-seong quickly rose and asked, "Where did they go?"

At that, Shadow answered, voice filled with concern. "To the Divine Maiden's Palace."

Woon-seong's expression sank. *So it looks like he went for the worst possible move.*

Joo Moon-baek's plan couldn't be any more obvious.

In the Divine Maiden's Palace, there was only the Divine Maiden. Cheon Ah-young... She had to be the target.

The two legitimacies required to rise as the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon: the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon and the Cheon bloodline.

Since he already had the art, Joo Moon-baek must have judged that he needed to obtain the bloodline in order to become the Leader.

Of course, since he would be trying to take the Divine Maiden and the daughter of the Leader with force — Cheon Ah-young wouldn't possibly give her body to such an old man — the public opinion on this matter would be in heavy opposition.

But the fact that he still decided to make such a move...

Joo Moon-baek must be confident that he can cover up the incident. Of course, he'll have to at least eliminate or convince everyone in my faction...

That brought up another question.

Does this mean he has the power to face the Demonic Masters on my side?

It was difficult to think that the current Joo Moon-baek had such a force. There were only two Demonic Masters left on his side, including himself. If he had the support of some other faction, he would've used them already.

Joo Moon-baek, what are you thinking?

Woon-seong turned his eyes towards the Divine Maiden's Palace in the distance. For Cheon Ah-young's safety, he had to reach her before Joo Moon-baek did.

Woon-seong knew this fact, which was why he was headed over with only a small group of people. Others would be able to catch up later.

Still, Joo Moon-baek had been the one to draw his blade first.

No matter how fast he moved, Woon-seong's group would likely arrive late.

Since he made the preemptive move, Joo Moon-baek might already be near the Palace.

Woon-seong stared at the rapidly approaching palace.

But you won't have an easy time getting past there, Vice Leader!

"Would you kindly let me pass?"

Joo Moon-baek stood there, staring at the man in front of him with cold eyes.

The other man had thick arms that rippled with muscle. The man had large hands too, balled into fists that looked like they could smash mountains. On both hands were gloves with the word 'wind' engraved upon the fabric. The man was hefty too, taking up space that might be given to seven.

From afar, he looked like a giant. Or maybe he was a tall oak, one that had not lost its vitality and remained relentlessly rooted in place.

Or maybe a rock.

A gigantic rock that could not be removed or eliminated with human power.

In the entire Cult of the Heavenly Demon, there was only one man who could make Joo Moon-baek feel this way with his appearance alone.

"I don't understand why you say such disappointing words, Vice Leader."

It was the 'Fist Master of Demonic Wind', who was known to easily throw a hundred punches within three breaths. The man better known known as the 'Wind Demon Fist King', Koo Jong-byuk.

It was this man who blocked the way of Joo Moon-baek. For the past few days, Koo Jong-byuk had basically been living on the steps of the Divine Maiden's Palace.

Ever since Lee Shin-jung was brought into Woon-seong's faction, the Demonic Teacher had visited the Fist King and tasked him with guarding the Divine Maiden's Palace.

I was dubious, the Fist King thought, but it seems like the Senior Strategist was right... So the Vice Leader did make such a choice. It's a bitter situation, but as a man, I must keep my promise.

"Anyways, I'm sorry but I cannot let you pass here."

Of course, Joo Moon-baek also understood the Fist King's personality.

"Don't worry. I didn't mean it... It looks like I don't have a choice. I didn't want to kill any of the Ten Demonic Masters if possible..."

“Not so fast. We’ll find out who will end up dead after we clash our powers.”

Joo Moon-baek snapped his fingers and the Fist King suddenly realized the number of people gathered had increased.

The Vice Leader shook his head. “When did I ever say I’ll kill you myself?”

At that moment!

Fwoo—!

Three black arcs were drawn through the air as swords slashed the ground where the Fist King had been standing a moment prior.

“The Soul Splitting Reapers?”

Just like before, the men were clothed in the colors of the Soul Splitting King. This time though, their clothing was more like a hand-me-down than a subordinate’s uniform. Moreover, instead of those weird black masks, they were now wearing white face coverings.

“Hahaha! The Soul Splitting Reapers are indeed quite capable, but don’t tell me you believe they’re enough to defeat me!”

At the end of his words, the Fist King had to block several more sword attacks. *A silent sword draw? That shouldn’t be something the Soul Splitting Reapers are capable of performing...*

“It looks like you’ve misunderstood, Fist King.”

“What do you mean?”

“When did I ever say that they’re the Soul Splitting Reapers?” sneered Joo Moon-baek. “They are blood jiangshi.”

“W-what? Blood jiangshi?”

Three of the now dead Reapers left in front of the Fist King.

Boom, boom!

The iron fist of the Fist King slammed into the swords flying at him, causing the ex-Reapers to fly back.

Additionally, a strong gale swept by, flinging the bodies further into the air. The blood jiangshi bled all over the place, but soon righted themselves like nothing had happened.

The ground trembled greatly as the Fist King prepared his next move.

“Haaap!”

The Fist King had used his unique move called ‘Gale Strike of World Extinction’ (滅世疾風打), wherein a single fist seemed to divide into fifteen, sweeping the opponent into a storm.

Boom, boom, boom, boom—

However, the bodies of the jiangshi endured without flinching, like they were made of steel. Of course, their arms broke and legs shattered. It was hard to endure the attacks of a Ten Demonic Master, after all.

Snap—

But after some time, the broken arms and legs seemed to become unbroken. Even snapped necks rotated back into place.

Tsk. Even my ‘Gale Strike of World Extinction’ barely did anything. Dispersed qi attacks barely give them damage, and even if they do, they just force themselves back to normal because jiangshi don’t feel pain. I’ll need to face them with pin-point attacks!

Even an Absolute Realm master could not defeat these blood jiangshi in a single blow without concentrating his strength.

It was the same for ‘Blade Demon of Hell’ Mo In-ryang.

Hmm... He's holding up pretty well, Mo In-ryang commented to himself. Considering he's facing three blood jiangshi... On top of that, he's still blocking the entrance to the Divine Maiden's Palace. He's barely moved from his position.

Obviously, the group of people had not been able to enter the palace yet.

When Joo Moon-baek and the rest tried to pass by, the Fist King would ignore the blood jiangshi and attack them in an almost suicidal manner.

But he won't last long. He's a fierce fighter, but he still has his limits. His muscles of steel are being ripped apart, while his mountain-like presence is nowhere to be seen.

Just as Mo In-ryang assumed, the Fist King was reaching his limits. The man's clothing was now torn and ragged, with cuts and bruises littering his body. His left arm was particularly injured.

I would surely have lost against three blood jiangshi; his defeat was decided from the beginning. He won't last any longer than a couple more minutes. He'll be forced to move from his position soon. And without Koo Jong-byuk, there will be nothing to stop us from entering the Palace.

Meanwhile, a blood jiangshi was torn into pieces by the Fist King.

Seeing that, Joo Moon-baek thought to himself, *What a shame.*

Now that one had been effectively destroyed, the Fist King only had to face two blood jiangshi.

Koo Jong-byuk at his prime state would've easily dealt with two blood jiangshi... But at this stage, he was no match against two.

Knowing that, the Fist King roared, "Joo Moon-baek, you bastard! How dare you create such cursed monsters!"

Though he had obviously heard this comment, Joo Moon-baek simply shook his head. "Such a damn shame."

The peak-level martial artists used as ingredients... And to properly create the blood jiangshi, I've spent a fortune on medicines and herbs... But if I can kill one of the Ten Demonic Masters in exchange with a blood jiangshi, that's still a quite fair trade.

No... If I end up obtaining the throne of the Leader, it is definitely a huge profit.

That was how Joo Moon-baek felt, so he was waiting for the sweetness after tasting the bitter.

It was then that someone suddenly appeared at the entrance to the Palace.

“What is going on?!”

Seeing them, Joo Moon-baek smiled brightly. *She just spared me the trouble of going inside.*

It was Cheon Ah-young who appeared.

“It's been a while, Captain of the White Ape Unit. Or, shall I call you the Divine Maiden.”

Since she was originally his objective, Joo Moon-baek did not bother hiding his expression of delight.

“What the hell are you doing, Vice Leader?”

She maintains calm in such a situation. Is it the blood of the Heavenly Demon? Her strength as a Great Demon? Or because she's the Divine Maiden chosen by the Divine Flame? Either way, conquering a disobedient woman isn't bad either. Joo Moon-baek could only continue smiling, “I'm just here because there's something I need from the Divine Maiden's Palace.”

“Something you need?”

At that, Joo Moon-baek nodded. His eyes travelled up and down her body, from her head to her toes.

Ah-young felt like ants were crawling over her body under this lecherous gaze.

Joo Moon-baek answered, “I’ve come because I need *you*, Divine Maiden.”

Cheon Ah-young shouted, “And what exactly do you mean by that?”

“I mean exactly what I said. I’ve come because I need your body. Or, should I say that I need the bloodline of the Heavenly Demon, to be exact.”

Though Ah-young was living in the Divine Maiden’s Palace, it wasn’t as if she was living under a rock. Actually, she knew very well what was going on within the Cult.

Moreover, she had no definite proof, but there was one person who had revealed his ambitions right after her father had been poisoned. If she thought about it, there was a good chance that said person had been the one to poison him in the first place.

If that were true, Joo Moon-baek was her enemy.

When that person said he wanted her body with such a dirty gaze, she became unbearably angry.

“That’s why you’ve started such a fuss?!”

“Of course,” shrugged Joo Moon-baek, expressing no reluctance or remorse.

At that time, the Fist King, who was still battling the blood jiangshi, cried out to her. “Go back inside, Divine Maiden. They’re blood jiangshi! They are highly dangerous!”

“Blood jiangshi!” That surprised Ah-young. *I knew they weren’t some ordinary martial artists when I saw three of them pushing back one of the Ten Demonic Masters, but I never imagined them to be blood jiangshi!* “Did you create those blood jiangshi, Vice Leader?”

“Yes. Since that brat of a young leader’s faction is stronger than mine, I was left with no choice. Please forgive me for having no choice but to take such measures.”

His tone of voice was very polite, but it was obviously mocking and sarcastic.

“Bullshit! How dare you even call yourself a man!”

To the Fist King’s reproach, the Vice Leader only snorted.

Unlike the Fist King, Cheon Ah-young’s expression had actually calmed down from when she first heard that they were blood jiangshi.

“I see. So that’s why you created such cursed monsters.”

Hmm. That’s not the reaction I expected..., Joo Moon-baek muttered. She must be aware of what situation she’s in. And yet she’s showing such a calm face? She’s up to something. But whatever it is, it shouldn’t be enough to stop the blood jiangshi...

Joo Moon-baek believed in the blood jiangshi.

In front of such a Vice Leader, Ah-young took out a small golden bell.

It was the Bell of the Heavenly Demon, the symbol of the Divine Maiden which was also used to commune with the Divine Flame

Joo Moon-baek tilted his head in confusion. *What is she planning to do with that piece of junk?*

“If so, do you also know this, Vice Leader?”

Joo Moon-baek shook his head, almost imperceptibly so. In response, Ah-young lifted the bell up before her.

“In the past, the one who suppressed the blood jiangshi within the Cult was the Divine Maiden of that time.”

Subsequently, the bell in her hand rang.

Daeng—!

Chapter 81: Collision And Reversal (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 81 – Collision and Reversal (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Martial artists utilized qi.

Then what about the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's Divine Maidens?

If a woman who never learned martial arts became the Divine Maiden, would they just be an ordinary woman who served the Divine Flame her whole life?

The answer to that was...

No.

The Divine Maiden possessed a special divine power that was different from that of qi.

It was a divine power uniquely inherited from the former Divine Maiden the moment a young woman was selected by the Divine Flame. And unlike qi which gathered in the core, divine power was gathered near the heart. When a new Divine Maiden was chosen, the former Divine Maiden would gradually lose her powers as the new one gained it. It usually took between six months and a year to fully inherit the powers.

Based on how long it had been since the ascension ceremony, it could be assumed that Ah-young had fully inherited the Divine Maiden's position and powers.

As divine power was completely different from qi, its usage and methods of practice were also different.

And right now...

That divine power was being manifested.

Ding!

With Ah-young and the bell at the center, a massive sound wave spread out.

At the same time, Ah-young began murmuring some unknown sentence. It was a secret phrase guarded as an important element of the Divine Maiden's holiness.

Ding!

The bell rang once more, louder than before.

Suddenly, the situation changed.

The blood jiangshi that had been pushing against the Fist King stopped moving at once, collapsing as corpses should.

Joo Moon-baek's eyes shook.

"The Divine Maiden took down the blood jiangshi?"

Ah-young nodded primly. "That's right."

Blood jiangshi were originally creations of a different cult, not the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The rumors that had spread about the Demonic Cult being the originators was simply because the Cult had fought and destroyed that lesser cult. That

no-name cult had been too weak and small to properly make or use the blood jiangshi, so it can be said that the Demonic Cult restored this horrific art.

The revival of this necromantic art was led by a former Ten Demonic Master who had been a master in necropsy.

At the time, the Cult was preparing for war against the Shaolin and needed great strength.

However, planning related to blood jiangshi was completely abolished.

The reason was a blood jiangshi's unique characteristics.

While it was known that the creation of blood jiangshi was forbidden, most assumed that this was due to the cruel manufacturing process.

The real reason was the frightening nature of the blood jiangshi themselves.

It was only after Ah-young became the Divine Maiden that she had learned this truth. She remembered what the historical records said: *'At first they heed their master's words, but gradually start to disobey. Eventually, they begin to attack everything without discrimination.'*

That was the biggest flaw of blood jiangshi.

The same problem was found in the blood jiangshi created at that time, so it was natural for the Demonic Cult to become confused.

Depending on the ingredients used, three blood jiangshi made from peak-level martial artists was enough to defeat a Demonic Master.

It had been the Divine Maiden at the time who had suppressed the rampant blood jiangshi.

Now, that power belonged to Cheon Ah-young!

Ding!

The moment the bell rang once more, the Fist Master landed heavily one the steps to the Palace. Using his downwards momentum, he gathered qi upon his fists and punched outwards with all his strength.

Fwoom—!

Qi and wind blasted outwards, knocking one blood jiangshi far into the distance and shredding the other.

The force swept through the area in front of the Divine Maiden's Palace, uprooting trees and clearing the rocks.

Soon, the front garden was just an open clearing.

“Huff, huff, huff.”

It was all from the efforts of the Fist King.

“Go back, Vice Leader.”

Along with Ah-young's words, the bell rang once more with a *daeng!*

There was now only one blood jiangshi standing before the Fist King.

Seeing that, Joo Moon-baek looked uncomfortable.

Hmm. It looks like I have to do this myself. With that bell and the divine power, the blood jiangshi are basically useless... However, there's still two Demonic Masters on this side. The Wind Demon Fist King is already at his limit.

With the Fist King basically out of commission, it would be a relatively simple task to subdue Cheon Ah-young.

There's no reason to hesitate.

Joo Moon-baek glanced over at Mo In-ryang, who was waiting for his orders. Just as a flame rose from Joo Moon-baek's palm, someone's voice echoed into his ears.

— *Wait. Let me take care of this.*

“Hwan Dok...”

Out of nowhere, a man appeared behind Mo In-ryang and Joo Moon-baek.

It was Hwan Dok, of course. In his hand was a tasseled bell, not a sword. On the bell was an engraving of a howling demon, with the demon’s eyes being the holes from which sound would flow through.

The man held the bell out.

“Who are you?”

At the sudden appearance of a stranger, Cheon Ah-young looked nervous.

Hwan Dok spoke to Ah-young casually, “Ah, the Divine Maiden. I’m quite impressed with how you suppressed the blood jiangshi with such ease.”

“...”

“Although, that history lesson of yours... That is a pretty ancient event you’re talking about.”

Jingle!

The blood jiangshi that had been blasted away began to twitch, as if it was about to stand up.

“W-what!” The Fist King was startled and shouted.

Ah-young urgently rang her bell again.

Ding!

Jingle!

Hwan Dok rang his bell, as if responding to Ah-young.

As such, the divine power had no effect on the blood jiangshi.

It can't be! He nullified my divine power! What is that bell? Cheon Ah-young bit on her lip, drawing blood. There's only one blood jiangshi left. What if I take it out with the Fist King and do our best to flee? Maybe I can survive this.

Almost as if Joo Moon-baek had understood her thoughts, he smiled at the Fist King and Ah-young.

“Don't you dare think you'll leave this scene easily today.”

Snap!

As Joo Moon-baek snapped his fingers once, seven more blood jiangshi crawled out of the ground, leaping forward.

“Go!”

A Great Demon and a Demonic Master going against a total of 8 blood jiangshi... How long can they possibly last? On top of that, the Demonic Master is already exhausted. 15 minutes, at best, Mo In-ryang snickered, smiling joyfully to himself as he watched the scene unfold.

As expected, Cheon Ah-young was almost immediately surrounded by five blood jiangshi.

The remaining three pushed the Fist King backwards, towards a wall. The blood jiangshi weren't very organized and wielded their weapons at random, but it was enough against an already exhausted Demonic Master.

The blast from their weapons threw the Fist King into the wall, where he collapsed onto the floor.

“Uaaargh!”

The Fist King coughed up a mouthful of blood, showing just how injured he was. Still, he pushed himself off the ground and wiped away the blood.

He stared intensely at a point behind Joo Moon-baek.

At this moment of desperation, the Fist King who was facing death, suddenly smiled with relief.

Joo Moon-baek's eyes narrowed.

Relaxing slightly, the Fist King said, "He's here."

"Who are you talking about?"

At the end of that question, the shadows of four men rose from the cliff before the Divine Maiden's Palace.

"Haaaaah!"

The man at the forefront fell down before Cheon Ah-young, swinging his spear towards the five blood jiangshi surrounding her.

Kakaka—

The spear move scratched the blood jiangshi, but was not enough to dislocate or cut off any limbs.

Still, it was enough to push them away.

"You...!" Ah-young gasped, disoriented by the sudden turn of events.

After pushing away the blood jiangshi surrounding her, Woon-seong picked Ah-young up and carried her a few dozen meters away.

In front of them landed Shadow, who had successfully brought the Fist King to safety, Sang In-hyo, and the Demonic Teacher.

Setting Ah-young down, Woon-seong spat, "Vice Leader...!!!"

"Young Leader...", returned Joo Moon-baek, before he focused on someone else. "Shadow... So you went to that side?"

Shadow technically used to work under Joo Moon-baek, but he had always been there as an observer for the Unrecorded Demonic Group. Now that the Woon-seong had been recognized as the heir to the Unrecorded, of course he would switch sides.

Though Joo Moon-baek probably didn't know Woon-seong's new relations with the Unrecorded Demonic Group.

It was at that moment that Lee Shin-jung became furious.

"You despicable brat! What the hell are you doing?"

Joo Moon-baek's eyebrows twitched at this reprimand and he opened his mouth as if he were about to say something. But eventually he only sighed.

"Teacher... There was something I've always wondered about."

"..."

"Why are only the *chosen* ones allowed to become the cult leader? The Cult emphasizes the survival of the fittest as our core value, yet only a specific chosen one is allowed to lead the Cult."

"Is that your justification for all of this?" Woon-seong asked.

Joo Moon-baek nodded.

"Yes. Why? Can I not be the one who rises to that position? And let's find out why things became this way, too. That was my whole plan."

It was all just personal greed and ambition.

"I got rid of those stronger than me by all means necessary... and I crushed the weak and arrogant who tried to target me. And once I stopped to look around, I had ended up in the position of Vice Leader."

Joo Moon-baek clenched his hands into a fist.

“But becoming the leader was not easy! For some reason, just being strong was not good enough. I was left with no choice but to break, destroy, and crush everything getting in my way, like I always did. I simply need to split them with my ‘Soul Splitting Flame Spirit’! I’ll split their souls so they can no longer see the light of day!”

Flames sprang from Joo Moon-baek’s palm.

It was very much like the ‘Soul Splitting Flame Spirit’ that made Joo Moon-baek known as the ‘Soul Splitting Flame King’.

But the color was unusual.

An aura of gray flickered between the red and black hues.

Woon-seong quickly realized it’s identity. *The incomplete Unrecorded Divine Flame!*

The flame slowly enveloped Joo Moon-baek’s whole body.

“But several years ago, a rat popped out of nowhere and started disrupting my plans.”

Turning his head, Joo Moon-baek glared at Woon-seong.

This pressure... It’s like he’s gripping my heart... Woon-seong felt like his chest was being ripped apart.

But he didn’t take a single step back.

Instead, he glared right back with a valiant expression.

Ba-bump. Ba-bump. Ba-bump. Ba-bump...

The Vice Leader was not an enemy Woon-seong could face with a wavering will.

Moreover, it was not just Joo Moon-baek that had to be dealt with. The other people around the Vice Leader were also dangerous.

Three Demonic Masters and eight transcendence level martial artists...

Fighting here will result in a definite loss! We need to escape here and combine forces with the other Demonic Masters. The problem is that retreating is difficult in and of itself...

“Why are you getting in my way?”

At that moment, Joo Moon-baek suddenly shouted.

Fwoom—!

A fierce circle of flames appeared, spreading out around the Vice Leader.

Standing amongst the flames, Joo Moon-baek truly gave off the image of a king.

Woon-seong gripped his White Night Spear a little tighter.

“I’ve never been in your way, Vice Leader.”

“What?”

“Both of us are here for each of our selfish goals... So stop that bullshit about someone getting in someone’s way.”

At that point, everyone’s gaze was on Woon-seong.

“In the end, Murim is all about the survivor being the strongest and the one who achieves what he wants. Don’t you agree?”

Survival of the fittest!

What Woon-seong and Joo Moon-baek were both arguing was fundamentally the idea of ‘survival of the fittest’, but their interpretations were different.

According to Joo Moon-baek, it was the strongest that survived.

However...

“Woon-seong. Kangho [1] isn’t a place where the strongest survives. It’s a place where the survivor becomes the strongest.”

Due to the passage of time, Kangho was a place where the survivors grew stronger.

If a rabbit survived a fight between two tigers, was the rabbit then the strongest?

“Puhahahahahah!”

Joo Moon-baek clutched his stomach burst into laughter, as if Woon-seong’s words were hilarious. His laughter eerily reverberated around him.

Suddenly, he stopped laughing.

“I see... So that’s how you think, eh?”

Joo Moon-baek spread out his arms, revealing his chest.

“Then let’s find out here and now, Young Leader. Who is it that survives?”

Joo Moon-baek smiled brightly, body shrouded in flames.

“And who is truly strong?”

With a *snap*, the blood jiangshi pounced towards Woon-seong’s group.

[1] There is some debate over whether Jianghu/Kangho is interchangeable with Wulin/Murim. My interpretation is that Kangho is the world of martial arts while Murim is the martial society.

Chapter 82: Collision And Reversal (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 82 – Collision and Reversal (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Cheon Ah-young shouted from behind them, watching the swarming shadows ahead.

Blood jiangshi!

The faces of Woon-seong and Lee Shin-jung hardened. This is because the two understood the terror of the blood jiangshi, from experience or hearsay.

Not only that, their enemies included Mo In-ryang, Hwan Dok, and Joo Moon-baek.

Moreover, the number on Woon-seong's side was clearly inferior.

The situation quickly became chaotic.

When Woon-seong swung his spear, two blood jiangshi were immediately struck.

Kuakuakua—

I couldn't cut them. They're tough...

At that moment, another blood jiangshi came after the youth.

It wasn't just the reanimated corpse.

The flames from the Vice Leader spilled across the clearing, tendrils of flame licking at his face and limbs.

"Is it too hot for you, Young Leader?" mocked Joo Moon-baek.

"It's quite the heat, I'll give you that. But I never let anyone get away with a burn on me!"

Kuang—

At the same time, Woon-seong leaped into the air.

'Rain of Star Destruction'!

With a flick of his spear, it looked like a meteorite shower had arrived.

However, this attack was focused more on overall coverage than pinpointed power. It was impossible to inflict serious wounds on the blood jiangshi or Joo Moon-baek.

"Hup!" the Vice Leader leapt to the side, avoiding the volley of attacks.

The blood jiangshi were momentarily incapacitated, but regained control of their bodies as their joints twisted back into place.

I knew I wasn't going to scratch Joo Moon-baek at all, but I didn't expect for even the blood jiangshi to come out unscathed. Looks like I need to use attacks that pinpoint my force.

Woon-seong took a small moment to glance around the battlefield.

Over on one side, Lee Shin-jung had been struggling against five blood jiangshi. Coming in at an opportune moment, Sang In-hyo had managed to deflect a blow to the Demonic Teacher's head.

“Thank you, Sang In-hyo.”

“Let me help you.”

“Then, can you just keep one of them busy?”

“Yes, sir!”

Thus, Lee Shin-jung was now struggling against four blood jiangshi while Sang In-hyo kept the fifth at bay.

Meanwhile, the unknown man in black, Hwan Dok, was rushing towards the Divine Maiden.

The situation over there was currently at a stalemate since the Fist King was desperately protecting Cheon Ah-young. Despite being a Great Demon, the Divine Maiden herself was also fighting back with all her strength.

In that situation, the man in black could only click his tongue, feeling quite victimized. “Tsk.”

This turned out to be more annoying than I expected...

In fact, the barely standing Demonic Master was not the problem.

The annoying existence was the Divine Maiden, Cheon Ah-young.

Originally a martial artist, Ah-young was light on her feet and adept at using both divine power and qi. On top of that, her divine power seemed to be strangely effective on Hwan Dok. Every time she used it, Hwan Dok would become disoriented.

Just killing her would've solved the problem, Hwan Dok muttered to himself. *She's only able to pull those tricks because I have to catch her alive.*

If Hwan Dok wanted to kill her, Ah-young was an easy opponent to face. Although she could use both energies, she was a much weaker martial artist and lacked experience using divine power.

However, Cheon Ah-young is only valuable when alive. For Joo Moon-baek to rise to the throne with legitimacy, her existence is essential.

For that reason, Hwan Dok had to pull his punches.

And it seems like she has noticed the fact that I cannot kill her... Every time I make a move to kill Koo Jong-byuk, she tosses herself into my sword. What an annoying bitch...

Just as he described, Ah-young leapt in front of Hwan Dok's sword. In order to not accidentally stab her in the heart, the man had to maneuver his sword to the side. Taking advantage of his sudden wavering movements, Shadow, who had been darting here and there, slashed at his exposed face and neck.

Damn it!

When I go after the Maiden, Koo Jong-byuk interrupts. When I try to stab him, she stops me and then that man nicknamed 'Shadow' comes and attacks me.

"None of this is easy," Hwan Dok muttered with contempt. It was truly a troublesome situation when faced with stubborn people.

"But none of this is particularly difficult either."

All in all, the Demonic Teacher's side of things looked bad, even with Sang In-hyo there to help him. The other side didn't look good either, especially since the Fist King was basically at his limit. Those three wouldn't be enough to keep up with the man in black.

Analyzing the tide was pointless, it was obvious that Woon-seong's group was losing.

What do I do...?

As his forces became worn out, a drawn out battle would become increasingly disadvantageous for Woon-seong.

There was not a single person fighting at the moment who did not realize that fact.

Not only was Woon-seong's group outnumbered, they were also out-powered. On top of needing to deal with the tricky blood jiangshi, Woon-seong's group had fewer Demonic Masters.

Woon-seong closed his eyes for a moment, remembering the last words the Heavenly Demon had spoken to him before passing out: *"Please take care of Ah-young."*

Had Cheon Hwi predicted the current situation?

Then why didn't he make a move earlier? It might not have come to this if he decided to nip the problem in the bud, right after he noticed he was poisoned. Instead, he trained an apprentice until he collapsed, Woon-seong complained in his heart.

Woon-seong shook his head.

He had many question, but none of them could be answered.

They were all questions that could not be answered because there was no Heavenly Demon to answer them.

Huffing slightly, Woon-seong wiped blood off his face.

On top of that, those questions aren't what I should be worrying about right now!

I need to focus on the blood jiangshi in front of me, and Joo Moon-baek who is attacking from behind them. Every one of them is a tough opponent.

Fwoom—

Kuakuakua—

It was clear that even a single mistake would mean death.

I can't let that happen.

Why, someone may ask.

Not when I did so much for this life.

My second life happened thanks to the artifact of the Spear Master Sect, but it was purely me and my effort that brought me to this position and status.

I can't let go of it now. I'll only burst out of my grave if I was killed here.

Bang!

Woon-seong was ambushed by Joo Moon-baek from the back, a blast of flames knocking him off-kilter and face-first into the ground.

If I die here, then my old man...! My masters...!

Woon-seong suddenly froze.

Wait, what was I just thinking now?

That had been an unexpected train of thought.

'Old man' obviously meant my Spear Master Sect master... But my 'masters'...?

The word 'masters' clearly indicated more than one person.

Forgetting that he was in the middle of a life-or-death battle, Woon-seong laughed maniacally.

It looks like I unconsciously thought of the Cult Leader as my real master too.

Perhaps in the teachings of the Heavenly Demon, Woon-seong had seen an illusion of his previous master.

It looks like I've always wanted someone to guide me forwards, to tell me not to walk a path of revenge filled only with loneliness and solitude.

Thunk. Thunk.

Woon-seong haphazardly unwrapped the bandages on his arms and legs, removing the bracers that weighed him down.

In the end, I wanted affection.

Woon-seong gripped his spear a little more tightly than before.

Then that's another reason why I can't die here!

I'll give you my everything to survive!

Woon-seong gripped his spear as he looked back at Joo Moon-baek.

Joo Moon-baek... He showed his ambitions the moment Cheon Hwi collapsed. Can we really call that timing a coincidence?

No, it couldn't be.

He must have been anticipating that moment for a long time. Maybe Joo Moon-baek is even the one behind the poisoning.

Actually, I may not have the evidence, but it seems obvious.

Now, if I can only find out more about that poison.

Back when Nok Yu-on was poisoned, Woon-seong concluded that it was the doing of the Sichuan Tang Clan. It was hard to imagine anyone outside the Sichuan Tang Clan, the renowned Masters of Poison, creating something so potent.

However, things were different now.

That very same poison had appeared in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

I don't care how powerful the Sichuan Tang are, they are not capable of poisoning the Cult Leader. A poison that can affect a man of his caliber has never existed in history. Even if they made such a poison, using it in such a manner would only risk a full frontal war against the entire Demonic Cult. Even an enemy of the Cult... No, no one in the Orthodox sects would want something like that to happen.

Either way, if the Vice Leader is really involved in this matter...

I'll get some answers once I take him down.

At this moment, Woon-seong's eyes were filled with fighting spirit. A flame erupted from his body, shrouding him in a faint aura of light.

Fwoom—

The true, completed Divine Flame was revealed.

This gray flame made Mo In-ryang feel like he was trapped in time, as if everything had stopped in reverence of the flame. Despite being so far away, he felt like he could feel the heat of the flame, which threatened to burn him down to the bone.

Mo In-ryang's legs trembled. *I'm clearly perceiving them as enemies, yet there's a sense of awe I cannot suppress. There's only one thing that can provoke such emotions from a demonic practitioner.*

Unknowingly, he muttered, "The Divine Flame?"

Although the color was a little different, there truly was only one thing that could make Mo In-ryang feel this way.

On the other side, the same thing was happening with Joo Moon-baek. *Hmm. So this is what made the Demonic Teacher choose his side,* the Vice Leader concluded, comparing it with his own Divine Flame.

Fwoom—

Joo Moon-baek's own flame also danced around. Although it was incomplete, it could still somewhat stand against the completed version.

Of course, it was all he could do to protect himself.

He was unable to protect those fighting by his side.

Tsk. It looks like I won't be able to help the Blade Demon.

He looked around. One of the blood jiangshi collapsed onto the ground, unable to get up once more.

Hmm. Another one bites the dust.

Standing on the other side of Woon-seong, Lee Shin-jung and the others were unaffected by the Divine Flame.

It seems like the Young Leader's Divine Flame isn't affecting any of his allies.

Moreover, Joo Moon-baek's incomplete flame was unable to cover the distance needed to affect the entire battlefield.

"Is that the complete Divine Flame, Young Leader? Heh, I can see that it's heaps better than my incomplete one. A Young Leader who was born with a talented body and loved by the Leader. He becomes the Leader's only apprentice and enjoys the privileges and inherits the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon," Joo Moon-baek mockingly complained. "How unfair is that?"

"A talented body and all the privileges..." Woon-seong muttered. Was that what Joo Moon-baek thought of him? "You have no idea how I reached this position."

With a glimmer of gold in his eyes, Woon-seong continued, "Vice Leader.

"Hmm...?"

"No, Joo Moon-baek."

“Those are some rude words you’re directing at an elder, Young Leader,” chuckled Joo Moon-baek.

That was meant as an insult, but Woon-seong didn’t falter at all.

“Let’s be honest. We’re in no relation to stay polite with each other. You shall fall here today and tell me about everything.”

“How absurd. And what exactly would I be telling you?”

Woon-seong slowly nodded and swung his White Night Spear.

In an instant, the White Night Spear was also covered with the Divine Flame. Now entirely immersed into the Divine Flame, Woon-seong looked like the incarnation of the God of Fire.

“About the poison you used against the Leader... No, my Master! Where you’ve obtained it and who created it!”

From another vantage point, Lee Shin-jung chuckled to himself as he observed Woon-seong.

Then, he grabbed the two ‘Heavenly Rings’. One was black and the other was white, representing yin and yang respectively.

In that state, Lee Shin-jung called for Sang In-hyo.

“Say, Demon Sword.”

“Yes, sir,” replied politely after a short pause due to the ongoing battle.

“The Lord used to be in the Cave of Latent Demons, correct?”

“That is correct.”

“And I remember that you were the General Manager of the Cave of Latent Demons.”

“That is also true.”

Lee Shin-jung nodded with a contented expression. Almost immediately, it was replaced with one of fierce determination as he stared at the energy surrounding Woon-seong.

“Haha. You’ve done a great job.”

“...” Sang In-hyo did not respond.

“The Lord is doing his best. Don’t you think I also ought to show some effort?”

“Same goes for me too.”

Lee Shin-jung nodded. “That’s right. We need to show our best too.”

At this moment, Lee Shin-jung’s ‘Heavenly Ring of Yin’ disappeared from his hands.

When it reappeared...

Clang—!

Startled, Mo In-ryang hurriedly blocked the oncoming attack with his sword.

Only momentarily stopped by the sword, the ring continued towards the Blade Demon.

Mo In-ryang’s right arm was lopped clean off.

On the other side, the battle, which had briefly stopped due to the appearance of the Divine Flame, resumed shortly.

The situation didn’t seem to have changed much.

Just like how Lee Shin-jung still had to deal with three, albeit weakened, blood jiangshi, Woon-seong was still in a tough situation.

Moreover, the mysterious Hwan Dok was still fighting with the Fist King, being almost entirely free from the effects of the Divine Flame.

The Fist King looked even more ragged than before, his body covered in wounds that would need more than a year to heal. If it weren't for the interference of Divine Maiden Ah-young and Shadow, the Fist King would already be a corpse.

It was no good! I was planning to use the Divine Flame to shake them up a bit and use that moment to escape...

But...

“Oh no you don't!”

Joo Moon-baek appeared before Woon-seong and swung at him, forcing Woon-seong to hurriedly retreat backwards.

“Ugh!”

Under the orders of Joo Moon-baek, the blood jiangshi pressed forward, attempting to surround Woon-seong.

“Young Leader, do you take me for a fool? Trying to escape now? How naive of you.”

If so...

Woon-seong grabbed his White Night Spear with both hands and swung.

A mix of Orthodox, Demonic, and fused spear arts rained down on the Vice Leader.

One movement managed to nick Joo Moon-baek on the shoulder, slicing through his fur coat and drawing blood.

“Tsk.”

In an instant, Woon-seong had appeared on the other side of Joo Moon-baek's body with his fingers outstretched.

‘Flying explosive rings!’

Boom!

A bright light engulfed the area.

Thwack!

A blood jiangshi was thrown away, bouncing away with its chest caved in. That was a wound that no living man would have survived. But it wasn't alive!

Damn it! A blood jiangshi soaked the explosion instead.

With a ‘crunch’, the blood jiangshi stood up again, revealing its crushed ribcage to the world.

“Huff. Huff. Huff.” Facing multiple enemies at or above his strength was making it hard for Woon-seong to regulate his breathing.

“You seem quite exhausted, Young Leader.”

Thwack!

It was not just Woon-seong that was breathing hard.

Launching an attack on Joo Moon-baek, Lee Shin-jung had just lost a finger.

“Demonic Teacher! Your hand—!”

“My Lord, do not worry about this old man. I exchanged a finger for an arm, so it wasn't too bad of a deal.”

Lee Shin-jung still looked calm and composed, which was relieving to see. Of course, even if he didn't show it on his face, the Demonic Teacher was

probably fighting against the pain.

There was another who was also struggling to stay conscious.

That would be Sang In-hyo.

“Sang In-hyo...”

“Kuh, I am also fine,” Sang In-hyo said, grabbing his bloody shoulder. He had joined in an attack against the Blade Demon, but had lost an arm after being counterattacked by a blood jiangshi.

Woon-seong closed his eyes. He could not help but curse, “Damn it!”

We’ve lost too much to take down all the blood jiangshi.

I’m out of options.

I don’t have the strength, the skills, nor the tricks to get us out of this situation.

It’s my fault for not predicting the use of blood jiangshi.

We wouldn’t have been in such a one-sided pinch if it weren’t for those blood jiangshi.

It’s all my fault. I should’ve prepared more meticulously... I finally manifest the Divine Flame, yet all I can do right now is regret.

“Is this as far as I go?”

As soon as Woon-seong asked himself that, a voice shook the battlefield.

“You’ve done well, my apprentice.”

A human meteor fell from the sky.

Kaboom—!

Chapter 83: Facade (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 83 – Facade (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The whole mountain shook violently as if it were about to collapse.

Rumble—

The ground where the meteor had fallen crumbled. A large fissure formed, leading all the way to the Divine Maiden's Palace and collapsing the entrance.

Rumble—

Thunder shook the air.

As if that was not enough, this fallen star continued to shine for a few more seconds, its bright light forming a large crater.

The surrounding landscape tore apart like a flimsy spiderweb, shattering into pieces.

The battlefield froze.

Woon-seong wanted to raise his head, but he couldn't.

It couldn't be him...

What fell down was not a meteor but a man!

How could that have been a man though?

A human would have burnt to a crisp under that heavy energy.

If so, that was not a human.

Woon-seong's eyes shook.

Joo Moon-baek was similarly dazed.

Both had been startled into near stupidity by one thing.

A being that took on the form of a human, yet performed miracles no humans could.

A being who was born as a human, yet transcended mortal limits.

“The realm of semi-divinity...”

Everyone nodded, agreeing with what Woon-seong had unknowingly murmured.

And thus everyone realized who had just appeared.

Throughout the entire Divine Cult, there was only one person who had reached that level of cultivation.

“Father!” called out Cheon Ah-young.

“Leader,” Lee Shin-jung shouted.

“Master!” Woon-seong shouted in surprise.

“LEADER!” roared Joo Moon-baek. His loud wail of fury echoed through the now silent Divine Maiden's Palace.

The man who had just appeared turned his gaze towards Joo Moon-baek, blank and mildly unimpressed.

Then, he reached over and ruffled Woon-seong's hair.

"You have done very well."

For some reason, Woon-seong felt like he was going to burst into tears. Maybe it was seeing the previously bedridden Cheon Hwi regally standing there, or maybe it was the way the burden of total responsibility seemed to slide off his shoulders.

But Woon-seong bit his lips and forcefully endured the stinging in his eyes. Barely able to speak with his trembling lips, he could only say, "Master..."

Cheon Hwi seemed to freeze for a millisecond, then nodded. "So, you finally call me your master."

Woon-seong nodded. *I wish I had called you so earlier...*

"You have done a great job. Now leave the rest to your master."

Meanwhile, Cheon Hwi's gaze had left Woon-seong and turned towards Cheon Ah-young.

With a swing of his hand, Ah-young rose into the air and floated towards him.

Telekinesis and remote manipulation, both refined to perfection! So that's the Heavenly Demon! Hwan Dok observed from the side. *But that doesn't mean I can just sit back and watch.*

"You don't get to have things your way just because you're the Cult Leader!"

Blades of qi rose up into the air, aimed straight at Ah-young.

But...

“Don’t you dare!”

Similar to how the Heavenly Demon had crashed into the fray, one more person landed on the cliff, though in a more human-like trajectory.

Life and death were only pools of ink!

A cultured aura, like that of a scholar holding a calligraphy brush, appeared from thin air and tore space apart.

In an instant, the space around the attacking Hwan Dok collapsed in on itself, creating a vortex that pushed the man away.

“Uack!”

Surprised by the sudden attack, Hwan Dok hurriedly defended himself. However, he couldn’t stop himself from being flung into the distance and crashing into the dirt.

Boom!

Hwan Dok found himself tumbling about like a torn kite.

A few more excruciating rolls and he could see the face of the man who had attacked him.

“The Brain of the Heavenly Demon...?”

Hwan Dok became a bit more vigilant.

The man who had appeared after Cheon Hwi was one to be cautious of, even if he was mainly a strategist. A set of metal pens glinted at the man’s waist. With just a moment of distraction, he could sever the life of his enemy.

Definitely one of the Ten Demonic Masters, the Senior Strategist of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon!

Sang Gwan-chuk hurried to Cheon Hwi’s side and bowed.

“I apologize for being late, my Lord.”

“It’s fine.”

The Heavenly Demon shook his head.

Although the Senior Strategist was always well-informed, it would still be hard for him to show up on a moment’s notice.

Meanwhile, Cheon Ah-young had flown into Cheon Hwi’s arms.

Cheon Hwi slowly patted her back. It was as if the mere presence of her father had calmed the mind of the young daughter.

“You have suffered too much.”

“Oh, Father...”

The voice of Ah-young, who was hugging her father, trembled.

Her father, Cheon Hwi, should not be standing here. He was dying of poison!

But how did he suddenly appear here?

Of course, Cheon Hwi did not answer her question.

Instead, he let go of his daughter. “Stay behind me.”

He glanced around, eyes landing on Lee Shin-jung.

“Demonic Teacher.”

“Yes, my Leader.”

“I also thank you for your hard work.”

“There is no need. I’ve simply performed my duty for my new master.”

“Your new master...”

Cheon Hwi turned his head to look at Woon-seong, as if he knew what Lee Shin-jung was referring to. Then he smiled proudly, just for one moment, before his gaze returned to the Demonic Teacher.

“I am terribly sorry about your finger. There is no way to replace a lost finger, but I will never forget this debt.”

Lee Shin-jung did not respond.

Cheon Hwi paid no mind and turned to look at the Fist King, who was taking the momentary lull to patch himself up.

“Fist King. You can rest now.”

“Haha. I can still keep going. Since you showed up, the only thing left is to wipe out that band of scoundrels.”

“Hmm,” Cheon Hwi paused for a moment, before turning to the Senior Strategist. “The moment this is over, get the medical group to look after the Fist King. Pay anything you need to return the Fist King to his healthy self.”

Sang Gwan-chuk bowed his head. “I understand.”

A king should never forget a loyal vassal. It was only fair to reward those who had been on his side, be the truly loyal or allies of personal benefit.

Helping the Fist King recuperate faster could be considered a prize.

“The same is true of the Demonic Sword. You cannot repair a severed arm, but I will give you all the support you can get.”

“Yes, sir.”

Sang Gwan-chuk remembered the command of the Heavenly Demon, who was even rewarding a Great Demon.

Thus, the gaze of the Heavenly Demon shifted once more.

Previously, if he was looking at his allies, he was now looking at his enemies.

A cold glare swept over Joo Moon-baek, Hwan Dok, and Mo In-ryang.

The three of them felt an intense chill, like the wintry winds of the Northern Plains.

“And you, Demon Blade...”

Crushed under the immense pressure of the Heavenly Demon’s ire, Mo In-ryang struggled to speak. “L-Leader...”

His voice was cut off by words sharp like a blade.

“Blade Demon. If it was your choice to stand on that side... Do not think of making excuses even if you end up dead.”

That was also a must.

It was a king’s job to reward the meritorious and punish those who had sinned.

With one hand still behind his back, Cheon Hwi pointed towards the other.

“Because I have no intention of sparing you either.”

What is this?! Mo In-ryang exclaimed to himself. This sensation, as though my whole body is being sharpened with the edge of a blade... Am I hallucinating because of the Leader’s pressure?

It was not cold, it was not hot.

It didn’t exist, yet it was tangible.

Mo In-ryang felt something foreign pass through his body like a phantom.

At that moment!

Phew!

Blood suddenly gushed out, splattering the ground.

“Ugh!”

How? Mo In-ryang looked down at his chest, which had split open. He's at least 200 feet away from me!

Mo In-ryang would have avoided an attack from that distance, or at least been able to defend himself.

It should have been impossible to slaughter a Demonic Master in one blow from that distance.

Yet Cheon Hwi had done so.

Mo In-ryang suddenly realized something.

Is it the Mind Sword?

A long time ago, he had seen Cheon Hwi slicing the moon reflected within a cup — the Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon.

Obviously he knew about the Mind Sword, but he had never thought it would be so powerful.

So he also splits my perception, causing me to believe that he can't possibly kill me from that distance.

Mo In-ryang collapsed onto the floor, his vision blurring. That was the last thought that he would ever have.

The Mind Sword... , muttered Joo Moon-baek as he watched Mo In-ryang die. As long as one was not a fool, it was easy to guess what had caused the man's death. *He slayed a Demonic Master with a single blow.*

At the same time, Joo Moon-baek had some questions.

The Mind Sword was a sword that cut through concepts and perceptions. Then what if a person's will or mental strength was enough to retain their ideas?

Would they be able to stop the Mind Sword from severing their thoughts?

Will I be able to stop the Mind Sword?

Mo In-ryang was unlucky. He had lost his arm to the Demonic Teacher, then lost his composure because of the sudden appearance of both the Leader and the Senior Strategist.

But Joo Moon-baek was different. He had no grievous wounds that shook his mentality.

Moreover, the loss of composure caused by the Leader had been restored by the death of Mo In-ryang.

Rather than questioning how Cheon Hwi had appeared here, Joo Moon-baek had a strong willingness to fight.

Will I be able to withstand the Mind Sword?

It was unknown.

No matter how Joo Moon-baek hypothesized, he couldn't be sure.

There was no guarantee that a strong mind was all that was needed to block the Mind Sword.

There was also no need for Joo Moon-baek to test out his theory. Instead, he snapped his fingers, calling the remaining blood jiangshi to attention.

Just as Joo Moon-baek was getting ready once more, Cheon Hwi spoke up once more.

“Vice Leader. I assume you have taken that side because of your own ambitions.”

It was almost the same question he had asked Mo In-ryang.

This woke Joo Moon-baek from his musings and he nodded.

“Haha. Things didn’t turn out as clear cut as I wanted, but that’s true, Leader.”

“I see. Then are you also aware of this, Vice Leader? I put you in that position while aware of such ambitions.”

At these words, Joo Moon-baek’s eyebrows twitched. “What do you mean?”

“It is a necessity of being a good leader. You always need someone to keep yourself in check to go the right path. Otherwise, another enemy would be binding my neck.”

Cheon Hwi’s face became colder and he made a choking motion.

“Hmm.”

“And that was your purpose. To keep me in check.”

At this sudden revelation, a part of Joo Moon-baek wanted to cry some indignant tears. His shoulders shook slightly.

“I see. So you made me Vice Leader despite knowing everything already. For this whole time, I’ve been dancing on top of your palm.”

Everyone thought that the Heavenly Demon would nod in agreement. Based on Cheon Hwi’s words, he had predicted everything.

Unlike everyone’s expectations, Cheon Hwi shook his head.

“Not always. I will admit the poison this time was quite ferocious. For a while, I thought I was actually going to die.”

“And how does any of that matter? Considering none of that worked on you anyways...”

Cheon Hwi’s lips twitched upwards, reminiscent of a smirk.

“!!!”

“Then, did he finally overcome the poison?”

“Of course he did! There was no way the Leader was going to lose to some poison!”

Everyone thought that the Heavenly Demon had successfully overcome the poison.

Everyone except one.

Woon-seong knew that life could not be that perfect.

No... Something’s wrong...

His fingertips are shaking...

Woon-seong only noticed because he was standing directly behind Cheon Hwi, blocking everyone else’s view.

The Heavenly Demon purposefully stood with his hands behind his back. It wasn’t because it allowed him to show a more regal disposition, but because his fingers were trembling!

In addition, the tips of the Heavenly Demon’s fingernails were tinged with black.

That was not overcoming the poison, more like barely holding the poison at bay.

Woon-seong raised his head in a hurry.

Right now, Master is...!

The Heavenly Demon was only pretending to be healthy. In fact, even though his body was likely close to death, he was still bluffing!

“Ma—”

As soon as Woon-seong tried to call out, a telepathic message cut off his words.

— I am fine. I can stand until the end, until the matter is over. So do not worry.

It seemed that Cheon Hwi realized that Woon-seong, who stood closest to him, had noticed his condition.

Woon-seong clamped his mouth shut.

But he still had doubts.

If he's really fine, why did he only show up now and not right after the Vice Leader started showing his ambitions? If he was simply acting as though he was poisoned so he can find out who was truly against him, he could've moved the moment the Vice Leader moved to kidnap the Divine Maiden.

There must be a reason.

The reason why he couldn't move then but he can move now. Is it to wait for a situation where all of his enemies are gathered in one spot?

It's not impossible, but that's too risky of a plan.

Woon-seong glanced behind him, where Ah-young and the others safely stood some distance away.

If Master had shown up even a minute later, nobody here would be standing like this.

Then there must be another reason. What is it?

Woon-seong's eyes trembled.

One thought passed through his mind.

No way...!

Chapter 84: Facade (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 84 – Facade (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

There were times when people had two faces.

It meant that when there was an outside, there was also something happening on the inside.

And that was exactly what was happening with the Heavenly Demon.

While it looked like he had completely overcome the poison on the outside, it was actually eating his life away on the inside.

Several thoughts flashed through Woon-seong's head. He quickly came up with a plausible conclusion as to why the Heavenly Demon only appeared at this moment.

You were planning to use this situation from the start.

Maybe his coughing up blood during Ah-young's inheritance ceremony was also planned.

But, after some time, Cheon Hwi must have realized that the poison was something stronger than he originally planned for.

A poison that even a man in the realm of semi-divine could not withstand. One that Sang Gwan-chuk, the smartest man in the Cult, could not find a cure for.

An unexpected turn of events.

However, the enemies hiding beneath the surface proceeded with their plans.

This confrontation was the result of all of that.

You might have been predicting this situation, ever since you planned to pose as a poisoned patient.

Even if it wasn't pre-planned, Sang Gwan-chuk would have done his best to steer everything towards this ending.

When all the enemies gathered in one spot, Cheon Hwi was planning to show up nice and healthy.

But the poison turned out to be more powerful than expected.

It took much longer to suppress the poison, which is why he showed up later than planned.

Of course, that was all just Woon-seong's theory.

Woon-seong stared up at the Heavens for a moment, hoping that his conjecture was wrong. He then turned back towards Cheon Hwi and prayed that even if poisonous residue remained, it would be eliminated soon.

Woon-seong then stared blankly at Joo Moon-baek, wondering if the Vice Leader had any idea of what was going on inside his head.

The tremor in Cheon Hwi's hand was now worse than before.

"Blood jiangshi... I am pretty sure all records on their creation have been expunged. Did you restore it?" mused the Heavenly Demon. "No, there

must be someone else who taught you about it. Is it the man that the Senior Strategist pushed away moments ago?”

Cheon Hwi looked around.

Attacking his daughter was an unforgivable offense, so he was still looking for that man in black.

However, the man had disappeared.

“It seems he has already decided to leave this place.”

What...?! He was here just a moment ago! Joo Moon-baek was surprised.
“Where did he...?!”

Was it the moment Mo In-ryang died? He must’ve fled after judging the situation as hopeless.

Oblivion... The man who deceives his even own allies into oblivion.

So I’m the one who ended up becoming the discarded one, Joo Moon-baek sighed to himself.

Off to the side, Woon-seong shook his head. That was truly some cowardly behavior — as expected of traitors who resorted to poison.

“A rat has escaped the scene. Strategist!”

Cheon Hwi called for his advisor, then passed down some strict orders.

“Command all the Ten Demonic Masters now: seal Mount Heaven and do not let a single rat escape.”

“Yes, sir.”

“There is no need to kill him. Bring him alive. I have a lot of questions for him...”

Cheon Hwi paused and rubbed the area around his heart with one hand.

Even then, the Strategist could guess what he meant to say.

“...Ones beside the origin of those blood jiangshi.”

“Consider it done, sir.”

The Senior Strategist clasped his hands in a bow, then left the battlefield. When he disappeared, he looked a little reluctant, like an old bird leaving its nest for the last time.

It seemed that the key to this entire mess would be left to the Senior Strategist and the other Demonic Masters.

“And I believe we still have matters to discuss, Vice Leader.”

Joo Moon-baek smiled faintly. “By that, I assume you mean you’re looking for a moment to cut my head off. But it won’t go the way you want it to, Leader.”

The Vice Leader spoke boldly, but he was currently measuring his own strength with a calculative gaze.

What if I kill the Leader here?

No, no matter how Joo Moon-baek thought about it, that was impossible.

He’s in the realm of a semi-divine being and can use the Mind Sword at will. A mere five blood jiangshi are no match for him.

Even if I do succeed in killing him, there’s still the Young Leader and the Demonic Teacher. It’s impossible to flee from this place without the help of others.

Then, I only have one option.

Joo Moon-baek rolled his shoulders, coming to a conclusion. He snapped his fingers.

The blood jiangshi, who had received new orders, began to move. This time, they bared their teeth, seeming more ferocious than before.

“Hmph,” Cheon Hwi snorted.

With a wave of his hand, he summoned a plume of the Divine Flame and blasted Joo Moon-baek.

“!”

Using his own incomplete Divine Flame, Joo Moon-baek was able to shield himself just enough to deflect the plume of flame, causing it to ricochet into a blood jiangshi.

“Are you trying to flee?”

Cheon Hwi couldn’t help but notice Joo Moon-baek was trying to run away.

“That’s right. You may be the almighty leader, but I’m sure four blood jiangshi are enough to at least buy me some time. Enough time for me to escape this scene.”

Joo Moon-baek knew that it was obvious, so he didn’t bother hiding it and spoke about his plans.

Everyone else had probably noticed too.

Cheon Hwi chuckled, shaking his head slightly. “It will not be easy.”

“I’m well aware of that. Even if I escape from here, escaping from the Heavenly Mountain won’t be easy. But I’d dare say that’s much better than dying right now.”

At that, Cheon Hwi smirked once more. Scoffing, he disdainfully repeated what he had just said.

“It will not be easy.”

“I already answered you. I said... Hup!”

Joo Moon-baek suddenly shut up.

A keen sensation, as though blades are aimed at the back of my neck... By 'it will not be easy', he was talking about me escaping from his Mind Sword!

As if knowing what the Vice Leader was thinking, Cheon Hwi spoke:

“Do you really think four of your blood jiangshi can stop my Mind Sword?”

Don't fall for it, Joo Moon-baek reminded himself. The Mind Sword is a sword that splits conscious conceptions. As long as I don't bow to Cheon Hwi's will, I can block the Mind Sword! Of course, I will have to risk some internal damage.

But, I have the blood jiangshi. The Mind Sword cannot reach me without going through the blood jiangshi. If that attack from a moment ago is how powerful the Mind Sword is, the blood jiangshi can at least work as meat shields!

“Vice Leader. Are you thinking that the attack from a moment ago was the Mind Sword?” the Heavenly Demon continued to say. “The Mind Sword is a sword manifested within my mind. Time and space are meaningless concepts to it.”

With each word, the Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon's aura became increasingly heavier.

“I split whatever I decide to split.”

Joo Moon-baek's will suddenly wavered.

There was some power held in the Heavenly Demon's words, a conviction that he had absolute control over what was happening.

Joo Moon-baek struggled to control his thoughts, but it was like trying to fix a dam that had already begun to collapse and flood its surroundings.

Fear was already influencing his decisions.

“Let me ask again. Can you really block my Mind Sword?”

It's coming... I'll use the blood jiangshi as meat shields to cushion the blow, then have the remaining blood jiangshi to rush in and buy some time...

“I told you. I split whatever I decide to split...”

Cheon Hwi stepped forward once, then made a sweeping motion with his hand.

‘I don’t think I can stop that.’

As soon as this thought appeared in Joo Moon-baek’s mind, his entire will collapsed.

The Mind Sword seemed to slash Joo Moon-baek in half.

Thud—!

“Is it over?”

Woon-seong stared at the corpse of Joo Moon-baek with a heavy expression.

The Vice Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had died, probably not even realizing that he had died due to a single slash. It was clear that Joo Moon-baek’s mind had crumbled long before the Mind Sword even reached him.

Of course, maybe it was better that way. The lofty Joo Moon-baek would not have wanted to meet such a humble end.

All in all though, Woon-seong understood — just as Joo Moon-baek probably did — that this was a result of ‘survival of the fittest’.

Perhaps this had proven Woon-seong’s interpretation correct.

Only the strong survive, but it was surviving which made them strong.

Joo Moon-baek was undoubtedly stronger than Woon-seong, but he had been killed in one stroke by Cheon Hwi.

Woon-seong looked at the corpse of Joo Moon-baek for a long time as he recalled this fact.

Who knows. I might be in the same position if I end up failing my revenge.

While Woon-seong was thinking about his own unknown future, Cheon Hwi was staring at the blood jiangshi, which were waddling about like lost ducklings.

They'll start attacking indiscriminately since they lost their master. I need to get rid of them before that happens. A blood jiangshi that moves on pure instinct is simply a dangerous beast.

Summoning his sword, Cheon Hwi used one slash to disintegrate each blood jiangshi that tried to attack him.

“Screech!”

One blood jiangshi screeched at him, as if it was trying to test out its opponent's strength.

“Hmm...”

Their instincts are slowly taking over.

Still, the blood jiangshi pounced towards the Heavenly Demon and was easily incapacitated with a sword slash.

The first blood jiangshi was split in half. As was the second.

Things were a little different with the third blood jiangshi.

The more their instincts take over, the more they will run away from the strong. Which becomes a tedious problem for me...

Slowly, the blood jiangshi were trying to maintain their distance from Cheon Hwi instead of attacking him. Realizing that they could not survive against him, they ‘debated’ running away.

Of course, escape was futile.

Instincts wouldn’t allow the blood jiangshi to survive against an absolute difference in power.

Instincts couldn’t stop the Heavenly Demon from slicing through the reflection of the moon.

The fourth and fifth blood jiangshi were sliced into halves.

It was only a matter of time before Cheon Hwi had killed almost all of the blood jiangshi, faring leagues better than Woon-seong and crew had against them.

By the time the sixth blood jiangshi was cut in half, their animalistic instincts hadn’t even fully awakened yet. If they had, the jiangshi would have actually ran away instead of even trying to confront Cheon Hwi.

Only one left.

It looks like my body made it after all.

That is the last of these cursed monsters. I should rest after this...

“Screech!”

The remaining blood jiangshi had been on the edges of the battlefield. Now that all of its brethren were piles of ash, it was a cornered rat. Realizing that it could no longer retreat, it staked its undead life on an all-out offensive.

Of course, its animal instincts had not been fully awakened either. Otherwise, it would have decisively fled the scene instead of hesitating at the edges.

Cheon Hwi easily dodged to the side and moved to slash its head off.

Then he froze.

Puchi—!

A cold, foreign energy penetrated his side and continued on to exit from his chest.

“Ugh!”

This sensation made Cheon Hwi grimace and he turned his head to look at the owner of the sword now stabbed through his abdomen.

It was not only Cheon Hwi who followed the hand to determine the culprit.

Lee Shin-jung, who immediately recognized the person holding the sword, grew furious.

“You! What are you doing!”

“Shadow!”

The Heavenly Demon groaned and stared into Shadow’s eyes.

They were glowing red, like hot coals.

Subsequently, Shadow started to speak: “I knew it. Your body isn’t in perfect condition. Right?”

The words came from Shadow’s mouth, but it was not his voice. It was the voice of the man the Senior Strategist had left in search of, the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion.

Everyone trembled at that voice.

Even so, Hwan Dok, who was borrowing Shadow’s mouth, continued to speak.

“Of course you aren’t all fine. That wasn’t some ordinary poison. It wouldn’t make sense if you were fine.”

The body of Shadow was forced to smile, distorted and grotesque.

Instead of moaning in agony, the Heavenly Demon boldly reached out and grabbed the controlled Shadow by the wrist.

In one smooth movement, he pulled the sword out of his own body.

Puchi—!

Blood spurted out from the wound.

Of course, Cheon Hwi stopped the bleeding by rapidly tapping a few acupressure points and sealing the wound.

But that wasn't the problem.

“That’s right,” cackled Hwan Dok. “Rotten, boiling blood... I was right.”

The blood on the floor smelled foul. It seemed to bubble and corrode the dirt around it.

Poison.

Human blood would not do that unless it contained deadly toxin.

“F-Father!” Cheon Ah-young could not help but tremble, her mind collapsing in horror.

Instead of dealing with the last blood jiangshi, the Heavenly Demon reached over and grabbed ‘Shadow’ by his neck.

In a cold voice, he asked, “Did you take over this man’s body?”

“Deceive to oblivion. That has always been my specialty. Hee-hee-hee...”

“And how do I pull you out of this body?”

“That’s impossible,” snorted Hwan Dok. “You’ll have to kill this man. He’s not my subordinate anyways.”

Hwan Dok had done what he set out to do, which was check if the Heavenly Demon was truly healthy. With that goal accomplished, he had no need or care for the disposable Shadow.

“I see,” Cheon Hwi nodded grimly. “It is a shame, but you leave me no choice.”

Crack—

With no ounce of hesitation, Cheon Hwi broke Shadow’s neck.

Thud.

As Shadow’s body fell to the floor, the remaining blood jiangshi had finally awoken its primal instincts. Scared out of its wits, it fled the scene. Given that the Ten Demonic Masters had essentially sealed the mountain though, it was impossible for it to survive.

Shaking his head, Cheon Hwi looked down at the body of Shadow. “Does this man have a family?”

Lee Shin-jung immediately answered. “Shadow is an orphan. He has no family, though he had close friends amongst his comrades from the Unrecorded Demonic Group.”

In response, Cheon Hwi closed his eyes for a moment.

“Recover his body and make him a burial mound with the highest respect from the Cult. Allow his friends to attend his funeral.”

The man’s death was an unfortunate inevitability, but his good deeds would not be forgotten.

An honorable burial was the reward chosen by Cheon Hwi.

“Yes, sir.”

Of course, Lee Shin-jung bowed his head.

With that, everything was over.

Yet, to Woon-seong, it felt like the dust had yet to settle.

Chapter 85: Ominous Star (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 85 – Ominous Star (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Heavenly Mountain Range was vast, with thousands of tall peaks and many more deep valleys.

Just as one could stand upon a peak and overlook the world, one could also tightly hide within a valley.

Not even the Cult of the Heavenly Demon knew all of the secrets within the depths of these mountains.

It was in one of those valleys that the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion currently hid.

He was in a dark cave protected by marshland.

He dove behind a large rock then coughed out a harsh breath.

“Hup!”

Some blood trickled out of his nose.

The ‘mind ghost’ he had planted in Shadow had been forcefully killed since its host died and the sudden disconnection caused a damage rebound.

Of course, it wasn't a very powerful rebound.

Except, he would have a hard time breathing and exerting any power for a while.

Naturally, this cave was the best place for him to hide.

He moved someone else's body to deceive, harass, and humiliate allies and enemies alike.

Truly, the word 'oblivion' did him no justice.

"He killed him. Hee-hee."

Moreover, the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion enjoyed such behavior.

After laughing some more, his throat could no longer take it and he broke into a fit of coughing.

Hwan Dok had lost a spiritual puppet, but he had gotten a large harvest.

"I didn't expect my insurance of planting a 'mind ghost' in one of the demonic practitioners would have paid off like this."

I confirmed the Heavenly Demon's illness. On top of that, his state is way beyond treatable. He was stabbed in the stomach on top of being heavily poisoned. Even the mighty Heavenly Demon shall not last longer than two weeks.

"Hahahahaha!"

He could not help but laugh as his excitement from killing the Heavenly Demon bubbled up.

I failed in making Joo Moon-baek the leader, but I succeeded in eliminating the top martial artist of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The 'Twin Stars and One Demon'.

A total of three martial artists in the realm of Semi-Divinity existed. Two were in the Orthodox sects, one in the Demonic Cult.

But that number was now about to decrease from three to two.

I should report this to the Imperial Court immediately.

He immediately pulled a piece of paper out and scribbled down a letter.

Then he whistled into the air. No sound could be heard, for humans were unable to hear it. Of course, birds would be able to catch the frequency though.

Caw—!

A hawk soon descended into the valley where the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion was hiding.

After familiarizing himself with the hawk, he tied the letter to its leg and sent it back into the sky.

“Hee-hee.”

Watching the bird leave, the man truly could not stop laughing to himself like a lunatic.

On the letter being sent, there were only three words.

“Heavenly Demon, dead.”

Well, technically, he's not dead yet. But he only has two weeks, at most.

By the time that letter reaches the Court, he shall no longer be a man of this world.

“Ugh.”

Cheon Hwi unknowingly let out a faint groan.

Feeling a weird sensation, he looked down at his waist.

I stopped the blood, but the wound is too deep. It's gotten worse... Is it because of the stab wound?

The wound seemed to make the poison return with an even greater intensity. The pain was excruciating.

As the blood within him boiled with toxins, Cheon Hwi was forced to cough some of the blood out.

No... Not yet.

Cheon Hwi closed his eyes and suppressed the poison with all of his strength.

How much longer can I bear with this...?

Maybe more than five days... But no longer than two weeks.

I must take care of everything before that.

He slowly opened his eyes.

“Demonic Teacher. Listen to my words.”

“Lee Shin-jung, at your service, sir.”

“When you go down, contact the Senior Strategist and tell him to proceed with the plans I have told him ahead of time. That will be all.”

“Yes, sir.”

Everyone wanted to know what that was supposed to mean, but no one asked.

That was because the countenance of the Heavenly Demon was growing paler and paler with each word he spoke.

Cheon Ah-young could not help but notice and shouted in a trembling voice.

“Father! You don’t look well...!”

Her shout brought his attention to her.

“I am fine.”

Cheon Hwi waved his hands in a dismissive sign, but no one believed him.

He can't be fine, grit Woon-seong. His blood is so full of poison that it even melts the ground and he has a stab wound on top of that. I can't even imagine what kind of pain he's bearing right now.

Cheon Ah-young was thinking much the same thing. Her eyes sparkled with unshed tears. *Father...*

Cheon Hwi gazed at her for a long time. It was as if he was trying to etch her image into his mind, to remember her until eternity. The man’s eyes held a thousand different words, but he was unable to say anything other than, “You have done well.”

Either way, perhaps the emotion within his eyes told her everything.

Ah-young didn’t say anything else either, she didn’t know what to say.

Breaking the silence, Cheon Hwi spoke to Woon-seong.

“My apprentice.”

Cheon Hwi called out to Woon-seong, but he was still gazing at his daughter.

Woon-seong raised his head, then answered.

“Yes, Master.”

I believe you won't be jealous of this, my old Spear Master Master...,
Woon-seong sighed to himself. *This person is also my master.*

The Heavenly Demon had also taught and guided him. Through this battle, Woon-seong acknowledged Cheon Hwi as a true teacher.

After all, having multiple teachers was not taboo at all.

“That is right, my apprentice.”

Cheon Hwi called out to him again, and Woon-seong responded once more.

“Yes, Master.”

“It is good to hear you call me that way.”

Cheon Hwi finally tore his eyes away from Ah-young and turned towards Woon-seong. In spite of the sweat that now formed a sheen on his otherwise pallid face, he was smiling faintly.

“I shall do so more often from now on.”

‘From now on’, he says. How much longer do I have... Cheon Hwi could not help but close his eyes due to Woon-seong’s words. This pain he felt was proof that he was alive and he wanted to enjoy the ‘now on’.

But the Heavenly Demon knew that he did not have much time left. He knew his destiny.

Woon-seong obviously knew this too.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong saying ‘from now on’ meant that he wished for Cheon Hwi to live.

I’ve already lost one master to that poison.

Woon-seong desperately wished for a miracle within his heart. If there was a god out there, he was praying with all his might that it was a God of Life and Death who was listening.

If the First Heavenly Demon, the ancestor of all demonic practitioners, had really ascended as a Divine Being, then Woon-seong prayed he would protect his descendants once more.

Cheon Hwi was able to guess Woon-seong's thoughts, so he spoke in a warm voice. It was neither the despondent voice of king who had lost his crown nor the commanding voice of an emperor, more like a father speaking to a son.

Just a benevolent ruler speaking to someone he trusted...

"I see you have acquired the Divine Flame."

"I was simply lucky."

Cheon Hwi shook his head. Woon-seong's accomplishments were not something that could be explained with simple luck.

No Heavenly Demon in the history of the Cult had manifested and controlled the Divine Flame at such a young age.

Cheon Hwi smiled to himself.

I am confident that this child is capable of leading the Cult.

Soon though, his eyebrows furrowed just slightly.

But I still wonder what the bitter feelings I sense within him are... I hope they don't become a problem in the future... Unfortunately, it looks like I won't have a chance to see the outcomes myself...

Whether Woon-seong would be blessed or whether he would be burdened by his emotions was something that Cheon Hwi's body would not last long enough to see.

However! As a master, there are some things I can leave for my apprentice.

"My apprentice."

“Yes, Master.”

“There is something I need to give you, but this is not the proper place. Would you follow me?”

Instead of asking what it would be, Woon-seong immediately slung the White Night Spear over his shoulder and prepared to leave. “Do not hesitate to command your apprentice, Master.”

“It will not take long,” Cheon Hwi smiled and muttered to himself.

The first one to turn away was the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong followed closely behind.

The back of the Heavenly Demon walking ahead looked a little desolate.

Was it that Woon-seong would be left behind or that the Heavenly Demon had already left?

Somehow, the path forward only seemed lonely.

Woon-seong imperceptibly shook his head. *Master...*

At that moment, a single voice grabbed the attention of the Heavenly Demon and Woon-seong.

“F-Father...”

It was Cheon Ah-young.

“Father!”

When Ah-young shouted a second time, Cheon Hwi turned to look back at her.

The same went for Woon-seong. He could not help but notice that Ah-young was struggling to hold back her tears.

Soon, she could no longer hold them in and burst into tears.

The Heavenly Demon did not respond. Neither did Woon-seong.

Ah-young shouted loudly once more, uncaring of the way she must have looked.

“You will come back... right?”

Her father seemed to be walking a path that followed Heaven’s Will, one that would not allow him to return to her side.

Woon-seong felt the same way.

He was following behind Cheon Hwi, but somehow felt that the Heavenly Demon was walking along a different path.

It could not have been more different.

Cheon Hwi still did not respond, only smiled softly and turned away.

The place Cheon Hwi brought Woon-seong was the Peak of the Heavenly Demon’s Majesty.

It was not easy to climb the peak.

How many times had Cheon Hwi clenched his fist as he stumbled?

“Master, I’ll...”

Every time, Woon-seong ran up to the Heavenly Demon and tried to support him.

“No. It is okay. I am fine.”

And every time, the Heavenly Demon would grit his teeth and wave him away.

The Heavenly Demon ascended the Peak of the Heavenly Demon's Majesty on his own two feet.

Even though his wound was now bleeding and he was barely able to walk, he continued on.

He was exhausted, but he did not need anyone's help.

Even if it was the path to death, Cheon Hwi wanted to protect this last sense of pride as the Heavenly Demon.

Moreover, a teacher needing the help of his disciple?

As a teacher... as the Heavenly Demon, Cheon Hwi could not tolerate it.

“Ah. So there were scenes like this inside the Heavenly Mountains.”

It was Cheon Hwi who spoke, a man who had been climbing these mountains for decades now.

“I never noticed them when I passed by using movement arts. It is quite the view.”

To some, these words may have been taken as a bluff that protected his pride.

Was he truly admiring the view, or did he just need a break and was unwilling to say so?

Woon-seong did not care whether it was a bluff or not. For him, Cheon Hwi's words evoked only pride.

It makes me want to brag to the whole world... That this is my master. This man, who can stand like this even when poisoned and severely wounded, is my master.

Woon-seong reflected on himself as he stared at the back of the Heavenly Demon. Truly, he could see the image of Nok Yu-on in Cheon Hwi.

My former master's final moments were like this too.

Even when he was framed for learning treacherous demonic arts, and even when his body had already reached its limit because of poison, he never stopped preaching harmony in the face of dozens of weapons pointing at him!

People who had achieved a certain realm no longer hesitated to attain their wills and ideals.

It looks like I still have a lot to learn.

I may have become as powerful as my old master, but my mind is nowhere as mature as his.

I'm not even worthy of facing Master Cheon Hwi upfront, despite him currently being wounded.

Woon-seong closed his eyes and chased after Cheon Hwi once more.

He did not want to watch the Heavenly Demon staggering anymore.

It took them a relatively long time to climb up the peak and reach the Palace.

If it were Woon-seong by himself, it would have taken him less than an hour. Because Cheon Hwi walked ahead and Woon-seong followed, it took more than two hours this time.

“Sigh.”

For the first time, the Heavenly Demon was exhausted after climbing up the peak. He heaved a deep sigh, but soon stood straight.

Woon-seong wanted to run over and help him, but didn't.

The Heavenly Demon would have refused his help anyways.

Instead, Woon-seong captured the last moments of the Heavenly Demon to keep in his memories.

Like a fire bursting in its last moments, even his last moments suit his title as the Heavenly Demon.

So this is what it means to be the Heavenly Demon.

Prideful, honorable, and also lonely.

It was then that the Heavenly Demon spoke once more.

“We are almost there.”

Cheon Hwi did not turn around, but he was pretty sure that Woon-seong nodded.

They had come so far, there was not much further to go.

On the other hand, the place where they were headed was one Woon-seong was familiar with.

It was a place they used to practice at.

The Third Gate, the Polymorphic Combat Illusion.

It was only after entering the center of the stone chamber inside the gate that the Heavenly Demon stopped walking.

Standing at the center of the formation, Cheon Hwi turned to look at Woon-seong.

“You have talent. And although I do not know exactly what the source is, you have firm determination. As a martial artist, having talent and a goal means that you have virtually everything you need to to be strong.”

After a slight pause, he continued.

“But you are still young. You cannot help the fact that you are lacking the experience only built through time.”

Cheon Hwi observed the youth — the child — before him, one who was barely twenty years of age.

Truly, too young for the burdens he would soon be bearing.

“So, to make you the Heavenly Demon, I intend to give you all the experience I have built up until now. Come here and sit.”

When he finished speaking, he called Woon-seong over as he sat cross-legged in the middle of the room.

The last words that the Heavenly Demon spoke resounded in the ears of Woon-seong.

“That is why I brought you here.”

TN: i am in tears (π^{^^}π)

Chapter 86: Ominous Star (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 86 – Ominous Star (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

In the dwelling of King Jinseong [1].

Obviously, the man who lived here was King Jinseong, born Yi Yeok.

As the younger brother of the Emperor, he was practically the second most powerful man in the world.

Being a blood related sibling, King Jinseong was able to remain alive when all of his half-brothers were eliminated by the Emperor [2].

Perhaps it was because he was never greedy for power in the first place.

King Jinseong closed his eyes and slowly recalled the old days.

Ever since King Jinseong was a child, he had never desired the position of emperor and always said that he would be satisfied being a mere king. And just as he had hoped, when the current emperor ascended to the throne, Yi Yeok was immediately granted the position of a king.

But the title of ‘Emperor’s brother’ and ‘only surviving Imperial Prince’ brought power to his position.

Of course, Yi Yeok was never interested in that power, nor did he wield it.

What he wanted wasn't power, but a peaceful world.

Having such a noble character, it was only natural that only the righteous followed him.

His brother, the current emperor, showed violence when purging their other brothers. But thankfully, the Emperor was a man who showed the will to set up a proper world order.

And that's why people started giving me different names... Some called me a good-natured person. Some even went as far as to call me a hero...

Of course, I am still at fault for doing nothing when my brother purged everyone else.

But Brother had a good reason behind every one of them.

They were either crazy with women, or showed symptoms of insanity, or even showed bloodlust like a crazed murderer.

At least, I assumed the Emperor wasn't like that.

Sitting in an empty room, King Jinseong clenched his fists. *But it looks like it's about time I start making a move.*

Rumor had it that the Emperor had changed.

No, actually, those rumors were decades old.

And now, King Jinseong was witnessing the truth in those rumors himself.

In the past, I thought all of it was just an act. Acting incompetent to reel out the ambitious enemies hiding inside.

However, no one could go on acting so consistently for decades. Even if the act did continue, it shouldn't be enjoyable to keep up the facade.

The current emperor had gone mad.

The benevolent ruler inside him had become no more and he had become like those half-brothers he slayed with his own hands.

The madness, the bloodlust, the lustfulness... The Emperor showed signs of all of them.

It might have been alright if he had chosen one of the vices, but he showed signs of all three.

“It’s as though the half-brothers slayed by him have become vengeful ghosts and possessed parts of him...”

The Emperor had become a completely different person.

“Hmm.”

King Jinseong sat there and wanted to weep.

Now, it was just a matter of what to do.

To be honest... I know what I need to do.

Like my brother has done himself, I just need to draw this sword, slay him, and become emperor myself.

However, is that the right thing to do?

Should I stay loyal as a brother, or should I remove the mad emperor and save the Imperial Court from darkness?

“I can’t help but find myself ridiculous.”

King Jinseong, who had been considering his options in silence, suddenly said self-deprecatingly.

Even though I did feel pity when my half-brothers were killed one by one, I didn’t care too much about it.

And here I am deeply troubled because I'm facing the possibility of doing the same with my one hands.

“So this must be what selfishness looks like...”

Or maybe it's a sense of guilt about having to kill my own brother.

But either way, it doesn't change the fact that this is a difficult decision to make.

What should I do?

King Jinseong continued to sigh.

It was at that moment that someone entered the residence.

As someone who had practiced martial arts with mercenaries since childhood, King Jinseong recognized the person at once.

“You are here, Sage.”

‘Sage of Earth and Sky’ (天地揮思), Do Jin-myung.

Having a deep understanding of the earth and sky, Do Jin-myung was once a member of the martial society, but had ended up as one of King Jinseong's close associates.

Although he was now part of the government, his reputation still lived on in Murim.

That was why King Jinseong often called on Do Jin-myung when planning work that involved both the government and Murim.

Additionally, the Sage of Earth and Sky had mastered astronomy and astrological divination, allowing him to read the will of Heaven in the celestial skies. As someone who understood the movements of the stars, the Sage had helped King Jinseong many times.

“I am back, sir. Haha.”

When King Jinseong called, Do Jin-myung answered politely.

King Jinseong nodded.

“Report.”

King Jinseong had asked Do Jin-myung to look into the situation regarding the Emperor. Since the Sage had returned, it was obvious what his report was about.

At that, Do Jin-myung bowed and began to speak.

“Have you realized that an unfamiliar star has illuminated the whole Imperial Palace?”

“An unfamiliar star...”

If it were someone else talking about ‘unfamiliar stars’, King Jinseong might have thrown them out of the residence for speaking nonsense and going on tangents.

But the one speaking was Do Jin-myung, an expert in the stars.

There should have been no stars he could not read.

“It was a star emitting a wicked red light. The star representing His Majesty is being suppressed under its light and barely shines”

“Does that mean someone is suppressing the emperor and using his power?”

Do Jin-myung shook his head.

“His Majesty is the most powerful person in the Imperial Palace. There cannot be such a person.”

“If so, why has such a star appeared?”

Do Jin-myung hesitated.

“What I am about to tell you... is my conclusion after reading the stars myself and going through numerous ancient texts. I should rightfully report about it, but it’s not something I can talk about with ease.”

“Do now worry and continue.”

King Jinseong urged the man to speak of his findings. Letting out a long breath, Do Jin-myung spoke.

“Astronomy is my specialty, but I could not find out what that star is. So to find it, I dug through some texts. Amongst them, there were some texts related to the history of Murim. Since I went through the texts detailing the last 400 years, it was no small amount.”

“And what did you find about that star?”

Do Jin-myung nodded.

“According to the records of the Sky Chronicler, that star is one of misfortune. It shines bright whenever the Cult of the Inverted Sky prevails in this world.”

As Do Jin-myung had reported, the Sky Chronicler was a man who had lived near the end of the Late-Ancient Era, about 400 years ago. Talented in both astronomy and astrological divination, he had gained the name ‘Sky Chronicler’ and left detailed observations behind.

Do Jin-myung wished that he was better at divination, but he could not be considered lacking.

Since many of the extraordinary prophecies seen by the Sky Chronicler were passed onto the government, King Jinseong had also heard of him.

“I have heard of the Sky Chronicler before... But the Cult of the Inverted Sky... It’s not only unfamiliar to me, but it is also ominous.”

A name that included turning the sky upside down could not be more ominous.

Did they want to topple the reigning elite?

Or were they aiming to pull down even the Heavens?

“Yes. It is only natural to find such a name ominous. It is the name of those who have driven the Murim into chaos, and even plotted to take over the Imperial Court.”

King Jinseong gripped the armrest of the chair he was sitting on, causing it to splinter as his strength increased.

“And why is such an ominous star shining on top of the Imperial Palace? Are you telling me that these people of the Cult of the Inverted Sky are trying to suppress His Majesty and take over his power?”

“As I said before, His Majesty is the most powerful person in this palace.”

“...”

After finishing his report, Do Jin-myung swallowed. He lowered his head, as if hesitating to speak once more, then spoke in a low voice.

“But unfortunately, amongst the sorceries of the Cult of the Inverted Sky...”

“Their sorceries?”

King Jinseong’s eyebrows twitched and he immediately refocused on the conversation.

“There is a spell which takes over the bodies of others.”

Back in the Heavenly Mountains.

In an uninhabited area of the Cult, people were rushing about a forest that normally would have been peaceful.

“Where did it go?”

“We can’t lose it! We need to find its tracks!

Gwan Tae-ryang found a corpse leaning against the trunk of a tree and shouted.

“There’s a body here! It went this way!”

After the collapse of the Heavenly Demon, Woon-seong had been busy dealing with problems regarding legitimacy of leadership. Moreover, the Young Leader had been called into the Divine Palace and the Charred Dragon Unit was ordered on a mission.

Gwan Tae-ryang was temporarily appointed as the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit.

Gwan Tae-ryang was not as strong as Woon-seong, but he was still a Great Demon. That was enough to qualify as the captain of a Twelve Supporting Unit.

Passing by him, Sang In-hyo reminded, “Do not let your guard down. It’s no easy opponent.”

“I will keep that in mind.”

Gwan Tae-ryang tamped down on some of the excitement running through him after hearing these words.

There were two other people running alongside them.

It was the Divine Maiden Cheon Ah-young and another young woman, who had become the new captain of the White Ape Unit.

“When we find it, I’ll use my divine power to tie it down first. After that, you take care of it, Demonic Sword.”

“Understood,” nodded Sang In-hyo.

“Captains of the Charred Dragon Unit and White Ape Unit, work together to prevent it from fleeing.”

“Understood.”

The reason the quartet was wandering through the deep forest was because of the blood jiangshi that had fled from the Divine Maiden’s Palace.

“That thing is a monster that maintains itself through blood. We need to stop it before it creates any more casualties. It will continuously look for blood just to sustain its existence.”

It was clear that the demonic villagers would be targeted. Several victims had already been found.

At that time, Sang In-hyo, who had been running in the front, shouted loudly.

“I found it!”

Just as he said, the blood jiangshi was running a few meters ahead of them.

At that moment, Cheon Ah-young took out the Bell of the Heavenly Demon.

Ding!

The moment she rang the bell, the blood jiangshi stopped.

Of course, it was stronger than before due to its awakened instincts, so ringing the bell once was not enough.

But Cheon Ah-young still had energy to spare!

Daeng—

A powerful energy flowed out from the bell, travelling along the sound waves. Forming a rope, the energy flew towards the blood jiangshi and tied it in place.

“Screech!”

The blood jiangshi screeched and thrashed at the sound of the bell, but it had already been tied up.

Before it could do anything more, Sang In-hyo appeared with a sword in hand.

The only time a blood jiangshi should be feared was when it could move!

With the blood jiangshi incapacitated by the divine power, even Sang In-hyo, who was a Great Demon, was capable to killing it in one stroke.

“Haap!”

Despite only having one arm now, Sang In-hyo charged at the blood jiangshi and slashed downwards. As his sword arched down, it was covered in layers of blood-red qi, which was what gave him the title of ‘Demonic Sword of Layered Blood’.

Fwoom—

Sang In-hyo gathered all of his energy on the sword, forming ‘sword aura’. He was currently weakened by the imbalance to his body, but he still had enough strength to maintain a cutting force that nearly surpassed Great Demon-level.

Still...

Thwack—

It was enough to cut the blood jiangshi in half.

Despite having feasted on fresh blood, the final blood jiangshi was unable to maintain its form.

“Whew.”

Of course, the blade had also stopped moving because Sang In-hyo could no longer maintain the sword aura.

But he had done enough.

With its body cut into little quadrants, the blood jiangshi was unable to continue to exist.

“We finally got it...”

Seeing the corpse of blood jiangshi, Cheon Ah-young muttered to herself.

The final blood jiangshi was finally destroyed after ten full days of pursuit.

It also happened to be the tenth day since Woon-seong entered the Divine Palace with the Leader.

[1] King Jinseong, otherwise known as Grand Prince Jinseong or King Jungjong of Joseon . He would succeed his tyrannical half-brother, Yeonsan-gun, after a military coup.

[2] While not historically accurate, the novel seems to imply that King Jinseong and the Emperor are full siblings.

Chapter 87: Reformation (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 87 – Reformation (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

It's hot.

Energy emanated around Woon-seong.

The sensation of the energy surrounding his whole body made Woon-seong feel like a roast chicken.

This was because the energy surrounding Woon-seong originated from the true Divine Flame, fueled by both Woon-seong himself as well as Cheon Hwi.

Woon-seong could feel the energy flowing in from his back extending to the rest of his limbic system.

With every breath, an exhilarating sensation spread from his spine to his fingertips.

Through repeatedly cycling this energy through his body, Woon-seong was able to assimilate it and make it his own.

I must not rush this.

The time of my master. A time longer than my past and present lives combined.

And that amount of time represents the amount of Master's qi.

If I try to swallow this much qi at once, it will only backfire.

Even the best of delicacies will upset your stomach if you consume too much too quickly.

So Woon-seong did not rush.

Slowly and delicately he worked, like a spider spinning threads of silk.

The incoming force weaved through his meridians, scattering to every corner of his body, then wound back and tied together at his core.

It was slow work.

But it didn't end there.

Once a certain amount of threads had been gathered, the energy was redistributed into his limbs.

According to the universe's laws guarding chaos and evolution, a new sort of energy swirled around Woon-seong's body.

Woon-seong slowly refined the energy received from Cheon Hwi to suit himself.

Naturally, there was some loss of energy during the transfer and purification process, but there was nothing that could be done about it.

If he tried to immediately assimilate Cheon Hwi's qi, the foreign energy would clash with his own, wrecking his core and meridians.

Of course, it was natural that Woon-seong would look for ways to minimize losses during the process.

The loss rate is about 20%.

As he focused, Woon-seong coldly calculated the amount lost.

It is not a constant amount though... 15% at minimum, 25% at maximum.

*Although there's an average of a 20% loss, Master's qi is already powerful.
Then there's my own qi on top of that...*

*Even with some amount of loss, the total should add to an equivalent of
Master's.*

As Woon-seong came to that conclusion, a problem suddenly occurred to him.

Then what about Master?! What happens to him?

That was a question Cheon Hwi could not answer, as the Heavenly Demon's hands were placed on Woon-seong's back, transferring energy.

He has grown well, mused the Heavenly Demon.

Cheon Hwi was injecting his qi into Woon-seong's body while simultaneously using his qi to assess the youth's body.

As I inject my qi like this, I can finally feel this child's effort.

*His muscle density, pureness of qi, and composition of blood vessels... It's
clear that he has grown well as a martial artist.*

As a teacher, Cheon Hwi could not help but smile.

However, it's such a shame.

At the same time, he could not help but feel sorry.

Their master-disciple relationship could not be considered long.

At first, Woon-seong had not opened up to his new master. Now, Cheon Hwi could tell that his disciple had finally decided to open up.

But I cannot stay with you any longer...

Woon-seong.

You were like the adolescent son I always wanted.

Maybe I felt that way because you're the first apprentice I ever had... or will have.

Not that any of that matters anymore...

Once I finish transferring my qi, I'll no longer be a person of this world.

The more I transfer, the more I can feel the poison inside me trying to take over.

Cheon Hwi's lower half was already blackened with poison, the red handprint-like markings were also slowly covering the rest of his body. His skin had also lost most of its sheen, causing him to look pale as a corpse.

But that wasn't all.

Every now and then, the stab wound would also throb with pain.

I'm sorry that this is all this fool of a master can do for you.

Cheon Hwi continued to inject qi into Woon-seong, feeling sorry for his apprentice.

Suddenly, the strength of the poison crescendoed and he became dizzy from pain.

Cold sweat dripping down his face, Cheon Hwi grit his teeth.

I have to withstand...

With our qi connected, if I faint right now, it will become much more than my problem.

There's also a possibility that the poison may flow into him through my qi!

I must prevent that at all costs.

There's only one life that I'll let this god damned poison take away.

Woon-seong, go spread your wings in this world without regret.

Cheon Hwi's body was like a rotten old tree.

But funnily enough, Cheon Hwi couldn't help but feel ecstatic in such a situation.

Even though he was dying, his death would be the catalyst that pushed the powerhouse named Hyuk Woon-seong to new heights.

Woon-seong had the talent. And although Cheon Hwi didn't know the details, it was clear that his apprentice also had a goal.

If his dying body could become the nourishment to help Woon-seong grow into a great tree...

Woon-seong, become a tree that covers the Cult...

No, a tree that covers this whole world.

It doesn't matter what you do on top of that.

Fulfill your dreams through the Cult.

Those were the last thoughts that the Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon left in this world.

Or, perhaps they weren't.

During the last moments of consciousness, Cheon Hwi's voice flowed into Woon-seong's ears.

“My apprentice, please take care of Ah-young...”

His only regret was his daughter.

Now completely drained of energy, only a smile remained on Cheon Hwi's face.

Having found his peace, his soul left the body.

Woon-seong was ecstatic.

With each passing second, the decades of qi from Cheon Hwi had slowly changed into his own. Slowly, but clearly, this energy had built up in his body.

What if it was too much for his body to handle?

It wouldn't be easy to expand his dantian. However, the Woon-seong who practiced 'Heavenward Soul Earthen Body' could do it! Just this much stress on his meridians was still acceptable!

As his excitement mounted, a disconnect between his mind and body began to appear.

With a rapid build up of power, Woon-seong began to feel invincible. Not only that, he became intoxicated by this feeling.

While under this illusion that he was alone and unmatched under the Heavens, Cheon Hwi's last wishes suddenly flowed into his ears.

“My apprentice, please take care of Ah-young...”

The voice freed Woon-seong from his fantasy.

At the same time, Woon-seong quickly regained control over his consciousness and operated his qi.

That was a lucky escape, he could have been in dire straights.

He had almost been intoxicated by the sudden, rapid increase in his strength.

For martial artists, an increase in strength was more addictive than opioids.

Just as it was dangerous to be addicted to pain medication, it was definitely dangerous to be addicted to strength and power.

Woon-seong knew that, which was why he had always been disciplined in the use of his iron bracers.

This time, it was because he did not know his limits and continued to accept Cheon Hwi's qi that a disconnection between mind and body had been formed.

Fortunately, the qi transfer had ended. If he had been unlucky, an additional amount of qi would have caused him to explode on the spot.

Perhaps he would not have died, but his life as a martial artist would definitely have ended.

That cannot happen.

Woon-seong grit his teeth.

He still had work to do in this world.

Master... Even in the end, you saved this foolish apprentice.

And because of that, my goal has remained the same.

The poison that took the lives of my two masters is the same, unique one. There are not many who can use such a poison. The people who poisoned them must be the same, or at least share the same goal.

Therefore, the people who have killed my two masters are either the same person or from the same organization.

When he thought like that, Woon-seong naturally made another connection.

Jwa Do-gyul.

Woon-seong almost snarled.

He must also have some kind of connection with the poisoners. If not, there's no reason for the Martial Alliance to destroy the Spear Master Sect.

And if that's the case, it's more of a reason to get revenge.

Because it would mean that I lost both of my masters to the same poison. And that I was played around by the same mastermind like a damn fool!

Woon-seong's face was set with newfound determination.

Then, he once again began to assimilate Cheon Hwi's qi with his own. This time, he took extra care in order to not get carried away.

It was hard to fathom how much time passed with Woon-seong in this state.

Perhaps it had only been a few minutes, a few days, or even a few months.

The concept of time had become meaningless to the Woon-seong, who was busy trying to increase his qi sea so that it could hold all of his energy.

Even his consciousness had become clouded and only instinctively controlled his qi.

It was a slightly different kind of state than intoxication. Actually, it was more like sensory overload due to a sudden increase of qi.

Within this state, Woon-seong had forgotten himself.

It was very similar to a state of drunkenness.

States of intoxication split the brain from the body, logic from the senses. Some people were able to channel this separation of mind and body into

allowing the body to enter its most natural state, supposedly reaching enlightenment.

But in the case of Woon-seong, with tremendous stamina, it was like he had reached enlightenment without aligning his body with nature.

Of course, his body and senses followed after accordingly, so it didn't matter.

The results were the same.

Woon-seong suddenly felt the changes in his body.

Weng—

A strange sound came from within his body.

Just as his mind shook, so did the entire Polymorphic Combat Illusion he was still sitting within.

An abundance of energy gathered within Woon-seong's body.

Finally, the energy rushed through his meridians, reaching his Twin Veins like a tidal wave.

Unstoppable, it crashed forward.

Boom!

The Twin Veins were only half open, so a major collision happened as the wave of energy found itself blocked by a sturdy wall.

A shockwave spread through Woon-seong's body, causing him to fly off the ground and smash into a wall.

Fwoom—

It didn't happen only once.

One more time!

Kuang!

Something collapsed.

Once a crack appeared in the dam, the entire structure quickly collapsed under the pressure.

In the meantime, a river of strength flooded in.

The Twin Veins had been fully opened.

Another change began once all the veins in his body had been opened.

Wooduk—

Woon-seong's whole body began to twist. It was a disturbing sight as his muscles spasmed and loosened, causing his body to balloon and stretch.

In the process, Woon-seong's body was entirely reconstructed.

It became the most suitable body for a spearman, ever.

The length of his arm changed. It turned out to be the best arm length for swinging the spear.

The length of his torso also changed, as had his neck.

The muscles that he used to have became stronger and better defined. Even his hair changed, now entirely smooth and silky.

Not all the changes were large, but each made a clear difference in appearance or strength.

Body reformation (換骨奪胎).

Change the bones and strip the husk.

Ignite the soul to reforge the Heavens, govern the body to dictate the Earth.

The body art he had been practicing, ‘Heavenward Soul Earthen Body’ had finally shown its true power.

By setting the soul aflame, one can change the Heavens. By refining the body, one can control the Earth.

The Heavens and the Earth meet inside a human’s body.

And with that, the spirit of a god dwells within the body of a human.

A Semi-Divine Being!

One who was born a human, yet set his foot on the threshold of becoming a god.

Of course, even within the ranks of Semi-Divinity, there were differences in strength.

“If I have barely set foot... Master Cheon Hwi had fully entered the realm of a Semi-Divine Being,” Woon-seong mused as he pulled himself out of the rubble.

But what matters is that I have also stepped foot into this realm.

Now I have enough power.

With enough time and effort, there is no doubt that I can become as powerful as Master Cheon Hwi ever was.

“Watch me, Master...”

A fabulous light seemed to emanate from Woon-seong’s body, covering him in the glow of a sacred blessing.

“And the bloodbath I will bring to Murim.”

It’s been about six months. He might come out any moment.

The Senior Strategist was the only one who knew exactly what the Heavenly Demon's plan was.

After the first realization about the strength of the poison, Cheon Hwi had made this plan.

That was why Sang Gwan-chuk was also the only one who knew what was going on inside the Third Gate.

“Are you really going to execute this plan? Please, reconsider it one more time...”

“Thank you for worrying about me, Strategist. But I've already decided to do it this way. I'll leave the rest to you.”

The Leader...

The Strategist stopped thinking from there.

As they had planned, Cheon Hwi was no longer a person of this world.

Hmmm.

He exhaled a long, almost watery sigh, one unfitting for his steadfast temperament.

Sang Gwan-chuk was a man deeply loyal to Cheon Hwi. It was hard for him to let the Heavenly Demon go like this.

If he had been a little more capable, he could have prevented the poisoning.

If he had been a little more capable, he would have been able to find a solution.

But now, he could only feel sorry.

Leader...

Facing the Inner Garden, Sang Gwan-chuk slowly and solemnly bowed his head.

It was then that someone walked out.

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Chapter 88: Reformation (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 88 – Reformation (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

It was a long time before Woon-seong woke up from his trance-like state.

As he opened his eyes, a colorful flurry of light flashed through the realm.

It was very brief, of course.

The light disappeared in an instant.

The awakened Woon-seong examined himself and tried to guess how long it had been.

It's been at least four months, maybe six.

Woon-seong estimated the time it took to assimilate all of Cheon Hwi's energy.

Of course, his conjecture happened to be very accurate.

It was the fifth month since the assimilation had begun in earnest, about half a year after the Heavenly Demon had brought him to the Third Gate.

Woon-seong smiled slightly.

I finally achieved full body reformation.

I can feel it myself, just by moving my body.

The body reformation that was only half complete has now been fully completed.

It makes me feel like I can do anything.

Woon-seong shook his head lightly.

No, not yet.

It's too early to be so confident. This can easily become vanity. And vanity always brings painful mistakes.

On top of that, my body seems to only be 90% complete. I feel a slight sense that says that I'm not quite there yet.

So Woon-seong decided to be reasonably confident.

Of course, that had always been his nature.

Additionally, there was a regal atmosphere surrounding Woon-seong, a pressure that caused the floor and walls to shake and crumble.

The qi emitted from me is crushing my surroundings.

It must be evidence that I achieved the realm of a Semi-Divine Being.

Not wanting to destroy the Palace, Woon-seong reigned in his qi.

And if I take in my qi, it makes me seem like a normal person, as though I have never practiced martial arts my whole life.

It must mean that I can completely cage this power inside my body.

This is the realm of a Semi-Divine Being.

I have become a container that can hold power beyond a human being.

After that, Woon-seong slowly rose from the place where he had been cultivating.

He turned his head to the side.

There was the corpse of Cheon Hwi, which had dried like the husk of an old tree.

There was a teacher who had handed over all of his strength to Woon-seong and guarded him until his last breath.

Rather than shed tears in front of Cheon Hwi, Woon-seong knelt so that his forehead hit the floor.

Master, please take the bow of this foolish apprentice again.

Once, twice, three times...

Soon Woon-seong had bowed nine times in total.

He had performed the three kneelings and nine kowtows, acknowledging Cheon Hwi as his master once more.

Afterwards, Woon-seong slipped off the outer robe that he had been wearing. With a careful hand, he wrapped the body with the cloth.

This poison loses its edge the moment the host dies.

Woon-seong had lost two masters to this poison.

It could be said that other than the makers and users, Woon-seong was probably the most knowledgeable about this specific poison in the world.

A poison that gnaws upon qi and innate qi.

If it's a poison that feasts off something, it also means that it dies the moment it no longer has anything to eat off of.

Now that there was nothing left within Cheon Hwi's body, the poison would have also been eliminated.

Woon-seong reached out and picked the body up, gently hugging it close to his chest.

Was it because the body had dehydrated? Or maybe because the soul had left the body?

Either way, Cheon Hwi's body felt too light.

Whew.

Woon-seong slowly walked out of the Third Gate, whose walls and ceilings were still mostly intact.

Soon, he walked out of the Inner Garden and headed to the outer circle.

Creak—

As soon as he walked out into the open, a familiar face waited for him.

“Strategist.”

Woon-seong called out to him first.

The Strategist approached Woon-seong and bowed his head, “Leader.”

Then he looked up and saw the body of Cheon Hwi.

“I’m sorry... He has already passed away.”

“Is that so... I’ve been expecting it and preparing for it, but...”

“We just need to let go of the dead, since the living should live on.”

However...

“But before that, we need to prepare for one thing. Prepare for a funeral.”

“I’ll prepare the grandest of funerals.”

Cheon Hwi, the living god of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, had passed.

There needed to be a final ritual, allowing him to return to the Earth and Heavens.

Woon-seong nodded.

“The enthronement will take place about a month after the funeral.”

“Yes, sir. And there was something the Leader had left for me.” Sang Gwan-chuk took a small book out of his sleeves and respectfully handed it over. “He had ordered me to pass it to you the day you came out.”

Woon-seong titled his head, but accepted the book.

‘Rare World Chapter’.

The Final Connection to the ‘Dark Flower Red Heart’.

The Dark Flower manifested a Red Heart and achieved a ‘rare world’ through the Flame (暗花紅心通炎橫世).

The true name of the final chapter of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon! The 10% I was missing was because of this.

As soon as Woon-seong read the title, he realized that this had been what he was lacking.

It was only then that he realized that he had truly become the new god of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Cheon Hwi’s funeral was conducted as a divine funeral, the highest order possible in the Cult.

It was a ceremony fit for the journey of a god who dwelled in this world returning to the Heavens.

During the ceremony, Cheon Ah-young could not restrain herself and broke into tears.

It was because her bad premonition had come true in the end. Her father truly had been walking down the path of no return.

Of course, Cheon Ah-young was not the only one who had tears in their eyes.

The members of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon were thrown into a deep sadness.

Though the demonic mourned for their Leader, the funeral eventually ended.

Soon, it was only two weeks before Woon-seong's enthronement.

Sitting alone under the light of the approaching full moon, Woon-seong picked up the Rare World Chapter.

The pages were crisp, as if the book had just been made.

“Woon-seong. There are a few things you need to know before I leave the Rare World Chapter to you. The Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon is traditionally not passed down as a text like this, but is passed down verbally from the Cult Leader to the Young Leader. Unless there's a special reason, there is no need to leave a text like this. But that also means a text can be made if there is a special reason. Just like the case of me and you, who is reading this right now.”

Woon-seong swept over the pages with his eyes closed, using his consciousness to read instead.

It was said that writing was a window that showed the result of a scholar's cultivation.

It wasn't much different for a martial artist.

I can feel a vigorous spirit from Master's words.

Master Cheon Hwi's spirit can still be felt within his writings.

Even though he had been weakened by poison, the true unyielding nature of the former Heavenly Demon appeared in the ink.

“I still have a long way to go.”

Although I'm in the realm of a Semi-Divine Being, I don't think I can show the same splendor as Master Cheon Hwi.

Maybe it will be a bit different if I learn some of the Rare World Chapter?

Looking for the answer to that question, Woon-seong continued to read.

The Rare World Chapter.

The most important portion of the Final Chapter of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon was about controlling the Divine Flame.

To the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the Divine Flame was the symbol of god itself.

Woon-seong happened to learn how to use the Divine Flame through the records of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon.

However, that didn't mean he had nothing to learn from the Rare World Chapter.

If the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon taught him how to manifest the Divine Flame and keep it under control, the Rare World Chapter showed him how to make it usable in combat.

The ‘Ruling Step of the Heavenly Demon’ (天魔君臨步), the footwork belonging solely to the Heavenly Demon.

The ‘Palm of the Heavenly Demon’ (天魔神掌).

There were numerous skills that drew out the strength of the Divine Flame recorded in the final chapter.

Woon-seong engraved each and every skill into his mind.

How to optimize his muscles, how to move his body, how to handle qi.

He did not forget anything.

Of course, it wasn't easy.

It only makes sense considering the Divine Art is one of the oldest and most powerful martial arts in history... But it's difficult to understand it only through reading. It's hard to imagine how difficult it would be to learn physically.

But ever since I became a Semi-Divine Being, my knowledge as a martial artist has also become vast.

The many theories and skills I have known have all combined into a martial theorem and become a large sea of knowledge.

Woon-seong decided to call it his martial sea.

Literally, a sea of martial knowledge.

Even the highest cliffs of martial knowledge will crumble, little by little, if battered by the waves of my martial sea.

Thanks to that, it only took ten days for Woon-seong to understand all of the skills written in the final chapter.

There was some other information that might have been useful for other Heavenly Demons, like calculating lifespan or consolidating a perfect foundation.

But that was basically useless for Hyuk Woon-seong, whose foundation was based on the Unrecorded's Tempered True Blossom and was barely in his early twenties.

It's over.

Once Woon-seong had read through all the pages, he picked the book up.

Fwoom—

With just a thought, the book burst into flames.

As one of the few legacies left behind by my master, I would love to keep this... But I shouldn't.

The Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon is not meant to be inherited through texts. That's the unspoken rule passed down by the generations of Heavenly Demons.

As the next Heavenly Demon, I cannot destroy this rule because of my personal feelings.

Woon-seong stared at the copy of the Rare World Chapter, which was now a pile of ashes.

Looking out the window, he could not help but notice the view outside.

So it's happening soon...

Since his rebirth into the Demonic Cult, Woon-seong had been eager to become the Heavenly Demon.

But now, he somehow felt bitter.

In the corner of my heart, I feel lonely and stifled.

When he first set his goal all those years ago, he had not expected this situation. *I didn't become the Heavenly Demon to feel such emotions.*

Woon-seong could only smile bitterly.

At that moment, he felt a presence beyond the door.

“Come in.”

Woon-seong didn't even bother verifying the person.

The door opened and the Senior Strategist walked inside.

I don't consider myself a rookie in hiding my presence..., mused Sang Gwan-chuk. But it looks like he has successfully entered the realm of a Semi-Divine Being.

Even before the energy transfer, Woon-seong had been adept at distinguishing people based on their qi presences. Now that he had reached a new level of cultivation, even the Ten Demonic Masters were unable to hide from him.

Woon-seong naturally asked the elder why he was here.

“What is it?”

“I'm here with a report.”

Woon-seong nodded, motioning for the Senior Strategist to sit with him.

“A report...”

“It was something the former leader had commanded. It has to do with pursuing the man who fled on the day of the attack on the Divine Palace.”

These words caused a glint to flash through Woon-seong's eyes.

The Strategist felt his skin prickle as flames danced in the new Cult Leader's eyes.

Those were flames of anger.

The man who controlled Shadow, a member of the Unrecorded Demonic Group, and left an irreversible wound on the Heavenly Demon's body!

The man who hastened the Heavenly Demon's death!

The man full of mysteries!

It was only natural for Woon-seong to emanate anger and killing intent.

“Did you catch him?”

“We searched every nook and cranny of Mount Heaven, but it looks like he has already escaped.”

“That’s a shame.”

Woon-seong chewed on his lips, sinking into thought.

He was our best chance at finding out who was behind all this... It looks like we just lost a major clue.

Wait... it's not all lost.

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

In my previous life, Master Nok Yu seemed to have a clue of who was behind this.

If the one behind Jwa Do-gyul, who killed Master Nok Yu, is the same one behind those who killed Master Cheon Hwi... I might find the answer there.

I need to go to the Secret Vault of the Spear Master Sect in Gansu and see if Master Nok Yu left something there.

But before that...

“Search one more time with additional manpower, just in case.”

“Understood.”

There was nothing wrong with one more search.

Chapter 89: A Visitor From The Empire (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 89 – A Visitor from the Empire (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The enthronement took place five days later.

Hyuk Woon-seong's coronation was in no means grand.

Only the Ten Demonic Masters, the Divine Maiden, and a few chosen Demonic Kings and Great Demons participated.

Before Cheon Hwi had brought Woon-seong inside the Divine Palace, he had asked Lee Shin-jung to pass on a message to the Senior Strategist.

Of course, the message had been 'follow the plan', but that was enough.

Sang Gwan-chuk knew what the plan was.

Build a foundation so that Woon-seong may peacefully inherit the position of Heavenly Demon.

Although about half the Demonic Masters had friendly relations with Woon-seong, and the other half were either neutral or had pledged allegiance after Joo Moon-baek died, Woon-seong's following within the Cult was still considerably weak.

That made sense.

Woon-seong was not a prestigious disciple that was brought up inside the Cult.

He was merely an outstanding talent from the Cave of Latent Demons — who knew who he was before that.

Moreover, the time Woon-seong spent as the Young Leader was also short, making it hard for him to build enough power.

In fact, the biggest force behind Woon-seong was currently the ordinary cultists, not the powerful elite.

Woon-seong, who had started off as the lowest of the low in the Cave of Latent Demons, was now the symbol of hope for the commoners.

But that heroism would not hold for the elite.

For those who had not seen Woon-seong in action, the youth was just lucky enough to be at the right place at the right time.

The plan of Cheon Hwi and Sang Gwan-chuk was to create a powerful backer for Woon-seong within this division.

Of course, it wasn't easy.

But it wasn't that hard either.

Like mentioned earlier, half of the Demonic Masters had already pledged allegiance to Woon-seong.

Woon-seong had barely met any of the Demonic Kings, but he received full support from the Charred Dragon Unit and the White Ape Unit.

Moreover, Woon-seong had unexpectedly been able to receive the support of the Unrecorded Demonic Group.

Although they were unrecorded, they were still very influential within the Cult.

Thus the Senior Strategist and Lee Shin-jung refined Woon-seong's foundation within the Cult.

This plan continued until the moment Woon-seong stepped out of the Inner Garden.

Thanks to their hard work, more and more supporters of Woon-seong began to appear.

Amongst them, Woon-seong ascended to his throne.

It was the day the Heavenly Demon, the god of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, rose to his throne...

But it was restrained due to the former Heavenly Demon's funeral, which had ended not long ago.

Still, Woon-seong was the new Heavenly Demon.

That was an undeniable fact.

As proof of that, Woon-seong was now sitting where Cheon Hwi had always sat.

Looking down from the highest level in the Palace...

During the beginning of this new era, the Ten Demonic Masters — which was now the Eight Demonic Masters — were showing either of two emotions.

Out of all of them, the one who seemed to be the most proud and triumphant was Koo Jong-byuk, the Wind Demon Fist King.

With the help of the medical division, he attended the enthronement fully healed. And as a man who fought side-by-side with the new Leader, he was naturally filled with pride.

The three Demonic masters who once sided with Joo Moon-baek each offered treasures and unique items as a sign of apology.

Woon-seong had no intention of blaming them. Though they had chosen the opposing side, they had eventually surrendered and asked to be punished for their sins.

And as a result, Woon-seong asked them to lay low for a while.

He also added one condition.

I'm sure they will follow this condition.

“Whenever I ask for it, would you promise that you will do a favor for me, no matter what it is?”

“Of course, Leader! How can we possibly refuse to do so!”

Woon-seong smiled.

Maybe he looked a little deranged, since the three Demonic Masters seemed to freeze and tremble.

Their expressions were clear to Woon-seong, as he was looking down at them.

Granting them some small mercies, he decided to move on.

“For now, I shall no longer talk about the past.”

‘Fow now’, he says..., grumbled one of the Demonic Masters.

The new Leader would not talk about it for now, but he would definitely be bringing up their unsatisfactory pasts the moment it was useful.

None of the people present did not understand the implications of those words.

Even the Fist King, who was not used to using his head, knew that much.
[TN: Ayo, burn]

However, the three Demonic Masters could only bow their heads because that was the new Leader.

Of course, the threat was not the only reason behind their deference.

Hmm... The force of the new Leader...

Hah. So he has already gone beyond Transcendence at such a young age.

It was because of the overwhelming force coming from Woon-seong's body, which crushed his surroundings.

It was not a conscious show of power.

Woon-seong had reached a level where the moment his mind decided on something, his qi would have already responded to that will.

The new Leader in front of us is no longer the same man as the Young Leader we once knew. We can no longer find the remains of the brat who was barely at Transcendence.

The Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong... How far did you go? Is this the realm of a Semi-Divine Being...? From the side, Ah-young could not help but comment within her heart.

Woon-seong had stepped into the threshold of the gods.

He's proven himself worthy as the new god of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“Now then, we'll start the regular meeting.”

All those Demonic Masters bowed their heads, including the Senior Strategist. Of course, so did the Demonic Kings and Great Demons standing beyond.

The regular meetings took place once a month.

Unlike other meetings, these were mandatory, even for Demonic Masters.

Each regular meeting determined the operation of the Demonic Cult for the next month.

This was the first regular meeting since Woon-seong's enthronement.

"I shall present agendas that need to be taken care of."

The Senior Strategist listed a whole number of things, including major issues that needed to be dealt with both inside and outside the Cult.

Woon-seong sat there and listened. None of what the Strategist was saying was unimportant.

"And each branch of the Cult will be informed of the appointment of the new leader via carrier pigeon. I doubt there will be any opposition."

Woon-seong nodded. "Proceed quietly as we are still in the middle of the funeral."

The Strategist bowed his head. All of a sudden, he remembered one more thing.

"Also..."

"Hmm?"

Words flowed from the Strategist's mouth and Woon-seong paid close attention.

"I'm sure everyone gathered here knows, but conquering Zhongyuan has always been our Cult's greatest ambition. Originally, our Cult was built by

those who fled from Zhongyuan after being unjustly framed by those in Murim. The First Heavenly Demon, the Founder of our Cult, heavily emphasized this as a shared dream. Of course, the Cult has weathered many hardships because of it and we have never been successful. Everyone in this place has learned the same history — the history of our ancestors who came here after being unjustly framed. Of course, we can't say that *everyone* was unjustly framed because there truly are treacherous beings among us demonic practitioners.”

Listening, Woon-seong nodded to himself.

“However, most of us cult members are not like that. They — we — are normal people who farmed and cultivated the harsh lands of the Heavenly Mountains. And I beg our Leader to fulfill the oldest wish of our members.”

Eventually, the Senior Strategist turned his attention back to Woon-seong, seeking his response.

So in short, he's asking what we're going to do about Zhongyuan and it's Martial Alliance.

As a matter of fact, Woon-seong did have an answer.

This reminds me of what Master Nok Yu told me long ago.

“The Demonic side has their own story.”

How interesting that Woon-seong would come to live that story.

Woon-seong's answer was already a given.

However, he could not quickly make a decision.

“How was Master?”

The Senior Strategist closed his eyes for a moment.

“Our former leader was preparing to conquer Zhongyuan. However, conducting such a campaign was not an option when internal affairs had yet

to be resolved. After all, Zhongyuan is no easy target.”

Woon-seong nodded.

That wasn’t wrong.

“However, we have already purged Joo Moon-baek, who was conspiring within the Cult. It’s safe to say we took care of our internal matters.”

“Ah!”

“Ooh!”

The possibility of war was the last thing on the agenda for the regular meeting.

Woon-seong slowly got up from his throne and looked down at the practitioners below.

“I also agree with the former leader.”

Cheering broke out amongst the crowd.

Naturally, the Cult had also been founded on the grounds of conquest, as the scarce lands of Xinjiang only provoked the aggressive nature of the demonic.

Among them, the Fist King clenched his fists and looked forward to battle.

“However!”

Woon-seong silenced them.

“Now is not the time! Build up your strength and hone your skills! Prepare yourself to bring hell to Zhongyuan!”

There was a reason behind Woon-seong’s words.

Obviously, the Strategist understood it well. *He's telling us to properly prepare for the upcoming war.*

Weapons, soldiers, supplies, tactics and strategy.

“We'll need to increase and reform our combat units. It's not just the Twelve Supporting Units. We'll need to systematically manage the other units too. I assume you understand my words.”

All of the practitioners bowed their heads.

“Yes, Lord!”

After saying his piece, Woon-seong left everything else to the Strategist.

As he was leaving, he suddenly heard a message.

— *Flower of the Dark Night reporting, Lord. Someone is making a fuss at the entrance of the Heavenly Mountain. He claims that he must meet the Leader. What should I do?*

There was a crowd of people gathered, swords pointed towards a certain direction.

There were a lot of them, though most of them could not be considered strong.

But with numbers you can overcome skill and power, so it was not a group of people easily ignored.

That was common sense for ordinary practitioners of Murim.

Did the person standing in front of them have no common sense?

“Oh my. What is all this?”

The man chuckled to himself.

“I simply asked for a meeting with the Leader, not a band of demonic practitioners. From Demonic Soldiers to Demonic Generals, this is quite the bunch.”

“You stupid old fart. Is the Leader someone you can meet just because you want to?”

The old man’s words made one of the Demonic Generals infuriated and he rushed forward.

A swift and unprecedented move flashed, proving that the Demonic General was top notch!

In a single movement, the Demonic General had dashed out and swung his sword, aiming straight at the old man’s head.

“Haha!”

Surprisingly, the old man laughed.

At the same time, the old man used a staff to keep the sword at bay.

Clang—

Half the sword flew into the air, landing on the ground a few metres away.

The Demonic General, now missing half a blade, stood there dumbfounded.
He broke the steel sword with a wooden staff! How?!

The Demonic General wasn’t given any time to think, as the elderly man danced with his staff and smacked him here and there.

“U-Ugh!”

In one fell swoop, the Demonic General had collapsed onto the floor spitting blood.

A clean, fast victory.

All the practitioners gathered realized that the old man was much stronger than they previously thought.

“Hmm. For a second, I almost thought you were the leader, judging by how confident you were... But I doubt you’re even a guard dog.”

Flames of anger flashed through the eyes of the crowd.

That man had just walked to the entrance of their Cult and provoked them!

They were indignant, knowing that they could not defeat the man before them, but unwilling to back down from such a taunt.

It was at that moment that Sang In-hyo, who had rushed over from the Palace, arrived.

“What is going on?”

Sang In-hyo could be considered a direct superior to the men gathered in the crowd. Hoping to resolve the conflict quickly, he met the eyes of the old man.

Formidable skills and an aged face... Holding a red pinewood staff in his hand.

With a quick glance, Sang In-hyo was able to guess the old man’s identity, though they had never met before.

“You’re... the Mysterious Old Man!”

“Call me a sage, you young brat.”

The old man was sometimes known as the ‘Mysterious Old Man’, but preferred to be known as the ‘Sage of Earth and Sky’.

It was unknown why such a figure had appeared in the Cult.

Sang In-hyo could not guarantee anything when faced with such an opponent. Still, he reached for his sword.

“And what brings you here?”

“Oh?”

The Sage found the overall situation a bit amusing, but he did not like Sang In-hyo’s attitude.

Groaning, he took something out of his sleeves and threw it at Sang In-hyo.

An assassination weapon?

No.

It was a scroll which read:

“The Sage of Sky and Earth comes as the messenger of King Jinseong and wishes to meet the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

Chapter 90: A Visitor From The Empire (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 90 – A Visitor from the Empire (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

At the doorsteps of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, an old man caused a fuss, wanting to meet the leader.

This was a strange event that had never happened in the history of the Cult.

For this reason, none of the demonic practitioners left even after the regular meeting had concluded.

Rather, they were waiting.

The Heavenly Demon was not a being that anyone could simply request to meet.

What kind of man would dare ask to meet the god of the Cult? How dare you make such a fuss in order to get what you want!

If the Heavenly Demon wanted to meet you, then he would meet you. If he didn't, how dare you disgrace us with your presence!

After hearing the news, the followers of the Cult could not help but show hostility towards this blasphemous man.

Sitting on his throne, Woon-seong calmly closed his eyes.

In order to silence the commotion, Sang In-hyo had been dispatched. By now, he had already reported the circumstances.

“Sage of Earth and Sky.”

Also known as the ‘Mysterious Old Man of Scattering Age’.

I never met him, but I’ve heard of him several times. A high level martial artist comparable to my previous Spear Master Sect master.

If so, he should easily be one of the top 20 martial artists in Zhongyuan.

He’s also famous for his personality.

“An oddball who lives an exceptionally free life... I guess the rumors were true. Only an old freak would start such a fuss at the doorsteps of our Cult.”

No, how many people would have found the entrance to the Cult in the first place?

No sane person would do that.

The entrance to the Heavenly Mountain was concealed by special formations, which was why the cultivators nearby had been immediately alerted of an intruder.

Woon-seong’s musings about the Sage’s weird personality slowly disappeared.

Only one thought remained.

“Why does the messenger of King Jinseong want to meet me?” Woon-seong could not help but ask himself.

Woon-seong did not particularly care how the Sage had broken in.

More importantly, King Jinseong was a relative of the Emperor.

As the ‘Sage of Earth and Sky’, or as the messenger of King Jinseong, there was no reason for the old man to come.

While small altercations here and there were inevitable, despite the vigilance of both sides, each group tended to leave the other alone.

That was true of the Martial Alliance and the Emperor’s government.

The Cult was no exception.

The Demonic wished to conquer the Central Plains, but they did not wish for the mobilization of thousands of imperial troops.

No matter how grand a dream was, the price of war was steep.

Therefore, even if there was a war, the battlefield only contained Murim.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon had a policy of protecting ordinary civilians. This was not just propaganda to spread their doctrines, but a move to gain public support.

Thus, in the view of the Emperor and government officials, the Demonic Cult would not be different from any other martial sect or religious group.

But now, the messenger of King Jinseong had arrived.

Why?

As Woon-seong continued to think, the Sage approached from the entrance.

Looking at him, Woon-seong briefly nodded to himself, “Let’s hear it.”

“Haha. This is my first time in the Demonic Cult. So this is what the Divine Palace looks like.”

The rumors of Sage Do Jin-myung being a bit insane were not unfounded.

Just as he had proven them true by making a commotion at the entrance, his personality did not change even after stepping foot into the palace.

Seeing that, the Demonic Kings and Great Demons gathered revealed their infuriated expressions. Some of them could not help but growl, cursing him under their breaths.

The Sage ignored them with a single snort.

However, there were also those who he could not ignore, no matter what names he called them.

The Demonic Masters..., mumbled Do Jin-myung.

The Sage stopped walking once he got to the center of the palace.

The Demonic Masters flanked the sides of the throne.

If the Sage continued to walk forward, he would eventually reach the throne of the young man who was the new Heavenly Demon.

But to do that, the Sage would have to cross the Demonic Masters.

As mainly Absolute-realm masters, the Demonic Masters wielded fame and strength equivalent to his own.

With eight of them present, their strength was terrifying.

The Sage of Earth and Sky stopped walking forward.

He had come as the messenger of King Jinseong, not to fight some demonic cultivators.

Seeing that he had stopped walking, the demonic cultivators relaxed slightly. As long as he made a passable greeting to their leader, then their impressions of him would not be trash.

Thanks to that, Do Jin-myung was able to safely walk before Woon-seong and lowered his head slightly in greeting.

Although the Sage had come as the King's messenger and the man before him was much younger, said young man was the Heavenly Demon.

A minimum of courtesy was required.

Moreover, Do Jin-myung had come as a messenger not as the ‘Sage of Earth and Sky’.

There was a need to help the Leader save face.

And he really didn’t have any bad intentions.

“I present myself to the Leader of the Demonic Cult.”

Seeing the calculated greeting, Woon-seong immediately got to the point after lightly nodding his head.

It wasn’t like he and the Sage were friends anyways, why should they exchange pleasantries?

“What is the messenger of King Jinseong doing in our Cult?”

Do Jin-myung trembled slightly, not thinking that the Heavenly Demon would get to business so quickly.

Of course, the panic was only for a moment.

He cleared his throat.

“Ahem. Before we get to the point...”

The Sage looked around.

There were eight Demonic Masters.

The fifty Demonic Kings and then the hundreds of Great Demons.

Within the Divine Palace, there were more than three hundred people.

Even though the Sage had confidence in his skills, there were just too many people.

“I wish to speak in private...”

The story was not appropriate to be told in front of so many people.

Regardless of the distance, the demonic practitioners were still capable of hearing his words.

The Demonic Masters glared at the Sage, but the decision was for the Heavenly Demon to make.

And soon...

“Everyone except the Sage and the Strategist, leave. I will conclude the regular meeting.”

Woon-seong had made his decision.

After all the people had left, the interior of the palace was quiet.

There was only Woon-seong, Sang Gwan-chuk, and the Sage.

So that's the Flower of the Dark Night, the direct guards of the leader... I see..., the Sage noticed.

“They are taught to never hear or speak of anything. So, do not worry about them.”

Loyalty towards only the Heavenly Demon was taught to the Dark Flower candidates from a young age. Thus, all Dark Flowers had infinite trust and loyalty towards whoever sat upon the Heavenly Demon's throne.

The Sage glanced at the young man in front of him.

So this man is the Heavenly Demon. I feel a wall that I cannot possibly fathom.

I never found the Demonic Kings of the Cult to be a huge threat... But I'm feeling such a wall from a young man who is probably barely in his twenties. When was the last time I felt such a feeling...

Suddenly, a name popped into his mind. A feeling almost forgotten had been remembered.

It's almost like... The 'Twin Stars'?!

I felt a similar sensation when I met those two.

Of course, I can't possibly measure who is more powerful...

In a vague sense, it seemed that the Twin Stars were probably stronger.

However, this young man had to be viewed differently. Sometimes, age and potential were more important than absolute strength.

This man is barely in his twenties. Even the Twin Stars must never have achieved such a feat.

Maybe Bodhidharma [1], the Founder of the Shaolin, or Zhang Sanfeng [2], the Legend of the Wudang Sect, might have been like this.

That's why the Sage started to speak.

"I heard that the Cult was blessed with a new leader, but I never imagined him to be such a young man."

Woon-seong's response was blunt.

"I assume you haven't come this far to speak such trivial words."

Woon-seong had many questions revolving around his mind right now, beginning with why the Sage was here in the first place.

Maybe it was the significance of the message, or maybe it was Woon-seong's sharp voice, but the Sage got to the point.

"I am here to ask the Demonic Cult for cooperation."

"You want to cooperate with our Cult? Is that a request from King Jinseong?"

It was the Senior Strategist who responded.

So this man is Sang Gwan-chuk, the Senior Strategist of the Cult. The Sage had heard rumors about the man. Considering the weight of the matter, it makes sense that he is here.

“That is correct.”

The Sage pulled a scroll out of his sleeves. It was the very scroll he had shown to Sang In-hyo.

“This is a message written by King Jinseong himself.”

The scroll was handed to the Strategist.

Sang Gwan-chuk glanced at Woon-seong. It was an unspoken question asking whether he could read it first.

Woon-seong nodded.

Without hesitating anymore, the Strategist unfurled the scroll and quickly read the contents.

As his eyes scanned the words, he paled.

Finally, having read everything, he shouted, “Are you suggesting that we commit treason? What do you mean ‘drag down the Emperor’?”

Ignoring the Strategist’s outburst, the Sage began to explain.

“Amongst the tricks of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, there is one which snatches the body of others. I don’t know how many times I’ve reconsidered presenting this fact to King Jinseong. I may be known to be somewhat eccentric, but can I easily tell him the the Emperor, his own brother, is an imposter? And after I finally made the difficult decision to tell him, this is what he said: Those words... Are you sure of them?”

Could Do Jin-myung be responsible for the consequences of those words?

What could Do Jin-myung do when asked that?

“So I have presented all the records and evidence against the Cult of the Inverted Sky I had gathered until then. King Jinseong carefully examined the records for days and nights. And he finally came to a conclusion. The conclusion is that a human-possessing art does indeed exist in the Cult of the Inverted Sky and that the sky above the Imperial Palace holds an ominous star, representing the Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

But that was not all.

Then the question arose: Had the Inverted Sky really possessed the Emperor’s body?

It took six months of observation to figure out.

King Jinseong risked his life to travel in and out of the castle, personally interacting with the emperor and court officials.

“During those six months, King Jinseong became confident that the current emperor is not his brother.

The appearance of the two was the same, but they were completely different beings.

The old man took a breath.

“But there is even more.”

While King Jinseong was observing the emperor, Do Jin-myung researched the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

Very secretly, since he did not want to get caught by the Inverted Sky.

“As a result, I have found at that the Cult of the Inverted Sky was conspiring not only in the Imperial Court, but also within Murim.”

At these words, Woon-seong’s eyes widened marginally from shock.

“The Cult of the Inverted Sky has already planted deep roots within the Martial Alliance of Zhongyuan... To the point that it’s hard to say that Zhongyuan truly belongs to the Martial Alliance. Would you believe it if I said that many important figures of the Martial Alliance are part of the Cult of the Inverted Sky?”

Woon-seong did not answer.

If the Sage had asked anyone else, they probably would not have believed those words so easily. Woon-seong, as the survivor of the framed Spear Master Sect, could.

Still, he remained silent.

Do Jin-myung ground his teeth in frustration. From the first time he heard of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, he disliked them. Those people were different from the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. Unlike the arguably noble Demonic Cult, the Inverted Sky were willing to slaughter the innocent without hesitation.

What would happen to the world if those lunatics took hold of not only the Imperial Court but also Kangho?

What should be done then?

King Jinseong and Do Jin-myung pondered over this matter for a long time before reaching a conclusion.

They needed to get help from somewhere else.

The Sage kept speaking.

“The problem of the Imperial Court must be taken care of by King Jinseong, a member of the Imperial Court. The problems within Murim should be solved by borrowing the assistance of another martial group.”

With that conclusion, there was only one option.

“The Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the only independent martial group that can possibly go up against the Martial Alliance.”

In order to succeed, King Jinseong had to combine forces with the Demonic Cult.

“That way we purge the vile forces of the Cult of the Inverted Sky from Zhongyuan, and drag down the despicable body snatcher who sits on the throne of the empire!”

That was the reason why ‘Sage of Earth and Sky’ Do Jin-myung had travelled all the way to the Heavenly Mountains.

The Sage of Earth and Sky had finished explaining his reasoning.

And what about Woon-seong who had listened to the entire thing?

The new Heavenly Demon said,

“And why should we do that?”

[1] Bodhidharma is credited as the founder of the martial arts at the Shaolin Temple in the Henan Province.

[2] Zhang Sanfeng was a legendary Chinese Taoist who invented Tai chi and supposedly achieved immortality.

Chapter 91: Preparations (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 91 – Preparations (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

In fact, Do Jin-myung's words could be a good opportunity not only for Woon-seong, but also for the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

If what the Sage said was true, the Demonic Cult would have a great excuse to wage war against the Martial Alliance and conquer Zhongyuan.

It was clear that King Jinseong would then use that opportunity to weed out the conspirators posing as the emperor.

Since the Cult of the Inverted Sky was deeply embedded in both these groups, this move would bring peace and balance back into the world.

What better justification for these actions?

However, what if all of that was a lie?

What if the Cult was just being used by King Jinseong for treason?

Then, there would be nothing left for the Cult.

No, it wasn't even a question of no *gains*.

If this plan failed and the Imperial Court became an enemy, Woon-seong was sure that the Cult would suffer greatly.

Even the most powerful martial artists could not defeat the numerous legions of the Imperial Army.

The punishment for rebellion would be destruction.

Failure would threaten the very existence of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Thus, Woon-seong had to ask.

“What reason is there for us to join you while taking such a risk?”

The Sage swallowed his saliva. The young man spoke with an aura of authority that only someone with absolute strength could have.

Of course, the Sage had already expected this question, otherwise he wouldn't have qualified as a messenger.

The Sage calmly replied.

“First of all, King Jinseong has promised that if the Demonic Cult assists his plans, he will acknowledge the Cult of the Heavenly Demon as the state religion, and also appoint the leader as the grand historian.”

The Demonic Cult as the state religion!

If so, the normal citizens would naturally learn the teachings of the Heavenly Demon.

It would only be a matter of time before the Cult of the Heavenly Demon became as influential as Confucianism, Buddhism, or Taoism.

Not only that... Appointing the Cult Leader as the grand historian meant that the emperor himself would learn the teachings of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon!

Essentially, the emperor would become a believer of the Cult.

King Jinseong said that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would become the state religion, but it also meant that he would give the Cult unprecedented support.

Given what the Cult's greatest wish was, the war against Murim was imminent.

King Jinseong's support essentially meant that the Cult would be able to fulfill its goals.

In fact, Woon-seong was quite surprised by this offer.

State and national affairs were not an easy thing to decide.

The fact that King Jinseong was willing to make this offer showed how important this matter was.

“You're saying that you'll fulfill our Cult's oldest wish?”

Woon-seong slowly made eye contact with the Strategist as he tapped his chin.

To be honest, the previous me would not have hesitated to wage war against Zhongyuan...

Not for the Cult, but for my own revenge...

But things are different now.

I haven't forgotten my revenge, but the Cult of the Heavenly Demon that Master Cheon Hwi has left behind is also important.

Now, Woon-seong had to consider both his vengeance and the safety of the Cult.

His thoughts slowly deepened.

It didn't take long before he opened his eyes.

There was something he had to check.

“How do we trust you?”

Instead of answering, the Sage took out another small scroll from his sleeves.

“This is a letter signed and sealed by King Jinseong.”

Woon-seong took the letter and read through it.

Once done, he folded up the letter.

Do I lead the demonic practitioners like this?

Do I point my spear towards Zhongyuan?

Seeing that Woon-seong was still stuck in thought, the Sage pulled out a small vial from his sleeves.

“Do you know what this is?”

Inside the vial was a purple liquid.

Just a simple glance was enough to know that whatever the liquid was, it was an ominous sign.

Woon-seong and Sang Gwan-chuk's attention naturally focused on the vial.

“What is in this bottle... is poison.”

The countenance of both Woon-seong and the Strategist suddenly changed.

It was because they had to figure out what the Sage was trying to do by taking out this bottle of unknown poison.

The first rule of poisoning someone was to do it silently.

Of course, neither Woon-seong nor the Strategist were easy people to assassinate. Unless it was the same kind of poison that killed Cheon Hwi, the poison would be naturally detoxified.

As soon as Woon-seong and Sang Gwan-chuk focused on him, the Sage spoke again.

“This is the poison that was injected into the leader... I mean, the former leader of the Demonic Cult.”

Boom!

At the end of his sentence, the Sage felt a force slam into him and he flew into the wall.

Krrr!

“Cough!”

The pain of a fractured spine lanced up Do Jin-myung’s back.

If he hadn’t focused his energy on protecting his lower back at the last moment, his spine would have protruded from his dead body.

The Sage could only gasp and cough up blood.

I did expect that, but it still almost killed me.

Raising his head, the Sage endured the pain.

There was a huge hole in the palace walls now.

Through the hole, Do Jin-myung was able to look inside.

The Heavenly Demon was slowly rising up from his throne.

Fwoom—

A flame rose from Woon-seong’s body.

At the same time, Woon-seong stood up.

Then he rushed forward.

Weng—

In an instant, Woon-seong had appeared before the Sage.

Reaching out, he grabbed Do Jin-myung by the neck.

Even like that, the Sage did not fight back.

Even though it was a matter of his life and death, the overwhelming difference in strength forbade Do Jin-myung from even trying to resist.

Woon-seong held the man by his neck, letting him dangle above the ground.

“Gasp!”

The Sage cleared his throat a few times, testing his lungs to see if he could still breathe.

Whatever was going through Do Jin-myung’s mind, Woon-seong had no intention of letting him go.

Woon-seong eyes shone gold, slitting into a glare.

The reptile-like sharp gaze examined the Sage.

The pressure and heat of the Divine Flame surrounded the two.

“Ugh.”

The Divine Flame seemed to have gained sentience, coiling around Woon-seong’s body and flicking its tongue like a viper.

Even though the flame touched nothing, Do Jin-myung felt himself burning.

Finally, Woon-seong asked a question.

“Why do you have that poison?”

Woon-seong’s voice was neither abnormally high or low-pitched.

Still, the Sage could not help but see an Asura. It was just a voice, but it gave him goosebumps.

“I-I stole it from the Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

Woon-seong’s eyes glinted at these words.

Obviously, he had not been overtaken by the spirit of the Divine Flame or by his anger.

“The Cult of the Inverted Sky?”

Woon-seong loosened his grip a little to make it easier for the Sage to talk.

“T-That’s right.”

Able to properly breathe once more, the Sage panted.

“You’re saying that the Cult of the Inverted Sky had this poison?”

Woon-seong’s eyes focused on the vial of poison, which he took out of Do Jin-myung’s grasp.

He stared at it for a long time.

There were a lot of complicated questions he had.

Why was Master Nok Yu-on poisoned by the Cult of the Inverted Sky?

Master Nok Yu-on...

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

“Are you sure this belongs to the Cult of the Inverted Sky?”

“Y-Yes.”

“The Sichuan Tang Clan, the Martial Alliance, the Orthodox Sects of Murim... Do you know if any of them are capable of making this poison?”

“I don’t know that far.”

“...”

“But remember what I told you. The Cult of the Inverted Sky has already set its roots not only in the Imperial Court, but also in Murim. They might as well have this poison too.”

Woon-seong opened his eyes and calmed his trembling fingers.

It felt like piecing back together a broken vase.

Everything had a purpose, but some of the pieces were jagged and could not be used by itself.

Woon-seong dropped Do Jin-myung onto the floor, finally letting him breathe normally.

“Jwa Do-gyul, the Master of the Martial Alliance. Is he also a member of the Cult of the Inverted Sky?”

“Huff, I believe there is a high chance for that to be so. Huff-puff.”

“A high chance?”

When Woon-seong asked once more, Do Jin-myung took a break and nodded.

“I say at least 80%.”

80% means that it’s safe to assume it’s true. Woon-seong closed his eyes once more.

Then he tossed the vial in his hand to the Senior Strategist, who had been standing to the side.

“Strategist.”

“Yes, sir.”

Sang Gwan-chuk lowered his head slightly.

“I believe you already know what to do.”

“Understood.”

After exactly two weeks, the Senior Strategist returned to Woon-seong with the vial and a report.

“After testing the poison on imprisoned criminals, I must conclude that this is the same poison. The poison’s symptoms and progression were identical.”

Sitting there, Woon-seong’s mind was flooded with thoughts.

Thoughts about his death, of his first life.

What exactly did Master Nok Yu-on find out back then? What was he involved in?

Now that I think about it my Spear Master master was full of secrets.

It wasn’t the kind of secret where he had some hidden evil identity or something out of his character, but he would go off traveling for two weeks every three months or so, without a word even to me, his only apprentice.

He never told me where he went or what the purpose of the journey was.

Nor was there any story of people seeing him during those two weeks of travel.

Which meant that he wasn't off on a simple journey to travel around Murim.

Master never ended up explaining anything to me.

Nothing about why the Martial Alliance had framed him and was after him...

I never solved this mystery, but from what I remember of his expression, I'm sure Master Nok Yu-on knew exactly why it happened.

Then why didn't he tell me?

If there was a problem, you simply needed to solve it.

I might not have been the most reliable apprentice, but two heads should still be better than one.

Maybe, as a master, he never wanted to rely on me and make me worried.

However, Master Nok Yu-on was not that kind of person.

He never hesitated to open up about his problems when he found it to be necessary.

And if such a person kept it a secret... There has to be a reason for it.

Do Jin-myung's story revolved around Woon-seong's mind.

The Imperial Court.

The Cult of the Inverted Sky.

The influences of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, which were deeply rooted in Murim.

What if Sage Do Jin-myung's words are the truth and what Master Nok Yu-on found out was the secret link between the Imperial Court and the Cult of the Inverted Sky?

And what if he found out that even the Martial Alliance was part of the corruption?

Woon-seong felt like a cog had just started turning.

He had a guess as to why Master Nok Yu-on had kept everything a secret.

Was it to keep me alive?

Being ignorant of the truth would give me a higher chance of survival.

He was that type of person...

My master... was someone who worried about me even as he breathed his last.

Just like Master Cheon Hwi...

Woon-seong clenched his fists.

Subsequently, he remembered something Master Nok Yu-on had said as they were chased through Changsha.

“Woon-seong, my apprentice... If you make it out of this place alive, if you successfully escape this situation, go to the safehouse of our sect in Gansu.”

It looked like Woon-seong was due for a visit to Zhongyuan.

Chapter 92: Preparation (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 92 – Preparations (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

After Woon-seong had cleared his mind, he secretly went out to search for the Senior Strategist.

He visited suddenly very deep into the night, but the Strategist was still working.

It was because his heart was filled with complicated emotions, so the man could not fall asleep.

The Strategist saw Woon-seong and jumped up.

“You could’ve just called me instead...”

Woon-seong shook his head softly.

The Strategist straightened up and picked up his tea set. In an instant, water was boiling. When he put the leaves in, a light aroma spread through the room.

Along with the caffeine, the scent and repetitive actions were mind-cleansing.

As the tea brewed, he placed a cup in front of Woon-seong.

Afterward, he picked up his own and sat across from the youth.

“What brings you here so late at night?” the Strategist finally asked, once half the kettle was finished.

At his question, Woon-seong hesitated for a moment, like the question was difficult to answer.

“What happens to the Cult if I leave?”

“If you leave...? That would cause a good number of problems, of course.”

Sang Gwan-chuk closed his eyes.

It was a difficult situation to imagine.

“I can take care of some internal affairs, but you are the one who makes the decisions. But there are still records of former Heavenly Demons secretly leaving the throne for a while. And naturally, we do have some preparation in case such things happen. The problem is the period... How long are you planning to leave?”

“Six months minimum, one year maximum.”

Six months to a year...

That was not a long time.

Time, however, was not always an absolute concept.

Depending on the situation, like a Cult Leader leaving the throne, a year was long.

“You’re planning to go to Zhongyuan.”

Sang Gwan-chuk guessed why Woon-seong was asking this question. There was a reason he was the senior strategist — it didn’t even take him a minute to draw upon this conclusion. Perhaps, as soon as he heard the length of time, this thought had immediately come to mind.

“We did get the message from the Sage and King Jinseong, but I cannot fully trust them.”

“Are you planning to meet King Jinseong yourself?”

Woon-seong nodded.

“I also want to see the state of affairs in Murim with my own eyes.”

Of course, that was only half the reason.

However, that was the only reason Woon-seong could give in the present situation. There was no way he could say that he wished to visit the Spear Master Sect’s safehouse.

Hearing this reason, the Strategist looked a little doubtful.

“If that is the case, you can order your people to do it instead. Do you really have to leave and do it yourself?”

Woon-seong laughed.

“King Jinseong may not be part of Murim, but he survived when the Emperor purged his many brothers. And if the Sage was speaking the truth, it means he’s been fending for himself against someone who can even control the emperor. He’s no normal man.

“...”

The Strategist understood what Woon-seong was trying to say.

It was hard to fully understand the situation by using a middleman.

“The only sure way to check it is by seeing him with my own two eyes.”

The Strategist sighed. He could say whatever he wanted, but Woon-seong’s mind had obviously already been made.

He could try to convince Woon-seong, but it seemed the new Heavenly Demon would be hard to persuade.

A man of his own beliefs. A man who will steadfastly stride towards his own goals.

Those types of people were difficult to persuade, regardless of age or identity.

The previous Cult Leader was like that.

It seemed the new Leader was like that, too.

Sang Gwan-chuk sighed and smiled for some reason.

Maybe it was because he could see the image of Cheon Hwi in Woon-seong.

Thus, he nodded. "I understand."

"Thank you for understanding."

Woon-seong nodded, standing up.

Seeing that, it seemed like he would leave as soon as he finished preparing.

"However!"

The Strategist suddenly shouted and stopped the Heavenly Demon from leaving.

Woon-seong turned and stared, a question in his eyes.

The eyes of the Strategist were decisive as he spoke.

"I would like you to give me about two weeks to prepare."

Two weeks.

Woon-seong was prepared to leave the next day, but two weeks was still alright with him.

Still, Woon-seong had no idea why the Strategist had asked for two weeks.

However, that did not mean that Woon-seong spent the two weeks doing nothing.

It was never easy to mix perfection with something imperfect.

But Woon-seong had caught the trail.

Slowly, he walked down that path.

“Whew.”

One wrong step and it will lead to qi deviation.

I push a little too much, qi deviation.

Walking on the edge of a knife was nothing compared to this.

A thought swirled through Woon-seong’s mind, before a wave of martial arts knowledge swept it away.

Woon-seong was sweating.

As someone impermeable to heat and cold, Woon-seong was sweating.

That was evidence of how focused he was on his qi flow and meridians.

In such a state, time was unfixed.

For him, a fleeting moment felt like an hour.

Even with my depth of studies, I’m facing limits every moment.

I have to weave the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, a martial art already at perfection, and push it even further.

It's not about trying to enter the realm of god...

Pushing the Divine Art further is only possible after becoming a deity myself!

But that's why I also know that if I continue to walk on this path, I will one day transcend my mortal body and become a deity.

Just like how my efforts with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body showed its results...

“Whew.”

Woon-seong finally opened his eyes and took a deep breath in.

That's enough for today.

A Dark Flower fell from the air, as if she had been waiting for Woon-seong to wake up from meditation.

Obviously, the Flowers of the Dark Night had been protecting him from the ceiling beams.

This wasn't out of kindness, but because they were trained to do so.

But it was a separate thing to be thankful.

“Thank you.”

Woon-seong took the towel and wiped off his sweat.

Then, he entered the next room and stripped off his clothes, relaxing in the basin of water prepared for him.

He thought about his achievements this time.

It's not bad.

Woon-seong smiled.

I've made progress with understanding the Rare World Chapter.

And if it's just mimicking the forms, I can perform it to some degree.

The problem is how much of the actual skills I can recreate, since they're hidden within the forms.

And my real goal isn't just the Rare World Chapter, but what's beyond it.

The Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon which is beyond the current Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

The Art of the Spear Master Sect which is beyond the current Art of the Spear Master Sect.

Woon-seong clenched his fists.

Then, he stretched and stepped out of the water.

With a flick of his qi, the water was dried.

A Woon-seong that had washed up dressed in the clean set of clothes prepared by the Flower of Dark Night soon walked through the palace and back into his room.

Entering his room, he was greeted by the sight of someone standing at his balcony.

“Hey.”

The person opened with the same greeting as the first they had met.

It was Cheon Ah-young.

She came to my place on such a night...

Woon-seong glanced out the window. Even the moon was buried in darkness. It was definitely too late to visit someone.

He turned his head to look at her face.

When she lost her father, she was unable to stop crying.

Although she pretended to be strong, she was still someone's daughter. A daughter who cherished her father.

Thanks to that, her face had been red and blotchy from tears for a while.

She seems fine now. It looks like time has helped. She doesn't seem to have completely overcome her grief, but she seems to have dealt with it.

"You seem to be better."

What was happening tonight?

Instead of asking why she was paying him a visit, he made that comment.

Ah-young nodded at his words.

Looking him straight in the eyes, she suddenly spoke.

"I heard that a messenger from King Jinseong has visited."

"....."

It was not something to hide, but a rumor had started that a messenger of the Empire had made a commotion at the entrance to the Cult. It seemed that said rumor had reached Ah-young and the Divine Maiden's Palace.

But it was only the parties involved who knew what was going on.

"There was a small commotion."

Of course, the details of the conversation did not have to be told to Ah-young.

Woon-seong did not wish to mention the death of Cheon Hwi again, given that he was not sure of the facts himself.

This was also in consideration of Cheon Ah-young.

“The news was related to Zhongyuan, wasn’t it?”

Woon-seong nodded, and Ah-young paused for a moment, then whispered, “Was it also related to my father?”

Her voice was bitter.

It was a woman’s intuition. Even if no one told her, she knew.

Woon-seong hesitated to answer.

Would silence be her answer? Ah-young lowered her head. “So there was a connection.”

It was pointless to lie.

“Yes. It was.”

Saying that the news was related to Cheon Hwi was no different from saying it was related to his death.

Unlike a few days ago, Ah-young clenched her fist instead of bursting into tears.

Barely holding back her tears, she stared at Woon-seong.

“Hey... Did you know?”

“...?”

“In the history of the Cult, there were several Divine Maidens who fought on the frontlines during war.”

“.....”

“Divine Maidens who were exceptionally skilled in martial arts. On top of that, they would cast spells with their divine powers. I don’t think you know, but there were Divine Maidens who made some significant contributions during war.”

Woon-seong listened to Ah-young quietly. He had a rough guess about what she wanted to say.

“When it was decided that I was to become the Divine Maiden, I thought of that. If I can’t become the Heavenly Demon, I should become a Divine Maiden who can fight instead.”

She probably wants to become part of the vanguard, where she has the opportunity to personally avenge her father, Woon-seong sighed.

“It used to be a mere idea, but I guess now I have a real reason to do it.”

Ah-young’s tone suddenly turned serious.

“On that note, I have a favor to ask.”

Woon-seong nodded slowly, “I understand. We don’t have clear plans yet, but if the man who killed Master is in Zhongyuan... And if we have to go to war because of that, I will let you—”

“Teach me martial arts.”

That was Cheon Ah-young’s request.

Woon-seong found it completely unpredicted.

Chapter 93: Heading To Zhongyuan (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 93 – Heading to Zhongyuan (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Just like Sang Gwan-chuk requested, two weeks passed by.

During that time, Woon-seong finalized his preparations for the trip to Zhongyuan.

Basic necessities could be used and bought along the way, but he packed a few food supplies and extra items just in case.

For example, clothing.

Aside from the simple robe Woon-seong was wearing, he'd also packed a few other comfortable sets.

Being impervious to heat and cold, temperature was not an issue for Woon-seong. However, he packed a few winter clothes so that he would not stand out too much.

If a young man, barely in his twenties, was wandering around with thin clothes during the winter, people would look at him with suspicion.

By the time he'd stuffed everything into a bag, the Strategist had arrived.

“It’s already time.”

“I did my best to prepare myself during the two weeks. I hope I didn’t miss anything.”

The Strategist smiled. It seemed like Woon-seong was almost daring him to nitpick.

Either way, his gaze turned to Woon-seong’s sleeves.

“Are you planning to wear your bracers?”

Woon-seong nodded. “Of course. There’s no reason to let go of my training during the journey.”

Ever since he entered the Semi-Divine Realm, his bracers have become heavier. It would be safe to assume he’s practically holding a full grown man on each of his limbs.

And the fact that he’s moving so naturally with so much weight...

It must mean that his qi is thoroughly distributed throughout his body, making such strength second nature.

Sang Gwan-chuk was an outstanding martial artist, but he was unable to compare.

The Heavenly Demon is the Heavenly Demon. I doubt anyone can deny his qualifications.

The Strategist stuck his tongue out in thought.

It was then that Woon-seong asked a question.

“Did you end the preparations on your side?”

Sang Gwan-chuk swallowed. It was for that exact reason that he had visited the palace today.

“May you allow a person to enter the Divine Palace?”

Instead of answering aloud, Woon-seong expressed permission with a wave of his hands.

“You may come in.”

As soon as the Strategist spoke, someone came inside. The moment their eyes met, Woon-seong shivered slightly.

Height and face.

Even the way they dressed and walked.

The new arrival looked very similar to Hyuk Woon-seong.

The visitor approached Woon-seong and bowed. “I present myself to the leader of the Divine Cult.”

Woon-seong stared at the man with an expression that said, ‘who the hell is this guy?’

Sang Gwan-chuk spoke with a confident expression: “He’s nowhere near you in terms of martial arts, but I made sure he perfectly replicated your habits and appearance. He’s not perfect, but while you’re away, nobody will realize the fact that you are gone.”

“So you’re setting a stand-in.”

“I found it necessary, considering how much impact your leave would bring. The previous leaders have also used stand-ins for similar situations.”

Woon-seong nodded and stared at his stand-in with a scrutinizing gaze.

Hmm. It is remarkable how much he resembles me. It’s like watching my own twin brother.

The stand-in even had a spear strapped to his back.

Is that a replica of the White Night Spear?

As Woon-seong stared at the replica spear, the real White Night Spear cried as if it found itself being replicated offensive.

Ah. I see it's made so elaborately that even my spear is reacting to it.

The White Night Spear stopped crying once Woon-seong patted it slightly.

“I have to admit it. He’s just like me.”

The young man standing in front of Woon-seong lowered his head even more. This was not from embarrassment, but from panic.

Woon-seong approached the young man and patted him on the shoulder.

“I’ll leave things to you then.”

Both the young man and the Strategist replied at the same time: “Yes, sir!”

The Strategist raised his head first. As Woon-seong left, he gave a meaningful look.

— Leader. Before you leave, I have combined the information that has come in from Zhongyuan.

Woon-seong titled his head, as if to ask what it was.

Looking at him, Sang Gwan-chuk curled his lips and transmitted another message.

— I cannot verify how much of Do Jin-myung’s words are true, but it seems true that the Emperor is rather eccentric. So the Sage of Earth and Sky wasn’t simply spitting lies...

— Still... that changes nothing. The things I need to do, should do, and will do... None of it has changed.

“Hmmm.”

Cheon Ah-young stared at the iron bracers in front of her.

It was hard to say how heavy they were at first glance, but they were undoubtedly heavy.

There were a total of four.

She picked one of them up, testing it on her left arm.

“Ugh!”

She immediately stumbled and had to grab her wrist.

It's almost like my arm is getting ripped off...

Instinctively, she circulated her qi. With that, she felt a little better.

A weight I can barely hold if I don't use my qi.

Soon, she felt cold sweat drip down her neck.

He wore bracers like these everyday?

It reminded her of what Woon-seong had said while giving her the iron rings.

“I wore bracers twice the weight of that.”

He has been bearing this much weight for such a long time...

If he's not lying, it's incredible...

One of those was already heavy, but four of them?!

This reminds me of the days back in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Remembering those times, Cheon Ah-young forced herself to wear all of the iron rings.

The additional weight was a clear sensation, like gravity pressing against her whole body.

Without using qi, I can barely even move a step...

He said that the combined weight of the bracers should be roughly equal to the weight of two full-grown men.

A training where I constantly carry two men, without using qi and only my physical strength...

I guess this will strengthen my body alright.

Ah-young bit her lips.

When she had asked Woon-seong to teach her martial arts, he had preached about crossing the limits of the human body first.

“Training martial arts starts with expanding the capacity of your body. Your body is the container that holds martial arts.”

Woon-seong’s theory was that the stronger and harder the container, the more capable it would become in holding a grand martial art.

The words of Woon-seong, who started as Number 900 in the Cave of Latent Demons and ascended to the throne of the Heavenly Demon...

It would be foolish to take those words lightly.

However...

“How long do I have to do this?” Ah-young had asked him. For her, this was basic training. What she wanted to learn was advanced martial arts.

At that time, Woon-seong had replied:

“When you can comfortably move without using qi, when the bracers on your limbs start feeling less cumbersome, start increasing their weight, 3.75kgs at a time. If you can move comfortably with a total of 225kgs within a year, I’ll start to teach you martial arts.”

Ah-young clenched her fists.

She was the daughter of the former Heavenly Demon and the Divine Maiden of the Cult.

If I was going to be dragged down by this kind of training, I wouldn’t have entered the Cave of Demons by myself in the first place!

Plus, she had a goal to achieve.

Her eyes blazed with fighting spirit.

I will make it happen.

A year.

225kgs.

That would be her first target.

Woon-seoong lit a small fire and sat before it with his eyes closed.

The conversation he had with the Strategist a few days ago came to mind.

Patting his pockets, he pulled something out.

It was a wooden name card, with words engraved into it.

Righteous Cry Sect of the Guangdong Province.

Disciple Hyuk Woon-seong.

That was the identity Woon-seong would be using in the outside world.

If I remember correctly, the Righteous Cry Sect is another name for the Cult's Guangdong branch.

They should also be informed by now.

A letter must have been sent there by now, stating that someone important to the Cult would be borrowing their name in Zhongyuan.

He didn't even have to change his name.

The name 'Hyuk Woon-seong' was quite common.

No one would recognize it as the name of the new leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Or as the name of the dead apprentice of the Spear Master Sect.

Well, there was a chance.

But...

Even if they did, there's no reason for them to connect it to me.

Just like that, Hyuk Woon-seong had gained another identity.

A cool wind blowing caused him to reopen his eyes. The flames swayed with the wind.

He looked up at the sky. Judging from the shape of the moon, the end of the month was coming soon.

It was around that time that some people approached the fire-pit.

"Oh, I was correct. There is a person."

Woon-seong turned to look at them.

Although a bit charred and dusty, the clothing the group wore was quite expensive.

There was a trail of carts behind, which were accompanied by some more men.

A merchant guild and a courier group?

A flag that said 'Four Sea Courier Group' billowed in the wind, proving Woon-seong's assumptions correct.

Unlike the magnificent sounding name, it did not seem to be a very large company.

I've never seen them in my past life.

Maybe it's a new group which appeared while I was in the Cult.

Or perhaps it was a group that only traded with specific groups and locations.

While Woon-seong thought about it, a representative of the arrivals approached him.

"This young mister. If you don't mind, may we camp beside you?"

Woon-seong nodded.

Merchants travelled as groups to protect themselves against monsters and bandits.

While Woon-seong looked young, the spear on his back meant that he was a martial artist.

A young martial artist was better than nothing, since a split second could mean the difference between life and death.

Seeing that Woon-seong had given his permission, the man immediately shouted at the others. "Everyone, come rest here!"

Afterwards, he settled across from Woon-seong. “Thank you...”

Woon-seong closed his eyes. He did not want to talk with people he had never met before.

The man kept talking, not caring about Woon-seong’s silence.

“Haha! So you’re the quiet type, I see! I’m Un Gwang-gook, the Head Representative of the Four Sea Courier Group.”

What a cheap mouth, unbefitting of a high-ranked representative. Woon-seong reluctantly opened his eyes. “Hyuk Woon-seong, Righteous Cry Sect.”

Maybe he had felt the annoyance in Woon-seong’s curt reply, but Un Gwang-gook grimaced.

Still, he did not shut up.

“By the way, where are you heading during a time like this, young sir? I assume you’re heading to Zhongyuan from the outside areas?”

He’s quite talkative... Woon-seong sighed. “I am heading towards Gansu for now.”

At that, Representative Un had a reflective look on his face. “Gansu, eh? Then that means you’re going to the Jade Gate [1].”

“That is correct.”

“Then do you know that there are mountain bandits near that place?”

Woon-seong eyes widened slightly.

Looking at his face, Representative Un chuckled. “It looks like you didn’t. So that’s why you were traveling alone. Going through these mountains alone is dangerous. You should go with us.”

Woon-seong had been startled for a completely different reason.

The Jade Gate was located near Xinjiang.

Technically, it was in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's territory. However, being so close to Zhongyuan, it was poorly managed by the Cult.

Even so, it was a gateway to Zhongyuan.

How could the forces of Zhongyuan leave the bandits be?

"Why aren't the government forces suppressing them?"

The man shrugged. "I assume they don't want to mess with problems beyond the Jade Gate. The Imperial Court already has enough problems. I'm sure no one wants to gain attention, especially the powerless officials in such a remote place."

It was easy to see that the emperor was not some adored figure.

Woon-seong remembered what Do Jin-myung had been talking about. *Does it have to do with the conspiracy happening in the Imperial Palace?*

"Enough problems in the Imperial Court? What do you mean?"

"You didn't know?"

Representative Un looked at the youth with suspicion. He had originally thought that Woon-seong was a man from Murim traveling back to Zhongyuan.

However, how could he not know that the Imperial Court was having problems?

Woon-seong coughed once. "Ah, I came to Xinjiang with my master when I was young. Now that my master passed away, I'm going back to my hometown alone."

Woon-seong hoped that explanation cleared the suspicion. After all, it was close to the truth.

“I see... Then it makes sense you know nothing,” Un Gwang-gook nodded to himself. “It’s been a while since His Majesty, who was once praised as a wise emperor, started to turn strange.”

[1] The Jade Gate, or Yümen Pass, is the name of a pass of the Great Wall located in the western side of the Gansu Province.

Chapter 94: Heading To Zhongyuan (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 94 – Heading to Zhongyuan (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

And so Un Gwang-gook started to talk about imperial affairs and current events.

“The first rumor was that the court ladies and eunuchs started disappearing. Next was the stories of increasing corrupt officials and trafficking of government positions. Alongside His Majesty’s changes, the high officials have also started changing. The changes, which once seemed trivial, have become serious. Even Prime Minister Hong Bin, who was once respected by everyone, has clearly become strange.”

Hong Bin... I should remember that name. Maybe he has also been body-snatched by someone else.

Of course, considering these are all from the mouth of a quite loose-lipped man, I should verify them when I get to Zhongyuan.

But rumors start for a reason. And merchants are especially sensitive when it comes to rumors.

Woon-seong continued to pay attention to the man’s narrative. He did not forget to ask about specific names and policies.

Since his previously quiet companion was taking the initiative to talk, Un Gwang-gook became more excited and spoke more freely.

Un Gwang-gook's words could be regarded as treason, since they were practically insults and denouncements of the emperor's reign.

However, the representative did not hesitate to speak of them. And to a complete stranger, at that.

Even considering the man's talkative nature, his ease meant that such rumors were widespread in the public.

I assume others are also thinking similar things.

Perhaps no one would say it out loud like Un Gwang-gook, but everyone was thinking it.

Woon-seong could not help but be derisive.

Zhongyuan is in quite a pathetic situation.

While Woon-seong was speaking with the Head Representative, the members of the merchant-courier group muttered amongst themselves.

One of them suddenly spoke up.

"I don't get it. Why is Boss even talking with such a young guy like him?"

The one who asked was much younger than the rest, though his weathered skin made it hard to tell.

The one who answered was middle-aged, but looked older than his years.

"Maybe he would rather talk with a stranger, since we don't play along with his chatter."

The others burst into laughter.

That middle-aged man's reasoning was quite plausible.

However, the younger man was not satisfied with that answer. He chugged the alcohol in front of him before muttering, “But does he really have to act that friendly? Maybe he thought it’s a good idea to befriend a martial artist because of the bandits, but it’s just one guy.”

The others nodded as well.

That wasn’t wrong either.

Again, the one who responded was the middle-aged man.

“Even a single martial artist is quite a significant force. Even a second-rate martial artist should be better than someone who learned some half-assed martial skill.”

Besides, this was Xinjiang.

This was the realm of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It was rare to meet a martial artist who wasn’t a demonic practitioner or a criminal.

There was no harm getting close with a martial artist, just in case.

In addition, the youth was by himself. Even if he did end up being some criminal or demonic practitioner, the Four Sea Courier Group could subdue him.

“Oh? So our courier captain, who’s just on the verge of becoming a first-rate, actually thinks that young man is a second-rate martial artist?” the younger man asked again.

Through interacting with the middle-aged captain of the courier group, he had some experience distinguishing martial artists by level.

As a young man himself, it was difficult to believe that the youth who looked even younger than himself was a second-rate master.

The middle-aged man looked at Woon-seong.

Flat temples and such ordinary eyes.

My bet would be a third-rate who's better than other third-rates, at best.

But that's still a third-rate.

“He seems somewhat hardened, but it doesn't look like it was through martial arts... Well, we'll find out about that when we actually encounter bandits.”

That was the middle-aged man's basic idea.

Of course, he did not have high expectations.

As he said, the group soon had a chance to see Woon-seong's talents.

“Stop. Hehe. Don't tell me you're planning to go through this mountain for free.”

Like Un Gwang-gook had foretold, a group of bandits appeared and surrounded the group, not far from the Jade Gate.

There were about fifty of them, each holding a weapon in hand. Obviously, it was not a rag-tag bunch but a well-managed group.

“Where are your manners to the master of this mountain?”

Looking at them, Woon-seong could vaguely guess their identity. *Since when did the Green Forest Stronghold have influence in Xinjiang...?*

While Woon-seong was thinking that way, the courier group was looking nervous.

The Head Representative stepped forward. “We do not wish to fight. If we have to pay a fee to pass by, we are more than willing to do so.”

Although he was a chatty person, Un Gwang-gook clearly recognized his role and responsibilities.

The word ‘fee’ made the bandits hesitate.

They also did not want unnecessary fighting.

They glanced back at their leader.

“A fee, eh? And how much are you willing to pay?”

“If you let us pass unharmed, we will pay half a silver coin per person. The courier’s captain will pay two. I, the Head Representative, will pay five. Of course, this is an official payment made under the name of the Four Sea Courier Group.”

The leader of the bandits who blocked the way slowly tapped his chin. He rolled his eyes to the side, as if he were in deep thought.

The air around the bandit leader suddenly seemed to become heavier and trembled.

Off to the side, Woon-seong suddenly smirked.

Still pretending to be in deep thought, the bandit leader said, “I’ll let you pass if you pay fivefold of that.”

“Fivefold?!”

“If we pay that much...”

The bandit’s words caused a commotion among the merchant guild members. They were immediately met by some brandished weapons shoved in their faces.

Even in front of Woon-seong, one of the bandits wielded a sword.

What a joke. Woon-seong honestly found it quite unpleasant.

The Head Representative shook his head, “We will.”

“Boss!” some of the members shouted, but Un Gwang-gook shook his head to silence them.

“If we can avoid a fight, it’s well worth it.”

Even if he had to pay five times as much, it was still okay as long as his people did not get hurt.

Other than talking too much, Representative Un was a good leader who thought about his subordinates.

The bandit leader smiled, trampling upon the heart of such a head representative. “Oh, oh... It looks like I made a mistake with my words. Did I say fivefold? Actually, I think I meant tenfold, no, twentyfold now.”

“Twentyfold...?”

Naturally, the Head Representative’s face had gone stiff.

The negotiations couldn’t have possibly gone this way unless the bandit had planned to just rob them in the first place.

It looks like this is where I die. The Head Representative was a swordsman, so he reached for his sword. *Of course, I’m not going down alone. I’ll take at least five of these bandits down with me.*

At that time, a young man walked past him.

It was Woon-seong.

“So you were never planning to take the fee in the first place.”

Woon-seong’s steps were so natural that no one saw him walk up there.

As if he had been there all along, Woon-seong stood next to the Head Representative.

Un Gwang-gook was surprised and shouted, “Young sir!”

Woon-seong ignored him and spoke to the bandit instead.

“Then why didn’t you say so in the first place? You could have just said that you were going to rob us.”

The bandit leader frowned at Woon-seong’s sudden appearance. Not only had he randomly butted in, he was speaking like an old man lecturing his juniors!

“You little brat... Do you have a death wish?!”

The bandit leader swung his blade towards Woon-seong.

With that one move, it looked like Woon-seong’s neck would be snapped in half.

Ugh. There goes a young, innocent soul, the merchant-courier group turned and sighed.

Obviously, everyone thought that Woon-seong was done for!

Bang!

Oops.

The bandit leader’s body flew into the air and crashed into the tree. The tree trunk then broke in half and smashed the bandit leader.

The bandit leader’s jaw dislocated and he seemed to be foaming at the mouth.

No one knew if the man was dead or just unconscious.

Everyone sharply inhaled.

“What just happened...?”

“Why is the young man still standing while the other flew like that?”

No one had seen what just happened.

Except for one person.

Clap, clap.

Clapping sounds echoed through the area. It originated from the grove Woon-seong had just thrown the bandit leader towards.

Soon, an old man walked out from the bushes.

“You’re pretty good for your age! He may be a bandit, but he’s better than some ordinary second-rate martial artist. Yet you just flung him like nothing!”

The man spoke as if he truly admired Woon-seong. It *was* quite impressive to fling a grown man.

“I don’t know who you are, but I get that you have quite some skill.”

Woon-seong laughed.

Then he slowly walked to stand before the old man.

As Woon-seong walked forward, the bandits opened the way for him. It was because the shock of what just happened caused them to be subconsciously fearful.

Soon, the old man and Woon-seong were face to face.

“Are you the leader of these bandits?”

“Hmm... I’m just a guest.”

“A guest?”

“That’s right. A guest who came to earn some money.”

Woon-seong snorted. *Those are some thick lies for someone who is probably close friends with the man stuck in the tree.*

Others might not know, but Woon-seong had overheard the conversation between this old man and the bandit leader.

It wasn't the bandit leader who wanted the money, but this old man.

Naturally, this old man was the big boss behind everything.

Obviously though, Woon-seong was just a young man in the eyes of this old man.

Whether the old man knew of Woon-seong's thoughts or not, he kept talking.

"Hmm. By the way, that was quite an impressive move. Which leads me to an offer. How about you become my apprentice?"

The old man said that and smiled sincerely.

How ridiculous. Woon-seong could not help but ask a quick question. Turning his head, he pointed towards the squashed bandit leader, "You did see me throw that man, right?"

"I did. And it was quite impressive. But it wasn't enough to deceive my eyes."

The old man grinned at the question. It was a nasty smile full of yellowed teeth.

Woon-seong smiled in return.

"Let me ask one thing."

Waving his head, he mockingly asked,

"Were you *able* to see it, or did I just *let* you do so?"

Chapter 95: Beyond The Jade Gate (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 95 – Beyond the Jade Gate (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

What's with this confidence? Is this kid actually...?!

The old man looked at Woon-seong's attitude with suspicion.

Suddenly, Woon-seong flashed forward like a bolt of lightning.

Bam!

The next second, the old man was already lying on the floor.

He had been completely unprepared.

Everything had happened in a second.

Even the man who was hit by Woon-seong could not determine what had happened.

What they hell just happened? I think I saw a faint shadow and then my body shifted. But the shadow had been...white? And then I was already on the ground...

The old man was not a fool, so it didn't take long for him to figure out the situation.

It's obvious. My body was launched by something.

“You bastard! You were hiding your strength!”

The old man slowly got up off the floor and grabbed something from around his waist.

Snap—

Short rods snapped together, forming a long spear.

A hexa-jointed spear..? And that purple colored blade...

Perhaps the weapon would give them some idea about who the old man was.

“The ‘Snake Spear Poison Artist’, Nam Choong!”

Was it because someone had recognized him? Nam Choong responded with a smile, “Hehehe. It looks like you at least have an eye.”

Nam Choong grabbed his spear and pointed it at Woon-seong, who looked at him indifferently, no matter what he did.

“You. You will pay for insulting me.”

The word ‘insult’ made Woon-seong laugh.

Apparently Nam Choong was not a very smart man.

There was a great wall between their strengths. As long as Woon-seong did not want others to know of his true strength, it would be impossible for insects like Nam Choong to know.

So Nam Choong had no idea.

The fact that he could still talk, that he was still alive, that even despite insulting Woon-seong, the young man had already been merciful.

Snake Spear Poison Artist, huh...I've never heard of him, but I assume his name is known for a reason.

Woon-seong wet his lip with the tip of his tongue.

Finishing him with a single blow will cause too much attention.

The appearance of new blood who defeated the Snake Spear Poison Artist after fighting for some time, and the appearance of one who defeated him in a single blow are two very different things.

I'm not planning to become famous during my trip to Zhongyuan.

Enough fame to make my journey a bit more comfortable is good enough.

Woon-seong turned around and asked, "Is he that powerful of a martial artist?"

"Y-Young sir. Have you never heard about Nam Choong, the Snake Spear Poison Artist?"

The Head Representative could not hide his trembling voice.

Originally, Un Gwang-gook thought that Woon-seong was one step ahead of them. He recognized that Woon-seong was strong, seeing as he had easily blasted the bandit leader into a tree.

But the young man hadn't attacked Nam Choong because of his identity? Was it just a coincidence?

Unwittingly, Nam Choong's pride had taken two blows from Woon-seong.

Woon-seong casually shrugged his shoulders. "I told you that I travelled to Xinjiang with my master at a young age. I know nothing about any recent famous figures."

At that point, the Head Representative swallowed. Just as he was about to explain some more, he was interrupted.

“Enough talk! We’ll see if that tongue of yours can keep you alive any longer.”

Nam Choong flew towards Woon-seong.

Woon-seong took a step back and lightly dodged the attack before reaching over his back.

Sching—

The White Night Spear flew into Woon-seong’s palms, as if reacting to the youth’s summons.

To be honest, Woon-seong did not even need his spear to feel with Nam Choong.

The Snake Spear Poison Artist was only about as strong as a high-level Demonic General or a really weak Great Demon.

Even before becoming the Heavenly Demon, Woon-seong had been able to deal with both Cheon Ah-young, the Divine Maiden, and Gwan Tae-ryang, the new Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit — both well established Great Demons.

But defeating him with my bare hands will cause too much attention. I don’t need that much fame.

Rumors that I went toe to toe with the Snake Spear Poison Artist are good enough.

Woon-seong swung his spear.

He did not use any particular technique, only the basics of the spear.

Whip and bounce the spear like breaking out of a cage.

Cut by twirling the spear in a spiral, like a conch shell.

Thrust to stab and pierce the opponent.

In Woon-seong's hands, even the most basic spear movements were dramatically reproduced.

That was the biggest difference between the skilled and unskilled.

He was using the Seven Stars of the Spear, but it couldn't be any different.

With smooth movements, the spear in Woon-seong's hand was so dazzling that no one dared to say he was using the Seven Stars of the Spear.

Inside what looked like chaos was logic and insight.

Woon-seong's spear arts had surpassed textbook perfection.

Obviously, this was not a level Nam Choong could surpass.

The Snake Spear which continually missed Woon-seong by the width of paper proved this point clear.

Woon-seong smiled as he glanced at the spear next to his cheek.

Others watching the battle probably thought Woon-seong was just barely blocking Nam Choong's attacks.

But Woon-seong was quite relaxed.

For example...

Kang—

Woon-seong did not get nervous, even as blades of wind rained down on him.

From his point of view, they were no different from fireworks to celebrate his successful acting in the drama called life.

After a few seconds...

Flash!

Woon-seong's spear squeezed through the wind wall and struck.

It was a move so precise that Nam Choong hadn't even known he had a weakness there!

"Ugh!"

A single blow was enough.

A white spearhead pierced through Nam Choong's navel, exiting through the back.

"H-How?"

Until that moment, Nam Choong did not fully understand what was happening and alternately looked at the spear-shaft in Woon-seong's hands and his pierced abdomen.

Perhaps, even until the end, he had no idea that Woon-seong was only playing with him.

Puchi—

Woon-seong withdrew his spear and Nam Choong fell to the floor, blood spilling from the hole in his body.

As he pulled his spear back, Woon-seong rolled his shoulders, conscious of the others watching.

"Whew."

He did not forget to exhale as though it had been a difficult battle.

The end of a perfect scene.

Woon-seong glanced to the side.

“R-Run!”

With the bandit leader down and the Snake Spear Poison Artist dead, all of the remaining bandits scattered.

With no leader and no strong backing, it was unlikely that there would be anymore bandits around this place.

Thus, Woon-seong did not bother chasing after them. He was no saint, but there was also no reason to kill unnecessarily.

After all the commotion had ended, Representative Un approached Woon-seong.

“Y-young master. That was some remarkable skill.”

The Righteous Cry Sect... I didn't expect much because I had never heard of its name... But he was strong enough to defeat Nam Choong, the Snake Spear Poison Artist. Un Gwang-gook was filled with newfound admiration.

Woon-seong shook his head, then motioned to his tattered sleeves. “It wasn't an easy fight.”

Though the wear and tear on the sleeves were intentionally made, none of those present were talented enough to see through the trick.

“Hmm, it was certainly not an easy fight. A little mistake might have been disastrous.”

Un Gwang-gook, who presented himself as the Head Representative of the Four Sea Courier Group, did not recognize the false traces made by Woon-seong.

“Are you hurt anywhere?”

“Thankfully, no. Although it seems like my clothes didn't survive.”

As Woon-seong smiled bitterly, the Head Representative perked up.

“Before we go through the Jade Gate, I’ll get you a good set of clothes at a nearby town.”

“I do have an extra set... But I’ll thankfully take the offer.”

“You just saved our lives. It’s nothing much compared to that.”

Just as the Head Representative said, the group stopped at a village and bought some new clothes for the youth.

As the village was frequented by merchants to and from the Jade Gate, the store was considerable and stocked with a variety of high quality clothing.

A nice bandana was paired with a purple-colored cloak, both spun from silk.

Neither was very expensive, as they were not embroidered or adorned with precious stones.

Nodding his head, Un Gwang-gook was satisfied with Woon-seong’s clean appearance. “Now that you’re dressed like this, you really look like some young hero from Murim.”

Without another word, the Head Representative paid for the clothing.

Woon-seong smiled bittersweetly as he looked at the clean clothes wrapped around his body.

A nice martial artist’s coat and a bandana. It’s the same clothing Master Nok Yu-on bought me when I first became his apprentice.

Although the colors and the quality are different, it’s a nice gift that reminds me of those days.

Though, it feels like a bit too much.

Woon-seong made a small sound of discomfort, then said, “Thank you for your gift.”

“Don’t worry. This is really nothing compared to what you did for us.”

He’s talkative, but still a good person, nodded Woon-seong, adjusting his impression of the Head Representative.

Soon they arrived at the entrance to the Jade Gate.

Beneath the tall walls was a long line of people trying to enter through the massive gate.

It was all people trying to get through the Jade Gate or enter into Zhongyuan.

The Jade Gate, which was connected to the Silk Road, had a thorough inspection process.

A number of officials were inspecting the people passing through.

What is your purpose for crossing the Jade Gate?

Do you have any prohibited items or items to declare?

Are you sure you’re not a criminal trying to escape?

The process was straightforward, but the guards were all showing signs of fatigue.

“That’s the Jade Gate. At least it doesn’t look too busy today,” commented the Head Representative as the group waited in line.

Soon, it was their turn.

“Hmm. You’re from the Four Sea Courier Group?”

An inspector checked their identification cards, then stood up and checked their carts.

“You don’t seem to have any contraband items. And your list of people...”

The inspector steadily moved around the group to keep track of the number of Four Sea Courier Group members, a little like a pigeon searching for crumbs.

In the end, he found something to pick at.

“Seems to have one extra. Your number of people does not match the records.”

Almost greedily, the inspector’s gaze focused on Woon-seong.

“I’m not part of the Four Sea Courier Group.”

“You’re not with the Four Sea Courier Group? Then why are you traveling with them?”

As soon as this question came out, it was the Head Representative who answered. He pulled out a small pouch from his sleeve and whispered to the inspector.

“This young sir is a martial artist. We met him in the mountains and just happened to enter Zhongyuan together. He says that he used to live in Zhongyuan but went outside with his master to train and is returning home for the first time in many years.”

“Is that so?”

The inspector acted like he was thinking as he listened to Un Gwang-gook. In the end, he snatched the pouch and tucked it into his sleeves.

Woon-seong felt like the inspector was greedy like a child. *He was planning to rip them off using some lousy reason.*

Looking around, the other inspectors were the same. They tried their best to find a problem and would make a big deal out of anything, no matter how small.

Among the inspectors were even those who would not let someone pass unless bribed.

Woon-seong frowned.

Based on the events at the Jade Gate, Woon-seong was convinced.

Even the officials in the outskirts are corrupted.

I can't even imagine how bad the officials in the court are.

The larger a well, the more water it contained, the easier it was to become rotten.

The same could be said for power and control.

Chapter 96: Beyond The Jade Gate (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 95 – Beyond the Jade Gate (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Thanks to the Four Sea Courier Group and the Head Representative, Woon-seong announced that he would be leaving shortly after crossing the Jade Gate.

“It looks like it’s time we go our separate ways.”

“I’m sorry that’s all I can do for my life’s savior.”

Woon-seong shook his head. “No, you’ve been a lot of help already.”

Of course, Woon-seong was not talking about how the Head Representative had bought him new clothes.

Woon-seong could have solved that himself.

Instead, the Head Representative had been much more helpful in other ways.

Thanks to him, I was able to learn the general state of affairs in Zhongyuan.

And thanks to his talkative nature, I'm sure he'll start the rumor of how I defeated the Snake Spear Poison Artist.

Some amount of fame will help me during my journey in Zhongyuan.

The two identities that I must hide are: (1) Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and (2) sole apprentice of the Spear Master Sect.

I don't have to worry about the latter, as that person is already dead in Murim.

But if the former one gets discovered, that becomes a big problem. The Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon setting foot into Zhongyuan by himself is not some ordinary occurrence.

That was the main reason Woon-seong needed to build a reputation.

I hope he does a good job with those rumors, he thought as he glanced at the now distant Four Sea Courier Group.

After parting ways with the Four Sea Courier Group, Woon-seong started heading straight to Hezuo [1], where the secret safehouse was located.

Traveling from the Jade Gate to the Spear Master Sect's safehouse in Hezuo would take a long time, even by horse.

But with Woon-seong's movement skills, it wasn't an impossible distance. Currently, he could run faster than a horse without rest for three days and three nights.

If Woon-seong wished to, he would reach Hezuo within ten days.

But those ten days on the road weren't eventless.

There was a minor incident which took place near the Qilian Mountains. [2]

The Qilian Mountains were a place where numerous cliffs created walls of spectacles, and many high peaks supported the sky.

Woon-seong ended up staying the night in a town near the mountain range.

As he entered the town, the chatter of guests greeted him. Around this time of evening, there was a crowd in every restaurant or inn in sight.

Many of them were drunk and causing a scene.

Woon-seong frowned. *This place is noisy... I should find some place quiet.*

He wanted somewhere with as few people as possible, an environment where he could sit and eat a meal in relaxed silence.

At the end of his search, Woon-seong found a suitable place a little further up the alley.

Old-fashioned, yet elegant.

It was a very nice place, except that it was not in the best location.

But above all else, Woon-seong preferred how quiet it was.

This place seems quiet. I like it.

As Woon-seong entered the inn, a bell at the entrance rang.

At the sound, a boy who had been sleeping in the corner of the room ran up to him.

“Welcome, sir!”

The boy looked very young, possibly malnourished.

A girl, who looked about sixteen, popped her head out of the kitchen and greeted.

“Welcome to the Golden Sunset Inn.”

An inn called the Golden Sunset.

Woon-seong followed the young boy to a corner of the room and settled down, ordering dinner.

“I’d like something to eat as a light meal. Is there anything you can get me?”

“How about fried rice made with minced meat, vegetables, and chili oil?”

Red pepper chili sauce, or chili oil, was originally a commonly used ingredient in Sichuan regional cuisine.

However, there was no law forbidding people in other provinces from using it!

Occasionally, there were people who enjoyed spicy flavors, so most inns kept a stock of chili oil.

Woon-seong nodded instead of answering.

The boy lowered his head and said, “Thank you.”

The little boy then ran to the front window of the kitchen. He glanced back at Woon-seong.

To be precise, he glanced at the spear strapped to Woon-seong’s back.

Most children admired the heroes of Murim. But the little boy’s eyes did not seem to hold admiration.

The boy shot one last glance at Woon-seong, then repeated his order.

Woon-seong heard the boy call the girl ‘noona’.

I was wondering why they seemed so young. It looks like this place is run by those two alone.

It did not take long for the food to come out.

Without hesitation, Woon-seong started to eat.

I was worried that maybe the lack of customers was because of the food, but it looks like I was wrong. This is some quality cooking for a child. Then why are there no customers here?

His question was soon answered.

By the time Woon-seong was halfway through his meal, a group of people burst into the inn, chattering amongst themselves.

“That was another productive day?”

“You’re damn right. Everyone, good job. If we just keep it up like this, people will start treating us like winners.”

“Hehe. So this is what it’s like to be in the Black Way.”

“The life of real men, right?”

A group of four men had just entered.

Woon-seong didn’t think that they had mastered any martial arts, but each man had a blade strapped to his waist.

The blades were of terrible quality, something you could get without paying much.

However, because of the crude appearance, the general public was even more fearful.

Black Way scum. On top of that, they’re low-lives who haven’t even learned any martial arts.

Based on the clothing, cruel looks, and poorly maintained weapons, Woon-seong had quickly guessed their identity.

No wonder there are no guests. If people of the Black Way are frequent guests of this place, it makes sense.

And how do the two owners of this place react...?

Just as I expected...

The little boy refused to make eye contact with the crown.

Not only that, the young girl hid inside the kitchen, shivering.

That was an unusual reaction, one that could not be explained by fear of the Black Way alone.

As soon as they sat down, the group glanced at Woon-seong before ordering a drink, not caring much about him. A young man probably wouldn't amount to much.

Woon-seong also turned his eyes away from them.

They're a bit annoying, but I want to stay out of trouble... I'll just bear with it.

As long as they don't cross the line.

At that moment, the man with an eye-patch stood up and headed towards the kitchen.

As he stepped inside, the rest of the group laughed, as the girl cowered further inside.

“Go easy on her, boss!”

“Hmm. How are you doing today?”

The man went inside and crouched next to the girl.

He teased the girl as they were very familiar. The whole time, he did not stop poking and prodding her with his fingers as he spoke sleazy words.

“I-I'm...”

The frightened girl trembled and tried to reply.

Her response only made the man tease her even more, liking her crying face.

No one helped her.

Poor girl...

But Woon-seong didn't particularly have a reason to help her either.

Just as he was standing up to leave, something caught his attention.

Tch—

Aside from the voices and footsteps was the sound of someone gripping an object very hard. It was very faint, but Woon-seong still heard it.

It sounded a little like metal hitting wood.

Woon-seong glanced to the side.

It was the boy, presumed to be the girl's younger brother.

The boy had grabbed a kitchen knife and glared at the man harassing his sister.

Eyes filled with hatred.

Maybe he wished to stab the guy. But did he have the courage to do so?

The boy grabbed the knife and shuddered, but didn't make any further movement.

This action caught the eyes of the other men as well.

“Huh? Look at this kid! He's holding a knife!”

“Hey. What are you going to do with that knife?”

“Were you trying to stab us? Hahaha! This little brat?”

The men of the Black Way surrounded the boy and sneered at him.

The one-eyed man walked out from the kitchen area and stood in front of the little boy. Bowing his head to make eye contact, he taunted, “What are you planning to do with that knife? Stab me because I harassed your sister?”

The man reached out and grabbed the boy by the wrist. With a slight exertion of power, a *crunch* sound could be heard.

“Ugh!”

The boy’s bones had not broken, but it was still an adult male’s grip. The boy groaned in agony.

Before the boy could regain his bearings, the man kicked him in the abdomen.

Pah!

The boy flew into the air and fell to the ground a few feet away.

“Ack!”

The boy groaned in pain.

The girl tried to run towards him, screaming, “What are you doing to my brother?!”

“No you don’t!”

The girl’s arms and legs were grabbed by one of the other Black Way men, who giggled. Although she struggled with all her might, the strength of an adult, a man at that, was not one she could overcome.

“So-san!” the girl could only scream.

The one-eyed man was ruthless as he violently hit the boy, whose name appeared to be So-san.

Pah!

Pah! Pah!

“I’m doing my best here to end up with your sister, you know?”

The one-eyed man was now kicking the boy in the stomach. Every time a kick landed, the boy would groan in pain.

“And you dare try to stab the person who might be your brother-in-law?”

Nevertheless, the boy did not let go of the knife in his hand.

He could not move, but that was the best he could do.

Seeing this, Woon-seong sighed.

The scene reminded him of some bad memories.

I was just like that before Master Nok Yu-on took me as his apprentice.

Of course, Woon-seong’s situation was even worse back then. There was neither a roof to escape from the rainstorms nor a sister to cry for him.

But that was how Woon-seong had survived.

One night he’d said, “How dare you beat me down today,” then stoned a man of the Black Way to death.

When Master Nok Yu-on chanced upon that scene, the Spearmaster concluded that the sins of the Black Way man had made him unworthy of life. He’d then taken Woon-seong to learn the spear and walk the righteous path.

Of course, Woon-seong’s talent and potential also played a part, but he had been way too young for the normal apprenticing process.

Maybe I was more suited to be a demonic practitioner than a righteous man ever since then.

Woon-seong raised his hand and covered his face, upset all of a sudden.

I didn't need to remember those times.

I'd really just rather destroy those Black Way scum for making me remember this...

But that would mean I would be helping those two children.

Venting out is fine, but I don't want to play a hero.

I hope you at least show me one reason for me to help you.

Slowly, Woon-seong started to murmur.

The boy, who Woon-seong was watching take the hits, soon heard a voice beside his ear.

— *Hold on to the knife.*

[1] Hezuo is a city in the southern part of the Gansu province of Western China

[2] The Qilian Mountains form the border between the Qinghai and Gansu provinces.

Chapter 97: Destiny Or Fate (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 97 – Destiny or Fate (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Hearing the voice, the boy, whose name was Kang So-san, trembled.

But instinctively, he gripped the knife even harder.

All he had to do was wait for a chance to use the knife.

He wanted to give these bastards who bullied his sister a nice lesson!

The boy grit his teeth.

At that moment, the sleazy one-eyed man struck him once again.

Pow, pow, pow!

It was unbearable pain for a child and the boy's determination wavered.

The hand gripping the knife trembled with pain.

Once more, the boy heard a voice in his ears.

— *Don't let go of it. Hold onto the knife. The chance will come.*

It was a voice of power.

The boy curled up into a ball to resist the kicking and looked around the inn, searching for the source of the voice.

Of course, he did not forget to tighten the grip around the knife.

The voice in his ears contained a powerful majesty that he could not help but follow.

Kang So-san was able to find the owner of the voice with no difficulty.

At the end of the stairs leading up to the second-floor living areas, someone was standing at the balcony, looking steadfast as a mountain.

That person said nothing, but Kang So-san instinctively realized that man was the owner of the voice just now.

If he weren't in so much pain, the boy might have smiled. Instead, his eyes watered.

As if to answer the boy, Woon-seong offered him a small smile.

There's a common saying that you should teach a man to fish instead of giving him a fish .

Give a man a fish and you feed him for a day; teach a man to fish and you feed him for a lifetime.

That was what Woon-seong was trying to do.

If you want to survive in this cruel world, you must be ready to defend yourself.

If you wanted to protect what you valued, you needed to know how to wield a blade with determination.

If you can't, you would only continue to be stuck in the same miserable life.

What Woon-seong wanted to see from the boy was action and determination.

— *Helping you is no problem, but I want you to show me at least one reason to help. Before I help you, prove to me that you can survive long after this.*

Woon-seong's eyes flicked between the one-eyed man and the young boy.

He did not forget to send a telepathic message to the boy.

— *Stay low and dodge his attack.*

Of course, the boy was not able to accurately pull off what Woon-seong was asking of him. But by instinctively trying to follow along, he was still somewhat able to protect himself from the incoming kicks.

Seeing that, Woon-seong smiled slightly before speaking once more.

— *Your chance will come soon. Wait for it.*

People had habits.

Habits revealed when eating.

Habits revealed when sleeping.

Habits revealed when taking a rest.

Naturally, people also had habits when fighting.

As the one-eyed man continued to hit and kick, Woon-seong was able to pick up on his habits.

— *Just take a breath. Keep your head down and avoid the current attack. After three more kicks he will stop for a moment.*

Woon-seong instructed the boy on how to use the one-eyed man's habits against him.

This habit was the only way that the small and weak boy would be able to strike the one-eyed man.

— *Here comes another kick. After that, he'll take time to catch his breath. That's your chance.*

And the chance came just as Woon-seong predicted.

— *That's when you will stab him in the stomach.*

Phew!

As fate would have it, the one-eyed man gave one more kick before stopping for a breather. He huffed three to four times. After that, the kicks would continue.

For the inexperienced boy, stabbing the man at this moment would be highly advantageous.

Now!

Woon-seong conveyed his thoughts through sound transmission.

— *Stab him!*

The boy gripped the knife.

He tried to stab the man standing in front of his eyes with the knife in hand.

However, the boy was unable to move the knife.

“You brat!”

Pah!

Once again, Woon-seong closed his eyes, not wanting to look at the boy who was once again rolling around and clutching his stomach.

The knife was now lying on the floor.

The one-eyed man soon started kicking once more, now even more violently than before.

He didn't stab... It's over.

I know it's difficult to kill a person at such a young age, but there are times when you need to attack others to protect your people.

You need to toughen up. But if you can't do that, there's no use in me helping...

Woon-seong was about to leave, thinking that way.

If Kang So-san hadn't picked the knife back up, Woon-seong might have.

Hmm? Woon-seong glanced at the boy.

Once again gripping the knife, the boy stared at Woon-seong.

Their gazes crossed.

Within the boy's gaze, Woon-seong read hatred. It was laced with determination and killing intent, much thicker than before.

Are you asking for another chance?

Woon-seong did not think it was a bad thing to give the boy one more chance.

After all, Woon-seong himself had been given another chance at revenge.

— *Then this is your last one.*

That was a warning to both the boy and also himself.

Soon, Woon-seong sent another message.

— *Now!*

Puchi—!

The sound of cold cutlery penetrating human skin.

It was the sound of someone being stabbed.

The knife in the boy's hand was now in the one-eyed man's stomach.

“Ugh!”

The one-eyed man collapsed, holding his pierced abdomen.

His colleagues threw the girl onto the ground and ran forward.

“What?!”

“You little brat!”

Even at that moment, the boy was alternating between looking at the knife in his hand and the man lying on the floor.

The boy was probably not feeling too good to see another person's blood flow from his hands.

No, considering it was the first time, it must have been shocking.

It had been the same for Woon-seong.

But what was more important is the boy had taken the first step to becoming strong on his own.

Meanwhile, the men had hurried to save their stabbed friend and surrounded the area.

As the men were large and ugly, Kang So-san once again became afraid.

But the boy did not let go of the knife in his hand. Hatred continued to flow from his eyes.

‘Hit me if you want, kill me if you can’, his eyes seemed to say.

Instead, the boy seemed excited that he would be attacked once more. He wanted to prove himself more.

That determination was what Woon-seong wanted to see.

Woon-seong made a move.

“Stop there.”

Woon-seong slowly made his way down the stairs.

All the men surrounding So-san turned their heads to look at the sudden intruder.

“Who the fuck are you?”

“Don’t you see what’s going on?”

“We only left you alone because you were staying quiet! Fuck off!”

Those were some obvious threats.

And their scare tactics might have worked...

If only Hyuk Woon-seong had not bludgeoned a man to death when he was even younger than So-san.

People of the Black Way were used to people being frightened by their threats.

What about Woon-seong?

Woon-seong laughed in their faces. Then, he walked very naturally and stood in front of the boy.

He did not forget to lower his head and make brief eye contact with the boy, commenting, “You did a good job. They say Kangho is a place where only the strong survive, but it’s also a place where those who struggle to survive will become stronger.”

Woon-seong then turned to look at the men of the Black Way.

They were also looking at him.

None of them had bothered with the young man sitting in the corner, since he had just been looking so far. But now he had interrupted them!

“It looks like you have a death wish!”

The other man took out their weapons. Soon, the inn was filled with the smell of dirt and rusting iron.

But Woon-seong didn't care at all.

He continued to speak with Kang So-san, who was standing behind him.

“You were weak until now, but you just took your first step away from staying weak. Then I shall show you. What you can do when you can become strong...”

Woon-seong raised his fingertips.

At that moment, one of the Black Way couldn't stand his anger anymore and swung his blade at Woon-seong.

“What the fuck are you babbling about?!”

Rushing over, the man swung directly in front of Woon-seong, the blade whistling towards Woon-seong's forehead.

Woon-seong hadn't even drawn his spear yet.

His head will split in two. The skull will burst as blood and brains spew everywhere! Imagining the horrific outcome, Kang So-san suddenly scrunched his eyes shut.

However, an intangible energy gripped his eyelids, forcing them open.

— *Take a good look.*

That powerful voice rang in his ears.

Puchi!

Something pierced his head.

Of course, it was the Black Way man's head that was pierced, not Woon-seong's.

The weapon seemed to be a bamboo chopstick, like the ones used by guests.

“Ugh?” The man with the new bamboo headpiece muttered to himself, not understanding what had just happened.

But what could someone stabbed in the brain say?

Thud!

The man fell back, crumpling to the floor.

Woon-seong then spread his arms out.

Shh, shh, shh.

A mysterious energy spread throughout the inn and bamboo chopsticks floated into the air.

“W-What the hell?! The chopsticks... Are in the air...?”

One, two, three, four...

Kang So-san, who was counting the number of chopsticks, soon lost track.

Soon, all the bamboo chopsticks the Golden Sunset Inn owned were floating in the air, aimed at the men of the Black Way.

“Ugh...?”

“W-What?”

The men had just seen one of their colleagues skewered by a chopstick.

Somehow, the chopsticks floating in the air seemed sharper than they remembered.

At this point, they had realized the young man before them was an unimaginable monster.

They wished that they had been sick and hadn't stopped by the inn, wishing to be at home and in bed with their wives instead.

But it was always too late for regrets.

There was a man who spoke with difficulty: "A-Are you doing this knowing who's behind us?"

Woon-seong smiled.

The men had entered the inn speaking loudly about themselves.

"We're part of the Black Law Sect."

"I know."

"I-I see. So you didn't..." The man was furious at Woon-seong's words. How could he still have that attitude? "Wait, you know? You did this even while knowing that?"

Was there anyone in this neighborhood who could stay calm even after hearing the name of the Black Law Sect?

"Y-You seem to be an outsider, but if you mess with us, the Black Law Sect will be after you."

In response, Woon-seong leisurely sat down on one of the guest chairs. Crossing his legs, he sniggered, "There's a saying my master used to tell me..."

Woon-seong was speaking of Nok Yu-on.

“If you’re going to clean up the trash, don’t only do so with what’s in sight, but clean up the whole street.”

Suddenly hearing a story about masters and trash, the men of the Black Way made faces.

Ignoring their expressions, Woon-seong continued to speak.

“In Kangho, resentment is no light matter, so don’t pull out your sword so easily.”

As he said so, Woon-seong lifted his hand into the air.

Woo-hoo—

The chopsticks floating in the air trembled.

“But if you did... do not leave any trouble behind. Especially when you’re facing trash.”

With a flick of his hand, dozens of chopsticks fell from the sky.

Crack—

That day, in an area near the Qilian Mountains, a faction known as the Black Law Sect disappeared into flames.

Chapter 98: Destiny Or Fate (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 98 – Destiny or Fate (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The next day, Woon-seong woke up and tried to leave the Qilian Mountains as soon as possible.

He had only been in this town for one night but had already set the Black Law Sect on fire. Staying any longer could mean being caught up in another bothersome incident.

Woon-seong packed up and hurried down to the first floor.

“Good sir.”

There was someone who had arrived on the first floor even earlier.

It was the young boy, Kang So-san.

The boy’s face was pale and haggard, with deep purple bags under both eyes.

“It looks like you stayed up all night.”

So-san raised his hand and scratched the back of his neck, slightly embarrassed. “I’ve been waiting for you.”

“For me?” Woon-seong laughed. “I assumed the business between us ended yesterday. Not only did I help you, but I have also exterminated the Black Law Sect from the face of this world. Are you saying you need more than that?”

Woon-seong’s voice bordered on cold.

Last night, he had shown his skills for basically no reason. If So-san hadn’t reminded Woon-seong of himself, he never would have stepped in.

Of course, So-san had a reason to wield the knife...

Anyways, Woon-seong was done.

Hearing those words, the young boy looked a bit troubled. It was obvious that he had more to say, but Woon-seong silenced him with another look.

Woon-seong could already guess what So-san wanted to say.

“If so, I can’t help but think you’re being greedy.”

Woon-seong tried to leave the inn quickly and quietly.

He was a busy man.

Although Sang Gwan-chuk had found a doppelgänger to replace him as Heavenly Demon, Woon-seong needed to finish his travels and return to the Cult as soon as possible.

However, So-san’s voice caused him to stop.

“Mister!” the boy shouted, throwing himself in front of Woon-seong to forcibly stop his steps. “Please teach me how to fight.”

Woon-seong laughed. “I have already done that yesterday.”

How to break the mindset of a victim and to know when to retaliate. The determination to wield a weapon when necessary, that was the basis of combat.

But it didn't seem to be the case for Kang So-san.

The boy fell to the floor, knocking his head on the ground.

Since he was so young, he looked quite ridiculous.

But there was sincerity in his movements.

The boy's forehead turned red and bloody, proving that he had smacked his head on the ground quite hard. Perhaps a small scar would form if the wound was left untreated.

"I have thought about it all night. Is it really over with the Black Law Sect? Will nobody bully us now that they are gone?"

Woon-seong titled his head slowly, unsure of what the boy was trying to say.

"We don't live with our parents. We weren't orphans... But they pushed themselves too far to buy this inn. They passed away within a year of buying this inn. And ever since, the two of us started running this place..."

As he spoke, the young boy started to cry. Unlike the poisonous eyes from yesterday, his eyes now only carried grief.

"But people started targeting our inn just because we're young! Some try to take down this inn and start a new business, and some try to buy this place for an unreasonably cheap price. Some of them approached my sister like the Black Law Sect did."

"..."

"I'm sure that the Black Law Sect won't be the last of them. The Black Law Sect will be gone... But some other group will be after us for a different reason. Because we're young and weak..."

Kang So-san slowly got up from the floor, clenching his fists. He wiped away the tears pouring down his face.

“So please, teach me how to fight. So I can protect my sister!”

Woon-seong shook his head. “I’m sure you can learn martial arts at dojos.”

“Dojos don’t teach you unless you pay them money. Running an inn like this is nowhere enough for that. I need a fortune to learn martial arts...”

Woon-seong slowly closed his eyes.

There was a time where he had been like that, too. A long time ago, before he met his master, Nok Yu-on.

At the time, Woon-seong had been wandering the streets as an orphan.

Seeing the strong martial artists, he admired them from afar.

Once, the young Woon-seong visited a dojo to learn martial arts. But he ended up not learning anything there. In exchange for becoming a sandbag for the other children, the dojo promised it would teach Woon-seong some martial arts. He ended up becoming sick after being used as a sandbag for ten days.

Damn it. Why is this happening?

Why is this boy reminding me of my past so much?

Is this supposed to be some kind of fate? Just like how I had the opportunity to live another life for revenge?

Then why is this damn fate only stimulating these fucking shitty memories?

Woon-seong grit his teeth.

But I’m not going to simply play along with this.

If I were to do that, I would’ve intervened even before this boy wielded his knife yesterday.

“There is a place I need to be. I don’t have time to teach you martial arts.”

“I’ll follow you.”

Woon-seong smiled. Although Kang So-san had thought about this all night, he was still a child in the end.

Kang So-san had forgotten about something.

“Then what about your sister?”

“My sister?”

“That’s right. If you leave here, your sister will be left alone. Didn’t you want to learn martial arts because you wish to protect her?”

When asked this, Kang So-san clenched his fists tightly and gripped the edge of his shirt. He hadn’t thought that far ahead.

He had only thought that he would follow Woon-seong, learn to be strong and protect his sister.

He hadn’t thought about the present.

He seems about fourteen in age, Woon-seong guessed. Considering his small physique, maybe he’s closer to twelve.

“...”

It makes sense that such a young child forgot to consider that aspect.

Kang So-san did not answer for a long time.

On his behalf, the answer came from inside the kitchen.

“Then we’ll both follow you.”

Woon-seong turned to look.

He had known that the sister was in the kitchen from the beginning.

Even so, I didn't expect this reaction. Woon-seong clicked his tongue lightly. He thought that the sister would stop So-san, but instead she wished to follow him too!

The sister left the kitchen and politely settled in front of Woon-seong, right next to her brother. She then bowed.

“If you allow it, I will also follow you. I know another person means more trouble, but if you teach my brother martial arts, I can do household chores and cook.”

“Noona...”

At her words, Kang So-san could not help but call out, and she reached out to grab his hand.

“Huh...” Woon-seong sighed heavily at her words.

Alternately looking between the girl and the inn, he asked, “I thought this inn was bought by the hard work of your parents. It is your inheritance. Can you sell it off that easily?”

At his words, the girl walked slowly to one side and swept her hand across the wall. Her eyes danced with memories, but her words were clear and decisive:

“It is the only thing our parents left behind, but it shouldn't get in the way of my brother's future. We don't know much because we're still young, but we understand how remarkable what you showed us yesterday was.”

“...”

“And if a person like you can become my brother's master, there is nothing more we can ask for.”

What selfish words.

She understood that they would be a nuisance to Woon-seong, but was more concerned with her brother's future and well-being.

But somehow, Woon-seong could not find it in himself to hate that selfishness.

All he felt was a sister's love for her younger brother.

Would I have been the same if I had a family?

No, it did not have to be a family.

Woon-seong had people who loved and cared for him like so.

Master...

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

Like this boy has his sister, I had my two masters.

People who taught me everything despite my origins.

After organizing his thoughts, Woon-seong opened his eyes.

He first looked at Kang So-san before turning his attention to the girl.

“What is your name?”

“Ye-ha. It is Kang Ye-ha.”

“Good.”

After remembering her name, he turned back to So-san. “I decided to give you a chance because of your sister's words.”

At his words, Kang So-san and Kang Ye-ha beamed.

But what Woon-seong had said was a chance.

“I'll take you with me if you pass this test.”

Woon-seong waved his hand. There was a sharp gust of wind in the inn and a wooden chair was cut. He made a smooth wooden plaque with a few more

swipes.

He then wrote in the air.

Fwoom—

The aura of the Divine Flame appeared as Woon-seong hovered near the wooden plaque.

Soon, words were burnt into the wood.

It was a martial art.

Of course, it was not an exceptional one.

Woon-seong had chosen one from the collections of the Spear Master Sect. At best, it was a little bit better than the Three Heart Method. However, it was still a good choice to accumulate qi if used regularly.

Woon-seong placed the complete plaque in front of the boy. “Do you know how to read?”

“Yes, a little bit.”

Woon-seong nodded and pointed at the plaque. “Starting today, study this.”

“Study this?”

“Yes. And also...”

Woon-seong raised his head slightly.

A wooden chopstick from the kitchen flew into his hands.

With a swinging motion, Woon-seong pointed it at a wall. The chopstick smoothly sliced through the wooden wall, leaving a marking.

This was a mark produced through simple muscle strength with no martial arts involved.

Although it stretched from the left all the way to the right, it was only about half a finger's length deep.

“By the time I come back after I'm done with my business, if you can imitate this sword mark, I'll take you two with me.”

A relationship that was simply passing by, or one where fate was inevitable.

The choice would be made by them.

Woon-seong took a step away, heading towards the Spear Master Sect.

Outside, the sun was just rising.

Chapter 99: Secret Vault (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 99 – Secret Vault (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

City of Hezuo.

“It’s been a while.”

Woon-seong stood on the hills and smiled as he looked off into the distance. He had changed a lot since his last visit, but the hills and valleys remained the same.

What greeted Woon-seong was memories.

The hill he was standing on was one he used to frequent with his master.

Nok Yu-on loved the view from this cliff which overlooked the other hills, choosing to stand here and watch the sunset. Whenever they visited Hezuo, they would stand here and watch the sky.

After so long, Woon-seong began to love that view too.

Were there tears in his eyes or was the setting sun shining a little brighter today?

All sorts of emotions rose in him as the scenery made him remember precious memories. For once, his thoughts of the past did not center around

pain and revenge.

“Master...”

I assume his remains are just lying abandoned somewhere back in that mountain. It's been quite a long time. Can I recover it...?

That's practically impossible.

Ten years is enough for even bones to wither away.

All I can do is make a memorial tablet and personally celebrate his anniversary in my memories.

I know this is the cold hard reality, but still...

Woon-seong could not help but be troubled.

As he sighed, the sun had already set and a glorious darkness was sweeping across the sky.

I shouldn't waste any more time.

Woon-seong hurriedly entered Hezuo.

It was around evening, so many people were still walking around the market streets. Some people came out to buy snacks, other people walked around drunk.

Woon-seong quickly travelled through the town and to the outskirts.

In Hezuo, there were a total of three shrines for Guan Yu [1].

The one Woon-seong was headed towards was the oldest of the three.

Opening the old doors, Woon-seong could see the inside of a dusty tower. There were cobwebs everywhere, making it obvious that the shrine was poorly maintained.

The shrine was cold and damp, as if it had just been raining.

Inside, the statue of Lord Guan stood alone.

Even the floor was covered in dust, so Woon-seong's steps left footprints behind.

Lord Guan Yu was the Martial God of Loyalty and Righteousness, but the shrine looked too dilapidated to be a place where a deity was worshipped.

That being said, there were two other shrines in Hezuo...

At least the praying mats and surrounding areas were still relatively clean.

Lord Guan Yu was a mortal warrior whose stories had been glorified after his death. Although he was a war hero when he was alive, it was only after his death that he received titles of nobility, each higher than the last.

This shrine, at least, was more of a proof of reverence towards a military prodigy than belief in a deity.

Woon-seong approached the statue with familiar steps.

Then, he tapped the fingers of the statue a few times.

They were very light taps.

Boom, boom, boom, boom.

Soon, whirring and thumping could be heard.

Of course, tapping on the statue a few times was not the only thing he needed to do. That was just preparation to get into the vault.

The door to the vault is hidden here.

After tapping the fingers, Woon-seong walked around the statue. Shuffling a few steps to the side, he lightly pushed the statue.

The statue was not as heavy as it seemed so it proved no problem to the well-trained Woon-seong.

And something amazing happened.

Krrr—

As the statue was pushed to the side, it revealed a passageway just wide enough for a singular person.

He spread his senses to look around, also turning his head to glance behind him. His qi spread through the area like a net, reaching about 5 li (2.5km).
There's no one here.

Woon-seong didn't detect anything other than the movements of a few mountain beasts.

Few could deceive the senses of a Semi-Divine Being.

Thus, Woon-seong entered the passageway.

Once Woon-seong walked down the stairs, the passageway automatically closed behind him.

With a loud *krrr*, the statue of Lord Guan Yu moved, causing the entrance to the vault to disappear once more.

The stairs led to another long, dark passageway.

But this didn't matter to Woon-seong.

Not only had he become accustomed to darkness during the training in the Cave of Latent Demons, his training with Cheon Hwi had allowed his senses to become extremely sensitive.

As a Semi-Divine Being, Woon-seong had reached a point where he did not need light at all.

Not caring about the time, he walked forward.

His surroundings suddenly changed.

With a single step, the darkness disappeared. At the same time, he was suddenly faced with a cool breeze and a bamboo forest.

Such a perfect boundary could not be natural.

That's because it wasn't natural.

It was an illusion called the 'Nine Hundred Bamboo's installed by an ancestor of the Spear Master Sect.

Instead of looking nervous, Woon-seong's face showed that he had actually missed this bamboo grove.

Due to it being an illusion, the bamboo grove would always look the same — from the day it was installed to the day it would be destroyed.

It made him sentimental.

But he could not stay for long.

The Nine Hundred Bamboos was an illusion art designed so that the target became distracted by the bamboo forest, spending time watching the scenery until they lost their sense of time and direction.

Woon-seong walked a bit faster.

In fact, if he wanted to, he could tear up the whole illusion formation with his strength. The Nine Hundred Bamboos was a powerful illusion, but it wasn't much before Woon-seong. With his knowledge of the formation itself, he could easily disable and destroy it.

But that was not an option.

The illusion was an important way to protect the Spear Master Sect's legacy.

Woon-seong would never compromise that.

After walking a few more minutes, the landscape changed once more.

Again, it was a sudden change, but he did not panic.

It was only natural for the landscape to change as soon as he stepped out of the illusion.

What stood out in this new area?

A steel door locked with three layers of mechanical devices.

The pattern to unlock it was... Move the handle left three times and right five times, I believe.

Kacha—

From inside, Woon-seong could hear the locks of the machine opening in succession. Shortly after that, the door began to open.

The safehouse of the Spear Master Sect stored records of martial arts and martial studies, documenting all the glorious achievements and unscrupulous conspiracies of decades past.

The complicated security measures were necessary.

In the past, there were many who targeted these records kept by the Spear Master Sect.

Even one of the texts flowing into Kangho would cause a fuss.

It might not be a major blood-shedding event, but there would still be casualties.

To protect such precious records, the Spear Master Sect had built such a hideout.

Klang—

Once the door was opened, the interior of the vault was revealed. On the surface, the secret vault was reminiscent of an ordinary library.

This place... Although it's nothing comparable to the Shaolin's Record House or the Divine Cult's Divine Vault of Demonic Sea, if we take into account the interpretations made through martial studies, its value is nothing short of those two.

Woon-seong walked inside, ignoring all of the shelves. *And if my master wanted to hide something here, there is only one place.*

Soon, he arrived at the bookshelf farthest to the back.

While all the other shelves showed the traces of time, this one and the one next to it were slightly different.

The shelf at the very end seemed to have been created very recently. The one next to it was a little older, but not as old as the others.

“Master.”

Woon-seong bowed before the bookshelf.

The slightly older bookshelf had the name ‘Nok Yu-on’ carved into it, the name of Woon-seong’s master.

The newest bookshelf had the name ‘Hyuk Woon-seong’.

Woon-seong’s bookshelf was only a tenth full.

It had been bought on the day Woon-seong was officially registered as the apprentice of Nok Yu-on, inheritor of the Spear Master Sect.

At the time, Nok Yu-on had shown Woon-seong his own bookshelf, saying:
“My goal is to fill this bookshelf with my own martial studies. The predecessors of the Spear Master Sect have done so too. You should also aim to fill your own shelf.”

Of course, Nok Yu-on had not achieved his goal. His shelf was only about half full.

Woon-seong carefully examined the shelf.

It's mostly filled with books related to martial studies.

But there is just one item which isn't a book, that red wooden box.

Woon-seong carefully grabbed it. Clicking it open, he found a neatly folded letter and a long knife.

On the side of the knife was inlaid with seven pieces of jade. Of them, the fifth one was black, while all the others were white.

What is this knife?

Woon-seong glanced at the knife for a moment, before lowering it to open the letter.

It was a message left for Woon-seong by Nok Yu-on.

“If you have reached this place, then it must mean you have survived. And it would also mean that I no longer live in this world. However, I am glad at least you survived, my apprentice.”

Apparently that was a must for a teacher.

Woon-seong seemed to shed tears as soon as he saw Nok Yu-on's writing. Although it was a written letter, he could almost hear his master's voice.

Even as he wrote this letter, Nok Yu-on had been worried about his disciple.

“Master...”

Woon-seong grit his teeth.

Then, fighting back his tears, he continued to read the letter.

[1] Guan Yu was a Chinese military general who served under the warlord Liu Bei during the late Eastern Han Dynasty. He was immortalized in the popular novel *Romance of the Three Kingdoms* and deified as the Martial God of Loyalty and Righteousness

Chapter 100: Secret Vault (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 100 – Secret Vault (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Although, as your master, I wish you not to be involved in this matter.”

That was something he read, but it made Woon-seong waver. His eyes trembled.

It was said that reaching the Semi-Divine Realm meant that a martial artist had stepped past the threshold of becoming a god, but they were clearly still human in the end.

A human had feelings and emotions.

As such, Woon-seong could not get rid of the feelings the letter evoked.

“Why...is that?”

His master did not want him to get involved, but how long had he been aiming for revenge?

Woon-seong tightened his grip on the letter, trembling.

So he did know about something. Something he didn't tell me...

He calmed himself down enough to keep reading.

“...do not be interested in this matter and forget about it for the rest of your life.”

I can't do that, Master.

If he did, he would have to deny the meaning of his existence.

Like answering his master's resolute words, Woon-seong also resolved his will.

Meanwhile, he read the letter from the start once more.

“It is simply too dangerous for you. So do not be interested in this matter and forget about it for the rest of your life. That is the only way for you to live a longer life.”

That said, Woon-seong smiled. This time through, his master's concern was clearly conveyed.

The only reason he wrote this letter with such firm words was because he worried about me.

That's just like him.

“And I do not wish for you to waste time on revenge, because it is guaranteed to be a bloody path.”

“Master.”

Woon-seong understood, but it was too late to turn back.

It was too late to give up on revenge.

Woon-seong had spent the entirety of his second life preparing for revenge.

Vengeance was his sole purpose of his new life.

Moreover, Woon-seong had now lost not one, but two masters.

Nok Yu-on and Cheon Hwi.

Two, not one.

That was why Woon-seong could not give up here.

And unlike what Nok Yu-on wished, Woon-seong had died that day.

I don't know if you were aware, but Jwa Do-gyul and his gang attacked us that day with the intention of ending the line of the Spear Master Sect.

Your wish for me to survive and continue the legacy of the Spear Master Sect has practically been destroyed.

However, I have earned an opportunity.

The opportunity for revenge!

Woon-seong snarled as he recalled the face of Jwa Do-gyul.

He turned back to the letter.

“However, if you truly desire to bring justice to Murim, do read what continues.”

Justice.

That was the word Nok Yu-on used. Even as he was dying from a poisonous scheme, he was a man who called for righteous vengeance and not dirty revenge.

Then, what of Nok Yu-on's apprentice?

Master... There is no more justice inside me.

Heroes and righteous men tend to die early.

I won't go astray from the path of a human, but I won't become a hero either...

That is what I have pledged.

Therefore, forgive me, as I will continue to read this not for justice, but simply for vengeance.

For the purpose of stabbing my deep grudge into the heart of Jwa Dogyul...

Woon-seong only wanted to know the truth about the demonic text the Spear Master Sect had been framed with.

He had no need for great causes such as justice.

Although it was different from what Nok Yu-on hoped, Woon-seong continued to read.

The first part of the letter ended there.

Woon-seong turned the paper over, glancing at the back.

On the other side was the reason the Spear Master Sect was framed.

Hmm?

Or not.

The writing on the back was not what Woon-seong expected.

It was another short message.

“If you have decided to bring justice to Murim, take the knife and the letter contained with it and go to the City of Yichang in Hubei Province. Find the master of the Justice Blood Sect. He will tell the truth to everything you want to know. Burn this message after you finish reading it.”

There was not a single mention as to why the Spear Master Sect had been framed.

There was only a plan for what Woon-seong should do next, like visiting Hubei and burning the letter.

Woon-seong could not take his eyes off the paper.

It was because of the final thing written, at the very end of the letter.

“Finally, my apprentice, I love you.”

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

Just as his mind had barely been calmed down, his emotions were sent into a mess again.

His eyes darkened.

Woon-seong tamped down on all of his emotions. Having this kind of heart was only allowed after he had finished his revenge and placed the heads of his enemies before his master’s grave.

Before that, emotional outbursts were strictly forbidden.

Reigning in his emotions, Woon-seong opened his eyes.

He looked at the letter in his hand.

It was not a long letter, but it was one written by his master.

This letter may be the last thing remaining of my master. But he wants me to burn it?

I don’t want to do that. I want to keep it like a treasure...

But my master wouldn’t say such words without a reason... There must be a reason why he said that.

“Sigh...”

Woon-seong sighed to himself.

Then he raised the letter and injected the Divine Flame into the paper.

Crackle—

The paper immediately started to burn, starting from the corner and gradually spreading.

Woon-seong paused for a moment.

One corner was not getting incinerated for some reason.

The flame refused to touch one part of the letter as if there was something special protecting the paper there.

Woon-seong glanced at the corner.

Were those words?

It was one last sentence, the last message Nok Yu-on had desperately hid with all his strength and intended to convey to Woon-seong.

Woon-seong read the sentence aloud.

“Believe not the Imperial Court...?”

Once Woon-seong read the words, the Divine Flame wiped out the sentence, as if the strength of the fire-proofing had run out.

Fwoom—

Do not believe the Imperial Court.

After the letter became a pile of ashes, Woon-seong ruminated over the final sentence.

My master says not to believe the Imperial Court.

How should I interpret this?

Does it mean that the Imperial Court is not in a normal state, just like Sage Do Jin-myung said? Did the Cult of the Inverted Sky take over the Imperial Court?

Hmm.

Does it mean that my master discovered this over a decade ago?

Woon-seong groaned. Perhaps all the answers would be found at the Justice Blood Sect.

He raised the knife up to look at it.

A dagger containing seven pieces of jade.

The black fifth piece of jade caught his eyes. Why was that piece black?

Jade was often used to make accessories, serving as an ornamental stone.

Of course, jade was also believed to harness the yin-yang of nature, allowing it to become the imperial gem.

Woon-seong could not believe he had to show the Justice Blood Sect a sword with jade stuck into it.

This knife had to be some kind of symbol.

The City of Yichang in Hubei Province...

That was a long way from Gansu Province. But it was also on the way towards King Jinseong's palace.

Thinking like that, Woon-seong muttered, "Not an easy road."

Not an easy road.

What Woon-seong was thinking about was not simply the problem of distance.

Hubei Province was one of the most rough and dangerous places in Murim.

Hubei Province was home to the Shaolin and Wudang Sects, which were two of the most admired Ten Great Sects.

It also happened to be home to the Jegal Family [1], a group of machine masters known as the most intelligent people in Murim history.

Most of all, the headquarters of the Martial Alliance was located in the city of Hankou.

Some of the most powerful groups of the Orthodox side were situated in Hubei.

And the leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon entering there?

If anyone finds out, even I won't be able to escape in one piece.

My level of martial arts has already reached the level of 'perfection and return to the truth' (爐火純青, 返撲歸真). It would be safe to assume that there is practically nobody who can sense the force of a demonic practitioner from me.

It should be impossible unless they were someone in the realm of the Twin Stars.

But according to what is known, there was almost no chance of me encountering the Twin Stars.

The two guardians of Murim, the Twin Stars.

The Buddhist Star had hidden himself in the Shaolin Temple for years and showed no signs of coming out. There were rumors that he had already passed away. Since there was no news from the Shaolin, he was probably just preoccupied.

And the Sword Star? He was known to isolate himself even further. As a matter of fact, his current residence was in Mount Paektu [2]. Having

retreated to that mountain, he rarely came out unless something special happened.

Therefore people said that the Buddhist Star had hidden in the Buddhist Mind and the Sword Star was strolling about in the Forest of Swords.

The Twin Stars would probably not appear. Unless something truly unusual happened, Woon-seong could set worries about them aside.

The problem was Jwa Do-gyul.

Although there was a good distance between Yichang and Hankou, Yichang was still within reach of the Martial Alliance.

It was a slim chance, but Woon-seong could not completely deny the possibility of encountering Jwa Do-gyul.

And when that happens, can I suppress my anger?

I was able to suppress my boiling rage until now, but that was since I didn't see his face.

Can I possibly stay calm when I see his face...

The qi from the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body coursed through Woon-seong's body. The strength of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, which had been boosted by body modification, not only relaxed his muscles and reinvigorated his blood, it also served to calm his mind.

Meanwhile, a ship carrying Woon-seong charged through the Yangtze River.

[1] The Zhuge, or Jegal, surname is basically synonymous with wisdom and strategy due to Zhuge Liang and *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*

[2] Paektu Mountain, also known as Changbai Mountain, is located on the Chinese-North Korean border.

Chapter 101: Acting (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 101 – Acting (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Mount Wuyi, Fujian.

A man named Han was digging the ground with a shovel in his hand. After a few moments of digging, he stopped to lean on his shovel. Raising his head, he looked up at the sky and complained.

“Whew. What a pain.”

The others around him nodded in harmony.

“I just want to finish this already and go down for a drink.”

“Same here.”

Complaints could be heard from all around.

It was hard not to complain if you had to dig all day with a shovel.

Even though there was a nice breeze, the workers were soaked with sweat.

At that time, one of the workers suddenly asked, “By the way, what exactly are we digging for here?”

Someone muttered as if they were answering, “What? You didn’t hear anything? They say there’s an iron vein somewhere down here.”

The story began to get muddy from there.

“Iron veins? I heard it’s silver?”

“Really? I thought it was gold...”

Everyone had a different answer.

It was clear no one knew what was buried on this mountain.

“So nobody knows what we’re even digging for.”

After all the commotion, the oldest worker, Kwak, spoke. “Meh. That’s a problem for the higher-ups. We just have to worry about getting paid.”

After thinking about it, Han nodded. “Hmmm. I guess you’re right.”

“Right?”

Han nodded his head reluctantly once more.

However, Han had a bad feeling. His gut feeling was warning him of something dangerous.

After so many years on the job, Han was very trusting of his sixth sense.

Whenever he began to feel anxious for no reason, something bad always happened.

For example, the last job he’d taken. One day he had taken a day off because of an upset stomach. At the work site, there had been a sudden avalanche that day and none of the workers present had survived.

If Han had ignored his gut feeling, he would have been caught up in the landslide too.

It's worse than back when that avalanche happened.

It could just be a coincidence.

Either way, Han wouldn't even be here if it weren't for a sudden increase in his gambling debt.

Ugh. Damn gambling debt... When I'm done with this and pay off my debt, I'm not gambling ever again.

Han sighed to himself. He then turned to yell at a young man, who was still working hard.

“Hey there. How about you rest a little too? Simply pushing yourself without rest isn't the smartest way to do this job, you know!”

The young man stopped shoveling, turning around to face the other workers.

“Haha, it's okay. I just want to get a bit more done. I'll take a break after I finish this part.”

The young man was obviously more sincere than the other workers. Thanks to his diligence and youth, his reputation amongst the workers was very good.

Hearing his words, compliments immediately began to follow.

“What a diligent young man.”

“If I had a daughter, I would've sent a marriage request immediately.”

“Your daughter? I'm not sure if she could marry anyone if she had a face like yours.”

“What?!”

“Ahahaha!”

“Shut up, you idiots!”

However, the praises of the workers soon led to lighthearted teasing.

Maybe it was because of the laughter, but a young supervisor, who had been overseeing some other workers, came running over.

“Misters! What are you all doing here? If the higher-ups find out that you guys are slacking off like this, we will all get into trouble.”

This young supervisor, who was named Jang Baek-gi, was also popular among the workers because he was nice.

As soon as he appeared, the workers stood up and smiled, dusting off their clothing.

“Look. It’s your nagging supervisor boy again.”

“We get it, we get it. We’ll get back to work.”

Jang Baek-gi faked being upset, but he was smiling too.

The warm atmosphere showed that their relationship seemed to go beyond that of mere supervisor and laborer.

It was then that a strange sound was heard.

Clang—

“Huh?”

While the other workers had been resting, the young man continued to shovel dirt. Apparently, his shovel had just hit something.

““What’s wrong?””

“Did you find a gold vein or something?”

The other workers gathered around him, causing a commotion.

The young man slowly looked down, wiping the dirt away with his hands.

The identity of the object the shovel hit was clearly revealed.

“Isn’t this... a coffin?”

It was indeed a coffin, surrounded by stone tablets on all four sides. The stone tables seemed to have various paintings on them, but they were weathered by the soil.

Han, who had studied a variety of things, walked up and muttered, “A coffin...? Is this place supposed to be a grave? It looks like it’s the grave of no ordinary man. Just look at all the paintings on the grave walls.”

It was more correct to say that all four paintings on the walls were part of the same large mural, depicting a hell-like battlefield.

Since the late Han Dynasty, murals were generally used to decorate palaces or statue altars. It was strange to see one decorating a tomb.

“Looking at the style, I assume this is pretty old.”

“Yes. At least 400 to 500 years old.”

“Wow. This was the last thing I was expecting to see from digging this place... Is this supposed to be expensive?”

“It should be priceless. On top of that, grave wall paintings sometimes turn out to be secret martial art materials. And if that’s the case, the price skyrockets again.”

At the appearance of the coffin, there was a commotion as everyone started chattering.

Meanwhile, the young supervisor Jang Baek-gi approached to take a look. Then, eyes glinting mysteriously, his hand went to grab something near his waist. “This is it. This is what we were looking for...”

Unlike how it had sounded before, Jang Baek-gi's voice was now deep and cold.

“Hmm? You're saying we weren't looking for a silver or gold mine, but this grave...?”

Confused, Han turned around and at that moment...

“Ah?”

Kacha—

Han's head had already been detached from his neck and flew into the air.

He'd just been beheaded.

The face of the man surnamed Han showed that he had not even realized he was dead. As his head spun in the air, his brain was still wondering why his body was now invisible.

Pu-huack—!

A fountain of blood sprayed everywhere.

Standing beneath the blood shower, Jang Baek-gi licked his lips. In his hands was a sword, one no one had seen him pull out.

“Now that I've found everything I need, you people are useless.”

The one standing there...

The Jang Baek-gi standing there was no longer a warm supervisor.

“Everything is for the Inverted Sky...”

He was just a faithful fanatic.

That day, none of the workers on Mount Wuyi survived.

The cause was said to be a forest fire.

Within the flames, the truth vanished into ashes.

The coffin and Jang Baek-gi disappeared like smoke, leaving behind only burnt skeletons.

But people did not know that similar incidents were happening not only in Fujian, but several places around the world.

Thanks to the invention of the boat, it did not take Woon-seong long for him to reach his destination.

City of Yichang, Hubei Province.

“So this is Yichang...”

This city was always crowded with merchants because it was a popular place for boats to come and go.

If the Justice Blood Sect was a fairly famous sect, Woon-seong could just ask anyone on the street about it.

So he asked around.

But...

“Is there such a sect in Yichang?”

“Never heard of them.”

“I’ve lived here for quite some time, but I’ve never heard of the Justice Blood Sect.”

No matter how many people Woon-seong stopped and asked, no one knew about the Blood Justice Sect.

He even commissioned a nearby branch of the Curiosity Sect, but the answer was the same.

Even the Curiosity Sect doesn't have a clue...

Out of the fifteen local sects in Yichang, there is not a single sect named the Justice Blood Sect.

Woon-seong stood in the middle of the street, closing his eyes.

Did it disappear over the past decade?

That might be possible.

Dozens of new sects were born and disappeared every day.

But soon he shook his head.

No, that's not it.

If that was the case, the Curiosity Sect would have said so. They were not a pleasant bunch, but they didn't hide information if you had money.

If so, they must be under a different name.

Or hiding in the shadows...

Woon-seong opened his eyes.

Yichang was a large place where numerous people came and went.

Even if he picked out only the martial artists, their number would be in the hundreds.

And if he wanted to find the Justice Blood Sect amongst them...?

It was easier to find a needle in a haystack.

In other words, it was almost impossible to find them without any clues.

But it wasn't like all hope was lost.

There was one way to find them.

I should make them come find me.

With that, Woon-seong set off.

Soon, he sat down in an inn with a plate of food, a brush, and some paper.

After eating, the first thing he did was take out a piece of paper to create a poster.

The content was simple.

There were no words and only a simple drawing.

A knife with seven pieces of jade, the fifth piece black.

Woon-seong made dozens of these drawings and pasted them all around the first floor of the inn, where people were sure to see them.

He essentially made a trail of posters leading to his room, the last poster being attached near his door.

“The Justice Blood Sect would know what this drawing means.”

I also set my room on the second floor, where I can keep an eye on every person entering this inn.

So Woon-seong sat and waited, gazing down at the first floor with a relaxed expression.

After a few minutes and some furtive glances, one of the posters was ripped off the wall.

The Justice Blood Sect had begun to move.

Chapter 102: Acting (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 102 – Acting (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

A quiet hillside not far from the city center.

There was a house made of rotting wooden planks.

It was a place where courageous children, as well as adults, were reluctant to enter because of rumors of ghost sightings.

An old, abandoned and haunted house.

There were those who used this house as a secret meeting place.

If other people knew, they would have lauded these people as brave.

But the people converged here as if there were no ghosts to begin with.

It was they who built this house, purposely making it look worn and torn, creating rumors to make sure no one would trespass.

Clearly, the rumors about the place were faked.

That was why everyone gathered looked relaxed.

There were a total of four people gathered today.

Three men and one woman.

It was the woman who spoke first. Straightening in her seat, she said:
“Hmm. We should go meet him, right?”

One of the men sitting across from her replied. He was a man with stubble.
“The fact that he spread the drawings of the Five Jade Knife everywhere must mean he’s looking for us.”

“No. To be precise, it means he can’t find us so he’s telling us to come find him.”

It was a younger man who corrected the elder’s words. Or at least, this man looked about ten years younger.

Even though the younger looking man had corrected him, the older looking one said nothing. The others in the room didn’t care much either.

That was because the younger looking man was actually the oldest amongst them.

Of course, seniority had nothing to do with why they were gathered here now.

Instead, the third man, one with a thin jaw, looked around and said: “Boss. Since he did show up with the Fifth Jade Knife, it’s likely that he’s the new master of the Fifth Jade Knife, which we thought was forgotten. But that doesn’t mean we should go meet him without some plan.”

The woman nodded, agreeing. “That’s right. But before we test him, we need to check if he’s really the master of the Fifth Jade Knife.”

What if he wasn’t actually the owner? That would be bad.

The young looking man suddenly spoke up once more. “He probably is.”

“Really?”

The young looking man nodded. “When he hung up the drawings, I kept an eye on him while hiding amongst the people. On his waist, he was wearing a curved jade knife. I’m sure that the fifth piece of jade was black.”

A curved jade knife where the fifth jade is colored black.

That was enough as evidence to prove the young man the new owner of the Fifth Jade Knife.

In addition, the young man had come with the knife and was trying to contact the Justice Blood Sect. He was clearly aware of the knife’s usage.

“Then he must be the master of the Five Jade Knife!”

“Yes. But there’s still one mystery.”

“I thought you were sure that he’s the new master? What else are you not sure about, Boss?”

The young looking man calmly explained: “The former master of the Fifth Jade Knife was the head of the Spear Master Sect, the Spearmaster Nok Yu-on. But Sect Master Nok Yu-on was killed as a victim of the Martial Alliance’s conspiracy. The Fifth Jade Knife was known to be lost at that time, so how did it appear right now?”

At that, there was a sudden silence.

None of them had ever met Nok Yu-on before, but they had all heard about the Spear Master Sect.

Moreover, they all knew that the destruction of the sect stemmed from a conspiracy, so it was difficult for them to speak of the death of such a respected person.

“So you’re saying that this man might be using the knife for some ulterior motives and is trying to contact us for that reason.”

“Yes. We must not forget that possibility.”

The situation had suddenly become more complex.

Suddenly, the woman stood up.

“Either way, we should test him. If he’s really worthy of becoming the master of the Five Jade Knife, he would be able to pass easily.”

The three men nodded in unison.

“If he’s worthy of joining the Justice Blood Sect, that is...”

By evening, many people had come into the inn for dinner.

Even then, Woon-seong was still quietly watching the first floor.

A drawing went missing about two hours ago... The Justice Blood Sect isn't making any noticeable moves yet, but there should be some reaction soon.

But Woon-seong wasn't nervous at all.

Maybe tomorrow evening. Tonight, if they move quickly.

He emptied his cup slowly.

While Woon-seong was drinking alcohol by himself, other people had also arrived since the afternoon and ordered alcohol themselves.

Some of them were townsmen, others were merchants passing by.

Of course, there were even some martial artists.

If a martial artist with a sword became drunk, there would always be a commotion.

“Excuse me?!”

On the first floor, a man slammed his fist on the table and stood up.

“Hmph. I’m just stating the facts! What’s wrong with calling a third-rate sect third-rate? The Loyal Light Sect? Never heard of it!”

The other man drew his sword. “You bastard! You think the Sword Body Sect is any better?! I’ll make you pay for insulting our sect!”

Sching—

The man supposedly from the Sword Body Sect also drew out his sword. Since his opponent had drawn a weapon out first, there was nothing wrong with doing the same thing!

Under that atmosphere, the disciple of the Sword Body Sect shouted loudly, “Those are my words! I’ll cut off your limbs and—!”

It was then.

Wa-pang—!

Someone flew through the window and into the inn.

The person — a woman — slammed into the floor.

Why was it raining glass and people?

Shards of glass fell to the floor and the woman rolled onto the ground miserably.

The men, who were seconds away from fighting, immediately retreated in haste.

The woman crawled into a standing position, holding her sword in hand. “Help!”

“What do you mean?”

“What’s going on?”

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“I am Lim Soo-yeon, an apprentice of the Jewel Sword Sect. I was traveling through Murim but stumbled into a nearby group of the Black Way and got caught in a fight... They’re chasing after me right now.”

“The Jewel Sword Sect... It’s not far from Yichang.”

“Isn’t it quite a famous sect?”

Even from ten years ago, I’ve heard of that name. It must be quite a large sect, Woon-seong thought.

A disciple of such a sect was being chased by the Black Way.

Woon-seong should have stepped up and helped her.

But...

“Where are you running?”

“Do you think anybody will help you, you bitch?”

“If there’s anybody who dares to get in our way, I can guarantee you will die early!”

Three men flew into the inn through the now broken window. All three had weapons in their hands.

They were obviously powerful too.

Whenever the swordsman moved his sword, the light seemed to split wherever it touched.

A big guy who’s a quick swordsman who can perform a spectrum? That’s proof that he’s a first-rate warrior alright, deduced Woon-seong.

“Who dares get in our way?”

“Is it you?”

“N-No. I was simply here before her.”

“Then is it you?”

“No. I’m the same.”

The two squabbling men from earlier retreated.

Lim Soo-yeon, the supposed disciple of the Jewel Sword Sect, had tears in her eyes as she glanced around the inn. “I-Is nobody going to help me?”

Woon-seong was smiling as if this was all very interesting. *Oh, for Heaven’s sake...*

Then he coughed and sat down on the railing of the second floor.

“Enough with this.”

The voice causes the people to raise their heads.

When they looked up, they saw Woon-seong sitting on the ledge.

“What did you just say?”

“So it looks like you have a death wish!”

Their voices were still confident.

Woon-seong sighed deeply. Then he picked up his cup and the bottle of alcohol.

It looks like I don’t have a choice.

Woon-seong jumped off of the ledge.

At that moment, the cup in Woon-seong’s hand flew into the air.

Pah!

The cup smacked the swordsman's forehead straight on, causing him to fall down.

The swordsman had fainted.

Woon-seong landed softly near him.

“Y-You bastard!”

“You’ll pay for this!”

The other two men dove towards Woon-seong.

Woon-seong sighed again and gently drank some of the alcohol, storing it in his mouth.

And...

Phew!

He spat out the alcohol, the liquor flying through the air like a powerful arrow.

These droplets of alcohol struck the other two men.

With a thump, the two men had fallen too.

“Ugh!”

“Fuck!”

Unlike the swordsman, who fell first, these two men did not faint despite the pain.

But it was clear... Woon-seong was not someone they could beat.

Looking around, Woon-seong exchanged glances with Lim Soo-yeon.

For a moment, Lim Soo-yeon's cheeks turned red.

Woon-seong clicked his tongue. *Tch, this is annoying...*

Without a word, Woon-seong took the bottle of alcohol, paid for his drinks, and stepped out of the inn.

Lim Soo-yeon chased after him.

“Sir! I owe you a great debt.”

“...”

Woon-seong stared at her without any words.

Without waiting for his answer, she continued, “If you don’t mind, I would like to buy you a drink.”

The place she led Woon-seong was not far from the noisy inn.

Lim Soo-yeon ordered an expensive drink then filled a glass for Woon-seong.

With a grave expression, Woon-seong stared at the cup.

Lim Soo-yeon handed the bottle over to Woon-seong. “Would you mind filling my glass?”

Instead of taking the bottle from her, he downed the alcohol in his cup.

“How much longer are you planning to proceed with this ridiculous act?”

Chapter 103: Fifth Jade Knife (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 103 – Fifth Jade Knife (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The woman sitting across from him stiffened.

Soon, she hid her unease and asked with a smile. “When did you realize?”

That question made Woon-seong smile.

It was such an obvious play.

Since when? He’d known from the beginning.

Of course, that was not what he said.

But the woman was able to guess a lot from his snickering.

“So you knew from the beginning.”

“Yes. Not only did I realize you were acting, I also know the so-called Black Way people are with you.”

“That’s quite the sharp eye you have there,” she complimented.

Woon-seong calmly gazed at her.

There were three men at different tables, drinking by themselves.

One was dressed like a merchant, another like a martial artist, and the third as a local resident.

“And of course I also know that the three people behind me are the same people as the Black Way men from before.”

The three men flinched. They then glanced furtively at Lim Soo-yeon.

Lim Soo-yeon muttered “fools” and then shrugged.

“He knows everything. Just come here.”

At her words, the three men stood up and awkwardly shuffled over.

The one disguised as a merchant raised his hand, which was large as a cauldron, and scratched the back of his neck.

“Haha. You even saw through our face changing art. Was our acting that bad?”

“He realized it so easily...”

“You have quite a sharp eye there, young sir.”

All three of them walked over to the table.

Of course, they did not forget to properly introduce themselves.

“I am Kwak Soo-dong.”

That was the handsome man disguised as a merchant.

“Woo Jo-ryang.”

That was the name of the swordsman with a wispy beard, who now had a large bruise on his forehead.

“Yup Pyung.”

The man with the slim chin was the last one to greet Woon-seong.

They didn't know who Woon-seong was, but they greeted him in order.

The last one to introduce themselves was Lim Soo-yeon, the youngest and only female.

"I am Lim Soo-yeon."

"My name... is Hyuk Woon-seong."

Woon-seong also shortly introduced himself.

With those over, it was time to talk.

None of those gathered around the table knew where to start.

After a bit, it was Lim Soo-yeon who spoke first. She tilted her head and asked, "By the way, how did you know we were from the Justice Blood Sect?"

Woon-seong looked back and forth between the three men.

"First i thought it was just an annoying fuss, but the three of you were exchanging glances. I assume you were sending messages to each other. That's how I realized."

Lim Soo-yeon sighed. *They were messaging each other for a split second, but he realized that?*

"You could've just come see me, what was with this useless acting?"

"This was a test."

"A test?"

Lim Soo-yeon nodded, glancing back at the three men.

“Yes. If you ignored the situation and didn’t help me back there, we wouldn’t have contacted you.”

The young woman then threw away her disguise as a disciple of the Jewel Sword Sect and picked up the bottle of alcohol, downing it straight.

Wiping away the liquor with her sleeves, she continued.

“Just as the name implies, the Justice Blood Sect is a sect that conducts justice and righteous acts. So it was necessary for us to test if you were worthy. If you were a righteous man that is worthy of joining our sect.”

Woon-seong laughed to himself.

A righteous man?

That is the last thing I am.

I didn’t even help her for that reason at all... I only moved because I knew they were from the Justice Blood Sect.

I’ll just let them believe what they want.

But before that...

There was something that had caught his attention.

“A test of righteousness to become a member of the Justice Blood Sect? I don’t know why I need to become a member of your sect.”

The four others exchanged looks.

“Aren’t you the master of the Fifth Jade Knife?”

“The Fifth Jade Knife?”

At that strange name, Woon-seong tilted his head. As if something suddenly came to mind, he grabbed the knife strapped to his waist.

Only the fifth piece of jade was colored black.

“Are you talking about this knife?”

“Yes! That is the Fifth Jade Knife.”

So the knife was the ‘Fifth Jade Knife’ because the fifth piece of jade was black.

How straightforward.

“Is this knife related to becoming a member of the Justice Blood Sect?”

Lim Soo-yeon stared at him incredulously. “What the... Did you come find the Justice Blood Sect knowing nothing? Even with the Fifth Jade Knife?”

“I was simply told to take this knife and find the leader of the Justice Blood Sect in Yichang.”

Lim Soo-yeon sighed deeply, slumping onto the table.

It was Kwak Soo-dong who explained further.

“The master of the Fifth Jade Knife has been one of the seven leaders of the Justice Blood Sect for generations. There are a total of seven knives that are engraved with curved jades. And the masters of each knife act as the leaders of the Justice Blood Sect. Officially, the master of the First Jade Knife is the leader of the Justice Blood Sect, but we call the seven of them the Seven Masters.”

Master of the Fifth Jade Knife and the Seven Masters.

Woon-seong engraved those words into his mind.

Then does that mean my master was one of the leaders of the Justice Blood Sect?

But Master was the sect master of the Spear Master Sect. How could he have been part of a different sect?

Woon-seong became a little confused.

However...

“Is there a chance that the Justice Blood Sect is called a sect, but is more like an alliance?”

Lim Soo-yeon suddenly perked up, smiling. “What? You did know about everything!”

Woon-seong nodded to himself.

I see. That was it.

So if the Justice Blood Sect is more of an alliance, it makes sense how Master was a part of it.

But then why did he join such a sect, which is basically a secret organization?

And even keeping it a secret from his own apprentice...

What is the purpose of this Justice Blood Sect?

“Whatever. I don’t care about that. Anyways, since I passed the test, am I allowed to meet the leader of the Justice Blood Sect?”

Lim Soo-yeon shook her head. “No. You can’t.”

“...?”

Woon-seong’s eyebrows twitched.

He had done something annoying to contact the Justice Blood Sect, even humored them by drinking here.

He could not believe that he wasn’t allowed to meet their leader.

All his hard work was in vain.

Woon-seong tapped the table with his fingertips.

Tak—tak—tak.

The table trembled as his qi unfolded, slamming into the area.

At that moment, the four people seated felt like a steel wall had slammed into their bodies, making it hard to breathe.

Unlike before, they faced unsurmountable pressure.

The young man before them was stronger than they thought!

As expected of the new master of the Fifth Jade Knife!

With an irritated tone, Woon-seong asked, “And why can I not meet the Leader when I passed your little test?”

Lim Soo-yeon trembled at his cold and harsh tone.

Only Kwak Soo-dong was barely able to respond.

“The test you passed is for entering our sect. You have yet to be acknowledged as the new master of the Fifth Jade Knife, which means you are not allowed to meet the Leader and the master of the First Jade Knife.”

Woon-seong took a deep breath.

The situation was starting to really annoy him.

He was not patient because he liked these people.

If only these people weren't related to my master's will...

I need to be patient. It's not only to have revenge against Jwa Do-gyul and the Martial Alliance, but also the rats hiding in the shadows!

Woon-seong tamped down on his killing intent, but did not lighten the pressure.

“Alright then. Then tell me how I can meet the leader of the Justice Blood Sect.”

Trembling, Lim Soo-yeon answered him. “I-I’ll contact him. If he allows it, you’ll be able to meet him.”

Woon-seong nodded, gathering all the energy that had been stifling the room.

“Good. Contact him now.”

Soon, Woon-seong had separated from the group and returned to his room at the inn.

He couldn’t leave until the response from the First Jade Knife’s owner came anyway.

Lying on his bed, he sighed and shook his head.

Everything was so complicated.

The Justice Blood Sect.

A group my master was a part of.

What is the purpose of this organization?

And is the Cult of the Inverted Sky really behind Jwa Do-gyul?

And while the world has gone astray, what have the Orthodox martial artists been doing...

He had so many questions and no answers.

What if the Cult of the Inverted Sky is behind Jwa Do-gyul?

If that poison that killed Master came from the Imperial Palace through the Cult of the Inverted Sky...

It means that this world will soon be engulfed in chaos and bloodshed.

It only makes sense that those who created such a deadly poison, took over the Imperial Palace, and planted themselves in the shadows of the Orthodox society are not decent people...

In the end, this all goes back to finding out what the Inverted Sky is.

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

If I contact a nearby branch of the Demonic Cult, I can tell Sang Gwan-chuk to research related matters.

It doesn't matter if there's no one behind Jwa Do-gyul.

I just need to stab my spear through their hearts, just like Jwa Do-gyul's.

But if they're really related to the Imperial Court...

Then I'm left with no choice but to cooperate with King Jinseong.

The moment I'm done with the Justice Blood Sect, I should go meet King Jinseong.

As Woon-seong's thoughts slowly organized, the night deepened.

Longzhong Mountain. [1]

A hawk flew through the night air without rest.

Once it arrived above the mountain, it swerved through the sky, accelerating as if it had found something.

A man in the forest raised his arm, welcoming the bird to settle on his arm.

The man was old and dressed more like a scholar.

“Good job.”

The old man stroked the head of the hawk, taking out a piece of jerky to feed it.

As the hawk ceased, the old man untied the scroll attached to its leg.

He read the message slowly.

After a while, a complicated look entered his eyes.

“The master of the Fifth Jade Knife, who disappeared long ago, has appeared once more...”

[1] Longzhong Mountain is part of the Ancient Longzhong scenic area, located in Hubei. It was the residence of Zhuge Liang.

Chapter 104: Fifth Jade Knife (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 104 – Fifth Jade Knife (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Five days later, Lim Soo-yeon visited Woon-seong again. The other three did not join her.

Kwak Soo-dong was the oldest, but it seemed that Lim Soo-yeon was in charge.

She finally came back with a letter from the master of the First Jade Knife.

“The master of the First Jade Knife sent an answer.”

“What does it say?”

Lim Soo-yeon flinched for a moment because of Woon-seong’s cold, serious tone.

She had no idea how to approach him

She did not want to accidentally anger him and be crushed under the pressure like the other day.

“Before you meet the master of the First Jade Knife, it looks like you need to meet someone else first.”

Woon-seong could not help but notice.

Just how many steps were there to meet the First Jade Knife?

It's quite difficult to meet the Alliance Master of the Justice Blood Sect. I'm sure it would be easier to meet the heads of the Five Noble Clans.

Woon-seong shook his head. "And who do I need to meet?"

"The Seventh Master."

The Seventh Master, owner of the Seventh Jade Knife.

The problem was that Woon-seong had no idea who that was.

"And who is that?"

Lim Soo-yeon shook her head too.

"Just because we're members of the Justice Blood Sect does not mean we know all seven masters. They each conduct missions secretly in their own positions. The Seventh Master is especially unknown, as none of us have met him."

"So you don't know either."

"Exactly."

The mysterious Seventh Master of the Justice Blood Sect.

Since my master Nok Yu-on was one of the Seven Masters, this person should also be at a similar level. But there aren't many people who are at such a level.

I know too little about this alliance sect and the Seventh Master. I can't make a reasonable guess based on this information...

I should just start with meeting this Seventh Master.

Woon-seong shook himself out of thought.

“So, I can meet the Leader of the Justice Blood Sect after I meet this Seventh Master?”

“That is a matter the Seventh Master will decide.”

Woon-seong sighed again. *Every step is so tedious.*

It felt like he was sighing a lot lately.

Two weeks after receiving the letter, the master of the Seventh Jade Sword contacted Lim Soo-yeon.

The message stated that he would be waiting in an old shrine just outside of Yichang.

“Do you know where this old shrine is?”

“We just need to leave from the east gate and walk northwest for a bit. People don’t use that place anymore.”

Woon-seong nodded at her words, satisfied.

“It’s good you know the way. Lead me there.”

Two silhouettes dashed through the mountains.

In front of Woon-seong, Lim Soo-yeon was running first.

Unfortunately, she had to lead because only she knew the location.

Lim Soo-yeon sighed deeply while guiding Woon-seong. *I can’t believe I’m acting as a mere tour guide.*

To her, Woon-seong was still frightening.

She may complain in her heart, but she had no choice.

He looks younger than me, but he seems used to commanding people below him. On top of that, his martial arts skills don't match his age.

Maybe he's one of those rejuvenated martial artists from the legends?

But I've heard that even rejuvenation can't hide the aging of fingernails and toenails.

And this young master's fingernails look like those of a young man who's barely in his twenties...

Then what does that mean? That he's one of those legendary innate martial bodies?

Or... I don't know... Did he learn martial arts since he was in the womb or something...?

While Lim Soo-yeon was busy with such thoughts, the two of them had arrived near the old shrine in no time.

The said shrine was one made for Taishang Laojun, one of the three highest deities in Taoism. [1]

But why this old shrine?

Woon-seong gazed at the shrine, tilting his head.

Most martial artists avoided high profile locations and used places like graves for meetings instead.

At least, it was the first time he was meeting someone for the first time at a shrine.

Is there some special meaning behind this shrine?

Maybe it's simply that this person is a Taoist who serves Taishang Laojun.

Taoism was quite a big influence, so countless sects and martial artists were followers.

That's right... he's most likely a Taoist.

Of course, that was just a guess.

Everything would be solved once he met the Seventh Master, so Woon-seong stopped thinking.

Lim Soo-yeon stopped running as soon as she reached the entrance.

Woon-seong walked past her and went inside.

Soon, he could see the face of the person waiting for him.

At that moment, Woon-seong flew towards him like an arrow.

“Sage of the Bright Rock!”

Mortal enemy (不俱戴天).

An irreconcilable enemy who could not possibly be kept alive under the same sky.

These words described the people on Woon-seong's hit list.

The Swords of Qingcheng, who had died under his spear were a few such people. The Sage of the Bright Rock, the Sect Leader of the Mount Hua Sect, was one of them.

So the Seventh Master was Sage Myung Am?!

Then why did he kill Master, who was also a member of the Justice Blood Sect?

Woon-seong ran, unwrapping his spear and swinging it.

Contrary to his expectations, when he saw the face of an enemy, he did not get lost in bloodlust.

Or perhaps it was different for each encounter.

The closer he got to Sage Myung Am, the more Woon-seong's mind was calming down.

It was as if everything unnecessary had flown from his consciousness, leaving behind only Woon-seong and his spear.

The White Night Spear in his hands split the wind.

Shh-shh-shh!

“W-What?”

The startled Sage of the Bright Rock drew his sword.

But he was half a pace slower and quickly retreated backwards.

Woon-seong did not let up, rushing forward.

Boom!

Woon-seong's shoulder slammed straight into the Sage's chest. All of his energy, from the tips of his toes, was transferred through this body slam.

Kuang!

The Sage of the Bright Rock smashed into the wall of the shrine, crashing through and onto the floor.

“Cough!”

The man threw up a puddle of blood.

Myung Am was around Demonic King-level in strength, which wasn't enough to face Woon-seong.

However, the leader of the Mount Hua Sect rolled a few times on the floor before getting up.

“So it looks like you didn’t become the sect leader of Mount Hua by winning it in a gamble,” Woon-seong sneered, walking towards the man.

It all happened so fast.

Lim Soo-yeon, who just figured out the situation, shouted: “You! What are you doing!”

But her cry was too weak to do anything.

Woon-seong was already in pursuit of the Sage of the Bright Rock, who had been thrown out of the shrine.

When Woon-seong stepped out, the man had his sword in hand.

Sage Myung Am’s nickname in Murim was the ‘Plum Blossom Sword Saint’ (梅花劍仙).

Like the plum blossoms Mount Hua was known for, their sword art caused swirls of pink and purple flower petals.

The moment this sword art came out, the Sage’s momentum skyrocketed.

It would not be smart to attack unprepared.

But who was Woon-seong?

Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Even if the Sage Myung Am was the sect leader of one of the Ten Great Sects, Woon-seong was one of the three semi-divine martial artists in the world!

He dashed forward in an instant.

Boom, boom!

“What is the meaning of this?!”

The Sage swung his sword to block the spear, but every time he did so, his body would violently shake.

Woon-seong’s immense qi, which he inherited from Cheon Hwi, was overwhelming.

How is each stroke of his spear full of such force—

“Cough!”

After the impacts accumulated, the Sage vomited blood again.

Woon-seong swung his sword relentlessly, pressuring the Sage into a cold sweat.

“Sage of the Bright Rock... You filthy hypocrite.”

“What are you talking about?! I simply came here because I heard the master of the Fifth Jade Knife was here...”

Woon-seong stomped his foot.

Kwa-rung—

A rumbling sound arose as the ground trembled.

The earth cracked open, shattering like a spider web and forming a large pit.

“You are the one who killed that very Fifth Master!”

Did something come to mind when Woon-seong yelled that?

The Sage shouted in horror, “What?”

In the meantime, Woon-seong reached for his ring.

A light flashed from his fingers and something flew towards the Sage.

‘Flying explosive rings’!

The man swung his sword in haste.

Kuang!

With a huge explosion, a massive flame engulfed the Sage of the Bright Rock.

With one sword swing, the flame was cut off.

From inside the explosion, a man with burnt clothes and skin walked out.

Because of the fire, the man weirdly looked healthier than earlier, no longer pale from coughing up blood.

Woon-seong pushed forward relentlessly.

‘Lightning stitching throwing knives’!

A shower of glass knives rained down on the Sage of the Bright Rock.

Of course, the man was in a hurry to get out of harm’s way.

The difference between someone who had stepped upon the Divine threshold and someone who had not was tremendous.

From the side, Lim Soo-yeon was gaping as she watched this fight. *This isn’t some fight I can even imagine intervening in! He’s pushing the leader of the Mount Hua Sect into a corner at such a young age!*

After some more struggling, Sage Myung’s movements had become slower and weaker.

At this point in time, one of his knees hit the ground.

He had become exhausted.

Woon-seong slowly approached the man.

Just like with the others, the Sage of the Bright Rock would vomit out everything he knew before dying by Woon-seong's hands.

I'll start with 'crushed bones and squeezed muscles'...

Woon-seong raised his hands to tap the other's body.

At that moment, the Sage grabbed hold of his sword, lifting it up.

“Are you still planning to resist? I pulled my punches until now, but if you continue to...”

Woon-seong raised his finger, ready to use another ‘flying explosive ring’.

But he did not do so.

The Sage of the Bright Rock was pointing the sword at himself.

In a situation that he did not understand, Woon-seong spoke frostily. “What are you doing?”

The Sage coughed before answering, “Before the very end... I'd like to ask you one thing.”

“I should be the one asking questions.”

“...”

Sage Myung paused, then blinked his eyes slowly.

“How are you related to the Spear Master Sect?”

It was enough to make Woon-seong pause momentarily.

[1] Taishang Laojun the ‘Supreme Venerable Sovereign’, is one of the Three Pure Ones at the top of the pantheon of Taoist gods.

Chapter 105: Bright Rock (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 105 – Bright Rock (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

With the sword still pointed at his own neck, the Sage of Bright Rock continued to speak.

The sharp blade of the sword nicked his neck, causing a trickle of blood.

“I have not the slightest idea why you attacked me, but your ferocious aura felt very familiar. On top of that, I realized your spear skills are similar to those of the Spear Master Sect.”

He glanced at Woon-seong with a sad look.

Woon-seong’s grip on the White Night Spear tightened. *It was that face. This man was making the same face the day he killed my master and I. He calls himself an ascetic and a man of the orthodox way, yet he makes such a despicable face.*

Perhaps he did not know the darkened heart of the youth, as Sage Myung continued calmly.

“I’ll ask one more time. How are you related to the Spear Master Sect?”

“And why would it matter if I was related to the Spear Master Sect or not? Are you going to bring everyone who was back there and attack me?”

Myung Am sighed heavily. Shaking his head one, he said, “I don’t know how you knew, but it seems like you know what happened that day.”

“Yes.”

Woon-seong’s voice was cold.

From a distance, Lim Soo-yeon observed the situation. She had no idea what was going on, but wouldn’t be able to do anything either way.

Meanwhile, the two men continued to talk in this strange confrontation.

“If so, please tell me. Your relationship with the Spear Master Sect... And h-how...” The Sage paused for a moment, as if he were choking. “How you obtained the Fifth Jade Knife, which belonged to my old friend.”

Woon-seong stared at the man in silence

He could not figure out why the man was saying all of this.

Why is he talking about this?

On top of that, he calls Master his friend, but he didn’t help us at all that day...

Woon-seong grit his teeth.

Then he slammed the White Night Spear into the ground, possibly out of frustration.

Boom!

The spear dug through the ground, creating a small crater.

Woon-seong then spoke slowly, “I don’t know why you think the Spear Master Sect only has one apprentice.”

“W-What do you mean?”

The Sage's voice trembled.

“Even the Mount Hua Sect has many offshoots and factions. Why do you think the Spear Master Sect is a sole apprentice sect? Never once did we say we are a sole-apprentice sect.”

The Sage's pupils trembled. Soon, he sighed, as if relieved. “Ah, I'm relieved to hear that.”

“...And why is that?”

“My promise that I will save his apprentice... My promise that I will let the Spear Master Sect continue its legacy. I wasn't able to keep that promise. But now you say there's an offshoot sect...”

Woon-seong crossed his arms. “What are you talking about?”

That said, the Sage of Bright Rock slowly lowered the sword, placing it beside him. As he did so, he positioned himself into a more comfortable and respectful kneeling position.

Not anyone else.

The head of the Mount Hua Sect was kneeling.

If those of Murim saw it, they would not believe their eyes.

Lim Soo-yeon, who was watching the scene, was dumbfounded. *Why is the head of the Mount Hua Sect kneeling down to this young master...?*

Woon-seong was no exception, though his confusion and shock were due to something else.

Why is this man kneeling down to me? And a promise to keep the apprentice alive, to let the Spear Master Sect live on? What is all of this?

As Woon-seong's mind was in chaos, the Sage slowly began to speak.

“To tell you the truth, he came to visit me six months before his death.”

A light breeze blew from the west as the man began to tell his tale.

At that moment, his mind had returned to the memories of the past.

“It was raining heavily that day. It was near the end of the summer. An unexpected monsoon made it rain for several days. I... still remember the fishy smell of water like it was yesterday. And even the guest who visited me late that night... “

The Sage of Bright Rock was grooming the bonsai trees he grew in his residence as a hobby.

He had been given some here and there and tended to them with his heart, so they were growing slowly and steadily.

Every time he moved his hand, the end of a bonsai tree would be trimmed. Dead branches were removed, allowing new life to flourish in its place.

As the skill with a sword grew, a sword master could become one with his sword.

As the leader of the Mount Hua Sect, the Sage of Bright Rock was not lacking in skill.

However, his peaceful times did not last very long.

He felt someone's presence outside the door.

“Who goes there?!”

He immediately grabbed for his sword. Feeling its familiar weight, he was more at ease.

But he was still anxious.

It's no normal martial artists! Someone who can sneak into the deepest residence of the Mount Hua Sect without being detected!

It was normal to feel anxious when faced with a hidden intruder.

However, the voice from outside the door cleared his nerves.

“It’s me.”

It was a familiar voice.

The moment he heard it, Sage Myung sheathed his sword.

With a smile on his face, he threw the door open.

“It was you?”

Outside the door was a man with a long spear.

It was Nok Yu-on, more commonly known as the ‘Spearmaster’ in Murim.

Said man walked into the room, as if very familiar with the place.

“This place is warm as always.”

“Where there is generosity, there is virtue. Where there is virtue, there is kindness. It is only natural for warmth to exist wherever the Mount Hua Sect exists.”

The two laughed.

“So, what brings you here so late at night. I would’ve prepared a warm meal if you told me beforehand.”

Nok Yu-on smiled bitterly.

It was an unbelievably serious expression for one trying to smile.

“Is something wrong?”

Nok Yu-on took out a knife, which had been hidden in his sleeves.

A knife with seven jade pieces, the fifth one colored black.

“I’ve come here today because of this.”

The Fifth Jade Knife.

Nok Yu-on had come as the Fifth Master of the Justice Blood Sect.

The Justice Blood Sect was a secret organization that had existed in Murim for a long time.

Meetings were meant to protect the morals of the Orthodox practitioners and protect Murim from underlying dangers.

That was also the reason why the Seven Masters, including the Sage of Bright Rock and the Spearmaster, were all individuals known to be virtuous in the Orthodox sects.

The face of Sage Myung, who had confirmed the Fifth Jade Knife, had stiffened.

“So it’s a Justice Blood Sect matter... Is it because of him?”

Nok Yu-on nodded. “Yes. It seems like they have realized who I am.”

The Sage grimaced.

Nok Yu-on had been tasked with watching an organization thought to be causing trouble in Murim since long ago.

They did not know what the organization represented or wanted, but they had allegedly been reaching out to the Imperial Court.

The Justice Blood Sect was so close to an answer, but Nok Yu-on’s identity had been compromised.

“What are you going to do? If you need to hide yourself, I’ll talk with the other masters and prepare a place to hide for you and your apprentice.”

Nok Yu-on was grateful for those words. *Thank you.*

However, he shook his head and solemnly refused the suggestion.

“But no. I know well about their strength and influence. I can hide anywhere in this world, but they will still find me.”

“Then what do you suggest we do?”

Nok Yu-on smiled slightly. It was a playful look, but it somehow felt bitter.

“I’ll... be the bait.”

“What?!”

“They will try to kill me at all costs. So use this opportunity to find out who’s behind them.”

“Are you telling me to find out who’s affiliated with them? Then what about you...?”

“I’ve made up my mind. I’ll use my life for the sake of justice in Murim. Besides, it will be difficult to get any closer to them without such sacrifice.”

It was a plan thought up by an old friend who was prepared to die.

Nevertheless, Sage Myung wanted to stop him.

That was why he suddenly brought up Nok Yu-on’s disciple.

“What about the apprentice who you bragged about so much?! Do you think they won’t go after your apprentice?!”

Nok Yu-on glanced at him with a serious expression. “I’m here today to also talk about my apprentice.”

“What do you...?”

The Sage trembled slightly. *I brought up his apprentice to stop him, but did it only make him more determined?*

“Now that I saw you worry about my apprentice, it looks like I can leave him to you without worries. If the ones hiding in the Alliance make a move, my apprentice will also have to hide himself.”

“...”

“So I want you to join the pursuit team.”

The words of the Spearmaster were so resolute that the Sage could not help but protest.

“Are you telling me to take both of your lives?! No! I cannot do that!”

“That’s not what I am saying.”

“Then what the hell do you mean?!”

Nok Yu-on reached out for the Sage of the Bright Rock.

The Sage took a step back on instinct, but Nok Yu-on gripped his hand tightly.

His old friend’s hands were strangely warm.

But that was not the only thing to be noticed.

His hands are shaking.

He is also afraid of death.

And he still decided to sacrifice his life to bring justice to Murim.

But there’s only one thing bothering him.

Nok Yu-on’s heart was conveyed through the warmth of his hands.

“Please.”

The lineage of the Spear Master Sect and his responsibility as a teacher are holding him.

Nok Yu-on didn't need to say anymore for the Sage to know what the request was.

He wanted the Sage to join the pursuit team and save his apprentice.

At that request, the Sage of Bright Rock couldn't say anything.

Chapter 106: Bright Rock (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 106 – Bright Rock (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

What are they talking about?

Lim Soo-yeon glanced over at the two men, as she was the outsider.

There was not a word she could hear.

She could clearly see them speaking, but no sound was heard.

A moment ago, I'm sure I was able to hear the two clearly, but now I can't hear anything anymore.

I hear high level martial artists can use their qi to conceal sounds.

But I have never seen it actually happen until now.

What could the two be talking about that she wasn't allowed to hear?

Lim Soo-yeon tilted her head in thought.

In the meantime, the dialogue between Woon-seong and Sage Myung continued.

“That is all I have to say.”

After he finished speaking, there was an unmistakable sense of liberation in Sage Myung’s eyes.

He had finally spoken the story he’d carried for a long time.

Finally, he had gotten this burden off his chest.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong’s voice was derisive.

“You expect me to believe that?”

The story had made Woon-seong quite emotional, but his voice barely trembled.

I knew Master always worried about me, but I didn’t know he was doing this much.

And his death... was his own plan...?

Master... Did you really have to go that way?

In his mind, Woon-seong asked Nok Yu-on for an answer.

Of course, Nok Yu-on could provide no answer.

The answer would not change the enemies that Woon-seong needed to defeat.

That’s right.

Nothing has changed.

Kill Jwa Do-gyul and everyone who was behind him.

They’re not only the ones who killed Master Nok Yu-on, but also the ones who killed Master Cheon Hwi.

“Why should I trust you?”

“It doesn’t matter if you believe me or not. That is for you to decide.” As he said so, Myung Am had brought the sword to his neck once more. “At first, I thought of sealing my core and abandoning my life because I was guilty.” Sage Myung fiddled with his sword, his eyes dull. After a moment, he shook his head and his gaze cleared. “But I couldn’t do that.”

“And why is that?”

Boldly, the man smiled. “It’s because I haven’t avenged my friend yet.”

Woon-seong’s face contorted into a grotesque smile. He couldn’t help but laugh. The words were so funny — so wrong — that laughter bubbled out of him.

“You failed to stop your friend from his own death, and you say you’re going to avenge him? Don’t make me laugh.”

Myung Am nodded. “I know. Those are some pathetic words. But after all my failures, the least I can do is avenge him...”

“To me, you’re a simple hypocrite. You’re still an enemy to the Spear Master Sect. Your words change nothing.”

Myung Am did not deny Woon-seong’s words.

He couldn’t deny them even if he wanted to.

He had no excuse.

The results were already out.

Whatever promises or intentions Myung Am had, the fact that he was involved in Nok Yu-on’s death would not change.

Even the fact that he had cornered Nok Yu-on to his own death.

That was why Myung Am did not correct a single thing Woon-seong had said.

“That’s right. I wasn’t able to keep my promise with my friend. And that is why I am relieved. I wasn’t able to keep my promise, but the Spear Master Sect lives on.”

“Bullshit. The fact that the Spear Master Sect’s lineage remains has nothing to do with you. Don’t try to forgive yourself using my existence. Don’t make me a reason to ease your conscience! You’re still a person on my list of enemies.”

“I know. But nevertheless, let me shamelessly ask you for a favor.”

“Are you going to beg for your life?” Woon-seong scoffed.

The Sage laughed bitterly. “Of course not... Even I know some shame.”

How he wished that he could go back in time, so that he would not have had to listen to Nok Yu-on’s request.

“However, I wish you to postpone my death just a little.”

The Sage slowly raised his sword.

The sword that had originally been aimed at his neck came to rest near his shoulder.

Instead of just letting it sit there, the Sage made one powerful downwards motion.

Swish—

Blood splattered the earth as the man’s left arm fell to the ground.

“Aah!” Lim Soo-yeon, who was watching what was happening, screamed. She tried to run towards the Sage, but could not get inside the qi barrier.

“It’s painful...”

Meanwhile, Sage Myung dropped his sword and gripped his severed arm socket, staring up at Woon-seong.

“Please forgive me for now with this arm. After I get revenge for my friend, I will end my own life. However, if you cannot allow that, take my life here and now.”

“...”

Woon-seong looked down at him.

The Sage’s shoulder was gushing blood, as just the pressure of a hand would not stop it from bleeding.

With enough bleeding, any person would bleed to death.

If I just leave him like this, he will end up dead soon enough. Too soon and painlessly for his deeds...

Woon-seong slowly walked towards the man.

The White Night Spear gave off a terrifying glow.

Approaching, Woon-seong looked like the incarnation of King Yama.

“You. What are you doing?” Lim Soo-yeon shouted from outside the barrier.

But Woon-seong did not stop walking.

Finally, his steps stopped in front of the Sage of the Bright Rock.

The Sage slowly closed his eyes.

It’s over.

It’s a shame I couldn’t avenge my friend...

But if this death is a way to atone for my sins, then so be it.

I forgot.

I didn't hand over the Divine Sword of the Plum Blossom to my apprentice.

The Divine Sword of the Plum Blossom, a symbol of the Mount Hua Sect.

Myung Am had left it back at the sect, as it was not his usual sword.

It's a shame I couldn't pass it on, but he'll take care of the rest.

Shh—

The Sage could hear the sound of a spear being lifted into the air near his head. In a few seconds, he would likely lose his life to that spear.

It's over... the Sage muttered in his mind.

The White Night Spear laced through the air.

Ssh—

As the spear was lifted, Lim Soo-yeon could not help but scream. She had no idea why Woon-seong was trying to kill the Seventh Master, Sage Myung Am, but that was a well-known member of Murim!

But Woon-seong did not stop.

As soon as his spear cut through the air, Lim Soo-yeon shut her eyes tightly. She was not confident she could bear to watch the scene.

Shing—

Immediately, something was cut.

Lim Soo-yeon slowly opened her eyes, her hands covering her mouth.

“Huh?”

The neck and head of the Sage were clearly still intact.

She was not the only one dumbfounded.

The Sage of the Bright Rock, who had prepared himself for death, also opened his eyes to find himself still alive.

He tilted his head, feeling that his neck was still fine.

Something had definitely been cut, but his head was still attached to his neck.

What the hell was cut then?

That question was easy to answer.

Glancing down, the Sage noticed something like a bundle of white thread on the ground.

It was part of a beard.

The Sage of Bright Rock's beard.

Woon-seong had lopped off Myung Am's beard instead of his head.

With the White Night Spear still pointed his way, the Sage could not help but ask himself, *Why did he not kill me?*

“You said that the Justice Blood Sect's purpose is to find out those in the shadows of Murim and prevent their conspiracies beforehand, right?”

“That is true...”

“And Mas...,” Woon-seong swallowed. “Mister Nok Yu-on was killed by those enemies as a member of the Justice Blood Sect?”

The Sage nodded his head instead of answering aloud.

Woon-seong adjusted his spear, so that it was no longer pointing at the Sage.

“Are those enemies somehow related to the Imperial Palace and the Cult of the Inverted Sky?”

The Sage was surprised.

“How do you...?”

I knew that there were conspirators hidden in the Martial Alliance, but even we only found out their connection with the Imperial Palace recently.

He may have inherited the Fifth Jade Knife, but how does he know that far...?

The Sage glanced up at Woon-seong.

On top of that, his martial arts level is at such a high degree for his age.

He couldn't have possibly lived longer than how he looks.

Yet, why do I see the eyes of a martial artist in his forties from a young man who is barely in his twenties?

Under that gaze, the man's eyebrows twitched.

I've seen those eyes somewhere...

The man's memories slowly shuffled.

Finally, Sage Myung remembered the image of a young man.

I see! His eyes are similar to those of the Spear Master Sect apprentice who died that day.

Eyes that held fury, yet were so clear.

Now that I see the heir of the Spear Master Sect, it's like the dead apprentice of Nok Yu-on has returned to stand before me.

I must be seeing things. But his eyes look the same...

Of course, the fact that the Sage of Bright Rock was right on the mark was not something he could have guessed.

Not unless Woon-seong ever let his secret out.

As the Sage's eyes considered Woon-seong, the young man had titled his head back and closed his eyes.

The Imperial Palace, the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

If they really are involved in my master's death, then my road will only get rougher.

It's the Imperial Court we're talking about.

In fact, the Imperial Court was the biggest problem. Their power was unimaginable.

Woon-seong swallowed some saliva, gripping the White Night Spear tightly.

Even the most powerful faction of Murim... No, even if all of Murim combined their forces, they can't dare fight against the might of the Imperial Court.

I need to fight power with power.

So it's King Jinseong again.

Woon-seong opened his eyes.

He glanced at the Sage, who was still severely bleeding. The man's outfit was drenched in blood. Kneeling in a puddle of his own blood, the man's face was waxy and pale.

"Let's stop your bleeding first."

At his words, the Sage nodded and tapped his shoulder a few times, cutting off circulation to that area.

The wound stopped bleeding as soon as he tapped it.

In that state, the qi barrier was also shattered.

“Sage!” Lim Soo-yeon hurriedly rushed over. “You! What is the meaning of this?!”

Of course, Woon-seong completely ignored her.

Still talking to the Sage, he said, “This does not mean I am forgiving you. Your life is now in my hands. Do you agree?”

Sage Myung narrowed his eyes, then nodded.

Just now, Woon-seong had clearly spared his life by only cutting off his beard.

Given that Woon-seong could let him live, that also meant Woon-seong could end the Sage’s life at any time.

“I agree.”

Woon-seong folded his arms across his chest.

“Good. Then...”

Chapter 107: A Hero's Life (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 107 – A Hero's Life (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Properly explain everything that has happened up to now. Tell me everything about the Imperial Court and the Cult of the Inverted Sky. Leave nothing out.”

What Woon-seong needed most was information. Everything he knew was way too fragmented.

He needed the bigger picture and the details to get back at his enemies.

Not just the end of Jwa Do-gyul, but everything behind him as well.

The Sage nodded softly. “I will. I rightfully should. But are you really okay?”

“...?”

“I did lose an arm, but I am one of the people that cornered the Spearmaster to his death. Are you sure you want to let me live?”

The loss of an arm meant nothing more than being unable to grasp a word with both hands.

Perhaps it was correct that the Sage's skills had diminished, since his power and balance would all be different.

But that was not the reason Woon-seong had spared him.

Woon-seong snorted. "You're misunderstanding something."

"...?"

This time, it was the Sage who was confused.

Woon-seong loosened his arms and grabbed the White Night Spear again.

Once more, he aimed the spear at the Sage's neck.

The Sage could clearly feel the cold metal against his skin.

Seeing that, Lim Soo-yeon could not help but say some words.

"Hey! Enough already! I don't know what conflict there is between you two, but this person is still— Ah!"

She didn't finish her words.

It was because she was met with an icy glare and blazing gold eyes.

What is that glare?

The young man's eyes glittered with gold, but were frostier than the winds of the North Sea.

"Hup!" Lim Soo-yeon choked on her words.

She had been briefly exposed to Woon-seong's Intimidation Qi.

An aura that stimulated fear.

It was not wrong for Lim Soo-yeon to believe it was because of Woon-seong's glare, but the cold sweat was more accurately caused by the

stimulation of her fundamental fears.

Having incapacitated her, Woon-seong glanced back at the Sage.

“I didn’t *let* you live. I’m keeping you alive. I will get back to you after I’m finished with my revenge.”

Myung Am nodded. “I see.”

To his answer, Woon-seong moved the spear away from his neck, slinging it back over his shoulder and walking away.

As he did so, Myung Am had a sad look in his eyes.

Ah... Such a thick aura of bloodlust and killing intent. If things go wrong, Murim might end up in great carnage.

Of course, that may have just been the musings of an old, dying man.

“You wanted me to tell you about everything that happened until now, correct?”

“Yes.”

The Sage pulled out a knife, on which the seventh piece of jade was colored black. “Then show me your Fifth Jade Knife first.”

Woon-seong grabbed the knife from his belt and threw it.

Light filtered through the air, illuminating the knife.

The symbol of the Justice Blood Sect was clearly visible.

“It truly is the Fifth Jade Knife. How did you obtain this?”

“Why is that important?” Woon-seong was blunt, but still told him about the location. “I found it in the safehouse of the Spear Master Sect. I also learned about the Justice Blood Sect there.”

The man nodded. *I was wondering where this knife went. Nok Yu-on... So that's where you hid it.*

He must've planned it so that his apprentice would find it if he escaped.

The Sage looked away from Woon-seong and turned towards the sky.

Although his apprentice wasn't the one who found it, it looks like it still fell in the hands of the Spear Master Sect. My friend...

As if answering the man's words, one of the stars floating in the sky flashed for a moment.

Of course, it might have been a hallucination, but it was nice to see.

It felt like a sign.

"Since it's clear that you're the master of the Fifth Jade Knife, there's no need for me to hide anything."

"..."

"However, I'm not the one who will tell you everything."

"What do you mean?"

"I was only asked to bring you. The person who will tell you everything is the master of the First Jade Knife."

There was an irritated look on Woon-seong's face.

I've already gone through tedious steps to meet with the Justice Blood Sect, and now another master?

But soon, he shook his head.

No. This is just another step for my revenge. I've even withstood the ten years in the Cave of Latent Demons. Compared to that, this extra step is nothing.

“So then, where is the master of the First Jade Knife?”

Mount Wolong, or Mount Fulong.

People used to call it that after its scenery, which resembled a dragon crouching in a dense forest.

However, it now went by a different name.

Longzhong Mountain.

“The Crouching Dragon and the Young Phoenix. If you can get either of them, you’ll be able to pacify the empire.” [1]

It was a well known fact that out of the two, the ‘Crouching Dragon’ Zhuge Liang used to live as a hermit in this mountain.

Naturally, it was the place the Jegal Family Clan was located.

The Jegal Family Clan was a clan of martial artists, but were also known to be scholars, producing talented military strategists for generations.

As such, the people of the Jegal family were all known to be cunning and intelligent.

If there was a Brain of the Heavenly Demon, then there was a Jegal sitting as the strategist of the Martial Alliance.

Even if there were no prodigies to appear for the past few years, the Jegal family would never be in jeopardy. With their generations of history, their name would still be praised to the Heavens.

With them there, other sects and families, especially those of the Black Way, were reluctant to settle in the area.

Mount Wolong and its surrounding area was clearly the realm of the Jegal Family Clan.

But the master of the First Jade Knife is there?

The Sage of the Bright Rock had clearly said that the only one who could tell Woon-seong the truth was the First Master.

And he had to go to Mount Wolong to meet said master.

Mount Wolong...

Woon-seong glanced up.

A few steps ahead of him was the Sage, who had lost an arm.

I can't believe the First Master is in Mount Wolong. What the hell kind of organization is this Justice Blood Sect?

Out of the Seven Masters, one of them was Spearmaster Nok Yu-on. Another was the leader of the Mount Hua Sect.

Then it wouldn't be a surprise if the leader of the Justice Blood Sect was the head of the Jegal Clan, or even the previous head of the Jegal Clan...

The Jegal Clan, also known as the masters of machinery.

Is he really from that family?

Woon-seong thought some more.

For some reason, about ten years ago, the previous head of the Jegal Clan abandoned his position as strategist of the Martial Alliance and retired.

It was around the time Jwa Do-gyul became the master of the Alliance.

Maybe the previous clan head released Jwa Do-gyul's identity and made such a decision...

It's just speculation, but it was plausible.

Well, I'll know for sure when I reach Mount Wolong.

At that point, Woon-seong stopped thinking.

It was then that a group of children ran past, boisterously teasing each other.

“Stop there!”

“Wait up!”

“Slow down! You’ll trip!”

“Haha! Catch me if you can!”

A group of young children, dressed in tattered clothing, rushed towards Woon-seong and the Sage of the Bright Rock.

All of a sudden, the chattering of noisy children filled the air.

Most of the children saw the two men and avoided them.

Not all of them though.

“Agh!”

One child smacked into Myung Am and fell backwards.

He seemed to be the oldest of the children running around.

The boy rolled onto the floor and Myung Am reached his remaining hand out to help him up.

“Are you okay?”

Neither of the two forgot to smile.

Seeing that, the child grabbed the Sage’s hand and hoisted himself off the ground, dusting the back of his pants. With courage, he said, “I’m fine. Thank you, grandpa.”

“Haha. What an energetic little kid.”

Myung Am laughed at the child, who bowed his head in thanks and tried to scootch away.

But...

“Wait a moment.”

The Sage walked up to the child, waving something in his hand. “Don’t you need to take this?”

“Ah, ah?”

Seeing what was in his hands, the child’s eyes widened in shock.

It was a pouch filled with coins.

To be specific, it was the Sage’s coin pouch.

Flustered, the boy patted his own pockets. “I thought I...”

The Sage laughed kindly. “You need this, right?”

In fact, the boy was a pickpocket. Just now, in the midst of all the confusion, the boy had tried to steal the Sage’s money.

How could he have known the target was a martial artist? The Sage had stolen the pouch right back.

The boy looked at the pouch, the face of the Sage, then glanced towards the alley with an embarrassed look on his face.

At the corner of the alley were the other children, hiding in the shadows.

The kids weren’t stupid, so they knew they’d gotten caught.

The Sage reached out and gently grasped the wrist of the young boy before him, before glancing towards the other children.

“Haha. It’s okay. Come here.”

The other children stumbled out of the shadows.

Once again, the Sage kindly called out to them.

“I won’t scold you. So you children come here too.”

Was it because of his kind tone, or because he was still holding onto the young boy?

The other children came running over.

“One, two, three, four, five. There are five of you.”

The Sage counted the number of children gathered.

In the beginning, the number of children who ran past them was four. Including the boy caught by the Sage, there were a total of five.

Everyone stood in a line in front of the Sage.

Woon-seong glanced at what the Sage was doing with an interested look. *Is he trying to lecture them?*

Given that the Sage of the Bright Rock was an old teacher, it was possible.

Just as he thought that, the Sage turned to ask, “Would you mind waiting for a moment?”

“...?”

“It won’t take long. Thirty minutes should be enough.”

Woon-seong nodded at the request. “Thirty minutes.”

“That’s enough.”

[1] The ‘Crouching Dragon’ refers to Zhuge Liang and the ‘Young Phoenix’ refers to Pang Tong, brilliant military strategists

Chapter 108: A Hero'S Life (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 108 – A Hero's Life (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

With Woon-seong's permission, the Sage of the Bright Rock turned back to look at the children.

"Haha. You little rascals. You kids look malnourished and untidy."

It sounded like a reprimand, but his voice carried warmth.

There were a lot of nagging adults, but it was the first time that the children felt this sort of love and care.

Was it because of the genuine concern?

The oldest of the children, the one who had tried to rob the Sage, replied: "We don't have a choice. There's no place for us to work or sleep. How can we possibly clean ourselves? Grandpa, people like you don't understand us."

It was an indelicate answer.

The other person was a renowned martial artist, the leader of the Mount Hua Sect, not your grandpa!

Someone else might have gotten angry with the children.

However, Sage Myung smiled.

He reached out.

As the hands approached him, the oldest boy flinched and wrinkled his nose.

The boy thought he was going to get it.

Unlike his expectations, the Sage stroked his head.

Then one by one, he patted each child on the head, dusting their clothes off while he was at it.

“I see. You have a point. Your environment simply didn’t give you a choice.”

The sand and dirt piled up on their clothes soon disappeared.

Their clothing was still old and raggedy, but the children looked better than before.

Satisfied, the Sage smiled. “That’s a little better. You all looked like crows a moment ago.”

“You can make us clean like this, but it’s not going to change anything. We don’t have parents. Being clean for a day isn’t going to change anything!”

The others added agreements.

“He’s right.”

“Nobody’s going to give us money if we look too clean.”

“That’s right. Being clean only makes it harder for us to beg for money.”

Hearing their cries, the Sage looked up at the sky, not even noticing that he had done so.

These children... This harsh world makes them lose their innocence at such a young age and forces them to live dirty just to beg for money.

What a pitiful sight.

To be honest, if I had the chance, I would like to take all these children back to Mount Hua.

But that's impossible...

There are many children like them all around the world.

I can't take them all in.

But that doesn't mean there isn't a solution.

That was when Woon-seong suddenly asked from the side. "What are you planning to do?"

"Just watch. It will only take a bit."

The Sage looked back at the children. He bowed his head, angling his body so that he could make eye contact with them.

"Where's the best dumpling place around here?"

Suddenly asked about dumpling shops, the children tilted their heads in confusion.

However, the Sage asked them again, not caring that they did not respond immediately. "You know at least that much, right?"

The youngest of the children piped up, "The meat dumpling at Wang's Dumplings is the best."

"Good. So that place has the best meat dumplings. This grandpa also likes meat dumplings. Eat them warm and you can enjoy the overflowing juices spreading into your mouth."

The youngest child had already started to drool.

He was not the only one.

The other children also swallowed their saliva, thinking about some dumplings for dinner.

The oldest shook his head, but even he did not seem to be able to shake off the temptation of dumplings completely.

The best way to distract children — or gain their trust — was truly by offering them something good to eat.

“Now that your clothes are clean, we just need to clean your faces. If you come back with clean faces, this grandpa will buy each of you a meat dumpling at Wang’s Dumplings.”

“How can we believe you, old—“

Just as the oldest one was talking back, the youngest child interrupted him.

“Then buy us large ones!”

“Of course! Large ones it is. How would the small ones possibly fill your stomachs?”

“Yay!”

The children cheered at his words.

They could eat dumplings just by washing their faces, how lucky!

Only the oldest, who had been cut off in the middle of the sentence, muttered to himself. “Ugh!”

Meanwhile, the other children were running to the stream to wash their faces.

Only the oldest was left, alternately looking at the Sage and the children.

“Are you not going?” asked the Sage.

“It’s because I can’t trust what grandpa says!” the boy responded. Years on the streets had taught him not to trust adults, especially those being kind. But as he saw his brothers getting further and further away, he reluctantly ran to join them.

Seeing him go, the Sage offered a sad smile.

“Meat dumplings, huh... You seem quite familiar with such food for an ascetic.”

“Haha. We’re not monks. There’s no reason for us not to eat meat. We can eat and drink when it’s necessary. Taishang Laojun has never forbidden meat or alcohol.”

“Hmph.”

The Sage of the Bright Rock wasn’t wrong.

The Mount Hua Sect was known as a sect of ascetics, but they weren’t actually monks.

Just like others, they were free to eat meat or drink alcohol.

“Now what? Is it over when you buy dumplings?”

The Sage replied with a bitter smile, “Take a good look.”

Woon-seong glanced at the Sage of the Bright Rock, who was watching the children disappear.

Every time the wind blew, the empty sleeve of his robe would flutter.

It looked strangely fitting.

Like an actual ascetic who had overcome his physical limits.

I must be crazy.

Why am I being so sentimental over a man that I will eventually be killing...?

Woon-seong could not help but feel upset.

In the Sage who helped the homeless children, Woon-seong saw the image of Master Nok Yu-on saving the young him.

A powerful martial artist helping a street rat.

“A hero...” Woon-seong muttered under his breath.

That was a phrase that anyone who grew up in Murim would have heard once or twice.

It may sound nice, but being a hero is about sacrificing one's self to save others.

To be a hero...

Woon-seong's master had already demonstrated what it meant to be a hero by sacrificing himself.

It is not the way for an avenger like me.

Woon-seong raison d'être was vengeance.

Therefore, it is not a life I can ever have.

Suddenly, he doubted.

But what about after my revenge?

After it's over...

It was a question Woon-seong could not answer.

The children returned in less than fifteen minutes.

Their faces were still wet, having no towels to dry off after rinsing in the stream.

“Haha. You all look so neat and clean after washing like this.”

Although the clothes were worn out, no one would think of them as children who were living the life of a vagrant.

“Hehe.”

“Tsk.” Although the oldest child had a rough look on his face, he still returned after washing his face.

Seeing him, Sage Myung smiled. “As promised, this grandpa will buy you dumplings. Show me where Wang’s is.”

The children, who were still excited, walked on ahead.

The Sage glanced at Woon-seong and said, “We’re not done yet, so why don’t we keep it simple?”

Wang’s Dumpling Stand was within a short distance, a few dozen meters past the corner of the alleyway they had been in.

As the children said, it seemed to be the tastiest dumpling shop in the area.

Even though it was after lunchtime, people were still waiting in line.

The owner looked busy, unable to handle the crowd of guests.

The children hesitated at the entrance of the stop.

After seeing that, Sage Myung stood in line and called out to them. “Come here. You have to wait in line for dumplings.”

The children came walking up to him. They felt awkward as it was the first time they had ever stood in line to buy dumplings.

The Sage smiled happily at them.

After waiting for a while, it was soon their turn.

“I’d like to order some dumplings.”

The Sage ordered king-sized dumplings, adding an order for himself and Woon-seong.

“You’re just in time. We’re running out of dumplings, but we have just enough left for your order, sir.”

“Lucky indeed.”

It didn’t take long for the dumplings to arrive, and the children reached out to stuff their faces with piping hot dumplings.

A rich juice flowed into their mouths.

They were quite delicious.

“Wow!” the children shouted.

Even the oldest child was trembling, savoring the flavor of the dumplings.

Seeing that, the Woon-seong felt that despite being street rats, the kids maintained the innocence of children.

“How much for the dumplings?”

“There are fourteen pieces of dumplings, two for each. By the way, are you an ascetic of the Mount Hua Sect?”

The owner’s gaze had turned to Sage Myung’s sleeve. It wasn’t difficult to recognize the plum blossom stitched onto it.

Myung Am nodded. “That is correct...”

“Then I’ll make the dumplings half price. Instead, can you write me a talisman?”

The Sage hummed at the word ‘talisman’. He was not an expert in talismans, but he was taught some shaman arts. He had the ability to use a talisman to some extent.

“Are you having some ghost problems in your store?”

The owner jumped and shook his head vigorously. “Ghosts? Oh, it’s nothing like that. It’s just that I’m having a hard time with my business, so I just want you to make a talisman for good luck.”

It seemed that business had been hard for a while.

And there was a better way for the Sage to solve it.

“Then wouldn’t finding someone to help you with your business be better than a talisman?”

“Anyone would think that, but no one is willing to work for long hours because it’s hard. I can’t hire people because they quit after a short while,” the owner responded, shaking his head.

The Sage looked at the children. He contemplated the qualifications of the eldest. “What about this child?”

“This child...?”

“A child that lives nearby. He doesn’t have parents, but he has the duty to feed his siblings.”

Pickpockets were definitely a bad thing.

“It’s a recommendation from you, sir, but can you trust an orphan?”

The faces of the children, hearing the word ‘orphan’, distorted.

The Sage smiled blankly and pulled money out of his pouch.

Fifteen silver coins, much more than the dumplings were worth.

“What is this money for?” the owner asked, glancing at the silver coins.

“If you need a hand, don’t be prejudiced. I recommend you hire these children. The salary is three silver coins a month. I’ll pay you five months’ salary in advance, so why don’t you try it for five months?”

“Five months?”

The Sage nodded, continuing, “If the child does a good job, you can pay him a silver coin three times a month. If he doesn’t do a good job, you don’t have to pay him at all.”

“Hmm.” The owner tapped his chin. He had nothing to lose from this offer. Eventually, he nodded. “I accept.”

Now that the shop-owner had expressed permission, Myung Am laughed and looked at the oldest boy.

Stroking the boy’s head, he said, “Well, what do you think? If you work here, you can feed your siblings. Plus, if you work well, you’ll still have a job after five months.”

For a child, three silver coins was an adequate salary. With it, the boy could feed his younger siblings proper meals. If he collected money little by little, he could save enough money to live in a house and avoid the cold wind.

The boy glanced at the owner, wondering if he could really continue working there after five months.

The owner nodded.

Immediately, the boy confirmed, “I’ll do it.”

At the boy’s words, the Sage gave a satisfied look and gently touched the storefront with his palm.

The storefront, which was made of wood, became smooth as if it had just been sand-papered down.

It was a generous move, as it made the store look newer, but it was also a threat.

The Sage tapped the wooden platform with his fingertips. “I’ll come around, so please take good care of them.”

The shop-owner bowed his head, though it was unknown if it was because of the threat.

“Of course.”

Chapter 109: First Master (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 109 – First Master (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Wouldn’t taking those children to Mount Hua have been the better choice?”

The Sage of Bright Rock turned his head to look at Woon-seong, who had been walking behind him.

That was the first thing Woon-seong had said after leaving the village.

The Sage blankly responded, “Were you quietly thinking about that this whole time?”

“Just answer the question.”

Myung Am nodded to himself.

There was no reason not to explain, just that he was surprised Woon-seong had been thinking about the children at all.

Looking at the aura of blood and slaughter filling his two eyes, I was worrying that he might step onto the wrong path and become a great killing star.

But it looks like there’s nothing to worry about.

Though it was not apparent, such a thought was something only a righteous mind would worry about.

It was not something people would consider unless they had righteous thoughts.

If a man thought twice about conducting a righteous act, he was either a villain or someone who had the traits of a hero hidden deep inside.

And since Myung Am did not think Woon-seong was a villain, it could only mean that the young man still had a chivalrous heart deep inside, even if the young man himself was unaware.

I do not know who his master is, but he has been taught well.

Myung Am unknowingly complimented an old friend.

“To be honest, I would’ve liked to take all of them to Mount Hua.”

“And why didn’t you do so?”

“Because I am the head of the Mount Hua Sect.”

The Sage of Bright Rock was the head of the Mount Hua Sect.

It was a simple answer, but it held a lot of meaning.

Woon-seong may have just been enthroned, but he was also the leader of a large group of people who called themselves the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It was not hard for him to understand the hidden meaning.

If he simply took in children under the reasoning of conducting a good act, it would cause a problem with the discipline inside the sect.

Maybe one or two children would be fine.

But soon two would become three, and three would become four.

What should they do then?

No one disliked being called a righteous hero.

If the Sage of Bright Rock, the leader of the Mount Hua Sect, started bringing random people into the sect on his whim, the elders of the sect would begin to do the same.

Their strength and stability would inevitably collapse.

Now, it could be said that the Sage had established a way for the children to walk a righteous path.

One where they accepted the world and the world accepted them.

Did Woon-seong understand the Sage's thoughts and intentions?

The Sage did not explain further.

Instead, he turned back around and mumbled to himself: "Heaven and Earth are not humane. At least us humans should seek to live virtuously [1]."

The words were carried in the wind, reaching Woon-seong's ears.

They stuck with him.

Since this world is cruel, at least the people should strive for virtue...

Woon-seong arrived at Mount Wolong about seven days after leaving Yichang.

The Leader of the Justice Blood Sect is here...

Woon-seong looked at the mountainous region.

Maybe it wasn't a man surnamed Jegal who lived here.

After all, it was not just the Jegal Clan that lived in these mountains. Perhaps it was just a righteous man who concealed his identity for a long time.

“To meet the First Master, we must enter Mount Wolong. The path is rough from here, so keep up with me.”

Sage Myung led Woon-seong along a quiet mountain pass.

Whereas the roads of the Jegal Clan were well paved, this pass was rough and untravelled. There were rocks protruding here and there, and the path itself was steep.

If it was anyone who had not mastered the Art of Lightness, they would have to climb up using their hands and feet to hug the cliff face.

The Sage walked ahead and pointed to a rope. “Some martial artists and apothecaries come here sometimes. The road is so rugged that even those raised in the mountains can’t climb without relying on this rope.”

Like he said, the rope was tied tightly to a tree above.

Woon-seong was sure that with it, the climb up would be much safer.

Of course, the rope was pretty useless for Myung Am and Woon-seong. The two climbed up the mountain on their own two feet, as if it was just a normal paved street.

As they had been walking, the sun began to set.

How much further do we need to go? It’s already been at least two hours.

In the mountains, the sun set early.

While it was getting darker, Woon-seong stared at the Sage’s back, navigating by moonlight.

There are fewer signs of people the more we go.

The road showed no sign of ending.

I get he's trying to stay hidden, but does he have to live this deep inside the mountain?

That's when fog suddenly appeared.

“Hmm?”

Woon-seong scrunched his eyebrows, as the fog began to disturb his eyesight. It was quite annoying.

The moment I perceived a fog, it covered me in every direction.

No matter how fast a naturally occurring fog spread, it would still take some time.

But this fog was different.

But even when this is happening, I can see Sage Myung's back clearly...

So it was artificially made.

Is it a fog made with illusion arts?

Woon-seong glanced down at the swirling fog.

If it felt hostile, I would've forcefully broken the balance...

Recently, his achievements with the Divine Flame had begun to climb. Using it, he could burn the entire place, illusion included, into ashes.

His semi-divine level of qi could also crush the formation.

But I don't sense anything like that.

Not only did it not seem threatening, the illusion did not even produce a hallucinatory vision.

Just fog.

It must be an illusion created to prevent people from entering.

Probably.

People would feel anxious the moment the fog surrounded them and immediately retreat.

I wasn't able to sense an abnormality aside from the fog spreading.

It's such a natural illusion... Impossible without remarkable talent.

And the illusion in the form of a fog...

That could only lead to one answer.

I don't know who the leader of the Justice Blood Sect is, but it's clear he's related to the Jegal Clan.

Meanwhile, the fog had begun to part.

The receding fog slowly split along Woon-seong's path.

With the fog gone, he could see a garden filled with all sorts of beautiful flowers.

Plants planted in formations of trigrams here and there in the garden... Is that the foundation for the illusion?

Even if Woon-seong had little to no knowledge of gardening or illusions, he could still tell that much.

If the foundation is here, it must mean the creator is somewhere nearby...

At that time, the Sage stopped walking forward.

“It's there. This is where the master of the First Jade Knife, the Leader of the Justice Blood Sect, lives.”

There was an old wooden house before the two of them.

An old wooden house that seemed to have been there for decades.

No, it wouldn't even be called a house at this point.

It was just a shack built with rotting wooden planks. It looked like it would fly away if the wind was a little stronger.

The leader of the Justice Blood Sect lives here...?

While Woon-seong was staring doubtfully at the wooden shack, the door opened with a creak.

A man walked out. "Welcome. Thank you for coming such a long way."

The Sage of the Bright Rock looked at him and said, "He's the leader of the Justice Blood Sect."

The man who appeared was dressed like a school teacher.

However, it was difficult to call him an ordinary man.

There was strength within the man, beyond that of his unknown age. It was a kind of strength different from that of internal qi or pure muscle strength.

Woon-seong recognized it.

An aura of elegance that shrouds him like clothing, and dignity that can only be expressed by someone who has reached the pinnacle of a way!

For that sense of dignity, Woon-seong was filled with admiration. In respect, the young man soon let out part of his own aura. Expressing himself by revealing part of the *true* him.

Instantly, Woon-seong's presence grew stronger, becoming quite huge. "Are you the leader of the Justice Blood Sect?"

The man nodded.

It was a simple action, but it was refined.

Woon-seong had not been wrong. This person was skilled enough to reach the pinnacle in his field.

As if proving so, the man's eyes burned with energy.

Except...

Even if this man was a giant of his time, Woon-seong was the Heavenly Demon. He was in a position where he could easily squash such a giant.

“Yes. I am the leader of the Justice Blood Sect and the master of the First Jade Knife, the ‘Venerable Dragon’.

The Venerable Dragon... That sounds familiar. Where have I heard that name before?

Woon-seong had definitely heard of it somewhere, but he could not remember.

Wait a minute.

He suddenly remembered someone.

The giant of Murim and the intellectual who brought the Jegal Clan, which was at the brink of destruction, to its current prosperity with his own two hands.

The star of the Jegal Clan, who deserved to be respected and feared the moment he raised his head, because he was a true dragon residing in Mount Wolong!

The man who granted the position of Clan Head to his son and was currently wandering the world with no destination!

“Grand Elder of the Jegal Clan, the Venerable Dragon, Jegal Sung?!” Even though Woon-seong had come to that conclusion, he could not help but add, “But your looks...”

If this man really is Jegal Sung, he should be 100 by now.. But the man in front of me looks to be around his forties.

The man nodded, smiling and laughing. “I am Jegal Sung alright. I only look young because I’ve rejuvenated.”

The man said that with a teasing face.

Woon-seong turned to look at the Sage.

Sage Myung nodded, agreeing to the words of Jegal Sung. “This man is indeed Master Jegal Sung. Why he looks so young isn’t simple rejuvenation. It’s because of the age reversing revival.”

“Hoho. Why explain simple rejuvenation with such big words.”

Age Reversing Revival!

[1] “Heaven and Earth are not humane, they regard all things as straw dogs. The sage is not humane, he regards all people as straw dogs.” (Lao Tzu, *Tao Te Ching* chap.5)

Chapter 110: First Master (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 110 – First Master (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Woon-seong faltered for a moment.

The momentary pause was because the words he had just heard were unbelievable.

Age Reversing Revival.

The upper realm where a person reversed time and returned to their youth.

It was a phenomenon known to happen when a person's inner strength and martial comprehension reached pure peak perfection, allowing them to purge their human husk.

Well, that wasn't entirely true.

Reversing time was not a work in progress — it would happen, or it wouldn't.

Age Reversing Revival was just a phenomenon that occurred after cultivating an art to a certain degree or more, be that body modification, inner qi, or something like pill-making.

Of course, not all martial artists who reached said peak would achieve Age Reversing Revival.

First, the art practiced must have characteristics that implied Age Reversing Revival was possible. For example, an art that was founded on self-harm would not work.

More importantly, the characteristics of the practitioner had to match the characteristics of the cultivated art. A cultivator whose qi followed the flow of water could not achieve Age Reversal by cultivating an art of fire.

It was for these reasons that very few people in Murim history had achieved Age Reversing Revival.

Not only were they few in number, not everyone had been on the Orthodox side.

Also, this did not mean that the person who achieved Age Reversing Revival had to be strong.

Of course, no one would tell someone else the secrets of their rejuvenation.

Still, most martial artists who achieved Age Reversing Revival were martial artists at an outstanding level.

It was not easy to force back the aging of a human body, to forcefully reverse time and return to youth.

So at least in the Absolute Realm, he may even be at the brink of being in the realm of Semi-Divine.

It's about forcefully revering the natural aging of a human body with inner strength. That is no shape or form an easy achievement.

And if this man truly is Jegal Sung, then what should be feared isn't his martial arts.

The Jegal Clan is a clan of intellectuals. And being on the top of that clan... I cannot even imagine who smart this man is.

The Jegal Clan was famous for the Stone Sentinel Maze, which had been created by their ancestor Zhuge Liang. [1]

The Stone Sentinel Maze was an array of rocks and boulders based on the Eight Trigrams. It was said to make rocks seem like swords and pebbles like mountains, generating dust storms and powerful rivers to crush the enemy.

Given how high the Jegal Clan was now, if Zhuge Liang's descendants had inherited even half of his abilities, Jegal Sung was unpredictably dangerous.

On the contrary, it could be bluffing.

Woon-seong could not believe that the man was Jegal Sung just because he said so.

“Can you prove that you're the Venerable Dragon?”

Myung Am was surprised, “W-What are you saying...?”

The man who called himself the Venerable Dragon only smiled lightly and picked up some pebbles.

A total of five pebbles, each spotted black and white.

Holding them in his hand, he stared at the moon.

“Even the smallest existences in nature all possess a meaning. Black and white are no different either. White is the yang, black is the yin. Find the harmony of yin and yang, birthing the three essentials and the four directions, and soon nature will be made whole again.”

As soon as he finished speaking, the man threw the pebbles.

Fwoom—

In an instant, the world before Woon-seong's eyes shifted.

The surrounding garden disappeared and he was standing amidst a vast ocean.

Where flowers had been blooming, massive waves crashed ashore.

Woon-seong stood atop a small rocky island in the middle of the sea, and Jegal Sung stood upon a small boat in the turbulent waves.

A realistic illusion comparable to the Polymorphic Combat Illusion. He created such an illusion with a few pebbles...

I don't believe there are many who can pull off such a feat beside Jegal Sung.

Even if it's not as good as the Polymorphic Combat Illusion...

The Polymorphic Combat Illusion had been made with care by Cult officials, so it was natural that Jegal Sung couldn't make that level of illusion with a few pebbles.

Even though the two illusions similarly reproduced life-like scenes, there would be a difference.

As if proving his thoughts, the vision soon blurred.

“Oh, and we're out of time.”

As Jegal Sung looked around, the illusion of waves surrounding them disappeared in a flash.

“Trying to embody all of nature's rules in a small stone is no easy task. But how was it?” Jegal Sung, who had been looking around at the remains of the illusion, turned to Woon-seong. In his eyes, was a burst of pride. “I would dare say that's enough for me to call myself the Venerable Dragon.”

Woon-seong nodded. “I'll admit that.”

The man was undeniably the Venerable Dragoon, Jegal Sung.

More importantly, he was the person who could explain the truth to Woon-seong.

“Then answer my questions now.”

“...”

Jegal Sung glanced at the Sage of the Bright Rock, who nodded, confirming that Woon-seong had the Fifth Jade Knife.

Satisfied, he turned back to Woon-seong.

“By the way, I’ve heard that you have inherited the Spear Master Sect’s martial arts. Is that true?”

Woon-seong turned to question Myung Am, thinking that the Sage had already told Jegal Sang.

However, the Sage quietly shook his head. It was not him who delivered that information.

There was only one other person who might have known.

Lim Soo-yeon. She must have told him.

Although there had been a qi barrier while Woon-seong and the Sage talked, she might have heard part of the story.

I wasn’t planning to hide it anyways.

Given that the Seventh Master knew, it was only a matter of time before the First Master found out.

Woon-seong nodded and grabbed his spear. “That’s true.”

At that, Jegal Sung smiled. “Then prove it to me.”

“...?”

Jegal Sung glanced at Woon-seong, then at his spear. “I’ve proven myself to be the Venerable Dragon. Therefore I want you to prove yourself as the inheritor of the Spear Master Sect.”

Woon-seong chuckled.

Although it was not strictly a sole apprentice sect, very few people had the chance to see the Spear Master Sect in action. Therefore, there was very little information about the sect known to Murim.

Even if he demonstrated the art, very few people would even recognize it.

Of course, the Sage of the Bright Rock had been able to recognize it, but that was only because of his friendship with Nok Yu-on.

“Would you even recognize it?”

“Why wouldn’t I?”

“...”

“The spear of the Spear Master Sect is like flowing water. With spear strikes that flow abundantly like a river, it traps the opponent in a massive sea. And the opponent, caught in this sea, struggles inside it, only to face their death.”

Woon-seong’s eyebrow twitched. Jegal Sung’s words had indeed pierced the core of the Spear Master Sect’s arts.

“How do you know that?”

“Historically, the leader of the Spear Master Sect has served as the master of the Fifth Jade Knife. I’ve heard about the skills of the Spear Master Sect from previous masters.”

Woon-seong had already known that his master, Nok Yu-on, was the owner of the Fifth Jade Knife.

However, he hadn't known that even the previous Spearmasters were also owners of the Fifth Jade Knife.

That's why you wanted to hand this down to me. Woon-seong touched the Fifth Jade Knife hanging at his waist.

“So that's what happened.”

With his other hand, he slowly moved the White Night Spear.

“Then take a good look.”

Divine Spear of the Ending Night!

The godly spear which erased the darkness of the night.

The spear arts, which had been developed from generation to generation, were once again in Woon-seong's hands.

The Spear Master Sect was a sect that had been studying and practicing spear arts for ages.

That was why the disciples of the Spear Master Sect were unparalleled in martial arts research and cultivation.

Even if you searched the entire world, it would be hard to find a scholar comparable to a disciple of the Spear Master Sect.

But the world was vast and people numerous.

The Spear Master Sect could not be considered unparalleled.

The Venerable Dragon for example, was a genius in his own right.

The Jegal Clan had also studied countless martial arts and would continue to do so for generations to come. That level of martial knowledge was likely comparable to the Spear Master Sect.

Jegal Sung was the Grand Elder of the Jegal Clan. He prided himself on understanding martial arts better than anyone else. His eyes, thirsty for knowledge, observed Woon-seong's movements.

This... is quite the view.

He is hiding the essence, but that is clearly the Divine Spear of the Ending Night of the Spear Master Sect.

There were many spear skills that imitated the form of waves.

But spear moves that created such powerful waves and created a great sea only existed in one place.

And this man's spear was creating a true great sea.

That was all Jegal Sung needed to see to believe that Woon-seong was an apprentice of the Spear Master Sect.

Nevertheless, he examined Woon-seong's razor-sharp spear.

But it's not completely the same.

If the former Spearmasters had pursued softness, the 'Divine Spear of the Ending Night' by Woon-seong contained vigor within that softness.

It was a combination of strength and softness.

Of course, Jegal Sung understood that martial arts changed gradually over time.

Softness and its flexibility was compatible with strength.

That was not the problem.

The surprising thing was the young man's age.

So he developed the martial arts of the sect at such a young age... And I heard he's from a branch sect. Amazing.

When Jegal Zung had first heard that the Sage of the Bright Rock, owner of the Seventh Jade Sword, had been defeated, he merely thought that Woon-seong was excellent.

However, Woon-seong's true talent far exceeded that estimation.

It's not something one can perform without being a true veteran.

If Jegal Sung saw 'Flow of the Divine Dragon', he would probably lose his mind. Was he the one who achieved rejuvenation, or was it Woon-seong?

But Woon-seong did not show Flow of the Divine Dragon.

Only the Divine Spear of the Ending Night was needed.

It was not necessary to show Flow of the Divine Dragon in a place where he did not know the full story.

Shh...

Soon, the spear stopped.

The waves of spear qi, which had been spread around, stopped too.

Woon-seong had decided that he had shown enough.

Jegal Sung nodded. "That is the spear skills of the Spear Master Sect alright. You have the right to hear what you want from me."

"Then..."

"But this is not the appropriate place to talk. Let's go inside first."

Jegal Sung beckoned him towards the small wooden shack.

[1] The Stone Sentinel Maze, or Eightfold Array, was an array of rocks and boulders thought to have been conjured by Zhuge Liang based on the Bagua, or Eight Trigrams.

Chapter 111: Identity (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 111- Identity (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Come in and have a seat.”

With the guidance of Jegal Sung, Woon-seong entered the shack.

The interior of the rickety old building was much larger and cleaner than its outside.

It was unbelievable that it was just an old shack.

Woon-seong stared out the window. *The shack... Was it also under an illusion?*

But soon he realized that was not the case.

The outward appearance of the wooden shack was real. The building just consisted of multiple layers.

Jegal Sung had dug into the ground, allowing for more space between the floor and the ceiling. But on the outside, it would still look like a worn-down building.

Woon-seong nodded to himself, admiring the ingenuity of the disguise.

Meanwhile, Jegal Sung placed a warm cup of tea in front of him. “It’s White Hair Silver Needle tea. I prepared some high quality ones, so I hope it works for you.”

Just as he said, the tea was not bad.

Woon-seong quickly finished his tea.

“I want to get to the point now.”

Jegal Sung sipped some tea, nodding. “Very well. Let’s do it this way. You ask me what you’d like to know and I will answer it.”

Woon-seong agreed. If he could ask the questions, it would be easier to get the answer he wanted.

Moreover, the first question he wanted to ask was already set.

“Okay then... Did the Spearmaster go that way because he truly wanted to do so himself?”

It was a question about Nok Yu-on.

Woon-seong had already heard the story from the Sage of Bright Rock, who assured him that it had been the Spearmaster’s own decision.

But Woon-seong wanted to confirm one more time.

Jegal Sung sighed deeply.

“I have never seen a man as righteous as he. People of the Spearmaster Sect have always been known to be chivalrous. But I doubt many of them would’ve sacrificed their own lives with the ease he did.”

Jegal Sung did not answer the question directly, but his words had meaning.

In those words, Woon-seong could confirm that his master had chosen his own path.

Master...

It was a decision he had been cornered into, but still a decision Nok Yu-on had made on his own. Moreover, even on the way, he had refused to tell Woon-seong to protect his only apprentice.

Understanding his master's mindset once more, Woon-seong gripped the teacup in his hand.

Those who led to such a wonderful master's death?

He could never forgive them.

The tea in Woon-seong's cup boiled.

It was not until cloudy vapor was rising from the tea that Woon-seong asked his next question.

"Tell me what the Spearmaster was looking into."

"As the Fifth Master, you have the right to know. But before that, there's one thing I need to check."

Jegal Sung's razor-sharp stare pierced into Woon-seong, like he was looking through Woon-seong's mind. This was a piercing look that viewed Woon-seong not as a martial artist, but as just another human.

Woon-seong nodded calmly, indicating for the man to continue.

"Do you have any intentions of working as the master of the Fifth Jade Knife of our sect? I'm asking if you can become a man of the Justice Blood Sect."

When asked, Woon-seong pulled out the Fifth Jade Knife.

He plunged the knife deep into the table, between the space left behind by his teacup. The knife dug deep into the table, cutting through it like tofu.

Once the knife was stuck half-way to its hilt, Woon-seong took his hand off.

With frosty eyes, he spoke. “While I do not plan to stray from the path of a human being, I have no intention of being a hero. Therefore, I cannot be the master of this Fifth Jade Knife.”

Woon-seong had proven himself to the members of the Justice Blood Sect simply because he wished to meet with the First Master.

To remain as the master of the Fifth Jade Knife, to become the Fifth Master of the Justice Blood Sect... Woon-seong did not know how much more of a hero he needed to be.

And most importantly, Woon-seong had no intention to live as a righteous man. He had no idea when his revenge would come to an end, but until then, concepts like justice were beyond him.

“So, you’re refusing to be the master of the Fifth Jade Knife, one of the Seven Masters of our sect?”

Jegal Sung’s voice was hard.

There was a threat hidden in those words: If you don’t become the master of the Fifth Jade Knife, you won’t get any information.

“How about I take this position temporarily, not officially?”

Jegal Sung’s gaze shifted. “Oh-ho?”

Usually, when faced with two options, people would pick between the two given.

Woon-seong had made a completely different choice. Not liking the ones offered, he had created a third option.

It seemed that Jegal Sung and Woon-seong had something in common — they were straightforward.

I don’t dislike this stubborn honesty. Jegal Sung leaned back in his seat, waiting to hear Woon-seong’s explanation.

“What I want is vengeance against those who made the Spear Master Sect like this. And for my revenge, I can be a man of the Justice Blood Sect, one of the Seven Masters or the master of the Fifth Jade Knife.

“But?”

“However, I am not a man that suits the Justice Blood Sect. So let’s make a deal. I will take the position of the owner of the Fifth Jade Knife for a while. And when this is all over, I will hand it over to someone more suitable. This shouldn’t be a bad deal for you people either.”

As he spoke, Woon-seong revealed more of his aura.

At that moment, Jegal Sung felt something appear in front of him.

A sense of pressure that has sprouted from an endless cliff.

It’s not simply a cliff.

It’s a vast mass of land.

Land that is only allowed to those who have pioneered a new paradigm in martial arts.

The young man in front of me is allowed to roam that place.

So there’s a reason why he showed such confidence.

Inwardly, Jegal Sung was quite amazed.

Woon-seong had decided to reveal his strength while he offered a deal.

Woon-seong was obviously not intending to let himself get the worse end of the deal. He had no intention of going out of his way for something he did not want. Besides, the young man obviously had the power to do what he wanted.

Jegal Sung glanced at Woon-seong’s eyes and laughed. *What an interesting fellow.*

Eyes were the window to the soul.

As a martial artist, you could hide as much of your heart as you wanted, but Jegal Sung had many people in his lifetime.

Among them, some had a unique aura and disposition.

Just like Woon-seong.

From experience, Jegal Sung just knew. *These people will never go behind my back while cooperating.*

Jegal Sung emptied his cup of tea.

“Good. Then I will consider you as the temporary master of the Fifth Jade Knife. I hope the position of the next master goes to no villain, but to a hero who will strive for the path of justice.”

Woon-seong wouldn’t even bother thinking about it until he had avenged his masters. So he nodded. “It’s always a possibility.”

A kind of deal was made.

“Then I’ll tell you. But before that, can you tell me how much you already know?”

“The fact that the Spearmaster was investigating a certain group and that he sacrificed himself to lure them out. And the fact that said group may or may not be the Cult of the Inverted Sky, which may or may not have taken over the Imperial Court.”

“Ha!” Jegal Sung almost spat out his tea. “If you already know that much, you know most of it. I’m not sure what more you want to know. Do you just want to reconfirm the truth?”

Shocked, Woon-seong’s voice pitched a bit higher. “Then is it true that the Cult of the Inverted Sky took over the Imperial Court?”

Jegal Sung nodded solemnly. “They didn’t simply take over it. They have already become both the Imperial Court itself as well as the very power moving it.”

Woon-seong went completely solemn. He thought back to what Do Jinmyung had said and muttered, “Now the emperor is not the Emperor, but someone wearing his husk...”

Woon-seong’s murmurs caused Jegal Sung to stiffen. Clenching his fist, the teacup shattered.

It was also because he was so surprised that his words came out harsher than before.

“How did you know that?”

“...”

Woon-seong stayed silent instead of answering.

Jegal Sung began to regard Woon-seong with more caution.

“A level of martial arts too high for your age. A man who knows too many secrets unknown to the world. Does it make sense that I am describing one person? Who on earth are you?”

Jegal Sang’s gaze was sharp.

A huge wave of energy surged from behind the man’s back and aimed at Woon-seong.

So he’s willing to attack me at any moment... What now? Woon-seong sighed.

There were a lot of options he could choose from.

So he just chose one of them.

It may have been a more...radical approach...

But sometimes it was better to rip the band-aid off then let a lie rot under the surface.

“The enemy is the Imperial Court and the Emperor himself. It looks like the Justice Blood Sect is already having a hard time handling the Orthodox side of Murim. Do you really have the strength to deal with the Imperial Court?”

“You have not answered me yet.”

“I am asking you to answer that question.”

Woon-seong also released some of his own energy, not lagging behind Jegal Sung at all.

Invisible to the naked eye, the forces collided with each other, causing the air to tremble.

At the same time, Jegal Sung began to feel pressure.

The enormous energy emanating from Woon-seong’s body began to crush him.

Yet, he began to feel a strand of a peculiarly familiar energy.

“This is...”

Demonic qi!

It was such a pure demonic qi that Jegal Sung would even think Woon-seong had cultivated it with an orthodox method.

Jegal Sung’s fingertips trembled.

There was only one martial artist capable of having such pure demonic qi.

Moreover...

I’ve had a recent report that said the new leader of the Divine Cult looked very young.

“Then are you...?”

For the first time since meeting Woon-seong, Jegal Sung’s voice trembled.

“I am the zenith of the 100,000 demonic practitioners, the Leader of the Demonic Cult.”

As he spoke in a calm voice, Woon-seong’s body became covered with a silent, purple-gray flame.

Two golden eyes pierced through the flames, locking Jegal Sung in place.

“I am the Heavenly Demon.”

Chapter 112: Identity (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 112- Identity (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Heavenly Demon!

“The hell—”

Jegal Sung made a strangled noise of astonishment at Woon-seong’s words and hastily flipped over the table.

Boom!

The table flew halfway towards Woon-seong in a flash.

Woon-seong reached out and the table was caught by the Divine Flame.

Whoosh—

The Divine Flame immediately burnt the table into ashes, disintegrating it into the room.

That was not the end.

Boom!

There was a muffled explosion and thick smoke began to rise from beneath the floorboards, obstructing the view.

In a quick motion, Jegal Sung flew out of the building, just as some metal balls flew at Woon-seong.

Shh, shh.

It was not just some metal balls, as numerous machine traps were installed inside the building.

Soon, all sorts of devices were aimed at Woon-seong.

There were dozens of arrows behind the row of metal balls, and a steel net soon fell over his head.

A dozen well-sharpened blades flew towards his nape.

The ground beneath him crumbled, revealing more traps.

Amazing! So this is the Jegal Clan's inescapable web of traps.

Weaponry and traps surrounded Woon-seong from all sides.

Each individual portion was easy to deal with, but they were all elaborately entangled together, making them a nuisance to deal with.

What a situation!

He couldn't even retreat.

Woon-seong moved forward.

If I can't avoid them, I'll just block them.

Woon-seong's eyes shone gold.

While the traps used well-crafted precision, there was still a very subtle difference between their timing.

Woon-seong decided to divide his personal time by smaller units.

He split a second into hundreds, then into thousands of milliseconds.

The objects flashing before his eyes slowed down as his concept of *one moment* lengthened.

Like this, he was able to decide which traps should be dealt with first.

Shh.

He took the first step forward.

That one step took him away from the edge of the pit, avoiding fall down.
The steel net falling from above was unable to catch him either.

There were still metal balls and poles flying right at him.

That one step had brought him closer to them.

He was expecting that though.

Instead of being surprised, Woon-seong merely blinked.

Fwoom—

The metal melted in an instant, unable to bypass the Divine Flame surrounding Woon-seong on all sides.

Tss—

Red hot globs of metal fell to the floor, sizzling on the wooden planks.

The fate of the arrows flying from behind him was no different. The moment the Divine Shaped Flame manifested, the arrows turned to ashes.

In an instant, all that was left were the blades.

Woon-seong reached out to them with his qi. With one motion, he extended his hand and gathered all of the blades together.

All of the blades aiming for Woon-seong stopped in midair, just floating in the sky.

The ability to move objects however he wanted.

Qi condensation, and eventually, telekinesis.

Woon-seong did not let them linger motionlessly in the air.

With another swipe of his hands, the blades flipped around in unison.

Now, they were no longer aimed at Woon-seong.

With a dazzling light, the blades formed a pin-wheel formation, pointed towards his enemies.

A technique that cast qi around the blade and granted it its own will.

An extension of the Lightning Stitching Art, which now applied the concept onto multiple sword blades instead of throwing knives.

The whole building collapsed with a cracking sound.

Boom!

“What’s happening here?”

Hearing the commotion, the Sage of Bright Rock rushed over from where he had been waiting.

Until then, Jegal Sang was watching the collapsed building.

“Did I succeed?”

Even though the opponent was the Heavenly Demon, perhaps it was still possible with this technique...

“Master?”

“Draw your sword.”

“What?”

“Draw your sword right now!”

Despite not understanding the situation, Sage Myung still drew his blade.

Jegal Sung drew his own blade, holding an iron fan in his other hand.

The iron feathers of the fan were made of black iron, cut to create a wave-like pattern on the surface.

Glancing back, Jegal Sung asked, “Did you already know?”

“...?”

“That he is the Heavenly Demon?”

“The hell?!”

Just as Jegal Sung had done, Myung Am also shouted aloud.

Heavenly Demon!

What kind of being was that?

He was the biggest nightmare to the Orthodox in Murim.

But that young man — who Myung Am had brought here himself — was the Heavenly Demon.

“I can’t believe that guy is the Heavenly Demon. Are you saying that he isn’t the descendant of the Spear Master Sect?”

“I’m not sure either. I’m sure he used the Spear Master Sect’s martial arts, but I don’t understand how he can control the flame...”

The Divine Flame was the symbol of the Heavenly Demon.

Even if Woon-seong insisted otherwise, manifestation of the Divine Shaped Flame undoubtedly proved him as the Heavenly Demon.

“Unbelievable. A Heavenly Demon that uses the Spear Master Sect’s arts...” Myung Am muttered to himself.

Jegal Sung, who had kept his eyes on the building the entire time, stiffened and shouted, “He’s coming!”

Boom!

At the end of his sentence, a massive pillar of flames shot into the sky.

Debris from the fallen building shot into the air with it, driven by the power of the fire.

Fwoom—

Soon, the burning remains of the building began to rain out of the sky.

Jegal Sung pulled out a few metal spikes from his pockets and threw them into the air.

Kwa-rung—

With the sound of rumbling thunder, the spikes fell out of the air and hit the ground.

“I shall put Heaven and Earth into the yin-yang and five elements to pass through the universe and flip the Nine Heavens, scatter!”

Along with Jegal Sung’s chants, a huge black wall rose and enveloped the burning building on all sides.

It was an illusion art created to destroy darkness and slay demons.

Supposedly, it was powerful enough to induce a martial artist to self-induce qi deviation and commit suicide.

Even though he is the Heavenly Demon, he won't be able to come out unharmed. At least it will deal some damage to his spirit!

But that was something Jegal Sung could believe because he did not understand the Semi-Divine Realm.

There was just one wall dividing those of the Absolute Realm and those of the Semi-Divine, but it was a very large and thick wall.

It was a wall that divided humans and those who had stepped onto the thresholds of the gods.

A man who had never crossed that wall himself could never peer into the realm of Semi-Divinity.

Fwa-ping!

More and more black walls rose from the ground.

Just as fast — or perhaps faster — the walls were sliced in half.

A fire rose between the broken walls.

“I couldn't hold him even with this spell?!” Jegal Sung shouted in surprise, but he added a few more metal spikes for good measure.

There was now double the amount of metal spikes.

If he couldn't do it the first time, he would just have to try again.

But...

Fwa-ping!

Just like the original walls, the new ones were also slashed down.

The standards of humanity could not be used to measure those of the Semi-Divine.

Fwoom—

The Divine Flame swallowed the foundation of Jegal Sung's illusion.

Like a greedy, evil dragon, it tore through the area.

The scene was terrifying.

Even though he was called the Venerable Dragon, how could Jegal Sung not be appalled by this sight?

How could the power of a human be that vast?

Intellect makes a decision solely based on information. Did I make the wrong decision? If I didn't, then was the information wrong?

Jegal Sung racked his brain for answers. It had gotten to the point where he was questioning himself.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong slowly walked out of the building and through the raging flames.

Around him flew several blades, each at least 10 *cun* (~1ft, 33cm) in length.

What was truly frightening was not the blades, but the spear in his hand.

Whoo-hoo!

Flames with a center of molten gold, wisps of fear-inducing qi, and a spear that seemed to contain the Will of Heaven.

This is the power of the Heavenly Demon... The weight of the name 'Heavenly Demon' is this great?

How could Woon-seong be called human?

What a nightmare.

A nightmare in the form of a man stood before their eyes.

But Jegal Sung and Myung Am couldn't give up like that.

That was the Heavenly Demon!

Jegal Sung had no idea why the man had approached the Justice Blood Sect, but he was definitely an enemy.

I should stop him here.

Myung Am also nodded his head, thinking the same thing.

Sharing just one glance, the two Absolute-realm masters quickly dashed towards Woon-seong.

Hmm. Woon-seong watched as the two ran towards him. They didn't even consider having a conversation and attacked immediately after finding out my identity.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly. *I see how bad the relationship between the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and the Orthodox martial arts is now.*

But that was that, and this was this.

I first have to suppress them in order to have a civil conversation.

Woon-seong raised his left hand.

The blades, which had been swirling around Woon-seong, flew towards the two figures.

At the same time, Woon-seong harnessed the mind tempering portion of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

Mind Split, Double Will.

With it, Woon-seong now had increased control over the dancing blades.

As if moving on their own, the blades flew into a different formation.

What Woon-seong had mastered was not just the spear arts.

Dozens of sword arts began to be executed.

The Sage and Jegal Sung urgently stopped the attacks, but it was not easy.

It's not just one or two sword skills! It feels like fighting against many different masters.

Is it possible for one person to know so much about martial arts?

Clang—

Jegal Sung grit his teeth as he smacked a blade to the side with his fan.

It was not impossible.

Jegal Sung knew a lot of martial artists who had such a vast sea of knowledge.

It can't be possible unless he is someone of the Spear Master Sect!

So it's true that the descendant of the Spear Master Sect became the Heavenly Demon?

What he had thought impossible was quickly proven to be possible.

However...

Why did the Heavenly Demon come to Zhongyuan?

That was a question Jegal Sung found puzzling.

In the meantime, the Sage of Bright Rock had fallen.

“Cough!”

Myung Am’s sword was cut in half and he was bowled over by a gust of wind. With a hammer-like impact, the Sage slammed into a boulder and collapsed.

The Sage did not get back up.

However, his body did twitch every now and then, confirming that he was at least alive.

“Sage Myung!” Jegal Sung called out to him in shock.

The broken part of the sword, swooped out of the air and aimed at the Sage’s neck.

The others, however, changed direction mid-flight and charged towards Jegal Sung.

Almost in a daze, Jegal Sung had to question what he was seeing. “He only suppresses and does not kill?”

But he didn’t even have time to process the thought.

Boom!

Metal pieces burst in the air, shattering above his head, and Jegal Sung dove for the ground.

Kacha—

The sword in Jegal Sung’s hand was broken into three pieces.

Shh.

An array of blades aimed at him from above.

Overwhelming defeat.

A part of Jegal Sung whispered that his days as a military strategist were over.

Beyond a wall of flames and debris, Jegal Sung could hear the voice of the Heavenly Demon.

“Looks like you’re ready to talk now.”

Chapter 113: Shared Goal (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 113- Shared Goal (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Hahahaha.”

Jegal Sung collapsed into a fit of half-maniacal laughter.

The energy emanating from Woon-seong was still heart-stoppingly strong, and his garden had been completely destroyed.

The Divine Flame was still spreading, so the entire piece of land would soon be burned.

This place looked like it could never be used again.

But was that all?

The Sage of Bright Rock had been smashed somewhere and was still unconscious.

Moreover, the safe-house and all the hidden devices were also no longer usable.

But...

“All of this was just to have a talk?!” Jegal Sung cried out, the words sounding more like a wail of anger.

Woon-seong smiled. He also saw the devastated surroundings.

But the young man didn’t think any of it was his fault.

There was a reason, of course.

“Do you want to say it is my fault? You were the one who started to attack me the moment I said ‘I am the Heavenly Demon’, weren’t you? From the beginning, I just wanted to talk...”

“Hahaha... Yes, You are right...”

Jegal Sung could not find anything wrong in those words. He could not help but start laughing once more.

As Woon-seong had said, the first to strike had not been the Heavenly Demon, but Jegal Sung himself.

The Heavenly Demon had acted in self-defense.

I was being arrogant, since everyone was praising me as the World’s smartest.

I was stupid.

Jegal Sung reflected on his mistake with an empty chuckle.

Then, he slowly picked himself up off the ground.

His garments had been scorched by the flames, but he didn’t care. He straightened them as best as he could.

After all the preparations, he finally spoke.

“It was my fault. I apologize for that. You came to the Justice Blood Sect with the Fifth Jade Knife to have a talk. What do you want to talk about?”

Jegal Sung's attitude was different from before.

Before Woon-seong's identity had been revealed, the young man in front of him was merely the successor of a sect.

But now it was different.

Although the man was the Orthodox's nightmare, he was the Cult Leader.

"I have said that already. What I wasn't is revenge for the Spear Master Sect."

Jegal Sung was silent for a moment. *His purpose really was revenge for the Spear Master Sect. If that is so...*

That made him confused, as he tried to guess the relationship between the Heavenly Demon and the Spear master Sect.

However, because he did not know the secret of Hyuk Woon-seong's existence, he could not reach an adequate conclusion.

Eventually, Jegal Sung had to ask.

"If you'll excuse me, may I ask what your relationship with the Spear Master Sect is?"

"Why not," nodded Woon-seong, briefly explaining. "The Spear Master Sect is known to pass down its legacy to only one apprentice, but that is not always true. Did you know that?"

Jegal Sung was silent instead of answering.

He was one of the few people who knew that the Spear Master Sect was not always a sole apprentice sect.

"A long time ago, one martial artist who inherited the Spear Master Sect's arts referred to himself to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. Because of him, the Spear Master Sect's roots sprang up not only in the Orthodox, but also in the Demonic Cult."

“So that’s how you learned the Spear Master Sect’s arts?”

“Yes.”

Of course, Woon-seong had changed the middle of the story.

It was true that the Spear Master Sect’s apprentice referred himself to the Demonic Cult, but it didn’t take root. Instead, it was passed down to Hyuk Woon-seong, the one who was reborn there...

But that was a story Jegal Sung would not believe, and it was not something Woon-seong wanted out there anyway.

“Huh, so that’s why you knew the Spear Master Sect’s martial art,” Jegal Sung muttered to himself as everything began to make sense. “I lost. I’ll admit that I have lost.”

Immediately, Woon-seong dispersed his energy.

The flames receded.

The blades, which had been spiraling in the air, fell straight to the floor.

The White Night Spear was gently strapped back onto Woon-seong’s shoulder.

The overwhelming aura pressing down on all sides also subsided.

Woon-seong once again looked like a normal young man.

If it weren’t for the scattered traces of destruction around him, Jegal Sung would not have believed his eyes.

Huh. If I tell anyone about what he is capable of, they will think I’m crazy, since he looks so young...

Jegal Sung groaned in his heart.

A remarkable master has appeared in the Demonic Cult.

It's good luck for the Demonic Cult, but if I stand in his way, he may become a nightmare for the Orthodox, one which has never been seen before.

While Jegal Sung was still starting, Woon-seong spoke once more.

“I want to ask you the same question again...”

“The same question?”

“The target is the Imperial Court. It's actually the Cult of the Inverted Sky, since the power of the Inverted Sky is the power of the Imperial Court in the situation. Is there any way that I can get rid of them?”

Jegal Sung shook his head. The way to deal with the Imperial Court was also of great concern to him.

“As far as I can see, there is no way. We are having a hard time just keeping those who are hiding inside the Orthodox in check.”

That was the answer Woon-seong had been expecting.

The Imperial Court was truly a pain to deal with.

Power was sophisticated.

It was another problem of brains or brawn.

Overwhelming brute strength could trample a sophisticated set-up. But on the contrary, a sophisticated trap could allow weak soldiers to defeat physically stronger enemies.

The emperor was at the pinnacle of the physical power known as the Imperial Court. At his beck and call were hundreds of thousands of Imperial troops.

Mostly, those of Murim would bravely say they would fight back.

However, there was a limited amount each martial artist could do by themselves.

It was also not easy for such masters to lay down their lives to stop the thousands of imperial soldiers.

So, of course the Imperial Court was a headache.

That was why brute strength should be dealt with using brute strength.

And Woon-seong happened to have a useful connection.

King Jinseong.

Remembering him, Woon-seong asked, “What if there’s a way to make a diversion within the Imperial Court?”

Jegal Sung’s eyes widened.

As he was riding through the mountains, a name suddenly came to Sage Do Jin-myung’s mind.

The Venerable Dragon, Jegal Sung.

A dragon who must be worshipped every time it raises its head. When was the last time that I heard his name?

He was the head of the Jegal Clan before I was even born, a hero of the times, the one who raised the Jegal Clan back to the top.

That was a man technically one generation older than himself.

It’s amazing that he’s still alive and wants to see me.

A few days ago, a letter had arrived at the Jinseong Palace.

It was an invitation from Venerable Dragon Jegal Sung, asking him to visit Mount Wolong as soon as possible.

The moment he read the letter, Do Jin-myung hesitated.

This was an invitation from someone whose name had not appeared for decades.

Is it okay to answer this?

Is it okay to meet him?

That was a natural reaction.

But there was another letter that came with the Venerable Dragon's.

A letter from someone who called himself the 'Leader of the Demonic Cult'.

The Venerable Dragon, who was an important person on the Orthodox side, and the Heavenly Demon, who was the zenith of the 100,000 demonic practitioners, were calling him from the same place?

He would not go had it been an ordinary day.

It honestly sounded ridiculous.

There was a good chance it was a trap.

Nevertheless, Do Jin-myung still went.

It was because of a single phrase written in the letter by the so-called Demonic Cult Leader.

'Empire's messenger'.

The title Do Jin-myung had never used in any place, except one.

The title I used in the Divine Palace of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon is on the letter...

The only people who would call him the Emperor's messenger were those who had been present on that day.

There's no way I can doubt it.

Do Jin-myung shook his head, not thinking about it anymore.

His horse had already carried him, crossing into the Longzhong Mountains.

As the mountains began to appear, Do Jin-myung took out the letters.

Hm. It's not the Jegal Clan, but a totally different place...

He directed the horse in another direction, using a different path to enter Mount Wolong.

The road was too rough for a horse, so he had to climb on his own feet.

How far had he travelled up the mountain?

Some distance away, there was someone standing in the middle of the path.

Do Jin-myung squinted at the figure, muscles tensing in preparation.

As his eyesight cleared, he was able to recognize the figure standing far away.

The leader of the Mount Hua Sect, the Plum Blossom Sword Saint.

“The Sage of Bright Rock, Sage Myung?”

The moment Do Jin-myung recognized the man, he felt cold sweat gathering at his nape and a chill ran down his spine.

The Sage of Bright Rock had some ties with the Orthodox Martial Alliance, but he was recently found to be related to an underground group.

Someone that an unknown group had planted...

An informer for the Cult of the Inverted Sky?

Was this a trap?!

King Jinseong did not know about the existence of the Justice Blood Sect, so it was natural that the unknown group would be considered an enemy.

Just as Do Jin-myung recognized him, Myung Am also recognized Do Jin-myung.

With a wave of his hand, Myung Am stopped Do Jin-myung from attacking. "I don't want to fight with you."

"You don't want to fight?"

Myung Am nodded.

His empty sleeve fluttered in the wind, catching Do Jin-myung's eyes.

Perhaps Myung Am felt the gaze on his empty sleeve. Smiling bitterly, he said, "I was only requested to bring you to them."

Again, the first thing Do Jin-myung thought was, *Wouldn't this be a trap? If it is so, this is the time for me to leave since he can't use his original power...*

Do Jin-myung still thought of the Sage of Bright Rock as someone on the side of the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

As soon as he thought so, a mist began to swirl around the area.

It's an illusion formation... Damn it.

As long as Do Jin-myung was trapped in the illusion formation, he had no choice but to move according to the creator's intentions.

In the end, I have to go.

He was already here anyway.

Do Jin-myung's shoulders sagged.

“Lead the way.”

Chapter 114: Shared Goal (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 114- Shared Goal (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Hoo...This should be enough for people to get comfortable.

While the Sage of Bright Rock went outside to meet with Do Jin-myung, Jegal Sung brought Woon-seong back inside the shack.

He had restored it to its original appearance to the best of his abilities.

“If you don’t mind, may I ask your name?”

Woon-seong opened his eyes from where he had been sitting and glanced at Jegal Sung, as if asking ‘why do you need to know my name?’

Jegal Sung nodded to himself, not making any excuse. “It’s just a little inconvenient to call you ‘Cult Leader’ all the time... Only if I know your last name would I be able to address you properly.”

“Don’t you know which last name the leader of the Demonic Cult uses?”

Unless it was a special case, most Heavenly Demons all had the same last name.

But Jegal Sung wasn’t playing around. He had some information networks that extended to inside the Demonic Cult.

“Well I do, but your last name isn’t ‘Cheon’, is it?”

As a result, Jegal Sung knew that the current Cult Leader was not of the Cheon bloodline.

But he didn’t know the man’s name.

So he asked.

Woon-seong smiled slightly. “Hyuk Woon-seong.”

“Hyuk Woon-seong?”

Jegal Sung felt like he had heard that name before.

Woon-seong blankly stared at the man, not revealing anything.

Wasn’t that Nok Yu-on’s apprentice’s name?

“Is that your real name?”

“...”

Woon-seong did not respond.

Seeing the lack of response, Jegal Sung had no choice but to judge for himself.

He concluded that it was an alias.

I am certain Nok Yu-on’s apprentice died on that day. I buried their bodies with my own hands.

He probably learned the name ‘Hyuk Woon-seong’ when he heard about the Spear Master Sect’s fate.

Did he choose that name as his alias because he wanted to let others know that he is out for revenge?

“I have one more thing I want to ask you...”

“...”

“Even though you are originally from the Spear Master Sect, was this relationship so deep that the Leader of the Demonic Cult needed to move?”

During the rebuilding of the shack, Jegal Sung had spoken with the young man a few times. Even before that, the Cult of the Inverted Sky had come up a few times in conversation.

Every time it was mentioned, Jegal Sung could feel a simmering anger from Woon-seong.

The young man looked calm on the outside, but his hatred burned like an active volcano.

This type of silent anger was the scariest kind, just as those who were able to suppress such anger were the most dangerous.

Silent, righteous anger.

It was too much anger for a Cult Leader to have.

Woon-seong did not answer the question for a long time. He just silently sat there.

When he heard no response, Jegal Sung began to shuffle away. Somehow, the atmosphere had become unbearably heavy once more. He decided he should brew some tea.

At that moment, Woon-seong’s voice drifted over:

“It wasn’t only the Spear Master Sect who got attacked by them.”

Having just reached for the tea leaves, Jegal Sung turned his head.

Woon-seong sat there with his eyes closed.

It was like the words just now had been a hallucination.

But Jegal Sung had heard them clearly.

And Woon-seong had definitely said them.

Jegal Sung calmly turned around and continued to brew tea. *Does he mean someone important in the Demonic Cult got attacked by the Inverted Sky...*

Soon, hot tea was poured into a cup.

Glug, glug—

Woon-seong opened his eyes when he felt someone approaching the building.

Naturally, it was the Sage of the Bright Rock and Do Jin-myung.

Do Jin-myung entered the garden area through the same path Woon-seong had and soon saw the garden where all kinds of flowers were growing.

“Did you get attacked?”

That was the first thing Do Jin-myung asked when he saw the garden.

Or more correctly, what was left of the garden.

Bright Rock smiled slightly, which looked more like a grimace.

He remembered who had made the garden look like this.

The building had barely been restored, but the garden would take a long time to fully heal.

“The one who called you here...”

Just as Bright Rock wanted to explain what had happened to Do Jin-myung, someone walked out of the wood shack.

“You arrived.”

It was Woon-seong.

Next to him was Jegal Sung.

Woon-seong’s appearance surprised Do Jin-myung.

Apparently it wasn’t a trap. *I wasn’t sure, but it was true that the Leader of the Demonic Cult is here.*

Regaining his calm, Do Jin-myung bowed to Woon-seong. “Good to see you, Leader of the Demonic Cult.”

He received a nod.

Then Do Jin-myung turned to look at the other man, who was standing beside Woon-seong.

Bright Rock kindly introduced the other, “He is the Great Scholar Jegal.”

Do Jin-myung’s eyes trembled. “If he is the Venerable Dragon, the Great Scholar Jegal, he should look...”

The Venerable Dragon should be older than himself, but the man before him looked at least a decade younger... How was that possible?

Bright Rock had no choice but to explain again, “He has succeeded in Age Reversing Revival.”

“Age Reversing Revival!”

Once again, it took Do Jin-myung a while to regain his calm.

But it was just for a while.

The reason they had gathered was not just to admire the Venerable Dragon’s new, younger look.

Jegal Sung placed a cup of tea in front of everyone.

“Thank you for coming all the way here.”

“Actually, in the beginning, I was suspicious. I thought I might end up being buried here.”

Do Jin-myung glanced at the Sage of Bright Rock.

Jegal Sung smiled bitterly, understanding the look. “He is a spy we planted inside of the Martial Alliance.”

“What do you mean by ‘we’?”

Use of ‘we’ meant a group.

So the Sage of the Bright Rock truly had been part of an underground group.

However, was there a group capable of controlling the head of the Mount Hua Sect?

That was the head of the Mount Hua Sect they were talking about!

However, Do Jin-myung could tell that Jegal Sung was not lying.

“A long time ago, to investigate the dark atmosphere in the Martial Alliance, seven chivalrous fighters gathered and formed a sect. That was about 400 years ago. That sect was shaped and led by Gija [1], and still lives on.”

“So you are saying that Bright Rock is a member of that sect?”

Jegal Sung nodded. “That sect is called the Justice Blood Sect. And I am its leader.”

Justice Blood.

Do Jin-myung closed his eyes as he thought of the meaning behind those words.

Obviously it meant blood that was shed during an act of justice or noble sacrifice.

I thought the Orthodox was disorganized, since they got attacked by the Cult of the Inverted Sky, but I guess it's true that old trees have deep roots.

We might be able to create a diversion for the rotten martial, even without getting assistance from the Cult of the Heavenly Demon —

Jegal Sung continued to talk, breaking Doo Jin-myung's thought process.

“Of course, since this sect works secretly, we are lacking in number. In other words, we don't have enough power.”

We will need the power of the Demonic Cult.

Do Jin-myung revised his thoughts in a split second.

I should be satisfied that at least the Orthodox martial's roots didn't get infected.

“By the way, what made the Leader of the Demonic Cult come here? I don't think the Cult Leader is a member of the Justice Blood Sect...”

“Since we have the same purpose, we made a deal.”

“You have the same purpose?”

Woon-seong nodded. “Vengeance against the Cult of the Inverted Sky. Isn't that what you and King Jinseong want too?”

Do Jin-myung smiled. Indeed, if they could attract the power of the Demonic Cult, it would help suppress the Cult of the Inverted Sky. “Yes. We also have the same thoughts.”

“I have something to tell you about that.”

As Do Jin-myung smiled amicably, the Sage of Bright Rock snuck into the conversation.

“It is true that the Martial Alliance’s power and spirit has been weakened, but that is a problem only for the Orthodox side. But you are trying to bring the Cult of the Heavenly Demon in to solve this... That is just like bringing in a tiger to hunt a wolf. And also, I don’t think the Demonic Cult will just help King Jinseong, so what is the price that King Jinseong would need to pay the Demonic Cult?”

It seemed like Bright Rock was trying to get at something.

However, the answer came from Woon-seong, not Do Jin-myung.

“They will recognize the Demonic Cult as the state religion and I suggested that since I’m the Leader, they should make me the King’s teacher.”

“Huh!” Bright Rock made a surprised sound, then shook his head. “That can’t be true. It will surely cause unrest should you summon the Cult of the Heavenly Demon into the mainlands.”

Woon-seong smiled.

Soon the building was filled with the Heavenly Demon’s aura.

A massive hurricane of energy rumbled into existence, swirling around the shack.

“You sound ridiculous. Then do you think it’s possible to fight the Cult of the Inverted Sky, which has already sunk their fangs deep into the Orthodox side, but using only the Justice Blood Sect’s power?”

The energy was overwhelming.

However, Bright Rock spoke as though he had no intention of conceding.

“Even though the Cult of the Inverted Sky holds much power over the Orthodox side, not all martial artists are on their side. I’m sure if we look for them, there will be enough sects who will support us. If we can

consolidate their power, we can defend against the Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

“That’s just an armchair theory [2]. Are you guys determined to go against the Emperor? And, are you sure everyone else is willing to do that?”

“Uhm.”

Bright Rock staggered and Woon-seong’s energy slammed into him.

“If that was possible, I’m sure the Emperor’s Sage of Earth and Sky wouldn’t have consulted me. Then I will ask you this: What have you done before the Sage of Earth and Sky visited me? What have you done until I, Leader of the Demonic Cult, contacted the Justice Blood Sect myself?”

“Uagh!”

Bright Rock frowned and retreated.

However, he felt something cool and hard hit his back.

It was the wall.

He had been pushed all the way across the room, to the opposite wall.

Can’t believe I got pushed this far by just his aura.

It was Jegal Sung that saved Bright Rock from anything else.

In a solemn voice, the man said: “Bringing the Demonic Cult into the mainland’s is not just a dichotomous matter that can be divided in Orthodox and Demonic, or black and white. I understand that not all Demons are bad, but do you remember how I acted as soon as I heard who you were?”

Woon-seong nodded.

As soon as Jegal Sung realized Woon-seong was the Heavenly Demon, the man had immediately launched an attack.

“There’s a deep misunderstanding between the Orthodox and the Demonic Cult. That’s not something that can be resolved within a short period of time. So if we can’t solve that issue, when the Demonic Cult comes to Zhongyuan, it will cause a huge problem.”

Jegal Sung was not wrong.

It was true that the grudge and misunderstanding between the Demonic Cult, who wished to take over Zhongyuan, and the Orthodox martial, who had settled in Zhongyuan, was very deep.

It was not that Woon-seong had not realized this.

He already had some solutions.

“Then here’s the deal.”

[1] Gija was a semi-legendary Chinese sage said to have ruled Joseon in the 11-12th Century BCE.

[2] An armchair theory is something based solely on the speaker’s own experience, introspection, and intuition (AKA it is entirely subjective and from only one point of view.)

Chapter 115: Sign Of Trouble (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 115 – Sign of Trouble (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Gan River.

A river that travelled through the Jiangxi Province from north to west, before flowing into Lake Poyang and thus the mighty Yangtze River.

Located along this river was the city of Nanchang, a strategic location that connected the prosperous East and South coasts.

There, King Jinseong had decided to settle.

Situated near lakes and rivers, access to freshwater had been established since ancient times.

In addition, the land was fertile and rice fields developed easily.

As if proving that, the group passed by a rice paddy field that spanned as far as the eye could see just a few days before reaching Nanchang.

In the rice field, the stalks of rice were ripening into a glittering gold.

Looking at it, Jegal Sung smiled. “This is a rich year. No one will starve, unless there’s an unusual problem.”

At his words, Do Jin-myung shook his head. “Once the war begins, all that rice will be used by the military.”

“That is why the war must end quickly.”

The two chuckled.

Watching them, the Sage of Bright Rock sighed deeply. “You guys sure are relaxed.”

He glanced at the corner of the wagon.

The wagon they were currently sitting on was wide enough for ten people to ride, and a young man currently occupied one corner.

Everyone else sitting there were all old men, so it was an unpleasant sight.

What was a young man doing with all these old men?

Moreover, all the other people on the wagon were masters of Murim, but there was an unknown young man sitting with them, so others could not understand it at all.

However, if only the onlookers knew who that young man was, they would lose all feelings of distaste.

Well, they would feel a different type of horror instead.

The Sage of Bright Rock groaned as if he was suffering from a headache.

Who was the young man?

The zenith of the 100,000 demonic practitioners.

A nightmare.

There were many secrets regarding the Heavenly Demon’s identity, but they would remain unknown.

Still, Bright Rock could not help but keep his guard up.

“Don’t be like that. There isn’t a better way than what he suggested.”

“But Sichuan, Qinghai, and Gansu...”

Bright Rock sighed once more.

Woon-seong had made both a promise and a demand in return for helping King Jinseong.

The grudge between the Orthodox and the Demonic Cult was deep. It was clear that it could not be easily narrowed down.

If King Jinseong’s plan was successful, then the Demonic Cult would be declared the state religion, gaining unprecedented power and support.

This was difficult for the Orthodox side to accept.

So Woon-seong had proposed a compromise.

“Then this is what we will do.”

Everyone turned to Woon-seong at his words.

He met each of their gazes before explaining.

“I know we can’t make those deep grudges between the Orthodox and Demonic sides disappear at once. But in order to drive out the Cult of the Inverted Sky, which has spread throughout the world, it is true that you guys need my cult’s power.”

Jegal Sung swallowed.

“So my cult will retreat after everything is over.”

The Sage of Bright Rock jumped in shock. “You’ll retreat back to Mount Heaven for nothing?”

Woon-seong shook his head. With a resolute tone he replied, “When did I say it would be for nothing?” His eyes turned golden and he stared at Bright Rock. “And I don’t think I mentioned the Heavenly Mountains.”

Bright Rock, who met Woon-seong’s eyes, trembled.

Even without the Intimidation Qi, the Sage of Bright Rock felt a chill run down his spine.

It was a change that had happened because he knew that Woon-seong could snap his neck at any point.

Bright Rock closed his eyes. *Fear of him has been etched into my bones.*

Woon-seong chuckled to himself, seeing the attitude of an otherwise prestigious person.

“Sichuan, Qinghai, and Gansu.”

Woon-seong listed the names of three provinces and Jegal Sung stiffened.

It was because he understood why Woon-seong had mentioned those three names.

“Your price is those three provinces?”

“Of course.”

The Sage of Bright Rock, who had been closing his eyes, suddenly shouted, “Nonsense!”

Those three provinces could be considered the edge of Zhongyuan.

These provinces were adjacent to the Demonic Cult’s territory, so they were considered the corner of Zhongyuan.

As such, the price Woon-seong had asked for was relatively small compared with the total land mass of Zhongyuan.

However...

“There’s the Kunlun Sect in Qinghai! There are the Emei, Qingcheng, and Tang Clan in Sichuan. Are you asking us to give up those three provinces?”

The sects of Murim were like local rulers.

As long as they were there, they would remain as the basis of power in the region.

Woon-seong could not say that Bright Rock was wrong in protesting, as people would not easily give up their foundations.

But he smiled coldly. “Bright Rock, do not try to test my patience.”

At the same time, a tremendous amount of energy erupted from his body, pressing down on Bright Rock’s shoulders.

Boom!

Bright Rock was forced to sit back down.

“Ugh...!”

Bright Rock tried to fight against the pressure, but the overwhelming strength of the aura laced with fear did not allow him to do so.

Woon-seong continued to speak, his aura continuing to press down on Bright Rock.

“The Qingcheng and Sichuan Tang have already handed themselves over to the Cult of the Inverted Sky. They are no longer the Orthodox sects you consider them to be.”

“Hmm.”

There was a thoughtful murmur.

It was as Woon-seong said.

The Qingcheng Sect and Sichuan Tang Clan were deeply involved in the Martial Alliance, and thus the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

If there was a war, the Qingcheng and Sichuan Tang would not be on their side.

“The Qingcheng Sect and Sichuan Tang Family Clan will disappear by my hands anyways. It is considered revenge on those who tried to eradicate the Spear Master Sect.”

Bright Rock had no objection to those words.

However, Jegal Sung suddenly spoke.

“Then what would you do about the Kunlun and Emei sects? And also the other, smaller sects that reside in those three provinces. Though the roots of the Inverted Sky had spread deeply through Murim, not all of them are rotten. But you’re not going to erase them all together, are you, Cult Leader?”

Jegal Sung’s question stabbed at the core of the problem.

But Woon-seong had already prepared an answer.

“I’m not trying to put those areas under the Demonic Cult’s rule. Originally, the Demonic Cult wanted to go to Zhongyuan.”

“And?”

“So what I want is for my people to freely move around in at least those three places. As long as the other sects, be they large or small, show no hostility, we will also treat them as they do.”

“Hmm.”

“And if people who live there want to migrate because of my cult, we will pay for the costs.”

Jegal Sung was a bit overwhelmed by these words. He could tell that Woon-seong had already made big concessions.

Given the terms of King Jinseong, the Demonic Cult had a reason to stay in all parts of Zhongyuan. The Orthodox could do nothing, even if the Demonic Cult decided to push all the way to Hebei Province.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong had limited the area of religious activity.

This was an act of consideration and concession for genuine sects who did not get caught up in the Cult of the Inverted Sky's schemes, such as the Kunlun.

What if they ignored this concession?

Probably a large group of demonic practitioners will invade Zhongyuan.

Then Murim would truly shake at its roots.

Jegal Sung knew that better than anyone.

However, this was not a matter he could decide on his own, even if he was considered the Great Scholar.

“I'll think about it.”

Woon-seong nodded, smiling. “I look forward to a positive answer.”

Even though Woon-seong said he was looking forward to the answer, in fact the response was already set in stone.

If the Orthodox did not get the Demonic Cult's power, it would be hard for them to contain both the Imperial Court and the Martial Alliance.

They had no choice but to accept Woon-seong's proposal.

Not only that...

Even though it's only three provinces, if the Demonic Cult can be active in those areas... As time passes, the deep misunderstanding between the two sides will decrease.

That was what Woon-seong was after.

Decreasing the hostilities and letting the Demonic Cult settle in Zhongyuan.

None of the Heavenly Demons had ever been able to do so.

Perhaps that had not been Woon-seong's original goal but it would still be done because of the Heavenly Demon named Hyuk Woon-seong.

I will become a bridgehead for those two goals.

Sitting in the rattling wagon, Woon-seong laughed to himself.

Meanwhile, the wagon was getting closer and closer to King Jinseong's palace.

"We will be able to reach Nanchang if we travel for three more days," muttered Do Jin-myung as the landscape became more and more familiar to him.

Bright Rock and Jegal Sung also looked tousled.

The sun was setting and the moon was on the horizon. It was time to prepare for the night.

"Hm, so we are sleeping on the road again today." Jegal Sung clasped his waist, pretending to be sore and uncomfortable.

Bright Rock smiled bitterly and prepared to sleep on the ground again.

"I don't think we will sleep outside tonight, Great Scholar Jegal."

“Oh-ho, is there a place where we can stay?”

Do Jin-myung nodded. “There is a sect called the Calling Sword Sect about an hour away. It’s a small sect which has only about fifty people, but I’m sure we can get a few rooms.”

“Sounds like you know them well.”

Do Jin-myung scratched his head. “The master of that sect is pretty nice and since it’s near the Jinseong domain, I maintained a friendship with them.”

“Haha, I see. Anyways, it’s a relief that we won’t have to sleep outside. Let’s hurry and go to that place.”

“Since I know the way, I’ll guide the horseman,” Do Jin-myung said as he leaned out of the wagon.

One hour was not a long time.

Nevertheless, the wagon carrying the group had yet to reach the Calling Sword Sect.

It may take longer, it may take a little less. One hour had only been a rough estimate.

Either way, the wagon would soon reach its destination for the night.

At that moment, Woon-seong, who had been resting, opened his eyes.

“I smell something burning.”

“Smoke?”

Hearing that, Do Jin-myung turned his head to open the window and looked outside.

Do Jin-myung knew that Woon-seong was likely in the Semi-Divine Realm, so he had the most understanding of the young man’s capabilities.

Although he could see no fire, Woon-seong would not be wrong.

Looking outside, he could indeed see something.

In the far distance, an area of the sky was burning red.

Black smoke rose into the air.

“T-That is...!” Bright Rock cried out in surprise, his expression darkening.

The direction of the flames was the Calling Sword Sect.

Chapter 116: Sign Of Trouble (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 116 – Sign of Trouble (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“I feel languid.”

It was a powerful voice.

There was a whirlwind of emotions and tones.

It was a thin voice, but cloying and disgusting to listen to.

It was a lamentation that the situation was boring.

The one who said such as the one who sat upon the throne, somewhere deep inside the Imperial Court.

Sitting on the throne as the highest reigning person in the world; the man muttered as if the world was boring.

Even with his moody atmosphere, the scene surrounding him was anything but normal.

Hell.

What would hell on earth look like?

Would it look like this if an artist used a hatchet and painted with blood?

Around the throne was a pile of dead bodies.

Those were the corpses of the previously alive court officials.

The corpses of those who lived and preached the majesty of the emperor.

They had all died miserably with their throats slashed.

The blade that cut their throats was lying to the side, covered in blood.

As if the horrible sight before him did not exist, the emperor muttered once more, “I’m bored. Really bored.”

That was not the emperor.

No, that could not be the emperor.

No matter how ruthless a tyrant was, he would not slaughter the palace officials like this.

A ruler could not run the country alone so officials had to be kept alive, even if just barely.

So this could not have been the emperor.

That man was just something wearing the skin of the emperor. Something that had forcibly stolen the emperor’s body.

Whatever that *thing* was, it moved it’s hand with a straight expression.

Several of the severed heads flew into the air.

Drip—

Blood still spilled from where the heads had been cut.

Seeing the gruesome sight, the ‘emperor’ giggled like a happy child.

Puff—

With a single squeeze of his fist, the heads of the court officials floating into the air burst.

Flesh, blood, and bones splattered in all directions.

The ‘emperor’ raised his head, letting the blood splatter onto his face. Licking his lips, he continued to chuckle.

It was a frightening sight.

But there were those who saw it and felt no emotion at all, like the ones who had placed that *thing* in the skin of the emperor.

“I know you are there, so come out, Grand Chancellor.”

At his call, a man slowly walked out from behind the pillars.

“Or should I call you Heo Hon-su?”

“Please call me by the name of my position. When else could I enjoy such a high position like the Grand Chancellor, if not now.”

At Heo Hon-su’s words, the *thing* inside the emperor’s body giggled.

At some point, it stopped laughing and said, “I feel too languid. Do I still have to wait?”

The ‘emperor’ looked like a child begging an adult for a cookie.

The Grand Chancellor responded as if used to such questions. “You just need to wait a little more.”

“How long do I have to wait?”

“Not much. Do you want me to bring some more people to kill while you are waiting?”

The chancellor looked at the dead bodies of the officials lying around.

The ‘emperor’ looked at the bodies too, the bodies with their heads blown off.

“I got sick of it.”

“Then I will bring some girls that you may enjoy.”

The ‘emperor’ waved his hand dismissively, not forgetting to shake his head too. “Got sick of that too. I just want to go out and kill everyone. But, since the Grand Chancellor told me to wait some more, I should wait, right?”

“You will be able to move soon.”

The *thing* nodded. “Yeah, if the Grand Chancellor says so, I should wait. By the way, about martial body arts?”

“That also won’t take long. Recently, a god of martial arts has been created. It’s being tested for stability and power right now.”

“Tested...”

“I sent it to the Nanchang area to slaughter the nearby sects.”

Liking the word choice, the *thing* continued to laugh. “Slaughter, slaughter...! It’s a nice word. I like the sound of it.”

“Wait a minute, isn’t Nanchang where King Jinseong, the little boy, is at?”

This *thing* occupied the body of the emperor, the brother of King Jinseong. Whenever King Jinseong was mentioned, the owner of the body, who had been relegated to a corner of the mind, cried out, “*Don’t touch my brother! Please leave him alone!*”

But whenever the real emperor tried to rebel, the *thing* would press down on him. “*It’s you, right? Just shut up and stay there.*”

The chancellor asked about King Jinseong: “What should I do?”

“Hm, I kept him alive since he’s interesting, but what should I do...”

The ‘emperor’ licked his lips, as if he had discovered something fun.

“Do you want me to keep him alive?”

The *thing* closed his eyes. After opening them, it said, “Just leave it. If he dies, he dies. If he lives, that’s his fate.”

When it finished, the *thing* continued to laugh and chortle.

The chancellor bowed politely. “So be it.”

“More importantly, are you planning to make a godly martial poison when your martial body arts plan is completed?”

“Yes. If I can make a great martial body art, it might be able to become the master’s new body.”

The *thing* contained in the emperor’s body smiled with satisfaction. “Take good care of my new body.”

“Yes, Master.”

That was a conversation that took place at the heart of the Imperial Palace while the Calling Sword Sect was being burnt to the ground.

Even as the group approached, the fire continued to burn fiercely.

Licks of flame covered the building, like a greedy snake swallowing a frog.

The buildings slowly collapsed as the wood panels burned under the fire.

Crack—

Another pillar collapsed into rubble.

“Huh.”

The group rushed through the flames.

Why was there nothing but flames?

They had ditched the wagon and run towards the Calling Sword Sect, but by the time they arrived, the sect had already been consumed by fire.

“That’s not good.”

“We should save the people who are still alive.”

Jegal Sung nodded. “Please help them.”

Woon-seong reached out instead of answering.

Fwoom—

A fierce gust of energy blasted through the flames, opening a clear road forward.

Woon-seong was not heartless enough to watch innocent people die before his eyes.

He may deny it, but the teachings of Nok You-on were carried deep within his heart.

Of course, had the Calling Sword Sect been one of his enemies, he wouldn’t have bothered helping.

As he dug through the fire and went inside, even more miserable sights greeted him.

He had thought that an accident had happened, causing a massive fire, but that was evidently not the cause.

Corpses lined the walls, severed limbs littered the floor.

A decapitated head, a split chest, two torn off limbs.

Bodies were scattered everywhere, burning in the flames.

Hmm. It seems like they were attacked.

Judging from the cuts on the corpses, whoever did it was skilled.

I should deal with the fire first.

Woon-seong moved his hands and the fire died down.

With each movement of his hand, a powerful gust of energy blasted out. These violent gusts stirred the flames, like snuffing out a candle.

Of course, a stronger gust was needed to extinguish the flames which swallowed the main building.

Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon – Heavenly Demon's Divine Palm.

Following Woon-seong's move, the flame slowly subsided.

Do Jin-myung, Jegal Sung, and Bright Rock rushed to find survivors who may have been trapped in the flames.

And then...

“Waaaa! Waaaa!”

Do Jin-myung found a crying little girl amongst the rubble.

The little girl wept, not caring about her surroundings. She was completely terrified, trembling like a leaf.

Do Jin-myung sighed heavily. “The daughter of the Calling Sword Sect's leader... I think she is the only one who survived.”

The group looked around.

“It seems like there was an attack.”

“Amitabha... Perhaps they got attacked by the unorthodox side of the Black Sword Sect?”

Bright Rock saw the bodies and came to a conclusion, but Woon-seong responded.

“No.”

Everyone turned to look at Woon-seong.

Until then, Woon-seong had been staring at the burning walls.

Everyone else followed his gaze.

On the wall was a single massive cut, spanning the entire length.

A single cut.

He uses a sword smoothly. It's been cut so smoothly that even though the building was cut in two, it has yet to collapse.

I can tell how strong he is by the traces on the wall.

It seemed that the level was about the same as his own.

Woon-seong chewed on his lips, deep in thought.

It was at that moment that Bright Rock asked for a clarification.

“What do you mean by that?”

Woon-seong turned away from the wall, pointing to the bodies. “The traces on the bodies were identical. In other words, they were attacked by the same sword. You can also tell that it was caused by the same martial arts. These traces point to a single person.”

Do Jin-myung stiffened. “Are you saying the Calling Sword Sect was attacked by just one person?”

Woon-seong nodded.

With a look of disbelief, Do Jin-myung asked once again, “Cult Leader... Are you sure? Even though there weren’t that many people in the sect, the Sect Leader was someone who almost reached the Absolute Realm. I can’t believe someone swept this place alone. Did an Absolute-level master attack...”

Woon-seong shook his head. “No, it’s not Absolute-level.”

“If it’s not, then what would...”

Woon-seong’s expression shifted and his gaze returned to the wall. He spoke slowly and clearly, eyes not moving from the sword slash.

“This person is in the realm of Semi-Divinity.”

Chapter 117: King Jinseong (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 117 – King Jinseong (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Maybe it was the warmth inside the wagon, but the girl had calmed down.

Otherwise, it may have been hard for her to endure more mental pain.

Either way, she was now trembling in her sleep, likely having a nightmare.

Do Jin-myung stroked the girl's hair, using some of his qi to calm the girl down.

“Poor thing,” Jegal Sung sighed.

The Sage of Bright Rock continued to chant. “Amitabha.”

It might be hard for a little girl to overcome... The memories might haunt her for the rest of her life.

But she survived.

I don't know what happened, but she survived that hell.

And as long as you survive, you can do anything.

That was something Woon-seong knew better than anyone.

After all, he had been able to come this far because he had been mysteriously saved.

Except, you have to overcome the memories and pain on your own.

Woon-seong glanced at the girl once more before closing his eyes.

“I’ll take care of this child.”

To Do Jin-myung’s declaration, no one said anything.

It was obvious that the Sage had been closer to the Calling Sword Sect’s leader than he had said. Otherwise, he would not have taken in the man’s daughter.

However, that was not an important matter.

There were other things to discuss.

Slowly, it was Bright Rock who spoke first.

“I have a question for you.”

Hearing someone speak, Woon-seong opened his eyes, only to see that Bright Rock had been asking him.

Bright Rock swallowed. “Are you sure the traces of the sword belong to someone in the realm of a semi-divine being?”

Woon-seong nodded instead of answering aloud. He had also been thinking of that problem.

Jegal Sung continued the discussion.

“Huh, then are you saying that attack was from either the Buddhist Star or the Sword Star?”

Woon-seong frowned. “Buddhist martial arts become stronger the more they train their merits. But the trace was distinctive from Buddhist arts.”

“Then the Sword Star...” Bright Rock said in a blank voice.

The Sword Star had been respected by all sword users in Murim for generations. As the head of the Mount Hua Sect, the Sage Myung Am naturally also respected the Sword Star.

It was hard for him to believe, but he would be entirely disappointed if he heard Woon-seong confirm it was so.

Fortunately, Woon-seong shook his head once more.

“It’s not the Sword Star either. I haven’t seen the Sword Star’s martial arts, but he uses the Sword Clan’s martial arts, right?”

“Yes, that’s true. I’ve seen the Sword Star some years ago and the feeling was clearly the Sword Clan’s martial style.”

“Then it’s certainly not the Sword Star.”

Jegal Sung sighed deeply. “Huh, it’s a good thing that it wasn’t either of them. Then who has done that to the Calling Sword Sect? Did another one in the realm of Semi-Divinity appear?”

Hearing that, Woon-seong muttered to himself, “No, I don’t think it’s a new person. The trace seemed more like a person from the past...”

Everyone suddenly hyper-focused on Woon-seong’s every word.

He was the zenith of the 100,000 demonic cultivators, the Heavenly Demon, as well as the successor to the vast knowledge of the Spear Master Sect.

Jegal Sung had excellent knowledge in martial arts, but his achievements were likely lower than Woon-seong’s.

Perhaps, as someone with greater cultivation, the sword traces had made him think differently.

So the words that Woon-seong would say would be an important clue in finding the attacker's identity.

Woon-seong looked up, noticing everyone staring at him. He shrugged.

After that, he collected his thoughts.

"I don't know who has done it. But everyone saw the slaughtered bodies in that place."

Woon-seong paused and the others nodded, their expressions solemn.

The bodies had been a gruesome sight.

There was not a single one of them who had not seen the bodies.

"Their bodies were cut clean, but the movement of the martial art which brought death upon them wasn't clean."

"What are you trying to say?"

It was hard for Jegal Sung to believe that the movements by the unknown assailant had not been clean.

Everyone else tilted their heads in confusion too.

"There's a difference between a clear cut and a clear movement. But those wounds can't be from the sword of a third-rate martial artist."

Everyone focused on Woon-seong's words.

"A person who learns a third-rate art can never reach the realm of Semi-Divinity. Most people say 'as soon as you comprehend the true meaning of swordsmanship, you comprehend Heaven, earth, and man'. But do you agree with that?"

No one responded so Woon-seong continued.

“A third-rate art is just that, third-rate. Maybe they can reach the Absolute Realm, but even if the ‘Swordsmanship of Heaven, Earth, and Man’ is the best martial art amongst the third-rates, that is the limit. Third-rates will never reach the realm of Semi-Divinity.”

The Sage of Bright Rock, who understood Woon-seong’s words, asked, “But what if someone in the realm of Semi-Divinity used third-rate martial arts?”

Woon-seong shook his head. “If someone like that used third-rate arts, their movements will naturally not be third-rate. Because their enlightenment will improve the third-rate movement, transforming it to above third-rate.”

“Then who can leave traces like those behind?” Bright Rock asked, looking at Woon-seong for an answer.

However, his eyes trembled, as if noticing that Woon-seong had prepared an answer.

“There’s two possibilities. One is a person who reached the realm of Semi-Divine had some fun and played around with them...”

“Or the martial art that he learned is from the ancient times,” finished Jegal Sung.

Woon-seong looked up at Jegal Sung, while the other two glanced at Woon-seong.

Woon-seong nodded. “Humans created martial arts to train their body by mimicking nature.”

That was the origin of martial arts.

Taoism, Buddhism, and Confucianism were added to martial arts later, as Murim developed into a true society.

Then, what was martial arts like before that?

Mimicking the animals that were around. That was the beginning of martial arts.

Hunt like a tiger, run like horse, be grand like a bear, hard as a turtle, etc...

There were many animals stronger than humans in this world, so humans learned to imitate them.

Higher-dimensional skills, ones that produced lightning or fire, emerged after that.

But the arts that mimicked animals were very rough.

They copied animal movements, but they weren't perfect, due to the lack of sharpness in their eyes.

However, there were talented ones amongst them.

Also at that time, the Heavenly Gate was opened wider, so the concentration of available qi was higher.

Therefore, whenever talented people thrived in high density of qi, they entered the realm of Semi-Divinity.

“In other words, even though the martial arts weren't refined, there were people who reached the realm of Semi-Divinity.”

“Then are you saying that an ancient martial artist has appeared again?”

Woon-seong shrugged.

It's just an assumption and I don't have the evidence to prove it.

Also, the Heavenly Gate is narrowed in the present.

So even if someone learned the ancient arts, I don't think they would be able to reach Semi-Divinity.

It wouldn't be possible even if they were Bodhidharma or Zhang Sanfeng.

It would be more believable if someone said there was a new Semi-Divine Being that was inhuman.

Then who the hell...?

It was clear there was a problem, whether the arts were ancient or not.

Woon-seong closed his eyes and thought.

Jegal Sung, too, closed his eyes, going through a list of possible people.

When the two men proficient in martial arts closed their eyes, the remaining two could do nothing.

In the meantime, the wagon carried them to King Jinseong's Palace.

King Jinseong's Palace was not very large.

Rather, it was a bit shabby for a king.

It was neither glamour nor grand, but it did not lose its dignity.

It was not hard to enter the palace.

The guard at the gate easily recognized Do Jin-myung and opened the gate. But he did not forget about the existence of the three others.

"You are here, Master. By the way, who are these..."

"There are His Highness's guests."

Although Do Jin-myung had explained their presence, the guard was still cautious.

A soldier who is watchful. Not bad, Woon-seong commented.

Even if these guards did not receive proper martial arts training, they seemed to be powerful. It was obvious that they had been trained by King Jinseong's Palace.

Meanwhile, someone came out and greeted them.

“The King is waiting for you.”

Do Jin-myung praised his master as he gestured to the guide. “Haha, since the visitors were special, the King sent a guide to us.”

The group was soon led by the guide to the part of the palace.

And there, Woon-seong met the man for the first time.

“Nice to meet you. It could not have been easy to come here, but you did.”

The Emperor’s brother, King Jinseong.

Chapter 118: King Jinseong (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 118 – King Jinseong (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“I thought all who are well known in the Orthodox side became a part of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, but it’s not true. I’m glad.”

At the words of King Jinseong, Jegal Sung bowed his head and expressed his respects.

Even though he was a giant in Murim and was relatively ancient, that was still the king.

Even the Venerable Dragon had to set an example.

“The old tree is not just big. It also needs deep roots to be called an old tree.”

Though the words were not bad, King Jinseong muttered to himself, “The roots are deep.” Then he smiled. “That’s right. Except, even though the roots grow deep, the tree will become weak if the roots are rigid.”

Jegal Sung smiled.

That was why they needed the power of the Demonic Cult.

Next, King Jinseong’s gaze slid to rest on Woon-seong.

“I already heard that the Leader of the Demonic Cult is young, but you’re younger than I thought.”

At his words, Woon-seong merely drank the tea placed in front of him.

A completely blasé attitude.

Do Jin-myung’s eyes seemed to spark.

However, Woon-seong did not care at all, drinking about half the cup of tea before placing the cup on the table.

“I heard you need the Demonic Cult’s power, King.”

Woon-seong was straight to the point.

Some pleasantries because this was the first time we met?

Don’t need it.

A politician trying to create a lasting friendship?

Doesn’t matter.

Woon-seong only wanted one thing, so he would cut to the chase.

At Woon-seong’s words, everyone’s expression became slightly unpleasant.

King Jinseong was no exception, but he soon nodded. “Yes. I think more than 50% of martial arts practitioners here are related to the Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

“50% percent!” shouted the Sage of Bright Rock, surprised.

Jegal Sung smiled bitterly.

“I can tell by your face that you already knew, Grand Scholar Jegal.”

“A lot of sects turned to the Martial Alliance’s side. And most of them follow Jwa Do-gyul’s lead. The King said 50%, but it might be more than that.”

“Huh!” Bright Rock continued to mutter to himself, “Amitabha...”

“50% of the Orthodox...,” Woon-seong began to estimate the power left on the Orthodox side. Soon, he came to a conclusion. “Certainly not a small quantity, but the Demonic Cult will be enough.”

The meaning behind his words were clear.

Jegal Sung and Bright Rock’s expression hardened.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon became stronger than before.

Huh... If the Demonic Cult wanted to conquer Zhongyuan and went to war, we might have shed lots of blood.

The Demonic Cult had been accumulating its power for a very long time without starting an all-out war against Zhongyuan.

Thanks to that, the power of the Demonic Cult was incomparable to its past.

It was not *equal* to 50% of the Orthodox side, it might actually be more than that.

However, that was not what the group should be concerned about.

“The problem lies elsewhere. It’s the Emperor,” Woon-seong pointed out.

King Jinseong nodded, “You mean the Imperial Army.”

The Imperial Army, guardians of the Empire.

An estimate of all the foot soldiers and cavalry men could reach the millions.

Even working with the Demonic Cult, it would be hard to deal with a million-man-army.

Moreover, this would be seen as treason to other people, no matter what the group did.

Perhaps it was someone of the Inverted Sky wearing the skin of the emperor, but that was still the emperor to the people.

To avoid troubles, King Jinseong must have thought a lot.

“You don’t have to worry about the Imperial Army.”

Woon-seong looked curiously at King Jinseong, who glanced at Do Jinmyung.

The Sage of Earth and Sky walked away, then soon came back with a large map.

It was the Map of the World.

A map that has information about all mountain ranges, strategic points, congested areas, and even the deployment of military forces.

It was not easy to obtain such a precise map.

Even if he was the king, if word got out that he had created such a detailed map, King Jinseong could have been executed for treason.

But King Jinseong still had a copy.

It was evidence that showed how prepared for this the king was, from beginning to end.

As soon as everyone had focused on the map, King Jinseong pointed his finger at the military symbols drawn.

First, he pointed to the north.

“You really don’t have to care about the Northern Army. They won’t be able to move during the upcoming winter.”

None of the people present were so ignorant that they could not understand his words.

When winter arrived, there was not much to eat.

The nomadic tribes of the North would begin to travel, exploiting everything to survive. The Northern Army had to stay in the area and defend against them.

As King Jinseong said, there was no reason to worry about the North.

So only the army stationed at the Qiantang River and the Imperial Metropolis were left.

The Army of the Qiantang River had more soldiers than the Army of the Imperial Metropolis.

And they specialized in warfare.

Through countless battles with pirates, they had become incredible battle-hardened veterans.

Clearly, they were the most troubling portion of the Imperial Army.

“But the Army of the Qiantang River will not move either.”

Apparently, King Jinseong had a way to stop the Qiantang River Army from moving.

“I heard the commander at the Qiantang River is greedy and seeks power... Do you have a plan for them?” Jegal Sung asked.

King Jinseong nodded, smiling. “A person who is greedy for money and power also cherishes their own life above all else. That is precisely why he won’t be able to move.”

“He won’t be able to move because he cherishes his own life...?”

The commander of the Qiantang River Army had control over the 30,000 soldiers in the army.

But he could not control them all by himself.

There were generals under him who led about 1,000 soldiers each.

King Jinseong pointed to them on the map, “And about 20 of those generals have a close relationship with me. If I exaggerate a little, they are like my brothers. They have my back.”

Jegal Sung listened to King Jinseong and remembered the past. Before becoming a royal, King Jinseong had been a major in the Army of the Qiantang River. Perhaps he had built many good relationships then.

“I have already sent them a message. They also think the world is becoming unstable, so they have decided to join me. So if the commander tries to move the army, they will stop him.”

The army was under the orders of the commander. However, twenty generals was a majority, meaning that the commander would have trouble trying to move the army.

“Also, if the Commander won’t stop, they promised to get rid of him.”

If what King Jinseong said was true, then two big worries were alleviated.

The most powerful forces of the Imperial Army were the forces in the North, at the Qiantang River, and in the Imperial Metropolis.

While the rest of the troops weren’t weak, they were spread out throughout the land.

Since they were less powerful and less organized, it was easier to pay less attention to them.

“Thus, the Imperial Metropolis Army is the only one left.”

“Hmm.”

The Imperial Metropolis Army was more systematically organized. Unlike the Northern Army and the Qiantang River Army, whose soldiers gained experience through direct combat, the Imperial Metropolis Army fought completely differently.

The Imperial Metropolis Army was a mixture of those who relied on the Emperor's protection, those who were proficient in warfare and tactics, and those who were just plain weak.

Overall, their job was to protect the Imperial Palace and maintain order in the Imperial Metropolis.

“The King's Palace will take care of the Imperial Metropolis Army.”

“The King's Palace?”

King Jinseong raised his head, then took a large gulp to tea.

“There are a lot of places under my influence. There are some helpers in the Imperial Court too. If I gather them together with the elites of the King's Palace, I believe they can handle the Army of the Imperial Metropolis.”

“The Demonic Cult needs to take care of the Orthodox martial arts who joined the Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

King Jinseong nodded at Woon-seong's words and turned to Jegal Sung. “But for the Justice Blood Sect, please take care of the other sects which haven't chosen the Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

“Alright.”

Woon-seong turned to Jegal Sung and added, “And also, when the Demonic Cult comes to Zhongyuan, if it's possible, work things out ahead of time so there won't be any trouble.”

The Demonic Cult might have to advance all the way to Beijing, where the Emperor resided.

In the process, not only would they cross the Cult of the Inverted Sky, they would also pass by other sects or groups.

It would be hard to advance to Beijing if they had to deal with all other factions.

Jegal Sung nodded. "I planned something else for that."

"What is the plan...?"

"There are some people who don't think the recently chosen way of the Martial Alliance is proper, even though the Orthodox side is being played by the hand of the Martial Alliance. I'm thinking of getting them to sign off their sects."

It's been a long time since the Martial Alliance has fallen into the hands of the Cult of the Inverted Sky. But he's going to send someone and have them leave their sects, which means...

Woon-seong suddenly asked, "Are you planning to make a new sect?"

Jegal Sung clasped his hands and leaned onto the table.

"I'm thinking of making the Justice Alliance, which will be based around the Justice Blood Sect."

Chapter 119: Ancient Martial (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 119 – Ancient Martial (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The talk continued for a long time.

It was a shock that Jegal Sung was planning to make the Justice Alliance, but the group also discussed what role the Justice Alliance should take.

Not only that.

A discussion about the size of the alliance.

Aside from that, there were also major issues that needed to be addressed.

During the process, Jegal Sung revealed the other Seven Masters of the Justice Blood Sect.

Even Woon-seong was surprised by the size of the Justice Blood Sect.

The Buddhist Star was the master of the Second Jade Knife and the leader of the Kunlun Sect was the master of the Third Jade Knife.

But there was more.

The master of the Fourth Jade Knife was related to the Namgung Clan, and the master of the Sixth Jade Knife was the head of the Gold God Merchant

Company, which was one of the top five merchant caravans in the world.

Even though these masters did not show themselves much in Murim, they were the large roots of the Orthodox side. Once they moved, the world would shake.

And they had joined the Justice Blood Sect.

The reason none of them had made a move was because of the sect's characteristic of hiding in the shadows.

But from what Woon-seong could tell, Jegal Sung seemed to have decided to get rid of the secrecy.

More like you have no choice but to do so.

The Cult of the Inverted Sky represented an unprecedented crisis for the Orthodox, no matter how deep their roots may lie.

In a crisis like this, no matter how secretive the Justice Blood Sect was, they would not be able to remain underground for long.

Revealing the Justice Blood Sect was a decision that showed Jegal Sung's determination to try and change the world.

“Counting on the Justice Blood Sect to organize the Justice Alliance, to announce a movement against the Martial Alliance when they try to do something wrong.”

The Martial Alliance was a large coalition that had been leading the Orthodox side for a long time.

By comparison, the Justice Alliance would be new.

Although the influence of a new faction would seem small, it was hard to say considering the sects that would be associated with the Justice Alliance — the Kunlun Sect, Mount Hua Sect, Jegal Clan, the Namgung Clan, and so on.

If the Justice Alliance truly issued a statement against the Martial Alliance, it might be possible for even small and medium-sized groups to act.

“It’s not a bad idea,” King Jinseong agreed.

Stroking his beard, Jegal Sung added, “During that time, I want the Demonic Cult to take care of the Cult of the Inverted Sky’s informers stationed in the Martial Alliance.”

Jegal Sung turned to Woon-seong when he finished.

Woon-seong nodded.

As long as the Justice Alliance moved properly, the Demonic Cult would not have to fight against the entire Orthodox faction.

“So you want the Justice Alliance to fight the Martial Alliance on the inside, while we wage war against them from the outside.”

Jegal Sung clenched his fists. *Even if we win the battle, if we lose the war, everything becomes worthless. The Cult of the Heavenly Demon will play the lead role in this plan...*

That was why King Jinseong encouraged Woon-seong.

“When the Demonic Cult comes into Sichuan, the King’s Palace will announce this.”

The statement read: The Cult of the Heavenly Demon is heading south, not to have war against the Orthodox. They are here to cleanse Murim, which has been imbued by the Cult of the Inverted Sky, and to right a wrong in our place. As long as you do not stand against the Divine Cult, the Divine Cult will also not point a sword against you.

“This should be enough for the announcement.”

The discussion continued and the night grew deeper and deeper.

It was only after midnight that the discussion ended.

King Jinseong stood up and looked outside, muttering, “Time flies by so fast.”

It was as he said.

Do Jin-myung also looked outside.

None of the others had realized it had gotten so late either.

“A night without a moon... Isn’t this a good time to plan a rebellion conspiracy?” King Jinseong joked as he walked towards the window.

He was definitely joking, but no one laughed.

A conspiracy to rebel...

That was a warning, reminding them of the consequences of failure: *Let us be aware.*

Those who took part in this plan would be deemed as rebel forces and likely beheaded.

At that moment, Woon-seong suddenly frowned. “I think there’s noise from outside.”

As if to prove his words, someone ran into the room shouting, “There’s an attack!”

“An attack?! What do you mean by that?!” King Jinseong shouted loudly at the messenger who had barged inside.

The messenger hastily bowed. “As I said, sir. Someone just broke the ramparts of the King’s Palace and attacked. We are fighting against him right now.”

The sounds of fighting could be heard outside.

Clang—

Subsequently came the voices of people screaming and giving orders.

“Stop him!”

“Argh! My arm!”

“Man your positions!”

“Don’t even let his foot inside! The King is inside!”

The messenger, hearing the shouts, yelled, “He’s already here!”

All he could hear was noise.

It sounded like dozens of soldiers had been attacked.

“What do you mean by he’s already here?! When did he appear?”

The messenger closed his eyes for a moment, rapidly calculating. “It’s been less than seven minutes! The leader, Gong Chun-huk, is fighting against him right now.”

King Jinseong was surprised. *They only took seven minutes to get here? The elite soldiers of the King’s Court and lots of martial artists were defeated within seven minutes.*

“Are there a thousand people attacking?”

The messenger shook his head. Speaking slowly, as if he couldn’t believe it either, he said, “There is only one person.”

“T-That can’t be,” King Jinseong muttered.

Impossible.

Only one person defeated all of the elite soldiers?

Why would such a master attack?

No. I should calm down.

I shouldn't let him destroy any more!

Still confused, King Jinseong turned to the others. "Could you help me?"

If he is a master, I should use another master against him.

Fortunately, there are four such masters here.

If I can get help from them, I'm sure they can defeat him.

At his words, Jegal Sung and the Sage of Bright rock stood up. Resolutely, they prepared to fight.

"I'll join."

"I'll also help, Amitabha."

Woon-seong firmly stopped them. "If you go, you will die."

Everyone froze.

Do Jin-myung's eyes trembled. "What do you mean by that, Cult Leader?"

"As I said. Even if you join them to help, you will die."

Everyone in the room winced.

Normally, they would not believe those words. But it had been said by the Heavenly Demon. He had also said it very matter-of-factly.

"Even I couldn't sense his presence until he revealed himself."

The others stiffened.

There was no one who did not understand what he meant.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong furrowed his eyebrows.

I'm so close to tracing his qi, but I can't do it perfectly. As soon as my senses try to feel his qi, it disappears like mist.

And right after it disappears, it will reappear somewhere else.

There was only one possibility.

Only a person who is at the same level or higher can escape my senses.

Either the Buddhist Star, the Sword Star, or someone of that level.

Plus, the Twin Stars would have negotiated with King Jinseong, not attacked him.

So who the hell was the attacker?

It had to be someone with overwhelming power and authority.

Woon-seong suddenly remembered a recent disaster, the one he had witnessed on the way to King Jinseong's.

The burning of the Calling Sword Sect, and the crude but powerful traces that remained there.

If they could turn an innocent to ashes, wouldn't they also attack the king?

No way...

Woon-seong and Jegal Seong guessed the same thing, "A martial artist who learned the ancient arts?"

Gong Chun-huk was responsible for training the soldiers of King Jinseong's court.

He was also the supervisor for the guards, as well as the prison warden.

Naturally, he was also granted the authority to temporarily lead in dangerous situations.

Watching the attacker from afar, he shouted out orders.

“Armored Turtle Formation!”

As the name suggested, the formation was designed to defend rather than attack.

Soldiers stacked their shields around themselves, layering them on top of each other. Spears were stuck through any remaining holes.

If the formation worked, they would be able to buy time.

Buy time for reinforcements to arrive.

But...

Clang—

Kacha—

Gong Chun-huk thought he saw the apparition of a giant horse, galloping through the area.

The formation collapsed in an instant and the soldiers were blasted to the sides.

He broke the Armored Turtle Formation so easily...

Is he the resurrection of King Xiang Yu [1]?

Gong Chun-huk corrected his earlier judgement.

If it's impossible to defend... Let's at least hold him here for as long as possible and buy some time.

“Killing Meteor Web Formation!”

This was a formation tantamount to suicide.

A net of soldiers who would undoubtedly die, but they had the determination to drag the stars down with them.

Hundreds of soldiers would surround the target.

Well-trained cavalry would swoop in and attack, while armored foot soldiers continued to press forward.

Armor was made of iron.

With the weight of dozens of people, no matter how brave you were, you would find it difficult to move freely.

That was when the target should be stabbed with a spear.

Stab a spear through the body of an ally to pierce the enemy.

The perfect way to destroy your enemies, at the cost of your allies!

“While he’s suppressed, hurry and stab him with your spears!”

Gong Chun-huk thought he could at least stall for a little...

Boom!

The attacker crushed the soldiers, basically throwing them into the air.

Rushing through the formation, his movements were like lightning striking the ground.

Soon the bodies of soldiers rained down.

Not only was the attacker perfectly fine, but the soldiers had been sliced into pieces.

Severed limbs dropped from the sky.

“Dear Heavens...What the hell is this...?”

[1] Xiang Yu was the Hegemon-King of Western Chu. His might and battle prowess have been glorified, making him a heroic but bloodthirsty warrior-king.

Chapter 120: Ancient Martial (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 120 – Ancient Martial (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Humans could do nothing in the face of a great disaster.

When rough waves swept a village, or the cracked earth swallowed a city, or when mud slicked the streets and rocks collapsed the buildings, humans could do nothing.

Therefore, humans called disasters ‘divine retribution’.

Punishment by the Heavens for the sins of mankind.

But this was the discovery of another type of disaster.

Disasters could come not only from the Heavens, but from men too.

That was the descent of a man-made disaster.

Kua-kua-kua—

Like the breath of a dragon, a gust of wind violently swept the soldiers away.

Even though the soldiers wished to die with their target, the situation did not allow for such free will.

Within the blink of an eye, a building had collapsed, trapping the soldiers beneath the rubble.

“How can humans deal with this monster...?” despaired Gong Chun-huk.

How he wished to run away. But he was the leader who had raised all of the soldiers following King Jinseong. He was the one person not allowed to back down.

Even if he would be swallowed by the disaster, he ran forward. To defend the king!

“Aaah!” Gong Chun-huk drew his sword and charged forward.

Even as he ran, he only had a single question on his mind.

Who can save us now?

And perhaps the Heavens had heard his plea.

Kua-kua-kua.

At that moment, another disaster fell from the sky.

It was a disaster, burning with the flames of Heaven and a brilliant spear.

Woon-seong stood on the edge of a rooftop and watched the soldiers, gripping his spear.

What I sensed was right.

I'm sure the man who is fighting against the soldiers right now is in the Semi-Divine Realm.

Even though his basic skill is brought and beast-like, he is certainly a Semi-Divine Being.

Who here could stop a Semi-Divine Being?

Just me.

Numbers were meaningless to a Semi-Divine Being.

If Woon-seong wished to, he could have reduced King Jinseong's Court into ashes overnight.

I don't know his motive, but I gotta stop him first.

Woon-seong moved forward.

He wouldn't have helped on another day, but those of King Jinseong were his allies now. If they died here, it would make the future more difficult.

Woon-seong's energy blazed and crackled.

Like a bolt of lightweight, he zipped through the battlefield and landed straight down in front of the attacker.

Ka-boom!

The ground was blasted into the air, creating a crater.

Between the falling debris, Woon-seong faced the intruder.

Red eyes?

The intruder's eyes were unnaturally red. There were no whites as even the pupils were blood red.

It was like seeing a berserk animal.

At the same time, the intruder swung his sword and Woon-seong.

This crude sword carrying immense ferocity was blocked.

Ka-clang—!

Woon-seong lifted the White Night Spear to defend, but the force of the blow caused the surrounding area to collapse.

However, Woon-seong's arm gripping the spear trembled.

The force of the blow had been overwhelming.

He's unbelievable.

Woon-seong tasted blood in his mouth.

If I only consider inner strength, he might be a step above me.

Even though Woon-seong had inherited the energy from Cheon Hwi, the man in front of him still carried more.

Where did this guy come from?

Woon-seong swung his spear, taking a slight step back.

The spear pierced through the air, piercing the intruder's body.

But the result was not great.

The intruder raced at Woon-seong, relentlessly and powerfully, like a devil of hell.

With a blast of wind, Woon-seong's attack shattered.

At the same time, the intruder wielded his sword once more.

That qi is... It's a horse.

Woon-seong could recognize the kind of ancient martial arts the intruder used.

It was based on a horse.

A horse that had once roamed the vast meadows of the world. A wild horse that ran unfettered by the world, destroying what it didn't like with a stamp of its hooves.

Woon-seong was hit on the shoulder and there was a spark.

The glow of the sword passing by his shoulder illuminated Woon-seong's face with an eerie light.

But he didn't care. *I'll take it.*

Instead, he reached out and grabbed the arm of the man, the sword arm.

And...

Kua—

He twisted the man by the wrist, pulling forwards as he did so.

The man spun and twisted in the air.

Woon-seong tried to slam him into the ground.

But...

Boom!

Mid-spin, the man's foot hit something and he catapulted the two into the air.

It was not a new martial art, but the intruder had used a small piece of debris as a launch pad.

With this newfound momentum, the intruder slammed into Woon-seong, causing both of them to crash through the wall of a building.

Boom!

The entire building collapsed.

This was a conflict between two Semi-Divine Beings.

The surroundings were completely devastated.

Fortunately, King Jinseong was leading his soldiers and advising them to avoid getting caught in the conflict.

“Siege Formation, but do not go any closer than 1 *li* (500m)! Keep the form fluid so we won’t get involved in the battle!”

“Yes, Your Majesty!”

The elite soldiers were still in shock, but they rapidly formed a siege formation according to King Jinseong’s orders.

Meanwhile, the fight between Woon-seong and the intruder was getting tougher.

“Is that really a battle between humans...?”

As soon as there was a clash on the ground, the sky fell and the group split open.

As soon as the wind howled, another one of the royal palaces would collapse under a dragon’s roar.

Like just now....

Boom!

Woon-seong blasted the intruder away, firing a ‘flying burst marble’ for good measure.

The intruder crashed the floors of a building, plunging straight down into the earth.

Boom!

The 'flying burst marble' blasted the door off its hinges and wreckage crushed the intruder.

An ordinary person would have died three times.

But....

Kacha—

A sword zipped through the air, sweeping away the falling debris.
Powdered down drifted through the battlefield.

Woon-seong rolled his shoulders.

Thunk, thunk, thunk, thunk.

The sound of something hitting the floor echoed through the area.

Woon-seong had taken off all of his iron bracers.

As he finally released all of the extra weight, his limbs and energy sang with freedom.

His body, having escaped from its confinement, pleaded for movement.

And so Woon-seong did.

From his storage ring he pulled out the glass knives he had been gifted, shooting them out.

Lightning Stitching Art – Thunderous Flying Glass Knives.

Clink—

Dang—

The sword fell down once more, and Woon-seong dashed to and fro, spear never resting.

Mind Split, Double Will.

Woon-seong split his mind and will.

One will travelled through his body, controlling the White Night Spear.

And the other?

Roar—

With a roaring noise, the other will rushed through his body, eventually settling in his left hand.

Suddenly, all of his energy concentrated in that palm.

Slowly spinning, it formed the shape of a wheel.

The conclusion to the Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon.

The Heavenly Demon's Wheel of Samsara.

A millennia of life and death, a symbol of birth and rebirth.

Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon – Wheel of Samsara.

The wheel of energy slammed into the intruder, smacking the man into the air.

That was the last move Woon-seong would be using as the Heavenly Demon today.

The noise in the palace is calming down.

*I should stop using the Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon from now on.
Too many eyes are watching.*

If there's a rumor that the Heavenly Demon appeared at the Jinseong Palace, it will cause trouble.

That was also why the Heavenly Demon's Wheel had not been used at full force.

If there had been a Buddhist nearby, his true identity would have been immediately discovered.

Thus, instead of the Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon, Woon-seong began to unleash other skills.

Divine Spear of the Ending Night.

Six Efforts Destroying the Law of Heaven.

Boom. Boom.

The intruder also jumped about, not losing to Woon-seong.

“Answer me. Are you an informer of the Cult of the Inverted Sky?”

Woon-seong had several more hand-to-hand exchanges with the intruder.

In the process, he was able to confirm one thing.

“You don't have rationale or wisdom.”

Every time Woon-seong approached, the intruder would cry out and make growling noises.

Woon-seong tried to talk to it several times, but nothing worked.

Moreover, the intruder's battle senses were not something a conscious person would have.

It was driven by pure instinct.

“Is it a jiangshi...?”

At first, Woon-seong recalled the blood jiangshi that had appeared in the Divine Cult.

But it was obviously not a blood jiangshi.

After Joo Moon-baek's revolt, Woon-seong had gathered information about the blood jiangshi.

It was possible for a Peak-Level martial to become a Transcendence-Level jiangshi, but it was impossible for an Absolute-level martial to become a Semi-Sivine blood jiangshi.

Then, what is he?

Woon-seong tilted his head in confusion, just as the intruder was picking himself back up.

“Grrrr...”

The intruder's chest had basically been split open by the Heavenly Demon's Wheel.

As I expected, it seems like he can't feel pain... A doll that has only instinct.

But Woon-seong had found a weakness.

It was precisely the fact that the intruder relied on instinct alone.

Meaning, it wasn't very smart and could not think ahead.

I should aim for that weak point.

Just as Woon-seong thought of this and was about to make a decisive move, he stopped.

The intruder had frozen in place, its eyes slowly returning to normal.

“Please kill me. Kill me, please kill me.”

It was for a very short moment, but the intruder had spoken.

Immediately afterwards, the intruder's eyes turned blood red once more.

“Grrrr.”

And it also went back to making unintelligent snarls.

As the intruder rushed at Woon-seong, there was another collision.

Woon-seong used his Orthodox skills generously.

Clang—

Boom!

The intruder’s body shook violently.

Woon-seong never missed an opportunity.

The intruder immediately pressed forwards even more courageously, causing more and more severe damage to Woon-seong.

But it was clear that the last one standing would be Woon-seong.

If he was conscious I wouldn’t be able to suppress him like this.

Maybe the battle would have taken three days and three nights.

I should thank him for being unconscious.

After a longer struggle, Woon-seong was able to adequately use the intruder’s weaknesses to his advantage.

It was harder than trying to thread a string through a needle, but Woon-seong’s attacks were able to squeeze through the tiny opening.

Puchi—

Woon-seong’s fist slammed into the intruder’s chest, punching all the way through the man’s body.

Ribs cracked, muscles tore, and all the blood vessels leading to the heart were severed.

But that wasn't good enough.

Woon-seong also snapped the man's spine.

Of course, Woon-seong was not unharmed by the process.

The youth had a large, bleeding gash running across his chest, which had been caused by a desperate sword slash.

His thighs also had numerous cuts, lightly bleeding.

His clothing had become ragged and the black iron pauldrons were shattered, completely unusable.

One of the class knives is almost destroyed...

I should be glad that I didn't get any serious injuries while fighting someone in the Semi-Divine Realm.

“Cough...”

The intruder had blood spilling from his mouth, slumped forward now that his spine had broken.

Woon-seong raised the White Night Spear.

This is the end.

I can end him if I use the White Night Spear.

In that situation, Woon-seong suddenly recalled what the half-conscious intruder had said.

“Kill me, please kill me.”

Woon-seong's expression immediately darkened.

Puchi—

The White Night Spear stabbed into the intruder's heart, almost slashing through half of the torso in the process.

With an annoyed expression, Woon-seong said:

“I was going to do that anyways.”

Chapter 121: The First Shot (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 121 – The First Shot (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Flap-flap.

Blinded by darkness, a hawk swirled through the night sky.

With the moon hidden behind the clouds, the hawk blended into the darkness.

But there was a man who recognized the sound of the hawk's wings.

Whee!

A small sound rang out in the night sky.

It was a whistle too high-pitched for animals to hear, but the hawk came flying over.

With a whirl, it twisted and plummeted towards the ground.

Like a bolt of lightning, it had landed on the arm of a man.

“Good, good... I'm excited to read this report.”

In the man's other hand was the whistle that he had used to call the bird down.

The man raised his hand, stroked the hawk, then grabbed its leg.

On one of its legs was tied a letter.

As the man unfolded the letter, a cloud shifted and a beam of moonlight illuminated the man's face.

It was only for a short minute, but the man's face was revealed.

It was a narrow face, reminiscent of a rat's, and stained with the traces of stubbornness and greed.

If Woon-seong had seen the man, he might have snarled.

The receiver of the hawk was the leader of the Martial Alliance, Jwa Do-gyul.

Jwa Do-gyul smiled to himself as he slowly read the letter.

Finishing it, he tied the letter back onto the hawk's leg.

With his arm raised high, he sent the bird back into the skies,

Flap-flap,

Soon, the bird was just a dot in the night sky, swallowed by darkness.

Jwa Do-gyul's lips curled into a grin.

"Yeah, Murim has been at peace for far too long. This world has become boring."

North is where the falcon had disappeared off to.

It was in the direction of Beijing.

“If there’s no wars, it’s not the martial world.”

The next day, there was an order passed down from the Leader of the Martial Alliance.

But since the order was passed securely, only a few sects received the order, and those sects moved quietly.

A storm was about to come to the martial world!

“Huh, I can’t believe it.”

It was an annoying voice.

And more annoying words soon followed.

“Your body is amazing. Even though I saw it myself, I still can’t believe that such a severe wound healed so quickly.”

Woon-seong glanced at the person disturbing him, frowning slightly. *Hoo. How annoying.*

Unlike the annoying voice, the person looked quite majestic.

Not just majestic, but a person whose eyes contained kindness and whose body contained elegant authority.

The person making a commotion in front of Woon-seong was King Jinseong.

Naturally, it was because of Woon-seong’s body.

It has only been a few days since he had wounds covering his entire body...
King Jinseong asked aloud, ““Normal people would need three months to reverse, but it took you five days. How can a human do something like that?””

Next to him, Jegal Sung tapped his chin.

“I heard that a person who reaches the Semi-Divine Realm can control qi freely. Human standards don’t apply to them... But still, it’s amazing. What the hell did you do, Cult Leader?”

If King Jinseong had stopped by simply to admire, Jegal Sung was here to get the details.

Under the scrutiny, Woon-seong sighed. He didn’t say it aloud, but he knew the answer.

It’s probably because of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body.

Ignite the soul to reforge the Heavens, govern the body to dictate the Earth.

By setting your soul aflame, you can change the Heavens. By refining your body, you can control the Earth.

If I do that, would I be able to have the soul of Heaven and the body of the Earth...

After I succeeded with the body reformation, the power of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body became stronger.

Even at this moment, the qi of the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body continues to run through my body.

If the situation doesn’t change, I will be fully healed in three days.

An unbelievable recovery speed, even for Woon-seong himself.

But that was not the point.

“Did you know, a lot of doctors in the King’s Court want to study your body.”

“Hm, I know it’s rude, but since I’m a scholar and a martial artist, I’m curious too.”

Woon-seong could only continue sighing. Then he asked, “How is the investigation going, King?”

King Jinseong and Jegal Sung, who were startled out of their musings, went silent.

King Jinseong eventually recovered to answer, “We are studying his dead body right now. Great Scholar Jegal is also studying it. So it would be better for you to hear it from him.”

King Jinseong turned to Jegal Sung.

As he said, King Jinseong’s Court had been researching the body of the intruder since a few days ago. They discovered that the man’s body was not much different from everyone else’s.

Average height, normal hair growth, etc...

But that was only externally.

The curious Jegal Sung had insisted on preserving the body so he could do more research.

When King Jinseong and Woon-seong turned to him, Jegal Sung hesitated for a moment. Soon after, he spoke in a solemn voice.

“I’ll tell you. I already felt unsettled when I saw it, and I found something more surprising after dissecting it.”

“What did you find?”

“It wasn’t only his martial art that was ancient.”

“What do you mean by that, Great Scholar Jegal?”

“As I said, your Highness... His martial art was from ancient times, but so was his body.”

Woon-seong's eyebrows twitched. "Are you trying to say that he's from the past?"

Jegal Sung shook his head. "It seems like that, but... It doesn't make sense that a man from the Ancient Age is still alive."

The Ancient Age.

The original meaning referred to the time before written history.

But in the world of martial arts, it had a different meaning.

It was the time before the world of martial arts was recognized as Murim, back when the basics were just being conceived.

It was the time when Heaven's Gate was wide open and people were closer to Heaven.

That was almost six hundred years ago.

A man from that time is still alive?

That doesn't make sense.

If he is human, it's not possible.

Even a man who reached Semi-Divinity cannot live that long.

Even if a man sheds his human form and reaches the realm of gods, living for that long is not possible.

Therefore, it was nonsense that a man from the ancient times is still alive.

Woon-seong chewed on his lips. "Then what is he?"

Jegal Sung sighed deeply. "I have to study more to find out whatever he is. But before that, I have a question for you."

"...?"

“When you were fighting against him, did it look like he had lost his mind?”

“How did you know that?”

Woon-seong was surprised. *I wasn't able to tell anyone about that because I was focused on healing.*

Jegal Sung sighed once more. “I have something to show you.”

Then he took something out of his sleeves and placed it in front of them.

It was a box.

Jegal Sung opened it.

The Sage of Bright Rock, who had been listening on the side, quietly remarked, “Aren't these iron needles?”

Like he said, they were iron needles.

Five iron needles, long and thin.

Jegal Sung nodded. He then turned to Woon-seong, saying, “I found them in his head.”

“In his head?”

“There are not many acupuncture points on the head. Most of them activate or control parts of the brain, twisting the mind and erasing memories. I'm not exactly sure since his mind was totally destroyed, but judging from the general placement of the needle, it is related to manipulation. And I was able to ascertain that it was connected to the parietal bone.”

Hearing his words, Woon-seong muttered, “Are you saying that the controller manipulated his mind to control his movements?”

Jegal Sung nodded.

“Is there a group who can control a man who reached the Semi-Divine Realm? Oh, what’s going to happen... Amitabha.”

Woon-seong looked down at the iron needles.

There are a lot of groups which have the skill to control men with iron needles.

However, most of their levels are not high enough to control someone in the realm of Semi-Divinity.

If I think about it, maybe the Quanzhen School might... [1]

The Quanzhen School had generations of history and had great achievements in the *neidan* practices.

As a result of commonly using acupuncture and extensive study into meridians, the Quanzhen School also had methods of making and manipulating iron needles.

But what if it’s not the Quanzhen School?

What if the Cult of the Inverted Sky has a similar skill?

They are ones with a skill that allows a person to take over a body.

It would not be far-fetched to say that they know a high level skill like the Quanzhen School.

Woon-seong and Jegal Sung locked eyes as they reached the same conclusion.

“It seems like the world will be in trouble...”

That was an undeniable fact.

Two days later, Woon-seong had to leave the King’s Court as soon as he recovered.

Because there was a rumor that hit the world.

The rumors were simple.

The Martial Alliance had launched a surprise attack on eighteen branches of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It was an unexpected outcome.

The Martial Alliance had fired the first shot of war.

[1] The Quanzhen School is the most dominant branch of Taoism in continental China. Quanzhen followed the “way of completeness and truth” and was particularly concerned with immortality through internal alchemy, which included medical theory and divination

Chapter 122: The First Shot (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 122 – The First Shot (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

As soon as he heard the news, Woon-seong ran for the Heavenly Mountains without a moment's rest.

Nanchang, where the King's Court was, was many thousands of miles from the Heavenly Mountains, where the Demonic Cult's headquarters lay.

It wasn't an easy route for Woon-seong, even though he was in the realm of Semi-Divinity.

On the way, Woon-seong threw away the iron bracers weighing him down. With a burst of speed, he flew towards the west.

However, as time passed, fatigue began to build up.

Soon his entire body was tingling.

He tried to decrease his fatigue using his qi and the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, but it was not easy.

It was only natural for him to burnout without proper rest.

However, Woon-seong was able to reach the Heavenly Mountains within seven days and seven nights.

I feel sorry for those kids I promised, but I don't have enough time right now.

It would take time to pick them up and then they would slow his travels even more.

Woon-seong could not spare even a second.

It was because the Martial Alliance had attacked the Cult of the Heavenly Demon first, a sudden shot signaling war.

In such a situation, the Heavenly Demon could not be absent.

Some might say that instead of returning to the Cult, it would be better to assist the attacked branches first.

But that was a bad choice.

A total of eighteen branches had been attacked.

It was as if all the branches the Alliance knew about had been ambushed.

Also, Woon-seong was only one person.

Unless he had eighteen bodies, there was a limit to what he could do by himself.

It was better to return quickly and find a way to help everyone.

Woon-seong's actions were a reasonable choice as the leader of a large organization.

“I was waiting for you. Please step inside.”

When Woon-seong arrived, Sang Gwan-chuk was waiting for him outside.

As he went inside, the Demonic Masters, Demonic Kings, and some Great Demons were gathered in the palace.

Their expressions were serious.

They had never been in this situation before.

Historically, it had always been the Cult of the Heavenly Demon who attacked first.

But the Martial Alliance had attacked first this time...

Woon-seong swiftly walked to his throne and sat down.

The Demonic Masters were once again ten, as the two empty seats had been filled by the Demonic Kings.

But there was no time for introductions.

Searching the crowd, Woon-seong asked Sang Gwan-chuk.

“So, what is the situation?”

“We have been attacked, but the damage is minimal.”

“There’s not much damage...”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded.

“For this attack, I ordered them to flee instead of defend. We destroyed supplies and burned documents so the enemies wouldn’t get their hands on them. Most of your people escaped and are currently in hiding.”

“What about the Demonic storages and the secret lines?”

The storages held the necessary materials and supplies needed to sustain the cult.

The secret lines referred to the guides and informants the Demonic Cult had placed in Murim.

Managing these two was the main task of each branch.

It was only natural to worry about these two, since if it was serious, the Demonic Cult would have some problems in the war.

Sang Gwan-chuk replied, "One of the storages has been attacked, but it was a small one."

"So the supplies we have are sufficient?"

"What about the secret lines?"

"Some of the secret lines at Hubei and Sichuan have gone silent, but we already prepared their replacements. I was able to manage it."

"That's a relief."

Woon-seong breathed out a sigh of relief, the tension in his chest relaxing a little.

For an ambush, the damage was pretty minor.

It was at that moment that the Wind Demon Fist King, Koo Jong-byuk, stepped forward.

"Leader, may I say a few words?"

The Fist King was frowning, as if ashamed that the Martial Alliance had been the ones to strike preemptively.

He was a feisty figure.

"I'm sure the Martial Alliance thinks our cult is weaker than them, so they attacked us. I think it's right for you to declare a holy war and show them the power of the Demonic Cult."

"I also agree."

"I also think the Fist King is right."

The Demonic Masters and Demonic Kings shouted out in agreement.

Woon-seong glanced at Sang Gwan-chuk, who met his eyes and nodded.

Woon-seong raised his hand and the noisy palace immediately quieted down.

Once the commotion subsided, Woon-seong spoke.

“You probably didn’t know, but I was outside for the last few months.”

There was some chattering.

“Is the Leader saying that he was not in the Demonic Cult?”

“Then who was it that we saw then?”

Probably no one outside the very inner circle had realized that Woon-seong was gone, since Sang Gwan-chuk’s replacement had imitated Woon-seong’s behavior and habits well.

Woon-seong raised his hand to silence them once again.

He then continued.

“While I was gone, I was in Zhongyuan. Do you know why I went there?”

Sang Gwan-chuk said nothing. He was the only person who knew why Woon-seong had left for Zhongyuan.

The others shook their heads and looked at each other, not knowing the answer.

Woon-seong told them the shocking reason:

“I went because of a rumor that an outsider was involved in the death of the previous leader, who was also my master.”

The palace was stunned into silence.

The Heavenly Demon had lost his life through an outsider’s intervention.

That was blasphemy.

The Heavenly Demon was a god to them.

His dignity could not be sullied by an outsider.

Frostily, Woon-seong continued, "I went to Zhongyuan to find out the truth for myself. And the rumor was true."

Perhaps, on the inside, all of those gathered were also raging.

"Then do you know who the villain is?" Woon-seong asked.

Those gathered raised their heads, eyes burning with anger and hatred.

It was as if as soon as Woon-seong revealed the culprit, they would attack the man on sight.

And so Woon-seong told them:

"The villain is the Emperor."

Suddenly, the fighting spirit froze, as if struck by lightning.

It was because of the weight of the word 'emperor'.

But wait a minute...

Their eyes changed once more.

Even if it was the emperor, he had to pay for his sacrilege.

The Fist King raised his fist, shouting, "Even though he is an emperor, he has no right to murder a god of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. He must pay for his sin!"

The other Demons echoed the cry.

Woon-seong nodded, "I also agree with that."

At his words, the Demons raised their voices.

“Please allow us to go to war!”

“Please allow us to go to war!”

“Give the Heavenly Demon’s punishment to the unbelievers who have insulted our god!”

“Give the Heavenly Demon’s punishment to the unbelievers who have insulted our god!”

Speaking to them, Woon-seong continued:

“The villain is not only the Imperial Court. There is a group hiding behind the Emperor’s back, controlling him. The same group that instructed parts of the Alliance to attack our cult.”

The voices of the gathered demonic practitioners echoed louder and louder.

“Punish them, too!”

“Punish them, too!”

“Retribution!”

“Condemnation!”

Woon-seong nodded.

“The current emperor has gone crazy. He became their puppet, and instead of being an exemplary ruler, he’s killing people. His sin is insulting your cult! Even though he’s an emperor, I shall not forgive him!”

Woon-seong growled and released his demonic energy.

Burning with determination, the others also released their demonic energy.

Soon, the Divine Palace was filled with demonic qi and flickered with the Divine Flame.

It swirled and roared.

At the center, Woon-seong cried out:

“King Jinseong has decided to help us! Some of the Orthodox sects, who are not yet controlled, will also be with us.”

As the Demonic Cult, they had never thought the Orthodox would also be on their side.

But help was help.

Woon-seong grabbed the White Night Spear and lifted it up, the spearhead shining brightly.

“Therefore, we are going to attack the Emperor!”

“Therefore, we are heading to Zhongyuan!”

Pointing his spear, Woon-seong yelled one last command:

“Prepare for war!”

As soon as Woon-seong spoke, the preparations for war began in earnest.

The Senior Strategist had expected this and had long started the preparations.

At Mount Heaven, the Order of the Divine Flame was issued.

The Order of the Divine Flame was the Heavenly Demon’s call, summoning all people from the sects which obeyed the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

As soon as the order came down, demonic practitioners gathered in the name of the Divine Flame.

There were about 50,000 people gathered from across the land.

It was decided that at the lead would be two young martial artists, rallying for chance.

Gwan Tae-ryang would lead the Charred Dragon Unit and Cheon Ah-young would lead the White Ape Unit.

Woon-seong had kept his promise to Ah-young, establishing the Divine Maiden as a leader of the war effort.

Eight of the Twelve Supporting Units would be active.

Two of the remaining four would be in charge of supplies and supporting the rear. The final two would be left to defend the Heavenly Mountains.

The rest of the practitioners would be divided into four large units.

On top of that, the Ten Demonic Masters would each lead their own forces, serving as independent military units.

The only thing left after that was inspection of the various consumables, ranging from food and medicine to ammunition.

Woon-seong soon stood in front of all the prepared Demons and said:

“We will go to Zhongyuan and punish the sinners.”

He pointed to the distance, where Zhongyuan was located.

“The war begins!”

TN: I did the math to see how fast Woon-seong was running. The distance between Nanchang and the Heavenly Mountains is about 2,250mi. Given that he made it within a week, he ran at least 13mph for seven days straight. Basically, mans ran 85 marathons back-to-back at a sub-2-hour pace. (Actually faster than the world-record by almost 2 minutes, as Woon-seong's marathon time would be about 1:56.96)

Chapter 123: Palace Of The Sun Devil (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 123 – Palace of the Sun Devil (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The advance of the 50,000 troops that began in the Heavenly Mountains was truly spectacular.

An army of magnificent size; the warriors marched in line.

They traveled along the Silk Road, which merchants used as a trade route, without slowing down their march.

As this imperious army began to move, and all the nearby sect-gates went silent.

Most of them were under the rule of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, but held their breaths believing that if they made a mistake, they might spark a fire.

The soldiers of this armed force wore black robes that symbolized the Demonic Cult.

On the backs of their robes, the word ‘demon’ was clearly embroidered.

At the center of the army, a flag fluttered in the wind.

In addition to the small flags representing each unit, there was also a flag representing the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

But there was also a flag that symbolized the Heavenly Demon.

It was a giant flag with a black dragon.

A six-legged and three-headed black dragon painted in dynamic flight.

Asuras, the mighty demonic beings.

Dragons, the divine creatures.

The two beings seemed to be merged.

That creature, which combined the Asura and the dragon, was the symbol of the Heavenly Demon.

A symbol of destruction and opposition, but was sacred at the same time.

Woon-seong stood just below the flag. Next to him was the man known as the Brain of the Heavenly Demon, as well as several shadows.

Woon-seong was wearing a set of majestic black robes. On the back was embroidered the same creature that flew across the Heavenly Demon's flag.

Formal attire, the Black Dragon Robe.

The Heavenly Demon wore the robes representative of the Cult of Heavenly Demon, revealing its pride and determination to never run away

Apart from the ornate embroidery, the clothing itself was light and breathable so that the wearer would feel no discomfort.

There weren't many ornaments decorating his waist.

What was surprising was that wearing this Black Dragon Robe would enhance the user's defense, becoming near impregnable to the blade.

It was possible because the material of the Black Dragon Robe was silk of the Golden Orb-Weaving spider, traded from Hong Kong.

Woon-seong asked the Strategist, "How much longer?"

"We will need three more days to reach the Great Wall."

"The Great Wall..."

The boundary dividing Xinjiang and Zhongyuan.

Once you crossed that line, you would be in the Central Plains.

"Demonic Cult has begun to descend south."

The Grand Chancellor reported.

The Emperor giggled and laughed at the man's words. Before his eyes was a map of the world, filled with red and blue dots.

There were also yellow dots scattered across the map.

The red dots represented the forces of the Demonic Cult and the blue dots represented the Orthodox forces.

What about the yellow dots?

The yellow represented the Imperial Army. As if to prove its strength, the Imperial Army's forces stretched along the Great Wall and the Jade Gate.

"What shall I do?"

The Grand Chancellor asked, looking at the map with him.

The emperor raised his cup, emptying it in a heartbeat, then said:

"Let them through."

He put a piece of meat into his mouth like a snack and chewed on it comfortably. Between his fang like teeth popped out a bone.

But the emperor cared about neither the throne nor the Orthodox sects.

More interesting things would be going on in the world.

“We’re going to have to fight with Murim and the Demonic Cult. Isn’t that what we wanted?”

At the words of the emperor, the Grand Chancellor chuckled and nodded.

Murim and the Demonic Cult would be punished and destroyed, as the flag of the Cult of the Inverted Sky flew high above the land.

It was they who forced the Orthodox sects to attack the Demonic branches.

The Grand Chancellor laughed to himself, thinking of Jwa Do-gyul. *He’s greedy in comparison to his skills, but he sure does what he’s told.*

The emperor glanced at the the map, then repeated:

“So let them go through. Let them destroy each other. ”

At the emperor’s words, the Grand Chancellor bowed and slowly stepped away.

While the emperor and the chancellor were talking in the Imperial Palace, an unexpected guest visited the Demonic camp.

He arrived when the Demonic army was about two days away from the Great Wall.

The visitor was neither expected nor someone Woon-seong recognized.

Mottled skin that looked tanned from the sun. On top of that, the guest’s muscles were clearly defined.

What about the guest's clothes?

The garments were thin to prevent heat, but long to protect the skin from seeing the sunlight.

At the same time, there was a strong force of qi emanating from the visitor's body.

Based on the qi...

On the level of a Demonic Master?

A master of the Absolute Realm.

Even amongst them, someone of the highest tier.

There were not so many people like that in Xinjiang.

"The Palace of the Sun Devil," Woon-seong looked at the visitor and said.

The person of the Sun Devil's Palace bowed his head and replied,

"I present myself to the leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon."

It was the Lord of the Sun Devil's Palace (太陽魔宮主).

Although the Palace of the Sun Devil was not a sect under the Demonic Cult, they acknowledged that the Lord of Xinjiang was the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

His attitude was quite polite.

Woon-seong nodded. "Raise your head."

To his words, the Sun Devil Lord lifted his head slightly.

The Strategist glanced at Woon-seong and the Sun Devil Lord, then warmed up some tea.

Silence stretched while the tea was heated.

Why has the Sun Devil Lord come to see me?

While Woon-seong was mulling this over in his head with a fierce gaze, the tea was ready.

Hoo—

The Sun Devil Lord blew on the tea to make sure it wasn't too hot. He took a sip before lowering the cup and opening his mouth.

"I heard that you will advance into Zhongyuan and march against the Martial Alliance."

At that, Woon-seong laughed.

"Against the Imperial Palace, to be precise."

That did not mean the rest of Murim would be forgotten. It was clear that the Alliance, including Jwa Do-gyul, were Woon-seong's enemies.

At Woon-seong's words, the Sun Devil Lord closed his eyes and said, "Regarding that, my Palace would like to join the Cult."

At that moment, Woon-seong still had tea in his mouth. After taking a moment to swallow the tea, he cocked his head. "Why?"

"..."

"Is there a reason for the Palace of the Sun Devil to join? In the event of failure, the entire group will face execution. Was the Palace's loyalty to the Cult so strong that it would support the Cult's efforts despite such a threat?"

Woon-seong glanced at the Strategist as he spoke. Sang Gwan-chuk shook his head.

Silence followed for a while.

It was the Sun Devil Lord who opened his mouth to end the silence.

His voice was heavy, but it also seemed to be a little wet.

“My son...” He briefly paused to take a deep breath. “My son is dead.”

“What do you mean?”

The Sun Devil Lord clenched his fists at Woon-seong’s question. “My son died when he was caught in the tomb of the Sword Emperor.”

Somehow, Woon-seong felt that the name was familiar.

In a timely manner, the Strategist sent Woon-seong a message.

— He’s probably referring to the Secret Vault of the Sword Emperor of Ice and Light, which was discovered a while ago. We felt like the situation had been manipulated and did not get involved.

Only then did Woon-seong recall the incident, going, “Ah.”

In the meantime, the Sun Devil Lord continued with his story.

“When I heard my son had been caught in the incident, I felt that it was an unfortunate accident. But I soon realized that was not the whole story.”

“...”

“To my knowledge, all news regarding the Secret Vault were forged. It was a case of manipulation within the Martial Alliance. ”

“...”

“While some things have been reported to the Alliance, none of newly joined sects were seriously harmed.”

Woon-seong glanced at the Strategist to ask whether or not this was true. Sang Gwan-chuk nodded.

This matter had been reported to Cheon Hwi, since he was the cult leader at the time. Naturally, as the young leader, Woon-seong had not been notified.

“A little further investigation revealed that all the rumors about the discovery of the Secret Vault originated from the Martial Alliance. They made the decision. They decided to reduce the power of Murim, pushing all forces that did not cooperate with the Alliance to their deaths!”

The Sun Devil Lord clenched his fists. Along the back of his hand, flames appeared.

It was the sacred fire of the Sun Devil.

“I filed a complaint with the Martial Alliance, but they said my findings were irrelevant.”

“Hypocrites, most of them.”

When Woon-seong commented, the Sun Devil Lord nodded.

Woon-seong sympathized with the Sun Devil Lord, “It must have been hard. Even if you tried to take revenge for your son, you cannot move so easily against such an enemy. ”

“Yes. While the Palace of the Sun Devil is the second strongest organization in Xinjiang, after the Demonic Cult, it is not strong enough to take on the whole of Murim. ”

“And then you heard that the Demonic Cult was on the move?”

As Woon-seong spoke, the Sun Devil Lord nodded and then smacked his head against the table.

Bang—

The tea cups shook and tea sloshed onto the table. At the same time, blood flowed from the Sun Devil Lord’s forehead.

The man's forehead had been injured because he slammed his head against the table without protecting himself with internal force.

But he did not show any pain at all.

"Please help me. Help me repay the enemy, burn their sects to the ground and avenge my son."

"..."

When Woon-seong did not respond, the Sun Devil Lord once again smashed his head into the table.

Bang—

"You can call upon me like a believer. As long as I can see the end of the Martial Alliance, the 5,000 troops of the Palace of the Sun Devil will support you."

5,000.

It was not a small force.

The army of Cult of the Heavenly Demon was currently about 50,000 strong, so that would increase the amount of people available.

In addition, martial artists from the Palace of the Sun Devil were masters of fire. Harnessing the what of the sun, they were skilled at offense.

Woon-seong stared at the man across from him silently.

He lost his masters to the Martial Alliance and its forces; the Sun Devil Lord had lost his son.

There was a difference in the relationship, but they had both lost someone precious to them.

It was at that moment that the Strategist sent Woon-seong another message.

— Please accept. The Sun Devil Lord is a strong man. Moreover, he has never been a follower of the Cult. Now that he is willing to follow the Leader, the Cult's influence in Xinjiang will be stronger than ever.

Empathizing with the Sun Devil Lord, Woon-seong would have accepted even if the Strategist had said nothing.

In this situation, the Strategist's words gave Woon-seong a more legitimate reason.

As Sun Devil Lord looked at him with uncertainty, Woon-seong said:

“I allow the Palace of the Sun Devil to join.”

At that moment, the power of the Demonic Cult had just grown stronger.

Chapter 124: Palace Of The Sun Devil (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 124 – Palace of the Sun Devil (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Demonic army, which became more powerful due to the merger with the Palace of the Sun Devil, camped near the Great Wall.

At this time, Woon-seong examined the Great Wall.

Their enemies were not only the Martial Alliance, but also the Imperial Palace. It would take a great battle to cross the Great Wall if the Imperial Palace would not let the Cult through.

That was why the army had set up camp here, to stay a day and see what the plans were for the Great Wall.

Perhaps it was because of rumors that the Demonic Cult was coming, but the Gateway to the Great Wall, through which many people travel to and from each day, was unusually silent.

Guards yawned in their seats by the gate.

Hmn.

Woon-seong stood in the camp and stared at the wall.

He was sure that the Imperial Court would have heard about the Demonic Cult coming, but the expressions of the soldiers guarding the walls were of boredom.

At first, he thought it was a trap.

But it wasn't a trap at all.

It was not an act of provocation, but that they were truly unprepared.

It was as if the war of Murim had nothing to do with them.

Hmm.

Woon-seong touched his nose lightly. A gust of wind blew his Black Dragon robes.

The Strategist appeared after a moment and said, "Leader, what shall I do?"

"Have some of the troops pass through and report the results."

"Respect," the Strategist nodded.

Immediately after the order was issued, a small group of scouts was separated and sent to the front.

The Eastern Armed Forces were camped out in front as the Western Armed Forces waited on stand by. The other two units, the Southern Armed Forces and the Northern Armed Forces, would assist the other two from the back.

As Woon-seong watched, the scouts approached the Great Wall from the outside.

By the time they were almost near the wall, the Strategist, who had gone down to give the order, returned and stood next to Woon-seong.

"They will pass."

Then he turned to look at the small group from the rearguard, who were now entering the gate.

Woon-seong nodded.

“Are you sure they’re not prepared for anything? ”

Sang Gwan-chuk glanced at the wall for a moment. As a soldier, his eyes were hard, as if he was ready for battle.

But he was a military strategist.

He always had to assume the worst.

“I’ll have some troops stay near the walls just in case. And if I see any movement, I’ll give the order to get back to you immediately. ”

The Cult Leader nodded his head. That was the least they could do.

Though it was a pity to leave a portion of the troops here, it was better than to fall into a trap and lose more.

Woon-seong looked up at the sky. Darkness had begun to spread like a curtain.

He lowers his head, looking down to where the troops had settled and were preparing a meal.

Woon-seong watched the smoke rise into the sky.

“I will spend the night here. Send a letter to the soldiers who entered first and tell them not to go too far. We will start marching again early tomorrow morning. ”

The Strategist bowed his head, “Understood.”

Dawn was brighter than Woon-seong expected.

Since it was an open plain, the sun rose more clearly.

Woon-seong glanced at the army and announced:

“Today, we shall enter the Central Plains.”

And finally, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had moved beyond its boundaries and into the Central Plains.

* * *

The Demonic Cult had entered Zhongyuan.

Although it was on the outskirts, the Qinghai Province was definitely part of Zhongyuan.

It was also home to the Kunlun Sect, one of the major Taoist sects.

They should have heard the rumors a while ago and prepared. But there was no commotion.

Rather, almost everything was abandoned. Everyone had retreated into their homes.

In this situation, the demonic soldiers were dumbfounded.

Woon-seong made a rough guess and told the Strategist, “The closed sects mean that they will not antagonize the Cult. They will not attack.”

“What is the reason for that?”

In response, Woon-seong briefly told the Strategist about the Justice Blood Alliance.

While the Cult was preparing for its trip to the Central Plains, Jegal Sung and King Jinseong would have made their own preparations.

Obviously, part of those preparations included making sure that factions that had joined the Justice Blood Alliance would not attack the Demonic Cult.

Woon-seong's conclusion was correct.

Most of the sects which closed their doors remained un-hostile to the Cult and had been contacted by Jegal Sung.

“Then what do we do with the other sects, the ones who have run away? ”

“I have to set an example. Burn down their forsaken sects and plant the Cult's flag in their place.”

“Understood.”

Everything was done as Woon-seong commanded. The flag of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon began to fly above buildings of Qinghai.

It was a very different situation from their previous march into Zhongyuan.

That time, the Cult had to shed rivers of blood in order to gain new territory. This time, it was bloodless.

Of course, that was not reassuring.

“What about the Taoists? ”

A major orthodox sect, occupying a seat in the Five Mountains Swords Alliance.

The Kunlun Sect.

Whenever the Cult had descended upon Zhongyuan, the Kunlun had been at the forefront of defense.

But right now, it was not moving at all.

The lord of the Kunlun is one of the Seven Leaders of the Justice Alliance.

The man would naturally also know that Woon-seong was the master of the Fifth Jade Knife.

He must have been contacted by Jegal Sung.

But even so, he was still the leader of the Kunlun Sect. Woon-seong had to meet with him at least once and find out what his intentions were.

“Send a letter to Kunlun. Tell the master of Kunlun I wish to see him. ”

“Understood.”

“What happened to the factions that abandoned their sects? ”

At Woon-seong’s words, Sang Gwan-chuk unfolded a map of Qinghai. He then pointed at the Qaidam Basin.

“I found that all those who retreated according to word from the Martial Alliance have set up in the Qaidam Basin.”

“The Qaidam Basin...”

A basin located in the north-western part of Qinghai.

This basin was located between the Altun, Qilian, and Kunlun mountain systems.

Although lower than the rest of the Tibetan Plateau, the altitude of the basin was still relatively high.

Since mountains bounded it from all sides and it had high elevation, the Qaidam Basin was an excellent strategic point.

Tsk, Woon-seong clicked his tongue lightly. Of course they were there.

The Martial Alliance could not just abandon their sects without thought. If they did, they would become the laughingstocks of the world.

So you decided to stay there.

There’s a lake nearby, so there’s even a source of water.

Woon-seong nodded to himself. It might take a long time to properly conquer the basin.

However, Woon-seong did not intend to stall in Qinghai. After occupying more than half of the province, the Eastern Army would continue eastward.

The Eastern Army had to move and completely capture Gansu in order to establish a safe supply route.

In order to do that, it was important for the Qaidam Basin to become part of the Cult's territory.

“Change direction and march towards Qaidam Basin. The Charred Dragon Unit will be at the front, and I will be the vanguard.”

Sang Gwan-chuk was startled at his words. “You will personally lead?”

“I don't intend to stall here. I will personally take down the Orthodox forces here. If the base can be destroyed and we can secure Qaidam and the passage to Gansu, it will be an advantage for the fight in Zhongyuan”

As Qinghai was located on the periphery, the number of martial artists in the area was smaller than compared to other provinces.

The fact was that martial artists of the Alliance here lagged behind the Demonic forces in both number and quality. The Demonic Cult would win if they could fight straight on.

I don't intend to save my strength. Push the Martial Alliance to oblivion within the shortest time and kill Jwa Do-gyul.

Beijing would be next.

Sang Gwan-chuk bowed his head. “I will send your letter.”

And a few days later, a reply arrived from Kunlun.

* * *

It was quiet.

All sources of light were extinguished. There was no sense of inhabitation at all.

This was not natural no matter how dark the night may be. It was obvious that someone had artificially made the area like this.

As if to prove it, a shimmering glow was emanating from the center of the city.

It was brilliant, like it had absorbed all the light in the area.

It seemed to be welcoming someone.

And sure enough, someone entered the village.

Where there was no signs of humanity within 20 li of the place, two people walked in with the flutter of wind.

One was an old man in uniform, and the other was a young man, in uniform as well.

A bright light seemed to emanate from the old man's eyes. The youth had a distinguished vigor and a unique grace with which he carried himself.

Tao was the source, pattern, and substance of everything that exists. It was a discipline of the mind. The more one walked down this path, the closer they would be to becoming one with the world.

From that point of view, the two of them could be considered quite close to perfection.

Among the two, it was the old man who opened his mouth first.

“There it is.”

Like the old man said, the young man bowed his head politely.

“Yes, Master.”

The two of them walked straight towards the building.

It was a brothel.

The old man soon burst into laughter.

“Such a place to meet a Taoist...This Cult Leader has a mischievous side to him.”

The two of them were members of the Kunlun Sect.

They were no ordinary disciples.

The elderly man who walked in front was Hyun Hak-jin, the First Sword of Kunlun and Master of the Kunlun Sect.

The following disciple was a man who had not yet gained such a title, but was called the Golden Dragon within the sect.

Kun Long was a late starter, but an accomplished man nonetheless, who would be named as a sword in the coming spring.

The two of them had showed up here because of Woon-seong’s summon.

And they finally entered the now illuminated building, stepping into the area where Woon-seong was waiting.

Squeak-

As the old floorboards creaked, Woon-seong’s voice echoed through the room.

“There you are.”

Chapter 125: Qaidam Basin (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 125 – Qaidam Basin (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Suddenly, a voice echoed throughout the building and Hyun Hak-jin hesitated.

His disciple, Kun Long, was startled and looked around.

Hyun Hak-jin started laughing.

“The Cult Leader’s skills have been revered for generations, but his skills are indeed incredible. ”

That skill just now.

It wasn’t exactly the same, but the skill was very similar to the Six Combination Sound Skill.

Ordinary martial artists might be frightened or frustrated.

However, the leader of the Kunlun was unlike any other martial artist.

His strength was also great. That was why he laughed at Woon-seong’s voice.

Then he starts climbing the staircase once more.

The wooden staircase continued to squeak.

There seemed to be no one inside, except for them. Even the rats were dead silent.

Perhaps Woon-seong had specially made it so, arranged for them to talk.

Hyun Hak-jin arrived in the space Woon-seong had worked hard to create. Ascending to the third floor, the highest level of the tower, a man was seen.

A man stood alone with a glass in his hands, admiring the beautiful scenery of the sprawling mountains.

Hyun Hak-jin immediately recognized this man as the one who had called him here.

It wasn't just the Black Dragon Robe the man was wearing.

There was the noble grace of a martial artist who had surpassed the absolute, and a unique feeling that could only be gained by a leader.

Hyun Hak-jin felt that way about Woon-seong.

Of course, this was only possible because Woon-seong did not hide all of his aura...

“The Ultimate Sword of the Kunlun.”

“Heavenly Demon.”

The two of them spoke each other's titles, without knowing much else to say.

Woon-seong threw a cup at the man.

Under the guidance of his qi, the cup shot through the air like a fleeting star.

Weng-

Tak!

Hyun Hak-jin lightly caught the cup and sat down in front of Woon-seong.

“This is the first time I am meeting you in person.”

Hyun Hak-jin emptied his cup before slowly saying, “I never imagined I would meet the Cult Leader in a place like this.”

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon and the Kunlun Sect gathered together to drink?

It was a scene that could not be understood with common sense. It never would have happened had the two of them not both been of the Seven Leaders of the Justice Blood Alliance, or if the present situation was not ongoing.

“I heard the story of the jade knife. I also heard that you will only be taking the position of Fifth Master temporarily.”

Woon-seong picked up a slice of pear and shoved it into his mouth, nodding, “When this is all over, I’m going to pick the right person and leave.”

Hyun Hak-jin nodded at Woon-seong’s words.

Was it because he felt like just that statement was enough?

After the bottle of alcohol had been emptied, Woon-seong set down his chopsticks.

“Actually, I didn’t call you here for some big reason. I just wanted to hear what your thoughts are.”

At Woon-seong’s words, Hyun Hak-jin also set his chopsticks down.

“You’ve already been told the story through the Justice Alliance. Cult Leader, what else do you want to know?”

One chuckled.

The other waved his hand.

It was an act of not bothering each other.

“Apart from what I’ve been told by the Justice Alliance, what do you think of Zhongyuan? Will you remain in silence, as it is now, or will you hinder our Cult’s movements...?”

At the end of his question, Woon-seong’s eyes flashed with golden light.

At the same time, demonic qi rose, spiking and bristling around the young man. In response, blue-colored qi also rose and billowed.

The pitiful Kun Long, who had been politely standing in the back, trembled under the pressure.

It was difficult for him, but if Hyun Hak-jin had not blocked part of it, his ending would be quite shameful.

The remaining power still made his hands and feet tremble.

Meanwhile, Hyun Hak-jin continued to talk with Woon-seong.

“After the war is over, I know the believers will enter Qinghai, Gansu, and Sichuan, Cult Leader.”

The man deliberately used the word ‘believer’ instead of the word ‘zealots’.

There was nothing good to be had from calling the demonic practitioners zealots to the Heavenly Demon’s face. This was a consideration from the older man.

Woon-seong nodded.

As the man said, after the war, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’s sphere of influence would extend beyond the Heavenly Mountains, stretching from Xinjiang and into Sichuan.

That was a promise made by King Jinseong.

When Woon-seong nodded, the man slightly lowered his head.

“There is only one thing this old man wants. I hope that when the Cult advances after the war, the demonic people will take care of the common people.”

Hyun Hak-jin asked for the civilians to be spared. That also implied that none of the civilians would be brought to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon or participate in war.

Woon-seong agreed, “I will do that.”

In fact, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had already been extremely careful so far to avoid interrupting civilian life.

The Demonic Cult might not have the upright character of the Orthodox sects, but its foundation was clearly religion.

In order for them to spread their religious doctrine, they needed to act with the public in mind.

The Cult hasn't touched the civilians.

The plan was to spread their doctrine as they went. Woon-seong had already spoken with the Strategist about this.

At Woon-seong's words, Hyun Hak-jin nodded as a smile spread across his wrinkled face.

“That is enough.”

That day's meeting ended there.

The first to leave were Hyun Hak-jin and his disciple.

Squeak- Squeak-

Hyun Hak-jin walked down the stairs and asked his disciple, “How was it?”

At the question, the disciple, Golden Dragon Kun Long, trembled. Then he raised his arms, curling into himself. “It was scary.”

To this point, Hyun Hak-jin nodded.

Woon-seong had not fully expressed himself, but it was true that the Heavenly Demon’s presence had been immense.

Even if the Kunlun tried to stop the Demonic Cult’s advance, they were afraid that their protest would lead to grief.

Of course, Kunlun was not weak. If they decided to feight, they would be able to do great damage to the Cult. But why foolishly start a fight?

“And he seems to be the same age as you.”

At Hyun Hak-jin’s words, the young Golden Dragon shivered once more.

Up until now, he had grown up hearing that he was a genius in the Kunlun Sect.

It had only been seven years since he learned martial arts, so it was indeed true that his outstanding achievements made him unparalleled among the disciples of Kunlun.

But today, he felt like he saw the sky beyond the sky.

A man of such skill was as old as himself.

“So that is the Heavenly Demon.”

Hyun Hak-jin smiled and told his disciple, “Kangho is wide, so never be arrogant.”

The Golden Dragon nodded heavily.

Hyun Hak-jin smiled slightly. With this, his disciple would continue to develop without arrogance.

With that alone, didn't that mean he had gained something from the meeting with the Heavenly Demon today?

“Don't be ridiculous.”

Hyun Hak-jin muttered to himself as he looked into the distance.

* * *

A few days after talking with the Kunlun Sect, Woon-seong stood at the top of a hill.

Of course, the pathway to the basin was higher than the hill, so he had to look up.

I don't like it.

Woon-seong rolled his neck and shoulders. There was the sound of his joints cracking as he stretched.

It wasn't just that he didn't like having to look up.

Lookouts and wooden barricades had been made along the path.

Although the camp had been made in a hurry, it used the geography to its full advantage, so the area seemed hidden at first glance.

If we fight here, we might have to fight a war of attrition.

Behind him stood the Strategist and the Charred Dragon Unit.

Gwan Tae-ryang, who was not Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, came to stand next to Woon-seong and bowed his head in greeting.

“It's been a long time since I've stood on the battlefield with the Leader.”

Woon-seong chuckled at his words.

As Gwan Tae-ryang said, Woon-seong had laid down the captaincy after becoming the Young Leader. So he had not fought with the other members of the Charred Dragon Unit for a while.

“Indeed, it’s been a while. ”

Woon-seong closed his eyes, as if recalling the past with Gwan Tae-ryang.

“It’s an honor to stand on the same battlefield again with the Leader,” Gwan Tae-ryang bowed his head and said.

The other members also bowed their heads.

There was not a single lie in their actions. They seemed to truly respect Woon-seong.

This was not simply the respect between the followers and the cult leader.

Apart from that, there was more respect that came from sincerity. It was a respect that stemmed from Woon-seong’s beginnings.

Woon-seong was a trainee from the Cave of Latent Demons, just like the Charred Dragons. At the same time, he was also the strongest of all of the trainees from the Cave of Latent Demons.

Therefore, Woon-seong was not only the pride of the Charred Dragon Unit, but also of the Cave of Latent Demons.

Look at him.

Our comrade stands so high up. We can do it, too.

Let us grow and become his strength.

With that in mind, all the ex-trainees of the Cave of Latent Demons had been training, their respect for Woon-seong only growing.

The Charred Dragon Unit was not an exception.

Gwan Tae-ryang's martial arts were so strong that he was incomparable to when he and Woon-seong had fought.

Other members of the unit, though not as strong as Gwan Tae-ryang, had still made significant improvements.

The one with the greatest accomplishment was Baek Woon-ji. As a female member who specialized in stealth, she used to lack combat skills in comparison with Gwan Tae-ryang.

And now?

If she fought in the dark, Baek Woon-ji's skills were a level above the Lieutenant's.

Baek Woon-ji faced Woon-seong and smiled, bowing her head.

After seeing that, Woon-seong turned towards the fortress. A moment later, turned to the Strategist, raising his energy.

“As soon as I enter, I will break down the wall. Afterwards, the Charred Dragon Unit shall charge inside. The army should then force the Alliance towards the center of the basin. ”

“Understood.”

He then turned away from Sang Gwan-chuk and spoke to Gwan Tae-ryang and the Charred Dragon Unit.

“I hope there will be no disappointments.”

“That's never going to happen. ”

Woon-seong nodded. Both of his hands were soon covered in flames of yellow and gray.

Fwoom-

The flame crackled and grew.

With his hands alight, Woon-seong took his first step towards the fortress and Qaidam Basin.

“This is the first battle. I better make it spectacular.”

An eerie sound burst from Woon-seong’s mouth.

“Hehehehehehehehehehe!”

Chapter 126: Qaidam Basin (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 126 – Qaidam Basin (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“The Demonic Cult has advanced right under our noses. ”

The faces of those gathered here were solemn.

The ones gathered here were none other than the masters of the Martial Alliance sects from Qinghai.

All those who had abandoned their sects and insisted on resolving the problem had retreated to this place.

“The numbers are great.”

“That’s only a quarter of the entire armed forces of the Demonic Cult...”

“The Demonic Cult must be determined this time. ”

Nervous murmurs arose.

There were a total of thirty sects gathered in Qaidam Basin.

Although that was not a small number, it was not a large number either.

Even if everyone was combined, they wouldn't number more than 3,000 men.

There seemed to be a dark cloud looming, saying that they would be unable to prevent the Demonic Cult's destructive offensive.

It was no wonder that there was a commotion.

At that moment, someone spoke up, "Everyone, calm down."

It was Yang Dam-seon.

In Qinghai Province, he was one of the three masters, and his skills were noted throughout Zhongyuan.

The man's business acumen was also outstanding. Some said that the Mount Chang Sword Sect had more than doubled in size since he rose to power.

Rumor had that he was offered the position of elder in the Martial Alliance; it probably wasn't a lie.

In fact, Yang Dam-seon was the one who had the most martial artists gathered here.

Once he spoke up, all the commotion died down and the other sect leaders went quiet.

Everyone tacitly acknowledged that Yang Dam-seon was the actual head of those gathered at Qaidam Basin.

Did he like such an atmosphere?

Yang Dam-seon smiled and spoke as he thought:

"Everyone here is a member of the Martial Alliance, and we have all made the decision to fight against the Demonic Cult. I do not think there is a need to be afraid of a fight that has not yet begun."

As he said, all the sects gathered were members of the Martial Alliance. The command to be stationed here was also from the Martial Alliance.

“Also, the Martial Alliance will send reinforcements as soon as possible. We will be enough to stop them. This fortress was not built up to that end.”

At that, the sect leaders nodded.

“Well, yes. ”

“Qaidam Basin and our fortress will be able to last a month, not ten days.”

While everyone was in agreement, there were still some who were pessimistic, as if they were not fully convinced.

“But I heard that the Demonic Cult’s leader is at least an Absolute master. Will the fortress be able to handle him if he comes?”

Yang Dam-seon frowned for a moment.

The sect leader who had brought up such a pessimistic thought lowered his head slightly.

It was Dang Cheol-sim, leader of the Shadow Gate. The power gap between the Mount Chang Sword Sect and the Shadow Gate was enormous. Even if he survived the battle with the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, it was likely the sect would need to leave Qinghai.

These were the worries of a small sect.

Whether or not Yang Dam-seon understood the man’s worries, he spoke to resolve the problems.

“Actually, I need to tell you something about him. ”

He looked around the crowd.

All of the sect leaders’ eyes were on him.

Before speaking, Yang Dam-seon looked at each sect leader one by one. Then he spoke with conviction, “For generations, it has been said that the Demonic Cult’s leader is a semi-divine being. But, how many times has he appeared in Zhongyuan since the last war?”

The Heavenly Demon had not made an appearance in Zhongyuan since the last Orthodox-Demonic War.

“In other words, the Heavenly Demon being a semi-divine being is a rumor the Demonic Cult spread. I don’t think he is as strong as the Buddhist or Sword Star.”

At that, those gathered nodded.

Perhaps the Demonic were bounded by religion, but for them, the Buddhist Star and the Sword Star were the pride of Zhongyuan and Murim.

Although not affiliated with the Martial Alliance, the Shaolin were respected — the Shaolin Temple at Mount Tai were the masters of Northern Murim.

The Buddhist Star was the best of them and the master of the Shaolin. In other words, it was not a lie to call him the strongest in all of Murim.

Also, what about the Sword Star? Although he was now isolating himself in Mount Paektu, he was still the strongest swordsman in Murim and the idol of all those who walked the path of the sword.

The Orthodox did not like the fact that their idols were compared with the Heavenly Demon.

When the other sect leaders agreed, Yang Dam-seon spoke with more power and confidence: “Besides, I heard that this time, the one who has risen to Heavenly Demon is just a child, barely twenty years of age.”

“Seriously?”

“Is that true?”

“Twenty?!”

The sect leaders exclaimed in disbelief.

Yang Dam-seon nodded, as if what he was saying was all true. “How can you put a child of such age in that position? The Demonic Cult is truly insane. I can’t believe that a child is the Heavenly Demon.”

“I agree.”

“Huh, I knew they were crazy, but the Demonic Cult is truly insane.”

“Their fanatic cultists.”

Whatever Yang Dam-seon said, the others at Qaidam Basin agreed. At this time they really thought that the new Heavenly Demon was nothing.

They felt like they could win against the Heavenly Demon.

At such feelings, Yang Dam-seon happily nodded.

At that time, a creepy sound echoed through the area.

“Hehehehehehehehehehe!”

It sounded like laughter.

Suddenly, those gathered froze, dumbfounded.

“What the hell was that?”

“Did the Demonic Cult attack?”

The first to recover was Yang Dam-seon. The others woke up after, one by one.

Soon they realized something strange had happened and ran out of the meeting room.

Yang Dam-seon ran towards the walls and asked the martial artists stationed there, “What the hell is this commotion!?”

With grave expressions guards answered, “We’ve got trouble! It appears that the vanguard of the Demonic Cult has begun to move.”

“The vanguard? They sent the vanguard, not a temporary attack force? Maybe you’re thinking of coming in after taking down the fortress? Of course that’s not going to happen!”

Yang Dam-seon spoke loudly and flew towards the top of the walls.

It was because he felt it would be easier to check the situation with his own eyes, rather than listen to reports.

As he ran, the others followed. Soon, they stood on the walls of the mud-brick fortress and looked down.

“Are they the vanguard? ”

A group of martial artists were moving from the Demonic Cult’s camp some distance away.

“Thirty people. You’re thinking of attacking the fortress and Qaidam Basin with just that many people? Even if you’re the Demonic Cult, you’re overconfident.”

At that time, someone pointed his finger at the man at the forefront.

“Look at that outfit!”

Everyone narrowed their eyes and looked where the finger was pointed.

It was a man in a black dragon embroidered robe.

In each hand was a bright, roaring flame.

The Divine Flame and the Black Dragon Robe were symbols of the Heavenly Demon.

The sect leaders cried out in horror and confusion.

“Heavenly Demon!”

“Are you saying the Heavenly Demon is personally attacking?!”

Yang Dam-seon calmed down the frenzy. “Everyone, don’t make such a scene. Didn’t I say that you don’t have to worry about the Heavenly Demon?”

Shua-

Yang Dam-seon pulled out his sword.

The sound and movement were smooth.

Of course it was.

Upon inspection it was the Sword of Mount Chang, belonging to one of the three Swords of Qinghai.

“I’ll prove it to you right now.”

The sect leaders gasped in shock.

Though not as strong as Yang Dam-seon, many of those gathered here were also masters.

Dang Cheol-sim of the Shadow Gate asked, “How can you prove that?”

Smiling arrogantly, Yang Dam-seon’s gaze was on the incoming vanguard of the Demonic Cult.

To be precise, it was on the Heavenly Demon at the very front.

He looked at the Heavenly Demon and said, “I’ll lead the Star Guard out and slit his throat.”

No matter how confident he was, the others thought it was too much.

Those who were running as the vanguard were elite martial artists, part of the Twelve Supporting Units.

Although they looked very young, the flag flying above them was definitely that of the established Charred Dragon Unit.

Thus, Dang Cheol-sim could not help but say, “But the opponent is the Heavenly—“

“He’s the Heavenly Demon, but he’s just a brat. His martial experience and qi are definitely lacking. I will go out and slit his throat.”

Yang Dam-seon cut Dang Cheol-sim’s words off.

In his head, Yang Dam-seon was already picturing himself as the hero who cut off the Heavenly Demon’s head.

“The Star Guards will be the masters of this gate. Listen, Ten Swordsmen!”

As he shouted loudly, ten swordsmen plummeted from the air.

These were the Ten Swordsmen, masters of the Mount Chang Sword Sect.

Although their individual skills were excellent, even elders of the Martial Alliance would be in trouble when three of them worked together.

“From now on, I’m going to behead the Heavenly Demon. Follow me! ”

As he finished speaking, Yang Dam-seon flew out of the fortress. *Ha, by leaving the army, the Heavenly Demon has given me an excellent opportunity.*

The Ten Swordsmen followed behind Yang Dam-seon.

Eleven figures dropped from the walls, arcing downwards.

The distance between them and the Demonic Cult’s vanguard narrowed at a rapid rate.

Soon there were only a dozen or so meters.

The face of the child, which the cultists of the Demonic Cult referred to as the Heavenly Demon, could now be clearly seen.

There seemed to be specks of strength and determination, but that was definitely the face of a twenty-year-old man.

He's just a kid.

Yang Dam-seon's lips curled up.

At that moment, the world seemed to rotate before his eyes.

As he spun in dizzying circles, a familiar body entered his vision.

Yang Dam-seon's eyes flew wide, surprise written across his face.

It was his own body.

Yang Dam-seon's severed head flew through the air.

Fwoo—!

After several rotations in the air, his head fell to the ground.

“Huh?”

Even then, Yang Dam-seon didn't realize what had just happened.

Woon-seong and his horse trampled upon Yang Dam-seon's head, and the Charred Dragon Unit and the Ten Swordsmen clashed.

Kuakuakuakua—

Chapter 127: Battle For Qinghai (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 127 – Battle for Qinghai (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The clash between the Charred Dragon Unit and the Ten Swordsmen.

Needless to say, the outcome was obvious.

Guaguagua—

Clang—

As soon as the Ten Swordsmen were trapped in the Charred Dragon Unit's formation, the Ten Swordsmen were torn apart.

This was not a figure of speech, they were literally disassembled.

They were slaughtered; they died without even being able to counterattack once.

Hoo—

Fragmented pieces of people and blood splattered the sand.

Fast, just like how Yang Dam-seon had been beheaded.

Woon-seong's first reaction had been to shoot out 10 meter long sword qi and cut off Yang Dam-seon's head.

What else?

That was it.

Yang Dam-seon, who dreamed to be a hero and pledged to behead the Heavenly Demon died a quick and worthless death.

His death left no impression on the Heavenly Demon.

Guaguagua—

While the Charred Dragon Unit fought with the Ten Swordsmen, Woon-seong passed through the group and approached the fortress walls.

He could see the heads of the martial artists standing at the top of the walls.

“Hoo!”

“My god! ”

When they saw the ends of Yang Dam-seon and the Ten Swordsmen, they were all terrified.

In that situation, some people screamed as Woon-seong approached.

“Throw the spears! ”

“Fire your arrows! ”

Shh, shh, shh.

Dang, dang.

An arrow fell towards Woon-seong's head.

Woon-seong raised his hand.

Glug-ug-

A tendril of sparks rose with a dark flame.

The tendrils whipped around, striking away the arrows and spears aimed at Woon-seong.

Boom-!

The arrows were immediately burned away, but the spears continued to strike at the fire with powerful force.

The Divine Flame was not simply fire, but had strength itself, which allowed it to exercise physical force.

Thwack-

That way, Woon-seong, who was able to guard his entire body, stepped into the air.

Dang, dang-

One step, two steps.

As if he was climbing a staircase, Woon-seong walked on air.

Ta, ta—

Standing in the air, he looked at the martial artists on the walls.

The moment he met their eyes, the fire wrapping around his body changed.

Fwoom—

Woon-seong raised his left hand high.

At the same time, there was an uproar.

Fwoom—

The flame had formed a wheel on the palm of Woon-seong's hand.

It was the Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon – Wheel of Samsara, on a scale completely different from back in King Jinseong's Court.

It was a genuine expression of his identity as Heavenly Demon, with the addition of the Divine Flame.

The Heavenly Demon's Wheel left Woon-seong's hand.

Crack—

The sound of thunder ripped through the area as the giant Heavenly Demon's Wheel collided with the earthen walls.

Crack-

Thud, clang.

Fwoom—

The fortress shook and cracked.

At the same time, the Divine Flame spread across the walls.

The flames roared and shook the air, as if an earthquake had hit.

Destruction unfolded.

“Ahhhh!”

“Fire, fire! ”

“Get some water! ”

To Woon-seong floating in the air, it was quite a mystery. *Did baking it with fire make the walls stronger?*

The walls had not been completely destroyed by the Heavenly Demon's Wheel of Samsara.

Even though the place had collapsed, the fortress was still technically standing.

But Woon-seong's attack had just begun. He inhaled and moved the White Night Spear.

“Hoo!”

Like a brush in the hands of a scholar, Woon-seong's spear was filled with inky strength. His eyes dripped with gold and a shimmering aura flowed from his body.

Internal qi, the Divine Flame, and Intimidation Qi were all mixed together.

The Heavenly Demon had demonic arts, but Woon-seong's origin was the spear.

One of Woon-seong's most prominent attacks unfolded.

The Art of Six Seals and Destruction — ‘Break the Vast Sea’ (六結破天例: 滄海破)!

Even the vast waves of the sea are split by a swinging spear...

A mysterious power gushed through the White Night Spear, threatening to rip the sea apart.

This energy was uninterrupted. Like the constant waves of the ocean, it battered the fortress walls.

The place it continued to hit was exactly where the Heavenly Demon's Wheel had hit.

Crack!

Woon-seong's spear continued to move. The fortress walls finally collapsed when 'Break the Vast Sea' was halfway through.

Boom!

The pile of hard soil that formed the fortress collapsed.

The walls, which were more than 3 meters thick, caved in.

The martial artists standing nearby were killed, crushed by the falling walls.

The dust and dirt soon settled.

All eyes turned to what was inside.

By the time the dust settled, the Charred Dragon Unit had finished decapitating the Ten Swordsmen and returned to Woon-seong's side.

The scenery was quite terrible.

The martial artists of Qinghai, had been caught in the crumbling walls and Woon-seong's offensive, buried under tons of dirt.

However, the Demonic peoples focused on something completely different.

“Oh!”

“Indeed, the Leader! ”

The fortress, which stood tall like an iron castle, had been destroyed. The meter thick walls had crumbled like sand castles.

The Heavenly Demon had accomplished it alone.

It was an act worthy of the god of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Sang Gwan-chuk, who believed in Woon-seong and had been preparing, commanded, “Comrades, advance!”

The Demonic Cult's troops poured into Qaidam Basin.

“Waaaahhhh!”

Later, this first battle would be recorded as the Great Battle of Qinghai during the Orthodox-Demonic War.

* * *

The first ones to enter the Qaidam Basin were Woon-seong and the Charred Dragon Unit.

Those who were still standing in the fortress, which had not yet completely fallen, struggled to stop the group.

Arrows were shot and spears were thrown.

They did not stop there; many of them leapt towards Woon-seong and the Charred Dragon Unit.

Each soldier had a weapon in hand, including sharp blades and poisoned daggers.

But they posed no threat to the Charred Dragon Unit, much less Woon-seong.

The Charred Dragon Unit began to show off its excellent skills.

Kwang-

With one swipe, a martial artist falling through the sky was cut in half.

It didn't stop there.

Throwing out the weapons in hand, the enemies rushing forth were blinded.

Gwan Tae-ryang's blades stabbed enemies and the ground was covered in blood.

Puchi-

There was the sound of someone being stabbed and a man fell.

Behind him was Baek Woon-ji, who had been hiding.

Woon-seong glanced around with a satisfied expression. “You’ve improved quite a bit. ”

It was to the point one could almost feel bad about the enemies, who were fleeing from Gwan Tae-ryang.

“Once again, I wanted to stand on the same battlefield as the Leader, so I worked tirelessly.”

The rest of the Charred Dragon Unit nodded to Gwan Tae-ryang’s words.

Their thoughts were conveyed and Woon-seong smiled.

“Ahhhh!”

“Die!”

At that time, there were martial artists who ran towards Woon-seong. Among them, there were some who seemed to be quite talented.

For comparison, they were weaker than Yang Dam-seon and around the level of the Ten Swordsmen.

People who could be considered strong in Qinghai.

“No way!”

“I can’t reach the Cult Leader! ”

They were barely worth a glance.

Gwan Tae-ryang and Baek Woon-ji cut them down immediately.

The two people were split apart at the torso.

Woon-seong swiped his hands as he passed between them.

Fwoom.

On one hand, the zenith of the Divine Flame. In the other, he executed Break the Vast Sea.

Rumble-

All around him, the walls of the fortress continued to collapse. The bricks turned to ash and crumbled.

It looked like there was a small landslide.

At the same time, the path inside the walls became wider and wider.

“Agh, abandon the walls. If you hang on any longer, the damage will only be greater,” someone shouted loudly.

Was there a commander with good judgement somewhere?

It was as he suggested. If they continued to stay on the walls, they would be swept away by Woon-seong’s attacks and continue to die.

“Retreat!”

The martial artists on the walls hurried down.

They then began to flee towards the center of the basin.

“The Heavenly Demon is still a human. No matter how strong you are, you’re going to get tired!”

“Repeat the offensive! Get in formation and surround the Heavenly Demon!”

Who knew who made that order?

The Martial Alliance surrounded Woon-seong and the Charred Dragon Unit.

It was as if the sheep had surrounded a herd of lions.

Despite their movements, the expressions of the martial artists were tense with nervousness.

“As long as you tire them out, you can even catch the Heavenly Demon”

“Activate the trap!”

There was a terrible snapping sound.

Fwee-bang—

At the same time, a large bundle of logs flew into the air.

Arcing through the air, they cascaded towards where Woon-seong and the Charred Dragon Unit stood.

Qaidam Basin had not only prepared earthen walls, they had even prepared traps inside.

As he watched the logs flying towards them, Woon-seong laughed.

At this time, the Divine Flame once again covered Woon-seong’s body.

Fwoom-

The fire rose into the air.

Pillars of fire shot into the air, following Woon-seong’s movements.

Boom. Boom.

Balls of flame intercepted the falling logs.

Caught by Woon-seong’s energy, the logs caught into flames and became balls of flame.

Woon-seong moved his hands again.

The burning logs were caught by Woon-seong's energy, not moving.

He then flipped his hands upside down.

A stream of qi threw the flaming logs straight back towards the Martial Alliance.

“Ahhhh!”

“Aah, fire! ”

“Hot!”

“What type of fire is this?!”

The flames that covered them refused to go out, even when they rolled on the floor.

The Divine Flame was the Will of the First Heavenly Demon, worshipped by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It could not be stopped unless one had immense inner strength, or if you cut off the source.

But for the majority of the poor soldiers engulfed in flames, they did not have the internal qi to blow out the flames nor the means to douse it.

For them, Woon-seong's martial arts was a ruthless offensive they had no way to resist.

Moreover, Woon-seong was not the only one attacking.

The Charred Dragon Unit ran like a wolf amongst sheep.

It was not just one wolf, but several.

Overwhelming terror ruled the battlefield.

Wherever the Charred Dragon Unit moved, the soldiers retreated.

The disaster for them was just beginning.

“Waaaahhhh!”

“Help the Charred Dragon Unit!”

“Fight alongside the Leader!”

“Demonic Cult, there is no such thing as retreat!”

“Punishment to the unbelievers who have insulted our god!”

“Punishment to the unbelievers who have insulted our god!”

All of a sudden, someone shouted, “Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

As if reacting to the rallying cry, the demonic soldiers also raised their voices.

“Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

“Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

As the fortress collapsed, a group of demonic practitioners rushed into Qaidam Basin.

Indeed, the disaster was only beginning.

Chapter 128: Battle For Qinghai (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 128 – Battle for Qinghai (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Demonic Army flooded into Qaidam Basin like a tidal wave.

They rushed in relentlessly, shoving the Martial Alliance to the sides.

Of course, they could only enter through the hole in the fortress walls. Not everyone could enter at once, but there were enough of them.

Even now, the main force was entering through the passageway.

And how did the Orthodox respond?

“Aah!”

“My legs -!”

“Ah, help me!”

“My arm! ”

There was no response. The abyss of destruction had unfolded.

Only a few sect leaders were barely standing and giving out orders.

“Fall back! ”

“Fall back! Get into the basin. Stay together or we’ll be surrounded!”

Their expressions were humiliating and disappointing, but they seemed to be aiming for a counterattack.

Despite the situation so far, they seemed to think there was still a chance of reversal.

Perhaps he had read this thought. Sang Gwan-chuk picked up his Blood Pen and ran towards the Orthodox forces.

“I think they have something prepared.”

Woon-seong nodded, agreeing with him. They would not simply flee to the basin just because the fortress had been seized.

Construction of the base had to take into consideration when the walls were breached.

What have they prepared?

Watching the basin with sharp eyes, he told the Strategist, “Have the generals be prepared for any unforeseen circumstances.”

The Strategist bowed his head and added, “I’ll tell them to stay in sight, even if they are fighting.”

When Woon-seong nodded, the Strategist disappeared.

Woon-seong continued to fight.

However, his current method was different from when he first attacked.

At first, Woon-seong’s movements had been quite spectacular. The Divine Flame exploded. He continuously attacked, breaking down the walls.

It was different now.

Quiet and discreet.

It was efficient.

With a flick of his hand, he reached for the neck of a martial artist.

Crack.

Woon-seong snapped his neck.

He then reached out and kicked another in the shin. With another *crack*, the martial artist with a broken leg screamed.

“Aaahhhh!”

Puchi.

Woon-seong plunged the White Night Spear into his heart.

Keep it short and concise.

He avoided attacks with minimum movement and focused on killing people in one blow.

Woon-seong’s hand swept across three martial artists.

With a *crack*, their necks were snapped.

A quiet, but terrifying offensive.

There was a reason for Woon-seong’s change.

The use of glamorous movements was to boost morale.

Woon-seong was the Heavenly Demon of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

He was the zenith of the 100,000 demonic practitioners and the nightmare of Murim.

The visual effects of his fighting would boost the morale of his allies greatly. On the contrary, the morale of enemy Orthodox martial artists would be greatly reduced.

His first few moves were the cornerstones to building this stage.

All of his actions were computed.

And now?

Even if it was Woon-seong, his dantian was not infinite. It was best to reduce unnecessary energy consumption by keeping his movement to a minimum.

Because of this, he kept concise spear movements instead of brilliant arts.

Of course, they were those who jumped at this opportunity.

“You bastard! ”

“Haha, no matter how many soldiers you command, you’re still just a brat”

“As long as you’re human, you must be tired! ”

Like right now.

Spear, sword, blade. Different weapons aimed at Woon-seong.

And...

Clang-

Their weapons bounced off as they collided with the Black Dragon Robe. It was the power of the evil dragon, which twisted the strongest silk threads in the world into the hide of a dragon.

Those who did not know it were startled.

“Huh!”

“What happened?”

It was then that Woon-seong moved. He reached out and caught one of the swords that bounced back.

Woon-seong tapped on the blade and used Lightning Stitching Art [‘empty-handed blade steal’?].

“Huff!”

The blade spun and slipped out of its master’s hand, sucked into the hands of Woon-seong.

At the same time, the sword swung, along the same movements the White Night Spear would have.

Thwack-

There were the gruesome sounds of flesh and bone being cut, blood splattering.

Fragments of flesh splashed in all directions.

Woon-seong threw the sword in his hand away, feeling nothing.

Fwah—

The lightly thrown sword smashed into a soldier’s head, one who was heading towards the rest of the Demonic Army.

It was so overwhelming that no one could deny his strength.

It wasn’t only Woon-seong who launched a wild offensive against the Orthodox.

Gwan Tae-ryang was like a wild horse racing through the field. With every gallop, the corpses of his enemies would increase.

There was, of course, movement to stop him .

But...

Boom!

With a blast of qi, the soldiers around him flew into the air.

Not only that.

Trunk! Trunk! Trunk!

Gwan Tae-ryang had loosened the iron bracers weighing down his body.

He watched Woon-seong grow in strength by his side and tried to chase after him. It was only natural for him to mimic Woon-seong's habits.

The iron bracers which sealed his strength were also quite heavy. They were nothing compared to Woon-seong's, but the moment he threw them off, his body became unbelievably light.

He could understand why Woon-seong was constantly wearing the weights.

Good. Stronger!

Gwan Tae-ryang began to attack even more ferociously.

Behind him, Baek Woon-ji flitted through the battlefield.

Baek Woon-ji trained herself in a slightly different way than Gwan Tae-ryang.

Instead of restraining herself with weights, she studied how to best use shadows and hidden weapons.

The basics of those who mastered stealth was how to hide oneself.

To do so, it was important not only to surround oneself with shadows, but also to assimilate with the energy of the environment.

Now, Baek Woon-ji had developed the art of stealth so far that she could hide from even Gwan Tae-ryang's detection.

Puk-

Baek Woon-ji stepped out of the shadows, wielding her blade and knocking down two Martial Alliance members.

Her blade had also changed to suit her inclination towards assassination and stealth.

From long to short.

Moreover, she had not forgotten to apply black paint to the blade so that it would not reflect light.

Thanks to this, she was like a moving shadow. And wherever there was light and people, there would always be shadows.

Additionally, Gwan Tae-ryang and Baek Woon-ji's cooperation caused an unexpectedly unreasonable impression.

“Rrrrghhh!”

With how aggressive Gwan Tae-ryang was, Baek Woon-ji's presence became more and more faint in comparison.

The brighter the light, the darker the shadow.

While the two of them were running wild, the other demons were also rampaging.

Sang Gwan-chuk kept track of the troop's movements while moving his brush.

His hand suddenly held the Pen of Life and Death, rather than the Blood Pen.

Tuk-tuk-

As he made his mark, the soldiers collapsed.

Most martial artists who used pens as weapons were scholars, since their weapons doubled as writing implements.

That was why Sang Gwan-chuk primarily used the Blood Pen to cut through his enemies, since blood was red as ink. Even the Cult did not know this.

“Watch out for the Blood Pen!”

“Is there anyone here who’s at the Transcendence? They’ll be safe.”

“Who knows blood transference?”

But the Orthodox faction didn’t know.

Sang Gwan-chuk wasn’t limited to using the Blood Pen, nor did he need to take their blood for the Pen of Life and Death to work.

He wielded the Pen of Life and Death.

A thin sword qi flowed out of the pen.

One of the orthodox warriors charged forward. The Strategist turned and snapped his finger in the man’s direction.

It was a small burst of energy.

Blood splattered the floor, dripping from the man’s wounds.

But the martial artist had not fallen.

“Haha, if we practice the method of transferring blood—”

The martial artist grinned, his eyes rolling back.

He had avoided being stabbed, but the Strategist's sword qi exploded inside of him.

Sang Gwan-chuk clicked his tongue as he watched the falling soldiers.

“Tsk, even if you see me as a Demonic King, how foolish of you to judge me by your skills.”

As he turned his head, he saw five warriors flying forward.

And in the middle of them,

“Kuhahahahaha!”

A fully-recovered Wind Demon Fist King was in a frenzy.

If the fight surrounding Woon-seong and the Strategist could be compared to an abyss, then the fight surrounding Gwan Tae-ryang and the Fist King were more like natural disasters.

Where had the Wind Demon Fist King gotten his name?

He was a walking disaster. With every punch of his, the space around him collapsed. Draconic winds rose, swirling through the air, reminding onlookers of the Wind God.

Hence, the Wind Demon.

And he had become a Demonic Master through his fists.

Thus, the Wind Demon Fist King.

The Wind God was unstoppable, and the Fist King was violent.

Of course, it would take tremendous strength to unleash massive draconic winds.

However, the Fist King did not stop enjoying the fight despite that.

Because of his aggressive nature, he would fight with all of his strength until he died.

And the funny thing was,

“That was quite an attack! ”

If the strength of his enemies was good, he wouldn't even bother avoiding their attacks. Instead, he would use his own move to counter their attacks.

Clang!

Of course, the Fist King's skin was hard as iron blades bounced off his body.

The Fist King's faction was not particularly favored, even in the Demonic Cult.

This was because they followed a path which exposed everything they had to their enemies, taking any decent attack with their steel skin and iron wills.

Though Wind Demon Fist King had a seemingly foolish tactic, there were also quite a few practitioners who liked this aggressive and crude way of fighting.

Of course, those who understood understood, and those who did not understand would never.

The Strategist shook his head.

It was then that someone among the Orthodox started yelling orders.

“Back up some more! Bring them in a little deeper!”

It was clear that something had been prepared.

The movements of the Martial Alliance were also strange. Instead of fighting them, they tried to surround the Demonic Army.

Of course, the encirclement itself was not very strong because there were more demonic practitioners.

However, it was clearly an ominous movement against the Cult. As the strategist, Sang Gwan-chuk needed to know what was going on.

He looked around with his sharp eyes.

He noticed stone towers piled up and down the Qaidam Basin.

Due to the large distances between one stone tower and another, it would be hard to notice a connection unless you were searching for one.

Beneath the towers were several ropes filled with oil.

What's that?

The Strategist had found what he was looking for and shouted, "There's a bomb, scatter!"

But before anyone could heed his words, someone from the Orthodox faction yelled, "It's too late!"

Kuakuakua— Boom!

Crimson flames exploded.

That wasn't the only thing the Orthodox had prepared.

"Open the Nine Heavens Devouring Array!"

Chapter 129: Heaven Annihilation (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 129 – Heaven Annihilation (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Nine Heavens Devouring Array was named after the nine layers of Heaven.

The Jun (Great) Heaven at the center.

The Cang (Azure) Heaven in the east.

The Hao (Bright) Heaven in the west.

The Yan (Flame) Heaven in the south.

The Xuan (Mysterious) Heaven in the north.

The Bian (Changing) Heaven in the northeast.

The You (Tranquil) Heaven in the northwest.

The Zhu (Vermilion) Heaven in the southwest.

The Yang (Solar) Heaven in the southeast.

These Nine Heavens were the skies that covered the entire world.

The Nine Heavens Devouring Array was created with the determination to force all the demonic beings to kneel under the Nine Heavens.

And as the name implied, the array would use the power of the Nine Heavens to devour demons.

The first explosion was a trap.

This Nine Heavens Devouring Array was the real weapon inside the Qaidam Basin.

It was also the reason why the sect leaders kept telling the martial artists to lead the demonic practitioners into the basin.

And as the name implied, it was enough to adversely affect all the demonic practitioners.

“What’s going on?”

“I don’t have any strength. ”

“Grrrgh.”

The demonic practitioners suddenly felt weak and limp. Among the demonic, those who weren’t as strong were already lying on the floor, or about to collapse.

It felt like their demonic energy was out of control

It felt like all the oxygen had disappeared.

What about the Demonic King and Demonic Masters?

It was true that they were better off than the others.

However, they were still filled with dreadful helplessness.

They had to be at least Peak Level to withstand the influence of the array.

But Great Demons were not common.

Even if you overturned the entire Demonic Cult, there would only be a few hundred Great Demons.

Only seventy were currently present. Even with the Demonic Kings and Woon-seong, they didn't even number 100 men.

Moreover, the offensive of the Orthodox faction was not over.

“The array works! ”

“Prepare your arrows.”

“Feed the iron rod!”

Convinced that the array was doing its job, the Orthodox went about preparing another wave of attacks.

They would be firing arrays battling upfront, forming a siege net.

As they were doing so, one of the Great Demons shouted, “I have one of your allies, you better watch where you're shooting!”

“You're targeting your own people!”

As he said, some Orthodox martial artists were in the area.

Tangled with the Demonic Cult, they were unable to leave the central area yet.

If the Orthodox continued to shoot arrows, their own people would also be hurt.

A shout was heard in response to the demonic practitioner from the Orthodox faction, “Sacrifices are absolutely necessary in order to uphold justice. They will be glorious, even in death.”

Even the Orthodox martial artists who were tangled up with the demonic practitioners were startled. They couldn't believe they were being thrown away just like that.

There was another person who snorted.

“That’s funny.”

It was Woon-seong.

Woon-seong’s voice resonated through the area.

He continued to mutter, “You guys have always been that way. Pretending to be righteous and pretending to be just. But you are all merely hypocritical, self-righteous, and stupid.”

Woon-seong was a Semi-Divine Being.

No matter how good the Nine Heavens Devouring Array was, it had no effect on him.

As Woon-seong moved about freely, someone who had been watching from the side shouted loudly, “What are you doing, don’t shoot arrows!”

The ones holding the bows muttered in confusion. Some archers personally knew the martial artists still trapped in the array. They were colleagues, brothers who they had shared a pot of rice with yesterday.

When they hesitated, the sect leaders screamed.

“Shoot or you will die! Shoot me!”

“Fire your arrows! ”

“We must uproot the Cult of the Heavenly Demon now! ”

The people who shouted were mostly those who were part of a major sect, or faced an area without members of their own sect.

At their cries, some soldiers shot arrows.

Sha-sha-sha

Each soldier shot very few, but there were many of them.

Hundreds of arrows poured down on the demonic practitioners.

At that moment, the Woon-seong reached out his hand.

Fwoom-

A wall of fire rose around the demons.

The Divine Flame burnt all the flying arrows. Needless to say, the Orthodox cultivators who were forming the encirclement felt the heat of the flames and stepped back.

Several shouted once more.

“Shoot more arrows! ”

“Don’t shoot horizontally, make them arc and fall from above!”

However, Woon-seong’s movements were a breath faster.

Bang, bang.

As Woon-seong moved his feet, the earth cracked like a spider’s web.

Even though he had simply stepped, he had created a large crater.

At the same time, Woon-seong stepped into the air.

Thwack-

Just like when the fortress was destroyed, a miracle was unfolding.

Thunk, thunk-

Woon-seong stepped into the sky, acting casual, but he had less stamina than expected.

With this move, his energy storage would slip below half.

I must have an overwhelming appearance.

After showing such incredibly strong power, it was likely that the Orthodox faction would surrender.

From the moment they were asked to shoot their colleagues, there had already been a disturbance amongst the Orthodox faction.

As long as we accept their surrender, they won't care about the hypocrites.

Moreover, the Woon-seong remembered the faces of all the Orthodox martial artists who had spoken out just now.

“My god.”

“He still has so much strength left?!”

The Orthodox cultivators were shocked as Woon-seong walked into the air. As if to show off some more, Woon-seong acted more casual.

The qi in my dantian is decreasing rapidly, but it's still tolerable.

Woon-seong reached out his hand.

The White Night Spear hovered around Woon-seong, according to the technique of Lightning Stitching Art. A powerful suction formed around his hand.

Kwaarnee-

At the same time, rocks rose from the ground and into the air. They gathered around Woon-seong's hand.

The small pieces were the size of man's head; the larger ones were the size of several people combined.

The rocks in the air formed a spectacular scene.

“Hehe.”

It consumes more energy than I expected.

But he did not stop.

Ruh-ruh-ruh-

Several swords also rose into the air amongst the rocks

Exactly twenty of them.

That was also the same number as the martial artists which Woon-seong had remembered.

But no one focused on the swords.

There was an even more spectacular sight.

Fwoom—

The Divine Flame from Woon-seong's hands enveloped the rocks in the air.

The burning rocks in the air reminded onlookers of a dozen suns.

“Is he really human?”

As someone muttered, that was not something a human could do.

Did that mean he was truly a Semi-Divine being?

The Orthodox soldiers prayed to gods they did not believe in to save their lives. Some even prayed to the Heavens and earth spirits.

A tick appeared on Woon-seong's forearm .

My stamina ran out faster than I expected.

Woon-seong urgently examined the situation. He glanced around, looking at the pieces of the Nine Heavens Devouring Array.

It should have been well hidden, but Woon-seong had gone through extreme sense training with Cheon Hwi.

Find the artificially planted rocks, there is an array setup here.

Woon-seong soon discovered the cornerstones.

There's exactly nine.

Each time one rock tower was destroyed, the power of the Nine Heavens Devouring Array would become weaker.

And what if all nine of them were destroyed?

The Nine Heavens Devouring Array would lose its strength.

Woon-seong dropped a boulder towards each of the towers.

Kuakuakua-

Fwoom!

Burning stones dropped from tremendous altitude.

“Woon-seong...! ”

Before the person was finished speaking, one hit the ground.

Kuakuakua—

Bang!

Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon.

‘Millenia of Heaven Annihilation’ (天魔滅世). [1]

As the name suggested, the Heavenly Demon destroyed the world.

* * *

Kuakuakua—

Boom!

There was chaos as meteors crashed into earth, dust billowing in the sky above the basin.

Every time a meteor landed, the whole basin would tremble through an earthquake.

These tremors turned the earth upside down, chipping away at the walls.

Several parts of Qaidam Basin were torn and flipped. It was hard to consider the area as flat land anymore.

“Cough, cough. ”

“Am I...am I alive? ”

Someone coughed in the frightening dust, and another was surprised to see himself alive.

In the meantime, the dust slowly settled.

The revealed scenery was devastating.

The world is a scene of constant changes (桑田碧海).

That was an apt phrase to describe how one man’s power could carve out mountains and turn the sea upside down.

All the demonic practitioners were enthralled by the incredible sight before them.

Some of them noticed that the power of the Nine Heavens Devouring Array had disappeared.

“The Leader has broken the array! ”

“Indeed, the Leader!”

“Hail the Heavenly Demon”

As the demonic cheered, the Orthodox were filled with despair.

In the meantime, they learned something amazing.

Annihilation...

A powerful move that looked like the destruction of the world, but few people had died.

Only a few cultivators in the immediate vicinity had lost their lives.

“What the hell...” someone muttered without realizing.

Once again, an eerie sound cracked through the air.

Bam!

Pang!

Pow, pow, pow!

Lightning struck from the air.

No, it wasn't lightning.

It was a sword.

The twenty swords in the air struck down like thunderbolts.

“Knng!”

“Huff! Huff! ”

All those that were targeted were the ones who had commanded the Orthodox to release arrows.

Woon-seong dealt with them all at once; there was no room for retaliation.

Everyone’s eyes had been on the annihilation, so no one had seen the swords coming.

Everyone then raised their heads towards where the swords had come from.

And they could see.

Woon-seong still floated in the air, looking fine.

“Oh.”

The demonic practitioners continued to worship.

As everyone turned to him, Woon-seong shouted, “Those who surrender can live!”

It was an irresistible voice.

[1] technically should be called ‘Heavenly Demon’s World Annihilation’ but I thought ‘Millenia of Heaven Annihilation’ sounded cooler

Chapter 130: Heaven Annihilation (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 130 – Heaven Annihilation (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Woon-seong's appearance was overwhelming.

It was a spectacular sight hard to express in words.

Was it because of this imposing scene? The Orthodox soldiers surrounding the Cult of the Heavenly Demon began to surrender one by one.

What sect leaders could stop them?

All of the instigating sect leaders had already lost their lives to the swords Woon-seong had dropped.

There was no one left to stop them.

So they surrendered.

Of course, nothing would have been different even if they continued to surround the demonic practitioners.

What difference would it make if they were all slaughtered by the demonic practitioners who were no longer affected by the Nine Heavens Devouring

Array?

Those who chose to surrender would have survived.

Some martial artists were uncooperative and fought. Most of them were immediately killed.

And what about Woon-seong, who had caused this situation?

Woon-seong's condition was not normal.

Since his energy had been consumed at such a rapid pace, he was feeling dizzy. He staggered when his feet landed on the ground.

There was suddenly someone supporting him.

“Are you all right?”

It was Baek Woon-ji, who had been hovering around Woon-seong since the days of the Charred Dragon Unit.

“Yes.”

Woon-seong nodded and grabbed onto Baek Woon-ji's shoulders as he rose to his feet. Soon, he stood without her help.

The situation had changed.

But there was no guarantee that those who surrendered would remain docile.

In order for them to stay put, he needed to remain strong.

The Strategist approached Woon-seong and handed over a small pill.

“What is this? ”

“A medicine.”

Woon-seong accepted the pill. It was about the size of a thumbnail and had a sweet smell.

It smells like an Ayu Kulpa Pill, but it's not that.

In a situation like this, the Demonic Army would not be carrying precious medicinal pills with them.

“A qi replenishing elixir.”

Woon-seong uncovered its identity and nodded.

Of course, it was not the kind of elixir that would increase his strength, but it could rapidly replenish some of his spent energy.

As he poured the medicine down his throat, the sweet smell of incense filled his body.

After seeing Woon-seong swallow the medicine, the Strategist said, “I will take care of the situation and report to you. Please return to the barracks.”

Woon-seong nodded.

The Strategist then turned to Baek Woon-ji, who was standing next to Woon-seong. “Help him back to camp.”

“Yes!”

Baek Woon-ji smiled brightly and nodded.

The barracks were in the center of the camp, set up so that they could see the Qaidam Basin.

Woon-seong returned to the barracks and laid down in the resting area prepared for him.

I recovered a bit thanks to the elixir Sang Gwan-chuk gave me, but that was only first aid.

The immense power Woon-seong had inherited from Cheon Hwi could not be recovered from a mere elixir.

It's hard.

Woon-seong slowly closed his eyes. He felt someone bringing a warm blanket and covering him with it.

He could tell who it was without looking.

He wasn't intending to sleep, but he felt Baek Woon-ji's intentions and murmured with his eyes closed, "Thank you."

Woon-seong had his eyes closed so he did not know...

When Baek Woon-ji heard Woon-seong's thankful words, her face turned scarlet...

Instead of closing his eyes to sleep, Woon-seong breathed in.

Slowly and deeply.

He breathed in and out, sucking and releasing air.

It seemed like not all of the air that went in was breathed out, as if some of it remained deep inside of his chest.

From there, he accumulated internal energy.

From there, his energy and health recovered.

Woon-seong immediately began cultivating.

Then, with that energy, he began filling his half-empty dantian.

The energy breathed in soon filled the emptiness.

"Phew."

The emptiness slowly began to disappear.

As he breathed in and out, Sang Gwan-chuk, who had been cleaning up the situation outside, entered Woon-seong's tent.

As he stepped inside, Woon-seong opened eyes.

Although he had restored some of his strength during this short period, he was still tired.

You're still a human being at Semi-Divinity.

The fatigued Woon-seong suddenly felt that way and smiled helplessly.

Sang Gwan-chuk bowed. "I will report the situation."

Woon-seong nodded and Sang Gwan-chuk began to speak.

"First, I will report the damage to our Cult. The damage was not great, but there were about 200 casualties. Excluding those who are merely injured, there were about 30 deaths."

As he said, it was minor damage for wartime.

That was only possible thanks to Woon-seong, who drove the battle to a quick end. What if they had fought to the death with the sects there?

I don't know, but there would be at least double the casualties. It would have been worse without me.

But Woon-seong did not speak about that. Instead, he asked something else.

"What are you going to do about the deaths? "

"I plan to pay a certain amount of consolation to their families at the Cult. I'm going to transfer their bodies back first, and then we will have funerals after the war."

"It is fortunate we were able to recover the bodies," nodded Woon-seong.

War was terrible because a person living today could become a corpse tomorrow; the person who you ate with today could disappear the next.

And often bodies couldn't even be properly recovered.

That was war.

But the damage was less than he had expected and they were able to recover the bodies of the fallen.

We were really fortunate.

“And what about those who surrendered?”

“The number of those who surrendered is about 1,700. The 200 who attempted to resist were all decapitated.”

“What will you do with the prisoners? ”

“I plan to gather them all in one place for surveillance. If the Leader commands it, the process will take place immediately.”

Woon-seong took a moment to think, as he was wondering what to do.

Sang Gwan-chuk solved his problem.

“I think it would be best if we keep them alive and let them return to their hometowns and sects.”

Woon-seong was contemplating something along this line. But when Sang Gwan-chuk had a similar idea, he was curious.

“Your thoughts are similar to mine. Why does the Strategist think so?”

Sang Gwan-chuk smiled.

He guessed why Woon-seong thought the same.

“Don't you want to set an example? ”

It was as he said.

Woon-seong intended to set the precedent that those who did not resist the Demonic Cult would be spared, and they could return alive.

Absolute obedience to the Demonic Cult was not necessary.

All they had to do was not bare your fangs or draw your sword.

A precedent of bloodless surrender.

And what it meant to return alive was huge.

If many disciples were able to return from the battlefield alive, a sect would be able to survive the war and continue into the next generation.

Unlike the Spear Master Sect.

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

When he thought of Nok Yu-on and the Spear Master Sect, he would still feel terribly upset.

However, Woon-seong knew that it was not these lowly foot soldiers whom his anger targeted.

It was those insane sect leaders who said that disciples had to be sacrificed for their cause.

And worse than them.

The Martial Alliance.

They were the ones who needed to be eviscerated.

It was not necessary for others to experience the grief of sect destruction, like the Spear Master Sect had suffered.

“I feel the same way as Leader. This is an opportunity to set an example.”

Woon-seong nodded.

It was then that Sang Gwan-chuk added something.

“But you can’t just send them back.”

Woon-seong lifted his brows. “What do you mean?”

Sang Gwan-chuk looked at him, smiling as if he had anticipated the question.

“If you just let them go like this, you can set an example, but it will not raise the dignity of the Cult. So instead of just letting them live, we should receive what we deserve — an exchange that establishes the majesty of our Cult.”

Woon-seong tilted his head, asking, “Are you asking for money?”

If Sang Gwan-chuk was talking about gold or goods, the Cult was involved with trade along the Silk Road and their riches piled high as a mountain.

Do we need the gold? Woon-seong’s expression darkened.

Sang Gwan-chuk shook his head.

“Why don’t we do this...”

* * *

“You’ll let me live, but you want me to leave a seal on the silk?”

There was a long line of martial artists.

One man standing in the middle of the line muttered as he looked ahead of him.

They were all survivors of Qaidam Basin from the battle in Qinghai.

The reason they were all standing in line was because of a command from the Demonic Cult, to which they had surrendered to not long ago.

The Cult would spare those who surrendered.

The Cult was not vicious enough to behead enemies who did not wish to fight.

Instead, one thing had to be left behind.

The only thing to leave behind was a seal — put some ink onto your palm and press it into the silk and you are good to go.

The strange request made all of the prisoners confused.

But they did as told.

If they could return alive with just a handprint, then this extra step didn't matter.

Loyalty to the former sect leaders?

There was no such thing.

How can we consider those who ordered us to shoot arrows at our fellow members as sect leaders?

They were all glad that their friends and colleagues they spent time with had survived, even if their leaders had died.

They were also thankful that they were able to return home and back to their sects.

That's why they were willing to use their handprints as a seal.

Some felt uncomfortable.

But when the others left a seal, they did too.

And a few days later, a new flag flew above the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's army.

It was a flag with hundreds of handprints on it.

This flag accompanied the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's procession, spreading its witnesses throughout the whole world.

And of course, there were also those who were sensitive to the flag.

Chapter 131: Green Forest (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 131 – Green Forest (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Boom!

Sect Leader Yeon Seong of the Great Dragon Gate stood up and smashed the table.

The rosewood table dented.

Yeon Seong, who showed his anger like this, shouted at the other sect leaders gathered around: “They left a seal with the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and returned home. What a disgrace!”

As he shouted, several others agreed.

“Truly people without pride.”

“No matter how scared they are of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, how can you make such a choice?”

“Shameful!”

Yeon Seong was satisfied to see that others agreed with him. However, the situation was serious and he spoke with sternest, not revealing his satisfaction.

“A seal flying upon the flag of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. Qaidam Basin was guarded by useless men.”

“Shouldn’t our Qinghai Alliance make a decision unlike theirs?” someone said in response.

The Qinghai Alliance.

It was a coalition of sects centered around Qinghai Lake.

It was not a coalition that originally existed, but rather an informal organization formed under the name ‘Qinghai Alliance’ when there was a big problem in Qinghai.

More specifically, it was because the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was advancing beyond the Qaidam Basin.

The Qinghai Provincial Orthodox Alliance, which Woon-seong faced at Qaidam Basin, was only about half of the Martial Alliance forces in Qinghai.

The other half were the sect belonging to the Qinghai Alliance.

So it was fair to say that the Qinghai Alliance had to be destroyed for Qinghai to be completely under the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’s rule.

Woon-seong also knew that, which was why the army was marching towards Qinghai Lake, where the Qinghai Alliance was located.

The Qinghai Alliance’s willingness to fight was firm.

“It is said that the Martial Alliance dispatched part of the New Dragon Battalion. Although it will take some time, which is why we couldn’t help in the Battle of Qaidam Basin, they should be able to join us in a few days.”

“Oh, the New Dragon Battalion.”

The New Dragon Unit Battalion was an object of admiration.

The group of dragons which brought about the dawning of a new day.

If there was the Charred Dragon Unit in the Demonic Cult, the Martial Alliance famously had the New Dragon Battalion.

It was originally the name of a teaching institution run by the Martial Alliance, but the title of New Dragons had eventually been handed down to the unit.

The sect leaders gathered suddenly felt much better.

Still, there were those unconvinced.

“What the hell are the Kunlun doing... Even if you’re not part of the Martial Alliance, isn’t that too harsh? I can’t believe the Cult of the Heavenly Demon came down and they just locked their doors.”

“Hmph, he’s scared.”

The man was ridiculed.

Of course, they would not be speaking like this if the Taoists were present.

But even the emperor can be insulted when he is absent.

After some time tearing into the Kunlun Sect, they began discussing the Demonic Cult again.

The results of the discussion were simple.

If they sailed into the middle of Qinghai Lake on boats, no matter how many demonic practitioners there were, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would not be able to follow them.

“Wouldn’t it be more advantageous for us to have an aquatic battle?”

They were all sects near Qinghai Lake. Most of them had even fought once or twice in Qinghai Lake.

It would be advantageous for them because of experience.

“That’s right.”

“Then let’s do it. ”

That was the end of the discussion.

The funny thing was that they had taken more than an hour to scold and slander the Kunlun Sect, but they didn’t even take half an hour to come up with a battle plan.

“There are complaints in the Martial Alliance about why we are not blocking the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’s progress.”

He was an elder of the Mount Hua Sect and the Martial Alliance, Elder Peng.

As he said, there was dissatisfaction about whether or not it was too late to stop the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’s advancement.

Of course, Jwa Do-gyul also had eyes and ears, so he received reports. He knew roughly what was going on.

So he lowered his head, making a pained expression.

“It’s all my fault. I borrowed some of the New Dragon Battalion, but sent them to support Qinghai yesterday.”

At his words, Elder Peng made an expression that read as ‘of course’. He then said, “Well, I was simply worried. Do not take my words as having another meaning.”

“It’s all right. I am glad that there are people who care about me and the Martial Alliance like Elder Peng. I hope that you will continue to work hard for the welfare and peace of Murim.”

The words ‘peace and welfare of Murim’ made the man smile.

Seeing that, Jwa Do-gyul chuckled to himself. *The Orthodox people are skilled, but their brains and eyes are dull. They’re so easy to use.*

If I act a little, they are so easily deceived.

Not knowing what Jwa Do-gyul was thinking, Elder Peng thought for a moment. He then tilted his head and asked, “You said the New Dragon Battalion left yesterday, right Lord?”

“Of course.”

“Isn’t that a little late, then? It seems the Demonic Cult’s movements are faster than expected. If the Qinghai Alliance doesn’t hold up properly, the battle in Qinghai Province might end before the New Dragon Battalion even arrives.”

Jwa Do-gyul waved a hand. “Haha, aren’t they masters of Murim, too? They should be able to hold out long enough for the New Dragon Battalion to arrive.”

It was not unreasonable, so Elder Peng nodded. “If so, that is a relief...”

Jwa Do-gyul’s eyes shone.

Hehe, we have to get rid of Qinghai anyway. Only then will Murim be angered, only then will the Martial Alliance and the Demonic Cult properly confront each other.

The Qinghai Alliance.

They had been thrown away.

* * *

The Demonic Cult’s march was unstoppable.

Even though only half of the factions had surrendered, they had increased their territory.

At least, when they crossed the territory those sects ruled, there was no one to stop the advancement of the Cult.

In addition, unlike those of Murim, the common folk were mostly welcome to the advancement of the Cult.

Compared to those who did things like steal and cheat under the name of their sects, the Demonic Cult was mild.

Combat and war were not the only outcome of fighting with the Martial Alliance, as the Cult made efforts to protect the civilians.

Firstly, the Cult fully waived one year of protection fees for the territories it occupied.

This policy was only possible thanks to the prolonged accumulation of goods and the vast increase in time spent in Zhongyuan in preparation for the war.

It was natural for cheerfulness to spread among the masses.

Moreover, security was more stable.

Under the observation of the Cult, neither the Martial Alliance nor the evil sects were able to stand tall.

Under these circumstances, the Cult continued to advance. Eventually, the flag of the Cult flew over half of Qinghai.

It was only then that a group of people appeared, blocking the advancement of the Cult.

This happened one evening as the Cult was marching.

A group stood in the army's way, blocking a section of the mountain pass.

The Cult paused its march.

There were about 500 people gathered. Even if they were insane, this was not a number that could halt the Cult's progress.

But they didn't seem to want to fight. Although they stood in the way, there was no outright hostility.

"Let us meet the Cult Leader."

The demonic soldiers had their eyes wide, observing those who stood in their way.

Their outfits were varied.

Many different types of weapons and shabby attire; there was hardly any uniformity.

At the very least, the only similarities seemed to be poorly washed faces and sparsely grown beards.

In addition, some of them were covered in animal hide.

One of the Great Demons, who was watching them muttered with a tilt of his head, "The Green Forest Stronghold?"

As he said, the ones who stood there were the Green Forest Stronghold.

"Why does the Green Forest Stronghold wish to see the Cult Leader?" one of the demons asked.

The one who looked like the head came forward and said, "Why should I tell you?"

The demonic practitioners were a little stunned.

"You think the Leader will see you just because you asked to see him?!" one of the demons shouted.

The aura of the vanguard immediately became unpleasant.

The bandits in the back were trembling.

However, the one at the front was the exception. He looked at the demonic with a more dignified look.

“If you let me see the Cult Leader, I will tell you why we have blocked the Cult’s path. And if he decides we should be punished, then we will be punished.”

“This one will fucking see you!”

As the Demonic General in the lead became angry, there was a shout from behind: “What’s going on?”

It was the voice of Gwan Tae-ryang, who had been part of the vanguard too.

At the Lieutenant’s appearance, who was both a captain of a Twelve Supporting Unit and of higher status, the vanguard bowed their heads.

“All of a sudden these people of the Green Forest Stronghold want to meet the Leader...”

“Green Forest?”

Green Forest Stronghold.

To put it nicely, people who lived in the Green Mountains. But that was just talking big; they were basically bandits.

Perhaps there was more to them than that, but their reputation as bandits was great.

When they asked to see the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’s god, it was natural for the believers to be put off.

Gwan Tae-ryang knit his brows as he looked at the Green Forest Stronghold.

Hmm.

At that moment, Gwan Tae-ryang released some of his qi into the area.

He focused on the man standing at the forefront.

That man seemed to have a subtle aura.

That meant the man's abilities were likely first-rate.

Maybe peak.

Since the man's abilities are at least first-rate, maybe even peak...

Feeling that the man was not some ordinary bandit, Gwan Tae-ryang asked, "Why did you ask to see the Leader?"

Just as Gwan Tae-ryang had been astonished by the man's skill, the man had also been astounded by Gwan Tae-ryang. He warily responded, "I will tell the Leader why when I meet him."

Confused and mildly irritated by his words, Gwan Tae-ryang pulled a blade from his waist.

Shink-

He pointed his blade at the man as he said, "This Cult follows only the strong. If you want to see the Leader, you will have to prove your worth."

At that, the man in the lead's face hardened. But he soon made a firm decision, walking before Gwan Tae-ryang and grabbing the heavy sword on his back.

Kung-

The tip of the sword was heavily dug into the earth.

Gwan Tae-ryang assessed the skills of the man wielding the heavy sword.

“If you endure ten of my moves, I will report your request to the Leader in the name of the Charred Dragon Unit, one of the Twelve Supporting Units.”

“Don’t forget your words. ”

The man grabbed the heavy sword with both hands.

A haze seemed to rise around the man’s shoulder.

There was no room for hesitation.

The two of them flew at the same time.

Pavat-!

Chapter 132: Green Forest (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 132 – Green Forest (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Perhaps it was because the army had stopped marching forward, but the commotion at the forefront reached Woon-seong, who was near the middle.

If you asked how the commotion reached his ears... It was a complicated process.

However, simply put, it was through the command system.

Anyways, Woon-seong heard about it.

Gwan Tae-ryang is fighting with the Green Forest.

Gwan Tae-ryang's skills were obviously much better than before. It was clear that if he took off the iron bracers, his speed and strength would jump several grades.

Moreover, the warrior from the Green Forest Stronghold could not be too bad either.

Gwan Tae-ryang pulled out his weapon first. Maybe it was because he thought the Green Forest Stronghold was worth it?

Is it about the Blade Ogre?

Upon receiving the report, Woon-seong recalled some past events.

A memory from before his promotion to the Charred Dragon Unit, from real world training.

I had received a command to help the Second Latent Demon Squad near Korla.

In that place, Woon-seong had fought a fierce battle with the Blade Ogre.

I later learned that the Blade Ogre was from the Green Mountain.

He was from the Green Forest Stronghold of Qinghai Province. The reason the Blade Ogre came to Xinjiang was because he was betrayed and ambushed by his subordinates.

Does this have something to do with him?

Maybe that was why he suddenly remembered that time.

Interested, Woon-seong slowly got up from where he sat.

As he stood, the people holding up the palanquin stopped.

The palanquin was set on the ground.

When it was set down, Sang Gwan-chuk came over to Woon-seong. “Would you like to go see for yourself?”

“I’m intrigued. ”

After speaking, Woon-seong immediately moved ahead of the group.

As the Cult Leader walked forward, the demonic naturally cleared a path.

Woon-seong soon reached the vanguard.

There, Woon-seong was able to see the fierce attacks of the Lieutenant and the man being targeted.

Weng!

Bang!

Leaping through the air, Gwan Tae-ryang's attack made a deafening sound.

The air rippled with energy.

The man was able to defend himself, but he felt like his limbs were being torn off.

The gap between this man and Gwan Tae-ryang was huge.

You need to stay alert.

If not, you will be beaten.

I have to meet the Cult Leader and tell him something.

I have to thank him.

That's why!

I must endure this!

The man bit his lip. He strengthened his legs and loosened his shoulders.

There was pain from his side.

Shua!

Gwan Tae-ryang's attack slashed past his flank.

The wound was long, but fortunately not deep.

It was still endurable.

I must endure!

In addition, the end was soon.

The man rooted himself to the ground, remembering the number of moves left.

Gwan Tae-ryang too, did not want to waste the two remaining moves.

Whoo-hoo!

As qi was infused into his blade, the weapon in his hands began to tremble and cry.

In order not to fatally injure, he did not use too much energy.

Still, Gwan Tae-ryang used a sliver of skill he had recently learned.

True Dragon Paralysis was not some spectacular divine art. It was just a method that described how to capture the weight of a movement close to textbook perfection.

It was the precise movement of a swinging ruler, one accompanied with the power to crush thousands of miles of rock.

Boom!

When he was struck, the man's body trembled.

One of his knees buckled.

His arms strained as pain lanced up, like they had been broken.

This is the power of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's vanguard. How amazing!

The man was amazed at Gwan Tae-ryang's strength.

Meanwhile, the Lieutenant continued with his last attack, not giving the man time to breathe.

If I stop that, I can meet the Leader!

The man's will burned, not knowing that the Cult Leader was already watching him.

Over his head, once again, Gwan Tae-ryang's offensive raged.

Boom, boom!

There was a loud rumbling sound, like the dreadful tolling of a bell.

At that time, the man's sword broke in hand.

Bam.

Half of the sword thudded to the ground.

Unable to withstand Gwan Tae-ryang's strength, the man flew into the air and crashed down.

"Cough!"

Blood spilled from the man's mouth. It seemed like he had internal injuries.

Nevertheless, the man stood up grumbling.

With his broken sword used as a cane to support his body, he got up on his trembling legs. Looking at Gwan Tae-ryang, he said, "Now can I meet the Cult Leader?"

At that, Gwan Tae-ryang nodded. As promised under the name of the Charred Dragon Unit, one of the Twelve Supporting Units, the Lieutenant would be responsible for reporting this matter to Woon-seong.

If he hadn't heard Woon-seong's voice, he would have said so aloud.

"You've got a good foundation. "

It was a voice that came out of nowhere.

Gwan Tae-ryang turned towards the voice. The same was true of the other demonic practitioners, who had been immersed in the battle.

Everyone looked surprised and bowed.

Gwan Tae-ryang recognized Woon-seong, and the others who had never seen Woon-seong recognized the Black Dragon Robe.

“Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon, long live the Cult!”

“Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon, long live the Cult!”

With all the demonic practitioners suddenly bowing, the Green Forest Stronghold was thrown into confusion.

The same was true of the man leaning his body against the broken sword. He looked around, not understanding the situation.

Gwan Tae-ryang’s next words allowed him to understand: “I greet the Leader.”

I heard you were young, but I never thought you’d be this young. The man opened his mouth, wrinkled his brow and muttered, “Leader...The Heavenly Demon?”

It was a mutter of fear and surprise.

At this point, Gwan Tae-ryang stood up and exclaimed, “How dare you!”

The same was true of the other demonic.

“Show some respect!”

The man fell to his knees and spoke like a demonic practitioner: “Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon, long live the Cult. I bow upon all Demons. I present myself to the Cult Leader.”

The other Green Forest Stronghold members were confused, but followed his actions.

Only after this did the noise subside.

Woon-seong nodded and asked the man at the front, “You wanted to see me?”

“Yes, Lord Heavenly Demon,” the man nodded, still bowing his head.

Woon-seong waved a hand. “You are not a Demon and need not be so afraid. Why did you want to see me?”

The man lifted his head and looked at Woon-seong’s face once. He then lowered his head and slammed his forehead into the ground.

Bang-

It was not just the man in the front. All the other Green Forest Stronghold members also bowed their heads.

Bang-

The man’s forehead was now bleeding, but he didn’t seem to be in pain at all.

“This lowly one has received the Lord’s grace, so he brought his men to join the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and repay the favor.”

Woon-seong narrowed his eyes, then shrugged. “A favor?”

Now matter how Woon-seong thought about it, he had never had any interaction with the Green Forest Stronghold. It was strange that this man was saying he helped them.

The man was still bowing as he asked, “Do you remember the Blade Ogre?”

Woon-seong lifted a brow. *I had wondered why that name came to mind when I heard about all the noise, but to think they were actually connected.*

“My men and I used to be subordinates of the Blade Ogre.”

“...”

“He was strong, but his personality was terrible. Many times, using his excellent martial arts and high status, he would intimidate our wives and families. Even though we were supposed to work for him, we decided to kill him.”

The reason why the Blade Ogre had come to Xinjiang and took over the Nine Vices was indeed because he had been kicked out from Qinghai.

At least, I think I heard that somewhere, Woon-seong thought.

Perhaps this really was the reason he fled to Xinjiang.

“We ambushed him during the night, successfully poisoning his drink. But unfortunately, I lost him...”

Woon-seong’s idea was correct.

“So that is why the Blade Ogre fled to Xinjiang.”

The man nodded. “Yes. I heard that the Cult Leader had dealt with the Blade Ogre, even before he became the Heavenly Demon. We have received a favor from the Lord!”

He smashed his head into the ground once more.

His forehead tore and blood continued to flow.

Nevertheless, his eyes did not shake as he looked at Woon-seong.

“Although our strength is weak, we wish to help the Cult. Please accept us!”

Woon-seong stared at the man’s eyes for a long time.

The man also did not avoid Woon-seong’s gaze.

Woon-seong recalled the fight between the man and Gwan Tae-ryang.

His basics were pretty good.

It was an unbelievable foundation for a mountain bandit.

In addition, his defense was solid.

If they were at similar levels, the man's defense would be better than Gwan Tae-ryang's.

Of course, there was a reason it had been a barrage of one-sided attacks.

Nevertheless, there was no denying that the man's fundamentals and defense were outstanding.

It's not bad.

Woon-seong opened his eyes.

“What's your name? ”

“This one is Nok Cha-seol of the Himalayan Mountains!”

Kung-

He slammed his head down again.

Woon-seong titled his head, murmuring:

“I allow you to join the Demonic Army.”

It was a soft murmur, but Woon-seong's voice definitely reached his ears.

Nok Cha-seol shouted with a bright smile on his face, “I will repay you with my life!”

As if responding to the man's cry, the other members of the Green Forest also shouted.

“I will repay you with my life! ”

The grudges and grievances of Murim were strangely and bizarrely karmically connected. Woon-seong was able to recruit about 500 mountain bandits thanks to the death of the bandit chief Blade Ogre of the Green Mountain.

Chapter 133: Martial Exchange (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 133 – Martial Exchange (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

There was a small commotion when the Green Forest Stronghold blocked the road, but the Demonic Army's march continued onwards.

Of course, the army did not stop using their secret lines to obtain information about all fronts of the war.

The reason a meeting was currently going on was because of some information obtained through these secret lines.

“Looks like they're planning to take the battle to the water.”

As the Strategist spoke, Woon-seong turned to look down on Qinghai Lake.

The Wind Demon Fist King swung his meaty fists. “The ships nearby were all sailed somewhere else, while even the small unused fishing boats were burned down. How are we supposed to take them in an aquatic battle?”

At the Fist King's words, the others nodded.

It was clear that things had become a nuisance.

But they still had to fight them.

If the Demonic Army ignored the Qinghai Alliance and kept moving, they would be fighting behind enemy lines.

“Tsk.”

Woon-seong clicked his tongue and looked at the Strategist.

Woon-seong had a good brain, but it was the Senior Strategist who worked on military operations and led the soldiers.

He was the Brain of the Heavenly Demon.

Others might not be able to, but he would have a way.

As Woon-seong looked at him, the eyes of the officers gathered were also on the Strategist.

And the Strategist did not disappoint. He smiled, one that clearly meant there was a way.

The Wind Demon Fist King, who was itching to fight, recognised the meaning behind the smile and complained: “If you have a strategy, hurry up and tell me. I’m so frustrated I might die.”

The Strategist nodded at the Fist King, then pulled out a black pen.

He swung the pen over a piece of parchment.

Schick.

With a few marks, he drew a map of the area surrounding Qinghai Lake. He pointed somewhere.

“It is not properly marked on the map, but this is the Heart of the Lake.”

“The heart of the lake?”

The ‘world inside of a gourd’ sounded a lot like ‘center of the lake’ and was often used to refer to midheaven or a hidden passage. [1]

However, among the fishermen here, the ‘heart of the lake’ could be interpreted in a slightly different way.

Mahādeva, the Heart of the Lake. It was a small island literally at the center of the lake. [2]

A place that was barely visible or accessible to others; you would never know it existed unless you lived nearby or had an aerial view.

That place was called the Heart of the Lake.

And how did Sang Gwan-chuk know about it?

“And there is a hidden branch of our Cult at the Heart of the Lake.”

Woon-seong tilted his head when he heard the word ‘branch’. Even the Heavenly Demon did not know the location of all the branches.

However, he had known the rough locations of the branches near Qinghai Lake.

This was because Qinghai had been an important location in the last war too, when the Demonic Cult had been attacking Gansu.

But this was the first time he was hearing about a branch *inside* the lake.

Sang Gwan-chuk bowed his head slightly, perhaps because of Woon-seong’s curious stare.

“This branch was created in case the enemies would force us to battle in Qinghai Lake, like they are now. When the Leader headed to Zhongyuan, he was in a hurry and we could not report about the new branch.”

At that, Woon-seong nodded.

Since Woon-seong had returned from Zhongyuan, they had all been busy preparing for the war. There was indeed no time to report.

And what was not important was not that it hadn't been reported, but what made the Strategist so confident about this branch.

“Is there a ship here? ”

At the Fist King's words, the Strategist nodded.

“I ordered them to buy ships in secret, so boats were bought from several different merchants. Not all of our troops can fit, but it should be enough to carry 6,000 men.”

“Oh.”

“Truly a strategist.”

A lot of people cheered.

It couldn't have been so easy to secretly prepare enough boats for 6,000 men.

Moreover, if it had been prepared after Woon-seong journey to Zhongyuan, it had been done in less than a year

“Well done.”

“I just did what I had to do as the strategist of our Cult,” Sang Gwan-chuk humbly responded to Woon-seong's praise.

“By the way, is it even possible to hide such a large fleet?”

Qinghai Lake was enormous.

If you stood on one side of the lake, you couldn't even see the opposite of the lake properly. If someone didn't know it was a lake, they might mistake it for the sea.

Of course, the area surrounding the Heart of the Lake was also enormous.

It was not a problem of whether that many boats fit, but about whether they would be seen.

Someone would definitely see a fleet of that size.

Sang Gwan-chuk continued, not concerned with such worries, “The area is surrounded by hills and wide forests. Also, there are a lot of wild animals running about in the forests, so most people do not enter the area.”

He paused, then continued, “It is not difficult to enter the Heart of the Lake, but the water flows backwards and rushes from the outside, so fishermen stay away. Without a large boat, they would not be able to withstand the currents.”

As the Strategist said, it was a fortune to find such a place.

“So even the Heavens are helping our Cult.”

Of course, my revenge too.

Woon-seong clenched his fists tightly.

Sang Gwan-chuk said, “Sichuan is looking down on our Cult.”

Qinghai, Orthodox faction.

There were hundreds of boats lined up in the middle of the lake.

The boats were of all sizes and shapes.

If there was one thing in common, it was that there were many martial artists with swords and spears gathered on deck.

They were all Martial Alliance members of Qinghai Province.

Some of the ships were chained together. Wooden planks spanned between some of the boats, allowing more people to stand above the water.

They were nervous because they did not know when or where the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would appear.

Though, many still held that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would never appear on Qinghai Lake.

The attitude of these martial artists was a testament to the horror and fear of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

So the soldiers were standing together while the sect leaders gathered on the main warship to talk.

“Alliance Leader Yeon, I have something to tell you. ”

Seeing the small group of sect leaders rushing towards him, Yeon Seong frowned for a moment. But he soon hid his emotions.

“What a crowd. Looks like everyone has something to say to this Lord.”

At his words, the sect leaders swallowed saliva.

Then one of them spoke as if it was difficult to make noise, “It is good to stop the Demonic Cult, but I think it was too harsh to drag off all the fishermen and burn every single one of their small fishing boats. And we didn’t give them any compensation...”

At their words, Yeon Seong snorted in his head.

“Orthodox” to the end.

There were always people like this.

People who cared about the lives of civilians and wished to live with them in harmony. And Yeon Seong was part of the group who regarded this kind of person as stupid.

He was in the Martial Alliance because it made him good money, but his disposition did not fit in with the Orthodox.

Not only that.

Currently, the majority of the sects that claimed to be Orthodox felt similarly to Yeon Seong.

In addition, it was generally those leading the larger sects who felt the same.

But look at these guys.

Fewer than thirty of them had come to speak to Yeon Seong.

It's easy to get caught in the life of a coward.

Of course, he didn't reveal any of his thoughts. With a handsome smile, he responded, "Even so, wouldn't it be a terrible deal if they fell into the hands of the Demonic Cult? I had no choice."

"Hmm."

Those words were not completely convincing.

Yeon Seong continued, "Besides, even if there is a small sacrifice now, wouldn't it still be better than their lives under the rule of the Demonic Cult? This was inevitable on both ends, so I hope that you honored sect leaders will not take it to heart."

"Hmm, I see. "

Reluctantly, they nodded. It seemed somewhat reasonable.

Yeon Seong clicked his tongue and turned around.

How annoying.

In fact, this was not the first time he'd said such things

In the past few days, several sect leaders had come over and they'd had similar conversations.

Of course, Yeon Seong said the same thing everytime.

Yeon Seong was beginning to get annoyed.

At least when the Demonic Cult arrives, all those grievances will disappear.

It won't be too bad to see a bunch of Demonic dogs rolling around the edge of the lake without boats.

I armored the boats, but there's no need to worry about fire.

They were in the middle of the lake, on a clear day with a perfect view.

An arrow would never be able to reach them.

And with not all ships connected, even if one blew up, not every ship would be destroyed.

We just need to take it easy until the reinforcements arrive.

He did not only believe in the support of the Martia Alliance.

He suddenly remembered the visitor who had seen him a few days before the ships were brought to Qinghai Lake.

Even though they had seemed a little dry and cold, he had immediately recognized his visitor.

He believed that with her on his side, they would have enough time to escape.

Yeon Seong's smile was dark.

Qingcheng's Sword of Earth.

That was the identity of the young woman who had visited him a few days ago.

[1] ‘world/sky inside of a gourd ‘ (壺中天) is pronounced ‘hu zhongtian’;
‘heart of the lake’ (湖中间) is pronounced ‘hu zhongjian’

[2] the island is commonly called Haixin Mountain (mountain at the heart of the sea)

Chapter 134: Martial Exchange (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 134 – Martial Exchange (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

When it was reported that the Demonic Cult had revealed its presence, Yeon Seong hit the deck.

Then, along the connected planks, he ran towards the boat where everyone was gathering.

It was not only Yeon Seong who heard the cry, as the other sect leaders also rushed about.

Like Yeon Seong, they scrambled over and shouted loudly.

“What are you talking about?”

“The Demonic Cult has finally revealed itself!”

“Where?”

They glanced around the lake with their eyes gleaming.

The fog was thick, but all of them were sect leaders.

They could not use fog as an excuse for lack of ability.

Some of them took out telescopes and scanned the lakeside. .

However, no matter how much they looked around, there was no sight of the Demonic Cult.

One of the annoyed sect leaders shouted, “Where did the Demonic Cult appear? Are you so tired that you’re hallucinating?!”

The soldier who had shouted it pointed towards one corner of the region.

“If you look over there, you can see the flag of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

There was more fog in that direction than anywhere else.

The old sect leader looked annoyed, but looked towards the fog.

And...

“Ah!”

When he saw something surprising, he dropped the telescope in hand

Yeon Seong tilted his head and picked up the telescope.

Looking towards the misty distance, Yeon Seong understood why the other man had been so surprised.

It was the same for all the sect leaders who took the telescope and looked at the same place.

“Huff!”

“Wait, aren’t they on the water?”

“How can there be a ship of the Demonic Cult?”

Everyone was surprised. They turned all the blame on the alliance leader.

“Alliance Leader Yeon, what the hell is going on here?”

“I thought you said you took care of all the boats!”

The problem was that Yeon Seong also had no idea what was happening.

He habitually chewed on his nails, the bits of nails being spat out.

How the hell did those Demonic dogs get ships? Why are there so many too...

As the fleet got closer, the size of the ships became more apparent.

There were many different kinds, ranging from very large to regular sized. There were even small boats, like messenger ferries.

“Say something, Alliance Leader Yeon!”

“Look, the important thing right now is not how they got boats. Now that they’re here, we should prepare for battle, too.”

Yeon Seong first deflected the blame away from him.

The topic had been changed.

Of course, that would not help him escape condemnation.

“After the war, you will surely be held accountable for what happened today.”

“Be prepared.”

Yeon Seong ground his teeth at their words.

Ugh.

But he couldn’t unleash his anger. For one, they were still one the same side.

He turned his gaze back on the Demonic Cult's fleet.

All kinds of thoughts flew through his head.

What should I do?

What should we do?

I wonder if we stand a chance against such a fleet.

How far are the reinforcements from the Martial Alliance?

I wonder if I can hold them off until they arrive.

While he was still in turmoil, there was a shadow who approached him.

“The Cult of the Heavenly Demon has appeared.”

A thin, fine voice.

It was the mysterious master who had visited Yeon Seong and the Great Dragon Gate a few days ago.

Dressed on dark robes, the others only knew that this was someone Yeon Seong had invited — they didn't even know whether this person was a woman or a man.

However, this time, it was revealed that the master was a woman.

She crosses the strait and stares at the tip of the Demonic fleet, which was appearing beyond the fog

The flag of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

And the flag with the seals of those who surrender at Qaidam Basin.

It was clearly the Demonic Cult.

“Please apply for an honorable martial exchange.”

Yeon Seong was surprised. “An exchange?”

“Yes. Isn’t it impossible to stop them all now with the power of Qinghai? If that’s the case, we need to buy some time with a martial exchange.”

It was as she said.

The situation would be more advantageous if they stalled for time, rather than fighting right this moment. They didn’t even know when the reinforcements would arrive.

“And if you defeat your opponent in the exchange, their morale will be greatly diminished.”

That was the same as saying she could beat any enemy.

Yeon Seong, who knew her identity, could not argue with that.

That was because this woman had been given the title of Qingcheng’s Sword of Earth.

“Mhm, I see.”

“In the exchange, I will be the first fighter. Please prepare a small boat.”

“Wait one moment.”

After he said that, Yeon Seong made an underling raise a patternless red flag, asking for a honourable exchange.

Several sect leaders protested.

“Why do you trust such a young woman’s words and apply for a martial exchange? If you’re going to have an exchange, you better have prepared more competent masters!”

Yeon Seong shook his head.

The red flag had already been up for a long time, and Jang Seo-ah was slowly approaching the cult on a small fishing boat.

Watching her back, Yeon Seong said, “You don’t have to worry about that. ”

“What do you mean we don’t have to worry? ”

The other sect leaders curiously asked, clenching their fists as the woman moved farther.

“She’s a swordswoman, one of the three Swords of Qingcheng”

* * *

Peek – Peek –

Accompanied by the sound of rowing, a small boat advanced.

Flying above the boat was a red flag, same as the ones on the other Qinghai boats.

It was a flag requesting an honorable martial exchange.

Although it was her first time fighting on water, she was confident she would not not lose.

No, she could not lose.

I must avenge Master.

She was Jang Seo-ah.

After the death of her master and martial brothers, she had become the only Sword of Qingcheng.

But even at this moment, when she grabbed her sword, she would feel burning anger towards the Demonic Cult, filled with the intent to avenge her master.

She was talented and skilled in the swordsmanship of Qingcheng. She was told that she would become a pillar of Qingcheng, as the sect did not permit female sect leaders.

Of course, she was uninterested in all of that. The only thing she cared about was revenge.

She had then heard a rumor about the Cult of the Heavenly Demon attacking Zhongyuan.

She wanted to take revenge by running ahead of the Demonic Army and slaughtering their men, but the elders of Qingcheng had stopped her.

But in the end, she was stubborn.

Although it took some time, she was eventually able to escape from the elders and reach Qinghai Province.

Of course, since it took some time, she wasn't able to go to Qaidam Basin.

But she had joined the Qinghai Alliance.

Anyway, why did the location matter if she was just going to kill the demonic anyway?

She was grateful she was able to fight the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Who knew who the culprit was?

But if she slaughtered mindlessly and without rest, she would eventually be able to kill the perpetrator.

This was a mindset that could not be considered normal.

In fact, Jang Seo-ah had gone half crazy after the deaths of her master and brothers.

Her hatred had weakened her judgement.

I will avenge my master.

Now that she had seen the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, that was the only thought in her mind.

Asking Yeon Seong to propose a martial exchange was also something done in a chaotic mindset.

She just wanted to cut down demonic practitioners.

And as if responding to her heart, a red flag was raised above the Demonic fleet.

They had accepted the martial exchange.

Looking at the request, Woon-seong's lips curled into a smile.

“Good timing.”

If the battle at Qaidam Basin was about the overwhelming appearance of Woon-seong, this second battle was about the Cult of the Heavenly Demon itself.

The Cult had to prove that it was not just the Heavenly Demon, but a group of thousands of masters.

Thus, Woon-seong was determined to be as uninvolved in this fight as possible. That way, this battle would give the enemies a reason to truly fear the Demonic Army.

In that regard, a martial exchange was an excellent opportunity.

It was a good way for the followers to show off their individual skills.

It seemed that Sang Gwan-chuk thought the same.

“Nice timing.”

Woon-seong nodded, “It’s convenient.”

And thus, a red flag was raised by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon in return, accepting the martial exchange request.

The one who would be fighting for the Cult, was of course Gwan Tae-ryang.

He had a lot of conditions that made him suitable.

First, he was the captain of the Charred Dragon Unit, one of the Twelve Supporting Units.

Thus, he was pretty qualified to represent the Cult.

At the same time, the Charred Dragon Unit, which he led, was working at the frontline. Gwan Tae-ryang could then be considered the leader of the vanguard, or the vanguard itself.

Elected as the first fighter, Gwan Tae-ryang grabbed a blade in one hand and rowed with the other.

Shua, shua.

The boat forcefully cut through the water.

The two stopped several meters away from each other.

Gwan Tae-ryang felt a sticky sort of energy sweeping across his body. It was obvious that his opponent was openly hostile.

At this time, the opponent threw off their cloak, revealing long hair.

The moment he saw that, Gwan Tae-ryang tilted his head.

“A woman?”

Jang Seo-ah leapt towards Gwan tae-ryang.

Chapter 135: Aquatic Fight On Qinghai Lake (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 135 – Aquatic Fight on Qinghai Lake (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Fababat-

The first one to attack was Jang Seo-ah.

The sword in her hand flashed, seeming to spark at random.

In addition, wind billowed, scattering the mist and fog surrounding them.

Blue clouds, red sunset.

The swordsmanship of Qingcheng.

Gwan Tae-ryang deflected the blue clouds.

Jang Seo-ah's attack unfolded along a straight path towards Gwan Tae-ryang, making it easier to defend against.

Although her first attack had failed, she didn't stop.

On the contrary, she attacked with a similar move.

Blue clouds and brilliant red glares flashed through the air.

Gwan Tae-ryang slashed through the clouds and smacked the balls of red qi everywhere.

Since they were relying on their boats to exchange moves, they had to make the best use of the available space.

Moreover, battles on water were hard to win unless one's lower body strength was tremendous. Every time the moves collided, the boats would rock back and forth with the waves, making it hard to grasp one's center of gravity.

Crash, bang!

Their blades collided again and again.

In this exchange of moves, Gwan Tae-ryang was quite impressed by this young woman. When he had first identified her as a woman, he had slightly dismissed her strength.

But now she was fighting him fair and square.

Her skills seemed to be higher than any other woman he had ever met.

No, there's one stronger.

Gwan Tae-ryang corrected his judgement. The strongest woman he had met was not the one standing in front of him right now.

It was Cheon Ah-young, who after graduating from the Cave of Latent Demons had become Captain of the White Ape Unit and was now the Divine Maiden.

Still, his opponent's skills could not be ignored.

You have no idea how vast the world is.

A frog in a well.

The world of Murim was vast.

That was something he had heard from Woon-seong, back when he was defeated for the first time in the Cave of Latent Demons.

Those words came back to him as he fought against this unknown woman.

Ever since leaving the Cave of Latent Demons, he had been training and training some more. Perhaps he had become proud of his progress and become arrogant once more.

Then let's take this opportunity to clear my pride.

Let's try our best once again.

With that in mind, Gwan Tae-ryang took a step back to avoid the blue clouds flying his way.

His heel touched the oar at the back of the boat.

He had stepped away from where the sword could reach and ended up in this situation.

Gwan Tae-ryang, realizing he was out of range, asked the woman, “What is your name?”

Hearing his question, Jang Seo-ah, who was about to swing her sword again, paused.

She drew her sword closer, keeping it defensively in front of her.

“Why?”

Gwan Tae-ryang shrugged. “I think your skills are amazing... I'd like to at least know your name before I kill you.”

Jang Seo-ah bit her lips. Gwan Tae-ryang's words were meant as praise, but she felt insulted.

For that reason, her blade became sharper.

“Dear demonic dog, I have no need to tell my name to a dead man!”

“How vicious.”

Gwan Tae-ryang released his iron bracers as he talked.

There was a loud thump and some splashed.

He groaned. The iron bracers had sunk into the water.

“Oh, I’ll have to make new ones.”

Gwan Tae-ryang showed a mildly upset expression, then aimed his blade towards Jang Seo-ah.

With his appearance, he made quite the valiant figure.

Jang Seo-ah was startled and stepped back.

Heavenly Sword Unification?

To be unified with the sword meant to see the sword as an extension of the body, to see the body as an extension of the sword.

It was to be one with the blade.

The user could not be separated from the blade.

Jang Seo-ah’s teacher had also been at this stage.

Of course, Gwan Tae-ryang’s state was not comparable to that of the First Apprentice. Even though the man had a terrible personality, his Orthodox practices had allowed him to reach tranquility of the heart and sword.

In comparison, Gwan Tae-ryang was a bit messy and awkward.

Nevertheless, Jang Seo-ah was furious.

“How dare you! ”

I can't believe you have reached a higher stage.

Jang Seo-ah swung her sword.

She leapt into the air. Like a swallow, her sword movements were elegant and sharp as she slashed towards Gwan Tae-ryang.

It was at that moment that Gwan Tae-ryang heard a voice in his ears.

– Never lose.

It was the voice Woon-seong.

Woon-seong was watching the two from a nearby ship. When the woman revealed her swordsmanship, he had immediately recognized it as belonging to the Qingcheng Sect.

Of course, it took some time to recognize who the woman was. But there was a reason.

Unlike the Sword of Heaven and Sword of Man, her appearance had gone through dramatic changes.

However, it did not change the fact that she was a successor of the Blue Clouds and Red Sunset Sword.

Needless to say, Woon-seong recognized Jang Seo-ah.

Jang Seo-ah was an enemy of Woon-seong; Woon-seong was an enemy of Jang Seo-ah.

He wanted to go out there and snap her neck, but he was an avenger and the Heavenly Demon.

He had to consider his identity.

That was why he had sent a message to Gwan Tae-ryang, telling him to never lose.

Gwan Tae-ryang simply thought that Woon-seong was cheering him on.

Cheering?

It was unnatural, considering the character of the Leader. But, it made sense given that the Cult was all about strength.

“Understood!”

Gwan Tae-ryang shouted loudly, so that he could be heard despite the fighting.

“Shut up!”

Jang Seo-ah shouted as she swung her sword. Gwan Tae-ryang blocked with a blade, using his own attack to propel her backwards and off his boat.

“Tsk!”

Jang Seo-ah spun in the air, trying to find her balance and return to her original boat.

However, Gwan Tae-ryang was a step faster.

Pung—

With a swipe, her boat split, bursting into pieces.

Now, the boat was just a bunch of wooden planks floating around Qinghai Lake.

Unless she could walk on water, she would not be able to continue attacking.

Gwan Tae-ryang thought this way and did not doubt that Jang Seo-ah would fall into Qinghai Lake.

However, Jang Seo-ah had better movement arts than Gwan Tae-ryang expected. She flipped in the air and let herself land on the water.

Murmurs of surprise came even from those of the Qinghai Alliance when they saw this.

“Crossing the River on a Reed?”

When one’s movement reached such a stage, it was possible to run on the ground so that the grass would not bend. Even more, it was possible to walk on water.

Being able to stand on water was the best way to prove you had learned the Art of Lightness.

In other words, standing on water was just below standing on air.

But had Jang Seo-ah reached such a stage?

While everyone else was astonished, Gwan Tae-ryang calmly examined the situation.

He shook his head.

No, she hasn’t reached that stage.

As if to prove him right, there was a wooden plank the size of a palm beneath Jang Seo-ah’s feet.

Daruma Crossing the River.

Bodhidharma, the founder of the Shaolin Temple, had crossed the Yangtze River by floating on a leaf.

‘Daruma Crossing the River’ was not comparable to the Art of Lightness, but it was another way one could seemingly float on water.

Of course, Jang Seo-ah was not able to support herself with just a reed.

But a wooden plank was sufficient.

She grabbed her sword and sneered, “Did you think it would be that easy?”

It was a venomous voice.

As soon as he heard this, Gwan Tae-ryang came to a conclusion. This match would not end until one of them slit the other’s throat.

Boom, boom!

The fight between the two became fiercer.

At this time, Gwan Tae-ryang’s boat was also shattered.

In this case, Gwan Tae-ryang chose to use Flowing Karmic Haste, not Daruma Crosses the River.

Both ‘Daruma Crosses the River’ and ‘Flowing Karmic Haste’ were fundamentally different from the Art of Lightness, and pursued different things.

If ‘Daruma Crosses the River’ had the serenity in movement, then ‘Flowing Karmic haste’ sought movement in the serenity of the world.

Of course, that did not mean that Gwan Tae-ryang’s movements were tranquil.

Boom, boom.

Each time the soles of his feet hit the surface of the water, there would be a burst of energy, like an explosion.

With the recoil, Gwan Tae-ryang would be propeled upwards.

Just as Jang Seo-ah could not perfectly use ‘Daruma Crosses the River’, Gwan Tae-ryang was not able to perfectly use ‘Flowing Karmic Haste’.

But even with that, there was a difference between the two.

The water splashed higher than ever before as Gwan Tae-ryang jumped about in the lake.

“Khhh!”

Jang Seo-ah grit her teeth.

As the lake water rippled, the boards floating on the surface would violently rock.

Moreover, the boards that were reasonably large and easy for her to stand on had been lost to the waves.

As a result, only a few planks were still floating, all of which were difficult to use.

In addition, Gwan Tae-ryang was not so gentlemanly as to pull his punches, or stupid enough to miss an opening.

Seeing his chance to victory, Gwan Tae-ryang’s offensive swirled like a storm.

At the same time, energy condensed around Jang Seo-ah’s sword.

A supercharged ray of energy could soon be emitted.

Gwan Tae-ryang’s attack exploded against Jang Seo-ah’s Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset.

Boom-

In the aftermath of the shock, Jang Seo-ah’s sword started to crack.

Gwan Tae-ryang did not stop attacking.

Boom-boom-boom.

Boom-boom-

The sound of metal against metal etched through the lake.

And finally.

Exactly six seconds after her sword first cracked, Jang Seo-ah's sword shattered into pieces of bronze.

“Ah!”

Looking at it, Jang Seo-ah's eyes widened.

In the seventh second, Gwan Tae-ryang's sword pierced her chest.

Puchi—

Broken bones, split muscles, torn blood vessels. The thick veins leading to her heart were slashed and she began to bleed out.

Jang Seo-ah raised a pale hand to her chest with a shocked expression.

Her hand came back wet with blood.

She moved her lips to say something.

“Dirty... ba—”

Before she could finish speaking, Gwan Tae-ryang swung his blade and cut off her head.

The severed head flew high into the air.

Gwan Tae-ryang stretched out his arm, grabbing it and brandishing it forth.

Then, as it was, he shouted in resounding victory.

“Aaaahhhhh!!!”

The first match against the Qinghai Alliance had ended with a fabulous victory.

Woon-seong raised his hands and clapped.

Clap, clap, clap.

It was the celebration of a victorious lieutenant, and a celebration for another enemy dead...

Chapter 136: Aquatic Battle On Qinghai Lake (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 136 – Aquatic Battle on Qinghai Lake (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

After the first victory, Gwan Tae-ryang continued to fight several more rounds. And after each round, he would roar in victory.

By the fifth round, Gwan Tae-ryang's voice had become a horror of the Orthodox faction.

Like right now.

Clang—

Gwan Tae-ryang had once again cut off the opponent's head.

As with Jang Seo-ah, Gwan Tae-ryang caught the head in midair and burst into a roar.

“Ooaaahhh!!!”

Whoosh—

The sound caused ripples to spread across the surface of the lake.

At the roar, the Orthodox tried to retreat.

Does that monster never get tired?

Their faces were pale with horror.

Given the situation, no one was willing to fight against the Demonic Army anymore.

At this point, normal people would be so exhausted they would feel like dying. But Gwan Tae-ryang continued to fight and win with his weary body.

Even the sight of his heaving chest seemed like a hallucination.

As opposed to the Orthodox peoples of Qinghai, the morale of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was soaring.

Holding the corpse, Gwan Tae-ryang shouted loudly, “Next!”

Cheering came from the Demonic Cult, as if responding to him.

“Woahhhhhhhh!”

The bodies of his enemies were floating around the small boat Gwan Tae-ryang stood on, which the Demonic Cult had entrusted him to.

There were five.

Exactly the same number of enemies that he had cut down today.

Gwan Tae-ryang’s gaze went to the Orthodox faction.

“I said, next!!”

No one came out and Gwan Tae-ryang shouted once more; the Orthodox faction trembled.

But no one stepped forward.

At that, Gwan Tae-ryang took some deep breaths and shouted, “Are there only cowards in Qinghai? And yet you call yourselves martial artists of Kangho?”

It was a clear provocation.

How many people had been killed because they fell for that taunt?

Qinghai did not respond this time.

Woon-seong exchanged glances with the Strategist.

“Looks like any more rounds will be meaningless.”

Sang Gwan-chuk seemed to agree with that. It was a waste of time to continue trying to fight in the absence of opponents.

“Thanks to the Charred Dragon Captain’s prowess, the morale on our side has greatly increased. So, I will start the attack.”

When Woon-seong nodded, Sang Gwan-chuk fluttered the large fan in his hand.

That was the signal.

Those who were watching the Strategist began to sound the drums.

Bang, bang, bang.

The sound of drums echoed across Qinghai Lake.

They sounded like the beating of a human heart.

The drumbeats were enough to create a strange tension on the battlefield.

“What are they going to do?”

“What’s going on?”

The Qinghai Alliance tightly grasped their weapons.

Their palms were already slick with sweat.

The drumming was from the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, so they could only feel terror.

Meanwhile, Gwan Tae-ryang listened to the drums and turned his boat around.

Shua, shua, shua.

Bang, bang, bang. That was because the drums signalled for Gwan Tae-ryang to return.

Of course, there was also another meaning.

The Demonic Cult's fleet began to move.

Each of the large and medium-sized ships moved to the side, opening a channel down the middle. In this gap, small vessels began to emerge.

There were pieces of wood, thin like chopsticks; pieces of wood which were covered in white cloth.

One side of the wooden sticks were iron points.

“Oh no!”

One sect leader recognized what the weapon was and screamed.

He then shouted at the others in a rush.

“Disconnect the boats!”

“Pull out the planks and break the chains!”

It was an urgent cry. But the Demonic Cult moved faster.

As the drum sounds changed, a flurry of fiery arrows arced from the Demonic fleet.

They were fire arrows, powered through oil.

They drew parabolas in the air, burning the fog above Qinghai Lake.

Some of them fell on boats carrying something.

Fwoom—

The white cloth covering the contents of the boat were burned away, as the contents of the ship began to ignite.

It was straw.

These flaming ships approached the Qinghai Alliance.

“Stop them!”

“Those who can do handiwork, dive in and flip those ships upside down!”

At the end of the shout, several people had jumped in Qinghai Lake with a *fwoosh*.

They then moved to clear the flaming boats.

But there were too many of them.

In addition, the Qinghai Alliance were not the only ones with martial artists.

According to Sang Gwan-chuk’s orders, there were already demonic practitioners waiting in the water.

Rrrrrrrrrrrrrrr—

Bubbles rose rapidly as the demonic practitioners approached the martial artists trying to get to the flaming ships.

And then...

“Knng!”

“Cough!”

Daggers and blades were stabbed into the backs of the men trying to approach.

They groaned and gagged, blood flowing from their mouths.

The flames continued to spread.

“Damn it, we should just burn them down too!” Yeon Seong cried out.

“But we don’t have boats to sacrifice!”

As the man said, since they weren’t intending on fighting like this, the Qinghai Alliance had prepared neither fireproof ships nor a large amount of flammable material to fling.

It was all because they did not think that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would have their own boats.

Damn it, cursed Yeon Seong. He then took an arrow from a nearby soldier and dipped it into oil.

“Shoot fire arrows!”

A flaming arrow was shot from his hands, flying towards the demonic practitioners.

Fwoo—

Sha, sha, sha.

The flaming arrow arced through the air, then landed on the surface of the water.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon was outside the range of an arrow.

That was not the only bad news for Qinghai.

Taeng.

Crack.

One flaming ship successfully crashed into a Qinghai boat.

Fwoom!

The oil and fire struck the Qinghai boat all at once.

Not only did it not break the chains connecting the ships to one another, the flames ignited the wooden planks, which had not been removed yet.

The flames quickly spread from ship to ship.

“Ahhhh!”

“It’s hot! ”

“Disconnect, move quickly! ”

Yeon Seong slashed at the chains with his sword. However, the chains were so thick that he couldn’t cut them in one move.

Clang, clang.

After two swings, the chain snapped.

If that was the case for a fairly high leveled martial artist in Qinghai, the other soldiers were doomed.

“Uack, it’s hot!”

One soldier tried to remove the chain with his bare hands and screamed. The flames around the chain cooked the palm of his hands.

Meanwhile, the flames were still eating away at the rest of the Qinghai fleet.

The flames were so great that the water around the fleet was starting to heat up.

Nevertheless, many of the martial artists jumped into the water, finding that it was better than burning to death.

But they did not know.

There were demonic practitioners in the water.

Puchi—

“Khh.”

“Agh—”

The practitioners protecting the flaming ships had not yet returned to the Demonic fleet.

Instead, they swam around, attacking anyone who leapt from the fire.

It seemed that for the Qinghai Alliance, being on the boats meant death and jumping into the lake also meant death.

This situation continued. But there was good news for the Alliance, too.

“I cut it off!”

“We’ve disconnected! ”

Thanks to the restless efforts of the soldiers aboard the ships, they had been able to cut off the ships caught in the fire.

Of course, a few sacrifices were made in the process.

“Get on a boat that’s not on fire! ”

The surviving martial artists scrambled and moved to a ship that was intact.

The number of remaining vessels was about a dozen, including one large and one medium.

That was less than a quarter of the original fleet.

They had survived, but there was another problem.

“What do we do now?” someone muttered to themselves.

These words were met with silence.

Dozens of boats had disappeared in the fire; the number of defenders had decreased a lot.

But was that all?

The Demonic fleet was still intact, with very little damage.

Additionally, while the Alliance had been cutting off the chains, the Demonic fleet had moved to surround them.

If the Alliance was to fight in this situation, they would be defeated, both in number and in circumstance.

“Ugh...”

One of the sect leaders heaved a sigh of mixed regret. Was this the price they had to pay for burning all those small fisherman’s boats?

His gaze turned to Yeon Seong.

They shouldn’t have trusted him from the start.

They shouldn't have yielded to his power or words.

If he had objected to burning the fisherman's boats...

"We might have been in a better situation."

But it was always too late for regrets.

While some of the sect leaders were filled with regret, Yeon Seong was bursting with fury.

"What the hell are they doing? Qinghai is being trampled upon by the Demonic Cult. You can say that we do not belong to Murim, but this is too much! Things would have been different if you helped!"

The worst things in the world are always the fault of others.

Yeon Seong blamed someone else.

As a result, several of the sect leaders turned to him with looks of pity.

It was only when faced with obstacles that a man's true nature was revealed.

An answer to Yeon Seong came.

"Because the rest of the alliance is not faux Orthodox like you."

It was a heavy voice, ringing in the heads of the Qinghai Alliance members.

Everyone turned towards the voice.

It came from someone of the Demonic Cult, standing on a ship's deck.

A man wearing a black dragon embroidered robe.

The main warship. Black Dragon Robe.

There was no fool who could not guess the identity of the man after seeing both of those.

Yeon Seong, of course, also recognized the symbols.

“The Heavenly Demon!” Yeon Seong cried out in surprise.

The others swallowed saliva.

As they said, it was Woon-seong who appeared on deck.

He was younger than they expected, but they could not take him lightly.

It was because they had heard what this young man had done in Qaidam Basin.

The Heavenly Demon had dropped burning rocks from the sky, which fell like meteors upon Qaidam Basin.

According to the rumors they heard, the Heavenly Demon was not human.

So instead of underestimating him, they chose to be afraid.

The Qinghai Alliance felt their backs drenched with sweat.

On the contrary, Woon-seong’s gaze was filled with magnificence and dignity.

Towards such a Woon-seong, one of the sect leaders had a question.

Chapter 137: Heroes Among The Demonic (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 137 – Heroes Among the Demonic (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“What do you mean, fake?”

When he was asked that, Woon-seong snorted.

“I heard that you took, burned, and destroyed all the nearby ships because you were afraid that our Cult would use them. Is that what a proper sect would do?”

Woon-seong’s words were not spoken harshly.

But frostiness, like the northern wind, seemed to blow through the air.

Several sect members bowed their heads at his words, as if they were reproaching themselves.

Woon-seong looked at them and continued to say, “A hero is someone who does what everyone else is wishing someone else will do, even if it is difficult. Only those who walk down that road can be called a saint.”

Someone who walked the windy and narrow road.

That was something Nok Yu-on had told Woon-seong.

A hero's path was narrow, steep and dangerous.

So no one wished to walk it.

However, there were those who chose that path, knowing it would be lonely and difficult.

Those were saints and heroes.

Nok Yu-on, Woon-seong's master, was such a person.

Even though he knew the end, he walked confidently towards death.

Compared to him, the martial artists of the Qinghai Alliance could not be considered as saints.

No, they couldn't even be considered Orthodox.

Woon-seong sneered, "In that sense, you are not Orthodox."

"Khh, khh. "

Yeon Seong bit his lip. In his mind, he wanted to rush out there and cut off the head of the one talking.

But he could not.

He could tell the difference between himself and the Heavenly Demon without fighting.

However, he shouted, "What the hell does that have to do with anything!?"

Woon-seong glared at Yeon Seong.

Without realizing it, Yeon Seong took a step back.

What kind of gaze...

Woon-seong eyes flashed with gold and rippled with energy. Others may not know, but Intimidation Qi covered Qinghai Lake.

Of course, the concentration was not very high, but it covered the entire Qinghai fleet.

But even with minimum energy, it could exert great power over the situation. After all, it was difficult to make rational judgments when your mind was clouded with fear.

The Intimidation Qi dug into his heart and Yeon Seong was terrified.

While Yeon Seong was terrified of Woon-seong's eyes, Woon-seong the image of Jwa Do-gyul in Yeon Seong.

A man who lacked abilities, but liked to stand in front of people and pretend to be smart.

A man who stole from those lesser than himself and took advantage of others.

A man who despised peacemakers and orthodox rule-followers.

He's just like Jwa Do-gyul.

Woon-seong reached out a finger, still looking at Yeon Seong.

Yeon Seong felt like Woon-seong was pointing to himself. "I'll ask."

Rawr! Rawr!

Woon-seong's energy spread through the area, amplifying his voice. It was like thunder rolling across the entire Qinghai Lake.

It was so loud that even the civilians living near Qinghai Lake felt like the sky was ringing.

"Huhu."

The pressure from the voice made Yeon Seong sound a little insane.

Woon-seong continued to speak, not caring about Yeon Seong.

“Why should I answer your questions?”

Rawr! Rawr!

It was extremely arrogant. However, Yeon Seong could not refute.

He was the Heavenly Demon.

The enemy had no reason to explain anything to him. It was clear that there was something going on between the Qinghai Alliance and the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“It is hard to say that the rest of the Alliance is innocent!”

Yeon Seong cried out, like a final plea.

At that moment, light flashed from Woon-seong’s fingers.

Bang!

There was a loud explosion.

There was a blast of white light.

Boom!

It contained tremendous power, as it was one of the demonic arts of a Demonic King!

“Cough!”

Even though it was a single explosion, Yeon Seong felt like his insides were shattered.

“Cough.”

The pain was not an illusion

After coughing up blood, pieces of his innards started coming out.

“W-what..... ”

He looked at the viscera mixed with his own blood, his eyes trembling.

There was no one who could live with shattered veins and mangled internal organs.

Yeon Seong collapsed, eyes filled with disbelief.

The eyes of the other sect members shuddered as they watched him fall like that.

Woon-seong then pointed at the rest of them.

He seemed to be asking who was next.

“If you lived like that, you should at least take responsibility.”

At Woon-seong’s words, they bowed their heads further. What were they supposed to say?

Woon-seong looked down at them. According to what the Strategist said, some of them had been against taking the fishermen’s boats. Woon-seong was going to provoke them.

“Are you not upset that I am blaming you for what you didn’t do?”

At his words, some of them raised their heads.

It was hard to understand what Woon-seong was getting at.

Woon-seong only smiled at them.

“What’s that supposed to mean?” one of the sect leaders asked.

Looking at the ships lined up around him, Woon-seong said, "I am returning the ships you took from the fishermen and merchants back to their hands. It would be terrible to just leave so many ships floating in Qinghai Lake."

"Really?"

"Of course."

Woon-seong meant what he said.

In fact, he had already talked this over with Sang Gwan-chuk.

As soon as this battle was over, even the boats prepared by the demonic practitioners would be given to the fishermen.

Of course, this was not done because Woon-seong was some hero.

It was an act to gain public sentiment, so to better spread the religious doctrines of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Religion was about faith, about moving the mind and heart. It was better spread through favor than military action.

The hearts of the people were the will of Heaven.

Even if the Demonic Cult stepped foot in Qinghai, it would be useless if the religious doctrine failed to spread.

All calculations were meticulous.

However, Woon-seong's actions looked different to those in Qinghai.

Especially to those who had protested about taking the boats in the first place.

Regardless of Woon-seong's intentions, his actions had forced them to think differently.

Is that the demonic?

Is it an act?

Hmn.

Even the demonic had their own stories.

I thought that it was all bullshit the demonic did to defend themselves, but perhaps it wasn't all nonsense.

So he put his sword down.

Clunk.

“If the words of the Heavenly Demon are true, then this one will surrender.”

That man was only the first.

Here and there, several others began to drop their weapons.

Clang.

Thunk.

“The same is true of this one.”

“I will surrender too, Lord.”

As the sect leaders dropped their swords, so did the sect members under their command.

“Huh, huh?”

Those who were still holding their swords began to notice.

Even if you wanted to shout out “fight”, it had become a situation where that could not be shouted.

The initiative was already in the hands of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The Qinghai Alliance's people, who survived because of such an atmosphere, surrendered.

A white flag appeared above the ships, signifying surrender.

Watching that, Woon-seong's lips curled into a smile.

Qinghai Province was completely under the control of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It had been a month and a day since the Cult of the Heavenly Demon advanced into Zhongyuan.

Qinghai had already fallen.

The speed of this war was unprecedented.

* * *

Woon-seong kept his word.

Immediately after the battle in Qinghai Lake, the group began to distribute the boats to the nearby fishermen and merchants.

"How can I thank you for this..."

"I thought I was going to starve to death..."

"Thank you. Thank you very much."

The fishermen and merchants, whose livelihoods depended on boating in Qinghai Lake, bowed and thanked them.

The Demonic Captain, who was handing out the boats, told them, "Do not thank me, thank the God of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon."

"Yes?"

The civilians tilted their heads.

Looking at the direction of Woon-seong's barracks amongst the Demonic Army's camp, the Demonic Captain murmured, "I am not the one who ordered the boats to be distributed, it was the Cult Leader."

At the man's words, an old woman raised her head in that direction.

"If the Cult Leader had not been here, this one would have starved to death."

The old woman was just the beginning.

An elderly man, a father with a child, a middle-aged couple hand in hand, all came out to bow.

Some even donated to the Cult.

"It is a small sum compared to the price of one ship, but I wish to make a donation." Of course, the Cult did not stop them. donating. It was a small amount of money, but their intention was what was important.

As the situation continued, the number of civilians in the area who admired the Cult increased.

As he did in Qaidam Basin, Woon-seong exempted the region from various taxes for a period of time, including protection taxes.

Those who were thankful about the reign of the Demonic Cult were not just those who received ships.

Soon, there were tales praising the Demonic Cult throughout Qinghai.

When Woon-seong heard the news, he nodded with a satisfied expression.

"It is proceeding as planned."

Like he said, this plan had all been designed by Sang Gwan-chuk. It was Sang Gwan-chuk who understood that the essence of religion was the heart, not Hyuk Woon-seong.

“If it wasn’t for the Strategist, I wouldn’t have so much support.”

At Woon-seong’s praise, Sang Gwan-chuk lowered his head slightly. He then turned the ball back to Woon-seong, “It is genuine support. It’s all thanks to your generosity.”

Of course, that was not enough for Woon-seong.

He turned to look at the map calmly.

Sang Gwan-chuk also glanced down at the map.

On the map, the area corresponding to Qinghai was now completely covered in the colors of the Demonic Cult.

Wherever they went in Qinghai Province, it was not difficult to find the flags of the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong continued to stare at the map, looking slightly north.

Gansu.

Beyond the Jade Gate, the Western Army would be on standby. And if the allies in Qinghai Province advanced at the same time, they would be able to attack Gansu from both sides.

Woon-seong wasn’t sure why the Martial Alliance’s response had been so slow, but if it continued like this, it wouldn’t take long to capture Gansu Province.

Gansu...

Woon-seong’s eyes as he looked at Gansu shone with significance.

Chapter 138: Heroes Among The Demonic (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 138- Heroes Among the Demonic (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Following Qaidam Basin, the Qinghai Alliance was defeated by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon; rumors that Qinghai had been completely taken over spread throughout the world.

It was only natural that Murim fell into sorrow at the news of defeat.

But unlike the other provinces, Qinghai itself was quite peaceful.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon was not the notorious unorthodox bastards, as they had been told.

There was a certain degree of zealousness due to its religious foundations, but that was it.

They did not force their doctrines on others, but slowly sank into the people's hearts.

There was no persecution of surrendered martial artists. As long as a seal was left, the Cult recognized their existing sect-gates.

There was no need to burn or abandon the sects.

“I can’t believe the Cult of the Heavenly Demon is more peaceful than Murim.”

That came from the mouth of a weakly sect leader who had surrendered to the Cult, so it was no lie.

But funnily enough, those rumors did not escape Qinghai.

It was as if someone was tightly controlling the spread of information...

* * *

The New Dragon Battalion was similarly disappointed when they heard that Qinghai had fallen.

Captain of the New Dragon Battalion, Sa Ryong-hui, shook his head.

“It’s only been a few days but we’ve already lost Qinghai... I can’t believe the speed of the Demonic Cult.”

The other members of the New Dragon Battalion also nodded. Clearly, this Demonic Cult was different from back in the First Ortho-Demon War. It was clear that they had clear strategies in how to deal with Murim.

If they were not nervous, big trouble could happen.

Most of them felt that way, but not all.

“Well, it’s still the Demonic Cult. Other than large numbers, they have nothing going for them.”

The one who spoke was the second son of the Hebei Peng Clan.

Sa Ryong-hui whistled slightly. “You shouldn’t think like that. Don’t you know that losing vigilance is like risking half your life in battle? In addition, you must have heard that the Heavenly Demon is the same age as us, but his power is beyond our imagination.”

“Hmph, that’s definitely an exaggeration.” Peng Hak shook his head, then continued, “Besides, I heard that this Heavenly Demon is from some obscure family, so his origin is unclear. The Demonic Cult’s level is obvious if someone like him was made the Heavenly Demon.”

His remarks meant that origin and lineage were the most important conditions for a martial artist’s strength.

In fact, his words completely disregarded those from minor families.

His views often clashed with Sa Ryong-hui’s.

That was because Sa Ryong-hui was from a minor family.

It was also because of his strong self-esteem that Peng Hak had lost to Sa Ryong-hui several times as a trainee for the New Dragon Battalion.

Sa Ryong-hui sighed to himself. *I want to teach him a good lesson.*

But he did not do that. If the leader of the New Dragon Battalion argued with one of the members, the group would lose morale even before fighting.

Peng Hak continued to grumble, whether he knew Sa Ryong-hui’s thoughts or not.

But Sa Ryong-hui didn’t know.

Some people sympathized with Sa Ryong-hui, but more than half of the New Dragon Battalion members despised him.

In that atmosphere, Sa Ryong-hui spoke.

“It’s too late to head to Qinghai Province now.”

There were about 700 men in the New Dragon Battalion.

If they fought against the Demonic Army, it would be like using an egg to strike a rock.

A fight without a chance at victory.

At Sa Ryong-hui's words, the eldest daughter of the Shandong Yue Clan — the Pure Yue Family — shook her head and said, "So we're returning to the Alliance?"

"Return? We should charge and fight the Demonic Cult right now!" Peng Hak shouted loudly, swinging his blade.

Sa Ryong-hui sighed.

Yue's words were plausible, but Peng's words were just bullshit.

Of course, he did not say that aloud, for the same reasons he didn't raise his voice a moment ago.

I don't want to do either.

Sa Ryong-hui lowered his head for a moment. He then spoke to those of the New Dragon Battalion, who were looking at him.

"I asked for the Lord's orders in case something like this happened."

"What is it? "

"If the march of the Demonic Cult is too fast to stop, I was told to turn towards Gansu Province."

"Are you sure?"

Sa Ryong-hui nodded. Now that they ruled over Qinghai, it was clear that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would march towards Gansu from the east and the west.

There was a good chance the province would have to fight an enemy coming from both sides.

"It's probably not going to be an easy fight."

“Hmph, it doesn’t matter as long as I break some demon bones,” Peng Hak exclaimed.

Sa Ryong-hui smiled bitterly at the others.

With the exception of those who followed Peng Hak, the others nodded, as if they would heed Sa Ryong-hui’s words.

The New Dragon Battalion turned as soon as the sun came up.

It was the direction towards Gansu.

* * *

The sword in her hand moved lightly.

At times, it was like she was dancing. Other times, it swung heavily, as if to break rocks. Others again, zipping as fast as lightning.

And sometimes it was majestic like the flapping of butterfly wings.

Cheon Ah-young, who was wielding the sword, was like a dancer.

Her whole body was soaked in sweat. That was because she was working hard in order to play the role of vanguard.

She would not disappoint Woon-seong, who had appointed her as general of the Western Army.

She also wanted to avenge her father, Cheon Hwi. To do that, strength was essential.

Shh. Shh.

Cheon Ah-young flipped in the air. The iron bracers restraining her arms and legs were no longer a problem.

I should make them heavier.

Cheon Ah-young smiled at the iron bracers, which she could barely feel.

At the same time, her left hand moved, as if drawing in the air. A complicated seal appeared.

It was a technique.

One that only the Divine Maiden could use!

“Hap!”

Leaves that were lying on the ground flashed into the air.

At the same time, she reached out with a hand.

Fababat-

The leaves flew like throwing stars and stuck into the ground, flower petals seeming to swirl in the air.

If martial artists had seen it, they would have been amazed at her use of the Crimson Leaf Illusion.

However, this was a technique passed to the Divine Maiden, not a martial art like the Crimson Leaf Illusion.

Although powerful, it lacked a lot compared to the real Crimson Leaf Illusion.

But it was enough to deceive the eyes of an opponent.

It was obvious that those who did not understand would be surprised.

Cheon Ah-young practiced several techniques, one after another.

Divinity of the Maiden flowed around her.

Cheon Ah-young’s movements were smooth, even though she performed both swordsmanship and divine techniques.

While she was wondering how to be stronger than anyone else, she had recognized the techniques that only she was capable of performing — she had tried to use divine sorcery and martial arts at the same time. Of course, it took a lot of effort to use it naturally like now.

At this level, she could say her efforts were not in vain.

Number 900, or the Leader, would be surprised.

Cheon Ah-young wiped her sweat as she stretched her last sword move.

She suddenly thought of Woon-seong, but shook her head.

“Phew. Phew. ”

Her breathing also quickly stabilized.

At this time, a woman approached Cheon Ah-young.

“Unni, no, milady.”

Cheon Ah-young turned towards the voice and recognized the woman.

The name was Moon Young, I think.

She had graduated from the Cave of Latent Demons with Cheon Ah-young, working in the White Ape Unit together. When Cheon Ah-young was Captain of the White Ape Unit, this woman had called her ‘unni’.

That’s why Cheon Ah-young replied in a friendly manner.

“When it’s just us, you can call me unni.”

“Really?”

“Of course.”

At Cheon Ah-young’s words, Moon Young smiled.

In fact, she was lonely inside the White Ape Unit after Cheon Ah-young became the new Divine Maiden.

One of the few female officers she was close to had suddenly disappeared, so it was reasonable.

Cheon Ah-young was also not acquainted with many other female unit members, but she had a close relationship with Moon Young.

However, she had become the Divine Maiden and now the general of the Western Army.

But it made Moon Young happy to hear that she was still allowed to call Cheon Ah-young ‘unni’.

It was because she realized that she was not alone in thinking they were close.

“Thank you, unni.”

“No need to say thank you between us.”

Cheon Ah-young smiled shyly. She had returned to the White Ape Unit to see Moon Young more often.

So she thought she should take care of this sister more.

Moon Young approached and handed over a dry towel.

Cheon Ah-young wiped off her sweat and asked, “What’s going on?”

No matter how close they were, Moon Young did not visit during her training.

It was because this would interfere with practice.

However, since Moon Young was here now, she clearly had something to say.

Something important must have happened.

If it was just personal business, no matter how urgent, Moon Young would have endured until after Ah-young came out.

To her question, Moon Young took out a letter from her pockets.

“It is a letter from the Cult Leader.”

“A letter from the battlefield.”

Cheon Ah-young took the letter from Moon Young and unfolded it.

The letter was not very long, but the contents were clear.

It was a letter saying that it was finally time for Cheon Ah-young to draw her sword and defeat her enemies.

Cheon Ah-young’s face slowly hardened as she read the letter.

After finishing, she muttered in a calm and restrained voice.

“Finally, to Gansu...”

After a few more days, the Western Army of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon began to advance beyond the Jade Gate and towards Gansu.

As if responding, their eastern comrades occupying Qinghai Province also began to march towards Gansu.

The New Dragon Battalion also began to move towards Gansu.

It seemed that the fight for Gansu would be extremely intense.

Chapter 139: Trace Of Chopsticks (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 139 – Trace of Chopsticks (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Just as advancement of the eastern allies was unstoppable, so was the advancement of the Western Army.

Led by Cheon Ah-young, the White Ape Unit pushed through the Jade Gate and into Gansu without hesitation.

Gansu Province, which was the second to be attacked, suffered greatly.

Elsewhere, the Demonic Army marched from the southern part of Gansu northward.

But it was more terrifying that the army just marched through the Jade Gate. In fact, Gansu's Martial Alliance could be considered quite large, but they collapsed at a rapid pace.

Importantly, the five large sects in Gansu had major weaknesses when compared to other major sects in other regions.

Usually, in areas without major sects, there would be other powers that rose to the top. But that was not the case for Gansu.

It was because Gansu was adjacent to Xinjiang, the territory of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Other than the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort, most orthodox martial artists were not willing to come towards this area.

Only the sects who had lived in Gansu for generations continued to defend the region.

The only places that could resist were the Dunhuang Baek Clan and the Iron Wind Cloud Fort.

Among them, the Dunhuang Baek Clan was not one of the Five Noble Clans, but was well-known in Gansu.

Five Noble Clans.

Five was a small number.

However, there were countless family clans who lived under the Heavens like stars. Being part of the Five Noble Clans simply meant that you had tremendous power over Murim.

Of course, the pride of the Dunhuang Baek was great.

That was why Baek Muk-ryong, the head of the Dunhuang Baek Clan, kept shouting.

“If the Cult of the Heavenly Demon arrives, we cannot stop them with the power of the Dunhuang Baek, but we can at least face them with pride.”

In fact, he had reached a peak in swordsmanship.

No, he could squeeze a piece of metal with his hands alone, so he could be considered a Peak-Level martial artist.

He was confident in himself.

That's why, when the letter from the Cult of the Heavenly Demon asking them to surrender arrived, Baek Muk-ryong immediately burned it.

That wasn't enough, so he also cut off the nose and ears of the demonic messenger.

That was an unfair act of war.

To Baek Muk-ryong, the words asking for surrender had insulted the pride of the Dunhuang Baek.

So even if he thought it was too much to kill the messenger, he still did it. He anticipated that it would provoke outrage from the Demonic Cult, but he thought that he could at least last long enough to escape safely.

Despite retreating, Qinghai had been able to do nothing.

So what if he retreated?

The Demonic Army vastly outnumbered them.

Even if Baek Muk-ryong chose to retreat, there would be no one to blame him.

No, actually, if they safely retreated, there would be more people that recognized the power of the Dunhuang Baek Clan.

At least, that was what Baek Muk-ryong believed.

Unfortunately, he had chosen the wrong opponent.

Very wrong, indeed.

Baek Muk-ryong, who had proposed a martial exchange in hopes of stalling the Western Army, was beheaded after 20 seconds.

His opponent was Cheon Ah-young.

“Sorcery—”

Baek Muk-ryong's head, which was rolling on the floor now, muttered unconsciously. He didn't even recognize his own death.

"That's right."

Cheon Ah-young did not deny his words. As he said, Cheon Ah-young's divine techniques were closer to illusionary arts.

Of course, it was much more than that, but it could be taken as ritualistic to the Orthodox.

There was nothing strange about them calling it sorcery.

Looking at the internal energy, she and Baek Muk-ryong were roughly on par.

Even if they fought for 100 seconds, it would be hard to determine a winner.

But once divine power was added, Cheon Ah-young vastly out-powered him.

Using her divine powers, Cheon Ah-young could even fight with Transcendence Level masters. That wasn't something Baek Muk-ryong could handle.

Strange techniques flew through the air and all sorts of illusions arose, disturbing Baek Muk-ryong.

In other words, Baek Muk-ryong was basically fighting with all five of his senses blocked, against an equal leveled elite.

"Go, Lord—"

The expressions of the Dunhuang Baek, who saw their lord's head go flying before 20 seconds even passed, were spectacular.

Then Cheon Ah-young slowly pointed her sword towards the other members of the Baek Clan.

“White Ape Unit, forward.”

Short but decisive.

Just enough to condemn the Baek Clan to death.

The White Ape Unit rushed into the clan house.

Whoa-whoa-whoa.

The rest of the Western Army poured in after them.

Since they had forsaken the practices of war and touched even the messengers, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon showed no mercy.

Less than a month after the outbreak of war, the Dunhuang Baek were wiped out of existence.

* * *

Moving from Qinghai to Gansu, the allies on the eastern front stopped when Gansu was right before them.

It wasn't because they encountered other disturbances or violent resistance.

They had stopped at the Qilian Mountains.

The Qilian Mountains were near the city of Jiuquan [1], where the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort was located — a region that would likely be used as a main battlefield. In addition, the high altitude and abundant water sources made it a good place to stop.

That was also why the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort had been built in this region, in order to protect the city of Jiuquan.

There, the New Dragon Battalion had also stopped in the Qilian Mountains.

The Eastern Army needed to join the Western Army in order to make a two-pronged attack.

If the two armies attacked from both sides, the strongholds built on the Qilian Mountains would not last long.

And so Sang Gwan-chuk had the army stop as they planned for the operation.

So the army set up camp.

Woon-seong spoke to Sang Gwan-chuk, "I need to head to the Qilian Mountains for a while."

Sang Gwan-chuk tilted his head in response. At the same time, his expression had hardened. "The Qilian Mountains is where the enemy has been preparing for war with our Cult. Are you saying you want to go there alone?"

Woon-seong nodded. Of course, he also knew what the Strategist was worried about.

"I'm not going to fight."

"Wouldn't it be better to send an envoy if you're encouraging them to surrender?"

"I'm not encouraging surrender."

At his words, Sang Gwan-chuk seemed more confused.

Woon-seong sighed, explaining, "My real destination is not the Qilian Mountains, but a village about a day away."

In fact, there was no significant difference between the Qilian Mountains and a village a day away from the Qilian Mountains for Sang Gwan-chuk.

There would be a lot of soldiers from the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort and the New Dragon Battalion nearby.

Was that all?

There were also several factions gathered around Gansu, who had united under the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort.

Although they weren't very strong, the number was not small.

If they all joined together, it would be an enormous force.

Moreover, the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort.

Iron Sword Yoon Jahryung became known to the Martial Alliance through his independent group of soldiers.

That was why the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort got its name.

There was a group of iron swords viciously defending this area.

Yoon Jah-ryung had survived for a long time here and served as an executive; they could not ignore someone who had led such a massive force.

For Sang Gwan-chuk, it was natural for him to worry about Woon-seong.

“If you must go, tell me why.”

When asked, Woon-seong sighed once more.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon was a group with fanaticism, but it was still a powerhouse of Kangho.

That was why Woon-seong could not just make decisions on his own.

Moreover, now that he had seen Sang Gwan-chuk's eyes, Woon-seong felt like he owed the man a good reason.

“I have some kids to pick up.”

“Kids to pick up...?”

Sang Gwan-chuk did not know about the Kang siblings Woon-seong had promised to take care of during his trip to Zhongyuan.

“I don’t know which children you are talking about, but why don’t you just send someone?”

Woon-seong shook his head with a smile. “There are things that I need to check before I bring them... I made a promise, so it’s best that I do it myself.”

Originally, he should have picked them up when he returned to the Heavenly Mountains.

But the situation had been too urgent at the time, since the Martial Alliance had attacked demonic branches, and he was unable to do so.

Sang Gwan-chuk sighed after some time. *His eyes right now are just like when he told me he was going to Zhongyuan to meet with King Jinseong.*

Even then, Sang Gwan-chuk had no choice but to accept that Woon-seong was leaving.

“The Leader is a man of secrets.”

Woon-seong laughed bitterly. *As he says, I have many secrets.* Of course, going to the Qilian Mountains could not be considered a secret. So Woon-seong took a moment to tell the man about the Kang siblings.

Sang Gwan-chuk listened to his story carefully before sighing again.

“What a selfish and embarrassing choice the sister made.”

“I liked that.”

Sang Gwan-chuk chuckled. Soon, he spoke with seriousness: “If the boy does what the Leader says and the Leader takes him in, the boy cannot become the Young Leader. I am sure you are aware of that.”

It was as he said.

One of the traditions of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon required the Cult Leader to be of the Cheon Family.

It was possible for Woon-seong to rise to the position of Cult Leader because Cheon Hwi, the former cult leader, had no son and only a daughter, Cheon Ah-young.

“What I am going to pass down is not the Divine Art, but my spearmanship.”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded at that.

Overwhelmed by the power of the Divine Art, he had forgotten Woon-seong’s beginnings with the spear.

“Right, the Leader also had spearmanship.”

He sighed.

I feel like I am sighing a lot lately.

Sang Gwan-chuk sighed again and nodded. “If you must go, you’d better wear something other than the Black Dragon Robe. I will have them prepare another set for you.”

“Thank you.”

To his words, Sang Gwan-chuk could only bitterly smile. “I have more things to worry about again.”

[1] the city of Jiuquan used to be known as Suzhou

Chapter 140: Trace Of Chopsticks (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 140 – Trace of Chopsticks (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Back to less than a month after the war between the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and the Martial Alliance had broken out.

Due to the war, the commercial area near the Qilian Mountains was actually booming.

Since the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort would soon become a battlefield, many martial artists surged into the area.

It was not just martial artists.

Merchants who made money from the war also began to gather around the Qilian Mountains.

The merchants in the area were quite busy.

It wasn't that they weren't afraid of war. But wasn't this a war that stayed between the martial artists of Murim?

Very few civilians were involved in battles between Murim, except in special cases, like what happened in Qinghai. In addition, Iron Sword Yoon

Jae-ryong was famous for his cooperation and character.

Unlike in Qinghai, there was no exploitation of the civilians by the militia.

In that situation, the merchants in the area happily set up shop.

The Golden Sunset Inn was not an exception.

They made food without rest and Kang So-san helped his sister serve the food without rest.

“When is the stir-fried meat coming out here? ”

“A little more vegetables too! ”

“Another bottle! ”

The orders were neverending.

In the meantime, it was clear that the workload was difficult for such a young boy.

Moreover, Kang So-san was smaller than other children, making the physical labor even harder.

Nevertheless, Kang So-san never stopped.

It was because he knew that he was not the only one struggling.

Noona must have it harder than me.

All he had to do was serve the food, but she had to stand in front of the fire and cook all day.

He could feel the heat just standing close by, but she had to spend more than half the day in front of the flames.

So Kang So-san did not rest.

He continued to work, encouraging himself to keep going. It was past midnight by the time the guests left.

Until then, Kang So-san and his sister worked tirelessly.

If I had somewhere to lie down, I'd fall asleep right here.

But he did not rest.

Instead, he sat on the floor and closed his eyes. As he began to repeat the mnemonics in his head, warmth bloomed beneath his naval.

Kang So-san continued to meditate and this warmth spread throughout his body.

Soon, warmth could be felt everywhere.

So this is internal energy.

He had never learned about martial arts properly, but he had still heard a lot about it. That was how Kang So-san could determine who was truly strong.

Whenever he repeated the verse Woon-seong taught him, energy would bloom in his dantian.

How long had he been practicing?

Kang So-san slowly got up from his seat, taking one last deep breath. He then went to pick something up from the corner, near the cupboard.

It was a stick wrapped in cloth.

No, it was not a stick.

When the cloth was unwrapped, it revealed a cheap sword.

It wasn't very expensive.

It was a shabby sword that could be bought at a cheap price from any forge.

But Kang So-san stared at the sword like it was a treasure.

He then slowly began to swing it while breathing.

Shua, shua, shua.

The sound of sword slashes cut through the air.

The direction in which the sword moved was always constant.

From the bottom left to the top left. The trajectory of the sword continued diagonally.

This coincidentally matched with one mark carved into the inn's walls. After some time, he stopped swinging to look at the marking. Then he started to swing once again.

What was he thinking of?

Kang So-san grabbed his sword and stepped out of the inn.

Moonlight shone through the clouds, illuminating the Qilian Mountains.

The place where Kang So-san was headed was a stone bridge across the nearby river.

The pillars supporting the bridge were wide and flat.

Kang So-san grabbed his sword and stared at the stone bridge.

He just looked for a while.

The moonlight reflected across his blade and Kang So-san made a diagonal slash. Kagagaga-

Kang So-san's sword scratched at the stone pillar, creating a diagonal gash.

It was not a pattern made by the sword slicing through the stone, but a mark formed by scraping it down.

It was impossible for Kang So-san to cut stone less than a year after practicing martial arts.

But Kang So-san was not disappointed.

He compared Woon-seong's markings to his own.

Every time he looked at Woon-seong's mark, the difference between them would naturally come to mind.

If it were a tree and not stone, could my blade leave such a trace?

Kang So-san shook his head lightly as he asked himself.

It doesn't matter.

I have to try a little harder.

Kang So-san grabbed his sword again, continuing to swing at the pillar.

And there were eyes watching Kang So-san from a slight distance away.

So-san.

It was his sister.

Kang Ye-ha's gaze was filled with a mixture of worry and pride.

I worry that he is working too hard and not resting enough.

But she was filled with pride at his determination to continue.

She watched him until Kang So-san finished training.

A wind blowing from somewhere rustled their clothing.

Wheeing —

* * *

“Fantastic.”

Sa Ryong-hui, who visited the Golden Sunset Inn to eat, was amazed.

The New Dragon Battalion had settled inside the Qilian Mountains, but came to the village to scout the area.

“It’s really amazing.”

As he continued to admire, the other members of the New Dragon Battalion gathered beside him.

Despite the food being served, Sa Ryong-hui continued to admire the walls of the inn.

“What’s so great about it? ”

“Please let me know too. ”

The ones who had approached were members of the Sichuan Tang Clan, including Tang So-bong.

As soon as they approached, Sa Ryong-hui was awakened from his musings. Slightly embarrassed, he pointed to the wall with his finger. “Oh, pardon me. Isn’t that scar amazing?”

“You mean the blade mark?”

Their gazes shifted along where he was pointing. Peng Hak, who was sitting down, also moved his head, even though he wasn’t very interested.

Where he was pointing, they saw the marks on the inn’s wall.

A small mark across the wall.

“Oh, there’s really a scar.”

Seeing it, Tang Han-mae added, “It’s quite crude.”

Tang So-bong tilted her head and asked, “Isn’t it just a blade mark? What’s so great about some blade marking?”

She wouldn’t be the only one questioning. Tang Han-mae shook her head, Peng Hak snorted.

“Hmph.”

Sa Ryong-hui shrugged at their actions, slowly approaching the wall of the inn.

With the tip of his fingers, he swiped at the mark. It was smooth, like it was all one clear stroke.

“It’s a straight slash. I can’t believe someone can swing a sword so perfectly...”

“Is that so hard? Even some random ten-year-old boy can swing a sword in a straight line,” Tang So-bong said.

Sa Ryong-hui shook his head. “It is simple, of course. But it is difficult to make such a straight cut like this. Among those who are confident that they can make such a cut, those who can do it perfectly can be counted on one hand.”

“Is it so impressive?”

Sa Ryong-hui nodded. He continued to look at the mark with admiration. “It’s amazing because it’s just a straight slash, there’s no waste of power at all.”

His gaze turned to the edge of the mark. He then turned to look at the other walls of the inn, since this one had been cut to the depth of a knuckle. *I knew it.*

There was not a single crack in the walls of the inn. Apparently, although the mark seemed to be quite old, it looked exactly the same as the day it was made.

A deadly sword.

A sword of death used to cut the walls by a skilled swordsman.

I can feel the stench of death here.

However, Sa Ryong-hui was not terribly repulsed. The sword might have been used to kill those of the Black Way.

Saving people is not about the sword of life, but about the chivalrous heart.

Suddenly, Sa Ryong-hui was curious about the person who left this sword mark.

“Let me ask you something.”

“Yes, sir. What is the problem?”

The one he asked was Kang So-san.

Kang So-san felt strange to see these unknown martial artists keep staring at the traces on the inn’s wall.

“Do you know who left that sword mark?” Sa Ryong-hui asked.

Kang So-san titled his head, “That isn’t from a sword.”

At his words, Tang Han-mae and Tang So-bong looked up, confused. Even Peng Hak stood up.

“Everyone can see that it’s a sword mark, but you’re saying it’s not? Is this little brat trying to trick us?”

As Peng Hak approached, Kang So-san stepped back unconsciously.

“It really isn’t from a sword.”

“Hey, you little brat! ”

As Peng Hak became angrier and his voice got louder, someone else's voice could be heard.

"It really is not a sword mark."

"N-Noona!"

The group's gaze shifted towards Kang Ye-ha.

Kang Ye-ha picked up a pair of chopsticks from the cups on the table and said, "It was made by a chopstick, not a sword."

"With chopsticks?"

Among the well-crafted swords, there were some with smoothened surfaces to help the flow of qi.

The skill of the swordsman was so excellent I thought it had to be because of his weapon, but chopsticks?

Sa Ryong-hui pulled out a pair of chopsticks. "I'll ask you again. You're saying this is what made that sword mark?"

"Yes, he just pulled out a pair of chopsticks and made that mark."

Sa Ryong-hui's eyes shook at her words. *Kangho is large and there are many strong people.*

Sa Ryong-hui traced the marking with his finger. Immediately after, he looked at Kang So-san and asked, "Did he say he would take you with him if you could replicate this marking?"

Kang So-san nodded hurriedly.

Sa Ryong-hui asked, "If you don't mind, can you show me what you've practiced?"

Chapter 141: Collect (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 141 – Collect (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Kang So-san, who held the sword in his hand, looked around with a dumbfounded look on his face.

The other members of the New Dragon Battalion were looking at him with mild interest.

Only Sa Ryong-hui was carefully looking at So-san.

“Swing your sword.”

Kang So-san once again looked around, gripping his sword tightly.

He then got into position to swing his sword with a determined look.

In fact, Sa Ryong-hui had a pretty good impression of Kang So-san so far.

The traces on the wall left by Woon-seong were the source of admiration, but the true value was recognized by Sa Ryong-hui.

Shua.

The scrap sword in Kang So-san’s hands split the air.

There was a flash as the blade slashed through the air.

Sa Rong-hui, who was watching, slowly lowered his head. He made a “pfft”, as he was unable to contain his laughter.

It was obviously pitiful, but he didn’t have to tell Kang So-san anything, in case it made the young boy sad.

Kang So-san was too tense as he gripped his sword.

You use more power than necessary when swinging. Sa Ryong-hui sighed.

“You said that the person who left this mark would accept you as his disciple if you could replicate it?”

“Yes,” Kang So-san nodded.

Sa Ryong-hui looked at the mark again. *Perfect energy control.*

“These traces can’t be mimicked by a child like you. Even a man who’s been practicing the sword for over a decade wouldn’t be confident he could make a mark like this.”

“Is it that impressive?” Peng Hak asked, disapproving of Sa Ryong-hui’s conclusion. “I think we could do it if we tried. Don’t give the man too much credit.”

Sa Ryong-hui shrugged, not wanting to provoke Peng Hak more. “You and I have different opinions. Anyways, it’s just what I think. And if I’m right, maybe this guy didn’t leave the mark hoping that the boy could perfectly replicate it.”

He raised a finger, pressing it into the carved notch on the wall. It went to the first joint.

“Look how deep this is.”

Peng Hak did not argue. Although he did not like what Sa Ryong-hui was saying, he agreed that it was a deep mark.

No one in their right mind would think that an untrained child could make such a perfect sword cut.

Peng Hak turned slightly more solemn and Sa Ryong-hui asked, “How long have you been cultivating?”

“It hasn’t been one year.”

Impressive. Sa Ryong-hui said, “Not bad.”

It wasn’t an empty compliment.

Although it wasn’t terrific, given that it had been less than a year, the boy’s muscle development seemed pretty good.

That way, it wasn’t impossible to offer some pointers.

“Are you cultivating internal strength?”

Kang So-san nodded.

Sa Ryong-hui quickly reached out and grabbed hold of his wrist.

If Kang So-san had experience in Murim, he would never have allowed some stranger to grab his wrist — since he would know what it meant to show his wrist to someone else.

However, Kang So-san was just an ordinary boy who had barely begun cultivating and had no experience in Murim.

That’s why he relaxed and allowed Sa Ryong-hui to read his pulse.

“Three months, or something like that. It’s not a lot of energy, but it’s pure. Maybe it could be filled faster if the energy was impure.”

Sa Ryong-hui let his wrist go. “Will you swing once again?”

At first, Kang So-san swung the sword because the man was interested in the markings on the wall.

But it was different now.

Now the man knew what the story was.

So Kang So-san asked, “Why?”

Sa Ryong-hui smiled and responded, “Don’t you want to make a trace like that? I can give you a bit of help.”

Sa Ryong-hui smiled, filled with good energy. *What’s wrong with helping the boy a little?*

Seeing the smile, Kang Ye-ha was slightly worried. The people in front of her were strangers. Strong ones, at that.

Otherwise, the other guests would have been complaining. But the other patrons were quietly minding their own businesses.

Still, expert advice would be of great help to So-san.

Kang So-san wielded his sword once more.

He wasn’t as tense as before, but it was still way off.

He was far from the level of striking with internal energy, rather than relying on physical muscle.

Sa Ryong-hui quickly realized the problem. “Why don’t you hold the sword more loosely?”

Kang So-san tilted his head. “Doesn’t making such a mark need a lot of strength?”

“Of course, but what you need to use is not the strength of your arm.”

Sa Ryong-hui pressed the area under Kang So-san’s navel gently. It was the same place where he felt warmth when he cultivated.

“Think of this area as a vessel for something. Imagine pulling the energy contained here like you are drawing water from a well and sending it into the sword.”

“What does that have to do with grasping the sword loosely?”

“Gripping the sword means that unnecessary force will enter. In addition, technique and breathing are things that come to mind naturally. If you grip too tightly, your mind will become tense and your spirit will wander, preventing you from properly exerting strength.”

It was natural for someone to realize this after studying martial arts for a while.

But Kang So-san was young and inexperienced.

Did he realize something from those words?

Kang So-san closed his eyes and tried to follow Sa Ryong-hui’s words.

There wasn’t an epiphany or sudden enlightenment, but he seemed to know what to do.

A simple piece of advice, through which he couldn’t help but slightly improve.

“Let me try again.”

This time, Kang So-san asked Sa Ryong-hui to look at his sword movements.

Sa Ryong-hui nodded.

Let’s loosen my grip first.

Kang So-san loosened the grip on his sword. The sword in his hands started to rattle.

It was because he was using too much energy.

Kang So-san tightened his grip to steady the blade.

Carefully, he experimented with his strength and grip, like he was cradling a small bird in his hands.

As he did so, he continued to imagine: *Like drawing water from a well...*

Of course, it wasn't easy.

It was not something that he could do at the first try, just because he told himself to do it.

However, he continued to imagine. He was eager to do it and to do it well.

He didn't know when the person who made the promise would return, but until then, he wanted to make a mark just like him.

Like drawing water...

It seemed like something happened.

All of a sudden, his spirit moved and followed the will of the qi. Something warm spread through Kang So-san's body.

Kang So-san did not miss this change, dragging it towards his fingertips.

Right now!

“Hiya!”

He wielded his sword in a practiced maneuver. Kang So-san's sword slashed diagonally.

This time, something amazing happened.

The sword was swung much smoother than any other time before this.

It was also much more powerful.

Even though nothing truly happened, just the usage of qi was intimidating enough.

“Wow!” Kang So-san exclaimed subconsciously.

Sa Ryong-hui turned to him and said, “Now you can be unashamed and call yourself a martial artist.”

As he said, Kang So-san still lacked experience, but what he just did was on the boundary between an ordinary civilian and a martial artist.

Sa Ryong-hui did not know whether Kang So-san would be able to continue down this road, but he had at least directed the boy onto the right path. Whether the boy had the strength to carry on was up to himself.

“Thank you!”

Kang So-san hurriedly bowed and thanked, noticing his own swing was much different than before.

Sa Ryong-hui nodded and looked back at the sword mark left on the walls of the inn with a complicated expression.

“I’d love to meet the man who made this mark.”

After all the guests who came during the day returned home, a tranquil silence covered the inn as always.

Inside, Kang So-san was relying on the light of a small oil lamp to stare at the walls of the inn.

To be precise, he was staring at the sword mark, not at the wall.

In his head, he remembered what happened earlier today.

Although his swing had gotten stronger, it felt like the internal energy accumulated in his body had been reduced by more than half.

It was hard to do that with a sword, so how hard must it be to leave such a trace with chopsticks?

It didn't look very hard to that man at all. Then again, that was the same guy who hurled chopsticks into the air and killed several people in an instant.

It couldn't have been very hard for such a person to leave a trace like this.

Maybe it's a good thing I didn't tell them about that.

Instead of looking at the mark, he suddenly thought about those who had helped him earlier. No matter how much he thought about it, Kang So-san had not told them about how the mysterious man had used chopsticks to kill his enemies.

He couldn't even believe his eyes, so how could they believe his words?

Thank you, though. I can't believe you let me use your sword for a while.

Kang So-san thought of Sa Ryong-hui and smiled. Thanks to his advice, he was able to get a better grasp of the blade.

When he thought about it, he was suddenly curious. With a burst of qi, would he be able to leave such a mark on the walls of the inn?

Shall I try?

Kang So-san thought he should and so carefully picked up his sword.

That's when the bell at the entrance to the inn rang.

Ding~

Someone walked inside.

Chapter 142: Collect (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 142 – Collect (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

It was very late.

They had run out of ingredients and there were no customers left.

The chef was doing the last bits of work, preparing to finish off the day.

In such a situation, a late visitor had arrived.

Why does this situation feel familiar?

Kang So-san opened his mouth, skillfully speaking to the customer without sounding embarrassed at all.

“My apologies, but the kitchen is closed—”

Kang So-san never finished his sentence.

His mouth fell open.

He knew who this late visitor to the Golden Sunset Inn was.

“You’re here!” Kang So-san shouted, smiling brightly.

There was a polite and slightly cold response, “You do not have to shout like that.”

The owner of the voice was Woon-seong. He was not in the Black Dragon Robe which symbolized the Heavenly Demon, but in plain clothes to keep his promise.

“Haha.”

There was very little warmth in Woon-seong’s words, but Kang So-san still laughed.

“Ah!”

At that time, Kang Ye-ha, who had come outside to check on the commotion, exclaimed. “You are here, sir.”

Is that still my sister? Kang So-san wondered as Kang Ye-ha left the kitchen area and quietly greeted Woon-seong.

Woon-seong nodded lightly. His eyes soon turned to the sword in Kang So-san’s hands.

It was a scrap sword, but it seemed that the grip was worn. The boy must have worked hard with the sword for a long time.

Then I’ll check if he’s completed his assignment.

The plan was to have Kang So-san inherit the Spear Master Sect. Of course, that was only if Kang So-san could pass Woon-seong’s test.

The Spear Master Sect’s foundations are in academia. No matter how hard you try, if you are not talented, you will never be able to go far. That is why I need to know how far you’ve come in this short time.

Recalling the conditions for the Spear Master Sect, Woon-seong told Kang So-san, “Then let me check right now.”

“Yes?”

Woon-seong had barely entered the inn, but he was already asking to see the boy's progress.

Kang So-san was surprised.

Woon-seong replied, "Why? Are you not confident?"

Actually, Kang So-san wasn't confident. There was some accomplishment, but he was not confident that he could make a mark on the wall.

But if he said he wasn't confident, it was likely Woon-seong would turn around and leave.

"Oh, no."

Kang So-san gripped his scrap sword tightly. He then realized he was overly tense and slightly relaxed his hands.

When Woon-seong saw that, something meaningful flashed through his eyes.

It was hard to tell, but there seemed to be some direction to the force applied.

Meanwhile, Kang So-san was staring at the blade marks left by Woon-seong.

Yes, you can do it, Kang So-san told himself.

You must replicate that mark. That way, you can learn how to be strong and protect your sister.

But what if I fail?

Even though he was determined, it was natural for a lump of anxiety to form in his heart.

Kang So-san shook his head.

Let's focus.

It was not just about drawing energy into the sword, but also about how to draw on more power.

A lot of thoughts crossed his mind.

Suddenly, a thought stuck to him. It was something a local merchant named Mr. Guang had told him several years ago.

“You don't just need strong arms to lift a large rock, but strength from the soles of your feet and ankles...”

Kang So-san began to concentrate.

From the lowest point of his body, a mysterious energy began to flow.

From ankle to waist, from waist to shoulder.

And then from shoulder to wrist.

He sent the strength into his arms, like drawing water from a well.

At that moment!

Scrape—!

Kuakuakua—!

With a slightly cutting sound, Kang So-san's sword dug into the wall of the inn. However, he continued to push down without hesitation. When the sword was pulled back, there was a new mark on the wall of the inn.

It was similar to the one Woon-seong left, but a little more rugged.

Woon-seong contemplated.

Did you use your entire body to cover your lack of stamina?

It was not enough to say that it was good. But couldn't he tell that the boy was trying his best, physically and mentally?

Given that the period of time was less than one year, it was quite an accomplishment given that he had only been taught one core technique.

Instead of praising Kang So-san with a satisfied expression, Woon-seong merely said, "Not bad."

The boy had a long way to go.

If he got praised and was satisfied with just this, then there would be no further development. Nevertheless, was he happy to hear Woon-seong's words?

Kang So-san had a bright smile on his face. The same was true of Kang Ye-ha, who was watching from the side.

"It's not there yet, but it's a decent imitation."

"Then..."

Woon-seong nodded. Kang So-san had done his part, so it was Woon-seong's turn to keep his promise.

But there was one important problem remaining.

Woon-seong raised his finger and pointed at the ground.

"What will you do about this inn?"

Kang Ye-ha responded without losing her smile, "Us siblings will return here one day."

Instead of handing the inn to another person, they decided to just close for the time being. At first, they thought about selling it to someone else, but eventually changed their minds.

This was a place their parents had struggled for a long time to have. It was the Kang sibling's home.

They could not sell it away so easily.

So they decided to temporarily close.

They did not know when, but they would eventually return to this place.

Of course, Woon-seong did not say anything. *I have no right to decide in the first place.*

This inn belonged to the two siblings. Still, it was somewhere they had lived for a long time, could they truly just close and leave?

After leaving the Qilian Mountains, Kang Ye-ha continued to stare in the direction of the inn and Kang So-san gripped his sister's hands tightly.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon's camp was not far from where Kang So-san and his sister lived.

But that was by the standards of a martial artist.

It would be hard for two siblings who had never trained in martial arts to travel such long distances.

“Huff. Huff. ”

Kang Ye-Ha gasped for breath, sweat dripping from her chin. Kang So-san helped his sister, encouraging her.

However, Kang So-san was also struggling.

Looking at them, Woon-seong lightly tapped on their shoulders.

A breath of warm qi permeated into their bodies, through his hands. It quickly spread through their bodies, stabilizing their breathing.

Feeling it's astonishing ability, the two siblings opened their eyes and bowed. "Thank you, esteemed sir."

Woon-seong nodded lightly and looked up at the sky. It was taking them too much time to move.

I have no choice then.

Whee!

Woon-seong let out a low whistle. The sound rose and echoed into the sky.

And soon.

Flap-flap.

A flying animal dove through the clouds towards Woon-seong.

It was a black eagle.

A giant black eagle, seeming to have a wingspan of a meter and a half.

The bird dropped like a stone, shooting downwards. It then flapped its wings in front of Woon-seong, wind billowing around it.

Due to the eagle's large wings, the winds were quite strong. In addition, the glossy feathers of the bird were clear to see.

"Wow."

Kang So-san's eyes were wide as he exclaimed in amazement. *I've never seen such a large bird before.*

Kang Ye-ha did not make a sound, but she was similarly amazed.

What Woon-seong had called for was a quaint creature called the Thousand Li Black Eagle.

Sang Gwan-chuk had asked Woon-seong to use it if he ever needed to contact him, since it was always roaming the skies above Woon-seong and the Strategist.

Of course, it was always flying high in the sky, unnoticed by others.

As the Thousand Li Black Eagle settled on his forearm, Woon-seong took a small piece of beef jerky out of his pockets and fed it to the bird. He then tied a letter to its leg and threw it back into the air.

The black eagle swirled into the air, immediately disappearing into the distance as a black dot.

Kang So-san and his sister watched in curiosity.

Thud, thud, thud.

It was about two days later that an earthquake occurred.

Kang So-san and his sister were still following Woon-seong through the mountains.

At the sudden sound, the two siblings froze.

They realized that the sound could not be from just one or two horses.

The sound of such a large number in the mountains...

The two siblings trembled as they thought of mountain bandits. The reason they stopped walking was because of fear.

Just as they stopped walking, so had Woon-seong.

Of course, his reason was different from theirs.

Woon-seong's gaze shifted towards the direction of the horses. It was coming from exactly opposite of where they stood.

In the meantime, the sound of rumbling worsened.

Clip-clop, clip-clop, clip-clop.

The horses were getting closer.

As time went by, the group finally appeared.

It was a group riding black horses, each man had a weapon in hand.

They also seemed to be wearing armor and devilish masks.

But it wasn't a devil.

It was merely someone who looked like a devil. The armor and the masks were not ordinary.

The armor was high quality from just one glance and also looked quite polished, gleaming in the light.

Could that have actually caused even more fear? The two siblings trembled.

Woon-seong's lips curled when he saw the group.

At that moment, the group of riders rushed towards Woon-seong, then stopped all at once.

The riders leapt into the air, then bowed and shouted before Woon-seong.

“Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon, we greet the Cult Leader, zenith of all demonic practitioners!”

Thirty people shouted at once, including the one at the front, the sound echoing through the mountains.

The two siblings turned to Woon-seong in surprise.

Woon-seong was casually receiving their gazes and greetings.

Chapter 143: Demonic Cavalry (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 143 – Demonic Cavalry (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Samsara Demonic Cavalry (轉輪鬼馬隊).

Demons, all of them, dressed in armor and moving like one body.

They were the Samsara Demonic Cavalry.

Although not a Twelve Supporting Unit, they were one of the major strike forces representing the Cult of the Heavenly demon.

“You are here?”

At Woon-seong’s words, the Blood Tears Mask Demon raised his head while still kneeling. “You said you needed riders and horses, how could we not come? Upon being called by the Leader, we rode like the wind.”

He was the leader of this group. Unlike the others, there were red lines underneath the eyelids of his mask.

That was where he got the title ‘Blood Tears Mask Demon’.

“You must have suffered.”

“Of course not!” Mask Demon shouted loudly, then slowly stood up. He then looked at the Kang siblings, who were standing behind Woon-seong. “Who are those children?”

“The children I have chosen to collect.”

Seeing Woon-seong and the masked demon talking, the siblings were dumbfounded.

Mask Demon saw the siblings and put the mask back over his face, approaching them. “Woah,” he loudly shouted.

Unlike his title of ‘Blood Tears Mask Demon’, the man was quite childish and enjoyed playing games with children.

Not understanding his intentions, Kang So-san and his sister scrambled backwards in fear.

“Agh.”

They fell down, not intending to get up.

Mask Demon laughed down at them.

Woon-seong said, “Mask Demon, stop playing.”

“Respect.”

At his words, Mask Demon returned with a stiff expression, as if saying ‘it was just a joke’. He then pointed at some of the horses he had brought. “I will escort you to the camp.”

If there was a minor problem, it was that the two siblings knew nothing about horseback riding.

Mask Demon put them on separate horses, then introducing someone to sit behind them and hold the reigns.

The problem was solved that way.

The Samsara Demonic Cavalry then began the march towards the Eastern Army, surrounding them as if they were protecting Woon-seong.

Even as they rode on the horses, the two siblings were still frozen in shock.

Woon-seong didn't look at them, but asked Mask Demon, "When did you join the army?"

"It's been about two days."

The Samsara Demonic Cavalry were originally a part of the Northern Army, not the Eastern Army.

It was Woon-seong who called them forward, changing their status.

*The Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fortress also has famous cavalry.
Nevertheless, the choice of the Water Temple in the Qilian Mountains...*

It was the Alliance's provocation, stating that they could battle on horseback even in the mountains.

Woon-seong had called upon the Samsara Demonic Cavalry in retaliation.
"You must be tired, but you still worked hard to come here."

Mask Demon shook his head. "I was restless because I was only in the North. I was actually uncomfortable that I could not greet the Leader upon arrival in the East."

You say that, but you must be tired. Woon-seong nodded, as if understanding. "I can feel your strength, so I don't have to worry about the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort."

"They are just frogs in a well. I will show them that the strongest cavalry belongs to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon."

"Indeed."

At Woon-seong's words, Mask Demon bowed his head and smiled brightly.

In Woon-seong's head, he pictured the battle that was to take place in the Qilian Mountains.

The Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort has cavalry and the New Dragon Battalion.

Cavalry would have to be dealt with by cavalry, so the Samsara Demonic Cavalry would take care of that side.

Then what about the New Dragon Battalion?

I have the perfect opponent for them.

The New Dragon Battalion (晨龍軍), the swarm of dragons which summoned the dawn, was now the name of a battalion. But 'New Dragons' was originally the name given to a training program of the Martial Alliance.

And graduates of a similar institution existed in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The New Dragon Battalion can face the Charred Dragon Unit and the White Ape Unit.

Woon-seong intended to use two of the symbolic troops to smother the enemy's pride.

That way, the enemy's morale would hit rock bottom.

Plus, it's a mountain.

Reminded of something Sang Gwan-chuk had said, Woon-seong smiled faintly.

It was at that moment that Kang Ye-ha called out, "Esteemed sir."

Woon-seong turned his head to face Kang Ye-ha, who was behind him. Her eyes were still full of surprise and her voice was trembling.

It was not only surprise.

There was also fear.

“What kind of person is Sir?”

The reason they were afraid could be understood from this question.

They were afraid of Woon-seong’s identity. From their first meeting, they had known that Woon-seong was extraordinary.

But until now, their gratitude had overwhelmed fear.

However, when a group of scary-looking masked people were listening to Woon-seong, they became more afraid than grateful.

Their experience and knowledge of Murim was limited.

However, even they could tell that the people Woon-seong commanded were not the same as those third-class martial artists and Black Law Sect.

It was a signal from their sixth sense, an instinctive feeling.

Their fear of Woon-seong grew.

What kind of people were they?

Woon-seong laughed at Kang Ye-ha’s question. “Do you not already know who I am?”

“Yes?”

Kang Ye-ha was surprised and hesitated.

Kang So-san, who had been staring at Woon-seong until then, subconsciously muttered, “The Heavenly Demon.”

That was what Mask Demon and the others had said when they first saw Woon-seong. Had that left a lasting impression?

Kang So-san, who muttered those words without realizing it, slapped his hands over his mouth.

He was not the only person in shock.

Kang Ye-ha, who had been talking to Woon-seong, trembled. “My master is the Heavenly Demon.”

Although they were ordinary civilians, they were not without eyes and ears. They knew what that meant.

Woon-seong nodded. “Yes, I am the Heavenly Demon.”

Kang Ye-Ha and Kang So-san closed their eyes at the same time. They knew he was extraordinary, but they didn’t think he would be the Heavenly Demon.

They felt goosebumps rising, their backs suddenly cooling with sweat.

However, Kang Ye-ha’s was feeling more relief than betrayal. If the Heavenly Demon was teaching her brother martial arts, she wouldn’t have to worry about his future.

Please help So-san in the future...

It seemed that her love for her brother was greater than fear of the name ‘Heavenly Demon’.

Was it because they were riding horses? Woon-seong and the siblings were able to reach the camp at an incredibly fast pace.

The siblings felt their jaws draw when they reached the military camp. There were an endless number of black-robed martial artists.

Among them, there were several people showing off incredible swordsmanship.

What was even more surprising was that when all those fierce martial artists saw Woon-seong, they all hastily bowed their heads and shouted out a

greeting.

They realized that Woon-seong was the Heavenly Demon.

Meanwhile, the black horses that carried Woon-seong and the children reached Woon-seong's barracks.

“Wow, I’ve never seen such a big tent.”

“Neither have I.”

It was a tent the size of their entire inn, so naturally their eyes widened.

Woon-seong was accustomed to resting on a chair located inside the tent.

“Let’s take a break. ”

Despite his words, the siblings only shuffled their feet, looking around.

The situation was a bit unfamiliar.

Before the situation could get more awkward, there was a voice from outside.

“My lord.”

It was Sang Gwan-chuk.

“Come in.”

With Woon-seong's permission, he walked into the tent and politely greeted. He then smiled as he looked at the two siblings, who were sitting uncomfortably in the chairs.

“These are the children you spoke of. ”

“I’m going to send them to the Heavenly Mountains once this battle is over. I can’t take them to the battlefield...”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded.

“As soon as things settle down, I will send some people to escort them back to the Heavenly Mountains.”

“Please.”

“I’ve prepared clothes and tents for the children. May I send them there and feed them?”

As soon as Woon-seong had explained the situation, Sang Gwan-chuk had gone about preparing things for their arrival.

Woon-seong smiled at Sang Gwan-chuk’s consideration. Woon-seong nodded and two women appeared to plunge from the air.

Guardians of the Heavenly Demon in the dark.

It was two Flowers of the Dark Night.

Seeing two people suddenly appearing, the siblings flinched.

Woon-seong’s voice calmed them down. “It’s fine. Follow them and they will tell you where you will be staying for the meantime.”

At his words, Kang Ye-ha stood up and bowed, still trembling. “Thank you for your consideration.”

Kang So-san also imitated his sister and bowed his head.

Woon-seong waved a hand. “It is not I who has prepared the tents or clothing. So if you want to thank someone, do not thank me.”

At his words, the two siblings bowed again.

“Thank you.”

Sang Gwan-chuk smiled and nodded his head. “Don’t mention it. It is all thanks to the Leader, so learn well and repay the Leader’s favor.”

The two children were led outside by the Dark Flowers.

As the children left, Woon-seong's expression hardened.

“Let me hear your report.”

Picking up the children was just a small thing, as he had not forgotten they were still in the middle of war.

Chapter 144: Demonic Cavalry (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 144 – Demonic Cavalry (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“First, there was a change in organization. The Samsara Demonic Cavalry joined the army two days ago.”

Woon-seong already knew about the Demonic Cavalry. Nevertheless, Sang Gwan-chuk reported it once again, since that was the right thing to do as a soldier.

Woon-seong was also aware of that. Thus, rather than point it out, he asked about something else.

“The horses of the cavalry shouldn’t pose too much trouble, will they?”

The Samsara Demons were a cavalry group. Their individual strengths were important, but so were the horses.

If the horses were unwell, it would be difficult for the guards to show their true skills. Now, Woon-seong’s question was essential to the success of the Samsara Demons.

“As always, we manage our priorities. Their feed is a mixture of top quality soybeans. The health of the horses, including muscle mass, is always being looked after.”

Woon-seong nodded.

That was all there was to know about the cavalry; next up was the Western Army.

Sang Gwan-chuk also moved on.

“The Western Army will be arriving at the planned location in a few days.”

The Western Army, led by Cheon Ah-young, was supposed to set up camp on the western side of Mount Qilian without joining the other forces.

At the promised date, the two armies would attack both sides of Mount Qilian and the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fortress at the same time.

It was an operation that would induce confusion in the enemies by creating two battlefields, instead of one.

This was possible because of the overwhelming number of demonic soldiers compared to the Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fortress.

If the two were similar in strength, there would have been no way other than all-out war.

“When they arrive, the assault will begin. First of all, the role of destroying the strongholds will be given to the Demonic Masters.”

Attacking was always more difficult than defending.

Even if the Demonic Cult divided the battlefield into two through numerical advantage, a continued siege would lead to great damage to the Demonic Army.

Wars of Murim were much different from civilian wars.

Here, just one master could turn the tide.

Some of them could tear down solid fortresses if they had adequate support from the rear.

For the Demonic Cult, those people would be the Demonic Masters.

“Our side has the Wind Demon Fist King and the Demonic Teacher is in the west?”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded. “The Wind Demon Fist King’s martial arts are destructive and wide in scope, suitable for dealing with large numbers or destroying large structures.”

Woon-seong had seen the Fist King in action. Based on his memory, Woon-seong was in agreement.

“Why is the Demonic Teacher in the West?”

“Because of his strength.”

The Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon had been among the Ten Demonic Masters for the longest time.

Woon-seong could not even fathom the amount of strength the Demonic Teacher had. Combining pure strength and experience, there was no one comparable to the Demonic Teacher in the Demonic Cult.

“I see,” Woon-seong hummed in agreement.

A large amount of internal energy was equivalent to a large amount of strength being emitted at once.

That was perfect for breaking down large wooden barriers and opening up fortified roads.

Moreover, even if his energy wasn’t pure compared to Woon-seong’s, the Demonic Teacher’s energy was very pure for a demonic practitioner.

That instantaneous explosive power would be great.

And so both spearheads were decided. The other units would be behind them to assist as these two cleared the path forward.

What about Woon-seong?

Woon-seong had already led the Charred Dragon Unit into Qaidam Basin and practically single-handedly destroyed Qinghai.

No matter how strong he was, he could not do everything alone.

But he could do other things.

“When the fort is destroyed and the enemies come out, the Samsara Demonic Cavalry, the Charred Dragon Unit, and the White Ape Unit will emerge.”

The ones to fight each other would be cavalry against cavalry, ex-trainees against ex-trainees.

It seemed everyone knew their roles.

“The Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit has been quite firm on that. It seems that they do not want to lose to you, my lord.”

It was as Woon-seong thought.

Otherwise, it would not have been possible to create such a plan.

“After the primary collision, it will become a melee battle.”

The White Ape Unit would also make their appearance.

Next came Woon-seong.

“Am I going in after the White Ape Unit?”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded and laid something down in front of him.

It was a huge iron rod.

Pure metal, the size and width of an adult forearm.

This would be the core of the battle.

Woon-seong smiled with satisfaction as he saw it.

Sang Gwan-chuk had come up with the name.

The Mountain Destruction Plan.

A plan to destroy the mountains.

It was quite well-named.

After completing the reports, Sang Gwan-chuk left Woon-seong alone in his tent.

“Phew.”

Woon-seong was alone and took a deep breath. He operated the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body.

Energy spread through his body, vitality refreshing his blood and muscles. His head cleared.

Woon-seong reached out.

Whееееek-

Pak!

The White Night Spear, which had been lying neatly against one wall, flew into his hands. Perhaps it was reacting to Woon-seong's energy, but the White Night Spear trembled lightly.

Whoo-hoo!

It sounded like terse disappointment.

It seemed like the spear was blaming Woon-seong for doing what he did without proper preparation.

Woon-seong grinned and swept a hand along the White Night Spear. He then began to review.

It wasn't anything special.

A level where martial artists had united themselves as one, inside and out, such that their mind and bodies were in union.

Sometimes, mental discipline alone was enough to reach such a level.

That process was similar to enlightenment, but at some point, Woon-seong had started walking the path of discourse.

Disputes of the heart and mind.

Woon-seong's practice was slightly different from pouring over and questioning passages in order to realize their truth.

My training is a relentless battle.

Woon-seong would pick an opponent in his head, then find the truth behind their martial art by fighting them to the death.

That was why it was better to call it discourse, rather than meditation.

In these altercations, Woon-seong sometimes chose one powerful master, other times many enemies.

In this case, he had chosen many.

In his mind, an illusionary Woon-seong gripped a spear and charged like a tyrant.

Qar-

Despite this being all an illusion, Woon-seong's spear never stopped moving. It became a wave which swept the enemies away, then a dragon to drive them back.

He used the Divine Spear of the Ending Night and the Art of the Six Seals and Destruction.

He purposefully did not use the Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon.

This was because he thought he had been neglecting the Spear Master Sect's arts during his battles so far.

So he deliberately did not use any of the Divine Arts.

The battle raged inside his mind. The time in his mind was different from time in reality.

In his head, Woon-seong fought endlessly for days.

Then, even his physical body began to react.

Sweat slowly flowed down his body.

Although only one hour had passed in real time, Woon-seong's body was soon drenched in sweat.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong continued to struggle in his mind.

Without rest, until the rays of dawn broke through the flaps of the tent.

A few days later, a letter arrived from the Western Army announcing that they had arrived at the planned location. The rest of the army started to head towards Mount Qilian.

“Huh.”

Iron Sword Wind Cloud Fort Master Yoon, who saw the martial artists crowding around Mount Qilian sighed.

Next to him was the New Dragon Battalion's Sa Ryong-hui.

“The forces of the Demonic Cult are strong.”

“I can see that. Apparently the Cult Leader of the Demonic Cult is powerful enough to be considered a god of death. It would probably be difficult to defend against that move.”

After using the Divine Art at Qaidam Basin, Woon-seong had become known as the ‘World Destroying Heavenly Demon’.

That power was terrifying, even if just a rumor. Yoon Ye-ryong could not help but be worried.

Sa Ryong-hui confidently said, “That’s why I chose Qilian Mountain as the battlefield. As long as the mountains are the battlefield, he will not be able to use that move.”

In fact, it was not Yoon Ye-ryong who insisted on using the Qilian Mountains as the battlefield, but Sa Ryong-hui who persuaded him.

“If he used such a move here, the mountains would crumble.”

“The mountains collapsing...”

No matter how many demonic practitioners there were, they could not actually destroy the mountains.

Especially such a large one like Qilian Mountain.

Thus, Sa Ryong-hui’s words had to mean something else.

Yoon Ye-ryong suddenly understood and exclaimed, “A landslide! I see, a landslide would happen. In such a large mountain range, it would be impossible to use such a large move!”

It was as he said.

A landslide did not pick and choose. Therefore, if the Heavenly Demon used such a powerful move and a landslide inevitably occurred, the aftermath would not simply destroy the Martial Alliance.

“Unless the Cult Leader is crazy, he wouldn’t do such a thing.”

Sa Ryong-hui nodded and added, “So long as he can’t control the landslides, such a move would be unreasonable.”

“Haha, how could the Heavenly Demon control a landslide? Even a Divine Being wouldn’t be able to do that.”

Sa Ryong-hui’s eyes shone in agreement. If you were Semi-Divine or Divine, you could probably survive a landslide.

But you still couldn’t control it.

Then there was movement from the Demonic Cult. Two people walked out of the group and started to climb Mount Qilian. One of the soldiers watching from the walls exclaimed in alarm. Yoon Ye-ryong and Sa Ryong-hui gripped their weapons tightly.

The battle would soon begin.

Chapter 145: Qilian Mountain (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 145 – Qilian Mountain (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The people climbing the mountain were two of the Ten Demonic Masters of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The Wind Demon Fist King and the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon.

As they began to climb, a group from the east and west began to follow behind.

Seeing this, Yoon Ye-ryong was surprised. “I can’t read their energy. Obviously, they must have high positions in the Demonic Cult. It looks like they’re planning to attack the fort’s wooden barriers. Shouldn’t they be stopped?”

Sa Ryong-hui shook his head. His eyes did not leave the two Demonic Masters climbing the mountain.

“No, not yet. The only way to make it out alive is to wage an all-out war with the Demonic Army.”

“What should we do then?”

Sa Ryong-hui turned his attention to the reinforcements slowly chasing behind the Demonic Masters. They seemed to be following behind the

Demonic Masters from a certain distance, but in reality, were actually increasing the distance little by little.

Sa Ryong-hui's excellent eyes did not miss that fact. He smiled, "Wait a little more. If the Demonic Masters move forward a bit more, it will be a lot easier for the New Dragon Battalion and the Iron Swords to isolate the enemy."

The Demonic Masters were elite martial artists. It could have sounded arrogant to say they could catch a Demonic Master.

But the one speaking was Sa Ryong-hui.

Not to mention, they were the Iron Sword Cavalry and the New Dragon Battalion.

Even a Demonic Master could be dealt with by excellent troops.

There was also Iron Swordsman Yoon Ye-ryong, who was a Peak Level Martial Artist.

New Dragon Battalion Master Sa Ryong-hui was also a Peak Level Martial Artist.

Although this was nothing compared to a Demonic Master, even a Demonic Master would face some difficulties against numbers.

In the meantime, the two Demonic Masters continued their climb up Mount Qilian in the direction of the fort.

"Hmm."

Demonic Teacher Lee Shin-jung raised a hand to sweep through his beard. As he concentrated his energy, the forces of yin and yang spread through his arms.

The black and white iron rings he was wearing around his wrists drew in the yin-yang energies.

Whoo-hoo!

The two rings trembled and a flash of light rose from both sides. It was the Heavenly Wheels of Life and Death.

The two wheels were black and white. Lee Shin-jung grabbed the two wheels in front of him and looked at the trees stretching before him. He murmured, “Haha, it’s been a while since I’ve been on the battlefield. ”

At the same time, the wheels in his hands split the air.

Clattering —

Unlike his eyes, the wheels in his hands were sharp. All together, the rows of trees before him began to crash down.

The mountside was scarred wherever the Heavenly Wheels passed.

Boom, boom!

Loud thuds echoed across the area. It took very little time for the forest to collapse into a field.

It took less than a single day.

In the meantime, all sorts of traps were revealed and destroyed along with the forest.

There were lightning traps that would also throw boulders, and spears in pits.

There were a variety of other types too.

Countless traps were destroyed by Lee Shin-jung. Everyone’s mouth was opened in shock.

At the same time, there was a loud noise from some distance away.

Kuakuakua—

Like Lee Shin-jung did in the west, the Fist King started to work in the east.

The Wind Demon Fist King channeled the wind with his fist. That was not a joke or an exaggeration; he literally channeled the wind with his fist.

Drawing in the wind with his shoulders, the movements of his arm centered the gust of wind around his fist, which was then extended forward.

That was the Wind Demon Fist King's martial arts.

And the result?

It went without saying, but he attracted the winds and produced a storm. Even though it looked like a light punch, he called for the draconic winds of a hurricane.

It seemed like his fist had formed into a dragon.

This draconic wind shook the earth, scratching through the ground as it passed.

It wasn't just one.

With his right fist extended, the Fist King still had his left.

“Hahahahaha!”

With joyful laughter from Koo Jong-byuk, draconic winds billowed from his left.

Qrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrr——

With the sound of thunder, the forest was swept away as the storm ripped the trees from their roots. Trees soared into the air as the ground was torn, raining dirt and debris.

All kinds of traps were also falling.

Looking at that, Koo Jong-byuk yelled back, “I’m going to climb without hesitation. Don’t be left behind!”

As if cheering for him, a shout came from his reinforcements.

“Waaaahhhh!!!”

Lee Shin-jung smiled as he heard that. “This old man will be left behind if he does not move quickly.”

The two Demonic Masters continued to climb.

Mount Qilian seemed to have been hit by a catastrophic disaster.

“That’s a Demonic master?”

Sa Ryong-hui and Yoon Ye-rong were gaping at the power of the Demonic Masters, which seemed to shatter the mountains. According to the usual classification of Murim, both of them also belonged to the Transcendence Realm. But being in Transcendence and being at the peak of Transcendence, or reaching Absolution, were two completely different things.

In both skill and competency, the two were incomparable.

The dominance of the Demonic Masters seemed to prove that. With one hand, the forest would collapse and the mountains would be carved.

In the meantime, all the well-camouflaged traps were swept away.

Truly overwhelming strength.

But Sa Ryong-hui was not afraid.

It’s not impossible if you get isolated.

Even as he was admiring them, his eyes were coldly analyzing the Demonic Masters.

And he came to a conclusion.

We can do it.

It may not be possible for other troops, but it was possible for the strong Iron Sword Cavalry and the unified New Dragon Battalion.

Reaching that conclusion, Sa Ryong-hui was not afraid. Rather, he was waiting for the Demonic Masters to reach closer to the fort.

And at that moment!

“Right now!”

Sa Ryong-hui shouted and the Iron Swordsman raised a hand into the air.

With the ringing of drums, the Orthodox faction set out from Mount Qilian.

Kuakua—

A part of the wooden barrier opened with a loud sound and a group of horses poured out.

It was the Iron Sword Cavalry.

At the forefront was the Iron Swordsman, his steed an untamable stallion.

Yoon Ye-ryong leapt over the barricades, which were more than three meters tall, and into the air.

It was not just the Iron Swords who poured out.

“Let’s go, too!”

The New Dragon Battalion, which included the Tangs and Peng Hak were also rushing out.

Sang Ryong-hui leapt off the walls like Yoon Ye-ryong had done, landing in front of the New Dragons.

Heeheeheeheehee-

It was at that moment that Yoon Ye-ryong shouted, “We’ll take care of the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon!”

“Then we will deal with the Wind Demon Fist King!”

Their gazes crossed in the air. The crowd pouring out immediately split in two.

The wooden barricades closed behind them.

Watching the swarm coming out of the fortress in Mount Qilian, Woon-seong’s eyebrows twitched.

He was not the only one watching this scene.

“A bit different.”

“Right,” nodded Woon-seong. *After seeing the stronghold, I thought they were going to lure us towards the Water Temple. But they’re actually trying to fight here?*

Definitely a little different than expected.

But the battlefield was no Sun Wukong in Buddha’s palm, so unexpected things happened.

Even so, whether these variables occurred or not would make no difference.

We have countermeasures prepared for the Iron Swords and the New Dragons.

Woon-seong called out to them.

“Mask Demon.”

“Present!”

Woon-seong’s call was answered by a loud response.

Right behind Woon-seong was the fully armored Blood Tears Mask Demon, riding on a black horse.

Woon-seong then called out to Gwan Tae-ryang.

“Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit.”

“Present!”

Gwan Tae-ryang also shouted in response, just as Mask Demon had.

Behind Gwan Tae-ryang was the Charred Dragon Unit, some of the demons who had survived the Cave of Latent Demons.

“I believe in you all. Go and kill the enemy!”

“We will repay the Leader for his faith!” Gwan Tae-ryang shouted loudly.

The horses whined, as if in response.

Hi-yi-ying-

Instead of answering, Mask Demon put the mask he had tied to his head over his face. It was a mask crying tears of blood. The moment he wore that mask, Mask Demon, who liked children, transformed into a member of the Samsara Demonic Cavalry, called the ghosts of the battlefield.

Overwhelming aura erupted from his body.

Gwan Tae-ryang’s energy was no less.

As if in competition, the Charred Dragon Unit and the Samsara Demonic Cavalry all released their energies.

Hi-yi-ying-

Perhaps they had reacted to the energy?

The horses on which the Samsara Demons were riding started to thrash. They were well trained horses too.

Even the horses could feel the energy, their hearts beating with adrenaline.

Woon-seong smiled, feeling the energy surge. He turned to Sang Gwan-chuk, "Send a signal to the White Ape Unit of the Western Army and command them to march."

Bowing his head, Sang Gwan-chuk responded, "I heed the Leader's command."

Soon after, a large firecracker burst into the air above the eastern group.

The Western Army began to move.

Naturally, the one leading the White Ape Unit was Divine Maiden Cheon Ah-young.

A large group of people rushed out from both sides, racing towards Mount Qilian.

Thump, thump.

"Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon. Glory to our Cult!"

"Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon. Glory to our Cult!"

Their fierce eyes burned, containing only the image of enemies who needed to be wiped out.

Chapter 146: Qilian Mountain (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 146 – Qilian Mountain (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“They’re coming!”

Someone shouted as they watched the group.

When Sa Ryong-hui heard the exclamation, he also saw the group.

I see you had a plan, Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Sa Ryong-hui chewed on his lips. He then shouted at the New Dragon Battalion, still beyond the barrier, “Release the arrows! Blast stones! Keep them from coming up!”

In response, stones and arrows ripped through the air, raining down from the walls.

Where they fell was where the swarms of demonic practitioners were rapidly ascending the mountain.

However.

Whee-hee!

Bang!

The falling arrows did no harm to the demonic. Like the well-trained and elite soldiers they were, they swung their weapons and deflected all the arrows.

The same was true of the rocks.

Clang—

As soon as the man in the lead waved his hand, the rocks falling were slashed into a dozen pieces, uselessly scattering in all directions.

Bang!

There was a sort of blue-green qi surrounding the man who had cut the rocks.

The moment Sa Ryong-hui saw this man, he tightly gripped the sword in his hand. It was because he felt some sort of fateful connection.

His heart began to pound. His palms became damp.

He felt like he had a destined opponent. He wanted to run out there and exchange blades with the man coming up the mountain.

No.

Sa Ryong-hui clenched his hands and suppressed the impulse, fingernails digging into his palms.

What mattered now were the Demonic Masters. If they could take care of the Demonic Masters before the rest ascended, that would certainly do a lot of damage to the Demonic Cult!

“Move according to plan!”

Sa Ryong-hui flew and stood in front of Koo Jong-byuk. The others also stood around Koo Jong-byuk, surrounding him.

The first to attack was Peng Hak.

“How dare the Demonic Cult come here? A half-wit who doesn’t even know his own blood wants to attack the Central Plains? Know your place!”

The great sword in his hand began to roar.

Peng Hak was the pride of the Hebei Peng Clan.

A blade technique that only the successors of the Hebei Peng Clan could learn was soon unleashed.

“Ahahaha, the Peng Clan’s successor!” Seeing the move, Koo Jong-byuk shouted in delight. “I always wanted to fight you one day, kid!”

Koo Jong-byuk swung his fist. He released sixteen punches in one breath.

Boom, boom, boom-

The Wing King’s Gloves, which he wore on both fists, seemed to roar as if responding to Koo Jong-byuk’s energy. The fist immediately turned into a blast of wind, slamming into Peng Hak.

“Knng!”

As soon as Peng Hak was pushed back by the tremendous force, Tang Han-mae helped him from behind.

Kuakua—

Tang Han-mae’s spear slashed at the Fist King’s sides like he was a lump of iron.

Koo Jong-byuk took the spear with his bare body and it only left one small abrasion on his back.

“Oh my god!”

“Monster!”

With a body reminiscent of iron sheets, Koo Jong-byul's defenses were rock solid.

At that time, Koo Jong-byuk moved.

Whee!

Koo Jong-byuk reached out and grabbed Tang Han-mae by the wrist. With a swing of his hands, the Tang clansman was airborne.

Fwing—!

Tang Han-mae's body was lifted into the air, tossed like a stone off a cliff.

“Han-mae!”

Sa Ryong-hui barely caught Tang Han-mae in the air.

Meanwhile, Tang So-bong was continuously releasing poison and energy to buy them time.

Other members of the New Dragon Battalion also pressed at Koo Jong-byuk with their swords. They seemed to have trapped the man inside a forest of blades.

However, Koo Jong-byuk ran rampant as if he weren't afraid of such things.

Although their swords were being dented and scratched, the New Dragon Battalion could not pierce Koo Jong-byuk's skin.

What a total monster. So this is a Demonic Master.

Sa Ryong-hui thought that their evaluation of the Demonic Masters was wrong.

The Demonic Masters were stronger than expected.

However, Koo Jong-byuk was not without damage. Poison was seeping through his wounds made by the New Dragon Battalion, including those by

Tang Han-mae.

Plus, as he continued to fight, the poison spread faster.

With enough time, it would even take down a Demonic Master.

Unfortunately, time was not on Sa Ryong-hui's side.

“Listen to me, Charred Dragon Unit! Kill the New Dragon Battalion at the behest of the Leader!”

Gwan Tae-ryang's voice rang out.

A little farther away, Cheon Ah-young's voice could also be heard.

“The White Ape Unit joins the Charred Dragon Unit to strike down the enemy. White Ape Unit, don't you dare lose!”

With an onslaught from both sides, it was clear that the Orthodox would be surrounded if the group continued to attack Koo Jong-byuk.

“Haha, you damn demonic bastards!” Peng Hak, who seemed to have bounced back from the Fist King's attack, seethed.

Sa Ryong-hui made a decision.

“Give up on the Wind Demon Fist King! Turn your blades to the oncoming enemies! I will buy you all some time against the Wind Demon Fist King!”

“Captain!”

Peng Hak shouted, as if that was reckless, but Sa Ryong-hui shook his head. He was the only one capable of stalling right now.

And what if Sa Ryong-hui couldn't block Koo Jong-byuk?

Then the wooden barricades of the fort would be compromised. Then they would have no choice but to fight head-on with the great army of the Demonic Cult.

The battlefield would overflow with blood. In order to control the demonic forces, the barricades had to remain intact.

“Miss Tang, you must defeat your enemies and come help me. I will buy you some time until then.”

The other did not answer. Sa Ryong-hui rushed off without waiting for an answer.

It was in the direction of where Koo Jong-byuk was going crazy.

The situation of the Iron Swords led by Yoon Ye-ryong was not much different from that of the New Dragon Battalion.

After going out to confront Demonic Teacher Lee Shin-jung, they were met with the charging Samsara Demonic Cavalry.

“How dare you meet with the Iron Swords of this great fortress on horseback? You’ve got some nerve!” Yoon Ye-ryong shouted as they collided with the Samsara Demons.

But come on.

The riding of the Samsara Demons was very good. On horseback, they leapt over rocks and wove through the trees.

It could be said that their skill seemed to be superior to the Iron Swords’.

That was because the Samsara Demonic Cavalry had grown up in the Heavenly Mountains.

Now matter how the Iron Sword cavalry trained to ride through the mountains, it was impossible for them to compare with those who had been born and raised in the Heavenly Mountains.

“Hmph. Just because you’re good at horseback riding doesn’t mean you can be called a cavalry!”

Yoon Ye-ryong admired their skills for a moment, but soon wielded his blade. The real game was martial arts. In addition, a cavalry had to be able to move seamlessly and crush the enemies.

Horseback riding was just the foundation and did not necessarily create any advantage.

Soon, however, he had to revise his evaluation once again.

“Grrrgh!”

Yoon Ye-ryong felt his hands trembling as he collided with an opponent wearing a bloodied mask.

The opponent’s spear was trembling, so their strengths seemed to be on par.

What strength!

Comparable to himself!

Yoon Ye-ryong grabbed his blade more firmly. He then rode his horse and attacked this blood-masked opponent.

“Yi-ke!”

As if responding to him, the opponent also spurred his horse forward.

“Irriririririririri-rit!”

A strange sound came out of his mouth and the black horse leapt forward, galloping.

On such a horse, the Mask Demon began to move.

He seemed to lean forward, but his spear swiped from the front to the back, attacking Yoon Ye-ryong.

This happened without him seeming to touch the spear!

Yoon Ye-ryong's eyes widened. Meanwhile, the Mask Demon had turned and avoided Yoon Ye-ryong's attacks.

What the hell...

At first, he thought he was wrong. But soon after that, he would be attacked several times. He had even attacked beyond the area where he thought he would be safe.

Soon, Yoon Ye-ryong realized the identity of the attack.

“Cavalry tactics!”

With one toe on the seat, the man would attack, before returning back to the saddle using the hooked toe.

The strength of that one toe was amazing, but the sense of balance needed to perform such a feat was beyond imagination.

“The Demonic Cult is truly a collection of monsters!” Yoon Ye-ryong shouted.

The man with the bloody mask simply aimed his polearm at Yoon Ye-ryong once more.

“Hmm.” Lee Shin-jung, who was watching the battle from the sides, stroked his long beard. “You’re doing well.”

The battle seemed to be intense, but if you looked closely, the Demonic Cult was gaining. The balance would soon collapse, so if they waited a little longer like this, perhaps the battle would end with a Demonic victory.

But that is not the victory the Leader desires.

He raised a hand, no longer stroking his beard.

Yin and yang collected in his hands, and the Heavenly Wheels rose.

“I can’t help but move this old body for the victory the Lord wants.”

The Heavenly Wheels whirled out of his hand and cut through the air!

Sou-bing-

Two cuts appeared on the massive wooden barricades.

Kuk-kua—

The walls began to crack apart, but Lee Shin-jung continued to wield the Heavenly Rings, deciding that it wasn't enough.

Kuakuakuakua—

The Heavenly Wheels flew all over the place and the walls were cut in dozens of places.

“It's over!”

When there was an urgent cry, Lee Shin-jung made eye contact with the soldiers standing inside of the walls.

He laughed, “Kekeke, how cute.”

The Demonic Army now had a hole through which to enter the fortress.

“You did it,” murmured Woon-seong, watching the barricades collapse.

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded. “Since that has been successful, let us move on to the next part of the plan.”

The plan to bring down the mountains.

The Qilian Destruction Plan had only just begun.

Chapter 147: Heavenly Demon's Reigning Step (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 147 – Heavenly Demon's Reigning Step (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

As soon as part of the wooden barricades were brought down, there was not much meaning to the fort.

It was natural considering the boundaries that separated the interior and exterior were no longer there.

After the walls were breached, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon sent more soldiers up Mount Qilian, and the Orthodox faction poured out to block them.

The scene was almost poetic.

It was common for opponents to change in the middle of such a struggle.

Either the opponent was struck with a blade and died, or they were flung off into the distance and someone took his place.

There were plenty of reasons to change opponents.

No one was an exception.

Sa Ryong-hui was fighting Koo Jong-byuk, while the New Dragon Battalion fought the Charred Dragon Unit. Rather than fighting, it was more correct to say Sa Ryong-hui was barely enduring.

However, the opponent soon changed.

After blocking Koo Jong-byuk's fist, he was thrown far enough away from him.

“Hmph.”

Sa Rrong-hui stabbed and killed a soldier coming from his side.

Puchi—

A demon, who now had a hole in his thigh and heart, fell down in a pool of blood.

Three more demons rushed at Sa Ryong-hui in succession.

“Glory to the Heavenly Demon!”

“Glory to the Heavenly Demon!”

“Glory to the Heavenly Demon!”

It was enough to remind Sa Ryong-hui that these were all fanatics, as they rushed to their deaths, crying out in glory of the Heavenly Demon. Sa Ryong-hui bit his lips as he looked at them, swinging his sword.

The sword in his hands split in all directions and the demonic soldiers came crashing down. After that, most of the soldiers tried to avoid him.

Where is he?

Meanwhile, Sa Ryong-hui's eyes continued to roam the battlefield. He was searching for traces of the Wind Demon Fist King.

He had faced the Demonic Master himself.

So he knew.

Unless someone keeps that Demonic Master busy, there will be great damage to my allies.

That was why he never stopped searching for Koo Jong-byuk.

Then, Sa ryong-hui's eyes narrowed.

There aren't that many demonic soldiers.

It was hard to determine because of all the chaos, but he could tell when looking carefully.

The number of demonic soldiers who had climbed Mount Qilian was less than 3,000. According to what he heard, the combined forces of the West and East should have been closer to 20,000 men.

Having not sent their entire army at once, Sa Ryong-hui suddenly wondered what the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was thinking.

That wasn't the only strange thing.

Despite the chaos, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon never left a certain area.

Sticking to that area, the demonic soldiers stretched out like long bands. The Orthodox faction was struggling against the demonic soldiers within that band.

Do you intend to form a siege?

It was then.

“Hahahahaha!”

After stabbing and killing another two demonic soldiers, Sa Ryong-hui heard laughter. He turned his head towards the sound. It was an unforgettable laugh.

“Wind Demon Fist King!” he raised his voice and shouted.

Someone responded to him.

It was not the Wind Demon Fist King.

Kuakuakua—!

A blade left a long mark where Sa Ryong-hui had just been standing.

If I hadn't jumped to the side just now, I would have been cut in two.

“Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit!” Sa Ryong-hui growled with his eyes wide, glaring at the man who had just attacked him.

It was Gwan tae-ryang.

Just like fate, the two men met on the battlefield for the first time.

“You are the leader of the New Dragon Battalion, right?” Gwan Tae-ryang asked.

Instead of answering, Sa Ryong-hui swung his sword.

That was an answer enough.

Kua—

The two blades collided and sparks erupted in the air. The sword and blade slashed through the air, targeting veins and joints.

Boom. Boom.

Energy exploded like firecrackers in the air.

In the midst of the clashes, Sa Ryong-hui suddenly faced Gwan Tae-ryang and roared, “What on earth is the Cult of the Heavenly Demon thinking?!”

“

Boom, boom!

“Why aren’t they attacking? What the hell are they after?!”

Chang-chang!

“Say it!”

Sa Ryong-hui shouted.

At that moment, Gwan Tae-ryang’s blade flashed.

Clang—

Sa Ryong-hui’s sleeve had just been torn. *If I hadn’t instinctively pulled my arm back, my wrist would have been cut off.*

His expression hardened.

Aiming straight for Sa Ryong-hui’s face, Gwan Tae-ryong spoke in a low and clear voice, “Focus on the fight, unless you want to compete with insults.”

In front of Sa Ryong-hui, the air rippled.

“Otherwise, you’ll lose your head before you even know what’s going on.”

Boom-!

While the battle continued, some people were secretly climbing Mount Qilian, as if they had nothing to do with the turmoil.

Their movements were very secretive.

They moved silently and quickly among the trees, flitting about like shadows.

Their feet hit the ground, but there was no sound.

They also did not forget to carefully observe their surroundings.

Like that, twenty people scattered across the mountain.

If there was anything common between them, it would be their clothing.

They were all wearing black robes, robes with the symbols of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon on one side.

Those who were climbing were all members of the Demonic Cult.

In fact, they were playing a central role in the battle.

To be precise, the objects in their hands would be the center of the battle.

As they climbed the mountain, they would stop and put iron bars into the ground.

Puk—

The iron rods were inserted halfway into the earth. After confirming that, they would set off a small firecracker in the air.

Pang, pang, pang!

These flares erupted into sparks. Such a scene unfolded all over the mountainside.

Unknowingly, there was a man who had climbed to the highest peak of Mount Qilian and watched the battlefield.

“Hmm.”

It was Sang Gwan-chuk.

His eyes slowly swept across the battle. Unlike when he was speaking with Woon-seong's, his eyes were cold and calculated as he calmly observed and predicted the field.

As his eyes swept through, a slight smile appeared on his face.

He liked the way the demonic followers had surrounded the enemies in a siege formation.

“You’re doing well.”

In the midst of such a skirmish, it was very important to distinguish between allies and enemies.

That was also why they hadn’t sent all the demonic soldiers into battle.

Hmm.

It was not only to reduce damage to the Cult as much as possible, but also to easily distinguish the two forces.

Sang Gwan-chuk suddenly focused on something else.

This time, it wasn’t another section of the battlefield, but somewhere in the forests of Mount Qilian. Sang Gwan-chuk’s eyes seemed to light up slightly.

He could see some of those men in black robes, symbolizing the Demonic Sect, moving secretly through the woods.

In their hands were iron rods the size of an adult’s forearm.

It was the weapon he had shown to Woon-seong.

Those iron rods were the core of the Qilian Destruction Plan. Seeing those iron rods placed in the designated locations, Sang Gwan-chuk smiled.

“This way, the enemies will know the greatness of our Cult.”

At this time, firecrackers burst through the sky.

All that was left was Woon-seong’s job.

Everyone fighting below could also see the sudden explosion of fireworks.

Pang-pang-pang!

The Orthodox soldiers, who did not understand, were puzzled by the sudden fireworks show.

Sa Ryong-hui's expression soon became horror. *This absolute confusion definitely has something to do with the enemy's secret movements!*

Seeing the fireworks, Sa Ryong-hui immediately shouted, "What the hell are you doing?!"

At that, Gwan Tae-ryang laughed. "Who knows?"

Gwan Tae-ryang didn't know what the exact plan was either.

But one thing was clear.

Those fireworks definitely meant something to the demonic practitioners fighting on Mount Qilian, including Gwan Tae-ryang.

"Keep your distance!" he shouted, maniacally rushing away from Sa Ryong-hui.

At that moment, the demonic practitioners immediately started to retreat.

Sa Ryong-hui, who intuitively concluded that something was going terribly wrong, also shouted, "Retreat! Stay away from the demons!"

At that, Yoon Ye-ryong, who was still struggling against the Mask Demon, called out, "What's going on?"

As soon as Gwan Tae-ryang's voice had rang out, the Samsara Demonic Cavalry had also moved as far as possible from the Iron Swords.

"I have a bad feeling about something. I think it's better if we stick together."

“Hmph, for the remnants of the Demonic Cult...”

Sa Ryong-hui screamed as Peng Hak ignored his orders and tried to rush forward.

Thud!

Peng Hak’s gaze flicked over.

Soon, he realized that he had been shoved and turned to shout at Sa Ryong-hui: “I already let the fact that some bastard from low birth became my superior—”

At that moment, an overwhelming weight pressed down on the entire mountain.

It was the appearance of Woon-seong.

Fwoosh—

Ta, ta.

Woon-seong stepped into the air.

His movements were natural, as if he were climbing an invisible staircase.

He climbed through the air and stopped at a point where he could see the entire Qilian Mountain at once.

All the demonic practitioners looked up at him.

“That’s not good...”

Someone’s voice was vividly transmitted to everyone.

Woon-seong looked down at them arrogantly.

His energy continued to press down across the entire mountain.

Energy emanating from the Heavenly Demon, not from anyone else.

Still looking down on them, Woon-seong said:

“Watch, this is the power of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

Rumble!

Woon-seong’s voice shook the air. In that state, Woon-seong slowly lifted one foot.

Fwoom—!

A flicker of fire appeared around Woon-seong’s heels. The flames flowing out formed a vortex, whirling around the soles of his feet.

Like that, a huge whirlpool of flames erupted around Woon-seong’s feet.

Someone muttered the name of the move in terror:

“Reigning Step of the Heavenly Demon.”

A move where flames would erupt under your feet, each step raining fire upon the earth...

As soon as someone called out this name, one which brought terror to the Orthodox faction, Woon-seong began the Reigning Step.

Kwa-rung!

Balls of fire began to fall towards Mount Qilian.

Chapter 148: Heavenly Demon's Reigning Step (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 148 – Heavenly Demon's Reigning Step (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

What were the symbolic martial arts that made the Heavenly Demon into an Orthodox nightmare?

If you were to ask this question to the martial artists of Zhongyuan, you would probably get two answers:

‘Millenia of Heaven Annihilation’ and ‘Reigning Step’.

All parts of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon boasted transcendent strength, but these two moves were particularly special.

Millennia of Heaven Annihilation had become famous because of Woon-seong.

According to a widespread rumor, Woon-seong used Millennia of Heaven Annihilation and blew up the entire Qaidam Basin, giving onlookers the illusion that meteors were falling from the skies.

In consideration of that, the Millennia of Heaven Annihilation had recently become a signature move of the Heavenly Demon.

What about the other Heavenly Demons?

Originally, it was the Heavenly Demon's Reigning Step that made the Heavenly Demon such a nightmare.

Many people in the Orthodox faction would probably still be more devastated to hear about the Reigning Step than anything else.

The Reigning Step was just that powerful and terrible a skill.

And that same Heavenly Demon's Reigning Step was currently unfolding on Mount Qilian.

An overwhelming amount of energy crushed the mountainside.

The martial artists who were oppressed by the energy felt like the Heavens and earth were weighing down on them.

That was just the beginning.

Once Woon-seong's foot started to move, flames started to descend, forcing all those beneath him to submit or die.

Huge balls of flame fell towards the ground. It was clear that with them so large, even the Demonic Army would be greatly harmed.

He has to be crazy! Sa Ryong-hui screamed in his head.

At that moment, the flames paused in the air.

Fwoom!

The falling pieces of flame gathered in the air, forming clumps.

This torrential fire-rain merged into about twenty massive balls of flame.

These fireballs absorbed the surrounding smaller ones and ballooned in size. The air rumbled as these plummeted towards the ground.

Rrrrrrrrrrrrr—

As they fell, they looked like massive pillars of fire, reaching towards the Heavens and exalting the Heavenly Demon.

Except, that still didn't explain the fireworks.

But, back to the Heavenly Demon's Reigning Step.

These tremendous pillars of fire struck the iron rods, bashing them deeper into the mountain like hammers to a nail.

Where there was a rod, there were ripples inside the earth.

Carried by these iron rods, the power of the Divine Flame permeated the area. The earth began to tremble, in tune with the rippling of the iron rods.

Rumble—

The first tremor was not so great.

However, the force pressing down on the iron rods grew, forcing the natural energy residing in the ground to constantly collide with the Divine Flame.

And as a result,

Kuang!

The whole mountain began to crumble.

The Qilian Destruction Plan; the plan to destroy Mount Qilian.

Woon-seong caused a landslide.

Kuakua—

Shua—

The mountain shook and groaned as it collapsed. Immediately after that, a pile of rocks rushed down the mountain side.

Kuakuakua—

Bam, bam.

Down below, loud noises echoed across the field.

The sound seemed to be coming from the top of the mountain.

Sa Ryong-hui noticed the wave of rocks and trees coming towards them. It was still far, but given the speed, it would soon be upon them.

Is that something a human can do?

The soldiers were filled with fear as they saw a wall of dust rushing down.

Yoon Ye-ryong loudly exclaimed, “The Heavenly Demon is insane! He’s trying to wipe out the enemies and his allies all at once! Even if he’s a cultist, that’s insanity! That’s definitely a demonic being who shouldn’t exist in this world!”

Yoon Ye-ryong’s exclamation made the Blood Tears Mask Demon smile, though you couldn’t tell because of the mask. “Our Lord is not insane.”

Yoon Ye-ryong almost spat out blood. “Fuck, you’re all insane!”

Even at that moment, the landslide was raging towards the Orthodox and Demonic soldiers.

There was very little time left.

What should the Orthodox soldiers do?

A landslide above and 20,000 demonic soldiers below!

What a terrible situation! Making a quick decision, Sa Ryong-hui ordered, “Move aside. Run towards the forests, but do not go down! There must be a

place where the landslide won't be so bad!"

If they tried to run down, they would be swept away by the coming landslide. But if they ran towards the sides, they could potentially escape the landslide's scope.

In that regard, Sa Ryong-hui's judgment was not wrong.

Now, if only someone wasn't controlling the landslide.

"Excellent!" exclaimed Sang Gwan-chuk from the top of the mountain as he watched Woon-seong move.

Soon, the avalanche of rocks began picking up speed, flooding down towards the battlefield.

Now that Woon-seong had caused a landslide, it was Sang Gwan-chuk's turn to make a move.

Sang Gwan-chuk began to gather his qi.

Hoo! Hoo!

After a few seconds, he burst the ball of energy apart, emitting a strange sound at a special frequency.

And there were certain things that responded to that sound.

The iron rods.

The role of those iron rods was not just to channel Woon-seong's energy into the ground.

These twenty iron rods trembled, rippling with a new kind of energy.

Sang Gwan-chuk had just put the landslide which Woon-seong caused under his control.

"Haha!"

Of course, it wasn't an easy thing to do. Despite being one of the Demonic Masters, it was never easy to completely control a force of nature.

Someone put their hand on Sang Gwan-chuk's back.

It was Woon-seong.

Through his palm, energy from Woon-seong's core flowed into Sang Gwan-chuk's body. An overwhelming amount of qi suddenly gathered around the Strategist.

"Focus."

Sang Gwan-chuk heard Woon-seong's voice and nodded, moving his hands.

Kuang—

The landslide shifted.

The iron rods under Sang Gwan-chuk's command controlled the landslide, pulsing to direct the flow. It was like a fence, corralling the rocks.

Krrrr—

Following the guidance of the iron rods, the landslide swept over the mountainside.

Seeing how the landslide seemed to be chasing them horizontally across the mountain, Sa Ryong-hui was dumbfounded. *They're controlling the landslide!*

Yoon Ye-ryong suddenly remembered what he had said before the battle:
"Mankind cannot control landslides."

Now, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had thrown his words back at him.

"Ahhhh!"

"Help!"

The Orthodox soldiers were swept away by the landslide. Some people were running around and avoiding the flood of rocks, but they weren't able to do it for long.

“Ah!” Sa Ryong-hui made a desperate noise. *Now I know why the demonic were so vigilant despite the chaos.*

It was because they were guarding themselves against the landslide, so that it would only attack the Orthodox soldiers.

I was wrong, he lamented.

To avoid the mudslide, they should not have run towards the side.

Even if there was the possibility of death by sword, they should have stuck to the demonic soldiers.

At least that way, they wouldn't be swept away by the landslide.

It would have been less shameful to die fighting the demonic.

Peng Hak seethed, “This damn—” before being drowned by dirt.

The Tang clansmen were no exception.

“Aaah!”

“Uack!”

As the rocks swept through, they ferociously resisted, but the result remained unchanged.

One large piece of rock smacked into them and the two went unconscious, immediately being swept away.

“Tang So-bong, Tang So-bong! Miss Tang?!”

Sa Ryong-hui hurriedly reached for them, searching through the rocks and dirt, but was unable to find a trace of them.

The same was true of Iron Swordsman Yoon Ye-ryong. A huge wave had swallowed him, along with his horse.

Hiiiiing—

The horse screamed in fear, but it was soon buried in the dust together with its rider.

And lastly.

Kuakuakua—

A piece of stone the size of a wall slammed into Sa Ryong-hui, sending him down too.

Krrrr!

The landslide was a complete catastrophe.

Of course, the landslide that swept through Mount Qilian was not a natural phenomenon, but a man-made one.

The landscape of Mount Qilian, which had been hit by said disaster, was a hellscape.

The ground seemed to have been turned inside out; unexplained debris and trees were strewn across the mountainside, tangled with broken rocks and mud.

There were also hundreds of bodies littering the ground, many half buried in the mud.

Few had survived the landslide.

It was useless to ask how the others had been lost. Some had been crushed by rocks, others drowned or were torn to pieces.

Additionally, the survivors trembled, traumatized.

But there were still survivors among those who had been swept away.

The stronger martial artists had escaped death, despite the massive injuries inflicted upon them.

For example, Tang So-bong and Peng Hak had made it out.

Yoon Ye-ryong and Sa Ryong-hui were also exceptions.

“Cough!”

Sa Ryong-hui scrambled out of the dirt and spat out the sand filling his mouth.

His dantian was empty and his arms and legs were trembling.

Near Sa Ryong-hui, Tang Han-mae and Tang So-bong also crawled out of the dirt.

They didn’t look very different from Sa Ryong-hui.

No, they were actually worse off. Their wounds were much more severe.

Both of Peng Hak’s legs seemed to be broken; Tang Han-mae’s breathing was uneven, as if her ribs were broken. Tang So-bong’s arms seemed to have been broken at weird angles.

Yoon Ye-ryong appeared some distance away. As the ground trembled, an arm appeared first. Soon after, his head appeared and he muttered, “I survived?”

At that, everyone who came out trembled.

It wasn’t very hard to remember that a landslide had just hit them.

Hearing Yoon Ye-ryong’s words, they realized that they had indeed survived.

Sa Ryong-hui looked around him, where half a dozen bodies were buried in the mud.

His allies had been slaughtered.

Should I grieve or rejoice at this situation, knowing I have survived while others did not?

Realizing he had made it, Sa Ryong-hui was thrown into a whole different state of confusion.

Then something cold was pressed to his neck.

It was a blade.

“The order is to capture all survivors.”

A voice colder than the metal entered his ears.

The Charred Dragon Unit, who had led the charge, began to surround the survivors.

Chapter 149: Frog In A Well (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 149 – Frog in a Well (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Charred Dragon Unit had no mercy for its enemies.

Even those who had broken limbs were dragged away as prisoners.

No one was an exception.

Peng Hak, who had two broken legs, was dragged towards the Demonic Army by members of the Charred Dragon Unit.

“Khh. Khh. ”

Every time he was dragged forward, his legs would be rattled and he would groan in extreme pain.

Peng Hak was not the type of person to suffer and stay put.

“You guys, do you know who I am?! I am a direct descendant of the great Hebei Peng Clan. At least treat your prisoners right!” he shouted, swinging his arms about.

The two Charred Dragons dragging him off seemed bothered. Different expressions flitted across their faces, eventually settling on something strange.

Approaching Peng Hak was Gwan Tae-ryang.

Bam!

Gwan Tae-ryang's fist slammed into Peng Hak's stomach. A giant wall of force swelled, breaking Peng Hak's body like a sickle.

“Cough!”

There was a gasp, before Peng Hak was screaming through the air. He landed on the ground.

But broken legs couldn't bear such force.

Kaka-dang!

Thud!

Peng Hak rolled across the ground, crashing face first into a pile of dirt.

“Huff. Huff. ”

He lay there for a while, as the pain did not easily go away.

Gwan Tae-ryang reached out and grabbed the man's head.

Win –

As he was pulled up by his hair, Peng Hak met Gwan Tae-ryong's gaze. Inside, it was like a massive hurricane.

A beast seemed to growl in his ear, “Your identity and status count for shit here. Even if you were the Buddhist Star, you would be a prisoner just the same.”

“How dare—”

He was about to say ‘How dare you?!’ However, Gwan Tae-ryang was much faster.

Bang!

“Ahhh!”

Gwan Tae-ryang kicked Peng Hak in the shin. The broken bones were splintered into three smaller ones.

Peng Hak was blinded by pain.

“Your situation is one of a prisoner, not an ally. Keep that in mind. Otherwise, you will feel suffering worse than death.”

“Ugh.”

Whether it was because of the pain of broken bones or if it was because of Gwan Tae-ryang’s threats, Peng Hak’s eyes filled with tears and he did not rebuke.

Watching from the side, Sa Ryong-hui had to give kudos, even if the man was his enemy. *He’s the perfect opponent.*

Meanwhile, Gwan Tae-ryang approached Sa Ryong-hui. Grabbing the end of the rope, he shouted at the men behind.

“We’re moving!”

Was it because he had been beaten up by Gwan Tae-ryang? Peng Hak did not groan in pain as he was dragged away.

Despite leading the New Dragon Battalion for such a long time, Sa Ryong-hui had never seen such an obedient Peng Hak.

However, if everyone is so terrified, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon sure lives up to its name.

Sa Ryong-hui was the leader of the New Dragon Battalion.

He was a thorough member of the Orthodox martial society. As such, all of his information about the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was controlled by

the Martial Alliance.

The information he knew was all about sects being eviscerated and civilians being plundered.

Of course, that was all information manipulated by the Martial Alliance, but it was all Sa Ryong-hui knew.

So he was worried.

If the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, who treated everyone so inhumanely like this, ruled the world, the land would be covered with blood and screams. Slaughter and piles of corpses everywhere.

That was why he asked.

“What happens to us now?”

Gwan Tae-ryang briefly answered, “Everything is up to the Leader.”

The captives were eventually dragged into the Demonic Army’s camp. Tied together like that, they looked like caught fish.

The demons inside the camp giggled and burst into laughter.

This caused discontentment among those of the New Dragon Battalion.

Most of the members of the New Dragon Battalion were the descendents of some faction or another. Whether major or minor, they could be considered as carrying the future upon their shoulders.

Although they had been divided based on their skills inside the group, that was purely internal assessments of the New Dragon Battalion. Nothing changed outside, in Murim.

On the contrary, every person of the New Dragon Battalion was praised as a young hero.

Treated like that, Tang So-bong could not believe she was being laughed at by a bunch of demons.

“Don’t fucking....”

She was about to shout ‘Don’t fucking laugh!’ but at that moment, Tang Han-mae shook her head from the side.

It was a signal of ‘don’t do that’.

Tang Han-mae then glanced at Peng Hak.

Tang So-bong endured what she was feeling, seeing Peng Hak being dragged with his broken bones.

She was afraid to end up like that.

“Huh?”

Tang So-bong then made a sound of confusion. As she was being dragged off, she seemed to have seen something among the demons.

At the noise, Tang Han-mae and Sa Ryong-hui turned to follow her gaze.

“What?”

“Oh!”

And soon they were also exclaiming.

They had found a familiar face.

“You...” Sa Ryong-hui could not help but say, eyes wide.

The other person also had their eyes wide at the sight of Sa Ryong-hui.

Soon, the other person rushed forward.

It was Kang So-san that made eye contact with Sa Ryong-hui.

Since Kang So-san was considered Woon-seong's disciple, he was able to move about freely in the Demonic Army's camp. He had come out because he had seen prisoners.

But one of those prisoners was Sa Ryong-hui.

As Kang So-san walked forward, Gwan Tae-ryang bowed.

"Young Master." [1]

The Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit was ranked not higher than Woon-seong's disciple.

Kang So-san awkwardly greeted the Lieutenant, then stood in front of Sa Ryong-hui.

"Why are you here?" Sa Ryong-hui asked Kang So-san, with a face of incomprehension.

"That..."

Kang So-san briefly explained to him what had happened.

Sa Ryong-hui heaved a long sigh. "Yes, I see." *The Heavenly Demon is the man who left that trace, the one I wanted to meet. Since it's the Heavenly Demon, I guess it makes sense he can leave a marking like that.* "Isn't it hard being with the Demonic Cult?"

In response, Gwan Tae-ryang's eyebrows twitched. The same was true of the other demons, who were listening closely.

Sharp energy hit Sa Ryong-hui all of a sudden. A chill went down his spine.

In contrast to them, Kang So-san shook his head with an innocent expression.

"No, they are very good to me."

“Good to you?” Sa Ryong-hui echoed, not understanding Kang So-san’s words at all.

At this time, someone ran out and told Gwan Tae-ryang, “Head inside. The Leader orders to bring the prisoners in quickly.”

Gwan Tae-ryang glanced at Kang So-san.

Kang So-san was also looking at Gwan Tae-ryang.

“Young Master, I think we will have to take these men with us.”

Sa Ryong-hui had helped Kang So-san match the trace Woon-seong had left behind.

“It is the Leader’s orders.”

But this gratitude did not compare to the gratitude Kang So-san felt towards Woon-seong.

It had been Woon-seong who saved him and his sister when they had been threatened by the Black Law Sect. He had even brought the siblings here, as promised.

That Woon-seong had passed a command.

Kang So-san nodded. “Then it cannot be helped.”

At Kang So-san’s words, Gwan Tae-ryang bowed his head slightly and brought the prisoners inside.

Until then, Sa Ryong-hui was still murmuring in disbelief and confusion. “Treat you well? It can’t be...”

The demons are insane.

The Demonic Cult is the worst of them.

It is the Demonic that insists on walking the evil and unorthodox path.

They take blood from their brothers and sisters. And if they can become strong, they will slaughter without hesitation.

Even children are no exceptions. Occasionally, the demonic will catch and eat the flesh of children.

Those were the stories that Sa Ryong-hui had heard.

But one word from Kang So-san had shaken his thoughts.

Are you trying to deceive me?

Using Kang So-san?

No way. That wouldn't have been worth it. Moreover, no matter how he observed, Kang So-san's smile was real.

Does that mean I have been wrong all along?

He suddenly had the thought that the demonic might be people, just like him and the rest of Zhongyuan.

In the meantime, Gwan Tae-ryang had been leading them forward. Soon, they reached the center of the camp. The soldiers had gathered in the center, but left an empty space.

On one side of the space was a dazzling throne.

It was a throne with black dragons climbing up the armrests and extending across both sides.

The prisoners were forced to kneel right in front of the throne.

“Unh!”

Peng Hak groaned when he was forced onto his broken legs.

No one felt sorry for him.

This place was the definition of hostile.

There were enemies everywhere. There was no one in the world who felt sorry for his enemies.

How long had they been kneeling?

Drums sounded inside the camp.

The demonic practitioners began to react.

The believers slowly and politely knelt on one knee. Then, all together, they shouted high towards the Heavens.

“Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon!”

“Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon!”

As the cry ebbed, the practitioners parted down the center.

A man wearing a black dragon embroidered robe slowly appeared.

The man appeared to be the same age as Sa Ryong-hui. But all the demonic believers were bowing down before him, as if worshiping him.

The same was true of Gwan Tae-ryang, who had dragged them here.

They were all subservient to the man in the black dragon robe.

Sa Ryong-hui suddenly came to a realization.

The young man who had just appeared was the Heavenly Demon.

It was Woon-seong's entrance.

Woon-seong sat down on his throne and looked down at the prisoners. His cold eyes swept over the group.

At this time, Woon-seong grabbed the armrests of the throne.

Wooduk—

There was a harsh sound as the torso of the black dragon was distorted. Clear fingerprints remained on the armrests of the throne.

Woon-seong's gaze was focused on two of the prisoners. He was swallowing his anger.

The Tang and Peng Clans.

The Sichuan Tang Clan and the Hebei Peng Clan.

They had been at the heart of the formation which once sealed Woon-seong and Nok Yu-on.

Now, their bloodline was in Woon-seong's sight.

[1] just to reiterate, Kang So-san is *not* the Young Leader.

Chapter 150: Frog In A Well (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 150 – Frog in a Well (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The blood of the enemy was before him.

Peng Hak looked like a cowering mouse. They were blood relatives, but they had such contrasting figures.

But Peng Hak wanted to look small...

It was so ridiculous Woon-seong laughed to himself.

Master, I have the blood of the enemy before me...

Woon-seong closed his eyes for a moment.

More strength entered his fingers.

Wooduck—

More markings appeared on the throne.

If it had been the Woon-seong burning for vengeance long ago, he would have killed them in a heartbeat.

He did not do so now.

It was not because his vengeance had disappeared.

Woon-seong's revenge had changed over a long time.

His hatred no longer burned.

Instead, it had become deeper and more poisonous. It coiled and slithered beneath, like a viper.

Woon-seong loosened his grip on the throne.

Bang—

The armrest splintered as it fell to the floor.

At last, Woon-seong opened his eyes to look at the enemy.

I will kill them, but in no easy manner.

Woon-seong stared at them.

When Woon-seong's gaze landed at them, they trembled.

Only one person was looking back at Woon-seong.

Leader of the New Dragon Battalion.

In his previous life, when Woon-seong learned about the New Dragon Battalion, he had also been told about a young and talented child in the New Dragon School.

Was his name Sa Ryong-hui?

The leader of the New Dragon Battalion seemed to have the exact same name as that little boy.

In the past, Woon-seong had considered it the appearance of a talented junior.

But now they were enemies.

Woon-seong opened his mouth, wanting to tell them something.

But Sa Ryong-hui was faster.

“What the hell is the Cult Leader planning in such a bloodied place?”

The demonic practitioners twitched; Gwan Tae-ryang glared down at the man.

However, Sa Ryong-hui did not take his gaze off Woon-seong.

“Scared?”

Woon-seong hummed and Sa Ryong-hui nodded.

“I heard that the world ruled by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon is full of evil and wickedness. That blood and corpses pile up like mountains, that sorrow and lament overflow like the sea.”

The expressions of the demons distorted in an instant.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong’s voice was calm and quiet.

“But?”

“But that cannot be. That would be hell on earth. If the Cult Leader made such a world, who would bow down before the Cult Leader? A leader with no followers would not last a hundred years. If the Cult Leader thinks he is a god, I say to ask the masses if he is.”

“.....”

“Return to Mount Heaven right now.”

Sa Ryong-hui’s voice was filled with strength.

There was an intense outcry.

Woon-seong dismissed their complaints, silencing them.

“You sound ridiculous. ”

“...?”

Woon-seong’s voice made Sa Ryong-hui tremble.

Suddenly, Woon-seong’s eyes were glittering gold. A gray aura flowed out of his body and wrapped around Sa Ryong-hui.

Sa Ryong-hui’s back was immediately drenched with sweat, goosebumps appearing on his arms.

He felt like he was facing a wall of overwhelming horror.

A wall he could never cross.

And that wall told him, “Sa Ryong-hui of the New Dragon Battalion. There is no support for the religion of our Cult... Who said that?”

“Well, that’s...”

There was no need for him to explain.

All the Orthodox martial artists would have said the same thing.

Woon-seong knew that too.

“Then, I ask you, what is the difference between our Cult and the Martial Alliance?”

Sa Ryong-hui bit his lips. Blood flowed down his chin. As the metallic tang hit his tongue, it seemed a little bit of fear went away and he was able to answer.

“The Martial Alliance is a union of factions. It is in place to bring good to Murim. To punish the demons, destroy evils, and fill the world with orthodoxy and roots of the crown—”

“Enough.”

Woon-seong interrupted Sa Ryong-hui. He waved slightly.

A torrent of energy slammed into the prisoners. Overwhelmed by the Intimidation Qi, Peng Hak fell unconscious.

Woon-seong’s wrath was pouring over their heads.

Woon-seong snorted to himself, *Those who have been educated by the hypocrites are usually less stupid.*

“Then I ask, what is righteousness?”

“Well, that’s...”

Sa Ryong-hui did not dare answer the question.

Woon-seong continued speaking.

“Is it just to sacrifice someone for a grand cause? Then, do you think those sacrificed will still consider it a grand cause?”

Sa Ryong-hui suddenly remembered everything he had done in the name of Murim, all those he had sacrificed in the pursuit of a grand goal.

The New Dragon Battalion, including Sa Ryong-hui, had tried to ignore the sacrifices under the guise of justice.

With Woon-seong’s words, these scenes clearly came to mind.

“If not, is justice shouting for peace and prosperity, but then raising the Black Way sects and bandit groups to terrorize the masses, forcing the people to rely on the sects?”

Woon-seong had once been a part of the Orthodox faction.

That was why he knew better than anyone what the Orthodox did in their hypocrisy.

Woon-seong's words dug deep into Sa Ryong-hui's chest, like sharp arrows.

"Or is the virtuous man the one who trains and hires devils to kill all those who oppose him?"

"....."

Sa Ryong-hui could not say anything.

"I'll ask you again: what is a grand cause?"

"....."

"What is righteousness?"

Woon-seong's voice squeezed Sa Ryong-hui. He signed, shaking his head, "I don't know."

"I see," nodded Woon-seong.

While the conversation was going on, Gwan Tae-ryang could see his old self in Sa Ryong-hui.

You are trapped in the world you know, thinking that is all.

'Frog in a well.'

Gwan Tae-ryang recalled those words again.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong continued.

"Let me ask you something else. The Qinghai Alliance was afraid of our Cult and thus stole the boats of the fishermen and merchants, burning them all. It was our Cult that returned their livelihoods to them. Does that make me noble?"

"....."

Woon-seong went on.

“In Qaidam Basin, those so-called Orthodox factions forced sect members to sacrifice their own brethren for the cause. Powerless sects had no choice but to aim their swords at the Cult. It was this Lord who let them leave the battlefield alive when they surrendered. Then, am I the emperor?”

Regardless of political faction, Woon-seong’s actions were unthinkable — they were *just*.

However, to acknowledge the Cult of the Heavenly Demon as good and fair... It was a difficult task for Sa Ryong-hui, who had been educated by Murim for years.

“Grrrgh.”

Sa Ryong-hui groaned.

Woon-seong added, “The Cult also reduced the protection fees across our territory. Isn’t that honorable?”

“ I still cannot answer.”

To Sa Ryong-hui, Woon-seong’s words were filled with ridicule. He felt like asking what the hell the man was talking about.

“Then I’ll change my words again. Who is it that insists on insulting the nature of our Cult?”

Woon-seong’s question penetrated through time to look at the history of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. To be precise, it was a question about the very beginning, before the Cult of the Heavenly Demon came to be.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon was demonic.

But who made them demonic? Did the Founder like the word ‘demon’ and so used it when founding the Cult of the Heavenly Demon?

The answer was no.

The First Heavenly Demon chose ‘demon’ because of the attitude of the Orthodox.

Prior to the birth of the Cult, the Heavenly Mountains were merely a place for those who had fled Zhongyuan to live.

The First Heavenly Demon united them and pointed his sword against Zhongyuan, calling himself a demon and founding the Cult.

The First Heavenly Demon, Founder of the Cult, chose to become a demon in order to become Zhongyuan’s nightmare.

So while ‘demon’ was at the heart of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, it was the Orthodox who had made it so.

“.....”

Sa Ryong-hui failed to answer again. No, he *couldn’t* answer.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon he had learned about was just stories. Nobody had explained why they were called demonic.

I have been trained not to tell the truth, but to close my eyes and distort the lies until I believe it is the truth.

Sa Ryong-hui dared not answer.

“I still cannot answer.”

“.....There is benevolence in the demon, love within the demons, and the chivalrous amongst the demonic” (魔中仁, 魔中愛, 魔中俠).

‘There are heroes even amongst the Demonic.’

Those were the words of Nok Yu-on, Woon-seong’s master.

And what he said was the truth.

“.....!!”

Sa Ryong-hui raised his head.

“There is benevolence in the demon, love within the demons, and the chivalrous amongst the demonic. But does your faction allow you to see that?”

Woon-seong’s gaze swept across the believers. His words had made some of them teary.

They could not agree with him more.

They were not so different from ordinary people.

“Look, are they three-headed monsters? If not, do they seem to be drinking blood? Do they have horns on their heads?”

The Orthodox faction taught children that the demonic were not human.

Now, Woon-seong threw those words back at them, mocking the teachings as backwards.

Behold.

Even though the demonic live a life of pride, we are still human. We may push others to the limit, but we are still human.

Who was it that forced us to live so harshly and cruelly?

Do you have the right to tell us to stop?

Do you have the confidence to call yourself fair and righteous?

“I, I, the.... ”

Sa Ryong-hui dared not answer Woon-seong and continued to mutter meaningless words.

Watching such man, Woon-seong snorted lightly.

Eventually, he turned to Gwan Tae-ryang.

“Take him away. He will be kept in prison for a few days and then enslaved.”

Gwan Tae-ryang bowed, “Understood.”

Rising from the throne, Woon-seong seemed to have remembered something.

“Ah, take special care of the children of Tang and Peng. Never let them die.”

After all, they will become a great source of despair for the Tang and Peng Clans.

As Woon-seong words fell, Gwan Tae-ryang shouted, “Understood!”

Chapter 151: The Black Way (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 151 – The Black Way (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Faith.

Those were the values, the soul and banner, of the life one had believed in so far.

What would happen to someone whose faith collapsed?

Some would commit suicide.

Some would lose all will to live.

Others would be devastated.

Of course, there were also those who broke their pre-existing notions and developed different beliefs.

Just as people varied, so did their reactions to life-shattering information.

And what about Sa Ryong-hui?

What did Sa Ryong-hui do when it seemed like he had been unfaithful to his moral beliefs?

Sa Ryong-hui was devastated.

Behind the prison bars, Sa Ryong-hui sat motionlessly, his limbs still bound in solid chains. His eyes were unfocused, as if there was no life inside them.

It was as if he had lost his soul.

At first glance, since there was almost no movement, you would think he had died.

But he was not dead.

He was constantly mumbling to himself, proving his survival with his voice.

“Grand, right. Great, great. Righteous, right.”

The porridge in the bowl placed before him was drying, the man not having even touched it.

His mind seemed to only have the word ‘righteous’ in it.

Seeing such a miserable Sa Ryong-hui, the demonic practitioners watching over him sneered.

“He must have gone insane.”

“Tsk, tsk, those trained by hypocrites.”

“But it was quite good for the enemy.”

“Hmph, that’s just what you think. He tried to cover the sky with his palm, and then this happened.”

“Puhahahaha. He was pretty good at preaching too, I thought Confucius had come back alive.”

“Did you? Puhahaha.”

The derision continued, but it seemed inaudible to Sa Ryong-hui.

There was someone who slowly approached them.

Bang—

The guards turned their heads towards the entrance. Seeing a boy, they hastily bowed their heads.

“I greet the Young Master!”

“I greet the Young Master!”

The boy who had appeared was Kang So-san.

Kang So-san waved a hand, still embarrassed and awkward in front of their polite actions.

“Everyone, raise your head. It is burdensome.”

The guards smiled and raised their heads.

One of the guards approached Kang So-san and asked, “What brings you here? The air in the prison is not very good.”

Kang So-san’s eyes shifted, focusing on Sa Ryong-hui inside.

Seeing that, the guard shook his head. “I don’t know what you want to tell him, but I think he’s gone insane. It probably won’t go well if you try to talk to him.”

“Let me talk to him for a second. Perhaps he has not gone insane.”

The guards looked at each other, then one of them nodded. “We will be a little further away then. If there are any problems, please call us.”

“Thank you, Mr. Guard.”

Kang So-san thanked them, then patted his pockets. He pulled something out, which steamed. He held it out to the guards. "This is a potato cake noona made."

The guards seemed to be embarrassed.

"No, we cannot accept this!"

Kang So-san's older sister, Kang Ye-ha, sometimes used the ingredients inside the camp to cook for the demonic soldiers. Her food was very popular.

And Kang So-san was now offering them a potato cake.

The guards swallowed saliva unconsciously.

"We made plenty of them, please share them."

"Thank you, Young Master. Tell the Miss we'll eat well."

The guards took the potato cake and moved away with a content expression.

They had a mission to manage the prisons, so they did not go far. They moved to the corner, where they could still see inside.

Immediately, they started munching on the potato pancakes.

Meanwhile, Kang So-san approached the cell Sa Ryong-hui was kept in.

"Right, right, right, right, right."

Even until then, Sa Ryong-hui was repeating the same words, over and over again.

Kang So-san grieved at his appearance, grabbing at the cell bars.

"It's me."

Sa Ryong-hui stopped muttering, but there was still no light in his eyes.

Kang So-san called out once again.

“It’s me. You helped me then.”

Sa Ryong-hui’s eyes twitched. Suddenly, life began to flood back into his eyes.

Soon, his eyes focused and he turned towards Kang So-san.

“You.....”

Kang So-san nodded.

Meanwhile, slowly regaining conscious thought, Sa Ryong-hui looked around.

Wet moisture seeped through the straw on the ground, the walls were made of lattice grates.

There was no place for him to go; the wooden grates surrounded him, like a boundary between him and the world.

Clang—

His arms and legs felt heavy, so he looked down to where they were bound in chains. Seeing as they were pretty thick, it would likely take quite a bit of effort to break them

“I see. So that’s what happened.”

After confirming all these things, Sa Ryong-hui understood his situation. He nodded, then asked, “Why did you come to the prison? It is not a good place.”

“I am here because I was worried.”

“Worried?” Sa Ryong-hui echoed, his brows twitching. “Worry about yourself among the demons.”

At his words, Kang So-san shook his head. “Aye, they’re not as bad as you think.”

“Not bad people, what do you mean?”

“I heard many stories about the demons before I came here. I heard from my friends in the village. I also heard it from the martial artists of Murim.”

Sa Ryong-hui asked, “But...?”

Kang So-san hesitantly continued, “The Cult of the Heavenly Demon does not eat other people. They are also not tyrants. There are some people like that, but they are also despised inside the Demonic Cult.”

“Despised....”

“And about the Evil Path? It is hard for me to say because I don’t know, but people who walk that path are also exorcized in the Demonic Cult. Even if they are Demons, they are still human...”

Perhaps it was just the unorthodox path.

“Huh.”

“And all the people of the Cult-controlled land are saying that it is better now than it was before.”

“Is that true? ”

Kang So-san nodded. He then told Sa Ryong-hui, rambling, “Please ask for help. Master is a person who likes talent. If you are among the Demons, you’ll learn that they are all people, just the same. And if I ask Master to spare your life, he—”

“Enough.”

Sa Ryong-hui shook his head, cutting the boy off. Instead, he asked Kang So-san, “Why are you telling me this?”

Sa Ryong-hui and Kang So-san had only ever met once.

I taught him how to increase the sharpness of his blade, but that is it.

However, Kang So-san was telling him all of this to save his life.

Sa Ryong-hui was curious about Kang So-san's heart.

“Did your master tell you to go and say this? Surrender and we live?”

It was a question from the twisted mind of a man whose beliefs were crumbling. It could have been hurtful for the young Kang So-san to hear.

But Kang So-san was not hurt.

The boy shook his head firmly. “No, it is because you helped me.”

“What?”

“Because you helped me get here. So I want to help you.”

If he hadn't obtained tips from Sa Ryong-hui, Kang So-san would not be here.

Though it was not on the same level as Woon-seong, Sa Ryong-hui could also be considered a benefactor.

The young boy wanted to repay his benefactor.

His sincerity was conveyed to Sa Ryong-hui through his eyes.

With a bitter smile, Sa Ryong-hui muttered, “Maybe you shouldn't be among the Demonic. You're a kid with a hero's heart.”

Kang So-san resolutely answered, “I am going to be a demonic practitioner.”

Sa Ryong-hui's eyes widened.

However, Kang So-san continued: “I heard you and Master talking from some distance. ‘There is benevolence in the demon, love within the demons, and the chivalrous amongst the demonic.’ Even the villagers say that Master is taking care of them. I want to be that kind of hero.”

“That’s ”

Sa Ryong-hui was no fool. Although he had been swayed by Woon-seong’s words for a moment, he knew that the Heavenly Demon’s actions were filled with political intent.

And he wanted to tell Kang So-san the truth.

Soon, however, he shut up.

No matter what the intentions were, he could not deny that it had been beneficial to the people. And he didn’t want to shatter the dreams of a young boy.

Instead, he spoke of something else.

“You know...”

“.....?”

“Breaking faith is never easy. It is a denial of everything I have seen, heard, and believed thus far. It is a literal denial of my life. That is why faith cannot be broken so easily.”

...

“Yes, but a belief is also something that can be easily changed.”

“Yes?”

When Woon-seong had said that, Kang So-san had titled his head. *Faith is unbreakable, but it is also easily broken.*

That was hard to understand.

Sang Gwan-chuk explained in more detail: “No matter how firm your conviction is, it can still be shaken.”

“Ah.”

I still don't really understand, but somehow it makes sense. Kang So-san nodded his head.

“So, is it possible that Mr. Sa Ryong-hui will be on Master's side?”

Woon-seong shrugged and closed his eyes.

“Well.... ”

If something would break his faith.

Sang Gwan-chuk smiled and told Woon-seong, “That wouldn't be too bad. Although things have happened like this, he doesn't seem like a bad person.”

Woon-seong nodded.

“Maybe so.”

Chapter 152: The Black Way (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 152 – The Black Way (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Ta-da, ta-da.

Under a shaking lantern, there were men facing each other with serious faces.

“Have you heard the story? ”

“Yes. They say that both Qinghai and Gansu have fallen to the Demonic Cult.”

“Whoa, so the Demonic Cult is really coming?

They were the leaders of factions near the cities of Barkham, Guangyuan, and Jiuzhaigou [1].

Now that Gansu Province had fallen into the hands of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, their goal was to discuss what to do, since it was clear the Cult would be coming.

The Demonic Cult was strong enough to take down two provinces with minor damage.

Now matter how united they were, their factions would not be able to confront the Cult.

There had already been attempts where the sects gathered to fight against the Cult, both in Gansu and Qinghai.

There was the Qaidam Basin and the Qinghai Alliance. But both failed to overcome the tyranny of the Cult.

Their defeat proved that the medium-sized factions could not stop the advancement of the Cult, no matter how united they were.

It was natural for everyone to worry.

“Don’t worry so much.”

There was someone who spoke.

He was the oldest and most experienced of the ones gathered.

It was Nok Ho-kyung, the leader of Jiuzhaigou Gate in Jiuzhaigou. He was sitting near the top of the sect leaders.

As he spoke, everyone else went silent.

“We are the people of Sichuan. There are two elite factions in Sichuan that cannot be compared to others.”

“The Sichuan Tang Clan!”

“The Qingcheng Sect!”

The Sichuan Tang Clan, renowned for its control of poison and silent assassination. And the Qingcheng Sect, one of the major Taoist swordsmanship sects. They were the powerhouses of the Sichuan Murim, pillars that had never been broken before.

Recalling them, the sect leaders gathered relaxed.

“I hear they are working together to prepare for the Cult of the Heavenly Demon’s arrival. Are we not martial artists of Sichuan? If we join the battle, even the Cult of the Heavenly Demon will not be able to advance easily.”

“We shall march. We must show them the poisons of the Sichuan Tang, desolating their blood.”

Several of the sect leaders nodded. Poison was a weapon that allowed a third-rate to kill a second-rate and a second-rate to kill a first-rate.

Among others, the poison of the Sichuan Tang was special. If used well, they could defeat the Demonic Cult.

We see power in that...

The eyes of the Sichuan cultivators twinkled.

Nok Ho-kyung focused on these thoughts.

“In addition, there is a special relationship between the Sichuan Tang and Namman Yasu Palace, which has agreed to send 500 beasts, including memorandums and statues.”

The Namman Yasu Palace was a sect that spanned Kangho, from Inner Mongolia to Yunnan Province. Since ancient times, it held a special relationship with the Sichuan Tang.

Among the poisons that the Sichuan Tang made, some ingredients were only grown in very special places, which only the Namman Yasu could obtain.

Plus, the Palace trained beasts.

The memorandum referred to a rhinoceros, which had thick leather that swords could not cut.

The statue was a war elephant. With its massive stature and force, it could kill a man in an instant.

The beast squad dealt with such rhinos and elephants.

If 500 beasts were dispatched, then about 100 rhinos and elephants would be sent.

Hearing Nok Ho-kyung's words, the sect leaders shouted in joy.

"If they join, we'll be able to show just how poisonous this province is."

"Come on, let's get ready to join the Sichuan Tang and Qingcheng Sect! "

Several hasty sect leaders shouted, immediately looking like they were going to run and join.

Nok Ho-ryung stopped them.

"Now, calm down. Even if we join them, we are martial artists. We can't just run in, can we?"

"....?"

Some sect leaders titled their heads.

"It would be nice to fight the demons, but how should we do it? Hand to hand combat is a must, but is that the only tactic?"

Several sect leaders blinked; they were good at fighting but not very good at strategy.

One of the faster sect leaders exclaimed, "Scorched earth tactic!"

Nok Ho-ryung nodded, "That's right. "

"Wow, what a trick."

Even if they retreated, it was a tactic that burned and poisoned, leaving the enemy with nothing to use.

At that, the people gathered around the table had excited expressions.

“Hey!”

It was then that a loud noise was heard from outside.

Nok Ho-ryung frowned at the commotion. He opened the door of the room, screaming, “What’s with the noise?”

A guard respectfully bowed and answered, “The Black Law is here to see you.”

“Black Law?”

His eyebrows twitched.

At that time, a group of people poured into the room.

It was the Black Law Sect. They shouted as they rushed inside.

“What are you talking about?”

“What are you talking about?!”

Nok Ho-ryung chewed on his lips, finding them annoying.

One of the Black Law Sect members shouted, “I heard that Barkham, Guangyuan, and Jiuzhaigou will be abandoned.”

Nok Ho-ryung flinched. *Now that I think about it, how did they know we were here?*

Nok Ho-ryung turned and glared at the other sect leaders.

Several flinched. They were the ones who had been preparing to flee, and it seemed the rumor had gotten out.

Idiots. There’s no reason to hide now.

“So what does that have to do with you? ”

“Huh, you’re just going to abandon us?” the Black Way exclaimed.

That aroused Nok Ho-ryung’s anger. “Bullshit, abandoning? Someone would think that we were taking care of your Black Way horde!”

At his words, the Black Way members shouted back with righteous indignation: “When I doubled my protection fees, more than half of that money went into your pockets. We ransacked merchants in the marketplace, since you said you needed to build a store. You wanted a woman, so I kidnapped her. We’ve worked so hard, how can you abandon us?”

Nok Ho-ryung looked ready to collapse. “Bastards!”

His blade shone in the room.

It looked like he wanted to split the people into nine ribbons, but he only slashed one of them.

Sobbing-

“You’re talking nonsense with your useless mouths. If you don’t get out of here right now, I will have your heads. ”

“Ugh... ugh... ”

The Black Way members trembled

Everything the dead man just said was true.

The complete truth, with not one lie

Nok Ho-ryung and the others had supported the Black Way for their own interests. Under the pretext of defending his cause, he had not rooted out the weeds.

“Hey, what are you doing? Go away! If you don’t leave by the count of three, I’ll kill you all!”

At Nok Ho-ryung’s words, the other sect leaders also drew their swords

Clang-

The Black Way trembled; they were not the kind of people who could deal with the sect leaders.

In the end, the Black Way had no choice but to return trembling at the actions of the so-called Orthodox faction.

The fear tactics were as expected.

But there was something the Orthodox couldn't stop.

It was a rumor.

Rumors began to spread that the Black Way had been raised by the Orthodox faction themselves.

The Demonic Army, which had seized Barkham, Guangyuan, and Jiuzhaigou without battle, had settled nearby.

Even the demonic knew about the rumors going on in these three cities.

“Scorched earth... What an interesting move.”

Woon-seong heard the rumors and laughed.

“Don't worry.” Sang Gwan-chuk said, “Most of our supplies have been replenished and our secret lines are still intact. Even if the enemy goes the scorched earth route, it won't be a big deal.”

Woon-seong nodded.

“The other problem is the Black Way. The rumors spread publically that the Orthodox factions were raising them, so they're crying out about justice.”

“The factional bastards are just that hypocritical.”

Woon-seong looked down at the map of Sichuan as he said so. Of course, there were those who were not, but for the sake of profit, many would close

their eyes to injustice.

It was corruption due to the sweetness of money.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong despised those who prided themselves on being self-righteous.

Sichuan Tang, Qingcheng Sect.

And many other minor factions.

In fact, Sichuan could be said to be the hotbed of factions Woon-seong hated.

I can't forgive any of you.

Those who were faux righteous drove him and his master to their deaths. Woon-seong could not forgive those people.

Then a soldier approached the tent and called out, "My lord."

At the call, Sang Gwan-chuk walked out to hear the report. He then came back inside and repeated the information.

The content was simple.

"The Black Way people who have been tossed aside by the Orthodox faction wish to see the Leader. I do not know what it is about, so I will deal with them."

Woon-seong nodded, then stopped.

He then got up.

I wonder what they're thinking...

"No, I'll go and meet them for a while."

[1] Barkham, Guanyuan, and Jiuzhaigou are all cities in Sichuan Province, but near the border with Gansu Province

Chapter 153: Recruiting Sa Ryong-Hui (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 153 – Recruiting Sa Ryong-hui (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The lords of the Black Way factions huddled together with their heads bowed.

Around them, demonic soldiers stood. There was nowhere for them to escape.

One of the people poked the man standing next to him and whispered, “Uh, did we really make the right choice?”

The other man responded, “We’ve been abandoned anyway. Shouldn’t we survive by serving a new master?”

“Well, that’s not wrong..... ”

The first man knew what it took to survive in the Black Way. But now that they were here, the atmosphere didn’t seem right.

Moreover, his developed sixth sense continued to warn him.

Something bad is going to happen.

The man shook his head, trying to ignore his anxiety.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong walked out of the tent and sat on the throne in front of them.

“You said you wanted to see me? ”

“Well, yes.”

“You did not say what it was about. If I don’t like the reason you have asked to see me, you will be punished.”

At Woon-seong’s words, the Black Way began to tremble.

But after a moment, one of them said, “Please accept us.”

“Accept you?”

“That is right.”

Woon-seong laughed. He understood what they were thinking and what they had come for.

“It’s funny that a group of Black Way people would visit the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and ask us to accept you.”

“ ”

“What can I do with all of you?”

The men of the Black Way dared not open their mouths and respond.

“If there are two men under your command, I have 100,000. If you have courageous warriors, my brave fighters overflow. Is there any reason for me to accept you?”

At the question, a lot of the Black Way members closed their eyes.

One of them grabbed at straws.

“If you are willing to collect it, I will pay you a monthly protection fee. I will pay twice as much as I offered to the sects. Not only that, but half of the income from running the Salt Palace will be offered to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

“And?”

“Yes?”

“Is that all?”

“Oh, no,” the man trembled. “I can give you beauties. I will offer virgins and prostitutes, dancers too. Originally, when running the Salt Palace, women were sold instead of interest...”

As they spoke, Woon-seong waved a hand. A massive wall of energy crashed into their bodies. The leaders of the Black Way slammed their heads into the ground.

“Queek!”

Heavy force pressed them into the ground. It seemed like gravity had just become ten times stronger.

“Eek!”

They all groaned.

Sitting on his throne, Woon-seong spoke:

“I am the leader of a martial arts faction and also the leader of a religion. Do you know what the most important thing about leading a religion is?”

The answer to his question was not given by one of the Black Way, but by a demon.

“The Founder said it was the people. That is, the faith of the believers.”

To their reply, Woon-seong nodded.

“That is correct. But to broaden our gaze, it is important not only to strengthen the faith of the believers, but to elicit the faith of those who will become one.”

At Woon-seong’s words, the demonic practitioners bowed their heads.

Woon-seong was not talking about the Cult of the Heavenly Demon now, but the Cult of the Heavenly Demon moving forward.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon which would draw on the faith of those in Xinjiang, Qinghai, Sichuan, and Gansu.

“But if I accept you, will they really believe me?”

The Black Way did not answer Woon-seong’s question, only trembling. Some of them were already breathless.

“You are rats. I don’t like the hypocritical sects, but I don’t like the guys who scurry around like rats either.”

Woon-seong turned his head.

He shouted at the soldiers gathered:

“Cut their throats and hang them on display. Also, go to their sects and burn their buildings, distributing the accumulated goods to the nearby civilians. Keep in mind that this must be done in the name of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. If there is someone who covets these stockpiled goods with private greed, his head will fly and be displayed with these rats.”

After Woon-seong’s words, the demons knelt in unison.

“Understood!”

“Cu-Cult Leader, give us one chance.....”

The Black Way screamed and tried to persuade Woon-seong, but it was useless.

Woon-seong turned his back to them and entered his tent.

Sang Gwan-chuk watched Woon-seong leave with a satisfied smile. *You are turning into more of a true leader every day.*

“It’s hard,” Woon-seong muttered to himself.

He had never been in such a position before.

However, for vengeance, he had become the Cult Leader.

If it were the early Woon-seong, he would have been busy using the Cult for revenge after becoming the leader. But he could no longer do that.

Master, Woon-seong murmured.

Like Nok Yu-on, the ‘Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon’ Cheon Hwi was also Woon-seong’s master.

It was impossible to say that one was a better teacher because he had received many things from both.

Therefore, Woon-seong could not simply use the Cult for his own gain.

It is difficult being the leader.

Indeed, as the Cult Leader, he had to think and act for the future of the Cult. The fatigue it brought about was great.

This was not fatigue of the flesh, but of the mind.

With that fatigue, he slumped into a chair.

When revenge is done, Woon-seong thought. *When the Cult has reached the top, it would be nice to retire and roam the world without any cares.*

But why...?

Suddenly, his conversation with Cheon Ah-young came to mind....

Will you still be waiting for my answer after everything is done?

“Did you hear the story? The Cult of the Heavenly Demon has beheaded all of the Black Way and displayed their bodies.”

“At the Cult?”

“Yeah. They even started returning the stolen goods a few days ago.”

“Huh .Isn’t the Cult full of man-eating demons? You must be mistaken. ”

“I thought so too, but the rumors are true. The housekeeper next door got back all of his stolen belongings. My daughter, who was kidnapped, has also returned.”

“I can’t believe it.”

“But it’s true. Rumor has it that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon even got rid of the protection fees for a year.”

“No fees? That’s great!”

“It’s only a year, but it’s something. Along with that news, my wife also received a scripture from the Cult yesterday.”

Rumors circled about what the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had been doing nearby.

The voices praising the Cult also increased.

This resulted in a sudden lack of scriptures, which had all been printed in advance.

It was not long before the news entered Sang Gwan-chuk’s ears. The Strategist laughed brightly and ordered his men to create more booklets.

Thus, the doctrine of the Demonic Cult was spreading throughout the Central Plains.

It wasn't just him who heard of the rumors.

Sa Ryong-hui also heard the same things. Kang So-san came every day and told him this and that, but he also heard it for himself.

That happened? Sa Ryong-hui tilted his head as he listened to Kang So-san talk.

It wasn't just Kang So-san saying these things.

The things the guards talked about were also heard by Sa Ryong-hui.

So there was no way he wouldn't believe it.

Their actions are more virtuous than those of the factions.

He closed his eyes.

My beliefs so far have been shattered.

Now, I don't even know what to believe.

Sa Ryong-hui's spirit was like a small boat thrown into a rough storm.

What have I known so far and what have I observed?

What did I hold my sword for?

What the hell am I doing...?

His head was a mess.

I don't want to hear anything, I don't want to say anything.

At some point, even though Kang So-san came, Sa Ryong-hui didn't move.

He closed his eyes, closed his ears, and closed his mouth.

Of course, that didn't mean he was doing nothing.

He thought endlessly.

About his beliefs.

About his goals.

And a long time later, the next time Kang So-san visited, Sa Ryong-hui finally spoke.

“Your master, I'd like to meet the Lord of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon once again.”

“Beliefs don't change that easily. But given the occasion, even a small event can shake someone's convictions.”

Kang So-san suddenly remembered those words.

The boy nodded, smiling brightly.

Perhaps it was because of Kang So-san, but Sa Ryong-hui was able to meet with Woon-seong without difficulty, despite being a prisoner.

Woon-seong spoke first.

“You wanted to see me? ”

“Yes.”

It was a clipped response.

Sang Gwan-chuk, who was sitting to the side, twitched. Energy wrapped around Sa Ryong-hui threateningly.

Of course, Kang So-san, who was not aware of the situation, innocently glanced between Woon-seong and Sa Ryong-hui.

“That was a quick response.”

“Maybe, but it is because my beliefs have not been completely contradicted.”

Woon-seong laughed, mocking, “What tough conviction. I know that belief is great. ”

Sa Ryong-hui bit his lips. It was mockery, but he could not refute it.

At that time, Woon-seong tapped the table with his fingertips.

“So, what does someone whose path hasn’t been broken want to see me for?”

Sa Ryong-hui swallowed. He hesitated, then spoke with difficulty: “I would like to take a look around the Demonic Army’s camp.”

Sang Gwan-chuk’s eyes shook. Just as he was about to speak, Sa Ryong-hui added some words.

“I know it is a lot to ask. I would like to see the land and the religion of the Demonic Cult with my own eyes. If it is necessary, you can seal my energy and attach a guard.”

At that, Woon-seong laughed. He sipped on the tea in front of him.

Tak-

The sound of a cup being placed down echoed.

“That’s an interesting idea. Freeing someone from the sects into my camp is definitely interesting. ”

“.....”

“What do I get out of that? ”

Sa Ryong-hui closed his eyes at the question. He knew what he needed to say, but it wasn't easy. His lips trembled and his shoulders shook. Soon, he steeled his mind and spoke.

“I willl give it to you.”

“What?”

“If I am wrong, if I have lived in the wrong world, I will give you my life. ”

“Life.... ”

“You are free to kill me or save me. I will honor the Leader as my lord and wield my blade for the ascension of the Cult.”

Chapter 154: Recruiting Sa Ryong-hui (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 154 – Recruiting Sa Ryong-hui (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Puhahahahaha!”

Sa Ryong-hui’s words made Woon-seong burst into laughter, as if the man had said something hilarious.

The laughter made Sa Ryong-hui’s face twist.

I am prepared to bend my faith, and even said it aloud.

But here you are laughing at me like this.

But Sa Ryong-hui’s position was that of a captive.

He was nothing compared to Woon-seong, in both status and strength.

Sa Ryong-hui did not dare open his mouth.

How long did that laughter continue?

At some point, Woon-seong stopped. Silence filled the tent, like the laughter had been an illusion.

In the silence, Woon-seong's eyes were sharp.

“You tend to overestimate yourself.”

“...?”

“I will admit that you are talented for your age. But there are many people like you in the Cult. Do I have to go through all that trouble just to get one of you?”

Sa Ryong-hui clenched his fists. *After everything, this is it. I was eager to change my views and asked for a meeting, but I couldn't achieve anything.*

Sa Ryong-hui grit his teeth.

It seemed like he wanted to bite his tongue and commit suicide.

Then Woon-seong spoke again:

“I will allow it.”

Sang Gwan-chuk was surprised and exclaimed, “My lord!”

Woon-seong silently shook his head. He then spoke while looking at Kang So-san.

“I heard you helped my disciple?”

“Ah!”

Sa Ryong-hui suddenly remembered what happened in the inn a while ago. He certainly had helped Kang So-san once.

The relationship with Kang So-san continued then.

Woon-seong stared at Kang So-san, before turning to glance back at Sa Ryong-hui.

“Then let us consider there to be no debts after this. Senior Strategist!”

Sang Gwan-chuk immediately bowed his head, “I heed the words of the Cult Leader.”

“Assign someone to watch the New Dragon Leader so he can look around the Cult for the next ten days. Of course, I’ll keep his strength sealed for the meantime.”

Woon-seong reached out and grabbed his wrist. His energy flowed through like a maelstrom, solidifying in certain areas.

“If you try to use more strength than third-rate, the planted energy will explode and your veins will shatter.”

Sa Ryong-hui bowed his head at Woon-seong’s icy gaze, putting his arm down.

“Thank you very, very much. ”

Ten days was all the time allowed for Sa Ryong-hui.

It wasn’t just a random number. It was the same as the time given for the Demonic Army to rest before moving on to the next region.

To date, the militia of the Demonic Cult had continued to advance without proper rest.

Thanks to that, about $\frac{1}{3}$ of Sichuan had already landed beneath Woon-seong’s feet.

However, since they had gone for so long without rest, even martial artists would get tired.

They needed time to recover from fatigue.

But that was not the only reason.

The next group of enemies included the Sichuan Tang Clan, a family known as manipulators of poison.

When dealing with them, one had to always beware of poison.

It was natural to have antidotes for different kinds of poisons on hand.

Ten days was also the time to prepare these antidotes.

Most of the antidotes were carried by the Southern Army, who were located in the rear of the Demonic Army and would need ten days to prepare and distribute the supplies.

In other words, ten days was the time to prepare for the next battle.

What about the Western Army?

The Western Army, which was relatively less fatigued than their eastern allies, set out for the next region.

The Western Army was marching for the province of Ningxia, which touched both the Gansu and Shaanxi provinces.

If they successfully captured both Ningxia and Sichuan, then a total of four provinces, large and small, would belong to the Cult.

One third of Zhongyuan would be under the dominion of the Cult.

But it's too easy.

Woon-seong slowly closed his eyes.

If war was easy, it was natural to become complacent.

But that was the idea of the soldiers.

A leader should never think that way. The easier the battle, the more vigilant one should be.

You had to keep thinking about what the enemy was planning and what they were doing.

It was the Martial Alliance who had started this war. But the movement of the Alliance had been too quiet, especially after attacking the branches and calling for war.

Jwa Do-gyul is a cunning bastard.

Someone with three faces.

Perhaps he was preparing a number of tricks.

From there to the Imperial Court...

Woon-seong closed his eyes. Whatever the Martial Alliance was doing, he had to trust the mysterious Justice Alliance.

If the Justice Alliance was successful, they would be able to drastically reduce the power of the Orthodox factions.

This is the beginning of a complicated war.

Woon-seong sighed.

In the meantime, ten days passed.

Kung-

Sa Ryong-hui shook his head.

In front of him was the bronze sword he had been using as the leader of the New Dragon Battalion, broken in half.

He shouted:

“From this moment onwards, this one vows to Heaven that he will become a member of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, to be the sword of the Leader, to be the hands and feet of the Leader, to do everything in his power for the prosperity of the Cult!”

In response, all the demonic practitioners behind him bowed to Woon-seong.

“Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon!” Sa Ryong-hui shouted without looking behind him.

“Hail the Immortal Heavenly Demon!”

The Heavenly Demon’s life would continue for a thousand years and all demonic beings would obey him...

In the last ten days, Sa Ryong-hui has seen a lot of things under the watchful eye of his guard.

In the process, he learned that the Demonic Cult was not so bad, and that the demonic practitioners were the same as him.

All the ideas I had so far were biases and errors.

When he confirmed that, it felt like his wrong beliefs melted away like snow.

And a new belief settled in his heart.

It was closer to the truth this time.

If the sects are wrong and the Cult is wrong....

Even if the Cult has the name of demon, they can be saints.

Justice.

Do not forget to question your surroundings.

Woon-seong looked down at Sa Ryong-hui, asking, “You have committed to this Cult, but what about your colleagues?”

Sa Ryong-hui’s face hardened.

“And I am also the leader of those who killed your colleagues. Can you really follow me?”

Sa Ryong-hui swallowed. He had observed and thought about this question too.

But ten days was not a short time and Sa Ryong-hui had some answers.

“We did what we had to do.”

“Obligation...”

“The Leader and I were enemies at the time, and we cannot blame each other for what we did as enemies. ”

“What about your colleagues?”

“I will persuade them.”

Woon-seong laughed at the word ‘persuasion’. Sa Ryong-hui’s body was trapped, but his mind was awake.

What an interesting turn around.

Sa Ryong-hui never would have thought about such a thing if he hadn’t been awakened to the world.

Then, how many of the New Dragon prisoners have come to their senses?

Woon-seong laughed at that thought.

“I’ll allow you to persuade them. ”

“Thank you!”

Sa Ryong-hui slammed his head into the floor.

But Woon-seong’s words were not over.

“However, the people of the Tang and Peng cannot be persuaded.”

Sa Ryong-hui raised his head, eyes filled with questions.

“It won’t do any good to convince them anyway. ”

Woon-seong had received a list of factions who were influenced by the Cult of the Inverted Sky. The Tang and Peng Clans were included in that list.

Such people would not have surrendered to the Cult. No, even if they surrendered, their families would not approve.

Of course, he did not explain that to Sa Ryong-hui.

Woon-seong words contained strong certainty and Sa Ryong-hui nodded, even though he looked unsure.

Well, either way, Sa Ryong-hui had decided to become a believer of the Heavenly Demon.

“I allow Sa Ryong-hui to become a member of the Cult. However, until recently, he was an enemy, so he will not be appointed here.”

Woon-seong looked down at Sa Ryong-hui and said:

“As a soldier of this Cult, I order you to serve in war wearing white clothes for a hundred days. His position will be determined by his merits after this period is over. ”

Sa Ryong-hui bowed his head. “Understood!”

The Demonic Army, which accepted Sa Ryong-hui, began to advance again.

Towards the place where the Tang Clan and Qingcheng Sect awaited.

During the past ten days, antidotes had already been prepared.

The Cult’s march was unstoppable.

As a new member, Sa Ryong-hui dutifully marched. But everyday, he would visit his former colleagues to persuade them.

Among them were those who spat and called Sa Ryong-hui a traitor.

As expected, this group of people included the people of the Tang family. Peng Hak also ridiculed Sa Ryong-hui, calling him a groveling dog.

However, Sa Ryong-hui calmly tried to convince the others, not caring about the Tangs and Peng Hak.

He could not deny the fact that he had turned traitor, but he still had connections inside the New Dragon Battalion.

After his everlasting persuasion, some people agreed.

They too had the opportunity to take a look around the Demonic camp and its land, just as Sa Ryong-hui had.

Three of the captive New Dragons surrendered to Woon-seong, just like Sa Ryong-hui.

They were all part of weak or single-disciple sects.

Those from moderately sized sects never surrendered. Instead, they cursed the Cult, saying it wouldn't last long.

At the same time, the prisoners were all begging for their lives.

Woon-seong heard the story and laughed in relief, saying, "Just as well."

Unlike the smaller sects, those from larger Murim sects couldn't join the Cult.

It was an act of treason.

The three who surrendered to the Cult were ordered to serve in white robes, like Sa Ryong-hui.

Thus, in the army, there were four soldiers dressed in white, unlike the other demonic soldiers.

This all happened not long before the battle with the Sichuan Murim.

Chapter 155: The Chengdu Plains (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 155 – The Chengdu Plains (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The advance of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was unstoppable. Less than two months after starting the war, they had swallowed the Gansu and Qingcheng provinces.

Nevertheless, they did not stop, greedily advancing towards the Ningxia and Sichuan provinces.

And now?

About a third of Sichuan had fallen into their hands.

Rumor had it that Ningxia Province, which was much smaller than Sichuan Province, had already fallen into the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's hands.

Hearing this rumor, an elder of the Sichuan Tang Clan, Tang Jin-ryong, clicked his tongue. "Tch, stupid bastards."

In front of him were many of the masters of Sichuan who hoped to join the Sichuan Tang. They were, but said nothing.

It wasn't just because the man before them was the Grand Elder of the Tang Clan.

The Immortal Poison (老毒不死).

The *Gu* poison never dies, its toxicity only strengthenin over time.

That phrase, which symbolized the Sichuan Tang, were originally words that described this old man.

A legendary man who had mastered all of the tricks of the Sichuan Tang since childhood, then developed them to the next level.

When it came to poison, there was no one for him to follow, nor anyone for him to chase.

Because of this man, the people did not dare speak.

Tang Jin-ryong asked, "Is that why you abandoned your sects and fled? Because you were scared of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon?"

It was almost like a grandfather speaking to his granddaughter. But there was a sinister undertone.

The sect leaders trembled.

"Hah, I have nothing to say. "

"Of course not. Don't you think it would be too humiliating to say anything here? "

Tang Jin-ryong slowly got up from his seat. He walked towards a bonsai to the side.

Raising his hand, he touched one of the branches.

And then something amazing happened.

Pashhun-

One branch of the bonsai disappeared into ashes. Even though it had been teeming with vitality, it had only taken one breath for it to wither and crumble.

Watching this, the eyes of several sect leaders widened.

If they had made a mistake, they too would be turned into dust, just like the branches of the bonsai.

“Since you have come to join us, I won’t say anything else. It is a little late, but please work hard to protect the Sichuan Murim.”

“Oh, understood.”

“Detailed instructions will be handled by the main house and the Qingcheng Sect. Since the Martial Alliance is still preparing, they have decided to send a good master, so he will arrive soon.”

“A master...”

An absolute master in the eyes of some random person and an absolute master in the eyes of Tang Jin-ryong were two different things.

That was why the sect leaders were curious.

Tang Jin-ryong clicked his tongue, as if annoyed. “Tsk, I don’t know who was sent. But he is apparently a master comparable to the Buddhist Star and the Sword Star.”

“The Twin Stars!”

The sect leaders were amazed. It seemed that the world was greater than they thought, with more Semi-Divine Beings than previously believed.

They did not know where the Martial Alliance had gotten the help of such a master, but with this man’s help, they would be able to fight against the Heavenly Demon.

Everyone had the same thoughts, their faces lighting up with joy.

Then Tang Jin-ryong clicked his tongue again. “Tch. The plan will be finalized soon. If you follow the instructions, you will be able to give the demonic a taste of heat. So please do as you are told,” he instructed, sweeping a hand across the bonsai.

This time, it wasn’t just one branch, but the whole tree.

Fouszek-

The finely pruned bonsai disappeared into a pile of black ash.

That was a threat, showing them their ending if they didn’t listen. Thus, the sect leaders had no choice but to agree.

After the crowd left, Tang Jin-ryong was left alone in the room and stared at the ashes.

“Hmm.”

How long had he been staring at the ash?

He sighed and waved his hand, dispersing the powder into the air.

Tang Jin-ryong said, “Come out now.”

What did he see and who was he talking to?

Once he spoke, darkness in the corner of the room rose. It shivered, like rippling waves, and a man slowly walked out.

“Hwan Dok.”

It was Hwan Dok, the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion.

It was the man who deceived even his allies into oblivion and belonged to the Cult of the Inverted Sky. It was the man who had entered the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and inflicted great damage to the Cult.

Such a man appeared in the Sichuan Tang.

“It’s been a while,” chuckled Hwan Dok.

The Demonic Emperor of Oblivion seemed to be quite familiar with the Sichuan Tang’s Grand Elder.

That was surprising.

Tang Jin-ryong’s attitude was also quite surprising. .

“Don’t pretend we are close.”

Tang Jin-ryong, who should have been attacked and become a pile of blood, received a bold response instead:

“You and I are in a cooperative relationship, are we not very close?”

Hwan Dok shrugged and continued, “That’s sad. I thought there was a connection there, but you—”

“You didn’t come to me to talk nonsense, did you? ”

Hwan Dok grinned, revealing yellowed teeth. “They’ll be here soon.”

Tang Jin-ryong’s eyebrows twitched. His expression seemed to be asking, ‘Who?’

“Didn’t you say it yourself? I’m talking about the best hidden card.”

Tang Jin-ryong nodded slowly. “A master comparable to the Buddhist Star and Sword Star... I said it as I heard it, but I still can’t believe it.”

As he said, masters at the Semi-Divine Realm were not beings you could just run around and find on any given day. It was rare for even one to appear each generation.

Although there were only three Semi-Divine Beings at the moment, that was still a lot. On average, there might only be one or two who existed in a generation.

However, it was not surprising that the Cult of the Inverted Sky had a hidden Semi-Divine Being.

“Hehe, this is the power of our Cult. Don’t you think you made the right choice by working with our Cult?”

The question made Tang Jin-ryong think. Neither positive nor negative. He shrugged, not saying anything.

There was an awkward silence.

After a while, Tang Jin-ryong could not hide the awkwardness. “The Tang Clan has been working with you for the glory and future of our House, so I have no interest in the deceit of yours. You must keep your promise.”

“Of course. We are loyal to our partners. I don’t know if the Qingcheng are doing so well though.”

As he said so, there was a sullen expression on Hwan Dok’s face.

Ta-da!

About 300 martial artists had come from Qingcheng. They were gathered together, warming themselves around a campfire on the other side of the Tang House.

Although the House had prepared an annex for them, they deliberately chose this inconvenient place.

The reason why soon came to light.

“We will not rest in a comfortable place until we have avenged our elders.”

To sleep on brushwood and taste gall.

To maintain one’s resolve for revenge (臥薪嘗膽).

To prepare oneself for difficulties and intentionally lead an uncomfortable life. It was the leader of the Qingcheng people who said that.

With the successors of the First Apprentice all deceased, this man was temporarily the leader of the Qingcheng Sect.

“First Apprentice, the Swords of Qingcheng, all died in the hands of the Demonic Cult. This has caused us to lose even the Sword of Blue Clouds and Red Sunset, along with the major forces of our sect.”

To his words, the swordsmen of Qingcheng gripped their swords tightly.

“With such loss, how can we rest comfortably?”

The swordsmen of Qingchen shouted:

“We must get rid of the Demonic Cult.”

“We must behead the Heavenly Demon as tribute to our ancestors!”

“The demonic will die, as long as they are human. I will put my blade through their hearts!”

These were words that did not follow the *Tao*.

This was because although the Qingcheng Sect was considered to be Taoist, they had a tendency to be harsh.

Even then, their words were a little excessive.

Han Chong, one of the Qingcheng Sect elders, nodded as if he liked the idea. “When there is a battle, this one will stand as the vanguard. Never fall until we can put a sword through their hearts.”

The others bowed, “We receive the words of the elder.”

Han Chong nodded in satisfaction. He then patted his pocket. *A pill that will increase my qi by several times.*

It was something that Hwan Dok had given him. If the effects were true, it would be good to use it during the battle with the Heavenly Demon.

But he couldn't trust Hwan Dok's words so easily, so he moved his hand from the pocket. *I don't have to use it.*

Even if it was the Heavenly Demon, the man would not be able to take the force of 300 Qingcheng swordsmen.

Han Chong believed in the power of Qingcheng.

That was only a few days before the Sichuan War.

"The Sichuan Union is waiting in Chengdu."

The city of Chengdu was a region of plains.

You could walk for seven days across Chengdu, only on flat land.

The meaning of preparing to fight the Cult there was simple:

"They want to fight straight from the beginning."

"Maybe they're just trying to use the best landscape for their beast army."

Woon-seong nodded. In order for the rhinoceroses and elephants to run properly, open plains were much better compared to narrow canyons or rugged mountains.

"Since we never faced a proper struggle, perhaps they thought we might be weak."

After all, the all-out in Qaidam Basin had been short.

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded in agreement.

Woon-seong asked, "What is it like?"

"Qingcheng is at the front, then the wild beasts, and the Sichuan sects at the back."

Woon-seong furrowed his brow. “The Sichuan Tang are missing.”

“They are at the rear, but they are camped a few hours away. It seems to be because some poisons need to be supplied by the Sichuan Tang...”

As soon as Sang Gwan-chuk said that, Woon-seong laughed. “The Sichuan Tang Clan have always had a nasty side.”

“Perhaps they intend to join the fight later and minimize damage.”

Woon-seong nodded. They were Orthodox, but they had always been insidious. This was true of many factions, but especially so for the Sichuan Tang Clan.

Nok Yu-on had disliked the Sichuan Tang. Therefore, it was only natural for his disciple, Woon-seong, to also dislike the Sichuan Tang.

On top of that, the Sichuan Tang had clearly been involved in the death of Nok Yu-on.

“Strategist, do not forget to check the formation.”

“Understood,” Sang Gwan-chuk bowed his head. He then asked, “What should we do about the rest?”

Woon-seong turned to look at Sichuan Province and the clouds above.

“If they want an all out war, then we will match them in stride.”

Chapter 156: The Chengdu Plains (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 156 – The Chengdu Plains (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Chengdu Plains.

The vast plains that would take seven days and seven nights to pass through from end to end.

The armies stood on opposite ends of the plains, facing each other.

They were quite far from each other. It wasn't clear, but both sides were still able to recognize the other.

On one side, the flags of Sichuan were clearly flying; it was a sea of Zhongyuan banners.

However, the ones on the other side were not nearly so colorful.

It was a sea of black flags. Two of them stood out: one with rows of black dragons with beady eyes and another with hundreds of handprints.

These flags alone revealed the identities of the two forces.

The colorful ones were obviously those of the Sichuan Union, an alliance of forces gathered to fight the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The other side, of course, was the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Gwan Tae-ryang was leading the Demonic Army.

There was someone walking ahead of him though: Woon-seong.

The Heavenly Demon spoke to the Demonic Army as they slowly approached the enemies:

“You know what? They have provoked our Cult so despicably.”

Roar, roar!

Woon-seong’s voice echoed through the air, rumbling like thunder across the plains.

To his voice, the Demonic Army swallowed slightly, anticipating his words.

“They chose this place to make war because they are looking down on our strength.”

Woon-seong never stopped moving forward.

Crunch, crunch.

Woon-seong grew closer and closer to the Sichuan Union.

“Then, we must show them. The Martial Alliance cannot ignore the power of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.”

Beyond the Demonic Army, Woon-seong’s voice was clearly conveyed to the Sichuan Union.

The soldiers of the Union swallowed, throats drying.

But their reason for swallowing was different from the demonic soldiers.

The demonic believers swallowed due to awe; the Union swallowed due to fear.

It was swallowing due to intense tension.

As the tension increased, Woon-seong stepped into the air.

Ta, ta, ta.

Someone muttered, “Void Walking...”

A legendary technique that only those of the Semi-Divine Realm were capable of.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong had climbed into the sky and arrogantly looked down at the Sichuan Union.

In a thunderous voice, he commanded: “Go.”

Rah, rah!

At his shout, the Demonic Army began to advance.

Seeing how the army marched, Woon-seong added, “Go and sweep them away.”

The advancing forces seemed like rolling black waves.

Wahhhhh—

Two waves of soldiers collided.

Clang—

There was a series of blade clashes, then commotion and chaos.

The mayhem only escalated from there.

The Charred Dragon Unit dug in between the enemies and the Samsara Demonic Cavalry crushed enemies under foot.

The apprentices of the Qingcheng Sect started to run amok and the beasts of the Palace ran wild.

Faaaah—

With its large trunk, a war elephant wiped out all demonic soldiers that came close to it. The rhinoceros charged any soldiers with its horns.

The Namman Yasu Palace was magnificent, as these tamed beasts allowed the army to unleash the power of real beasts, not humans.

Even the fanatics called the Demons were afraid.

Actually, correction: not all the demons were afraid of the Beast Squad.

Gwan Tae-ryang had changed his direction. He then stared at the rhino charging his way. *We have lived with beasts far more savage than these mere animals.*

Boom. Boom.

Wherever the rhino ran, the ground shook. Its horn seemed to sharpen.

Gwan Tae-ryang's thighs bulged, lowering his stance as he charged towards the rhino.

Kaga-bang!

The rhino's and Gwan Tae-ryang's blades collided, a beam of light blinding the surrounding soldiers.

Shua—

A severed horn flew into the air.

Instead of stopping there, Gwan Tae-ryang rotated his body. As he twisted at his waist, he hooked his legs and was suddenly on the rhino's back.

Puchi—

Gwan Tae-ryang stabbed at the hides covering the rhino. Although the animal wore tough leather and armor, they were unable to withstand the blade.

With shattered leather, the rhino collapsed.

After disposing of a rhino, Gwan Tae-ryang turned and aimed for an elephant.

Elephants were large, meaning they were bigger targets than rhinoceros.

At the same time, an elephant was stronger than a rhinoceros. They were usually mild creatures, but war had trained them to rampage.

Boom, boom!

The elephant's trunk slammed into Gwan Tae-ryang's body. He endured the attacks, searching for a gap.

Thwack—

Scrambling along the trunk, he slammed his blade into the elephant's spine.

Fuuuuuaaaa—

The elephant fell to the side, screaming for a long time. With an injury to its spine, it was unable to get back up.

Gwan Tae-ryang stabbed it in the head, smashing its brain, just for good measure.

Then, it was time to find the next target.

It was not only Gwan Tae-ryang who was slaughtering prey left and right.

The Blood Tears Mask Demon ran his horse without rest.

“Hehe!”

His subordinates, the Samsara Demons, chased after him.

Deng, deng, deng.

The hooves of the horses rumbled across the plains, sending vibrations through the hills.

The Mask Demon and his men crushed the men of the Sichuan Union, crashing through blades and soldiers alike.

The black horses they were riding were not ordinary horses, but well-trained beasts — a horse that was trained in the hands of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

A third-class soldier collapsed in a single kick, weapon broken. These horses could also deal with a second-rate martial artist with ease.

And what if the riders of these powerful horses were known as the Ghosts of War?

The Samsara Demonic Cavalry became a massive storm; a black storm that raged through the enemies.

Blood splattered on all sides.

Pieces of fleshed rained to the ground.

The Samsara Demonic Cavalry was overwhelming.

Woon-seong, who had dispatched the troops, also descended from the air and engaged in battle. The spear in his hands danced as he swept the enemies away.

Woon-seong’s spearmanship was truly astonishing.

There was no one who could break his flow.

Stab.

Stop.

Turn around.

Disarm.

Kill.

The beautiful dramatics of martial arts, which Woon-seong could unfold through the spear, was shown by the Heavenly Demon without rest.

It seemed like no one could stop Woon-seong's movements.

“Ahhh!”

“Die!”

Two soldiers brandished their swords at Woon-seong. At that moment, Woon-seong lightly stepped on the ground.

Kua—

The ground crumbled beneath his feet and the Divine Flame began to rise. The surging flames shifted into the shape of a spear and slammed into the two soldiers.

“Cough!”

“How is he human—”

They coughed blood, skewered by the spear of flames.

Uncaring, Woon-seong moved forward.

No matter who or how others tried attacking Woon-seong — rhinos and elephants included — it made no difference.

Everyone and everything ended up like the previous two martial masters — dead.

“Palm of the Heavenly Demon.”

Boom—

Woon-seong’s flames hit the abdomen of an elephant. The animal was left bleeding from a large gash and there was a huge hole in its armor, like something had passed through it.

It was like a vortex had erupted and passed through the animal’s massive body, leaving only embers in its trail.

There was also a scar across the earth as the move had passed by.

Seeing the results, Woon-seong smiled with satisfaction.

At this time, three rhinos surrounded Woon-seong and charged. It seemed like at least one giant horn would pierce the young man’s body.

Seeing them, Woon-seong burst into laughter. His lips curled, revealing bright white fangs.

As soon as fangs, like those of a god of death, appeared, so did the White Night Spear.

The ‘Art of Six Seals and Destruction’.

Scorching the earth like a giant fire, just six moves were enough to destroy the Heavens.

Woon-seong’s spear cut through the sea.

No, to be precise, he had broken the ocean.

Break the Vast Sea.

Pieces of the broken sea roared, swallowing the three rhinos in no time. Their bodies were swept away and ripped apart.

When the spear move had finally ended, the three rhinos had disappeared. The only trace they had ever existed were puddles of blood.

The battlefield was like a gathering place for monsters and demons.

These plains, where dozens of demons and monsters roamed, was the true picture of war.

The Charred Dragon Unit, including Gwan Tae-ryang, were like devilish monsters. So too, were the Samsara Demonic Cavalry.

Woon-seong was neither a demon nor a monster. He was simply a man who had surpassed absolution and reigned above others.

Then, was the Cult the only one with demons and monsters?

No, they existed among the Orthodox too. Even the fiendish beasts who exerted terrifying power against the demonic soldiers could be considered demons.

And the three hundred swordsmen of Qingchen could be considered devils. Despite numbering only 300, they moved through the battlefield with surprising ease.

Everyone in their way was swept away by a wave of blades. It was a huge ocean, an ocean formed by the swords in their hands.

There was blue at the center of these red waves.

The 'Wave Sword Sea Formation' (波浪劍海陣).

Once upon a time, there was a young man named Bo Lang from Qingcheng who wanted to visit the sea. Born and raised inland, he had never actually seen the sea, but longed to visit the coast.

However, it was not easy to get from Sichuan to the coast. Moreover, he was a young man who was not allowed to visit the coast due to his mother's illness.

Perhaps, that young man's earnest desire to see the sea reached the Heavens.

One day, a deity appeared in his dreams and showed him a sea of swords. So when Bo Long woke up from his sleep, he had created the Wave Sword Sea Formation. [1]

The Wave Sword Sea Formation moved hundreds of swords like scattering waves, concentrating all the power in a single sword like a tidal wave.

It was no wonder any demonic soldier in their path was unable to even fight back, washed away in a tsunami of energy.

Soon the Qingcheng saw a huge pillar of flame in the distance.

Unlike ordinary flames, it seemed to burn on in silence.

The Divine Flame.

The one who saw the flames screamed, "Heavenly Demon!"

At that moment, Woon-seong also turned towards them. "Qingcheng Sect!"

A sea of swords rushed towards Woon-seong.

[1] In Chinese (the name of the formation is in Hanja), the character for 'sword' is pronounced 'jian', and so is the character for 'see/meets'. The name for the formation thus sounds a lot like "Bo Lang Sees the Sea"

Chapter 157: Erasing Qingcheng (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 157 – Erasing Qingcheng (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

It was around the time when Woon-seong began to collide with the Wave Sword Sea Formation of Qingcheng.

There were three pairs of eyes watching the scene from a little distance off the field.

No, it was actually two pairs. One of them was only full of whites, like there was no soul at all.

One man opened his mouth first.

“Here we go.”

His eyes were focused on the conflict between the Heavenly Demon and Qingcheng.

In the distance, someone on Qingcheng’s side was shouting. His words couldn’t be heard from here, but he must have been angry.

The man watching the same scene, Hwan Dok, curled his lip slightly and asked the first man, Tang Jin-ryong, “Do you think the Qingcheng can catch

the Heavenly Demon?”

Tang Jin-ryong paused, then responded, “The Taoists are strong.”

“.....”

“In particular, the swordsmen are very strong, and the Qingcheng occupies one of the Five Mountain Sword Alliance.”

“So do you think that the Qingcheng can catch the Heavenly Demon?”

Tang Jin-ryong nodded. “It is possible.”

“Hah, your jokes have increased,” Hwan Dok cackled.

Tang Jin-ryong also chuckled. “Perhaps it would have been possible a hundred years ago.”

A hundred years ago, the Qingcheng Sect had once surpassed the Mount Hua Sect to become the greatest sword sect in Murim.

Qingcheng had really been at its peak back then. At that time, the Qingcheng were even capable of fighting the Wudang Clan and Shaolin Temple.

But now?

Impossible.

The Qingcheng Sect, which had been poisoned by the Cult of the Inverted Sky, would never be able to catch the Heavenly Demon.

Hwan Dok knew this, as did Tang Jin-ryong.

“What a nasty habit you have, asking a question you already know the answer to.”

Hwan Dok laughed.

Tang Jin-ryong continued to speak, not caring about the man's reaction. "Still, the Heavenly Demon can't be in good shape after dealing with the Qingcheng."

"Ho, you make it sound like the Wave Sword Sea Formation can hurt him."

Tang Jin-ryong smiled bitterly at the man's words. He knew how powerful Semi-Divine Beings were.

The Wave Sword Sea Formation was definitely powerful, but it wouldn't do much to hurt the Heavenly Demon.

However.

"The meaning of fine or not does not necessarily have to refer to the physical wounds on the body."

The Heavenly Demon would need to do his best to deal with the formation.

In the end, even if he wiped out all the Qingcheng without a wound, he would have least used up half his energy.

"After that, it's your turn, right?"

Tang Jin-ryong glanced over at Hwan Dok.

The man smiled, then turned to the person next to him. "It's this thing's turn, not mine."

This thing.

It was inappropriate to call a person a 'thing', but the man did not seem uncomfortable at all.

"A flawless corpse puppet made using the Sword Emperor of Ice and Light... You really succeeded in making it."

The thing in front of him was a monster in humanoid form, not a real person.

Demon-Awakening Corpse Puppet.

A technique that reanimated the dead, making it into a puppet and controlling it — a necromantic technique that the Cult of the Inverted Sky had developed after experimenting with blood jiangshi.

The Sword Emperor of Ice and Light, the base body for this puppet, was a Semi-Divine Being of the past who had the power to subvert the world. If the puppet could completely reproduce his skills, it would not be easy for even the Heavenly Demon to knock it down.

Unfortunately, a puppet would not be able to completely reproduce the skills of the original.

“Don’t praise me like that. It’s not perfect.”

“Hmm.”

“But I am confident that it has 80% of the Sword Emperor’s skills. Perhaps this will be enough to deal with the Heavenly Demon, who will have less than half his strength after dealing with the Qingcheng. Of course, it won’t kill the Heavenly Demon.”

Tang Jin-ryong nodded. The Sword Emperor was just a corpse puppet now. He had no intention of giving such a thing the honor of killing the Heavenly Demon.

I shall slash the Heavenly Demon’s throat myself.

That way, the glory of the Tang Clan would continue for a hundred years, even if they didn’t join the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

Thinking of that that, Tang Jin-ryong smiled.

Seeing that, Hwan Dok laughed to himself.

Heeheehee.

It was an evil cackle.

Woon-seong stared at the surrounding sea of swords. They swirled like waves, wrapping around his entire body.

He reached out to those swords.

Kwa-rung –

With the sound of thunder, the Heavenly Demon's energy struck the swords.

At that moment!

Glug-ug-

Dozens of swords swept over the Heavenly Demon, roaring. Suddenly, the Wave Sword Sea Formation violently trembled.

“Khh!”

“Huff!”

Each of the swordsmen groaned. Surprisingly, however, the Wave Sword Sea Formation had not broken.

It had overcome the strength of the Heavenly Demon.

“No matter how strong his attacks are, when divided amongst several people, the impact isn't that great!” one man shouted from the center.

Woon-seong zeroed in on him and laughed, “Clearly.”

“Attack once more!”

Glug-ug-

The two arms of the man moved again, his sword streaking through the air.

At that moment, the Wave Sword Sea Formation swarmed Woon-seong once again. Dozens of swords rushed to strike, stab, and slash.

Woon-seong swung his spear as he saw it. The White Night Spear pushed towards the black sea of swords.

And...

Kaga-shua –

The White Night Spear slammed the swords back.

It was no wonder that Woon-seong's lips curled.

“It was a good idea for you to share strength in order to defend, but you didn't gather enough strength to attack.”

With his bare hands, Woon-seong caught several of the swords. It was like he was holding a stick.

“These sticks, it doesn't matter how many times you try to stab me with them.”

“Grrrgh!”

The Qingcheng groaned and slowly pulled back.

It wasn't just because they were scared.

It was to maintain the formation against the monster known as the Heavenly Demon.

One of the leaders looked around, then decided. “I'm going to be the center of the formation.”

“We hear the words of the elder!”

As soon as the command was issued, the Wave Sword Sea Formation began to change. Unlike how one man had been at the center, controlling everyone

else, the elder had walked out.

Behind him, the other swordsmen lined up, forming crane wings.

It was as if all of the energy from the formation was being channeled into one person.

Woon-seong's eyebrows twitched.

It wasn't just in appearance. In fact, all the energy from 300 swordsmen were indeed being gathered into that one man.

The energy of 300 men was not something to ignore.

Although there would be some loss of energy, it was an insane amount.

Even if you compared it to the amount of qi Woon-seong had inherited from Cheon Hwi, it wouldn't be lacking!

As if to prove that, the man's blade was trembling.

Kwang—

There was what seemed to be a lightning strike and Woon-seong's toe was sliced off.

Kuakua—

If Woon-seong hadn't stepped back, his leg might have been cut off.

There was a deep furrow in the ground and dust billowed.

Within the swirling dust, the man's sword shone blue.

It was sword qi.

A sword so powerful that it was on par with Woon-seong.

The sword was shaking with energy. A massive vortex of qi seemed to be wrapping around the area.

Seeing that, Woon-seong slowly raised his spear.

Soon, there was a turbulent storm of energy raging around the White Night Spear, comparable to the Qingcheng's.

Rain of Star Destruction.

Death Moon of the Dark Night.

Divine Wind of the Past.

Break the Vast Sea.

And then what?

His fifth move would destroy the earth after the sea.

Hell's Punishment to the Land.

It destroyed the earth and banished all life.

A name fitting of the fifth move of the Art of Six Seals and Destruction, which broke even the Heavens on the sixth.

A ferocious skill revealed itself.

A torrent of torn trunks were caught up within the qi, wrapping around the White Night Spear. The storm seemed to be about 5 meters wide now.

Woon-seong swung his spear.

It was an ordinary arc.

Just that.

But the results were extraordinary.

A giant pillar of light seemed to connect the Heavens and Earth in a single blow.

Guaguaguaguaya-

An illusion that the world had ended appeared, like life itself had been torn into two pieces.

Massive waves swept the field, out of control.

Kuakuakua—

The ground split open. The waves of energy swept beyond the Qingcheng Sect and crashed into the Sichuan Union.

“Ahhh!”

“How’s that a human?”

“He’s not a human being!”

Screams erupted everywhere.

However!

“Ahhh...”

“Shhh.”

One man survived the apocalypse. Both his beard and eyebrows had been burned away, his clothing torn to rags, but he endured.

“Khh,” the man groaned, struggling to get on one knee.

Woon-seong smiled coldly. “Hmm.”

The Qingcheng Sect had driven Nok Yu-on to his death. Not only were the Three Swords of Qingcheng his sword enemies, but all of the Qingcheng Sect were on Woon-seong’s death note.

So he did not intend to kill them so easily. And now one of them was refusing to die like so.

Revealing his white fangs, Woon-seong said, “Defy me more. Make it more enjoyable!”

He moved his left hand.

“That way, I can feel that killing you was worthwhile.”

The Divine Flame roared to life, wheels of flame appearing on his left hand.

The Heavenly Demon’s Wheel of Samsara.

“Let the Qingcheng Sect burn, as well as Qingcheng Mountain, then I can laugh all I want.”

A massive flame stretched around from the Heavenly Demon’s Wheel. Overwhelming pillars of fire surged in all directions.

The heat seemed to distort space.

A nearby soldier caught on fire, quickly disappearing into ashes.

There were screams from all around.

“Don’t come any closer! ”

“We’re being swept away!”

“Keep your distance! ”

The heat was so great that weak martial artists would lose their life just from being nearby.

Woon-seong gripped his wheels tighter.

“Try harder. ”

He threw the wheel at the Qingcheng swordsmen.

A huge wheel of flames crushed towards the soldiers.

Seeing the scene, Woon-seong's voice was cold as he declared:

“Today, the Qingcheng Sect shall be erased from the earth.”

Kuakuakuakua-!

Chapter 158: Erasing Qingcheng (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 158 – Erasing Qingcheng (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

It was around the time when Woon-seong began to collide with the Wave Sword Sea Formation of Qingcheng.

Crackle—

A huge fire blazed. Silent flames spread out in all directions, burning the surroundings.

Bloom-

The heat was so intense that the surrounding space seemed to be distorted.

The Heavenly Demon's Wheel.

Tendrils of flame emanated, consuming nearby soldiers.

“Ahhh!”

“Huff-puff!”

Screams sounded everywhere; ash billowed into the air.

The Qingcheng Sect had the greatest number of casualties.

They were within the direct range of the Heavenly Demon's Wheel, and more than a dozen people were burnt to a crisp in the first blow.

Surprisingly, though it was hit with the Heavenly Demon's Wheel, the Wave Sword Sea Formation did not collapse.

“Grrrgh.”

The elder slowly raised his head, straightening his knees as he stood up.

Immediately after....

Bzzt!

Blue lightning flashed in front of Woon-seong, tearing the Heavenly Demon's Wheel apart.

Seeing that, Woon-seong laughed, as if he found this very interesting. “Oh-ho.” *I heard that you were very strong, but I didn't think you could stop it.*

Woon-seong's smile was frosty, but the other side was still staring.

How can the demon be so powerful?

His eyes were one Woon-seong, but his heart was filled with fear. The hands gripping the sword trembled.

In the eyes of this elder, Woon-seong's power was beyond human understanding. He had never met someone of the Semi-Divine Realm before, so this was quite natural.

Can one be this strong simply by stepping into Heaven's threshold?

To be more precise, it was surpassing the status of a human.

The man did not know this, but fear of Woon-seong was deeply branded into his bones.

First Apprentice.

The elder remembered the First Apprentice, who had died, and couldn't hide his trembling hands.

Although the energy of some 290 people flowed into the sword in his hands, it still seemed too little.

Is there no other way?

The man felt like he was facing Death.

It was difficult to say that the Heavenly Demon was not just another word for Death coming to him.

In that situation, something suddenly popped into his head.

— *Really?*

It was a voice inside the man's head. His hand twitched as he grabbed at his chest, feeling a few small pills.

But because this was medicine made by the Cult of the Inverted Sky, it was not trustworthy. However, Hwan Dok had said that ingesting it could amplify internal qi by several times.

— *If you eat this, you can achieve anything you want.*

As the man's hands trembled, the voice of Hwan Dok continued to echo within his mind.

Under normal circumstances, the man, Han Chong, would have realized that this was the beginning of some illusionary scam.

But this time, the situation was bad.

Han Chong was frightened by the overwhelming presence of Woon-seong.

Fear covered his entire body and his back was covered in cold sweat, making his entire body feel heavy as a wet cotton ball.

The temptation of immediate power amplified inside his mind because of that fear.

So he did not care that it would be his downfall.

Han Chong stuffed a pill into his mouth.

“You ate the Drunken Dream Pill,” Hwan Dok muttered as he watched the fight between Qingcheng and the Heavenly Demon from a distance.

Tang Jin-ryong turned and asked, “What did you say?”

Hwan Dok shook his head. “It’s nothing.”

The Demonic Emperor of Oblivion was waiting to see the effects of the pill with cold eyes.

You might not know it, but that pill is a failure.

His mouth was curled into a pitying sneer.

Pill of Drunken Dreams.

This pill, which induced the wayward dreams of a drunken man, was something created by the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

No, it was more than just a failed pill.

While it did indeed increase the internal qi of the user, the user would be quickly consumed by their hallucinations and fall into intoxicated madness.

The insanity that the Drunken Dream Pill induced was not very special. It merely made the user become controlled by their base desires and emotions.

The main problem was when these emotions or desires were too strong.

“Hahaha, die, Heavenly Demon!”

As the energy within the Drunken Dream Pill entered his body, Han Chong felt the internal qi in his body fluctuating.

The power of Qingcheng was added to it. Unexpected power began to surge around the man.

In the process, the consciousness of the man slowly dissipated. Only one strong emotion remained in the end, becoming the controller of Han Chong’s body.

That emotion was hatred.

A desire for vengeance against the Heavenly Demon, who had killed the First Apprentice, moved Han Chong.

Kwa-rung –

There seemed to be a thunderstorm gathering around the sword and suddenly the sword began to rotate.

The metal continued to rotate and eventually compressed, transforming into a new appearance.

Kuakua—

It was a vortex.

The man had compressed energy by spinning the sword at high speed!

Bang—

The sword could not contain the ferocious energy and shattered.

Nevertheless, Han Chong did not falter.

Guaguaguaya-

With only the handle left, the no-longer-a-sword continued to spin.

Seeing this, Woon-seong moved the White Night Spear.

Kwa-rung –

A wall of wind rose into the sky. Woon-seong couldn't bear to do what the man was doing and destroy his weapon.

Moreover, there was a crucial difference between Woon-seong and Han Chong.

“Fool,” Woon-seong muttered as he swung his spear towards Han Chong, who also swung his blade at Woon-seong.

The might of the Wave Sword Sea Formation blasted out.

Woon-seong broke the move with a flick of his spear.

Disconnect, divide, and eventually the man was blown backwards.

Kuakuakua—

Han Chang, who collided with Woon-seong's wall of wind, was forced several meters back.

“Cough!” Han Chong coughed out a mouthful of blood.

The biggest difference between Woon-seong and Han Chong was in their abilities to manage internal qi.

The difference between Semi-Divinity and Absolution was not just one step.

Having more internal qi would not fill in this gap.

A martial artist at Transcendence could handle their internal qi in a much more sophisticated manner than a martial artist at the Peak Level. A regular

sword in the hands of a First-Rate martial artist would be more powerful than that same sword in a Third-Rate's.

And now, that same logic applied between Woon-seong and Han Chong.

Woon-seong simply overwhelmed the Qingcheng's offensive.

Wherever the Wave Sword Sea Formation fell, the White Night Spear was there.

The White Night Spear quickly scattered traces of the Qingcheng's skill into the four winds.

The Qingcheng's formation was being split right in front of Woon-seong.

As if the fog had been scattered, the move had no effect on Woon-seong.

In that situation, Woon-seong smiled.

There was a technique called the Dismantling Sword. It was a swordsmanship style which read the opponent's qi flow, then sealed the opponent's sword path.

That was what Woon-seong was using.

No, it should be called the Dismantling Spear, since I'm using a spear. I quite like the name.

Either way, the important thing was that Woon-seong was able to freely control both his spear and the opponent's swords.

Not bad.

The martial arts of the Spear Master Sect aimed to build knowledge of martial arts in order to develop their own techniques. In the process, because they analyzed such a large number of techniques, sometimes their spear arts held the traces of other weapon arts.

That was the case right now.

Enlightenment from stepping into Semi-Divinity had only added to Woon-seong's knowledge of martial arts.

With that, the famous Wave Sword Sea Formation of the Qingcheng Sect became like children waving wooden swords about.

The main reason wasn't Woon-seong's skill, but actually that Han Chong failed to fully master the Qingcheng Sect's swordsmanship style.

Thanks to that, Woon-seong dealt with the Qingcheng as easily as flicking a child on the wrist.

“Aaaah, die, Heavenly Demon!”

On the other hand, Han Chong, who had already lost all rational judgment, needed more and more power to defeat Woon-seong!

The victims here were the disciples of Qingcheng.

“Cough!”

“Cough!”

The disciples, who made up the Wave Sword Sea Formation, coughed up blood. This was because Han Chong was robbing them of tremendous amounts of energy.

Those who were weaker were already dying, bleeding out from their orifices.

“E-Elder...”

“S-Save...”

The remaining swordsmen gathered their energy and called for Han Chong to stop.

But these voices fell on deaf ears.

“Heavenly Demonnnnnnn!”

Han Chong only continued to scream bloody murder. He was so consumed by his anger towards the Heavenly Demon that he didn’t realize he was hurting his own people.

He only continued to take qi and life force away from the swordsmen remaining inside the formation, trying to gain even more power.

That was the raving madness of a drunken man.

Woon-seong coldly ridiculed the man.

You’re so drunk on getting revenge that you’ve lost all semblance of self-preservation or care for others.

If you really wanted revenge, you shouldn’t have done that.

You have to look at things a little less emotionally, hiding yourself until you have reached perfection.

It is also important to act carefully until you achieve your goals. Humans cannot help but be affected by emotion, but you can do your best to mitigate these effects.

Woon-seong couldn’t do that in his previous life, so he lost his life to Jwa Do-gyul. But this life would be different.

That was the way of an avenger which Woon-seong walked.

But what was this man doing?

He was bursting with rage, shouting for revenge.

There was no questioning what he should do and what he should not do.

I’m appalled by this weakness disguised as strength.

Watching on, Woon-seong's emotions could be described in a single sentence: *I wish you'd disappear from my sight.*

Woon-seong's energy rose. At the same time, a grayish energy surrounded him and his eyes turned gold.

White Night Spear clasped in his hands, the Divine Flame went wild.

Soon, it wrapped around the White Night Spear, forming one giant flaming torch.

Woon-seong swung.

Flow of the Divine Dragon.

A golden dragon haloed by flames left Woon-seong's hands and sped off into the world.

Kwaarnee-

Watching the dragon wreathed in flames rush towards the Qingcheng Sect, Tang Jin-ryong muttered, "It's about time."

"Indeed, it is time."

It was time for the corpse puppet Sword Emperor of Ice and Light to move.

To shave off the power of the Heavenly Demon...

Chapter 159: Birth Of A Divine Bird (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 159 – Birth of a Divine Bird (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Are you all right?”

Immediately after the fight was over, Gwan Tae-ryang, who had been protecting Woon-seong from any other enemies, ran over in haste.

Where he stepped was where the Flow of the Divine Dragon had passed, the flames still burning.

Of course, there was no need to say that the bodies of the Qingcheng swordsmen were blackened and mangled.

Perhaps the body of Han Chong was also amongst the piles.

Gwan Tae-ryang casually stepped over all the bodies.

These were the corpses of the non-believers who had pointed their swords at the Heavenly Demon — they meant nothing to him.

Psst-psst—

The bodies of the blackened Qingcheng crumbled beneath Gwan Tae-ryang's feet.

The young man asked once more as he approached, "Are you all right?"

Woon-seong shook his head lightly as he gathered the scattered energy. "I'm a little tired."

It seemed like an overwhelming victory, but it had not been easy for Woon-seong to deal with the Wave Sword Sea Formation.

Not only had he consumed about $\frac{1}{3}$ of his internal qi, but he had exhausted some of his spirit and vitality.

"Whew."

Woon-seong let out a long sigh. He then turned to look at the ongoing battle and asked, "What is the status on our side?"

Woon-seong's victory against the Qingcheng Sect was just a small section, as the war had not yet been won.

Even if he won the battle, if he did not lead this war to victory, Sichuan would not be under his feet.

Only when we put the Sichuan Province under our feet will King Jingseong and the Justice Alliance move.

Woon-seong recalled the plans he had made with allies in the Central Plains.

Meanwhile, Gwan Tae-ryang nodded and reported the situation: "There have been some tight confrontations, but with the Qingcheng Sect gone, victory will soon be in our hands."

"What about the beasts?"

"The wild beasts are being dealt with by the Samsara Demonic Cavalry and the Wind Demon Fist King. Our Charred Dragon Unit is also assisting, so

they will collapse soon.”

Woon-seong nodded. The biggest problems on the battlefield had been the Qingcheng swordsmen and the Namman Yasu beast squad.

With them mostly gone, there was only one more problem.

“What about the Sichuan Tang?”

The Sichuan Tang Clan, manipulators of poison and masters of assassination. As the situation began to crumble, it was unknown what they were up to. The only thing that was certain was that there had yet to be any trace of them.

Gwan Tae-ryang shook his head. “Same as before, they have not moved.”

“Is that so.... ”

The Tang Clan’s poison was a pain in the ass. If they had intervened early in the war, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon would not have been able to dominate the battlefield so easily.

However, the Sichuan Tang had chosen to abandon that advantage and just watched on.

What the hell are you thinking?

What is your purpose?

Woon-seong opened his troubled eyes. At the same time, he shoved Gwan Tae-ryang in the chest.

Whoo—

Unprepared, Gwan Tae-ryang tumbled across the field.

Knng!

At that moment, a fragment of energy fell from the sky.

Kuakuakua— bang!

It was the exact place where Gwan Tae-ryang had been standing.

Seeing that, Gwan Tae-ryang sucked in a cold breath.

“Huff!”

Woon-seong lifted up the White Night Spear and struck at the falling energy. The shock conveyed in these pieces were not light.

Who is it?

As evidence, these pieces of energy had dug holes into the ground. The bodies of the burnt Qingcheng swordsmen disappeared in powdery puffs.

The wild beasts in the area also fell, bleeding. Blood quickly darkened the earth.

Woon-seong slowly raised his head, frowning across the tip of his nose.

There was someone floating in the sky, like a small speck.

With Woon-seong’s eyes, he was able to clearly see the figure’s characteristics.

Hair like a white carpet.

Not only the hair, but also the eyebrows and beard were white, as were the eyes.

The eyes were thin and the body was slim.

Woon-seong felt the ferocity emanating from this man’s body. A presence not below his own.

With the spear, Woon-seongs’s presence had been fixed into this man’s view.

The floating man began to descend towards Woon-seong. Kwa-rung –

The earth collapsed due to the collision of Woon-seong and the man.

As Woon-seong crossed blades with the man, he asked: “Who are you?”

Instead of answering the question, the man moved his sword. His sword seemed to be surrounded by the brilliance of pure white, which instantly turned into light.

Beyond Luminosity.

It was a tremendous move, meant to reach speeds beyond that of light.

Clang—

Woon-seong’s long hair was cut. If he had not turned his head, that would have been his carotid artery being sliced.

Woon-seong’s fingers twitched.

Thunk—

His knuckles cracked as force flowed through his fingers.

“Who are you?”

Woon-seong asked again to the man who did not give his name, and the man swung his sword instead of answering once more.

Once more, energy scattered through the air.

It was another move of the Sword Emperor of Ice and Light — Brilliance of the Dragon-Tiger.

Split from two beams of light, a dragon and a tiger pounced towards Woon-seong at the same time.

With the Heavenly Demon's Wheel in one hand and a spear in the other, Woon-seong called out, "I don't care who you are, stand down!"

Boom-

The Heavenly Demon's Wheel and Rain of Star Destruction slammed into the dragon and tiger.

There was a massive collision in the air and the strange man swung his blade multiple times.

The fastest line between Life and Death was drawn beyond light.

Extreme light-speed.

The Brilliance of the Dragon-Tiger cut through space simply by connecting two particles of light.

The true power of the Brilliance of the Dragon-Tiger was that it transcended light, and thus sight.

With that power, Woon-seong retreated.

This isn't good.

Once you reached Semi-Divinity, you could ignore the different types of techniques and skills thrown your way.

Overwhelming difference in skill and competency, plus the difference between internal qi and experience, would crush the opponent.

This was not something that could be applied among elites at the same level.

In other words, the strange man was on a similar level to Woon-seong.

Kuakua—

The sword and spear continued to collide, the space distorting with flames. The waves of energy spread out in all directions and the ground split apart.

In the process, Woon-seong successively used the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

If the opponent was speed to the extreme, Woon-seong was destruction to the extreme.

No matter how powerful this strange man was, he would not be fine if hit.

The man cackled, as if laughing at Woon-seong's plan.

Shh. Shh.

The man dodged the Heavenly Demon at the same speed as his blade.

Where do these masters come from...?

Woon-seong suddenly recalled the monster he had fought in King Jinseong's court some days ago.

Immediately, his eyebrows twitched.

“Huh. They're very similar.”

Avoidance of the skill just now seemed like instinctive behavior, not calculated movements.

A person who trusted the instincts of the flesh rather than good judgements, and was also unable to properly communicate...

Woon-seong felt like the two beings were very similar.

Moreover, there is less vitality in the body than regular people.

When they exchanged moves, Woon-seong could tell clearly: this strange man had very little life inside him.

Usually, those at Semi-Divinity had more vitality than others.

But this man did not.

It's like the vitality of an old man, right before death.

In other words, this man was alive but not alive.

It felt like someone had forcibly planted a spirit into a corpse.

It's necromancy.

Woon-seong had determined that this man was not a human.

At the same time, he tilted his head. *But where the hell do these things keep popping out from?*

However, Woon-seong did not continue thinking for that long.

In the meantime, the offensive of the monster continued.

Kuakuakua—

The rays of light divided once more, a dragon and tiger crushing towards Woon-seong. They swept past the young man's waist.

Kuakuakua—

The fabric at Woon-seong's waist was torn apart, blood spilling. He hurriedly pressed to stop the bleeding, but he bled quite a bit.

Not good.

After fighting the Qingcheng swordsmen, it was natural for Woon-seong to be somewhat exhausted.

Besides, I don't think this is a good match.

Force against speed with someone at the same level wasn't optimal.

So?

Three choices came to Woon-seong's mind.

The first was the Art of Six Seals and Destruction.

But soon, he threw that one out.

Just like the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, the Art of Six Seals and Destruction was also a technique of force.

If there was a difference, it would be that the Art of Six Seals and Destruction was more narrowly based, while the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon pursued power itself.

Dismissed.

Next up was the Divine Spear of the Ending Night.

This godly spear that brought the dawn after erasing the night was about flow and flexibility.

It created a cycle of softness.

There were some similarities with the Divine Spear of the Ending Night and the Brilliance of the Dragon-Tiger which the corpse puppet used.

But this time, Woon-seong pushed it aside.

Similar doesn't overwhelm.

As long as the Sichuan Tang Clan was an enemy, Woon-seong could not drag the fight on. In order to preserve his strength and stamina, he needed to deal with this opponent as soon as possible.

Then, the Flow of the Divine Dragon?

Woon-seong's strongest move, except for those of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

The same spear move which had blown apart the First Apprentice and the Wave Sword Sea Formation.

Would this move be able to defeat the puppet in front of him?

Woon-seong shook his head.

Flow of the Divine Dragon is strong...

It was a spear move which combined strength and flexibility together, but it did not match with speed.

The energy within the Flow of the Divine Dragon could enter the man's field of light, but would be beautifully divided into hundreds of little light eruptions.

Even if they could reach the corpse puppet, there would not be enough power to leave a scratch.

Is the only way to fight a drawn out battle after all?

This man and the one who had attacked King Jinseong's Court must have similar weaknesses.

If he aimed for its weakness, he would be able to take it down with time.

Woon-seong shook his head even at this.

He smiled and murmured, "It seems I have been much too lazy recently."

It was time to cast off that idleness.

Chapter 160: Birth Of A Divine Bird (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 160 – Birth of a Divine Bird (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

I ran a long distance without pause.

There was no proper rest, nor any time for me to have sweet dreams.

That is how I have been living so far.

No, that is only how I believe I have been living.

At this moment, Woon-seong denied all of it.

I only brainwashed myself into believing that I lived that way.

He asked himself: *Have I really been living such a harsh life?*

It didn't take long for him to come to a conclusion.

“I don't know.”

But saying “I don't know” was just an excuse.

If you really lived such a harsh life, you would be able to honestly and straightforwardly answer: “Yes, that is how I lived.”

“I don’t know” only meant one thing: I did not live like that.

I don’t know when it started.

Perhaps it had been right after he left the Cave of Latent Demons, or it may be after he became the Young Leader.

No, maybe it was after he became a Semi-Divine Being and sat on the throne as Heavenly Demon.

The moment when someone thinks they’re nearing the goal is the moment they let down their guard.

Perhaps that was where his laziness had begun.

Not good.

Woon-seong denied that way of life.

If I have been idle, I have been living wrongly.

He should have been striving harder than anyone in order to achieve his goals.

It is not too late to correct course.

Woon-seong gripped the spear. He then turned towards the strange puppet, which swung his sword.

Hundreds, thousands, even tens of thousands of swords seemed to rush towards Woon-seong in one tidal wave.

In between them, dragons and tigers roamed, claws out.

The power of ‘Brilliance of the Dragon-Tiger’ which transcended even light.

And Woon-seong didn't even know its name.

However, it was clear that this swordsmanship before him aimed to go beyond the light in pursuit of extreme speed and ferocity.

That conclusion was the result of looking at it with the eyes of a scholar.

It was also the result of judging by the thoughts of a scholar.

If so....

In order to catch up, Woon-seong also had to transcend light.

When it came to combining such a skill, it was a step ahead of the Divine Arts of the Heavenly Demon, the Art of Six Seals and Destruction, and the Divine Spear of the Ending Night.

If he could contain the utmost speed, he would be able to match that swordsmanship.

Can I do it? Woon-seong wondered.

He shook his head.

Questioning himself meant that he had not shaken off that laziness inside his heart.

Whether it could or could not be done was not important.

In order to move forwards, it was more important to try.

It was important to get over this wall.

After that, the two would have to face each other no matter what.

Boom, boom!

Boom, boom!

Woon-seong threw off the iron bracers binding him. His whole body was suddenly filled with a sense of freedom.

Laziness included holding the best of himself back.

Do it.

Woon-seong gripped his spear tighter.

Whoa, whoa, whoa.

The White Night Spear trembled, as if responding to the will of its owner.

At the same time, a white glow began to envelop the spear.

The time captured by Woon-seong's senses split into tens of millions of fractions. Time began to flow slower.

At first it was just a little bit, but Woon-seong's focus was terrifyingly multiplied. Time slowed down more and more.

In that bubble of time, Woon-seong scoured through all of the martial arts techniques in his mind.

A crowd of people and places came to him, tens of thousands of words devoured by his mind across two lifetimes.

It was a mess, a raging river of knowledge.

Within it, Woon-seong's spirit drifted about like a leaf thrown into the wind.

But Woon-seong did not lose consciousness.

Instead, he began to concentrate these thoughts together.

The words and text began to run wild. It was like they were screaming "We can't mix together" and rebelled against his control.

Woon-seong gripped the White Night Spear with more strength, commanding them to group together.

No, they can be mixed.

Woon-seong commanded once again.

Blend together!

His command was short but powerful.

It was an order issued by a man of the Semi-Divine Realm who had united his body and soul.

The texts responded to the command.

The countless words spinning around finally produced a single verse!

As soon as he read the verse, it seemed like lightning struck Woon-seong's mind and something shattered inside his mind.

This is it!

At the same time, the slowed down time began to accelerate and Woon-seong's spirit returned to his body.

Boom!

What should I name it?

Standing amongst the pouring blades of light, Woon-seong looked at the White Night Spear in his hand.

A new skill lingered in his mind.

It was clear as day to him.

He had never used it before, but it was somehow familiar.

Perhaps that was because it was a technique combining skills he knew like the back of his hand.

It was also likely because most of the technique was based on the Art of Six Seals and Destruction and the Divine Spear of the Ending Night, not the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

What was this technique to be called?

A new skill could only be completed when it was given a name.

Having been unable to name it before use, Flow of the Divine Dragon had been unintentionally made.

But this was different.

Woon-seong wrestled with this question as the blades continued to fly towards him.

At this time, he could see a bird flapping its wings in the distant sky.

It appeared near the sun.

A bird that flew over the sun, shining with glorious brilliance.

Faith.

A bird that had been given a sacred soul.

Let's do that.

Birds had large wings which allowed them to fly in places where even the sun did not shine.

By the truest definition, the righteous heroes of old were the same.

Birds that did not fly in ordinary winds, choosing to take off once a storm hit and crossing the vast Kumari Sea during a typhoon.

With such Faith, you could fly to places where even the light could not reach.

And soon, Woon-seong had decided on a name.

Birth of a Divine Bird.

Woon-seong moved his spear.

A huge light flowed out of the White Night Spear, snapping and splitting into the shape of wings.

Woon-seong threw the White Night Spear straight forward.

Faith had begun to spread its wings into the world.

A bird had broken from its cage.

A giant bird shot from the White Night Spear and pierced through the puppet's body.

Kuakuakuakau—!

The battle seemed to be over.

However, those who were watching did not seem to easily recognize this.

Regardless of faction, the soldiers were all squinting at the sky. They were all blinded and dumbfounded because that overwhelming light, which seemed to overturn the whole world, had been seared into their minds.

The brilliance emanated from the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It was still reflected in their retinas.

What the hell had that been?

What was that technique which was so fascinating?

Many people were curious.

Some demonic arts were said to tempt people's souls; they wondered if it was something like that.

The first one to come to his senses was Gwan Tae-ryang.

The Samsara Demonic Cavalry, who were pushing the remnants of the Beast Squad away, soon also came running towards Woon-seong.

But quicker than them, there were others who judged and moved faster.

“Spread the poison!”

“Release the poison!”

It was the Sichuan Tang Clan.

At the most appropriate moment — when they thought Woon-seong would be the most exhausted — they made their appearance.

They leapt into the battlefield, flying the green flag symbolizing the Sichuan Tang, and relentlessly releasing their poison.

“Glug!”

“Knng!”

The demonic soldiers who were poisoned fell, foaming and choking.

It wasn't just the demonic soldiers.

In the midst of war, the Orthodox factions and the Demonic Cult were still entangled. Nevertheless, the Sichuan Tang continued to release poison without hesitation.

One of Murim's soldiers screamed in protest: “What the hell are you doing? How can you still say the Sichuan Tang is an orthodox faction?”

At that moment, someone's hand pressed down on the soldier's head.

“Tsk, tsk.”

Someone clicked his tongue as if it were a pity and a monstrous poison seeped into the soldier's head and into his whole body.

“Cough! Cough!”

The soldier was a master of Murim and a sect leader in his own right, but he was unable to resist at all.

The poison flowing in his own body was just that strong.

The soldier collapsed into a puddle of blood, unable to withstand more than a few seconds.

Neither brains nor bone, nothing was left behind.

Even amongst the Sichuan Tang, there was only one master who was capable of this.

“Tang Jin-ryong, the Saint of Immortal Poison.”

Woon-seong called out his name.

Hearing it, Tang Jin-ryong walked through the blood, smiling in satisfaction.

Tsst-tsst—

The ground was covered in toxic blood, but the man didn't seem to mind.

Tss—

He had turned his whole body into poison. He couldn't be hurt by someone his own poison melted.

“I didn’t know the Leader of the Demonic Cult knew my name. It is an honor,” Tang Jin-ryong said with a shrewd expression.

Woon-seong slowly turned to look at him. “You’ve been waiting until now.”

“Yes.”

“Was sending in the Qingcheng and then that unknown thing to weaken my power?”

“You know very well. But don’t call him a thing, that was the Sword Emperor of Ice and Light.”

Several surrounding martial artists were surprised by the words ‘Sword Emperor of Ice and Light’.

However, there was no change in Woon-seong’s expression.

He had no interest in the name of a dead body.

“You don’t have the courage to fight by yourselves, yet you call yourself orthodox. No matter how much I think about it, the unorthodox suits you better.”

“Then what about the Cult? Are you willing to accept me if I join the Demonic Cult?”

When Tang Jin-ryong asked this, the demonic soldiers in the area writhed with anger. It was as if they had been deeply insulted.

The expression on their faces was of disbelief.

“What are you talking about?!”

“No matter how much you call yourself a martial master, there are actions you can and cannot do! What do you mean you’re willing to surrender to the Demonic Cult after committing a massacre like this?!”

The Orthodox factions also shouted loudly at Tang Jin-ryong.

However, there was no change in the old man's expression. It was a face that said he was waiting for Woon-seong's answer.

Woon-seong blinked, his face blank. "You say things you don't even believe. You have no intention of surrendering to our Cult, do you?"

"Was it that obvious?"

"Your acting was awkward."

Tang Jin-ryong grinned.

As Woon-seong had said, he and the Tang Clan had no intention of surrendering to the Demonic Cult at all.

If they had planned to surrender in the first place, they would not have done this.

At this time, Woon-seong continued: "Of course, even if you truly surrender, our Cult will not accept you."

Tang Jin-ryong's eyebrows went up, but Woon-seong did not give him time to respond.

"This Cult is not a gutter."

Woon-seong waved his hand and shook it, like he had touched something nasty.

"And piles of shit belong in the gutters."

Those words seemed to be a signal, as something began to happen on the Demonic Cult's side.

Chapter 161: Betrayal (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 161 – Betrayal (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

When the bustling movements of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon ceased, a watchtower had been erected where Tang Jin-ryong could see.

“A watchtower?”

No, it looked like a watchtower but was not one.

The old man’s eyes narrowed and his eyebrows raised.

With his power, he could clearly make out the top of the tower.

Tang Jin-ryong’s eye twitched when he looked.

He could see someone kneeling at the top.

“Hmm. What a funny thing to do, Cult Leader,” Tang Jin-ryong said with an uncomfortable face.

Kneeling on the tower was Tang So-bung, granddaughter of Tang Jin-ryong.

Woon-seong responded with a calm expression. “I can show you something even more interesting.”

Woon-seong raised his hand.

Then, one more person appeared on the tower, next to Tang So-bung.

It was a man with a long blade in his hand.

The blade in his hand was so well forged that it seemed like it could sever a man's head in a heartbeat.

Based on the situation, it was obvious why the man appeared on the tower with a blade.

It was exactly as guessed.

The blade in the man's hand flashed.

Seeing that, some of the other Sichuan Tang clan members looking up at the tower cried out in regret and sadness.

“No!”

“You vile bastards!”

But they were too far from the tower. At this distance, even an arrow wouldn't be able to reach in time.

The poison boasted by the Sichuan Tang could also not affect the result.

In the end, the Sichuan Tang had to watch as the knife slashed through the young woman's neck.

Thwack!

Tang So-bung's severed head soared into the air, then fell.

Like it had been catapulted, the severed head fell from the tower and rolled across the ground.

Tang Jin-ryong closed his eyes.

Tang So-bung was of the main family. And the Sichuan Tang was a clan that held immediate lineage to be more important than anything.

Hot flames of anger must have seared through Tang Jin-ryong's heart.

I was the same when I lost my two masters, Woon-seong thought.

Tang Jin-ryong soon opened his eyes.

Not surprisingly, although he looked calm, he was unable to hide the red in his eyes.

His fingers twitched. A fine toxic dust flowed from his fingertips, as if proving his fury.

The poison he had accumulated in his body for so many years was responding to his anger.

"The Cult Leader is indeed a demon."

"I am a demon. Sounds interesting."

Tang Jin-wrong smiled at Woon-seong's words. It was a cold smile, like an ice field.

He looked around with this smile on his face.

Nearby, martial artists from both the Demonic Cult and the Sichuan Union were dying from poison.

"It was hard enough to poison the enemy without affecting my allies. Now you try to shake the hearts and minds of the Tang with such a wicked trick... What do I call you if not a demon?"

One of the Orthodox martial artists who were dying from poison shouted, "What are you talking about?! The Sichuan Tang poisoned us—"

Foo-scht—

A fluttering butterfly blew the man's head off and his brains splattered everywhere. Meanwhile, the butterfly flew off again, flapping its wings.

With a few graceful flitters, it landed back in Tang Jin-ryong's hands.

Deadly Wings of the Butterfly.

A blade-like butterfly that could make eight turns in the air, bringing death.

It was a unique technique of the Sichuan Tang.

Tang Jin-ryong clicked his tongue when he recovered the blade.

"Tsk, tsk. History is written by the victor anyway. That is a reminder that if the Sichuan Tang win here, all of this will be a rumor, Cult Leader."

Woon-seong snorted. "You speak as if you can beat our Cult."

"Even a viper will die when you cut off its head. In my opinion, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon is a snake. If you lose your head, you will lose your place and wriggle around, eventually dying a pitiful death."

Woon-seong grabbed the White Night Spear.

At the same time, energy began to flow around the body of Tang Jin-ryong.

It was a poison that made Woon-seong's nose tingle and his eyes feel dull.

In response, energy began to gather around Woon-seong.

The young man was physically exhausted. His internal qi was much less than usual.

At this moment, Woon-seong's momentum could not compare to Tang Jin-ryong's.

Still, Tang Jin-ryong looked slightly surprised. *At least Transcendence. So you still have this much internal qi even after facing the Qingcheng Sect and the Sword Emperor puppet.*

Immediately, he fixed his expression.

“This is a scene I’ve always wanted to see.”

“...?”

“Isn’t the great scene of beheading the Heavenly Demon like some Murim hero’s story? Seeing as how I’ve been hoping for it even at this age, I must still have a childish side.”

“You don’t seem to care about your granddaughter’s death.”

Tang Jin-ryong smiled. He lightly waved his hand and said, “The glory of the living is more important than the dead.”

A few weapons were tossed into the air, flying towards Woon-seong. In response, the young man threw out a glass knife.

“Then any further conversation would be meaningless.”

The weapons collided with the glass knife and exploded in the air.

At the same time, Woon-seong reached out with a finger.

A flying burst marble shot out.

As if in response, two butterflies flew over.

Like torpedoes, they whipped over in an instant.

Boom!

With an explosion, the two butterflies changed direction. This time, they flew towards Woon-seong’s heart.

The weapons were dangerous by itself, but the real danger was the poison on the blade-like wings.

You could not avoid becoming poisoned if you touched it. Woon-seong twisted to the side. The blades swooped past his waist with a paper-thin gap, then swiveled and aimed for the back of his head.

Woon-seong was one step faster.

He moved his body and shot straight towards Tang Jin-ryong.

Boom—

Like a meteor, Woon-seong crashed to the ground, right in front of Tang Jin-ryong!

Tang Jin-ryong stepped back and released more poison.

Again, Woon-seong was one step faster.

He stretched out the White Night Spear and scattered the poison. At the same time, the Divine Flame covered his entire body.

Fwoom—

Fire against poison!

The energy of the Divine Flame burned the scattered poison. Not stopping there, Woon-seong shot towards Tang Jin-ryong again.

“Huff!” Tang Jin-ryong snorted.

Woon-seong’s movements were so fast that he had lost sight of the young man for a moment.

Tang Jin-ryong had been practicing the poison and assassination arts his whole life. In order to see the skills his enemies threw at him, he was confident that he had trained his eyes more than anyone else.

Yet all of a sudden, his eyes were unable to follow the Heavenly Demon.

It was no wonder he was surprised.

How can someone be this fast?!

You spent so much stamina and internal qi, but you're still moving like this!

While Tang Jin-ryong's eyes widened in surprise, Woon-seong slammed a shoulder into the man's chest.

Wooduk-

There was an eerie sound and Tang Jin-ryong's chest seemed to cave in a bit. It seemed like a few of his ribs had just been crushed.

"Grand Elder!"

"Elder!"

The rest of the Tang Clan could not tell what was happening, but they could clearly see Tang Jin-ryong being flung back.

"Queek!"

Tang Jin-ryong coughed up a mouthful of blood. He grabbed his broken ribs and tried to breathe.

He prided himself on being able to fight anyone in any position, but when he broke his ribs, he suddenly lost confidence.

However, this time, Woon-seong's movements were even faster.

Blubber-

A huge flame rose and slammed towards Tang Jin-ryong.

"Khh!"

Tang Jin-ryong scattered all of his blades, trying to pierce through the flames.

But something even faster ran through the flames towards him.

Su-wook-

It was an arm.

Woon-seong smacked Tang Jin-ryong in the shoulder.

Snap, crack.

The man's shoulders crumbled as the bones cracked.

No matter how talented you were, you could not throw any weapons without your arms.

Next was the mouth.

Woon-seong's fist literally smashed Tang Jin-ryong's mouth.

Roar—

Huack—

There were hidden weapons even in Tang Jin-ryong's mouth, falling between the teeth. Like both arms, you would not be able to shoot weapons from the mouth without tongue or teeth.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong did not stop attacking.

With flames covering his body, he swung his fist.

It was merciless violence.

This offensive swept across Tang Jin-ryong's body.

Cough- Cough-

With every punch, Tang Jin-ryong's body trembled.

What was even more frightening was that this ruthless offensive was taking place under careful calculation.

Wherever Woon-seong's fists hit was where a weapon could be hidden or stored.

First the shoulders, then the mouth, then the wrist.

Finally, even the ankles.

Wooduk-

Light rotations collapsed all the places where hidden weapons could be placed.

“

After that ruthless violence, Tang Jin-ryong finally became silent. No more movement could be seen.

He had not lost his life, but he was no longer in a situation where he could put up any resistance.

Woon-seong slowly grabbed the man by the neck.

Overwhelming force lifted Tang Jin-ryong from the ground.

Woon-seong stared into his eyes and snarled, “You did some interesting tricks to try and cut my strength. Indeed, it was the way of hypocrites. Pretending to do good things while digging a hole behind.”

As the young man continued, Tang Jin-ryong flinched.

“Unfortunately, you made two mistakes.”

Tang Jin-ryong trembled. Although he could not move, it was clear that Woon-seong's words were clearly conveyed to his ears.

“First, the tricks you prepared were enough to consume some of my stamina, but not enough to exhaust me completely.”

The strength and stamina of a Semi-Divine Being surpassed imagination. Even after dealing with the Qingcheng Sect and Sword Emperor puppet, Woon-seong would not die from exhaustion.

“Second, did you think I entertained such a long conversation because I enjoyed talking to you?”

At this point, it seemed like Tang Jin-ryong had been struck by a thunderbolt. The killing of his granddaughter, Tang So-bung, and the long speeches and time lapses were all ways for Woon-seong to regain bits of strength.

I didn't even realize that much!

Tang Jin-ryong's body went limp.

Woon-seong pulled him closer and whispered into his ear: “You shouldn't have been involved with the destruction of the Spear Master Sect.”

Tang Jin-ryong's eyes widened.

“When you die and go to the afterlife, my master will be waiting for you.”

As these last words entered the man's ear, his neck and spine were crushed.

Crack—

At the same time, the eerie sound of metal hitting flesh split the air.

Puchi—

Chapter 162: Betrayal (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 162 – Betrayal (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Huh?”

Time stopped.

Woon-seong, Gwan Tae-ryang who had been watching the confrontation between Woon-seong and Tang Jin-ryong, and all the other demonic practitioners who were there.

It was as if time had stopped.

The only one moving around was...

“It’s been a long time.”

Only the sword that stabbed into Woon-seong’s shoulder and the man holding on to it.

Time soon returned to normal.

When Woon-seong threw away Tang Jin-ryong’s corpse, he slowly turned around.

The sword was still in his shoulder.

Woon-seong glanced down at the blade. He then turned his head to see who had done it.

“You...” Woon-seong said.

The man nodded and smirked. He then politely greeted, “It is my first time greeting the Cult Leader, I am the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion.”

He chuckled, “Isn’t it fitting?”

Oblivion.

He had deceived everyone in his position again, just like his name suggested.

To be precise, he had deceived Tang Jin-ryong.

There was no way we could have caught a Semi-Divine Being with just the Qingcheng and some corpse.

The man wasn’t that crazy to believe in an impossible plan.

Tang Jin-ryong had been used to shave the Heavenly Demon’s energy too.

Tang Jin-ryong might not know it, but he and the Sichuan Tang Clan played in the hands of the Cult of the Inverted Sky from beginning to end.

“Was it all your plan?”

With a calm expression, Woon-seong pulled the sword from his shoulder. If he had been even a beat slower at dodging, the sword might have hit his heart instead.

That was fortunate.

However...

This makes it hard to move my shoulder.

Woon-seong frowned slightly.

Hwan Dok smiled brightly and responded, “Yes. It was all part of my plan.”

“So the Qingcheng Sect and the Sword Emperor corpse were tricks to tire me out?”

“You’re so judgmental.”

“Tang Jin-ryong would have thought that was enough. But that was also part of your plan, right?”

“I thought that the Qingcheng, the Sword Emperor, and the Saint of Immortal Poison would be enough to tire the Cult Leader. You would have to be some monster to not be tired after dealing with the Saint of Immortal Poison.”

Woon-seong nodded. The evidence of that truth was the sword, which had been stabbed into his shoulder.

“Disgusting.”

Woon-seong felt a slight discomfort thinking that he had been playing in someone’s palms. He frowned.

At that moment, Gwan Tae-ryang moved.

“My lord!”

Gwan Tae-ryang rushed over, wielding his blades and hurtling towards Hwan Dok. At that moment, Hwan Dok pulled out another sword, which he had been hiding.

Kua-bang!

Hwan Dok’s sword hurled through the air, pushing Gwan Tae-ryang back.

Right after that!

Thwack—

Hwan Dok slammed his fist into the Lieutenant's temple. With a shock to his brain, Gwan Tae-ryang flew back like a broken doll and hit the ground hard.

Gwan Tae-ryang had been exhausted by the continuous battle too.

If it weren't for that, Gwan Tae-ryang wouldn't have been beaten like that.

Woon-seong flew over and checked on the man. He had fainted from the pain, but wouldn't die any time soon.

"You did a good job. Somehow, Tang Jin-ryong was very confident."

"I only thought this was the best way to deal with the Cult Leader."

Woon-seong nodded.

He admitted it.

If the situation continued like this, Woon-seong would not be able to deal with it.

He seemed fine, but it was just a smokescreen — even Woon-seong was exhausted from the constant fighting.

Moreover, his strength had decreased to an unusual degree.

Is it enough?

Everything was disadvantageous.

But instead of despairing, Woon-seong still had a smile on his face.

Did that smile feel ominous?

Hwan Dok asked with a stiff expression, "What are you smiling about?"

Woon-seong put a hand inside his pockets and pulled something out.

“But even your plan had limits,” Woon-seong said quietly.

His voice was not loud, but it was clear.

There was clear hostility in that tone.

Hwan Dok was an enemy of the Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon, who was another one of Woon-seong’s masters.

I cannot forgive him.

Woon-seong glanced down at what he had taken out.

I didn’t expect to use this here.

Once upon a time, before Woon-seong was enthroned, some of the Demonic Masters from Joo Moon-baek’s faction had turned to Woon-seong’s faction, offering items in return for mercy as they pledged loyalty.

Woon-seong found many of these things useful, like the glass throwing knives.

What he took out was also a gift.

Poison.

A pill from one of the Demonic Masters.

Poison could kill people, but when used well, it could also save people. It was a kind of medicine that the Poison King had given Woon-seong.

A medicine that would quickly replenish strength when consumed in a situation that rapidly depleted energy, but would not last forever.

“What?” Hwan Dok did not understand and tilted his head.

Woon-seong downed the pill from the Poison King.

Hmph.

A sweet aroma seemed to spread through his body. At the same time, he could feel his strength recovering at a rapid rate.

At this rate...

It will be enough to deal with Hwan Dok, Woon-seong concluded without hesitation, twirling his spear.

Woon-seong's sudden movements surprised Hwan Dok.

“Phew!”

However, he was not so weak he would just take a beating.

He swung his sword.

The sound of the sword colliding with the spear was loud and clear like a bell.

Hwan Dok's body trembled. The strength of the blow had traveled through the weapon.

Once is enough!

Withstand.

Hwan Dok did not know what Woon-seong had eaten, but he decided that the effect wouldn't last for long.

It is my victory as long as I endure until then.

The moment Hwan Dok decided that, the momentum of the White Night Spear changed.

The spear seemed to wrap around his sword, curling like a snake.

Startled, Hwan Dok tried to pull his sword back, but it was already firmly captured by the spear.

Shua—

The spear kept the blade in place, but kept going forward. A spear that would not stop!

Staring at the sword, which seemed like it had been embedded in a rock, Hwan Dok pulled out another hidden blade.

His expertise was in using twin swords!

He slammed the other sword horizontally, blocking the spear from spinning forward.

Kuakuakua—

As the weapons met, sparks flew into the air.

Woon-seong let go of the spear.

Flames rose around the area in a vortex, swirling around Hwan Dok.

“Heavenly Demon’s Palm!”

Hwan Dok made a sound of surprise as a wall of flames sped through the air, knocking into the butt of the spear Woon-seong had left in the air.

It was like a hammer and a chisel.

The hammer was the Divine Flame, the chisel was the White Night Spear.

Like it was cracking through rock, the White Night Spear exploded forward, fueled by the Divine Flame.

Boom!

Hwan Dok's blade, which had been blocking the spear, shattered from the power. At the same time, the spear continued, slamming into Hwan Dok.

Fwa-ping—

The power still remained and Hwan Dok was skewered to the floor.

Boom.

The White Night Spear had formed a crater in the ground. At the center was Hwan Dok.

“Grrrgh.”

Was he in pain because of the spear through his chest? Hwan Dok reached out with his hands and grabbed at the spear.

He tried to pull it out.

But the White Night Spear had dug deep into the ground.

Woon-seong slowly approached him.

“When you made your plan, did you think this far?”

Hwan Doks slowly closed his eyes. His internal organs had long been crushed by the White Night Spear piercing through his chest.

He could not escape. Even if he succeeded, he would not survive for long.

“Hehe, hehehehe.”

Perhaps it was fear of death, but laughter poured from his lips.

“Hahahaha.”

For a while, Hwan Dok giggled to himself.

Not liking that laughter, Woon-seong grabbed the White Night Spear.

Kwa-rung—

“Cough!”

Enormous strength gushed through the White Night Spear, shaking Hwan Dok’s internal organs once again.

Blood flowed from the man’s mouth.

His internal organs were scattered like chunks of meat in porridge throughout the blood.

“Let me ask you again. Did you expect this?”

When asked, Hwan Dok slowly opened his eyes. Even though he was dying, he opened his eyes and stared at Woon-seong as clearly as he could.

“Predicted... I did.”

At his words, Woon-seong twitched.

It was because that answer was unexpected.

“Predicted?” Woon-seong asked again, and Hwan Dok nodded with great difficulty.

He slowly reached out, pointing to his blade.

It was the same sword that had stabbed Woon-seong in the shoulder.

“Yes. I anticipated a situation where I could not kill you, and so I had one more thing prepared.”

Woon-seong stared at the blade.

It meant that something had been added to that blade.

The answer naturally flowed from Hwan Dok’s mouth: “I can’t believe I got to kill the god of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon twice. Both times in the

same way too, hahahaha!”

Hwan Dok leaned his head back and cackled.

Woon-seong stared at him.

“Poison?”

“Cough, cough.” Hwan Dok coughed up more blood. He was a man about to die, so he did not deny anything. “Yes, poison. Ack.”

“...”

“The same poison that killed the other Heavenly Demon.”

Hwan Dok’s words made Woon-seong’s expression strangely distorted.

It was because although he did not know the name of that poison, he knew what it was.

It was a poison that had taken away his master, twice.

Woon-seong clenched his fist.

Hwan Dok continued to cackle. “Hehe, I have killed the Heavenly Demon twice.”

Woon-seong reached out and grabbed the man by the throat. He then said in a low voice: “I don’t care about my life. I’ll have you all killed before my life is over. After that, I don’t care what happens.”

Woon-seong meant his words too.

Revenge was what Woon-seong wanted the most in the first place. He didn’t care if he died after achieving that revenge.

“And no matter how powerful the poison is, it can’t kill me in a short time.”

Like Cheon Hwi, Woon-seong could last between half a year and up to a year.

That was enough time to turn the world into a sea of fire and twist the necks of all his enemies.

“I’ll have you all thrown in hell before my life is lost,” Woon-seong growled with all of his heart.

Hwan Dok, who could read his expression and tone, felt stiff. *That is a lot of anger.*

It was something beyond the norm.

It was the anger of losing two masters, not one. Compared to the anger of others, it was on a different dimension.

While receiving such anger, Hwan Dok shook his head. “The Cult Leader will never accomplish his goals, cough!” Coughing up another mouthful of blood, he muttered, “Everything is for the Inverted Sky—”

Woon-seong swiftly yanked the spear from the man’s stomach.

Puh—

Blood splattered everywhere.

Chapter 163: Secret (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 163 – Secret (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Hmmm.”

The one wearing the Emperor’s shell hummed.

The Leader of the Inverted Sky breathed in slowly. The air around him was filled with smoke and fog, making it hard to see even one inch in front of him.

The smoke slowly seeped into his body as he inhaled.

Opiates.

A cursed scent that was a mixture of flowers, perfume, and the scent of flesh permeated deep into his lungs.

His eyes were dull and glazed.

It seemed like his body was heavier.

In the meantime, the Leader of the Inverted Sky felt immense pleasure.

“Not bad.”

It seemed that the effect of narcotics was better than the sexual exploitation of beautiful women.

Was it just ‘not bad’?

The man corrected his words with an indifferent expression.

“Pretty good. No, I really like it.”

The pain that had consumed his whole body disappeared. It seemed like the pressure of the body imprisoning the soul had disappeared, like the clothing he wore suddenly fit perfectly.

The Emperor’s body was one that did not suit the Inverted Sky Lord’s soul.

Among the techniques of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, there were those that built up the strength in the soul.

The soul of the Leader of the Inverted Sky, who had practiced all of these arts, was truly enormous.

However, he had forced himself to take over the body of the Emperor, so he had no choice but to bear with it.

The dissonance between the soul and body eventually led to the rapid collapse of the physical body, and the Leader of the Inverted Sky continued to suffer.

At first, he overcame the pain through sexual pleasure.

And then it was alcohol.

And now?

As the pain became worse and he needed more and more to stop it, the body he inhabited was reaching its limits — it was a body that could no longer last without drugs.

Thinking up to here, the Leader of the Inverted Sky frowned.

“Hmm.”

He soon changed his words again.

“I feel bad. That’s not good. ”

At that point, someone swiftly appeared behind him. “The pain seems to be getting worse. ”

Like the emperor, or the Cult Leader of the Inverted Sky, a cloak of smoke covered his body.

When Grand Chancellor Heo appeared, the Inverted Sky Lord frowned and said, “The collapse of the body is accelerating. That’s a bad sign...”

“Most of our preparations are complete. There are some failures like the Sword Emperor puppet, but the number of successes is not small, so the new body will soon be ready for the Lord.”

“As soon as possible.”

The Grand Chancellor lowered his head slightly. “Understood.”

After the conversation was over, there was a moment of silence.

Then, it was the Inverted Sky Lord who opened his mouth.

“But did Hwan Dok succeed? Did he? Tell me, Young-*gun*. You must know.”

He tilted his head, like a child asking for answers.

At the question, the chancellor nodded.

As the lord said, he knew the answer.

“Yes, haha. I know.”

Red light flashed through the eyes of the man.

The chancellor had a technique where he could take a piece of someone else's soul.

It was called the 'Thousand Mile Eye' (千里眼). [1]

The Thousand Mile Eye was slightly different from Abhijñā (六神通). [2]

If he took a tiny piece of another person's soul, he would be able to see what was happening with the other person through a connection of the spirit.

It was quite useful.

Before leaving, Hwan Dok had left a fragment of his soul with the 'Demon Sucking Evil Puppeteer'. Thanks to that, the chancellor could watch everything from his seat.

That was why he was able to easily answer the Inverted Sky Lord's question.

"It was a success."

"Success... Did he succeed in slitting the Heavenly Demon's throat?" giggled the Inverted Sky Lord.

The chancellor sighed for a moment. He had a rough idea of what happened, but had a hard time reporting it.

Moreover, he felt like he was dealing with several people at once, since the emperor's tone had changed.

It was because the history of the Inverted Sky was accumulated inside the Leader's soul. In order to build more strength, the soul would increase in size by absorbing other souls.

In other words, the Inverted Sky Lord's soul contained thousands or tens of thousands of other souls. In that process, several personalities had been born.

They were all the Inverted Sky Lord. So of course it would feel like several people.

But the chancellor had no choice but to answer to all of the personalities.

“We failed to slit the Heavenly Demon’s throat, but we succeeded in getting the poison into his body.”

“Hmm, I see. It’s not a big success, but a small success. Definitely not bad.”

The Inverted Sky Lord’s attitude and personality changed again. This time, it was that of a proud lord.

“What will you do?”

At the question, the Inverted Sky Lord closed his eyes. His nostrils flared and he tapped on the armrest with his fingers.

It looked as if several personalities were having a heated debate in the emperor’s head.

The Demon Sucking Evil Puppeteer waited in silence.

The Inverted Sky Lord was holding a personality debate so that he could draw conclusions.

The emperor did not stay silent for long. The time in the mind and the time in the real world are clearly different, so it was useless to think about how deeply the man had thought about what to do.

“Maybe I should stab him first?”

The Chancellor, understanding, bowed his head. “I will instruct my men in the bureau to proceed.”

When he heard about the bureau, the Inverted Sky Lord twitched.

“Bureau... Have you completely taken over the Eastern Depot?” [3]

“A couple of years ago, we got rid of the old Eastern Depot Chief and placed our own man in his place.”

“The push back inside the bureau must have been terrible.”

“Of course, if they knew it wasn’t the Chief sitting there.”

The emperor giggled. Perhaps the man sitting in the position of chief looked the same as before.

The emperor smiled and added, “Good job.”

“I will contact the bureau and arrange for my best men to take care of it.”

Even the same poison would have slightly different effects on different people. Depending on the situation, the impact would change slightly.

In the case of the Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon, the man had forcibly pressed down on the poison and even Hwan Dok had been dispatched. Cheon Hwi had lived longer than expected.

The current Heavenly Demon?

The current Heavenly Demon was now embroiled in war. So unlike his predecessor, the World Ending Heavenly Demon could not afford to stamp down on the poison with all his strength.

Curious, the Inverted Sky Lord curled his lips. *What will you look like?*

Assassins sent from the Eastern Depot would be a good sacrifice to determine the poison’s effects.

“Okay, let’s do it. Assassinate him.”

When the emperor’s orders were issued, the Eastern Depot moved about.

The Eastern Depot was a secret institution under the emperor’s command. It was made up of eunuchs, but their power was unimaginable. Ordinary citizens, as well as martial artists, were afraid of this hidden organization.

Their movements were silent.

Almost immediately, the best assassins were ready.

Ones who could hide themselves in the darkness and could assimilate to their surroundings energy. If they went to Murim, they would be able to receive the title of lords.

The process of preparing was very secretive.

But no matter how silently you moved, you couldn't cover up all rumors.

What happened inside the Eastern Depot was secretly reported elsewhere, as were the overall movements of the government.

“Hmm.”

An old man hummed as he looked at the two letters in front of him.

The one on the left was in a white envelope, stamped with King Jinseong's seal of authenticity.

What was in it?

The contents were no longer in the envelope. After all, they had already been burnt.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon is the force that Jinseong brought in.

He raised a hand, slowly stroking his chin. He then picked up the other envelope.

It was a black envelope, contrasting the white one.

Despite the black envelope not having a signature on it, he tore it open.

The elderly man's eyes trembled as he took out the letter inside and began to read it.

His eyes shook as if he had read something unbelievable. He put the letter down with difficulty.

“Ugh, there are so many idiots who can’t tell if it’s my command or not because I’m gone.”

He reached for the letter, which floated into the air and immediately flew into the hearth.

Crackle—

The flame swallowed the letter in an instant.

The old man muttered, “All because I made a mistake with the Emperor. If you do this, I have no choice but to raise my head.”

He watched the flames for a few moments.

Soon, he took out some ink and paper and began writing a letter.

Finishing the letter, he folded it gently, then wrote another letter about what he was thinking about.

“Who’s outside?”

Finishing the letter, he called someone from outside.

At his call, two men entered the room.

“You summoned me, my lord.”

“You summoned me, my lord.”

In the light, the faces of the men were black. It was not just their face, their whole body remained dark in the flames. This was not usually seen in Zhongyuan.

Members of the Brocade Guard. [4]

“Excellent, there’s two of you.”

The man turned to them, handing one letter to each of the attendants.

“Take this letter to the Heavenly Demon.”

“Are you referring to the Cult Leader of the Demonic Cult?”

The old man nodded, seriously adding, “Whatever it takes, you must deliver this letter to him. You must move as quickly as possible, since we’re fighting against an emergency. Be careful not to be seen by anyone.”

“I will move in the darkness of the night and amongst the shadows of the day.”

The old man nodded, then turned to the other attendant. “Take your letter to Nanchang.”

“Do you want me to go and say something?”

“Secretly seek out the Sage and ask to meet the King. If you tell him you were sent by Jo, he will speak to you.”

“I hear the master’s command.”

‘Jo’ for Jo Woo-sang.

It was the name of the eliminated Chief of the Eastern Depot.

[1] Thousand Mile Eye (千里眼) would usually be translated as ‘clairvoyance’

[2] Abhijñā (六神通) is a Buddhist term generally translated as ‘supernatural knowledge’ or ‘direct knowledge’

[3] The Eastern Depot/Bureau, was a secret spy and police agency run by eunuchs

[4] The Brocade Guard were imperial secret police that served the emperor

Chapter 164: Secret (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 164 – Secret (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The battle against the Sichuan Murim Union ended with a Demonic Cult victory.

Although the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had prevailed, the result was also because the Qingcheng Sect had collapsed, followed by the fall of the Sichuan Tang Clan, which led the morale of the Sichuan Murim Union to fall significantly.

Additionally, the Sichuan Tang Clan had poisoned both enemies and allies alike.

Of course, winning did not mean the Cult did not suffer damage at all.

It was an all-out war, full of brawling and carnage.

There would always be damage.

That was why they stopped marching for a few days in order to recuperate.

In the course of those few days, there was a visitor to the main camp.

“Cheon Ah-young, Captain of the White Ape Unit and Divine Maiden, greets the Leader.”

She had come to Woon-seong's tent, bowing as she entered.

It used to be between the Young Leader and the Leader's daughter, but now it was a meeting between the Leader and the Divine Maiden.

Formalities were more necessary.

Woon-seong nodded his head.

With his permission, Cheon Ah-young raised her head.

She zeroed in on Woon-seong's shoulders.

News about the wounded shoulder had spread throughout the camp.

However, she was even more worried when she saw that he was actually wrapped in bandages.

Maybe it was because he could feel Cheon Ah-young's gaze, but Woon-seong opened his collar and showed his shoulder.

Cheon Ah-young asked aloud, "Are you all right?"

A little uncomfortable, Woon-seon nodded. "It is not a large wound."

As he said, the wound was not very large. Scarring or tissue trauma wasn't a big deal because he was a Semi-Divine Being.

The wound, which might have taken months of healing for others, would be healed within a few days.

The problem was the poison residing in his body.

There's no solution for that yet.

On the day Woon-seong had been poisoned, Senior Strategist Sang Gwan-chuk had kowtowed until his forehead was torn and bleeding.

It was because Sang Gwan-chuk still had not developed an antidote.

At his actions, Woon-seong helped the man up and sent him away.

There is obviously no way to cure it quickly.

Even though he knew that, Woon-seong was bitter.

First of all, Woon-seong did not intend to stop walking upon this path of vengeance.

If he did not have much life left, he would wipe out his enemies, even at the cost of burning out his life.

I have no idea what they were thinking when they poisoned me, but they have only set fire to my march.

Wooduk-

Woon-seong grip on the armrests tightened, leaving finger marks engraved into the chair.

Seeing his appearance, Cheon Ah-young let out a tearful noise. “Ah.....”

Woon-seong woke up from thought and said, “You succeeded.”

“It was not difficult compared to Sichuan, as there were not many of them.”

Woon-seong nodded.

She wasn’t wrong.

However,

“Success is still success.”

Woon-seong waved a hand.

That was the signal.

A guard, who had been waiting on one side, approached Cheon Ah-young.

He held something in his hands.

A large wooden box.

Accepting the box, Cheon Ah-young tilted her head in confusion.

It was because compared to its size, the box wasn't very heavy.

Seeing Cheon Ah-young tilt her head, Woon-seong nodded.

It was unspoken permission for her to open the box.

With permission given, Cheon Ah-young clicked the lid open.

At that moment, her eyes widened.

“This, this...”

What was in the box was a man's head preserved in salt.

It was an ugly sight for a woman.

However, Cheon Ah-young wasn't surprised because it was gruesome.

As a demonic practitioner, she had seen similar things.

What surprised her was the identity of the man.

While Cheon Ah-young was still surprised by the severed head, Woon-seong said: “Now, I have brought vengeance to one enemy.”

The severed head belonged to the Demonic Emperor of Oblivion, Hwan Dok.

Woon-seong had cut off the man's head and presented it to Cheon Ah-young.

After all, the man had been directly involved in the death of the ‘Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon’ Cheon Hwi, leader of the Cult and Cheon Ah-

young's father.

The one who had personally suffered and seen the man during the battle in front of the Divine Maiden's Palace.

That was why Woon-seong had cut the man's head off.

That was why he presented it to Cheon Ah-young.

And how did she react?

Cheon Ah-young dropped the box, kneeling on the floor and bursting into tears.

Because she remembered her father's death, she knelt before the severed head and silently cried.

Seeing Cheon Ah-young like this, Woon-seong took off his cloak and covered her with it. That way, even the smallest tears would be hidden...

After some time, Cheon Ah-young wiped away her tears.

Her eyes had turned red and puffy from crying.

"I apologize for showing you such a sorry state."

Woon-seong shook his head.

Perhaps he would be the same as Cheon Ah-young after he achieved his revenge.

If I'm still alive.

That was why he understood her emotions.

"It's alright."

At his words, Cheon Ah-young chuckled softly.

“I am going to send the head to the Heavenly Mountains and place it as an offering to Master’s shrine.”

“My father will be pleased.”

Woon-seong thought so too.

“But this revenge is not over yet.”

“.....”

“The forces that commanded him to poison Master. We still need to find out who is behind him and burn them to the ground, to offer up all of their heads. Until then, this revenge is not over.”

Cheon Ah-young nodded to his words with a resolute expression. She then nagged about his health for a bit, internally scolding herself.

Never forget until the moment revenge is over.

Following the reorganization of the army, they continued to march.

The Western Army decided to go back to Ninghai and join later.

They marched by day and set up camp to rest at night.

Meanwhile, there was a gaze hiding in the dark watching the Demonic Camp.

No, the person was completely assimilated with the darkness, watching the Demonic Army in secret.

Since the man’s skin was dark, he easily assimilated with the shadows.

It was an assassin.

More accurately, a messenger sent by Eastern Depot Chief Jo Woo-sang.

The man studied the camp for a long time, then pulled out an arrow.

After tying the letter sent by Jo Woo-sang to the end of the arrow, he yanked the bowstring back.

A tremendous amount of spiritual power poured out from the man's body.

The string strained, looking like it was about to snap.

Right after that!

Fiwheeying-!

An arrow splits the darkness like a shot.

Pak-!

Not too long later, there was the sound of an arrow hitting something.

Confirming that it had hit a tent, the man slid back into the night.

The last thing he saw of the camp was a commotion.

Pak-!

Despite having hidden himself, the man was soon caught by Gwan Tae-ryang.

Once the chaos had started, Sang Gwan-chuk had commanded the Charred Dragon Unit to search for suspicious people.

Thus, the bowman was quickly dragged into the camp by Gwan Tae-ryang and forced to kneel before Woon-seong.

Woon-seong stared down at the man, whose name was Oh Neung, wearing his Black Dragon Robe and chin resting in his hand.

In his hand was the letter that Oh Neung had sent tied around the arrow.

You saw it. The man swallowed.

The mission was a success.

Oh Neung's gaze lifted and met with Woon-seong's.

At that moment, the man felt a wall of energy. Goosebumps rose on his arms and cold sweat dripped down his neck.

How can a human's eyes be so deep and radiant....

Is this what it meant to be able to overwhelm people with your gaze alone?

It was truly terrifying.

Working with the Eastern Depot, Oh Neung had met many leaders in the empire, but not a single one of them had this kind of gaze.

While Oh Neung faced Woon-seong and began to sweat, Woon-seong was also looking at him.

“A foreigner...”

Woon-seong tossed the letter in his hands at the man.

The letter fluttered to the ground in front of Oh Neung.

“Did you send this letter to me?”

The one to answer was Gwan Tae-ryang.

“When I found the man, he had a bow and extra arrows on him. Considering they are the same as the one from the barracks, it should have been this man.”

The man did not deny it.

“That is the arrow I shot.”

“Are you the one who wrote this letter?”

Oh Neung shook his head at Woon-seong’s question. “It was my master.”

“Your master...”

Woon-seong’s gaze left the man and turned back to the letter.

Its contents were not complicated.

Instead, it was a simple cautionary note.

It warned that in a few days, an assassin would attack Woon-seong’s tent.

If it was true, it was something to be aware of.

But what if it was not true?

What if someone had created this situation on purpose?

Woon-seong was now poisoned, so he couldn’t believe anything easily.

“Who is your master?”

The man did not answer. He pressed his lips together, as if saying he would never answer.

Woon-seong smiled. “Are you not going to tell me?”

“I have been instructed by my master to not reveal his identity.”

Woon-seong rose from his seat. It was just a matter of simple torture and he would be able to make the man spill.

Moreover, Woon-seong knew a technique more effective than any other.

Even if the man’s skin was dark, the location of his blood vessels, muscle, and bones would still be the same as any other man.

“I don’t know if you can say that after you’ve endured the ‘Crushed Bones and Squeezed Muscles’.”

Woon-seong pointed one finger at Oh Neung with a cold expression.

Before anything could happen, an urgent cry came from the man’s mouth: “Quanzhen!”

Woon-seong’s expression hardened. The same was true of Gwan Tae-ryang, who was watching on.

The only ones who knew that Woon-seong had allied with the Quanzhen Sect were the executives of the Demonic Cult. But now the man in front of them had said ‘Quanzhen’.

Coincidence?

Nope.

There could be no coincidence in Kangho.

Obviously.

Woon-seong looked down at the man.

Under his gaze, Oh Neung trembled and remembered his master’s words.

— *“If the Cult Leader asks about me because you have been captured, mention the Quanzhen.”*

His master had foreseen this situation. Oh Neung then calmly recalled the next words.

— *Then...*

The man nervously wet his lips.

“Cult Leader, please give me some time.”

Chapter 165: Jwa Do-Gyul (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 165 – Jwa Do-gyul (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

A certain eunuch who lived in the Eastern Depot, Geum Gwang.

The status of Geum Gwang was very high inside the bureau, one of the highest three seats.

The Eastern Depot was originally a group of eunuchs who gathered inside the Imperial Palace, but they had been transformed into an organization holding massive power.

In the process, not only did they solve problems of the world in daylight, but they also hired assassins and killers to take care of the dirty work holding up the Imperial power.

Of course, getting to this position was not easy.

At first, the family had nothing to eat and so Geum Gwang's father had cut off his son's testicles and sold the boy as an eunuch. The boy would have lived a life just like any other eunuch, if not for an official suggesting that his qualities made him fit to be an assassin.

What did he say at the time?

Geum Gwang grabbed the sickle he wore around his waist, scratching his head. He was thinking of the person who recommended he become a murderer-for-hire.

“If you become a killer for the Eastern Depot, neither you nor your parents will have to live a life of hunger ever again.”

He remembered exactly what he had said in response.

“I don’t care about hunger or living. But if I become an assassin, I think I’ll kill my parents.”

No matter how much they wanted to live, those parents had cut off their own child’s testicles and sold him to the government.

Geum Gwang was very young at the time, but for that single reason, he hated his parents to death.

After that?

Afterwards, he entered a training institute run by the Eastern Depot.

An institute for assassins.

At that time, he really thought he was going to die.

If there was hell in this world, he believed it would be that institute.

After enduring that hell and becoming an assassin of the bureau, Ko Su, the master who had recommended him, presented him with two heads.

It was the heads of Geum Gwang’s parents.

A few years later, the old man who had beheaded his parents was assassinated by Geum Gwang.

The circumstances surrounding that old man’s death remained a mystery inside the bureau.

Was it revenge for his parents' deaths?

How could a madman like me do such a thing?

It was just that.

If you asked him for a reason, it was because Geum Gwang was upset he couldn't kill those pathetic people with his own hands.

He still was upset.

And then what?

After that, Geum Gwang lived as an assassin without much thinking.

He made a fool of a man who had made a fool of him, he saved a man who had saved him, he killed a man just to kill.

The better his skills, the harder the missions became. He almost died many times in the process.

Sometimes, he fell into a trap or met a very strong opponent.

Sometimes, other assassins thought he was a problem and drove him into set-ups.

As he went back and forth between life and death, Geum Gwang realized one thing.

The joy of life, which he thought he had become numb towards, had returned.

Dancing between the gaps of life and death became like a drug.

This excitement brought great pleasure to Geum Gwang. It was more pleasure than embracing a woman, more pleasure than winning big in a gambling den!

He was delighted to feel how close he had come to facing his own death, to see the life drain out of his enemy's eyes as he himself became the god of death.

He was most delighted when his sickle penetrated the target's skull.

The stronger the enemy, the more pleasure he derived from sicking the man.

This excitement allowed Geum Gwang to ascend to the ranks of great assassin. After becoming such a mass murder, he was able to work a little freer.

No powerful man had escaped his sickle, and no trap had brought him close to death.

Then a new mission came down to the ropes.

This time, it was a mission from the emperor.

“Kill the Heavenly Demon.”

Oh my.

Geum Gwang had heard that name before.

For the people of Orthodox Murim, that was an object of fear, the so-called nightmare of the martial factions.

But Geum Gwang was not afraid.

He was addicted to walking the line between life and death anyway.

In addition, he knew how vain and exaggerated fame in Murim was.

What if the Heavenly Demon was as strong as rumors said?

It doesn't matter.

That would only be more exciting.

And the man would die as it was.

No one can defeat me in the dark.

Geum Gwang smiled.

As evidence of this, no one noticed his presence, even though he had entered the camp of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“I’ve got to get to work.”

“I’m glad it’s not too cold.”

Demonic soldiers passed by him.

“Was there wind just now?”

One of them seemed to feel Geum Gwang’s movements, but mistook it for the wind.

No one truly noticed Geum Gwang’s presence.

It was as if he had dissolved himself and assimilated with nature. Even a sliver of darkness was enough to hide himself; even if there was no darkness, he could still hide...

This was the power of the stealth techniques handed down from the Imperial Palace.

That way, Geum Gwang slowly pulled out his sickle with a happy expression. He was starting to be able to see the center of the camp.

He could also see the largest tent.

That was the tent of the Heavenly Demon.

Tomorrow morning, there would be a great commotion.

If the Heavenly Demon's head is found impaled by a sickle, there will definitely be a commotion.

He smiled viciously.

He snickered, not forgetting to hide his body once again. The light seemed to distort around him and Geum Gwang disappeared. No one seemed to even notice a trace of him.

Geum Gwang, who showed the best techniques of an assassin, entered the Heavenly Demon's tent.

Kill the Heavenly Demon.

Puchi—

The White Night Spear melted through the air and blood splattered everywhere.

Geum Gwang, who had just entered the tent, had his head blown off.

Looking at the corpse of the man, Woon-seong chuckled coldly, "How pitiful."

Through Geum Gwang's eyes, the Demon Sucking Evil Puppeteer, who had been watching the situation, let out a sigh.

"Hah."

The red energy in his eyes soon disappeared. Since Geum Gwang had died, the Thousand Mile Eye also had to be canceled.

The Inverted Sky Lord, who was watching the scene in interest, asked, "How did it go?"

A spider was being destroyed in his hands.

It was a spider as big as the palm of his hands, with its fangs torn out and legs broken one by one.

Tuk—

Tuk—

Every time one of its legs broke, the spider trembled. A green liquid flowed from its wounds.

It looked a little watery, but it wasn't poisonous.

In the hands of the Leader of the Inverted Sky, the spider continued to twist in agony.

The Inverted Sky Lord did not care about the spider, waiting for the Chancellor's words.

"He failed."

"Right? I knew it."

The Inverted Sky Lord sighed at the words of the man in Young-gun's skin. He then pressed his finger against the spider, which had now lost all of its legs.

Foo-seok—

Green liquid splashed in all directions.

Seeing that, the Inverted Sky Lord chuckled, "This is fun, this is fun."

He said it was fun, but his face was full of dissatisfaction.

The Chancellor knew what that expression meant. "Haha, there is still time. Do not rush."

At this point, the emperor glanced at the Chancellor with dead eyes. Overwhelming weight suddenly crashed down onto the chancellor.

"I'm rushing?"

He looked frightening, but the Chancellor had grown used to it. He chuckled lightly and bowed his head. “I think this old man has grown older. I have offended you.”

Seeing the chancellor like that, the emperor shook his head lightly. “No, you are right, I was rushing. The last Heavenly Demon lasted a long time after being poisoned, right? Why would this one be different? I’m sure he’ll survive despite the poisoning too.”

The Chancellor nodded. “He will last for a while. But the situation is different, so he will be unable to hold on as long as the previous Cult Leader.”

The emperor smiled brightly. “Is that so?”

The Chancellor smiled and nodded. “Of course. We are at war now.”

There was a commotion during the Cult of the Heavenly Demon at this time, like Geum Gwang had predicted.

No, to be precise, there was a commotion in Woon-seong’s tent.

“I have committed a grave sin.”

Kung—

Gwan Tae-ryang’s head hit the floor. Blood trickled down his forehead.

“I will increase the security. At the same time, I will place more masters around the barracks...”

Woon-seong waved a hand to stop the man’s words.

It was a sin to allow an assassin into the dwelling of the Leader.

But...

“It was no ordinary assassin. Not only his walking, but even his breathing and energy were completely synchronized with the surrounding objects. His skills did not fall under those of the new Demonic Masters.”

The Demonic Masters were the Top Ten in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. Last time, something had happened inside the Cult and so there had been two empty slots. There was a great competition and two skilled Demonic Kings had taken those places. In fact, their skills did not fall short even compared to the pre-existing Demonic Masters.

Nevertheless, that assassin had been about the same as a Demonic Master.

Gwan Tae-ryang seemed to wilt.

Woon-seong shook his head, correcting his previous evaluation.

“He seemed a little insane, so probably not Absolution; a little lower than that. If he fought against the mid-level of the Demonic Kings, it would probably be a fair fight.”

That was still the upper echelon.

With that, there was no use increasing the guards.

In other words, it was not Gwan Tae-ryang’s fault.

Woon-seong glanced at Gwan Tae-ryang and commented, “A little stronger than you.”

After losing to Woon-seong, Gwan Tae-ryang had brutally trained himself.

As a result, he had been able to rank amongst the top of the Great Demons before the war. Now, he was confident that he could even place amongst the lower Demonic Kings.

But a little stronger than myself.

It was natural for Gwan Tae-ryang’s expression to grow somber.

Woon-seong turned his head away from Gwan Tae-ryang, looking at one corner of the tent.

“As you said, there was one assassin.”

Where Woon-seong’s gaze reached was a man of all black, Oh Neung.

Chapter 166: Jwa Do-Gyul (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 166 – Jwa Do-gyul (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

When Woon-seong's gaze landed on Oh Neung, the man shivered.

But he wasn't surprised because an assassin had actually come.

Indeed, Master was right.

"If the Heavenly Demon tries to kill you, tell him."

Thanks to Jo Woo-sang's orders, Oh Neung had preserved his life.

As the man was trembling, Woon-seong said, "Eastern Depot?"

At the question, the man calmed down. He was trained to be that way in the first place.

Information about the Eastern Depot was strictly controlled not only within the imperial court, but also outside.

That was why those of the Eastern Depot were trained to never reveal any information regarding the bureau, even in the face of death.

Oh Neung was no different. That was why he was composed.

As if the man's attitude did not matter, Woon-seong settled into his chair and crossed his legs. "Perhaps the assassin who attacked me was from the Eastern Depot. I don't know why, but I think it is so."

Oh Neung turned his gaze to Woon-seong. The same was true of Sang Gwan-chuk.

The man, Geum Gwang, could have been a simple assassin.

They hadn't even had a conversation, so he was wondering how the Heavenly Demon could be so sure.

This question was soon resolved.

"The assassins of Zhongyuan and those of the Eastern Depot have subtly different ways of hiding their presence. The assassins of Murim start by killing the sound of their footsteps, then hiding their movements. On the contrary, assassins of the Eastern Depot are trained to synchronize their energy with the environment, rather than silence their steps."

Woon-seong paused, then continued on:

"Although the lines are being blurred, it is difficult to completely erase habits that have been passed down for generations. That is why even if the boundary is crossed, there is still a subtle difference."

Woon-seong turned.

He pointed at the headless corpse of the assassin.

"He assimilated with the energy around him just before he killed his steps. Thanks to that, I knew he was an assassin of the Eastern Depot, and likely your peer. Your skills suggest that you are no ordinary assassin; you are either the best of the best or an advanced assassin of your class."

Woon-seong stopped talking, turning to look at the man.

He simply looked, but Oh Neung felt like the gaze was coldly piercing through him. Perhaps was surprised by the level of insight, inferring

affiliation merely by the habits of an assassin.

Regardless, Woon-seong continued to stare.

“W-What are you saying?”

The man’s words trembled and Woon-seong chuckled. The fangs that appeared when he smiled gleamed like those of a beast.

“An assassin of the Eastern Depot made his move. That would have been made in secret. But you know this information in advance and even pass it on to me?”

Woon-seong tapped on the armrest with his fingertips.

“In order for you to know this information in advance, it would be impossible unless you were a very senior official within the bureau.”

One side of Woon-seong’s mouth twitched up.

“One eunuch sends an assassin to kill, another sends an assassin to give me information. Isn’t it funny?”

Woon-seong rose from his seat. He then grabbed Oh Neung by the collar.

“What is going on in your organization? Are you having some civil war?”

Oh Neung trembled hearing Woon-seong’s growl.

“.....”

After a while, he opened his mouth.

“My master is not a mere eunuch.”

His master *was* the chief.

He was definitely an eunuch. No, he was not a normal eunuch, but the eunuch who ruled over the entire bureau.

But now...?

The man had lost his position as the chief, and even his name had been stolen from him, forcing him to live like a savage in the dark.

Nevertheless, he continued to live on thanks to many of his servants who remained inside the bureau and who knew the truth.

Of course, Oh Neung did not tell Woon-seong any of that. He had not been ordered to speak of it, nor did he have a reason to.

However, he said something else.

“What is certain is that Master is trying to help you.”

“Trying to help me?”

Oh Neung nodded, adding, “And Nanchang.”

Woon-seong stared at the man, searching through his soul.

Oh Neung closed his eyes.

“Hmph.”

Woon-seong dropped the man’s collar.

He then called out an order, “Offer lodging for the intruder. Just make sure he doesn’t stray more than 30 meters from the area. If he tries to escape with force, you can kill him on the spot.”

Gwan Tae-ryang shouted loudly, “Understood.”

At that moment, Oh Neung understood: *Until everything is clear, I’m a prisoner...*

Gwan Tae-ryang dragged the man off.

Only Woon-seong and Sang Gwan-chuk were left inside the tent.

There was a beat of awkward silence.

Woon-seong deliberately poured water into a cup.

Watching him do it, Sang Gwan-chuk worriedly asked, “Are you alright?”

Woon-seong nodded his head. He could feel the poison swirling inside his body, but it was bearable.

Not yet.

Yes, not yet. I can't stand it, but I will endure it.

Woon-seong clenched his fist.

He then changed the subject.

“Senior assassin...”

“They are arrogant. What were they thinking by sending an assassin into the middle of the Cult?”

Woon-seong chuckled bitterly. He could guess why the assassins had been sent, but he still asked Sang Gwan-chuk.

“You know why, don't you?”

Sang Gwan-chuk was silent for a moment. Woon-seong also did not speak.

Perhaps the silence sounded like a push to speak, as the Strategist sighed and said, “I cannot fool the Leader.”

“I noticed too.”

“Perhaps the Eastern Depot sent an assassin to find out what the Leader was up to?”

“To see how poisoned I am?”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded.

“Master endured a little longer. No matter how you look at it, the poison won’t work right away.”

“Nevertheless, the former leader refrained from using internal qi as much as possible, unless it was a special circumstance. That was how he managed to suppress the poison for so long.”

Woon-seong’s eyes trembled. “He was restraining his internal qi to the fullest extent?”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded.

In Woon-seong’s mind, memories of his training with Cheon Hwi rushed to the fore.

The image of Cheon Hwi facing him, the figure of Cheon Hwi as he split the moon.

Standing before Woon-seong, Cheon Hwi had shown no sign of holding back his internal qi.

The man had acted that way, despite knowing that using his strength would bring him closer to death.

“Master.”

Woon-seong bowed his head.

I didn’t know any of that. I was just trying to take advantage of my status as the Young Leader.

Cheon Hwi had treated him as a real disciple, no matter how Woon-seong felt.

Woon-seong desperately tried to reach for Cheon Hwi in his mind, but the man had already left this earth.

With his head down, Woon-seong told the Strategist, “I want to be alone for a while.”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded and turned away.

The day after the assassin was sent to Woon-seong’s tent, there was a huge commotion in the middle of Murim.

Hundreds of people were filling the field.

With all these people gathered, it was surprising that there was not some huge disturbance.

There were a few words here and there. Some talking here, another over there.

What was more surprising was they were all the leaders of different sects and factions. They were all masters in their own right, but they were all affiliates of the Martial Alliance.

Hundreds were gathered.

As the atmosphere continued, a flag slowly rose from the platform in the middle of the field.

A flag that symbolized the Lord of Murim.

The Martial Alliance.

As the flag rose into the air, whatever talking there ceased.

It was the authority of the lord.

As it rose, the elders of the Martial Alliance ascended the platform.

Looking at their faces, they were all famous people of Murim.

If those below the platform had names that shook each province, then those walking up had names that could shake not just one province but the whole world.

Murim's masters had walked up, then parted to the sides, opening up a path.

It was the appearance of the Martial Alliance.

As soon as the lord appeared, everyone swallowed their saliva.

Looking at them, Jwa Do-gyul slowly opened his mouth.

“Haha, before I start, I would like to thank all the sect leaders for rushing here in one month without delay because of a call from this old man.”

Roar-roar!

Jwa Do-gyul's voice echoed through the area. All the sect leaders were astonished by the strength in those words.

Ugh, the lord's strength.

It is nothing compared to before.

With this level of strength, I can say that he has reached the end of Transcendence.

The ability of the Lord is not lacking compared to those at the top of the 72 Supreme Masters.

Jwa Do-gyul's current strength was incomparable to back when his finger had been sliced off by Hyuk Woon-seong.

In fact, he was able to contest for the throne amongst the Supreme Masters.

The Twin Stars and the 10 martial artists just beneath them were considered the 12 Supreme Masters.

Nok Yu-on, Woon-seong's master, had been amongst them.

However, as the field of Transcendence-Absolution was quite fluid, people often broadened this list.

With the exception of the Buddhist Star and the Sword Star, the 72 strongest martial artists in the world were often called the 72 Supreme Masters.

Even among the most supreme masters, Jwa Do-gyul was there.

It was not the same as ten years ago, when he could barely be considered as the bottom of the 72.

Seeing the people surprised, Jwa Do-gyul smiled before opening his mouth once again.

Chapter 167: 1000 Absolute Routes (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 167 – 1000 Absolute Routes (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“As you all know, we punished the wicked devil’s followers who were hiding in Zhongyuan not long ago.”

Technically, this war had been started by the Martial Alliance.

If they hadn’t moved and attacked the demonic branches, this Orthodox-Demonic war might have been postponed for several years.

Nevertheless, Jwa Do-gyul did not talk about ‘the first shot’.

For their cause, the Martial Alliance wrapped up their actions as justifiable punishment for the followers of the Demonic Cult.

They were demons; that was the reason.

If they said that it was the Martial Alliance who had started the war here, justification would go over to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Jwa Do-gyul was also aware of this fact, so he did not tell the sect leaders the truth.

Instead, they were more likely to respond to his words denouncing the Demonic Cult.

“The filthy demons!”

“We must drive them all out of this land. Let them know the fear of the righteous and chivalrous!”

Those who did not know the truth?

Those who did not know the truth bandwagoned together, knowing nothing of the reactions of those who *did* know the truth.

“Yes, yes!”

As all of their opinions converged, Jwa Do-gyul smiled. He raised his hand.

As if it were a sign, those who had been talking went quiet.

Jwa Do-gyul nodded. “This old man agrees with you. Everyone here has the same opinion, don’t they?”

Jwa Do-gyul glanced around the platform. He then looked at each person one by one.

“Of the 570 factions who have joined the Martial Alliance, 500 of them have gathered today for our cause.”

500 sect leaders.

If you combined the sect members under their command, that would be a large and united army. Even when compared to the army of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, it would not be small.

Among the four Demonic Armies, the Southern and Northern Armies hadn’t yet advanced, but that didn’t matter.

The victory of Orthodox Murim wasn’t what Jwa Do-gyul was after anyways.

It will be time after the blood has flowed and the seeds of Zhongyuan have died out in this land.

At that time, the Cult of the Inverted Sky would appear.

That was the moment Jwa Do-gyul was waiting for.

Without even knowing this, the sect leaders of Murim raised they're energy, as if responding to Jwa Do-gyul.

Seeing their momentum, Jwa D-gyul slowly unsheathed the sword strapped to his waist.

Whoo-hoo!

The sword in his hand began to vibrate, and a white light wrapped around his blade.

Huai—

It was a brilliant and shining sword.

Sword aura wrapped around the sword, pulsating with energy.

Jwa Do-gyul raised the sword high into the sky.

“On this day, this Lord makes a declaration to the Heavens and earth!”

Roar! Roar!

His voice echoed across the area.

It was as if the spirits of the Heavens and earth were responding to his call.

“May all those Demonic cultists be defeated at the hands of cloud-like heroes of Murim who have come here with a just cause!”

Standing underneath the platform, the sect leaders shouted, echoing his call.

“Waaaahhhh!”

“Waaaahhhh!”

And, as if responding, the martial artists who had not been allowed into the meeting also shouted.

“Waaaahhhhhhhh!”

It was the moment the Martial Alliance officially called for war.

“Waaaahhhh!”

It was not easy for the cheers and rising excitement to die down.

The shouts continued even after Jwa Do-gyul had descended from the platform.

There was overwhelming applause.

Jwa Do-gyul walked down from the platform, glancing back with a cold smile. “You are all fools.”

Peng Ah-hu, an elder of the Alliance who was walking behind him, concluded, “Those who are Orthodox are all those who tremble with hypocrisy, but act magnanimous and majestic.”

Jwa Do-gyul nodded at Peng Ah-hu’s words.

If it were someone else, they would never be having this conversation.

Outwardly, Jwa Do-gyul was known to be the kind, compassionate, and judicious Lord of the Martial Alliance.

The only exception to this farce was an elder of the Martial Alliance and the Peng Clan, Peng Ah-hu.

He was a member of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, just like Jwa Do-gyul.

“Phew, didn’t it go well?”

Agreeing with that, Peng Ah-hu smiled brightly. However, the smile was brief. He frowned and spoke in a gloomy tone: “Some of the Taoist factions and Five Great Sword Sects were absent.”

His words were enough to make Jwa Do-gyul’s expression harden.

“Hmm.” Jwa Do-gyul paused, then murmured, “Clearly, almost half of the Taoist sects did not attend. The same is true of two of the Great Five Sword Sects.”

Peng Ah-hu nervously muttered, “I wonder if they have noticed.”

Jwa Do-gyul tilted his head in thought. “Well...”

In fact, it was a bit surprising that the Mount Hua Sect had not been present. Not to mention, the troops of the Demonic Cult were currently occupying Sichuan, weren’t they?

The Mount Hua Sect was still motionless, even though it was obvious that Shaanxi Province would be attacked, since Gansu Province had been.

In that regard, it was the same for the Taoist sects.

Soon after, Jwa Do-gyul made a solemn expression. “We will soon find out what they have in mind.”

Peng Ah-hu’s expression shifted and he tilted his head. “What are you talking about?”

At his question, Jwa Do-gyul nodded in satisfaction. “Shouldn’t there be sacrifices in order to speak to the emperor about grandeur?”

“Sacrifices...?”

“Hehe, you’ll see.”

Poison.

While the Martial Alliance called for war, Woon-seong was deep in thought.

He wasn't thinking about much.

An unknown poison was in his body. He was thinking about how to overcome this poison.

How do I decipher the poison without the actual poison?

Ordinary poisons could be collected and drained from one place. Or they could be burned within the body by internal qi.

But if that were possible, Master wouldn't have fallen to this poison.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly.

Even now, the poison was persistently clinging to Woon-seong's body. He had tried to rip it away, but it only stuck on stronger and did not give way.

It wasn't weak to fire either. He had tried to collect and burn the poison with Semi-Divine internal qi and the Divine Flame.

Even after all of that, the poison was still intact.

Woon-seong, who had tried many different things, had to laugh.

Now, he no longer tried to stimulate it, just letting it sit. It was because the poison seemed to be having a seizure as he stimulated it.

It was the Earthen Body.

The Heavenward Soul Earthen Body was a body refining technique that burned the soul to change the Heavens, and converted the body to the earth. That was a power which allowed him to operate his innate essence qi and to heal rapidly.

But the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body was also useless against the poison.

In the end, I have no choice but to limit my usage of qi as much as possible.

Woon-seong shook his head.

The enemies he was against were strong enough to swallow the Imperial Palace. Moreover, the emergence of those Semi-Divine puppet things continued to threaten him, forcing him to use his abilities.

Do I do nothing?

If he preserved his strength in order to live on, he would not be able to achieve revenge even in this second life.

Woon-seong bit his lips so hard they began to bleed.

The metallic and bitter tang of blood coated his tongue.

Perhaps he should have been grateful for that.

Deep in thought, his chapped lips were now wet.

At this time, another method came to mind.

The poison requires the physical body.

So what if he changed bodies?

It was not a question of whether he could transfer his soul to another person's body. He was just wondering what would happen if he could reforge his body once again.

Body modification.

The phenomenon of emptying the body of all impurities and eliminating all unnecessary things.

If he somehow caused such a phenomenon, he could probably blow out all the poison in his body.

At this, laughter bubbled out.

Woon-seong burst into a fit of laughter, not hiding any of its emptiness.

“Whew.”

A sigh followed the laughing fit.

The best way is always the most difficult.

Woon-seong had already achieved a martial body through body modification once. In other words, not only had his soul and internal qi crossed the threshold of humanity, so had his body.

It's already hard to do it once, but twice...

If he knew how to cross that wall, perhaps it would not be so difficult.

He did not know when he could experience another phantom metamorphosis or when he could surpass the limits of his body again.

But.

If this is the only way, I'll do it.

A second body modification.

If you run hard, you will reach it someday.

Woon-seong clenched his fists.

In order to push this body even harder...

Woon-seong's gaze turned to the iron bracers curled around his wrists and ankles.

Even after reaching Semi-Divinity, he had continued increasing their weights.

Just based on the sounds they made, they were terribly heavy.

Indeed, the iron rings on Woon-seong were unbelievably heavy for a person to carry.

They were 75 kgs (165lbs) each, weighing just a bit less than an adult man.

Combining both his arms and legs, his body was imprisoned by a total weight of nearly 300 kgs.

It was quite a frightening weight.

But now I feel no discomfort moving with them on.

That meant it was time to change the weight.

I should call someone and ask them to make new iron rings.

Just as he was thinking that, there were voices from outside the tent.

“May I come in?”

It was the Senior Strategist.

Chapter 168: 1000 Absolute Routes (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 168 – 1000 Absolute Routes (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

With Woon-seong's permission, Sang Gwan-chuk ducked inside the tent.

He looked up and said, "I am here to report on the situation."

Woon-seong narrowed his eyes at the word 'situation'. Was there something that was worth reporting on right now?

Sichuan Murim had collapsed, Ningxia Province had collapsed.

A few days ago, he heard reports that the factions in Chongqing Province had packed up and run away, while those in Guizhou Province were planning the same.

But there was a situation to report?

"Is there something worth mentioning?"

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded with a hardened expression. "The Martial Alliance has called a meeting."

Hearing this, Woon-seong's expression also hardened.

“The Martial Alliance intends to use Chongqing and Guizhou as battlefields,” Sang Gwan-chuk said as he laid some new flags onto the map of the world.

They were blue flags, different from the red ones that symbolized the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

They were flags representing the Martial Alliance.

Woon-seong furrowed his brow. “Is this how they are occupying the area?”

Based on the situation illustrated by the map, it was clear that it would not be an easy fight.

The Martial Alliance had already occupied various highlands and ridges, as well as key strategic points. Still, fortunately, Woon-seong’s worst case scenario seemed to have been avoided.

Sang Gwan-chuk shook his head.

“This is only what I expect based on the current advancement of the Martial Alliance, but not all of these areas have yet been occupied.”

As he spoke, he pulled a pen from his waist. He dipped it in ink and drew a circle around some flags.

“These are the only occupied points. As you can see, there are still many areas that have not yet been taken.”

“In the end, if we want the fight to be a bit easier, we have to move quickly.”

“We have rested long enough during the march, so if we start advancing right now, we should be able to fight with about a third of these occupied.”

Woon-seong nodded. It wasn’t ideal, but it would be much better than going into battle without occupying any favorable land.

“Let us split the rear Southern Army into two, so that they can march through Sichuan and Gansu respectively. The Eastern and Western Armies will continue forward.”

“How would you like them to move?”

Woon-seong responded by moving a red flag without physically touching it. “The Eastern Army will go to Guizhou and the Western Army can move towards Chongqing. That way, the distance traveled by the armies will be shorter.”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded. “Understood.”

Woon-seong suddenly remembered something. “Oh, and I have a favor to ask you.”

Sang Gwan-chuk titled his head.

Placing one of the iron bracers on the table, Woon-seong said, “I would like to increase the weight of the iron rings by 100 kilograms, please have new ones be made.”

Sang Gwan-chuk had a relatively frightened look on his face hearing that Woon-seong wished to make the rings even heavier. He knew the weight of the current ones, since he had ordered them himself.

But how can you want more weight...?

If exaggerated a little, that was almost double the original.

It made Sang Gwan-chuk wonder if the Leader was truly poisoned or if he didn't understand the direness of the situation well enough to limit the use of internal qi as much as possible.

I don't think that's it.

But soon, Sang Gwan-chuk corrected himself. Woon-seong's eyes were as serious as ever.

It was not that the Leader is unaware of the situation.

He had made such a request knowing the gravity.

If so... Sang Gwan-chuk swallowed. Have you found a way?

If Woon-seong said he had found a way, Sang Gwan-chuk would believe him. He was young, but the Leader had never let the Strategist down before.

“I heed the command of the Leader,” bowed Sang Gwan-chuk.

After the Strategist left, Woon-seong confirmed that there were no eyes on him. No longer hiding his tired expression, he settled deep into the chair.

He closed his eyes.

The way to drive the body to its limit was to increase the weight of the iron rings. Then what about my qi?

Any martial artist would tell you that above all, harmony between the internal and external were important.

This was no exception for Woon-seong, who was a Semi-Divine Being.

If the body was strengthened, then both his external and internal strength had to develop.

After all, you have to find a way.

The path for his martial arts.

Woon-seong thought of many different paths.

The first thing that came to mind was the Heart Sword, which ‘Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon’ Cheon Hwi had shown him.

Rather than the moon reflected in the lake, the Heart Sword shattered the moon reflected in the heart.

The memory of that time remained as a shock in Woon-seong's mind. That was the first time he had seen the physical manifestation of the State of Mind and the Heart Sword of rumors.

Should I have the Heart Sword be my path?

Woon-seong's brows twitched.

No.

Heart Sword.

Using a sword to soften a person's state of mind was definitely powerful.

But Woon-seong didn't think that it was the way to go.

He knew that the Heart Sword was definitely a path to develop his martial arts, but it was not the absolute answer.

If there were a hundred different martial artists, there were a hundred different martial arts.

Only the Heart Sword was chosen and achieved by Cheon Hwi; Woon-seong did not have to walk down that path.

Then what path suits me?

Wasn't there a way for him to strike his opponent across space-time that wasn't the Heart Sword?

If not, was there a way to forge an intangible sword using intangible sword force?

An endless number of forks in the road appeared in Woon-seong's mind, then disappeared.

Suddenly, it was like lightning flashed.

Woon-seong's mind went blank.

It was because of a single word passing through his head.

Why did I forget?

Woon-seong clenched his fists tightly.

His path of martial arts had already been set. He had just forgotten about it.

“An expansive martial sea...” muttered Woon-seong.

A sea made of martial arts knowledge.

An endless sea that weaved the strings of Heaven and earth together.

Wasn't it a scholar's dream to make such a theory of academia? Any descendent of the Spear Master Sect, who would be both a scholar and a martial artist, should hope to develop such a grand theory.

No.

Woon-seong shook his head.

He was not here to create some academic theory, but to make a martial technique that would allow himself to transcend his own limits.

And he would have to make the technique again and again.

Woon-seong slowly licked his lips.

“One Thousand Absolute Routes.”

One thousand routes to perfectly capture all of the martial arts that existed in this world.

No faction, no theory, or martial technique would be able to escape this course...

Woon-seong muttered its name again, “One Thousand Absolute Routes.”

Truly, the sound of that name wasn't so bad.

The way I must go.

One Thousand Absolute Routes. [1]

As Woon-seong and Sang Gwan-chuk had discussed, the Demonic Army began to advance.

The Southern Army took the spot of the Eastern and Western Armies, as the front of the Demonic Army advanced in separate directions.

This was to grab any and all advantages they could in the battlefield chosen by the Martial Alliance.

It was during the third day of the march that Sang Gwan-chuk visited Woon-seong's tent once again.

“I have brought the items you asked for.”

Kung-

After Sang Gwan-chuk finished speaking, the soldiers behind him laid down a huge box.

Just by placing it down, the ground seemed to ring — what a terrifying weight.

The demonic soldiers who had carried it inside did not ask anything aloud, but looked on in curiosity.

What is the leader going to do with all this weight...?

It was because they felt first hand and knew the box was heavier than it looked.

The weight of four adults was not easy to carry.

They stuck their tongues out in thought.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong approached the box.

It was made of iron.

“I used an iron box because I feared that a wooden one would have broken under the weight.”

Woon-seong nodded at the explanation and opened the lid.

There was a squeaking sound and the inside was revealed.

Four well made iron rings could be seen.

“A considerable amount of Black Iron Stone was added in order to make sure the small size could accommodate the desired weight. Any missing weight was filled using Mud Iron.”

Both Black Iron Stone and Mud Iron were much denser than other ferrous materials. And they were costly.

Woon-seong picked up one of the weights.

Perhaps it was because they were nearly twice as heavy, but the weight in his hand was quite sturdy.

“Well done,” Woon-seong said, satisfied with the weight.

Sang Gwan-chuk bowed his head.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong clipped one of the four bracers onto his arm.

Clank—

There was the sound of iron interlocking with iron and his arm sagged down. Woon-seong slightly shivered at the weight.

It is definitely heavier than before.

It was enough to force his physical body to the limits. He might even dislocate his shoulder if he wasn't careful.

Woon-seong silently put the other iron bracers on.

As they watched him do so, the guards and soldiers who had been carrying the box were wide-eyed and slack-jawed.

Oh my...

Even if he's the Leader, that much...

They were unable to believe that a human could bear such weight with physical strength alone. If you wielded that weight, you might be able to burst someone's head with just a flick of the wrist.

But can he move? A guard tilted his head in wonder.

Woon-seong loosened his shoulders, as if laughing at such thoughts.

Peng—

A fist was thrown forth and a heavy echo sounded. Not done with just that, Woon-seong tested out some more physical combat moves.

Bang, bang, bang!

Thump—

It was truly a terrifying resonance.

Whenever his fist or feet stuck the air, you could see a ring of air being pushed and exploding outwards.

Almost unknowingly, Sang Gwan-chuk chuckled. "Huh, huh."

The other soldiers did not make a sound, but had similar reactions.

Whether he saw their reactions or not, Woon-seong nodded with a satisfied expression.

It would take some time to adjust, but it was the first step towards crossing a new wall.

That was why Woon-seong spoke, meaning it with all his heart.

“Not so bad.”

[1] been struggling to come up with a name, since it's supposed to be 1000 all-encompassing, perfect, and unified routes; if someone can come up with a better translation of 一千圆路 pls send help

Chapter 169: Conquest (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 169 – Conquest (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Oh my god.”

“Just one of those is the same weight as me...”

“I can’t believe you can carry that with just muscle strength. Indeed, the Leader’s way of training is much harsher than ours.”

The group stared at Woon-seong like they were looking at a monster. He himself would too, if only he couldn’t see the strain on his muscles.

Woon-seong glanced down at his arms. It was clear that his muscles were straining.

Why wouldn’t it be hard for Woon-seong?

He just didn’t feel like expressing it.

If you struggle with just this much, you won’t be able to wade through the muddied and thorny fields before you.

Also, he had to act strong as the Cult Leader, not just an avenger.

Woon-seong pulled down the Black Dragon Robe, which had been rolled up. He waved his hand and said, “That is all.”

The soldiers bowed their heads.

They then dragged off the empty box.

Maybe it was because the weight of the box had greatly reduced by removing the iron bracers, but they did not feel the danger of collapse from earlier.

Watching them, Woon-seong smiled predatorily as he lounged in his seat.

Seeing Woon-seong like that, Sang Gwan-chuk could not hide his worrying tone. “Are you sure you want to do this?”

Woon-seong nodded. “It’s okay.”

He would make it okay, even if it wasn’t okay. Those were Woon-seong’s inner thoughts, but he did not have to say them aloud.

Despite Woon-seong’s words, Sang Gwan-chuk could not shake his worries. He continued to look anxious.

Woon-seong changed the topic to distract him.

“How is the occupation going?”

While the Cult of the Heavenly Demon marched, they had made several missions to occupy parts of the region first. What Woon-seong was asking about were the results.

Sang Gwan-chuk slowly talked.

High west, low east (西高東低).

Was there a phrase more suitable for expressing the geography of Guizhou Province?

Guizhou, where mountains covered almost the entire province, had higher altitudes in the west and gentler slopes in the east.

The place where the Martial Alliance had decided to settle was the city of Anshun.

Anshun was a mountainous region about three days away from Guiyang, the capital city of Guizhou Province.

From Anshun, it was not only easy to procure supplies because of nearby hubbubs, but it was also in a support position to protect the capital and its numerous temples.

The capital city was the pride of a province.

It was as if the Martial Alliance expressed their willingness to protect their pride by choosing Anshun as the battleground.

Then, the question arose as to what kind of place Anshun was as a battlefield.

Anshun.

There were over a hundred large and small peaks where small battles could be held, and a basin suitable for all-out fighting right in the center.

That was Anshun.

Clang—

In one of those hundred peaks located in the region of Anshun, the sound of metal colliding with metal rang through the air.

The sound was jarring.

A loud shout could be heard: “Don’t be forced back! Push forward. They can’t hold out either. Just a little more and we can take it!”

It was Gwan Tae-ryang.

Gwan Tae-ryang slashed through the soldiers of the Martial Alliance with his blade.

The members of the Charred Dragon Unit lined up behind him, as did demonic soldiers behind them.

They were currently climbing along a rugged ridge.

To seize the base of the Martial Alliance at the summit, obviously.

This is an order from the Senior Strategist. In other words, it is no different from a direct order from the Leader!

Gwan Tae-ryang cut down another Alliance soldier. You could tell how many people he had already slaughtered based on the sticky blood clinging to the metal blades.

Gwan Tae-ryang didn't care about that at all. Wielding his blade, he shouted: "Glory to the Heavenly Demon!"

The Charred Dragon Unit and other Demons echoed his rally: "Glory to the Heavenly Demon!"

The soldiers began to climb faster.

While the Charred Dragon Unit was fighting, the Samsara Demonic Cavalry had also been tasked with another summit, struggling against Martial Alliance soldiers there.

Mask Demon lifted his weapon and shouted. "Follow me!"

Then, all those who wore face masks followed after the black horse.

It was as if one person was acting, smooth without a single error.

Not, it felt like a river of black was bending.

Heeheeheeheeheeheehee –

Soldiers were entangled together on the battlefield and the horses of the Demonic Cavalry snorted.

At this time, the riders let go of the reins, lifting from their saddles and swinging.

Thwack—

Someone's head was smashed, raining bits of brain.

The man didn't care about the blood raining down, as he continued to swing.

Puchi—

Three more people were attacked.

Heart, head, abdomen.

All places were different, but none of the attacks were fatal.

“Growl.”

Perhaps there was a wily one among the Alliance soldiers. One of them reached out, grabbing at the spear which pierced through his body.

“Hoho?” His eyes raised beneath the blood-stained mask.

But that was it.

“Heiyah!”

Mask Demon sped up instead of retrieving the weapon.

Heeheeheeheehee —

The horse sprinted forward, charging through the battle. Still holding onto the spear, the soldier was dragged along.

Dragged along the floor, the soldier eventually let go.

Mask Demon, wielding his polearm again, shouted: “Scatter!”

This cry echoed through the guard, as the horses scattered amongst the battle.

Their horses could run across mountains and plains, their weapons able to tear apart limbs!

Wherever a member of the Samsara Demonic Cavalry galloped would be a river of blood.

It was like a vortex had torn people into pieces, still swirling.

Seeing the sight, Mask Demon roared: “Glory to the Heavenly Demon!”

It was the same cry Gwan Tae-ryang had made.

Hi-yi-ying!

“Heh-heh.”

Peng Ah-hu showed signs of discomfort as he stared down at the map. He had planned to occupy all the bases, but ended up losing about a third to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“Damn it.”

He swore. It was a remark he would usually never make because of his status as an elder.

But what did he care? No one was watching right now.

It was okay to do whatever he wanted when no one was watching.

That was why he swore again, not hiding his frustration.

“Fuck you...”

But he swallowed the insult he was ready to spit out, fixing his expression.

Someone came inside the room.

“I heard that the movements of the Demonic Cult are unusual.”

The one who had entered was another of the 72 Supreme Masters, just like Peng Ah-hu.

It was Seo Jong-tak of the Three Gorges Sect.

Like Peng Ah-hu, he was also placed in Guizhou as an elder of the Martial Alliance.

Peng Ah-hu was uncomfortable with the question, but pretended to be relaxed.

“This is still within my expectations. Besides, knowing that it would be impossible to add any more bases, the Demonic Cult won’t be thinking of making another move.”

Seo Jong-tak nodded his head. “If so, I am glad we can prevent the Demonic Cult’s movements in Guizhou.”

That made Peng Ah-hu laugh. “Puhahaha, I don’t know what you’re worried about. They’re just cultists, after all.”

“Right? I guess I’m too worried.”

Seo Jong-tak laughed faintly and Peng Ah-hu nodded.

However, he grimaced at the next words.

“But Elder Peng, you might be worried.”

“Worried?”

“I heard your nephew was in the New Dragon Battalion, but he is now strangely missing?”

“Hmm, do not speak of such negativities.”

As soon as the story came out, Peng Ah-hu’s expression was solemn. No matter who saw him, they would say he was worried about his nephew.

But his internal thoughts were completely different from his face: *What does whether he survive or not have to do with me?*

Peng Hak was a direct descendent of the Peng Clan, but Peng Hak and Peng Ah-hu had a poor relationship.

There was a reason, of course.

It was actually because while Peng Ah-hu had been hiding his ambition, he wanted to become the clan head.

As the son of Peng Ge-ak and direct descendant of the main line, Peng Ah-hu’s nephew was the legitimate next in line.

In fact, even within the Peng Clan, Peng Ah-hu and Peng Hak were famous for colliding events. However, this was not known to the outside world because it was taken as family in-fighting.

Without knowing Peng Ah-hu’s thoughts, Seo Jong-tak said, “I hope he is alive.”

“Haha, it will be alright,” Peng Ah-hu said, agreeing with him. *Hmph, it would be better for him to die at the hands of the Demonic Cult than to give him the clan head’s seat. So of course it will be alright.*

Of course, he did not forget to suppress these thoughts. As if he didn’t want to talk about such depressing matters, Peng Ah-hu changed the topic.

“Beyond that, it seems like things have fallen within the expected range in Guizhou, but I am not sure how it will be in Chongqing.”

Seo Jong-tak still hadn't noticed anything off, immediately worrying about the future of Murim.

“Well, we are here, but it's not like there aren't martial artists in that direction.”

As he said, there were other Orthodox factions in Chongqing. There was also the Mount Tai Sword Sect there, so there should be no problems.

“Haha, we should be able to stop the Demonic Cult safely in both Guizhou and Chongqing.”

At the same time, Peng Ah-hu felt a chill go down his spine. For some reason, he recalled Jwa Do-gyul's words.

What do you mean that a 'sacrifice' is necessary? Hmn...

Somehow, the words made him feel uneasy. Peng Ah-hu closed his eyes.

Chapter 170: Conquest (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 170 – Conquest (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

While Peng Ah-hu was looking down at the situation with the Demonic Army in Guizhou, the Martial Alliance in Chongqing was doing the same thing.

The map representing Chongqing was filled with blue and red.

About a third of the province was red.

And red stood for the Demonic Cult.

“Huh, the advancement of the Demonic Cult was quite vicious.”

Tae Hee-jin, one of the sect leaders, laughed at the absurdity. It was clear that the Martial Alliance had started the occupation war first, but a third of the bases was lost to the Demonic Cult in just one day.

Many of the martial artists spoke in agreement.

“I don’t think we should underestimate the Cult.”

“That’s exactly what I said. In particular, the White Ape Unit and troops led by the Demonic Master are our biggest problems.”

The words ‘White Ape Unit’ made Tae Hee-jin frown. It was quite unbelievable that a martial artist’s face could distort like this.

However, the martial artists around neither reacted nor were they familiar enough with the man to react.

Tae Hee-jin sighed. “The White Ape Unit is definitely a problem. Especially the demon who leads the unit.”

Tae Hee-jin clicked his tongue.

He knew that the Demonic Cult was strong, but they were really monsters.

He didn’t know if all the Twelve Supporting Units were like that, but the White Ape Unit was terribly persistent.

That was likely because the White Ape Unit was filled with graduates of the Cave of Latent Demons.

And survivors of the Cave of Latent Demons were ones whose obsession with living and whose allegiance to the Cult were stronger than anyone else.

And Cheon Ah-young, captain of the White Ape Unit, was a monster even amongst them.

“Knng.”

There was a sound of pain somewhere. It was a natural sound as many of those gathered here had fought against Cheon Ah-young and barely escaped with their lives.

As if to shake the uncomfortable atmosphere, Tae Hee-jin turned the conversation back to the topic.

“But it is still a relief, isn’t it? The damage is still occurring within the expected range...”

Several sect leaders nodded.

“Indeed.”

“Where did those masters come from...?”

Once one brought it up, the others agreed.

“They were a great help.

“True. If they weren’t here, the Demonic Cult might have taken more than one third of the land.”

Tae Hee-jin smiled. In his head, he was thinking about those two outstanding masters. *It would have been a hard fight had it not been for those the Lord invited.*

“Cough!”

A martial artist was split in half, blood pooling.

There were dozens of bodies already piled on the floor, with their throats slashed and torsos torn open.

“Ugh.”

Some of the practitioners, who were fearful, retreated. But only a few of the demonic soldiers had retreated.

The other Demons gripped their weapons tighter. They stared at the man at the heart of the carnage.

An old man with an ordinary iron sword.

And dull skin.

They did not know his name or title, but it was he who had created this devastation.

“You can’t just show up and push us around!” one of the demonic soldiers shouted, gritting his teeth.

“Push forward. No matter how strong he is, he’s already dealt with dozens of people. He has to be exhausted!”

At his words, the other demonic soldiers screamed and ran towards the man.

“Waaaah!”

“Die, monster! ”

“I’ll avenge my comrades!”

Their momentum was great. The demonic soldiers had brought out their energy to the extreme.

Some of them were quite good, others only had faint energy wrapping around their weapons.

But even if it was weak, that was still a sword!

Like someone shouted, the man with an iron sword had to be tired — he wouldn’t be able to dodge that sword!

While the demonic practitioners were thinking that, the man moved his old and rusted sword.

With smooth movements like the flap of a butterfly’s wings, his gentle movements immediately brought about a typhoon.

Quaguaguaguaguaguagua -!

It was a storm.

A storm made of swords, not ordinary just wind.

Crescent-shaped blasts of sword qi scattered through the air.

“Growl!”

Sobbing-

Puchi!

The blades split the soldiers attacking from the air into pieces.

The soldiers approaching from the ground and aiming at his ankles were no exception.

Thwack—

Foo—

The carcasses rained down.

“Ugh.”

“Is that really a monster? ”

Several Demons shook their heads at the horrifying power.

The man raised his sword again, as if he was not finished.

Flash-

“There was some unexpected damage in a few of the Chongqing areas, but overall, the expected bases were occupied. The number of warriors on our side is also greater than those in the Martial Alliance, so I think that even if we can’t occupy a few places, the situation will not be too bad.”

Woon-seong’s brows twitched. He then pointed out a certain topic.

“Unexpected damage?”

Since they had generally occupied most of the anticipated areas, this meant that the unexpected damage was not great.

But it was important to note that the damage was unexpected.

Some people think that this was being too sensitive.

But Hyuk Woon-seong was the head of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon. He was the leader of the largest organization in Murim. No minor damage could be overlooked.

Moreover, there was a saying that there were no such things as coincidences in Murim.

Sang Gwan-chuk was aware of Woon-seong's thoughts and carefully reported the damage.

"After the people occupying the area were slaughtered, the Martial Alliance took over."

"Slaughtered?"

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded. "But there was something strange about it."

Sang Gwan-chuk glanced down at the map. On it were forces of the Martial Alliance and Demonic Army splayed out.

"There were no Martial Alliance troops moving towards us before the men were attacked."

When Sang Gwan-chuk said that, Woon-seong's face was cold. Eyes were placed all around the battlefield, and they had a way of looking down at the area from a bird's point of view.

But they hadn't caught any troops moving in this situation?

That was ridiculous. If more than a certain number of people moved, there would be traces.

Nevertheless, there had been no sign of the enemy.

What that meant was simple.

“It was an individual.”

A fatal variable.

It meant there was someone who could move alone and annihilate one of the Demonic Cult’s attacking groups.

Although the slaughtered unit was not one of the Twelve Supporting Units or one led by a Demonic Master, the individual had killed dozens of people by himself.

“With that level of strength, they would have to be amongst the 72. Did anyone from the Martial Alliance leave their post?”

Sang Gwan-chuk shook his head. He was the Senior Strategist of the Cult, who could be called the Brain of the Heavenly Demon.

Obviously, the man had investigated this manner.

The result was...

“There was not a single one of the 72 who left that day.”

Woon-seong frowned.

Something was unsettling.

Unexpected damage.

It could be a coincidence of war, an accidental confrontation. It could also have been insufficient information.

But this was a planned war.

And information had been sufficient.

But there were still variables?

It's worth investigating.

Woon-seong slowly told the strategist, "Tell the Demonic Teacher and the Captain of the White Ape Unit to look around and consider the unexpected variables."

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded. "Understood."

After learning about the situation in Guizhou, Woon-seong slowly got out of his seat.

He then stepped outside.

As he left, the flat lands caught his attention. He stood at the end of the plains.

Foo—

The wind blew. At the same time, the scenery at the bottom was in sight.

Woon-seong was standing at the summit of a mountain. To be precise, it was one of the Cult occupied bases. Looking down, he could see several peaks and ridges.

Each peak was randomly mixed with dark red and blue flags.

The dark red belonged to the Demonic Cult.

The blue ones with a cloud belonged to the Martial Alliance.

Perhaps tomorrow all of these flags would change color. All in dark red, symbolizing the Demonic Cult.

As Woon-seong was conjuring up such a scene, Sang Gwan-chuk approached his side.

"I am going to do a rabbit drive."

Woon-seong, who had an overview of the operation, did not ask why Sang Gwan-chuk had chosen to use the words ‘rabbit drive’.

The Strategist knew that too, but still explained it again. “The Charred Dragon Unit and the Demonic Master will drive out the Martial Alliance from each base. Eventually, they will be thrown out of the peaks and gathered into the basin.”

That was why it was a rabbit drive. [1]

Woon-seong nodded, turning to look around. Like he said, the basin caught his eye.

It was a basin surrounded by peaks.

It was a basin with plenty of space, even when armies were entangled together.

And the operation did not end just by pushing them into the basin.

“The specially custom-made items arrived earlier today. By the end of this rabbit race, we should be able to finish setting up.”

Sang Gwan-chuk continued to draw operation plans in his head.

“That way, we can show hell to the sects.”

Looking down at the basin, Woon-seong muttered coldly, “That basin will be their graves.”

And the next day, the battle began.

And just as Sang Gwan-chuk had said,

“Chase after them! ”

It was a rabbit drive.

[1] a rabbit drive or jackrabbit drive; during the Great Depression and Dust Bowl, farmers would organize rabbit drives where they essentially encircled and forced jackrabbits out of their dens and into a central pen for easy slaughter

Chapter 171: Rabbit Drive (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 171 – Rabbit Drive (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Rabbits were better at climbing up than climbing down mountains.

That was why a rabbit driver would force the rabbit from the top of the mountain to the bottom of the mountain.

That way, it was easier to catch the rabbit.

However, the rabbit drive in Anshun was different from the usual rabbit drive.

The rabbit driver did not start from the top of the mountain, but from the bottom.

And it was not rabbits being chased.

“Shoot the arrows!”

“Roll the rocks! ”

It was people.

Arrows flew over Woon-seong’s cry as someone shouted. A rain of arrows began to fall on Woon-seong.

Seeing it, Woon-seong raised his hand slightly.

There was a rush of terrifying energy rushing through his fingertips and a flame rose into the air like a vortex.

Glug-ug-

Tendrils of flame pierces large gaps between the arrows.

All the arrows caught in the flames disappeared into ashes. Seeing that, someone on the mountain shouted: “Heavenly Demon’s Rising Dragon!”

That was the name of the terrifying technique splitting the arrows, as if trying to tear the sky apart.

Peng—

Favavavavak-

All the intact arrows scattered in every direction and lodged into the dirt. Not a single one of them was able to hit Woon-seong’s body.

They were all flung far away from Woon-seong.

Woon-seong continued to walk up the mountain without giving them any thought. His steps were unstoppable.

It seemed like he was walking up normally, but it also seemed like no one would be able to stop him.

“Eek!”

Some of those at the peak shivered, others were terrified.

“Rock, what happened to the rocks? Throw the rocks!”

A stone was thrown over the cliff.

A round shadow filled the air, casting a patch of darkness above Woon-seong's head. He looked up at the boulder covering the sky without stopping.

Five rocks in total.

It was like meteors raining down on him and Woon-seong laughed to himself. *Did the enemies facing Millenia of Heaven Annihilation feel this way?*

Perhaps he would have felt the same. If only Woon-seong didn't have the power to stop the meteors...

But...

Rawr-!

Woon-seong merely punched upwards. At this moment, a crack began to appear in the closest rock falling down, causing it to shatter.

Not just one.

The boulders that were flying down shattered one by one, raining smaller bits of rock.

Oops.

Bang, bang.

Woon-seong continued to punch the air. Pieces of rock fell all around him.

They had been boulders the size of a house, so the chunks of rock were the size of a man's head.

Boom. Boom.

Chunks of rock fell beside him, burying deep into the ground.

There may have been some that blocked his way up the mountain, but with a light wave of his hand, the debris was shoved to the side, like they were opening up a path.

Woon-seong's speed going up the mountain was still unceasing.

Not too fast, not too slow.

They were relaxed steps.

Each step, however, was a horror to the Orthodox warriors on the mountain.

“Ugh.”

“Well, that's not a human!”

“The Heavenly Demon. How can he be so strong at that age? It has to be sorcery. It's some evil demonic art!”

The word ‘sorcery’ made Woon-seong smile coldly. *It's always been like this.*

Those who deviated from the standard path were said to have learned sorcery. Moreover, there was a very thin standard for what was considered orthodox.

Woon-seong could not help but chuckle.

“Pour the boiling oil!”

Then the commander's shout was heard again.

Glug, glug, glug.

Boiling oil was poured from a pot. Like lava, it flowed down the mountain and swept towards Woon-seong.

Seeing it, Woon-seong's eyebrows twitched. “Oil.”

If it was around fire, oil would burn very easily. With so much oil around him, no matter how careful Woon-seong was, he would easily be trapped in his own fire.

This is a trick designed to seal the Divine Flame.

The enemies had used their heads, in their own way. Hyuk Woon-seong laughed again.

At the same time, he took a step towards the boiling oil.

Jubbuck-

The oil flowed under his feet.

He took another step.

Jubbuck-

There was about a hand's breadth of distance between Woon-seong and the oil.

Jerbuck- Jerbuck-

With each step he took, the distance between the oil and his feet increased.

The people watching were almost mesmerized.

The world before Woon-seong's eyes grew wider.

As his visibility increased, so did his physical body.

The gazes of those looking at him slowly went from looking down to craning up.

How could that be?

How could someone at the top of a mountain look up at the person at the bottom of a mountain?

Could the natural order of the world be reversed like this?

No, what was more surprising was...

“Huh, it’s empty air!”

It was a question of how a person could stand in midair.

Woon-seong stood in the air and looked down at the top of the mountain.

At this time, his eyes met with the commander of the factions at the top.

The commander felt like he was looking into the eyes of a ferocious beast, one with eyes dipped in gold.

Suddenly, there was fog everywhere.

Gray fog.

It was Intimidation Qi.

Woon-seong covered the entire mountain peak with Intimidation Qi.

As a result of his increase in strength, the Intimidation Qi spread out in all directions.

The man who had met Woon-seong’s eyes trembled as if he had epilepsy. He then muttered, “Yes, we’re giving up this peak. If we don’t, we’re all dead!”

Seeing that, the Woon-seong quietly muttered, “Rabbits don’t even know they’re being hunted. Not until the moment you catch them.”

...

A rabbit drive led by Woon-seong was taking place across various peaks of Anshun.

“Hahaha, this is more like it... Run faster!”

It was Wind Demon Fist King Koo Jong-byuk, fists shaking with excitement.

In one breath, his fist had struck more than ten times. A massive vortex of wind was scratching through the ground.

Kwaarnee-

There was a terrifying rumble as it sounded like the mountain was about to collapse.

Warriors shouted in fear.

“Stay back, don’t face them!”

“He’s a monster! ”

“Demonic Master!”

There were cries from all over the place.

Koo Jong-byuk approached them one step closer. The warriors stepped back by exactly one foot.

Koo Jong-byuk took another step forward.

The orthodox soldiers took another step back.

Between Koo Jong-byuk and them was exactly 200 feet.

It was a distance where Koo Jong-byuk’s attacks could not reach. None of the Orthodox soldiers had the courage to step into the attack zone.

It was because everyone knew what would happen if they did. It was not just one or two curious people who had been ripped apart by winds in that realm.

Through the evidence of a dozen corpses around Koo Jong-byuk still pooling blood, they knew.

Jubbuck-

Koo Jong-byuk stepped again.

“Huh?”

As Koo Jong-byuk approached, the soldiers retreated in unison. One of the slow-reacting soldiers was left by himself.

He turned in surprise and tried to move!

Kwa-rung –

Koo Jong-byuk was faster. The soldier’s head burst like a watermelon.

After crushing one, Koo Jong-byuk took another step and the soldiers took another step back.

Looking at them, Koo Jong-byuk showed his white teeth and said, “I have a question...”

“.....?”

“Is there anywhere else for you to run?”

At his words, the soldier turned around in unison. Where they stood was a cliff at the top of the mountain.

Behind them, the only option was down.

It was a thoroughly planned rabbit drive.

...

Someone once said that the technique of the Brain of the Heavenly Demon was the line between life and death.

Death depended on black and white characters written in block style script, or cursive like the handle of the Big Dipper dipped in blood.

But these were all outside assessments:

“They’re all wrong.”

Sang Gwan-chuk chuckled and shook his head, wielding his brush. The reason he should be feared was not because of his intelligence or the pens themselves.

It was the mysterious techniques he could use with one pen.

That was why people should truly be afraid of Sang Gwan-chuk.

The martial arts of the Brain of the Heavenly Demon was much like the techniques of the Ancient Era.

No, to be precise, there were parts of it that were completely unintelligible to current people, just like the martial arts of those days.

If Cheon Ah-young, captain of the White Ape Unit, combined martial arts and sorcery to cross over the wall, the sorcery of the Senior Strategist was one with his martial arts from the beginning.

Unlike Cheon Ah-young, whose boundaries were strictly divided, Sang Gwan-chuk’s were innate and fluid.

As if to prove this, he wielded his pen through the air.

At this time, an inferno unfolded around the Strategist.

Blood seemed to fill the empty air, flowing and turning into an image of a raging field.

Two large devils (*yaoguai*) with large swords appeared in the image.

Devils made of blood.

Rrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrr!

The devils swung their blood-stained swords and ran wild.

That was only the start.

Asuras also rained from the sky, following the devils.

Not only asuras.

All kinds of monsters from the legends began to appear.

Sang Gwan-chuk had drawn an image of hell with blood.

‘Blood Demon Hell Drawing’ (血墨地獄圖).

That was the name of the technique that broke the boundary between sorcery and martial arts.

Sang Gwan-chuk became a one-man army as he released dozens of creatures into the world through the image.

The monsters rampaged.

They charged at the Orthodox faction.

Yaoguai who did not live chained to the earth dove through the air with their jaws open. Their teeth glistened with blood, yet to dry.

Huge snakes slithered across the earth, tongues flicking. Some of them wielded their tails like sickles.

There was a monster like a porcupine, rolling into a ball and slicing its enemies into ribbons with the spikes all over its body.

There was another monster, a giant who would grab its enemies and squeeze them until they exploded.

They were all terrible monsters.

Some of them had been conjured up by Sang Gwan-chuk through human imagination and brainpower, others mythical creatures.

All kinds of monsters imaged and drawn by the Strategist entered the world through the Blood Demon Hell Drawing.

The fires of Hell unfolded.

“Aah!”

“Monster!”

“Run!”

Screams erupted from everywhere.

One of these screams was clearly carried into Sang Gwan-chuk’s ears:

“Ahh, it’s sorcery!”

Sang Gwan-chuk laughed and nodded at the man. “Yes. My martial art is sorcery.”

Chapter 172: Rabbit Drive (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 172 – Rabbit Drive (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Boom!

Peng Ah-hu, face red with fury and frustration, smashed the table.

The thick wooden table cracked. Peng Ah-hu's anger was just that strong.

Why was he so angry that he smashed the table?

Peng Ah-hu roared, "Why?!"

Everyone who gathered in the room shut up. Peng Ah-hu glanced around with beady eyes.

"Why can't you win?"

Everyone was silent. Some of them, though, quietly closed their eyes.

Like Peng Ah-hu, they were part of the 72 Supreme Masters.

"Speak up!"

One of them answered Peng Ah-hu: "There are not enough masters."

"Not enough masters?" echoed Peng Ah-hu.

The man speaking stroked his chin. “I am one of the 72, so I also have responsibility, but I don’t think we can do much against a Demonic Master. And two such Demonic Masters are running wild.”

Peng Ah-hu did not speak, taking a long sip of tea from the cup of tea to quench the burning in his throat.

“That is not enough, even if they have been running to the ends of the world. Thanks to you all, I can’t even imagine how many bases we’ve lost today.”

“Hnng.”

Peng Ah-hu made a groan of acknowledgement. There was absolutely no way to stop the Demonic Masters from wreaking havoc.

As long as they were still human, Demonic Masters would suffer against combined forces. And if they continued to fight, Demonic Masters would become exhausted.

There was a problem though.

More specifically, the military forces of the Martial Alliance in Anshun were currently dispersed.

This was because they had divided their forces in order to preemptively take the high ground.

Due to this division of troops, each base barely had any soldiers assigned to it.

As the group thought about this problem, someone muttered, “Could the Cult of the Heavenly Demon have predicted this?”

The question silenced them all.

Predicted or not, it was true that the Alliance was playing right into the Cult’s hands.

“It’s not too late now, so why don’t we gather our forces together?”

“In one place?”

The others nodded.

“There is a basin in the middle of Anshun where a battle might be worth it. The Cult of the Heavenly Demon will have no choice but to come down from the mountains and into the basin if we are to fight...”

That was a valid point. If the Alliance could unite all their forces in one area, they would be able to fight back, hopefully with minimal damages.

“That’s not a bad idea,” Peng Ah-hu agreed. A moment later, however, he shook his head. “But not as it is.”

At that moment, some people widened their eyes. They turned to Peng Ah-hu and asked, “Are you planning to use *thatit*?”

Peng Ah-hu nodded slowly. “To those coming from outside, shouldn’t we at least give them a gift?”

Peng Ah-hu’s words were barely finished when there was a great cry from their mountain peak.

Waaaahhhh!

It was the sound of demonic soldiers coming to occupy the base.

Hearing that, Peng Ah-hu laughed viciously. *Even if you try to retreat, I’ll show you the right way down, you filthy demons.*

Boom-boom-boom-

Fire erupted.

At the same time, it seemed that lightning struck. A spherical bolt of lightning slammed down between the demonic practitioners.

Boom!

The bolt exploded and the shock blasted outwards.

“Ahhh!”

“Rrrrgh!”

“My arm!”

“My legs!”

Screams erupted after a single bolt, but several more lightning bolts fell.

Rrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrr!

Boom, boom!

A loud thunderclap rolled through the mountain.

Hearing the loud sound, several people turned towards the source, only to see flames cutting through the air.

As they followed the flames through the sky, lightning struck once more.

No, it wasn't lighting.

One demonic practitioner cried out in surprise and recognition, “A cannon! The Orthodox are using gunpowder!”

“Gunpowder?”

Woon-seong's eyebrows raised at Sang Gwan-chuk's report.

Just their use was enough for Woon-seong to be surprised.

“Fortunately, there weren’t too many shells, since they stopped after fifteen rounds. But it is clear that they had access to gunpowder and artillery.”

“Hmnn,” Woon-seong hummed in thought.

Ammunition and artillery were powerful enough to change the course of the war.

That was why the use of ammunition and artillery was strictly prohibited by national law.

How strict were these regulations? Even the Sichuan Tang Clan, who were authorized to use poison by the Imperial Court, were not permitted to have access to gunpowder.

It was absolutely not a tool allowed for use in the wars of Murim.

Nevertheless, they had been used.

Thus it was natural for questions to rise.

It made no sense that the gunpowder prohibited by national law appeared in the Martial Alliance.

And had been so obviously used at that.

But the reason the Alliance could so blatantly use gunpowder was simple.

The Imperial Court has allowed you to use it.

The Imperial Court had long since fallen into the hands of the Cult of the Inverted Sky. Since the Inverted Sky had also infiltrated the Martial Alliance, there was nothing strange about the two supporting each other.

In addition, there was also Jwa Do-gyul as the lord of the Martial Alliance.

Woon-seong chewed on his lips. “The damage was unexpected.”

Sang Gwan-chuk ducked his head.

Woon-seong shook his head. “I also find it unexpected, so it is not a military crime.”

Regardless of what Woon-seong said, Sang Gwan-chuk did not lift his head.

Woon-seong sighed. “What happened to the injured soldiers?”

“We were able to recover all of them because the Alliance retreated to the basin after they ran out of cannonballs.”

Woon-seong raised his hand in a blessing. “Let all their bodies be laid within the temple.”

In the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the temple was land hallowed by the Heavenly Demon.

A land of god’s will.

In other words, it was the land closest to god.

To be buried in the temple was the greatest posthumous honor that could be given.

It’s unfortunate. Woon-seong closed his eyes for a few moments. Had he been there, he could have stopped the cannons.

If so, the damage could have been reduced.

As the man who led the Cult, Woon-seong felt responsible.

He opened his mouth and said, “I must raise a memorial service.”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded. A memorial service in Murim — especially for the Demonic — was different from a general memorial service.

A life for a life.

The souls of the dead in Kangho could only be appeased by the lives of their enemies.

Sang Gwan-chuk raised his head and said, “I will prepare a grand memorial service.”

At first glance, the basin in Anshun looked like an open area.

This was because it was easy to see the front, so it was easy to see when others approached.

The Martial Alliance’s forces had gathered at the center.

Exhaustion showed on their faces. This was because they had been chased by the Demonic Army for the past few days.

“But now that we’ve come down to the basin, there is nothing to chase,” someone muttered and the others nodded.

“Perhaps we can have a good fight here.”

“Yes, we can’t just run away forever. We have been eating shit for a few years, so we’ll just have to fight for better things.”

Some of the young soldiers gripped their swords even while resting.

At their words, an older soldier sighed. “Hah...”

Some of the younguns turned to him, burning with determination.

“Hey, old man, what are you so worried about that you have to be sighing? There’s nowhere to be chased here, so the only thing to do is fight.”

The old man, Jang Han-su, sighed. “Hey, young man. I’ve been on the battlefield for a very long time, ever since I was young like you.”

“Old man, were you an infantryman?” frowned the soldier.

He was a consumable soldier, written off as an infantryman. The old man frowned, but nodded.

Generally, people would be somewhat disrespectful when faced with infantry.

Meanwhile, the soldier glanced at Jang Han-su's body.

"But you survived for so long."

"Yes, I've had one thing better than others since I was young, which has allowed me to survive for so long."

The profession of the foot soldiers at the front were to be arrowheads. So it was hard to survive for long.

But the old man in front of him said that he had a talent which allowed for survival.

Although it was just a lowly foot soldier, it was natural to be curious about survival skills.

"What is it?" the young man asked.

The old man briefly answered, "My senses."

"Senses?" The young man tilted his head. Then, after a bolt of realization, he concluded that the old man meant his sixth sense or intuition. He laughed, "Puhahahaha!"

The young man scornfully said, "So it was possible for you old man to survive just because of your gut feelings?"

The old man murmured, "Yes, that is right. But somehow this battle is very unsettling. I have never been more anxious."

The young man's expression darkened at the man's grim words. It was because he felt uncomfortable talking about anxiety before the battle.

The young man shouted, "Hmph, check your blades again if you have the time for nonsense. That cheap iron sword won't save your life."

“I still have a feeling....”

The old man opened his mouth again and the young man interrupted him.

“Oh, come on, don’t believe that feeling—! ”

Puchi-

Immediately, the young man’s head fell forward, punctured by something that had flown through the air.

Forward was the direction of where the old man sat.

Blood and brains were now pooling at the old man’s feet.

Seeing it, the old man trembled.

“Seems my anxiousness was justified.”

Arrows began to rain down on the Martial Alliance’s soldiers.

Weng—

Chapter 173: Written In The Booklet (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 173 – Written in the Booklet (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Crossbows?”

Peng Ah-hu screamed with his eyes wide.

Bolts and crossbows.

Those were the arrows raining down on them and the bow shooting them.

Cross-bolts and arrows flew from some distance away, sinking into the soldiers’ bodies.

Weng—

Weng—

Puchi—

Fwing—

These arrows flew so fast through the air that it was almost confusing whether they hit first or were shot first.

The arrows were coming from the outer edge of the basin.

To be precise, they were coming from where the basin met the mountains.

The sky had darkened because of all the arrows, as if it were actually raining.

“When did they set up so many traps?!” Peng Ah-hu roared, knocking a bolt away with a swing of his fist.

At his shout, one of the other 72 Supreme Masters, who was also busy stopping the volley of arrows, snapped, “This is no time to be surprised!”

That was true.

If all of these arrows hit, the number of Murim allied troops gathered in Anshun would be reduced by nearly half.

They had to prevent that.

“Damn it!” cursed Peng Ah-hu. “Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron of the Peng Clan, listen to me!”

The cavalry and troops of Peng bowed and shouted, “Yes, my lord!”

“Set up a wall of qi, block the flying arrows and reduce the damage!”

“Understood!”

The men scattered, setting up a defensive formation.

Fwi-bing—

All arrows that collided with the wall bounced off.

Indeed, worthy of one of the strongest forces of the Peng Clan.

However, the number of men in the Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron was less than 100, so the cover they created was not enough to protect all of

their allies.

“Khhh!”

“Knng!”

Away from the cover, Martial Alliance soldiers were pierced by arrows and killed.

“Not only those who can make walls of qi, those who can use blades to knock back the arrows, come forward. We must stop the raining arrows!”

Did they agree with that?

Several of the men swung their weapons. At the same time, various layers of qi appeared in front of them.

Arrows bounced off the swords.

“Ah, I’m alive!”

“I’m not dead!”

Thanks to that, many of the soldiers who avoided death cheered.

But not all soldiers were able to experience such luck.

The only people who could make a wall of qi with their weapons were those who were at least first-rate.

There were not many first-rate warriors in the entire Murim allied forces.

And they couldn’t protect everyone.

Arrows rained down on the soldiers outside of the cover.

That meant at the very least, whoever had their heads under the cover wouldn’t die.

“Arrrgh!”

“Uagh!”

They did not have to feel their arms and legs cut off, or their abdomens screaming from pain as they bled out.

“Damn it. I didn’t expect the Cult of the Heavenly Demon to be equipped with so many arrows.”

Peng Ah-hu growled as he formed qi wall larger than everyone else’s, the arrows bouncing off it. A trickle of blood flowed from his lips.

Despite all of this, the soldiers of the Alliance were still falling.

Already, about 600 people had fallen. The damage did not spread further because they had begun using the dead as shields.

Using the corpse of a friend to block an enemy offensive.

And this was seen from the factions shouting about a noble cause and justice.

But they couldn’t help it.

Because war was like this.

While you might discuss righteousness before, the intense desire to survive will be the first thing to bloom in chaos.

What the hell is going on here? The Lord said that it would be a sure victory, but the current situation...

A word that Jwa Do-gyul said suddenly crossed Peng Ah-hu’s mind.

“Sacrifice?”

He blanked like he had been struck by a bolt. His hands stopped, causing the shield to soften.

At the same time, arrows continued to fly towards him.

“What are you doing?!”

Another master took over his position, but Peng Ah-hu still could not move. He just stared, hands trembling. “Haha, haha...”

The Lord, Jwa Do-gyul, had clearly said: A sacrifice is needed to attract some of the Taoist factions and Five Great Sword Sects out, the ones who did not attend even though the Lord’s Order has been used.

At the time, Peng Ah-hu hadn’t thought much about it. He only thought that the Lord had been planning something.

But he only now did he realize.

I never thought the victim would be myself!

The sacrifice of others was tolerable. After all, he had lived that life, too.

But what if the victim was himself?

Peng Ah-hu, who had been born and raised as a prestigious nobleman, could not accept such a fate.

Maybe that was why a fierce anger rose behind his devastation. And that anger was not directed at Jwa Do-gyul, but at the Heavenly Demon, who was firing arrows at them.

And so, after a moment,

“Heavenly Demonnnnnn!”

Peng Ah-hu roared in anger.

At that moment, the arrows stopped.

As if responding, Woon-seong muttered, “Shut up.”

It was a coincidence that the arrows had stopped as soon as Peng Ah-hu yelled.

At that moment, the Cult had run out of arrows. More arrows would have done more damage, but the result wasn't so bad.

There wasn't enough time to prepare more arrows, Woon-seong sighed with regret. Still, more than 800 of the Orthodox soldiers had been struck by the arrows, so that was good.

Woon-seong slowly approached the Alliance.

His eyes met with Peng Ah-hu's.

They were quite a distance apart, but Peng Ah-hu felt a chill crawl down his spine. It was like his brain had been pierced through with one glance. *How could a person's gaze be so cold?*

As Peng Ah-hu was thinking, Woon-seong was contemplating Peng Ah-hu.

Hmm, Peng. Woon-seong shook his hands lightly. He could see the man's gaze on him.

At this time, Peng Ah-hu's eyes trembled, as if he were afraid.

Like a mouse trying to escape.

Was it that small?

He was not talking about the man's stature. He was not talking about the size of the forces. He was just talking about qi.

Peng Ah-hu's qi presence felt small.

This conclusion wasn't simply because Peng Ah-hu was one of Nok Yu-on's enemies.

Peng Ah-hu was one of the 72 Supreme Masters, but as Woon-seong grew stronger, his perspective on the man named Peng Ah-hu changed.

This man was jealous of Master.

And in the end, took his life.

It is a seed of vengeance no different from Jwa Do-gyul.

Woon-seong's eyes sank into iciness. At this time, a stream of gray qi flowed from his body.

Intimidation Qi wrapped around the area, slowly spreading out close to the ground. It was like a fog, unrolling like a carpet.

Woon-seong threw something in his hand without stopping his approach.

Peng Ah-hu was frightened as soon as he saw it.

The round thing that Woon-seong threw drew an arc in the air, then dropped and rolled.

With a small thud, it stopped at Peng Ah-hu's feet.

Peng Ah-hu subconsciously drew back.

It was a head.

A severed head.

The head of someone he knew well.

Not just Peng Ah-hu, but the Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron, who were members of the Peng Clan, also recognized the owner of the head.

No, how could they not know.

“Peng Hak!”

The owner of the severed head had also been a member of the Peng Clan.

It was Peng Hak.

He was a member of the New Dragon Battalion and was caught and imprisoned at the time.

Just as Tang So-bung had died in front of the Sichuan Tang, Peng Hak's head was thrown before the Peng Clan.

At this time, Woon-seong greeted Peng Ah-hu.

“It's been a while.”

Peng Ah-hu retreated several steps and was unable to hide his trembling voice as he asked, “Do you know me?”

“Do I?” chuckled Woon-seong.

It was a hollow laugh, one that could shorten one's lifespan.

Peng Ah-hu felt like it belonged to a god of death.

That was why he clung to the blade which had kept him alive so far.

Meanwhile, demonic soldiers ran behind Woon-seong.

There was a confrontation between the two leaders, Woon-seong and Peng Ah-hu, while the soldiers stared at each other.

There had been skirmishes, but the two forces looked different.

The Alliance forces, who had been harrassed for days and demoralized by the volley of arrows, could not be compared to the Demonic Army.

Woon-seong said, “Peng Ah-hu, elder of the Mount Hua Sect.”

That was the man's status.

And Peng Ah-hu got the vague feeling the Heavenly Demon knew him well. So he asked again, “Do you know me?”

Woon-seong grabbed the White Night Spear, then opened his mouth.

It was a voice transfer.

His words reached Peng Ah-hu and only Peng Ah-hu's ears.

At the words, Peng Ah-hu's eyes widened in surprise. He pointed and yelled, "You, you!"

His voice was one of agitation. Many of the others were surprised to see the man so angry all of a sudden.

But his face looked confused too.

Ignoring the eyes on him, Peng Ah-hu shouted, "How do you know that?"

Woon-seong snickered, revealing his fangs. "I guess it is true, seeing that you did not deny it."

Peng Ah-hu's shoulders shook as he spat, "Oh, no. He was really learning demonic arts!" He was huffing at this point.

What Woon-seong had said to Peng Ah-hu was about the story of Hyuk Woon-seong and Nok Yu-on's death.

Something you would never know unless you were there that day.

That was also why Peng Ah-hu was so agitated. He shouted again, "Who the hell are you? Who are you to know about this?"

Woon-seong titled his head. "I don't know."

The Divine Flame burned in his left hand.

Hot air blew in Peng Ah-hu's face.

Watching him, Woon-seong spoke coldly.

"There may be someone in the afterlife who can answer that question."

At this time, a new technique from Woon-seong erupted.

Against his Master's, against Nok Yu-on's enemy.

Whoo—

Chapter 174: Written In The Booklet (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 174 – Written in the Booklet (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Boom!

The White Night Spear slashed through the basin, colliding with the other man.

Peng Ah-hu, who had a blade powerful enough to cut through mountains, was still powerless in front of the White Night Spear.

The man flew in the opposite direction.

A tremendous amount of power slammed into one of his arms and he thought that it might break.

But fortunately, it did not.

Considering that his weapon was not cut in half either, should he be considered lucky?

“Grrrgh!”

Peng Ah-hu rolled over, trying to stand up. However, his body was trembling, as if the shock had not completely lifted.

He stared at the ground in front of him.

Even at that moment, Woon-seong was flying through the air at incredible speeds.

Woon-seong rushed through the basin, a huge blast of energy smacking into Peng Ah-hu.

Until then, Peng Ah-hu had not been able to shake off the shock.

Another one of the 72 Supreme Masters blocked in front of Peng Ah-hu, pushing his own spear towards Woon-seong.

“For the Orthodox!”

The man didn’t forget to shout some words against the demonic.

At that moment, Woon-seong’s spear and this master’s spear clashed in the air.

Kuakuakua—

Clang—

Little sparks of fire bounced through the air and the man was pushed back. Deep furrows were dug into the earth.

What was more surprising came immediately after.

“Is that it?” Woon-seong’s voice echoed in the ears of the man. That moment, his eyes practically gleamed. “How dare you use your spear to stop me!”

Boom!

Woon-seong spun his spear, swirling the dust. Like a snake, Woon-seong's spear wrapped around the spear.

And then Woon-seong pulled the White Night Spear towards him!

Weng—

The spear in the master's hand quickly slipped through his spear and cracked through the air.

“Huh?”

It was a humiliation to lose your weapon on the battlefield. How embarrassing for a so-called master!

Fortunately or unfortunately, the master who had been robbed of his spear did not feel ashamed.

Before he even realized what was going on, the White Night Spear split him in half.

The man only thought the world in his eyes was a bit different, like the world splitting apart.

And then darkness came upon him.

And that was the last thing the master saw.

“Bang, bang!”

Woon-seong roared.

‘Demonic Emperor’s Roaring Laughter’ (魔皇廣笑)!

Another technique of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon was thrown out once again. It was the Heavenly Demon’s Roar.

Khehehehehehehe—

A listening soldier stiffened just by hearing the sound.

Terror had arrived.

Unlike other Heavenly Demons who had used this move before him, Woon-seong was able to heighten the effects using Intimidation Qi.

Peng Ah-hu was no exception.

The man trembled like a rat dropped in cold water.

Woon-seong's eyes burned with energy and Intimidation Qi.

At this time, a golden energy suddenly covered his Intimidation Qi. This energy left Woon-seong's body and fell on Peng Ah-hu.

In that qi, Peng Ah-hu felt death.

Spear in one and flames in another.

If Death came to find me, would he look like that?

If I saw the god of death at this last moment of life, would he look like that?

“Ugh.”

While Peng Ah-hu stood there not knowing what to do, Woon-seong slowly approached the man.

Several soldiers flew in to stop Woon-seong.

Amongst them were the Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron.

“Stop!”

“Don't you dare!”

“Elder!”

Woon-seong saw the horde of soldiers attacking him.

Right, you were there too.

That day, the place where Hyuk Woon-seong had died, at the place where Nok Yu-on had ceased to exist on this earth... There had also been the Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron.

Woon-seong waved his left hand.

A flame rose and subsequently slammed into the oncoming squadron.

Kuang—

Huge flames devoured them. It was a fire so hot that their flesh burned and their bones turned to ashes.

“Rrrrghhh!”

“Argh!”

“It burns!”

The men of the Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron, who ran towards Woon-seong and the wall of flames, rolled about on the ground.

With waves of heat, it was like the earth had been overturned into the sulfurous fires of Hell.

The soldiers thought that the fire would be stamped out if they rolled on the floor, but the fire continued to burn.

The Divine Flame was a fire that burned the enemy's origin. The moment that it touched you, your life would be burnt shorter.

Woon-seong laughed at the people rolling on the floor. “You thought you could die easily.”

A man who had been a chivalrous hero all his life had been insulted to death for learning cursed demonic arts.

The pain and shame that Nok Yu-on suffered at that time was greater than this.

Woon-seong spoke to the soldiers and Peng Ah-hu, who were still alive, “It is your turn next.”

It wasn’t only Woon-seong who attacked the Orthodox faction.

Despite being one step behind Woon-seong, Sang Gwan-chuk led people from the Heavenly Brain Tower towards the Allied forces.

It was not just the Senior Strategist.

The Wind Demon Fist King had also liberated himself, swinging mercifully. Draconic winds surged and the enemy was swept away.

After him followed the Charred Dragon Unit.

At the front of the Charred Dragon Unit was Gwan Tae-ryang, screaming, “Forward!”

Following his cry, the Charred Dragon Unit moved in unison to assemble into a formation.

A spear like formation which pierced through the factional forces. The ranks of the Martial Alliance were split, as if they had been stabbed by an elongated blade.

That was the power of a good formation.

While the Charred Dragon Unit dug towards the right, others were going towards the left.

“Hiya!”

They were the members of the All-Masked Demonic Guard, including the Blood Stained Mask Demon.

The two groups flanked the sides, while the Heavenly Demon and Demonic Master rushed the front.

That was not enough, so the demonic soldiers moved too.

The demonic soldiers, who surrounded the whole area, crashed towards the Alliance.

“Glory to the Heavenly Demon!”

“Glory to the Heavenly Demon!”

Woon-seong reached out with a hand. A flame danced across his fingertips and the ranks of soldiers collapsed.

Within the crowd, Woon-seong stepped forward.

Even though the Martial Alliance was in chaos, it didn't seem to matter.

Naturally, half of the chaos was from Woon-seong and his Intimidation Qi.

This had no effect on Woon-seong. Rather, as if opening the way for him, the Divine Flame would tear apart the ranks standing before him.

Through the gap, Woon-seong could see Peng Ah-hu and the Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron.

Woon-seong continued towards them.

After just one step, the distance of about three meters was closed in no time.

“Die!”

“Stop!”

Some soldiers tried to block Woon-seong's path by raising their shields.

But it was all worthless!

Boom!

Woon-seong crashed through the squadron of soldiers with his shoulder. Once he smashed into them, the ranks shook and human bodies flew into the air.

In the meantime, someone fired a bow at Woon-seong.

FWIBING—

When he heard the sound of a string being thrummed, like the playing of a note, Woon-seong flipped.

The arrow plunged into the earth where Woon-seong had just been standing. His eyebrows twitched.

Excellent archery skills.

A list of archers that matched those skills came to mind.

A member of the 72 Supreme Masters.

Someone who was an Anshun at this time.

“Is it the **Brilliant Archer King**?”

An archer who could hold a candle to even those who followed the path of the sword.

“Huh, I didn’t know the Cult Leader knew my name. It is an honor.”

‘**Brilliant Archer King**’ Kun Ok-nam shifted his body and shot more arrows consecutively.

Woon-seong smacked the arrows out of the air with his spear. He then moved his left hand. Glass knives appeared between his fingers and he flung them forward.

Koo-

Klang—

“Phew!”

Kun Ok-nam threw up his guard and used arrows to stop the knives.

Fwibing—

The energy of the arrows smashed into the knives and they exploded in the air.

When the two strong forces collided, sparks flew everywhere.

As the sparks fell to the ground and sand swirled into the air, something shone in between the dust.

“Huh?”

Kun Ok-nam widened his eyes.

At that moment, the flash pierced his heart.

Kuang!

It was a small ring.

Non-explosive.

This non-exploding ring crushed the heart of the archer.

Not only that, but the cracked pieces of his ribs rattled in his chest, piercing his lungs and heart.

For the famous archer who had shaken Zhongyuan, it was an end in vain.

Woon-seong did not feel any regret or hold any grudges against the fallen archer. He quickly turned his eyes towards the trail of Intimidation Qi.

Clang—

The sound of a sword colliding with another sword.

“Help me! ”

“Die!”

The rumbling cries of soldiers.

In between, Woon-seong’s gaze shifted here and there.

Woon-seong soon found who he was searching for — Peng Ah-hu.

The funny thing was, the man was trying to run from the battlefield. He was also leading his own people, the Overlord Demon Slaying Squadron, out!

“The commander is a fool.”

Woon-seong smiled and wielded the White Night Spear.

Flow of the Divine Dragon!

Kua—

A giant dragon flowed from Woon-seong’s spear, opening his path forward. Woon-seong flew along his way.

“Ahhhhh!”

As Woon-seong rushed towards him like a hurricane, Peng Ah-hu screamed and choked. His face quickly became blue.

Woon-seong sneered, “You’re trying to escape the battlefield to save your worthless life. In doing so, you prove that you are not a chivalrous man of the Orthodox Way.”

As Woon-seong coldly spoke, he walked closer to Peng Ah-hu.

Less than three meters to go.

Given Woon-seong's leaping ability, it was a distance he could cross in one movement.

Peng Ah-hu knew that too.

That was why he hid himself among the soldiers.

"No, stop him. Protect me!"

The soldiers looked at Peng Ah-hu.

"Ah, Commander..."

Their voices were filled with disappointment.

Peng Ah-hu hid even further, as if he did not notice any of it.

Woon-seong coldly ridiculed the scene. "No need to feel disappointed."

He raised his spear.

"Because it is written that you are all going to die here."

One of the soldiers asked, "What?"

It was a question Woon-seong didn't even register.

"To the afterlife!"

Sobbing-

Blood splattered.

Along with shredded corpses, blood pooled everywhere.

Covered in blood, Woon-seong caught his breath.

Perhaps it was because the weight of the iron bracers had increased, but he felt more tired than before.

Chuck- Chuck-

Blood dried on Woon-seong's back and a red mist rose.

There was only one survivor.

It was Peng Ah-hu.

Woon-seong saw him and smiled, fangs out.

“It's your end, too.”

In Anshun that day, Woon-seong crossed another name written in his booklet.

Chapter 175: The Buddhist Star (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 175 – The Buddhist Star (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“They must have started fighting by now,” King Jinseong said with a worried look. He couldn’t hide his anxiety and continued to tap the armrest of his chair with his fingertips.

Tak-tak.

Every time his fingertip hit the armrest, there would be a dull sound.

Just based on the sound, his fingertips must hurt, but King Jinseong didn’t seem to care at all.

No, it would be correct to say he didn’t even notice the pain.

All of his senses were focused on the battle going on in Guizhou and Chongqing.

Guizhou and Chongqing were equally important. The Cult of the Heavenly Demon had to take both of these provinces in order for King Jinseong and the Justice Alliance to move.

If the Cult of the Heavenly Demon could occupy Guizhou and Chongqing... That held more significance than simply indicating the Demonic Army had advanced into the center of Zhongyuan.

It was clear that the Martial Alliance would soon press charges against the factions that had not responded to the Lord's Order, and it was clear that the Inverted Sky's people inside the Imperial Palace would also take action.

In preparation for such a situation, the Justice Alliance needed to quickly establish a place as the foundation for uniting three forces.

“Hmm.”

King Jinseong couldn't hide his anxiety and clenched his fists tightly.

Seeing him like that, 'Sage of Earth and Sky' Do Jin-myung, sighed lightly and reassured him.

“It will be fine. Since the armies of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon have been advancing with minor casualties so far, won't they conquer Guizhou and Chongqing as planned?”

At his words, King Jinseong nodded slightly.

“Are we ready to move?”

“We have all the necessary personnel and supplies. If we have to fight, we can always move and enter Chongqing.”

“Check again just in case. It would be bad if we realize we forgot something later on.”

Do Jin-myung bowed. “Got it, haha. This old man moves his old body once again.”

“Please do, Sage.”

In his mind, King Jinseong added, *I hope the Cult Leader can take over Guizhou and Chongqing with just his strength...*

A few days later, news of the battle in Guizhou and Chongqing was sent to King Jinseong.

As in Guizhou, battles large and small continued to take place in Chongqing. There were three days of fighting to steal each other's bases. After that, the two camps rallied the remaining forces.

Then they began marching towards each other.

The armies advanced to shove each other out. The two armies met in one region, flying their own banners, and began to fight.

Boom, boom.

There was a series of explosions on all sides.

As she heard screaming all around her, Cheon Ah-young wielded the sword in her hands.

First Connection of the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

Energy from the Red Heart spread out in all directions before gathering together again.

Glug-ug.

A vivid red sword rose into the air.

Cheon Ah-young swung her burning sword as she ran. The head of an Alliance soldier rushing towards her split open.

She moved one of her hands behind her. It was the hand holding nothing.

The moment that hand touched the air!

Gah.

Time was frozen with sorcery.

“Huh?”

Of course, time wasn't actually frozen.

“My body...?”

But the people aiming at Cheon Ah-young did not know that. They could not move their bodies because of divine power.

“What the hell...?” one of the soldiers muttered.

Then, one of the soldiers recognized Cheon Ah-young and screamed, “Don’t, she’s a sorceress!”

However, the cry was in vain as Cheon Ah-young’s sword was already cutting off their heads.

Fwa-bing.

Two severed heads flew into the sky. At the same time, a fountain of blood sprayed into the air.

Cheon Ah-young was already running towards her next prey.

Cheon Ah-young’s way of fighting was different from Woon-seong’s way of running like a wolf or lion amongst sheep. There were differences not only in internal qi, but also in their breathing patterns, and so on and so forth.

Cheon Ah-young was well aware that her abilities and skills were inferior to Woon-seong’s.

That was why, combining martial arts and divine power, she continued to wade through war and create her own combat techniques.

And it worked.

Every now and then, she would step back and catch her breath. Regulating her breathing, she would charge right back into the fray.

Cheon Ah-young faithfully followed this pattern and defeated a number of enemies.

She twisted her waist. A blade cracked through the air at the side of her waist.

Another enemy.

Cheon Ah-young stretched out with her sword, using her sword to split the blade.

Clang—

The blade split vertically and the swordsman's finger was cut off.

“Ahhh, my finger!” he screamed, but Cheon Ah-young stabbed him in the shoulder without changing expressions.

And then what?

With a downward swing, she slashed from his shoulder and through his heart.

Clang—

Another one down.

She could see enemies coming from all directions.

Cheon Ah-young retreated, controlling her breathing.

A moment to rest.

It was at that moment.

“You witch!”

“Enemy of the orthodox!”

Two soldiers of the Alliance charged towards Cheon Ah-young.

The problem was that her breathing had not fully stabilized yet.

Her eyes shook for the first time.

I can stop them but...

There would be damage. Moreover, the soldiers attacking now were superior to the two from earlier.

“Hmm.”

In the end, Cheon Ah-young chose to take some damage and stop the attack.

Being injured was better than being dead.

At least I should stop the damage.

The wound was relatively small.

The offensive from the right seemed more intense than the left's. Cheon Ah-young turned and blocked the right.

Clang—

The two blades collided!

“You filthy witch of the Demonic Cult!”

The sword from the left came towards her thighs.

At that moment!

“Unni!”

Someone stood between Cheon Ah-young and the sword.

It was a Dang Boo-ah from the White Ape Unit.

The rest of the White Ape Unit wrapped around Cheon Ah-young.

“Captain!”

“Thank you!”

Cheon Ah-young greeted Dang Boo-ah with gratitude and quickly disappeared between the Charred Dragon Unit, the dozens of blades held in their hands slicing the soldiers.

Clang—

Clang—

Like Cheon Ah-young, there was another person causing a commotion.

It was the Eight Bolt Blade King (八節雷擊刀), one of the Ten Demonic Masters.

He had been stationed in the Western Army with the Demonic Teacher. Back then, the Eight Bolt Blade King had not been on the side of Woon-seong, but on the side of the Vice Leader.

That was why he needed to prove his worth by ensuring carnage more than anyone else.

Though he had apologized for his sins by gifting Woon-seong with throwing knives, the man didn't think that was enough!

He swung his huge blade across the enemy ranks.

Kwa-rung—

Every time the man swung, a lightning bolt would split into eight pieces and fall, thunder rolling across the field.

That was why he was called the ‘Eight Bolt Blade King’.

The Bolt King blasted the earth. At the same time, his body shot forward like an arrow.

Dragging his huge blade and blasting lightning, the Eight Bolt Blade King looked like he was flying straight.

Lee Shin-jung, who was watching the scene, smiled and said the name of the technique.

“Heaven Tearing Lightning Steps (天節雷步).”

Thunderous steps which could tear the Heavens apart!

The bodies of Orthodox soldiers flew into the air.

Do not forget, the bodies of the soldiers were twitching, like they had been electrocuted.

Kuang—

The Lightning Steps did not end after blasting a few soldiers into the air.

The Demonic Master made his way through the enemy ranks, sprinting back and forth, momentum not diminishing even after multiple collisions.

The nightmare did not end.

The Eight Bolt Blade King lifted his blade towards the sky.

A thunderstorm gathered, striking down towards the blade.

As the lightning flashed, it was like the divine punishment of Heaven.

And as soon as the bolt fell, the man wielded his sword, weaving the bolt into eight and sending them in multiple directions.

Clang—

Clang—

The bodies of the soldiers, who had been swept by electricity, fell to the ground.

Blood misted through the air.

When someone saw the scene, they screamed in surprise: “Ah, he’s not human!”

As the soldier had said, this was not the appearance that a human should have.

Thwack—

The one who had just screamed had his upper and lower body separated, soon dying.

“Keep your body away. Since he just used a huge move, he won’t be able to use the same skill any time soon!” someone calmly judged and yelled.

It was a martial artist of the 72 Supreme Masters.

The Eight Bolt Blade King’s eyebrows twitched. “Wow, you have good eyes. Obviously, if you press your body too hard, it won’t be able to handle it.”

At that, those who had hope charged. They were like heroes, throwing their lives away.

Others fled.

However,

“That is a weakness which disappears at Absolution.”

Wherever they were running, the faces of the soldiers became pale.

At the same time, the Demonic Master plunged his blade into the earth.

Kua—

Lightning bolts rose from the cracks in the ground.

These bolts spread out in concentric circles, rippling outwards.

Those who were running were swept away, screaming like they had been stabbed and electrocuted at the same time.

“Augh!”

“Shit—!”

It was a blood storm.

Blood and flesh splattered in all directions.

Those who watched were slack-jawed in horror.

However, Lee Shin-jung only shook his head from a distance away. “People can be so mischievous...”

As if agreeing, the Eight Bolt Blade King laughed and revealed his yellowing teeth.

Lee Shin-jung clicked his tongue and moved his hands.

Immediately, two blasts of light flew from his hands.

Actually, two wheels, resembling the sun and moon.

Fababababa!

And then...

“Haha, this old man should work hard if he doesn’t want to fall behind.”

The bodies of Alliance soldiers were scattered around the Demonic Teacher’s feet.

Clang—

One of the Ten Demonic Masters, Leader of the Unrecorded Demonic Group — ‘Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon’ Lee Shin-jung had also started to rampage.

To end the war in Chongqing with the victory for the Cult of the Heavenly Demon...

Chapter 176: The Buddhist Star (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 176 – The Buddhist Star (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Mount Song, Henan Province.

Made up of Taishi Mountain and Shaoshi Mountain, it had at least 36 different peaks.

The Central Great Mountain was home to the Shaolin Temple and generally considered the birthplace of Zen Buddhism.

Around the time the battle between the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and the Martial Alliance was in full swing elsewhere, there was a tapping sound from a peak on Mount Song.

Tak-tak-tak.

It was somehow a dull sound.

If someone had come to the Shaolin Temple, they would have thought so too.

Instead of doing anything else so late into the night, someone was knocking on a wooden bowl.

But who knew, this dull sound did not mean that someone was practicing how to drum on a table.

Also, the sound of these taps was spreading throughout the mountains...

Tak-tak-tak.

Surprisingly, the source was an old man who looked over seventy.

Sure he was tapping a wooden bowl, but how and why was he tapping on the bowl like that?

Perhaps it might be meditation rather than a proper martial technique.

Indeed, it was a form of meditation.

Such resonance should not have been produced, but the actor was someone at the top of the Shaolin, at the top of Murim.

He was a Semi-Divine Being.

The Buddhist Star knocked on the bowl for a while longer.

He did not forget to say “Amitabha Buddha” while he was at it.

Behind him, a shadowy figure blurred into view.

It was a middle-aged man.

“Namo Buddhaya,” the man bowed his head and greeted.

This man was the current leader of the Shaolin Temple and the successor of the ‘Hundred Step Divine Fist’ (百步神拳) technique, named Hye Gwang.

Once Hye Gwang appeared, the Buddhist Star stopped knocking on the wooden bowl. He placed the bowl down on the table.

“Haha, no fun. It is no fun.”

“Are you doing that for the sake of worshiping Buddha or for entertainment?”

The Buddhist Star chuckled. Stroking his beard, which was long like a carpet, he asked, “Do you persevere to become a Buddha, or do you persevere to serve the Buddha?”

Hye Gwang froze.

Bodhisattvas wanted to become a Buddha by gaining enlightenment. However, after respecting the Buddha for such a long time, he had gained the heart to serve him.

The man hastily bowed. “I made a mistake, Amhitabha.”

The Buddhist Star smiled. “It is enough that you know.”

He reached out as he spoke and a bowl in one corner of the room came flying into his palm.

It was a bowl of Buddhahood.

It was not just any bowl, but one that had been passed down from master to disciple.

The Buddhist Star picked up a handful of uncooked rice from the bowl and shoved it into his mouth.

Then he began to chew.

That was the Buddhist Star’s dinner.

Hye Gwang had come to the Buddhist Star for a reason, but waited for the man to finish eating.

Finally, the Buddhist Star finished all of the raw rice and emptied the bowl of cold water on the side.

“Thank you for the food!”

A handful of raw rice and a bowl of water. The Buddhist Star would say that any meal was a good meal, as long as he had eaten well.

Soon, he graciously turned to Hye Gwang.

“Well done, you did as I said.”

“I did not respond to the Martial Alliance as the master had commanded me.”

The Buddhist Star responded, “You did as you were told, but you do not like it.”

Hye Gwang sighed. “The Cult of the Heavenly Demons is raging under the skies. This one does not understand why the master wishes for us to be silent.”

The Buddhist Star chuckled. He then placed a piece of black paper and a piece of white paper in front of him. “What are these?”

“What are they?”

The Buddhist star repeated, “What are these?”

“Black and white, aren’t they?”

“Indeed. And is the piece of black paper evil?”

Hye Gwang shook his head. Paper was merely paper; it was black in color, but how could it be considered evil?

“Then is the piece of white paper good?”

“That is also not the case.”

The Buddhist Star chuckled, as if he liked that answer.

Was there something that suddenly came to mind?

“Ah!” Hye Gwang hurriedly bowed his head.

“Do you understand?”

Hye Gwang nodded. “I see. Black and white are simply colors, not standards for dividing good and evil. Also, the division of black and white is just a human standard...”

“In the eyes of the Buddha, there is only a sheet of paper.”

Black is not evil and white is not good.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon may be good, the Martial Alliance may be evil.

The Buddha was a single piece of paper, conveying the truth to Hye Gwang.

“Hye Gwang.”

“Yes,” nodded the man.

The Buddhist Star took something out of his robes and threw it.

Tuk—

It was a knife.

A knife with seven pieces of jade, the second of which glittered black.

Hye Gwang picked up the knife from the ground, looking bewildered.

“If the old man of the Jegal Family calls later, show it to him and join him.”

There was only one person who the Buddhist Star would call the ‘old man of the Jegal Family’: the ‘Venerable Dragon’ Jegal Sung, a man who had entered Murim and reached similar pinnacles along the Way.

“What is this?”

“It is a jade knife.”

After he finished speaking, the Buddhist Star stood up from his seat.

In the past year, that had never happened.

It was the first time the Buddhist Star had moved from his spot — whether rain or shine, the man had meditated with the struck bowl.

“Master!” Hye Gwang exclaimed in surprise.

It was because the Buddhist Star seemed to be heading somewhere.

“It has been a long time since I stood up and my legs are aching. I have sat for a long time.”

“Where are you going?”

“Do not move the Shaolin until the people of the Jegal Clan move. It should be enough that I make a move on behalf of the Shaolin...”

The Buddhist Star turned to look up at the darkening skies, speaking with pity: “Huh, it is dark. It is so dark. Namo Amitabha. I pray the Buddha shows mercy to Zhongyuan...”

The old man clasped his hands together and prayed.

“Where are you going?”

“I am going to do what needs to be done.”

“If you are going far away, you must take some disciples with you...”

The man shook his head. He then smiled softly. “I will go alone.”

“Alone...”

Hye Gwang was about to shout.

But the figure of the Buddhist Star had already disappeared.

“Do not forget. You must never move the Shaolin until the Jegal Clan moves.”

Only the voice of the Buddhist Star echoed through the peak.

Seeing the man disappearing without moving, Hye Gwang muttered, “Golden Vajra Unmoving Divine Steps (金剛不動神步)...”

The same day the Buddhist Star disappeared from Mount Song, a person disappeared from Mount Paektu.

The only one who knew was a man hiding on Mount Paektu with a sword attached to his waist.

And that man continued watching in silence, sending only one bird off of a branch.

Lee Shin-jung waved his hands.

Along the tips of his fingers, two rings of light split the air.

Kuakuakuakua—

The Black and White Wheels slaughtered the Orthodox soldiers, each emitting a brilliant light.

A fountain of blood soared into the air and flesh scattered like a storm. Amongst it, the soldiers collapsed.

One person being a match against a thousand (一騎當千).

Was that an apt description of a Demonic Master?

However, the ones holding such power were not limited to only the Demonic Cult.

“Demonic Teacher, why don’t you put mercy in your hands?”

There was a sword that swung at the demonic soldiers.

A man wearing a blue robe appeared. Like many of the other swordsmen, he had a sword in his hand, but it did not look forced at all.

Based on the man's strength, Lee Shin-jung quickly realized the man's identity.

“The head of the Wudang.”

“This one is Tae Heo-jin,” the man said. “My apologies.” He put his hands together.

“Are you here to block my way?”

“I am just here to save one more.”

Same meaning.

Different words.

Though they had only exchanged a few words, Lee Shin-jung felt that Tae Heo-jin was different from the other Orthodox people.

One that accepted death honestly and truly felt regret.

Rather than shouting revenge, he wished to save lives.

To care for the survivors, to save even one more life.

Lee Shin-jung wondered if there were any Orthodox martial artist who had fought against him like this.

Hmm. If we had met somewhere other than a battlefield, we might have shared a drink.

But this was the battlefield.

And he was in the position of taking orders from the Heavenly Demon.

“You will have to stop me to save lives.”

Lee Shin-jung caught the wheels, which had flown back to him.

Tae Hae-jin sighed and raised his sword. “If that is the only way...”

The Light Wheel of Yin and Yang collided with the Taegeuk Dispelling Sword.

Kuakuakua—

Taegeuk Dispelling Sword.

Technically, it should be called the Taegeuk Wisdom Sword. In the past, the Shaolin Temple lost the secrets to the Taegeuk Wisdom Sword. [1]

The current Taegeuk Wisdom Sword had been recreated by the Wudang Sect in remembrance of the lost art.

That was why the name was different.

Because they could not forget that the current technique was different from the real Taegeuk Wisdom Sword, they purposefully renamed it the ‘Taegeuk Dispelling Sword’ and vowed not to lose the same art twice.

There was no denying that one sword could be freed from the state of Taiji! [2]

Ooooo—

As the sword in Tae Heo-jin’s hand drew a circle, a ripple of energy appeared.

At the same time, the yin and yang from the sword collided with Lee Shin-jung’s Heavenly Wheel.

Kwa-rung –

As the explosion rang, Tae Hae-jin and Lee Shin-jung were surprised and shouted at the same time.

“Are you unleashing yin and yang by following the flow with the will of Heaven (顺天)?”

“Are you unleashing yin and yang by following the flow against the will of Heaven (逆天)? ”

There were a lot of similarities between the Taegeuk Dispelling Sword and Lee Shin-jung’s martial arts. It was only a difference of with or against.

Well, the amount of qi was also different.

Tae Heo-jin was a person in the top 10 amongst the 72 Supreme. He was able to fight against a Demonic Master without being outmatched.

Cosmic forces collided against each other. The rivers of qi were scattered in all directions like waves.

Deep grooves appeared in the ground.

It seemed like it was a fight that would not end easily.

“Hmm.”

“Hmmm.”

Lee Shin-jung and Tae Hae-jin stared at each other without saying a word.

At that moment!

When no one was watching, two objects split through the air.

They left long tails in the air, like shooting stars.

At this time, someone recognized the objects!

“Huh?”

A massive bomb dove through the air.

Krrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrr!

They were being bombed.

[1] ‘Taegeuk Dispelling Sword’ is Taegeuk **Hae**geum (태극**해**검, 太極**解**劍) while ‘Taegeuk Wisdom Sword’ is Taegeuk **Hye**geom (태극**혜**검, 太極**慧**劍)

[2] Taegeuk is the Korean cognate of Taiji, meaning ‘supreme ultimate’; specifically, it is the red and blue symbol at the center of the S. Korean flag, representing the dual forces of nature

Chapter 177: A Defeat (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 177 – A Defeat (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Defeated?”

Jwa Do-gyu’s eyes were wide as he heard the news. He then slowly chewed on his lips.

There was a chuckle.

“Defeat, defeat...”

That smile... That was a genuine smile. To begin with, he hadn’t held any hope that the battle in Guizhou could be won.

The last thing Jwa Do-gyul wanted was for the Martial Alliance to be annihilated. Nevertheless, he was not satisfied with the damage done to the Demonic Cult.

I even gave them a bomb, but the result is only this much damage.

There was too little damage.

He raised his hand and chewed on his nails.

Tsk-tsk.

His chewed nails fell in front of him.

He didn't like it.

Since I gave them that much firepower, they should have done more damage.

Soon, however, Jwa Do-gyul shook his head.

No. After all, Peng Ah-hu was too greedy and dumb compared to his abilities. I overestimated him.

Anyway, the purpose was achieved in Guizhou. As a result of this defeat, the power of Murim was reduced considerably. It also provided the opportunity to attract those who had not yet participated in the war.

Satisfied with that, he suddenly smiled and began writing something.

For those who were silent during the events in Murim, who should be angry...

Even as he thought to himself, he was snickering.

My sincerest apologies, it is all my fault. What a pity...

Jwa Do-gyul continued to write with a smile.

“How amusing.”

It really was ridiculous.

“But that's what makes life fun.”

Jwa Do-gyul continued to write, laughing to himself.

The next day, an official message was delivered to several factions of the Martial Alliance.

It was a message written by the Lord of the Martial Alliance, expressing his sincerest condolences for their loss and requesting the help of others.

“Defeat...”

Woon-seong frowned on his throne.

He was not in his usual meeting room, but in the Western Army’s camp.

After hearing about their first loss from Sang Gwan-chuk, he had rushed straight here.

Sang Gwan-chuk and the Captain of the Charred Dragon Unit had also come with him.

Given that Woon-seong had run all the way over to the Western Army, it could be seen how urgent this situation was.

“Planning is with man but accomplishing is with Heaven.”

In front of Woon-seong, the Eight Bolt Blade King and Cheon Ah-young bowed their heads.

The Bolt King shouted, “We have committed a grave sin!”

Woon-seong shook his head as the man kneeled, forehead touching the floor.

“No, from ancient times, victory and defeat have not been permanent. One defeat is not a sin worthy of death. In addition, I was told that you remained until the end to ensure the safety of the other soldiers during the retreat.”

“I only did what I needed to do, but I am unworthy.”

Woon-seong waved a hand. “Just because it is something that can be done does not mean everyone will do it. We can consider it as losing the battle, but winning the war. This is the same for the Captain of the White Ape Unit and the Demonic Teacher.”

To his words, Cheon Ah-young and the Bolt King bowed their heads once again.

“I will carve the grace of the Leader into my bones.”

Woon-seong sighed.

The Demonic Teacher was not present.

No, the Demonic Teacher couldn't be here.

This was because the old man had struggled against the enemy during the retreat and suffered gruesome injuries.

A couple of broken ribs, a sword stabbed in his diaphragm. Two black poles had slammed into his abdomen; spears. He had over ten arrows in his back.

Had the Demonic Teacher been an ordinary person, he wouldn't be holding on. No, it would not be strange for the man to keel over and die.

However, since he was in the realm of Absolution, he was already different from the average person.

Lee Shin-jung was still breathing.

Woon-seong sighed once more. He then ordered, “Tell the doctors at the Cult to save the Demonic Teacher's life. It is a command in the name of Heavenly Demon.”

“Understood.”

Woon-seong continued, “I heard that we were unable to recover the bodies of the victims.”

“The damage was so great and the bodies were so fragmented that it was impossible to recover them.”

“Burn the entire battlefield instead of holding a funeral. Also, erect a large memorial stone and carve all of their names onto it. I will make the

monument open to the public.”

“I will carry out your command.”

After dealing with that, Woon-seong lifted a hand and pressed it against his forehead. He massaged his temples with the other hand.

Sang Gwan-chuk watched him with anxious eyes, but said nothing.

Very few people in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon knew that Woon-seong was poisoned. Among the Demonic Masters, most didn't understand how serious it was. And it was impossible to let others know such an important fact in the middle of war.

Dissemination of this information would have a huge impact on the war ahead.

However, the Strategist could not hide his worried glances.

Woon-seong told the Strategist he was okay with a side-eye.

Then, still sitting, he tapped his chin. “I heard that the reason for your defeat was because of two mysterious masters who intervened during the battle.”

“That is correct”

“And their presence was enough to change the tides?”

At his question, Cheon Ah-young and the Bolt King trembled. They understood what he was getting at.

A master who could change a battlefield. There were only a few such people in the world.

Only a Semi-Divine Being could turn the tide by themselves.

Now, Woon-seong was asking whether or not those two mysterious monsters were at that level.

The Eight Bolt Blade King swallowed. He had fought one of them.

What was the result?

He was unable to last 100 seconds.

“It seemed to be the boundary between Absolution and Semi-Divinity.”

Woon-seong’s eyebrows twitched.

Boundary between Absolution and Semi-Divinity.

Demonic Masters had also reached such a peak. Although there was a difference in the degree according to each person, Demonic Masters were also in a position where they could dream of being able to cross that wall.

And the Eight Bolt Blade King said these people were on the boundary between Absolution and Semi-Divinity.

So Woon-seong could not help but ask, “Is that different from a Demonic Master?”

The Blade King shook his head. “I think my words came out wrong. Their internal energy was clearly in Semi-Divinity. But...”

“But?”

The Blade King sighed at Woon-seong’s prompt. He looked like he didn’t understand himself.

“Their senses did not seem different from those in Absolution, and their swordsmanship was crude. The internal qi and understanding had reached Semi-Divinity, but they could not use their techniques properly.”

Woon-seong’s expression hardened. He had met two such masters twice.

The first was at King Jinseong’s Court. The master at that time was able to talk a bit, but still seemed incomplete.

And then what?

The second was on the battlefield.

A monster who appeared before the Immortal Poison Saint, Grand Elder of the Tang Clan.

I think they said he was the Sword Emperor of Ice and Light...?

He, too, showed an incapability to fully manifest techniques, even with qi at the level of Semi-Divinity.

It seemed like Sang Gwan-chuk was thinking of the same thing.

When their eyes met, Woon-seong could see the Strategist's stiff expression.

At the same time, the man said, trembling, "Corpse puppet."

Woon-seong sighed. *I knew it.*

Sang Gwan-chuk was thinking the same thing.

Has the Cult of the Inverted Sky really started to intervene?

That led to another question.

How did the Cult of the Inverted Sky keep putting things like that on the battlefield?

Two had already been smashed by Woon-seong.

Another two appeared in Chongqing.

That was a total of four.

They were no match for real Semi-Divine Beings, but they could be considered four well-made monsters.

How many more were there?

Woon-seong didn't know, but there were probably more hidden somewhere.

And since they're starting to intervene, why isn't this organization called the Cult of the Inverted Sky on the front lines?

Besides, the Imperial Palace was under their control.

It was weird that the Imperial Palace showed no movement. If they really decided to intervene in earnest, the Inverted Sky would have mobilized the Imperial Army.

However, the Imperial Palace seemed to have not moved at all, other than sending an assassin from the Eastern Depot.

What the hell are you thinking, Inverted Sky?

Woon-seong closed his eyes, gripping the armrest of his throne tightly.

Crunch.

The armrest was crushed.

Woon-seong opened his eyes.

“Bolt King.”

“This one accepts the words of the Leader,” the man bowed and replied.

Woon-seong's eyes were deep. “How long will it take for you to recuperate?”

“Five days should be enough!”

Woon-seong glanced over the man's body and clicked his tongue. “I will ask again. How many days will it take for you to completely recuperate?”

“.....”

The Bolt King was silent.

Five days was the time necessary for his outer wounds to heal. But how long until his internal injuries healed?

His wounds were not as severe as the Demonic Teacher's, but they were still heavy. Unless precious elixirs and medicines were used, it would take half a year.

The Bolt King did not answer, but Woon-seong had a rough estimate. So he said, "I will support you generously so that your wounds may be healed within a month."

"The Leader's grace is as vast as the sea!"

"This is the same for the Captain of the White Ape Unit, please bear it in mind."

"Understood!" Cheon Ah-young responded with a slightly dead expression.

Woon-seong turned to look at the Strategist. "We will resume the war after a month."

"I will devise a plan."

"No, you don't have to replace the current plan. I will deal with one of those two monsters."

"And I will deal with the other one," Sang Gwan-chuk said.

Woon-seong shook his head.

Two of the Demonic Masters had already been injured. Even though a Demonic Master was terrifyingly strong, they could not stand alone.

"The Strategist will deal with the other one with the recovered Bolt King."

To his words, the Strategist and the Eight Bolt Blade King answered:

“Understood.”

“Understood.”

Chapter 178: A Defeat (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 178 – A Defeat (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Lee Shin-jung's wounds were worse than Woon-seong expected.

Fortunately, the man's dantian had not been broken, but his life was leaking out.

If not properly treated, he might not be able to last more than half a year.

Even with proper treatment, it was a wound that would need careful tending to for several years.

Even if the Demonic Cult used all of its power, it would take a year.

“Demonic Teacher.”

Woon-seong called to the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon, who was lying down next to him.

A low but heavy voice.

Normally, the Demonic Teacher would have bowed to Woon-seong by now and presented himself to the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong was not just the Heavenly Demon for Lee Shin-jung, but the successor they had waited eons for.

Successor of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon.

Lee Shin-jung did not respond.

“There is nothing else to do.”

Woon-seong sighed, “The Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon will be sent off the battlefield.”

He then told Sang Gwan-chuk, “Transfer him to the Heavenly Mountains with the doctors, with the focus on treatment. You may enter the Divine Vault in order to heal the Demonic Teacher. Command them to heal him.”

“Understood.”

It was a signal that Lee Shin-jung was exiting the war.

“The number of soldiers we need will be drawn from the Southern Army, and the Southern Army will replenish through the Northern.”

“What should we do with the empty Demonic Master position?”

When Sang Gwan-chuk asked, Woon-seong twitched. He scratched his cheek in thought.

“No matter who comes, it will be difficult to replace the Demonic Teacher.”

However, the position could not be left vacant. Though they might not be as strong as the Demonic Teacher, at least the absence needed to be filled.

“The new Demonic Masters...”

“The ‘Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign’ and the ‘Lonely Dancing Youth’.”

After hearing the options, Woon-seong said, “Let’s go with the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign.”

There were two Demonic Masters in each of the four armies. They were in charge of each camp's leadership, protection, and other duties.

When they were pulled out, a hole would be made in another army camp.

If you pull on the bottom stone, the top stone will also be affected. To prevent such a situation, they had to bring in a Demonic Teacher that was not currently involved.

Those would be the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign and the Lonely Dancing Youth.

Newly risen Demonic Masters. Unlike the others, they had not been part of the army. Their mission was to protect the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's headquarters.

However, now that the Demonic Army had marched deep into the heart of Zhongyan, the Heavenly Mountains were much safer than before.

So it was alright to call one of them out.

Moreover, Sang Gwan-chuk had seen both of them fight once.

Both of them were quite good, but if they fought to the death, the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign was slightly better.

That was the reason Woon-seong chose the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign.

Sang Gwan-chuk also acknowledged this judgment.

There was only one problem.

“It will be difficult for the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign to join before the next battle begins.”

Woon-seong nodded.

It was as he said. They were a long way from the Heavenly Mountains so the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign would have to travel a long distance,

but the enemies were close by.

Even if it was Woon-seong and not the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign, he was not confident in crossing the distance within ten days.

Even if I did, I'd be exhausted.

It was not a problem, however, that he could not join quickly.

“I will participate in the next battle anyway, so there is no problem.”

“Then I will send a letter to the headquarters.”

The work was complete.

“Hah.”

In her tent, Cheon Ah-young lowered her head, wrapping her arms around her knees and burying her face in her arms.

She felt sick.

Immediately, her eyes were flush with tears.

Tears dripped onto her bed, soaking the sheets.

Cheon Ah-young didn't even notice, continuing to shed tears.

She was angry.

She felt like she was going crazy because she was so upset.

I thought I had crossed a wall by adding martial arts to divine power, but I never thought there'd still be so many stronger people in the world.

I thought I could avenge Father by dealing with the Orthodox, but I have never felt so powerless.

In the end, someone else even helped me get revenge.

Cheon Ah-young bit her lips. She tasted the tang of blood and Woon-seong's words came to mind.

In the end, she had done nothing with her own hands. She had only said that she would try each time, but there were no visible results.

Above all, she felt the greatest despair because she had let down Woon-seong's expectations of her — he had placed her as vanguard and she had failed.

So her emotions were complicated and confusing; she continued to cry.

It felt like 50,000 different emotions mixed inside her soul. Cheon Ah-young shut her eyes tight.

At that moment, there was noise outside Cheon Ah-young's tent.

“Unni.”

It was Dang Bu-ah.

“Please go back,” Cheon Ah-young indifferently responded.

But she could not hide her wet voice.

“But unni...”

Dang Bu-ah struggled to speak.

Cheon Ah-young spoke more coldly, “Please go back. Please.”

It was a slightly more assertive tone.

The decisive voice made Dang Bu-ah turn away.

Cheon Ah-young could feel the presence move away.

But wait a minute.

There was still a presence at the entrance.

Cheon Ah-young shouted, “I told you to go back—”

“May I come in?”

If it weren’t for the voice, Cheon Ah-young would have continued shouting, but she stopped mid sentence.

It was not Dang Bu-ah at the entrance.

Low but clear voice.

A powerful tone...

It was Hyuk Woon-seong.

Cheon Ah-young was surprised and raised her head.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong entered the tent.

Cheon Ah-young remembered that her eyes were puffy and buried her head back between her knees.

But she had yet to greet the Heavenly Demon.

Soon she realized her mistake and blankly said, “Ah...”

“Since it is just the two of us, I’ll ignore the blunder.”

Woon-seong waved a hand. An iron chair from the other side floated over.

Woon-seong sat down and crossed his legs.

“Were you crying?”

Even though they were both from the Cave of Latent Demons, Cheon Ah-young was still a young woman. Without any consideration for delicacy, Woon-seong asked her directly.

Cheon Ah-young looked at Woon-seong sitting in the chair.

I hate you.

She literally hated him.

But it was true that she had cried, and it was true that she had been caught.

Instead of saying ‘I hate you’, Cheon Ah-young lifted her sleeve to rub at her eyes.

She rubbed at the tear marks, but her eyes became redder.

Subconsciously, Cheon Ah-young spoke to Woon-seong with a dead expression, “Disappointed...”

Here, Cheon Ah-young paused for a moment.

Last time, when Woon-seong had handed over the decapitated head of Hwan Dok, her emotions had been overwhelming. Thus, she had momentarily forgotten that Woon-seong was the Heavenly Demon. At the time, he hadn’t said much either because he understood.

But was that the case now?

Cheon Ah-young clapped a hand over her mouth to stop from habitually talking back.

Woon-seong laughed as he saw Cheon Ah-young muffle her words.

“When it’s just us, let’s talk comfortably. It will make you feel better, and it will make me feel better.”

“.....”

Cheon Ah-young hesitated for a moment and sighed. As Woon-seong said, she was more comfortable this way. She then repeated, “Are you disappointed?”

“I am disappointed.”

Woon-seong words were sharp as knives. They dug into her chest, colder than the northern winds.

Is this what they mean when they say words can kill a man?

Oblivious to Cheon Ah-young’s distress, Woon-seong continued, “I am very disappointed in you.”

Woon-seong’s voice was even and he turned to look at Cheon Ah-young with serious eyes.

Cheon Ah-young wanted to turn away, but felt like she shouldn’t.

So she seriously faced him.

“I know that. I told you that I wanted to take the lead, but I did not properly play my role,” Cheon Ah-young said.

Woon-seong chuckled. “You are mistaken. That is not why I am disappointed.”

Cheon Ah-young trembled.

Then why on earth are you disappointed?

She turned to stare at his lips.

What straightforward words is he going to say to hurt me now?

She wanted to cover her ears with her hands.

Instead, Cheon Ah-young gathered her courage and squared her shoulders.

It was then that the next words fell out of his mouth.

“I am disappointed that this is all you are.”

“...?”

“You were a little stronger, a little more cheerful back in the Cave of Latent Demons. Even I recognized you as a rival and was nervous.”

He wasn't lying.

Woon-seong considered no one but Cheon Ah-young as a competitor inside the Cave of Latent Demons. Only she was capable of fighting him on equal footing at the time.

The sincerity of his words were conveyed to Cheon Ah-young without filter.

Her eyes widened.

I can't believe you thought that...

That was the first time she had heard his inner thoughts.

Woon-seong continued.

“But what about you now? You are depressed after one defeat, hanging your head low and asking if I am disappointed.”

“.....”

“How can I not be disappointed?”

At his words, Cheon Ah-young trembled.

Woon-seong stood up.

“Do not be so disheartened. Be thankful that you are not dead. If you are alive, you can do anything. If you are alive, you can achieve whatever you

want. Train yourself through the disappointment and escape from death. Encourage yourself to move forward, to reach what you want. If that fails, you try again. Grasp your sword instead of disappointing me.”

Woon-seong shook his head.

As he walked out of the tent, he added,

“Do not let me down twice.”

That was the end of it.

With a fluttering sound, the entrance of the tent was opened and Woon-seong left.

Nevertheless, Cheon Ah-young stared at where Woon-seong had just been.

After some time, she clenched her fists.

“Do not let me down twice...”

Woon-seong’s last words continued to linger in her ears.

Chapter 179: Five Skies (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 179 – Five Skies (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

During the following month, the Eight Bolt Blade King concentrated all his time and energy on healing. He was given numerous elixirs and his torn meridians were soon repaired.

The medicine was not enough to heal everything, but he focused on restoring the many large and small injuries.

As a result, although not all wounds were gone, he was able to repair one of his arms.

That meant he was able to maintain strength in the level of Absolution for about half an hour.

From these results, it could be seen how generous Woon-seong and the Cult of the Heavenly Demon had been in their support of the Bolt King's recovery.

The Eight Bolt Blade King was not the only one recovering.

Soldiers from the Southern Army filled the Eastern Army's ranks. As a result, despite suffering losses, the Eastern Army was able to regain its massive size and strength.

A large platform was erected in front of these soldiers.

Woon-seong slowly walked to the top.

As Woon-seong appeared, the more than 10,000 soldiers gathered there greeted in unison:

“Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

“Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

Woon-seong nodded.

Burning with the Divine Flame, he looked at those standing in front of him and shouted, “Do you know why we are here today?”

Sheer flames seemed to pour from Woon-seong’s eyes. His voice was carried to all of the 10,000 soldiers.

There was not a single soldier who could not hear his voice, and so they all responded:

“We are gathered here to wage war!”

“We are gathered here to wage war!”

Woon-seong shook his head. “Wrong!”

All the demonic soldiers went silent at the same time.

Woo-seong looked at them and said, “We are not here to wage a war.”

The Divine Flame burned in both of his eyes and his fangs flashed brightly whenever he spoke.

Kung—

He stomped his foot and the platform trembled.

“Today, we are gathered here not for war, but for a memorial service!”

The demonic soldiers twitched at the words ‘memorial service’. The recent defeat was still fresh in their minds.

Woon-seong continued to shout at these demons.

“Look around you! Look at the face of the person next to you!”

Listening to him, the demonic soldiers looked at each other with puzzled expressions. Then, their faces hardened, as if understanding what the Heavenly Demon meant.

“Is that the same face you saw the other day? I am asking, are they the same comrades who stood by you on the battlefield?!”

No one could answer him easily.

Soldiers from the Eastern Army and the Southern Army had come together, mixing with soldiers from the West.

Of course, there were faces who had not changed, but that was a minority.

Many new faces had appeared; others had disappeared and new people filled those spaces.

The Western Army’s morale was at an all time low. Even those who were newly joining seemed affected by the mood.

“Your brothers-in-arms from the Cult are still lying on that cold ground. Those who are willing to abandon their identity as Demons and wish not to avenge their brothers, you may leave here.”

The demonic soldiers were silent.

Then someone raised their sword up high and shouted, “We will raise a memorial service!”

That was the signal.

Soldiers all around him drew their swords and yelled, “We will avenge our brothers!”

Like ripples on the surface of a lake, the soldiers drew their swords and shouted. Each person lifted their weapons high.

And they shouted together:

“Avenge their spirits with blood!”

Woon-seong nodded with satisfaction.

He then stomped again.

Kung—

It echoed and the platform cracked.

Standing atop it, Woon-seong commanded: “Look behind you!”

The soldiers turned in unison.

A wide open plain appeared in their sights.

“The enemy is at the end of this plain!”

The soldiers stared at the wide rolling fields.

They could not see it, but Woon-seong could.

Enemy barracks, enemy movements!

It was blurry, but visible.

Woon-seong roared:

“Do not think of this as war. It is merely a memorial service. No one is going to die in the midst of holding a memorial service!”

The demons shouted:

“There is no such fool!”

“There is no such fool!”

Woon-seong nodded and stomped again.

Kung—

The platform collapsed with a groan.

Woon-seong still stood high.

He was standing on air.

Woon-seong roared, pointing at the enemies from the air, “Then, let’s go!”

Kuaa-

Woon-seong’s roar echoed and rippled.

Rough sand and dust swirled from the fields.

“Let us hold the memorial service!”

“Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

“Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

Bang, bang, bang.

The drums boomed, echoing across the ground.

That was a signal.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon began to advance across the land.

At the forefront of the advancing army were Woon-seong, the Eight Bolt Blade King, the Senior Strategist, and Cheon Ah-young.

“I see them.”

As Woon-seong said, the enemy was beginning to appear. Previously, they might have been blurry, but they were now clear as day.

Woon-seong glanced at them and asked the Bolt King and Cheon Ah-young, “Do you see either of the two masters?”

Cheon Ah-young and the Bolt King shook their heads.

Nothing.

It was all just ordinary soldiers. But if that was all there was, the Western Army would not have suffered so.

The Eight Bolt Blade King swallowed as he remembered, “That day, too...” He gripped his blade. “They did not intervene at first, but suddenly appeared in the middle.”

“So they may appear today.”

Cheon Ah-young and the Blade King nodded.

“You have not forgotten the signal, have you?”

The Blade King and Cheon Ah-young rolled up their left sleeves. To their arms were tied bamboo containers.

Those were the signals.

At the critical moment, if they saw the masters, they would fire off the blue firecrackers.

Woon-seong nodded his head in confirmation.

As the Demonic Army advanced, the Martial Alliance had seen them and was now moving to engage.

If we keep going like this, there will be a collision halfway.

Woon-seong stepped forward.

Kuung—

The ground trembled as an earthquake shook the area.

Woon-seong roared once more,

“Do not forget. We are raising a memorial service!”

Hehehehehehehehe!

His voice reached even those in the back, touching even the weary.

“We will not forget!”

“We will not forget!”

Soon after, the blue and dark red waves collided with another, just as Woon-seong predicted.

Without hesitation, the two sides roughly slammed into each other.

Waaaaahhh!

It was a vicious struggle.

In the middle of the violence, one of the Orthodox soldiers shouted: “Do not retreat! It is merely a person called a demon! We have already defeated them once! Do not lose!”

Cheon Ah-young, offended by these words, frowned. She gripped her sword and moved her other hand.

It was clear that the voice had come from somewhere near the center of the Martial Alliance formation.

Cut down the leader to demoralize the enemy.

Cheon Ah-young, who had practiced martial arts, thought that way.

She immediately restrained the man and moved her sword.

Puchi—

Blood splattered and the enemy's head was cut in half.

“Huff!”

With her making a move, several soldiers shouted, “Kill her!”

Someone swung at her.

Cheon Ah-young had already retreated.

Again.

She would fight someone, back up to stabilize, then fight again. She repeated that inhalation and exhalation.

At the same time, she thought about what Woon-seong had said ten days ago.

I won't let you down twice.

Cheon Ah-young's sword began to slash enemies more ruthlessly.

Puchi—

The Eight Bolt Blade King grasped his own blade. He may not have fully recovered in such a short amount of time, but he left a field of electricity in his wake.

Zzzt—

Bang!

Pure thunderstorms of chaos, carrying lightning that separated the earth and sky amongst the enemies!

The blade in the Eight Bolt Blade King's hand erupted with the intensity of lightning. An eight-branched blast swept through the enemies in a fan shape.

“Ah!”

“Stop him!”

Enemies were dismembered, electricity crackling at their wounds.

Those who prevented serious injuries were not better off.

Zzzt-zzzt!

“Cough!”

Once the Orthodox soldiers had been paralyzed by the electric currents, other demonic soldiers would slash through them ruthlessly.

The Demons' eyes were filled with venom.

To avenge my comrades!

To avenge my brothers!

Let's raise a memorial service!

As black waves surged, the demonic soldiers poured through. Between them, swords, spears and more washed through their enemies.

Fwa-bing—

Blood sprinkled the air and Cheon Ah-young danced through the enemy lines.

If the Eight Bolt Blade King was a wave sweeping through the enemy, Cheon Ah-young was an eagle who grabbed her prey.

The rising waves instantly brought fish to the surface and the eagle rushed to catch them.

And what was the fate of a fish caught in an eagle's claws?

Was there a need to say more?

They were torn apart by the eagle.

And thus was the fate of enemies caught in the hands of Cheon Ah-young.

Her sword seemed to divide into five, creating a sword aura and enemies were split apart.

Woon-seong watched Cheon Ah-young and smiled. *My words seemed to have helped.*

He then turned to face his own enemies.

Woon-seong was currently surrounded by soldiers.

No one slackened their wall around him.

Even without the Black Dragon Robe, they knew who he was.

“Heavenly Demon, prepare to die!” someone yelled.

Woon-seong smiled coolly looking at the riffraff. “None of you are attacking me, what a waste of those swords in your hands.”

It was a taunt.

Nevertheless, the soldiers did not attack. It was because fear of the Heavenly Demon was stronger than anger.

“If you don't want to come...”

Seeing such enemies, Woon-seong said,

“Then I will go to you.”

Kuakuakuakua!

Chapter 180: Five Skies (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 180 – Five Skies (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

City of Suzhou, Anhui Province.

Moonlight shone on Suzhou as darkness fell.

Shua—

In the middle of the night was the sound of trickling water.

It was late at night, but someone was dipping their hands in the water.

No, it wasn't their hand.

Shua—

There was the sound of water once more, and someone slowly started walking across the water.

If someone was on the scene, they might have felt the freshness of summer lingering in the air.

A martial artist would have inhaled the wind, saying that it contained the lightness of life.

What about now?

The only one watching the scene was an old man, who laughed. He set down the bottle in his hand and said, "I've thought this before, but you're a lucky fellow."

The man walking across the water smiled. "You also have too much luck. It seems this is a drink at the lakeshore."

The old man was the Buddhist Star. He glanced at the bottle in his hand and said, "Try a sip."

"Liquor. I don't know where from, but that seems to be rice wine."

"Perhaps it's not alcohol." The Buddhist Star laughed, raising a hand to scratch at his head. "Let me have my fill. I have been living in Shaolin and pretending to be a virtuous person, eating raw rice and having a hard time."

That said, he lightly tossed the bottle in his hand.

It arced through the air.

Still, not a single drop of alcohol spilled out.

Indeed, what amazing skill.

The swordsman standing on the water caught the bottle from across the lake.

The man inelegantly poured some of the alcohol into his mouth.

"Sour. It must not have been very expensive."

"Haha, what money do I have? If you are thirsty, even the smell of it can satisfy you. Namó Amitabha."

Did he respond to that?

The swordsman continued across the water, striding unlike earlier. He stopped some distance away.

A swordsman appeared in the moonlight.

Sleek and stubborn. Its form did not hide the irresistible and powerful force contained within.

What if they made clay swords and molded them into human form? The Buddhist Star smiled, “Can this be considered drinking together?”

There were still several meters between the swordsman and the shore.

The Buddhist Star shook his fist in mockery, “I can still reach you with the Great Arhat’s Fist. This distance is nothing.”

The swordsman standing on the water grabbed the sword hanging at his waist. “My Galaxy Meteor Sword would be one step faster.”

Unlike the man’s solemn face, the Buddhist Star responded lightly, “You want to fight, asshole?”

“It would be fun.”

“You’re still like this, Sword.”

The other man was the Sword Star.

In Murim, the Semi-Divine Beings were known as the ‘Two Stars One Demon’, or the ‘Twin Stars One Demon’.

Able to split a cliff with his sword, the Sword Star now appeared in Suzhou.

“I read your letter well.”

The Sword Star jumped off the water and sat by the Buddhist Star.

The Buddhist Star nodded stiffly. “I can’t believe they’re acting again...”

The swordsman swiped a finger across his sword.

Seeing this, the Buddhist Star said, “The swordsmen of Paektu and them have been enemies for a long time, right?”

“Irreconcilable enemies.”

That was what the Sword Star said. Enemies that could not exist under the same sky.

“The Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

A long time ago, the founder of the Changbai Sword Sect of Mount Paektu had lost his life to the Inverted Sky. Since then, there had been a large chasm between the Inverted Sky and the Changbai Sword Sect.

“Hmm, I heard there was something a long time ago, but how did it happen...”

The Buddhist Star spoke as if he was frustrated, but the Sword Star cut him off.

“Do not pretend not to understand, the Shaolin also had a relationship with them.”

The Buddhist Star smiled bitterly. “Because they chose the Unorthodox Path. Isn’t it because of the name ‘Inverted Sky’?”

A long time ago...

At the dawn of the Ancient Era, there were five outstanding masters called the ‘Five Skies Beyond the Heavens’ (天外五天).

The Buddhist Sky, who had inherited the dharma of the Buddha.

The Sky Demon, who said that the demons could afford to walk above the Heavens. [1]

The Spear Sky, who aimed to capture all the martial arts of the world in a single spear.

The Sword Sky, who was going to show Heaven in a single sword.

And the Soul Sky, who would reach the Heavens with the force of a human soul.

They regarded each other as competitors, but yet were comrades walking the same path, so they were specially connected.

“That relationship changed once the Soul Sky began to devour others, no longer embracing the soul of a human.”

At that time, it was the Sword Sky who stopped the Soul Sky. But the Soul Sky still had connections with the rest of the Five Skies Beyond the Heavens and sought the Spear Sky for help, sharing his difficulties. However, the Spear Sky had refused the Soul Sky’s requests.

It was because he had never made friends that the Soul Sky began walking upon the Unorthodox Path. He was so angry that he devoured the souls around him to form the perfect, embittered heart. That was the beginning of the Inverted Sky.

“The Sword Sky died trying to stop him, and the other Five Skies Beyond the Heavens joined forces to finally stop the Soul Sky.”

That was a Murim legend forgotten by all.

The Sword Star smiled bitterly, “And yet his descendants appear in this world again...”

“Everyone has forgotten, but it is time for the Five Skies Beyond the Heavens to stop them once again.”

The Sword Star nodded at the Buddhist Star’s words. “Is it a coincidence that the descendants of the Sky Demon are at war with them?”

The Buddhist Star pressed his hands together. “The Heaven’s net casts wide. Though its meshes are coarse, nothing slips through...”

He did not forget to add a ‘Namo Amitabha’ at the end.

“The power of the Spear Sky has been broken. But even if that power is gone, there are still the descendants of the Sky Demon. We must work with them to stop the descendants of the Soul Sky.”

The Buddhist Star chuckled and looked up at the night sky. “Do you really think that the bloodline of the Spear Sky are broken?”

The Sword Star was startled. “Does the line of the Spear Sky still continue?”

The Buddhist Star tilted his head and replied, “Well, I don’t know.”

However, as the Buddhist Star stared up at the night sky, it seemed like at least two stars shone brighter, seemingly to overlap.

“There is no one... Even the young children of Murim know the story of the Spear Master Sect’s destruction.”

The Buddhist Star laughed at these brutal words.

“Everything will be revealed with time.”

Staring at those two almost overlapping stars, he muttered to himself, *The Heaven’s net casts wide. Though its meshes are coarse, nothing slips through...*

It was a few days before the battle in Chongqing.

Woon-seong reached for his spear.

He swung.

Cut, stab, block.

He reached out with a hand.

Swing with your fist, stab with your finger, block with a palm.

It was not just his spear and hand.

Woon-seong's body moved about, like it was being thrown through a storm.

He purposefully did not use the Divine Flame.

The Divine Flame could almost be considered an external power.

Woon-seong was limiting his power to deal with enemies with nothing but martial arts.

And he did not feel a great crisis even without using his Divine Flame.

No, these ordinary people could not dare to even bring Woon-seong to a crisis.

Hmm.

Both hands swept through the enemy without rest, his feet swirling the dust.

Various skills and techniques poured from Woon-seong's mind and body.

Each time, the number of corpses would dramatically increase.

One enemy would fall to a single technique.

One move, one kill.

He did not need a second attack.

What was even more surprising was that Woon-seong did not repeat the same skill or technique once as he wiped out his enemies.

Even if he technically used the same skill, there would be a subtle difference. For example, there would be a difference in the amount of strength he used, or how he breathed or used his qi.

Hmm.

In the process, Woon-seong split his mind and observed himself.

Not bad. The previous attack was a bit efficient, but the current retreat was quite effective.

Effective attacks would be slightly modified; inefficient ones would be tossed out and changed.

Woon-seong was experimenting with his own martial arts. Or, to be precise, he was using his martial techniques one by one in practice.

Of course, this was not a mindless decision.

This was done with purpose, to achieve that one goal.

One Thousand Absolute Routes.

This goal, barely named and set, was the ultimate pinnacle of Woon-seong's martial arts.

In order to achieve such a peak, Woon-seong was testing out all of his knowledge in a thousand different battles.

Attack, correct and catch any deviations.

He repeated the process over and over and over, pushing out anything unnecessary.

Repeat, erase, save.

Quadduk-

Kwaarnee-

The Orthodox soldiers collapsed in puddles of blood.

The blood ran thick. Pieces of flesh and bone littered the area, the blood pouring down like rain and forming a river.

He seemed to be building a mountain of corpses. That was how violent Woon-seong was.

Of course, there were people trying to prevent Woon-seong from continuing.

“You wicked Demon!”

“Wicked leader of the Demons, go back to Hell!”

Of course, it was possible for these people to block Woon-seong because on top of not using the Divine Flame, he had been limiting use of internal qi.

They could only block once though.

After that, they could not block Woon-seong’s offensive and were helplessly beaten back.

Woon-seong reached out and smashed another head.

Bang—

Bits of brain and blood splattered in all directions.

Woon-seong then moved his spear to sweep the front.

At that moment!

Kaguang—

A sword swooped in from somewhere, blocking Woon-seong’s spear. A spark crackled and the White Night Spear bounced back.

Although he did not use the Divine Flame, that was still Woon-seong's spear.

It was a spear much stronger than a bear's paws.

That a sword has blocked my spear...

Woon-seong stopped and looked towards where the sword had come from.

Four other men stood beside the owner of that sword.

Woon-seong read their qi presences and concluded, "Supreme Masters?"

Five of them.

That was not something Cheon Ah-young or the Eight Bolt Blade King had mentioned in their report.

[1] The position of Cult Leader would be better translated as 'Sky Demon', which is Cheonma (天魔), and not the 'Heavenly Demon'. This is also why it is the Cheon Family, 'Cheon' for 'Sky'. However, I will continue to use 'Heavenly Demon'.

Chapter 181: A Fool (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 181 – A Fool (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

They had not been mentioned in the report.

Was Cheon Ah-young and the Eight Bolt Blade King's report wrong?

No, it doesn't seem like that's the case.

Woon-seong stared at the five men blocking his path with sharp eyes. Perhaps they were relocated here just for this fight.

Otherwise, Cheon Ah-young and the Blade King wouldn't have missed them.

“Some petty things,” Woon-seong said, still watching them.

The five men trembled. It was as if they had been insulted.

The real insult was Woon-seong's next words:

“You dare to think of stopping me with only five of you...”

“Even if you are the Heavenly Demon, I think that is too harsh.”

The one who spoke was the oldest of the five. The clothes around him snapped and he stood like a doll made of cloth.

But Woon-seong was able to identify the man.

The ‘Flood Demon’s Indestructible Technique’ (沔妖不壞功).

A monster that flows like the river does not collapse.

“The ‘Indestructible Flood Elder’.”

The man made a happy expression and nodded. “It is an honor to be recognized by the Heavenly Demon.”

Woon-seong turned a smile on the other four. The information about the 72 Supreme Masters was quite well known in Kangho.

Woon-seong was able to tell their peculiarities.

The man standing to the left of the Indestructible Flood Elder wore a chain wrapped around his arm. A sickle was visible behind his back. A man who dealt with demons using a sickle and chains.

“Nine Knots Death God (九節死神).”

“Hmm.” The Nine Knots Death God trembled under Woon-seong’s gaze.

After that, Woon-seong continued identifying the men standing before him.

“Ageless Old Man (童子老君).”

The man looked about as old as a child, but was actually over seventy years old.

“Quick Flying Hog King (快飛豚皇).”

A man who used his rolls of fat and unexpected speeds to swiftly crush the enemy.

And finally...

“Iron Cannon Twin Fists (鐵炮雙拳).”

A martial artist whose two fists packed the same punch as a steel cannon.

Each was a master in their own right; they all stood at the peak of Zhongyuan. Any province they went to, they would be amongst the top ten masters in the area.

Ah. Indeed, this is war.

Woon-seong clenched his fists. He then stretched out his index finger and said, “Come all together, it saves time and is less of a hassle.”

At his words, the Iron Cannon Twin Fists protested with dark eyes. “What?!”

From the beginning, they knew that none of them would be able to win against the Heavenly Demon alone.

That was why they had united, but the Heavenly Demon was being arrogant now.

The Death God swung his chains, as if in response to the man’s shout.

Ssssss—

As he swung the chain, it sounded like a snake hissing.

“The Heavenly Demon is still a young child. Don’t you know you can’t catch ten hands with one?”

Woon-seong smiled. “Are you confident that you can stop even one hand of mine? It is bad to overestimate yourself.”

“You bastard!”

It seemed that they couldn’t take any more insults.

The Iron Cannon Twin Fists clenched his fists, which were as large as a pot each, and charged forward.

At the same time, the man pulled his fist back and swung.

The ‘Iron Cannon’ in his title was not just for show since he could smash through large rocks with just one blow, much like a cannon.

At the same time!

Kuang—!

A vast stream of air shook the ground.

This massive offensive should have been enough to make even the Heavenly Demon step back.

At least, that was what everyone watching thought so. Even the Iron Cannon thought so, until he punched.

There was a crucial miscalculation.

“Ugh?!”

The Iron Cannon’s face, who had been punching blind through the sand and dust, was bizarrely distorted.

There was a strange noise.

Crunch—

It sounded like something had been broken and warped.

The Quick Flying Hog King startled. “What?”

In conclusion, all guesses were wrong.

It wasn’t the sound of something breaking or twisting.

Well, not exactly.

It was the sound of something being compressed.

The Iron Cannon's massive fists had been crushed by Woon-seong's grip.

With just his finger strength, Woon-seong was wrecking the man's hands.

“Huhuhuhuhaugh.”

With how much pain he was in, the Iron Cannon's body trembled. He wanted to run away, but his legs would not listen.

Within the swirling dust, Woon-seong's eyes flashed golden.

“Is it only this much?”

The sand cleared and Woon-seong appeared. He had blocked the Iron Cannon Twin Fists with one hand, but he was without a scratch.

The Quick Flying Hog King was startled, but cried out to the others. “We must help!”

“Let's move out!”

That was the signal.

The Ageless Old Man moved first, rushing towards Woon-seong. Running around like a child, he spread his palms out in front of Woon-seong, using his martial arts.

He tried to shoot out the energy that he was so proud of.

But something was faster than that.

Puchi—

“Ah!”

A scream tore from the Ageless Old Man's mouth. As he pulled his hand back, a glass knife could be seen embedded into his palm.

“Hah.”

The Ageless Old Man was supposed to spread poisonous qi into the air so that the Iron Cannon could distance himself from Woon-seong.

Everyone thought this would work.

Actually, it had to...

Until they heard...

The Iron Cannon Twin Fists thought the world in his eyes was tilting. Not, it seemed to be shattering.

At the same time, he fell to the floor.

“Huh?”

Suddenly pain struck the Iron Cannon. His left leg.

“Ahhh!”

Woon-seong had broken the man's shin bones, then dropped him.

“How dare you!”

The Indestructible Flood Elder moved, blocking a blow coming at the Iron Cannon and probably saving the man's life.

The Indestructible Flood Elder specialized in defensive martial arts. No matter how many times you hit, you won't be able to slam him down with a single blow!

At least, that was his conviction.

But...

Kuah—

Woon-seong's fist plunged into the man's abdomen. At the same time, the force of the blow tore apart the man's insides.

One force destroying his internal organs, another crushing the skeletal structure.

Two forces simultaneously devoured the Indestructible Flood Elder's body.

"Stop!" the man screamed, attempting to release his own power.

But Woon-seong's energy was too strong.

"Aaah!"

Eventually, the man was unable to release even half of the energy contained in Woon-seong's fists before he collapsed on the floor, dropping like a puppet without strings. He died, not bleeding a speck of blood. Though it must be noted that all of his bones, joints, muscles, and blood vessels had shattered.

"That's one," commented Woon-seong briefly as he moved the White Night Spear, blocking the Iron Cannon Twin Fists.

"Son of a bitch, I'll make you drop that fucking spear!"

Kuakuakua—

A large ball rolled towards Woon-seong.

No, not a ball, a person.

Like his name, the Quick Flying Hog King had rolled his body at unbelievable speeds and was tumbling towards Woon-seong.

If he was hit, Woon-seong would go down like a bowling pin.

Woon-seong pulled the White Night Spear, which had been stretching towards the Iron Cannon, back towards himself.

He then squeezed his left hand.

Woon-seong shoulders tensed and swung backwards. Then releasing, a cannon stronger than those of the Iron Cannon Twin Fists' hurtled towards the Quickly Flying Hog King.

The Quickly Flying Hog King suddenly felt like a cliff was crumbling around him.

At the same time, he cursed his own martial arts for being unable to abort halfway. Although it allowed for fast speed, he was unable to stop his own movement until he collided with something.

And collide with something he did.

Pah—

There was the sound of a pig bursting.

Like a perforated balloon, the Quick Flying Hog King's body soared into the air, blood spilling out instead of air.

“Two.”

Woon-seong, after getting rid of the pig, pointed a finger at the Ageless Old Man.

Peng—

A series of explosions later and the Ageless Old Man's body was wrapped in flames.

“Get it off, it's hot, hot!”

At that moment, the remaining glass knives stabbed into the man's body.

Puchi—

And then what?

It was the Death God's turn.

The Nine Knots Death God turned around and fled, knowing that everything had gone wrong.

Woon-seong was faster. Using some of his qi, he threw the White Night Spear like a javelin.

Fwoosh—

The air exploded and the White Night Spear raced through the sky.

It was as if the palm of the Shaolin had been stretched into a spear.

And as a result!

Pang—

The head of the runaway Death God was smashed and bits of brain sprayed in all directions.

“Four, and...”

Woon-seong used a vortex to retrieve the White Night Spear. He walked towards the Iron Cannon Twin Fists, who was lying on the ground with his broken leg.

Crunch, crunch, crunch.

“You're the last one.”

As he approached, the Iron Cannon Twin Fists trembled. “Agh, agh. Monster, monster!”

The word ‘monster’ caused Woon-seong to pause. He was about three steps away from the man now.

It was a distance where he could easily slit the man’s throat with the White Night Spear.

Woon-seong stood there and coldly smiled. “First, thank you.”

All of a sudden, the Heavenly Demon was thanking him. The Iron Cannon Twin Fists could not understand the situation. “Agh. What? What are you talking about?”

“Thanks to you, I was able to develop a few skills. It is definitely easier to test them against those who actually know how to move their bodies than against weaklings.”

The Iron Cannon Twin Fists felt despair at these words.

It was not just a problem of overwhelming power.

From the beginning, Woon-seong hadn’t even shown his true colors.

The Iron Cannon asked in a trembling voice, “O-Oh. You mean you tested your martial arts on us?”

“Don’t say it like I was testing my martial arts on you.”

The Iron Cannon’s palms were sweating. He was trembling, but he didn’t even notice because of his horror.

“Well, then...”

“I was creating a martial art.”

“Creating a martial art?”

“Yes, thanks to you, I have a few takeaways.”

The few moves that he had used to beat the group.

These moves still needed to be united. In the process, there were several movements that would form the One Thousand Routes to One.

“So, before I kill you, I would like to thank you.”

After he finished speaking, Woon-seong raised the White Night Spear high.

At that moment, someone shouted at him: “The Cult Leader must stop his bloodshed.”

A voice that was dignified in strength.

Throughout this battlefield, there would only be one possessor of this kind of power.

Is it Tae Heo-jin?

Leader of the Wudang Sect.

Woon-seong looked up and saw the man’s face. The Taegeuk engraved onto his sword and uniform. Even the wrinkles on his face, traces of time.

Woon-seong glanced at him and responded, “Why would I do that?”

Shua—

The Iron Cannon Twin Fists’ severed head rolled across the ground.

Tuk-

Degururu...

Chapter 182: A Fool (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 182 – A Fool (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Tae Heo-jin looked at the Iron Cannon Twin Fists' head rolling on the ground with bitter eyes. Sobering up, he asked, "Must you have used your hands so cruelly?"

Woon-seong grinned with his White Night Spear in hand.

Drip, drop.

Red blood dripped from the end of the spear.

It was the blood of the man he had just beheaded.

He pointed the still dripping spear at Tae Heo-jin.

"Why should I let those who tried to kill me live?"

When asked, Tae Heo-jin sighed. "Is this not a war the Cult Leader waged? If the Cult Leader had not started the war, none of this would have happened."

"Idiot."

Woon-seong swung the spear, shaking the blood off. Chunks of flesh unstuck from the spear and flew through the air.

“It is like you are imitating a speaker, but you are blindfolded and deaf.”

Woon-seong mocked Tae Heo-jin, “You are playing the hypocrite, not the hero.”

Tae Heo-jin’s eyebrows twitched. He was someone who claimed to have walked the path of a righteous man, not wavering an inch since birth.

But he was now hearing that he was playing the part of a hypocrite; words denying Tae Heo-jin’s life.

“What do you mean?”

“Do you not even know what I mean?” Woon-seong responded, twirling his spear. “It was not me who started this war, but you.”

Tae Heo-jin furrowed his brows. “Even if you try to shake me with your nonsense, it will not work. This one is willing to risk his life today to stop the Cult Leader.”

“And if it is not nonsense?”

“.....”

Tae Heo-jin paused.

Woon-seong continued, his voice containing only confidence. “Have you not heard from Jwa Do-gyul? It was your side who started this war.”

“What are you talking about?”

Woon-seong tilted his head back and burst into laughter, “Hahaha, how naive.”

When he lowered his head, there was not a trace of a smile on his face.

The Divine Flame burned in both of his eyes.

He stared at Tae Heo-jin with his blazing eyes.

“An ignorant coward is just playing the righteous. Yet, he swears to be a righteous man, knowing nothing of the before or after.”

Woon-seong clenched his fists.

“The Martial Alliance attacked the branches of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon in Zhongyuan. You started this war!”

Tae Heo-jin trembled.

In fact, there was a rumor that everyone had heard.

One that Tae Heo-jin had heard, but one he did not believe.

Tae Heo-jin firmly believed that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon started the war. This was because he believed too strongly in Jwa Do-gyul.

He trusted in the good of people so much he believed the Lord of the Martial Alliance at once.

And that was why he could not accept Woon-seong’s words.

“No way...”

He shook his head.

Woon-seong roared, looking around at the other soldiers too: “You accused us of starting this war, but it was you who attacked our branches first! So cut off your ears that refuse to listen! If that is your unseeing eye, pluck it out. Lose those tongues you have used to brag about yourselves!”

Woon-seong’s words shook Tae Heo-jin, for his words were filled with confidence.

Can a man tell a lie so confidently, unless it is actually the truth? Tae Heo-jin had no choice but to ask, “Are there no lies in your words?”

Woon-seong shrugged. “If you call yourself a righteous man, if you want to live like that, turn around and see for yourself. Jump to your feet and find out what happened. Are you prepared to do that?”

Tae Heo-jin hesitated.

Since he talks so confidently, it is only right to get to the bottom of this. It is right to tell the Wudang disciples to retreat, to return to Wudang Mountain and to collect the correct information about the situation.

But,

“If I leave the Cult Leader as he is, will you continue your slaughter? I must stop you.”

Tae Heo-jin chose to raise his sword.

Woon-seong laughed. “That is a good excuse.”

“An excuse?”

“You are afraid to recognize your own faults, to learn that I am right. So you are staying here to make sure you do not feel your whole life has become a lie. If this is not an excuse, then what is it?”

Tae Heo-jin trembled. But after a moment, he gripped the sword tighter. “You can say what you want, but I will stop the Cult Leader here today.”

“If you can. Stop me as much as you can.”

Tae Heo-jin was definitely a strong man.

In terms of how strong, he was probably one of the strongest in Murim. Among the tens of thousands of martial artists, he could be considered amongst the top ten.

This was, of course, excluding the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, but it was still a really great rank.

In fact, his skill was on par with one of the Ten Demonic Masters, Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon Lee Shin-jung.

But what did that mean to the Heavenly Demon?

Kuang—

Tae Heo-jin was pushed back.

The man flew into the air like a broken kite and barely landed on the ground. However, his body was shaken and the shock did not completely subside.

It meant absolutely nothing.

Tae Heo-jin bit his lips.

Even though Tae Heo-jin was strong, he could not be compared to the Heavenly Demon, the ‘One Demon’ of the ‘Twin Stars, One Demon’ of the Semi-Divine Beings.

“But!”

Tae Heo-jin raised his spirits. He, too, did not come here with a normal resolution.

He had come here today prepared to lay down his life to stop the Heavenly Demon.

At the same time, he recited a mantra and a mighty power rose from his body. Its strength was undiluted, like a draconic wind hurtling towards the skies.

When Woon-seong saw it, he paused for a moment and muttered, “Heavenward Soul Earthen Body?”

It seemed a little similar.

But Woon-seong shook his head. *Nope, the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body can't do that.*

It was only able to encourage the flow of innate essence qi.

But what was this?

Burning the soul to draw the power out.

“Are you trying to stop me by burning yourself?”

Woon-seong grabbed his spear.

Maybe if he, Tae Heo-jin, saw the world a little more broadly...

If only you didn't believe in the information given by Jwa Do-gyul...

If so, he might have been a real chivalrous man. Like his master, Nok Yu-on, who sacrificed his whole body to prevent the conspiracy in the dark.

But it is already too late.

Tae Heo-jin was already burning through his dantian.

It was the maximum power of a Taoist of Wudang who had the root of a hero, yet was not a hero.

Woon-seong decided to face him.

Kwaarnee-

There was an explosion inside Woon-seong. At the same time, Intimidation Qi wrapped around his body.

A fire was burning.

Fwoom—

The flame spread from Woon-seong's back, tendrils licking up his arms.

Balls of it floated through the air like little firecrackers.

It was the Divine Flame.

A fire that burned the world, manifested Hell, and brought Demons to the pinnacle.

Woon-seong made his decision as a scholar.

In this situation, if you are the head of the Wudang, you will show me the 'Seven Celestial Stars Sword'...

In the meantime, Tae Heo-jin moved his sword.

“Stop your advance, Heavenly Demon!”

His sword drew seven stars across the night sky. These seven stars swirled around the Taegeuk blade and rushed towards Woon-seong in a flash.

The Seven Celestial Stars Sword, as expected!

Fwoom—

In response, Woon-seong changed the shape of the Divine Flame. The ghost fires floating in the sky united into the shape of a sword, colliding with the Seven Celestial Stars Sword.

Boom—

Rrrrrrrrrrr!

Kuakuakua—

Bang!

There was a large explosion, like a single bullet had been shot. A huge shockwave exploded in all directions.

The ground flipped. It cracked and split, revealing its insides.

The world turned white.

Inside, Woon-seong moved his spear.

In a pure white world, he could not see, but that was no problem. He had raised his senses during the chaos, allowing him to perfectly capture the world, even without sight.

The Taegeuk Dispelling Sword.

A technique of the Wudang Sect that unraveled the spearmanship of Woon-seong from the ground up.

A sword that contained the flow of the world's cosmic powers..

The Taegeuk Dispelling Sword would unleash its own power to the Taiji (supreme), while dismantling the opponent's martial arts through Taiji at the same time.

As a scholar, this is the greatest honor!

Woon-seong met the sword with his own blade. No, it should technically be called a spear.

Woon-seong's spear moved. Every time the Taegeuk sword moved, it would also move.

Boom—

Shua—

Shick—

The spear version of the Taegeuk Dispelling Sword began to be released from Woon-seong's hands.

There was no one who could compete with the Spear Master Sect in academia, unless they were Jegal Sung.

And Hyuk Woon-seong was the last person to succeed the Spear Master Sect!

It was a mistake to fight against him with a weapon.

Tae Heo-jin, who burned his dantian, had less energy than Woon-seong, but was able to at least use it to the best of his abilities.

Woon-seong was simply a step ahead.

And finally.

Clang—

The Taegeuk Dispelling Sword was completely broken. All of the martial arts contained in that swordsmanship were completely destroyed under Woon-seong's spear.

When the Taegeuk Dispelling Sword disappeared, there was only one thing left.

Woon-seong stared at Tae Heo-jin's blade, then shot forward.

Kuakuakua—

Dozens of swirls burst in the air.

It was a technique that contained the heart of Woon-seong, who had dealt with five of the 72 Supreme Masters.

Dozens of these swirls tangled together, surrounding the sword. It was not just the sword. They rushed towards Tae Heo-jin too, wrapping like serpents.

Even though it is not enough to call it One Thousand Absolute Routes...

It should be enough to deal with Tae Heo-jin, whose sword had disappeared.

As Woon-seong thought, dozens of bundles of flame and energy swept across the man.

Kuakuakua—

“Haha.”

When the man woke up, he saw a blue sky and emptiness.

The sky was unbelievably clear for a battlefield. There was not a single cloud in sight.

Maybe it was because it was autumn.

The autumn sky was beautiful.

I do not remember the last time I looked up at the sky with a hopeful heart. I have been in too much of a hurry to save this dying world.

Tae Heo-jin sighed to himself, almost subconsciously. He then raised his hand and tried to scratch his head.

Hmm.

But nothing moved.

He could barely move his eyes, but he turned to look at his body.

He had no arms.

It was not the only thing missing.

He had also lost his lower half.

It was because they had been swept away by a tremendous flood.

Tae Heo-jin sighed.

Somehow, I feel lighter.

Woon-seong approached Tae Heo-jin.

That spear is my death, sighed Tae Heo-jin.

Everytime he sighed, he could feel his life draining away. His body became lighter.

“In the eyes of the Leader, was I really just playing the role of a righteous man?”

At the question, Woon-seong stabbed the White Night Spear into the ground. With an almost tired expression, he responded, “A fool who was obsessed with heroics.”

“Haha, ha-ha-ha...”

To his words, Tae Heo-jin sighed emptily. He closed his eyes slowly.

Woon-seong told him, “But you were quite devoted to your role as a fool.”

Tae Heo-jin smiled. “Was I?”

“Yes.”

“Then, can this fool who was loyal to his role ask for a favor?”

“Greedy, too.”

Woon-seong clicked his tongue, but he did not refuse.

Perhaps it was out of pity for a man who could have walked the path of a hero.

For a moment, perhaps the figure of Nok Yu-on had overlapped with this man.

Seeing him, Tae Heo-jin sighed once again, smiling as he spoke.

“I...”

Chapter 183: Sword At The Enemy'S Chin (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 183 – Sword at the Enemy's Chin (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The sunset lit the sky in a blood red glow.

With blood pooling everywhere, it was hard to separate the sky from the earth.

“Phew.”

Woon-seong breathed out quietly.

By the time Woon-seong knocked down Tae Heo-jin, the battle was almost over.

Unlike the Demonic Army, which had been reinforced by their rear, the Martial Alliance had received no support.

Moreover, the two masters from the Eight Bolt Blade King's and Cheon Ah-young's report did not appear. Instead, only a few of the 72 Supreme Masters had appeared.

It was unknown why this was.

But one thing was for certain.

The current battlefield was Chongqing.

A little further was a place called Wuhan, the City of Three Garrisons.

Wuhan was a hub of the Martial Alliance.

Obviously, Jwa Do-gyul would be there as well.

Woon-seong ground his teeth as he looked in the direction of the sunset.

East.

Where the Martial Alliance was.

Where Jwa Do-gyul was.

Woon-seong growled.

“Hmm, defeat again. Now, they are at our throats.”

The man sat alone in a dark room and spoke calmly.

It was too calm of a voice for Murim, which had experienced another defeat.

In the meeting about an hour ago, the man had acted completely differently, expressing regret for the dead and shedding tears.

Perhaps Jwa Do-gyul remembered that, too.

His lips curled up into a bloody smile.

Maybe I have a talent for Chinese opera. [1]

He changed his face so well that it might work.

For a while, there were miscellaneous thoughts.

Jwa Do-gyul eventually closed his eyes, firmly fixing his expression.

“Hmph.”

The sound of irritation tumbled from his lips as he closed his eyes. There seemed to be something bothering him.

Unlike before, was it pity for the damaged Martial Alliance?

“Too little damage.”

Those words told differently.

“We have enough damage to the sects, but there is far less damage to the Demonic Cult than expected,” he muttered and slowly opened his eyes.

It was as he said.

The purpose of this was to weaken the two forces simultaneously by pitting them against each other.

However, the number of demonic soldiers lost was too small.

There was also damage to the sects, but not as much as expected.

It was because many of the Taoist factions as well as the Great Jegal Clan had refused to get involved. If their power remained intact, the large forces of the Orthodox Murim would pose a big problem for the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

Even more problematic was the power of the Demonic Cult.

The power of the Demonic Cult had been less affected than the Orthodox factions.

“Huh, even though six provinces were captured, the damage to the Demonic Army is only 5,000.”

5,000 soldiers.

That was a number that would make rivers out of blood and mountains out of corpses. But Jwa Do-gyul was saying that was too few.

That was because 5,000 men was nothing compared to the full size of the Demonic Army.

Too little damage.

This was not good. It would not fulfill the orders given by the Inverted Sky, so his position inside the Inverted Sky would also weaken.

I can't have that.

Jwa Do-gyul closed his eyes again.

He thought about his relationship with the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

He had no memories from childhood.

His first memory was the time spent with an old teacher inside a thatched house, aided by a dying candle.

His teacher used to beat him harshly.

He told Jwa Do-gyul that he had to save the sect.

The boy had to find his teacher food everyday and was beaten if he failed to do so.

The boy had to learn martial arts, and on the days he failed to do so, he was beaten.

That did not mean the teacher was an excellent martial artist.

At best, he was second-rate.

One day, after enduring severe abuse, Jwa Do-gyul killed his teacher.

He stabbed and stabbed the sleeping man in the heart.

It was not difficult to kill a second-rate martial artist, especially when they were passed out drunk. It was also because the man did not imagine Jwa Do-gyul would kill him.

Jwa Do-gyul was fifteen then.

After that, he ventured into the world and did what he had to do.

What could a martial artist, who killed his own master, do with a sword?

Sell his skills, earn a day's worth, eat and live another day. Soaking his feet in danger, not knowing when he would die.

It was almost romantic.

He lived like that until he met the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

The Inverted Sky gave him elixirs and freedom. They did not hesitate to falsify rumors if need be.

And so Jwa Do-gyul's power and reputation sky-rocketed. Suddenly, he became a lord of Murim and could not live without the support of the Inverted Sky.

I will be abandoned by the Cult if I continue like this.

Jwa Do-gyul shook his head.

To the Cult of the Inverted Sky, he was a consumable. Annoying if he disappeared, but replaceable.

Many of the masters of Murim, like Jwa Do-gyul, were supported by the Inverted Sky and addicted to it.

Thus, in order not to be thrown out, Jwa Do-gyul had to constantly prove his worth.

In this case, too.

I can't help it.

To prove his worth, he needed to greatly weaken the power of the Demonic Cult.

A method of weakening the power... Was there any other way?

We have no choice but to capture the maximum power of the Cult.

Jwa Do-gyul's lips curled.

The Heavenly Demon.

Defeating the Heavenly Demon would be the most shocking way to take down the entire Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The founder of the Martial Alliance was also a member of the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

The Martial Alliance.

That was the place which would be used as the Heavenly Demon's grave.

The Martial Alliance will disappear with the Heavenly Demon.

He tapped on the armrest, contemplating his plans. It was as if there was something there.

To do that, I must first create an atmosphere for the resolution. I cannot let the Heavenly Demon think it is a trap.

There was a good thing for that purpose.

A pouch sent from the Cult a while ago. The powder in it would create the atmosphere he wanted.

Thinking up to this point, Jwa Do-gyul tilted his head back and laughed like a lunatic.

He shook his head after a few moments, sobering.

But what are the other Taoists and the Five Sword Sects doing?

“This is no easy task...”

The ‘Mysterious Old Man’ sighed deeply.

‘Venerable Dragon’ Jegal Sung sat across from him.

“That is all I have. I have gathered information, but I don’t have enough.”

Jegal Sung sighed.

Concurrent with the war between Woon-seong and the Martial Alliance, the Justice Alliance was preparing something big.

They had gathered information about people in the Martial Alliance, the Imperial Court, and the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

Jegal Sung shook his head as if apologetic. *Information is lacking.*

In order to obtain justification for the enactment of justice, it was first necessary to prove that the current Martial Alliance was unfit, but there was very little evidence.

“It’s only Jwa Do-gyul.”

The Sage said and Jegal Sung nodded.

“Perhaps that vile bastard left some evidence.”

“We must find it...”

It wouldn't be easy. Perhaps the evidence was deep inside the Alliance, somewhere only Jwa Do-gyul knew.

"In the end, what the Justice Alliance needs is to find it."

"King Jinseong feels no different."

Jegal Sung sighed again. *I feel like I have been sighing too much recently.*

They also briefly mentioned Mount Hua, Shaolin, and the Five Sword Sects. But after some discussion, there was nothing much to do.

"I should send word to the Cult Leader."

"We should tell him not to kill Jwa Do-gyul, but to capture him alive and grab the tail of the Cult of the Inverted Sky."

"Is it too much of a burden on the Cult Leader...?"

Jegal Sung sighed again.

"I don't know. It just happened to be this way."

Obviously, he could not deny that he had been sighing a lot lately.

And that evening, from the dwelling of Jegal Sung, a messenger bird flew across the night sky.

Flip—

"Hmph."

Woon-seong opened the message sent to him and snorted.

Fwoom—

A flame rose from his hands and burnt the letter.

Black ash fell to the ground.

Woon-seong muttered briefly after reading it, “These guys don’t know Jwa Do-gyul.”

Sang Gwan-chuk tilted his head and asked, “Was there something offensive in the message?”

Woon-seong shook his head. “No, no.”

Even as he said that, he was already thinking of Jwa Do-gyul. Evidence to connect Jwa Do-gyul, the Martial Alliance, the Imperial Court, and the Cult of the Inverted Sky...

If it was Jwa Do-gyul, the man would have prepared for many situations since they would be his lifeline at any moment.

But to keep Jwa Do-gyul alive in order to find one?

I cannot agree.

Woon-seong shook his head lightly.

We don’t need him alive to find these strings.

There were other ways to find them.

Woon-seong came up with an idea and smiled. He asked the Strategist, “What is public opinion like in the Martial Alliance?”

The Martial Alliance had already been defeated by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon in Guizhou and Chongqing. If he thought about it normally, it would make sense for their spirits to hit rock bottom.

But the Strategists’ words were completely out of common sense.

“There is a calling for war.”

“For war?” Woon-seong eyes trembled.

Sang Gwan-chuk said, “When the Martial Alliance loses, they incite the rest of Murim to fight. It seems like the Martial Alliance is leading the charge.”

“The Lord of the Alliance is indeed an inciter. Looks like the rest of Murim seems to work well as sheep.”

Woon-seong clicked his tongue.

“In the end, we are going to hold an all-out war with the Martial Alliance. But no matter the call for either side, is there a way to change the resolution?”

Sang Gwan-chuk also wondered, but shook his head. “Actually, that was a concern.”

“You have your doubts.”

Sang Gwan-chuk grunted.

“Actually...”

[1] Chinese opera, specifically Sichuan opera, is known for its actors changing masks/emotions (bian lian, or ‘face-changing’)

Chapter 184: Sword At The Enemy'S Chin (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 184 – Sword at the Enemy's Chin (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“How is everyone so stupid?!”

At the heart of the Martial Alliance, a man burst in fury.

The man's name was Kang Sook. He was one of the many elders of Murim, but was usually called the ‘Iron Swordsman’ rather than his name.

He always said what he wanted with a stiff face, but now his expression was twitching. That wasn't enough so he raised his voice.

An Iron Swordsman like this appeared once or twice every few years.

And the reason?

The poor decisions made by executives of the Martial Alliance.

“How can you change your opinions as easily as flipping a hand?”

Boom!

He hit the table in front of him.

Currently, the Martial Alliance was divided into two factions and had a sharp confrontation.

It was because of something a few days ago.

Among them, the faction that belonged to the Iron Swordsman supported not a decisive battle, but recommended retreating and rearranging their ranks.

A few days ago, the Lord of the Alliance secretly summoned members of the opposing faction. Since then, anyone who spoke with the Lord of the Alliance changed their opinions.

“You are all fools. Why do you not understand that fighting the Demonic Cult like this means annihilation?!”

Kang Sook was red with anger.

It was then that he felt someone’s presence at the entrance of his room.

“Who is it?” the man shouted.

“The Lord is looking for the Elder.”

The moment he heard that, the Iron Swordsman clenched his fists and thought: *Finally, it’s my turn.*

And he pledged that he would not change his mind so easily like everyone else.

Once Kang Sook reached the office located at the very center, he swallowed. *The office of the Lord.*

Then, once again, he mentally prepared himself.

If there was an all-out battle, the Martial Alliance would definitely lose.

If the Martial Alliance was defeated, Murim’s morale would fall through the floor.

I must stop that with my own hands.

After checking his resolution, he approached the office.

“Lord, I heard that you called for me.”

As Kang Sook walked closer, he could hear the voice of the Lord.

“Oh, Elder Kang. Come in.”

He opened the sliding door, which revealed the interior.

Kang Sook stepped inside.

No, he hesitated before stepping inside.

An unusual scent tickled his nose.

Hibiscus incense?

It was the scent of hibiscus blossoms blooming in water.

As Kang Sook stepped inside, the scent disappeared and Jwa Do-gyul turned towards the man.

“Are you going to stand and talk? Please come in and have a seat.”

At that, Kang Sook nodded and put his thoughts about the incense away.

Looking at the man, Jwa Do-gyul smiled faintly.

And the next day, ‘Iron Swordsman’ Kang Sook shouted around the Martial Alliance.

“I’m sure there is something suspicious going on.”

Woon-seong listened to Sang Gwan-chuk's reports and nodded in agreement.

It was not unusual for a person had changed his opinion.

But just one meeting turned your opinion on a critical issue related to the Martial Alliance's destiny?

That was definitely suspicious.

Closing his eyes, his eyebrows twitched. It was clear that it had something to do with Jwa Do-gyul, but he wasn't sure what it was.

The effects were clear, but there was no physical evidence.

I look like a man of justice now.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly.

"Let us continue our investigation into that first. And if anything comes up, report it to me immediately."

"Understood."

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon continued to move.

Following Qinghai and Gansu, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon reached Sichuan, Chongqing, and Guizhou.

The other parts of the army also advanced and joined the Western Forces.

With two parts gathering in one place, the forces of the Demonic Army reached 20,000.

Since there were about 7,000 men in the Martial Alliance who claimed for a decisive battle, the Demonic Army had about 3 times as many people.

Moreover, the power of the Demonic Cult was not limited to only that.

After the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon had been sent back to the headquarters for care, another Demonic Master, the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign, had joined to fill that position.

“Hail the Heavenly Demon, the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign greets you.”

She was the only woman ranked in the Ten Demonic Masters, making her a dragon amongst men but a lotus flower amongst dragons.

The Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign was a middle-aged beauty reminiscent of a lotus flower. She exuded an irresistible glamor, emphasizing her youthful looks.

Woon-seong nodded at her. “You realize how important your mission is, right?”

The Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign nodded softly. “I understand that this is on behalf of the Demonic Teacher. I will do my best not to disappoint you.”

Woon-seong nodded. He then slowly stood up from his seat to address the other demons.

“I do not know what the numbers are, but right now, the Martial Alliance is united and insists on an all-out war. The way they talk, it is as if they have become immortal.”

The faces of the demons gathered hardened.

“Do not forget one thing. This is a war of vengeance and also a memorial service to avenge the former Cult Leader who died in their vile plot.”

At his words, Cheon Ah-young clenched her fists.

It was not just Cheon Ah-young. All of the executives gathered focused.

Woon-seong spoke, as if proclaiming, “I will not tolerate defeat.”

At his words, the demons all knelt and shouted,

“Hail the Heavenly Demon!”

It was often said that the headquarters of the Martial Alliance was in Wuhan.

Strictly speaking, the headquarters was only near Wuhan, not inside the City of Three Garrisons.

A wide plain near Wuhan, about a day’s travel away. That was where the Martial Alliance’s headquarters were truly located.

Why was it there?

If they were inside the city, they would be able to attract more people. Why were they located on an empty plain?

There were two answers to that question.

The first was the size of the Martial Alliance.

300 meters wide.

300 meters long.

What were those? Those were the measurements of the wall surrounding the outside of the Alliance building.

There was no plot of land within the city that could house such a massive structure.

Even if there was, it would only be possible by destroying the surrounding buildings.

For this reason, the Martial Alliance was established a little outside Wuhan.

Of course, with the wealth and power of the Martial Alliance, it was not impossible to buy land and buildings nearby and destroy them.

Yet, there was another reason the Martial Alliance was outside of the city.

The second reason...

It was the Imperial Court.

Although the Imperial Court had now been handed over to the Cult of the Inverted Sky, it had not been so when the Martial Alliance first appeared.

At that time, the emperor objected to the establishment of the Martial Alliance within the Wuhan city confines.

Imperial power and Murim were supposed to stay strictly apart, but the imperial family had been involved in the establishment of the Martial Alliance.

The reason for this was that if fighting in Murim took place, the damage would affect the common people if the Alliance was within the city.

And since this was reasonable, the founders established the Martial Alliance away from Wuhan.

And it was on these very plains that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon stepped.

“I see the Martial Alliance.”

Woon-seong looked forward, standing at the forefront of the army.

He had visited the Martial Alliance a very long time ago, with Nok Yu-on.

Was there no iron at the time?

Or was it because he had been young?

The Martial Alliance’s building was not — had not been — very cool.

He used to think that it was a place full of heroes and righteous men.

There were few righteous men in the Martial Alliance.

It was like they were laughing at the sympathetic heart of a young Hyuk Woon-seong...

Woon-seong gripped the White Night Spear.

There was still distance from the Martial Alliance, but it was short for a Semi-Divine Being.

Jwa Do-gyul is inside the Martial Alliance.

There was an enemy here.

How long had it taken to get here?

It was said that vengeance for a soldier might take ten years, but Woon-seong was not a man worthy of being called a soldier.

The past ten years had truly been a journey.

But after all those years, he now had the opportunity to strike the head of the enemy.

Woon-seong slowly collected his energy.

His energy was pulled from the dantian, circulating through his limbs and flowing into the White Night Spear.

The heart prompts the qi, the qi prompts the heart.

The heart is the mind, the breath, and the conviction.

Woon-seong's heart was cold fury and the long-standing venom of a viper. So, the energy that flowed into the White Night Spear was also cold anger and enduring poison.

Whoa, whoa, whoa.

As if it were reacting, the White Night Spear trembled.

At the same time, Woon-seong's eyes turned molten gold.

A gray fog seemed to surround him, fluttering in the wind.

Not only that.

Glug-ug-

A flame broke out across Woon-seong's entire body.

“Oh!”

“Woah!”

Each of the demonic practitioners widened their eyes because of the appearance of the Divine Flame.

In the meantime, the distance between the Martial Alliance and the Cult of the Heavenly Demon continued to close.

Blah, blah.

The flames around Woon-seong surged and the ground split apart.

There were vivid traces, like spiderwebs, where Woon-seong stepped.

Perhaps the members of the Martial Alliance were also watching.

They would see Woon-seong enshrouded in Intimidation Qi, wielding the Divine Flame, and radiating massive waves of fury.

What would they think watching this?

Do you feel fear?

Woon-seong thought of Jwa Do-gyul. Would he be afraid?

It doesn't matter.

Not holding the White Night Spear, Woon-seong raised his empty hand slowly.

I will make you feel it soon.

His arm fell and pointed at the front door of the Martial Alliance.

In that position, his voice was low but clear.

“Let’s go!”

These words reached the demonic practitioners gathered.

The demons holding the drums pounded the drums.

Boom-boom—

Along with the sound of the drums, the Demonic Emperor’s Roaring Laughter cracked open the skies.

Hehehehehehehehehe!

Chapter 185: I've Missed You (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 185 – I've Missed You (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Occasionally, very rarely, there are certain things...

Things that you would rather see broken than intact. Or things that you want to see completely destroyed, shattered beyond recognition.

It bothers me.

For Woon-seong, it was the wall around the Martial Alliance.

300 meters across, 300 meters long.

The stone wall was even dozens of meters in height.

It was a stone wall he had longed to break down. Woon-seong clenched his fists, as if he finally had the chance to fulfill his dream.

Woon-seong's shoulders hooked backwards for a moment, like he was loading something up.

At the same time, a vortex formed around his fist.

The Divine Flame twisted through the vortex, tendrils of flame igniting the air around it.

“Huff!”

Knocked over by the wind, a nearby demonic practitioner stumbled back and gasped for breath. Was the Divine Flame consuming all the air around it?

No, it was not.

The vortex was drawing in all the air.

So the surrounding air disappeared.

The sand dust on the floor rose and swirled, sucked into Woon-seong’s fist.

Stone pieces, leaves, branches — there was no need to distinguish. Everything was sucked into his palms, like the whole world was contained within his fist!

Woon-seong punched forward.

Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon – Heavenly Demon’s Divine Fist (天魔神拳)!

At least, everyone watching thought it was so.

The Divine Fist of the Heavenly Demon would indeed look like so.

But Woon-seong shook his head quietly.

His lips curled as he remembered the name he had given this move.

“Annihilation in a Thousand Battles.”

Just like the name of the move, a feast of a thousand blows that brought about destruction, concentrating all of the strength into a single point!

A great disaster swept the earth.

The ground was stripped of its husk.

Kuakuakua—

A chunk of rock rose, the earth crumbled, boulders split apart.

A huge furrow was dug into the ground. One giant trail of destruction!

“Ahh! Aah!”

“No, stop!”

There were frantic screams from beyond the walls.

As soon as they heard a sound, a few martial artists flew into the air. Then, each one of them surrounded in a splendid light and weapons ready, blocked the oncoming apocalypse.

No matter how powerful the blow may be, they had to stop it here. It may be difficult alone, but if they worked together, it was possible!

They seemed to think that, at least.

“Hiya!”

“Chaaaaaaa, Steel Wall Sword!”

Some people swung in silence, others called out the names of their moves.

Kung—

There were some people who somersaulted over the walls with a seriousness. From the perspective of the Martial Alliance, they might have looked like heroes.

Like moths to a flame.

But to Woon-seong, they were like moths rushing towards their deaths.

Kuakuakua—

“Cough!”

“Huff-puff!”

The destruction devoured them all.

The force remained unaffected and advanced forward.

Kwarneeee—

The moment the apocalypse finally hit the walls of the Martial Alliance, the whole world seemed to be set ablaze!

Rrrrrrrr!

The ground shook violently.

White light covered the world.

Then came pure darkness; light was extinct.

Only Woon-seong remained, staring at the Martial Alliance.

The earth peeled off its crust, the earth collapsed in an explosion, and the earth burned with heat.

Kwaaaaaa—

When the light and darkness which had destroyed the world finally disappeared, the people gathered there could see how devastating a single move could be.

There was a clear trace of lava flowing through the earth. At the end, along with marks of explosions, one side of the wall had completely collapsed.

There were enormous holes in the earth, large enough to fit hundreds of people inside.

Beyond that were the remains of the bodies of martial artists defending the Martial Alliance strewn throughout the landscape.

Seeing that, one of the demonic practitioners muttered, “What in the... Heaven Annihilation?”

When Woon-seong heard that, he laughed. “I guess it is similar.”

As the man said, Woon-seong had included ‘Millenia of Heaven Annihilation’ in that move just now.

Of course, that wasn’t the only skill.

To control the landscape, he had added in ‘Flow of the Divine Dragon’ and other moves, taking the trouble to mix them all together and turn them into something new.

This move could be considered complete.

Currently, it was also the most ferocious technique that Woon-seong could use.

But there is still a long way to go.

Woon-seong repeatedly clenched and unclenched his fists.

Meanwhile, Sang Gwan-chuk walked by his side. “The way has been opened. I am going in.”

Woon-seong nodded.

“From now on, the Martial Alliance is a battlefield.”

The war between the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and Orthodox Murim had reached the headquarters of the Martial Alliance.

It was the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign that entered right after Woon-seong.

As she waved her arms, there was the sound of bells.

Ting, ting, ting.

At the sound of these bells, a beautiful poem began to flow from her mouth.

“The moon above the Han Palace and the land of Qin, sheds a flood of silvery light, bidding the radiant lady farewell.

She sets out on the road to the Jade Gate, a road she will not travel back.

The moon above the Han Palace rises from the eastern seas, but the radiant lady wed in the west will return nevermore.”

...

‘Wang Zhaojun’. [1]

A poem about the legendary beauty Mingfei (‘radiant lady’), who played such beautiful music that even geese forgot to flap their wings.

It was actually a sorrowful poem that sang to Wang Zhaojun’s heart.

The Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign’s voice was beautiful, but her poem wasn’t just emotional.

Her bells continued to sway and energy built up in the air. This energy began to fluctuate, coagulating into the shape of swords.

According to her voice, the strength of the swords would flutter.

Shua, shua.

The powerful swords flew through the air, destroying enemies.

The number of qi swords was currently three.

Each of the swords danced beautifully amongst the enemies, as if dancing to the tune of the poem.

Shua, shua.

Blood spilled and splattered.

At this moment, the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign was very concerned about the results of the battle.

The reason for that was because this was the first time that she would be showing her skills in front of the Heavenly Demon since being named among the Ten Demonic Masters.

As long as she could catch Woon-seong's eyes, there was no reason to consider herself at the bottom of the Demonic Masters.

I can be at the top of the Demonic Masters.

The Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign sang more powerfully, the dancing of her swords becoming more intense.

“Phew.”

Woon-seong breathed for a moment and regained his strength. The destruction had consumed just as much inner qi as the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon, so it would need time to refill.

While restoring his strength, he looked over at the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign's fight.

“Not bad.”

Sang Gwan-chuk nodded his head. “She is still lacking, but she can handle being a Demonic Master.”

Sang Gwan-chuk moved his pens without rest. Every time he moved, the Blood Demon Hell Drawing would open up and blood would flow.

“She would be the strongest woman in the Cult.”

“After her would be the Divine Maiden.”

Woon-seong nodded and found her in the battlefield.

Cheon Ah-young was swinging her sword vigorously, as if she had forgotten all of her heartache from the previous day.

Her swordsmanship, in harmony with her divine powers, was a marvel that Zhongyuan had never experienced before.

But you still don't have a solid grasp of the martial arts.

If it could be supplemented, Cheon Ah-young's martial arts could enter a completely different state, well beyond the boundaries of divination and swordsmanship.

There was only possibility.

Woon-seong shook his head.

There is no correct answer.

In the history of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, which spanned nearly a thousand years, had there been another Divine Maiden who practiced both divine powers and martial arts?

Probably not.

In that sense, Cheon Ah-young, who mastered both of them, was already heading towards a path of unpredictability.

A path entirely your own.

Woon-seong turned his gaze slightly to the side. Most of his strength consumed by the power of destruction had been restored.

When he turned, he could see Gwan Tae-ryang fighting with one of the 72 Supreme Masters.

In the Cave of Latent Demons, that man's pure talent had been ranked at the very top. Even now, other than Woon-seong and Cheon Ah-young, he was

still the best among the graduates of the Cave.

If he continued forward without arrogance, he would one day make a name for himself amongst the ranks of Demonic Master.

If so, he would be able to engrave his name in the history of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Woon-seong noticed Sa Ryong-hui next to Gwan Tae-ryang. The man was busy fighting against a swordsman.

The opponent crackled with blue lightning and screamed, “You filthy traitor! Even the leader of the New Dragon Battalion has become a dog of the Demonic Cult. Shame on you!”

Sa Ryong-hui flinched. The word ‘traitor’ caused him to freeze.

Seeing his hesitation, the opponent pressed forward. “Are you not ashamed, you traitorous dog of the Cult?!”

“That’s not true!”

“How is it not? Everyone in the world knows you’re a traitor!”

“I-I...”

Thanks to this, the balance that had been maintained was broken and Sa Ryong-hui was pushed to the defensive.

A frenzied storm of blue lightning blazed past his body. A sword slashed his side, creating a wound.

Sa Ryong-hui’s expression hardened.

At that moment, Woon-seong moved his hand.

Fwoom!

The Divine Flame wrapped around his finger and shot straight. It was an ultra-heat method reminiscent of the Shaolin finger styles, except it originated from the Heavenly Demon.

The Divine Flame bounced off the sword which had been attacking Sa Ryong-hui, knocking it away.

“Grrrgh!” the man pulled back.

Woon-seong’s voice seeped into the confused mind of Sa Ryong-hui.

— *“Do not be deceived. He is out of his mind.”*

Sa Ryong-hui raised his head. If the man was out of his mind, then he was spouting nonsense.

As if to answer Sa Ryong-hui’s unspoken question, Woon-seong continued to speak.

— *“Look at his eyes. Do not be deceived by what he says and look properly at the human being himself.”*

Sa Ryong-hui looked into the man’s eyes, searching for something.

“Can’t you tell? His eyes are vacant.”

Meanwhile, Woon-seong had moved closer to Sa Ryong-hui.

“This man’s name is Mang Bo-gan. He was originally one of the people in the Martial Alliance who insisted that the factions retreat and regroup.”

And just like Woon-seong said, the man’s eyes really did look empty.

[1] excerpt from “Wang Zhaojun” by the poet Li Bai; Wang Zhaojun was one of the Four Great Beauties of Ancient China

Original Poem: 漢家秦地月，流影照明妃。一上玉關道，天涯去不歸。漢月還從東海出，明妃西嫁無來日。燕支長寒雪作花，蛾眉憔悴沒胡沙。生乏黃金枉圖畫，死留青塚使人嗟。

Chapter 186: I've Missed You (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 186 – I've Missed You (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“But his opinion flipped the next day, right after a meeting with the Lord of the Martial Alliance. Why is that?”

“That’s true, but...”

Sa Ryong-hui tried to say that the man could have been persuaded. However, it was hard to say that when the man’s consciousness looked so hazy.

Woon-seong smiled. “One or two people might have been persuaded. But if all of those in opposition to war changed their mind after meetings with the Lord of the Alliance, can that still be considered persuasion?”

The word ‘persuasion’ made Sa Ryong-hui twitch.

Woon-seong told him, “So, do not be deceived. Murim is already rotten.”

Sa Ryong-hui nodded and turned towards his opponent again.

A short conversation with Woon-seong seemed to cause his doubts to subside. There was no longer hesitation in his steps.

After confirming this, Woon-seong turned and approached Sang Gwan-chuk. He had already recovered enough.

“I will leave the battlefield to you.”

Sang Gwan-chuk swung his pen to form a block character in the air, splitting an enemy’s body vertically.

“Where are you going?”

“To catch the Lord of the Martial Alliance.”

Woon-seong’s fangs glinted as he spoke. The man was probably lurking somewhere.

The Strategist politely bowed his head. “I will clear a path.”

“No, I will go alone.”

Sang Gwan-chuk was startled. “But...”

He tried to say no, but Woon-seong cut him off.

“Do you not trust me?”

The Strategist shook his head. *It is not that I do not trust you, but that I am worried for you.*

Of course, Woon-seong understood.

But even so, he could not take the Strategist or any other demonic practitioners with him to see Jwa Do-gyul.

He might say some things about himself and his secrets when he got emotional during the exchange with Jwa Do-gyul.

“I leave the battlefield to you,” Woon-seong repeated before leaping away.

As Woon-seong entered the inner quarters of the Martial Alliance, Sang Gwan-chuk watched his back for a long time.

As he flew through the air, Woon-seong looked around. With the eyes of a hawk, he scanned the battlefield.

Was it because of the overwhelming number of demonic practitioners?

The fighting had almost entered the interior.

Of course, this was not without damage to the Demonic Army.

The remaining soldiers of the Martial Alliance also knew that all would be lost if they were pushed any further back. That was why they grit their teeth and stood their ground.

Not only were the Orthodox outnumbered, but they could not stop believers in the Heavenly Demon with some other religious calling.

It is only a matter of time before they are inside.

The problem was after entering the inner parts of the Alliance.

The Martial Alliance was built in expansions as it grew in size.

That meant that virtually all important institutions or offices were located in the inner regions.

Perhaps it would be the same for the traps and hidden weapons.

Woon-seong looked around as he entered the Alliance.

I wish I had more experience with dismantling traps and illusions.

Woon-seong smiled bitterly, standing on a wall that separated the inner and outer courts. If he had some device, he could easily smash all the traps before they were triggered by soldiers later.

It was a pity.

But even though it was a pity, Woon-seong had other things to do.

Jwa Do-gyul.

Woon-seong gripped the White Night Spear and flew into the Martial Alliance.

I'm here for your head, asshole!

Woon-seong flew into the compound like a meteor.

Kuakuakua—

Waves of energy spread out around him.

Surprised by his appearance, the martial artists of Murim ran about shouting.

“The Demonic Cult is inside!”

“The Demonic Cult has entered the Alliance. Stop him!”

Dust churned around Woon-seong feet as he landed; an arm protruded out from the storm.

Woon-seong grabbed the hand of a soldier and pulled.

“Aah!”

Screaming, the man was ground through the sand and dust, and soon stopped screaming.

The dust cleared.

There was a black clothed man of the Demonic Cult and a soldier of the Orthodox, whose head had been ripped off.

The Demon's eyes glittered with specks of gold, like a precious gem.

The surrounding soldiers looked at the black robes and suddenly deduced the man's identity.

“Cult Leader!”

“Stay back!”

There was fear in those voices.

It was because since childhood, they had been taught that the Heavenly Demon was the Orthodox's nightmare.

Woon-seong shuffled where he landed, taking in their fear with a glance. He slowly walked out of the pit he made when he landed.

As he emerged, the soldiers stepped back.

The ranks surrounding him had opened.

Of course, not all of the warriors parted.

“Heavenly Demon, you've come to die!”

“I will use this place as your grave today!”

Several soldiers grabbed their swords and blocked Woon-seong's path ahead.

Even if he's the Heavenly Demon!

Stabbing you with a sword will kill you, and fighting will tire you out!

Woon-seong turned slightly to glance at them. He then began to map out the structure of the inner courtyard. Since he had last visited so long ago, nothing came to mind clearly.

It really had been a while.

He motioned with his head, “Is the Lord's office that way?”

The soldiers trembled at the question.

“You’re going after the Lord!” several shouted and hurriedly moved. They blocked where Woon-seong’s gaze was directed.

Woon-seong smiled and nodded. “I guess I was right.”

Perhaps they realized that Woon-seong wasn’t taking them very seriously. The soldiers’ faces turned red with fury.

One of them yelled, “How dare you talk about us—”

“Waaaahhhh!”

Before the man could finish, the border walls between the inner and outer Alliance fell.

At the same time, the Demonic Army poured inside.

Immediately, as with outside, the inside of the Alliance was soon entangled into battle.

There was fighting everywhere.

The sound of metal colliding with metal rang in his ears.

The Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign sang and slashed her enemies, the Senior Strategist wielded his pens, surrounded by a bloodbath. The Eight Bolt Blade King was using his field of lightning to push the Orthodox soldiers away.

Of course, it was not as if there were no masters in the Alliance. It was just that without many of the Taoist factions, all five Sword Sects, or the Great Jegal Family, there were not that many left behind.

It was an insufficient number at Absolution to stop the Demonic Masters.

Woon-seong listened to the sounds and spoke to the men before him, “Will you stop me?”

“Hmph, if we stop you here, there won’t be any more damage!”

“We will stop you even if we die!”

As they shouted, Woon-seong grabbed the White Night Spear.

“Alright. In that case...”

The White Night Spear was like the sickle of the god of death.

“I will kill you.”

Woon-seong began to rampage.

Who could deal with Woon-seong like this?

Five of the 72 Supreme Masters had partnered up against Woon-seong, but only held their ground for a few moments.

The spear swept across the land.

A river of wind and a wave of energy crashed across the area.

Pshhh-pshhh.

The ground was shattered as the waves emanated from Woon-seong. There were deep and long furrows left in the places where the spear had crossed.

A huge beam of light rose and the whole area collapsed.

Kwaarnee-

The ground below the soldiers who were blocking Woon-seong was crushed, either by the move or by the rubble.

“Ugh.”

Those who did not die were unable to move.

Survivors?

They were visited by Woon-seong's spear.

As the cold and foreign metal penetrated their chests, they experienced a blessing.

Of course, it was a blessing they would never be able to wake from — the cold kiss of death.

“Ahhhh, no!”

“How dare you!”

Some of the soldiers were actually still standing.

They were the ones who were barely able to rank amongst the 72 Supreme Masters, or did not reach it, but were at least someone along the path of Transcendant-Absolution.

Bang, bang.

Woon-seong collided with one of their swords.

It sounded like a bell had slammed into another bell.

Subsequently, a flame blazed to life around Woon-seong chest, coiling around both him and his opponent.

“Cough!”

“Ahhh!”

Blocking the attacks of these men did not stop Woon-seong's advances.

Heart of the Alliance.

After sweeping the warriors away, Woon-seong quietly entered the heart of the Alliance alone.

Several more men rushed at him.

“Die!”

“How dare you!”

Woon-seong’s White Night Spear snapped into his hands.

One small movement cut off the rushing soldiers.

One move slashed through their weapons, the second through their necks.

The White Night Spear crackled with light, and at that moment, a destroyed world was reflected in the eyes of the warriors.

“Cough!”

“Cough!”

Blood flowed.

Woon-seong passed through their blood and corpses, the piles and puddles only increasing as he moved.

Of course, just because he was in a hallway did not mean that no one rushed at him.

Woon-seong cut them down in succession, expression unchanging.

Clang—

Shua—

Immediately, the hallway was riddled with corpses. There was blood everywhere.

Thunk—

Woon-seong crossed through all of that and entered the depths of the Martial Alliance, opening a door.

There, he noticed a tall man laying deep in the chair.

It had been a little over a decade, but this man's face had barely aged.

It was a face he had pictured every day in thoughts of revenge.

Was it because these feelings had been inside him for so long?

Woon-seong felt his boiling blood freezing like ice.

Instead of excitement, momentum as sharp as an awl surrounded his body.

The air quickly cooled, like winds from the North Sea had rushed in.

This energy quickly wrapped around the body of Jwa Do-gyul.

“You...”

The air around seemed to press down like wet cotton.

Meanwhile, Woon-seong spoke to Jwa Do-gyul:

“I've missed you so much.”

Even Woon-seong found that unexpected.

Never thought I'd tell Jwa Do-gyul I missed him.

But it was not a lie.

The words were filled with wrath and years of venom.

“Jwa Do-gyul.”

The man could not have understood this hatred. Nevertheless, he smiled.

A smile that seemed to be hiding something.

Woon-seong seemed to freeze at this unknown smile.

“I’ve missed *you* so much, Cult Leader.”

At that moment,

Click—

The earth seemed to tilt on its axis as a massive storm shook the area.

Kuakuakuakua—

Chapter 187: A Fight Between Semi-Divine Beings (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 187 – A Fight Between Semi-Divine Beings (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The roar swept through the battlefield.

At the same time, huge flames rose.

A huge fireball burned all the Orthodox martial artists gathered in one place.

“Ahhhh!”

“My arm, my arm is on fire! ”

“Water, water! ”

“My back is on fire! ”

“Roll on the floor and put out the fire! ”

Demons and Orthodox soldiers alike stopped swinging their weapons. They looked around at the flames everywhere.

“Why is there so much fire...?”

“Were there mines?!”

That was exactly it.

The moment Woon-seong had entered the Alliance, when Jwa Do-gyul confirmed that the demonic soldiers had gone deep enough, he had triggered the process and detonated the buried landmines.

Moreover, they were not ordinary landmines.

They were Steel Lightning Mines, made by a legendary explosive manufacturer.

These landmines, which would explode with lightning, were powerful weapons whose destructive power was not reproducible by modern weapons.

Hundreds of them exploded in unison. What a sight!

It was natural for the situation to go into disarray.

Watching on, Sang Gwan-chuk turned his head with a worried look.

The place his gaze was directed was the place where the loudest sound had originated.

“My Lord!”

Kuang—

At that moment, a huge flame, incomparable to before, soared into the air. Like the sound, the color was also different from that of real lightning.

Fwoom—

Dark and gray flames soared high like pillars holding up the sky.

The device which exploded the Steel Lightning Landmines, while also triggering all the other traps and illusions, had been under the armrest of the

chair Jwa Do-gyul was sitting in. He had kept his finger there and the moment the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon walked inside, he had pressed down.

As soon as the devices were activated, Jwa Do-gyul moved.

To kill the Heavenly Demon?

No, that was not it.

The moment the traps were activated, the first thing to collapse would be the building. Jwa Do-gyul did not want to die with the Cult Leader, buried under the rubble of a crumbling building.

So he chose to flee.

Crack—

Jwa Do-gyul slammed into the wall behind him. But that was not enough; he kept running.

A few moments later, he saw the Martial Alliance's main building falling.

Looking at it, Jwa Do-gyul smiled faintly.

“Hehehe.”

As the building was collapsing, hundreds of arrows installed inside the walls would have flown towards the Heavenly Demon.

If Jwa Do-gyul was lucky, that would kill the Heavenly Demon. Even a master at the realm of Semi-Divinity could panic, get hurt, and then die.

And if he was unlucky?

If he was unlucky, then the collapse might just slightly wound the Heavenly Demon.

But that didn't matter because he already had plans in place.

His eyes darted around.

The battlefield was a wasteland.

Other traps and illusions had kicked in after the landmines did their part. If the illusions worked as intended, they would conceal the enemy, then lead allies to attack each other.

One way or another, it would work out.

Enemies were thrown into these traps, without distinguishing between Alliance soldiers or Demonic soldiers.

From the beginning, Jwa Do-gyul's goal was to hit the Demonic and damage both forces, not protect the Orthodox forces.

Protect the Orthodox forces, that's funny, Jwa Do-gyul mocked and scorned, looking at the mess.

He then patted his pockets.

What he took out was a small, black flute.

Called the Insanity-Inducing Black Flute, it was a flute specially made to give orders to those with half-dead.

Jwa Do-gyul filled his heart with commands and powerfully blew into the Insanity-Inducing Black Flute.

Fwoo-oo-oo~

A sound that humans could not hear spread throughout the battlefield.

Soon, a puppet would hear this and come to stand beside Jwa Do-gyul.

Jwa Do-gyul's lips curled.

Even if he is the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, he will not be able to handle two Semi-Divine Puppets.

In addition, the two Semi-Divine puppets called on by Jwa Do-gyul had their powers raised.

Semi-Divine Beings whose powers had been increased by 80%.

That was why Jwa Do-gyul was confident in predicting the Heavenly Demon's death.

At that moment!

Kwawang—

An even larger flame than before enveloped the ruins.

The flames encircled the ruins and soared into the sky, becoming massive pillars of flame.

The rubble from the collapsed building was also pushed into the air by the explosion.

As if swept by massive winds, the sky burst into flames as debris rained through the air.

At that moment!

Glug-ug-

Kuakuakua—

The debris rained through the sky in a shower of fire, covering the ground.

A man slowly walked out from between the pillars of flame.

“Jwa Do-gyul.”

He looked like a furious beast; Jwa Do-gyul unknowingly trembled.

Woon-seong walked out of the fire, assessing the situation. Given the magnitude of the shaking that had hit the area, something must have

happened and covered the entire battlefield.

And as he predicted, the battlefield was utterly ravaged.

Everything had mostly collapsed and people were rolling about in flames.

Some had fallen to hallucination, others struck down by traps.

It was only the highest-ranking officers and masters who remained intact.

When he saw this, Woon-seong felt deep fury.

It was not just the anger he felt towards Jwa Do-gyul for being his enemy.

Deeper anger than that.

He was infuriated by the mindless slaughter of Orthodox and Demonic soldiers.

No, technically, they were not the only ones trapped.

The Martial Alliance was not just filled with martial artists.

Some of the remaining members in the Alliance had never been trained in martial arts. There were some maids in the wreckage, a few cooks from the kitchens.

Knowing that..!

You didn't even evacuate the civilians?

Woon-seong walked out of the flames. He stared at Jwa Do-gyul.

“Jwa Do-gyul.”

He could not hide the venom in his voice. At the same time, enormous waves of energy rolled from his body.

Woon-seong did not realize this himself, but he never would have noticed the collateral damage unless he was righteous at heart.

He denied his life as a chivalrous hero, but he had a conscience deep down.

It was thanks to Nok Yu-on emphasizing the spirit of cooperation to Woon-seong.

That was why, for whatever reason, Woon-seong had both Orthodox and Demonic Arts.

Immediately, Woon-seong was filled with the strong desire to tear into Jwa Do-gyul.

Woon-seong wanted to give into to his instincts.

I want to grab that son of a bitch and rip him to shreds.

The moment Woon-seong felt that and tried to move...

Puk-

Something appeared and stabbed Woon-seong in the shoulder.

Woon-seong twitched. There was some blood dripping onto his clothes.

“You’ve arrived!”

Woon-seong could hear Jwa Do-gyul calling out in joy. But for the moment, Woon-seong stared at those who had attacked him and the blood on his robes.

The wound on his shoulder was not very serious. When he had been attacked, he had instinctively retreated.

It was bleeding, but it was just a nick.

“Corpse puppets?”

What mattered was *what* they were.

When Woon-seong said that, Jwa Do-gyul spoke as if he was doing well, “Does the Cult Leader know about them?”

The question was like a taunt.

Woon-seong swung the White Night Spear.

Boom-

Struck by a huge storm, the two corpse puppets were pushed back.

One step, when it should have been at least two.

Woon-seong’s eyes suddenly turned golden.

Stronger than the ones I fought before.

There were two of them too.

At this time, the two corpse puppets rushed towards Woon-seong.

Kuakuakua—

The moment the two struck Woon-seong like a thunderstorm, Woon-seong became a hurricane facing them.

Two storms collided.

Three draconic winds intertwined. The wind blasted in all directions.

Woo, woo.

The wind split the earth.

Boom-

At times, the buildings were crushed.

Inside the storm, Woon-seong continued to observe the enemies' qi.

Even Woon-seong could not guarantee his victory here.

Unless you find the characteristics of their martial arts and attack their weakness, there is no chance.

If not that, they were dead bodies. He should be grateful that they lacked the mind to make rational judgements or deal with unexpected situations.

Woon-seong focused his attention on one puppet at a time.

The sleek impression of one of them caught his eyes. The sword in the man's hand rushed about like a wild horse.

Rather than a sword, it was more like a crude club.

That's right.

Woon-seong had uncovered the foundation of this puppet's martial arts.

It was a horse.

A horse galloping wild. One that was unfettered in the wind, crushing enemies underfoot as it ran.

It was the symbol of freedom, of being unbounded.

But it's a pity.

Someone who had developed such an inner qi method had become like this. Woon-seong shook his head lightly once.

Meanwhile, the horse-like swordsman drew his strength and pierced through Woon-seong's defenses.

Neigh—

There was the sound of a horse neighing and strength rose from behind the man's back.

A rising river swirled behind the man like a horse's mane. At the same time, his sword, or club, seemed to become even more dull.

Kung—

Woon-seong's ankle was buried as his feet dug into the ground. It was a tremendous power hard to express in words.

There was another corpse puppet coming in from behind.

A martial art that rushed about, wielding two weapons in the shape of a sword and dagger.

This technique...

Watching the puppet, it wasn't hard for Woon-seong to figure out its foundation.

Two attacks pressed from the front and back. If he was caught by either, he would be torn away.

Shua!

Woon-seong twisted to the side. Treading carefully, he pulled his foot off the ground.

Boom—

The ground trembled. When the movement of the men aiming for him paused, Woon-seong shifted his momentum from his feet to his upper body.

His waist twisted and a typhoon-like force erupted from his upper body.

Boom-

Rough winds drove the swordsman away. There was a small gap at that moment. Taking advantage of it, Woon-seong floated into the air.

From below, the two corpse puppets chased Woon-seong into the sky.

Woon-seong looked at them, then glanced at Jwa Do-gyul. The man had fled, looking like he wanted to immediately withdraw from the battlefield.

Of course, that was only conjecture, but there was no need to deal with these corpses if the man really ran.

I have no choice but to overdo it.

Woon-seong shook his limbs, breaking off the iron bracers that trapped his body.

Boom-!

Chapter 188: A Fight Between Semi-Divine Beings (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 188 – A Fight Between Semi-Divine Beings (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The corpse puppets crashed to the ground when the iron bracers slammed into them like bullets.

Boom!

As soon as the two landed on the floor, flames and dirt filled the skies.

The Divine Flame flickered.

Glug-ug-!

Fire rained down from the skies.

The falling raindrops were actually little balls of fire. As they fell, sand and debris from the collapsed buildings swirled through the air.

It was an amazing sight for everyone.

Despite being the person who had created such an astonishing scene, Woon-seong did not relax.

No, he could not relax.

If they could have been taken down this easily, I wouldn't have needed to release the iron bracers.

Krrrrrrrrr!

At the growl, Woon-seong's grip tightened.

Something soared through the debris, arcing towards Woon-seong.

Woon-seong flipped backwards.

A dagger slammed into the ground where Woon-seong had just stood.

Fire and energy crackled in all directions, like firecrackers bursting.

“Hoo!”

Amidst the explosions, Woon-seong retreated back into the air.

It was a scene where onlookers found it hard to follow what was going on.

Boom.

Kuang—

The puppets attacked from the left and the right. Woon-seong used the White Night Spear to successfully defend. Still, their strength caused Woon-seong and the White Night Spear to be knocked back.

Boom—

Every time, Woon-seong's shoulders would tremble. He was able to disperse the shock, but not all of it.

Ugh, this is killing me.

Even if it was Woon-seong, he had to stick it out. Eventually, he gave up on fighting in the air.

Woon-seong landed on the ground, feet firm. The two corpse puppets chased after him, twisting to get a better angle.

Pow, pow, pow.

Weapons and techniques came out relentlessly.

Obviously, each of the corpse puppets were stronger than Woon-seong by themselves. Their internal qi and understanding of martial arts were also deep.

However ancient they were, especially with two of them, they were able to overpower Woon-seong.

Damn it, cursed Woon-seong.

Since there were two of them, he could not win the battle quickly.

These were probably the two mysterious monsters the Demonic Teacher and the Bolt King had met in Chongqing.

The two corpses moved without pause. Every time Woon-seong blocked their moves, the ground would collapse a little more.

The ground had been split deeply by two furrows, even though it was merely a fragment of the used strength.

This is insane.

Woon-seong had already released his iron bracers. Nevertheless, he was not able to overwhelm them. If he had continued to fight with the bracers on, perhaps he would have already lost.

The first corpse I saw was at King Jinseong's Court.

At that time, there were many crude aspects. Rather than facing a Semi-Divine Being, it felt more like an Absolute Master wielding the power of Semi-Divinity.

And the next time, what had they said?

Sword Emperor of Ice and Light.

The Sword Emperor's corpse had been much closer to perfection than the one from King Jinseong's Court, but it was still manageable. It was only a matter of time before the corpse fell, even if Woon-seong had been tired from fighting the Qingcheng.

But what about this time?

It's nothing like the Sword Emperor.

It was much more sophisticated than then. In addition, two corpse puppets had come together; as if they had somehow been connected, their strikes were precisely coordinated.

Claaang—

If Woon-seong found a gap and tried to use it, the other puppet would be in the way.

This might take a while.

Woon-seong grit his teeth.

He had even been using Intimidation Qi, but it had no effect. It was probably because the puppets weren't alive in the first place. They acted as if they did not know the feeling of fear.

If that's the case, it's better not to use Intimidation Qi.

Woon-seong stopped using it.

In the meantime, a sword came striking at his head and waist.

It took crazy control to block the swordsman's blows with the White Night Spear.

“Hoo!”

Woon-seong grit his teeth and spun. It was not just the White Night Spear that shook.

Thunk—

Woon-seong's body rolled across the ground.

Dirt swirled.

In Murim, there was a humiliating technique called Narathagon, but it was still a way to take an inevitable attack.

I didn't think I'd be so cornered.

Woon-seong could see Jwa Do-gyul laughing to the side, standing safely behind the corpse puppets.

The man's smile was wide.

I should have ripped his face off!

“Jwa Do-gyul!”

Woon-seong emitted a wave of crushing qi and swung his spear as hard as he could. A blade of qi stretched out like a whip, slamming towards Jwa Do-gyul.

If it continued, it would be able to cut Jwa Do-gyul's heart out.

No, no, no.

I hope it tears at least one arm off!

At that moment!

Peng—

Jwa Do-gyul defended himself with all his strength.

The horse-like swordsman slashed down with his sword towards Woon-seong.

Clang—

The length of the spear qi became shorter, barely missing some of Jwa Do-gyul's hair.

Fwoo—

The ground crumbled; some of the severed hair floated in the air.

“Huff,” sighed Jwa Do-gyul. If the corpse puppet had been half a breath later, it would have all been over. He felt cold sweat down his spine.

“Aaaggghhhh!”

At the same time, Woon-seong's infuriated roar broke some eardrums.

How deep must the anger be for such a piercing cry?

Jwa Do-gyul felt his palms go damp. *It will be bad if I stay here any longer.*

He had no idea why, but the leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon seemed to be burning with never before seen anger.

What if the Cult Leader ignored his own life to attack? Then Jwa Do-gyul would definitely die.

“I wanted to enjoy the glory of beheading the Heavenly Demon...”

He pictured the scene of the Heavenly Demon, bleeding out from his throat.

It was a scene where the devil cackled as it slashed the neck of a demon.

Who in Murim would not want to see that?

But Jwa Do-gyul shook his head.

“Unfortunately, I will have to give that up.”

It was a pity he would not be able to see it.

As Jwa Do-gyul moved his sight downwards, he saw the ground. Perhaps this place might have been his grave.

Who were the fools who risked their lives because of regret? If anything, Jwa Do-gyul was not such a fool.

This was good enough. At least, Jwa Do-gyul felt so.

He had done great harm to both the demonic and orthodox forces, and the Heavenly Demon would die here today.

He had completed his role. If he wanted more, that would be greed.

And Jwa Do-gyul was a person who was more obsessed with his comfort than greed for more.

“I should step back.”

Jwa Do-gyul shifted backwards, stepping slightly.

Woon-seong shouted louder, “Jwa Do-gyul!”

His voice continued to carry venom, but his physical body was blocked by the two corpse puppets and could not reach Jwa Do-gyul.

“Damn it!”

Like an explosion, he swung the spear once more, but he could not get rid of both of the puppets.

If he tried to chase Jwa Do-gyul, the two would come after him with frightening ferocity.

Like they were trying to protect Jwa Do-gyul...

This was because of the flute in Jwa Do-gyul's possession.

Woon-seong could see Jwa Do-gyul's back becoming more distant. It was obvious where he was going.

It was probably to the place where all the evidence of his partnership with the Cult of the Inverted Sky was stored.

Jwa Do-gyul continued to move further and further away.

The opportunity for vengeance is at hand. The chance to kill Jwa Do-gyul is here.

Will I have another opportunity if I miss this? How long would it take?

Ten years?

Twenty years?

Can I endure those years?

Any good person would have no choice but to feel distressed.

However!

By the time Jwa Do-gyul's figure had almost completely disappeared, Woon-seong burst into laughter.

"Hahaha."

At the same time, Woon-seong raised his hand.

Kuakuakuakua—

A beam of light, much like a weapon itself, swept across the earth in a straight line.

The golden glow and silvery sword flying through the air blasted the two corpse puppets attached to Woon-seong away.

Boom—

The corpse puppets landed on the ground.

The light and sword slowly lifted, revealing human forms.

“It was not enough to desecrate their graves, they have even schemed to raise the spirits of the dead. Descendants of the Soul Sky... such wicked people. Amitabha.”

When the golden glow dissipated, it was the Buddhist Star.

“Huhu, so it is indeed this situation.”

The sword glow had been the Sword Star.

Woon-seong approached them slowly and said, “As discussed, I will have the neck of Jwa Do-gyul.”

The Buddhist and Sword Stars had approached the army of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon a few days before this battle with Murim.

At the time, Woon-seong had been planning with the Senior Strategist for the struggle against the Martial Alliance.

“The most concerning would be the masters who showed up in Chongqing.”

Woon-seong nodded. Even though the Demonic Army completely occupied Chongqing, those two had not appeared.

They had been a bit reluctant to just leave it be.

Woon-seong and Sang Gwan-chuk gathered information.

They did not miss even a small scrap of data, and through all possible calculations, identified a specific place those two mysterious masters might be hiding.

“The Imperial Palace, otherwise the Martial Alliance.”

“Right, we cannot rule out the possibility of them being in the Martial Alliance.”

Woon-seong nodded gravely. “Two corpse puppets...”

They had set countermeasures in place for Chongqing.

While Woon-seong would deal with one puppet, two of the Demonic Masters would work together to stall the other one.

Unlike then though, the Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign had now joined the Wind Demon Fist King on the field.

It would be possible to carry out the operations without much effort.

But it was at that moment that a strange voice came from outside the barracks.

“This looks like a fun plan, why don’t we join you?”

Someone walked in, opening the flap to the tent.

Surprised, Sang Gwan-chuk pulled the Pen of Life and Death from his waist and shouted, “What are the guards outside the tent doing...”

Before he could finish, another elderly man walked slowly into the tent.

One with a sword, one with a shaved head.

“They could not stop them,” Woon-seong said, reading their qi presence.
“Isn’t that right, Sword and Buddha?”

At that moment, the Buddhist Star clapped his hands together and lowered his head in greeting:

“It is nice to meet you for the first time, descendant of the First Heavenly Demon.”

Chapter 189: Concerns (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 189 – Concerns (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Huff!”

When he heard Woon-seong’s words, Sang Gwan-chuk sucked in a cold breath. Then his expression quickly hardened.

The Buddhist and Sword Stars. If there was the One Demon in the Cult, then there were the Twin Stars in Orthodox Murim.

In other words, this small tent suddenly housed all Semi-Divine Beings mentioned in the ‘Twin Stars, One Demon’.

Besides, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was at war. Sang Gwan-chuk could not believe that the Buddhist Star and Sword Star, the giants of the Orthodox factions, had come to visit the Heavenly Demon’s tent for a chat.

No matter how harmless they appeared, the Senior Strategist of the Demonic Cult could not come up with any good intentions.

No, in order to best serve the Demonic Army in the current situation, there was no need to find out their good intentions.

Whee!

Sang Gwan-chuk stood in front of Woon-seong.

Seeing the Strategist like that, the Sword Star smiled bitterly, while the Buddhist Star muttered, "Amitabha."

Woon-seong's expression hadn't changed much. "Looks like you are not here to fight."

The Sword Star nodded, expressing his agreement. "Yes."

The Buddhist Star also nodded, but he did not say anything.

Despite their answers, the Senior Strategist did not open the way for them.

Then, Woon-seong waved a hand and said, "Let's sit down."

Two chairs from the corner flew into the air and landed before the Sword and Buddhist Stars.

Tak, tak.

The swordsman's eyes trembled. *I thought he had just barely entered Semi-Divinity, but it's already like this...*

The Sword Star was a natural martial artist; his enthusiasm rose when Woon-seong's skills were not inferior to his own.

Depending on the mood or physical condition, the gap between the Sword Star and Woon-seong was enough to reverse victory and defeat.

"Haha."

The Sword Star hid his surprise with a smile, and Woon-seong sat down in the seat of power.

The same was true of the Buddhist Star.

"Master of the Second Jade Knife."

When Woon-seong asked the Buddhist Star to sit down, the man laughed loudly. He had a kind smile on his face, reminding one of the Buddha.

“It has not been that for a while, Leader.”

“How long ago?” Woon-seong tilted his head, as if confused by the fact that the Buddhist Star was no longer the owner of the Second Jade Knife.

“I have already handed over the position of owner of the Jade Knife to the next generation.”

“But that does not change the fact that you are related to the Justice Alliance.”

The Buddhist Star nodded.

When the man admitted that, Woon-seong turned to the swordsman.

The Sword Star was an old man who looked like the embodiment of a sword, his skin like pure iron.

“It is my first time hearing that the Sword is associated with the Justice Blood Sect.”

The Sword Star smiled, revealing slightly yellow teeth. “Of course I have nothing to do with the Justice Blood Sect.”

“.....”

Woon-seong would not ask useless questions like ‘Why are you here then?’

The Sword Star knew that too.

“But that does not mean that I have nothing to do with the ‘Five Skies Beyond the Heavens’.”

“The Five Skies Beyond the Heavens?”

Woon-seong closed his eyes slowly.

The five legendary martial artists who led Murim in the Ancient Era.

But why were they being mentioned now?

Actually, the First Heavenly Demon — the immortal Sky Demon — was one of the Five Skies Beyond the Heavens. But what does that have to do with anything?

Woon-seong frowned.

“This one also came to visit the Leader not only because of the Justice Alliance, but also for the problems of the Five Skies Beyond the Heavens.”

The Buddhist Star echoed the sentiment.

Woon-seong, who did not understand, fiercely told them, “Explain it to me so I can understand.”

The Sword and Buddha began to explain the connection between the Five Skies Beyond the Heavens and the current situation, from what happened all those years ago to their relationship.

Woon-seong listened quietly to these stories.

In fact, it was quite a strange story. It was a story like a myth of legendary figures who had seized the Murim of an era.

In some ways, the story of the Five Skies Beyond the Heavens might be a myth.

Of course, myths would not continue until the present.

But...

“Why are you talking about that? Does me being a descendant of the First Heavenly Demon have something to do with this situation?”

“Of course. Just as you are the descendant of the Sky Demon and we are descendants of the Sword and Buddhist Skies, the Cult of the Inverted Sky

is descended from the Soul Sky.”

And the Buddhist Star said that the myth continued to this day.

Then he glanced at Woon-seong’s chest.

Right where the necklace, artifact of the Spear Master Sect, hung.

“And is the Leader not a descendant of the Spear Master Sect?”

At that moment, the energy surrounding Woon-seong shifted. A frost-like aura pointed towards the Buddhist Star like hundreds of blades.

And...

Shua!

The White Night Spear hovered around the neck of the Buddhist Star. It was in the position where a slight swing would completely cut off the man’s head.

However, it was difficult to say that Woon-seong’s power overwhelmed the Buddhist Star’s.

This was only possible because the Buddhist Star and Sword Star had been surprised and thus had not avoided it.

Woon-seong moved the White Night Spear even closer and asked, “What are you talking about?”

Woon-seong was struck by the urge to slit the man’s throat and shut him up for good. It could not be known to anyone that he had gained another life because of the artifact of the Spear Master Sect.

But the Buddhist Star’s reaction was natural, speaking as if he understood.

“Haha, Leader, I felt the unique energy of the Spear Master Sect. It is mixed with the ‘Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon’, but its uniqueness remains.”

Woon-seong glanced towards Sang Gwan-chuk.

What did the Strategist think of this situation? What were these two men thinking?

Surprisingly, Sang Gwan-chuk looked calm. He tilted his head, "Is it not because of the 'Divine Art of the Unrecorded Heavenly Demon'? That is also based on the Spear Master Sect."

Sang Gwan-chuk's words struck Woon-seong like a lightning bolt. It was because he had suddenly realized that this was also possible, that people could think like that.

Thank goodness.

That greatly reduced the misunderstandings to be solved.

No, there would be no misunderstanding at all.

It was never revealed that Hyuk Woon-seong had been reborn for revenge.

Woon-seong nodded at Sang Gwan-chuk and turned back to the Buddhist Star.

"Does the fact that I am related to the Spear Master Sect also matter?"

The Sword and Buddhist Stars nodded.

"Of course, my lord. The descendants of the Spear Sky are the Spear Master Sect."

Woon-seong squeezed the artifact hanging on the necklace; it was a story he had not been aware of. Then, was this necklace somehow related to the Soul Sky?

Did the descendants of the Soul Sky, who now presented the banner of the Inverted Sky, have something to do with his rebirth against the will of Heaven?

Woon-seong was filled with doubts.

The Sword Star said, “That is why we wish to join forces with you, why we want to help you.”

Woon-seong, who had stood up earlier, settled back down.

The thoughts that had come to mind still did not show a sense of clearing up.

However, there were two things that were certain.

First of all...

“You are willing to help us fight the Martial Alliance?”

“We will not attack the Martial Alliance, but the descendants of the Soul Sky in Zhongyuan.”

Secondly...

“I will have the head of Jwa Do-gyul. I cannot yield that.”

That man was definitely the prey he had to kill himself.

“As discussed, I will have the neck of Jwa Do-gyul.”

The Buddhist Star and Sword Star nodded their heads.

The Buddhist Star glanced back and muttered, worrying, “We must save the living after we return these souls to the Buddha.”

That said, Woon-seong’s expression had hardened too. He had tried to use the Cult of the Heavenly Demon for revenge, but the Woon-seong who had climbed to the position of Heavenly Demon understood his position.

The fact that someone understood their position was no different from saying that he or she acknowledged the required behavior and responsibilities.

The believers were suffering. Many of them were still wrapped in flames and illusions.

Although Jwa Do-gyul was escaping, Woon-seong was not wicked enough to abandon his own people.

“Hmph.”

After an exhale, Woon-seong sighed and stepped into the air. He soared into the sky.

“My lord!”

“Hail the Heavenly Demon, release us from our suffering!”

“Leader!”

Seeing Woon-seong rising into the air, the demonic practitioners screamed in agony.

Woon-seong glanced to look at the traces Jwa Do-gyul had left while running, but focused on the people in pain.

“Listen to me, Demons!”

There were several responses to Woon-seong’s call across the battlefield.

“Brain of the Heavenly Demon, I heed the orders of the Leader!”

“Wind Demon Fist King, I await the Lord’s command!”

“Eight Bolt Blade King, I listen to the Leader’s command!”

“Lotus Demon Ballad Sovereign, I follow the order of the Lord!”

Four Demonic Masters knelt as one.

Woon-seong commanded them, “There are many water sources from Wuhan nearby. Use them to assist the Cult in our efforts to extinguish the flames.”

The situation on the battlefield could no longer be maintained.

The Martial Alliance had also been caught in the fire and few soldiers were intact.

The Demonic soldiers shouted: “Understood!”

They flew in different directions and ran towards those still alive. Soon, they led people towards sources of water.

When the Buddhist Star saw this, he pushed the corpse he was dealing with to the Sword Star.

“You take over for a minute. ”

“What?”

The swordsman was surprised, but the Buddhist Star had already disappeared.

Alone, the Sword Star muttered to himself as he looked at the two corpse puppets, “Haha, I can’t believe I have to move around and sweat from the soles of my feet even when I’m this old...”

“Stop the battle and make every effort to extinguish the fire for those not involved in Murim. Not only may the flames harm you, they will cause great loss of life and may even damage the civilians...”

At the appearance of the old man standing in the sky, there was a great disturbance in the Orthodox factions.

“That’s him! ”

“Woah!”

Devout robes, a shaved head, old age, and a warm halo of light. There was no one who did not recognize the old man.

“Buddhist Star!”

The Buddhist Star was a legendary figure in Orthodox Murim.

At his appearance, many of the soldiers faltered.

They were worried about whether or not they should move.

At that time, there were several who jumped forward and shouted at the Buddhist Star.

“How can you cooperate with the wicked demons and do that? Nonsense!”

“That’s right! Did you live too long and develop dementia? Or are you a demon yourself?!”

These were men whose consciousness had been blurred by the hibiscus incense Jwa Do-gyul used. Their voices were clear, but their eyes were vacant.

The Buddhist Star stood in the air. He looked at them and sighed, slowly raising both hands.

TN: Sorry for skipping a week of updates, I was in Yellowstone, where the service and wifi are garbage. (∩_∩;)

Chapter 190: Concerns (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 190 – Concerns (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The protesters flinched when the Buddhist Star raised his hands. Then, as if remembering something, they started screaming again.

“Is a monk of Shaolin who follows Buddha’s will trying to kill people?”

“Are you still the Buddhist Star?”

At that, the Buddhist Star laughed bitterly and lowered his hand. “It is certainly not a situation to spill blood.”

The faces of those protesting relaxed.

The Buddhist Star raised his hand once more.

“There is no need to spill blood. You are merely having a terrible dream, Amitabha.”

When his words fell, he spread his ten fingers.

Carrying divine energy, One Finger Zen slammed into the heads of those protesting — “Sleep!”

“Huff!”

“Ugh.”

Those hit fell asleep or passed out, their heads down.

The Buddhist Star had overpowered them without killing anyone.

The Buddhist Star echoed as he watched them, “May Buddha’s mercy be with them, Amitabha.”

Seeing him, the Sword Star yelled, “It looks like that’s done. You can have this back now!”

Peng—

A corpse puppet flew through the air, wreathed in fire and rubble, towards the Buddhist Star.

“Amitabha...”

“Huff. Huff. Huff.”

Outside of the Martial Alliance headquarters, Jwa Do-gyul was climbing up the mountain with all his might. He was lacking the relaxed appearance from when he first left, scrambling like he was being chased by something.

He did not forget to turn his head every now and then to check behind him.

Not good.

Jwa Do-gyul clenched his teeth.

Someone had to be chasing him. They were a long ways away, but they were definitely coming.

Otherwise, he wouldn’t be feeling like he was running from a predator.

Who the hell is chasing me?

Jwa Do-gyul wondered but did not stop moving. He could not keep running while looking behind back.

Where he was headed now was where the things he needed most lay.

I can't give them up.

Jwa Do-gyul quickly scaled trees to try and lose the pursuer.

He was still the Lord of the Martial Alliance. He was a master who could be ranked at the very top of the 72 Supreme Masters.

Jwa Do-gyul's martial arts were not to be trifled with. The tree branches did not shake when he stepped on them, the blades of grass did not bend.

He was not slow either.

Each time he tapped his toe, Jwa Do-gyul would go straight up the hillside.

He looked around as he rapidly climbed the mountain.

Shua—

There was a flying beast searching for food, but there were no signs of anything else.

There was a chill, as if the pursuer was still on his trail. Yet no matter where this pursuer was, they would not be able to find this place.

He looked around and approached a pile of rocks. He tapped on one with his fingertips.

Tak-tak.

And then something amazing happened.

A tree several meters away from the rock lowered.

Kung-rung.

No, it was not lowered.

The land caved in and the trees went down with it.

Jwa Do-gyul took a step towards it. In the meantime, a small passageway emerged from the ground.

“Hehe.”

Looking at the passageway, Jwa Do-gyul smiled slightly. No matter how powerful the pursuer may be, they could never enter here.

Unless you know the rules for knocking on that rock, you will never be able to get inside.

Jwa Do-gyul hurried into the passageway.

As he disappeared into the darkness, the passageway began to move again, making heavy noises.

Kung-rung.

A staircase appeared. The light did not hit this area, but Jwa Do-gyul seemed familiar with the layout.

How many steps did he descend?

At the bottom of the staircase, another passageway extended. He ran through it for another length of time.

At the end of this corridor, Jwa Do-gyul reached to his right. His hand touched an oil lamp.

He rubbed his finger against the oil wick.

As a flame suddenly appeared, light illuminated the area.

The dark space was suddenly filled with light.

A cave with a round ceiling appeared.

The cave was laid with bedding in case of emergencies, and there was a jar filled with grain balls. There was even a device to draw water, so drinking water was also available.

This place can last me a month.

Jwa Do-gyul had carefully prepared this place in advance.

Now, of course, the point of his visit was not so he could hide here.

It was for a completely different reason.

Jwa Do-gyul walked forward and knelt by the bed. He flipped it over, revealing a small trap door.

Creak—

He opened the door and stuck his hand inside. Not only did the door easily open, he felt his hand touch something.

The hidden compartment was filled with stacks of paper and letters.

Jwa Do-gyul smiled faintly as he looked at the stack.

“Hehe. With this, I can recover at any time.”

Although he had lost his position in the Martial Alliance, which had been built all these years for the Inverted Sky’s plan, it was not a problem.

As long as he held onto these, the Inverted Sky would continue to support him.

I could even get a spot in the Imperial Court if I wanted to.

Jwa Do-gyul had a relieved expression on his face.

It was all because the stack of papers in his hand documented his relationship with the Inverted Sky.

If he was threatened, he would release them. The Inverted Sky would listen to him for some time.

Jwa Do-gyul grabbed the stack and tried to exit through another passageway.

‘Always have multiple plans.’

With this in mind, he would never make only one passageway.

I can get out of here.

That was what Jwa Do-gyul thought, until he heard a voice right behind him...

“So this is it.”

Jwa Do-gyul froze. A chill crawled down his spine.

At first, he thought he heard wrong. He might have been convinced, if not for the cold feeling behind him.

Jwa Do-gyul swallowed. How had he not noticed such a huge presence until now?

He did not know how this person had managed to chase himself here. You couldn’t even come inside unless you knew the code.

Unless...

At that moment, a flying beast burst into cries.

Turning his head, Jwa Do-gyul noticed an eagle sitting on the man’s shoulder.

The eagle's entire body was black as night. It was the very bird Jwa Do-gyul had seen when he entered.

Damn it.

Jwa Do-gyul just remembered that there was a technique for a human to share eyes with a bird...

What should I do?

If he stalled for a little, could he escape?

He didn't think for long. Jwa Do-gyul quickly twisted and threw weapons.

Kuakuakua—

A massive wave struck Woon-seong.

“It worked!”

Jwa Do-gyul felt the sensation from the palm of his hand and was delighted.

And so he tried to run.

But...

Shua—

A hand protruded from the explosion and grabbed hold of his hand.

Woon-seong slid their hands together, intertwining their fingers.

Crunch—

“Gahhh!”

As Woon-seong did so, he crushed Jwa Do-gyul's hand with a powerful grip.

The man screamed like he was dying.

“Uaghhhh!”

Woon-seong pulled him closer and made eye contact. He growled, “Why did you come here? You didn’t really think that you were smart, did you?”

Unlike his growling voice, Woon-seong’s face was full of smiles.

It was a cold smile, like that of an Asura.

From the beginning, everything had been planned.

From the moment the two corpse puppets appeared, to the fact that Woon-seong’s attack had not reached Jwa Do-gyul.

It was also part of Woon-seong’s plan for to explode in anger.

Woon-seong’s true fury was not like an active volcano, but rather the cold winds of the North Sea, so it was all smoke and lies.

It was also planned that the Twin Stars would not be involved with the death of Jwa Do-gyul.

Ah, there was something not planned for.

It was the myriad of landmines that had buried the Martial Alliance, those had certainly been unexpected.

Everything else had gone according to Woon-seong’s plan, which had read into all of Jwa do-gyul’s movements. As proof of that, Jwa Do-gyul had guided Woon-seong straight to the evidence he needed.

“Oh, how...?” Jwa Do-gyul trembled as he asked.

Woon-seong reached out and grabbed the man by the head.

Kuak—

With his other hand, he grabbed Jwa Do-gyul by the neck.

Weng—

With his grip, he could wring the man's neck and pull his head off right now.

But Woon-seong did not wield his power.

Instead, with a swinging force, he pulled the man's face closer.

“Actually, I’ve been thinking a lot.”

“Knng, Knng!”

Jwa Do-gyul wriggled in Woon-seong's grip. Every time, a powerful force would slam down on Woon-seong's body.

However, none of it was fatal to Woon-seong. It was primarily because of the power of the Black Dragon Robe, but also because Woon-seong dispersed the power.

“What should I do when I meet you? How can I kill you in the most painful way? What can I do to resolve my grudge against you? I’ve been thinking about this a lot.”

“Ugh...”

Jwa Do-gyul twisted. For him, Woon-seong was just an enemy, not such a hostile life or death foe.

But what was with this man's deep grudge?

Jwa Do-gyul continued to twist and struggle, as if asking why.

As if he had just remembered something, Woon-seong suddenly said:

“Oh, did you know that my name is Hyuk Woon-seong?”

Hyuk Woon-seong.

It was a common name. That was why Jwa Do-gyul did not recognise Woon-seong's identity right away.

Woon-seong continued to speak, reminding Jwa Do-gyul.

“The disciple of Spearmaster Nok Yu-on was also named Hyuk Woon-seong.”

At that moment, Jwa Do-gyul's eyes widened, like they were about to be torn apart.

“You won't be dying so easily.”

Chapter 191: You Remembered (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 191 – You Remembered (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Boom!

Woon-seong threw Jwa Do-gyul to the ground. He then tipped the man's chin up with his foot.

Tuck—

“Ahhhh!”

Screaming, Jwa Do-gyul slammed against the wall. The man screamed and muttered, lifting his head. “Th-That can't be...”

That was the first time Woon-seong had heard the man's voice after all the screaming.

Woon-seong smiled.

“Yeah, it cannot be. The dead cannot come back alive. The disciple of Nok Yu-on, Hyuk Woon-seong, I am sure you killed him. You can't keep loose strings like him alive, can you?”

Woon-seong's gaze turned to Jwa Do-gyul's left hand, which was missing two fingers.

On that day, on his and his master's last day, he had cut those two fingers off himself. Woon-seong smiled brightly upon seeing the gap, while Jwa Do-gyul's stiffened.

"Wretched demons."

That was something Jwa Do-gyul remembered. He had said it himself that day, while killing a despairing Woon-seong.

While Jwa Do-gyul was frozen, Woon-seong continued talking.

"So it is not possible. I have ascended to the throne of the Heavenly Demon, and you will suffer in my hands here today, and you will be killed. None of this should have been possible."

Woon-seong shrugged.

"But what can I do?"

Jubbuck-

Woon-seong moved. It was towards the direction of Jwa Do-gyul, who was still slumped against the wall.

"Because it is all your fucking fault."

Jerbuck- Jerbuck-

Everytime Woon-seong stepped, the distance between him and Jwa Do-gyul would draw closer.

Jwa Do-gyul tried to run away on his arms, since his leg had broken.

But there was a hard wall behind his back; there was no where to run.

Realizing his situation, Jwa Do-gyul had no other option but to go crazy.

"Ahhhh!"

Kuang – Kuang –

A mighty stream of energy gushed from his hand. A brilliant force blew over Woon-seong.

“Don’t come! You evil spirit, you devil! ”

Jwa Do-gyul’s hands shook; he looked seconds away from pissing himself.

Woon-seong reached out towards him.

Feng- Feng-

The energy Jwa Do-gyul had blasted collided with Woon-seong’s energy, dissipating like fog.

So Woon-seong continued to gradually approach Jwa Do-gyul.

Though Woon-seong had reached Semi-Divinity, Jwa Do-gyul was still a martial artist at Absolution.

Even Woon-seong should not be able to defeat Jwa Do-gyul so easily.

But the current Jwa Do-gyul had lost his mind. Even before he feared being chased down, he had already been affected by fear of Woon-seong.

The man’s mind had already collapsed.

Woon-seong reached out again and grabbed the man.

He then tried to move his other hand.

At that time, Jwa Do-gyul opened his mouth:

“S-Spare me.”

Woon-seong paused.

Spare you? Is that what you want? Woon-seong scoffed. The thought had never once crossed his mind. *I can't believe you are begging me to spare your life. No matter how obsessed you are with life, your heart can't be this ugly.*

Woon-seong stared at the man.

Not knowing what Woon-seong was thinking, Jwa Do-gyul continued to plead.

“Please, please spare me.”

Woon-seong spoke: “Do you have no conscience?”

Woon-seong's grip tightened.

Wing –

His fingers dug into Jwa Do-gyul's body.

“Even if all of the other dirty and hypocritical men asked for their lives, *you* cannot ask me to spare you.”

Wooduk-

Woon-seong's fingers were digging into the man's flesh, drawing blood. The nasty stench filtered into his nose.

“I am offended.”

“Damn it!”

Jwa Do-gyul cursed, swinging towards Woon-seong's chest. It was an attack that did not take into consideration Woon-seong's hold on his body.

Kuang –

The explosion sounded and Woon-seong's chest shook.

No matter how strong you think you are, you can't take a blow so close to your heart! “Hehe,” laughed Jwa Do-gyul.

But...

Weng—

Woon-seong's grip tightened. The dust from the explosion dissipated and parted to reveal Woon-seong's slightly scorched palm.

Jwa Do-gyul had hit Woon-seong's palm, not his chest.

Woon-seong grinned, as if the scorched palm didn't even sting. “Yes, it would feel good to kill me. So you still have a conscience!”

Woon-seong's laughter felt like the frozen waters of the North Sea. He moved his hand as he laughed.

Weng—

His hand was now half dug into the man's body.

“Ahhh!”

Jwa Do-gyul screamed; Woon-seong's hands showed no mercy.

Before inflicting more pain on the man, Woon-seong stuck his hand into the robes and pulled out the documents.

Those were the same documents that listed all of the factions that collaborated with the Cult of the Inverted Sky, Jwa Do-gyul's own involvement in the Inverted Sky.

A document that, if known to Murim, would cause a large wave of chaos.

“I'll be taking this.”

Woon-seong's voice made Jwa Do-gyul scream.

No, he tried to scream.

“Ohm no! That’s my—”

But no sooner than that, Woon-seong’s fingers dug even deeper.

“Aghhhh!”

Jwa Do-gyul flailed about. Various types of pain, including the flipping and compressing of bones, or the stretching and tearing of muscles, coursed through his body.

“Aargghhh!”

It was the same ‘Crushed Bones and Squeezed Muscles’ Woon-seong had used on Mae Hong-sung and several others.

Suffering hard to endure, it swallowed Jwa Do-gyul.

Weng, weng.

Tuk, tuk, tuk.

Bam, bam.

Something broke, split, then broke again.

Nevertheless, Jwa Do-gyul’s life had not been cut short.

Even though I’m suffering so much, I’m still alive!

“Make it stop!” Jwa Do-gyul screamed, twitching backwards.

He fainted.

Woon-seong would not accept that.

Tak—

With a flick of his finger, Jwa Do-gyul's body trembled and the man woke up.

“Ahhh!”

Seeing that, Woon-seong coldly murmured, “I told you I will not have you dying too easily.”

Jwa Do-gyul struggled with the pain.

Everytime, he would faint to escape the pain.

Shick—

And every time, Woon-seong would flick his finger, and Jwa Do-gyul would wake up screaming.

Within this agonizing cycle of pain, Jwa Do-gyul's spirit was gradually destroyed.

His eyes faded and he foamed at the mouth.

By the time those twisted limbs finally stopped trembling, Woon-seong's hands were caked in Jwa Do-gyul's blood.

“.....”

Jwa Do-gyul, who was whole in neither shape nor mind, did not dare open his mouth, even though the pain of torture had disappeared.

A living corpse.

A body that only breathed.

Was there a better word for describing Jwa Do-gyul?

Woon-seong looked at the crumpled form of Jwa Do-gyul under his feet.

This has been a scene a long time in the making.

Ten years, it is finally the moment to release all that venom.

But then, why is it so frustrating?

Why are the corners of my heart not refreshed?

Woon-seong slowly raised the White Night Spear.

Revenge leads to more revenge, and the end of revenge is hopeless nothingness.

“Fucking bullshit.”

Woon-seong wasn’t sure if or why he was frustrated. It just felt like he was doing what he had to do.

However, there was this feeling of irritation that remained in the corner of his heart.

After clicking his tongue, he raised the White Night Spear high.

But, I still have to do something.

Puchi—

Thwack—

With the sound of a cut, Jwa Do-gyul’s head flew into the air. It then fell to the floor, bounced once or twice, then rolled into a corner.

Blood soaked the floor.

“Master.”

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

Have I successfully achieved vengeance for Master Nok Yu-on?

It was then.

Tuk-Tuk-

Something rolled over and touched Woon-seong's foot.

Looking down, it was a head.

Woon-seong's eyes twitched.

A severed head had rolled over by itself.

That wasn't all: it seemed to be squirming by Woon-seong's foot.

It was a frightening sight.

Woon-seong stared at it in silence.

Finally, the head flipped over, so that the face was turned towards Woon-seong.

Red pupils were revealed.

Looking into those eyes was like making eye contact with the devil king in the Underworld; it washed the world in eeriness.

Intimidation Qi rose.

Just like how Woon-seong's Intimidation Qi stimulated the opponent's fears, those red eyes also stimulated a man's fundamental terrors.

Though Woon-seong was not aware of this fact, the Intimidation Qi had reacted to something similar to itself.

Woon-seong had not realized it, but when he looked into those eyes, he felt a twinge of fear.

And so his Intimidation Qi had reacted. It showed itself to confront the fear its master felt; it didn't like that its master felt fear!

The aura of those red eyes intertwined with the spirit of the Intimidation Qi. Fear and horror ran wild, slamming into each other.

At the same time, Woon-seong swallowed a small sound. Thanks to the Intimidation Qi, fear he didn't even realize he felt dissipated.

But the important thing was that just for a moment, Woon-seong had been terrified of those red eyes.

I did not feel fear from the Sword or Buddhist Stars.

Woon-seong bit his lip. The bitter taste of blood flowed into his mouth.

At that moment, Woon-seong's mind was startlingly clear.

Woon-seong's gaze and those red pupils' crossed each other in the air.

The severed head of Jwa Do-gyul curled its lips and offered a terrifying smile.

"You remembered."

At that voice, Woon-seong froze again.

The dead talked.

That did not make any sense.

That was why Woon-seong was frozen for a moment.

Ah. There's someone controlling it.

Woon-seong quickly relaxed. He realized that someone was controlling Jwa Do-gyul's severed head.

He did not know who it was or what they were doing, but the puppeteer must have been somewhere far away.

When Woon-seong came to that conclusion, the head spoke again.

“The next time we meet, I will kill you—”

Fur-Seok-

That was it.

Woon-seong lifted his foot and stomped on the head. Shattered pieces of skull and brains splattered.

I see.

Now he understood why he did not feel relieved.

Thanks to the talking head, he found the answer.

There are still too many people left to kill.

His revenge was not finished.

I have only killed one Jwa Do-gyul...

Woon-seong clenched his fists.

Maybe I should rewrite the list in my booklet.

And of course, at the top of the newly written list would be the name of the emperor, or the man who now wore the skin of the emperor.

Chapter 192: You Remembered (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 192 – You Remembered (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

In the Martial Alliance, there were men wearing two different colors just staring at each other.

They were the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and the Orthodox factions, who had extinguished the fire together.

Martial Alliance and Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

Orthodox Murim and Demons.

How long had these two forces been fighting each other?

A hundred years?

Two hundred years?

No, it could be hundreds of years.

Maybe a thousand years.

Before the immortal Sky Demon, the First Heavenly Demon, gathered together the people under one religion, there were already demons living in the Heavenly Mountains.

And most of those were people who had fled or were driven out of Zhongyuan, settling there.

From that point on, the relationship between the two sides was like oil and water.

A relationship where the two could never be mixed.

A vicious cycle.

When an Orthodox and a Demon met, they would fight each other.

Now, it was the same.

“I never thought I’d sit in the same place as these devils... What the hell is this?” one of the warriors, dressed in fiery robes, muttered.

“Excuse me?!”

It was natural for the demons to be offended.

A group of demons leapt to their feet.

Then, a group of Orthodox soldiers also stood up.

It was fortunate that no one had pulled out their weapons.

When such conflict arose, Sang Gwan-chuk had a terrible migraine.

It was not easy to approach each other, or control each person.

Sang Gwan-chuk sighed. He then went to stand in front of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and shouted loudly:

“From now on, fighting with the Martial Alliance is strictly forbidden. Hurry and take care of the wounded. I will punish those who are caught picking a fight.”

The Senior Strategist was one of the Ten Demonic Masters. It was true that he had a distinct position inside the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

However, his influence was not as great as Woon-seong's.

That was why one of the demons muttered, "One of the sects started it..."

There was sudden silence.

The muttering demon gasped. "Huff!"

A terrible aura was emanating from Sang Gwan-chuk.

As if to support Sang Gwan-chuk, the Wind Demon Fist King stepped forward and stomped his feet.

A wave of energy stretched out.

As a result, the demons who were about to show their dissatisfaction clamped their mouths shut.

Then, the sects mocked them.

"Hah, you're all cowards."

"I'm sure you're not talking about the demons. They only bow their heads to the strong."

The words caused the demons to look unsightly. They wanted to yell something, but they could not stand up because the Demonic Masters were glaring.

They truly wanted to pull their blades out and cut the sects' heads in half.

Of course, nothing happened.

"Stop it, Amitabha."

The Buddhist Star drifted between the Orthodox warriors and stopped them. But he was only one person, and there were many warriors. He wanted to use the same technique as the Senior Strategist, but he was a buddhist. Perhaps he felt it was not right to press down with force.

But the Sword Star obviously felt differently.

“Shut up.”

A tidal wave of energy erupted from the Ssword. It was as if hundreds of intangible swords filled the air.

The moment the factions felt the sharp swords in front of them, they kept their mouths shut.

“Huff!”

Watching on, the Buddhist Star could hear the Sword Star’s voice in his ears.

— If you want to be a peacemaker, then do it. But I will not be like that, I am not partisan.

“Amitabha.”

It was as the Sword said.

Although the Sword Star had never practiced anything that contradicted the Orthodox Path and Murim liked to include him as part of the factions, the Changbaek Sword Sect was not an orthodox sect.

Martial artists drenched in gray; it was a sect that was caught in the middle.

Maybe it was different for the Sword Star, a disciple of that sword sect. He was also gray, but leaned towards white.

The Buddhist Star continued to speak, the Sword Star continued to pressure.

It was at that moment Woon-seong appeared.

Unable to fight, a martial artist raised his head to stare mindlessly at the sky. A shadow seemed to have been cast, and he saw a bird flying near the sun.

“A bird?”

At that moment, the bird fell from the sky.

Immediately recognizing that it was actually a person, the man exclaimed loudly. “Woah!”

At that moment, Woon-seong landed on the ground.

Kung-

He had descended from such a height but did not seem shocked at all.

Once on the ground, Woon-seong read the atmosphere on both sides and asked, “What’s the situation here?”

“So that’s what happened.”

Woon-seong had been briefed by the Buddhist Star and Sang Gwan-chuk, nodding.

The Orthodox factions were staring at Woon-seong’s figure.

A young man.

He looked like he could be a disciple, or still in his apprenticeship.

But he was the Heavenly Demon.

Other than a slightly bleak expression, he didn’t fit the image.

Rumor had it that the Heavenly Demon was a three-headed freak.

Still, the martial artists that met Woon-seong's eyes flinched.

Unlike his youthful appearance, Woon-seong's eyes were a deep abyss.

But while the warriors were thinking about Woon-seong, the young man in question pulled out a stack of paper.

“Is that.....?” the Buddhist Star asked.

Woon-seong waved the papers in front of him. “It was a request from the Justice Alliance.”

“Amitabha,” the Buddhist Star echoed faintly.

The documents in Woon-seong's hands was the crucial evidence proving the relationship between the Martial Alliance and the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

Evidence with details too precise to be manipulated.

And along with Jwa Do-gyul, there was a list of all the clans who cooperated with the Inverted Sky and their handwritten signatures.

With this, there would be a reason to overthrow the Imperial Court and a reason not to join the Martial Alliance — a declaration of justice.

The Buddhist Star reached his hand out to take the documents.

But...

Zek-

“But I can't just hand it over.”

Woon-seong retracted the hand holding the paper.

The Buddhist Star frowned.

Handing the evidence over would make the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's work easier.

The Buddhist Star's expression clearly conveyed his confusion.

Woon-seong explained, "There are conditions."

"Conditions?"

Woon-seong nodded and spoke.

"

"Public work?"

After the situation was roughly straightened out, Jegal Sung, who had found a secluded place, listened to the Buddhist Star's words.

"Amitabha," the man nodded.

Woon-seong's conditions were simple.

"If it went according to plan, this evidence should have been found by the Justice Alliance. However, this evidence was obtained by my Cult. Moreover, my people should have been fighting alongside allies."

If it had gone according to plan, the Justice Alliance should have been launched before the Martial Alliance and the Cult of the Heavenly Demon went to all-out war.

And the Cult of the Heavenly Demon should have joined forces with the Justice Alliance to face the Martial Alliance, not been fighting alone.

Lacking the evidence, the full-fledged war against the Martial Alliance had been shouldered entirely by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and damage had increased.

Woon-seong wanted public works in return for that damage.

Where the Martial Alliance was, not anywhere else.

It was fortunate that Woon-seong had not demanded another province be included in the Demonic realm.

A public work, such as a monument.

That was not necessarily a difficult request. But was he serious about the location?

Although Jwa Do-gyul had been compromised by the Cult of the Inverted Sky, the Martial Alliance was still the strongest force of the factions.

In other words, it had long been a focal point for gathering the power of Orthodox Murim.

But he was asking to erect a monument with the names of demonic practitioners there.

He's experienced. Not only is he strong, he has excellent political sense, mused Jegal Sung.

As long as this place had historical significance as the site of the Martial Alliance, it was clear that many martial artists would still flock here, even after the Justice Alliance was established elsewhere.

But if a monument was raised here, martial artists would see a memorial stone with the names of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and their achievements here instead.

“He said we would regret it if we do not raise that monument.”

What if the army of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was to immediately assemble?

More than half the provinces of Murim had already been handed over to the Demonic Cult.

Then, there would be the enemies of the Orthodox called the Cult of the Inverted Sky inside and the enemies called the Demonic Cult outside.

That was a far worse situation.

Of course, Woon-seong did not necessarily mean his words.

The Inverted Sky Lord wearing the emperor's shell was clearly Woon-seong's enemy. Woon-seong could not fight the Orthodox because he needed to kill the Inverted Sky Lord.

But that did not mean it was not a threat.

It's a good threat too.

Jegal Sung chewed on his lip.

After a moment of thought, he finally made a decision.

"I guess I have no choice."

"Is that so?"

"Is it not better to lose something smaller than to lose something bigger?"

The Buddhist Star responded with, "Amitabha."

Within a few days after Jegal Sung and the Justice Alliance reached the former Martial Alliance, King Jinseong's Court also arrived.

Among them was King Jinseong himself.

"Thank you. Thank you very much. I heard you took a lot of damage. Thank you so much."

On that day, King Jinsung said 'thank you' a few times, holding the hand of Woon-seong tightly.

If Woon-seong had not brought down the Martial Alliance, then this plan would have failed without the crucial evidence linking the Imperial Court and the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

Even if they succeeded in taking down the crown, it would likely be recorded as a usurpation, not a revolution.

However, these concerns were ended by Woon-seong and the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

As such, King Jinseong was bound to feel infinite gratitude for Woon-seong and the Demonic Cult.

Woon-seong briefly responded, “Just keep to what you promised. That is enough.”

And finally, after some time, it was the day for King Jinseong’s declaration of rebellion and the reveal of the Justice Alliance.

Chapter 193: Justice Alliance (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 193 – Justice Alliance (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The Justice Alliance was not so grand.

Usually, when a large organization was established, it was a matter of orthodoxy to prepare a grand stage to announce it.

But the present Justice Alliance could not afford to do so. Not only were they in the middle of a war right now, but if things went south, the factions might be split four-way.

Since it still had to happen, the alliance members hurriedly prepared for the ceremony. But the buildings were not built properly and the number of members was not tallied accurately.

And finally, on the day of the opening ceremony,

Fwoo-

The wind blew in.

The opening ceremony took place where the previous Martial Alliance had stood. This location was chosen because it was where a lot of martial artists and others of Kangho liked to gather.

A platform had been erected.

‘Venerable Dragon’ Jegal Sung slowly walked on stage.

After him followed the Buddhist and Sword Stars.

The Buddhist and Sword Stars would empower the Justice Alliance.

Woon-seong watched on from afar.

The location of the ceremony was right next to the Demonic Army’s camp, so it naturally caught his attention.

Jubbuck-

Finally, Jegal Sung climbed to the top of the platform. Beneath him were a group of sect leaders, all who had been members of the Martial Alliance.

They did not know what was going to happen, but they stared up at Jegal Sung.

Finally, the man slowly spoke.

“There was once a chivalrous man.”

Usually, the first words someone said onstage would be salutations. But Jegal Sung suddenly started talking about some ‘chivalrous man’. The audience tilted their heads.

However, they focused on Jegal Sung’s words, interested.

Jegal Sung continued in a low voice.

“Anyone who knew him would tell you he was a brilliant man.”

The hero in the story was a martial artist with a spear. The man looked up to the skies and did things without shame; he was more fierce than anyone and yet more kind than anyone else.

Jegal Sung was telling the story of a spearman.

And finally, the story reached its peak.

The spearman in the story decided to be a scapegoat in order to prevent a great conspiracy and to protect his people.

Ah.

As soon as he heard that, Woon-seong realized who this spearman was.

No, he had guessed before. But now he was convinced.

“Master.”

Jegal Sung was talking about Spearmaster Nok Yu-on.

Tears welled up in Woon-seong eyes. It almost seemed like they might fall.

At Jegal Sung’s story, the audience felt righteous fury. They did not know who this protagonist was, but nevertheless felt empathy and resentment for the life of the man who lived as a hero.

And at the end, when the hero lost his life to the forces of darkness, there were some who shed tears.

Bang!

“Do you know this man’s name?” Jegal Sung asked, stomping on the platform.

The question rippled across the audience.

The audience was restless.

“Is there anyone who knows the name of this hero?”

No one answered.

Many had thought it was just a story, but it was a real person.

“If I say his name, you will all recognize it. They lived in the same generation as you!”

The murmuring grew louder and louder.

At last, Jegal Sung spoke a name:

“His name is Nok Yu-on. He was known as the master of the Spear Master Sect and the Spearmaster of his time in Murim.”

Jegal Sung sighed as he spoke. It was a voice filled with sadness and pity. His emotions were conveyed to the audience through tone.

The murmuring died down. The atmosphere sank, like it had been doused with cold water.

They chewed on the name ‘Nok Yu-on’.

“Do you have proof?”

Of course, not everyone believed it. Among them were those who questioned.

If the story was true, if the Spearmaster did not die because he had learned forbidden Demonic Arts, that would be a terrible stain on Murim’s reputation.

The Martial Alliance had been in charge of investigating this matter at the time.

Moreover, based on what had been said, was there a power that could uproot Murim like that?

There had been a group in the shadows for that long, but they hadn’t even heard of it.

It was unbelievable without evidence.

As they shouted, Jugal Sung pulled out a stack of documents from his arms. He held them up.

“This is the proof.”

The audience looked up.

The Buddhist and Sword Stars divided the papers amongst themselves.

With a wave of their hands, the papers flew into the air and fanned out.

Not only was what Jwa Do-gyul had done written out, these papers also documented the relationship between the Imperial Court and Inverted Sky, as well as names of traitorous peoples and factions.

Originally, it was all material that should not be disclosed. If something went wrong, the whole foundation of Murim would be shaken.

Nevertheless, the Twin Stars decided to release the documents to the sect leaders, not concealing anything.

Jegal Sung, who had released all the information, slowly closed his eyes. *This is an apology to all those who have been caught in the hands of the Inverted Sky, and at the same time, it is our responsibility to bear these sins.*

“Amitabha, may Buddha look down...,” chanted the Buddhist Star.

The audience glanced at the contents of the papers.

Of course, the papers were not large enough for everyone to see.

Moderately advanced masters were able to see everything by enhancing their eyesight.

The readers slowly became stiff, their faces paling.

“Good Heavens, is this not a set up?”

It was so surprising that someone thought as much.

Unfortunately, nothing had been manipulated.

Since Jwa Do-gyul had prepared this as his lifeline, he had carefully written everything down so that it could be used as damning evidence at any time.

The causal relationship between everything was revealed.

Among them were the stories of the clans massacred by the Martial Alliance. They had all been framed, just like Nok Yu-on had been.

“Huh, I thought it strange that the Calling Sword Sect was decimated, but my god...”

“How can you do something like that?”

“Not just the Imperial Court, the entirety of Murim is in their hands!”

There were those who mourned, there were those who were angry.

“The Cult of the Heavenly Demon was also harmed by the Inverted Sky.”

“Thousands of demonics were killed by a poison made by the Cult of the Inverted Sky.”

There was also information about the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

“I cannot believe he used himself as bait against these guys.”

“Nok Yu-on. He really was a good man.”

“For a moment there, I was angry at myself for doubting him.”

Many people talked about Nok Yu-on’s story.

It was far away, but Woon-seong could still hear them.

“Master.”

Woon-seong clenched his fists. He thought revenge would be good enough, but his master's guilty sentence had just been overturned.

It felt like a weight had been lifted off his shoulders.

Even though he had made his own decision and sacrificed himself for the sake of his friends, Nok Yu-on must felt terrible to have been framed as a Demon.

But his innocence was finally proven.

Perhaps, after so long, Nok Yu-on would be able to live comfortably in the afterlife.

“Master.”

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

The face of Nok Yu-on was clearly pictured in his head.

His grace was immediately large, and instead of fading overtime, it had become clearer and clearer.

The Nok Yu-on in Woon-seong's memory was smiling brightly.

“Such a thing should never happen again.”

Over time, the commotion over the documents subsided and Jegal Sung spoke again.

“This tragedy should never happen again.”

At Jegal Sung's words, the audience nodded.

They were unknowingly exploited by the forces of the Inverted Sky, but they were not all corrupt. They were a group of martial artists who grew up listening to the tales of righteous men, dreaming of being heroes.

With their sympathy, Jegal Sung spoke louder.

“That is why we are trying to create a whole new group, not the Martial Alliance playing in the hands of the Inverted Sky.”

But Jegal Sung’s words shocked the audience.

Not the Martial Alliance, but a whole new organization.

Ignoring their reactions, Jegal Sung continued on.

“The name shall be the Justice Alliance, made to defend justice. Those who support it, raise your hand.”

The audience began to murmur.

Then, there were those who acted first.

Hum-

The first to agree were the Twin Stars, standing by Jegal Sung.

But that was only the beginning. Along with murmurs, other sect leaders began to raise their hands.

Some of them were elders of the Martial Alliance.

The night before, the Twin Stars and Jegal Sung had been busy persuading people.

In fact, while the commoners did not know, the executives had already known what this meeting was about.

When the executives agreed, the others had no choice but to agree.

Jegal Sung nodded in satisfaction and shouted at the skies:

“I will make a declaration to the Heavens with the martial artists gathered here today. We are here to take responsibility for the sins that we have committed — those which were not corrected until the world fell to ruins

and the weaknesses our enemies used to confuse us as the world fell to chaos.”

Kung-

Jegal Sung stepped forward.

At the bottom of the platform, drummers began to bang on the drums.

Boom, boom, boom.

Jegal Sung’s voice stretched and echoed with the drums, knocking at the ears of the audience.

The beating drums made their hearts skip.

Doom, doom, doom.

The drums beat and their hearts beat. Many of the martial artists subconsciously clenched their fists.

Jegal Sung’s voice echoed, even at the end.

“To the Heavenly Gods, I announce the creation of the Justice Alliance!”

“Waaaahhhhhhhh!”

Chapter 194: Justice Alliance (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 194 – Justice Alliance (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Finally, the Justice Alliance was revealed to the world.

After declaring the existence of the Justice Alliance and its pursuit of justice, King Jinseong did not forget to make his own statement.

The current emperor was another person wearing the skin of the true Emperor, and the entire Imperial Court was playing in the hands of the Cult of the Inverted Sky. It was a statement proclaiming King Jinseong would stand up and correct this wrong, protecting the crown.

There was no commotion this time, since evidence had already been released by the Justice Alliance.

Of course, that did not mean there was no turmoil.

King Jinseong had just declared that he would act against his own kin.

It was also announced that the Demonic Army had reached an agreement with King Jinseong and the Justice Alliance.

The Cult of the Heavenly Demon had lost their cult leader to the Inverted Sky, so they had entered Zhongyuan in order to take revenge. Since it

would be difficult for either group to deal with the Inverted Sky alone, they would cooperate.

The people who were there spread such gossip throughout Kangho.

“The Hebei Peng Clan was actually part of it.”

“I guess it’s true that old water rots then?”

“You won’t believe me, but there’s even more.”

“Even though the Emei and Mount Hua weren’t part of it, most of the noble clans or great sects were!”

“How can they do that without guilt?”

Rumors and discussion were widespread. In addition to talk within Murim, public opinion had turned against the Inverted Sky and all related parties.

The evidence presented by the Justice Alliance contained everything the Cult of the Inverted Sky had done. Even if they wanted to deny it and claim the information to be fabricated, it was too detailed for that to be possible.

As a result, there were few options available to the factions which had joined the Inverted Sky — they could either lock their doors and go into hiding, or try to fight it out and die.

The Hebei Peng Clan was one such faction contemplating their future.

Boom-

The leader of the Peng Clan smashed his fist down. The cup which had been in front of him split in two and crumbled.

Tak, tak.

However, Clan Head Peng only snorted harshly.

Although he was the leader of a noble family, Clan Head Peng had a personality that could be considered violent and temperamental.

Infuriated, Clan Head Peng yelled at the elders gathered.

“What the hell did that boy do to make this happen?!”

One of the elders in the lower ranks answered with difficulty, “He has already lost his life in the hands of the Heavenly Demon...”

Bang—

Clan Head Peng slammed a fist against the table again.

“Damn it.”

He couldn’t help cursing aloud.

Unlike other sect-gates, where only a few members joined the Inverted Sky, the Hebei Peng Clan, which was located next to the Imperial Palace in Beijing, had fully allied itself with the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

In fact, it was no exaggeration to say that all members of the Peng Clan had dipped their feet into the Inverted Sky.

Clan Head Peng was worried, but there weren’t many options.

He could either shut the clan indoors, or keep cooperating with the Inverted Sky.

He had to choose between the two.

Sitting at the seat of honor, his worries only deepened. He asked, “What happened to Hak-ie?”

Leader of the Hebei Peng Clan, the ‘Great Mountain Cleaver’; the man’s name was Peng Ga-hyuk. He was given such a nickname because he was the strongest martial artist in the Peng Clan at the moment.

The elders were silent.

“I asked, what happened?”

Ooh-ooh-ooh-

His voice echoed; a turbulent force stretched out.

If asked to choose who was the strongest person in the world, it would be difficult to pick. But if someone was asked to choose the strongest out of the 72 Stars Beneath the Heavens, it was Peng Ga-hyuk without hesitation.
[1]

It was quite obvious why once you felt his presence.

One of the elders kept his voice low, but reluctantly answered tremulously, “We know that Peng Hak is currently being held captive by the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and living a life of servitude.”

By saying ‘servitude’, the elder was being cautious.

He was not the only person who was holding his tongue and walking on eggshells.

It was due to Peng Ga-hyuk’s nature.

Of course, the man had not been so temperamental at birth.

His personality had been quite blunt, but he did not easily hurt people.

After joining the Inverted Sky and gaining strength, Peng Ga-gyuk had become a completely different person.

Instead of a king, he began to act like a tyrant.

“Come again?” Peng Ga-gyuk’s eyebrows twitched.

The elder flinched. However, he could not take the man’s glare and continued, “In addition, in light of the Heavenly Demon’s actions so far,

Peng Hak may have ended up like the child of the Tang—”

Fur-Seok-

At that moment, the elder could no longer speak. A huge aura from somewhere had crushed his head.

Fragmented pieces of skull and blood blasted about.

The terrible scene caused everyone to close their eyes for a moment.

Peng Ga-hyuk took a moment to recover before saying, “Our choice has been made after all. Irreconcilable enemies. What becomes of us if I surrender to those who have harmed my immediate family?”

The elders trembled. It seems they would end up fighting the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

“We will have no choice but to work with the Imperial Palace, which is no doubt allied with the Cult of the Inverted Sky. They would be able to move Beijing’s defense forces.”

The elders all turned their heads to stare at the clan head. As long as the evidence about how the Imperial Court was in the hands of the Inverted Sky had been revealed, even the Beijing defense forces would not listen to the crown.

No, even if they listened, suspicion had blossomed in their hearts. If King Jinseong appeared to persuade them, they might easily be swayed.

But why did the man sound so confident that the Imperial Palace still controlled the Beijing forces?

At that moment, someone’s voice echoed from outside.

“His Majesty asks me to convey a message to Clan Head Peng.”

Everyone turned towards the voice. Peng Ga-hyuk swung his hand to open the door.

Standing there was a man dressed in golden robes.

With blazing eyes, he lowered his head to Peng Ga-gyuk.

“Before we are ready to move the Beijing defense forces, don’t even think about it. His Majesty asks you to bring your own troops into the Imperial Palace.”

...

After the establishment of the Justice Alliance, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon formed an alliance with them to create the Justice-Demon Alliance.

There was more.

Now that the Martial Alliance had collapsed and the Justice Alliance was established, there was no place to stop the advancement of the Justice-Demon forces.

And thus the Justice-Demon Alliance marched through Murim without a single proper battle.

Of course, that did not mean there was no turmoil at all. There was no need for the Justice-Demon Alliance to fight, but there was a commotion with the military troops in each province.

Now that King Jinseong had decided to turn against the emperor, there would be clashes between King Jinseong’s forces and the imperial forces.

But it wasn’t that frequent.

King Jinseong had a strong political sense and was well liked, attracting many talented people to his side.

People partnered with King Jinseong occupied important positions in each city.

When King Jinseong stepped forward to persuade them, they would think for a while and open the way. In fact, the evidence from the Justice Alliance

was so detailed that even they doubted the Imperial Palace.

Moreover, even if not everything was true, the current emperor was clearly insane. Rumor was he made a hobby out of killing people.

Thus, these people thought it would be better to allow King Jinseong and the Justice-Demon Alliance through, to let the revolutionary forces through.

People in power opened the way.

Of course, while there were those who let them pass, there were those who did not.

That meant some battles were inevitable, but they were easier than predicted.

Although Murim forces might be fewer in number than civilian armed forces, it was certain that an individual martial artist was far more capable on the battlefield.

For example, Sang Gwan-chuk ordered Demons to sneak inside the fortresses, assassinating the commanders or city governors and ending the battles in one night.

Of course, cutting the head of a lord or commander would not end the war. There was no guarantee that the next commander would open the way.

But that didn't mean much either.

You could just slash the next lord's throat too.

As for failure?

If the first assassin failed, then a Demonic Master could be moved. No matter how well you defended yourself, it would be hard to defend against a Demonic Master coming to kill you.

“We have fulfilled the commandment given by the Heavenly Demon!”

The Wind Demon Fist King laid the head of the lord of Zhengzhou, a city in the Henan Province, at his feet.

“It seems that your men are skilled, Cult Leader.”

Seeing this, King Jinseong laughed helplessly. *I prepared for a fierce war, but I didn't expect it to be so simple.*

It was a sight to realize that the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was the most powerful of the independent forces.

And above all, what was important was not the skills of the demonic peoples who went in alone and killed the lord.

It was the plan that turned a great war between the imperial forces and Murim into a game of assassination in one fell swoop.

The brain of the man who planned it all was terrifying.

Not only had the ‘Brain of the Heavenly Demon’ changed the battlefield, he had changed the type of war fought and shortened the amount of time necessary.

King Jinseong swallowed as he observed Sang Gwan-chuk, then turned to Woon-seong.

“Hmm.”

It was a deep sound of contemplation.

A lord who reigns at the top of it all...

King Jinseong was suddenly filled with the thought that he should never turn against the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It seems that my decision to make the Cult of the Heavenly Demon the state religion was correct.

When King Jinseong first made this decision and borrowed the hands of the Demonic Cult, how much had he worried? He understood now that his choice had been correct.

Moreover, the man who ruled the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, a man named Hyuk Woon-seong, did not seem to be a man who coveted power.

The man gives back as much as he takes.

That was how King Jinseong rated Woon-seong.

Hmm, he looks old enough to get married.

King Jinseong tapped his chin as he estimated Woon-seong's age. He had heard that martial artists often looked younger than their age. For example, 'Venerable Dragon' Jegal Sung had regained his youthful looks through some regenerative phenomenon. But apparently the Cult Leader was truly just over twenty.

It was a thought he should not be having.

But he thought about it anyway.

Which noble daughters are of marriageable age...?

King Jinseong suddenly had some absurd thoughts for a revolutionary in wartime.

Then Woon-seong spoke:

“We will soon be in Beijing.”

[1] 72 Stars Beneath the Heavens = 72 Supreme Masters

TN: So updates are going to be a bit irregular because I just moved into a new apartment and classes are starting _:(‘π`┘ ∠):_

Chapter 195: Eunuch Jo (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 195 – Eunuch Jo (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“We will soon be in Beijing.”

As Woon-seong said so, King Jinseong’s expression stiffened.

Just as Woon-seong observed, since Henan Province had essentially fallen, they would be able to reach Beijing after advancing just a little more.

And in Beijing....

“The emperor, or the leader of the Inverted Sky.”

Jegal Sung and King Jinseong nodded.

The Buddhist and Twin Stars had cold expressions on their faces.

Now that the Martial Alliance had collapsed, it was safe to assume that no force could stop the Justice-Demon Alliance from advancing towards Beijing.

And thanks to the extraordinary brains of Sang Gwan-chuk, the road there would not be difficult.

But Beijing?

Beijing was the exception.

It was fair to say that Beijing, where the Inverted Sky Lord sat on the throne of the emperor, was the epicenter of the Inverted Sky.

The defenses of that place would not be weak.

“They might move the Beijing Defense forces.”

Jegal Sung and Sang Gwan-chuk nodded at King Jinseong’s words.

However, unlike Sang Gwan-chuk or Jegal Sung who were military leaders, the Sword Star was not terribly strategic. He tilted his head, not understanding immediately. “Even if the Inverted Sky has taken over, there will still be those who are doubtful, so wouldn’t there be some gaps in the Beijing defense?”

The Buddhist Star shook his head and said, “Amitabha.”

That only made the Sword Star more confused.

Jegal Sung answered, “You have already forgotten. What did the Martial Alliance do when they insisted against the Cult of the Heavenly Demon...?”

The Sword Star had a sudden enlightenment. “Ah!”

Hadn’t Jwa Do-gyul manipulated those executives in the Martial Alliance using some sort of brainwashing incense?

The evidence of this had also been written down by Jwa Do-gyul.

And this incense had been obtained from the Cult of the Inverted Sky.

It was likely that the Inverted Sky would do the same thing.

No, they definitely would.

But then again, there was a question.

“But there are many more soldiers in Beijing than there are executives in the Martial Alliance. It would be hard for the Inverted Sky to use hibiscus incense on all of them...”

“Probably,” agreed Sang Gwan-chuk.

“But then how...”

“You do not have to use the incense on all of them to move the entire Beijing Defence Force. You only have to manipulate the commanders. ”

After this explanation, the Sword Star understood and his expression hardened.

Then it really was a big problem.

The Beijing Defense Force was a well-trained and veteran force.

Even if you searched the entire world, it would be hard to find such a large elite force.

Obviously, there were the other parts of the Imperial Army, like the Northern Army and the Qiantang River Army.

Even the Justice-Demon Alliance would suffer greatly if they fought against the army within the imperial metropolis.

And unlike other cities, the battle couldn't be avoided by cutting off the commander's head.

There was no single commanding officer overseeing Beijing, there was only the emperor sitting on the throne of the imperial palace, the Inverted Sky Lord.

Even if they cut off the head of the commander in charge of the Beijing Defense Force, there would be another leader to take his place.

Obviously, that new leader would be another member of the Inverted Sky.

Beijing was like that.

The Inverted Sky had placed itself in the easiest place to use the Imperial Army, as well as a place where they could get reinforcement any time and anywhere.

From now on, the Justice-Demon Alliance would have to prepare to fight in such a place.

“It’s good that we’ve tied up the Qiantang and Northern Armies then.”

The others shuddered at Woon-seong’s words.

It was as he said.

If the Inverted Sky Lord used the Emperor’s skin to summon the Northern Army as reinforcement, the Justice-Demon Alliance might be wiped out. Even just the troops in the Northern Army numbered a few tens of thousands of men.

That was not a situation where the Twin Stars and One Demon could make a huge difference. Even if they were mighty warriors who were a match for thousands, they were still human beings that would eventually tire.

Fortunately, neither the Qiantang or Northern Armies moved.

There were, of course, reasons for that.

First, the Qiantang.

Most of the commanders in the Qiantang Army were followers of King Jinseong. Since King Jinseong had made his declaration of intent, they would not be moving.

What about the Northern Army?

The Northern Army was unable to move its forces because they were stuck in a scuffle against invaders from the north.

As winter approached, looting from northern bandits worsened. If the Northern Army neglected the border and turned to Beijing, invaders would pour in.

Even the Inverted Sky had no way to deal with both the Justice-Demon Alliance and the northern invaders, so the Northern Army could not move.

“Even so, the situation is dire.”

One problem did not disappear.

“Beijing Defense Force,” Jegal Sung said with a hard expression.

As its name suggested, the Beijing Defense Force was trained to defend Beijing. They were skilled in both land and aquatic warfare.

“All out war should be avoided, as it may cause significant damage to the allied forces. Even if we win against the Beijing Defense Force, the damage will be severe...”

“It is a little difficult to find another way to avoid all-out war without making a siege...”

Jegal Sung and Sang Gwan-chuk put their heads together to fulfill their military responsibilities. Nevertheless, it was not easy.

The situation was that complicated.

In the midst of brainstorming, Jegal Sung lamented, “If there was a way to rush into the Imperial Palace directly, it would be possible to work with a small group of people without causing an all-out fight”

I wish I could do that, but there's no way.

At that moment, a guard hurried into the tent and shouted, “A nobleman who came with King Jinseong is making a fuss, saying he is looking for a friend!”

As a comrade of Jo Woo-sang, Oh Sam was originally under the supervision of the Eastern Depot.

Just like how Oh Neung had been sent to the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, Oh Sam had been sent to King Jinseong.

Until now, he had been with King Jinseong. When King Jinseong's forces joined the Justice-Demon Alliance, he had come along.

It has been a long time since I have seen him, was what Oh Sam thought while joining the Justice-Demon Alliance.

Oh Neung was supposed to be with the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, but what was this?

Even after joining the Justice-Demon Alliance for several days, Oh Sam had not been able to find his comrade.

He had randomly searched the camp, but found nothing.

Even so, Oh Neung had a distinct appearance. His skin color was significantly different from those in Zhongyuan and he was taller than average.

Although the man's physical characteristics should have made him easy to spot, there were no signs of him.

After a few days of wandering, Oh Sam finally gave up on searching by himself.

He wandered through the camp and asked the allied soldiers.

"I haven't seen anyone like that."

"Are you not talking about yourself?"

"Huh, was there someone like that in our Cult?"

There were a few clues from that.

Not only were the Orthodox warriors ignorant of Oh Neung's existence, even the Demonic soldiers had no clue.

This was because Oh Neung had shot a letter at Woon-seong's tent and immediately been captured by Gwan Tae-ryang. Those who knew about this incident were few and far between.

Meanwhile, Oh Sam was finally able to obtain some information.

"I heard from a friend of mine who is a guard, he said that there was someone similar to your description in the Charred Dragon's barracks."

So Oh Neung *was* in the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's side. As soon as he heard that, Oh Sam went to visit the Charred Dragons.

However, the Charred Dragon Unit was one of the top combat units within the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The Charred Dragons were one of the Twelve Supporting Units — Oh Sam could not just randomly enter their barracks.

"Please, I have to find someone."

"Hmph, this isn't a place where anyone can enter."

"Let me see my friend's face, just my friend's face."

"The man is being watched by the order of the Leader. I can't let him meet you just because you want to!"

"No, what did my friend do wrong for him to be locked up like that?!"

And that was how the commotion happened.

"Oh, I forgot about that."

Woon-seong closed his eyes and rubbed at his temples.

It turned out to be because of a man named Oh Neung.

Oh Neung had not revealed who was behind the intel, but the hidden master must have handed out information to other people.

When Woon-seong looked tired, Sang Gwan-chuk showed slight worry.
With the poison from the Inverted Sky eating at his insides, it's obvious that he's tired.

Woon-seong shook his head lightly to calm the Senior Strategist. He then spoke to King Jinseong.

“I never thought the man would have a comrade. Was he not an assassin from the Inverted Sky?”

King Jinseong shook his head.

“The one inside the palace is merely imitating Jo Woo-sang's behavior, while the real chief is blocking the Inverted Sky's movements elsewhere.”

So it was a mistake.

Woon-seong closed his eyes.

I'm a bit dizzy.

He told Sang Gwan-chuk that he was okay, but Woon-seong actually realized that the poison had gotten stronger.

Perhaps it was because he had been using a lot of energy lately. The poison gradually eroded his body, but he still had no idea how long it would take to achieve a second body modification.

If I don't achieve a modification, I must endure until I have gotten my revenge at the least.

Woon-seong looked down at his body. You could tell the toughness on the outside, but his insides were shaken by poison.

Woon-seong clenched his fists. It was as if he was telling his body to hold on. His arms trembled. He pressed down on the swelling poison.

He then opened his eyes and asked Oh Neung, “You are fending off the Inverted Sky?”

“That is correct.”

“Then what the hell have you even been doing?”

It was at that moment.

Oh Sam opened his mouth from his place next to Oh Neung.

A stranger’s voice came from his mouth.

“You wanted to see me?”

It was not the accented voice of a foreigner, but closer to someone from Zhongyuan.

“Do you want to know what I am doing?”

But it was also the voice of someone who had lived longer than Oh Sam looked.

King Jinseong responded, “Eunuch, is that Eunuch Jo?”

The owner of the voice did not betray King Jinseong’s question.

“Long time no see, Your Highness.”

Chapter 196: Eunuch Jo (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 196 – Eunuch Jo (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

A group of people were climbing the mountain, each with their own weapons.

There was a young man dressed in black robes embroidered with a dragon, and a middle-aged man dressed in blue.

There was a young man in neat attire, like a scholar, and an old man with a shaved head.

There was an old man who looked stubborn and reminiscent of a sword, another holding a long staff.

Not only were there both young and old, their clothing was mixed too.

It was quite the eye-catching combination.

But what was most eye-catching were the two men walking at the front.

In Zhongyuan, it was rare to see dark-skinned foreigners. Thus, they would be eye-catching wherever they went.

But, as they were hiking up a mountain, no one paid them any attention.

More accurately, there was no one to pay attention to them.

The mountain they were climbing up, Little Wutai Mountain, was located just outside of Beijing.

Usually, the mountainside would be dotted with hunters, woodcutters, and herbalists from the nearby villages.

But now there was the Justice-Demon Alliance and the Beijing Defense Force and their mounting tensions.

In such a volatile situation, civilians did not dare climb Mount Wutai.

Thus, the group was able to climb the mountain without caring about the gazes of others.

For how long had they hiked?

The young man in the black robes furrowed his eyebrows as he glanced at the foreigners walking ahead. And then he thought back to what happened just a few days ago.

A voice had come from Oh Sam's mouth.

"If you want to meet me, follow these children."

To meet you...

And apparently they would meet somewhere in Mount Wutai.

It was a bit too close to Beijing to say that the former bureau chief was hiding.

To exaggerate a little, Mount Wutai was right under the enemy's nose. No matter how deep they were hidden, this was a bit too much.

It was then.

Shhh.

The wind began to blow as they walked deeper into Mount Wutai. At the same time, the surroundings began to strangely distort.

Woon-seong's eyelashes trembled.

Jegal Sung determined, "We're in an illusion formation."

Oh Neung, who was walking ahead, glanced back. "Don't worry. This is proof that we are in the right place."

Oh Sam added, "You must be careful from now on. You should follow our steps and avoid diverging from the path."

As soon as he said that, numerous crossroads appeared before them.

There was one crossroad, then the path divided into five, another path that had them scaling a cliff.

Of course, the martial artists gathered here were at the top of the world.

The harshly blowing wind was nothing to them.

Even the weakest, King Jinseong, had strength equivalent to a 72 Supreme Master.

How many roads did they cross?

"Hmm, was there such a place on Mount Wutai?" King Jinseong tilted his head.

Having lived in the Imperial Palace since childhood, King Jinseong had visited Mount Wutai several times. Nevertheless, he had never seen such a place during his previous visits.

'Sage of Earth and Sky' Do Jin-myung suggested, "Perhaps you don't recognize it because the scenery was temporarily changed by the illusion."

Oh Neung shook his head. "No, that's not it."

Woon-seong looked around and said, “I see.”

Sheer cliffs and green hills surrounded them on all sides, with a small lake at the center.

It was a sight he recognized.

“The city of Hangzhou.” [1]

It seemed like the forks in the road had actually been some kind of gateway to Hangzhou.

At the center of the lake was a small wooden house.

“That’s it,” Oh Neung said, pointing towards it.

Creak—

“I’ve been waiting.”

As Woon-seong entered the house, there was a voice that echoed naturally.

Everyone tilted their heads and looked around.

There was no one, but a voice had been heard. Woon-seong frowned and reached out.

Woon-seong’s hand passed through the wall.

No, it was not a wall.

Since his hand passed through, it could no longer be considered a wall.

The ‘wall’ shook and the surrounding scenery changed again.

The walls disappeared.

Beyond that was a man dressed in black.

“I greet Your Highness.”

The man walked forward and bowed to King Jinseong first.

At the greeting, King Jinseong looked like he wanted to rub his eyes.

“It’s really you, Jo...”

“Yes, Your Highness.”

When he had last met Eunuch Jo, who was a chief in the Imperial Palace, King Jinseong thought the man had changed. He thought that even Eunuch Jo had been bought by the Inverted Sky.

But now he knew that was wrong. The man’s attitude had not changed. Rather, it had been someone else entirely.

Someone different from the real Chief Jo.

King Jinseong clenched his fists tightly.

In the meantime, Eunuch Jo was greeting the others who had gathered at the table.

“It is an honor to have you all here. My name is Jo Woo-sang, a former eunuch in the Imperial Palace.”

“Hyuk Woon-seong.”

Woon-seong was brief, as always.

Jo Woo-sang smiled bitterly.

“The zenith of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the Heavenly Demon.”

Woon-seong nodded.

Afterwards, the man also greeted Do Jin-myung, the Twin Stars, and Jegal Sung.

After the greetings came a period of silence.

In the silence, Woon-seong slowly raised his head. He did not want to waste his time with silence.

The Justice-Demon Alliance encamped outside of Beijing was about to start a war.

An extremely volatile situation.

Woon-seong growled, "You must have a good reason for calling us here."

Jo Woo-sang smiled. He did not avoid Woon-seong's eyes and responded, "The Cult Leader wishes to enter Beijing right away."

Woon-seong shook his head, "No."

It was not Beijing that Woon-seong wished to enter. If they went to Beijing, they would need to fight the Beijing Defense.

All-out war was not what he wanted.

"We need a way into the Imperial Palace."

The man stiffened. He then sighed.

"You don't mean to say that you're just playing hide-and-seek and have nothing prepared, right?"

Perhaps it was because Woon-seong's words had stabbed at a sore spot. But the man wasn't playing around.

"Wait a moment," Eunuch Jo said before walking somewhere. He headed towards a wall on one side.

It was a very ordinary wall, not like the illusionary one Woon-seong had stuck his hand through.

If there was anything unusual, it would be the tiger painted onto it.

Jo Woo-sang moved his finger to poke at the tiger's beady eyes.

Click—

There was a heavy thud and the tiger's mouth began to move.

It seemed like an ordinary wall, but it had a hidden mechanism.

Of course it would, this was a safehouse that the former chief of the Eastern Depot had set up for himself after all.

A moment later, the tiger's jaws opened and a small space was revealed.

Eunuch Jo stuck his hand inside without hesitation and searched around, pulling out a small roll of paper.

Shua—

Unfolding the paper revealed a map.

Of course, just like the tiger painting, it was no ordinary map.

“This...”

King Jinseong recognized the map and his expression hardened.

Eunuch Jo nodded. “Yes. A map showing all corridors inside the Imperial Palace.”

A map showing all the hallways inside the Imperial Palace.

The existence of this map had huge implications.

If someone with a grudge against the Imperial Court or a group of rebels had this map, someone big could happen.

Jegal Sung sighed, “Sounds like a good match for traitorous rebels like ourselves.”

He said it like a joke, but no one laughed.

That's because it was ironically the truth.

The coalition of troops, including the demonic forces and King Jinseong, had to destroy the emperor.

That made it a rebellion.

The Buddhist Star said, "Then it seems like great things have already happened."

It would not be too hard to enter the Imperial Palace quickly with this map in hand.

When King Jinseong and the Twin Stars thought so, Woon-seong doused cold water on the atmosphere.

"But don't they also know this map exists?"

"What do you mean?" King Jinseong hurriedly asked.

"It is a detailed map of the rooms and hallways inside the palace, but it is just a map. Looking at it, there are no secret passageways."

Do Jin-myung nodded. "Then it is likely that the enemy also has a version of this map, my lord."

King Jinseong's expression had fallen. He turned to Jo Woo-sang.

Seeing the king's grim expression, Jo Woo-sang smiled slightly. "It is alright. I have already thought about that."

Jo Woo-sang then pulled out a map of Beijing and the one of the palace over it.

A map the size of two palms rested on top of a large map of Beijing.

"In fact, there are several passageways that are not shown on this map."

“Secret passageways?”

Jo Woo-sang nodded. “Yes. In the event of major incidents inside the palace, past emperors have prepared passageways through which they can escape.”

Immediately after speaking, his fingers moved.

A powerful heat rose from his hand and where his fingers touched turned black.

Tuk-tuk, tuk-tuk-tuk-

In that way, he marked five spots on the map.

“Every passageway is a two-way street. Is an entrance not an exit, and vice versa?”

There were five dots on the outskirts of Beijing.

He pointed at the spots.

“The places marked right now are the exits.”

Understanding what the eunuch meant, a vicious smile appeared on Woon-seong’s face. “Those could be our entrances.”

Jo Woo-sang nodded, smiling.

“Exactly.”

[1] the city of Hangzhou is in Zhejiang Province; it’s more than 600mi (more than 1000km) from Beijing

Chapter 197: Tomb Of Martial Gods (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 197 – Tomb of Martial Gods (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Is there a chance that the enemy also knows of the passages marked on this map?”

Jo Woo-sang decisively said, “No. I swear on my life.”

“I don’t know how much you think your life is worth to me, considering you’re no longer the chief of the Eastern Depot.”

Jo Woo-sang smiled, “Certainly the value may fall, but it is still my life. I am not stupid enough to make an uncertain wager with my head on the line.”

Woon-seong smiled bitterly. Since Jo Woo-sang said it like that, the man must be truly confident.

“Don’t play, tell me why. Why won’t the enemy know these passageways?”

Jo Woo-sang looked down at the map when King Jinseong asked this.
“Because managing these passageways is the job of a eunuch.”

“The job of the Chief of the Eastern Depot, you mean.”

“The man sitting as the chief of the bureau...”

Jo Woo-sang took a moment before choosing his words carefully. “That fool is just imitating me. He resembles me and mimics my habits somewhat, but he is not me.”

“He would not know what goes on in your head.”

Jo Woo-sang nodded.

Jegal Sung asked, “Is there any chance that the enemy found them while you were gone?”

Jo Woo-sang resolutely answered: “There is no way.”

The ‘Thousand Paths Disorienting Labyrinth’ (千道迷路陈).

That was the true name of the five passageways joined together.

“As long as that is true, they will never find the entrances.”

“Just tell me what you mean by ‘it changes regularly’,” King Jinseong insisted.

As King Jinseong urged him on, Jo Woo-sang wet his lips with his tongue. “The entrance to these passageways, which, by our standards, is the exit...” He pointed at the scorch marks on the map. “It is only the exits that are fixed.”

“Then what of the entrances?”

“The entrances are all inside the Imperial Palace, but they keep changing. The number of entrances is also five, but I cannot say which entrance leads to what exit, my lord.”

King Jinseong made a low sound.

Five entrances.

Five exits.

In that case, the total number of paths created was twenty-five.

King Jinseong's gaze turned towards the point outside of Beijing. Originally, it was a place that should have been used as an exit, but was now an entrance.

No matter which entrance we choose, we cannot be certain they will lead to a specific exit.

Jo Woo-sang moved his hand again. The energy wrapped around his hands and five points appeared inside the Imperial Palace.

“These are the exits.”

“There are two near the throne room.”

“They were designed so that the emperor could quickly escape an incident inside the palace.”

Jo Woo-sang smiled bitterly as he spoke. The secret passageways created to keep the emperor safe were now being used to take the emperor's head.

It was a great disservice to the people who designed these passageways and the craftsmen who built them.

But there was no other choice.

As if he could read these thoughts, King Jinseong said, “Then the one who enters nearest the throne room should take on the emperor. So what should the people who entered through the other passageways do?”

King Jinseong looked bewildered.

He was not the only one.

“Can you tell me how many people can enter the passageways?”

The Justice-Demon Alliance was at least 2,000 men strong. Since there was still the delicate situation with the Beijing Defense Forces, it was difficult for all of them to enter, but it would be alright for only 1,000 to enter.

Jo Woo-sang shook his head, understanding Jegal Sung's question.

"If the weight limit is breached, the passageway will automatically collapse. We can probably get up to five people per corridor, but to be on the safe side, I would recommend two or three each."

"Hmm."

In the end, it had to be a small number of people.

Jo Woo-sang then answered King Jinseong's question: "Everyone who escapes the passageways has a job to do."

"What would that be?"

"The first would be to purge the remnants of the Cult of the Inverted Sky."

"The remnants..."

"Take a good look at where these passageways lead."

Listening to him, everyone's focus went back to the map. But there were only two people who understood the actual layout just by looking at the map.

One was the Chief of the Eastern Depot, the other was King Jinseong.

King Jinseong spoke with a serious expression, "One leads to Hong Bin's office inside the palace. The other is Young-gun's [1]. And lastly, what is this place?"

Woon-seong, who was listening, tilted his head. *Hong Bin?*

Somehow, the name 'Hong Bin' sounded familiar. It was not a name he heard very often, but he had definitely heard it somewhere before.

Woon-seong shook his head several times before remembering where he had heard of this ‘Hong Bin’.

Prime Minister Hong Bin.

At the top of the officials in the court.

I heard of him from Un Gwan-gook of the Four Sea Courier Group.

Woon-seong nodded to himself. If the prime minister was still alive, then it was likely that he was in league with the Inverted Sky.

Then what about this Young-gun?

Woon-seong was not aware that this ‘Young-gun’ was actually an impersonator from the Inverted Sky. But of course, the Inverted Sky wouldn’t have let that slip.

It must be the same for Young-gun.

By the time Woon-seong had sorted out his thoughts, Jo Woo-sang had answered King Jinseong’s question.

“Originally, that was where the imperial concubines resided.”

“Ah, the Palace of Eternal Spring. But you said originally. Are you saying it is not right now?”

“That is still the name now,” Jo Woo-sang responded grimly.

King Jinseong seemed to find that frustrating. “You say it both is and is not. Explain what happened.”

Jo Woo-sang sighed heavily.

And then someone said something ominous: “Divine martial puppets.”

It was Woon-seong that spoke, his eyes slightly trembling.

“And the Tomb of the Martial Gods. Have you heard of this?”

Woon-seong nodded.

Jo Woo-sang turned to Woon-seong. “You said you’ve heard of martial puppets and the Tomb of the Martial Gods, Cult Leader?”

“Of course, I’ve fought against them three times.”

“Huh, and you survived against them...”

Jo Woo-sang trembled as if he was genuinely terrified.

In response, Woon-seong tilted his head and asked, “What is with the reaction?”

Jo Woo-sang swallowed. He then walked to the corner and drank some water to settle his heart. As the cool water washed down his throat, his heart seemed to calm down a little.

“These martial puppets are creatures who have been made from awakened ancient spirits. The tomb is the place where they are created.”

Divine martial puppets.

And the corpses, vessels to produce them.

It was unknown how the Cult of the Inverted Sky was making these creatures.

But one thing was certain: the Cult of the Inverted Sky was confident that each one of these puppets could handle a Semi-Divine Being.

Jo Woo-sang had never actually encountered one, but he was well aware of their horror. He turned and asked, “The Cult Leader said he fought against these monsters three times. How are you alive?”

Woon-seong snorted.

“I don’t know who boasted, but the Inverted Sky overestimated their creations. Do you think that just because you can reanimate a corpse and stuff it with energy that it will suddenly regain the understanding and skills of a Semi-Divine master?”

It seemed that the Buddhist and Sword Stars were in agreement, like they had been reminded of something.

“Amitabha.”

“Maybe that is why they were fighting about in Murim.”

Jo Woo-sang turned to them. “You fought those monsters too?”

“I only fought one. I fought and won.”

“Hurrah,” sighed Jo Woo-sang. *The Twin Stars and One Demon are called the best in Murim, but they truly are strong.*

While Jo Woo-sang was thinking that, the Buddhist Star said: “Eunuch Jo, there is no need for you to worry as much as you are. Those monsters may be as powerful as the Inverted Sky says, but they are not enough to threaten a living Semi-Divine Being.”

The Sword Star tacked on, “Maybe if two puppets worked together.”

However, these words made Jo Woo-sang’s expression harden. He actually shook, his expression only paling further.

King Jinseong anxiously asked, “What is it?”

“The tomb, the tomb must be destroyed.”

Jo Woo-sang pointed at the passageway leading to the room with his finger.

“I don’t know which one of you will make it out this way, but if it is you, you must head towards this room. And you must destroy the tomb.”

Failure to do so would bring about great despair. Maybe it would cause everyone to experience Hell.

Although he did not say it aloud, his voice conveyed that message.

“I do not know who will end up here, but you must do it.”

“Of course. I would do it, but you should tell me why.”

Jo Woo-sang seemed to heave a sigh when he heard King Jinseong would do it.

“There are fifteen additional corpse puppets being made there!”

It was enough to shock everyone.

“So if you come out this way, you must destroy the place. Before all of those corpse puppets are completed, by all means!”

.

.

.

And a few days later, the Buddhist Star exited the passage and quietly stood next to the Sword Star.

“Haha, it seems like we will be the ones to do it.”

“Indeed.”

Near the front of the exit where they were standing.

The words on the board hanging over the door were clearly visible.

Palace of Eternal Spring.

Reading the sign, the Buddhist Star muttered a prayer.

“Namo Amitabhaya Buddhaya. May the Buddha have mercy.”

Above them, the sunset glowed above the Heavens in a blaze of red — red, red as blood.

“Amitabha.”

[1] to be clear, the ‘gun’ in Young-*gun* is an honorific

Chapter 198: Tomb Of Martial Gods (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 198 – Tomb of Martial Gods (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Woon-seong shot down the passageway like an arrow.

It was obviously a passageway of the Thousand Paths Disorienting Labyrinth.

The ceiling and floor or the corridor were made of stone. Woon-seong dashed through, feet slamming against the bottom.

His body was lighter than ever; energy coursing. At this rate, it didn't seem like he would tire even after fighting for several hours.

Since there was a weight limit on the passageways, he had removed his iron bracers.

Of course, he wouldn't actually be able to fight for hours on end. A strong poison was still eating away at his body.

Even now, after releasing the iron bracers, he couldn't feel the coming of his second body modification.

It was just that hard for a body that had crossed the wall to cross a second time.

Please let my body endure until the end of this battle.

Woon-seong hit the ground running. He was the only one in this corridor.

Only a few people could use each passageway or the Thousand Paths Disorienting Labyrinth, by design, would collapse in on itself..

Thus, the number of people entering the Imperial Palace using the secret paths was very limited.

In fact, it was only the people who had gathered at the wood house with Jo Woo-sang that were a part of the mission. Each of them had separated too.

How long had he been running? Woon-seong felt a strange twist in his senses. He suddenly remembered what Jo Woo-sang said:

“When you enter the passageways, you’ll feel like the sky and earth flip, while the four cardinal directions rotate.”

It was an apt description.

Everything went distorted and Woon-seong’s senses had to be recalibrated every few meters. The passage was clearly straight, but it felt like he was running along a winding road towards nowhere.

In other words, he felt nauseous, like he was running while seasick.

The Imperial Palace...

An illusion formation that could twist even the senses of a Semi-Divine Being. In fact, Woon-seong had to admit he had been looking down on the labyrinth.

Not anymore.

It was a very practical invention that would save the life of the emperor in the event of a conflict.

How long had he been running?

At last, the end of the passage could be seen. He could feel a wind blowing, even though there was still no light.

A faint breeze brushed Woon-seong's nose.

That was impossible without an exit point.

Woon-seong rubbed the tip of his nose and grabbed the White Night Spear, thinking, *The others must have also arrived.*

“But how are we supposed to find the tomb?”

The Sword Star looked at the board with the words ‘Palace of Eternal Spring’ on it.

The Buddhist Star only chanted, “Amitabha.”

The swordsman sighed, “Let us hide our presence and take a quick look around.”

After that, the existence of the swordsman became blurry. The same was true of the Buddhist Star.

Though their stealth arts were not profound, they were able to assimilate themselves with the surrounding environment. By simply assimilating their energy, they were able to disappear.

In this scattered form, the Sword Star pointed towards one side while the Buddhist Star pointed to the other.

The buddhist nodded.

They would split up and take a look around.

With a hand signal, the two separated.

The Buddhist Star headed towards the crest of the Palace of Eternal Spring.

Hidden among the shadows, he looked around the interior.

He also observed the passersby. Among those moving inside the palace, there were definitely many soldiers and armed guards.

That was to be expected, since the Justice-Demon Alliance had set up camp right outside of Beijing. It was only natural for the enemy armed forces to be more active than usual.

However, unarmed workers were also rushing about.

These people moved back and forth through the hallways, their hands filled with medicinal ingredients.

“Hmm.”

The buddhist enhanced his eyesight in order to look at the ingredients.

— *Soul-Erasing Grass and Spirit-Calling Flowers. [1]*

A voice then flew from the opposite side. It was the Sword Star.

— *There was a pile of herbs nearby. Turns out they weren't medicinal, but Soul-Erasing Grass and Spirit-Calling Flowers. They took it from the pile and then walked around.*

“Amitabha,” echoed the Buddhist Star.

Soul-Erasing Grass and Spirit-Calling Flowers. Weren't those plants mentioned in a recipe of advanced techniques for creating jiangshi?

The city of Kimitsu was home to the Tao (Do) Family, but it was also the gathering place for many unorthodox peoples who practiced shamanism. [2]

When performing cleansing rituals or funeral rites on behalf of the sects, these shamanistic rituals could look similar to or use similar ingredients as blood summoning. Soul-Erasing Grass and Spirit-Calling Flowers were also commonly used when calling upon ancestral spirits.

Since making a corpse puppet technically also included communication with ancient spirits, it could loosely be considered as an offshoot of shamanism.

— *That seems to be the place.*

— *I think so too.*

The Twin Stars looked at each other and nodded in agreement. Soon, their presences scattered once more and they disappeared.

Zek—

Where the Twin Stars reappeared was the entrance through which the people carrying the Soul-Erasing Grass and Spirit-Calling Flowers were walking.

A subtly hidden passageway between two pillars and a staircase descending down, seeming to lead underground.

The two hid once more, then glanced at each other before climbing down when there was no one coming in or out.

Through the entrance, a narrow staircase wound down.

Of course, there were guards at the entrance.

— *The guards are hiding.*

— *Their skills are pretty good.*

If an unauthorized person attempted to enter the passage, the guards would have appeared in a flash and slit their throats.

Exceptions to that fate would be the Buddhist and Sword Stars.

The Buddhist Star, who felt their qi senses, flicked his fingers.

‘One Finger Zen’ was once again used, clogging their veins.

“Huff!”

“Glug!”

With their veins blocked, the guards passed out, strangled without knowing why.

The Sword Star did not stand still. He swung his sword.

Sok—

A blue light flashed through the air, the sword shooting forward like an arrow.

“Queek!”

The blade flew through the air, blocking the bloodstream of the guards, just as the Buddhist Star’s ‘Taiji Shen Gong’ had done.

The swordsman who had achieved perfection with the sword could cause blood clots just by striking the air.

Using sword qi to hit acupressure points (剑气点穴).

Of course, the Twin Stars could also have just stabbed the guards. It was because of the metallic scent of blood that they forced the guards to die or pass out without any external injuries.

How far did they go after these murders?

“.....”

“...!”

At the bottom of the corridor were voices talking.

Sensing they had reached the end, the Twin Stars began moving faster.

And finally, the scene revealed was terrible.

“Uagh.”

“Please, please kill me.”

Dozens of bodies lay flat on beds. A few of them were dying.

They were not bodies.

Those were living people.

When the Buddhist Star saw this, his expression darkened. “They’re transferring qi!”

“They’re taking the qi of living people and bringing the dead back to life. That’s insane!”

The sword swiftly grabbed his sword and swung, smashing down the wall.

Kuakuakuakua—

The wall of the tomb was broken. But what he was aiming for was not the wall!

“Huff!”

It was the assassins who were hiding behind the walls. With their torsos slashed open, they slid down to the ground.

There was no one strong enough to stop the Sword Star when he was angry.

“I’ll deal with the guards. In the meantime, save those who are being deprived of life.”

“Of course,” nodded the Buddhist Star, clenching his fists.

“Hurry!”

Kung-

As the two scrambled back, the Buddhist Star released a dazzling white light from his fists. It was the highest level of the 72 skills of the Shaolin Temple, the ‘Hundred Steps Divine Fist’.

Boom!

The white light slammed into a body lying on the bed, a corpse puppet still in production.

“Agh!”

At that moment, one of the guards growled.

Chaos unfolded.

In the midst of the confusion, one of the guards, suspected to be the leader, shouted loudly, “Tch, there’s no other choice. Wake them all up! Stop production and get out!”

“But they’re not complete yet, so they can only buy...”

“Do you want to die?! Abort the mission and move, now!”

A white light flew from somewhere to the side and pierced his head. It was the Taiji Shen Gong, aimed to kill.

“If I do not go to Hell to help the suffering there, who else will go? In this day and age, I follow Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva and will not become a Buddha until the hells are empty. Only when all beings have been saved will I attain Bodhi. Amitabha.” [3]

At the same time, a different type of energy began to flow around the Buddhist Star’s body compared to before.

It was because of his anger towards those who had killed the living and defiled the dead.

A golden glow began to rise around his body, flickering like flames. These tendrils gathered together and shot forward, like a mixture of the Taiji Shen Gong and the Hundred Steps Divine Fist.

Boom-

There was a loud explosion and the corpses were destroyed one by one. Since they were unfinished products, they were not very durable.

“No, the products!”

“Ahhh!”

The Inverted Sky’s workers, who had devoted their strengths to producing these puppets, screamed nonstop.

“Please, kill me instead!”

Some of the workers screamed like that.

However, their cries angered not only the Buddhist Star but also the swordsman, who had been dealing with the guards.

“You bastards!”

A glow rose from around the swordsman’s body. At the same time, a bright sword made of light rose from the ground.

Like stars dotting the night sky, a swarm of swords made of qi appeared.

In Murim, the Sword Star, who had reached perfection, was said to be able to make swords with just his own energy.

Kuakuakuakua—

Dozens of intangible swords, which had reached physical limits through qi, cracked through the air.

The space through which these intangible swords passed burned with a white trail.

They were much sharper than swords made of metal. Whenever these swords passed through, the workers of the Inverted Sky would fall down clutching their throats.

“You have committed sins you should never have committed. Sins against a man’s right to life. Pay for your crimes in Hell!”

Huahuahauhuhua—

The swords tornadoes through the room. One of the workers, who had barely escaped the net of sword qi, trembled as he pulled something from his robes.

It was a black flute which controlled the corpse puppets.

It was the appearance of the Insanity-Inducing Black Flute.

[1] soul-erasing grass (忘魂草) and spirit-calling flowers (招灵花) aren’t real, unless someone can help me find what they actually are

[2] Kimitsu is a city in Japan; all I could find about the Tao/Do Family in regards to shamanism is the *Shaman King* series

[3] Ksitigarbha is often considered the Bodhisattva of Hell or Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva of the Great Vow; a reference to his pledge to take responsibility for the instruction of all beings in the six worlds in the era between the parinirvana of the Buddha and the rise of Maitreya

Chapter 199: Price Of Sin (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 199 – Price of Sin (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“This is.....”

King Jinseong, who had escaped from the Thousand Path Disorienting Labyrinth, looked around under the light of the setting sun.

‘Sage of Earth and Sky’ Do Jin-myung followed after him, dressed in black.

The imperial courtyard sprawled before them.

Kuakuakua—

It seemed like the fight had already begun elsewhere.

King Jinseong muttered, “Near the Palace of Heavenly Purity.”

The Palace of Heavenly Purity.

The emperor’s current audience hall.

The exit through which King Jinseong had come out was connected to one of the two entrances located right outside of the inner court.

The building caught his eye as he turned his head.

“Brother, I can finally avenge you.”

King Jinseong tried to take a step forward.

At that moment though, those who had heard the commotion found King Jinseong.

The one in the lead shouted, “Your Highness, King Jinseong! That means...”

King Jinseong had given a proclamation earlier, standing on the side of Murim. The fact that he was here definitely had something to do with that.

Considering that, the leader called out, “Secure the perimeter! We don’t know how many more there are, but prepare to fight against the rebel leader!”

Bam, bam.

Soldiers marched towards them, surrounding King Jinseong and Do Jin-myung. Do Jin-myung stood in front of King Jinseong, pushing him back.

“Your Majesty!”

King Jinseong looked at the man who had shouted that order.

“Oh Geum-jang.”

To his words, the leader, Oh Geum-jang, responded, “Your Majesty, why have you caused this conspiracy?”

The man raised his hand as he spoke. As soon as he lowered his hand, the other soldiers would shoot their arrows.

Do Jin-myung watched the soldiers with sharp eyes.

Small explosives were attached to the arrowheads.

Hmm.

He wondered how many explosives he could withstand.

“It is the opposite. I am trying to make things right.”

“You are trying to bring down the Emperor, so you are in the wrong.”

King Jinseong’s expression turned ugly. He thought Oh Geum-jang would understand, but it was now unclear. His emotions bubbled up.

“How do you know he is the true emperor?”

In fact, King Jinseong did not want to fight Oh Geum-jang. The man had been loyal to the imperial family since his brother was first crowned.

He was a real man, but was not good at digging below the surface.

Oh Geum-jang resolutely responded, as if he did not understand King Jinseong’s words.

“The mouth that gives the orders is His Majesty’s, and the hand that holds the seal is His Majesty’s. Why do you say he is not the Emperor, Your Majesty?”

It was almost a scream.

At Oh Geum-jang’s self-immolating cry, King Jinseong closed his eyes.

He did not say it aloud, but it seemed like Oh Geum-jang’s true voice was transferred over.

And that was why King Jinseong also spoke with his heart.

Oh, you know.

You know, Oh Geum-jang.

You know that the lord you serve is wrong. Since the Heavens do not have the power to rectify the lord who has gone astray...

Even if the soul has changed, Oh Geum-jang will do everything in his power to protect that husk of flesh.

A person who follows himself.

Why must you pay for others' failures?

King Jinseong opened his eyes. It seemed like he had already made up his mind.

“So this is how it ends.”

“It turned out this way, my lord.”

King Jinseong took a step forward, stepping around Do Jin-myung. “I will take the head of the emperor today.”

“I will stop Your Highness today.”

“And then I will make things right.”

“Whatever you do, you will have to step over my dead body.”

Oh Geum-jang also took a step towards King Jinseong.

It was a tense situation.

“You will not be able to clear the way easily.”

“Our side is stronger.”

Do Jin-myung was a master in the Absolute Realm, no matter what anyone else wanted to say. Although King Jinseong was not as strong, he was still a skillful person within the category of Transcendence.

However, there were more than two hundred soldiers surrounding them.

Encircled, their enemies had drawn their bows, arrows glistening with gunpowder.

“One who has mastered martial arts is a force that transcends mortal understanding.”

“Then let us take a look at the power of martial arts.”

King Jinseong nodded and walked forward. He then turned, facing Do Jin-myung, “It won’t be an easy fight.”

“Is there a simple solution to fighting against the Heavens? It cannot be easy.”

King Jinseong smiled brightly at Do Jin-myung’s words.

“I have good allies.”

Kuang—

At that moment, a huge sound rang out and Oh Geum-jang’s hand slowly began to descend.

“Looks like they’re preparing something great there, too. Let us go all out.”

“Release the arrows!”

Papababababak-!

Dozens of arrows flew towards King Jinsung and Do Jin-myung.

“There’s only three left!”

The workers had awakened the incomplete corpse puppets with the power of the Insanity-Inducing Black Flute.

In the short period of time the Twin Stars had been raging, most of the puppets had already been destroyed, leaving only three behind.

“Haha, did you wake those cursed things again? How can you ever repay your sins? Amitabha.”

The Sword Star raised his hand and shouted, “How can they repay? They can pay with their lives!”

Intangible swords were already hovering around the swordsman. His ability to create and control dozens of swords seemed to have escaped the realm of humanity, reaching the realm of myth.

“Hah.”

The corpse puppets wavered. At that moment, the Black Flute sounded once again.

Fwoo-ooo-ooo!

As the sound spread throughout the basement, the three corpse puppets scrambled towards the Twin Stars.

Even though they were incomplete, they had all been Semi-Divine Beings!

“Be careful!”

“Don’t let your guard down!”

The Sword and Buddhist Stars collided with the three corpse puppets in a series of wheel battles. The moment the Buddhist Star stretched his fist and punched one, the Sword Star would switch places and slash downwards towards another.

The Buddhist Star would then strike the next puppet, and so on.

Bam, bam.

With a loud sound, the sword slashed the puppet.

But the gash was only half a finger deep.

Even a rock the size of a boulder could be cut straight through, yet the flesh of the puppet had barely been cut.

“Cursed monsters, they’re tough!”

As soon as the swordsman stopped, one of the other puppets flew forward with long claws out, aiming for that one moment. Its claws were covered in something red.

Kuang!

“Be careful!”

The Buddhist Star took the attack. He tanked the hit, body wreathed in flames.

The ‘Golden Vajra Unmoving Body Skill’ (金剛不動身), one of the Shaolin’s divine techniques.

With the Golden Vajra Body, there was not even a scratch on the Buddhist Star’s body.

“Your Golden Vajra Body!”

The Sword Star spoke of his admiration before raising his sword. Blue qi surged around his entire body.

A swift stream of qi rushed down the sword and a dozen intangible swords superimposed upon the real blade.

Fwua—

A bright light spilled out across the sword.

At that moment, the sword in the hands of the Sword Star was the earth and sky.

A sword reminiscent of a giant’s bane squashed one of the corpse puppets.

Kuang—

Boom!

Along with a thunderclap, the corpse puppet began to collapse, screeching.

The huge pillar itself was a massive collection of swords!

Looking at the huge pillar, the Buddhist Star clapped his hands together. Within seconds, a white light wrapped around his hands.

The Hundred Steps Divine Fist was about killing an enemy even a hundred steps away, perfect as a white lily.

But that is not the limit to the true Hundred Steps Divine Fist.

The power to walk a hundred steps in a single step.

He condensed that kind of power into one fist and then shot it out!

“Amitabha!”

Boom-

All of a sudden, a bright white light filled the field of view.

The skill slammed into the corpse puppet that was already being squashed by the pillar of swords.

The other puppets were also hit by the fist skill.

One crossed its arms in order to defend itself.

But...

Crack—

Its arms were immediately broken. It was not enough to stop the fist; the fist skill continued forward without losing power at all.

Crunch—

“Kwuah!”

Qua—

The fist advanced, marching forward. It was completely unlike the first time the Buddhist Star had used this skill, inherently different from when he was destroying unmoving corpses.

When the white light of the Hundred Steps Divine Fist receded, it had burned all things in sight and there was only one corpse puppet left.

One of the workers, stunned by the overwhelming power, dropped the black flute in his hand.

“Ugh.”

“Kiei!”

It didn’t take long for the last corpse puppet to fall. It was an incomplete product from the start, a corpse puppet that only had half the power of a Semi-Divine Being. The idea that the three corpse puppets could prevent the Buddhist and Sword Stars was absurd.

And when all the corpse puppets were down, then what?

Next came the workers.

Clattering—

The Sword Star swung his sword, and one man fell in a fountain of blood. He had been wondering if there was anyone who had been forced to join this project, but there was no such thing.

All of these workers had originally been members of the Cult of the Inverted Sky. For their own purposes, they were all ready to use the lives of others.

“You are on your own.”

“Heh-heh-heh.”

The words of the Sword Star made the last man laugh. One of his hands had already been cut off.

“You’re all going to die.”

The man cackled madly in the face of death, aiming his good hand at the Twin Stars. “You’re all going to die. Hahaha. We got what we wanted in the first place. The corpse puppets are merely a product of that process, and you will lose your lives to *him!*”

“Him?”

The Twin Stars titled their heads.

At that moment, the man’s eyes flickered to one corner of the basement.

It was an ordinary wall.

The Buddhist Star approached and knocked on it lightly.

Tong—

There was light ringing.

“There is space beyond this.”

The Sword Star aimed a sword at the man’s neck, but the man only burst out laughing.

“It is too late. There’s nothing there now. Ke-ke-ke, it will kill. Yes, kill you!”

That was the last thing the man said.

Swallowing a poison pill hidden in his mouth, the man vomited blood and breathed his last.

The swordsman smiled bitterly, looking down at him. “Nasty bastards.”

The Buddhist Star turned his head, clenching a fist and nodding towards the wall, “Shouldn’t we take a look?”

Kwa-rung—

When punched, the wall collapsed and another passageway was revealed.

Chapter 200: Price Of Sin (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 200 – Price of Sin (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

When the wall collapsed, the passageway led further underground.

The Sword and Buddhist Stars, who had entered into the basement, saw the scene and made gasps of shock.

“Hmm.”

“What is this...”

It was a terrible sight.

Dead bodies where everywhere.

The Buddhist Star could only say, “Amitabha.”

There was not a single intact corpse. Not only were arms and legs missing, the limbs themselves were torn to pieces.

The floor was slick with blood, skulls and spines scattered here and there.

What was more horrifying were the scars left on the walls.

The swordsman frowned and headed to the wall to look closer at the traces. He then shouted in surprise, "This is Millenium Steel!"

These words shocked the buddhist, who touched the wall with his hands.

As the swordsman said, the wall was made of a metal known as Millenium Steel.

Suddenly, the situation became much more ominous.

"Was there anyone who can make such a scar in Millenium Steel?"

The Sword Star examined the massive marks left all over the walls.

It looked like a sword slash, but it was easy to discover that it was actually a fingernail scratch.

The scars were remarkably deep too. You could not leave such a mark in the walls unless you were at least Semi-Divine!

Even more so, the scars were the height of an adult!

It was a terrifying scene.

The Sword Star looked at the mark and asked, "Can you make a mark like this?"

"Hmm," the Buddhist Star thought for a moment, then responded, "With enough time, I can do it. I could probably make it half as deep."

The Sword Star nodded. "I am the same."

Half of the depth was already being generous. But what of the marks left all around where they were standing?

Moreover, there was blood on these traces. Around them were pieces of flesh.

"These bodies, all of them were things like puppets."

The Buddhist Star's expression hardened. Even if dozens of corpse puppets and innocent people fought here at the same time, it was impossible to make the traces seen here, no matter how the Twin Stars thought about it.

“What in the world happened here? Amitabha.”

The Sword Star responded with a stiff expression: “Well, one thing we know for sure is that something in this room did this and that said monster has already entered the world.”

The Sword Star moved his gaze as he spoke.

Following his eyes, there were bloodstained footprints continuing along one side.

They led towards the same staircase from which the Twin Stars had descended...

Boom, boom, boom-

An explosion sounded as a sword and arrow collided. With each flick of the sword, an arrow would explode.

The repulsive force shook King Jinseong, causing him to stumble. He was unsteady on his feet, like he would fall over. Bruises and burns covered his body.

But it was Do Jin-myung who was most injured.

“Sage.”

At his words, Do Jin-myung barely raised his head. “Your Grace.”

Do Jin-myung's clothes were soaked in red blood. In addition, there were dozens of arrows protruding from his back, and one hand was charred ugly. His prized weapon, the red pinewood staff, had long since broken, unable to overcome the explosive power of the arrows.

This was all because he continued to block the arrows flying at King Jinseong.

Boom—

Once more, the body of Do Jin-myung, who had blocked the flames, trembled.

That was the last arrow.

It would take some time before the soldiers could reload.

King Jinseong took deep breaths and said, “I think you have suffered too much at this point.”

At that, Do Jin-myung smiled, enduring the pain. His expression was twisted because of the pain.

“I have had the opportunity to grow up as a martial artist and serve the true members of the imperial family. Do not be ridiculous, this is no hardship.”

“Sage.”

Do Jin-myung stood up. He put more weight on his good knee and used his good hand to straighten up.

The soldiers who were firing the arrows looked mildly surprised.

Martial artists were born human, but grew into monsters and spirits. But did they truly look like monsters?

“If you think about it, this martial artist named Do Jin-myung has lived a long life.”

When he learned how to fight and joined the military, when he fought on the battlefield, when he earned a title from Murim.

The ‘Sage of Earth and Sky’ had been very concerned on where to use this name. Would he simply live as a martial artist, or did he wish to leave his

name in every corner of history?

At that time, it was King Jinseong who came to find him. And with the help of King Jinseong, he became an official of the Palace, not a lord of Kangho.

That is how he lived his life.

If so, can I leave my name in this corner of history?

That thought came to mind.

In the meantime, the archers surrounding them aimed their bows.

Beyond that was the leader surnamed ‘Oh’.

Do Jin-myung laughed, his lips curving.

It is not enough yet. This is not enough to leave my name in history.

So what should he do?

He turned his head and saw his lord. The man who had given him the chance to leave a name in history.

He had to repay the man for this opportunity.

If I send him there, I can leave my small name in every corner of history.

Do Jin-myung gathered the last of his power.

Terminal lucidity (廻光返照) [1].

Not thinking of death, Do Jin-myung’s entire body was filled with strength. At the same time, his eyes were filled with life which was quickly burning out.

“Your Majesty, this one shall pave the way.”

“Sage...”

“Please step on the corpse of the imposter and right the wrongs.”

“Sage!”

King Jinseong shook his head, but the Sage of Earth and Sky nodded.

Thus, King Jinseong could do nothing but nod. “I will never forget your sacrifice.”

“That will suffice.”

As soon as he finished speaking, the Sage moved.

Why was his title the ‘Sage of Earth and Sky’?

“Today, I will bend the sky and earth with this single mortal life!”

The Sage raised his staff. A blackened fishing line seemed to protrude from his staff.

Suabbing-

The archers near him collapsed in pieces.

“Stop him! Release the arrows!”

The archers shot when Oh Geum-jang told them to.

The arrows this time were all ordinary.

Furverbuck-

The arrows embedded into Do Jin-myung’s body.

Blood soaked the ground.

Nevertheless, he did not stop walking.

To make way for King Jinseong!

To right the wrongs!

And to leave a name in a corner of history, as he wished.

No, even if I don't leave a mark in history, my name will remain in someone's memory forever!

He was empowered by that thought.

The arrows sticking from his back made him look like a hedgehog, but it was not enough to stop Do Jin-myung from moving.

He continued to struggle forward.

“Aah!”

“Growl!”

Seo-Seok-

Suddenly, the path opened up, a free stretch paved with flesh and blood.

“Ahhhh!”

Do Jin-myung could hear King Jinseong running down the path, his feet pounding on the bloody path.

There was only one thing left!

As long as he could slit the throat of the man named Oh Geum-jang, the road would open. At that moment, Oh Geum-jang leapt forward.

“Chaaaaaaaaa!”

The spear in his hand was like an illusion.

“I, too, am prepared to lay down my life for my conviction!”

Is that spear aura?

The spear quickly came at Do Jin-myung. Do Jin-myung used his half-broken staff to try and stop him.

But...

“Grrrgh!”

The energy within his body could not connect properly because of his wounds. The qi flowing through his body traveled a broken path.

I have to, I have to!

Time slowed down. Bloody tears flowed out in frustration and resentment.

Qajik-

The spear broke the staff. The wave of spear aura broke Do Jin-myung’s weapon, but also crushed any momentum Do Jin-myung had gathered.

“SAGE!!!”

King Jinseong cried out in a loud voice as he approached the man.

And...

Kwawoowoowoowoo –

White spear energy, shaped like a dragon, flooded in from the sides. It swallowed up Oh Geum-jang and his spear, who was still fighting against the Sage of Earth and Sky.

Kuakuakua—!

After that, only the traces of a giant dragon remained clearly on the ground.

‘Flow of the Divine Dragon’.

“You’re wasting your time in a place like this.”

It was the appearance of Woon-seong.

The power of Flow of the Divine Dragon was amazing.

“Ugh.”

It had to be said that Oh Geum-jang, who was nearly beaten to death by Flow of the Divine Dragon, was also unusual.

“Urgh.”

But that was it.

The man was on the verge of death, his lower body completely lost. It had been torn apart by the overwhelming power of Flow of the Divine Dragon, completely disappearing.

However, there was technically still a lower half, since there was bloody flesh and pieces of bone still attached to his upper body.

“Make it stop.”

A sudden onset of pain.

There was no one who could survive with their lower half gone. Oh Geum-jang was no different.

The world in his eyes was blurry.

In a world gone hazy, Oh Geum-jang saw King Jinseong.

It was the form of King Jinseong shaking Do Jin-myung, who still had arrows stuck all over his body.

Oh Geum-jang knew that the emperor had changed a long time ago. It was right that the true lord be King Jinseong. And he had to pay for serving the wrong lord.

“Queek!”

Oh Geum-jang, who had lost so much blood, slowly closed his eyes and thought, *With this, the price...*

That was Oh Geum-jang's last thought.

“Hnng.”

Thanks to Woon-seong's arrival, Do Jin-myung was still able to make noise. However, that did not mean his life was no longer hanging in the balance.

“Thanks to the Cult Leader, my life has been extended for a short while.”

The wounds that had been inflicted were so severe that Do Jin-myung was on the verge of death.

“Thank you, Cult Leader.”

Do Jin-myung barely opened his mouth, unable to move his body.

Woon-seong nodded.

It was fortunate that Woon-seong had been closeby, otherwise Do Jin-myung would have lost his life on the spot.

“Your Majesty, it is fortunate that this one's life has been prolonged so that I may speak with you like this.”

“Do not speak. Don't say anything, Sage!”

King Jinseong spoke, his hands pressed to Do Jin-myung's wounds. One wound was too severe. Blood continued to flow through his fingers.

Do Jin-myung's eyes gradually lost their fire. His life drained away.

“Please, please accomplish the cause, Your Majesty.”

“Sage!”

“Do not be deceived by the crowd, but right what is wrong, and that ye may come unto the family...”

“Ahhhhhh!”

Do Jin-myung’s eyes had shut.

King Jinseong screamed with all of his strength.

For a moment, King Jinseong crouched there in tears. He then picked up Do Jin-myung’s staff, cradling it.

“Do Jin-myung, I will not forget your sacrifice, nor my conviction. I will fight, just as you have. So watch over me, Sage of Earth and Sky.”

After he finished speaking, King Jinseong slowly rose to his feet. He then leaned Do Jin-myung’s body against a wall. It was in a spot where the throne room could be seen.

It was like the dead Do Jin-myung was watching the palace.

Only then did King Jinseong turn his head.

Woon-seong also gripped the White Night Spear as he looked at the throne room.

Here we are.

Revenge was imminent.

[1] 회광반조 (回光返照); lit ‘final radiance of the setting sun’

TN: 200 chapters! Let’s go!

Chapter 201: Behead The Emperor (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 201 – Behead the Emperor (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

Jegal Sung wielded a sword and a fan at the same time.

Kuakuakuakua—!

The sword split through the air, swirling like a hurricane.

Shua, shua, shua, shua!

“Aah!”

“What the hell!”

“You’re a monster!”

Any imperial guards blocking the way were swept away.

It was unbelievable once a man of the Jegal Family, who was known to be the most intelligent in the land, had decided to act directly.

It was because he had built up enough energy to accomplish such a rebellion. Of course, Age Reversing Revival was a phenomenon that

happened regardless of one's martial achievements, but even so, no small amount of time and energy would have to be spent!

If you were talking about the strongest person in the world, you would choose a Semi-Divine Being, represented by the Twin Stars and One Demon. But right under them would be 'Venerable Dragon' Jegal Sung.

After seeing such a scene, the Sage of Bright Rock followed behind Jegal Sung and commented, "You're energetic because your body is young."

Jegal Sung smiled. "Why don't you also attempt Age Reversing Revival?"

Sage Myung Am shook his head. "I am the wretch who couldn't save his friend's life from the hands of his enemies, nor was I able to fulfill his last request. What is the point of me being younger and living longer?"

"You are thinking of Nok Yu-on?"

"It is a sin I will carry for life."

After saying that, Myung Am swung his sword. A purple qi flowed out from his sword, flooding the sky.

This purple qi swarmed the enemies. Those trapped in it were exposed to the pain of their lungs tearing, suffocating under the aroma of plum blossoms.

"Knng!"

"Kuagh!"

Jegal Sung was surprised and called out, "Did you perfect the sword using the connections between the 'Violet Mist Divine Skill' and the 'Plum Blossom Twenty-Four Strokes Sword Art'?"

"It was only a moment ago. "

"Hahaha."

Jegal Sung burst into laughter. It was because he knew how hard the Mount Hua Sect's divine skills were to master, 'Violet Mist Divine Skill' and 'Plum Blossom Twenty-Four Strokes Sword Art' being the top of the top.

For the first time in fifty years, someone has touched perfect unity with the sword.

Meanwhile, some imperial soldiers barreled towards them. It was those who had already lost their reason, their eyes hazy.

“Stop the traitors!”

At the cry, Myung Am smiled and lifted his own sword. “If we are a horde of traitors,” he said as he stomped his feet and ran forward, “then you are a crowd of sinners, the true traitors.”

“What?”

As soon as the people gathered due to Myung Am's words, violet energy spread out in all directions.

The world split in two: one reflected in flesh and blood, another reflected in snow.

Although he was not as strong as those in the Semi-Divine Realm like Woon-seong and the Twin Stars, Myung Am was still a master among masters of this era.

He was the leader of the Mount Hua Sect, chief of the Five Mountain Swords Alliance. In his youth, he had been titled the Plum Blossom Swordsman.

No matter what they did, the imperial guards could not stop Myung Am.

Besides, Myung Am was not alone.

“You, take a moment to breathe.”

While Myung Am fought ahead, Jegal Sung had taken the time to recover some of his strength. Now, he moved forward.

He then wielded his sword and fan in succession. White light crackled in all directions, cracking the beams and girders of the palace.

“Stay back!”

Immediately thereafter, Myung Am cried out and swung his sword. As soon as the cracked beams were cut, the building collapsed.

Kuakuakuakua!

“Knng!”

“Aah!”

The building collapsed on top of the imperial guards. As a result, a dozen or so soldiers were buried and lost their lives.

“Phew, not bad.”

“At this rate, I can handle a few more imperial guards.”

Just as Myung Am said that...

“Do you really think so?”

There was a voice from somewhere.

At the same time, darkness began to gather and condense into a human form.

Seeing the newcomer, the imperial guards greeted, “Grand Chancellor Young!”

“Grand Chancellor Young is here!”

“With Grand Chancellor Young here, we can subdue the traitors!”

The darkness in the form of a person suddenly emitted a red glare. The surrounding air suddenly felt sickly.

Life-draining energy flowed through those eyes.

At that moment!

“Knng!”

“Huagh!”

The imperial guards gathered there suddenly grabbed their necks. They shuddered and trembled, as if they were unable to breathe.

And then!

Choo-choo-choo!

Each of them grabbed a weapon.

Dozens of imperial guards opened their mouths at the same time, completely in sync.

“Stupid bugs. They’ve gathered so many numbers, yet can’t even deal with two intruders.”

It was the moment when the man hiding in Young-gun’s body, the puppeteer of the Inverted Sky, had decided to make a move.

Jegal Sung and Myung Am felt a chill running down their spines.

The man continued to borrow the mouths of the imperial guards to speak.

“Was there a secret passageway?”

He shifted his eyes. The red glare flashed around.

Kuakuakua—

Kung—

Noises seemed to be coming from all directions. That meant that it was not just one or two attackers on their ways here.

“Looks like the passage was quite wide.”

Jegal Sung stepped forward and responded to the words of the Chancellor.

“No, it was quite narrow.”

“Is that so?” the man shrugged. “But it doesn’t matter. You are alone amidst an army. How many enemies do you think you can cut down before you are annihilated?”

Myung Am raised his sword. “There are only a dozen imperial guards. Do you think this number can stop us?”

At that, the man laughed bloodily. “Dozens? You are mistaken!”

Shua—

Imperial guards appeared on the nearby rooftops.

Shua—

Beyond the wall, imperial guards raised their heads.

Shua—

Behind the pillar of the building were imperial guards.

Hundreds of them.

And they all had red eyes.

“You have made a big mistake.”

At the words of the man, Jegal Sung and Myung Am felt their blood freezing.

Hundreds of imperial soldiers with red eyes. Swords in hand, aimed straight at the two men.

Schhhing!

It was the sound of metal being pulled out, the blade of a sword cold to the touch.

“Huff, huff.”

Jegal Sung tasted iron in his mouth. The robes he was wearing were already soaked in blood.

Myung Am was in no better condition. There was a knife embedded in his shoulder, his robes also splattered with red.

The five plum blossoms embroidered onto his cuffs were covered in blood.

Steam seemed to rise from his back with how much he moved.

Meanwhile, blood mixed with the sweat, creating red mist.

“The numbers are against us. It is not as easy as it appears,” Jegal Sung said.

Myung Am held his sword in one hand and said, “Indeed. If I knew this was going to happen, I would have long handed over command to my disciple.”

“Haha, I am better than you. I handed it over almost immediately.”

Around them were the corpses of seventy or so imperial guards. The blood dripped to the ground, both of their blades drenched. It was to the point that it was hard to determine what type of weapon it was.

Myung Am sighed at these words. “I should have brought a better blade.”

“Haha, I’m glad you can still joke.”

The Plum Blossom Divine Sword that Myung Am used was a keepsake handed down to each leader of the Mount Hua Sect. Despite cutting down dozens of soldiers, it was still sharp.

Jegal Sung burst into laughter. He was trembling, but not enough to be near death.

Still, even if he didn’t do anything, it seemed like he would collapse on the spot.

Seeing the pair, the chancellor flashed his teeth. “Scary bastards. I never imagined the power of Orthodox Murim to be so strong.”

“Haha, that is what Murim is all about. If you have the confidence, come out here and fight me.”

Jegal Sung provoked the chancellor like he wasn’t terribly exhausted.

The man ground his teeth. The chancellor was also a master of martial arts, but his techniques focused on the control of others and not pure qi.

Jegal Sung had discovered this fact during the fight, which was why he taunted the man.

“There are so many people who will die soon.”

That said, Myung Am raised his sword. “Will we be dying soon or will it be you?”

Clang-

As he spoke, he slaughtered one of the imperial guards aiming from behind. However, another one of the blades could not be avoided.

“Khh!”

A burning sensation traveled up his side. The pain seemed to flare and boil, but Myung Am did not pull out the blade.

If he prematurely removed the blade, he would only spill more blood.

Seeing that, Jegal Sung grimly said, “Without reinforcements, we will likely die.”

In response, the chancellor’s eyes shone red. “Isn’t that right?”

Yellow teeth were revealed in the dark. The man was laughing.

Jegal Sung said, “Did you not hear me? I meant only if nothing special happened.”

As he spoke, his eyes turned to the side. At the moment, he noted how the area surrounding the chancellor was strangely chaotic.

“Let’s go!”

“Let’s go inside!”

“Everyone, follow the Chief!”

The chancellor’s eyes shook.

There were still over a hundred imperial guards here. Of course, they were all under his command.

But it was not the guards who caused the commotion.

The man soon realized that the chaos was coming from outside.

“What!?”

The Chancellor turned his head in the direction of Jegal Sung’s gaze, startled.

At that moment!

Boom-boom!

The wooden gates collapsed and two men emerged from beyond it.

“Haha!”

Seeing them, Myung Am laughed. Although he did not turn around to face them, Jegal Sung also smiled.

“Look at that. We have reinforcements.”

“What can two lowly devils do?!” cried the chancellor.

The answer came from beyond the broken gates:

“What if it’s not just two migrants?”

At the end of the sentence, something rolled over the ground.

It was a human head.

A very familiar head to ‘Chancellor Young’.

As the head appeared, he squinted and muttered, “Chief Eunuch?”

“No. He is not the chief of the Bureau.”

A man walked through the door after the head.

The first two men bowed politely to him.

A crowd dressed in maroon robes followed behind the man. They wore uniforms, signifying they belonged to the same group.

“I am the chief of the Eastern Depot.”

Myung Am called out, “Eunuch Jo!”

The man smiled.

“It is a little late to regain control of my bureau. Thanks to you, I lost my seat...”

Reinforcements had appeared right at the moment of desperation.

Chapter 202: Behead The Emperor (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 202 – Behead the Emperor (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“That’s our cue, isn’t it?”

At Chief Jo’s words, the ‘Demon Sucking Evil Puppeteer’ ground his teeth.
“You’re still alive, Chief Jo?”

“As you can see, strings are not usually tough.”

“Somehow, no body was found...”

At the time, the Evil Puppeteer should have investigated more thoroughly.
He never thought the eunuch would come back with a vengeance.

But it was always too late for regret.

“I’ve come to live this way and rip your strings for not investigating harder back then,” Jo Woo-sang snarled.

“So much anger.”

Jo Woo-sang nodded. “Of course. The owner of the skin you’re wearing was my friend!”

“I didn’t know that Eunuch Jo and Dae Young were friends, how amazing!”

“Something like that. Opponents who understood each other better than anyone else, improving together! That was what Young-*gun* was to me!”

Kung-

Jo Woo-sang stepped forward. The stones beneath his feet trembled, floating into the air and flying forward.

“Hmph!”

The Puppeteer moved both his arms. The imperial guards, which moved as his faithful puppets, shuffled to stand in front of him.

Fwoo—

The stones and imperial guards collided with one another, pieces of rubble blasting in all directions.

“And so, I will take revenge. If that is all I can do, I need to see it through!”

“As you wish! Your dear Young’s swords will now begin the battle!”

After he finished speaking, the puppeteer leapt forward. Powerful energy flowed through his fingertips, tearing through the body of one of the Brocade Guards.

Puchi.

As the blood flowed, some of the Brocade Guards, including Oh Neung and Oh Sam, shouted loudly: “Follow the Chief!”

In succession, many who had once belonged to the Eastern Depot poured into the palace and tangled with the imperial guards. Thanks to the reinforcements, Jegal Sung and Myung Am let out sighs of relief.

In contrast, the Evil Puppeteer let out a furious roar, “You fucking cockroaches!”

Kwa-rung –

The red glare in the eyes of the imperial guards became brighter. At the same time, they began to move like waves.

The red glare of the gold Bladers has become stronger. At the same time, they start pouring in like waves.

“I’ll sweep them all away!”

“You make living in this world sound so easy!” Jo Woo-sang marched forward as he responded. The qi flowing from his hands was quite strong. “The world I live in is not so simple!”

Boom-

Jo Woo-sang, who stood against the wave of imperial soldiers, stood next to Jegal Sung and Myung Am.

Sage Myung nodded at the man, “You came at just the right moment.”

“I am glad I was not too late,” Chief Jo responded, then reported the situation. “On the way here, I seemed to see a fire in the direction of the tomb. It seems things are going as planned.”

“It is a bit unfortunate that I missed that, but I’m glad some of my goals were accomplished.”

At Jegal Sung’s words, Jo Woo-sang nodded.

“What about the situation with the throne room?”

Myung Am stabilized his breathing and knocked down one of the imperial guards. Then Jegal Sung took over and slashed the man with his fan.

Jo Woo-sang answered: “It seems that the ones to be sent near the throne room were the Cult Leader and King Jinseong. Considering the power of the Cult Leader, they should be able to handle it, but I sent fifty of my men towards the throne room. That was to reduce the stress on Do Jin-myung.”

“Good work. This place should be good enough with these people.”

Sage Myung gasped as he spoke. Although he was curious, his internal energy was reaching a low.

Jo Woo-sang handed Myung Am and Jegal Sung to pills. “You’re taking these.”

They were green pills, marble-sized and a little like grapes, or drops of jade. However, considering that the surrounding area was filled with blood mist, it was hard to tell what it was.

“This...?”

When Myung Am tilted his head in question, Jo Woo-sang answered, “An elixir made by the Eastern Depot. It won’t increase the total amount of internal qi, but it will help you recover your stamina at once.”

“Thank you.”

Jegal Sung took the medicine at once. Myung Am followed suit, chewing and swallowing the pill.

Just as Jo Woo-sang confidently said, their strength rapidly recovered.

This energy flowed through the hand gripping the swords.

The swords, which had been losing power, once again radiated a brilliant light.

A white light flowed out of Jegal Sung’s fan and sword; violet mist poured from Myung Am’s sword.

At the same time, there was Jo Woo-sang.

“Indeed.”

In this place, he would behead the man who had covered himself in the skin of Dae Young.

King Jinseong and Woon-seong, who had defeated the soldiers in front of them, rushed onwards.

Of course, that did not mean that no one tried to stop them.

But...

Clang-

“Ow!”

“Cough!”

There was no one who was able to take one of Woon-seong’s hits.

Woon-seong climbed over the palace walls.

“Release the arrows!”

At that moment, the archers waiting below shot arrows. Dozens of arrows soared upwards, aiming for Woon-seong.

At the same time, Woon-seong swung his spear.

Shua-

With a short and resonant sound, the White Night Spear was like the wind on a silent night.

Fwoo-

The Divine Flame spread like a river. Like wings unfurling, the flames devoured and burned the flying arrows.

Subsequently, spear qi and burning arrows rained down on the soldiers.

Rain of Star Destruction.

Boom!

This heavy rainfall, which included even flaming stardust, slammed into the ground.

“Aah!”

“Uagh!”

The archers were swept into chaos and lost their lives.

Behind him, King Jinseong crossed the wall and a pitying expression flitted across his face.

Despite the circumstances, all of the dead archers were men valuable to the imperial court.

They would not have lost their lives if not for the current situation.

Why have we reached the point where we need to bathe the imperial palace in blood?

Perhaps Woon-seong had read King Jinseong’s thoughts. He turned towards the building and spoke with a hardened expression, “It is too early to be emotional.”

At Woon-seong’s words, King Jinseong snapped out of his musings. It was as Woon-seong said.

The Palace of Heavenly Purity was right in front of him, and all of this would only be finished if he entered and killed the man wearing the Emperor’s skin.

Woon-seong extended his senses. He detected some people hiding inside.

They were in a straight line around the throne; all archers with bows in their hands.

Archers who were willing to shoot and kill those who were headed there, no matter who it was.

But...

“Hmph!”

Woon-seong snorted. Then, in an instant, he flew through the air and into the throne room.

The throne caught his eye. At the same time, dozens of arrows flew towards Woon-seong.

Pavat-

Energy filled the air.

Woon-seong spun through the air. A powerful gust of energy rose around him, slamming into the arrows.

Voodoo-

The arrows swirled through the air, snapping and plunging back to the ground.

Even the sound, the emperor sat upon the Dragon Throne with a blank expression. Woon-seong was only two steps away from the throne!

Fuabababa-

More arrows flew into the air. Woon-seong moved his left hand.

Rrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrr!

With a thundering sound, transparent blades filled the air, similar to the Mind Sword.

They thundered through the rain of arrows, weaving around them like a net.

Lost in the net, the arrows lost all power and dropped to the floor.

Furverbuck-

One step left!

Pavat-

Woon-seong hit the ground. In a moment, the distance to the Emperor's throne was narrowed.

Another batch of arrows flew into the air.

“Hehe!”

Woon-seong raised the White Night Spear and the Divine Flame blazed across his back.

Fwoom-

A huge flame enveloped the hall. The arrows flying towards Woon-seong melted in midair.

And finally, the moment the White Night Spear lifted into the air, wreathed in flames — it fell!

Fwua-

The emperor's body was sliced in two.

The severed head flew into the air, rolling under the throne.

Gulooloo-

Blood gushed from the wound.

Finally, Woon-seong had cut the Inverted Sky Lord's head.

Seeing the scene, Woon-seong became a bit puzzled.

It was too easy.

Like he said, it had been too easy.

His instincts screamed and signaled that something was wrong.

And...

A sword at least ten meters in length was swung from outside the hall.

Kuakuakua-

The hall collapsed.

“Oh my god...” King Jinseong, who had been outside the hall, muttered to himself. *I never thought such a large building would collapse from a single sword.*

King Jinseong turned his head, expression still shocked. He saw the face of the man who had collapsed the building in one strike.

A young man with white hair and fair skin.

Although handsome, it felt like he would be difficult to approach, giving off a sharp presence.

Did he feel King Jinseong’s gaze?

The young man turned his head and smiled.

Within that smile, King Jinseong felt the shadow of death.

If we gave the intangible thing called Death a shape and called a skilled sculptor to mold it into human form, wouldn’t it look like him?

The young man’s red eyes caught his attention.

A group of people, dressed in green uniforms, crowded behind the young man.

“What happened to that demon?”

It was Peng Ga-hyuk, head of the Peng Clan, and the main strike force of the Peng Clan, the Tyrant King Troops.

Instead of answering the question, the white-haired man pointed down with his finger. “You there, do you know who I am?”

After a few beats of silence, King Jinseong woke from his stupor when the young man spoke with look of genuine disappointment:

“I am disappointed, brother. You don’t recognize me.”

As he spoke, King Jinseong seemed to have been jolted by lightning. He then muttered the man’s identity with a hollow expression:

“Could it be the Inverted Sky Lord?”

Krrrrrrrrr!

A man walked out of the collapsed building, turning it into ashes.

The white-haired man, the Inverted Sky Lord, smiled brightly, just as he had done with King Jinseong. He told the man walking out of the burning building, “Your life is very tough. I would like to end it myself.”

These words were filled with liveliness and amusement.

Woon-seong shrugged off the ashes piled on his shoulders. “I was going to say the same thing at first, but it is really unpleasant to agree with you.”

To Woon-seong’s words, the Inverted Sky Lord smiled brightly and replied, looking like a pure child.

“I told you. I remembered you.”

Chapter 203: Final Battle (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 203 – Final Battle (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

When Woon-seong heard the voice, he tightly gripped the White Night Spear.

“Inverted Sky Lord.”

The white-haired man chuckled. “Yes, that’s me.”

It was a creepy smile. Even though it was just a smile, it seemed to contain all of the sins of the world.

Woon-seong lifted his energy and took away the smile’s effects. “You are a bit different from what I’ve heard—”

It was then.

“Come out and die!”

The Inverted Sky Lord frowned at the cry coming from behind him.

Peng Ga-hyuk continued to shout at Woon-seong without realizing the frown: “What have you done to my son?!”

Woon-seong looked at the man. He glanced at the uniform and the unusual size of the man. “So it’s the Peng Clan. By your son, are you referring to Peng Hak?”

“Yes, my son, whom you have taken captive!”

Woon-seong laughed. “You don’t seem to be familiar with the situation. I don’t know what happened to your son.”

At Woon-seong’s words, tension seemed to rise from Peng Ga-hyuk. “Hey, you!”

“He’s probably lost his head by now.”

“Aaah! Heavenly Demonnnnn!”

As he screamed, Peng Ga-hyuk flew forward, swinging his blade. Woon-seong swung the White Night Spear in response.

There was a huge collision. After that enormous noise,

“Grrrgh!”

There was a clear view of who had suffered the loss.

Whereas Woon-seong stood on the ashen building, Peng Ga-hyuk’s body had been bounced back as fast as he came.

The man flew back towards the rest of the Peng Clan.

“Grrr!”

With that, he dug a long furrow into the ground.

Was that all his strength amounted to? The man stretched his arms, trying to rush back towards Woon-seong.

Someone stopped him.

“Stop it.”

As soon as the Inverted Sky Lord put a hand on him, Peng Ga-hyuk froze. The sensation of a sword pointing at his corpse filled him with cold sweat.

“If you’d given me a chance to speak, you’d understand. You can’t win against him.”

The Inverted SKy Lord smiled, making eye contact with Peng Ga-hyuk. Even as an ally, Peng Ga-hyuk trembled under that eerie gaze.

“So I told you from the beginning. You deal with the rest of them.”

As soon as he said that, eunuchs from the Eastern Depot appeared behind King Jinseong.

“You guys...”

“Your Majesty!”

“Chief Jo sent us!”

Looking at the new arrivals, the Inverted Sky Lord said, “See? You’ve got things to deal with.”

The Inverted Sky Lord’s face was calm and arrogant.

However, Peng Ga-hyuk, who was still frozen by the man’s eyes, couldn’t harden his expression. Rather, he was getting more pale. He was just that afraid of the Inverted Sky Lord.

“Oh, I understand.”

Peng Ga-hyuk nodded his head with difficulty and the Inverted Sky Lord smiled brightly.

“As you should.”

Then, he lifted his hand and patted Peng Ga-hyuk on the head.

Some of the warriors of the Peng Clan reached for their swords as they saw their clan head being humiliated. Rather, it seemed like they were about to attack the emperor.

Their qi slammed into the Inverted Sky Lord.

However, the Inverted Sky Lord turned around without any response. He scattered the qi with a light motion, like swatting a fly.

“Quiet now.”

The Tyrant King Troops rushed towards their clan head with grim expressions. One of the elders of the Peng Clan amongst them, whispered to Peng Ga-hyuk: “Though we are members of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, we are not his servants but his trading partners. This is outrageous!”

Peng Ga-hyuk shook his head. He then raised his hand and touched his eyes, “No, no.”

In his mind, he could still see the grisly face of the Inverted Sky Lord.

In his mind, he could still feel death.

Death that could not be escaped.

The existence of the grim reaper, who would come at the moment of defiance.

“Did I tell you that a Semi-Divine Being is a man who has shaken off his mortal husk and stepped into the threshold of the divine?”

Then that should hold true for this white-haired monster.

But was it?

The energy from the white-haired man seemed to kill all the light in the world. His surroundings turned colorless.

Nevertheless, the man himself was shining white. A white light colder than an ice sheet.

Looking at the light, Peng Ga-hyuk chewed on his lips.

Suddenly, there was a word that popped into his head.

“A Divine Being?”

Peng Ga-hyuk said these words subconsciously.

This was a level so unreachable that there were no more than five of them throughout the entire history of Murim.

It was not simply shaking off the mortal husk and stepping into the divine threshold, but to be born a human and raised into a deity.

Maybe the Inverted Sky Lord was walking towards that wall. Of course, he would not be a perfect Divine Being.

But what if he was halfway there?

At that level, no matter how strong the Cult of the Heavenly Demon and the World Ending Heavenly Demon were, they would be no match.

“We, we should not think about the lord.”

At the words of Peng Ga-hyuk, the others titled their heads. He turned away, ignoring their gazes.

“Like the lord said, we’d better deal with the others.”

Peng Ga-hyuk firmly gripped his blade. The palms of his hands were already slick with sweat. There was no need to explain why they were damp.

Sping-

Peng Ga-hyuk and the Tyrant King Troops stood in front of the Brocade Guard and blades of the Eastern Depot.

Peng Ga-hyuk raised his blade and settled it over his shoulders. “So it is time for us to deal with the rebels.”

King Jinseong drew his sword. “Bastard. You don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Although the Tyrant King Troops were said to be the elite of the Peng, the blades of the Eastern Depot had also been groomed into fighting machines.

They were the ones who had been his strength even after the true Jo Woo-sang had hidden away.

These two forces collided in quick succession.

Qi danced through the air.

Peng Ga-hyuk stared at King Jinseong. “Can you handle it?”

“You should worry about yourself.”

Energy rose around Peng Ga-hyuk’s forearms. Tendrils of qi writhed on his forearms, which were thicker than the waist of an average woman. “I am actually very angry right now. I may be a little violent.”

“I have also lost someone I did not want to lose. I need to take out this anger somewhere. I can’t believe the opponent is also losing his mind.”

Clan Head Peng grunted. He then came up to King Jinseong, his gaze on the men behind. “Obviously they’re hard working men, so they don’t lack any imperial affiliations.”

“The Imperial Palace is usually a little prejudiced when it comes to this kind of work.”

Peng Ga-hyuk nodded. He had to admit that.

But...

“By the way, do you think they can handle me?”

Suddenly, his momentum skyrocketed, growing large as a giant’s.

Peng Ga-hyuk was ranked as the first amongst the elites known as the 72 Supreme Masters.

He was clearly a difficult opponent for King Jinseong, who was about the same level as someone just barely on the edge of the 72 Supreme Masters.

No, it wasn’t just difficult.

Even two King Jinseong’s wouldn’t be enough.

But King Jinseong did not provoke this man without thought.

“Do you really think so?”

A voice from somewhere; a group of people slowly approached King Jinseong.

A young man in bloody scholar robes.

An older man with five plum blossoms embroidered on his sleeves.

And a eunuch spilling creepy qi from his hands.

The man recognized who they were.

“The Venerable Dragon, the Plum Blossom Swordsman, and Chief Jo of the Eastern Depot.”

After killing all the imperial guards who had been manipulated by the fake chancellor, the group came here after beheading the man.

Of course, they were a little tired in the process.

But even so, they could not be ignored!

King Jinseong welcomed them, “You’ve come at the right time.”

“Haha, I’m a little tired, but I have to finish the job.”

At the words of these men, Peng Ga-hyuk ground his teeth. Some worried that their clan head would crack a tooth.

King Jinseong asked, “What about the Twin Stars?”

“They destroyed the tomb made from the Palace of Heavenly Purity. Immediately after that, they rushed off.” Myung Am paused, then added, “No, they said they were going after Hong Bin.”

“Then all that is left is the enemy here.”

King Jinseong turned his head, smiling brightly. He then showed a full smile towards Peng Ga-hyuk.

“Don’t I have a shot?”

It was self-confident, but he deserved to say it. They were tired, but all of these people were masters in their own right.

Even a tyrant would have to risk his life.

However, Peng Ga-hyuk did not intend to retreat like this.

Ugh. He grit his teeth and raised his blade.

“Listen to me!”

“Fifty members of the Tyrant King Troops, we listen to the Lord’s command!”

Peng Ga-hyuk pointed his blade at King Jinseong.

“These men are allied with the demons who have slaughtered our direct descendant. Do not let any of them return alive!”

In response, the fifty members of the Tyrant King Troop raised their voices, raising their own blades: “Yes, sir!”

And, as if in response, King Jinseong raised his own sword high in a cry: “I am here today to wipe out the sinners of the Inverted Sky and set things right!”

At the end of these words, the two forces collided.

Kuakuakua-

Clang-

Crash-

Boom-

Clang-

Loud noises rang out as the men crashed into each other.

The white-haired man smiled brightly, as if the noise was pleasant.

Woon-seong told the Inverted Sky Lord, “Everything you have been preparing so far has been for nothing. I hope you watch carefully.”

The Inverted Sky Lord continued to smile brightly. He responded in a sinister voice:

“Do you really think so?”

The question of whether or not he really thought so seemed to reverberate in Woon-seong’s mind. This was more of a rhetorical question, but Woon-seong could tell.

“You...”

Everything that had happened so far was just in passing for the Inverted Sky Lord. The subordinates who followed him, the Cult of the Inverted Sky itself — everything was like a whim he had acted on as he passed by.

The Inverted Sky Lord smiled wider and said, as if proving Woon-seong's thoughts true:

“That is what power is. That is what strength is. That is its purpose. Something that can be consumed by other people if necessary. I am a powerful man, and they are just supplies. That is all.”

It was a creepy, cold, and ruthless bright white smile.

TN: Sorry, I'm going to be taking about a 2 week break due to my exams. The novel has been translated to completion on Buy Me A Coffee. Good luck to anyone else taking exams!

Chapter 204: Final Battle (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 204 – Final Battle (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

TN: I have slogged through my exams 😊 ! I am also working on the extra chapters for CHD, so those will be up on Buy Me A Coffee soon.

“Heeheeheeheeheehee.”

The Inverted Sky Lord laughed with his arms spread wide. At that moment, there was a repulsive force and his body hovered about an inch off the ground.

While in that state, the Inverted Sky Lord laughed wild and free. He tilted his head down, making eye contact with Woon-seong.

The man made an imposing figure, but Woon-seong did not turn away. Instead, he returned the look with his own smile.

Huiying-

The Inverted Sky Lord’s laughter contained a strange power, so it could not be resisted without the use of internal qi.

“Heeheeheeheeheeheeheeheeheehee.”

Whether he realized the effect of his laughter or not, the Inverted Sky Lord laughed ceaselessly. Then, as if he suddenly remembered something, he pointed at Woon-seong.

“By the way, what were you going to say earlier?”

“Earlier...?”

Woon-seong immediately thought back to what he was saying before Peng Ga-hyuk’s shouting cut him off. Then, he looked at the Inverted Sky Lord, who stood as a white-haired man amongst an achromatic world.

“Just that you look a lot different from what I’ve heard.”

To this point, the Inverted Sky Lord smiled brightly, like a child who had just been praised for his new clothes. “Hehehe. Do you think so? I like this body quite a lot too.”

“I heard you were wearing the skin of the Emperor.”

“It was like that, but it was just a tool. I used it and threw it away once it got old.”

King Jinseong, who was engaged in a fierce battle with the imperial guards, cried out, “Inverted Sky Lorddddddd!”

It was a voice filled with anger.

That was natural. The Emperor, the body the Inverted Sky Lord had discarded, was King Jinseong’s brother.

He had to be angry.

In response to King Jinseong’s fury, the Inverted Sky Lord waved his hand lightly.

“Oh, shut up.”

At that moment, a powerful white aura shot from the Inverted Sky Lord's hands and struck King Jinseong in the shoulder.

“Ahhh!”

King Jinseong screamed, grabbing his shoulder. The area where the white light hit burned brightly, then seemed to disintegrate.

“Huagh-huah-hagh-huagh.”

And soon, his left arm was completely gone. The one-armed King Jinseong fell to his knees and vomited.

“That wouldn't have happened if you'd just been quiet. I am still the elder.” The Inverted Sky Lord smiled, like an innocent child who had just ripped off the wings of a dragonfly. “Isn't that right, little brother?”

An evil spirit that erased a man's arm with a smile. One who could laugh and kill a man in jest.

Swallowing his brooding, Woon-seong asked, “Where did you get that body?”

“Ah, you mean this body?”

The man glanced down at his body, which was basically glowing white. His pupils spun.

It was a nauseating scene, but the man didn't care at all.

“Made it.”

“Made it?”

The word ‘made’ caught in Woon-seong's throat like a thorn. He did not understand what ‘making a body’ meant.

That was why Woon-seong tilted his head in confusion.

The Inverted Sky Lord explained as if he no longer had anything to hide: “You already know about the puppets right? You probably know very well. I’m sure you would’ve fought with them a few times. Then, why did I name them ‘Divine *Gu*’?”

The man flew up into the air as he asked. He seemed like a pure child, roaming the air.

Each time he spun, the world around him would gradually grow colorless.

It seemed like a gray light of despair flowed from the man’s body, drenching the world.

Perhaps the glow of the man’s body was possible because he breathed despair and absorbed all hope into his own body.

“Think about it. Divine corpse puppets are obviously strong, but I raised them like *Gu*. Why is that?”

The Inverted Sky Lord suddenly spoke about a poison called *Gu*.

Gu was produced by placing dozens of toxic beings — spiders, scorpions, snakes, etc — into a jar. Inside the jar, these toxins would devour each other, kill each other, and nurture the toxicity level until there was only one poison left: the one that took on all the energy of the other poisons, killing them all and rebirthing into a powerful *Gu*.

And did the man know about Woon-seong’s sudden thoughts about these *Gu*?

Probably.

The Inverted Sky Lord’s eyes turned into crescents as he chuckled, “So you understand. That’s right.” The man stopped flitting about in the air. Instead, he turned to look in the direction of the tomb and said, “I made over ten corpse puppets and made them fight each other.”

His voice changed into one of seriousness, unlike when he had been playing around.

If it had been that of a playful child's until now, the voice was now a heavy bass. It was like the person itself had changed.

“The body I am using right now is the sole survivor of that fight.”

The man gently patted his body with his fingertips. “Should I name them Divine Corpse Puppet *Gu*?”

Divine Corpse Puppet *Gu*.

Woon-seong shuddered at the name, since it meant that the Inverted Sky Lord had created *Gu* using the corpses of deities.

Woon-seong had fought with the corpse puppets himself, and even then, just one was terrifyingly strong.

But *Gu* had been made with these corpse puppets?

He had no idea how powerful the evil born from it could be.

“The Divine Corpse Puppets were just a byproduct of my plan to build my body, hahaha. My soul is strong and I needed a new body to withstand it. The Emperor's skin was only used for a short time, since I needed a body to sit in for a while. Besides, the body of the Emperor seemed to be more comfortable than I first thought.”

“Huh-huh-huh-huh.”

To his words, King Jinseong held his severed arm and wept bitterly.

The emperor of this land, this massive stretch of land, had been used by this man like a tool. King Jinseong couldn't bear to stand this thought without wanting to cry or vomit.

Woon-seong did not lose his temper, but he understood King Jinseong's feelings. It was as if his two masters had simply disappeared, byproducts of this plan.

The Inverted Sky Lord observed Woon-seong. For just a short moment, a red glow came into his eyes. Soon, the Inverted Sky Lord tilted his head and asked, “And why are *you* different in body and soul?”

At that moment, Woon-seong jolted as if he had been struck by lightning. It was as if the Inverted Sky Lord had seen right through him.

The truth that no one — other than Woon-seong himself — had ever known was just revealed!

“What do you mean?”

Woon-seong pretended not to understand.

This time, the Inverted Sky Lord’s voice sounded like a woman swooning. “Yes, I see. You, as well as being of the Sky Demon, were also a descendant of the Spear Sky. You did something that no human could do!”

The man chuckled.

Almost just as quickly, his giggling stopped, lips curling to reveal creepy teeth. The teeth were sharp and cutting, like a beast’s.

He clenched his teeth and whispered to Woon-seong from a great distance:

“You’ve lived twice.”

Woon-seong trembled.

He had met many enemies so far and faced many life or death crises, but he had never been more terrified.

No, had he ever felt the fear of death since he rose to Semi-Divinity? Even though he had approached it before, he would press it away somehow with his transcendent will.

But...

Now that transcendent will did not listen to its master.

His legs were trembling.

Subconsciously, the Inverted Sky Lord continued to mumble: “Well, how did you live twice? A man can’t do that, so how did you do that?”

He narrowed his eyes. A red glare swept Woon-seong’s body once more.

And soon, the Inverted Sky Lord smiled brightly. His voice turned back into one of a child.

“Wow, you’ve got something good.”

His gaze was on Woon-seong’s chest.

To be precise, it was on the necklace hanging at Woon-seong’s chest.

He was looking at the artifact of the Spear Master Sect.

“I am sick of this sect!”

At that moment, Woon-seong recalled a story told by the Buddhist and Sword Stars.

Before the Soul Sky walked the path of the Inverted Sky, before he walked the evil and unorthodox path, the Soul Sky had given one of his belongings to the Spear Sky.

An item said to belong to a deity — a necklace.

And so the necklace Woon-seong was wearing had once belonged to the Soul Sky!

That made sense.

It was creepy, appalling.

The Soul Sky was an existence in pursuit of Nirvana. Wasn’t it odd that his belonging exerted a power that allowed someone to live once again?

The Inverted Sky Lord could barely stand still, his legs and hands twitching. He then turned towards Woon-seong and positively drooled.

It was like a child with delicious ice cream in front of him.

Like a child deciding whether or not to eat the ice cream, whether or not the ice cream would be delicious.

No, it seemed like he was deciding whether to save the ice cream for later or to devour it now. Either way, he wanted to extend his arms and latch onto Woon-seong.

This feeling was clearly conveyed.

Soon, the Inverted Sky Lord laughed brightly, reaching a decision.

“Since I’m sick of this sect having this relic, I should retrieve it. Right?”

He reached out. His hand swept towards Woon-seong like a huge net.

The moment he faced this hand, alarm bells blared in Woon-seong’s mind.

As the Inverted Sky Lord said, this necklace may have once been a sacred relic belonging to the Soul Sky.

But at the same time, it was the last inheritance left to Woon-seong by the Spear Sky, ancestor of the Spear Master Sect.

He did not want that legacy to be taken away.

No, it should not be taken away!

Woon-seong conveyed this will through his whole body.

The qi swirling through his body, along with the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, represented his will. A manifestation of the transcendent will that had freed Woon-seong from countless death threats so far!

Fear receded when it touched this will. At the same time, Woon-seong was filled with the Tempered True Blossom. Along with the Divine Flame, Intimidation Qi seeped out.

A gray stream spread over the flames.

Every texture of the Heavenly Demon's practice, including the Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, the Tempered Orthodox Qi, and the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon all wrapped around Woon-seong's body.

Huiying-

Meanwhile, the Inverted Sky Lord's palm became enormous, covering the sky as he came to grab at Woon-seong.

Woon-seong's feet slammed into the floor.

Pak-

Hyuk Woon-seong was pushed back.

At the same time, the Inverted Sky Lord's hand was also pushed back.

"Huh?" The Inverted Sky Lord widened his eyes, as if surprised. But he soon smiled, "How annoying. It seems that one hand is not enough."

Both of the Inverted Sky Lord's hands came at Woon-seong.

Kuakuakua-!

Chapter 205: Divinity (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 205 – Divinity (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

“Amitabha.”

The Buddhist Star sighed as they followed the traces of Hong Bin, leaving the Tomb of the Martial Gods behind.

Next to him, the swordsman also sighed, “Where on earth is he hiding?”

“I don’t think he ever learned martial arts, but he sure prepared well for his escape.”

Indeed, Prime Minister Hong Bin had prepared very thoroughly for his escape. That way, in case something like this happened, he could immediately extract himself from danger.

His preparations were so thorough that even the Buddhist Star and Sword Stars were unable to follow his trail, as it cut off in the middle.

“Hmm.”

Even if you hadn’t learned martial arts, if you rose to a position of royalty, you could prepare this much with just authority alone.

It showed how refined status was compared to strength.

The Sword Star tried to find more traces of Hong Bin with his eyes, but sighed after a few moments.

“Hah...”

“Amitabha.”

“Looks like he prepared well. Since he joined the Cult of the Inverted Sky, I assume he would be smart enough to stay low until this all rolls over.”

The preparation of the inherently corrupt officials was usually this thorough.

“How about we stop pursuing him and return to the Imperial Palace to finish off the rest?”

The Sword Star nodded his head.

No, he was about to nod.

If it weren't for the gray energy suddenly watering the sky, he would have done so.

Kukuku-

The Twin Stars turned their heads in unison.

Heaven went colorless.

The sunset sky turned gray.

All the gloom in the world seemed to rise up and flood the sky.

Such deep hopelessness that it was impossible to drown out.

It was an attack called Despair.

“What the...!”

“What in the world...”

The Twin Stars were both surprised by the sight.

The source of such despair flowed from the imperial court.

It seemed to be from the Palace of Supreme Harmony, in the deepest part of the Imperial Palace.

If it was the throne room, wasn't that where the Inverted Sky Lord was?

What in the world was going on over there for such despair to be pouring out?

The Twin Stars frowned and trembled, almost subconsciously.

The Buddhist Star could not hide his tremor as he prayed. “Ah, Amitabha.”

The swordsman grabbed his blade and said, “Hmph. I don't know what's going on, but I'm definitely going back to the Imperial Palace.”

As soon as the swordsman said that, the pair turned and began to head back towards the palace.

Where the gray despair flowed from, two huge hands scrambled for Woon-seong.

Woon-seong barely dodged and avoided the hands.

He slipped through the man's fingers, rolling across the floor to avoid the offensive.

Every time the palms cut through the air, they would scratch the ground.

Kuang-

The ground split apart, fissuring like during an earthquake.

A crevice appeared in the spot where Woon-seong had just been. If he hadn't somersaulted and dodged, he would have been split just like the ground.

It gave him goosebumps.

There was no shame in avoiding an offensive by rolling around.

No, Woon-seong didn't even think about things like that.

Woon-seong's robes were already soaked in sweat.

At the same time, laughter bubbled from within him.

What a big difference.

It wasn't like the Inverted Sky Lord was using sorcery or martial skills. He was simply spreading his energy to swell his hands, then grabbing for Woon-seong.

They were light movements, like swatting at a fly.

However, there was no way for Woon-seong to resist even those casual movements.

A storm raged from those fingertips and all Woon-seong could do in front of the ruthless offensive was dodge with all his might.

The existence of the Inverted Sky Lord was just that overwhelming.

Woon-seong grit his teeth.

What does that say about all of my efforts so far?

He had lived one life as a disciple of the Spearmaster Nok Yu-on.

And at the last moment, he had lost his life in vain, unable to remove the sins framed on his master.

And then what?

After that, he was brought back to life by a strange force.

Not as a disciple of Spearmaster Nok Yu-on, but as Hyuk Woon-seong of the Cave of Latent Demons.

He thought opportunity had come once again.

He thought that the Heavens had once again given him a chance to take revenge.

So he worked tirelessly.

He trained in the Cave of Latent Demons with all of his strength and graduated from the Cave of Latent Demons with greater achievements than anyone else.

And then what?

In order to gain access to the power of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, he built a foundation for his rise as a Demon.

He increased his skills and accumulated achievements. And finally, he was able to ascend to the position of Young Leader.

But wait a minute.

The group that had harmed Spearmaster Nok Yu-on, his former master, was the same one that caused him to lose the Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon.

And so Cheon Hwi added to Woon-seong sadness, for despite starting off as hoping to merely use him, Woon-seong had been touched by the man's true heart.

And that was why he pledged vengeance without expressing his sorrows.

He had allied with the Orthodox Murim and the Twin Stars, even King Jinseong was a partner — and now Woon-seong was here.

In the process, the truth of Master Nok Yu-on's sacrifice had even been brought to light.

And now, with just his last step for vengeance left, Woon-seong seemed to be facing a wall he couldn't resist.

He felt crappy.

The decades of hard work he had put into reaching this point were being denied all at once — useless.

“Hmm, you aren't getting caught.”

Woon-seong could hear the Inverted Sky Lord.

Whether he could understand Woon-seong's thoughts or not, the Inverted Sky Lord moved his hands to grab Woon-seong, to grab the artifact of the Spear Master Sect hanging around his neck.

Light movements, like catching a fly.

Did he come all the way here just to fight against movements like this?

For decades, he had tried so hard just to face this situation!

No.

Woon-seong gripped the White Night Spear.

He could see the palm coming.

The huge palms were coming at him from the left and right, as if trying to clap him between the palms.

Woon-seong grit his teeth.

I will not fall like this.

Even if his muscles tore and his bones broke, he would land the hit.

The plum tree withers in place of the peach tree, or maybe cut one's own flesh in order to cut the other's bones [1].

No

It would more appropriate to say that those two phrases meant the same thing.

In order to avenge his two masters, Hyuk Woon-seong was prepared to lay down his life.

Hadn't he decided to live for revenge in the first place?

Yeah. It was a waste of my life.

As he prepared to die for his vengeance, Woon-seong regretted that he had accumulated so much.

Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

The status of the head of the force which occupied half of the world.

Everything he had attained so far!

Woon-seong set them all down.

Then, he confirmed everything one by one.

He took a step.

It was a very light step.

With that step, Woon-seong penetrated through the palms that came towards him.

He took a second step.

These two steps contained everything.

The Heavenward Soul Earthen Body, the Dark Flower Red Soul.

The Tempered Orthodox Qi, the Divine Art of the Heavenly Demon.

The Divine Spear of the Ending Night, the Art of Six Seals and Destruction.

The Flow of the Divine Dragon, a skill he had completed successfully.

He pushed them all into the White Night Spear.

The techniques sleeping within Woon-seong's mind shook.

An enormous amount of martial knowledge flooded in from the recesses of his memory.

Woon-seong did not leave anything out.

Without any filtration, he shoved all of his strength into the spear.

The techniques and skills that could not be united were forcibly mixed together.

Repulsion and attraction occurred simultaneously.

These swirled and wove together into a group of nine-hundred and ninety-nine techniques!

Woon-seong's body was like a storm.

“One Thousand Absolute Routes!”

Along with the shout, energy poured from Woon-seong's body.

999 strokes slammed into the palms coming towards him.

Kuakuakua-

Holding out his hands, the Inverted Sky Lord looked surprised by the huge repulsive force approaching.

“Huh?”

He was surprised by the unexpected counterattack.

Woon-seong did not miss the gap.

Woon-seong collected all of the remaining power in his body and smashed into the turbulence created by ‘One Thousand Absolute Routes’.

Kuakuakua-

What was a violent rainstorm became a galactic storm.

As the river of stars flowed, they battered against the Inverted Sky Lord’s palms, finally piercing through them.

Boom!

Not slowing down, the river of stars slammed into the Inverted Sky Lord’s body.

With the White Night Spear in hand, Woon-seong did not miss this scene.

The Inverted Sky Lord was clearly caught up in ‘One Thousand Absolute Routes’.

That was what Woon-seong thought.

At that moment!

Fwoom!

Gray energy spilled through the thousand strokes of stardust.

Hopelessness.

Despair from the devil named the Inverted Sky Lord pushed the stream of stars apart.

No, it was not just pushing. It was causing the galaxy to shatter and crumble.

The power in those thousand strokes dissipated.

Then the Inverted Sky Lord walked out intact.

“Heeheehee.”

He smiled brightly, “That was fun. Anything else?”

That counterattack was an ant’s counterattack, at best. And ants could not fell an elephant, no matter how much they resisted.

The Inverted Sky Lord’s bright laughter seemed to break Woon-seong’s will.

“Heeheeheeheeheeheeheehee.”

The Buddhist and Sword Star ran without rest.

Of course, their destination was where that gray light of despair had originated.

They felt like they had to go there.

They felt like they *had* to see what was going on there.

So they rushed there and they could finally see what was happening in the midst of despair.

That terrible sight...

“Heeheeheehee, heeheeheeheehee.”

A young man glowing in white was bursting with laughter, seeming very lively.

Ashen despair poured from his body.

No one needed to say it, for it was obvious he was the Inverted Sky Lord.

And as he smiled and laughed, he clutched someone in bloodied robes within his grasp.

The Inverted Sky Lord spoke in a child's voice:

“Why no more? You don't want to show me something more interesting?”

His voice turned into that of a middle-aged man.

“Is that really all? Then, I'm disappointed...”

Right after that, it became that of an angered woman.

“Why don't you try a little harder?! This is your last chance, isn't it?!”

Nevertheless, the man in his hands was limp as a doll, showing no sign of movement. He was still breathing, but was as unresponsive as a corpse.

“Well, there's poison in your body. Even if I leave you alone, you'll die soon. No more fun.”

The Inverted Sky Lord huffed at the man, then tossed him aside.

As the identity of the unresponsive man was revealed, the Buddhist Star subconsciously prayed.

“Amitabha.”

The Inverted Sky Lord responded to the sound, head snapping towards the sky. He then smiled brightly, pupils spinning widely and glaring red.

“Hmn?”

His voice changed again. It was the voice of a child, like earlier.

“Is there a new toy again?”

The man tossed onto the ground...

He was the Leader of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, the Semi-Divine Being named Hyuk Woon-seong.

[1] two four character idioms used: (1) the plum tree withers in place of the peach tree (李代桃僵) = to substitute one thing for another; (2) to cut one's own flesh in order to cut the other's bones (肉斬骨端) = to pay a small price in exchange for victory

TN: Oh how I want to stall at this cliffhanger 😊

Chapter 206: Divinity (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 206 – Divinity (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

There was a dull ringing in his ears.

It was so loud that he couldn't understand what those around him were talking about.

But thanks to the ringing, Woon-seong was just barely conscious.

He then tried to remember the current situation.

What was I doing?

Thoughts did not immediately come to mind.

As time passed and his consciousness became clearer, the situation became more clear.

Oh, right. I was fighting.

No, it wasn't correct to say that they had been fighting. Woon-seong had been toyed with.

He had nearly died in front of the Inverted Sky Lord, an almost insurmountable enemy.

It seemed like death was near.

There was no strength left in his body; he couldn't even move.

No, he only seemed to have lost his physical body.

His soul, his consciousness floating about, continued to sense and think.

Am I going to die like this?

In that sense, Woon-seong recognized death.

He didn't have the strength to lift even a finger. The poison, which he had been barely suppressing, coarsed about as his internal energy was eaten away.

Maybe it was because he had been holding back for too long. Or perhaps it was because his body was abnormal.

The poison, which was originally strong, felt even more toxic.

At this rate...

Within half an hour, he would be dead.

Just like his master, Spearmaster Nok Yu-on, was — poisoned.

Just like his second master, the Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon, was — poisoned.

Master?

At that moment, a few things suddenly passed through his mind.

After Nok Yu-on's image, the image of Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon Chun Hwi also appeared in his head.

If I die like this, who will avenge them?

Oh, move, move, move body!

Please move so I can take revenge.

Woon-seong's consciousness focused on that thought with all of its might.

Every last bit of power he had left.

However, the body did not listen to him, as if it had already died.

Nevertheless, Woon-seong did not give up.

He did everything he could think of.

All the phrases he knew, including prayers, flashed through his mind.

Woon-seong focused his efforts on finding a way to reanimate his body for a short while.

Throughout the process, thousands of spirits — inheritances, skills, techniques — were caught in the tide.

Woon-seong's spirit was literally a sea of martial arts.

He slowly stirred this sea.

Whirlpools began to form.

He also remembered the last move he had used against the Inverted Sky Lord.

He had said that it was One Thousand Absolute Routes, but there had only been nine-hundred and ninety-nine.

Despite the name, the number had not reached 1000.

Was I short one?

Whoo-hoo!

The Divine Flame inside Woon-seong's body began to crackle and burn.

The martial arts inside of his head began to form a mountain, waves battering against itself.

Only one more route was needed to complete One Thousand Absolute Routes.

It seemed like his body could rise once again.

Woon-seong wasn't sure of it. It was just a hunch, but there was nothing else he could do, so Woon-seong left everything up to uncertainty.

By focusing on his consciousness, he reduced his physical body's strength in hopes that it would help as a whole.

Repetitively building and breaking mountains within his martial sea, he gathered different types of martial arts.

Build up and break down.

Use only the best.

Take what is needed and exclude what is not.

The moment was long and repetitive, yet it was fleeting.

Woon-seong had no idea how much time had passed.

This all happened within the timespace of Woon-seong's consciousness in the first place.

And in that moment, Woon-seong found something.

I see.

Got it.

In order to achieve revenge, it was not a thousand techniques that were necessary to advance to new heights.

It was just one.

A single technique that contained his whole.

Woon-seong extended his hands.

Within his consciousness, energy began to spread.

This energy caused waves in his martial sea.

Woon-seong controlled the waves of internal energy that took place in this sea, as if he were a god of storms.

Compress and compress internal energy.

Reduce and reduce somewhere.

Until only one remains.

Su-su-su-su.

As the process repeated, strange sounds began to emanate from Woon-seong's body.

The sound of water flowing.

No, that was not quite right.

It was not the sound of a babbling brook, but of a drying stream.

The phrase consisted of only one technique — itself — and was at the same time a law of his heart.

The dried martial sea gave vitality to his whole body.

He felt his consciousness gradually returning to his physical body.

This is it.

A single technique that contained all of his consciousness.

As his consciousness returned to his body, Woon-seong held on to the technique.

I don't need a thousand routes.

To kill the enemy, he did not need a thousand ways.

The idea of a thousand to capture perfection was wrong from the start.

Having too many techniques was cumbersome.

Just one.

The moment he realized that, Woon-seong woke up.

Wham-!

Ooh-

Yok-

The Sword and Buddhist Stars were thrown to the ground like rags.

The Inverted Sky Lord looked at the scene and muttered in disappointment, "Oh, that's no fun."

"Cough."

"Ugh."

The Twin Stars groaned from their places on the ground. Their arms and legs were almost completely broken and the Buddhist Star's fists, which had been hit by the Inverted Sky Lord, were disintegrating into powder.

The Sword Star's sword was no different.

The sword, which had accompanied the swordsman for a lifetime, had splintered into five pieces scattering the battlefield.

Is this the end?

The Sword Star could barely think or see.

He could not stop *it*.

That thing was not human.

A man born and raised as a human, had risen fully to the status of a deity.

He was a myth, a literally 'divine' being.

The problem was, of course, that he was an evil deity that would bring disaster to this world.

An aura that caused hopelessness flowed from the Inverted Sky Lord's body.

The Sword Star closed his eyes in despair.

The Buddhist Star muttered, "Namo Amitabhaya Buddhaya. May the Buddha look down upon me with mercy."

At that, the Inverted Sky Lord cackled.

This time, it seemed to belong to a woman.

Dang-

The Inverted Sky Lord stomped on the Buddhist Star's chest.

The man's body slammed into the ground.

Wooduk-

“Huagh-”

The Buddhist Star had the wind knocked out of him, his rib cage cracking.

The Inverted Sky Lord leaned down and chuckled, “There is no Buddha. If there was a Buddha, he wouldn’t have spared a guy like me. Isn’t that right?”

The Buddhist Star closed his eyes. He did not dare answer. If he did so, everything he had done so far would be for nothing.

The Inverted Sky Lord also did not seem to expect an answer from the Buddhist Star.

However,

“Indeed, there is no Buddha.”

There was an answer.

The Inverted Sky Lord turned his head in surprise. The Twin Stars did the same.

The voice was somewhat familiar to their ears.

As soon as he turned, the Sword Star’s eyes widened.

The Buddhist Star also looked surprised.

“Heavens, you’re alright?”

“Cult Leader?”

The Buddhist and Sword Stars made astonished gasps.

Hyuk Woon-seong, who had been tossed to the side like a ragdoll, was rising to his feet.

The bones and torn muscles in his body had still not been healed yet.

But he was standing on trembling legs.

The Inverted Sky Lord's expression was stiff.

It was because he could still see the large and small wounds on Woon-seong's body.

“You...”

Psh.

Shh.

At the same time, a cloud of poison flowed from Woon-seong's body, disappearing.

It was the same poison that had been eating away at Woon-seong's body.

“You!”

The Inverted Sky Lord crossed the distance in an instant.

Boom!

Woon-seong's body shook and flew back, slumping down.

With a crack of thunder, Woon-seong's chest, which had taken the hit, caved in.

As the walls of the palace collapsed, the ground shook and a building crumbled on top of Woon-seong.

[illegible]

Nevertheless, the Inverted Sky Lord did not relax his stance.

“You should be dead.”

Between the debris of the building, Woon-seong was standing up again.

His caved-in chest was being healed quickly by a bright light.

The ‘Heavenward Soul Earthen Body’, innate essence qi, was keeping him alive. .

His body was filled with so much vitality that he quickly recovered from all his injuries.

Woon-seong had experienced this feeling once before.

Body modification?

The moment he thought he slammed into a wall, a second body modification had occurred.

It was a miracle!

“Arrrgh!”

The Inverted Sky Lord flew into the air as if he could not stand to see this.

Spreading gray despair, shining with white light!

Kuakuakuakua-

The man rushed over, charging down.

At that moment!

Boom-

Woon-seong extended a hand.

The Inverted Sky Lord’s palm was blocked by Woon-seong and pushed back.

“Knng!”

Under the enormous pressure slamming him back, the Inverted Sky Lord tumbled across the ground.

Seeing that, Woon-seong coldly muttered, “That’s a good look on you.”

Woon-seong struggled to keep himself from sneering.

Meanwhile, all of Woon-seong’s wounds were rapidly healing.

Originally, all of his bones would have had to undergo reconstruction and modification one by one, but in this case, the Inverted Sky Lord had helpfully left Woon-seong’s body in tatters.

Woon-seong’s body was so broken that he didn’t even need to go through the process of disassembly, he just needed to be pieced back together.

And he would be stronger than ever, surpassing the limit of a human body!

“Uuuhhh!” the Inverted Sky Lord burst into frustrated tears.

Woon-seong waved his hand. The White Night Spear flew through the air, arcing towards him.

Shua-

Woon-seong grasped the White Night Spear.

At that moment, Hyuk Woon-seong disappeared from his spot.

Huak-

The Inverted Sky Lord’s body flew into the air faster than an arrow and was thrown backwards just as fast.

Boom. Boom.

The building that had been along the trajectory collapsed.

Woon-seong kicked off the ground once again.

Huak-

Woon-seong moved faster than the Inverted Sky Lord could fly, appearing behind the man and punching him in the abdomen.

Boom. Boom.

“Uagh!”

The man slammed through the rubble of a collapsed building.

Boom-

The ground caved in, forming a huge pit.

It was a pit that seemed to be nearly ten meters deep.

“Ahhhh, you, you, you, how can you...”

The Inverted Sky Lord snarled as he crawled out of the pit.

Woon-seong stretched a fist towards the man. “You can’t lose something you never had.”

The Inverted Sky Lord stiffened, like he had been struck by lightning.

As Woon-seong noticed earlier, the Inverted Sky Lord had not used a proper martial skill once during his fight.

When a martial artist reached the boundary to divinity, he lost the mortal skills that he had learned up until that point, but his habits remained intact.

However, the Inverted Sky Lord had no such muscle memory.

He didn’t forget his martial arts because he never had them in the first place.

In other words, the Inverted Sky Lord was just wielding another person’s body in the Divine Realm by using the power of his great soul.

He did not know how to manipulate the power, nor to control his energy.

But what about Woon-seong?

Woon-seong had torn down the walls before him and climbed into the Divine Realm by hand.

This was a power built entirely through Woon-seong's own efforts.

And thus, Woon-seong was able to handle this power properly.

Woon-seong approached the man step by step.

The Inverted Sky Lord swung his hand.

“Ahhh!”

It was this threatening gesture that had almost driven Woon-seong to his death.

But now, it was no threat.

Jubbuck-

With a side step, the man's hand passed by Woon-seong like a gust of wind.

“Hey, you, don't come any closer!”

Jubbuck-

One step closer, the man's hands hit only air.

Jubbuck-

One more step narrowed the distance between Woon-seong and the Inverted Sky Lord. They were now separated by a distance that spears could breach.

“Hey, this can't be right. This can't be happening! ”

The Inverted Sky Lord swatted with his hands like he was having a seizure.

Woon-seong stretched out the White Night Spear.

There was no strong force that emerged, no bright radiance.

It was just a stab of ordinary spearmanship.

I don't need a thousand techniques.

However, all of the martial arts in which Woon-seong had accumulated was contained therein.

I only need one technique to kill my enemies.

Woon-seong spoke the name of the technique.

“Heaven-Breaking Martial Ultimate” (天绝武极).

The last technique needed to reach one thousand and the most perfect martial art.

It pierced through the Inverted Sky Lord's heart.

Puchi.

Chapter 207: Conclusion (1)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 207 – Conclusion (1)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The war was over.

When Clan Head Peng Ga-hyuk, who was watching the battle between Woon-seong and the Inverted Sky Lord, committed suicide, the Tyrant King Troops lost their will to fight.

The Buddhist and Sword Stars were barely saved when Woon-seong, who had risen to a Divine Being, stimulated their innate essence qi.

But there were some things that could not be salvaged.

One of the Buddhist Star's fists, which had been reduced to powder, could not be returned, no matter how rich his essence was.

After all the fighting, King Jinseong ascended the throne as emperor.

Immediately after, he began to heal the world which had been ravaged by war.

He called in all of the Beijing Defense Forces and with the help of the Eastern Depot, began filtering out the deeply rooted Cult of the Inverted Sky.

Murim was no different.

All the factions that had joined the Cult of the Inverted Sky were sealed, while those who had not formed a new system under the Justice Alliance.

What about Woon-seong?

Woon-seong led the Demonic Army back to the Heavenly Mountains, where the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was founded.

Of course, that did not mean the Demons were restricted to the Heavenly Mountains like before.

As had originally been promised, the Demons were able to freely travel to and from Zhongyuan.

Although the territory was limited to Qinghai, Gansu, and Sichuan, some of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon's long-standing wishes had been fulfilled.

In this area, where there were still Orthodox martial arts, the promises made by Woon-seong and the Justice Alliance were kept.

The monument of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was built upon the Martial Alliance's ruins, engraved with the names of the Demons who had lost their lives in the war.

Of course, this was not without backlash.

However, the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was by far the most powerful force in the world.

King Jinseong, the new emperor, recognized the Cult of the Heavenly Demon as the national religion and appointed Woon-seong as the national historian.

As this was happening outside, someone slowly climbed to the Peak of the Heavenly Demon's Majesty.

It was a peak that had barely been graced by people.

No, it was a peak that no one was allowed to enter without the Heavenly Demon's command.

Who could enter the area was...

It's been a long time.

Only one Hyuk Woon-seong, the Heavenly Demon.

Where Woon-seong stopped was the very peak, before a shrine made of wood.

As he entered the shrine, two spirit tables could be seen.

Although he did was unable to recover the body, one was for the Spearmaster Nok Yu-on, and the other was for Woon-seong's second master, 'Moon Cleaving Heavenly Demon' Cheon Hwi.

Regardless of the practices of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon, this was a shrine that Woon-seong had built only for his two masters.

In order to construct this shrine, Woon-seong had carefully hand-selected and placed each piece of wood.

The shrine was named the Temple of the Parted.

A shrine in honor of a deceased master.

Only one person was allowed inside: Hyuk Woon-seong.

Woon-seong entered the shrine and quietly murmured, "It's really been a long time."

He closed his eyes.

"But at last, I was able to avenge you both."

There was no more Cult of the Inverted Sky.

When the leader disappeared at the hands of Woon-seong, the Cult of the Inverted Sky was torn into thousands and thousands of pieces. The remnants were still disappearing each day, chased by both the Demonic and the Justice Alliance.

Considering the venom within Woon-seong, there was no doubt that the chase would continue until every last one disappeared.

So it was safe to say that there were no more enemies.

“So...”

After all the vengeance was said and done, he knelt before the spirit tablets.

“Please rest peacefully there.”

There was a war that washed away the entire Murim and Imperial Palace with blood, but time continued on and on.

With the passage of time, the seasons changed.

And finally, it was the season of spring, the dawn of a new year.

“Haha.”

On one peak of the Mount Hua Sect, there was a man standing in the spring wind dressed in white robes.

It was the Sage of Bright Rock, Myung Am.

Immediately after the war against the Cult of the Inverted Sky ended, he returned to the Mount Hua Sect and passed on his status of sect leader.

Then he chose to retire into one of the many peaks in Mount Hua, one which was barely graced by people.

It was because he was apologetic to Spearmaster Nok Yu-on, who had passed on first.

Even now, only the disciples of the Mount Hua Sect would seek out his abode and no other martial artists had visited him.

Myung Am, who stood amidst the light breeze, shook his head.

Out of the corner of his eye, he caught sight of a tree branch.

It was the branch of a small plum tree, rooted in a sheer cliff.

At the ends of the branch were small flower buds.

“In the meantime, plum blossoms have bloomed.”

He had spent a lifetime in Mount Hua and thought he had a plum blossom in his heart.

But after laying everything down, he wondered if that was true.

I couldn't do it in the end.

If he had truly embraced Mount Hua and its plum blossoms, he would not feel anything different as he looked at the blossoms now.

After staring at the plum blossoms for a long time, Sage Myung sighed deeply.

Seeing plum blossoms like this, it reminds me of you again.

Nok Yu-on.

He had enjoyed plum wine.

Plum wine...

When he thought about that, he remembered that he had hidden some plum wine in the backyard. Myung Am smiled at the thought.

As he moved towards where he had buried it, he suddenly stopped.

— Remember this. You will be held accountable for your sins for the rest of your life and you will have to live with the memories.

A voice seemed to have come from somewhere. Myung Am gave a sharp nod, subconsciously gazing north.

I will live like that for the rest of my life.

“The Divine Lady enters.”

Baek Woon-ji’s voice echoed through the palace.

Not long after the war, according to the wishes of the previous Cult Leader, Hyuk Woon-seong and Cheon Ah-young held their marriage ceremony.

Baek Woon-ji hid her face for several years after watching the scene. But a few years after disappearing, she became a part of the Flowers of the Dark Night and reappeared in front of Woon-seong.

Of course, it was unrequited love in the case of Baek Woon-ji.

However, through the harsh training for the Flowers of the Dark Night, she had organized her feelings for Woon-seong to some extent. Even though her heart ached, she chose to watch over her love quietly.

It was unknown whether or not Woon-seong knew her feelings, but he nodded his head at her announcement.

“Come in.”

When Woon-seong’s words fell, the gates of the palace opened, revealing Cheon Ah-young.

The Divine Lady of the Cult of the Heavenly Demon was in elegant robes, fit for the wife of the Heavenly Demon.

“I greet you, Lord.”

Cheon Ah-young greeted him with practiced ease. She had a bright smile on her face.

However, the expression of Woon-seong receiving that smile was somehow uncomfortable.

Since he was not used to dealing with women, his married life had not been very comfortable.

Fortunately, Cheon Ah-young had a unique and cheerful personality.

Thanks to her attitude, although it was a little shaky at first, Hyuk Woon-seong and Cheon Ah-young were able to continue their marriage smoothly.

Once she had greeted the Heavenly Demon, Cheon Ah-young slightly raised her head.

Then, she looked around and tilted her head, commenting, “I don’t see So-san.”

Cheon Ah-young was referring to Kang So-san, who Woon-seong had accepted as a disciple some time back.

When the Demonic Teacher of Sun and Moon was severely wounded in the war, Kang So-san had returned to the Heavenly Mountains with him. Immediately after the war, he began to formally learn martial arts under Woon-seong’s tutelage.

Since the war had ended about five years ago, it would be about five years since he started training.

And for the last five years, Kang So-san had been a tenacious learner.

He had mastered the spear arts with all of his might, then learned about the internal arts.

Of course, he was a little lacking in body development and experience. Moreover, it could be a problem that he had started on this path so late.

But who was Kang So-san's teacher?

It was not an exaggeration to say that Woon-seong was the most powerful person in the world right now, and at the same time, he was the only person in the Divine Realm.

Woon-seong neatly solved all potential problems by improving and accelerating Kang So-san's bone structure.

Not only that, with great strength, he was able to wash Kang So-san's marrows of toxins.

And perhaps it was thanks to this.

Despite starting later, after only five years of training, Kang So-san was able to reach first-rate in strength.

The status of Demonic General while slightly younger than twenty.

Compared to Woon-seong, it was true that this was slow growth.

However, it was not terribly slow compared to Gwan Tae-ryang, who Woon-seong had trained with.

In addition, Cheon Ah-young, who recently tried to watch over Kang So-san, had a good impression of the disciple and thought about teaching him some sorcery.

After five years, Cheon Ah-young's skills were also far better than before.

Since Cheon Ah-young was originally talented in divine arts, and since her skills had increased, Kang So-san was able to grow at an even faster pace.

It was then natural for Cheon Ah-young to view Kang So-san in an even better light.

It was not unusual for her to look for Kang So-san.

Woon-seong replied to Cheon Ah-young with a short, "I sent him down the mountain."

"You're sending him down the mountain?" Cheon Ah-young's eyes opened wide. "You mean the kid who's not even twenty yet?"

"Isn't eighteen old enough? At his age, he needs to experience Murim. When we were sent for real world training in the Cave of Latent Demons, some of us were eighteen."

"But..."

Cheon Ah-young, who held a teacher's heart for Kang So-san, couldn't shake off the feeling that she was throwing a child to the water's edge.

Seeing her expression so anxious, Woon-seong sighed.

"Don't worry about it, I sent the White Ape Lord with him."

The White Ape Lord was referring to Sa Ryong-hui.

After returning to the Cult, Ah-young had put down her position as the Captain of the White Ape Unit and once again returned to her place as the Divine Maiden, so the captaincy became vacant once more.

The spot was given to Sa Ryong-hui, who had served as a white-uniformed soldier.

Hearing that the White Ape Lord had been sent along, Ah-young nodded with a relieved look. "I'm glad that is so."

Sa Ryong-hui had already been nearing transcendence five years ago. Now that he could use his strength more naturally, few people would be able to harm him in Murim.

At Cheon Ah-young's relieved face, Woon-seong added on with a mutter, "Perhaps by now, the two will already be completing their mission."

Cheon Ah-young's eyes snapped up. "Mission?"

Instead of answering aloud, Woon-seong only grinned.

"Damn it."

A shabby man took a swig from a bottle of liquor in his hands. The drink seemed to bubble, dripping from his sleeves.

He was in a shabby guestroom.

Around him, there were already five empty jars.

Nevertheless, he poured alcohol into his mouth, as if he were not satisfied.

"Damn it!"

At the same time, he lamented, "Why the hell do I have to drink cheap liquor in a shabby room?!"

The man who was drinking was Hong Bin.

It was not just someone with the same name, but that same Hong Bin who once joined hands with the Inverted Sky and climbed to the top of this massive land mass.

The reason Hong Bin was drinking in this village was because of the incidenta five years ago.

Five years ago, the Inverted Sky Lord and his allies had fallen overnight to King Jinseong, the Demonic Cult, and the Justice Alliance.

In that situation, Hong Bin barely escaped with his life.

And he was now hiding in this village, drinking as he avoided the pursuit of the Demonic Cult, Justice Alliance, and Imperial Court.

“Dammit, if the Cult of the Inverted Sky hadn’t been defeated, I wouldn’t have to live like this!”

It was then.

Knock-knock.

Someone knocked on the door of the room he was staying in.

The sound made him nervous, so he stopped drinking.

“Who’s there?”

“Sir, it’s me.”

A voice familiar to his ears.

It was the voice of the owner of this inn.

Aware of this, Hong Bin opened his eyes and yelled, “I told you not to come unless I called for you!”

“Well, you have visitors...”

“Someone came looking for me?” Hong Bin tilted his head, bottle in hand as he walked over and threw the door open. “Who is it?”

At that moment, the door slid open and the men standing behind the owner of the inn could be seen.

Men with scorpions tattooed on their heads and scars all over their bodies.

The moment he saw them, Hong Bin’s expression shuttered.

“Huack!”

Hong Bin hurriedly tried to close the door. The men, however, familiar with similar situations, slipped their feet in between the crack.

Tuk-

The door was unable to be shut and the men slid inside, grabbing Hong Bin by the collar.

“If you borrow someone else’s money, you should work hard to pay it back. Why are you just drinking here?”

These men ran the loan agency nearby. While Hong Bin had some wealth when he left the palace, he had been in too much of a rush to bring enough. He had used it all up over the last five years running here and there.

Eventually, he had no choice but to borrow money, going to the Salt Palace nearby. But he was behind on repayments.

“Well, that’s...”

Hong Bin slowly stepped back.

But there was nowhere to escape in the shabby room.

Even more so, Hong Bin was unfamiliar with martial arts.

Turtub-!

One of the men grabbed Hong Bin by the shoulder.

Hong Bin shouted, trying to cause a commotion.

“You bastards! Do you know who I am?!”

However, these screams had no effect on the Black Way men who managed the Salt Palace. The man grabbed him forcefully.

“Shut up. Prepare to be sold into slavery. If you don’t like it, maybe you could sell some of your limbs.”

Another man next to him chuckled, taking over.

“That’s all he’s good for. If he was a girl or had a nicer face, we could have done something more comfortable, haha.”

The laughter made Hong Bin’s face pale.

“Yi, this guy!”

TN: Sorry for the late uploads, we’re so close to the finish line (:

Chapter 208: Conclusion (2)

Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon

Chapter 208 – Conclusion (2)

Translated by : moonchildkhz

The two men dragged Hong Bin to an alleyway leading up to the village.

“Rrrgghhh!”

Terrified, Hong Bin flailed with his hands, but his opponents had no intention of letting him go.

How far along did they drag him?

At last, a small manor with an eerie atmosphere appeared, located in an area infrequently traveled.

It was a manor that Hong Bin recognized.

It was the same manor he had visited when he first went to borrow money from the Salt Palace. Even then, it had been a creepy place.

But now, he was even more scared.

The entrance to the manor seemed like the entrance to the Underworld.

“Ugh. You bastards!”

Hence, not wanting to be dragged inside, Hong Bin struggled even more violently than before. However, on top of not knowing martial arts, he had never even worked out before.

With such a weak body, he could not escape the hands locking him in place.

He was dragged inside and thrown into the creepy atmosphere.

“Ow!”

Kwa-dung!

Hong Bin rolled over. He then lifted his head up and looked around.

Inside the building, there were a lot of men who looked just like those that had brought him here.

This was the headquarters of a Black Way sect known as Black Scorpion Gate, which now ran the Salt Palace.

Thrown amidst them, Hong Bin clammed up, shaking and trembling.

Hong Bin was a man who had once ascended to royalty. When would he have ever experienced such an atmosphere?

Having never been in such a situation before, Hong Bin stopped screaming and instead curled up, eyes darting back and forth.

At that time, the man who was sitting at the top opened his mouth.

“Hey!”

He was the sect leader of the Black Scorpions, the head of these martial artists, and the owner of the Salt Palace.

At the call of the sect leader, Hong Bin trembled and raised his head.

“Ugh, huh?”

At the same time!

Bang!

Hong Bin saw stars spinning before his eyes.

A guard from the Black Way, who had been standing next to him, smashed a fist into Hong Bin's head.

“Uagh!”

Before he could go on screaming, the man slammed his mouth shut and grabbed Hong Bin by the collar.

“How can you say ‘huh’ to the leader? You need to be more polite.”

Hong Bin was terrified by the yelling.

“O-Oh, I understand.”

Hong Bin quickly nodded his head and the man dropped him.

Then the sect leader sat down with a satisfied smile and said, “Hey.”

“Yes, sir. Hello.”

Perhaps it was because he had been beaten once, but Hong Bin replied in a polite voice. You would never know that he had once been royalty.

Of course, the reason he had risen so high up was not because he was talented.

Hong Bin was only good at planning an escape route; without the support of the Cult of the Inverted Sky, Hong Bin wouldn't have been able to even hold an imperial office.

And of course, the Inverted Sky was also aware of this, so they set him up as an useless official.

Anyway, that was all in the past. What was important to Hong Bin right now was the fact that he had been placed at a crossroads of life and death.

“If you borrow money, you have to pay it back. You haven’t paid back a penny and now the interest is greater than the principal, and we have to do this and stare uncomfortably at each other’s faces.”

Hong Bin trembled, replying, “Yes, I’ll pay you back.”

The man tilted his head and smiled, “How?”

The question caused Hong Bin to go silent.

How?

He hadn’t thought of a way to pay them back. He merely said that so he could get out of this place alive.

However, when asked, Hong Bin looked flustered.

The sect leader did not miss that look.

“Look at this. These days, customers are all like this. They just borrow money without thinking and they keep pushing back the deadline and saying they’ll pay it back... But that sounds like something anyone with a hole in their head can do.”

As he spoke, the man pulled a blade from his waist.

“I guess you are the same as them. Someone who says he’ll pay it back without actually being able to, and then walks away.”

“Hiek!”

Hong Bin sucked in a breath as the blade was turned towards him.

The sect leader slowly rose from his seat and walked towards Hong Bin. He tapped Hong Bin on the cheek with the blade.

“Tell me the truth. You can’t pay me back, can you?”

“No, I can pay you back.”

“How then?”

“.....”

The sect leader sighed. He then titled his head down and said, “Let’s not bother each other because we’re busy men. I am busy getting other people’s money. And you, you’ll have to do everything in your power to pay me back. Even if it takes a lifetime.”

Hong Bin seemed to have turned stupid. His body trembled as if had epilepsy.

It was then...

“Black Way scum who dares to expand their power into the realm of the Heavenly Demon. You’re up to no good, I see.”

Someone’s voice rang through the building.

The Black Way men, including the sect leader, raised their heads in surprise!

Roar-!

A rock flew into the air and smashed into a guard’s head. The man’s eyes rolled back and he collapsed.

“What the hell?!”

In the commotion, the men drew their swords. They looked around and saw two shadows on the wall.

The sect leader turned towards the shadows and ground his teeth.

“You children dare to stone our Black Scorpion Gate. You’ve got a lot of nerve.”

One of the men standing on the wall laughed. With a smile, a black stream of energy flowed into the air.

Energy which symbolized the Cult of the Heavenly Demon.

It was demonic qi.

“Since you’ve expanded your power into the realm of our Cult, I think you’ve got more guts than I do.”

“What?”

One of the two shadows, a slightly taller young man, leapt down. Then, falling down among the Black Way, he wielded his sword.

Sgarak –

Two men of the Black Way were sliced to bits.

“Pu-ha, attacking while speaking. Such dirty bastards! You dogs of the Demonic Cult!”

At that point, another shadow joined the fray.

“A dog of the Demonic Cult... I can’t believe you’re about to die to a dog then.”

The sword flashed in the dark.

Every time that happened, the throats of the Black Way men would be slit.

It was quite savage. These two shadows swept through the men like wolves.

There was not a single Black Way man or other warrior who could take their attacks.

At the very least, the only one who could resist was the sect leader.

“Aahhhh, Black and White Storm!”

The skill, which the sect leader had named the ‘Black and White Storm’, split the air. To onlookers, it seemed like a small storm had gathered as sharp qi rained down.

But...

Caang-

The storm dissipated with a swing. At the same time, a tremendous shock wave sliced the sect leader in half.

Shua, shua.

The two halves of the sect leader’s body were slammed together.

Shua, shua.

The body was cut in half once again.

Shua!

As the pieces were pulled together once more, the sect leader’s neck went flying.

Blood sprayed like a fountain from the wound.

Seeing how their sect leader could not stand even three moves, the other men tried to run away.

That was how powerful the two shadows were.

In this sudden situation, Hong Bin watched the scene with his mouth wide, not knowing what to do.

How much time passed?

The strong and ferocious looking men were not opponents for the two young men.

It took less than half an hour for the fifty or so men of the Black Way to be slaughtered.

And so after half an hour, the only ones left were the two young men and Hong Bin.

The rest were blood and corpses.

In that situation, Hong Bin said with a trembling voice, “Sirs, thank you.”

To Hong Bin, these two masters had appeared and saved his life.

Hong Bin thus thanked his saviors; in the dark, the two warriors slowly walked towards him.

At that moment, the clouds covering the clouds disappeared. The moonlight poured down, revealing the faces of two warriors.

One warrior walked over, smiling brightly at Hong Bin.

“Do you really appreciate it?”

The two men who showed up...

The two were Kang So-san and Sa Ryong-hui, who were pursuing Hong Bin under the orders of Woon-seong.

Subsequently, Kang So-san’s spear pierced the man’s chest.

Puchi-

Woosh!

Kang So-san swung his spear, flicking off the blood on the blade.

As the man cleaned his blade, Sa Ryong-hui asked, “What about the wealth the Black Scorpions accumulated?”

“Since it is originally from the nearby villagers, isn’t it right to give it back?”

Sa Ryong-hui lowered his head, “I will do as the Young Master says.”

Kang So-san asked, “Why? Are you still worried about your justice?”

Sa Ryong-hui paused. “I am not sure yet, actually.”

But he lifted his head.

His gaze turned to Kang So-san. He said he did not know, but he seemed to have found some answers.

He smiled at Kang So-san.

“But seeing the Young Master, I don’t think my answer is too far off.”

Kang So-san returned the smile.

Underneath the moonlight, it was a beautiful smile.

Although the man belonged to the Demonic Cult, the orthodox factions did not hesitate to call the Cult Leader, who had reached divinity in martial arts, a deity.

The members of the Demonic Cult naturally continued to refer to the Heavenly Demon as their god, since the Cult Leader’s power had reached the end of mortal understanding...

And future generations would not hesitate to call Hyuk Woon-seong the ‘Divine Heavenly Demon’, for he was both heavenly divine and a demon [1].

[1]: The raws state that Woon-seong is known as Shinma (神魔), which translates to 'Divine Demon' or 'Heavenly Demon'. However, we have already been using 'Heavenly Demon' to denote the position of the Cult Leader, which is Cheonma (天魔) or 'Sky Demon', so I'm translating Shinma as 'Divine Heavenly Demon'.

TN: And that's the end! Thank you for following Hyuk Woon-seong's story in all 208 chapters of 'Chronicles of the Heavenly Demon'. I hope you'll stick around for the 8 extra chapters, which will be exclusively on Buy Me A Coffee (unless the manhwa covers the extra chapters).

Otherwise, thank you for reading ('◦•ゝ•◦ ') ♡